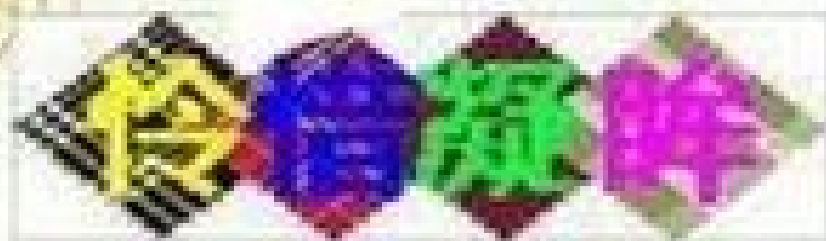


穿越之

勉为其男



完结



Information

Table of Contents URL:

<https://www.lightnovelworld.co/novel/transmigration-of-mian-reluctantly-becomes-his-man-wife-12040103>

Transmigration of Mian [Reluctantly] Becomes His Man [Wife]

Transmigration: To Be His Man

Author: [Liánxī Níngmóu](#)

RANK 599

4.8
223
Chapters
726K
Views
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Categories

- Historical
- Slice of Life
- Supernatural
- Yaoi

Transmigration of Mian [Reluctantly] Becomes His Man [Wife] novel is a popular light novel covering Historical, Slice of Life, and Supernatural genres. Written by the Author Liánxī Níngmóu. 223 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

Qin Mian opened his eyes and found himself lying in a leaky thatched room. The problem was that he was still in his family's villa beforehand! What's more, there was another man lying next to his leg in the quilt!

“You, you, who are you?”

The man sat up quietly, his upper body exposed as looked at Qin Mian for a moment before he carried a worn out bowl with a cracked corner from the low table at the head of the bed. The man said in a muffled voice, “Wife, drink water.”

Qin Mian's eyes rolled backwards and he passed out.

—

TN:

Title explanation: 勉为其男 [miǎn wéi qí nán] have the same sound as 勉为其难 [miǎn wéi qí nán] which means to do something reluctantly. 勉 [miǎn] is also part of MC's name: Qin Mian. Also, 其[qí] sounds the same as 妻 [qi] means wife. So, there are words plays. Basically, Qin Mian reluctantly becomes someone's man [wife] after he transmigrated.

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- 13
AvaRead
Reader
28d

Is this good? I'll let you know once I'm done 😊

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0 0

- 1
Parvinan4
Reader
6mo

Всё понравилось. Но у меня осталось 3 вопроса: 1) Кто убил Ду Ши? 2) Что с вором которого отпустил гг?(Там был намек будто он потом поможет гг) 3) Что был в коробке которую принес Лэй Те своим детям и жене???(Чтобы его открыть нужно было подумать, и мне так хотелось узнать что он подарил)

Edited: 6mo

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0 0

- 1

Kirboo

Reader

7mo

This was a cute read. Short and sweet. I thoroughly enjoyed it. Can anyone recommend similar novels please? Pretty please 😞

Edited: 7mo

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 3

Diandian

[Kirboo](#)

Reader

5mo

Stone age husband raising journal... exciting fight and full of dog food and mysteries.

[Reply](#)

3 0

- 3

WangXian

Reader

1y

Done reading and it was good, I love how the couple came from being poor to rich. It's so fun how MC think of ways to earn money until they became nouveau rich. I wish the time together of the couple protagonist was a bit longer in the end plus their twins, some scenes and arcs could actually be explore some more. I wouldn't mind reading a hundred chapters more of this. Their love and tacit understanding made them be on top of my bl couple list 😊. It's rare to have a loving ML that's full of doting towards MC in a world full of domineering ML's lol 😂

Reply

8 0

◦ 60

Sumer

WangXian

Reader

1y

How much pain and s*d*st stuff does this have??? (^ ▽ ^)/♪
asking for a friend

Reply

2 0

• 60

Sumer

Reader

1y

Is there some goal or some good drama in the middle? Reading 200+ of just fluff might be a little boring

Reply

1 0

- 6

HarmonicaMan

Reader

1y

Honestly I'm not a fan of the whole "reincarnated directly into a relationship" (really just reincarnation stuff in general. It's a decent plot device but it's usually not used properly. It gives the mc an outsiders perspective which adds a lot of possibilities, but so would amnesia, being from a foreign place, a sudden change in lifestyle, or just straight up a recluse or sheltered child to name a few. Not to mention an outsider perspective isn't always necessary, even if it is a bit easier to write. Reincarnation should be saved for when it's actually important, like the mc having a relevant past life like trash of the counts family or return of mount hua. Otherwise amnesia serves the same purpose for the most part. Or maybe they actually are trying to return home which adds a goal) thing but the reviews and comments seem really positive so I'm going to check it out. Honestly it seems wholesome just from the concept, and I am desperate for good Yaoi which is kind of rare.

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1

Arkian

Reader

1y

You know that feeling of emptiness after finishing a story? That feeling of attachment and pride for that story? It was lovely yet emptying. This story really made it felt like I was there watching their growth. I love how they both had that tacit understanding and how smooth their relationship was. No third parties, no misunderstanding, and no cold conversations. I love how Lei Tie loved his man and accepted him wholeheartedly, now I wish I'd find a man like that too.

Of course, the quick-witted and smart wife, Qin Mian. Ah how I love his sharp tongue and his twin son. so cuuute. Anyways, if only I could forget the whole story and reread it again. I'd love to experience the same thrill and enjoyment.

[Reply](#)

7 0

- 5
CritikalReader
Reader
1y

This is my comfort novel, I always come back and reread this

[Reply](#)

4 0

- 1
Secretism231564
Reader
2y

I'm kinda scared reading some Yaoi novels after reading that fvcking misunderstandings in manhwas... So to anyone who read it already Does this novel have a fvcking bitch that is eyeing our MC's man?? No cheating?No misunderstanding?

[Reply](#)

5 0

- 1
Shadowprinceeee
[Secretism231564](#)
Reader
2y

The story is superb!! Must read this one, highly recommend it.
There's a bitch but the MC is so smart and deal it easily

[Reply](#)

2 0

- 1
lnwUser67608
Reader
2y

The glory after rebirth

[Reply](#)

0 1

◦ 8

niet

[lnwUser67608](#)

Reader

1y

This guy is lvl -1 lool

[Reply](#)

0 0

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Chapter 000: Characters Guide

NOTE: TO BE CHANGED AS THE STORY PROGRESS

MAIN CHARACTERS

1. 1. Qin Mian
2. Lei Tie

Lei Family

1. 1. Lei DaQiang – father
2. Du Shi – Lei DaQiang’s wife on his second marriage / Lei Tie’s stepmother
 1. Lei XiangRen – 2nd child/ Du’s firstborn
 1. Zhou Shi (wife)
 1. Lei Dabao (son)
 2. Lei Xiaobao (son)
 2. Lei XiangYi – 3rd child
 1. Qian Shi (wife)
 1. Lei Xinxin (daughter)
 3. Lei XiangLi – 4th child
 4. Lei XingZhi – 5th child/twin boy
 5. Lei ChunTao – 5th child/twin girl

Villagers

1. 1. Zhang Dashuan – farmer/friend
 1. Sister Zhang (wife)
 1. Zhang Baolu (son)
 2. Zhang Yimei (daughter)
 3. Zhang Erli (daughter)

2. Wu Di – farmer/friend
3. Zhou Cuihua – villager/gossiper
4. Fang Hongliu – villager/gossiper
5. Zhao Sifa
6. Zhou Erhao

The staff of Eating Savory Restaurant

1. 1. Yue Dong – Accountant
2. Zheng Liu
3. Wang Shun
4. Chen Si
5. Shi Tou

THE DENG FAMILY

1. Master Deng + Madam Deng
 1. Eldest Uncle Deng
 1. Daughter
 2. Daughter
 3. Deng Quan
 1. Xiya [f] 10 y.o
 2. Kunzai
 2. Second Uncle Deng
 1. Deng Zhong
 1. Manya [f]
 2. Yuanzai 5 y.o
 2. Daughter
 3. Deng Xiao
 1. Xuanzai
 2. Yuya [f]
 3. Lanya [f] 5 y.o
 3. Deng Shi [Lei Tie's mother]

Chapter 001: One Day, Transmigrated into Someone's Wife

001 – One Day, Transmigrated into Someone's Wife

Qin Mian opened his eyes and found himself lying in a leaky thatched cottage. The problem was that he was still in his family's villa beforehand! What's more, there was another man lying next to his leg in the quilt!

“You, you, who are you?”

The man sat up quietly, his upper body exposed as he looked at Qin Mian for a moment before he carried a worn out bowl with a cracked corner from the low table at the head of the bed. The man said in a muffled voice, “Wife, drink water.”

Qin Mian's eyes rolled backwards and he passed out....

Qin Mian had a dream that he became a woman. Within the burst of suonas¹, gongs and drums beating, he was forced into a sedan chair to marry a man.

He was scared to the point of cold sweating, then woke up, and pulled his clothes apart. As soon as he saw a flat chest, he was relieved and laughed at himself, “I'm scaring myself; it's just a dream...”

Suddenly, he felt something was wrong. How could his clothes be so worn out? And how could he be so swarthy and thin, just like a child of eleven or twelve.

He raised his head hastily and found that he was in a thatched cottage. He jumped to the ground from the bed in fright. The thatched room was only about seven to eight square foot with two of the walls made of clay and the other two walls were merely made of wood, hay, and old cloth. There was nothing else in the room except for a wooden bed, a low table at the head of the bed, and two wooden boxes. Oh, there was also red paper-cutouts pasted on the wall, which were big “囍”² character. There was no mirror, but when Qin Mian looked at his little arms and calves, he could be sure that this body was not his at all.

A thrill crept up his back. What's going on? He clearly remembered that he had been in his family's villa beforehand. Right, he was pushed by Qin Lian. He had rolled down the stairs and hit his head. Very suddenly, he had an incredible idea: Was he dead and reincarnated in someone else's body?

Qin Mian dared not to believe it. He pinched himself hard but the scene in front of him didn't change at all, as if it was laughing at him coldly.

He was completely dumbstruck. After a moment of stupefaction, he quickly looked at the pulse point on his left wrist. There was a small, unremarkable black mole there. With a thought in mind, a familiar mysterious world appeared in front of him. He breathed a moment of relieved, his tensed face also eased a lot.

He walked toward the door with great strides; his feet pressed painfully on something hard within two steps. He looked down and saw a pair of skinny black feet without shoes. The ground was full of potholes; it would be a wonder if his feet did not get pressed painfully on something hard. Looking around, there was a pair of straw sandals by the bed. They had been worn for a long time that they were half black. Under the bed were two other pairs of straw sandals, one big and one small, all of which were new. He put on the new straw sandals without hesitation.

When he opened the door, he found that the thatched cottage was built in a yard. At a glance, he could tell that it was built later. A foul smell assailed his nostrils; he could not stand it, so he covered his nose.

“*Snort...*” A pig in the opposite pigsty looked up at him before lowering its head. Its dirty mouth dug the vegetable leaves scattered in the rice straws. There was a big pile of shit next to those few vegetable leaves.

Qin Mian’s mouth twitched as he walked to the tightly shut main house. He pushed open the door and called out; the unfamiliar voice was a little hoarse, “Is anyone there?”

No one answered.

He raised his voice and called out again. He could not help frowning when he didn’t get an answer. This body was too inferior: aching, limp, and weak. He merely shouted a few words but it was like he had exhausted all his strength. He couldn’t help wondering if this body was sick?

Looking to the right, there was a closed entrance door. The entrance door was made of several planks nailed together and he could faintly see gleam of light appeared from the cracks of the planks.

Qin Mian opened the entrance door and walked several steps to escape the stink in the pigsty. A gust of wind came gently; the fresh air made him greedily take a few mouthfuls of air.

On the left side of the sky hung a half height –unbeknownst whether it was morning or dusk– sun. The sun shone on the green verdant trees reflected the rays of light, and with the sway of the wind, they looked like glittering gold. Several chimneys erected in the rows of houses not far away from each other; the smoke from the chimneys spiraled up to the sky. Looking up, there was a large field in the distance; green crops blown by the wind set off long green waves. In the field, the farmers bent their backs and went busy; the oxen swung their tails while eating grass on the ridge. Further away was a tall green mountain with green trees stacked on top of each other. Faint smog curled around the mountainside made it looked like a fairyland. From unknown direction, came fuzzy noises, which were mixed with the cries of cattle and sheep, and the bark of dog, but contrarily, it reflected the tranquility of this village even more.

What a nice little village.

If not for Qin Mian hadn't figured out his situation, he wouldn't mind strolling around the village. He had lived in the reinforced concrete forest for a long time. Such a small village was just what he liked.

At this time, an old woman of about 60 years old came from behind a pile of haystacks with a basket on her right arm, containing some wet clothes.

As soon as Qin Mian saw the old woman's hair bun and ancient clothes, his heart thumped. Could it be that he not only reincarnated in someone else's body, but also went to ancient era?

It was not easy to meet a person; he was wondering whether to go up and test out the old woman, but the old woman suddenly stepped up and came straight to him. Her expression was very bad and her two thin lips were tightly pursed, showing a thread of mean aura.

"Since you have woken up, why don't you feed the pigs? Standing here to watch the scenery, ah?"

Qin Mian internally said: really am watching the scenery. He saw that the old woman entered the courtyard he had just come out of. He did not know what the relationship between him and the old woman was currently. He had to pinch his nose and as he walked in, his stomach rumbled like thunder booming.

He was hungry.

Du Shi³ was going to dry the clothes on the rope, but when she heard that there was no movement behind her, she turned her waist and glared as she roared with rage, "Eldest family's⁴, are you dead, ah? Go feed the pigs quickly!"

Eldest family's son or eldest family's what? Qin Mian thought. Except for the old woman, he was the only one here. Even if he didn't want to endure the old woman's shout, but it was about him. So, he could only sigh and walked there.

Du Shi glanced at him, "Feed the pigs!"

“Can’t.” Qin Mian smiled gently, “I have to trouble you to teach me.”

Du *Shi*’s face sank as soon as she heard it. She looked around, picked up a worn out broom and whipped it toward Qin Mian’s body. “Can’t? Can you eat or not? Are you trying to piss me off?”

Qin Mian was shocked. He reached for the broom while internally thought whether the old woman was ill to have hitting someone before saying a word? But he forgot that he was about 11-12 years old at most and with his very poor health, he was severely tugged by the old woman. The pain on his hands made his grips loose and his bum fell on the ground.

“How dare you fight back? Return to you.” Du *Shi* raised the broom and whipped at him again.

Qin Mian’s face coldly darkened, but he didn’t have the strength to dodge. He internally thought: what a bad luck, I’m afraid I’m going to suffer for a bit. The old woman looked old, but she was very strong.

The awaiting pain did not fall onto Qin Mian, but he saw Du *Shi*’s face frowned unsightly while looking behind him.

Qin Mian looked back and saw the broom was gripped by a tall man. He seemed to have seen this man somewhere before.

“Mother, he is my wife.”

Qin Mian coughed violently. No wonder he felt that he had seen the man; it was precisely the man who had handed him water and called him “wife” last night!

Chapter 002: A Little Dispute at Breakfast

This man looked in his early twenties; tall and strong with a straight disposition. He was wearing a gray open-slit duanda[1] on his upper body, tied a simple knot with a black belt on his waist with pants of the same color on his lower body rolled up to a small belly and a pair of old straw shoes on his feet. This man was rather handsome. He had waist-long black hair which simply bundled up with a mere blue cloth and a wooden hairpin. His thick eyebrows were slanted towards the sideburns with bright and deep eyes. Due to being basked in the sun often, his skin was bronze, which made him look more imposing. However, there was a scar on his left cheek, extending from the inner corner of his left eye all the way to the bottom of his earlobe. The wound looked old, but the scar was very obvious; it seemed somewhat intimidating.

He was this man's... wife? Qin Mian coughed and stood up. His knees were a little soft that he couldn't help sitting back down.

That man had sharp eyes and agile hands; he tightly held Qin Mian's arm in one hand.

Qin Mian felt like a chick being picked up. He took a look at the man but he didn't say anything and only murmured in his heart that this man was too tall, almost two heads taller than his present self. At the same time, he was surer that this body he possessed was ill and that this kind of weakness was not normal at all.

Du Shi's face eased up as she put down the broom. "Eldest[2], mother is angered by him. He said he couldn't feed the pigs! What's this if not to piss me off? Properly manage your wife!"

Qin Mian didn't make a sound. He could feed the pigs. He lived in the countryside with his maternal grandparents from birth to the age of 15, where they farmed, raised chickens and pigs at home; he could do it all. But now he was in a strange environment and had no memory of the original body's owner. He didn't know what the pig feed was, where it was and how much it was to be fed. If he did something wrong, it would lead the old woman to be suspicious of him, which was not good. As it was well known, people in ancient eras were superstitious. If someone found that the body had changed its core, he might have to die again. Therefore, he said directly that he could not, even if contrary to the fact, the old woman at most only thought he was deliberately looking for trouble.

Lei Tie took a look at Qin Mian; contrariwise, he didn't look displeased and without saying a word, he strode away.

Du Shi gave Qin Mian a fierce look.

Qin Mian did not fear her. He silently thought about what to do next while he wondered about that man, who walked in a windy way, with an unspeakable sense of out of sorts. He did not know what went wrong.

After a while, that man came up with a bucket, went to the pigsty and quickly poured the rotten vegetable leaves and some kind of grass in the bucket into the trough.

Du Shi's face was a little blue but her tone was as warm as possible: "Eldest, you are an adult man; why would you want to do this thing?"

Qin Mian was angry. *He's a man but I'm not a man?*

Lei Tie didn't say a word as he put the bucket on the ground. He led Qin Mian into the thatched room and sat him down at the edge of the bed.

Qin Mian was taken aback by him. He hadn't remembered to speak yet and he watched the man go out and brought in a basin of water. He took a brand-new cloth towel from a rope tied behind the door and put it in the basin. Then, he also sat down at the edge of the bed with three fists distance

with Qin Mian and looked at the opposite wall with no expression, silence without utterance.

“Thank you.” Qin Mian thought to himself: truly airtight[3]. But despite their abnormal relationship, he had nothing to dislike this man so far. He didn’t say much and used the cloth towel to wash his face and hands. When he was about to pour the water out, the man took the basin and washed his face and hands silently.

Qin Mian was a little uncomfortable. Two men share a washcloth....

“Have a meal.” After Lei Tie washed his face, he took the basin in one hand, stood up and looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian nodded and followed him out.

The man splashed the water on the corner of the wall and put the basin beside the well before he walked into the main house.

Qin Mian followed.

At this time, several people came in from the entrance door; men and women all dressed in ancient costumes, carrying farm tools, walking and talking at the same time. Those several people were followed by three small children.

Speaking of this, let’s talk about the Lei Family. The head of Lei Household Lei Daqiang was 40 year old and married to Du Shi[4], 38 year old. The eldest child of Lei Family Lei Tie was 22 year old and his wife was precisely Qin Mian, only 14 year old. The second child Lei Xiangren was 21 year old and his wife was Zhao Shi with his eldest son Lei Dabao was 5 year old and his youngest son Lei Xiaobao was 3 year old. The third child Lei Xiangyi was 19 year old and married to Qian Shi and had a daughter named Lei Xinxin, 2 year old. The fourth child Lei Xiangli was 17 year old and had not married yet. The fifth children were twins Lei Xiangzhi and the only daughter Lei Chuntao, 15 year old.

At this time, it was precisely Lei Daqiang and the others who came in. Except for Lei Xiangzhi, others were there.

Lei Xiangren put down the farm tools and upon seeing that Qin Mian's face looked a little strange, he called out "eldest sister-in-law".

Qin Mian, who had just transmigrated, was feeling uneasy. Afraid to be seen abnormal, he did not look at them carefully and only vaguely nodded. Now that he had transmigrated, it was impossible to transmigrate back. He had some ideas in mind. No one knew that he had a magical space. As long as there was this magical space, with his wit, it was not a problem to live a good life. But at the moment, all he could do was to remain calm.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi went to the well to draw water for the men to wash. While drawing water, they talked in low voices, with a strange smile on their faces and consciously or unconsciously, their eyes also drifted to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian didn't care. There were two old-fashioned square tables for eight people in the main hall. Seeing Lei Tie sitting at one table, he went to sit on the empty seat beside him and secretly took note of Lei Tie's reaction.

Lei Tie glanced at this out-of-ordinary wife of his. He had no expression but there was a little unexpected in his eyes, yet he didn't say anything.

"Second family's[5] and third family's, still haven't come in to help?" When Du Shi came out of the kitchen and saw Zhao Shi and Qian Shi chatting there, she was furious that she shouted coldly with arms akimbo.

"Coming!" Zhao Shi and Qian Shi immediately put away their smiles and sped up washing their hands.

A while later, all the people outside came in after they had washed up. Upon seeing Qin Mian sitting at the men's side, their footsteps faltered at the same time and they looked at each other in dismay.

Father Lei didn't speak as he went to sit down at the seat of honor. As a matter of fact, he was only in his early 40s, but he looked very old because

of the hard work all year round; he looked like he was 60 year old.

When the few men saw that their father didn't speak, they also took their seats at the table where Qin Mian was sitting.

After a moment, Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi came in with their meals.

As soon as Du Shi saw Qin Mian, her face changed. Restraining her displeasure, she motioned to the other table: "Eldest's [wife], are you confused? Your seat is here."

Both Zhao Shi and Qian Shi wore a face like watching a show. It was enough for them to be happy when the eldest son married a man as his wife, whom after just a few days of marriage had started to work with mother-in-law, which gave them a topic to talk for several days.

Lei Chuntao's eyebrows wrinkled. She took a dish from Du Shi's hands and put it on the table. When she went to pick up another dish, Du Shi did not let go. She looked up; her mother's face was taut and her eyes were full of anger as she stared at the eldest [male] sister-in-law, as if wishing her eyes could be turned into two needles to poke him a few times.

Qin Mian saw that the other table was full of women and children. He laughed in his heart. Without changing his expression or talk, he turned to look at the man beside him to see how he would react.

This man's attitude would determine the direction of his future plans.

Lei Tie didn't look at the person beside him, but he pressed the other person's leg, not letting him get up. He said dully and succinctly: "My wife will sit here henceforth."

Du Shi put on a straight face and slammed the dish on the table with all her strength.

Qin Mian thought to himself that this plate was still very strong that it hadn't broken under such strength.

Du Shi's allowed no doubt as she said: "How can this work? All the daughters-in-law are sitting at that table; no matter which family, the rules are the same. You come here, Eldest's [wife]."

Lei Tie didn't loosen his hand, dully but determined: "Just sit here."

"Mother, between the sexes there should be a prudent reserve. Isn't it embarrassing for them if I were to sit there? There is even a girl[6]." Qin Mian pushed away Lei Tie's hand and smiled at the old woman. He didn't know which dynasty this was, so he didn't dare to say "men and women with seven years different could not be seated and eat together". That little girl didn't have her hair bound, so he knew that she was not married.

Du Shi's face was red with anger. The reason why she let the Eldest's [wife] and the other two daughters-in-law sit together was to straighten him out, but she forgot that her daughter had reached the age of marriage. Although Eldest's [wife] was a "sister-in-law", he was a man after all. Thinking of this, though she was angry, she couldn't say anything against it. She only gave Qin Mian a fierce look when people didn't pay attention.

She looked at the plate of steamed buns in her hand that was going to be sent to the big table (the table where the men were sitting). She wanted to put two less but was afraid that the few of the family's labor forces would not eat enough, so she had to give up. She then hated Qin Mian even more.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were secretly disappointed that they didn't see a good show and they were a little puzzled. The other day, "eldest sister-in-law" looked timid and cowardly. Today, he was calm and dared to talk back to Du Shi. Remarkable ah. Was this relying on Eldest's support?

Note:

[1] the labouring people's townwear, with Chinese-style jacket and trousers. The jacket has slit on both side, with narrow sleeves

[2]老大lǎo dà = eldest child in a family. I just short form it into Eldest. It can be Old One, Old First just like Old Two or Old Three.

[3] I think QM refer to LT being too silent, like his lips was sealed tightly

[4] Shi is clan name; maiden name. For example: the mother's maiden surname is Du. Basically, the author didn't give some characters a specific names, only the maiden names.

[5] Du Shi called her daughters-in-law 老大家的 [lao da jiade]; 老二家的 [lao er jiade]; 老三家的 [lao san jiade]. Only referencing them to which Lei children's family they belong to.

[6] 姑娘 gū niang = [unmarried] girl; young woman; young lady; daughter

Chapter 003: Magical Space

“Enough, I’m hungry.” Lei Daqiang thumped the table with his hand and spoke.

Du Shi was very gentle when she spoke to Lei Daqiang: “Then I won’t say. Let’s eat.”

Qin Mian looked at the table with a plate of steamed buns and a pot of vegetable soup that was so clear that he could hardly see grease on the surface. Although he had expected that the living standards of ancient peasants could not be too high, he was surprised.

While he was still in a daze, each of the men had taken a steamed bun and ate it with a big bite. They ate very fast where they took only two or three bites of the steamed bun before they went to get the second one.

Suddenly, a steamed bun was stuffed in his hand and Qin Mian turned to Lei Tie. Lei Tie didn’t look at him but ate the steamed bun in silence. Qin Mian watched other people devour like wolves but this man beside him, though eating fast, hardly looked conspicuously vulgar. Once again, Qin Mian felt out of sort at the bottom of his heart.

He turned to the other table. The women ate the same things as this one, but the soup was thinner with only a few clear vegetables floating in it.

The stomach tightened again. Qin Mian took a bite of the steamed bun and frowned. He was not a man who couldn’t bear hardships. When he lived with his maternal grandparents, he usually ate less steamed cornbread or steamed bun and even steamed filled bun for breakfast. Later, life became a bit easier when Qin Shiyuan received Qin Family’s livelihood. On top of that, he inadvertently obtained a space for planting and began to like

studying and exploring gourmet food. Afterwards, when he graduated, he became a photographer of food program. Still, he didn't know how this steamed bun was made. It's very rough enough to scrap his throat.

Yet, he continued to eat the steamed bun and drink a bowl of soup, which then made his stomach more comfortable.

After eating breakfast peacefully, Lei Daqiang began to arrange today's work for the labor forces in the family. Now it's the time when the weeds were growing crazily and the grass in the rice field should be pulled out. Du Shi arranged work for the daughters-in-law: Zhao Shi carried water and vegetables, Qian Shi cut grass and fed pigs, Qin Shi went up the mountain to cut firewood and she herself took care of the children at home. As for Lei Chuntao, this girl needed to be pampered so she could find a good family to marry. Now the sun was high, she couldn't go out to be basked in the sun and only needed to embroider in the room.

"My wife has to take a rest." Lei Tie began.

Du Shi's face was black again and she said stiffly: "As someone from a pheasant family, how can he be so fragile? How many days has he been off duty? The work at home has been delayed."

Qin Mian was very clear about this. He himself was not familiar with this place and could not leave Lei's house for the time being, so he could not quarrel with Du Shi now. Just as he was about to respond, Lei Tie said again: "He has to rest."

Ignoring Du Shi, Lei Tie then led Qin Mian into the thatched cottage, closed the door and left.

Du Shi's eyes were red as she looked at Lei Daqiang. "Family Head, look at Eldest. He married a wife and forgot his mother..."

Lei Daqiang watched Lei Tie pick up a carrying pole and go out of the entrance door without looking back, his brows creased. "Let it go. The health of Eldest's [wife] is really not good now. Give him two days."

Du Shi however, obeyed Lei Daqiang. Although she was not comfortable with it, she didn't say anything more. She comforted herself that when Eldest's [wife] was well, he could do more work. Thinking of this, she no longer insisted. Then, she saw the other two daughters-in-law standing there doing nothing and she was filled with anger. Her eyes were round, her face looked cold and she didn't talk. But the anger at the bottom of her eyes was like a fierce wind blowing towards Zhao and Qian.

Zhao and Qian hurriedly took the farm tools they needed to use and walked out of the courtyard.

Qin Mian stayed in the thatched cottage and be at ease after he listened to the silence in the yard. He expressed a few thanks to Lei Tie before he inserted the latch. Then, he shook the quilt, took out some clothes and two pillows from the wooden box, stuffed them under the quilt and made them look like someone was lying in it. Afterwards, he got into the quilt and entered the space. It was no wonder he was so cautious because the cottage was too dilapidated and full of tiny cracks. It's easy to peek in. The space was a heaven-defying existence, so he must be very careful not to let anyone find its existence.

In the ordinary course of events, if he changed his body, the space would not follow him, but maybe it was because after it recognized the owner with blood, the space was integrated with his soul, so it also followed him.

In the beginning, he was able to obtain the space was truly by chance and odd. One night, he was in a depressed mood. After drinking a little wine, he went out for a walk to sober up and accidentally saw two men killing a black dog in a small forest. There were several vertical and horizontal bloodstains on the dog as it curled up on the ground and whimpered, enduring the pain and sorrow. It was very miserable. So, he ran over angrily, took out his cell phone and threatened the two men that he had already reported them to the police. The two men were little ruffians less than 20 year old. They were scared by him and ran away.

The dog looked very weak. He didn't have any experience in dealing with the dog's injuries. He didn't dare to move it at will. Thus, he called a veterinary clinic and asked them to send someone to deal with it. At the

same time, he stroked the black dog's head to comfort it as he said to it that someone would come to save it immediately.

The black dog looked at him, whined twice before it stood up with difficulty and licked the palm of his hand. Then, it opened its mouth, spit out a maroon jade ring before it limped away.

He drank wine at that time, so his brain was still a little fuzzy. He was blank for a long time before he sobered up with a gust of wind and even thought he had hallucinations just now. But when he looked at the palm of his hand, he *did* have a jade ring.

He was surprised and hurried to look for the black dog but the black dog had disappeared.

It was very strange. Moreover, the black dog obviously understood human and was harmless. It not only left the jade ring but also put it on his hand in cherish manner.

Later in 2012, eschatology[1] was very popular and eschatology novels emerged in an endless stream. When he was bored, he read a few books and was very interested in the portable space and that the space of the protagonists in many novels was inadvertently triggered by dripping blood onto an ancient object. Therefore, he cut his finger and dropped the blood onto the ring. Unexpectedly, it really opened a mystical space!

Note:

[1] a part of theology concerned with death, judgement, and the final destiny of the soul and of humankind.

Chapter 004: Evil Mother-in-law

Ah...

The ring turned into a small mole and appeared on Qin Mian's left wrist. The current Qin Mian also had the exact small mole on his left wrist. Maybe it was a coincidence or maybe there was some mysterious reason, but Qin Mian didn't care. What's important was that he still had this space.

The space was a small world of its own, with mountains, water, rising sun and setting sun, as well as a classical courtyard. In particular, there was a spiritual spring in the space. Qin Mian didn't know where the spring came from, but he was sure that there was no end to it. The water of the spiritual spring had a wonderful effect. After drinking spiritual spring water, his body had always been healthy and good. The vegetables and fruits watered with the spiritual spring water were all in good form and tasted very good that it was unimaginable how many times better than the vegetables sold outside.

Because 2012 was theorized to be The Doomsday, Qin Mian collected a lot of materials to be stored in the space, including food, clothing, useful items etc. and not only that, but also raised a few chickens and ducks, planted a variety of vegetables and fruits, and even a few field of rice and wheat. It's more reassuring to grow one's own food. It's also because Qin Shiyuan gave him 5 million yuan in order to compensate him that he had the capital to squander for these things.

Now, although he transmigrated, but with these materials, he was confident that he would have a good life. There was also a strange thing in this space where it could form a 'heartstrings knot'. When he found a person who he would mutually love in the future, he could share this space with her, live

and die together. Even in this backward ancient era, they could live a beautiful life.

After drinking a glass of spring water and watering the unknown flower bud in the flower bed behind the house as usual, Qin Mian left the space. Now that he was in a strange place, he tried to stay in the space as little as possible and if he couldn't go in, then he couldn't go in.

He stayed in the room until he heard Du Shi saying to Lei Chuntao that she would prepare meal. He got up and went to the kitchen to help light the fire.

Du Shi still didn't have a good face for Qin Mian and he also didn't care. He could not be hurt even if she stared at him. He even waited for Du Shi's words to reveal some information about this space-time.

"Eldest's [wife]." As soon as Du Shi saw his '*clouds were light and windy*' appearance, she was annoyed. "Since you are married to Lei Family, don't be lazy all day long! It's your blessing that Eldest loves you dearly, but you can't want a mile after win an inch just because of it and unable to recognize others' good intentions! You understand?" She used the spatula to vigorously turn the dish in the wok. The spatula knocked and banged on the wok, as if the wok was regarded as Qin Mian. Even if she turned the dish fast enough, the dish in the wok still very quickly emitted scorched smell.

"Or are you against me or something! Are you trying to make the fire big?" Du Shi abruptly used the spatula to hit on the kitchen stove and stared at Qin Mian coldly: "Do you want to burn the wok through or don't want to let the family eat? Ah?"

Qin Mian was speechless for a while. *In the first place, fried eggplants need more oil but you only used a spoon to drop a few drops of oil, it will be strange if it doesn't scorched.* Doing was wrong, not doing was also wrong. He understood that Du Shi was not pleased with him. He became more and more confused. *In this case, how could she agree for Lei Tie to marry Qin Mian?*

"If you[1] don't salvage this dish, it really won't be edible. I'll go see if they're back." After that, Qin Mian stood up and left.

Without waiting for Du Shi's response, he went straight out of the yard. For a moment, he really had the urge to leave, but reason quickly convinced him. His health was not good and he was only a teenager; how far could he go even if he leaves? He could stay in the space until he gained a good health, but he knew nothing about this world and if there was any taboo or someone discovered the existence of the space, he had no choice but to die. There was also the problem of household registration. He would become a black household after leaving in this way. It was unknown how much trouble he would have in the future. He was most worried about whether there was any special reason for the original body's owner to get married with that man. If he ran away, would that lead the Lei Family to chase him down?

Not far out, a group of people came across while talking and laughing. It happened to be Lei Daqiang and the others.

Qin Mian hesitated for a moment and stood by the side of the road waiting for them.

Lei Tie saw the child from afar and walked two steps quickly before soon came to him while looking at him with questioning eyes.

Qin Mian didn't know what his 'questioning' meant. He simply shook his head and smiled at the approaching Father Lei.

"Dad, you are all back. I was going to call you all back to have meal."

"Um." Father Lei replied simply.

Lei Xiangren and the others called out "eldest sister-in-law".

Qin Mian nodded as before.

Behind them were several villagers who had also finished their farm work and returned home. They looked at Qin Mian strangely and smiled vaguely before they walked to another path.

Qin Mian stealthily pulled Lei Tie's arm. When Lei Daqiang and the others went in, he let go. "I have something to talk with you."

Lei Tie hinted for them to go inside to talk.

Just after the two entered the thatched cottage, Du Shi shrieked: "Eldest's [wife]! Where are you running to goof off again?"

Qin Mian sighed. "Forget it. We'll talk at night." He didn't believe that the old lady would be tied in front of him after dark!

Lei Tie watched him walk out of the door as he stood still with his thoughts unknown, before he went out after a while.

Note:

[1] Said in polite term. Keep in mind the younger generation used polite 'you' to address their elders

Chapter 005: Reason

When the Lei Family finished their dinner, it was not completely dark. The shadow of the house and trees were made into dim silhouettes by the remnant sunlight. All peasant families were like this; they tried to eat dinner before dusk, so that they could save some lamp's oil.

Qin Mian, Zhao and Qian washed the dishes and cleaned the kitchen under Du Shi's hostile eyes.

When he came out of the kitchen, he saw that Lei Tie took a dark brown wooden basin to draw water from the well. Qin Mian was afraid that the man would wash his feet with him, so he rushed to the well and scooped a ladle of cold water from the bucket with a wooden ladle and poured it directly onto his feet. After he washed his feet once through, he looked at Lei Tie dully for fear that the man could not see his estrangement towards him, but inwardly, he shivered. The water in the well he had just drawn was not cold in general, but his heart was chilled.

Lei Tie paused before he bowed to draw water, still without expression as before.

Qin Mian went back to the thatched cottage. The sandals were wet and uncomfortable. He simply took them off and let his feet dry naturally. There was no small seat, so he sat down on the edge of the bed. The inside of the room was very dark and the light from the outside came in through some big or small gaps on the wall, which appeared very miserable. Qin Mian saw an oil lamp on the low table at the head of the bed but he didn't know how to light it, so he didn't touch it.

In a moment, Lei Tie came in.

Qin Mian asked in a low voice: “Is there anyone else outside?”

Lei Tie didn’t know what he meant but shook his head, walked in and sat down on the bed.

Qin Mian thought for a moment before he said directly: “I don’t know what happened. I don’t remember anything before. Can you tell me who I am and why I married you? We are both men.”

Lei Tie turned and looked at him in surprise.

Qin Mian looked straight at him with a calm face.

“You are my wife. I’m Li Tie. Go to sleep.” Lei Tie got on the bed first and lay down on the outer side.

“I’m a man!” Qin Mian was a little anxious and asked: “How did I get married with you? Why did my family marry me off to a man?”

Lei Tie didn’t speak. The room was too dark that Qin Mian couldn’t see his expression.

“You are my wife.” After Lei Tie finished talking, no matter how Qin Mian asked, he never opened his mouth again and his breath was long and steady, as if he was asleep.

It’s no use worrying, so Qin Mian stayed very calm and blankly sat for a while. When a cold wind blew, he shivered and crawled to the inside of the bed to lie down. At least one more thing to be thankful for now: Lei Tie did not force him to exercise the rights and obligations of ‘husband and wife’. Pooh-pooh![1]

Qin Mian shook his head and drove away the appalling thought. After hesitating, he dragged the only quilt which covered Lei Tie to him. The body temperature beside him was like a warm stove. It’s hard for him to ignore it. He simply didn’t want to think about it anymore and intended to have a good sleep. After dawn, he must try to find ways to ask about. He lay down very much at ease. According to his estimation, this body was at most

12 years old, still a child. In every case, Lei Tie shouldn't be a brutal person to really treat him like *that*.

.....

After two days, Qin Mian finally knew his current situation. As soon as he transmigrated, he went through different time and space. Now he was in the Great Xia Dynasty and lived in Green Mountain Village of Running Water Town.

He was also very clear about the Lei Family. Lei Tie and Lei Xiangren siblings were born of the same father. Lei Tie's biological mother died in childbirth when she was giving birth to Lei Tie. Six months later, Lei Daqiang married to a second wife, which was Du Shi. The Lei Family had one more son who was only a few minutes older than Lei Chuntao. He studied in the town's private school and came back every few days. Qin Mian had not met him yet.

It's a coincidence that the original owner of this body was also called Qin Mian and in was true that there's some inside story about him marrying Lei Tie. Speaking of this, he had to say that Lei Tie was very pitiful. When Du Shi just married in, she was pretty good to Lei Tie. But when she had her own children, she was not happy with Lei Tie. If she was a little dissatisfied, she would either beat or scold him. As the saying goes; where there's a stepmother, there would be a stepfather. Du Shi said something bad about Lei Tie from time to time and gradually swindled Lei Daqiang to not care much about Lei Tie. When Lei Tie was 12 years old, Du Shi urged Lei Daqiang to sell Lei Tie to a rich family as a manservant. Lei Tie couldn't bear it and left home quietly. It was almost ten years ago. He came back less than a month ago with an ugly scar on his face. It was unknown what happened to him outside. The family asked and the villagers also asked, yet they couldn't get an answer.

After all, it's his child. Eldest was old enough and his two younger brothers were married. It's no excuse for Eldest not to marry. Lei Daqiang then pondered how to talk to Lei Tie about his marriage. However, with a scar on the face of a straight and handsome man, which girl could fancy him? This matter then had been dragging on continuously.

Until one day, an old fortune teller came to the village and simply said that Lei Tie's predestined person was a 14-year-old boy who would appear in the woods in the west of the village at a certain time on a certain day, a certain year! If the two of them were united, they would enjoy endless glory, splendor, wealth and rank, and even be a blessing to the whole village. But if Lei Tie married someone else, then the Lei Family would be faced with imminent disaster and the calamity even befell on the descendent.

As he listened up to here, Qin Mian's first thought was that this fortune teller must have been invited by someone who didn't like Lei Tie.

The talk resumed. As soon as the fortune teller's words were out, the Lei family members all turned pale. They'd rather believe it than not! On that day, Lei Daqiang took Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi to the forest where the fortune teller had mentioned and they didn't expect to really see a teenager there!

The boy was dressed in rags, lying on the ground, unconscious.

The trio hesitated for a moment before they took the boy home.

When the teenager woke up, he only said his name was Qin Mian and he had escaped from a remote town. Other than that, he shook his head in answer to all questions.

Because Lei Tie had been away from home for many years, Lei Daqiang felt a little guilty towards him and didn't really plan to let him marry this teenager. It's not a big deal to raise this picked up child. Should that be able to withstand the disaster?

However, he couldn't bear Du Shi making tearful scene in front of him, saying that it didn't matter for two old people to be implicated by Lei Tie. Even if they lost their lives, it didn't matter. But they couldn't kill their other children because of one Lei Tie, right? In particular, Lei Xiangyi had no son, Lei Xiangli had not married and Lei Xiangzhi needed to study, which perhaps could become an official and glorified his ancestors in the future, as well as their only daughter, who had yet set a matchmaker.

In this way, Lei Daqiang relented and had Lei Tie married Qin Mian.

Qin Mian was ill and homeless. If he didn't agree to marry Lei Tie, he would be driven away. Thus, he could only agree.

Note:

[1] Spit in contempt

Chapter 006: Want to Divide up Family Property and Live Apart

006 – Want to Divide up Family Property and Live Apart

After marriage, his household registration naturally transferred to Lei Family.

Until now, they had only been married for a few days.

Qin Mian had even heard another thing, which made his heart sink to the bottom. The fact that the two men married had spread throughout the county and it was unknown whether it had spread further. Men and women together was the right way, but there were two men in Green Mountain Village who had become a married couple; would not this be object of ridicule to others? That was to say, even if he left Lei Tie now, his reputation would be ruined. It was impossible for him to find a wife near here. Which family's parents would like to marry their daughter to someone who once married a man?

To divorce¹ Lei Tie, namely “harmonious divorce”, was imminent.

During the day, Du *Shi* tried various devices to make Qin Mian and Lei Tie work. Only in the evening could he have a chance to talk to Lei Tie. That night, after Lei Tie finished washing, Qin Mian said tentatively, “In fact, you and I were forced to get married. You wanted to marry a wife, I mean, you wanted to marry a normal wife to live a good life, right?”

“You *are* my wife.” Lei Tie looked at him and didn't seem to understand why the other person said these words.

For a period of time, Qin Mian was burning with suppressed anger; could that mean he was abnormal? He tried to be calm and patient: "I mean, you wanted to marry a wife who can have children, don't you?"

"No need." Lei Tie took off the straw shoes as he said simply and matter-factly.

Qin Mian didn't know if he really didn't understand or pretended not to. Without any better option, he straightforwardly said, "Let's harmoniously divorce."

Lei Tie suddenly turned back and stared at him for a moment. "I will not harmoniously divorce."

After that, he went to bed just like last time.

Qin Mian was shocked and thought with horror: could it be that Lei Tie like men originally? But that didn't make sense. He used to look in the mirror in the space and right now, he was not good-looking at all. He was black, thin, and shriveled. Besides, he was still currently a child. Even if Lei Tie liked men, it was impossible to like him (QM).

In any case, Lei Tie didn't agree to harmoniously divorce, so he couldn't help it. As long as his household registration was still under the Lei Family, he couldn't get away. As he had heard from Brother Zhang in the village, this country's management of household registration was quite strict. If one started another one, it would not only need a lot of money, but also a connection. Even if there was money, without the right connection, there was no way. Could it be possibly hard to be an unregistered household all the time?

Qin Mian reluctantly admitted: he had better to stay at Lei Household.

Since Qin Mian decided to stay, he combed the situation of the Lei Family. The conditions of Lei Family were average in the village. The main house was made of brick, sat in the south and faced north. There were six rooms in total: the room at the entrance was a main hall and also the place to eat; Lei Daqiang and wife were in one room; Lei Xiangren's family was in one

room; Lei Xiangyi's family was in one room; Lei Xiangzhi was a scholar, so he enjoyed a room alone; and the last room was divided into two parts for Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao.

Outside the main house was the courtyard. In the northwest corner was the kitchen, in the right corner was a well, and in the east was a pigsty near the entrance gate. There was a space between the pigsty to put some farming tools and other things. When Lei Tie came back later, there was no place for him, so he had to build a thatched cottage in the southwest corner of the yard. First of all, there was the problem of pigsty on the opposite side of the thatched cottage. Now, the thatched cottage could block the wind at most. Once the weather turned colder, it might not work. Moreover, when it rained and snowed, who knew if one could live in it? *Very pitiful ah.*

Qin Mian felt a little exasperation for Lei Tie. Why didn't Lei Tie want to do anything about it when the Lei Family bullies him such? Since he was a person who had wandered outside, shouldn't he have some insight at least?

It would be good if they could move out. On one hand, it would be more conducive for him to persuade Lei Tie to harmoniously divorce without the interference of other Lei members; on the other hand, it would be more comfortable managing his own life.

Oddly enough, Du *Shi* hated Lei Tie very much, but why didn't she encourage Lei Daqiang to make Lei Tie move out?

"Lei Tie's wife, be careful!"

All of a sudden, there was an urgent warning in his ears. Qin Mian quivered, subconsciously threw away the thing he had in his hand, and stepped back quickly—he suddenly remembered that he was cutting firewood. Just now, the axe cut down empty air; he almost gotten hurt.

A rough man in his early thirties came quickly and looked at him up and down with deep concern. The man carried a basket on his back with an old axe in it.

"Are you alright?"

“I’m alright. Thank you, Brother Zhang.” Qin Mian sincerely thanked him. Basically, all the news he heard came from this man, Zhang Dashuan. In recent days, apart from the Lei Family, he had met more than ten people. Only Zhang Dashuan and his wife, Sister Chunhua, had a normal attitude toward him. When other people see him, they either looked scornful or avoided him as if they were avoiding the plague.

In Zhang Dashuan’s eyes, Qin Mian was a child, a few years older than his son. Seeing that he was really alright, he casually asked, “What were you thinking to look so distracted?” As he said, he put down the carrying pole, picked up the axe, and cut down a tree. As soon as the axe went down, a deep trace appeared on the half-withered, arm-thick tree. The autumn harvest was coming soon; the farmers would have more chores during this period.

Qin Mian thought about it and said truthfully, “I’m thinking, since Mother doesn’t like me and Lei Tie, why don’t we live apart from them? As far as I know, isn’t the Liu Family also living apart?”

THUMP. The small tree was cut down and Zhang Dashuan continued to cut with his axe. It was easier to dry woods by cutting them into small pieces. The sound of slamming scared away the birds on the trees and made the leaves rattle.

“It’s impossible for your family in this short time.” As Zhang Dashuan cut wood, he jokingly said, “You and Tiezi had just gotten married. If she split with you guys, wouldn’t she be afraid of the villagers stabbing her backbone? Besides, Tiezi is the eldest of the Lei Family. Even if you guys live apart, in principal, you and Tiezi would have to raise the two oldies.”

Huh? Qin Mian was dumbfounded.

Behind them came the sound of branches swaying; the two turned around.

Lei Tie walked up with his big bow on his left shoulder and a deer on his right shoulder. The deer, weighing at least 50~60 jin², hung motionless on his body.

“Tiezi, what a good luck! Such a big livestock may have sold for a lot of money or you can eat it for a long time if keeps for yourself.” Zhang Dashuan said to Lei Tie with a smile as he glanced at the deer enviously.

Qin Mian stared at the deer and couldn’t help licking his lips. He craved meat. However, he knew that even if Lei Tie hit the prey, the meat wouldn’t be eaten. Du *Shi* was a penny-pincher, who usually even begrudged stir-frying vegetables, let alone meat. Even the eggs were only cooked for her two baby grandsons and her only daughter. Others, including Lei Xinxin, who was only two years old, couldn’t even think about it. There were actually meat and eggs in his house [in the space], but he had no chance to cook them.

Lei Tie nodded to Zhang Dashuan as he walked to Qin Mian. He stopped and took out a thing from his inner breast-pocket, which was wrapped in a green lotus leaf that permeated a faint smell of meat, making Qin Mian swallowed his saliva secretly.

Zhang Dashuan faintly smiled at Qin Mian and continued to cut wood.

Qin Mian struggled for a moment before picking up the lotus leaf wrapper. “Thank you.” Once he opened the lotus leaf, inside was a roast chicken drumstick, which was still slightly hot.

Lei Tie put down the prey and the bow. Then, he picked up the axe and went to one side to cut wood. When he moved his arms, the muscles on his shoulder were prominently strong and powerful.

The baskets that had only four blocks of firewood previously were gradually piled up.

Qin Mian finished eating the drumstick, feeling that it was better than any other chicken drumstick he had ever eaten.

Almost at the same time as he finished chewing the chicken drumstick, Lei Tie stood up. Between the two baskets Qin Mian brought, one was full of firewood. Lei Tie put the axe, prey, and bow into the other basket and picked them up with the carrying pole.

Qin Mian's feeling was a little subtle. Why did he feel that Lei Tie cutting the wood was just to wait for him to finish eating the drumstick?

"Brother Zhang, we'll go first." Lei Tie said to Zhang Dashuan.

Zhang Dashuan waved his hand. "Aye, alright. I'll chop some more before I get back."

Chapter 007: Prey Dispute

007 – Prey Dispute

Qin Mian licked his lips, trying not to leave a trace of grease. Looking at his clothes, he chose to wipe his mouth with the lotus leaf. When he assumed there was no more grease on his mouth, he discarded the lotus leaf.

Lei Tie took notice of his movements and pursed his lower lip as his eyes wavered for a moment.

At sunset, the yellow sunlight was projected through the clouds; the clouds were dyed into bright and dark colors, as if they had been rendered by colored pigments. The water in the pond also reflected the tangerine yellow as it drifting care-freely and rippling flourishingly. A flock of birds flew across the sky, leaving behind a crisp song. The busy people in the field walked back quickly to their homes before dark. They could have a good rest at home after finishing their work. Only the naughty children, unaware of worry, was playing chase in the field. They laughed happily from time to time. Even if they fell carelessly, they didn't care and got up happily to continue the game. A few native dogs, as if complying orders, ran along with their tails wagging lively.

Lei Tie didn't like to talk and Qin Mian didn't talk to him either. He looked at his bow. The bow body was gray, which he didn't know what kind of wood it was made of, but looked particularly sturdy, sleek, and shiny. It must have been wiped and maintained frequently, which meant it was cherished by the owner. The quiver was made of grey cloth and there were ten arrows in it, clean as pins.

“Oh, the young couple going home together, really affectionate ah.” From the field path came a woman in her 40s, dressed in a thorn hairpin and a

coarse skirt[en_note]the simple dress of a woman; a poor housewife; have only a thorn for a hairpin and plain cloth for a skirt[/efn_note], with a hoe on her shoulder, smiling at Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The periphery of her eyes lingered on the deer in the basket for a while.

Qin Mian could clearly see that this woman looked kind, but her contempt was not hidden.

The woman continued, “Such a big one ah. Your family won’t have to worry about meat for ten and a half days. Little Brother Qin, you just arrived at Lei Household, don’t you know? Your mother-in-law’s cooking is one of the best in our village! You get the luck for chancing upon fine food tonight.”

Walking not far behind the woman, another woman, carrying a basket of vegetables and covering her mouth, began to smile with an unclear meaning, “Eldest Liu’s wife, why jeering at them? Who in our village doesn’t know that Sister Lei keeps her home hardworking and thrifty?”

Lei Tie turned a deaf ear as he walked neither too fast nor too slow as before.

Qin Mian sighed inwardly and quickened his pace.

When they entered the house, Du *Shi* was about to go outside. She stopped, glanced at the basket, and when she saw the prey, she looked pleased, but when she saw the firewood in the other basket, her face darkened.

“Eldest’s wife, you cut so little firewood this whole afternoon?”

Qin Mian went to stand behind Lei Tie. “Mother, I’m a small person, I don’t have the strength. Please excuse me.”

“If I excuse you, who is going to excuse me? No dinner for you night! Each and every one never attaches importance to me.” When Du *Shi*’s eyes fell on the deer again, her tone to Lei Tie was slightly eased up, “Eldest, you take this thing to be dealt with.”

“Eldest Brother, you’re back.” A coarse-clothed man stepped out from the inside and looked at the deer with a happy face. His pair of triangular eyes twinkled gloriously and there were two inconspicuous lines on the corner of the eyes. “Such a big one; we can have meat tonight. Mother, how about stewed potatoes with venison for dinner?”

Lei Xiangren was only one year younger than Lei Tie, but he looked five years older than Lei Tie. Lei Xiangyi also looked older than Lei Tie. If the three of them walked outside together, people who didn’t know would surely think that Lei Tie was the younger brother of the two. This was one of the reasons why Qin Mian always felt there was something out of sorts about Lei Tie. He was curious about the ten years that Lei Tie had left home.

Inside, Zhao *Shi* heard the sound of people talking and walked out quickly. She smiled and held Du *Shi*’s arm, seemingly very close, “Mother, we get the luck for chancing upon fine food then. The stew made by Mother is always delicious. When I think of the stew of wild boar with radish made by Mother after I gave birth to Xiaobao, your daughter-in-law is already drooling.”

Qin Mian nearly choked with laughter. These words, weren’t they meant to say that the Lei Family hadn’t eaten meat for a long time?

In the kitchen, Qian *Shi*, who was cooking, glanced at Zhao *Shi* from the crack in the window. She sneered scornfully and mumbled under her breath, “It’d be a wonder if we can eat it.”

Lei Xiangyi, who had just come in, happened to hear Zhao *Shi*’s words. He looked at Du *Shi* with expectation. He was tired of eating vegetables, radishes, and sweet potatoes all day long.

“Eat what?” Du *Shi* glared at Zhao *Shi* fiercely and allowed no doubt as she said, “This will be preserved until the autumn harvest.”

Then, Lei Tie took the chance to speak up, “Selling it tomorrow morning.” After that, regardless of other people’s reaction, he put the carrying pole aside and took the deer to the well.

Du *Shi*, Lei Xiangren, and the others were stunned speechless.

Lei Xiangyi didn't care about it very much and so he directly entered the house.

"Eldest," Du *Shi* walked over to him, "the autumn harvest is coming soon. We need a lot of fat¹. Keep the deer and then we won't have to spend any more money on meat. Listen to Mother, let's keep the meat."

Lei Tie squatted by the well, took out a knife from nowhere, and cut the deer's belly neatly, preparing to skin it. He still used the same words, "Selling it tomorrow morning."

Qin Mian was waiting to see a drama. Although he only got along with Lei Tie for a few days, he had seen Lei Tie's unique personality; as long as it was something decided by him, it was hard to change. What would Du *Shi* do?

"Eldest Brother-in-law, why do you have to fight against Mother? Mother is angry." Zhao *Shi* said reproachfully, "Why do you have to sell the meat?"

"Little Mian and I need more clothes." Lei Tie replied in a light voice while his hands kept moving. The smell of deer blood filled the whole yard.

Du *Shi* suddenly turned her head.

Qin Mian internally said, *not good*.

"Excellent!" Du *Shi* stepped up to him in two steps, pointed to his nose as she shouted. She was so angered that her eyes seemed about to pop out, as if she had been wronged by Heaven. "I say, why Eldest is so stingy all of a sudden? It turns out that you instigated it in the back! Qin *Shi*, are you intentionally making us, mother and son be at odds?"

"I didn't, it's none of my business." Qin Mian slickly dodged to Lei Tie and used him as a shield. He was not half sorry about doing this. His inter monologue: *Who ask you to disagree to harmoniously divorce?*

It was not that he couldn't deal with Du *Shi*, but the word "filial piety" killed people. If he really contradicted Du *Shi* or did something to Du *Shi*, it wouldn't be just the Lei Family, but perhaps the whole village couldn't accommodate him. To deal with Du *Shi*, he had to think about something else.

"Didn't?" Du *Shi* stormed over aggressively, "Didn't Eldest just say he wanted to give you more clothes? Had my Lei Family shortening your food or drink? Didn't know how to add clothes to you by then? You just can't see the whole family being polite and amiable, can't you? Eldest, you get out of the way!" Because of her temperament, she wasn't a bit patient and accommodating toward Lei Tie at all. But since Lei Tie left home, people in the village had been pointing fingers behind her. Xiangli hadn't been matched and Chuntao also hadn't been betrothed yet. For their reputations, she could only bear it. It was not good for her to make things hard for Lei Tie directly, so then Qin *Shi* became her point of attack.

Chapter 008: Divide up Family Property and Live Apart (1)

Du Shi chased to the left of Lei Tie and Qin Mian would hide to the right of Lei Tie. Since he began to drink the spiritual spring water, his body had already recovered to 80% and not only he became stronger, but his responsive rate also became higher.

From the beginning, Lei Chuntao didn't come out and stood by the window as she looked out. Since Qin Mian came to Lei Household, he had been gloomy and silent. This was her first time seeing his.... 'lively' look, which showed clearly that he deliberately teased mother. Seeing one escaped so easily and the other caught up so breathlessly, she didn't get angry, but thought it was funny as well as feeling helpless. Mother too, always tried to make life difficult for Qin Mian. Although she also felt uncomfortable about having a male sister-in-law, Qin Mian had already entered the family and could not leave because of the fortune teller's words. Since they're a family, wasn't better to be in harmonious than fighting every day?

"Stop for me!" Du Shi hated Qin Mian for not giving her a bit of face. She was angry and rushed to him, but Qin Mian still avoided her.

Lei Tie watched Qin Mian come and go nimbly, a glimmer of surprise and smile flashed in his eyes before it disappeared. He stood straight to protect the person behind him and faced Du Shi, "Mother, if the prey not to be sold, give two silver taels to buy clothes."

To take money out of Du Shi's hand was like plucking out her flesh. She stopped, took a breath and nonchalantly said: "It's easy to say, but where do I get the money? It's time for your fourth brother to marry a wife, have the betrothal gifts prepared? Your little sister hasn't been betrothed yet, but has

the dowry prepared? And your fifth brother doesn't need to spend money for school? Eldest, you have to be considerate toward mother, too."

Lei Tie once again said: "This prey will be sold tomorrow."

Du Shu's face was so gloomy that she could drip water. "What should we do for autumn harvest if you sold it? Forget it, you can sell it if you want, but I will deal with all the prey you hit in the future."

Lei Tie: "Talk about it later."

Du Shi wore a stony face as she furiously stormed into the house.

Lei Xiangren looked disappointed. He couldn't help but take another look at the venison and after a thought, he caught up with Du Shi, following her into the main room and closed the door.

"What are you doing lurking and sneaking around like a ghost?" Du Shi hit him hard on the arm and stared at him in rebuke.

"Mother, as long as you can calm down, your son will let you hit some more." Lei Xiangren smiled and stretched out his arm.

Du Shi was immediately amused by him, patted him lightly, "What are you doing following me in?" This was her first son, whom she loved dearly, how could she really hit him?

"Mother, have tea." Lei Xiangren took the teapot and poured her a cup of tea. He sat down beside her and lowered his voice for fear of being heard. "In fact, I've wanted to ask you for a long time. Since you don't like big brother, why don't you just make him move out and leave it go at that? You won't be upset if you don't see him." In fact, Du Shi found troubles for Qin Mian every day and he felt it was noisy. As soon as he returned home, he hardly had a quiet time.

"You don't think I want to?" Du Shi moodily said, "But there are so many places to spend money in our family. Eldest can work and also skilled in hunting. If I really make him move out, are you going to the work at home?"

Are you going to bear the expense burden of your two younger brothers and the only younger sister?"

Lei Xiangren quickly shook his head. "How can your son have such a great ability?"

"What's more, he's been away from home for ten years, so he should have some savings." Du Shi's tone was very plain, seemed as though she didn't care, but the mood of determination to win in her eyes revealed her mind.

Lei Xiangren was happy, but then he felt a bit unsure. "Didn't he give father twenty silver taels when he came back?"

"Heh, I don't believe that he only earned twenty silver taels in ten years. Taking out twenty silver taels in one shot, I see ——" Du Shi noticed that Lei Xiangren's eyeballs mulled about and she suddenly regretted telling him all these things. She waved her hand and stood up. "It's just my guess. Let's not talk about that. Go and see if dinner is ready."

Qin Mian didn't go to dinner. Du Shi said that he wouldn't be given dinner and so he didn't go. Otherwise, it would be another fighting. He disdained fighting with a woman every day and was too lazy to mind about her. If the worst came to the worst, he could secretly eat some snacks in the space.

When people didn't pay attention to him, he came out of the yard and wandered slowly into the distance. The sun would set, the sky in the West would be warm and yellow, the people in the field would come back home, the whole village would be quiet, which was suitable for him to think: what could he do to let Lei Daqiang and Du Shi take the initiative to make them move out?

There was no one on the road. Qin Mian trotted along the side of the road without hesitation. He ran for some distance and then ran back. While thinking about it, he exercised by the way. Running for half an hour and doing pushed ups for half an hour every day were bound to strengthen the body. He always thought that the body was at most 12 years old, but later he knew that it was actually 14 years old. At the age of 14, he was only about

1.3 meters tall, so now he was stunted. Fortunately, he was young, there was enough time to make up for it.

Qin Mian calmly analyzed. Although Lei Daqiang was the family head, he only cared about the works outside, and other things were basically managed by Du Shi. So the key to move out was Du Shi. There was no doubt that Du Shi held no feelings for Lei Tie. Qin Mian was sure that Du Shi also wanted to separate Lei Tie from this family. There must be other reasons why she didn't do that, besides being afraid of being gossiped by the villagers.

Excluding Lei Xiangzhi, whom Qin Mian had not met up to now, Lei Tie was the tallest and strongest of the four brothers in Lei Family. For peasants who relied on physical strength to eat, this was a strong and free labor force.

Besides, there was money. Qin Mian analyzed this point from Du Shi's saying: *I will deal with all the prey you hit in the future*. Qin Mian saw the deer. The arrow hit the deer's neck, killing it with one shot. This showed that Lei Tie's bow technique was very good and there would be no less prey from now to autumn harvest. No matter whether in modern or ancient times, meat would not be cheap and there must be a lot of money if sold. Du Shi wanted to keep all this in her hands, not for money. Why? Besides, there were three children in Lei Family who had not married. Betrothal gifts and dowry had always been valued in marriage, especially in ancient times. Lacked of betrothal gifts, whose family's girl was willing to marry? Lacked of dowry, the girl would have no confidence when she went to her mother-in-law's house. She might be looked down upon by others. Therefore, Qin Mian's analysis showed that Du Shi probably wanted to make money from Lei Tie as much as possible for Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao. Lei Tie gave more, while she gave less. Good schemes.

If he wanted Du Shi to take the initiative to divide up the family property and live apart, there were several ways....

Qin Mian's brain was spinning fast when his wrist was suddenly clenched tightly and a deep voice sounded in his ear.

“Where are you going?”

Chapter 009: Divide up Family Property and Live Apart (2)

Qin Mian looked back and saw Lei Tie stared at him tightly where his eyes kept Qin Mian motionless and he had a bowl in his right hand. The bowl was filled with sweet potato millet rice and there was a pair of chopsticks. The so-called sweet potato millet rice was exactly rice steamed with sweet potato and millet. Most of their recent staple foods were sweet potatoes, millet, rice and steamed bun. On top of the rice was a heap of fried vegetables and to his surprise, there was even a fried egg.

It's impossible for Du Shi to kindly give him an egg to eat. Mostly, it was Lei Tie who gave up his share of fried egg. Qin Mian very much wanted to overturn this speculation.

He moved his wrist as he gave an explanation: "Where can I go when I'm empty handed and hungry? I was just exercising and ran over carelessly." Except for the part of Lei Tie insisting on refusing to harmoniously divorce, Lei Tie gave him a good impression, so his tone was very mild.

Lei Tie released his hand and handed him the rice bowl before leading him to the old locust tree on the side of the road. There was a flat stone under the tree. The villagers often chat here in their spare time.

Qin Mian sat down on the stone and ate only the egg, the rest he couldn't. Not to say sweet potato and millet rice, anyone couldn't even stand eating chicken, duck, fish and meat for ten days to half a month in a row.

"I can't eat this anymore." Qin Mian held the bowl with both hands, looked at the sunset in the west and sighed, "I want to eat white rice; want to eat chicken, duck, fish; want to eat barbecue, steak; want to drink beer..."

Lei Tie watched him for a while before he took the bowl and ate quietly.

Qin Mian was shocked. “You haven’t eaten?”

“En.” Lei Tie answered.

“Oh.” Qin Mian leaned on the locust tree and continued to ponder the possibility of making Du Shi divide up family property and live apart. He didn’t care about the others, but he must find a way for Du Shi to let him and Lei Tie to move out.

He could try to find out Lei Tie’s opinion on dividing up family property and living apart.

“I want to ask you something.”

Lei Tie took a look at him, nodded and continued to eat.

“Where will we live in the future? There’s a pigsty across...” Qin Mian asked very vaguely.

Lei Tie paused and without looking up, said, “After the autumn harvest, we move out.”

The unexpected happiness made Qin Mian stand up excitedly. “Are you serious?” He originally had two vague ideas: either let Lei Tie pretend to be ill but also seriously ill to cut off Du Shi’s idea of treating Lei Tie as a labor force; or use Du Shi’s superstition belief and her concern for Lei Xiangzhi, a scholar, to make Du Shi drive him and Lei Tie out. Never had he thought that Lei Tie was neither stupid nor naïve, but had other plans for a long time.

At the thought of leaving Lei’s house, Qin Mian couldn’t restrain his good mood. He even smiled at Lei Tie and sat down again before he said in a much lighter voice, “Can we move out earlier? I know that the reason why you want to move out after the autumn harvest is to help the family get through the busy season, but even if we are living separately, we can also help with the farm works. What do you say?”

Lei Tie looked at him before suddenly came out with a sentence; his voice was still stuffy, but the tone was firm and incomparable, "I will not divorce."

Qin Mian was surprised. How sensitive was this guy? He avoided Lei Tie's eyes and said with a dry smile: "I didn't mention the matter of divorce ah. I'm talking about dividing up family property and living apart. People who are often angry grow old quickly. I don't like mother. Isn't unfilial to keep living together and make her angry?"

"I won't do the laundry."

Qin Mian promptly said: "I will!"

"I won't cook."

"I will!" Qin Mian was afraid that he could not be persuaded to split up as soon as possible.

Lei Tie nodded.

The little man in Qin Mian's mind excitedly jumped up high. He urged: "Eat quickly."

Lei Tie still ate neither in hurry nor slow. Qin Mian watched him anxiously, itching to help him eat.

Lei Tie touched his head. "No hurry."

Qin Mian didn't have time to protest his action and said directly: "It's urgent!"

Only then Lei Tie slightly sped up. When he finished the last bit of the meal, they went home together.

The sunset glow gradually disappeared, leaving only faint residual light. The whole village was shrouded in dim. A few houses had already lighted their oil lamps. When the lights swayed with the wind, the shadows of the courtyard walls also swayed with it.

When Zhao Shi saw Lei Tie go to the kitchen with dishes and chopsticks, she raised her eyebrows with a smile as she measured Qin Mian and said in a sour tone: “I’m really envious of eldest sister-in-law. Not only had big brother given eldest sister-in-law a meal, he even helped eldest sister-in-law with the empty bowl. Make people envious oh!”

Du Shi’s in the room immediately followed with a sentence, “Eldest’s family [wife], don’t you hurry to wash the dishes? Is the oil lamp free, ah?”

Qin Mian didn’t feel hurt or itch[1] because he’s going to separate and live apart from them soon and didn’t want to bring forth side issues. He went into the kitchen and could only wash the dishes by the dim moonlight. There was no detergent in the ancient era. If one wanted to clean the oil stains on the dishes, one could only use hot water. Because there were two woks on the kitchen stove’s hollowed spaces, the outermost wok was used to cook rice and fry vegetables while the innermost wok was used to boil water at the same time. Qin Mian opened the lid of the innermost wok and found that there was no hot water. He did not know who used it, so he had to boil it again.

Lei Tie sat down in front of the stove and helped to light the fire.

When they finished washing the dishes, the main house was dark and it was already quiet.

They went back to the thatch cottage after washing up under the moonlight.

Note:

[1] lit. doesn’t hurt, doesn’t tickle (idiom); fig. not getting to any matter of substance; superficial

Chapter 010: Divide up Family Property and Live Apart (3)

They didn't light up a lamp either and went to bed in the dark.

Qin Mian felt the both old and stiff worn out quilt on his body while he was in a relaxed mood—he would soon be separated and live apart from this family. Compared with the separation and living apart, the other grievances were nothing at all.

“By the way, where shall we live after dividing up family property to live apart?” Qin Mian asked in a low voice as he suddenly thought of the most important thing.

In the dark, Lei Tie paused. “There's only enough money in hand to build a thatched cottage.”

Qin Mian smiled nonchalantly, “As long as we can move out of here, we can even live in a cave.” As long as he left this place, he could make money.

Lei Tie hadn't spoken for a long time, he didn't know if the man was asleep.

Qin Mian couldn't sleep. He tossed and turned for nearly an hour before he sat up.

“Where to?”

Lei Tie's voice suddenly sounded.

Qin Mian was taken aback. Fortunately, he didn't take the food out of the space. He touched his stomach and sighed, “Hungry.” Right when he was

still growing up, how could he be full with only a chicken drumstick and an egg? Even the rest of the meal was locked in the cupboard by Du Shi, who was the only one with the key.

There was a rustling sound at the side, which followed up by Lei Tie getting up. A large amount of moonlight came in from the outside. It turned out that Lei Tie had opened the door silently.

“Go.” Lei Tie said softly.

“Where to?” Qin Mian wondered. He got out of bed and put on his straw sandals.

Lei Tie opened the gate of the courtyard. After Qin Mian went out, he closed the gate lightly.

The moonlight shone on the ground was as calm as water. In late September, it was rather cold at night, but it didn’t make people feel cold. The evening wind blew on their faces, felt very nice.

Lei Tie held Qin Mian’s wrist tightly. Qin Mian couldn’t break free after struggling for a while and without any option he could only follow after the man. There were potholes in the ground. If one was not careful, one would step into the pothole. It’s better for Lei Tie to hold onto him.

Going along the road, Qin Mian was becoming more confused. If they went further, they would be out of the village. At the grain-sunning ground, Lei Tie stopped in front of a crenel as tall as a person, reached for the crenel on the top and fished out three eggs.

Qin Mian looked at him in surprise. He didn’t expect someone like Lie Tie would steal someone’s eggs.

Lei Tie seemed to have seen through what he thought, “Pheasant’s.”

Once Qin Mian thought about it, it seemed to be true. How could a domestic chicken come here to lay eggs?

“Wait.” Lei Tie stuffed the three eggs into his hand.

Qin Mian watched his back go away gradually until he could not see it anymore. A perfect silence prevailed and there was no one but the shadow of the crenel under the moonlight. The wind behind him was cool which gave him gooseflesh that he rubbed his arms. He was moved by Lei Tie's action but at the same time he felt sympathy for him being born in such family. Du Shi's act of locking the cupboard was not only to prevent him, but also to prevent Zhao and Qian from stealing food. It went without saying that they were a family, but to have reached this extent, how could one not think it was ridiculous and sad?

Before long, Lei Tie came back with a small bundle of firewood and in his right hand were two corn cobs that came from nowhere. He used flint to light a fire and put the eggs in the fire. He also used two thin bamboo sticks to pierce through the corn cobs and roasted them on the fire.

Under the flickering fire, the man's face was gentler than that during the day. Even if he sat with bent back, it was still so upright that he would appear very steady and reliable.

The tongue of flame licked the corn cobs and after a moment Lei Tie would turn the bamboo sticks in his hand. Qin Mian beat out a yawn, laid his head on his knees and as soon as he caught the smell of corn, he straightened up. When Lei Tie handed over the two corns, he took only one.

"You have one, too." He took a bite of the corn; it was soft and fragrant that smile emerged from within his eyes. He looked up and smiled at Lei Tie as he said, "It's fragrant. You've good roasting skill. It's not burnt at all." Lei Tie didn't come back to eat at noon when he was hunting, so he needed to deal with food by himself. This skill was probably honed due to that.

Lei Tie didn't speak and there was still no expression on his face, but the cold lines on his face obviously softened a little. He picked up a stick and turned over the eggs in the fire.

Even later when Qin Mian and Lei Tie had been together for many years, Qin Mian would still felt full of warmth whenever he recalled this scene in the evening.

“When are you going to talk about the separation? I’m not urging you, but ask to understand thoroughly. I have things in mind.”

Lei Tie didn’t eat the corn. “Fifth brother will be home tomorrow evening and following that is off day. Will talk about it at that time.”

Qin Mian nodded. He already knew that Lei Tie was a man of his own mind and must have a good idea of how to divide up family property to live apart. He didn’t need to say more. Besides, he always felt that he was an outsider, so it was hard to interfere.

Lei Tie took out the eggs and put them on the windward side to let the wind cool them.

Qin Mian chewed on the corn cob and touched the egg, but it’s not hot. He took it and peeled it. After he ate all three eggs, he became full.

Lei Tie only ate the corn in his hand.

The corn cores were thrown far away into the knee high rice field.

“There will be traces here.” Qin Mian pointed to the burning fire.

Lei Tie said: “It’s not the time to use the grain-sunning ground.” This meant that the traces wouldn’t be found these days. In fact, it’s nothing even if it’s discovered. At most, it would cause some speculation. In serious cases, some people would be gossiping.

“Then, let’s go.” In order to express his gratitude to Lei Tie, Qin Mian stooped to hold the extra firewood.

Lei Tie quickly beat him to it and picked up the firewood before he signaled him to follow.

When passing by the firewood at home, he put the firewood on the firewood pile. Then, they went back to the thatched cottage.

There was no sound in the yard. Their departure did not alarm anyone.

With his stomach satisfied, Qin Mian's sleepiness also came. He laid in bed and soon fell asleep. In the middle of the night, he felt vaguely cold and unconsciously leaned on the heat source nearby and fell into sound sleep.

Chapter 011: Make More Money; Let You Put As Much Oil As You Want

When the rooster crowed for the first time, Lei Tie opened his eyes. The faint gleam of light and wind outside pushed in through the gaps in the thatched cottage. He soon sobered up and looked down at the warm object in his arms. The teenager curled up in his arms was sleeping soundly. In the middle of the night, the teenager felt cold and unconsciously squeezed his head under Lei Tie's right armpit.

He took back his arm and tucked the teenager nicely into the quilt before he dressed quietly, washed his face with cold well water in the courtyard and then went back to the thatched cottage to collect the prey and bow set and set out in the dim morning light. The town was not close by and it's going to take more than an hour to walk across the mountain. If he departed early, he could arrive at the opening of the market. At that time, it would be the most bustling time. The people who were in charge of purchasing from the well-to-do families chose to come out at this time, so he could sell the prey sooner.

Not far out, several people from the same village came from another direction, each carrying a shoulder pole which already bent by pressure.

"Tiezi." One of them was Zhang Dashuan.

"Brother Zhang." Lei Tie greeted without saying a word more.

Zhang Dahuan knew his character, so didn't mind and smiled as he nodded.

A man looked about in his 30s came to Lei Tie's side. "Tiezi, how is your newlywed life? Is the wifey cuddly?"

"Dashan!" Zhang Dashuan's face changed slightly as he frowned at him.

"What's wrong with that?" The other one, a bit younger and looking in his mid-twenties, laughed and bumped against Zhang Dashuan's shoulder pole with his shoulder pole. "Brother Zhang, aren't you curious? Brother Shan too, one can see at first glance that Tiezi's wife isn't nice to touch, you don't need to ask more."

Zhang Dashuan angrily stopped him from continuing, "Qiangzhu!"

Lei Tie stopped his footstep. His pair of black eyes without billows stared fixatedly at Song Qiangzhu, seemingly even the air had cooled down.

Yao Dashan was shocked and regretted it a bit. Lei Tie didn't seem a person who was easy to provoke, he shouldn't provoke the man. In case he offended the man, it's not impossible to be shot with an arrow.

Song Qiangzhu's back felt chill, but he didn't want to lose face in front of others, so with a sneer he raised his head as he said: "What? If you dare to marry a man as a wife, I dare to say so!"

Lei Tie restrained the cold light in his eyes, turned around and said to Zhang Dashan in a low voice, "Brother Zhang, I go first."

"Alright, alright." Zhang Dahuan immediately nodded in fear of another dispute between him and the other two.

When Lei Tie's back view had integrated into the black shadow of the green mountain, Song Qiangzhu said coldly, "I told you; look at what you can do to me!"

Zhang Dashuan and Yao Dashan looked at each other and inwardly shook their heads. *If you're not afraid, why don't you say this in front of Lei Tie?*

Zhang Dashuan gestured with his hand, "Go, go, and keeps going."

Qin Mian naturally didn't know what happened to his cheap 'husband' and was sleeping soundly under the covers. It was unknown how long it took for the door to be slammed open.

"Eldest's family [wife], still aren't getting up? Have you lived with the pigs for a long time that you turned into a pig?"

Qin Mian suddenly sat up and looked at Du Shi coldly. This old hag had no such propriety in speech. This was not only cussing him, but also cussing her man's eldest son.

"What? You're still not obeying?" Du Shi didn't care about him at all as her voice was even louder, "Don't roll up still!"

Qin Mian took a deep breath and smiled at her. "Mother, I was about to get up. You've working hard, I'll make breakfast today."

Du Shi's face eased a bit. "Hurry up!"

After Qin Mian dressed, he went out. The sky had yet brightened, looked like six o'clock at the most. He simply washed his face before he went into the kitchen and looked around. There were some sweet potatoes, some autumn eggplants, some green peppers, three potatoes and two eggs in the bamboo basket.

Du Shi followed in. "Just fry the vegetables in the basket for breakfast. I've scooped up the brown rice; when the rice is cooking, steam the two eggs on it."

After that, she did not leave, but looked from the door.

"I understand." Qin Mian knew that she was afraid of him cooking too much rice. Regarding her as non-existent, he swiftly lighted the fire and cooked the rice first. The farmstead families all done hard works, so they didn't eat the kind of soup or liquid as breakfast like the city people did, but they ate staple food like in lunch and dinner, otherwise they would get hungry easily.

When Du Shi saw that he did not secretly add rice from the rice jar, she left at ease.

As the rice was boiling, Qin Mian washed and cut the vegetables. After the rice was cooked, he put the brown rice with sweet potatoes in a basin and put it on the hot water of the innermost wok to keep warm, and then washed the other wok to fry the vegetables.

Qian Shi probably had nothing to do as it was such a rarity for her to come in to help him add firewood.

Qin Mian found exactly what he had been looking for. When the wok was dried up on fire, he scooped out a large spoon of oil and poured it in. The oil smelled delicious.

Qian Shi was too late to stop him. “Eldest sister-in-law, you put too much. If Mother-in-law knew, she would definitely scold you.”

Qin Mian calmly said: “Eggplants consume oil, more oil to fry, more delicious.”

Qian Shi was indifferent because the one going to be scolded anyway not going to be her. She smiled and praised: “It’s really fragrant. Eldest sister-in-law, you are bold. If you are the one to cook in the future, it will be good.”

Qin Mian gave a faint smile, noncommittal.

Just like that, Qin Mian fried two plates of eggplant, two plates of potato shreds and two plates of green pepper. As soon as the vegetables were fried, he quickly slipped out.

He had yet walked far and he heard Du Shi’s loud scolding but it went into the left ear and went out the right ear. He walked slowly along the way out of the village.

Seeing a tall figure coming neither too fast nor too slow from afar, he waved quickly. That’s indeed his *amulet*!

When Lei Tie looked at the small and thin figure in the distance, he felt a strange feeling in his heart and unconsciously accelerating his pace. For the first time, someone was waiting for him to come back.

When he got closer, he couldn't hear anything unusual in his voice, "What's the matter?"

"It's nothing. I've just finished preparing meal and mother thinks I put too much oil in it." Qin Mian told the story frankly and did not deny that he was intentional.

Lei Tie nodded, "I'll make more money, let you put as much oil as you want when cooking."

Qin Mian's face felt a little hot, so he changed the topic, "Was the prey sold? How much did it cost?"

Lei Tie answered: "3 taels[1] and 2 diaos[2]."

Qin Mian gave an 'oh'. He knew that 1 tael of gold here was equal to 10 taels of silver, 1 tael of silver was equal to 10 diao coins, and 1 diao was equal to 100 wen[3]. But he didn't know exactly what the concept of 1 wen and how many things it could buy, so he didn't know whether 3 taels and 2 diaos were more or less.

When they got home, the meal was just served.

As soon as Du Shi saw Qin Mian, she was about to scold him but Lei Tie called out "mother" before he led Qin Mian pass over her to sit down at the table.

Du Shi remembered that Lei Tie got the money, so she held back her anger and let Qin Mian go for a while. She said gently, "Eldest is back. How is the market price today?"

"Enough to buy 2 sets of clothes for me and Xiao Mian."

Qin Mian disregarded Du Shi. He took his bowl and clipped eggplants and shredded potatoes in it. Although there were all vegetables, it's a lot better

than Du Shi's fried vegetables.

Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren and the others were all eating with relish, mouths full of grease. Seeing the vegetables in the dishes become shallower and shallower, Qin Mian quickly took some into Lei Tie's bowl.

Lei Tie glanced at him and Qin Mian returned with a smile.

Du Shi was not satisfied with Lei Tie's answer and asked, "There must be 2 or 3 taels?"

"1 tael and 200 wen." After that, Lei Tie talked no more and lowered his head to eat.

He didn't hand over the slightest amount to her and Du Shi's heart began to feel uncomfortable again. Just as she was about to open her mouth, Lei Xiangren's cry came out from the kitchen, "Why is there no rice left?"

Lei Xiangyi said: "Haven't you eaten two bowls already?"

Du Shi returned to her senses and looked at the table. There was only a little soup left on the bottom of the three dishes and there were only a few vegetables in her bowl. Needless to say, it was Lei Chuntao who gave it to her.

All of a sudden, a burst of anger and smothered breath came out of her chest at the same time and rushed to her brain. She picked up her chopsticks and dropped it to the ground, shouting to Zhao Shi and Qian Shi: "Eating such the likes of scoundrel, are you just released from the prison? Even dogs don't eat as clean as you all!"

Qian Shi quickly emptied the rice in the bowl without uttering any sound.

Zhao Shi murmured to herself unwillingly, "Younger sister-in-law also ate..."

"Second sister-in-law!" Lei Chuntao blushed and glared at Zhao Shi.

Du Shi's anger made her stagger.

“Enough! Even having a meal can’t be in peace!” Lei Daqiang slapped his hand on the table. Who knew why, his face was a little red.

Du Shi sat down heavily and her eyes shifted to Qin Mian; they were indignantly resentful and cold, just like looking at the enemy.

Qin Mian hid behind Lei Tie and continued to eat.

Du Shi looked at Lei Tie, who was blocking her sight. “Eldest, are you going to town tomorrow? Buy two jin of oil.”

Lei Tie answered: “No, I have something to do.”

After the meal, Qin Mian took the initiative to say: “Mother, I’ll go chop firewood.”

Du Shi said immediately, “No need for you! You can’t even chop two jin[4] of firewood in a day! Second’s [wife] and Third’s [wife] go to chop firewood; Eldest’s [wife] go wash dishes and clothes!”

Qin Mian secretly congratulated himself.

It was only when he saw a large pile of clothes piled by the well that he knew he had underestimated Du Shi. Did Du Shi even take out the clean clothes?

“Wife, follow me to mow the grass.” Lei Tie came, took Qin Mian and left.

Qin Mian reckoned that his wish to separate and live apart had been determined; therefore he didn’t have to attend to Du Shi.

Note:

[1] Tael = unit of weight equal to 50 grams (modern)

[2] Diao = a string of 100 (wen) coin

[3] Copper coin

[4] 1 jin = a catty; 0.5 kg

Chapter 012: Divide up Family Property and Live Apart (4)

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went out with a sickle and just so happened that the neighbors in the east came out of their yard, their eyes were on each other inadvertently.

Qin Mian was very embarrassed and admired the good temper of that family. Du Shi scolded so much every day that half the people in the village could hear her. The neighbors were the ones who suffered the most. How could he never hear a protest?

“Going out, ah.” The older man was all smiles as he spoke. He looked very gentle and there was no contempt in his eyes.

Qin Mian smilingly nodded, “Uncle[1], morning. We’re going to mow grass.”

The older man chuckled, “What uncle? Call me Eldest Uncle[2] Jiang.”

“Eldest Uncle Jiang.” Qin Mian readily followed good advice[3]. He guessed that this man’s seniority in the family or clan was high. There were many people in the countryside who were related to each other and this was how their seniorities were ranked.

“Hurry to go.” With his hands on his back, Eldest Uncle Jiang wandered in another direction.

Qin Mian followed Lei Tie all the way to the foot of the mountain and went onwards.

“Going into the mountain?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie nodded.

The duo went around twists and turns in the woods as they climbed up the mountain about more than ten minutes before they stopped.

“You stay.”

Lei Tie bent to cut couch grass. He grabbed a handful of couch grass with his big palm, put the sickle in his right hand to the root of the couch grass as he pulled the couch grass towards him and easily cut off a handful before he put it down on the ground and cut the second batch.

Qin Mian found out that he only had a sickle and was willing to help but also had no tools. Then, he wanted to walk around to see if he could dig some wild vegetables or find some wild fruits.

“Don’t walk around. There are snakes.”

Qin Mian had to stand in place obediently. There was a stone not far away and he moved to sit down as he watched Lei Tie cut bundle after bundle and then moved them all into a small mound cavity that was not easy to find. Several bundles of couch grass had been stored in that small mound.

Qin Mian didn’t understand, “Put here?”

Lei Tie answered: “Build house.”

Qin Mian suddenly realized. It turned out that Lei Tie didn’t cut this couch grass for Lei Family’s use, but to build a house. It seemed that he had started to plan to separate from Lei Family.

Qin Mian said, “In the afternoon, I will cut with you.”

Lei Tie didn’t speak. Qin Mian regarded it as his consent.

When it was time to return home, Lei Tie picked only two bundles of couch grass to go back, which was considered as a task completed. The dried grass was also a burn material.

In the afternoon, Qin Mian brought cloth towels and went up the mountain with Lei Tie. When cutting grass, he wrapped his hands in cloth towels. It's not due to his pettiness but he was young and tender which could easily be cut by the grass. In the backward ancient era, there were lack of medicine treatments and so, less injury was safer.

In the evening, they returned home. Sitting in the yard was a young and graceful teenager dressed in a clean and tidy white long gown, looking down to read a book.

Qin Mian immediately guessed who this person was: Lei Xiangzhi, the youngest son of Lei Family. Lei Xiangzhi was the only person in Lei Family who was unlike a farmer's child aside from Lei Tie. He was also the only one who wore white clothes.

At the sound of footsteps, Lei Xiangzhi raised his head before he stood up and smiled at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, even bowing. The scholar's temperament was completely displayed. He said in refined and courteous, "Big brother, elder sister-in-law."

Lei Tie replied lightly, "Fifth brother."

Qin Mian only smiled and nodded to Lei Xiangzhi, not calling out "fifth brother". He hadn't admitted the identity as Lei's eldest daughter-in-law in his heart and currently he was one year younger than Lei Xiangzhi, it's awkward to call him "fifth brother".

When Du Shi came out of the hall with a basin, as soon as she saw Qin Mian, she unexpectedly didn't scold him, but glanced at him lightly before she rushed into the kitchen.

Thus it could be seen that Du Shi minded herself for Lei Xiangzhi.

Sure enough, Du Shi didn't scold anyone until dinner. At the dinner table, never mind she was inquiring about Lei Xiangzhi's wellbeing, but she even specifically asked Zhao Shi to buy a fish from the fish farmer's house at the top of the village when she made breakfast the next day.

These had nothing to do with Qin Mian. After eating, he went to bed. Because when he woke up, they could talk about separation and living apart.

The next day, after breakfast. Zhao Shi and Qian Shi got up to clear the tables under Du Shi's urging. Lei Daqiang was also ready to go out to work.

Lei Tie began, "Father, sit down. I have something to say."

Lei Daqiang sat back down and asked casually, "What's it?"

Lei Tie said without mincing words, "I want to separate and move out."

Everyone was stunned. Nobody expected that Lei Tie would say such a sentence so suddenly because there was no sign at all. Zhao Shi and Qian Shi, who had already held the chopsticks in their hands, turned pale at the same time. They put the plates back on the table and sat back where they once were.

Zhao Shi inwardly frowned. She didn't want to let Lei Tie go. If Lei Tie left, the family would have less labor force and her husband would have to work more.

Qian Shi supported Lei Tie to move out. It's really awkward with the two men being together ah. In addition, because the family's money was in Du Shi's hands, whether Lei Tie moved out or not had no substantial impact on her interests. Du Shi quarreled with Qin Mian every day. Even for the sake of peace, she hoped Lei Tie and Qin Mian would move out. In fact, she also wanted to be move out. Just because there was no separation, the money the brothers of Lei Family usually earned as they went out to do some odd jobs or the money the women at home earned by selling embroidered handkerchiefs and knotted luozi[4] all had to be handed over to Du Shi, to the extent that she had little money in her hands and could not even usually buy some delicious snacks for Xinxin. That old hag Du Shi only had her youngest son, her only daughter and two grandsons in her eyes, and didn't care about Xinxin at all. But she also knew that it was impossible for Lei Xiangyi to move out by his own, unless the old father was willing to separate his sons.

Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao all had different looks.

Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi also wanted to separate and live apart. Who didn't want to be in charge of their own money? Lei Xiangyi didn't have a son. Every time he saw his mother put delicious food in the bowls of Dabao and Xiaobao, and then he saw the look in Xinxin's eyes, he felt frustrated. If he had money, he would buy whatever his daughter wants!

Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi both knew that their parents would not agree to separate the family, but they listened quietly.

Lei Chuntao supported Lei Tie's decision from the bottom of her heart. When Lei Tie left home, she was only five years old and she had yet an impression with the original Lei Tie. When Lei Tie came back, he was pretty good to her and also gifted her with a hairpin worth at least 4 taels. However, her mother tried various devices to take advantage of big brother and even arranged the thatched cottage opposite the pigsty, which made her feel sorry and ashamed. Even walking in the village, she felt a head lower than others. It's a good thing if big brother could really separate and live apart. Although Du Shi loved her, she was the daughter and had no right to speak at home. She could only restrain her excitement and wait for her parents to make a statement.

Without waiting for Lei Daqiang to speak, Du Shi immediately put on a negative attitude and said coldly: "Eldest, what are you talking about? Your father and I are not dead yet."

Note:

[1] 大叔 dà shū = eldest of father's younger brothers; uncle (term used to address a man about the age of one's father)

[2] 大爷 dà ye = father's older brother; uncle; term of respect for older man

[3] willing to accept other people's views

[4] Luozi is a Chinese knot which was very popular in ancient times. When wearing clothes, you need to tie cloth straps and then tie a knot. It can be worn as decoration on the waist, hair, fan, curtain etc.

Chapter 013: Finally Divide up Family Property and Live Apart!

Lei Daqiang then said: “Eldest, I disagree. Why don’t you think better? If you really move out, where will you live? In the woods? Well, don’t talk about it anymore.”

With that, he got up to leave.

Lei Tie looked into his eyes and said lightly: “Ten years ago, I left; ten years later, not that I’m really unable to leave again.”

Lei Daqiang’s face changed a lot and his hands hanging on his side trembled slightly. “You!”

“Eldest!” Du Shi was unable to contain her anger. “Did you not take your father seriously? You are unfilial!”

Lei Tie looked at her and said, “I’m unfilial; I didn’t fight back when I was beaten and scolded by you. I’m unfilial; you let me live opposite the pigsty, I have no objection. I’m unfilial; because a word from the fortune teller, I married a man.”

He looked at Lei Daqiang again and asked plainly still, “I wanted to ask a long time ago, am I your son?”

Even Qin Mian as an outsider who heard this was feeling heartache and sympathetic towards Lei Tie.

Lei Daqiang opened his mouth but didn’t speak. He didn’t dare to look into Lei Tie’s eyes.

Lei Chuntao's eyes were red and she couldn't help crying out, "Father! Mother! Just agree to it! Big brother doesn't owe us!"

Du Shi raged, "You shut up! You favor an outsider instead of my side!"

Lei Xiangzhi sighed silently and with a gentle voice, "Father, let big brother move out. We're still a family even if he's separated." In a word, the relationship between Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi with Lei Tie was passable. Lei Xiangren was the most exclusive. But the reason was that he was the first son of Du Shi. When he was very young, Du Shi's attitude towards him and Lei Tie was quite different. Du Shi's attitude towards Lei Tie affected him to some extent, so he didn't like Lei Tie at all. In this respect, he agreed to let Lei Tie move out. As for Lei Xiangzhi, who was only five years old at that time, what could he understand? Later, he was educated and understood the principle of showing love and respect as good brothers should. Although his relationship with Lei Tie could be regarded as deep, neither was he willing to bully or insult him.

"Fifth?" Du Shi looked at Lei Xiangzhi incredulously, but could not say a word to him.

Lei Daqiang fell into his chair feebly, "Fine. If you want to move out, then move out."

"Old man!" Du Shi glared at him.

Lei Daqiang ignored her.

Lei Daqiang had made up his mind, Du Shi had no choice but forced to say: "If you want to move out, you can. But there is nothing in the house for you to take."

Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao frowned.

Lei Tie only looked at Lei Daqiang.

Lei Daqiang sighed and said: "Eldest, you know the situation at home. The house, there is really no extra things to share with you. If you are in a hurry

to move out, your brothers and I will help you build a thatched cottage to live in first. The farmlands, all together are only some. When Fourth and Fifth married, there will be more people, so we can only give you one mu[1] of paddy field and one mu of dry farmland. As for money...”

Zhao Shi, Qian Shi, Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi all perked up their ears.

Du Shi interrupted Lei Daqiang and said without emotion: “Are you confused old man? There is no money at home.”

Lei Daqiang said: “You gave me 20 silver taels at the beginning and I spent some money during this period of time. There are still 10 taels left. I will give you 2 taels.”

Qin Mian sneered in his heart. In the morning, when Zhao Shi bought fish, Du Shi asked her how much it cost. He heard Zhao Shi’s reply clearly: 11 wen. That fish was about two jin, which was about 5 wen per jin. Therefore, 20 silver taels were not a small amount. He and Lei Tie did not throw a ceremony during their marriage and nothing else happened in Lei Family in more than a month, so where was the 10 silver taels? In particular, Du Shi was such a provincial miser that he did not believe that the Lei Family had no savings at all.

Even at this time, Lei Daqiang was still calculating towards his own son. In public, Qin Mian couldn’t pat Lei Tie on the shoulder, so he quietly patted Lei Tie on the leg under the table to comfort him.

Lei Tie’s face was as usual, his mood unreadable.

Lei Daqiang wiped his face, seemingly wanted to wipe away the shame on his face. “As for the household tools and so on, there is no extra... The two pigs, one is originally going to be slaughter for the Lunar New Year, I’ll give you some in due course. What do you think?”

Lei Tie asked: “Where will the house build?”

“Th...” Lei Daqiang faltered out a few words, “There is no extra land at home and there is really no spare money to buy land for you...”

Du Shi laughed out a sound and said slowly: “Eldest, at the beginning you gave 20 silver taels in one shot. I don’t believe that you didn’t keep any to yourself at all.”

Don’t tell me it is wrong to return the 20 silver taels that big brother gave to father! Lei Chuntao was so ashamed that she almost went under the table.

Lei Xiangzhi’s face also felt hot as he frowned at Du Shi, “Mother, please say a few words less.”

Lei Tie stood up. “I’ll go invite Li Zheng.”

Lei Xiangzhi promptly said: “Big brother, I’ll go.”

Lei Tie nodded. “Thank you.”

After Lei Xiangzhi went to invite Li Zheng, no one in the hall room spoke. The three children had been rushed to play in the room beforehand. Silence was like a dark cloud over the heads of these people and the atmosphere in the hall room was very depressing.

Of all the people, only Lei Tie and Qin Mian were calm. Lei Tie’s eyes were flat and calm, none could guess any trace of emotion in them. Qin Mian, restrained by excitement and happiness, looked at the door from time to time without expression.

Very soon, Lei Xiangzhi brought in Li Zheng with him.

The peasant families basically dressed in duanda for the convenient to do farm work, but Li Zheng wore gray changpao inside with a thin black cotton breasted jacket outside. The cotton breasted jacket was embroidered with the noble character “福[2]” with gold thread. He was pacing with measured gait as he walked steadily. He looked to be in his early fifties, hale and hearty, his eyes twinkling with shrewd light.

Lei Daqiang and the others got up to greet him.

“Li Zheng, we’ve troubling you to come here.” Lei Daqiang said politely with an apologetic face.

Lei Tie cupped his hands in salute towards Li Zheng.

Li Zheng nodded and glanced at the people in the hall room. His eyes lingered on Lei Tie for a while before he said: “Brother Lei speak so seriously, it’s merely a very slight effort and nothing more. As for how to divide the family property, if you have already discussed it, I will just write it down.”

Lei Xiangzhi went to his room and brought out the ‘scholar’s four jewels’[3]. Lei Chuntao was smart; she quickly tidied up the table.

“Have to trouble Li Zheng. This way, please.” Lei Tie raised his hand and led Li Zheng to the table.

Li Zheng nodded to himself secretly. Although the eldest of Lei Family was frightening in appearance, he acted steadily and knew etiquette. He was much better than any people in general. But unfortunately....

Lei Daqiang felt slightly uncomfortable, but he didn’t know why. In fact, it was because his sense of existence weakened, but he didn’t realize it. He walked over a few steps, sat down next to Li Zheng, coughed before said: “Li Zheng, we have discussed the contents of the division. I’ll say and trouble you to note it down. After discussion, it was decided to give Lei Tie a mu of paddy field, which is located in... one mu of dry land, which is located in...”

Qin Mian leaned over to see that the characters here were traditional Chinese characters. He could basically understand them. Li Zheng was writing on the paper: “Today, Lei Tie the eldest son of Lei Daqiang, has come to a man’s estate[4], peacefully divides family property to live apart and Lei Daqiang, the head of the family gives Lei Tie...”

Qin Mian nodded. Since it was a document of family property’s division, it should clearly state the identity of both parties, just like Party A and Party B in the contract, in case of future disputes.

Li Zheng was listening to Lei Daqiang and he couldn’t help shaking his head. Lei Daqiang didn’t treat his eldest son as his own. All of them belong

to one village, who didn't know that there were 12 mu of paddy field and 8 mu of dry field owned by Lei Family. Even if the brothers got equal shares, Lei Tie should not only get a share of 2 mu of field. Besides, Lei Tie had no home base to build a house on. It could be said as leaving a marriage with nothing. But since both sides had agreed, he had no right to intervene. Seeing that Lei Tie had no objection, he wrote it down.

After Lei Daqiang finished, he thought over it, not to miss anything before he said: "That's all."

Standing beside Lei Daqiang, Du Shi hurriedly said: "Also, since we haven't split the family yet, shouldn't the money of Eldest's family [wife] be handed over too and then give him a part of it?"

"Mother!" Lei Xiangzhi blushed. "Let alone big brother doesn't have money at all now, even if there is, it's his."

"It's none of your business!" Du Shi glared at him and pushed Lei Daqiang, "Old man."

Lei Daqiang felt that everyone's eyes were stabbing him. He said: "What Fifth said is right. When it comes to family separation, the men decide and you women should shut up!" He gave Du Shi an angry look.

Seeing that he was angry, Du Shi grew apprehensive and said anything more.

Lei Tie was not affected by them for even a bit and he said in a low voice: "Please add in a sentence—from today until two months later at the same day, our pair of husbands can pick vegetables in the vegetable field."

Du Shi's eyes bulged out and her mouth agape, wanting to speak.

Li Zheng saw it but regarded as if he didn't see it, he nodded: "Yes. You two aren't given a share to the vegetable field. It's fine to pick some vegetables in the vegetable field." He smiled at Lei Daqiang. If Lei Daqiang couldn't even accept this, he should stay away from such a person in the future.

Lei Daqiang's face felt hot and nodded repeatedly, "Naturally, naturally. Already old, memory is bad; I may have forgotten to say that just now."

"What else to add?" Li Zheng's words seemed to ask both sides, but his eyes were looking at Lei Tie.

Qin Mian pulled at Lei Tie's arm and said, "Separated from the family but still close relatives, however it's two families. Brother Tie, I think we should add that both parties are not allowed to interfere in each other's family affairs, including housework and finance. What do you think?"

Lei Tie nodded and remembered the word "Brother Tie" in his heart.

Du Shi immediately screamed, "Eldest, don't think you are responsible for your brothers and sister if you separate from the family! You have to contribute for the marriage of Fourth, Fifth and Youngest[5] and you also have to pay for Fifth's study. Otherwise, I don't agree with the separation!"

Lei Tie said: "Whether it's Fourth, Fifth or Little Sister who gets married, if father gives me five silver coins, I will give one. It's only fair since your family has more labor forces and my family has less labor force. Father, do you think what I said makes sense?"

Qin Mian laughed in his heart.

Lei Daqiang could only nod.

Du Shi wanted to open her mouth again but was stopped by Lei Xiangzhi.

Li Zheng wrote it down again.

Lei Tie said again: "Every month, our pair of husbands will provide 100 wen for the elderly expenses. But I'm afraid I can't during these two to three months because I'm short of money."

Du Shi's heart felt a little more comfortable. She got 100 wen a month, which was more than one silver tael a year!

Li Zheng nodded approvingly. Seeing that Lei Tie spoke in an orderly way, considering all aspects, it was obvious that there was a long-term plan. “Lei Tie is filial. I’ll write ‘provide 100 wen monthly’ in the paperwork. I don’t need to write the last sentence, do I?”

Lei Daqiang’s heart was in complex and he hurriedly said: The last sentence doesn’t need to be written, doesn’t need to be written. Little by little is fine.”

After that, Li Zheng read the content completely at a slower speed.

Lei Tie nodded without objection.

Lei Daqiang didn’t have any education, so his reaction was a little slow. After a while, he said: “No problem.”

The documents were in triplicate, with each party keeping one copy. Lei Tie, Lei Daqiang and Li Zheng all pressed their fingerprints as to complete the separation.

Matter finished, Lei Tie sent Li Zheng to the entrance gate for nearly half a li[6], “Many thanks, Li Zheng. Someday, Lei Tie will visit to express thanks.”

At the side, Qin Mian smiled and said “thank you” to Li Zheng.

“Go back and live a good life.” Li Zheng had nothing else to say and he left with hands clasped behind his back and shook his head as he walked.

Qin Mian looked at the bright sunshine on top of his head and couldn’t help laughing. He asked briskly, “When will we move away?”

Lei Tie answered: “Today.”

Note:

[1] Mu = classifier for fields; unit of area equal to one fifteenth of a hectare

[2]福 fú = blessing; happiness; good luck; good fortune

[3] the scholar's four jewels are writing brush, ink stick, ink slab and paper

[4] come to a certain condition, stage, or situation in life

[5] 老幺 lǎo yāo = youngest

[6] li, ancient measure of length, approx. 500 m

Chapter 014: Rent a House

Qin Mian worried, “Today, we can build a thatched house?”

Lei Tie responded: “Autumn harvest is coming, rent first.”

Qin Mian patted his head, “I forgot the autumn harvest.” Although they were only two people, at least they had to build two rooms, which couldn’t be completed in a day or two days. All the wood and couch grass needed to build the house must be prepared; there were more work than one could deal with only two people. They must invite others to help, treat them to meal and prepare all the ingredients needed. It all took time. When autumn harvest arrived, at that time everyone should be busy with rush-harvesting and rush-planting and couldn’t divide the labor forces to help them. So the construction could only be postponed temporarily.

“Can we rent a house?” Qin Mian was worried. Lei Tie didn’t like to talk and hadn’t been in the village for a long time, his relationship with the villagers was just average.

Lei Tie nodded and beckoned him to follow.

During the day, the village was like waking up, very lively. The chickens in the yard laid eggs and “cluck cuck” asking for credits from their owners; a flock of fat ducks quacked and swayed to the pond; occasionally, there were loud voices of adults scolding naughty children and wake-up babies crying. Farther away, the oxherd shouted to the ox to quickly move. At the top of the trees, birds were chirping spiritedly, not knowing what sort of communication they had with each other.

A few villagers chatted under a tree and laughed from time to time. When Qin Mian and Lei Tie approached, they stopped talking and laughing. The

villagers looked at them with complicated eyes and turned their heads when their eyes were about to contact. There was a silence.

Qin Mian's mental state was very strong, as if he didn't realize it, he walked over calmly.

Lei Tie was silent like a mountain, only marched with steady steps.

The villagers began to talk in low voices when they were not far away.

"*Sigh*, do you guys think they are really going to live together in the future?"

"No way, right? Can two men get along?"

"Keep it down. Speaking of which, Lei's eldest son is also very pitiful. He married a male wife just because of a word of fortune telling; oh what a sin."

"Who made him have a stepmother? Lei Daqiang can't manage his family! I heard Du Shi called Lei Xiangren "Eldest" several times; she really didn't care about Lei Tie at all. "

.....

They went to middle of the village and stopped at tall courtyard gate. The gate was thick and imposing, with smooth reliefs engraved on it. Although it finest couldn't be compare with that of a rich and influential family's house, it was much better than that of a common villager's house. It could be seen that this family could be considered as the wealthy household in the village. There was a tall persimmon tree in the yard that stretched out a branch from inside. The persimmons were full like small lanterns and some of them had turned yellow.

Lei Tie lightly tapped the door knocker and a rough voice transmitted out from inside, "Coming."

The gate was opened. A middle-aged man with a potbelly and a stout body had opened the gate. He was a bit surprised before he smiled very politely,

“Is it Lei’s eldest son? Come in.”

“Senior[1] Zhao.”

Qin Mian followed after, “Senior Zhao, excuse me.”

Zhao Wenzhong invited the two to come into the house to take a sit as he wondered what the two sought him for. Their two families had nothing to do with each other besides he and Lei Tie exchanged greetings when he bumped into Lei Tie in the village, who had just returned.

Zhao Wenzhong’s family [wife] was at home, sitting at the window mending clothes. Next to the window, she listened to the people talking outside and was also curious about the two people’s purpose of coming.

Standing in the courtyard, Lei Tie said, “Senior Zhao needs not to be polite. The two of us venture to bother Senior Zhao because we want to rent Senior Zhao’s old house at the back of the village.”

Qin Mian was afraid that his lack of words would make Zhao Wenzhong misunderstand them and so he added: “It’s like this, Senior Zhao. Brother Tie and I have separated from our parents and we are going to have autumn harvest soon. Now it’s too late to build a house, so we want to rent your old house for a while. I heard that Senior Zhao is usually warmhearted, so we dare to ask you to facilitate us.”

Lei Tie said: “Two months at most.”

The eyes of Zhao Wenzhong’s family [wife] flashed as her blood of gossip boiled. *The Lei Family split? This is big news and first-hand news at that.* She couldn’t stay still for a moment.

“So it’s like that.” Zhao Wenzhong was very generous. “It’s not inconvenient for you to stay temporarily. It’s just that you probably don’t know that no one had managed the house for a long time, I’m afraid the house can’t be lived in.” That house was given to him when their Zhou Family split. Later, he made a small fortune and built another house. The old house was empty and he didn’t take care of it.

Lei Tie said: “Can give shelter from the wind and rain will suffice.”

Zhao Wenzhong nodded, “Move in if you don’t mind.”

“Thank you.” Lei Tie took out a silver coin from his bosom, which was equivalent to 500-600 wen. “This is the rent for two months.” 500-600 wen was quite a lot, enough for an average family to eat for two to three months.

Zhao Wenzhong waved his hand away. “We’re all from the same village, don’t need to rent.”

Zhao Wenzhong’s family [wife] emerged from behind him, took the silver coin in Lei Tie’s hand and smiled enthusiastically at Lei Tie and Qin Mian before glanced at Zhao Wenzhong angrily, “Family head, can they live in peace if you don’t accept it? Lei Tie’s family [wife], don’t you think so? Here, this is the key to the old house.”

Qin Mian smiled as he nodded, “Auntie’s right, you have to accept it. We’re deeply grateful for you both for letting us live there. If you don’t accept the rent, we’ll feel uneasy.”

Zhao Wenzhong had no choice but to glare at his wife and forced to say: “In this case, we will accept it. I remember there are some old desks and chairs in the house. You can use them freely.”

“Many thanks.”

Seeing Qin Mian and Lei Tie leave the gate, Zhao Wenzhong’s family [wife] stared coldly at Zhao Wenzhong. “How rich are you ah? Easily saying no to 500-600 wen.”

“What do you womenfolk know?! Go-go-go!” Zhao Wenzhong didn’t bother to talk nonsense with her and turned to enter the house.

“I don’t understand, you understand! I don’t want to talk to you.” Zhao Wenzhong’s family [wife] murmured and when she thought of the big news she had just heard, a smile emerged from her lips. She went back into the house, took the sewing basket and went out to find someone to chat with.

Note:

[1]伯bó = senior; respectful form of address

Chapter 015: Settle In

An old house stood alone behind the village. The houses in the village were basically connected to each other, but only this one here was independent, separated by about ten meters. There was also a pond in front of the house. The Zhao Family used to raise fish in this pond, so they built the house beside it. The water in the pond was dark green with several trees were on the bank.

Noticing that the roof of the house was tiled, Qin Mian was immediately elated and quickened his pace.

Lei Tie's eyes followed him all the time. *It was so easy to satisfy him?*

“Hurry up!”

Qin Mian hurried and ran to the house. A mouse in the grass was frightened and quickly shrank back to disappear.

The lock on the door had been battered by wind and rain for a long time, it was rusted. It took Qin Mian a while to open it. Pushing the door open, a burst of dust assaulted him. He sneezed a few times and hurriedly stepped back.

“Cough...”

Sunlight shone obliquely into the door and one could see the dense dust floating in the air. Inside, there was an old table with its skin peeled off and three high-back chairs covered with a thick layer of ash. Dense spider web stretched from the table and chairs all the way to the beam of the roof, there was not even room for a person to stand.

Qin Mian was satisfied. This house was old, but if he could live in a clean place, it was many times better than that thatched cottage.

There was a small bamboo forest beside the house, the green bamboo leaves rustled along the wind. He got an idea and mentioned it to Lei Tie: "You go back and move our things, I'll clean the house."

Lei Tie stood beside him, glanced inside and asked in a low voice: "Can [you] do it?"

"What can't I do? Quick, you go. The sooner things are sort out, we can live here today."

There was a worn out kitchen knife full of yellow rust in the corner of the wall. Qin Mian picked it up to cut the bamboo.

Lei Tie took out the table and chairs inside before he turned around and left. Walking out a few steps, he came back again and took off his overall before throwing it to Qin Mian. Without saying a word, he left.

A flying object covered Qin Mian's head. Unable to make head or tail of it, he pulled off the overall and conveniently hung it on a small tree. Then, he continued to cut the bamboo. When he used to live in the countryside with his grandparents, they would have a big cleaning before the New Year's Eve. They would cut some bamboos and tied them together to make a long stick to clean the dust on the beams and high walls of the house, which was as easy to use as a feather duster. He was not unaccustomed with these farm works.

The worn out knife was not making things easy. Qin Mian chopped more than 20 times before cutting off a bamboo. He broke some branches below to reduce the weight of the bamboo pole. He took it to the house and began to clean the spider web and dust on the beam. Just after sweeping, the dust fell on his face and he spat out a few times. All of a sudden, he realized that the man was very attentive.

He went outside and took Lei Tie's overall to cover his head and mouth before he continued to clean. All of a sudden, dust and dead leaves were

flying in the house, like a sandstorm struck in. The window papers were already broken, it didn't make any difference whether the windows were opened or not.

There were three rooms in the house. After he was done cleaning, Lei Tie came back with a big chest, followed after by Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao. They all held things in their arms. Lei Xiangli was holding a bundle of firewood, which knew if he took it secretly from home. Meanwhile, Lei Xiangzhi was holding a slightly smaller wooden chest.

Lei Chuntao put down the basin in her hand and walked over. She was a little shy, "I'll help you, elder sister-in-law."

How could Qin Mian let the little girl work? He hastily said: "No need, it's dusty. Don't dirty your clothes."

Lei Chuntao thought that she couldn't hold the bamboo pole and didn't insist, "Then, I will help you clean the table and chairs after the dust have cleaned up."

Lei Tie and Lei Xiangli went back to move the rest of things, while Lei Xiangzhi took the worn out kitchen knife to cut bamboos, helping to sweep the dust.

The second time Lei Tie came back, he borrowed a wooden ladder from the village.

Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao all felt awkward. They were too embarrassed to say anything but worked in silence.

Qin Mian was wholeheartedly thinking to move in as soon as possible, not in the mood to chat.

After the cleaning, Lei Tie climbed to the roof and rearranged the tiles that had been moved because of the cleaning to ensure that they would not leak in rainy days.

After that, they swept the floor, cleaned the table and chairs, and wiped the windows. They had been busy for more than two hours before the house was cleaned and looked much more comfortably.

Lei Xiangzhi's eyes fell on the broken window papers shaking along the wind. "Big brother, I have some unused paper. I'll go back and get it for you to seal the windows."

"Big brother, Chuntao and I are also going back." said Lei Xiangli.

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian felt somewhat helpless. He saw Lei Tie was quite shrewd before, why couldn't he understand human relations at this time? He had to speak, "Thank you all for your help today. It's too late for lunch. In the evening, your big brother and I want to invite you all to dinner—— if it's convenient." Convenient or not, he was afraid they would have to ask Du Shi's permission.

Lei Xiangzhi quickly declined, "It's not easy for you and big brother now, so we won't have dinner."

Lei Tie said: "By that time, I'll call you all."

Lei Xiangli and company had to agree.

After they left, Qin Mian began to count their property; a wooden bed, a low table, two wooden chests, a bow set, a wok, a square table, three chairs and a wooden basin. Other than those, there was practically nothing else. Fortunately, there was a room that was used as a kitchen and the stove was still there, so there was no need to build one.

The sun was very big, the washed table and chairs dried quickly. They moved everything in and put them in order. Three rooms; one for dining and entertaining guests, one for kitchen and at the same time storing sundries, which meant that he and Lei Tie still had to share one room or even one bed.

After finishing work, Qin Mian heated a big wok of water, washed his hair and took a bath, changed to clean clothes before switching with Lei Tie to take a bath. Not far away was the pond and he easily washed their clothes, but without a clothesline, he hung them on a small tree in front of the house. Inside the house, Lei Tie was repairing the broken chair.

“Lei Tie’s family [wife].” Zhang Dashuan strode over with a bundle of firewood on his shoulder and an expansive smile on his face.

“Brother Zhang, aren’t you busy.” Qin Mian greeted.

“What busy?” Zhang Dashuan set the firewood against the wall. “I heard that you guys split up with the family. I supposed you guys lack everything but I can’t help with the rest, so your sister-in-law and I gave this bundle of firewood for you guys to use.”

Chapter 016: A Good Husband Should Take the Initiative to Hand over the Financial Power

“How can we accept this? It’s not easy for you to cut this much of wood.” Qin Mian hurriedly refused. This big bundle of firewood was very finely chopped and one could see that it had been dried in the sun, could burn for at least five or six days. This Zhang Dashuan was really a warm-hearted man.

Lei Tie heard the voices and went out, “Brother Zhang, many thanks. We have firewood.”

“I give to you, so take it. I’ve already carried it here and I don’t want to carry it back.” Zhang Dashuan wiped the sweat on his forehead as he laughed heartily.

Qin Mian had to accept it. “Then, thank you very much, Brother Zhang. Brother Zhang, come in and have a seat. Right, how do you know we’ve split up from the family?”

Zhang Dashuan waved his hand to express that he didn’t need to sit, “Not only do I know, but all the villagers knew. Most probably heard it from Aunt Zhao.”

All in all, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi were Lei Tie’s parents, so in front of Lei Tie, he couldn’t say much.

“You guys are busy, I’m going back. There’s work in the field.”

“Thank you, Brother Zhang. Take care, Brother Zhang.”

After sending off the visitor a few steps, Qin Mian came back to finish drying the clothes.

“Have you fixed the chair? There are too many things to buy; there aren’t even bowls and chopsticks for eating. We’d better go to town soon.”

“En.”

Lei Tie stared at Qin Mian’s back, where he stood on tiptoe to dry clothes on the tree for a while before he went to the pond to wash his hands, took out a key from his bosom and walked into the house to open the smaller one of the two wooden chests. He took out a gray money pouch from it and handed it over to Qin Mian along with the key.

“Wife, take it.”

It was a bit heavy in Qin Mian’s hand. He guessed it was silver money and hurriedly pushed it back. “Better you keep it. Another thing, don’t call me ‘wife’.”

Lei Tie didn’t take it and didn’t promise not to call him ‘wife’ anymore. He went out the door and said in a low voice, “Going?”

Qin Mian held the money pouch and felt it was a little hot. His heart beat faster than usual. Lei Tie was not afraid that he took the silver money and ran away? Did Lei Tie trust him, or did Lei Tie think he could catch him even if he ran away? He didn’t want to think about it. At the beginning of the marriage with Lei Tie, Lei Family found Li Zheng to apply for his household registration and registered him in Lei Family with the identity as Lei Tie’s ‘wife’. As long as the household registration was not settled, he couldn’t leave. And being only 14 years old, it was not safe for him to wander outside alone. It was the best choice to stay in Green Mountain Village temporarily. In this respect, Lei Tie’s ‘wife’ status was not without any benefits. In this period of time, he totally couldn’t eat and live for free all the time, but also needed to earn money. It was also good to hold this money for a while.

Thinking like this, he felt relieved.

“How much is it?”

Lei Tie answered: “20 taels and some bits and pieces.”

“How much is it to buy a home base? How much does it cost to build a house?”

Lei Tie answered every question: “The home base of three rooms, 12 taels; the building, more than a tael.” This ‘building’ referred to building a thatched cottage.

Qin Mian calculated the sum of bill in his heart and could not help but lament: really poor.

“Don’t go first. Let’s see what we need to buy.”

Hearing that, Lei Tie followed him into the house.

There was no need to count what needed to be added in the kitchen. Almost everything was missing. Qin Mian went directly into their bedroom.

He looked at the bed first. It was still that bed, padded with an old cotton-padded mattress. The mattress was covered with a dark blue sheet and a coarse quilt. “Quilt need to be added.... One. This one is too old and coarse, and how about replacing the mattress?” He would like to add two quilts, but the problem was that there were so many places to spend money now. If some could do without, then better be doing without.

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian went to the two wooden chests and looked at Lei Tie. Seeing that he didn’t mean to stop him, he opened one of the chests with folded clothes inside. He picked them up one by one and counted them. Lei Tie’s five sets of clothes, three of which were thin for summer and two of which were slightly thicker for spring and autumn. The other three smaller ones were his, one old and the other two brand new ones should have been prepared when he married.

Qin Mian closed the chest and opened another wooden chest, which was empty. He couldn't help shaking his head. *Let's fill it up over time.*

He looked around the room and then looked back at Lei Tie. He thought it was safer to put the silver money on Lei Tie's person for the time being.

"You hold this first, lest we meet a thief in the market."

Lei Tie complied and took it. Then, the duo went out together.

Qin Mian locked the door and thought of another thing, "The door lock need to be replaced."

"You make decision." Lei Tie had only three words.

Without a pocket, Qin Mian handed him the key.

"Big brother, sister-in-law!" Lei Xiangzhi came over quickly and handed Qin Mian a stack of paper in his hand as he smiled slightly, "These papers are for you to mend the windows."

Qin Mian saw that these papers were new and white; it was not unused at all. He secretly thought that Fifth was thoughtful and smiled at him sincerely, "Thank you, fifth brother. We're going to town, so we won't invite you in."

"Sister-in-law is too polite. You guys are busy, I'm going back." Lei Xiangzhi smiled back and turned to leave.

Qin Mian rolled the paper into a tube and squeezed it into the window pane. With the sun on top of the head, he headed to town with Lei Tie. His hands were empty, while Lei Tie back-carried a large basket woven of bamboo strips. There was only one water pouch in the basket.

"That... Our social connection in the village is too weak. Brother Zhang is very nice, let's invite him to dinner in the evening." Qin Mian spoke with Lei Tie as he walked. He couldn't call 'Brother Tie' without outsiders present.

“Listen to you.” Lei Tie had no objection.

Qin Mian was used to his introvert character, he didn't mind. He looked at the sun and estimated it was almost 12 o'clock. It was too hot and the road was far away. He didn't talk anymore and looked at the road while shading his head.

In the fields on both sides of the road, the golden rice was about to mature completely, the stalks were heavy. On the ridge, experienced farmers were observing the rice to determine when the harvest was most appropriate.

When the busybody women saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie, they gave ambiguous laughter.

Without changing his expression, Qin Mian muttered to himself, *you guys better not ask me for anything in the future.*

Chapter 017: Purchase (1)

For the first time, Qin Mian's foot hurt so much that he could hardly feel it. He had expected to meet a cart heading to town until he saw the gray city walls of the small town; it was not what he expected. It was much livelier near the town. Pedestrians came and went; some were walking, carrying baskets or carrying a pole containing vegetables, fruits, handicrafts, etc., hoping to sell some for money in the town. Some people took carts, ox carts, donkey carts and horse carriages in and out, and the grooms sometimes made a few angry yells. There were also people who rushed to sell sheep and pigs in the town. The cries of sheep and pigs came one after another, as if it was a competition.

Qin Mian rubbed his stomach. Since Lei Tie listened to him in everything, he didn't ask as he led the man into a noodle shop. In fact, he would like to eat white rice more, but knew that white rice was more expensive, so he could only bear and thought about it later on.

He found an empty table to sit down and ordered: "Shopkeeper, two bowls of vegetable noodles."

Lei Tie abruptly said: "Two bowls of shredded meat noodles."

"Okay!" The smile on the shopkeeper's face was more enthusiastic.

Qin Mian's chest was filled with a feeling that was hard to say. He looked up at Lei Tie and saw that the man wanted to say something. He was afraid the man would say something like 'you are my wife' in public, so he said it first with tone a little helpless and gloomy: "I know!"

Lei Tie asked in a low voice: "Know what?"

Qin Mian turned away from him, stared at the shop assistant cooking noodles and said calmly: “Never mind.”

The wok was steaming hot. The shop assistant scooped up the cooked noodles and put it in a bowl. With another hand, he picked up a spoon and quickly added shredded meat, chopped green onion and diced tofu into the bowl, one after another. Finally, he added a ladle of soup and poured it on top. The fragrance immediately turned stronger.

“Two customers, here are your noodles. Please enjoy it.”

Qin Mian looked at the shredded meat in the bowl and silently counted; six. He comforted himself that something was better than nothing. He took all the shredded meat and put it into his mouth before eating the noodles. A bowl of noodles would not fill a stomach. He reckoned that Lei Tie was not full. Saving money didn’t mean starving. He shouted with bold manner: “Two more bowls!” This manner was easy for people to mistake him for a nouveau riche.

The other customers in the shop looked at him strangely and someone muttered: “What are you shouting for? It’s only two bowls of noodles, not two bowls of emerald and white jade soup[1].”

The angle of Lei Tie’s mouth rose faintly to an almost imperceptible arc.

Four bowls of noodles costed 12 wen. The most important thing was that after a long time, Qin Mian finally tasted the meat for the second time. Although the shredded meat was tough and lean, Qin Mian was satisfied with it. He didn’t like food made from wheat flour, but he even drank the soup clean.

After eating, Qin Mian didn’t go to shop immediately. Instead, he went around the town and looked left and right from time to time. Lei Tie followed him silently, without any impatience or asking why.

This made Qin Mian secretly admire the man’s good temper. Lei Tie didn’t doubt that he was deliberately teasing?

The fact was, of course not. They were too short of money that it was time to find a way to make money. Qin Mian just wanted to see if there were any business opportunities in the town.

After strolling, Qin Mian knew what to do. He went to the grocery store to buy oil, salt and other necessities. There was no oil jar and salt jar at home, which also sold at the grocery shop. He bought two jars costed 6 wen, five jin salt which costed 22 wen per one jin, and two jin of oil costed 24 wen.

“Give two jin each of black pepper and Sichuan pepper.”

The shop assistant looked confused, “There is black pepper but what is Sichuan pepper?”

Qin Mian was stunned. *Could it be that there is no Sichuan pepper in this world?*

“Then, two jin of black peppers and one jin of soy sauce.” After Qin Mian finished, he glanced at the grocery store. The goods here looked quite complete. Then, he bought a spatula, ten plates, one soup bowl, ten rice bowls and ten pairs of chopsticks.

The shopkeeper was behind the counter all the time and saw that they had bought a lot of things. He came over and said enthusiastically: “What else do you need, young man? Choose at will. We basically have everything in our store.”

Qin Mian looked at the rice and flour sacks at the side. The sacks were all open for customers to see what was inside.

Qin Mian asked: “How much it cost for rice and flour?”

To be a shop assistant basically had enough quick-witted. The shop assistant immediately quoted fluently, “4 wen per jin for corn flour, 6 wen per jin for wheat flour, 1 wen per jin for sorghum flour, 3 wen per jin for glutinous millet rice flour, 2 wen per jin for brown rice and 10 wen per jin for refined rice.”

Qin Mian's eyes reluctantly left the rice and fell on the wheat flour. He was about to speak, but Lei Tie, who was so silent that his existence was practically forgotten, said, "Ten jin of rice."

For fear Qin Mian would cancel it, the shopkeeper immediately told the shop assistant, "Pack it."

Qin Mian didn't decline, "And five jin of corn flour, two jin of wheat flour, five jin of sorghum flour."

The shopkeeper's face lit up with happiness, "Alrighty."

Qin Mian also picked a set of tea sets, two porcelain cups for mouthwash, a kitchen knife, three face washcloths, a sewing set and a jar of soap powder, as well as other odds and ends.

Note:

[1] A bowl of Chinese style of Spinach Tofu soup

Chapter 018: Purchase (2)

“That’s all. Settle account.”

The shopkeeper took an abacus and calculated the account, “All total is... 272 wen. Seeing that young man takes care of my business, I’ll take out the remainder 2 wen and charge a total of 270 wen.”

Qin Mian said with a smile: “As shopkeeper said, we are taking care of your business. You see, we buy so many in one purchase, it’d be better to charge 250 wen. We will definitely come to patronize again when our oil, salt rice and flour are finished. Correct?”

Lei Tie’s eyes fell on Qin Mian, this teenager brought more and more surprises to him.

The shopkeeper was stunned and smiled helplessly. “Young man has the gift of the gab. But we are a small business and to cut down the price this way is too cruel. How about I cut another 5 wen, otherwise I will make a loss.”

“How so?” Qin Mian swiftly said, “You see the goods here are so complete, everyone who knows will come to your shop to buy things. You can imagine how prosperous the business will be. After I return to the village, I’ll help you to publicize, which will bring more money. Charge less will bring more repeat customers. It’s a good deal!”

The shopkeeper couldn’t help laughing, but there was a helpless look in his eyes. “Alright, alright, charge 250 wen is just fine.”

“Many thanks, shopkeeper.” Only then Qin Mian was satisfied, cupped one fist in the other hand towards the shopkeeper and then beckoned Lei Tie to pay the bill.

There was big pile of things; the plates, tea sets and porcelain cups which were easy to break were put in rice and flour, so not to be easily collided by pressure.

The shopkeeper nodded to himself, *this young man is clever.*

Fortunately, the basket was big enough to hold almost everything. The neck of the oil jar and the salt jar were tied with a rope and directly held in Lei Tie's hand.

When they were leaving, the shopkeeper sent them off for a bit of a distance.

Qin Mian reached out. "I'll hold oil and salt."

"No need." Lei Tie avoided his hand, "I will make more money in the future, so that you can buy whatever you want."

"*Cough cough!*" Qin Mian pretended not to hear, "We have more things to buy. Do we hire a cart? Is it expensive to hire a cart?"

"Don't know."

"Don't mind it. Spend on what should be spent; money can be earned." Qin Mian went to a cloth shop with purpose. Because he had been wandering around before, he had already remembered it.

Lei Tie walked on the outer side of him as to avoid him bumping into people as he looked around.

Once arrived at the cloth shop, Qin Mian asked about the prices of various kinds of cloth before he directly chose the cheapest linen. When he asked what color Lei Tie wants, he got "you pick" as response, and so he chose blue and cyan for himself, indigo and black for Lei Tie. Each color was to be made into a set of clothes and would be picked up in a few days. After that, he asked for two pieces of gray cloth for window curtains. Four sets of clothes, two pieces of cloth, plus the labor cost of making clothes were a total of 285 Wen.

Qin Mian was flexible and knew what to say in different situations and to different people. He called the lady shopkeeper in her early forties ‘sister’ and got 15 wen cut down easily, which surprised him a bit.

But Lei Tie didn’t feel surprised. His wife of today was no longer the black, thin and cowardly teenager. In recent days, his recuperation had come into effect and in addition, he had been exercising. His skin was not only white, but his body was also stronger, especially the pair of bright eyes were spirited. His whole person was full of vitality and there was even a little ingeniousness. On top of his eloquence, it’s hard for people to dislike him.

Coincidentally, the cloth shop sold cloth shoes. Qin Mian bought two pairs of cloth shoes for each of them and asked the shopkeeper for some odd bits of cloth. He planned to sew several pairs of socks to wear when he went back. Ah poor.

After leaving the cloth shop, the duo rushed to the food market. They didn’t have to buy vegetables as Lei’s vegetable garden had them. Qin Mian mainly bought meat; firstly, it was for entertaining guests and secondly, it was to eat to one’s heart’s content.

The shopkeeper of the butcher stall had a pair of keen eyes. When he looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, he knew that Qin Mian was the master of the two, so he took the initiative to say, “Young man, these are fresh pork. Which part do you want?”

Qin Mian’s eyes were drawn from the pieces of liver, spareribs, streaky meat, bone, lean meat and fat, “What are the prices?”

“2 wen for one jin of bone, 3 wen for liver, 10 wen for lean meat, 12 wen for spareribs, 14 wen for streaky meat and 16 wen for fat.”

Qin Mian took into consideration that he was still growing up, so bone soup was good for his health, “Two jin of bone, one jin of lean meat, two jin of liver, one jin of streaky meat and one jin of fat.”

Lei Tie said: “Can buy more fat.”

Qin Mian was taken aback, “Do you like pork fat?”

Lei Tie shook his head.

Qin Mian didn’t understand and it took a while for him to realize, *did Lei Tie think the more expensive, the better?* He smiled at Lei Tie and said to the shopkeeper, “Two Jin more fat.”

“No problem!” The shopkeeper picked up the butcher’s knife, skillfully chopped the meat and weighed it one by one.

“Young man, look at the scale. Bone is two jin[1] and two liang[2], consider two Jin for you; lean meat is one jin accurately; liver is two Jin and two liang, also consider two jin; streaky meat is one jin also accurately; fat is three jin and one liang, consider three jin. All total up to 82 wen, consider 80 wen for you.” The shopkeeper tied the bone and meat together with straw rope and handed it to Qin Mian.

“Shopkeeper is a jolly man.” Qin Mian praised and waited for Lei Tie to give the money.

Lei Tie raised his hands, both holding the jars and motioned Qin Mian to his chest.

Qin Mian glanced at Lei Tie, speechless. He took the salt jar in Lei Tie’s right hand as he looked at the man smilingly and said nothing.

Lei Tie calmly took out the money pouch and handed it to him.

Qin Mian counted 80 coins before he paid the shopkeeper and returned the salt jar to Lei Tie.

After that, they went to buy two big items ——water vat and quilt. The quilt costed 120 wen without getting even a wen discounted. But this quilt was ten jin, very thick and worth the money.

At the entrance of the town, there was an open space where there were various kinds of carts, such as ox carts, donkey carts and horse carriages. This was where one hired a cart.

When they arrived there, it was not morning anymore.

Qin Mian asked how much it cost to Green Mountain Village. The old man who drove the ox cart said it was 2 wen per person. If too many things occupied a place, they needed to pay for a seat.

Qin Mian didn't bargain this time. They got on the cart and went back home.

On the way from Running Water Town to Green Mountain Village, two women in their 30s were on their way as they chatted. One of them was Zhou Cuihua, the other was Fang Hongliu. Today, they went to town together to sell some insoles and own made luozhi. They chanced upon a lion dance performance for the town's newly open restaurant and came back late because they went to watch the bustling scene.

Hearing the sound of trod behind them, they hastily hailed.

"Cart driver, take us along!" After Zhou Cuihua finished shouting, she saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat in the cart and her wave slowed down.

Fang Hongliu didn't care. She waved, "Stop, stop."

The old man said, "Going to Green Mountain Village, right? 2 wen per person."

"2 wen?" Zhou Cuihua raised her eyebrows. "It's 2 wen from the town to our village. I've gone half way here and I still have to pay 2 wen?"

Fang Hongliu corresponded, "Exactly. Are you crazy to make profit?"

The old man waved the whip to make the ox go on and said in a low voice: "Haven't reached half way. Either sit or not."

Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu had no other choice.

"Sit, sit."

If it weren't for eggs were on sale today and standing for too long watching the bustling scene, they would be reluctant to spend the money.

The old man stopped the cart and let the two get on.

"Sit still." The old man yelled and the big yellow ox walked slowly.

Zhou Cuihua poked Fang Hongliu's arm, motioned her to look at the back and whispered, "Look at how many things they have bought, are they really planning to live together? It doesn't look probable no matter how you see it."

Fang Hongliu came close to her. "Keep your voice down. I think Qin Mian is a schemer. He was picked up by Lei Family, penniless and helpless; won't he starve to death without clinging to Lei Tie?"

Due to the spiritual spring water, Qin Mian's five senses were very sharp. He was looking at the scenery and turned around when he heard that. In Lei's house, he didn't talk back to Du Shi besides not wanting to incite trouble, another reason was that he didn't want to fuss with women, but now he didn't want to be silent. Otherwise, wouldn't others treat him as a soft persimmon?

"Aunt, isn't it bad to mind so much about the family affairs of us men? Fortunately, we know etiquette, but if people who don't know etiquette hear it, they will think you have some hidden motives." Qin Mian's tone was of console and concern.

Fang Hongliu was taken aback and followed by anger. She turned her head, "What did you say, stinky boy?"

"I don't stink, but I smell a bad breath." Qin Mian pointedly looked at her mouth.

"You!" Fang Hongliu turned her body around and raised her hand.

A shiny kitchen knife suddenly stood between them.

"Wife, this kitchen knife doesn't look handy." Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian almost laughed, Lei Tie was too cool. “Nonsense. Why is the new kitchen knife not handy? If it is cutting bone, it must be the same as cutting tofu.”

Fang Hongliu quivered and put down her hand as if it was electrocuted. She also turned around, back stiffened.

Zhou Cuihua also looked at Qin Mian in surprise. Seeing him looking at her lightly, she turned around quickly, her heart pounding.

Scared you guys not to death. Qin Mian chuckled and lay lazily against the basket behind him. He could eat meat tonight which made him in a good mood. This little episode had not affected his mood at all.

The old man who drove seemed to hear nothing. The ox cart walked slowly and left behind the green mountains on both sides.

Fang Hongliu and Zhou Cuihua didn't talk again. As soon as the ox cart arrived at the entrance of the village, the two couldn't wait to jump down, leaving four copper coins behind before they walked away in a run.

Qin Mian said politely, “Uncle, we have a lot of things, could you please send us to the door? Our house is not far ahead.”

“Sure.”

The ox cart took a turn and drove all the way to the entrance of their house.

They got out of the cart and paid the money with word of thanks.

Then, the old man drove away.

Note:

[1] 斤jīn = catty; weight equal to 0.5 kg

[2] 两liǎng = unit of weight equal to 50 grams (modern) or $\frac{1}{16}$ of a catty (jin)

Chapter 019: A Busy Day

Lei Tie threw the money pouch to Qin Mian, opened the door and carried the big water vat into the house.

Qin Mian smiled and went into the bedroom with the money pouch. He still put it in the wooden box and locked it with a new lock. The key was put under the mattress first before he put a string to wear on his person.

“Wife, I’ll go carry water.”

Since the protest against this title was to no avail, Qin Mian didn’t bother about it with him anymore and nodded immediately, “Alright.”

After Lei Tie left with two buckets, Qin Mian took out the dishware in the rice and flour sacks, heated up water to wipe the new water vat several times, then soaked the new dishware and tea sets in the boiling water to simply disinfected them. There was no cupboard, so he brought the low table in the bedroom and put the dishware on it. Rice and flour were put in their bedroom for the time being and be taken care of in the night, so as not to be eaten by rats.

Qin Mian then made some paste with flour and picked up the white paper on the ground to stick onto the window.

Once Lei Tie had filled the water vat, he came quietly to help.

“I can take care of this alone.” Qin Mian looked at the sky. “It’s late. Go to Brother Zhang’s house to inform him first, so that Sister Zhang doesn’t have to cook Brother Zhang’s meal portion.”

After thinking about it, he looked at Lei Tie and explained that since they want to live together, the misunderstandings that could be avoided should

be avoided. “It’s not that I don’t want to invite Sister Zhang and their children. Brother Zhang and Sister Zhang are not necessarily willing to let their children know about us two men living together. If we invite without consideration, it may turn awkward. We’ll consider that again after the two of our families have deeper association.”

“I understand.” Lei Tie pressed him on the shoulder.

Qin Mian put off his worry and continued to arrange work for the man. “You take the basket and pick some vegetables in the vegetable garden, such as eggplant, bitter melon and whatnot. Pick a lot of chili and some other green vegetables you see. You’d better bring back some potatoes and don’t forget to cut some if there are green onions. Eggs... Forget it, the villagers must have kept eggs for busy farming season, I’m afraid we can’t buy even if we pay. Oh, forgot to buy wine!” He tapped on his forehead in frustration.

“There is a wine shop in the village. Don’t worry.” Lei Tie nodded and went away.

Qin Mian watched him go far before he quickly scooped a bowl of spring water from the space and added it into the water vat and continued to bustle about.

After all the windows were pasted with paper, he nailed two nails on the top of each of the two windows in the room, tied a string in between the nails and then hung two pieces of cloth on the top before he sewed several stitches to avoid it falling off. It was a simple version of sliding curtain. Not pleasing, but practical.

“Wife, I’m back.”

Qin Mian was rinsing rice and almost splashed the rinsing water onto his feet. *So be it if you are back, is it necessary to say it deliberately? Is it necessary to add a “wife”? Is it necessary to be so loud?*

Lei Tie put the wine jar on the table and the basket beside Qin Mian. “Eldest Uncle Jiang next door [at Lei’s] gave ten eggs.”

Feeling touch, Qin Mian said: “Eldest Uncle Jiang is a warm-hearted man.” All the good things someone done to them was remembered in his mind, so he could return the favors later on.

He shook the water off his hand, rummaged through the basket and gave Lei Tie a funny look. This was really something that someone who was not in charge of the household could do. In addition to eggs, there were several purple eggplants, several bitter melons, handful of green onions, some green peppers, three big potatoes, a handful of chrysanthemum greens and a handful of leeks in the basket. There were a lot of variety, but there were only a handful of leeks enough to fry for a small plate; the chrysanthemum greens seemed a lot, but it was sure to fill two or three mouthfuls after stir-fried. There were going to be several adult men to dine together in the evening, so it would not be enough. Fortunately, there were leeks and chrysanthemum greens in his space. He would add some when Lei Tie didn’t notice.

Lei Tie looked at the basket. “What’s wrong?”

“Nothing.” Qin Mian said with a smile.

Lei Tie thought he didn’t tell the truth, but he didn’t ask again. “Not enough stool. I’ll go to the mountain back to chop some wood stumps.”

“Go ahead. I don’t need your help here.”

Qin Mian cooked the rice first, cleaned the pig liver, cut it into thin slices and soaked it in water. Although pig liver contained a variety of nutrients as well as fresh and tasty, it must be detoxified before eating, because pig liver was the largest detoxification organ in pig body. After cleaning, it was best to cut into thin slices and soaked for one to two hours to eliminate residual blood. But today, he was in a hurry to cook. He could only soak it first and fry it last. When it was time to fry it, he could fry it for a while.

Because there was no tenderizer powder and starch, Qin Mian used eggs as tenderizer. He mixed the egg white with the thinly sliced meat and cured for a while. Today was for their own enjoyment and serving guests. Until their

financial conditions become better, there could be no such luxury. When he was in town, he had inquired that an egg costed a wen, not cheap.

Afterwards, Qin Mian cleaned the bones and fat, and prepared them the same for use.

Lei Tie came back with a few wood stumps. Qin Mian directed him to pick the edible part of the vegetables while he started to cook.

When there were two dishes left [to be cooked], Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to invite people.

When Brother Zhang, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao followed Lei Tie, it had been passed six o'clock in the evening. The setting sun dyed the western sky orange.

Smelling the attractive fragrance, several people involuntarily wanted to quicken their steps but suddenly realized that they were in a bit of a state of disrespect, they hurriedly restrained themselves and followed Lei Tie to walk neither slow nor fast.

Consequently, they didn't notice that Lei Tie was moving faster than usual.

"Eldest brother, we can smell the fragrance all the way. It seems that the eldest sister-in-law is not only good at cooking, but also very well at craftsmanship." Lei Xiangli said with a smile.

Zhang Dashuan nodded and laughed out loud, "It seems that we have the luck to get something nice to eat today."

In the house, the fragrance was stronger. Stewed pork bone with potato, sautéed shredded pork with green pepper, stewed pork fat with eggplant, simple version of twice cooked pork, bitter melon with scrambled egg, stir fried chrysanthemum greens and stir fried leeks had been brought to the table in the central room in all sort of colors and flavors.

There was surprise in Lei Tie's eyes but it soon turned serene.

The Lei brothers and sister as well as Zhang Dashuan were stunned speechless at the dishes on the table. At the same time, they sighed with emotion: *Lei Tie family's [wife] / eldest sister-in-law is very generous in treating guest.* In fact, Qin Mian had made some reservations. He kept half of the lean meat. The fat was oily, there were only seven or eight pieces of fat in the eggplant stew, but the taste was not bad. The rest of the fat was extracted to make lard.

The Lei brothers and sister couldn't help swallowing their saliva. Du Shi didn't begrudge them in treatment compared to Lei Tie, but in general she was a stingy person. The family ate meat less than a few times a year and she was reluctant to put more oil in the cooking. Qin Mian's cooking today was comparable to that of a wedding banquet for them.

"Second brother and second sister-in-law must be very regretful if they knew." Lei Chuntao was laughing and whispering in Lei Xiangli's ear.

When they went out, Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi was ridiculing Lei Tie and Qin Mian in innuendo. Lei Xiangli could not help laughing at the expression that his second sister-in-law would show when she knew they had eaten something good.

Qin Mian appeared carrying stir fried pork liver with green pepper that was just scooped out of the wok. He said with a smile, "Please sit down."

"Eldest sister-in-law." Lei Xiangyi and the others spoke in unison.

"Lei Tie family's [wife], pardon my intrusion." Zhang Dashuan also said.

"Sit down." Qin Mian put the dishes down. "There are no outsiders; there is no need to stand on ceremonies."

The few of them thanked as they each took a seat.

Lei Tie opened the wine jar to pour wine for the few people. Without wine cups, he directly used bowls.

After Lei Tie poured wine for Zhang Dashuan and the others, he wanted to pour for Qin Mian but was stopped by Qin Mian. He wanted to leave his stomach for eating meat.

“I won’t drink. You guys drink to your heart’s content.”

At the table, Lei Chuntao was the only girl, but because there were basically her elder brothers at the table, she didn’t need to pay much attention to segregation between male and female. Lei Xiangli was sitting on her left side and Lei Xiangzhi was sitting on her right side.

Qin Mian was afraid that Lei Chuntao would not be comfortable, “Little sister, are you going to eat some dishes first or directly eat cooked rice? Your eldest brother’s home is the same as your own, help yourself.”

Lei Chuntao hurriedly said: “Eldest sister-in-law, you don’t have to take care of me specially. I won’t stand on ceremonies with you guys. Eldest sister-in-law’s craftsmanship is so good. I’ll eat the dishes first, and then I’ll scoop the cooked rice myself.”

Qin Mian saw her conducted herself in natural and unrestrained manner, he nodded and said nothing more.

Zhang Dashuan and the others also started eating. Their mouths were full of praise for Qin Mian’s craftsmanship. They felt that even the potatoes in the bone stew were tender and fragrant, which made people want to swallow their tongues.

“I’m flattered. Don’t just drink wine, eat more dishes.” Qin Mian smiled and said simply, pretending to be bashful, eating the dishes from time to time.

Lei Tie had few words, but Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi were all eloquent. The atmosphere on the wine table was relatively warm.

After finishing meal, the guests were very pleased. Except for stir fried leek and stir fried chrysanthemum green still had a few left, all the other dishes were eaten clean.

Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were all drunk, but not to the extent of not being able to walk. Lei Tie and Lei Xiangzhi had drunk less.

Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to send them off, but they refused and went away with a smile.

It's already dark, but the moon was high, so he wasn't worried for them not being able to see the way.

Zhang Dashuan lived at the other end of the village, so the few of them split up halfway.

Lei Chuntao snorted, "I dare say second sister-in-law hasn't slept yet, waiting for us to go back and laugh at us. I'll tell her later what fine food we ate to keep her awake all night!" After that, she could not help laughing.

Lei Xiangzhi suddenly said, "Third brother, fourth brother and little sister, I think it's better not to mention about it."

"Why?" Lei Xiangyi and the two were puzzled.

Lei Xiangzhi sighed, "Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law finally get peace, better let them be in peace."

Lei Xiangyi and the two thought of their mother and second sister-in-law with a temper that wished for the whole world to be in chaos, and they nodded at the same time.

"Okay, no mention."

Chapter 020: Autumn Harvest

When Qin Mian finished washing the dishware, he put everything back to its original position before he walked out of the kitchen and saw Lei Tie sitting at the table, with one hand supporting his chin, head drooping, eyes closed and the smell of the wine on his body wafted with the wind.

He brought rock salt to the outside of the house and squatted on the ground. While gurgling, he sensed the quietness all around; his mind was at peace. Moving out was indeed a good start.

Afterwards, he went to the bedroom to get clean clothes and scooped hot water into the tub. There was no bathroom, so he had to make do and lifted the bathtub outside. He took off his clothes and went in. He felt so comfortable that he breathed a sigh of relief. Just then he secretly added some spiritual spring water to the bathwater. Now he felt very comfortable to soak in that the previous hard work was not worth mentioning.

Lei Tie opened his eyes and heard the sound of the water outside. His eyes were like a well without waves[1], his thoughts unknown.

After taking a bath, Qin Mian felt refreshed. Water had splashed everywhere and he relaxingly stretched out, “I’ll go to sleep first. There is still hot water in the wok, it should be enough for you.”

“Nn. Today, I passed by the rice field, the rice can be harvested.” Lei Tie said.

It seemed that Lei Tie was still very sober, Qin Mian said his own thoughts, “I think we should buy the home site first, so that we can open a vegetable field nearby to grow some vegetables, otherwise we will have to spend money to buy vegetables two months later.”

Lei Tie was about to go to the kitchen but turned around, “Go tomorrow morning.”

Qin Mian did not ask where he was going to buy it but he nodded and entered the bedroom.

Lei Tie looked at the two mouthwash cups placed side by side in the kitchen, he stood still for a moment before he picked up the one which was not wet to gargle.

After cleaning himself, he put the bolt on and blew the oil lamp before he went to the bedroom. Qin Mian had closed his eyes and lay on the side of the bed, leaning to the edge of the bed. Lei Tie didn't mind, he opened the quilt and went into bed, lying on his side facing Qin Mian. It was because he knew that the little guy would automatically squeeze into his arms when he fell asleep.

This night, Qin Mian slept very comfortably without a dream until he naturally woke up. It was bright outside the window and the sunlight came in through the gap in the curtain, soundless and stirless.

Outside the house, there was a sound of blade being sharpened. Lei Tie was sitting in front of a sharpening stone, intently sharpening a sickle.

The sunlight casted a shadow on his forehead, making his angular face softer. Qin Mian stared blankly for a few seconds before regaining his mind.

“Sorry, I got up late. I'll make breakfast now.” Qin Mian felt a little ashamed. He scratched at the tangled hair on his head and coughed softly to ease the embarrassment.

Lei Tie took a look at him and shook his head before continuing to sharpen the blade. “I'll go to the field first.”

Qin Mian wanted to ask about the home site, but thought it was important to harvest rice and so he swallowed the question. “I will send you food soon. By the way, why only one sickle?”

“I can do it alone.” Lei Tie stood up.

Qin Mian had other things to do, but thought that he and Lei tie had only a rice field which could be done in one day with Lei Tie’s strength, so he didn’t insist on helping. Looking at the sky, he estimated that it’s nearly nine o’clock and quickly stepped into the kitchen to light fire, mixed wheat flour with water to make a semi-thick liquid, added in chopped green onion, salt, minced meat and eggs, then stirred evenly. Then he quickly made a few sheet of savory chopped onion meat pancakes. He kept three for himself and the remaining seven were rolled up and put in a bowl. Afterwards, he put a lid on before putting it in a small basket. After a thought, he found a clean water jar and filled it with cold [boiled] water. He locked the door and went to send the food to Lei Tie. In his hand was a chopped onion meat pancake which he ate while walking.

The sun was shining brightly in the sky. In the golden rice field, there were farmers bending over to harvest rice. As they quickly and skillfully waved the sickle, a handful of rice stalk was cut down and soon piled high. People dreaded rain in the harvest season, so no one was chatting and everyone was racing against the clock. Only a few rice fields matured a little later. From a distance, the golden yellow was like plushy carpet.

When people in the field heard the movement on the ridge, they looked up. Qin Mian smiled politely and nodded in assent. People with good attitude gave him smile; people with bad attitude quickly lowered their heads.

Qin Mian didn’t pay any attention at all. He soon arrived at “his family’s” rice field and was surprised to see that one *mu* of rice filed had been cut to one fifth.

Lei Tie was bending down to work. With a sickle, he cut down a lot of rice stalks. He consciously glanced at the back and upon seeing Qin Mian, the indifference in his eyes faded away.

Qin Mian waved, “Brother Tie, eat first.”

In the nearby rice field, an old man in his early fifties was leading two young robust men harvesting rice. Seeing Qin Mian, the old man’s eyes

narrowed as he chuckled a few times, “What tasty food did Lei Tie’s wife[2] deliver to Lei Tie?”

Qin Mian found out that the old man was Li Zheng, he was surprised. In ancient rural areas, it could be said that Li Zheng was the villager’s parental official[3] and having a good relationship with Li Zheng could reduce a lot of troubles. Were Lei Daqiang and Du Shi confused or stupid? It was a real surprise that they were given the rice field that was adjacent to Li Zheng.

He walked over quickly. “Is Uncle Li busy? Unexpectedly, the fields of our families are adjacent. It’s a coincidence, later on we will have to bother Uncle Li Zheng a lot to keep an eye on. I made some chopped onion meat pancakes. If Uncle Li Zheng and the two big brothers don’t dislike it, do want to try it?”

Uncle Li Zheng hurriedly declined, “How can we? No need, no need. ”

His two sons had smelled the fragrance and couldn’t help looking into the basket.

Qin Mian gave Lei Tie a hint with his eyes.

Lei Tie took the basket, brought out the bowl and took out three pancakes before he handed them to Li Zheng, “Uncle Li Zheng, taste it. My family’s made is not worth anything.”

Li Zheng had to rub his hands on his clothes before he took the chopped onion meat pancakes and gave two pieces to his two sons. He took a bite. The lingering aftertaste of the egg with the rich taste of the meat complemented each other well. He nodded repeatedly, “Delicious. Lei Tie’s wife’s craftsmanship is good.”

Note:

[1] Well without waves = have no more sexual desire

[2] 家的= jiā de= (old) wife. So jia de [family’s] is an old address for a wife... huuhu... why did I find it late? Anyhow, from now on, a lot of

changes will be made. You might not notice it anyway.

[3]父母官parental official (a popular term for a county magistrate)

Chapter 021: First Pot of Gold — Manual Noodle Maker (1)

“Uncle Li Zheng flattered me.” Qin Mian took a look at the paddy in the field and praised, “Uncle is worthy of being a good farmer. Seeing that the ears of the paddy are full, there must be a good harvest this year.” In fact, it’s a left-handed compliment. This paddy was much worse than what he’d seen in previous life.

“Hahaha...” Li Zheng burst out laughing, knowing that Qin Mian was trying to pick up good words, but it was so simple that it made people felt at ease, “Nah, your field’s also good.”

Qin Mian made modest remarks and didn’t talk to Li Zheng anymore. The so-called catching up was not a business transaction but these words were truthful when it came to interpersonal communication. It would seem hypocritical to say too much good words.

Lei Tie ate the chopped onion meat pancakes and only when he finished did he asked: “Have you eaten?”

Qin Mian said: “No yet. I’ll go back now and deliver your lunch at noon.”

“Send it to the grain-sunning ground.” Lei Tie caught a sight of Lei Xiangren walking his way in big strides and he stuffed the basket into Qin Mian’s arms. “Go back.”

Qin Mian also saw Lei Xiangren. He took the basket and left. He didn’t like Lei Xiangren very much and if he could avoid contact with him, he would. Lei Tie was Lei Xiangren’s eldest brother, so it would have to be wronged to deal with him.

After a few steps, he turned his head and smiled sympathetically at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie was baffled, he raised his chin slightly.

Qin Mian guessed that Lei Tie was urging him to go quickly. Smiling, he quickened his pace and went home leisurely.

Li Zheng took in the whole scene of the situation here and shook his head secretly. He ate up the chopped onion meat pancake in two-three bites and he continued to harvest paddy.

“Eldest brother, Father told me to ask you to harvest paddy.”

“My paddy is still not completely collected.”

“When you have finished harvesting this field, go there.”

“No, I still have to thresh the grain later.”

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Qin Mian had gone far but still faintly heard Lei Xiangren’s indubitable tone and Lei Tie’s indifferent response. He laughed silently and praised Lei Tie in his heart: Good!

When he got home, he filled his stomach and washed their clothes first. Then he found that there was a bamboo pole between the two trees in front of the house. The two ends of the bamboo pole were fixed on the branch of the trees which as tall as a person and tightly bound with cloth strips.

This must be the “clothesline” made by Lei Tie.

A smile involuntarily emerged from the corners of Qin Mian’s lips. After hanging the clothes, he went back to the house to start his “first pot of gold[1] plan”.

There were two main things that he was good at in the previous life; one was farming, the other was gourmet food. In today’s backward era, planting

food in the field was toilsome and it's impossible to make any money. He could only start with gourmet food.

Yesterday in the town, due to the rushing time, he just strolled about and discovered the first business opportunity — manual noodle maker. He had calculated that there were more than 20 noodle shops in the town and their noodles were all made in this way: first, mixed the flour well, then rolled the dough into thin sheets with a rolling pin and then cut the noodles into strips with skilled knife work. This was not only tiring, but also toilsome. He believed that if he made the manual noodle maker, it would sell.

Qin Mian found the paper left over from yesterday's window pasting, took out a pencil from the space, and drew all the parts of the manual noodle maker, including the container for the dough, the handle and the templates with several small holes on it. The principle of manual noodle maker was also simple, mainly by extrusion, somewhat similar to air pump. Placed the dough in the fuselage, held the handle and pressed it down, the dough would be extruded from several holes at the bottom and became strips of noodles. If one wanted to eat thin noodles, just used the base template with smaller holes and for flat noodle, used the base template with larger holes. It was very convenient.

After he was done drawing and verified it, Qin Mian put away the blue print, took out the oddments of cloth he bought yesterday, found the manual sewing machine from the space and sewed several pairs of socks. Then, he did fitting and felt it was a little loose. He sewed two belts at the sock's opening, which could be tied like leggings to prevent slipping. The socks were ugly in appearance, but better in fine stitching. Even if Lei Tie saw it, he would only think that Qin Mian was good at needlework and would not think that he had a cheat.

He washed the several pairs of socks and hung them on the bamboo pole outside.

Looking at the sun, it's almost noon.

Qin Mian picked some vegetables directly from the space and prepared lunch. He made sautéed shredded pork with green pepper with the

remaining lean meat of yesterday, chive omelet and cold eggplant salad. Lei Tie had a large appetite, so he directly filled the cooked rice in a big soup bowl. He also put half of the three dishes into the bowl, covered it with a plate and put in the basket. In the same way, he used a water jar to fill cold boiled water.

The vegetables in the space tasted delicious. Qin Mian wiped out the rest of the dishes, burped two times before he picked up the basket to deliver lunch to Lei Tie.

The grain-sunning ground, which used to be the place where he and Lei Tie roasted corn, covered an area of about one and a half mu and was divided into eight squares of similar size. When Qin Mian arrived, the villagers wearing straw hats were in full swing busy under the big sun. Some of them were speedily spreading out the newly picked paddy crops, ready to thresh; the quick farmers were already driving the oxen to pull the stone roller to crush it, raising the whip and making loud yells from time to time; and some villagers put the threshed grains into sacks because there were others waiting to use the grain-sunning ground; below the haystack beside the grain-sunning ground, three sweaty men sat in the shade, gobbling food and talking loudly.

There were more than 20 people on the grain-sunning ground. Somehow, Qin Mian saw Lie Tie standing alone in the corner of the grain-sunning ground, bending over to spread out the paddy crops.

Note:

[1] From My First Pot of Gold, an American business handbook for Chinese immigrants written by consultant Karina Wong. Chinese came to San Francisco Gold Rush for mining gold and in the new millennium, it means Chinese start their own business to seek wealth.

Chapter 022: 600 Jin of Paddy

Beside Lei Tie, there were bundles of paddy tied by a rope made of straw. He untied the rope and spread the paddy on the ground. The sweat on his cheek rolled down one by one and disappeared onto the paddy, the bare sturdy arms were shining under the scorching sun.

Standing not far away was a few idle women chatting away with baskets hanging on their arms, about to send food to their own men.

There were another four to five farmers gathered for meal and spoke loudly.

“Lao Liu, your family only harvested paddy in the field south of the village this morning, right? That field is less than 7 fen[1]. I saw you pulled seven or eight carts to the grain-sunning ground in the morning, such good harvest ah! We are fellow villagers, if you have any secret recipe for farming, you must have hid it.” The speaker’s face looked envious.

Another man was annoyed by what he said. The man sneered and said: “Who in few miles of the village doesn’t know Third Brother you likes to hang around in *other people’s* fields when you don’t have anything to do? If I really have a secret recipe, can I hide it from you?”

Several others laughed heartily at the words and didn’t cut in, taking pleasure to watch them fight.

The pervious speaker laughed hollowly, “Look at what you say. Even forbid people who had nothing to do to roam around casually?”

Everyone laughed even louder. They all knew what Third Brother thought.

Qin Mian glanced at them but didn’t see any acquaintances and went directly to Lei Tie’s side.

“Brother Tie, eat first.”

“Nn.” Lei Tie followed after him to the short willow tree beside the grain-sunning ground and took the basket in his hand.

Qin Mian liked to be clean. He couldn’t stand the sweat on the man’s face and took out the water jar in the basket. “I’ll pour the water, wash your face.”

Lei Tie nodded and took off the new face washcloth hanging on his neck to soak it with cold water. He wiped his face, neck and hands and suddenly felt much cooler.

Lei Tie sat on a bundle of paddy as he uncovered the lid and saw the dishes in the bowl. His black pupils were dyed with some faint warmth, “Have you eaten?”

“Yes.” Qin Mian sat down beside him and looked around casually.

The grain-sunning ground was located at the edge of the village. It was an open space and the trees around were not dense that one could see the scenery in all directions. In the field, people were busy transporting the harvested paddy to the grain-sunning ground. Some people used oxen to pull the cart, others use donkeys, more people relied on their shoulders to carry using a sturdy shoulder pole hanging a bundle at each end and the heavy paddy tottering on their shoulders along the pace. Although tired, the farmers still wore a satisfied smile on their faces. This year’s harvest was slightly better than that of the previous years. Although they had to pay a lot of land taxes, there were still some left for them and their families also could solidly eat few meals of white rice.

Qin Mian turned his head to ask Lei Tie, “We don’t have animal power. Do we need to borrow from others?”

Lei Tie took a bite of chive omelet and spoke profusely with strong fragrance. “There are too many monks and too little gruel[2]. If I can’t borrow it, I’ll pull the stone roller myself.”

Qin Mian was surprised and opened his mouth but he didn't know what to say. Pulling by manpower? His eyes drifted to an idle stone roller beside the grain-sunning ground. This thing weighed at least 400~500 jin. Even if he could pull it, it would be very tiring, right? At this time, he felt that their family was poor, without a house or a cart. Although this was ancient era, the cart was also divided into 3-6-9 grade[3]. Donkey cart was equivalent to modern three-wheeled vehicle, ox cart was equivalent to modern car and horse carriage was equivalent to modern BMW level. Qin Mian's goal in this life was to buy a cart. Don't say buying a 'BMW', having a three-wheeled vehicle was good enough.

With a large bowl in his hand, Zhang Dashuan came over with big strides while eating a big mouthful of meal. He was accompanied by a black faced young man in his early twenties with handsome facial features and a tall, thin figure, also carrying a big black porcelain bowl in his hand as he pushed food into his mouth and made a loud chewing sound.

“Tiezi, what's tasty food are you eating?”

“Brother Zhang.” Qin Mian got up to greet.

Zhang Dashuan introduced the young man beside him to Qin Mian, “This is my neighbor, Wu Di.”

“Greeting, sister[4].” Wu Di had a smile on his face and his eyes were very lively when he looked at Lei Tie's bowl, “Brother Tie, what kind of food does sister make for you? I can smell it all the way.”

Several women in the field saw this and whispered.

“Are Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di stupid? What kind of people are Lei Tie and Qin Mian? They (ZD&WD) actually went to join those (LT&QM).”

The woman who was talking was glared at by her man, “Do you have to care about other people's family?”

Lei Tie moved the bowl to Zhang Dashuan's direction. “My wife made sautéed shredded pork with green pepper, chive omelet and cold eggplant

salad.”

He ate in refined manner. Currently, there were still many dishes in the bowl.

Qin Mian looked into the bowl of Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di quietly. There were two salted eggs in Zhang Dashuan’s bowl and Wu Di’s bowl was full of vegetables, but he could see that there was much oil.

Zhang Dashuan unceremoniously took a clip of shredded pork with green pepper from Lei Tie’s bowl and upon seeing the greedy but embarrassed appearance of Wu Di, he laughed. He squatted down on the side. They were all families of peasant, who didn’t pay much attention about chewing with mouth closed and lay [to rest] with silent. “Tiezi, how are you going to thresh your paddy?” While he spoke, he glanced at Wu Di either by design or accident.

Wu Di looked at the spread out paddy. His eyes immediately lit up and he hurriedly opened his mouth before Lei Tie answered, “Brother Tie, my family only harvested less than a half of the paddy in our field. After this, we are not going to thresh it. In the afternoon, we will continue to harvest. You can use our donkey.”

For fear that Lei Tie would be silly, Qin Mian took the bowl out of his hand and brought it in front of Wu Di, “Many thanks. If you don’t dislike it, try some.”

“No dislike, no dislike. How fragrant! Thanks Brother Tie, thanks sister.” Wu Di grinned and stretched out his chopsticks, but not taking too much. He took a bit of shredded pork with green pepper and a small piece of chive omelet.

Lei Tie still kept the posture of holding the bowl with his left hand. Looking at Qin Mian, his gaze both carried helplessness and a little connivance.

Zhang Dashuan saw it clearly and quickly took back his gaze, bowed his head to eat.

“Eat.” Qin Mian returned the bowl to Lei Tie, patted him on the shoulder as a token of comfort and said generously, “If you like it, I can cook these three dishes for dinner.”

Lei Tie nodded, mixed the remaining dishes with the cooked rice and began to eat again.

Qin Mian was kind to the young man, “Wu Di, thank you so much for today. After done with the busy season, Brother Tie and I will invite you to dinner.”

Wu Di waved his hand, “It’s not worth being anything. Anyway, my donkey is idle.”

“Just agree on this.” Qin Mian insisted.

Wu Di then no longer refused and happily nodded, “Then, deference is no substitute for obedience[5]. I’ve heard Brother Zhang said that sister is good at craftsmanship. I’ve the luck to get something nice to eat.”

“At that time, I’ll have to bother Brother Zhang to accompany him then.” Qin Mian said to Zhang Dashuan. He didn’t fail to see that Zhang Dashuan intended to help.

Zhang Dashuan and Lei Tie had a good relationship, it would be too hypocritical to be polite and so he laughingly said, “Of course that’s fine.”

After finishing lunch, Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di left in a hurry as they would have to continue to be busy in the afternoon.

Lei Tie ate all the food and drank half the water.

“Go back. Sunning. ”

Qin Mian didn’t get up at once, but asked: “When will you finish the work here?”

Lei Tie answered: “Four hours top.”

Qin Mian asked tentatively: “What about your parents’ side?”

Lei Tie said in a low voice: “We take care of ourselves first.”

Qin Mian nodded in his heart with great satisfaction, “I’ll go back and tidy up first, then come to help.”

“No need.” Lei Tie looked at the sun as he refused.

Qin Mian didn’t say anything verbally, he had his own opinion. He went home to wash the dishware, locked the door, made a straw hat out of bamboo strips, took the basket with him as well and went to the grain-sunning ground. He didn’t want to be in the sun either, but since he and Lei Tie were a family for the time being, he had to take some responsibility for this family. Otherwise, he wasn’t living in a reasonable way.

When Wu Di’s family done with the donkey, Lei Tie led the donkey over and took the stone roller to begin threshing the paddy. Qin Mian turned the paddy over with a pitchfork and the process continued on. After so many times doing this, almost two hours later, Lei Tie stopped, took over the fork in Qin Mian’s hand, picked up the stalk and saw to it that the grains had basically fallen off. He nodded to Qin Mian and led the donkey away.

After threshing, the paddy stalks becomes rice straws, which could be used as burning material or fodder. Qin Mian picked up all the straws with the pitchfork and piled them aside. When he picked them up, he had to shake them a few times to make sure that all the grains in the stalks were shaken off. Afterwards, he swept them with a bamboo broom to form a pile.

When Lei Tie came back, he used a wooden shovel to winnow. The wind blew in waves; the dust and the chaff in the grains were blown away along the wind, leaving only clean grains.

Their one mu of paddy field eventually harvested 600 jin of paddy, filled in five big sacks. After sunning, it’s about 400 jin, which was too low for modern society, but it’s not bad for this era.

Lei Tie easily picked up a sack onto his shoulder and carried the grain home in five trips. The straws were all tied up and transported back home the same way.

On the last trip, they picked some vegetables in Lei's vegetable garden.

Lei Tie brought clean clothes to bathe in the river but Qin Mian bathed in hot water at home before he started to prepare dinner.

The dishes for dinner were the same as they had at noon but there was no lean meat left, the sautéed shredded pork with green pepper turned into sautéed streaky pork with green pepper.

Lei Tie ate a lot, as if he wanted to make up for what he ate less at noon. The green pepper was very spicy, but the spiciness lessened with the cooked rice. Both of them were satisfied.

After the dinner, the sun would set.

"I have something to discuss with you." Qin Mian said as he cleared away the dishware.

"What is it?" Lei Tie looked at the socks hung on the bamboo pole outside the house.

Note:

[1] 1 fen = 61.44 m²

[2] 僧多粥少 [sēng duō zhōu shǎo] = There are too many monks and too little gruel — cannot meet the needs of the people; The monks are many and the supply of gruel is meager — not enough to go around;

[3] 3-6-9 grade means various grades and ranks

[4] Sister (saozi) here is an address to married woman/someone's wife

[5] deference is no substitute for obedience (idiom); (said to accept sb's request, invitation etc)

Chapter 023: First Pot of Gold — Manual Noodle Maker (2)

Qin Mian took the dishware into the kitchen. Coming out, he wiped his hands, took out the blueprint and handed it over to Lei Tie. “This is my drawing of a manual noodle maker.”

A manual noodle maker? Lei Tie looked at the paper doubtfully. First of all, he felt that the strokes were very delicate that he didn’t know what it was drawn with. For the moment, he put his doubts in his heart and looked at the contents of the drawing. This little wife had many doubtful points on him, just like this one.

The drawing was clear, concise and easy to understand.

Qin Mian sat down beside Lei Tie. “Didn’t we go to town yesterday? I found out that most of the noodles in the noodle shops in town are freshly-made, freshly eat, which is very time-consuming. This manual noodle maker can make noodles quickly and store noodles for a long time after they are air-dried. I have two ideas. Either sell this blueprint to a craftsman, or find a craftsman to make noodle makers and sell to taverns and noodle shops. It can be sold for a good price.”

Lei Tie stared at him for a moment and he began to speak but then hesitated. This little wife of his seemed to be in a hurry to make money. His eyes went back to the drawing, a smear of deep pondering streaked across his eyes, “If it’s as you said, why don’t you keep it and run your own noodle shop?”

He didn’t expect that this ancient man had such quick thinking. Qin Mian looked at him approvingly, “I think so, too. But we are common people

without a backer. Once such a good thing is fancied by powerful and influential people, I'm afraid it will cause trouble." He also had a lot of money making ideas, not particularly concerned about the noodle maker. At present, the most important thing was to earn enough money to build tile-roofed house with the fastest speed. He didn't want to live in a thatched cottage.

Lei Tie had a change of heart and changed his opinion, "The price can't be low."

"Of course." Qin Mian nodded affirmatively, "isn't this new technology anyway? I think so. If I sell the blueprint, I will sell it for 50 silver tael. If I sell the noodle maker, I will sell one noodle maker for 2 silver tael. How is it?"

Lei Tie said: "5 tael."

Qin Mian couldn't help laughing. He didn't expect that Lei Tie was also a man who loved money. When he thought about it carefully, 5 silver tael was equivalent to 5000 yuan in modern times. It shouldn't be expensive for those noodle shops.

He frowned in some embarrassment. "No matter who it is sold to, it's better to make a finished product. But if we find a craftsman to do it, won't they disclose the content of the drawing?"

Lei Tie said in a low voice: "I'll do it."

Qin Mian looked surprised. "You will do it?"

Lei Tie nodded, "Going to the mountain tomorrow to chop wood."

Qin Mian was curious about Lei Tie's experience in the past decade. What's actually did he experienced? Unlike the country folk, Lei Tie could hunt, read and worked as a carpenter.

Lei Tie stood up. "Go to sleep."

“Wait.” Qin Mian stopped him and said, “Since I have come up with an idea to make money for our family, shouldn’t you wash the dishware from now on? This family belongs to both of us. I have expended, you should also expend.”

Lei Tie was taken aback and without saying a word, he turned to the kitchen.

Ah, good man. Qin Mian gave his back a thumbs up and followed him in. “There is hot water in the wok. Use the hot water otherwise it won’t be washed clean. After washing, rinse three times. ”

Lei Tie didn’t make a sound, but did as told.

Rest assured, Qin Mian took the mouthwash cup and face cloth to wash up. Before he entered the house, he conveniently collected the clothes on the clothes-drying pole. After a day drying under in the sun, there was a smell of sunshine on the clothes. He folded the clothes and placed them separately; eight pairs of socks were also placed separately, four pairs for each person.

After putting things in order, he climbed onto bed and beat out a yawn.

After a while, Lei Tie came in.

“I made you four pairs of socks, in the trunk.”

“Nn.”

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows. No thanks? He turned over to the wall and was ready to sleep.

“I’ll go up the mountain with you tomorrow.”

“Need to grain-sunning, someone has to keep watch.”

“Don’t worry, I have a way.” Qin Mian composedly said.

Lei Tie didn't speak. Qin Mian adjusted his sleeping posture and closed his eyes.

In the middle of the night, Qin Mian dreamed of looking for a toilet and he woke up with a start. His underbelly distended. When he was in school, he had a habit of going to the toilet before he took an exam, took a bus/train or went to bed. Otherwise, his mind would be uneasy. He drank too much water in the afternoon and forgot to go to the toilet before he went to bed. Now he was woken up by the urge to pee.

The room was pitch-black. He groped about in the dark as he got up and his hands pressed on a warm and sturdy thing. There was a whiff of heat in his ear, accompanied by a hoarse voice, "Had nightmare?"

Qin Mian then found out that he was holding Lei Tie's waist and what he pressed on was Lei Tie's stomach. He quickly withdrawn his hand as his heart beat faster and his tongue tied, "No.... I, that is, I want to go to the lavatory."

"Don't move."

His shoulder was pressed down before he heard a rustling sound. Then he heard a light "zap" and a spark scuttled in the dark. After another sound, the oil lamp was lit by Lei Tie.

Qin Mian jumped out of bed, put on his shoes and rushed out of the room.

Lei Tie heard the door bolt slid away quickly, the corner of his lips drew up an obvious arc but disappeared quickly and then he closed his eyes.

Qin Mian didn't go to the latrine behind the house but rushed to the edge of the bamboo forest, quickly drained his bladder and then went back to the house at ease. He got on the bed first, then blew out the oil lamp and deliberately lay down next to the edge of the bed.

After falling asleep, he sensed a heat source beside him. He went over it unconsciously and was held by the similarly sound asleep man, who habitually stretched out his arms without realizing it.

Chapter 024: Go up the Mountain to Cut down Trees

“Cockadoodledoo——” In the early morning, the roosters in the village were crowing one after another. Qin Mian yawned and opened his bleary eyes. What caught his eyes was him hugging a man’s waist and there were shock and confusion in his eyes. He raised his head abruptly and came into contact with a pair of bright and serene eyes.

“I came over to you myself?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie nodded. When the rooster first crowed, he was ready to get up, but he was held tightly.

“Really?”

Lei Tie nodded again.

“Do you mind?” Qin Mian narrowed his eyes.

Lei Tie was calm as he shook his head slightly.

Qin Mian calmly moved his arms away and sat up. “That’s fine then.” He had no parents since he was a child, so he felt insecure and liked to curl up and hold something when he went to sleep. He thought that sleeping with a stranger would get rid of the problem, but habits and instinct prevailed.

He opened the trunk to get socks, threw a pair of large ones to Lei Tie and put on the new socks and shoes. After washing his face, he was fully clear-headed.

Lei Tie felt the socks and put them on.

The two had a clear division of labor. Qin Mian lit a fire and prepared breakfast; Lei Tie took a broom and cleaned up the open space at the entrance. He carried out several sacks of rice grain and spread them on the ground, golden-bright and dazzling. The freshness of the rice grain subsequently overflowed and the air in the morning smelled better.

Breakfast was a few savory veggie pancakes and plain congee.

“Are there any honest and obedient children in the village?” Qin Mian took a bite of the veggie pancake and looked at the rice grain on the ground. The golden color was dazzling under the sunlight.

Lei Tie understood, “Let them look after the rice grain?”

“Those children can’t do any heavy work at home, but it’s still possible to look after the rice grain. Find an obedient child to help and buy him some snacks from the town.” Qin Mian tasted the congee and after determining it was not hot, he took a big sip.

Lei Tie said: “Go to the grain-sunning ground later.”

After breakfast, they locked the door and went out. Lei Tie carried a saw, a rope and his bow set; Qin Mian carried a basket on his back, he could perhaps dig some wild vegetables or pick some wild fruits on the mountain.

The grain-sunning ground was still so bustling. The adults were busy husking the rice grain, the children were running around the grain-sunning ground, some were playing hide and seek, giggling behind the haystacks; while the more mischievous children were having somersault competition on the spread rice grain, letting out crisp big laughter from time to time, even if they were sweating, they didn’t feel hot.

Qin Mian noticed a seven or eight year old boy looking dignified and strong, sitting alone in the corner holding his knees and seemed bored. So he beckoned the boy.

The boy came running over in puzzlement, blinked and looked at him with distrust.

Qin Mian gave him a gentle smile, “What’s your name?”

“Xiao Hu.” There were familiar villagers nearby, so Xiao Hu was not shy at all. He answered honestly.

Qin Mian asked again: “Xiao Hu, do you want to eat snack?”

The boy nodded with a little embarrassment but at the thought of delicious snacks, his eyes showed craving.

“We live in the old house behind the village. As long as you do us a favor, we’ll give you a packet of snacks.” Qin Mian said.

Lei Tie quietly watched Qin mian “abduct” the child.

Xiao Hu’s eyes brightened, but he was a little suspicious. “Really?”

“Of course it is true.” Qin Mian said patiently, “We are going to cut down trees on the mountain. We want to find someone to help us look at the rice grain outside. If you want to help, I’ll buy you a packet of snacks from the town. Are your father and your mother here? You can ask them for permission.”

“Wait a bit.” Xiao Hu ran to a black faced man in his thirties and looked back, as if he was afraid that Qin Mian and Lei Tie would be gone.

The man looked their way and nodded to Xiao Hu.

Xiao Hu immediately showed a happy smile and like a small cannon shot, he rushed over.

“My father allowed!”

Qin Mian nodded to the man and took Xiao Hu away. He left Xiao Hu at the door of his house and brought a chair out for him, telling him not to let birds and chickens eat the rice grain.

Xiao Hu sat on the chair, shook his small legs and waved his hand like a little adult, “Don’t worry! I will do what I promise you!”

Qin Mian laughed in spite of himself and left with Lei Tie towards the back of the mountain.

This mountain was called Mount Cloud Summit and was the highest mountain nearby. It's tall and steep, seemingly be able to reach the sky. Hence it's called Mount Cloud Summit. The mountain was lush with trees and wild animals frequently roamed about that the villagers dared not come here, only the brave hunters dared to go deeper.

As soon as they entered the forest, the dense leaves blocked the sun, the light was dim and the temperature was a few degrees lower that Qin Mian shivered before he adapted to it. The path in the mountain was not easy to walk, overgrown with weeds and in some places, there was no sunlight all the year round, there were also morning dew and autumn fog permeated, making the soil wet which was easy to slip.

Lei Tie had experienced and purposely chose uneven area to set foot, walked safely and securely. With him leading the way, Qin Mian followed his footprints and looked around in hope of finding some treasures. To him, the mountain was a treasure waiting for his exploration. The birds in the forest woke up too with the twittering came from nowhere, the sound was particularly clear and lyrical in the morning forest.

Lei Tie walked slowly and looked back from time to time.

“Lei Tie, what tree are you going to cut down?” Qin Mian himself was a cheerful person; he found a topic to talk when there was none.

Lei Tie said, “Why don't you call me ‘Brother Tie’?”

Qin Mian muttered, *I was three years older than you in my last life*. But of course he couldn't say that.

“Because——AH.”

Qin Mian didn't pay attention for a while that he stepped on a piece of grass with morning dew on it. His feet slipped and his whole person leaned backward.

Lei Tie quickly grabbed his hand, pulled him back into his bosom and put another arm around the other's waist.

Qin Mian's face hit him on the chest. After standing steadily, he looked back at the steep slope and the big tree several steps away, he was a little scared. He had a small body and he would have been seriously injured if he fell.

Lei Tie let go of him, took his hand naturally and went on.

Qin Mian couldn't pull out his hand, so he was forced to follow Lei Tie. Feeling a heat on his hand, he kept repeating in his heart: I am a child, I am a child.

"By the way, you haven't answered what tree are you going to cut down? As far as I know, not all wood is suitable for ware making."

He automatically ignored the question that Lei Tie asked.

Chapter 025: First Pot of Gold – Manual Noodle Maker (3)

- - *Hi~ Sorry I took a few weeks to rest aka binge-reading (still reading) and the weather isn't nice for a stable internet connection so.... Enjoy the chapter~*
 - *And thanks somebody for the kofi~*

Lei Tie didn't bother about his intention. "[China] fir. It is fairly pliable, straight vein lines, easy handling and corrosion resistance."

Qin Mian thought for a moment. "Make two; one for the sample and the other for our own use."

"Nn."

Qin Mian was about to speak when he was pulled.

"Be careful with your steps."

He looked down and saw that there were some hedgehog-like fruits scattered on the ground and several brown fruits were wrapped in the prickly shell. His eyes brightened. "This is..."

Lei Tie explained: "Prickly fruit; walking into the mountains, pay attention above your head."

Prickly fruit? This is obviously chestnut! Qin Mian was so excited that he almost blurted out.

"It's called prickly fruit?" He asked tentatively, "Can it be eaten?"

Lei Tie looked at his eyes with some complexity. After a moment's silence, he said: "Can't eat. There are wild apple trees^[1] ahead."

Qin Mian opened his mouth with some helplessness in his eyes. Lei Tie thought he was fond of good food. He conveniently snapped two twigs, squatted down and picked up the "prickly fruit" to look at it carefully for a long time, he was very sure that it was chestnut.

He took his hand out of Lei Tie's hand and quickly picked up the chestnuts into the basket. "Come and help. This is a good thing!"

"Can't eat." Lei Tie frowned with a little distressed surged up in his chest.

"Can be eaten, trust me!" Qin Mian looked up at him with firm eyes.

Lei Tie pulled him, "Pick them up when we go back."

"Right." Qin Mian responded, dumped out the prickly fruits in the basket and piled them at the side.

His hand was back in Lei Tie's. Probably because this was the second time, he was not as uncomfortable.

Two pheasants passed through the dense grass in front of them. The pheasants noticed them and wanted to sneak away. Lei Tie loosened Qin Mian's hand and shot two arrows at the same time. The two pheasants died without even having a chance to flap their wings.

Qin Mian gave a thumbs-up Like^[2] to Lei Tie and ran over to pick up the pheasants.

They found a fir tree as thick as thigh. Lei Tie made Qin Mian to step back and cut it with a saw. While waiting, Qin Mian was bored and wandered around.

"Wife, don't go too far." Without turning back, Lei Tie knew what he was doing.

"I know."

Qin Mian luckily found a few hawthorn trees with bright red hawthorn fruits hanging on them. He picked the big ones and soon filled less than half of the basket.

Lei Tie found a time to glance at him and was puzzled by the excited expression of his shining eyes, but he didn't ask and diligently sawed the tree.

After the fir tree was cut down, he sawed off a half-person-high section from the top and carried it on the shoulder easily, "Let's go to pick apples."

Lei Tie familiarly took Qin Mian to the apple tree. The apple tree was very thick, but only one person tall. The apple on the branch was only slightly bigger than a tennis ball, but the pink color looked very enticing. Qin Mian picked one and wiped it on his clothes before he took a bite. He was pleasantly surprised. "This fruit is not big, but it tastes good. It's sour and sweet."

Lei Tie put down the fir wood and chose big ones to pick.

After picking more than 20 of them, Qin Mian stopped. If he picked too many, his back would not be able to bear it.

When they returned to the chestnut area, Qin Mian knocked off the chestnut shell, picked up a lot of chestnuts and straightly filled the basket with chestnuts. It was hard for his shoulders to bear it but he was reluctant to throw out some of them.

Lei Tie put the basket on his back without saying anything.

Qin Mian rubbed his nose, "Or else, pours some out?"

"No need. Go."

Qin Mian obediently kept up with Lei Tie, admiringly looking at his big and strong back. When could he grow up like this?

When they got home, Xiao Hu was sitting obediently under the shade of the tree with a long stick next to him, which was unknown where he got it.

“Uncle Lie. Brother Qin.”

“*Cough*——” Qin Mian choked by his own saliva. Why did it sound like “dear (Qinq) brother”?

Lei Tie gruffly said, “Call him Uncle Qin.”

“Oh.” Xiao Hu nodded in assent.

Qin Mian took two apples and handed them to him, “We won’t go to town until later. You go to the grain-sunning ground to play first. We will call you when we leave and then you can help us look after the rice grain.”

“Alright.” Xiao Hu smiled with crescent eyes. He took the two apples and ran away.

Lei Tie took out all kinds of tools as he sat at the entrance and made the noodle maker according to the drawing.

Qin Mian took out all the things in the basket and put them under the shade. He cleaned the two pheasants and prepared some dough for use. Then he washed two apples and sat next to Lei Tie to watch and guide.

Upon seeing Lei Tie skillfully peeled the fir wood unlike a novice, he got more confidence in the noodle maker. The holes in the bottom plate were the most difficult to do and needed to be chiseled one by one. Lei Tie was very patient; neither in a hurry or impatient.

“Chisel a notch here on the body, connect it with the base plate, it can be removed with a twist on the left and right..... Right..... Polish here..... The slide bar here should be straight to ensure that the handle can apply vertical force.....”

In less than an hour, the first noodle maker was finally produced.

Qin Mian stroked the smooth body and sung praises, “This is the first noodle maker in the world. We keep it for our own use.”

Lei Tie nodded and was very satisfied with his craftsmanship.

“Let’s try it.” Qin Mian ran into the kitchen excitedly. First, he cleaned the noodle maker inside and outside with water. Then he propped up the noodle maker with a triangle trestle, put it in a basin, and then put the dough into the body.

Lei Tie held the handle and pressed it down hard. The long and thin noodles suddenly extruded from the hole below and fell into the basin.

Qin Mian laughed and said: “It’s a success.”

Lei Tie’s eyes also flashed a smile and he continued to press.

Qin Mian took a pair of scissors to cut the noodles and smilingly said: “Let’s have noodles for lunch.”

Lei Tie naturally had no objection and then made a second noodle maker.

After lunch, the two went to the grain-sunning ground to call Xiao Hu over and took the noodle maker and dough to town.

Note:

[1] Also called crabapple

[2] to like (an online post on Weibo, Facebook etc)

Chapter 026: Made Money!

Because of his good mood, Qin Mian didn't feel that it was a long way to town. On the way, they came across a donkey cart going to town, so they hitchhiked.

Arrived in the town, Qin Mian took Lei Tie to a teahouse and asked for two cups of herb tea.

Lei Tie saw that he seemed to have a plan and became almost as silent as a post. He just followed and wondered what the little wife would do.

“Waiter, check out.” Qin Mian only took a sip.

The waiter wiped his hands and came over. “Thank you for your patronage. It's 2 wen in all.”

Qin Mian paid the money for the tea and handed over three more coins. “Waiter, I want to know something.”

Lei Tie then understood why the wife went to the teahouse when they had brought their own water. His dark and deep eyes fluctuated slightly and then returned to calm.

The waiter took the money and was happy,” You ask away. I'm not bragging but there's really nothing in this town that I don't know about.”

Qin Mian carried off with a laugh, “We want to customize some furniture, do you know which shop has the best woodcraft work in this town?”

“Hey, you are asking the right person. Yao's Woodcraft Shop is the best one to do carpentry work. In the town, the rich people with some money basically make furniture in their shop.”

Qin Mian showed a look of embarrassment, “The Yao’s ah, I didn’t have a pleasant time with the shop assistant in their shop few days ago. Aside from the Yao’s?”

Without thinking, the waiter replied, “The Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop. Their shop is no worse than Yao’s only because they rise later than the Yao’s and has a little bad reputation. The competition between the two is fierce!”

Qin Mian had been waiting for this sentence and he nodded with satisfaction, “Thank you very much.”

After asking the address of the Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop, he left with Lei Tie to find it.

The building of the Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop was not small. There were exquisite wardrobes, carved beds, round tables, mahogany chairs and other things at the door, which made the shop easy to find.

As soon as they entered the shop, a young shop assistant straightened his *Baotou hat* on the head as he greeted them with a smile on his face.

“What do the two honored customers want to buy?”

Qin Mian said: “Where is your shopkeeper? I have something to sell to your shopkeeper.”

As soon as the shop assistant heard this, he looked at him up and down again. The enthusiasm on his face immediately faded away. The right corner of his mouth rose disdainfully as he waved them away, “Go go go. This poor looks yet still want to sell things in the woodcraft shop. Hurry and go!”

Lei Tie frowned.

Qin Mian however didn’t take offence. He shook his head and said with a light smile, “I finally understand why your Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop’s is not as good as that of Yao’s Woodcraft Shop.”

“What did you say?” The shop assistant stared at him with a particularly bad expression. “Boy, are you tired of living? Go go go!”

“Wait!” The blue curtain behind the counter was opened by one hand and a somewhat stout middle-aged man came out.

“Manager Liao.” The shop assistant’s expression became respectful.

Liao Zhifu ignored him and raised his eyelids to size up Qin Mian. He had an air of arrogance and a foxy smile, “I’d like to ask this brother what you said just now.” The employer left the woodcraft shop to him to manage and he thought he was doing his best but today, being criticized by an ignorant youth caused him to be angry.

“Is it?” Qin Mian was fearless and pointed to the direction of the assistant. “I’m not a customer of your shop today, which doesn’t mean I’m not a customer of your shop tomorrow. It’s no wonder that the first thing people think about when they mention the woodcraft shop is the Yao’s. Be done with it, I don’t want to talk to you much if my words are regarded as ill-mannered. Farewell.”

This brother’s extraordinary speech and calm momentum made Liao Zhifu care a little, his heart jolted, “Wait!”

Qin Mian stopped and faintly smiled before he turned around.

“You just said you wanted to sell something?” Liao Zhifu’s eyes drifted to Lei Tie’s basket on his back. Anyway, he had nothing to do, so he regarded it as killing time.

Qin Mian nodded, “That’s right. It’s a blueprint of a manual noodle maker.”

“Manual noodle maker?” Liao Zhifu was at a loss.

Qin Mian explained: “It’s a tool for making noodles.”

He smiled without saying a word and motioned to Lei Tie to take out the noodle maker, dough and wooden basin. He demonstrated it directly.

Seeing the long and thin noodles appeared from the bottom of the noodle maker, Liao Zhifu's eyes were wide open in surprise. He was excited yet remained calm and collected as he said: "It's barely considered as a good thing. What is the price of the blueprint?"

The assistant stared straight at the noodle maker with a 'strange' written all over his face.

Qin Mian said: "Only sell to one shop. 50 tael. Fixed price."

"Oh." Liao Zhifu uttered a sound with an unclear smile, shook his head and said contemptuously, "I don't think this brother really understands what the concept of 50 silver tael is. You know, a silver tael is enough for an average of four mouths to feed for a year. 50 silver tael is too high."

"Manager Liao's words are incorrect." Qin Mian said calmly, "How many noodle shops are there in the town, Manager Liao? Don't they need a lot of noodles every day? How many rich people are there in the town? They don't mind spending a little money on a noodle maker, do they? With the blueprint, you can produce a batch of manual noodle maker. Even if you sell one for a silver teal, you can earn at least 200 tael in the town. What about in the whole county? What about in the whole state? 50 tael is absolutely not high."

Liao Zhifu was somewhat interested, but the so-called businessmen were all evil, he wanted to keep the price down as long as there was no fraud or business. "This brother has a point. But this doesn't seem to be so complicated [to make], so I'm afraid it's easy to imitate."

"Manager Liao is wrong yet again." Qin Mian still had something to say. "Tables, chairs, cabinets and cupboards are more easily imitated, but why do some woodcraft shops become famous, while others are unknown? What's more, if you have the blueprint, you can seize the market first. Even if someone imitates it, they will lose the decisive occasion."

Liao Zhifu stroked his beard and remained silent.

Qin Mian waited for a while deliberately, but Liao Zhifu still kept silent. He stood up without any anxiety on his face and smiled lightly. "It's already late; we still have to go to Yao's Woodcraft Shop."

"Wait!" Liao Zhifu panicked. "I buy it!" Yao's Woodcraft Shop was more famous than them. If he could get the blueprint of the manual noodle maker, wouldn't his shop be better?

Qin Mian quietly gave a proud smile toward Lei Tie.

Lei Tie stroked his head.

Liao Zhifu added: "But we have to write a guarantee document. You have to make sure that you don't sell the blueprint of the noodle maker and the noodle maker to a second individual, or you will have to compensate 1000 tael of silver."

"It ought to be." Qin Mian nodded, "But we are not the two wise people in the world. Since we can make a noodle maker, it doesn't mean other people can't do it. If there is a second noodle maker, Manager Liao can't blame us. Manager Liao can produce a large batch first and sell them all over the country at the same time."

Liao Zhifu frowned and also understood that this was the truth. After thinking about it, he nodded, "Alright."

He wrote down two documents on the spot and then he and Lei Tie pressed their thumbprints.

Qin Mian accepted 5 *shoe-shaped silver ingots* weighted 10 liang[1], took out the blueprint and explained them to Liao Zhifu in detail before he dissembled the noodle maker apart to show it.

Liao Zhifu patted his thigh and put on a long face, "So simple? Lost money, lost money!"

Qin Mian smiled and shook his head. "Manager Liao, these—"

“This brother doesn’t need to say ‘these words are wrong’ again.” Liao Zhifu was really annoyed.

Qin Mian didn’t take offence. “If it’s as simple as you said, why hasn’t anyone done it before?”

Note:

[1] Each silver ingot is worth 10 tael. I used both tael and liang (tael) to differentiate between money and weight (even though it is the same) as not to confuse some people who hasn’t familiarized with ancient currency which based on weight. I mean, if I translated 1 jin and 5 liang of meat as 1 jin and 5 tael of meat, won’t some be confused? [don’t know if it matters to you, but let me explain anyway]

Chapter 027: Money is Spent When It is Earned

Liao Zhifu was rendered speechless and only said after a long time: “Hah-hah, young people are good talkers; I’m not able to outdebate you.” He still kept his words and didn’t tear up the agreement.

Qin Mian made a lot of money that he was in a good mood and didn’t care about being treated coldly. “We still have something to do, so we are going. Manager Liao, you continue on [working].”

Liao Zhifu was not in the mood to say more and waved his hands perfunctorily. He took the blueprint and asked the assistant to hold the noodle maker before he walked quickly into the workshop at the back of the shop.

Qin Mian walked out of the door and looked back. He pulled Lei Tie and walked away quickly. After walking far, he looked behind him and his eyes turned left and right as he secretly looked at the passers-by. He pulled back his gaze only when he didn’t find anything suspicious.

“What?” Lei Tie also turned around and didn’t find anything unusual.

Qin Mian whispered: “Nothing. I was just wondering that I made so much money from that man and he would not be willing, so he would send someone to follow us secretly to rob the money back when there was no one around.” He hugged the heavy pouch in his hand and couldn’t help but look back. However, an able-bodied man who had been on the same road with them was puzzled and looked at him suspiciously.

“Hah.....”

There was a chuckle nearby. Qin Mian was stunned as he thought he had heard it wrong. He stood in the middle of the street, staring at Lei Tie with a face of beyond comprehension. Lei Tie actually laughed, but also laughed out loud?

Lei Tie seemed to be surprised by the fact that he had laughed, his upturned lips immediately returned to their usual position. He took away the money pouch before he put it in his bosom and pulled Qin Mian to move forward. Without looking at him, he lightly said: "Don't be scared."

When Qin Mian returned to his senses, he felt quite regretful. Couldn't he (LT) laugh for two seconds at most? Although the man was handsome, he didn't have any expression and also tongue-tied. Just now, with a laugh, he looked quite eye-catching. Still, he (QM) also didn't look bad in the previous life!

However, Lei Tie's word "don't be scared" really appeased him. He relaxed and didn't notice that Lei Tie was still holding his wrist.

"What to buy?" Lei Tie asked.

When it came to how to spend money, Qin Mian was excited and looked at Lei Tie with bright eyes. "I want to build the house first. Will it be done in time for the New Year?" At this time, he suddenly remembered that he had not visited their home base. Lei Tie didn't even mention it.....

Lei Tie nodded, "After the busy season." His wife was so capable, did he want to do something about it?

Although the paddy had been harvested, the next step was to cultivate the field and prepare to plant winter wheat. Only after the wheat was planted did the busy season concluded as over. However, Qin Mian still could wait ten days to half a month.

"Roughly, how much is it cost?"

"For three rooms, 12 tael will suffice." Lei Tie answered without thinking about it.

12 tael wasn't much for all their property. Qin Mian heaved a sigh of relief and smilingly said: "Can't buy the cart for the time being, but can buy a calf to use when ploughing. How much is it?"

Lei Tie shook his head, "Should have enough."

Qin Mian was not surprised. Lei Tie had just come back, afraid that he didn't know the current market.

The duo inquired about it or some time and went directly to the place where livestock were sold. Because those animals "produced" excrement everywhere and the smell was bad, a special place had been designated in the town. In fact, it's an open space on the edge of the town. People who bought and sold cattle, sheep, pigs, donkeys and mules all came here. Over time, this place had become a small livestock trading market.

When the duo got to the vicinity, a burst of odor assailed their nostrils. They glanced around carelessly; the ground was full of manure. The sounds of pigs, cows and sheep were mixed together, very lively.

Those sellers were used to this kind of environment. They sat by the wall and looked uninterested as they waited for buyers.

"Buy male or female ox?" Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie answered: "You decide."

Hearing these words again, Qin Mian felt helpless while thinking that if he really decided everything at home, he didn't know whether Lei Tie really didn't care.

"Then buy a male ox." He said while looking left and right.

A little donkey kicked the ground anxiously and suddenly took two steps back. Qin Mian hurriedly flashed to the side.

Its master was an old man in his fifties, smiled at him sheepishly and pulled the rope in his hand, dragging the donkey aside.

Qin Mian smiled back to express that he didn't mind. He saw several people selling cattle in front of him. After he shopped around and compared prices, he finally saw a two-year-old young ox. It's a water ox. Its horn was thick and flat, and its two big eyes were as clear as glass. It should have been washed by the owner specially; its hair was jet-black and clean, which made people like it. Qin Mian saw such a beautiful water ox for the first time.

After asking the broker in charge of livestock sales in the market to see it and determined the ox had no health and convenience problems, Qin Mian spent 6 tael of silver to buy it and gave the broker another 100 wen.

Lei Tie really let him decide as he said. He had no objection during that time and merely looked at him lightly with those dark and deep eyes. Occasionally with those eyes of his, Qin Mian's heart beat unstably.

But his attention soon shifted, because he had a lot to buy. Making Lei Tie led the young ox, he went to buy some vegetable seeds, 2 Jin of sugar and 2 Jin of streaky pork. Of course, he didn't forget to buy the promised snacks. Finally, he went to the cloth shop and picked up their new clothes, and then led the young ox home.

Translator's rant corner: Do you know how it feels when you have 55 more words to translate but suddenly the connection was lost? Then, when you are about to publish the chapter that'd been delayed, you discovered that you'd translated the wrong chapter? I felt pure frustration...

Chapter 028: Pamper

Qin Mian was in a particularly good mood because he had made money. Although Lei Tie was still expressionless, his relaxed pace showed that he was also in a good mood. He carried all the things they bought on his back while Qin Mian led a water ox and stroked its back and neck from time to time as he walked. The ox was docile in character, it didn't mind his harassment. It moved forward slowly and flicked its tail from time to time, very leisurely.

Lei Tie looked on in puzzlement.

Qin Mian smiled at him, continued to touch and his words irrefutable, "I'm cultivating feelings with it. When I get familiar with it, I can ride it like a horse to town." Just now, he didn't see horses in the market. After all, they were backward in ancient times. Horses were probably controlled by the imperial court as military supplies.

Lei Tie shook his head and threw a glance at the ox thoughtfully. Without saying anything, his eyes fell on the smiling side of his wife's face.

It always seemed that it took less time to return. It didn't take long for them to get to the foot of the mountain and see the village below.

When the sweat-soaked farmers saw Qin Mian coming back with an ox while he talked with Lei Tie, they were very surprised. They talked in low voices as their eyes mostly fell on the buffalo with both admiration and jealousy.

"Hey, are that Lei Tie and his wife?" Sister Zhang straightened up and wiped her sweat. She had inadvertently glanced at the way out of the village and saw the two. Surprised, she patted her man.

The sickle in Zhang Dashuan's hand was askew and he almost cut his own hand. He stared helplessly at his wife before he looked at the road and was stunned, "Yes."

Sister Zhang said in a low voice: "Such a big ox is not cheap. It seems that Lei Tie really hid the money before parting ways with his family."

Zhang Dashuan was upset, frowned and scolded: "You mind so much about other people's family!"

Sister Zhang knew what he was worried about and didn't take offence. She looked at him with a smile and said in a warm voice, "Alright, don't I know what you are worried about? Let's just talk about it in private. Don't worry, I won't gossip."

Zhang Dashuan breathed a sigh of relief and looked at his wife with gentler eyes. He lowered his head and continued to cut the grain. How could he not know his wife was not a loose mouthed person? He was merely reminded her a little more so as to avoid quarrel.

"I'm afraid that the news will soon reach the old Lei's house and the young couple won't be in peace again." Sister Zhang shook her head and sympathized with Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Over there, Qin Mian and Lei Tie walked into the village, and very soon someone came up from the field to greet to them.

"Lei Tie, have you added a big ox to your family? This ox is bought well, it looks strong." Aunt Xiulan seemed to be in admiration as she sized up the buffalo and praised. Her clear voice carried a hint of swiftness.

Lei Tie nodded, "Aunt."

Interpersonal communication had to be relied on Qin Mian. He immediately showed an intimate but not too enthusiastic smile to the woman. "Brother Tie and I are not familiar with ox and we are unable to perceive the good or the bad. Before that, we were worried about whether we would buy a bad one. It's relieving to hear that from Aunt."

He seamlessly flattered Aunt Xiulan. When Aunt Xiulan heard that, she felt more comfortable with the only male wife in the village which gave her a good impression. She smilingly said: "Don't worry, this ox is fine. My parents have two oxen, I'm familiar with them. Whether this ox is healthy, firstly, it depends on its spirit whether it looks spirited enough? Second, it depends on the hair whether it is neat and glossy. Third, it depends on the pace where a stable and steady gait is definitely a healthy one. The easiest way is to look at its appetite. It's no problem if it can eat."

Qin Mian nodded and admiringly said: "Aunt knows so much. Before, we saw it eating fresh straw, so we decided to buy it." At this time, he vaguely understood why the aunt, who he had not known before, came to show up suddenly. She mentioned that there were oxen in her parent's family, which was to say that her family did not have them. If she had a good relationship with them, it would be easy to talk if she wanted to borrow it.

He patted the back of the ox and said, "Thank you for telling us so much. If you want to use it later, just say it."

Aunt Xiulan was really happy now. She secretly praised this brother's intelligence. She laughed and was all the more satisfied the more she looked at Qin Mian. "Then, Aunt thanks you first. You're still tired after you've gone so far. Aunt won't delay you guys."

"Aunt, you continue on [working]."

They continued to go into the village and a few villagers warmly greeted them. Qin Mian responded with the same courtesy. Although he knew that they did that only for the ox, he didn't dislike them. As long as the villagers was no longer pointed out to him and Lei Tie, which spoiled people's mood for no reason, it's no big deal to lend them the ox.

When they got home, Xiao Hu sat lazily on the back of his chair and waved his bamboo pole from time to time. What's unexpected was that there was a boy of the same age next to him, whose clothes were still stained with straw scraps. He squatted on the ground and played with worms. He kept shouting something as he played enthusiastically. He seemed lively.

“Xiao Hu.”

Xiao Hu immediately jumped down and smiled at Qin Mian. His eyes unconsciously looked at Lei Tie’s basket, “Uncle Lei, Uncle Qin.”

The other little boy also stood up and watched Qin Mian and Lei Tie with a bit of blush, eyes moved about and then he also called out, “Uncle Lei, Uncle Qin.” His voice was quite loud.

How could Qin Mian not perceive the little demons’[1] mind? He secretly thought it was funny, but he didn’t tease them. He took out two packages of snacks from the basket. At that time in the snack shop, he had only bought one package for Xiao Hu but then Lei Tie took another package for him, so he bought two packages.

He handed one of the packages to Xiao Hu, opened the other package where there were eight colored pastries in it and took out four for the other little boy.

“You guys have worked hard.”

“Thank you, Uncle Qin.” Xiao Hu happily held the snacks in both hands.

The little boy understood why he got less, he smiled, “Thank you, Uncle Qin.” Unable to hold himself back, he picked up a piece and took a big bite, chewing quickly.

Qin Mian saw it and sighed with emotion. He had tasted it before and compared with modern ones, it was far worse in appearance, color and taste. *There is a business opportunity.*

“Go play.”

The two little demons ran with delight. This time, there was something to show off to their companions.

“Uncle Qin, if there is anything, I can help you again.” Xiao Hu waved as he ran away.

“This is becoming aware of the benefits of something.” Qin Mian laughed in spite of himself.

“Nn.” Lei Tie waited for him to open the door.

Qin Mian’s left hand hugged his chest and reached out his right hand to Lei Tie as he looked on with a happy smile and without speaking.

Lei Tie was taken aback before he took out the money pouch and handed it to him.

Qin Mian looked at him approvingly with the eyes that said “the young man was promising and worthy to be taught” before he took the money pouch and fished out the key to open the door.

Lei Tie shook his head, afraid that he didn’t find his own eyes laden with pamper.

Note:

[1] little demon = term of endearment for a child; mischievous child

Chapter 029: Lei Tie's Regard

Lei Tie put down the basket, took the tether from Qin Mian's hand, and tied it to a tree. Then, he brought a bundle of fresh paddy straw.

The water ox chewed the straws with its head down as it wagged its tail; it seemed very happy.

Qin Mian didn't leave. He bent down and fed it a handful of straw. He turned to Lei Tie and said: "You should be close to it too, lest it won't listen to you when you are plowing the field."

Lei Tie was stumped for words. He really picked up a handful of straw and fed it to the ox. He raised his big palm and stroked the ox's head stiffly.

Qin Mian was stunned, then he couldn't help laughing, "Hahaha..." He was just teasing Lei Tie, but the man took it seriously. An ox's nature was usually docile and would not cause trouble unless it was deliberately provoked.

Lei Tie vaguely understood that he was teased. He was still calm as before and only took a profound glance at Qin Mian. Instead of leaving, he took a handful of straw and continued to feed the ox.

Qin Mian took a look at him with a smile and vaguely felt that it's awkward for them to feed the young ox together, but somehow, he didn't find an excuse to go away but watched the ox eat the straw in Lei Tie's hand and also eat in his own hand.

Running in a hurry, Lei Chuntao saw from a distance that their shoulders seemed to be next to each other but also not, and the view of their backs looked very harmonious. She stopped and a look of deeply moved floated on that pretty face. This scene appeared to give people comfort that no one

would want to disturb it. In fact, it seemed that there was nothing wrong with the eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law to live together.

She hesitated for a moment before continued to run over and deliberately raised her volume, “Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law!” The small bell on her purple thin silk skirt rung along and it sounded very pleasant.

Qin Mian immediately threw away the straw. Lei Tie’s body was stiff for a moment, his hands uneasily loosened before he turned around and shoot a glance at Lei Chuntao.

“Little sister, why are you here?” Qin Mian patted off the debris on his hand and asked politely. These days, he had already found that girls who had yet married were awfully refrained from going out and walked too close to men. It could be seen that this was indeed a time when feudal proprieties were relatively strict. Although Lei Chuntao was his nominal sister-in-law, he still should pay attention to the impact.

Lei Chuntao thought that she had disturbed the two people and felt embarrassed. “Nothing, I... just want to tell you that someone may come.... to trouble you.....” The more she talked, the redder her face was. It’s embarrassing to think of the harsh words that her mother, her second brother, second sister-in-law, and third sister-in-law had said. But they were her mother and her second brother. She was the younger generation, how could she talk about people behind their back? However, if she did not warn the eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law, she would be uneasy. She had no choice but to rush over.

After she finished saying, she lowered her head and ran away again.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie knew what she meant by “someone”.

Lei Tie subconsciously looked at Qin Mian and discovered that the other person was at ease. Qin Mian either didn’t care about it or he had some countermeasures, in that case, he also would not take it seriously. Looking back at the ox, he felt a slight regret.

Qin Mian remembered an important thing, “Where is the home base you bought?”

Lei Tie breathed a sigh of relief. He thought Qin Mian was completely unconcerned about it....

“Lock the door.”

Qin Mian locked the door and looked at the ox. He was afraid that someone would steal it but then he thought of how simple the people in the countryside were and that the farmland was not far away from many people in the field. So he put his worry down and followed Lei Tie into the village.

It didn’t take long to get to the west end of the village.

The house planning of Green Mountain Village could passably be computed as standard, basically in a row. Lei Tie bought a three-rooms-space land in the west of the village. There were still marks on the ground that Li Zheng measured last time. There were neighbors in the east, open space in the west, and a grove not far away.

Qin Mian turned around and thought that the position was really good. The old Lei’s house was in the east of the village. To live in the west of the village, they could avoid them and be lacking a few small-minded people. Secondly, there was a vacant lot on the west side and an empty lot on the north side. It would be easy to expand in the future. He felt that Lei Tie was a man of ideas.

“It’s a nice place.” Qin Mian said to Lei Tie with a satisfied look.

Lei Tie nodded, “I’ll buy the materials after plowing the field.”

Qin Mian said: “Brother Zhang should know more about it, you can ask him about the market price of bricks, tiles, and so on. Don’t get cheated.”

“En.”

A married woman’s head stuck out behind a wall. After discovering that Qin Mian noticed her, she squeezed out a smile before her head quickly

withdrawn.

Qin Mian assumed that she was their neighbor. There was no need to make a contact with the neighbors at the moment and it would be put off until the house was up.

The duo strolled back home.

Lei Tie took a saw and a bow set with a basket carried on his back, “Wife, I’m going to the mountain.” He left without saying anything more.

Qin Mian didn’t ask but casually said “be careful” as he fetched a coarse toothed wooden rake to turn over the paddy grain for drying. Therefore, Qin Mian didn’t notice that Lei Tie’s body shook when he heard these two words. He took a look back at Qin Mian before he left. The expression in his eyes was deeper than before.

Qin Mian went to the vegetable garden to pick the vegetables he wanted to eat in the evening. When he got home, he didn’t see “someone” coming to find fault, which was quite unexpected.

Without Du Shi, Zhao Shi, and the others came to be an irksome presence, he readily took the opportunity to be at ease. He turned around and saw hawthorn and apple on the ground.

He cut down bamboo and made dozens of long and thin bamboo sticks. He then grabbed a handful of hawthorn, cleaned them, cut in two, and dug out the core before closing the two halves. After that, he fetched a few apples from the space, washed them, and cut them into dices.

He wanted to make tanghulu[1]. So many hawthorn and wild apples couldn’t be wasted, right?

After washing clean the bamboo sticks, he skewed the hawthorn and apple; two hawthorns and a dice of apple for each skewer. After he did a series of ten skewers, he lighted a fire and heated water.

After the water was boiled, he added a proper amount of white sugar, boiled it slowly over medium heat, and constantly stirred it with a spatula. When sugar liquid started to foam, he put the tanghulus in it and rolled them quickly. Then, he put them onto an oiled plate.

After cooling for about ten minutes, the tanghulus were ready, with bright color and attractive aroma.

Hearing the “bang” from outside, he picked up the plate and walked out quickly. Sure enough, it was Lei Tie who came back and was looking at the wooden block and the cut-off bamboo. At his feet laid two logs.

Qin Mian grabbed a tanghulu and took a bite. He nodded and handed out the plate to Lei Tie.

“Taste it.”

Lei Tie frowned. He hadn’t seen it before, but it didn’t look like an adult man’s type of food. His wife carried the plate and did not withdraw his hand. He picked up one and bit it reluctantly.

“It’s not poisonous.” Qin Mian joked, “Don’t worry, you won’t be forced to finish all this. I didn’t see anyone selling this in the town before. I think this is a new thing. It tastes good, sour, and sweet. How about making it to sell?”

“En.” Lei Tie was frowning all the time. It really looked like he was taking poison. He only unfolded his frown when he bit the apple.

Qin Mian saw clearly that Lei Tie swallowed the hawthorns directly but he would chew the apple before it entered the stomach.

“What are these logs for?” Actually, Qin Mian didn’t like sweets either and he was just trying something new today.

“Useful.” Lei Tie replied vaguely. “There’s another trip.”

Qin Mian saw that it was getting late, “Don’t be too late.”

“En.” Lei Tie quickly finished the tanghulu, took out a pheasant in the basket, and left in a hurry.

After Qin Mian cleaned the pheasant, he made more tanghulus, but he didn’t use the apple in the space anymore. It was too troublesome to remove the core and so he omitted the process. Lastly, he counted them and there were more than sixty altogether.

Lei Tie had already come back and was sawing the log into planks.

Qin Mian made a firm stand out of bound paddy straws and stuck the tanghulus on it one by one.

Lei Tie looked at over for a few times, as if thinking of something.

After that, Qin Mian began to cook dinner. A big wok of stewed fowl with chestnut, the strong aroma was captivating. When it was done, he ladled up a large bowl and handed it over to Lei Tie.

“Send it over there.”

Lei Tie was dumbfounded.

Qin Mian knew what he was uncertain about and said with a smile: “We still have to live in the village, so we can’t really become enemies with them over there. It’s fine to tolerate them on the surface, lest we become the cause of people’s gossip.”

With that, he winked at Lei Tie. “At this moment, the busy people in the field are going home one after another. You pick the place where there are many people to walk.”

Lei Tie’s eyes flashed a ghost of a smile and he touched Qin Mian’s head.

Qin Mian rubbed his nose and turned into the kitchen. “*Cough*, I have other dishes to make.”

The 100 Wen which needed to be given to the old house over there for this month was already prepared at an earlier time. But Du Shi was a capricious

mule-headed[2] person. Even if this dish diffused the trouble at this time, there would be another. The 100 Wen should be kept for the next time to block her mouth.

Sure enough, until the next morning, no one from the old house over there came looking for trouble.

Qin Mian got up at dawn, but Lei Tie was no longer in bed. When he saw that the ox was gone, he was shocked. He ran back into the house and upon seeing that the plowing tools were not there, he was relieved.

As he was about to enter the room, he caught a glimpse of several planks that had been nailed together in the shape of a handcart model placed against the wall. He was surprised and pleased.

After breakfast, Lei Tie didn't come back. Qi Mian took the meal and delivered it to him.

As expected, Lei Tie was in the middle of urging the ox to plow the field. The ox was really docile, pulling the plow forward without any trouble. Half of a *mu* area had been plowed.

"Brother Tie, have a meal."

Lei Tie tied the ox's rope to a wood post before he came over.

"I see some planks outside the room. Are you going to make a cart?" Qin Mian asked.

"Buy you a new one when I have money." Lei Tie took a quick look at him as he said in a muffled voice and took over the bowl.

Qin Mian couldn't help but laugh out. He didn't know what he was feeling at that time. He changed the topic, "I'm going to sell the tanghulu in town later."

Note:

[1] tanghulu; candied fruits on bamboo skewers dipped in sugar syrup, a common Chinese snack

[2] savage and unreasonable

Chapter 030: First “Confrontation”

“Wait, I’ll send you off.” Lei Tie ate with absorbed concentration.

“No, I can—”

“Send you.” Lei Tie didn’t back down.

Qin Mian was thinking that it was quite far from the village to the town and it was a busy season, there would be no one on the road. In case of wild animals or someone robbing in the middle of the road, it would be really unsafe. “Might as well. By the way, where are our vegetable fields? It’s going to be cold. If we don’t grow vegetables, we won’t have vegetables to eat in winter.”

Lei Tie thought about it before saying, “The field was divided into half a *mu*.”

Qin Mian said: “We have too few fields. There’s no harm to grow vegetables in the half a mu field. If we have enough money, we can buy more fields.”

“Nn.” The little wife was indeed a person with ideas, Lei Tie had no objection. After thinking about it, he spoke, “No one eats sweets too early [in the morning].”

Qin Mian suddenly realized that who would buy sweets in the morning? It’s really something he had ignored.

When Lei Tie finished eating, Qin Mian took the bowl and went home. When he passed the grain-sunning ground, Xiao Hu and the little boy from

yesterday impatiently looked at him. He suddenly lost his smile and beckoned them.

Two little demons came running over excitedly.

“Uncle Qin.”

“I only need two people here.” Qin Mian was afraid that Xiao Hu would call all the children in the village.

The two little demons, who dared to do mischief, understood his meaning and tapped their small chests to pledge, “Uncle Qin can rest assured. If there are more people coming, our share will be less.”

Qin Mian then knew that the other little demon called Gou Dan[1] was Xiao Hu’s older male patrilineal cousin. They enjoyed playing together.

“I’ll call you guys over when I have to leave.”

When Lei Tie was done with ploughing and came home, it was about ten o’clock. Qin Mian locked the door, wrapped the tanghulu’s stand with a clean cloth and let Lei Tie carry it first to keep it away from Xiao Hu and Gou Dan. It’s not that he was stingy and didn’t want to give them the tanghulu, but he still counted on to earn small money from the tanghulu. The children couldn’t hide it and if the information was leaked, it was far from good.

Assuming that Lei Tie had left the village, Qin Mian went to the grain-sunning ground to call Xiao Hu and Gou Dan over and tell them to turn over the paddy grain to dry it for a while before he left in a hurry.

Both sides of the road out of the village were planted with poplar and locust trees. It was still yet the time for trees to lose leaves, so the cascading leaves blocked one’s view. Qin Mian ran a few steps before he saw Lei Tie looking back from a hundred meters away.

“Where is eldest sister-in-law in a hurry to go?” Carrying a water jar, Zhao Shi walked over quickly and followed his gaze, “Isn’t that eldest brother?”

Are you guys going to town again? You just got a big ox yesterday. What do you want buy in town today? Your lives are getting prosperous ah.”

Qin Mian ignored her and quickened his pace.

Zhao Shi’s voice was so kind that it made one’s back chilled, “Eldest sister-in-law, I’m not telling you off. But if there’s any way to get money, take more care of the parents. Otherwise—”

Qin Mian interrupted her, “Second younger brother’s wife, I have something else to do. I’ll go first.”

“Hey!” Upon seeing that he was evading her so fast, Zhao Shi became more and surer of her guess. She gnashed her teeth, stamped her foot and swung her willow hips to turn back to walk home.

Qin Mian caught up with Lei Tie and wiped his sweat.

Lei Tie threw an eye at the back and said lightly: “Don’t mind it.”

Qin Mian waved his hand. For those people in the old house, he had nothing to say and simply gave a cold treatment.

When they got to the town, they went straight to the most prosperous street. On both sides of the street were stalls selling all kinds of things, pancakes, cloth, umbrellas, rouge and gauche, vegetables... The shouting of the hawkers sounded from time to time with some of the tones were lethargic and drowsy, while some were high-pitched and sonorous like singing, making people laughed. The ordinary people who strolled around the streets, the merchants who traveled in a hurry, and even the ruffians who did nothing at all, picked and chose in front of the small stalls, which was interesting.

Qin Mian found a place to set stand, but his enthusiasm suddenly faded in half—who was going to hawk?

He looked at Lei Tie with ardent gaze.

Lei Tie took a quick look at him and put the tanghulu's stand on the ground without squinting or squeaking.

Qin Mian walked closer to him, patted him on the shoulder and looked at him smilingly. "Brother Tie, you'll shout 'delicious tanghulu, 2 Wen for a skewer'."

Lei Tie still did not utter a sound or a word.

Soft approach did not succeed, Qin Mian used force, "If you don't shout, you can't eat at noon."

Lei Tie's mouth opened wide and suddenly shoved the stand into Qin Mian's hand. "I'll ask butcher Zhang if he needs preys."

After saying that, without waiting for Qin Mian to respond, he walked away quickly.

"Hey, you—" Qin Mian was speechless. Seeing that Lei Tie really didn't return, he became angry and his heart felt empty and cold. This town was completely strange to him and when he came here before, there was no special feeling. Today, there was an inexplicable sense of loneliness in his heart and a feeling of uneasiness surged from the bottom. It was as if he was the only one in such a big world.

People passing by all looked at the red tanghulu curiously. They wanted to come and have a look, but all he did was only smile. Did he really have to hawk? At this time, he regretted the idea of selling tanghulu. Why didn't he expect such a problem?

"Little brother, what are you selling?" An old lady with gray hair cheerfully asked.

Qin Mian said: "This is tanghulu. It's sour and sweet, suitable for children. Does Aunt want to give a skewer to your family member?"

"Tanghulu? Is it delicious?" The old lady asked with a strange look in her eyes.

Qin Mian saw that she was plainly dressed and there were several patches on her clothes; she was probably not a generous person. But anyone dropping in was a customer. He took a skewer with a smile on his face and handed it over to her. "How about tasting it first and buy it if you think it's delicious?"

A few other people around also showed some interest. Who wouldn't want free food?

Qin Mian simply took three more skewers and handed them to several envious children.

"Have a taste, the children definitely like it. 2 Wen for a skewer."

The old lady took a bite and frowned at the sourness, but she was very kind and still smiled, "This old lady can't eat it, but the little baby definitely like it."

After saying that, she fished out a few coppers from her bosom and took four to hand over to Qin Mian, "Give two skewers."

The business was finally opened. Qin Mian breathed a sigh of relief and hurriedly took two skewers to exchange with the money.

"Mother, it's delicious. I want another one." A little girl about six years old, tugged at her mother's sleeve as her eyes stared at the bright red fruit on the stand, shining brightly.

"It's very sour, how can it be eaten." The woman glanced at Qin Mian secretly and pulled the little girl away with some embarrassment. That being said but the skewer of bitten tanghulu in her hand was not thrown away.

Qin Mian felt helpless. He felt that today was a blunder. Looking in the direction where Lei Tie left, he still couldn't see the man's figure, so he harbored even more bellyful of fire. This aroused his fighting spirit instead. Carrying the stand, he shouted, "Take a look, come visit, sweet and sour tanghulu, 2 Wen a skewer. Take a look, come visit..."

He walked half the street and also shouted for half the street but only sold six skewers.

Qin Mian realized the reason being that there were few people who dared to try because this thing was new. But he really couldn't believe that as an open-minded modern man, he couldn't help turning into a conservative ancient man.

Instead of hawking, he went back to the original place and handed two skewers to the woman in her fifties who sold cloth on the left and the young man who sold vegetables on the right.

"If you don't mind, try it."

People who did business were basically adept at dealing things for others' interest. The two people generously thanked him after receiving the skewers.

Qin Mian took a skewer to eat himself and shouted loudly, "2 Wen for a skewer of delicious tanghulu; 2 Wen for a skewer of delicious tanghulu..."

"Not to mention," The woman said with a smile, taking a small bite. "It's a little sour, but it's just perfect. It's delicious."

The young man also bit a hawthorn from the bamboo stick, "I don't like it very much, but my wife likes to eat sour and sweet snacks. Little brother, give me five skewers."

This method actually worked. The people who passed by saw all three of them eating and even chatting, they became interested. It's worth spending 2 wen to buy a skewer and try something new.

Soon Qin Mian sold more than ten skewers. A girl less than ten years old came from the opposite rice shop and bought five skewers.

Qin Mian generously gave her an extra.

The little girl looked at him with a smile and ran back happily. After a moment, a little girl about her age was dragged from the deli food shop next

door and also bought five skewers.

Qin Mian also gave her an extra.

After more than an hour, the tanghulu was sold out.

Qin Mian felt a sense of achievement. Looking at the declining sun, he unhurriedly found a small restaurant with the stand carried on his shoulder. He ordered a scrambled egg with tomato, a fried meat with green pepper and a bowl of rice, and ate by himself. As for Lei Tie, who cares?

He only took two bites and a shadow fell in front of him. Qin Mian looked up and saw that Lei Tie had come out of nowhere and automatically sat beside him.

A waiter ran over immediately. “Are you two together? What else do you need?”

Qin Mian ate without saying anything.

Neither did Lei Tie speak.

The waiter looked at Qin Mian suspiciously and then at Lei Tie. Both of them kept silent, so the waiter had to walk away helplessly.

Qin Mian raised his eyelids and looked at Lei Tie defiantly.

Lei Tie’s expression was indifferent as before.

The dishes in this shop were well fried. Qin Mian ignored him and ate with big bites.

“Wife, I’m hungry.”

Qin Mian was shocked and immediately covered his mouth. “Shut up!”

Mouth covered by the other person, Lei Tie still didn’t move. He blinked and because Qin Mian’s hand blocked the area under his nose, his dark eyes turned more and more deep.

Qin Mian's heart was shaken by his blink. He turned to look at other customers in the shop. Seeing that no one heard Lei Tie's words, he took a sigh of relief and gave Lei Tie a fierce look.

Lei Tie backed away from his hand and said, "I'm hungry, wi—"

"Waiter, another bowl of rice!" Qin Mian shot a dagger look at him.

The waiter almost dropped the dish he was carrying in his hands by Qin Mian's roar.

Note:

[1]狗蛋 [gǒu dàn] = son of a bitch; or literally dog's egg meanwhile小虎 [xiǎo hǔ] = little tiger. {Seriously? Like seriously, why would anyone name their kids that? That's why I left it in pinyin lest it left a bad taste in my mouth.}

Chapter 031: Who Admit Defeat

When the meal was served, Lei Tie shut up.

Qin Mian was very angry, but he added two dishes and a bowl of rice.

After eating, he paid before leaving. Lei Tie followed like a mute person and took over the stand in his hand. Qin Mian didn't refuse, but didn't say a word to him all the way.

Lei Tie was about to speak, but said nothing. His eyes fell on the thin back of the teenager. Recently, they ate good food, so the wife had been raised well. While his body was still thin, he had more meat on his face than before. His dry hair was soft and black which was tied into a high ponytail that swayed as if it was afraid that people wouldn't know its master had a hot-temper.

Thinking of the teenager's angry expression, Lei Tie's corner of the lips slightly cocked but disappeared in a flash. He was not used to the teenager being uncommunicative. However, if he was to coax, he was really helpless.

As Qin Mian walked, he listened to the movement behind him, but he didn't hear anything. He wasn't really angry, but it was true that he was dejected and there was a part of unreconciled at the bottom of his heart. He actually wanted to see who gave in first.

Thinking of this, he relaxed a lot and his footsteps became more brisk.

Whether he walked fast or slow, Lei Tie always kept the same distance with him.

Passersby on the street noticed that the two—one at the front and the other at the back—looked as if they were fighting, and they amusedly pointed

fingers at the duo.

As if unaware of it, Qin Mian bought two packages of snacks and 2 Jin of sugar before leaving the town.

No words were said along the way.

When they got home, Qin Mian gave the snacks to Xiao Hu and Gou Dan and went out with the basket on his back.

“Where to?” Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian looked at him with a smile, but didn’t speak. He went to the back of the mountain.

Lei Tie was taken aback. He fetched the bow set, locked the door and quickly followed.

Xiao Hu and Gou Dan sensed the strange atmosphere and looked at each other inexplicably before eating the snacks with relish.

Qin Mian walked very fast, but when he got into the mountain, his strong-willed deflated. He looked around and couldn’t make up his mind. He planned to pick more hawthorn and wild apple, but he didn’t know where hawthorn and apple trees were.

“What are you looking for?” Lei Tie asked again with a flat voice without a thread of emotion.

Qin Mian opened his mouth but closed it immediately. He took out a hawthorn fruit and an apple from the basket and waved them at Lei Tie.

At this moment, Lei Tie finally understood that his wife was acting in a fit of pique with him. It was a bit funny, but he was never a person who easily showed emotions. Nothing could be seen on his face, only a pair of deep and frightening black eyes covered with a layer of softness. He took Qin Mian’s hand, looked around and walked in one direction without hesitation.

Led by the other man, Qin Mian looked around leisurely but he still didn't speak.

After picking a lot of hawthorn and wild apple, the basket was full. But of course, the basket was on Lei Tie's back.

Once at home, Qin Mian sent Xiao Hu and Gou Dan away. Then, he ladled up water into a basin to wash the hawthorns and apples. Lei Tie went to take a look in the water vat before he went out with an empty bucket.

Upon seeing him go far, Qin Mian spat out a mouthful of breath, "I almost suffocated! How can that guy manage not saying three sentences a day?"

It was really a chore for a talkative person like him to refrain from talking for such a long time.

In a distance, Lei Tie turned his head and looked back.

Qin Mian didn't notice it as he was cleaning the fruits quickly and neatly. Today's tanghulu had sold for more than 100 Wen, almost equivalent to more than 100 yuan in modern times. It didn't sound like much but in this era, it was not a small amount and it was enough to buy many things. However, selling tanghulu was not a long-term thing after all. If he wanted to get rich, he had to think of other ways.

As he was thinking, he heard the sound of pouring water.

After Lei Tie filled the water vat, he brought in the planks and found the carpentry tools. He moved a wooden log and sat at the door in the central room. His head lowered as he hammered with a look of concentration.

Qin Mian gave him a furtive look.

After washing the fruits, he put them in a sieve and let dry under the sun, mainly to drain the water. Then he took out yesterday's cut off bamboos and continued to make bamboo sticks.

Upon seeing this, Lei Tie took over Qin Mian's work without saying a word.

It was exactly what Qin Mian wanted as it was easy to get his hand scratched if the bamboo stick was not smooth. Yet, he was not idle. He turned over the grain for drying, led the ox to the pond to drink water before tying it back and dragged over a bundle of straw.

When the fruits had drained, he made more than sixty skewers of tanghulu.

After dinner was done, he didn't call Lei Tie but sat down and ate. Minced meat with eggplant was very appetizing.

Lei Tie was thinking about how to nail the planks more firmly when he heard the clinking sound of chopsticks colliding with dishware and only then found out that the wife had already started eating. After a brief pause, he silently washed his hands and came to eat.

Qin Mian snickered and almost choked on food.

Lei Tie was steady and stable, clipped a dish to eat neither tense nor slow and glanced at Qin Mian with an uncertain meaning.

Qin Mian's stone face made out a look of indifferent.

He didn't say a word to Lei Tie until he went to bed at night. As for the matter of squeezing into Lei Tie's embrace after sleeping, he ignored it breezily.

The next day was just like yesterday; Lei Tie went to plow the land till about 10 o'clock before they set out for the town.

When Qin Mian got to the previous place, he greeted the owners of the left and right stalls. Qin Mian was about to start hawking when Lei Tie suddenly stood in front of the stand and without looking at him, Lei Tie brusquely said to the passersby: "Delicious tanghulu, 2 Wen for a skewer."

An elderly woman who was going to come over with her little granddaughter was frightened by his expressionless face and she stepped back while looking at him hesitantly.

Stunned, Qin Mian couldn't help laughing and quickly lowered his head, "*Puff...*"

Lei Tie turned to look at him with his dull gaze full of emotions that seemed to be unknown.

Qin Mian couldn't say what it was, but he was in a good mood. He didn't intend to embarrass Lei Tie anymore, but he couldn't help laughing a few times. "Hahaha. Stop, I'll do it."

In fact, this "confrontation" was also a kind of test for Lei Tie. Qin Mian was satisfied with the result.

Chapter 032: Farming

“Delicious tanghulu, 2 Wen for a skewer!” Qin Mian shouted loudly.

Lei Tie stood beside him, never leaving.

This time, the tanghulu was sold faster than yesterday. In a short time, only two skewers remained, which were left for Xiao Hu and Gou Dan.

Qin Mian happily weighed the money pouch and smiled at Lei Tie as he said: “Do you have anything to buy?”

Lei Tie immediately realized that his wife had a better attitude towards him, more casual and intimate to him to be precise.

“No.”

“Let’s go and get some food. It’s still early, so let’s not have lunch in the town. The food in that restaurant is not as delicious as I made it. Do you have anything you want to eat?” Qin Mian asked, thinking about what he himself wanted to eat.

Lei Tie was about to answer “no” but seeing how Qin Mian was in a good mood, he changed his mind, “Fish.”

“Sure, go buy fish.” Qin Mian felt very refreshed.

The both of them consumed a large amount of food, so Qin Mian simply bought two fish of about 2 Jin. There were condiments of onion, ginger and garlic at home, no need to buy another. The tube bone was cheap and he bought 2 Jin to simmer, which was good for one’s health.

When they were about to leave the town, they saw an old man selling straw hats on the road.

“Buy two hats.” Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian spent 4 Wen to buy two hats, one for each person, which dispelled the scorching sensation on their heads.

On the way back, they chatted as they walked.

“The dry land has been half ploughed, is it possible to plant vegetables?” The work in the farm field couldn’t be left behind, Qin Mian was very concerned.

Lei Tie replied: “Nn.”

“I plant vegetables, you plant wheat.” Qin Mian said.

Lei Tie took a look at him. “Will you?”

“It’s not hard.” Qin Mian said calmly, “But I don’t know if I still remember...” After all, he hadn’t done farm work for many years.

Lei Tie thought nothing of it. There were only two *mu* of land in all and he alone was too busy to manage it.

When they entered the village, Xiao Hu and Gou Dan saw them. Xiao Hu was more reserved but Gou Dan jumped with joy and waved at them from far away.

Qin Mian gave each of them a skewer of tanghulu and a package of snacks. He said with a smile, “You guys don’t need to come here tomorrow. Thank to both of you for these two days.”

“Uncle Qin, what is this?” Gou Dan was more active than Xiao Hu, he asked curiously as he held the tanghulu.

Qin Mian said: “This is tanghulu. It’s sweet.”

“Thank you, Uncle Qin.” Gou Dan got both a snacks he never seen and also pastry, he was filled with joy.

Xiao Hu couldn’t help licking his lips.

The two bouncingly ran away.

After lunch, Qin Mian and Lei Tie put on the straw hats and went to the farm field. They were going to that one *mu* of dry land. Qin Mian planted vegetables and Lei Tie plowed the remaining half.

The vegetables planted in autumn were nothing more than pak choi, cabbage, radish and spinach which were the vegetable seeds Qin Mian had bought. Qin Mian roughly divided the ploughed part, namely the part to be planted with vegetables, into four small plots –one plot for each species.

Chapter 033: Lei Tie Knows Martial Arts!

Lei Tie was a man of action; the soil in the earth had been ploughed loose. First of all, water needed to be applied to ensure the water content in the soil. It was only that Qin Mian had a small body and merely carried water on a shoulder pole for one trip. The two buckets were only half filled but his shoulders were extremely painful under the pressure, which made him bared his teeth.

Lei Tie frowned and took away his shoulder pole, “Go back.”

“But...” Qin Mian rubbed his shoulder and looked at the field in embarrassment. The current him was indeed not made for heavy work, but he was a man, too. It was impossible for him to eat a ready-cooked meal. He had to do something for the family. Since he was not good at farming, then he must do something he was good at.

“Then I’ll go back first. Leave this work to you? Can you [manage]?” He was a little suspicious. Looking at Lei Tie’s appearance, it was impossible that he could be farming during the ten years he left.

Lei Tie said as if by the way, “I used to live with an old farmer.”

Qin Mian noticed that there was an illusion of sadness flashed past in Lei Tie’s eyes, his mouth opened wide. Lei Tie was born in a farming family, but his farming skill came from outsiders, which was a sad thing. His past ten years had certainly not been a pleasant experience. Although Qin Mian was curious, now was not the time to ask. It was just that the sadness he just saw made him care.

He stepped forward in two, patted Lei Tie on the shoulder and said positively: "It's all over. Come home when the sun sets."

Lei Tie nodded and thrown a look at his shoulder.

Qin Mian hurried home. The farm work was left to Lei Tie, but he didn't eat idly without work.

He took out a pencil and a stack of white paper he bought in the town last time and leaned forward on the dining table as he recalled the things that might be used to make money. Lei Tie made money by his physical strength, while he made money by his brain. In fact, he had a preliminary plan in mind for making a fortune, but that plan was too big and right now, he was short of manpower and capital, so it was difficult to carry out. He could only do it slowly.

He didn't think much, only took consideration of what in front of him first.

He found a straight stick for a ruler, picked up a pencil to write and draw on the paper. It was about an hour before he raised his head and looked at the drawing on the paper with satisfaction. He could earn another sum of money with these things.

It was still early in the day. He took out another piece of paper and continued to draw on the table. The design drawing of a table, chair and cabinet with modern characteristics gradually appeared on the paper. He didn't plan to sell them, but he planned to find someone to make them for his own use after the house was built. As a modern man, he was still more used to modern furniture. Idle with nothing to do, he simply drawn an interior design planning for reference.

"Wife, I'm back." Lei Tie looked down at the man who was writing and the strange thing in his hand that he used to write attracted Lei Tie's attention. Light flashed past in his eyes but he didn't disturb the wife. He retreated a few steps and called out again before he came near. The papers on the table were still there, but the thing that he used to write was gone.

“You’re early today.” Qin Mian loosened his muscles before he got up and took the hoe in Lei Tie’s hand to put it aside. “You go wash up first. The rice is already cooked; I’ll go stir-fry the dishes.”

After Lei Tie led the ox to the pond to drink water, he tied up the ox and dragged a small bundle of straw before he went to the kitchen to scoop water to wash his face.

Qin Mian poured oil into the heated clean wok. “I thought of another money-making idea. I want to go to town tomorrow.”

“Together.” Lei Tie said.

“Done with the farmland?” Qin Mian asked.

“No yet.”

Qin Mian hesitated for a moment, knowing that Lei Tie wouldn’t let him go to town alone. “Better forget it. Ah, if only I could master kung fu, I wouldn’t have to make you to accompany me to town all the time.”

“I’ll teach you.” Lei Tie suddenly uttered.

Surprised by the turn of events, Qin Mian was startled and the water on his hand dripped into the frying wok which then made “zeze” sound. With a “pat”, a drop of oil splashed on the back of his hand that almost made him thrown away the spatula.

“You know martial arts?” He looked at Lei Tie in surprise and joy.

“Nn.” Lei Tie frowned as he grabbed Qin Mian’s hand and rubbed the back of it. His plain tone seemed as though kung fu was a trivial matter.

Qin Mian gripped Lie Tie’s hand instead and couldn’t hide his joy. “Excellent! When will we start?” Which man hadn’t had a kung fu dream? For him, the matter of Lei Tie knowing kung fu could be interpreted as a surprise no different as gold dropped from the sky.

Lei Tie motioned to the wok, “Stir-fry first. Talk after the house is built.”

“Why?” The wok was heated up until it fumed smoke, Qin Mian hurriedly poured in the washed vegetables. “Can’t you teach me tomorrow?”

He yanked Lei Tie’s hand and signaled him not to leave.

Lei Tie sat down on a bench in front of the stove and added wood into the hearth, “I don’t want outsiders to know about this. Basic martial arts require horse stance training. After the house is built, [we] can train in the yard.”

He said it reasonably. Qin Mian could only say “oh” regretfully, but his excitement didn’t subside. When he thought that one day he could not only protect himself or help others, he was excited. He became more curious about Lei Tie’s past experience. He didn’t forget to turn over the dishes in the frying wok, “Who taught you kung fu? How long did [you] train? Can [you] fight one against ten?”

Lei Tie paused. “One against ten is a cinch. Talk later.”

Qin Mian felt a bit lost, but he was not an unreasonable person and soon left this feeling of loss at the back of his head. He had never seen Lei Tie practice martial arts during this period of time. It must be that Lei Tie deliberately concealed it from him. Since it’s been revealed to him today, didn’t it mean that the relationship between them was gradually getting closer? Thinking of this, he was in a good mood again. “In this case, I’ll continue to run and exercise from tomorrow to lay a good foundation. You, the Master, should be generous with the teaching in the future.”

“Nn.”

Qin Mian was in a good mood. Seeing Lei Tie was more pleasing to the eye, he thrown a smile and raked up a sweet-smelling sweet potato from the ashes under the stove. It was very hot and he quickly threw it to Lei Tie. “It was buried in when cooking the rice, it should be cooked.”

Lei Tie juggled the sweet potato in two hands. After a while passed, he broke it into two parts and handed one to Qin Mian.

After dinner, Qin Mian took a bath first. Now it was cold, he dared not wash outside and could only wash it in the house. However, the ground was not cemented, or tiled, or compacted soil. It got wet as soon as water sprinkled on it and couldn't dry up for half a day, which was really inconvenient.

“Sigh, there seems to be a lot of place to be remodeled.” Qin Mian soaked in the tub as he watered himself and looked out through the curtains. From here, he could see the lights in the village. There was only their house in the vicinity. It was too quiet, but he also wondered that although there were only two people in the house, even one of them didn't like talking, he still didn't feel lonely. On the contrary, the twinkling lights in the hall made him felt warm.

Sitting in the tub, he could even hear Lei Tie washing dishes in the kitchen, which made him involuntarily smile again.

There was no other entertainment in the evening, so Qin Mian went to bed after washing.

Lei Tie was taking a bath in the hall.

Qin Mian still had something to say and couldn't help urging: “Come quickly.”

Lei Tie paused. The foot that stepped on the soaked ground nearly slipped, he grasped the edge of the barrel with quick with hands and sharp-sighted. He glanced at the open door and shook his head slightly, but his movement sped up.

Qin Mian craned his neck to look several times and Lei Tie finally came in with an oil lamp. Under the light, the side face of the little wife anxiously waiting looked hazy in moonlight, which made people soft at the knees.

He blew out the light after he climbed the bed.

Qin Mian came closer to him in the dark. “You should keep practicing martial arts. If you don't practice for a long time, you'll be out of practice.

Otherwise, we'll go to the mountain in the morning and you can practice properly. I'll also widen my knowledge of your chivalrous demeanor, how about it?"

He heard a rustling noise and then an iron arm wound around from his back and held him. His body turned stiff. It was not the same thing to be held when he was awake and when he was asleep, alright? He struggled for a moment, but his waist was held tighter.

"Why do you want to practice martial arts?"

"Self-protection, build up a good physique and improve health." He answered without hesitation.

The top of his head was gently stroked and the arms on his waist were slightly loose before a deep and steady voice sounded in his ear, "Sleep. Get up early tomorrow."

Qin Mian had a feeling that Lei Tie would hold him tighter once he struggled, so he didn't move, but he thought it was necessary to explain, "Actually, we don't—"

Before he finished speaking, the hold on his waist tightened and even felt a little hurt. Qin Mian compromised and said: "Be gentle." *You want to hold then hold, but be careful of extermination after I got your handed-down techniques.*

Because there was something in his mind, Qin Mian woke up very early and he looked at the window, it was dark outside. He sat up and pushed the sleeping man hard. "Get up, quickly get up."

Lei Tie opened his eyes and put his hands under his head as he watched Qin Mian dress up speedily. His gaze slipped from Qin Mian's sober eyes to the uplifted corner of his mouth. This high spirited and cheerful look was really a rare sight.

"You hurry up." Qin Mian looked back and saw that the man was still lying lazily, he raised his voice and thrown his clothes at him.

Only then Lei Tie got up and dressed. The clothes on his body were a little untidy, showing a coppery chest.

Qin Mian looked away uneasily and ran away to wash.

After they had tidy up, with bow set and baskets on their backs, they marched up the mountain in the first rays of the morning sun.

The village was so quiet, no one got up earlier than them.

When they got to the mountain, they went deeper.

“Here is fine.” Qin Mian stopped, unable to hold himself back.

Lei Tie didn’t say anything and he put down his basket and bow set. When he stood straight as ramrod here, his momentum changed in a flash. If he was usually a silent tree, he was like a double-edged sword out of its sheath at this time. His fierce eyes, pursed lips and tense muscles all give off an aura of a destroyer.

Before Qin Mian could recover from the shock, he saw that Lei Tie had begun to demonstrate a set of fist techniques. He didn’t clearly see the change of the moves, but the rapid unpredictable moves and the intensity of tiger roaring wind[1] not only made him shocked, his heart pounded and even his blood was boiling.

After demonstrating a set of fist techniques, Lei Tie raised his head and upon coming into contact with a pair of sparkling eyes, there was a thin smile on the bottom of his eyes.

Note:

[1]虎虎生风 [hǔ hǔ shēng fēng] basic meaning is that heroes rise up and show great ambitions.

Chapter 034: Daughter-in-law PK Mother-in-law

034 – Daughter-in-law PK[1] Mother-in-law

“So powerful!” Qin Mian walked quickly to Lei Tie and grasped his hand excitedly. “I’ll study hard in the future. When you teach me, I’ll put my heart and soul into it.”

Lei Tie looked at the hand tightly grabbed on his, not batting an eyelid. It was small and still thin. “Depend on your performance.”

Qin Mian said: “No problem! If I’m right, you really like me——really like my cooking, don’t you? You can eat more now than you used to in that old house. I’ll make you more delicious food later, alright?”

Lei Tie was surprised that the wife seemed to have misunderstood him. His words “depend on your performance” referred to the aptitude of the wife to practice martial arts. However, he didn’t plan to rectify it, and a smile swept past the corner of his lips.

“En. The dew is dense on the mountain, go back.”

Their shoes and trouser legs were wet with dew from the vegetation.

They went down the mountain hand in hand. Qin Mian habitually looked at the scenery in the forest, so he was unaware of it.

Back at home, Qin Mian immediately started to run around the house.

Lei Tie hesitated for a moment and didn’t hurry out to the farmland. He took out his toolbox, sat at the door, and seized the time to complete the last

procedure of the wooden cart. Every time the little wife gallantly passed in front of him, he looked up.

After Qin Mian ran for five laps, he was sweating and panting. He was fully aware that going beyond the limit was as bad as falling short. He went to make breakfast after washing his face.

The wooden cart was soon finished. Lei Tie was only going to make an ordinary flat cart to pull goods. At Qin Mian's suggestion, he added compartments. The compartments were made into detachable type. If the cart was loaded with firewood and other things, the compartments could be removed to increase its capacity; if it was for carrying people, the compartments could be installed to give shelter from the wind and rain.

It took a total of two days for Lei Tie to plant two *mu* of farmland by himself; half a *mu* of vegetables and half a *mu* of wheat. Paddy field and dry farmland were basically used universally, so after a *mu* of paddy field was meticulously sorted out, it was planted with wheat.

After the work in the farmland was finished, Lei Tie went to Zhang Dashuan to inquire about the purchase of building materials and later went to the town to make a purchase. He only had to wait for the other people in the village to be done with the busy farming season before the construction could start.

Soon, everyone in the village knew that Lei Tie was going to build a new house. The Green Mountain Village was neither big nor small that even a trivial matter could be spread in a hubbub. There would admiration, jealousy, and also many sour[2] words.

People in the old house definitely had heard the news. Qin Mian was always on guard against them coming to find fault. Even if when going to the vegetable garden to pick vegetables, he either let Lei Tie go or try to stagger the time.

Even so, he still couldn't avoid it.

That day, when Qin Mian was cooking in the kitchen, he heard a sharp female voice in the distance and the corner of his mouth involuntarily rose.

“Eldest brother is feeding the ox *ah*.”

Du Shi, Zhao Shi, and Qian Shi came together as a group. Zhao Shi greeted while smiling happily and Qian Shi also had a smile on.

Only Du Shi was stone-faced. Her eyebrows were slender, her cheekbones were protruding and her mouth was thin, which when pursed tightly, the corners of the mouth unconsciously flicked down, seeming exceptionally vitriolic.

Lei Tie’s action of shaking apart the straw didn’t change in the slightest. He looked back and asked dully: “Is there anything?”

Qian Shi was a little afraid of this brother-in-law. When she came into contact with his cold eyes that one was unable to perceive any emotion, she felt timid and seamlessly retreated back to fall behind Du Shi and Zhao Shi. This was a favorable position that if there was a loss, Du Shi and Zhao Shi would suffer; if there was a small advantage, she would take. Nevertheless, her pair of eyes spun around and when she saw the compartment under the eaves, her eyes brightened.

“What are you saying? You’re our eldest brother, can’t we come even if there isn’t anything? Mother and we especially came to see you guys today. Eldest brother’s words are mean.” Zhao Shi said in a rebuking manner with a touch of intimacy tone, as if the relationship between their families were very good.

But it was a pity that she came across was Lei Tie, this kind of fashion was useless against him. Lei Tie didn’t make a sound, as though he didn’t hear her.

Du Shi used to “fight” with Lei Tie many times before. Knowing that he was not easy to deal with, she didn’t bother to argue needlessly with him, and without outsiders here, she didn’t hide her dislike for Lei Tie anymore. She said coldly: “Now that you are grown and become independent, you

don't take me and your father seriously. How could I dare to offend you again? Since you have the money to buy an ox and afford a house, then give that 100 Wen."

Qian Shi's delicate brows creased as she secretly gave her a look of dissatisfaction. The old lady made a mistake today. No matter how one looked at it, Qin Mian was easier to deal with than Lei Tie. Why did the old lady directly attack Lei Tie? Thinking of such, she still disinclined to raise her head.

Zhao Shi clicked her tongue, "Eldest brother, this is your fault. Since you have money, take the initiative. You bought ox and stuff, people in the village all have noticed it. Now, who doesn't know you are liberal with money? If they know you haven't given that money yet, who knows how many bad things they will say about you behind your back! But why should it? Eldest brother, do you think this one is right?"

Lei Tie turned and went inside the house.

Qin Mian had been peeping through the window crack in the kitchen. Seeing this, he was sure they came to ask him money. He rolled his eyes with a smile and put down the spatula before going out.

Lei Tie caught sight of him and opened his mouth, about to speak.

Qin Mian hinted at him and walked to stand in front of him. His intention of not letting Lei Tie speak was obvious.

"Mother, second younger brother's wife, and third younger brother's wife, why are you all here? Pardon me, the stir-frying echoed, so I didn't hear you. Please take a seat."

Seeing that Qin Mian had other plans, Lei Tie kept silent as he wished and watched him served cold water.

Du Shi gave Qin Mian a cold look and sat down at the table.

Zhao Shi and Du Shi dawdled. When they entered the hall, they stealth a few glances into the bedroom through the half-closed door. The furniture in the room was still those same pieces, which made them a little disappointed.

Du Shi didn't look at Qin Mian. "We have agreed for 100 Wen every month, Eldest shouldn't have to forget it? Since you have promised, you should be more conscious and don't make others urge you, or people who don't know would think that as a mother, I extort from you."

Lei Tie said: "My wife manages the money."

All of a sudden, three pairs of eyes full of surprise and shock looked at Qin Mian.

Qian Shi exclaimed in a fuss: "That's what happened? Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law is still young and has no parents' home to look after him; isn't it inappropriate for him to manage money?"

Qin Mian's face darkened as soon as he heard it. Who couldn't tell her meaning was that he came from other places, afraid that he would take the money and ran away.

Zhao Shi also chimed in malicious intentions, "Third younger brother's wife is right. Eldest brother, you still need to be careful with your wife, don't end up losing both the person and money. Oh, look at my mouth. I mean, if something goes wrong, isn't it you who is going to be heart-broken? Eldest sister-in-law, don't think that I speak badly, I only speak frankly."

Qin Mian didn't get angry but smiled a little and took a sip from the teacup, then unhurriedly said: "Second younger brother's wife and third younger brother's wife, we have already separated [from the family], isn't it inappropriate of you to *extend your hand*[3] to your brother-in-law's family? If this gets out, it'll hurt your reputation." *Acting like this is your family!*

Lei Tie was indifferent and silent, as though his speech right was given to Qin Mian.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were even more shocked and looked at each other. It would be bad for them to talk about it and if words got out, it wouldn't be pleasant to hear. But if it was Du Shi who spoke, she would be unimpeded. They both looked at Du Shi.

Du Shi was not a fool. Before the separation, she didn't get any money from Lei Tie and now she couldn't count on it anymore. She glared at Zhao Shi and Qian Shi, looked at Qin Mian, and said impatiently, "Fine, give the money quickly. I don't have an effort to debate with you."

"Mother, don't be in a hurry." Qin Mian went to the kitchen to serve them a pile of fragrant fried peanuts. He said enthusiastically, "This had just been out of the wok. It's very fragrant. Taste it."

Lei Tie took a look at Qin Mian. He hadn't thought that the little wife wanted to foster cordial relations with the old house, but he still didn't speak out.

"The peanuts are well fried, fragrant, and not scorched at all. Eldest sister-in-law is very skilled!" Zhao Shi praised, smiled at Qin Mian, and immediately reached for a handful of peanuts. Immediately, a plate of peanuts was a quarter less.

Qian Shi was unwilling to fall behind and immediately reached out. Having something to eat, she no longer wanted to talk and quickly stuffed the peanuts into her mouth.

Qin Mian reddened with shame for them. Seeing Du Shi's face was not good, he quickly put the plate in front of Du Shi's and said with a smile: "Mother, second younger brother's wife, and third younger brother's wife, even if you guys don't come today, I was going to visit you."

Thinking that he was going to offer money, Du Shi's face eased up a little.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi also thought the same.

But Qin Mian said: “Well, to tell you the truth, Brother Tie did have some money in hands at the beginning of separation. It’s also not proper for the husband to have money in hands. Second younger brother’s wife and third younger brother’s wife, don’t you think so? In particular, the beloved child, second brother. I saw him buy a tasty vegetarian pastry for Dabao two days ago...”

Tasty vegetarian pastry? Why didn’t she know about it? Du Shi gave Zhao Shi a fierce look. Even if she was an old biddy, she often heard the villagers said that the tasty vegetarian pastry was good and also expensive, which people generally wouldn’t want to buy it. Where did the second [child] get the money? It must be his private saving.

Zhao Shi trembled as she opened her mouth to explain but Qin Mian didn’t give her a chance at all. As if he didn’t notice it, his glib talk was especially quick-witted, “But Brother Tie can’t hold money at all. You see, not long since we’ve been living here, he bought an ox, bought land, and build another house! I told him these things don’t need to rush, but he wouldn’t listen...”

The corner of Lei Tie’s mouth twitched a little.

Note:

[1] PK as in the game player-killing (PK)

[2] Sour = jealous

[3] Extend one’s hand can mean interfere

Chapter 035: Playing Tricks

035 – Playing Tricks

“Even if there is money, he had spent them all. Don’t we still need to live? Now we only have one or two silver in our hands. We have to pay people’s wages to build the house, right? And treat them to a meal, right? That’s not enough money. So, I thought, can I trouble mother, second younger brother’s wife, and third younger brother’s wife to borrow some? We will definitely return it as soon as possible.” Qin Mian looked at Du Shi with sincere and earnest eyes, spontaneously added, “We can write a receipt for a loan to ensure that there is a lent and a return!”

“What?”

The expressions of Du Shi and the company changed simultaneously.

Zhao Shi scrambled to open her mouth, her voice was loud, “Eldest sister-in-law, aren’t you making things difficult for me and third younger brother’s wife? How can we have money when the mother is in charge of home?”

Du Shi looked sullen and her chest was stuffy with anger. She grasped the edge of the plate with both hands until her fingers whitened and wanted to drop the plate on the ground, but she also wanted the glossy oiled peanuts. She had thought that this Qin Mian was easy to grasp, but never expected he was neither easy to deal with! Don’t even mention about giving money, he even wanted to borrow money. No way!

“It’s your problem that you don’t have enough money. I came here today to ask for money.” Du Shi glanced at the peanuts and then looked directly at Qin Mian, with chin held high. “No, it’s fine. I haven’t seen any oil in our

house for several days. From today on, I have to ask the eldest's wife to take care of our family's meal."

When Zhao Shi and Qian Shi heard that, the side of their lips quietly emerged a wisp of a smile as they looked gloatingly at Qin Mian while still chewing the peanuts.

Qin Mian's eyes flooded with cynicism and face stiff as he pleaded: "Mother, it's not that we don't want to give the money, but we're just in a difficult time. We really don't have money. When the deal was made, it was agreed that the money could be given in two or three months——"

Du Shi waved her hand with an unsightly face. "It's no use saying that. If you want to go back on your words, you must go to Li Zheng[1]."

Zhao Shi's clicked her tongue without stop and then added fuel to the fire, "Eldest sister-in-law, it's nothing more than a 100 wen. Your ox was bought for at least 5 silver taels, so then only 5 taels were spent and now you're short of a 100 wen? I think you better give it, otherwise, I'm afraid that the mother believes you want to repudiate the debt."

Chewing can't even stop your mouth. Qin Mian glanced at her contemptuously and pretended to be embarrassed as he muttered, "Fine, I'll give you that 100 Wen."

He leaned over to Lei Tie's ear and whispered in a deliberative tone: "Brother Tie, after paying the money back, we won't have enough money. Let's go to father after two days to see if we can ask to borrow some."

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian with an odd expression in his eyes, but he didn't say a word.

Du Shi's face suddenly became alert when she heard it clearly. She made up her mind to talk with Lei Daqiang and tell the whole family to avoid Qin Mian and Lei Tie when she got home.

Only then Qin Mian got up and walked into the bedroom. As soon as he turned around, he sniggered and closed the door behind him.

After a while, he came out with a handful of copper coins and put them on the table. He blocked them with his arms, squeezed out a smile as he said in low voice: “Don’t be anxious, mother. I’ll count first, so as not to give less.”

Zhao Shi softly murmured, “Poor.”

Qin Mian lowered his head and counted the copper coins one by one, “One, two, three.... seventy-six.... seventy-six, seventy-seven... one hundred.”

Du Shi was taken aback and stared at him in a ridiculing manner. He couldn’t even count and counted five times wrongly, giving 5 Wen more which was enough to buy a big fish.

Du Shi’s eyes twinkled and she reached out to set aside the copper coins into her bosom.

“Mother, I’m afraid I’d counted less. I’ll count again.” Qin Mian hastily stopped her with a smile.

Du Shi swatted his hand open and frowned, “You guys are after all my son and daughter-in-law, how can I pursue you for giving me three or four coins less? So be it, I’m still in a hurry to get back to cooking.”

Before Qin Mian could respond, she gathered the copper coins together and put them in her bosom. Then she stood up and took the plate. “I’ll take it home to give your father as snacks while drinking.”

With that, she walked away as quickly as though someone was chasing after her.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi hurriedly kept up.

Watching them go far, Qin Mian finally couldn’t help laughing out loud, “HAHAHA...”

Lei Tie came to his side and touched his head.

Qin Mian turned to look at him, still unable to restrain the smiling expression. “Believe it or not? It will surely keep them to detour from us for

a long time.”

“Not hungry?” asked Lei Tie in a low voice. For the people over there, he bore no sentiment.

“Hungry. I’ll go fry the dishes.” Qin Mian stretched out his arms, shrugged his shoulders, and then went to the kitchen briskly to continue his work.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s life was calm again without the people from the old house coming to bring vexation.

Soon, most people in the village were done with the busy farming season. Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to find someone to ask about auspicious day and time and inform the 20 casual laborers who were invited once the time to start building were set.

Qin Mian had inquired about it. The average wage for a casual laborer building a house was about 25 wen. Qin Mian planned to pay 20 Wen a day, including a lunch of four dishes; two meat and two vegetables. He made Lei Tie be thoroughly clear with these when asked for help. Generally speaking, these laborers were from the same village who could eat three meals a day at home and didn’t need the meal inclusion, just a few wages would be fine. But making them a delicious meal at noon would make them work more diligently and efficiently to build the house. Normally, they didn’t necessarily have such a good meal at home.

The invited people were very happy. When there was no work in the farmland, these farmers would also go to the town or the county to find work. The wages were not necessarily satisfactory. Now, they could earn money in the village and have a good meal at noon, who would not like to come? As for those slanderous gossips of Lei Tie and Qin Mian, who cared? Who could live without money?

Note:

[1]里正 [lǐ zhèng] village head (a small officer), who mainly in charge of account registration and tax payment. (T/N: previously thought of Li Zheng as a name but it’s actually a position)

Chapter 036: Build New House

036 – Build New House

Qin Mian also had asked Lei Tie to invite Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli when there were many people on the road. It was only an invitation out of showing manner, because otherwise an ‘unfilial’ hat would fall, he and Lei Tie would have a bad reputation in the village. Whether Lei Daqiang and company would like to come or not was their problem. Now, it was enough for the two families to maintain their sentiments on the surface.

Before that day came, Lei Tie went to the mountain with a bow set and a basket on his back. If he could hunt some preys, they didn’t need to spent money.

Lei Tie grabbed a stick in front of him to *beat the grass and frighten way the snake*[1]. In his basket, there was a new and slightly smaller basket.

Qin Mian followed after empty handed. His idea was that since Lei Tie was a kung fu expert, they wouldn’t be in danger on the mountain, so he took going up the mountain as a tour. Two days ago, there was an autumn rain. In the wet underbrush, there were patches of mushrooms huddled together like small umbrellas. They stood lively and fully in the underbrush, making whoever saw them happy.

The mushrooms were fresh and beautiful. Qin Mian took out the shovel in the basket to dig. Although he didn’t communicate with Lei Tie, they went up the mountain many times at a time and had a tacit understanding. Lei Tie grabbed the bow set and turned around looking for prey. In a short time, he hunted a hare weighing more than 3 jin.

When the farmers were done with the work in the farmland, they were idle. Since the two people were not in a rush, after Qin Mian had dug up the surrounding mushrooms, they went deep into the mountain.

It was just that the dew was too dense. Although the two people wore an extra pair of trousers, their trouser legs were still wet and felt a little cold when they stuck onto the flesh.

Lei Tie's trousers were also wet below the knees, but he paid no mind to it.

"Is there any big animal in the mountain? If you can hunt a big one, the hide can use to make several kneepads to keep warm and waterproof."

"There is. Go further in." Lei Tie caught a glimpse of a brown snake on Qin Mian's left side, peering out of the grass silently. Without battling an eyelid, the stick in his hand poked and jabbed, the snake then flew far away.

"What's wrong?" Qin Mian looked up inexplicably when he heard the sound of leaves rustling.

"Nothing."

There was a stabbing pain on the back of his hand. Qin Mian looked down and it turned out that he had been scratched by a branch. There was a small tree over a person tall bearing red wheat-sized fruits with thorns grown slightly obliquely upward the branches.

"Why careless?" Lei Tie saw a long and thin scratch on the back of his hand and frowned.

"This is..." Qin Mian couldn't believe his eyes. A few days ago, he was still lamenting that there was no Sichuan pepper in this world. Today, he found it on the mountain. In his previous existence, there were three types of Sichuan pepper trees in his grandfather's vegetable garden.

Lei Tie said: "Spicy fruits."

Another new name again. Qin Mian didn't know whether to laugh or cry. He picked a fruit and put it into his mouth. It was the familiar peppery and

spicy taste.

Lei Tie grabbed his hand abruptly. “Why put it in [your] mouth?”

This was the first time that he spoke to Qin Mian in such a harsh tone that Qin Mian thought it was a bit unusual. It turned out that this man also had a temper. Feeling a bit warm inside, he smiled. “This is a Sichuan pepper tree and this fruit is a kind of seasoning. I have a hunch that we have another way to make money. We have to make a mark on this place and dig it up when we return.”

Lei Tie stared at him for a long time before taking out a shovel from his basket without a word. Without even looking, he poked hard at a tree trunk nearby and turned around to leave. A bark larger than a face was poked out of the tree trunk, revealing a beige tree core.

Qin Mian had an illusion that it was his skin that had been peeled off, his back felt cold and he looked at the man’s back suspiciously. *This guy is not pissed off, right?*

He walked quickly to catch up with Lei Tie and looked at his face — expressionless and cold.

Really angry? Qin Mian was extremely surprised. As he vaguely aware of something, he went to catch up again, raised his arm to hook around Lei Tie’s shoulder and then raised his lips to smile at him when he looked over. Because of the height difference, the posture was a little awkward, but he didn’t let go.

“I’ve a sense of propriety, I won’t rush to eat things I don’t know. I didn’t eat the Sichuan pepper just now, just licked it with my tongue.”

It was only then Lei Tie’s expression eased up.

“You people called that thing a spicy fruit? You didn’t know it could be used as a seasoning?”

“It tastes spicy. The old people believe it’s poisonous.”

“So it is like that.” Qin Mian rolled his eyes with a smile on his face.

At about two o’clock, they went down the mountain with a hungry stomach. The harvest for the half a day was quite abundant: one hare; three pheasants; two roe deers which assumed to be siblings weighing more than 40 jin; a basket of mushrooms and chestnuts. Because there were so many things, both of Qin Mian’s hands were occupied. The Sichuan pepper tree could not be dug for the time being, but would be transplanted after the new house was built. Thus, Qin Mian picked a lot of Sichuan peepers.

They arrived at home with sweat on their faces. Qin Mian was in good health now, so he didn’t feel too tired but his arms were a little sore. He sat for a while before going to cook.

Lei Tie had known earlier that the wife had no joy without meat. Without being told to, he carried a pheasant away to deal with.

Qin Mian watched him walk to the pond with satisfaction and decided to cook pheasant stewed with chestnut for lunch.

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In the blink of an eye, it was the day when the new house construction started. The weather was good, the blazing sun rose in the sky.

Qin Mian invited Sister Zhang and another Aunt Wang, who had a good skill in cooking. Aunt Wang was in her forties and her skill was among the best in the village. People in the village usually asked her to handle happy events. Sister Zhang had a good relationship with Aunt Wang and invited her on behalf of Qin Mian which she readily agreed.

Having had breakfast at home earlier, the two people came to Qin Mian’s home together and brought along some bowls and chopsticks. Because Qin Mian had not enough dishware, it could only be borrowed from others.

Qin Mian had prepared today’s ingredients the night before and explained in detail how to make the lunch to Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang.

They had heard that Qin Mian had planned to serve two meat and two vegetable dishes. Upon seeing the pheasants and hare in the kitchen, they were internally excited because they could also taste these dishes at noon.

The main food was steamed bun with two meat and two vegetable dishes which were stewed hare meat with potato, stewed pheasant with mushroom, stir fried crown daisy and stir fried eggplant.

Both Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang were quick and neat workers. They pulled up their sleeves, washed their hands and started to work.

After telling them not to forget to make tea, Qin Mian hurried to the house site.

The laborers were all honest people. They didn't come late on purpose and also came after breakfast. When Qin Mian arrived, everyone was busy. Lei Tie was talking to Zhang Dashuan while holding a piece of paper.

There were two tables and a few chairs not far from the brick pile, which should be borrowed by Lei Tie.

Qin Mian walked over quickly.

Upon seeing him, Zhang Dashuan smiled at Lei Tie and said, "This plan wasn't drawn by your wife, is it?" The houses in the village were basically of the same structure — a three-room house was divided into three parts; a central hall with bedrooms on both sides. But Qin Mian's plan divided the three-room house into four parts; two big and two small rooms. There was a hallway and a back door between the two rooms in the north. This kind of layout was unique in the village, so Zhang Dashuan thought it was a little unusual.

Lei Tie didn't deny it.

"Brother Zhang." Qin Mian greeted Zhang Dashuan, but he didn't get near at once. Instead, he faced the laborers and secretly sized them up. With a smile on his face, he said in a loud voice, "Thank you for coming to help, brothers and uncles. This noon's dishes are stewed hare with potato, stewed

pheasant with mushroom, stir fried crown daisy and stir fried eggplant, oily guaranteed. Everyone work harder and let's have meal on time at noon!"

Looking at the skinny and regarded as a useless teenager, whose words said were straight to the point without the slightest hesitation, and also calm and easy-mannered, the group of big men suddenly put away some contempt.

Some of the lively younger guys even took the lead in cheering.

In an instant, the atmosphere was heated. While they were enthusiastically digging the foundation, moving bricks and mixing starch paste, they were tearing their voices to chat at the same time. The children who were attracted by the noises here came over running one after another, playing around the brick pile. They were not afraid to be scolded when they accidentally got in the way of the adults and laughed merrily as they got out of the way. It was very lively.

Zhang Dashuan cheerfully whispered to Lei Tie, "Your wife is amazing."

Lei Tie looked at the teenager coming by and nodded to Zhang Dashuan.

"Brother Zhang," Qin Mian stood beside Lei Tie and warmly said, "Brother Tie and I don't have much experience in this field, and we'd still need to trouble you working hard today. Please help us take care of it."

Zhang Dashuan frankly said: "It is as it should be, don't worry. I'll go ahead and be busy."

"You don't need to help here. Bring the tea later." Lei Tie said to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said: "I know. You only manage things here, I'll arrange the rest."

He didn't see the people in the old house and thought they would not come. When he was leaving, he saw Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli going this way. Lei Daqiang was nowhere to be seen.

He didn't care. Since he couldn't help here, he turned to go home.

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang had their own division of labor; one dealt with the dishes and the other kneaded the dough, working in an orderly manner. Unable to intervene, he didn't get into the kitchen.

This arrangement allowed Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang to receive his trust, and his heart settled.

Qin Mian went to deal with the housework. He collected his clothes and Lei Tie's to wash and then led the ox to drink water and eat grass. Afterwards, he hid in the bedroom and took out the pencil and paper to scribble.

Now in early October, the weather was cooler. It was expected that the winter here would be very cold. He felt it was necessary to build a heatable brick bed in the bedroom. He was very clear about how the heatable brick bed was made. Previously, he had lived with a northeastern family for two days when he went to the northeast to shoot food programs because he was curious.

Note:

[1]打草惊蛇 [dǎ cǎo jīng shé] = beat the grass and frighten away the snake
— act rashly and alert the enemy

Chapter 037: Thick-skinned

037 – Thick-skinned

There were several more female voices outside the room, making Qin Mian lifted his head from the drawing and put the pencil back into the space before he opened the door.

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi stood in front of the kitchen with their heads held high. Lei Dabao and Lei Xiaobao, who were holding Zhao Shi's legs, looked at the uncooked pheasants in the basin while drooling. Lei Xinxin was also there, holding Qian Shi's hand while sucking her finger.

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang stood awkwardly by the water vat as they wiped their hands on the aprons with a furious expression.

Qin Mian understood. Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang must have been bullied. He raised his voice and spoke, "Mother, second younger brother's wife and third younger brother's wife, why are you guys here?"

Zhao Shi coquettishly laughed. "Eldest sister-in-law, don't you want to treat people meal at noon? We came to help you cook. But, we didn't expect you to invite other people."

Du Shi's face was grim. "Eldest's wife, don't you take me and your father seriously?"

"Yeah, inviting outsiders rather than the relatives, eldest sister-in-law, this is going...." Qian Shi intentionally spoke halfway.

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang were silent while frowning. Just now, the words of Du Shi and her company were rude which made them both angry. They both were invited by Qin Mian and Lei Tie, which had no relation

with Du Shi and her company. What's going on with Du Shi and her company being arrogant and bossy here?

Qin Mian looked at Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang with an apologetic look. Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang shook their heads to signal that they were fine.

“Mother, second younger brother's wife and third younger brother's wife, you guys misunderstood. I have to pay for inviting Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang to cook. I do want to ask you guys to help me cook, but should I pay or not? If don't pay, I feel apologetic to trouble you guys; if I pay, it's too outlandish and hurts the relationship between the two families. Mother, don't you think so? I didn't invite you guys after much thinking, but didn't expect mother, second younger brother's wife and third younger brother's wife to misunderstand. I'm really sorry.”

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were speechless for a while. They had inquired that the salary of Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang to help cook for a day was the same amount as those men. They earned 20 wen for doing a meal, which was quite a lot, and it also included free lunch. If Qin Mian asked them to help cook but didn't pay for it, they would be unwilling, but how could this be said directly?

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang, upon seeing that the three people's faces had changed, they laughed secretly and busily turned around.

“I was also afraid you'll be bored if come early. I was going to call you guys at meal time.” Qin Mian looked at the sky. “Mother, it's roughly another two hour or so before meal time, why don't you sit down, have some tea and chat for a while? Just leave the work in the kitchen to Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang.”

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang smiled at each other and went to the kitchen to keep busy.

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were annoyed by Qin Mian's disregard of their “face”, but they couldn't refute his flawless words. Moreover, they were all looking forward to the lunch at noon and didn't want to argue with Qin Mian at this time.

The three people looked at each other. Ignoring Qin Mian, they really sat at the table in the hall, drinking tea and chatting.

Qin Mian secretly admired their thick-skinned. As long as they didn't make trouble, it was only a matter of adding a few pairs of chopsticks at noon.

“Sister Zhang, Auntie Wang, I'm going to trouble you both with the work in the kitchen.”

“Don't worry.” Hearing the implication in his words, Sister Zhang responded in clear sound with a smile, looking at Du Shi and her company indiscernibly.

Qin Mian also smiled, calmly locked the door of the bedroom and went to the construction site to deliver tea.

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi stared at the locked door, their chests felt suffocated. They wanted to say something, but Qin Mian had walked away quickly. That back figure looked very carefree and leisurely.

On the construction site, everyone was working very hard. Many hands made light work. At present, the foundation pit had been almost dug. Lei Tie was not idle. With his jacket off and shovel in hands, he shoveled up the soil in the pit. The strong and tight muscles moved with the movement of the arms, completely showing the power of masculinity.

“Everyone has worked hard. The tea has been delivered, everyone is welcome.” Qin Mian took out water pot and teacups from the bamboo basket and put them on the table.

“Okay.”

There were few people who answered and came to drink two cups of tea before continuing the work.

When Wu Di came over, he smiled at Qin Mian. He was also a steadfast worker. After drinking water, he continued to dig up the soil.

Qin Mian didn't want to go back to face Du Shi and her company, but he also couldn't help any by staying here. He simply moved some bricks to the shade under the tree and sat down against the tree trunk, feeling somewhat bored stiff.

Lei Tie noticed that Qin Mian didn't go home. He put down his shovel and lifted his long legs to walk out of the foundation pit easily. He went to the table and drank a cup of water before walking up to Qin Mian and casually asked: "What's wrong?"

"Nothing." Qin Mian glanced at the construction site and said with a forced smile: "I didn't see your father." He thought that Lei Daqiang would be a little late at most, but he didn't think that he was still not here.

"En."

Qin Mian raised his eyebrow. En what?

"I'm just a little curious about what he thinks — whether he wants to be to coax and plead or afraid that others don't know that he has a bad relationship with us." The three Lei brothers had all come, it was totally impossible for Lei Daqiang to be busy that he couldn't come. Qin Mian said these words without thinking whether Lei Tie would be unhappy because he mentioned his father, but perhaps subconsciously, he believed Lei Tie must be on his side.

From time to time, the busy people at the construction site secretly looked over and wondered how the two got along.

Lei Tie didn't say a word. His cold expression obviously shown he didn't care whether Lei Daqiang would come.

Qin Mian didn't want to hear his answer, so he added: "It's not a formal treat. I think, if he still doesn't come at lunch, not need to go invite." He smiled somewhat cunningly. To be honest, seeing Lei Daqiang incurred his dislike.

Lei Tie nodded, "I'll go work."

“Go.” Qin Mian waved him away.

It was only until the sun was up, which indicated lunch hour, did Qin Mian go back. Once he saw that the meal was indeed ready, he went back to the construction site to call for the big guys to eat.

The men stopped working with a clear loud laugh and easily moved the tables and chairs as they walked to the back of the village while laughing and talking.

Chapter 038: Upset

038 – Upset

There were more than twenty people but the hall had not enough room, so four tables were set up outside. Although the autumn sun was up the sky, it was not fierce but rather warm on the body basking under the sun.

Lei Tie greeted the guests and took them to their seats, while Qin Mian directed to serve the dishes in the kitchen. Aunt Wang effortlessly moved out one steamer basket of sweet-smelling steamed buns, which were still piping hot. Qin Mian served the dishes on the tables with Sister Zhang and saw Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi sitting at the table very well-disposed, which drawn a mocking smile on his lips.

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang looked at each other at a loss and shook their heads. It was no wonder Lei Tie and Qin Mian had to separate from that family.

The guests had even looked at Du Shi and the two with strange eyes, but these three were completely unaware of it. Their eyes were solely on the dishes in Qin Mian's hands.

There were four dishes on each table: stewed rabbit with potato, stewed pheasant with mushroom, stir-fried crown daisy and stir-fried eggplant. Each course of dishes was served in a small basin, wrapped in a strong meat flavor which made people unable to shift their gazes.

“Everyone, please, no need to stand on ceremonies.” Lei Tie stood up to say a few words before sitting back down.

Everyone smilingly said: “Won't stand on ceremonies.” In their heart, they thought Lei Tie and Qin Mian were honest people. The quantity of meat in

both meat dishes was ample, unlike some stingy people who when they treated the guests, the meat in the meat dishes was only a smidgen with vegetables being the majority.

Qin Mian said: "All the steamed buns are here, everyone is self-served. I won't serve one by one, so that you won't feel uncomfortable."

Zhang Dashuan voiced out: "Lei Tie's wife, you can rest assured that we won't stand on ceremonies."

Du Shi took a large piece of boneless pheasant meat to put it into her bowl and then another piece of rabbit meat for fear that she would be slower than others. She swept a glance at Qin Mian and said as if it was a matter of course: "Eldest's wife, go call your father."

The guests couldn't help fell into silence and looking at each other. On such a large construction site, who wouldn't discover Lei Daqiang was not there in the morning?

Wu Di sniggered inwardly and inquisitively looked at Qin Mian, somewhat curious to how he would reply.

Qin Mian kept his cool, "Mother, father has always been very good to me and Brother Tie, and we bear in mind. It's just that he hasn't come yet probably because he's not well and resting at home. It's very cold these days, easy to catch cold if you're not careful. I think we shouldn't ask father to come here, so as to avoid the wind. But don't worry, I've left food for him and little sister, so take it along when you go home. I'll come to see him later with Brother Tie."

Du Shi choked up and glared at Qin Mian coldly.

Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang both carried a smile in their eyes. Qin Mian used words to stop Du Shi and they felt their irritation vented out.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli bowed their heads in shame. In fact, they knew exactly why Lei Daqiang didn't come. Inwardly, they blamed Lei Daqiang;

if you want to put on airs, don't choose this time. The two looked at each other, somewhat helpless.

Qin Mian acted as though he was unaware of Du Shi's glare, taking Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang to a brand-new small square table to sit down and rather apologetically said: "Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang, if you don't mind, you two can sit here. It's a bit quieter." This small square table was the extra woods from the cart Lei Tie made, which was not much. Therefore, Lei Tie used it to make a small square table.

Naturally, Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang knew what he meant by "quieter", so they both were relieved. They didn't want to sit with Du Shi and her company. After all, they were from the same village, who didn't know Du Shi and her company? Besides, after the fuss they made priory, the two didn't want to sit around with Du Shi to find trouble for themselves. How could they blame Qin Mian when they were inwardly rejoicing? It was just that they never made out Qin Mian to be very attentive. Although it was a small table, there were also four dishes on the table with enough quantity for them to eat and would still have many left.

"Don't say that. Giving this table for both of us is exceedingly most welcome." Aunt Wang, whose character was straightforward and generous, said cheerfully.

Sister Zhang also repeatedly agreed, "Exactly. Lei Tie's wife, don't be busy. Go have a meal, too. "

After Qin Mian had properly arranged things, he sat down beside Lei Tie. The empty bowl in front of him had already been filled with dishes for him. He smiled at Lei Tie before picking up his chopsticks to eat.

Although the occasion was made awkward by Du Shi, there were Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi and Wu Di with their glib tongues, whom soon broken the rigid atmosphere. People joked and chatted freely, the atmosphere was very lively.

Stir-fried crown daisy and eggplant were vegetable dishes, but they were stir-fried with lard oil, the flavor was precise to the finest detail. After a

meal, there were almost no leftovers on the four tables. Everyone was satisfied with the food and didn't delay the time. After a short rest, they went to the construction site.

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi didn't mention anything about staying to help clean up. They left carrying the meal Qin Mian prepared for Lei Daqiang and Lei Chuntao.

After Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang washed the dishware, they cleaned up the kitchen neat and tidy.

Sister Zhang said: "Lei Tie's wife, we'll go back if there's nothing else to do here. We'll come back tomorrow morning."

Qin Mian came over with two bowls and smilingly said: "Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang, you guys have worked hard. These are the unfinished food on the small table. If you guys don't dislike it, take it back. Brother Tie and I both have a large amount of food intake, with this much it is not enough for us to eat in the evening."

The people of farmer household weren't choosy that much. Although it was leftover food, it was also good food. Sister Zhang and Aunt Wang happily accepted, thanked him and left together. They walked while talking about what Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi had done today, which invoked their dislike even more.

Sister Zhang disdainfully said: "Normally, doing that in their home is not an issue. Today, so many people are present, yet Du Shi and her two daughters-in-law are still doing it. It really makes people unable to look on."

"Who said no, ah? Their family's fourth son still hasn't been match. Du Shi is not afraid that with her reputation spread out, no one wants to be their family's daughter-in-law?" Aunt Wang chimed in.

"Heehee." Sister Zhang laughed with her mouth covered, "In any case, if I have a daughter, I will never marry her to their family. You didn't see Zhao Shi's appearance at lunch today, wishing she could have two mouths."

The two had gone far away but it couldn't deter Qin Mian's good hearing ability, who heard them crystal clear and couldn't help bursting with laughter. He wondered if he could think of a way to prevent Du Shi and her company from coming. They weren't even willing to do anything, why should they be allowed to freeload? It would take half a month to build the house at the latest, were they going to come over for lunch every day? It's no big deal to let people take advantage of it, but letting people he didn't like to take advantage of it, Qin Mian would be upset no matter how he thought about it.

However, when he thought about it, if the three thick-skinned people weren't allowed to come, he didn't know what they were going to do, so he gave up devising a plan. That's fine, just put up with it some more. After the house and the courtyard were built, it wouldn't be so easy to take advantage of their family again.

Chapter 039: Live In a New House

(1)

039 – Live In a New House (1)

Later, Qin Mian wasn't in the slightest surprised to see Du Shi and her company coming back for lunch, or to see Lei Daqiang at the table. Only Lei Chuntao, who's skin was too thin, unwilling to come. Despite that, Qin Mian still prepared her meal every day and asked Du Shi to bring it home.

Nearly half a month later, the new house was finally completed, standing in silence with greenish-black bricks and black roof tiles. For the reason that Qin Mian often went to "supervise" and treat the laborers warmly and considerately, in return, the laborers worked very carefully. Every brick and tile was very neatly put and one would know at a glance that they had done their best.

On the day when the house was completed, Qin Mian moved the meal from noon to evening and also prepared good wines. The laborers ate and drank to their heart's content and satisfaction, to the extent where they were smiling broadly even when being scolded by their wives who called them home.

After this event, they had a little more understanding of Qin Mian and Lei Tie, and later treated the two with a little more kindness. To a certain extent, this attitude had affected other villagers. Qin Mian and Lei Tie then had a better relationship with the people in the village, especially Qin Mian. This was a part of the story to be recounted later, not to be mention at the moment.

Qin Mian *struck the iron while it was hot*[1]. He found several experienced masons earlier and showed them the drawing of the heatable brick bed that had been drawn for a long time as he explained in detail so that the heatable brick bed would be successfully built.

Aside from having a trace of surprise when seeing the drawing, Lei Tie didn't voice out an opinion and gave Qin Mian a free rein to do what he wanted.

After the heatable brick bed was completed, Qin Mian focused on the bathroom. It took him and Lei Tie two days to find some blocks of marble from the mountain and sent them to the Precious Stones Pavilion where jewelries and ornaments were made, requesting them to use special cutting tools to cut the stones to flat slabs for the bathroom floor and the kitchen stove. It costed 5 taels of silver just to cut and polish it, which made Qin Mian so distressed that he didn't buy meat dishes that day.

The cutting master in that shop was more distressed than him. His cutting knife was used to cut precious stones, jadeite and pearls, not rocks. Ultimately, he cut it for the sake of money.

Afterwards, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop with furniture drawings.

Liao Zhifu saw Qin Mian enter the door with a smile on his face, while Lei Tie followed him silently with a basket on his back. This familiar scene made him think that time had turned back to a month ago.

"Manager Liao, hope that you are well."

The sprightly smile on Qin Mian's face suddenly made Liao Zhifu feel a little stomachache, "Haha, it's little brother, all thanks to you." The last blueprint made their employer earned more than 5000 taels, which was not much for them businessmen, but it was rare to get 5000 taels for a month's net profit. Therefore, he didn't want to offend Qin Mian.

"I really don't deserve this [compliment]," Qin Mian said with a more enthusiastic smile, "I'm sending you *money* again."

“Oh?” Liao Zhifu was interested.

Lei Tie’s eyes had always been on Qin Mian. How should he be no worse than the wife who could make money?

“What are you thinking?” Qin Mian hit Lei Tie with his arm. He called for several times but Lei Tie didn’t respond.

Lei Tie returned to his senses and was inwardly surprised to find that he could be absent-minded even when he was not alone. He kept his composure and upon seeing that Liao Zhifu also looked at him uncertainly, realization hit him. He took out some papers from the basket and handed them to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian threw a glance at the top one and handed them it to Liao Zhifu. “Manager Liao takes a look first before we discuss?”

Liao Zhifu looked intently and was surprised, “This is a wardrobe?”

“Correct.” Qin Mian nodded.

Liao Zhifu didn’t immediately express his opinion, seeing that Qin Mian still had several pieces of paper in his hand. He glared at the shop assistant who was curiously coming over to have a look. “Don’t you have any foresight? Why don’t you serve tea to these two brothers?”

“Yes.” The assistant quickly stepped back to withdraw.

Qin Mian smiled plentiful and pulled Lei Tie to sit down.

Liao Zhifu sat down opposite them, looked at the drawing and considered: “I only ever see a wardrobe with sliding doors, but this is the first time I see this kind with flap doors.” Qin Mian’s drawing was very meticulous and not difficult to understand at all.

Qin Mian came straight to the point, “We are here today because first, we want to order some furniture in your shop; and second, we want to make some money to supplement our family expenses. What do you think of this drawing, Manager Liao?”

Liao Zhifu was a businessman with unique vision. This wardrobe was divided into different sizes of slot, which were integrated with a dressing table. There were several small slots beside the mirror in the middle that could put some rouge, gouache, comb, jewelry box and other objects within reached just by sitting in front of the dressing table. He was sure that such a wardrobe would be popular with the ladies.

Strange to say, how come no one thought of doing this before? Liao Zhifu was a little upset, but he still straightforwardly said: “10 silver taels for this drawing. What do you think little brother?”

Qin Mian had no objection since there was nothing strange about such a wardrobe and felt sorry to overcharge.

When Liao Zhifu saw that the other party didn't keep bidding, he vaguely guessed that the other party also intended to be on friendly terms with him and the smile on his face became more sincere. He asked: “The other drawings?” He looked at Qin Mian's hand.

Qin Mian handed him the design drawing of a settee and explained it in detail. The drawing was highly praised by Liao Zhifu, which fixed the price of 50 taels.

Finally, Qin Mian took out a plate and a potato from the basket.

Liao Zhifu and the downright curious assistant were rather baffled as they looked at him.

Qin Mian chuckled, turned his back to them and peeled the potato in a short period of time before turning around and showed it them.

“Is the speed of peeling fast?”

Liao Zhifu amazedly asked: “How.... did you do it?”

Qin Mian smiled but didn't speak. He turned his back to them again and similarly, he turned back not a moment later.

When Liao Zhifu saw it, there was a plate of finely shredded potatoes.

Note:

[1] act at good opportunity or while circumstances are favorable

Chapter 040: Live In a New House

(2)

040 – Live In a New House (2)

“How did you do that, little gongzi? You can cut into shreds faster than the master in the big restaurant!” The assistant had a look of beyond comprehension and shortly after, he scratched his head in puzzlement, “But, I didn’t see you use a chopping block either?”

Qin Mian put his hands behind him and said mysteriously: “I can, not only peel and slice this thing quickly, but also cut it into shreds quickly. Manager Liao, what do you think?”

Liao Zhifu offered directly and delightedly, “50 taels!”

Qin Mian felt very satisfied. He handed Liao Zhifu the small tool in his hand and spoke nicer words, “Exactly as told, Manager Liao is a forthright man. Otherwise, we won’t go straight to you.”

After seeing what the small tool was about, just like the noodle manual maker he bought last time, Liao Zhifu’s face once again showed a strange expression of both pleased and depressed.

Qin Mian took a sip of tea with a smile. “Manager Liao, if I hadn’t peeled potatoes until my hand was bloody that day, I wouldn’t have thought of such a convenient tool. This is what I came up with at the cost of my blood, so the 50 taels you spent won’t be a loss.” This was pure bullshit.

Liao Zhifu didn’t know whether to cry or to laugh.

Qin Mian passed him the remaining drawings. These drawings were nothing peculiar, only more modernized for their own use to be made in this shop.

After making appointment to deliver the goods in ten days, Liao Zhifu politely sent them out.

Half a month later, the new house had ventilated. The furniture arrived a few days earlier. The new house could be lived in but Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not in a hurry, they carried the furniture into the new house trip by trip. Coincidentally, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli saw them and came to help out.

When the sun set, everything was settled.

Qin Mian looked at his new home with appreciative eyes. After the entrance gate was a yard of about 60 square foot. There was nothing in the yard at present, only a small house in the northwest corner, which was a bathroom. In this ancient era, it was impossible to make the bathroom as it was in the modern era. It was just a place to take a bath, with a big tub and a drainage hole in the corner.

Into the main house was the living-cum-dining room. Placed beside a square pine wood dining table were two dining chairs of the same material, while against the wall were a settee and a coffee table, all of which were of modern styles. There was a window embedded in the south wall that was half larger than the window of an ordinary house, so the hall was particularly bright. Thick reddish brown, absolutely still curtains added some warmth to the autumn air. The conditions were limited, or else Qin Mian wanted to lay marble slabs on the floor of the central hall.

On the left side of the living-cum-dining room was the kitchen. The kitchen stove was paved with marble slabs, it looked smooth and clean. Having a cupboard, more dishware was added. The commonly used ones were placed in the most convenient position and the rice, flour and oil also got their own spot. The kitchen and the bathroom in the yard shared the south wall, but because the bathroom was smaller, the south wall of the kitchen could still open a window, providing sufficient light.

There were two rooms in the north; the smaller one was used to store various bits and bobs, such as farm tools, grain, spare chairs, etc.; the larger one was the bedroom. The utility room was opposite the bedroom with a hallway leading to the back door. The back was a vacant lot. It's convenient to have a backyard in the future.

Qin Mian was most satisfied with the bedroom. Although he and Lei Tie still had to share the same room and bed, at least they had a large enough wardrobe that their clothes could be set apart.

Lei Tie followed him to look around the new bedroom and his eyes lingered for a long time on the heatable brick bed with the new mattress. It was just that the two separate quilts and a pillow at each side was somewhat an irksome presence.

After dinner, Qin Mian took a hot bath. Unable to hold himself back, he jumped onto the new 'bed' and the corner of his lips raised a smidgen of smile after measuring the width of the heatable brick bed. The bed was so big that it should be able to get rid of his problem of drilling into Lei Tie's bosom. He rested in his own position, shaking his quilt open and lying down comfortably. Because he had some money in hands, he bought a new mattress and a new quilt.

The pillow was also new, with silk wadding inside, soft and comfortable. He rubbed against it with the back of his head and looked at the roof. The light on the table flickered gently and swayed his thoughts, making him unconsciously lost in thought.

Was he considered to have a home in this world?

Lei Tie came in wrapped in a faint steam, silently gazed at the teenager's absent-minded face and the slight loneliness in his eyes. His heart throbbed.

He closed the door with a thud, neither light nor heavy.

Qin Mian turned to look at him and asked worriedly, "The gate is locked?"

“Locked.” Lei Tie drew the curtains, took off his shoes and went to bed. He stared at his quilt before raising it to be put on the other end with his right hand.

Qin Mian was dumbfounded as he watched Lei Tie put the pillow on the other side to the side of his pillow and then got into his quilt. His heart stopped for two seconds. Half propped up and chin slightly raised, he looked askance at Lei Tie. “What are you doing?”

Lei Tie said: “You’ll still squeeze in when you’re asleep.”

This unperturbed and determined tone almost made Qin Mian angry. Just as he was about to open his mouth, the man stretched out his long arms and encircled him. Although Lei Tie didn’t use force, it was nevertheless a gesture that wouldn’t accept rejection.

Qin Mian stabbed him with a piercing look but didn’t get a response, so he could only resign to his fate and lie down.

All of a sudden, Lei Tie spoke: “Not happy to live in this new house?”

“No.” Qin Mian’s attention had been shifted by him. “Right, do you think there is something missing in the room?”

Lei Tie’s eyes swept around the room.

He was really a stuffy man who wouldn’t talk even beaten with a stick. Qin Mian didn’t expect him to answer, but then heard him said, “Emptiness.”

“That’s it!” Qin Mian gave him a look of approval and pointed to the bare wall opposite him. “There is no lack of furniture, it’s the defect on the wall. Let’s go to town some other day and buy calligraphy and painting to hang.”

“In a few days. Tomorrow I’ll go up the mountain.” Lei Tie’s face was tickled by Qin Mian’s hair and he raised his chin to rub against it [the head].

All of a sudden, Qin Mian felt that the atmosphere was delicate, making him shrink his neck. “Going to hunt? You said you would teach me kung fu.”

“I’ll go up the mountain after teaching you.” As soon as Lei Tie raised his hand, the light went out. The room plunged into complete darkness.

Qin Mian secretly breathed a sigh of relief, but he couldn’t explain why he wanted to be as quiet as possible, “There is another thing; is there a practice that one has to pay a house-warming visit after moving?”

“That’s why I’m going to hunt,” said Lei Tie.

Qin Mian hurriedly said: “Game meat is more expensive than pork. This time, we entertain guests with less game meat and more pork. You figure it out.”

“En.” Lei Tie’s chest felt very hot. Was it because there was one more person in it?

Chapter 041: House Warming

041 – House Warming

After sorting himself out, Qin Mian unhurriedly walked to the outside of the door. The sky was just touched by the first glimmer of light. In autumn, the song of cicadas and the croak of frogs were absent, which made the village rather quiet.

The sound of footsteps startled Lei Tie, who was practicing kung fu in the yard. He turned to look back.

The teenager was wearing a brand-new cyan cotton duanda[1] on the top, with a light brown vest and a light brown waistband around his waist, cyan slim-fit pants on the bottom and deerskin boots on his feet. This manner of dressing was both concise and nimble, just like a little gongzi of any family. His long hair was not tied into a top bun like other people, but rather into a high ponytail tied with a cyan headband. He looked full of youthful energy, stretching and looking up at the sky at the same time, and with a relaxed smile on the face that blossomed heroism, he appeared even more refresh and energetic.

Lei Tie also wore a new same outfit, but the duanda and pants were dark blue with also light brown vest and waistband. The vest was not worn on his body as he was practicing, but was hung on the clothing bamboo pole.

In fact, it was just because Qin Mian didn't bother to draw more clothing design drawings, so they made the same style and added modern elements to the ancient conservative style.

Although Lei Tie's face was scarred, it was almost nonexistent after looking at it for a long time. Then, with the help of such outfit, it perfectly outlined

his wide shoulders and narrow hips. Moreover, his whole person was tall and upright with heroic posture that made him seemed stately and handsome.

“Morning.” Qin Mian looked up and down at Lei Tie with appreciative eyes and greeted him in high spirit.

Lei Tie pulled back his gaze as soon as he saw the other person and continued to practice. Every gesture and motion was powerful and forceful, vigorous and dynamic.

Might as well suffocate you to death! The smile on Qin Mian’s face froze as he looked down at the man. He glanced around and saw a small pebble on the ground. Seeing that Lei Tie didn’t notice him, he picked up the pebble and threw it towards the man’s back. His practice seemed exemplary, but who knew if it was just for show? He tested the man.

Lei Tie appeared as though he was not yet aware of it and still continued with practicing palm moves, but when the pebble was about to touch him, his right hand suddenly changed its movement and inclined to the back as if he had eyes at the back of his head and caught the pebble between his index finger and middle finger. Without turning back, he continued to practice the move just now.

Qin Mian raised up his eyebrows. It turned out, it was not for show. He wasn’t sure if he was wrong, but just now Lei Tie seemed to shoot a glance his way. Although it was a very mild one, it appeared as if the man belittled him.

He rolled his eyes and cackled. The yard hadn’t been cleaned up yet, so there were still many pebbles scattered on the ground. He bent down and picked up some more pebbles and threw them towards Lei Tie in succession.

Lei Tie was practicing ‘fishing for the moon in the sea’, suddenly leapt up and turned over in midair. His right palm was like a palm-leaf fan moving to and fro abruptly, and all the five pebbles were caught in his palm. At the

same time, his body also fell on the ground steadily and noiselessly, and his gaze on Qin Mian.

So cool!

Qin Mian's eyes lit up and rushed to him. "I'm old now. Can I learn to your level?"

Lei Tie's corner of the lips rose. As he was not used to smile, it looked somewhat rigid but the smile in his eyes was undoubtable. Qin Mian noticed that and he was even in a better mood.

"You're not old," said Lei Tie.

Qin Mian didn't know whether to laugh or cry. Of course he didn't mean that. If he was old, wasn't Lei Tie 'older'? If other people said this, he would think that they were trying to make a difference with him, but it was kind of funny when it came out of Lei Tie's mouth.

"I don't mean that, of course. I heard that if you start training martial arts from a young age, you can progress quickly."

"No matter, step by step. Teach self-defense first." Lei Tie threw away the pebbles.

The few pebbles fell in the corner, next to each other. Qin Mian gave him a squint. "What a show off."

Lei Tie patted his head and began to teach him.

One could never assume that only women needed self-defense, men did too, especially the underage. In ancient era, human traffickers were rampant. There were not a small number of teenagers who were abducted and sold by the traffickers in that business.

The so-called self-defensive techniques were generally short-range and close to the body attacks; simple, practical and fast. In other words, hit the opponent's vital points, attacked the eyes, temples, jaws, throat, abdomen, between the legs, knees and other positions in the shortest time.

Lei Tie stood behind Qin Mian with one arm around his waist and the other arm around his neck, “If the opponent holds you from the back...”

The warm breath fanned on his ear made Qin Mian shrink his neck.

Seeing the other person’s earlobe red, Lei Tie paused before he went on: “You can hit the opponent with your elbow, or kick the knee with your heel.”

He looked at the head of the person in his arms, paused and added, “If you are tall enough and in a quandary, you can ram the opponent’s head with your head.”

Qin Mian’s face turned gloom. *What did he mean by the pause in the middle?* He might not be tall now, but that didn’t mean he wouldn’t grow tall in the future.

He turned his head and stared at Lei Tie badly.

Lei Tie changed his position as if nothing were wrong, “I’ll teach another way...”

In this fashion of someone taught and somebody learnt, Qin Mian had mastered several basic skills of self-defense.

“I’ll run for a few laps and come back to prepare breakfast.” Qin Mian was very interested in practicing martial arts, so he was very concerned about daily exercise. If he wanted to have profound kung fu, he should first improve his physical fitness. He waved to Lei Tie and began to run out.

Lei Tie locked the gate and went up the mountain with bow set on his back.

When Qin Mian came back from running, Lei Tie also returned. There were three Sichuan pepper trees in the yard.

“It’s a misjudgment.” Qin Mian stepped into the door, panting, sweating, and fanning himself with his hands, “I sweat all over. Forget to prepare a set of running clothes and shoes.”

“Buy it next time in town.” Lei Tie grabbed a shovel in his hand and asked, “Where to plant?”

Qin Mian poured a cup of water and drank in a big gulp. He glanced around the yard and went to the place not far from the gate, pointed it with his feet, “It doesn’t smell very good, plant it here.”

Lei Tie nodded and bent down to dig a hole.

Qin Mian stood by and watched for a while before he went to make breakfast.

At breakfast, the two decided on the house warming day — two days later.

After breakfast, Lei Tie went hunting. Qin Mian poured some spring water on the three Sichuan pepper trees and then went to invite the villagers to their house warming from door to door while meeting the villagers in passing.

Instead of going to the old house first, he went from the west to the east of the village.

When he arrived at the old house, Du Shi, who was drawing water at the well side, saw him enter the gate, her eyelids twitched. She asked impatiently, “What are you doing here?”

Since the other party didn’t like him, Qin Mian also didn’t allow himself to be snubbed despite showing good intentions and straightforwardly said: “Mother, the day of our house warming is fixed in the day after tomorrow, you guys should come earlier.”

Only then did Du Shi’s face eased up. “You’re thoughtful, we’ll go earlier.”

Qin Mian added: “We are going to make eight dishes; four meat and four vegetables. I’m afraid I’ll have to go to the garden to pick some vegetables then.”

Four meat and four vegetable dishes were a pretty good banquet. After thinking that her whole family would go to the banquet, it would be bad not

to let him pick the vegetables. “Got it.”

Qin Mian didn't want to talk more with her, “Mother, continue your work. I've to go to the next house.”

Du Shi waved her hand.

When Lei Tie returned home in the evening, he and Qin Mian decided on the menu. Eight dishes; four meat and four vegetables were diced chicken with pepper, simmer-fried fish, twice cooked pork, sweet and sour pork ribs, three delicacies stir-fried (potato, eggplant and green pepper), simmer-fried tofu, baked golden corn and stir-fried lettuce. There was no soup because most of the people from the peasant household preferred solid and few like watery soup.

The snacks and deserts for the guests were quite common, namely, fried melon seeds, fried peanuts and osmanthus cakes. They couldn't prepare anything too good otherwise it would be too eye-catching.

There were three people in charge of the cooking, which included Aunt Wang, while the other two were the women that had done banquet with Aunt Wang. They were Aunt Liu from the same village and Sixth Sister Ma[2] from the neighboring village.

In the early morning on the day of the house warming, Qin Mian and Lei Tie drove the cart to town to buy vegetables, wines, snacks and cakes. Once home, Qin Mian cleaned the house and Lei Tie went to the village to borrow tables and stools.

Aunt Wang and the other two had come early and were busy in the kitchen. There were more than 70 families in the village, even if there were only two people from each family, there were going to be more than 100 people. Moreover, most of the villagers like to benefit at others' expense, so those who had children would surely bring them along. One could imagine how many ingredients were needed to feed so many people.

Fortunately, Qian Shi and Lei Chuntao came here early to help wash the ingredients.

Qin Mian was quite surprised that Qian Shi would come and secretly asked Lei Chuntao, which let him know that Lei Xiangyi scolded her and forced her to come.

Nearly noon, the villagers came with gifts one after another, all of which were from their households. The gifts prepared were ordinary but practical. They gifted a few eggs, or vegetables, or a piece of cloth and if their conditions were good, they would gift a piece of bacon or a jar of wine. It was all the same in whichever village and no one would do anything wrong with it.

Qin Mian happily accepted the gifts and courteously invited them to the table.

The meal was served turn by turn. Those who came early could eat first and those who came late didn't have to worry as they could look around the new house, admire the new furniture, and then eat snacks while chatting and laughing.

Qin Mian had foresight and expected that there would be some confusion on this day. He came into agreement with Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli in advance to ask them to help entertain the guests, and together with Lei Tie, there wasn't any mishap throughout the event.

Even so, Qin Mian was very tired. When he sent the last wave of guests out, he sat on the settee, not wanting to move while his stomach growling with hunger.

The three chefs, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli hadn't eaten the food either. Qin Mian didn't sit for a long before Lei Tie and two others brought out the reserved table of dishes. The few of them wiped out the food completely. A jar of wine was also finished without a drop left.

When Sister Zhang, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli left, Qin Mian not only paid the three chefs high wages, but also packed a cake for each of them.

After everyone left, Qin Mian lay on the settee holding his full stomach and lazily bumped into Lei Tie's back with his leg. "Wash the dishes."

Also seated on the settee, Lei Tie who had drank a bit much wine, supported his head on one hand and patted Qin Mian's leg with the other before he stood up, "Go to sleep."

Qin Mian heard the sound of water and dishes colliding in the yard from time to time and his lips rose unconsciously before he fell asleep in a daze....

Note:

[1] An outfit specially made for hand-to-hand fight

[2] Sixth here denoted her husband is the 6th child in the Ma family

Chapter 042: Rent a Shop

042 – Rent a Shop

After the sun set, it rose again for the new day.

Qin Mian slowly drank the egg soup in the bowl, his calf under the table bumped against Lei Tie's leg. "Today, let's go to the town and buy everything that need to buy. Besides, I'd like to see if I can rent a shop. Autumn and winter seasons are the perfect times to make money."

Lei Tie's hand paused, "Sell what?"

Qin Mian tapped the bowl with the soup spoon and said confidently, "Food." He had all kinds of food in his head, not a thousand, not a hundred. Anyway, he had spiritual spring water, he wasn't afraid that he couldn't make money. If he wanted to stand up in this era, he must have money, authority and influence. At present, he could only aim at money. Plus, the food industry was the fastest way to earn money. For the other things, he would consider them later.

Lei Tie profoundly looked at him before he nodded.

After breakfast, the two drove to town in an ox cart. The wheels rolled up the withered leaves and blew them farther along the wind.

There were a lot of things to buy. The ox cart didn't have a carriage, so Qin Mian and Lei Tie were sitting on the shaft together. They weren't cold as they wore a lot of clothes and it felt refreshing when the cold air blew on their faces.

Qin Mian had quietly fed some spiritual spring water to the ox and therefore, the young ox completely awakened human attributes. It

cooperatively walked by the side of the road and automatically bypassed pits and stones on the ground, which made people secretly wonder.

When they got to town, they followed the street to find the suitable shop. However, Qin Mian very quickly found out he had been too optimistic. Running Water Town was a lively town, but because of this, the marketplace had been saturated and relatively stable, it was not easy to find a store for rent or sale.

After not finding the suitable shop around the town, Qin Mian didn't quit and went to look for a broker. There were several shops in the broker's hand, one of which was near the fork in the road. The size and location of the shop were very suitable, but the shop was only for rent and the price was 200 taels. Qin Mian couldn't afford it. He could only wave his hand regretfully and consider turning a house into a shop. However, the houses that were sold and rented in the broker's hand were not suitable for shops.

"This is a good one." Not giving up, the broker recommended the 200 taels shop to Qin Mian. "Such a big shop with good light is worth only 200 silver taels! There is no such shop as this one beyond this village."

Qin Mian laughed hollowly. Even if he had money, he wouldn't want to buy it.

"This one." Lei Tie opened up, as his long finger pointed to a piece of paper on the table.

Inwardly, the broker was pleasantly surprised. This shop had been up for a long time, but nobody showed an interest in it. Could it really be able to rent out today?

Qin Mian was a little stunned. When Lei Tie was with him, especially during business matters, he usually didn't speak easily. This was the first time that the man offered an opinion. However, he didn't feel displeased but instead he was happy because it made him feel that he wasn't alone.

He smiled at Lei Tie before looking at the paper, which briefly introduced the situation of the shop. He frowned slightly, "This place is good, but it's

too small. How can we accommodate five or six tables when we are selling food?”

Lei Tie said: “I’ve an impression of this place. The shop is not big, but there is an open space at the door.”

Qin Mian’s heart jolted. If there was an open space at the door, it would be fine to add some tables outside. Thinking of this, he asked the broker, “What’s the situation of this shop?”

The broker was happy at once and spoke in detail, “We’re honest person and I’m not afraid to tell you the truth. Several years ago, a hundred year old tree was planted here. On the left was a grocery store and on the right was a clothing store. Later, the tree was bought and dug out by a rich family. The feudal official felt it was a pity that the land was empty, so they built a house here, which turned out to be a tea shop. Although the shop is small, it has a good location and the rent is not high. It’s only 2 silver taels a month, 24 taels a year.”

“So, it was like that.” Qin Mian was a little moved. “Can we visit the shop to have a look?”

“Of course, I’ve the key.” The broker was smiling from ear to ear and was even more polite, “These two gentlemen, please.”

They followed the broker to the shop and the broker opened the door. Qin Mian looked at the left and right shops before entering. There were four sets of tables and chairs in the room, which were old but intact. The shop was indeed not very big and its entirety could be concluded as crowded. It was trapezoid, narrow inside and wide outside. The inside couldn’t run a back kitchen, only could place four more tables at most. As Lei Tie said, there was an open space outside the door, which could hold about four or five tables.

Qin Mian thought the place was small before, but now he thought it was just right. If the shop was too big, he and Lei Tie might be too busy to handle it.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie in consultation.

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian made up his mind and said to the broker: “This shop, rent for a year.”

The broker said happily, “Good, let’s go back to sign the paper first?”

Qin Mian gestured towards him to lead the way.

After going through the formalities at the brokerage, the broker gave Qin Mian the key.

Holding the key, Qin Mian felt a subtle emotion: *we can be considered as people with career*. He excitedly led Lei Tie forward. “Go, let’s make up the things in the shop today and open it as soon as possible.”

Chapter 043: Wife, I Can Raise You

043 – Wife, I Can Raise You

Opening a shop was not a simple thing. Before opening, it was necessary to decorate the shopfront, supplement all kinds of materials in the kitchen, add equipment, hire employees, and advertise.

The catering business mainly focused on cleanliness. Therefore, Qin Mian didn't spend much time in the decoration of the shop, only let people clean the roof, walls and ground. There were some unsightly holes in the wall, so he asked Lei Tie to make bamboo pieces and wood chips of different sizes and arrange them into artistic and stylish patterns to fix on the wall that might after all be accepted as a kind of distinguishing feature. The tables and chairs were all new, so as to make the customers feel comfortable when they ate.

In addition, Qin Mian bought a large noodle maker. The noodle maker of the Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop had its own characteristics in Qin Mian's design. Its appearance was polished perfectly and was carved with patterns, which sold well. At the beginning of the noodle maker springing up, other woodcraft shops in the town had to buy from here.

After dark, Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't go to sleep immediately, but discussed things on the heatable brick bed with the oil lamp lit.

"You didn't say what to sell." Lei Tie's back leaned on a lump of a quilt.

Qin Mian raised his head with a smile and looked very confident. "It's cold, so naturally people want to eat something warm. I want to sell 'hot spicy

soup' and 'hot pot'." He was very glad that people in this world didn't think that food could be cooked by dipping finely sliced ingredients briefly in boiling water or soup.

He explained to Lei Tie in detail how the hot spicy soup and hot pot were made. "In short, I cooked vegetables and meat dishes in the boiling soup. This soup is not a common soup, but a special one, made of 18 kinds of seasonings. Do you remember the cinnamon, dried tangerine peel and vanilla I bought? That's what this soup needs."

Lei Tie looked at him for a moment before taking away his brush and paper. "It's late. Talk tomorrow."

Qin Mian also began to feel sleepy. He yawned and lay down, "Let's sleep. I'll make it for you tomorrow and you'll know."

Lei Tie blew the oil lamp and lay down, habitually holding a person in his arms. "Okay."

Qin Mian was excited when he thought that he would be able to open business in a few days. His sleepiness suddenly subsided and he made a joke: "Now, it's me raising you."

Lei Tie's arms stiffened. "I'll go up the mountain tomorrow."

Qin Mian laughed, "I'm joking."

"Spicy hot soup requires meat dishes." Lei Tie left no room for doubt.

Qin Mian thought about it and acquiesced, "Alright. There are still a lot of things to prepare. Tomorrow I have to grind the dried tangerine peels and cinnamon into powder." He also bought a stone mill purposely for the seasoning.

"I want to go deeper this time, be back in two days." Lei Tie spoke again.

"For so long?" Qin Mian vaguely felt that something was wrong with the man, but he was unable to get the words out, so he didn't think much about it, "Fine, I'll prepare more dried food tomorrow morning."

The next day, Qin Mian felt vaguely aware of the movement around him. He woke up abruptly when he remembered that Lei Tie said he would go up the mountain last night.

The morning light had glimmered outside, because the curtains were closed, the room was dark, but the lamp was still lit at the head of the bed.

Lei Tie was sitting on the edge of the heatable brick bed, putting on his shoes. Turning around, he whispered: "Go back to sleep."

Qin Mian shook his head and looked at his clothes. "No. The temperature in the mountains is low, put on a lined jacket."

After he dressed neatly, he went to the kitchen to make breakfast and made some thick minced meat pancakes. Then, he wrapped them in oil paper and put it into the bum bag he made for Lei Tie.

They ate the remaining pancakes with mushroom soup.

"Be careful." This was not the first time Lei Tie went hunting in the mountain, but Qin Mian felt uneasy for no reason, so he repeatedly cautioned.

"Nothing will happen." Lei Tie stroked his side face. "If there is something, wait till I come back."

Qin Mian's heart jumped. How did this conversation sounded like a conversation between husband and wife? He pinched his hot ear and waved his hand to drive the man away. "I know. Go, go. Go early, return early."

Lei Tie nodded and left.

Qin Mian stood in the yard for a while before walking around the yard to aid digestion and then reviewed the moves he had learned before. Afterwards, he went to work on his proper business, which was grinding dried tangerine peels, cinnamon and Sichuan pepper into powder with a stone mill.

Since there was no one at home, the yard was strangely quiet. Qin Mian felt that the empty yard was an eyesore. He went out with a hoe and a basket, planning to dig out something to decorate the yard.

The sky was overcast, the sun was missing and there was no cloud in the gray sky. It didn't look like it was going to rain, but Qin Mian still felt very jittery. After wandering at the foot of the mountain for a long time, he found several wild chrysanthemums. Although the white and yellow flowers were small, they were blooming brightly. He planted chrysanthemums in the yard and poured a cup of spiritual spring water.

Until the afternoon of the third day, Lei Tie hadn't come back, and Qin Mian's heart sank abruptly. Lei Tie said that he would come back in two days, but he hadn't appeared yet, could something have happened? He was so flustered by the thought that he couldn't help running to the mountain in the distance.

At the foot of the mountain, he couldn't help laughing bitterly. He had gone crazy, he actually wanted to find Lei Tie. This was a mountainous area and he didn't know where Lei Tie had gone, finding him would be not as easy as he thought it to be?

"Boom—" A thunderbolt sounded overhead. After two days of gloomy weather, it finally began to rain. The continuous patter of raindrops fell and soon the ground was soaked.

Qin Mian's heart sank to the bottom of the valley. The condition on the mountain on rainy days would be more arduous. Immediately, a burst of anger erupted and he ran into the forest, shouted: "LEI TIE— YOU ASSHOLE—"

His voice was like light swallowed by darkness, leaving not a thread of trace.

He walked back with a cold face and caught a sight of Lei Daqiang standing not far away with a load of firewood, looking at him in a bad way.

"Eldest's wife, what are you shouting?"

Qin Mian frowned and eased his mood, “Father. Brother Tie went hunting and said that he would come back in two days, but until now, there isn’t a sign of him. Do you think there’s—”

Before he finished his words, Lei Daqiang interrupted, “It’s not the first time for him to go hunting in the mountains, he knows his boundary. But you, since you are eldest’s wife, you should know that he is the most important to you. What did you shout just now?” Lei Daqiang sternly stared at the teenager who stood up as stubborn as a little poplar, not very pleased.

Qin Mian’s face changed. He snorted, “It’s none of your business!” He didn’t look at Lei Daqiang as he walked away quickly.

“You... You...” Lei Daqiang stared at his back in disbelief, trembling with anger as he yelled, “STOP FOR ME!”

Qin Mian pretended not hearing it and walked away quickly. Whether he was filial or not, no one saw him anyway and Lei Daqiang couldn’t do anything about him either.

He wasn’t in the mood to have dinner and only ate two steamed stuffed buns. When it was past ten o’clock and he still hadn’t seen a sign of Lei Tie, he could only put out the light and go to bed.

In the middle of the night, a dull sound in the yard woke Qin Mian up. A thief?

He didn’t dare to light the oil lamp and groped around the door. Then he heard the sliding sound of the main door’s bolt, his heart rose to his throat and he yelled, “WHO?!”

“Wife, it’s me.”

Qin Mian felt both happy and angry, only to find that his night clothes were wet with sweat. His voice carried reproach yet very gentle, “How come you are back now?”

He groped around in the dark and opened the door before he went to light the oil lamp with the *fire fold*[1] on the side table. Then he looked back. Wasn't Lei Tie standing in front of him?

"I went to the county."

The rain was still falling. Lei Tie had brought in a burst of dampness as he conveniently put the bow set on the table, took out a piece of paper from his bosom and said with pursed lips: "I can raise you."

Qin Mian was taken aback and looked at the paper in puzzlement. Although it was written in traditional Chinese character, he still recognized the three words of 'five hundred taels'.

"Where did it come from?"

Lei Tie made light of it, "Hunted a black bear and the four paws sold for 500 taels. Is there food?"

Qin Mian was shocked as he connected the man's 'I can raise you' and noticed that the man's clothes on the waist side were torn as well as there was a faint smell of blood. His heart squeezed tight, his expression also sunk as he threw the silver banknote to the man and sneered: "I was just joking and you slap me in the face with the money. Lei Tie, you are truly skillful!"

He turned around and left. He had gotten up urgently and only wearing night clothes, his body was so cold but it couldn't be compared with his heart.

Lei Tie was stunned. Seeing Qin Mian storming towards the bedroom angrily without turning his head back, he was flustered and went to grab the other person's arm. "I'm not."

"Let go." Qin Mian said coldly.

Lei Tie's pupils turned darker and his mouth agape. He fastened the person into his bosom and his big palms pressed the other person's back tightly.

“You let me go!” Qin Mian couldn’t get free, he was fuming with rage. The bloody smell caught in his nose made him even angrier.

“No.” When the wound was touched, Lei Tie grunted but his arms were not loose, he said in a muffled voice, “I didn’t want to slap you in the face. Wife, I can raise you.”

Qin Mian’s struggling movement froze as there was a burst of acid-like in his thoracic cavity and at the same time, there was a kind of reality enlightenment in his brain. He was also a man, how could he forget how strong a man’s self-esteem was? Although he said that at first, it was really just a joke, but it was a fact that he made more money than Lei Tie before. How could Lei Tie not care? He was angry that Lei Tie didn’t see that he was joking and that he didn’t take his own safety seriously.

He raised his head, the man was still expressionless, but there was a touch of imperceptible bewilderment hidden in his deep eyes and his arms wound around his back were very hot.

He was somewhat defeated as he softened his voice, “Let go, I’ll see your wound.”

Lei Tie grabbed his wrist, went back to the table to get the oil lamp and pulled the other person to the bedroom before he let go. “Get dressed.”

Qin Mian put on his cotton-padded jacket and glared at him unhappily, “Sit down.”

Lei Tie complied and sat down by the heatable brick bed, “Just a small wound.”

Qin Mian ignored him, lifted up his wet clothes and once he saw five bloody scars, there was a tremor in the apex of his heart. He angrily said: “Didn’t you go to the county? Why didn’t you go to a physician’s and bandage the wound before coming back?”

“It looks serious, but the injury is not serious. Afraid you’re worried, I returned as soon as the bear’s paws were sold. The injury is not serious.”

Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian gave him a severe look before he fetched water, gauze and wound healing medicine. He carefully cleaned up his wound, sprinkled the powder carefully and bandaged it up.

“When did you go to the county? How did you get back?”

“At about late afternoon[2], I happened to meet someone who drove to the town after going down the mountain and hitchhiked his cart. No one in the town bought bear paws, so I had to hire a cart to go to the county. It was already night when I was going back, couldn’t hire a cart, so I walked back.”

Perhaps he knew that Qin Mian was still angry, he who seldom said so many words, gave a very detailed answer. This made Qin Mian’s heart soften and his anger dissipated.

He stood up. “There is still hot water in the pot. You should take a bath and change into dry clothes. Be careful not to touch the wound. I’ll make you something to eat.”

Lei Tie gave a response and followed him out with the oil lamp.

That silver banknote lay silently on the ground. Lei Tie picked it up and handed it to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian put it in his pocket and walked into the kitchen.

Note:

[1] A tight straw paper roll that was burned and put off but was left only ember. The ember is easily ignited with a skillful blow.

Image credited to Pear Video.

[2] 酉时 [yǒu shí] = 5-7 pm (in the system of two-hour subdivisions used in former times)

Chapter 044: Drop a Visit

044 – Drop a Visit

These days, Qin Mian cooked more rice every day so as to make sure Lei Tie could have meal at any time he returned. The remaining cooked rice in the evening was just right for making fried rice. He took two eggs and stirred them into liquid, next he grabbed a carrot and a handful of vegetables to wash before the carrot were diced and the vegetables were chopped, and then delicious fried rice was made. At the same time, strong aroma of sour and spicy soup was cooked on the charcoal stove.

After taking a bath, Lei Tie put on clean clothes and came to the kitchen. He saw the wife was putting the fried rice on the table, so he bent over and carried the earthenware pot on the stove and followed after him.

“Is it enough?” Qin Mian asked. The fried rice piled high on the plate was full of color and flavor. Because of his love of food, Qin Mian had a special love for all kinds of dishware. The dishware at home was of different shapes, sizes, and the plate for the fried rice was very large.

“Enough.” Lei Tie went to the kitchen and took four bowls; two rice bowls and two soup bowls. “You have some too.”

Qin Mian was really hungry and scooped a bowl of fried rice.

“Enough?” Lei Tie sat down beside him and asked. Seeing the wife nodding, he moved the rice plate to his front and began to eat.

It could be seen that he was really hungry, but although his movement didn't lose the former grace, it was somewhat urgent. The corner of Qin Mian's lips gave a tiny smile, yet his words were blunt, “No one's robbing

you.” He said that, however his hand picked up the soup bowl, scooped a bowl of soup and put it on Lei Tie’s left hand side.

“Hadn’t eaten for a day.” Lei Tie replied briefly. After a sip of soup, he continued to eat.

Qin Mian couldn’t bear to say anything more and bowed his head to eat. After he finished a bowl of rice, he drank half a bowl of soup before putting his chopsticks down and watched Lei Tie eat.

Then Lei Tie drank the rest of the soup.

Qin Mian asked uncertainly: “Are you full? If you aren’t, I’ll make two more pancakes.”

“Full.” Lei Tie got up to collect the bowls.

Qin Mian beat out a yawn, “Wash them tomorrow.”

Lei Tie was taken by surprise. He had always known that the little wife liked cleanliness and neatness, especially in the kitchen. The used bowls absolutely were not allowed to be left for the next day to wash. This was the first time.

The black pupils under the light were covered with soft tinge as he agreed and only put the bowls and chopsticks on the stove before he came out of the kitchen.

After they both rinsed their mouths, they returned to the bedroom together.

Qin Mian put the banknote into a money box, locked it, put away the key and got into the bed.

Lei Tie put out the light and took someone into his arms. Qin Mian wasn’t in the mood to be contentious and adjusted to a comfortable posture, carefully avoided the man’s injuries as he enjoyed the man’s body temperature far higher than himself. Once again, he ascertained that this man was the best stove in winter.

“How are you these days?” Lei Tie was still able to objectively touch the wife’s face in the dark, and he gently caressed and stroked it.

Remembering Lei Daqiang, Qin Mian hesitated for a moment before he said it. He was sure that Lei Daqiang would drop a visit tomorrow.

“I haven’t seen you for a few days and it’s raining, so I scolded you to the mountain and your father scolded me back. Then, I returned with ‘it’s none of your business’.” Qin Mian said calmly, but he felt a little perturbed. After all, Lei Daqiang was Lei Tie’s father. He quickly added, “There was no one else around at that time.”

“There’s no harm.” Lei Tie apathetically said, “Just tolerate on the surface will suffice.”

Qin Mian didn’t like the suddenly roused lonesome atmosphere. He turned over in the man’s embrace and said in a loud voice, “Sleepy. Sleep, sleep.”

Lei Tie enclosed his arms and held the person in his embrace more tightly as he also closed his eyes.

The next day, the sky finally cleared up and the cool wind was gentle. It was a clear and refreshing autumn weather. Although the chrysanthemum in the yard had been hit by the autumn rain, it looked more vigor with dewdrops. The newly blossomed flowers were bigger and the fragrant was more concentrated. The ground in the yard was soaking wet and whenever the feet trampled on, it would get muddy. Previously, he had no money thus he didn’t spend any effort on the yard. At present, he had the 500 taels brought back by Lei Tie, he had enough confidence. This yard needed to be sorted out.

“Lei Tie, where are you?” Qin Mian looked at the open gate and shouted out, knowing that the man wouldn’t go far away.

Lei Tie’s voice came from outside the courtyard wall, “Here.”

Qin Mian turned and went into the kitchen. As expected, he saw that the bowls and chopsticks of yesterday had been washed, and the cooking wok

and stove were also cleaned up.

After making breakfast, there were two additions of osmanthus trees in the yard with luxuriant flowers and sweet smell that assailed the nostril.

Qin Mian walked over in surprise, “Where did you dig it up?”

“On the mountain.” Lei Tie had seen the chrysanthemum in the yard and guessed that he didn’t like the empty space in the yard.

“Plant it after breakfast.”

Lei Tie washed his hands and sat down at the table. There were two portion of stir-fried noodles and two bowls of soup on the table. Both of them consumed a large amount of food, so their bowls were large, but Lei Tie’s bowl was larger than Qin Mian’s.

Lei Tie emotionally sighed in his heart that the wife’s craftsmanship was good. Since they lived alone up to now, basically, breakfast wouldn’t be repeated within five days. Today’s stir-fried noodles were added with golden eggs, bright red shredded chili and green pakchoi’s leaves, which aroused people’s appetite.

He was thinking thus much but his face had been consistently expressionless.

However, Qin Mian could still see from his eyes that he liked today’s breakfast. He was secretly being cocky: *You bastard should thank your ancestor for ‘marrying’ this young master.*

“The road is full of mud, it’s inconvenient to go to town. It’s better to wait until the ground is dry. Today, let’s go to the river bank to pick up some stones to pad the yard. At least, there has to be a walkway. How about it?”

“En.”

“Plant the two osmanthus trees next to chrysanthemums. Leave some room for some fruit trees.” Qin Mian glanced at the yard, but still felt that the yard was a little small. He had lived in the city for a long time in his

previous life that he didn't like narrow space. Well, he would have to wait until he made a lot of money.

"Fruit trees, find in the mountain later. Eat quickly." Lei Tie gently tapped his (QM) bowl with his chopsticks.

While they were eating, there were two people outside coming in. They were a man and a woman that looked less than 30, with smile on their faces.

Qin Mian recognized that the woman was the one who had been prying when he came to see the house site, that lived next door to them and her man was called Zhou Erhao.

"Lei Tie and Lei Tie's wife are eating *ne*." Erhao's wife's smiling expression seemed to be forced out and both corners of her eyes outlined with deep lines.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie got up and invited them to come in to sit down, unclear of their purpose of coming.

"Hah-hah, thank you for your hospitality." Zhou Erhao put his hands in his sleeves as his triangular eyes kept looking east and west, rounding the whole circle before his eyes fell on the oily stir-fried noodles on the dining table and secretly swallowed his saliva. He'd heard that Lei Tie's treat to the guest was very generous. However, when Lei Tie was building the house, he was delayed by his father-in-law's family affair and when Lei Tie family's was having house warming, he was yet again dragged by his brother-in-law's affair and failed to eat that meal which made Zhou Erhao regretful. Last night, he heard something from his neighbor's house and he knew the opportunity was coming. Today, as soon as his wife urged him, he followed her coming over here. The breakfast of the people in the villager was basically porridge, steamed cornbread and pickles vegetables. Lei Tie's family's livelihood was really prosperous. That stir-fried noodles weren't only filled with eggs but also a lot of oil, which made it smelled delicious.

Qin Mian intuitively disliked them. He thrown a meaningful glance at Lei Tie and lowered his head to eat his noodles. He couldn't always be the one to get them out of predicament.

“Is there something?” Lei Tie was suspicious.

Erhao’s wife quickly waved her hand and looked concerned, “It’s nothing, nothing. It seems that you two had a quarrel in the middle of the night. We came to see if there is anything we can do for you. Since we are going to be neighbors hereafter, please don’t be polite to get our help.”

“Thank you very much.” Lei Tie nodded his head as he said in low voice.

“Looking at the style of your furniture,” Zhou Erhao touched the settee with greedy eyes as though he was staring at a beautiful woman. “It must not be cheap? Your family is the only one in our village who has these things.”

Lei Tie frowned and sat down to eat his noodles.

Qin Mian kicked him under the table, “Thank you for your concern but there’s nothing wrong with Lei Tie and me. You guys can sit anywhere. The weather is getting colder and the food cools quickly, so you’ll have to wait for us to finish our meal before we accompany you guys.”

He and Lei Tie looked at each other and very tacitly slowed down. After they unhurriedly finished eating the stir-fried noodles, they dilatorily drank the soup.

Zhou Erhao and his wife sat for a while and felt bored. Eventually, they were aware that they weren’t welcome and stood up while smiling dryly and said few words of farewell before leaving.

Qin Mian hit Lei Tie with his knee, “These two people don’t seem good. Afterwards, be cleverer.”

Lei Tie glanced at Qin Mian with unclear meaning, he drank his soup in one gulp and watched him drink it. He waited patiently for Qin Mian to finish drinking before self-consciously collected the dishware.

“Spicy hot soup or hot pot for lunch?”

He still remembered. Qin Mian squinted at him, “Sure.”

After Lei Tie washed the dishes, they planted the osmanthus trees, put on old shoes and went to the river bank to pick up stones.

Plain Water River was one of the main water sources of Green Mountain Village, which flowed from north to south close to the west of the village. It was basically this place where the villagers irrigated their farmlands, watered their vegetables, washed clothes, fished in their leisure time and so on.

Beside the greenish-black stone slab by the river, two women were chatting while washing clothes. They were Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu. When they saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie passing by, they smiled kindly.

Qin Mian was taken by surprise and smiled back. No matter why they changed their attitude, it was not a bad thing.

There were many large and small stones on the river bank, which had been washed away by rain all the year round. Not a while later, they picked up to half a basket.

“Eldest, you are here.” An ill-meaning voice sounded from behind them.

Qin Mian’s movement paused before he seamlessly retreated behind Lei Tie.

Lei Tie straightened up, “Father.”

Lei Daqiang snorted coldly, stepped closer with large strides and yelled with his rough voice: “You know I’m your father! Do you know what attitude your wife taken in front of me?”

Lei Tie looked as usual as he casually lifted his right hand and the goose warm stone in his hand fell accurately into the basket in the distance.

Translator’s side note: Hi! I just want to thank you for the few people who are generous with comments. Comments keep the translators motivated ~~believe me it does~~. Also, thank you for reading this novel. That’s all.

Chapter 045: Qin Mian's Counterattack

045 – Qin Mian's Counterattack

Du Shi stood by Lei Daqiang's side with schadenfreude in her eyes and shot a glance at the eavesdropping Fang Hongliu and Zhou Cuihua. She pulled down Lei Daqiang's sleeve and hypocritically advised him: "Old man, if there is something, talk it over."

"He can't even manage his own wife, how can I talk it over with him?" Lei Daqiang jumped to his feet and pointed to Lei Tie's nose. "What's the use of you, this son?! Your wife dared to say disrespectful words to me, and that was unfilial! You tell me, how to justify him?"

Fang Hongliu and Zhou Cuihua looked at each other, staying there without any intention of leaving as their hands assumed a feigned manner of rubbing their laundry.

Qin Mian's expression changed. He went to Lei Tie's side and stood still. He hesitated for a moment before quietly held the man's hand.

Lei Tie hadn't carried any expectation for Lei Daqiang for a long time, he said indifferently: "My wife and I already know that you don't welcome us. Since the last time we built the house, my wife has not been to your house. I also want to ask how my wife provoked you."

"You!" Lei Daqiang was so angry that he became very red and contemptible: "Bastard rebels against me! Last time, he called you an asshole on the mountain, so I scolded him and he actually said it was none of my business. Was that what someone's wife should say?"

“Ha! Funny.” Qin Mian didn’t want to put up with the old man anymore; he blocked Lei Tie with his arm and refused to let him speak. He raised his voice as he said: “It happens that Sister Zhou and Sister Fang are also here, they can bear witnesses. Now that you mentioned it, I’ll talk about it. Your son had gone hunting for three days and he had not been seen. I asked you to find some people to go with me to find him. However, as a father, you acted as though you didn’t hear me as you only cared about your face as an elder and didn’t care about the safety of your son. That is case number one. No matter what, you could say it in private, but you humiliated your own child in front of two outsiders. That is case number two. You are ‘heartless’! If a father is heartless, why should you ask the son to be filial? Even if these cases are brought to the feudal authority, there is no excuse for you!”

Report to the feudal authority? Du Shi was scared, her pupils contracted and her neck shrank after.

“You, you... rebel, rebel...” Lei Daqiang’s fingers trembled with face red as if it was about to burn.

Qin Mian held his head up and chest out as he stealthily took aim at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie seized Qin Mian’s shoulder and dully said: “We still have something to do. Please excuse us.”

The two people no longer paid attention to Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, continued to pick up pebbles as if nothing had happened.

“You, you guys wait for me, I’ll find someone to judge who is right! Humph!” Lei Daqiang was furious. He left a sentence that appeared severe, but weak inside as he walked away flipping his sleeve.

Du Shi quickly followed up. When she thought of Qin Mian’s words just now, she felt uneasy.

Qin Mian frowned. He must taught Lei Daqiang and Du Shi a lesson, otherwise, if they did this a few more times, could he and Lei Tie be at peace? When he caught sight of Fang Hongliu and Zhou Cuihua make faces

at each other and murmur in low voices in excitement, he thought of a plan. He walked over quickly.

“These two sisters.”

“What, what’s the matter?” Recalling of the shiny kitchen knife in her memory, Fang Hongliu shivered and her laundry almost drifted away with the current.

Zhou Cuihua smiled dryly and didn’t dare to make a sound.

Qin Mian took out a money pouch from his sleeve pocket and smilingly said: “No need to be nervous, sisters. I already forgot about the last time. We’re all from the same village, some bumps are inevitable. Don’t you all think so?”

“Yes, yes, little brother is right.” Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu nodded repeatedly while glancing at Lei Tie, who was still picking up pebbles. It appeared that he coddled Qin Mian very much.

Qin Mian said with a smile: “As long as you two do me a little favor, I can give 100 Wen each. How about it? Of course, it’s not murder and arson.”

Zhou Cuihua’s and Fang Hongliu’s eyes brightened.

Zhou Cuihua testily asked: “What is it?”

Qin Mian crouched down beside the two women and lowered his voice. The smiling expression on his face was wicked and his bright eyes twinkled with excitement.

Lei Tie saw clearly, shook his head slightly, picked up two pebbles and threw them into the basket.

Over there, Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu didn’t wash their laundries but stood up with excited eyes.

“Little brother rest assured. We’ll make sure it’s done.” Zhou Cuihua vowed in all sincerity and seriousness.

Fang Hongliu picked up the laundry into the basket and said in a hurry:
“Count on us. We’ll do it right now.”

Qin Mian generously gave the two women a total of 40 Wen. “This money is a deposit. After you have done it, I’ll pay the rest.”

“No problem.”

Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu carried their laundry baskets and walked quickly with their small feet. They soon enter the village.

Qin Mian insidiously laughed, and then a small pebble hit him lightly in the chest.

“Come and help.”

“Coming.” Qin Mian walked over as he smiled happily.

“What did you say?” Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian squatted down beside him and sneakily laughed, “Secret.”

Lei Tie actually heard all about it. He just liked to see the boy’s complacent look and very much liked how the boy cared about him.

The two people made round trips several times until they picked up a sufficient number of pebbles. The pebbled path ran from the courtyard gate to the house door and connected with the bathroom door. Lei Tie hammered the pebbles hard which embedded them into the ground. They were solid enough and looked both scenic and stylish.

It was noon when it was done.

“Hot pot for lunch?” Qin Mian sought Lei Tie’s opinion, “There is no bamboo sticks for hot spicy soup.”

“En.”

“When you go to the garden to pick vegetables, pick some of every kind of vegetables. While you are at it—” Qin Mian smiled, “Pay attention to whether there is any astir in the village.”

Lei Tie nodded and went out with a basket.

Qin Mian went to the kitchen to make hot pot seasoning. Most people could see the basic materials of the hot pot base in the modern hot pot shop. The reason why Qin Mian ground tangerine peels and Sichuan pepper into powder was to make it difficult to recognize. There were 18 ingredients in his hot pot base, including hot pepper, Sichuan pepper, cinnamon, tangerine peel, star anise, cassia bark, etc. Some of them were not used as seasoning by people in this world, but used as medicinal materials or spices. This was also the main reason why the food in those restaurants was not so good. It was only because Qin Mian was blessed to travel through the time and space that he could pick up such a big bargain.

This seasoning could be used not only for cooking hot pot, but also for stir-fry.

As soon as Lei Tie entered the door, his nostrils were assailed with spicy aroma and his Adam's apple rolled involuntarily.

“You're back.” Qin Mian unscrupulously instructed him, “Wash the vegetables together. We have to dig a well in the yard. It's too troublesome to carry water from outside all the time and that's inconvenient to wash vegetables.”

Lei Tie's eyes swept over the brilliant red soup on the charcoal stove before he moved a wood block to the kitchen, sat face to face with Qin Mian, took the peeler and peeled the potatoes, “I'll find people after lunch.”

“Is there any astir in the village?” This was what Qin Mian most concerned about.

Lei Tie raised his eyelids to look at him, “En, I saw many people talking together on the road, but I didn't hear what they were saying.”

Qin Mian decided to wait for news from Fang Hongliu and Zhou Cuihua. He discovered two wet lotus roots in the vegetable basket. "Where did these lotus roots come from?"

"From Brother Zhang."

Qin Mian got up to wash the vegetables and got a shiver from the cold water, "Brother Zhang is really good. We need a lot of bamboo sticks to sell hot spicy soup. If Brother Zhang is willing, how about asking him to make bamboo sticks? It can be done at home and it's easy."

"He certainly is willing." Lei Tie also got up, "You trim the vegetables and I'll wash them."

"Sure, you do it." Qin Mian was glad, "Anyway, your skin is thicker than mine."

Lei Tie silently let Qin Mian take advantage of him.

With a clear division of labor, they quickly put the processed ingredients on the table, including lotus root slices, spinaches, pork balls, potato slices, mushrooms and tofus. Because of the short time, these were the only kinds they prepared and the chopped pheasant was cooked in advance. At this time, it was already well-cooked and the aroma was mouth-watering.

Unfortunately, there was no vermicelli, which was Qin Mian's current regret. However, he would be able to make it later.

"Let's eat."

They picked up chopsticks and ate while dipping.

"How? Isn't it good?" Qin Mian took a bite of the pheasant's meat. It was soft and delicious. He squinted contentedly. "There is a vegetable market in the town, so it'll be convenient to buy vegetables. When the shop is officially opened, there will be more varieties."

Lei Tie picked up a piece of pheasant's meat and seeing that it was drumstick's meat, he put it into Qin Mian's bowl, "Hire a person to wash

dishes.”

“Of course.” Qin Mian said, “You’re in charge of food preparation, I’m in charge of collecting money and then hired a waiter to be in charge of washing dishes. That is the arrangement for the time being. If the business is good enough, more people will be hired.”

Speaking up to this point, his butt moved uneasily on the stool as he whispered, “I don’t want people from the old house to intervene in the business of the shop, so I don’t want to ask any of them to join. Do you have any opinion?”

Lei Tie didn’t show an unhappy look, only asked: “Why?”

Qin Mian explained: “In my opinion, the most taboo in business is the involvement of relatives, which is inconvenient for management. In case of any contradiction, it will affect the relationship. Third brother, fourth brother, fifth brother and little sister are all good. Later, it is better to give them an idea of making money and let them do it by themselves, rather than let them interfere in our shop.”

Lei Tie gave him a gentle look. “Follow you.”

Only then Qin Mian was smiling again and picked up the colander to scoop out two meatballs for the man.

When Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu entered the gate and smelled the spicy aroma, they secretly drooled.

“Oh, you are having meal.”

“You two are here.” Qin Mian got up to meet them.

Zhou Cuihua hastily said: “You sit down and continue to eat.”

Qin Mian saw their looks and knew that it was done. He invited them to sit down and sent Lei Tie away with an excuse first. “Brother Tie, go and get some meatballs.” What he asked Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu to do was aimed at Lei Daqiang and Du Shi. Even if Lei Tie knew what it was, he

couldn't let Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu know that Lei Tie knew it. Otherwise, it would be harmful to Lei Tie's reputation when it was spread out.

Lei Tie obediently entered the kitchen.

Translator's side note: Hi! Just to let you know, the first week of the month, I usually take a break, so there might or might not be updates (depends on my laziness or sometime it is the bad weather). But anyway, thank you for the comments/supports!!!!

Chapter 046: Lei Xiangzhi

046 – Lei Xiangzhi

Qin Mian asked with a smile: “How is it?”

Fang Hongliu said in a low voice: “It’s done. As soon as we returned to the village, we let others hear what you taught us to say. Now, it has been spread to the whole village.”

Zhou Cuihua then said: “Everyone knows that today’s thing is because the old couple is being heartless that they came to find fault with you when you’re already separated from them. At this time, the whole village is talking about it. Everyone is mostly on your side.”

“That’s good.” Qin Mian took out the two shares of 80 Wen that he had prepared. “Sisters also had seen it today that Brother Tie and I were forced to do nothing by them. Without any other choice, I just came up with this method. We only seek to live peacefully in the future. Therefore, I don’t want a fourth person to know that today’s thing is what I asked people to do. Can sisters understand?”

The teenager’s usual kind eyes suddenly became sharp and showed a kind of compelling aura. Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu both looked shocked.

Fang Hongliu hurriedly stated her stand: “Little brother, you can rest assured that no other person will know.”

Zhou Cuihua also nodded incessantly.

Qin Mian gave a wee smile and handed over two strings of copper coins. “Thank you very much.”

“You’re welcome.”

Once the money was in hands, the two women were all smiling and stood up to leave.

“We won’t disturb your lunch time.”

Qin Mian sent them until to the gate of the courtyard and snapped two osmanthus flowers to give them. “These flowers are very fragrant, sisters should like them. Put them in the side room and the smell will give you a refreshing spirit once you wake up.”

Zhou Cuihua and Fang Hongliu felt moved in their hearts and said thanks as they received it.

When they hadn’t walked far away, they met an old aunt.

“Which house did you go just now?” The aunt forced a smile as she glanced at the enclosed wall of Qin Mian’s house.

Fang Hongliu smilingly said: “Oh yes! We heard that their family dug up two osmanthus trees from the mountain; it is very fragrant. We both had the cheek to break a branch. Don’t you smell it, Auntie?”

.....

After lunch, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to Zhang Dashuan’s house. The Zhang couple had three children in total. The eldest was an 11 years old son and his name was Zhang Baolu. The second and the third were girls. They were very beautiful little girls. The second was 9 years old named Zhang Yimei and the third was 6 years old named Zhang Erli. [Note[1]]

When Qin Mian first learned of this, he had even joked with Zhang Dashuan that he (ZDS) knew how to pick a name.

When they arrived in front of the half-person high fences, Qin Mian saw the door of the main house was opened.

“Is Brother Zhang at home?”

After a while, a tall and big man came out of the house with a smile on his face. “Here. Come in and have a seat.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie scraped mud off their feet at the door before entering.

“How come you two are free to visit today?” Sister Zhang poured tea for them while asking with a smile.

Zhang Baolu was not at home. Zhang Yimei and Zhang Erli were a little timid and clung to Sister Zhang.

Qin Mian handed the snacks in his hand to Sister Zhang, “This is a snack that I made up myself at home to give to the children.”

Sister Zhang and Zhang Dashuan looked at each other and burst into laughter. In their eyes, Qin Mian himself was still a child. Thus, it sounded especially funny.

The relationship between the two families was good. Sister Zhang politely received it and opened it. “If every time you come here and bring food, be careful that the children might run to your house every day. How to make this? It looks quite nice and smells good.”

Qin Mian disagreed and said: “Simple. It’s called sweet *guozi*[2]. When mixing flour, adds some sugar in, kneads the dough into small lumps, roll it in sesame seeds, and then fry it.”

Fried food required oil, which no one would eat aside from during New Year and festivals. From this, Sister Zhang thought deeply that not only Qin Mian had a good relationship with Lei Tie, but Qin Mian also managed their family.

Seeing that the two children were staring at the oil paper package, she gave them each a small handful and wrapped up the rest. “Quickly thanks Uncle Qin.”

“Thank you, Uncle Qin.” The two little children held the *guozis* in hands and happily ran out to play.

“Are you coming for something today?” Zhang Dashuan asked. Knowing that Lei Tie didn’t like to talk, he simply didn’t look at the man, but asked Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said that he was going to open a restaurant and wanted to hire people to make bamboo sticks.

Lei Tie was drinking tea on the side with the attitude that said he followed Qin Mian’s decision in everything.

Sister Zhang was overjoyed. “This is a good thing. Our family head has been thinking about going to the town or the county for work these two days. Look, your two brothers still keep you in mind.”

Zhang Dashuan was also happy. At the moment, the farmers were idle. Many people went to the town to look for work, but they might not be able to find one. In addition, some jobs were tiring and the pay was little.

“Make bamboo sticks, simple, and hands over to me.”

Having said that, Qin Mian still wanted to make the request clear, “The pay is according to the number of bamboo sticks. A hundred bamboo sticks is paid for 10 Wen and because they are for food, the bamboo sticks can’t have bamboo spines. It is not clear how the business will be in the first few days of opening, but first prepared 400 bamboo sticks on the first day. 100 of them should be painted with red paint at one end of the stick. After that, how much sticks to paint red depends on the actual situation.”

Bamboos grown everywhere, it costed nothing; this was a business without any cost. Zhang Dashuan and Sister Zhang wouldn’t decline, thus they nodded at the same time.

“You guys seek me because you guys trust me, so I’ll definitely do it to your satisfaction.” Zhang Dashuan promised.

Coming out from the Zhang’s house, Lei Tie went to find a well digger. Qin Mian had nothing to do, so he went with Lei Tie and they got things done.

The next day, four well diggers came to work in the yard. Qin Mian and Lei Tie couldn't help and didn't go to add to the mess.

Qin Mian recalled the water pressure well he had seen in the countryside in his previous life and drew a structural diagram. He planned to take it to the iron shop to build it immediately, but he changed his mind and put the drawing into the space for later discussion.

Unexpectedly, not long after breakfast, a rare guest came to their home.

"Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law." Lei Xiangzhi had a warm smile on his face.

"Fifth brother has come back. Come in and sit down." Qin Mian warmly welcomed him. He had heard many times that Lei Xiangzhi was a good at learning. He would participate in the county level imperial exam in February next year and very likely to win a Xiucai[3]. As the saying went, 'things could be handled easily with having someone in the Imperial Court', it was necessarily to make a good relationship with such talented people.

The trio sat in the living room. Lei Tie rarely took the initiative to care about the youngest brother, "Today's holiday?"

"Yes. I'll go back to school again tomorrow morning." Lei Xiangzhi held a teacup as he answered his older brother respectfully.

Lei Tie said: "We have an ox cart. I'll send you off tomorrow."

"Alright, thank you very much, eldest brother." Lei Xiangzhi gladly accepted.

After the basic greetings, Lei Tie was silent.

Lei Xiangzhi looked at the osmanthus trees in the yard. "The house of eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law has changed a lot. I can see that you two are doing well. The other brothers and I can be at ease."

Qin Mian cheerfully said: "The change is quite big. You and your other brothers can visit when you guys are free."

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, looked at him and was about to speak, but saying nothing.

Qin Mian said: “Fifth brother came here because of the rumors circulating in the village?”

Lei Xiangzhi was taken aback. Subconsciously, he avoided Qin Mian’s sharp eyes. After thinking that he had no malice, he met Qin Mian’s eyes again. With a helpless expression, he said frankly: “Such is the case. This little brother knows that there has been a long-standing conflict between eldest brother, father and mother. I dare not ask eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law to forgive them, only hopes that it will not break the mutual affection between us brothers and little sister.”

Lei Tie was silent without words.

“Of course.” Qin Mian nodded and motioned to Lei Xiangzhi to drink the tea. “Fifth brother is knowledgeable and reasonable. I think you know that this contradiction is difficult to reconcile, so it is not as good as to let nature take its course. Your eldest brother is not unreasonable. You guys are still brothers and sister. Just, I’ll speak out of turn and ask fifth brother not to take offense.”

When Lei Xiangzhi heard his extraordinary speech and on point wording, he knew that his family had looked down on the teenager before. He stood up and bowed with hands folded in front as he said: “Eldest sister-in-law’s counsel, Xiangzhi dares not ignore. There will be no harm for eldest sister-in-law to say it.”

“Don’t regard me as a stranger. Sit down.” Qin Mian was fond of this child and didn’t mind giving him more advice, “If possible, fifth brother should persuade father and mother often. *《The Book of Rites》 said ‘to govern the country and bring peace to all, one should first be able to govern one’s family; to govern one’s family successfully, one should first learn to govern oneself’.* The family’s reputation is related to fifth brother’s examination as an official. If fifth brother can’t ‘govern one’s family successfully’, how will others think of you?

Judging from today's situation, even if you brothers are separated in the future, father and mother most probably will follow you. After all, the old parents are big on leaning upon benefits. The sooner you deal with them, the better. There is no need for me to say much about the principle within it."

Lei Xiangzhi nodded and faintly smiled, "Thank you for your advice. I understand. The child that father and mother most care about is me. In other words, I'm the one who can keep them within bounds. Eldest sister-in-law can rest assured. After I go back, I'll give them a detailed justification."

"That's exactly what I meant." Qin Mian nodded approvingly.

After chatting with him, Lei Xiangzhi only felt that his downheartedness had dissipated a lot. He stood up and said: "Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are still busy here, so I won't disturb you guys anymore."

"You wait first." Qin Mian walked into the bedroom. When he came out, he had two small silver ingots and two oil paper packages, and handed them to Lei Xiangzhi. "A few days ago, your eldest brother said he would like to support his youngest brother's study. You take these two silver taels. It isn't much, but it's your eldest brother's regard. These snacks are for you bring home to try."

Lei Xiangzhi refused to accept, "No need, father and mother give me enough money."

Qin Mian put things into his hand, "Take it, be a man and get it over with, don't be like an overly caring woman."

Woman... Lei Xiangzhi was at a loss whether to laugh or cry.

Lei Tie indisputably said: "Just take it."

Lei Xiangzhi had to take it.

Qin Mian said: "Don't tell others about this money, keep it to yourself."

Lei Xiangzhi nodded: "I understand."

He put the money into his sleeve pocket, bid farewell to his eldest brother and sister-in-law, and went far away. He walked along in a leisurely way while thinking about how to persuade Du Shi. Before he even reached the gate of his home, he saw Du Shi and two women of her age with hands on their hips, traded insults at each other. There was also a circle of people watching the fun. “Why is this old hag scolding me? A thing that didn’t give birth to a son! My son will be a Xiucai next year. Where is your son, ah?”

After hearing this, the initially high spirited woman’s red face turned white. She screamed and rushed at Du Shi, “AHH— EMBROIDERER DU! WHAT ELSE CAN YOU DO WITH YOUR MOUTH APART FROM SWEARING AND TALK CRAP? I’LL TEAR YOUR MOUTH!”

Note:

[1]张宝路 [Zhang Baolu] Bao= treasure/precious; lu=path/journey

张一美 [Zhang Yimei] Yi=One/First; Mei=beautiful

张二丽 [Zhang Erli] Er=Two/second; Li=beautiful

[2] 果子 [guǒ zi] is fruit, but since it is a snack, I leave it in pinyin bcuz I couldn’t find a suitable name for it.

[3] 秀才[xiù cai] a person who has passed the county level imperial exam (historical); scholar; skillful writer; fine talent

Chapter 047: Eating Savory Restaurant

047 – Eating Savory Restaurant

What happened in front of the old house soon spread to Qin Mian's ears, but he didn't pay any attention to it. About the old house, if he could avoid them, he would do it desperately. Afterwards, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi no longer provoke him and Lei Tie. However, if they came to provoke again, he still had more vicious tricks. *If people don't offend me, I won't offend them. If people offend me, I will definitely offend them.*

After the well construction at home was completed, Qin Mian and Lei Tie drove the ox cart to the town. In order to promote their "Eating Savory" Restaurant, Qin Mian specially painted 20 posters with the paintings of hot pot on the top and hot spicy soup on the bottom, as well as the restaurant's address and opening time stated at the very bottom. The promoting paintings were very lifelike that it aroused people's appetite when looking at it. Fortunately, he learnt to paint in the previous life for three years, therefore he could paint so well. These paintings alone took him a day. When they entered the town, he and Lei Tie pasted the posters in conspicuous places in the town. Two sheets were left and they pasted one at the door of the shop.

In order to save time, Qin Mian went directly to the brokerage and hired a waiter named Zheng Liu, who lived in the town and was only 14 years old. Although he was not very old, his glib talk was particularly nimble. The agreement was 500 Wen per month and there would be a bonus if work did well. Qin Mian had inquired that this monthly salary was higher than that of the ordinary hired worker. He didn't mind being generous as long as the waiter get right on the job.

Back in the store, Qin Mian gave Zheng Liu the last poster and asked him to beat gong on the street while shouting: “‘EATING SAVORY RESTAURANT’ WILL OPEN TOMORROW. ALL DELICIOUS HOT SPICY SOUP AND HOT POT WILL BE 20% OFF!”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stayed in the shop and bustled about, seizing the moment to make pork meatballs and vegetable balls.

Zheng Liu went back and forth several times around the town and every time he passed the shop’s door, they could hear his clear and brisk voice: “‘EATING SAVORY RESTAURANT’ WILL OPEN TOMORROW. ALL DELICIOUS HOT SPICY SOUP AND HOT POT WILL BE 20% OFF! ‘EATING SAVORY RESTAURANT’ WILL OPEN TOMORROW. ALL DELICIOUS HOT SPICY SOUP AND HOT POT WILL BE 20% OFF!...”

“He seems to be a steadfast person.” Qin Mian rolled a ball in his hands and said to Lei Tie at the same time.

Lei Tie said: “Time reveals a person’s heart.”

More than two hours later, Zheng Liu stepped into the shop.

“Bosses, I’m back.”

Qin Mian said: “You’ve worked hard. Thirsty? Pour your own water.”

“Thank you, small boss.”

Qin Mian glanced at Lei Tie and said with a severe countenance: “I’m the big boss. He’s the small boss.”

Zheng Liu was taken aback and suspiciously looked towards Lei Tie while murmuring in his heart: It’s the opposite?

Lei Tie nodded, “He is the big boss.”

Qin Mian’s face looked smug, “Heard that?”

“Yes, big boss.” Zheng Liu responded with a laugh. After drinking the water, he self-consciously squatted on the edge of the big wooden basin to help washing the vegetables.

There was a corner door in the kitchen leading to the back of the shop and there was a well in the back of the shop, which was shared by several shops nearby. It was very convenient to wash vegetables.

Qin Mian informed Zheng Liu, “The vegetables must be washed clean. If I find worms or rotten leaves in it, you’re in trouble.”

Zheng Liu patted his chest and said: “Don’t worry, big boss. This little one doesn’t have any other prospects, but this pair of eyes is capable. If you find worms or rotten leaves in the vegetables, you can immediately chase me out.”

“En.” Qin Mian kept rolling ball in his hands. “We are doing food business, so I’m afraid the food is not clean. You can understand this principle without me saying it. Anyway, you don’t have to be too nervous. If you do well, your big boss I will reward you.”

“Yes.”

Afterwards, the trio didn’t talk anymore.

After the food balls were ready, Qin Mian taught Lei Tie and Zheng Liu to skewer them.

“The bamboo sticks with red paint are used to skewer meat dishes and those without red paint are used to skewer vegetables. This will make it convenient for us to charge for meat dishes and vegetable dishes. When I collect the money, I count the bamboo sticks. Four on a bamboo stick for the boiled meatballs; also four for the vegetable balls; four pieces for fish fillets; four slices for streaky pork; six slices for potato... As for noodles, 2 Wen per serve...”

The boiling wok in the kitchen made a gurgling sound. Qin Mian went to stirred it and the aroma became stronger.

Zheng Liu took a sniff, “Smell so good! Big boss, what are you cooking?”

Qin Mian voiced: “Big bone soup. Our hot pot and spicy hot soup are not suitable for eating in the morning. The shop is open for business at about *three quarter of snake hour*[1]. Your small boss and I will come very early to bring the ingredients over. Your small boss and I are in charge of making the balls while you’ll stew the big bone soup to be used, wash the vegetables and skewer the dishes every morning. When the shop opens, you’re responsible for entertaining the customers. Seeing that you’d work hard today, you can have dinner with us in the evening before you go home.”

Zheng Liu was greatly happy and glad that he found good employers, “Thank you very much big boss; thank you very much small boss!”

Qin Mian secretly praised him for his cleverness for not leaving out Lei Tie. He took a glance at Lei Tie, but he couldn’t help laughing again and then cracked a joke: “Small boss, add more strength. Otherwise, it will be dark when we get home after dinner.”

Lei Tie looked at the remaining bamboo sticks; there were about 40 sticks left. He stood up and said, “I’ll make dinner.”

Qin Mian voiced: “It’s time-saving to cook spicy hot soup. Just cook it together with noodle.”

By the time Qin Mian and Lei Tie got home, it was dark. The next day when the sky was bright, they drove the cart to the town. The cart was loaded with noodles made by the noodle maker and vegetables they bought priorly. When they returned to the shop, they conveniently bought a few steamed stuffed buns for breakfast.

Zheng Liu was a diligent person. He appeared at the door of the shop almost at the same time with them. The trio had breakfast, and then each had their own division of labor.

At three quarter of snake hour, Lei Tie ignited firecrackers, and together with Qin Mian, they uncovered the red cloth on the plaque.

Altogether, there were eight tables in the shop; four in the shop were for the customers who ate hot pot. Qin Mian had taken these four tables to be rebuilt in the carpentry shop and each table was embedded with a charcoal stove to cook hot pot. The four tables outside the shop were for spicy hot soup customers.

The big pot for cooking the spicy hot soup was placed at the door. After boiling the thick soup with hot pot ingredients, the rich aroma floated around along the autumn wind, attracting people from afar to look over curiously.

Yesterday's publicity was very effective, and soon a group of people flooded into the shop.

Zheng Liu hollered: "DELICIOUS HOT POT AND SPICY HOT SOUP; EAT ONCE AND WANT SECOND!"

At the entrance, there a three layered wooden rack, on which various kinds of dishes that had already been skewed were placed. Seeing a young gongzi[2] about 20 years old curiously scanning all kinds of dishes on the wooden rack, Zheng Liu immediately took a small hollow wooden basket and handed it to him, "For delicious spicy hot soup; vegetarian dishes for 1 Wen a skewer, meat dishes for 2 Wen a skewer! It's cheap and delicious. Gongzi, you can choose what you want to eat."

The gongzi interestingly picked up the dishes he wanted to eat and put them in the basket. Then, he handed the basket to Lei Tie at the door, to simmer the dishes.

A moment later, a second person came, then a third person — — —

"Waiter, we brothers are going to have hot pot!" Four big men wearing duanda garment walked into the shop.

Zheng Liu quickly ran over, "Gentlemen, please sit down. We have all the dishes on that rack in our shop, which can be served immediately after you order."

“Fish fillet, streaky pork, pork balls...”

Zheng Liu nodded as he listened, waiting for the customers to finish order before he quickly ran to the kitchen, put food ingredients on plates and served on the table. Once black charcoal was added, the fire on the stove roared more and the hot pot soup soon boiled. The aroma lingered around.

A man on the table outside the shop was eating spicy hot soup, and he was full of praise, “Delicious. It’s spicy and numbing. Gratifying spicy and satisfyingly numbing!”

People kept coming and soon there were no available seats.

Qin Mian watched with a smile. Based on this trend, today’s turnover wouldn’t be bad.

“Check out, boss.” A young couple beckoned Qin Mian.

Qin Mian quickly walked over, “Coming.”

He swept the bamboo sticks on the table and said with a smile, “Seven skewers of vegetarian dishes and six skewers of meat dishes, 19 Wen in total. After 20% discount, it is 15 Wen. Thank you for your patronage and please come again.”

The couple paid the money happily and after they went away only in few steps, the seats were occupied by new customers.

An old man with a short beard and two boys of about ten years old walked slowly to the shop. Upon seeing that there was no empty seat in the shop, the old man frowned and dissatisfiedly asked: “There is no seat left?”

Qin Mian said, “Welcome, honored customers. These three customers must be from the town. I don’t know if these customers want to eat hot pot or spicy hot soup? The raw ingredients of hot pot are the same as spicy hot soup. Both are delicious. If these customers want to eat hot pot, I’m afraid you’ll have to wait. But, if it spicy hot soup, you can pack it to take home; undisturbed and it won’t take long.”

The old man couldn't help laughing and looked at him a few times. "You this small boss actually simplify matters."

Qin Mian also laughed, "I'm^[3] telling you the truth."

"Grandfather, I don't want to wait." The older boy took the old man's hand and hinted.

The old man looked at him with a smile, "Then, we'll order spicy hot soup."

Qin Mian made a gesture, "Customers, please come in and choose what you want to eat."

Qin Mian hadn't in the least expected that the scene of full seats continued until the sun went west, and even the nearby residents brought their own bowls.

"Big boss, we've run out of dishes for spicy hot soup!" Zheng Liu reported in time, wiped the sweat on his face with the cloth towel on his neck and rubbed his stomach quietly. There were too many customers today. Not only he, but also the two bosses were too busy to have lunch. They had been hungry until now.

Qin Mian was both happy and worried. "They are sold out so soon? Now it's too late to skewer another. Forget it. Close the door when the dishes are finished."

As he was entertaining two tables of hot pot customers, the dishes in the kitchen ran out.

Lei Tie asked Zheng Liu to close half of the shop's door.

Qin Mian looked at the sky and lamented: "Our estimation was still too cautious. If we sell in two more hours, we can make a lot of money."

Lei Tie said to placate: "Tomorrow, prepare more dishes."

Qin Mian thought so, too. He looked at the broken silvers and copper plates in the drawer happily. He took out ten copper plates and handed them to Zheng Liu. “Little Liuzi, go buy some steamed stuffed buns. I’ll be counting the money with your small boss.”

“Alrighty.”

Qin Mian divided the money into two piles. He counted one pile and Lei Tie counted the other.

Note:

[1] It’s the Chinese zodiac hour; 9 a.m to 11 a.m, Basically $\frac{3}{4}$ of it is 10.30 a.m

[2] son of a feudal prince or high official. Basically, a wealthy young man

[3] Qin Mian used 在下 [zài xià] which meant humble me

Translator’s side note: Sorry, I got distracted and hungry when googling for the food images. Therefore, I stopped and there were no pics to be included here. You can google Malatang and Hot Pot if you want. uwu

On another note, I hope none of you reading this on an aggregator site.

Chapter 048: The People from the Old House Come To Make Trouble

048 – The People from the Old House Come To Make Trouble

“Two, four, six...”

When Zheng Liu came back from buying the steamed stuffed buns, Qin Mian thanked and rewarded him with 5 Wen, sending him away first. While gnawing at the steamed stuffed bun in one hand, his other hand skillfully fiddled with the copper coins, “86, 88, 90...”

Only after a long time did he raised his head and exhaled easily, “My count is finished; a total of 2 taels and 319.”

Lei Tie quickly finished counting the last copper coin, “2 taels and 453.”

Qin Mian’s eyes brightened, “Hahaha! So much, and it only took one day to earn the monthly rent back.”

Lei Tie glanced at his (QM) hand, “Hire another waiter tomorrow. You’re only responsible for collecting money.”

Qin Mian only hesitated for a few seconds before he agreed, “Sure, it’s a matter of 500 Wen.”

They put all the money in the money pouch, locked the door and drove the cart home in the dusk. The night wind was colder than the day, especially when they passed over the mountains, the wind was stronger that the shivering cold went straight into the neck. Qin Mian sat next to Lei Tie, but he still had to press onto the man’s body. He also didn’t understand it himself why he didn’t get into the cart’s compartment.

Lei Tie switched to his left hand to raise the whip while his right arm enclosed a person.

“Wear more clothes tomorrow.”

“Go to the cloth shop tomorrow and buy some good cloth to make two scarves.” Qin Mian rubbed his stomach, “I’m not full. I’ll cook the hot pot at home.”

Lei Tie said: “400 bamboo sticks and not one is missing.”

Qin Mian understood his meaning and said with a smile: “Don’t worry. I need the bamboo sticks for other purposes.”

Until half a month later, the business of Eating Savory Restaurant still didn’t fall back, but was getting better with each passing time. Qin Mian added barbecue business in the shop. Due to the shop being too small, he discussed with the owner of the neighboring grocery store to occupy the open space in front of their store and gave the owner of the grocery store 100 Wen a month as fee. Qin Mian got along with people quite well and gave the owner a bowl of spicy hot soup or a few barbecues to eat from time to time. Consequently, the last trace of unhappiness in the owner’s heart disappeared.

The name of Eating Savory Restaurant gradually became well-known. Some people in the county even went to Running Water Town to eat hot pot and spicy hot soup, merely to get through this kind of spicy and numbness addiction. There were two restaurants that tried to make hot pot and spicy hot soup dishes. Unfortunately, no matter how much they tossed about, the taste of the soup was not as good as that from Eating Savory Restaurant. Another restaurant wanted to buy Qin Mian’s secret recipe, but Qin Mian refused without hesitation.

The ox cart of Qin Mian’s family dashed to the town every day and finally attracted the attention of an idle hoodlum in Green Mountain Village. In less than a day, the news about Qin Mian and Lei Tie opened a restaurant in the town blew across the village like a gust of wind.

“What?” Hearing the news, Du Shi accidentally broke a bowl.

“Second brother, does eldest brother really run a shop in the town?” Lei Xiangyi somehow couldn’t believe it.

Lei Xiangren looked anxious, “Really! It was Zhao Mazi who told me. At the beginning, I also didn’t believe it. I secretly went to the town to have a look and confirmed it. Not only that, the business is also very good!”

Lei Xiangli frowned to himself and said dully: “Even if eldest brother run a shop, how about it? It has nothing to do with us.”

“That’s not the case.” Lei Xiangren glared at him, “I saw he also hired two waiters in that shop. He would rather hire others than us. This is inexcusable, right?”

“This...” Lei Xiangyi felt a little uncomfortable. They had been looking for jobs recently, hoping to earn some money to support the household expenses, but they had not found any.

Lei Xiangli lightly snorted, “That’s their shop. It’s their business to hire people. Why must we be hired?”

Lei Daqiang’s face turned red and then white. At this time, he deeply regretted that he had quarreled with the eldest son. If there was no such thing, he could make the eldest son hire all of his brothers to help in his shop.

“Mother, says something.” At the thought of not taking advantage of that shop, Zhao Shi’s heart was burning with discontentment.

Qian Shi also eagerly looked at Du Shi.

Du Shi rightly and self-confidently said: “What else can I say? Of course, your own brother must run the shop with people on our side.”

Lei Chuntao frowned and said in a slow voice, “Mother, did you forget? We have already separated from eldest brother; he and we can’t be considered as a family.”

“You little girl!” Du Shi was so angry that she jabbed at her head. “You always favor outsiders!”

Qian Shi secretly cut a quick look at Lei Chuntao and hugged Du Shi’s arm affectionately, “Mother, what do you think that we should do now?”

Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao’s faces sank simultaneously.

Lei Xiangren squeezed to Du Shi’s side.

“What do you say, old man?” Du Shi did not immediately comment, but looked at Lei Daqiang.

Lei Daqiang patted the table, “Anyhow, it’s wrong for him to ignore his brothers.”

“Father, what should we do? We all will listen to you.” Lei Xiangren immediately asked.

Lei Daqiang squinted. “When they come back in the evening, go to them and ask them to arrange for you brothers to go help in the shop. If they don’t agree, force them to agree.”

Lei Xiangyi was surprised, “Isn’t that not good?”

Du Shi’s corner of her mouth cocked up and her voice was as gentle as a real loving mother, “The older generation had passed on ‘*if brothers are of the same mind, their sharpness can cut through metal*’[1]. Only by working together can you five brothers have a bright future.”

“Absolutely not, father.” Lei Xiangli abruptly stood up, “The relationship between us and eldest brother has been extremely bad. If you really do that, the two families will breed enmity.”

“Where is the relationship as serious as you said?” Lei Xiangren pushed him aside and disdainfully said, “Old Four, you are too timid. That’s not going to work for you.”

Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao looked at each other as there was a sense of uneasiness in their hearts. It was fine if it was only Lei Tie, but judging from the several interactions they had with Qin Mian, Qin Mian was definitely not a simple teenager; he could not be underestimated.

Lei Chuntao apprehensively spoke: “Father, mother, did you forget what fifth brother said last time?”

Du Shi recalled what Lei Xiangzhi had said to her last time when he came home, and she immediately hesitated. In case the small trouble became serious, it was truly going to be unfavorable for Little Five.

Upon seeing that the situation was going badly, Lei Xiangren blocked Lei Chuntao’s view. “Mother, I think Little Five thought too much. We can make more money for Little Five is a good thing. Don’t you think so?”

“Second brother!” Lei Chuntao stomped her feet.

Du Shi waved her hand and said: “What your second brother said is reasonable. I think we should arrange people to go to their shop. Not to mention, we can take this opportunity to restore the relationship in our big family. What do you think, old man?”

Lei Daqiang nodded in agreement, “That’s right, it’s for Eldest own good. Old Four, you watch the movement over there. As soon as they come back, immediately return to inform me.”

Without waiting for Lei Xiangli to talk, Lei Xiangren said, “Father, I’ll go. Anyway, I’m free.”

“Sure.”

Du Shi purposely served the dinner in advanced by nearly an hour. Lei Xiangren quickly finished his meal and went to the village. When he saw the familiar ox cart from a distance, he ran back home.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very tired after a busy day. When they got home, they bolted the courtyard’s gate and got ready to have a rest after

taking a bath.

The courtyard's gate was knocked before the water had boiled well.

"Who?" Qin Mian raised his voice as he asked.

"Eldest sister-in-law, we have come to see you." Lei Xiangren happily called out.

Qin Mian's good mood was half spoiled. He glanced at Lei Tie, turned back and returned to the house.

Lei Tie spoke towards the outside of the courtyard: "You all go back. There is no need to see us."

There was a moment of silence outside the courtyard. Lei Daqiang lightly shouted as he unyieldingly said: "Eldest, your mother and I also come, quickly open the gate."

Lei Tie indifferently spoke: "Besides at every festival and New Year, it'd better for our two families to pay fewer visits to each other."

"What are you talking about? You open the gate first and we talk." Lei Daqiang's patience was limited.

"I know what you want to say. There are enough staffs in the shop. Moreover, we had written agreement, it's impossible to fire them. You can't possibly make me arrange second brother and the others to work in the shop." Lei Tie explained.

"You!" Lei Daqiang's liver ached with anger.

Lei Xiangren also carried a stomach of anger, "Eldest brother, aren't your words too unreasonable?"

Qin Mian had reached the end of his forbearance. He ran into the yard. "Second brother, you're bullying people too much. At the beginning, we said that both sides should not interfere in each other's family affairs. Or, do

you all want to go to Li Zheng's house and have a good look at the agreement to see if this was written in it?"

"Fine, fine, fine!" Du Shi said in shrill voice, "Since you two don't care about a few younger brothers, don't blame me for bringing people to the shop to make trouble tomorrow."

In the yard next door, the eavesdropping Zhou Erhao and his wife exchanged looks, and shook their heads as if by prior agreement, expressing sympathy for Lei Tie and Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said coldly: "Oh? You are welcome to try."

Lei Daqiang was furious, "Let's go!"

Angry and resentful, Lei Xiangren shouted: "Lei Tie, Qin Mian; you all are cruel!"

When outside the courtyard came the sound of distant footsteps, Qin Mian elatedly went back to the house.

Lei Tie walked with him. "They are really going to do it. Don't be afraid, I've my own countermeasure."

"I'll be afraid?" Qin Mian's eyes flashed as he sneered. He walked into the house with his hands on his back and said calmly, "I'm waiting for their move. Actually, I'm looking forward to them making trouble. Heh, heh, heh."

Lei Tie's back felt inexplicably cold. This little wife of his was really...

"Won't you come in to scoop out the water for bath?" Qin Mian prompted him from the kitchen.

The next day, the restaurant opened as usual.

The middle of the horse hour[2] was the busiest. Many people squatted on the roadside with bowls as they ate. This was a phenomenon that had never occurred in any other restaurant.

Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi furiously came over.

As soon as Du Shi patted her thigh, she sat on the ground and howled, “O God, open your eyes. My eldest son is unfilial ah...” All the customers in the shop were surprised. They turned around to look at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with *heads together and ears stretched out*[3].

“What’s the matter? Which boss’s mother is this old woman?”

The two waiters; Zheng Liu and Wang Shun looked at each other helplessly.

“It is stepmother.” Qin Mian coolly provided a sentence as he walked out of the shop, “Everybody, since you don’t need ears to eat, you may as well listen to it.”

Hearing his words, Du Shi was stunned. Upon seeing that his expression looked confident yet normal, she felt inexplicably uneasy and somehow couldn’t keep going [with her plan].

“Mother, we all depend on you.” Zhao Shi whispered.

Qian Shi promptly pushed Du Shi’s back.

Note:

[1] If the brothers work together, they can overcome any difficulty.

[2] the period of the day from 11 a.m. to 1 p.m. The middle period of it basically 12 p.m

[3] exchange confidential whispers; gossiping

Side Note: I put a Characters Guide chapter in the ToC before 001.

Chapter 049: Without Fierce Tricks, It Won't Work

049 – Without Fierce Tricks, It Won't Work

Du Shi then wailed loudly, “He has money to open his own shop, I only asked him to take account of his blood brothers, but he didn't want to. This unfilial thing...”

Qin Mian inserted again, “His brothers know that our shop is not short of staff and the two employees we hired are both on contract; we can't break the agreement, but they still insist on us to hire them. Dear customers, as you can see, our shop is so small, where do we need so many staffs?”

“That is true.” Majority of the customers nodded in agreement.

Some also boldly said: “The brothers still want to, isn't it so they can take money for doing nothing?”

Du Shi's face intermittently turned blue, red and white. She lowered her head, her thoughts unknown. Then, she got up from the ground and looked at Lei Tie, who was cooking the spicy hot soup as if nothing bothered him. She said in a sad voice: “Eldest, I know you don't like me and always think that this stepmother I, am aiming at you. I don't ask you to be filial to me, only ask you to take your brothers into account based on the fact that you all are of the same father.”

A few customers showed an understanding look and nodded slightly, feeling that what Du Shi said was reasonable.

Qin Mian's expression turned cold. *Good one, Du Shi. You know it won't work by using force, so you have to mislead the outsiders.*

“Whatever you say, it's a fact that you abused Lei Tie and forced him to run away from home when he was 12. Do you think so many people are fools and only listen to your one-sided words? A little inquiry into these matters will tell us who is telling the truth.”

Du Shi fiercely stared at Qin Mian like staring at the enemy who killed her son. The jeering eyes of the people around continuously fell on her, which made the hatred and anger in her chest constantly stirred up and blood rushed up to her head. Suddenly, she strode to the nearest table and overturned the table without warning.

All of a sudden, the six bowls of spicy hot soup on the table all flew out. One bowl flew straight to Qin Mian.

Everyone cried out in alarm.

“AH!”

“BE CAREFUL!”

Qin Mian was also frightened and helplessly watched a bowl of spicy hot soup fly towards his face.

Just then, a dark shadow flashed by.

It turned out that Lei Tie abruptly stepped into the air and moved his hands several times to catch all the six bowls of spicy hot soup and put them steadily on another table. There was not a drop of soup spilled from the six bowls.

After another look, Lei Tie had stood by Qin Mian's side, as steady as Mount Tai.

“Oh!” A customer stared at Lei Tie as he marveled, “I didn't expect that the big boss of this shop can even do Kung Fu!”

“Big boss?” The corner of Qin Mian’s mouth twitched as stared at Lei Tie. Aside from the two waiters and a few old customers in the shop, others were still used to calling Lei Tie the big boss.

Lei Tie paid attention to him without him (QM) noticing as a ghost of smile flashed through his eyes.

“Are you all right?”

It was only his heart that beat a little too fast, thus Qin Mian shook his head. “I’m fine.”

Du Shi was frightened to be as dumb as a wooden chicken by Lei Tie that her legs trembled and she could not move for a moment. Just now, she could see it clearly that Lei Tie flew over from the door of the shop and caught the six bowls. *How, how can he fly?*

“Everyone had been frightened,” Lei Tie said to the customers with hands cupped in obeisance, “All customers are given 20% discount from us two as a means of helping everyone get over the shock.”

“Exactly.” Qin Mian smiled genially, “Everyone, please eat slowly. Don’t need to spoil your mood to enjoy [meal] because of others.”

Majority of the customers in the shop were men, therefore they weren’t afraid of Du Shi – a married woman. They laughed one after another as they said that it’s fine, and stayed to continue eating.

Lei Tie looked at Du Shi coldly; his black pupils becoming more isolated and deep, as if the two eyes were black pool.

Du Shi tried to move her eyes away, but she found that she could not move her gaze, her lips trembled but she could not speak a word and the panic in her heart drowned her like the tide, somehow put her out of breathe.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were also scared to death. They huddled together for fear that Lei Tie would transfer his anger to them.

Lei Tie held back his threat and said in a low voice, “Still not going?”

After saying that, he pulled Qin Mian back into the shop.

At once, Du Shi's back straightened up again.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi secretly breathed a sigh of relief, rushed to hold her up as they whispered, "Mother, let's go."

Du Shi walked out a few steps and recklessly snorted, "Heh! Look at your terrified appearance! He merely intimidated me, and that's all. How could he dare do that to me? This won't do, I've to find another way. In a word, this shop – heh."

One of the customers, who immersed in spicy hot soup dish, shook his head at her words. *This stepmother is truly making one speechless.*

Qin Mian stood at the door of the shop and looked at Du Shi, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi murmuring over there with a sly smile on his lips that appeared horrifying.

Wang Shun asked carefully, "Big boss, what are you thinking about?"

With a smile on his face, Qin Mian inadvertently asked: "Little Shunzi, you're 18 years old now, right? Have you been matched a wife?"

Wang Shun's face turned red, "Getting married in March next year."

"Oh, then take this 'Congratulations' in advance from me." Qin Mian said again, "Boy, look at you, obviously very satisfied with your wife. You must have hired a famous matchmaker to act as go-between the prospective marriage partners?"

Wang Shun shook his head. "The matchmaker who acted as my go-between was Aunt Wang from Yao Mountain Village. The most famous matchmaker in our Running Water Town is Matchmaker Jin in the town. Allegedly, 9 out of 10 people who she had acted as go-between have a very peaceful married life."

A customer who ate barbecue called out: "Small boss, collect the money!"

“Coming!” Qin Mian answered while begrudged. *The small boss is Lei Tie!*

He turned his head to glare at Lei Tie, who happened to look at him.

Qin Mian was sure that Lei Tie was smiling just now; although the man didn't smile on his face, he did in his eyes. After receiving the money, he went on to talk to Wang Shun, “What you just said is true? Is that Matchmaker Jin really that good?”

“Of course!” Wang Shun affirmatively said, “That's what the aunties in our village said. However, she is also more expensive than others.”

“Oh.” Qin Mian glanced at Zheng Liu, who was passing by with a dish in his hand and overheard them. He joked: “Little Liuzi also wants to marry a wife? Little Shunzi, quickly tell him the address of that Matchmaker Jin. Hahaha.”

Zheng Liu knew that this *small* boss was very kind and instantly asked Wang Shun for the address of the matchmaker with a grin.

Qin Mian had a sly smile in his eyes as he quietly memorized the address in his mind.

In the afternoon, after the dishes sold out, Qin Mian ran to Lei Tie, who was cleaning up the kitchen utensils. “Why don't we stay out tonight and spend a night in town?”

Lei Tie nodded in agreement.

After Qin Mian took the money from the cash box, he said to Zheng Liu and Wang Shun, “You two should go back to rest earlier after you clean up.”

“Aye, see you tomorrow, bosses.”

They went to book a room in the only inn in town and after telling the waiter to feed the ox, Qin Mian took Lei Tie to a clothing shop.

“I’ve a fierce way to make Du Shi preoccupied to try finding trouble with us later on. Do you have any objection?”

Lei Tie shook his head, somewhat curious of the wife’s plan.

Qin Mian replied with a mysterious smile and said without explanation, “You’ll know soon. Come with me.”

.....

The past few days had been fine weather with cloudless blue sky and shining blazing sun. The warm sunshine sprinkled on the mother earth and covered everywhere with a layer of warm color, making people feel good.

Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were in a very bad mood. At the thought of Lei Tie and Qin Mian counting money every day, their hands ached and their hearts felt just like a hundred ants biting it.

“Mother, have you actually come up with a way? Are we really going to watch eldest brother make money?” Between Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, Lei Xiangren had more faith in Du Shi.

Du Shi frowned, “Am I not trying to figure it out?”

“It’s been several days...” Qian Shi murmured and sighed to herself. Here she was worried, but her husband didn’t care in the least.

Lei Xiangyi was aware that his wife was staring at him. He also wanted to make money, but while he felt very apologetic for his brothers, he felt lack of interest because they did not separate from the family that even if they really got money from his eldest brother’s shop, he would not get a share of it.

Lei Daqiang hatefully said: “This really won’t do, I’ll personally make an appearance. I just don’t believe this.”

When the family was discussing, a sprightly voice came from outside the courtyard, “Is this Lei Daqiang, Brother Lei’s home?”

At the gate stood a woman dressed in a bright red gown[1] with golden border, looking very festive. She had gray hair, was about 50 years old, but she had a smile on her face and bright clear eyes as she stood with her head raised high, bearing a unique momentum. Taking a look at her hair worn in a bun, there was a bright red flower. Wasn't this a matchmaker dress up?

At thought that there were two sons and one daughter in the family who had not been engaged to others, Du Shi was pleased and quickly went out, "This is the Lei's home. May I know who are you?"

The woman cheerfully said: "I'm Matchmaker Jin from town."

Du Shi was greatly rejoiced, "You're surnamed Jin? Are you perhaps the one who is called the 'famous mouth'[2]?"

"I'm not worthy of such compliment. Hehe, it's merely praise made by others." Although Matchmaker Jin said so, her eyes looked a little proud, clearly pleased with her own skill.

"Come in, come in." Du Shi's face was radiating with smiles and said to Zhao Shi and Qian Shi, "Why haven't you bring out the tea and snacks yet?"

Lei Xiangli's earlobes were red as he hung down his head uneasily. Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao were both younger than him, this Matchmaker Jin most probably coming for him.

As Matchmaker Jin walked into the house, she looked around at the people in the room. Soon, her eyes fixatedly fell on Lei Daqiang's face. Lei Daqiang's face looked a little old, but all the countrymen were like this. He was in his early 40s, his body seemed thin, but judging from his strong arms, he was not weak. After getting this basic information, Matchmaker Jin felt a greater chance of success.

"Congratulations to Brother Lei and Sister Lei. If the next step succeeded, not only will Brother Lei enjoy happiness in the future, but sister will also gain a bosom friend." Her face was full of smiles and while the words she

spoke were a little unclear, her intonation was spry that could easily obtained people's favorable impression.

“Gain a bosom friend”, in other words, the family would be adding people. Du Shi thought about it for a while. She didn't dare to slight Matchmaker Jin and added tea to her as she asked, “Which family's girl is it? Is it for Old Four or Old Five in our family?”

Matchmaker Jin did not answer immediately, but mentioned: “This girl is not only beautiful and kind-hearted, but also quick at manual work. Not only that, she also said that she was willing to bring a dowry worth 20 silver taels. Brother Lei and sister, don't you think this is a great joyful event?”

20 taels! Du Shi and Lei Daqiang's eyes sparkled, showing a great sense of joy.

However, Lei Xiangli felt rather uncomfortable. 20 taels dowry was not a small amount. Ordinary people could only save less than 2 silver taels even if they tired themselves out for a year. Would he be able to keep such a rich wife under control?

“Is what Matchmaker Jin said true?” Lei Daqiang couldn't believe it. “The conditions of our family are just ordinary. Will such a girl wants to marry into our family?”

Matchmaker Jin smiled deeper, “Why not? What's more, aren't matchmakers playing the role of mediators?”

Du Shi asked: “Then, does this girl meant for our family's Old Four or Old Five?”

Matchmaker Jin sipped her tea, chuckled and looked at Lei Daqiang. “None of them. She meant to be an equal wife[3] for Brother Lei.”

“What!” *Bang*, Du Shi fell from her chair and sat on the ground, struck dumb with astonishment.

Note:

[1] Chinese-styled gown

A matchmaker

[2] Mainly describe people who are good at expressing eloquence and the like

[3] Compared with concubines, the legal and social status of an equal wife is equivalent to that of a formal spouse, and the children born are regarded as inherited children with inheritance rights.

Chapter 050: Give Matchmaker Jin a Like

050 – Give Matchmaker Jin a Like[1]

“Puff–” Lei Xiangren coughed and sputtered out tea. He wiped his mouth as he stole a glance at his parent’s face. He wanted to laugh but didn’t dare to. “Matchmaker Jin, you must be mistaken.”

Lei Daqiang’s face flushed red; it was unknown whether he was shy or angry.

Both Zhao Shi and Qian Shi lowered their heads as they snickered while suppressing the laugh, making their faces flushed red.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli looked at each other. Their father had three grandchildren; two grandsons and a granddaughter, but still had someone came to act as matchmaker.

Lei Xiangyi stammered: “Matchmaker Jin, is mistaken, right?”

Matchmaker Jin seemed as though she did not notice the others’ flushed faces and waved her hand as she said: “How could I make a mistake? If I’m mistaken, won’t it hurt my own reputation? The girl also knows about your family’s situation, and she is quite satisfied. I’m not exaggerating but the girl’s appearance is first-grade. She is gentle, amiable and her cooking is especially first-class. When she truly became your family, you all can live comfortably afterwards.” She spoke as she looked at Lei Daqiang.

Lei Daqiang was cornered, sitting on pins and needles. However, the words “gentle”, “beautiful” and “20 silver tales” constantly circled around his

mind.

At this time, Du Shi finally regained her mind, stood up and glared at Matchmaker Jin, “Get out of here! You go match such a *good* girl to others!”

The smile on Matchmaker Jin’s face faded and her cold eyes fell on Du Shi’s face as she said calmly, “Why should sister be so angry? Brother Lei hasn’t said anything yet.”

“You get out of here, I—”

“Mother!” Lei Xiangli was shocked and hurriedly stopped her. He said quickly in her ear, “Don’t be impulsive! If you offend Matchmaker Jin, what will happen to the marriage of me, fifth brother and little sister?”

The flame of fury in Du Shi’s belly swirled, she couldn’t understand Lei Xiangli’s words at all, “What’s the relationship between your marriage and her? Get out of the way!”

Matchmaker Jin sat there, looking at Lei Xiangli with a smile. *Finally, someone has a brain.*

Lei Xiangli said anxiously: “Listen to me. Matchmaker Jin is the most famous matchmaker in town. She must know other matchmakers. You think about what would happen if she spoke ill of us to other matchmakers? Fifth brother and I are men, but little sister’s reputation must never be spoiled.”

Du Shi quivered and her mind finally cleared up with incessant lingering fear. However, the anger and reluctance did not disappear.

“Matchmaker Jin, our family head doesn’t plan to marry an equal wife. Can you please,” Du Shi suppressed her anger and grudge as she made a gesture with her right hand towards the door. If she could, she would like to pick up Matchmaker Jin and throw her out.

Matchmaker Jin sneered to herself. The people who asked her to come forward promised to give her 8 silver taels, more than double the price of

matchmaking. The disparity between Lei Daqiang and that girl was too far that she didn't have much confidence at first, but she had to get it done just because of Du Shi's attitude towards her today.

She ignored Du Shi and looked at Lei Daqiang, "Brother Lei, I've come today without malicious intention. As soon as you heard mine, Matchmaker Jin's reputation, you will know that I, Matchmaker Jin don't tell lies. Otherwise, my reputation won't be so loudly praise. Don't you think I'm right?"

Lei Daqiang was not muddle-headed. Lei Xiangli's worry was the same as his. His youngest son and his only daughter were his treasures. Therefore, he didn't dare to offend Matchmaker Jin and just nodded in embarrassment, "Yes, I know that Matchmaker Jin, you are showing goodwill, but..." He had been with Du Shi for so many years that the feelings were quite deep, so it was unreasonable to marry an equal wife.

Du Si furiously stared at him, "Old man, why you paying attention to her?"

Matchmaker Jin looked at Lei Chuntao, who was stunned with fright, and said gently: "Better let the girl step out first."

Lei Chuntao had long been scared witless being under the oppressive pressure, hurriedly went back to her own side room.

Matchmaker Jin confidently said to Lei Daqiang: "Before coming, I'd inquired about your family's situation. There are three unmarried people in your family; they need money whether they are married in or married out. The fifth gongzi is studying; more money needs to spend on various things. Adding it all up, the sum is not small. Sister Du is managing the household, but the money saved isn't increasing." She gave Du Shi a meaningful glance. She actually despised Du Shi's "stinginess". It was fine if she was stingy to others, but she was even so stingy to her own family.

Du Shi said coldly: "Matchmaker Jin, you are an outsider, not qualified to interfere in our family's affairs."

“Brother Lei, the girl’s joining to your household will benefit you all and do no harm.” Matchmaker Jin continued, “Why don’t you listen first? If you don’t agree, can I still force you to marry her? I think Sister Du is not feeling well. It’d be better ask her to have a rest first.”

Lei Daqiang looked at Zhao Shi and Qian Shi as he said: “Help your mother-in-law back to her room.”

Du Shi felt all the more far from good, “Lei Daqiang, you dare!”

“Go quickly!” Lei Daqiang glared, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi hurriedly dragged Du Shi to leave.

Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli did not leave. The appearance of Matchmaker Jin was so sudden and strange that they doubted her. They also wanted to hear what Matchmaker Jin was thinking of doing.

Matchmaker Jin’s expression eased down and her smile was more sincere. “I’m a person that speaks the truth. If there’s something that doesn’t sound good, please forgive me, Brother Lei.”

Her attitude had always been very kind and gentle that the uncomfortable feeling in Lei Daqiang’s heart couldn’t even flare out. He nodded, “Matchmaker Jin’s words are valued upon. If you have anything to say, feel free to.”

Matchmaker Jin said: “Money; it can’t increase on its own. Brother Lei, there are still three unmarried children. You all ask yourself honestly, if the situation in your family continue to go on like this, can you make up the money for the three people to get married? Well, even if you have enough money now, do you all want your sons and grandchildren to continue to suffer in the future? There are also two daughters-in-law who don’t even have a decent hair ornament on their heads. You two don’t want to be better to your wives?”

Lei Xiangli didn’t say a word. He knew that his parents had some money, but it was not enough to hold a wedding ceremony for the three. Moreover,

Old Five needed money to spend on his studies. The main reason why Du Shi was stingy was Old Five.

Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi both nodded their heads slightly.

“The money you have can’t give birth to money, but you have to find a way to make the money grows money.” Matchmaker Jin spoke with sincerity, which easily let people’s guard down. “The girl I want to match with Brother Lei is a dowry maid of a young lady from a rich family. The young lady valued her very much and originally agreed to let the girl go out to get married, but the young lady got pregnant soon after she got married, so the girl stayed with her for three more years. After she was let go with great difficulty, the girl’s father died of illness and she had to observe the mourning for three years[2]. Now, the girl is 26 years old. Because of this, the girl with such older age has yet been match with a man. But this girl is really good. She has learned a lot from following the young lady, including nursing people’s health with meals and particularly adept in managing affairs.”

After a pause, she went on to say: “I don’t think it’s strange to say that if isn’t for the girl’s older age, which is not easy to match, as an outsider, I won’t be willing to match her to Brother Lei.”

Saying such words, she appeared even more sincere.

At this moment, Lei Daqiang’s interest was aroused. Nursing people’s health with meals? Wasn’t that mean he could get healthier and live longer in the future?

Matchmaker Jin had a pair of piercing eyes, how could she not see it? She added *a handful of firewood*[3], “Brother Lei, think about it. This girl has a wide range of knowledge and is good at managing affairs. Once she joins the household, she will surely lead the family to live a prosperous life. Brother Lei is not very old. It will be a great joy if you can have children at old age.”

Lei Xiangren and his two brothers looked at each other while wondering in their hearts. Was Matchmaker Jin’s mouth too eloquent, or were they too

easily incited? At the bottom of their hearts, they felt that the girl was really too good. But after all, this matter concerned their parents. The three brothers dared not express their opinions and secretly looked at Lei Daqiang from time to time.

Everything that needed to be said had been said. Matchmaker Jin stopped talking and drank tea slowly, giving Lei Daqiang time to think.

Lei Daqiang was silent for a long time before he asked, “The betrothal gift?”

Matchmaker Jin said: “Miss Wei is considerate. She said it is fine as long as it is not much worse than the ordinary people’s.” At this time, she mentioned the girl’s surname.

Lei Daqiang tentatively said again: “If I can meet her...”

Matchmaker Jin laughed candidly, “This is easy to do. On a certain day, I’ll call her to the town and you two can meet at a distance.”

“Lei Daqiang, you dare!” Du Shi’s shrieks came from the side room. It turned out that she had been eavesdropping.

In a short while, she rushed out of the side room.

Lei Daqiang had just heard so many good words about Miss Wei. At this time, once he heard Du Shi’s reaction, he thought about Du Shi’s various frivolous quibbling acts and his heart became more inclined to Miss Wei. He berated, “Why are you making a ruckus?”

The authority of the owner of the house had made an appearance; Du Shi did not dare to utter anything for a moment and just looked at him with unbelievable eyes.

Matchmaker Jin stood up, “I’ll go back first. I’ll accompany Miss Wei to sit at the teahouse the morning after tomorrow.”

Lei Daqiang politely sent her until the courtyard’s gate, “Thank you for your trouble, Matchmaker Jin.”

As soon as Matchmaker Jin left, Du Shi finally blew up and yelled as she threw herself at Lei Daqiang. “Lei Daqiang, I’ll fight with you——”

Lei Daqiang’s neck was scratched by her fingernails, leaving a bloodstain. He gritted his teeth in pain as he pushed Du Shi away and covered his neck with anger: “You shrew!”

Bang, Du Shi hit the table and fell to the ground.

“AHH—” Du Shi got up and rushed to Lei Daqiang. The two wrestled with each other.

“FATHER!”

“MOTHER!”

The central hall was in chaos.

.....

Qin Mian sat behind the counter, collecting money while sneakily laughed. Today was the day when Matchmaker Jin went to the old house. As long as he thought of the scene that would appear at this time in the Lei’s house, he felt overjoyed.

All the customers who came to eat looked at him in a funny way.

Seeing that Qin Mian was in a good mood, Zheng Liu came to the counter with a broad smile, “Big boss, eat spicy hot soup tonight?” Because of the busy business, the shop covered his and Wang Shun’s lunch and dinner, but they were usually not the food in the shop. Very rarely, Qin Mian would take the initiative to leave the food in the shop for them.

Note:

[1] Like as in an online post on Weibo, Facebook etc.

[2] In ancient China, when one’s parents died, the children aren’t allowed to do things for example: marrying, participate in imperial examination, going

to war and etc. for three years in the name of filial piety.

[3] Add firewood to the fire, making it bigger – give encouragement

Chapter 051: Give Miss Wei a Like

051 – Give Miss Wei a Like

Qin Mian subconsciously said “alright” and when he returned to his senses, he slapped Zheng Liu on his head, at a loss whether to cry or laugh, “You boy dare to trick your boss.”

Wang Shun also looked at him with eager eyes. Qin Mian thought for a moment before saying: “All right, the shop’s business is good, and the two of you and the barbecue chef are doing well. This way, your boss and I will invite you three to have dinner in the shop on the evening of every particular day with ‘one(1)’. For example: on the first(1) day, the eleventh(11) day and the twenty-first(21) day.”

Wang Shun and Zheng Liu were so happy that they quickly expressed their thanks and flattered Qin Mian. The spicy hot soup, barbecue and hot pot in the shop were so delicious that once they ate it, they wanted second.

Lei Tie coughed lightly as he swept a quick glance.

Wang Shun and Zheng Liu’s backs felt chill. They quickly left and continued to be busy. They were not afraid of the big boss, but the “small boss” struck their hearts with veneration and fear.

Lei Tie poured the spicy hot soup that had just cooked into a bowl and put it on the counter.

Qin Mian took a look and saw spinach, food balls, mutton, mushrooms and potatoes, all of which he loved to eat.

“Don’t be too nice to them.”

“Ah?” Quan Mian bit half a ball and looked at him stupidly.

Lei Tie didn't talk and merely watched him.

Qin Mian smiled. He picked up a bamboo stick, poked a meatball from the bowl and handed it to him while beaming with smiles.

Lei Tie reached for it, turned back, and returned to the pot.

Over there, the barbecue chef yelled, “Barbecue at table 2 is ready!”

A busy and fulfilling day passed just like that.

On the other side in the old house, trouble had just begun.

In the house, Du Shi was desperate and quarreled until Lei Daqiang got a headache and gave her a slap at the end of his patience. Du Shi's left face was red and swollen that she did not dare to go out of the house. She lay down on the bed and cried bitterly.

Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were helpless in the conflict between their parents. On one hand, they pitied their mother. On the other hand, based on Matchmaker Jin's words, they thought it was not a bad thing for Miss Wei to join their household. However, the main point was that Lei Daqiang was their father, the so-called elder that they had to respect. As the younger generation, it was improper for them to intervene in the elder's bedroom affairs. As for Zhao Shi and Qian Shi, they did not even have the right to. Meanwhile, Lei Chuntao was a girl who had yet married, so it was also improper for her to intervene.

In a word, the people in the old house had forgotten about Lei Tie and Qin Mian.

On the day of his appointment with Matchmaker Jin, Lei Daqiang cleaned himself up appropriately and came to the town.

Nearing the appointed teahouse, he didn't enter the door, but went to a stall that sold dishware on the opposite side according to the agreement, pretended to choose dishware and looked up to the other side.

He saw Matchmaker Jin dressed in red and looked across from her. His heart suddenly jolted. Facing Matchmaker Jin was a gentle and graceful girl dressed in blue. She was indeed 26~27 years old. Her look could not be regarded as beautiful, but she possessed a 6/10 of good looks and her eyes were especially lively. When she spoke to Matchmaker Jin, she wore a smile on her face and her smile was very natural and poised. From the movement of her occasionally raising her hand and nodding her head, he could feel a kind of swift strength.

She was a really nice girl. Such a young and beautiful girl could almost be regarded as a good fortune (in love affairs) to him.

Lei Daqiang's heart was burning now.

Matchmaker Jin looked at the sun and then looked at the stall opposite. She confirmed that Lei Daqiang had already appeared and nodded to Wèi Wei.

Wèi Wei followed her eyes and looked at the other side. The man by the stand was really a bit old, but she didn't care. She looked at the man's facial features and was quite surprised. Matchmaker Jin told her that Lei Daqiang must have been very handsome when he was young, she hadn't believed it. However, she had to believe it when she saw him with her own eyes. Her heart was slightly relieved. It was fine to marry an old man, but it would be too misery if the man was intolerably ugly. Fortunately, Lei Daqiang did not let her down.

When she took back her gaze, Matchmaker Jin nodded to Lei Daqiang.

Lei Daqiang left first. He was too excited, his feet floated like stepping on cotton. However, there was some anxiety as he worried that Miss Wei would not like him.

"I can tell that Lei Daqiang's body and bones are still good. I'm afraid that Du Shi bears most of the responsibility for the reason why his body is too thin." When Du Shi was brought up, Matchmaker Jin's face showed disdain. "According to the people in their village, the Lei Family only serves two dishes for each meal and they don't put much oil in it. They also don't have a few chances to eat meat throughout the year. Which village in

our town lacks few poor families? But there's none like them. It's fortunate that I don't say it, or it would be a joke for no reason."

Wèi Wei picked up the teapot, poured a cup of hot tea for her and said with a smile: "I've heard that Granny Jin never talks empty words when acting as a matchmaker. I myself trust Granny Jin wholeheartedly."

Matchmaker Jin was very puzzled, "Based on your qualifications, it's really unlikely to find someone that old, is it worth the trouble?" She had a good impression of Wèi Wei, so she couldn't help but making a few comments.

Wei Wei nonchalantly smiled and didn't mind telling her, "Some people had introduced a few men. Among them, one was a cripple and two wanted a second wife[1]; one has a 6 years old son, the other has an 8 years old son. Children at 6 and 8 years old already remember things and can only remember the good of their birth mothers. It'd be even more difficult for me to cultivate feelings with them after I join the household. If I'm a little careless, I'll be a *person neither inside nor outside*[2]. Is it worth the trouble that I come here? Although Lei Daqiang is a bit older, his children can already acknowledge that they and I just need to be on courteous term. If I help them to make more money, they aren't necessarily unable to be inclined towards me. What's more, from what you said, Du Shi is a failure. As long as I hold Lei Daqiang's heart close and have children with him, even if he can only live for another 20 years, I'll have my own children to rely on in the future. Whether my children are married in or married out, they'll be no worse than his children."

Matchmaker Jin secretly admired her. *She has proven herself to have been serving in a rich family household; turns out, she had already considered so much.*

Since the other person was willing, she certainly would not object.

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"In that case, I won't say much. Today I'll go to Lei's house to inform that you've agreed and discuss the next step."

“Thanks for your trouble, granny.” Wei Wei smiled confidently.

Two days later, Qin Mian received the exact news. The matter of Lei Daqiang and Wei Wei had been settled. Lei Daqiang was not only willing to marry Wei Wei as his equal wife, but also too impatient to wait and set the date on 18th of November.

Qin Mian was beyond excited when he thought that Du Shi would soon have a strong opponent.

At the beginning, he disguised himself to find a matchmaker and asked her to find Lei Daqiang an assertive woman to be his equal wife. The purpose was only to contain Du Shi; he had no other bad intentions. Moreover, he specially told Matchmaker Jin that the woman must have a good heart. Sure enough, Matchmaker Jin had the ability to find Wei Wei.

According to Matchmaker Jin, Wei was indeed a competent person. As long as Du Shi, Lei Xiangren and the others were behaving themselves, Wei Wei might be able to let the people in the old house live a good life.

Besides, it was Wei Wei's own free will. Qin Mian had nothing to feel guilty about, just waiting to watch the drama.

Du Shi completely had no free time to find trouble with him and Lei Tie. Every day, in addition to quarreling with Lei Daqiang, she cursed Wei Wei. It was unknown how rowdy the old house would be in the future.

Without Lei Daqiang and Du Shi taking the initiative, Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi also temporarily stopped thinking about how to get along with Lei Tie.

Qin Mian disguised himself again and paid the other half of the money to Matchmaker Jin.

From beginning to end, apart from Lei Tie and Qin Mian himself, no one knew that Qin Mian was responsible for Lei Daqiang's ability to marry a beautiful young wife.

Two days later, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi came to the shop together, their expressions looked a bit distress.

“Eldest brother.”

The two didn’t call Qin Mian “eldest sister-in-law” in front of outsiders making Qin Mian breathe a sigh of relief, “You two came. It’s almost noon, have you eaten yet?”

“No yet,” Lei Xiangzhi said with a smile, “Fourth brother and I came here to eat.”

Qin Mian also smiled, “Very much welcome. Would you like spicy hot soup or barbecue? If you want to eat hot pot, you have to wait for a while to be seated.”

Lei Xiangli said: “I’ll eat spicy hot soup then.”

Lei Xiangzhi said: “I’ll have the same as fourth brother.”

“Go pick your dishes first and let Lei Tie simmer them.” Qin Mian asked Zheng Liu to move two stools and put them at the counter.

When the two picked out the dishes, Qin Mian said: “If you two have nothing to do, help in the shop in the afternoon. We are having hot pot or barbecue in the evening.”

“Sure,” Lei Xiangli smilingly said, “I’ll listen to you arrangement.”

Lei Xiangzhi pulled at his clothes, “Of course we’ll help; I purposely wore stain-resistant clothes.”

Qin Mian said: “Actually, your eldest brother and I have planned to invite you to have a meal, but you know what’s going on, so I won’t say more. When you go back in the evening, you bring a pot of soup and some dishes for the family to taste.”

Lei Xiangli lightly sighed, “We understand. You and eldest brother can be at ease.”

“Based on your expression, is there something wrong at home?” Qin Mian could guess what they were coming for and pretended not to understand.

At those words, Lei Tie lowered his head while cooking the spicy hot soup and then looked at the innocent and confused expression of the little wife; the corners of his lips rose into an imperceptible radian.

Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Xiangli knew that Qin Mian could represent Lei Tie, in which if they told him, it was equal to talking to Lei Tie. Therefore, they didn’t hold back, “Do you and eldest brother know about father?”

Qin Mian nodded while internally said: not only I know, but it is also my doing.

“I see. This matter... We, the younger generation don’t know how to say...”

Lei Xiangzhi sighed, “Mother makes trouble at home every day and because of the quarrel, fourth brother and I got a headache. So, we might as well come to see you and eldest brother.”

“In my opinion, since this matter has become a foregone conclusion, it’s useless to oppose it any more. Why should mother act thus?”

Qin Mian took an attitude of thinking for Du Shi, “I’m afraid that if she goes on like this, father will feel vexed with her. Fourth brother, fifth brother, you two should persuade her when you have chance. Family harmony is the basis for success in any undertaking.”

Eldest sister-in-law was a good person. Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi looked at each other. They both secretly regretted that the separation was too early. If it weren’t for their mother who was too much – it was too late to say anything now.

“It’s just that I still don’t understand. How can that Miss Wei took a liking to father?” All along, Lei Xiangzhi couldn’t get over this.

Note:

[1] second wife after one’s first wife’s death

[2] a metaphor for doing things that are not pleased, and people are complaining everywhere. [1]

Side's note: The weather is bad, the connection is unstable. I might not be able to upload as frequently as I did before (and I already planned reach 060 this month, but well). Thank your for support and comments!

Chapter 052: Visitor from the County

052 – Visitor from the County

Qin Mian inwardly broke in chills but maintained his composure, “This is a bit beyond our comprehension. Anyway, the Lei Family has no authority and no influence, and there is nothing worth to be plotted against with. Miss Wei used to be a competent maid in a rich family household, maybe she thinks differently from other people.”

“That’s right.” Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi were no longer entangled in this.

This afternoon, both Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi helped in the shop, which greatly relieved the pressure on Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The brothers were surprised to see that many people in the town brought their own bowls to eat spicy hot soup. In fact, many customers had suggested that Qin Mian and Lei Tie should expand their shop or change to a bigger one. However, firstly, they had no opportunity. Secondly, Qin Mian did not have so much energy for the time being and the Lunar New Year was coming soon. Future matters should be put off until later.

In the evening, the four people ate hot pot in the shop and went home together riding in the ox cart. Because today’s food sold out fast, when they returned to the village, the sun had just set.

Qin Mian let Lei Tie drove the ox cart all the way to the gate of the old house. He didn’t deny that he wanted to see Du Shi making a fool of herself.

In the old house, the meal was served on the table.

Qin Mian came in with a basket of food. With a smiling expression on his face, he said loudly: “Father, mother, are you about to have dinner? It seems that we are back just in time. Brother Tie and I have brought you a lot of food. Father and younger brothers can have wine to your heart’s content.”

Lei Tie carried a pot of soup in both hands and went in with him.

Qin Mian motioned to Lei Tie to put the soup on the women’s table and deliberately looked at Du Shi’s face. “Mother, this is the hot pot soup in our shop that cooked with big bones; very savory. I also brought back some meatballs, mutton, streaky pork, chicken meat, and fish fillets. It’s very tasty when cooked in the soup.”

Lei Xiangzhi touched his chin. How did he feel that eldest sister-in-law came back to “*show off his military strength*[1]”? Looking up at his eldest brother’s eyes which contained imperceptible pampering and connivance, he could only shake his head helplessly.

Qin Mian really had a mind to provoke Du Shi, so he was generous enough to bring back a lot of meat dishes, enough for the whole family to eat.

Du Shi’s eyes swept over all kinds of meat dishes one by one, neither happy nor angry. For a long time, she did not utter a word.

Qin Mian felt his anger had vented off.

Lei Xiangren knew that Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi had gone to Lei Tie’s shop. He regretted that he had not gone with them. He quickly walked over and said, “Smells good. Wife, why don’t you quickly go to the charcoal stove and get a clean pot? Third brother’s wife, you go get wine.”

“Ah.” Zhao Shi swallowed her saliva and turned to the kitchen.

Qian Shi followed.

Lei Daqiang coughed softly, “Eldest, have you and your wife eaten? If you two haven’t eaten, have some.”

Lei Tie said dully: “Already ate. Wife, let’s go. ”

“Alright. Mother, father, we’re going back.” Qin Mian waved his hand in a good mood and left with Lei Tie. Sitting on the ox cart, he couldn’t resist humming a song.

“In a good mood?” Lei Tie asked.

“So-so.” Qin Mian continued to be happy and inadvertently said, “When Miss Wei joins the household, how about providing a hot pot to each table on the banquet? Let the villagers see that even when we were forced to separate and live apart, we still ‘care about’ the parents.”

Lei Tie held Qin Mian’s hand and his chest felt warm as he said in a hoarse voice: “Listen to you.”

After several days, Du Shi apparently continued to be silent. Qin Mian then stopped investing effort to think about the old house.

On this day, after preparing all the ingredients in the back kitchen, Qin Mian went to open the shop.

Lei Tie threw a look out of the door neither intentional nor unintentional, wiped the water on his hands, and then walked over neither too fast nor too slow.

Qin Mian looked at the several people who seemed to be waiting outside the door for a long time, and felt suspicious.

There were three people in total. One was a young man of 25~26 years old dressed in a white cotton-padded robe with snow-white fox fur around his neck and a precious white jade hanging on his waist. He seemed like a rich gongzi. He looked at Qin Mian with a pair of narrow phoenix’s eyes, which were full of inquiry.

On his left was a middle-aged man in early 40s dressed in gray and looked like a person who managed affairs [steward].

On the right side of the gongzi was a youngster of 17~18 years old, dressed up as a manservant.

“Little Liuzi, Little Shunzi, greet the customers.” Qin Mian called out from behind.

“Coming.” Zheng Liu quickly ran out, “Welcome, several customers. Do you want to eat hot pot, spicy hot soup or barbecue?”

The young gongzi ignored him, glanced at Lei Tie and looked back at Qin Mian. “Are you the owner of this shop?”

“Exactly,” Qin Mian said with a faint smile, “If gongzi isn’t coming to eat, please give way to the side, don’t block other customers.”

The manservant glared, “Audacious!”

Lei Tie frowned.

Qin Mian harshly said: “You are audacious! Your master hasn’t spoken yet, but you, a servant dare to cut in the conversation. If you’re my manservant, you’ll be slapped on mouth 20 times.”

The manservant’s face changed greatly. He peered at the young gongzi’s face and quickly bowed his head.

Zheng Liu looked at his boss admiringly. The young gongzi had an extraordinary presence and a look could tell that he was very influential socially. However, the boss was not afraid at all.

“Gentlemen, please give way to the side.” Qin Mian urged.

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The young gongzi took an interesting look at Qin Mian and sat down at the nearest table. “We’ll be having hot pot.”

Zheng Liu seized the opportunity to open his mouth, “If you want to eat hot pot, please go into the shop. The table outside is for the customers who eat

spicy hot soup and barbecue.”

The young gongzi said again: “Oh, it’s cooler outside. In that case, we’ll be eating spicy hot soup and barbecue. Chunsheng, you go and order.”

The manservant respectfully responded: “Yes, gongzi.”

After Qin Mian returned to the counter, Lei Tie also returned to the pot.

“They’re mostly here for the soup base’s recipe.” Qin Mian whispered to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie said indifferently: “I’m here.”

The spicy hot soup and barbecue ordered by young gongzi were served. Qin Mian noticed that he and the middle-aged man first picked up a spoon of soup and drank it, tasting it carefully as if to distinguish the taste.

They were not the first to do so.

Qin Mian didn’t worry that they would taste the ingredients of the soup. He used some seasonings that ordinary people didn’t use and there was also Sichuan pepper, which had never been used as seasoning. Besides, the spiritual spring water that he added without anyone knowing had excellent flavor effect.

“How?” The young gongzi asked in light tone.

The middle-aged man whispered: “This subordinate is ashamed; can only taste eight ingredients.”

The young gongzi’s eyes showed an expression of surprise and did not say anything. Only then he picked up his chopsticks and began to taste the food in the spicy hot soup.

“Little Shunzi, it seems that there are many more workers in the town these two days. What’s going on?” Qin Mian glanced at the four customers who were stained with dry mud and asked Wang Shun. Not only Eating Savory

Restaurant had a large flow of customers, but the business of other restaurants and noodle shops in the town was also better than before.

Wang Shun said: "Small boss doesn't know? The water surface of the river decreases in every autumn and winter. So, before it is frozen, the local authority will organize a great number of manpower to dredge up the Six Bends River. Those workers that went to the Six Bends River to dredge it up could earn at least 20 Wen a day. I did it last year." The Six Bends River was the largest river in the county and the small river in the Green Mountain Village was precisely its branch.

"Oh?" Qin Mian quickly asked, "Is the Six Bends River far from here? How long will the dredging work last?"

Wang Shun answered, "Last year, it lasted half a month or so. The Six Bends River is a little far away, it takes at least more than thirty minutes on foot."

"What about their lunch?" Qin Mian asked again.

Wang Shun said: "Most of them bring their own dried food. If they have a cart, they can come to the town to eat."

Qin Mian's eyes twinkled, squeezed to Lei Tie's side and whispered: "The idea of making money has come."

Lei Tie raised his eyebrows. In fact, his work was not heavy. He only needed to put the dishes selected by the customers into the colander, poured them into the bowl after they were cooked, and then added soup, onion and garlic to the bowl.

"This idea is for the old house. Tell Old Three and Old Four when we return home. As for whether they tell others, it's none of our business."

Lei Tie nodded and conveniently stroked Qin Mian's head.

The young gongzi looked up at the two people who were smiling at each other. He had planned to wait until fewer customers were left before talking

to the owner of the shop, but the shop was always full, so he had to get up and walk over.

“Gentlemen, I’m Nie Heng from Zhaoyang County. Do you have time to talk? I’m interested in purchasing the recipe of your soup.”

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian.

Nie Heng also looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian cupped one hand in the other towards Nie Heng and said: “It’s our honor to be highly thought by Nie gongzi. Since Nie gonzi is so frank and honest, I’ll say it straight. We have no plans to sell the formula until May next year. Nie gongzi looks like a smart man, so you must also understand that the spicy hot soup and hot pot is sold depend on the weather.” His and Lei Tie’s influence were weak; they never thought of monopolizing the market forever.

Nie Heng’s furrowed brows relaxed, “In other words, after next May, Boss Qin and Boss Lei will sell the recipe.”

Qin Mian’s pupils shrunk. The man had investigated him and Lei Tie.

“We’ve this intention, but there is no specific plan yet,” said Qin Mian.

After much weighing and considering, Nie Heng said: “In this case, I hope that the two bosses can give priority to me at that time.”

Qin Mian said with a faint smile: “If Nie gongzi set your mind on it, see you in May next year.”

Nie Heng took a deep look at him and determined that the teenager was not a simple person. Well, the man standing by the side of the teenager in a protective posture was certainly more than not a simple person.

“With pleasure!” Nie Heng kindly reminded, “There is more than one person who has the same idea as me. They may not be as magnanimous as me. If the recipe really falls into the hands of others, I think I would be very sad.”

Lei Tie stood toweringly as he said with voice steady but cold, and words powerful and resonating like a sudden clap of thunder, “Go ahead and try it.”

Nie Heng nodded slightly. After signaling the manservant to pay, he took the manservant and the middle-aged man to leave.

Note:

[1] to show off one’s military strength (idiom); to strut around; to flaunt; to boast

Chapter 053: Warning

053 – Warning

When the ox cart drove into the village, Qin Mian took the rope from Lei Tie's hand and said to him: "Go invite third and fourth brothers to come home together. I'll tell them in detail."

Lei Tie nodded, lifted his long legs, and jumped easily from the still moving ox cart.

Several villagers followed him with curious eyes. The news about Lei Tie knew kung fu had been spread widely. Such a person made them felt both respect and fear.

Every day when he got home, the first thing Qin Mian did was to boil water for washing. When the firewood in the hollow of the stove just burned up, Lei Tie came back.

"Third and the fourth brothers also went to dredge up the river. They are having dinner, so they will come soon." Lei Tie took the firewood from Qin Mian's hands and sat down in front of the kitchen stove.

The weather was becoming chilly and everything was ice-cold. Qin Mian happily allowed him to help and put his hands back into his pockets.

"Did second brother go?"

"No."

He knew it would be like that. Qin Mian disdained this person, Lei Xiangren.

“You didn’t say anything to the third and fourth brothers, did you?”

Lei Tie said: “Just said there is something important to look for them.”

“That’s good.” Qin Mian turned to open the cupboard and took out the tangerine peel, cinnamon and other things to be ground later, weighed them one by one and put them aside. These ingredients should be ground before going to bed, to be used for the next day.

The two did their own things respectively. Although there was no conversation, the atmosphere in the kitchen was quiet and warm.

“Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law, we came.”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli walked in one after another, both were shrinking their necks and hands in their sleeves.

“This damn weather is getting colder.”

“You two came.” Qin Mian was blunt with them, “The water hasn’t boiled yet, so I won’t serve you tea. Go sit in the living room.”

Lei Xiangyi sat down on the soft settee, felt it quietly before he sat upright and asked curiously, “Eldest brother said you are looking for us for something. What is it?”

Qin Mian sat on the settee. “I heard your eldest brother say that you’ve been to the Six Bends River to dredge it up these two days? Are there many people going there?”

Lei Xiangyi said: “Today is the third day. There are a lot of people. Eldest sister-in-law probably doesn’t know. The Six Bends River is wide and long, so the local authority hired many people to dredge up the river every year.”

“It must have been hard work.” Qin Mian asked again, “How are so many people’s lunches solved?”

“Basically, they bring their own dried food. The section of the river we are in charge of is a little far away from the town; the upstream is very close to

the county town, but most people still bring their own dried food.” Lei Xiangli vaguely guessed something, “Why does eldest sister-in-law ask so?”

Qin Mian gave a wee of smile, “I suddenly thought of an idea to make money while in the town today and wanted tell you two about it. If you two are willing to do it, you can earn more than dredging up the river and it will be easier than that.”

Lei Xiangli’s eyes lit up and immediately said, “Of course willing. What’s the idea?”

Lei Xiangyi also looked happy, “It’s arduous standing barefoot in the water. Of course it’s good to have a more effortless work.”

Qin Mian didn’t beat around the bush. “My idea is that you can cook some hot soup and sell it at Six Bends River. Those workers stay in the water for so long every day and can only eat dried food at noon. There is nothing more comfortable than drinking hot soup. You can borrow a cart, just bring a pot and firewood, and then buy some bones, radishes or potatoes in the town and stew them in the large pot. If you want to be generous, you can add some minced meat. Even if a bowl of soup is sold for only a Wen, you can earn a lot of profit in a day.”

“That’s a good idea.” Lei Xiangyi clapped his hands as he applauded and wished that it was dawn now, so he could drive the cart to the town right away. “Bones are cheap, won’t be worth more than a few Wen. At most, it costs for some firewood, so the cost of making this soup isn’t high. It’s profitable.”

Lei Xiangli couldn’t help but be overjoyed. “There are at least 400~500 people dredging up the river, even if only 100 people are willing to spend money, we can still earn 100 Wen. We still have 60~70 Wen left after removing the cost, right?”

Between the two of them, one wanted to save private money to provide for his wife and daughter, and the other wanted to save money for his marriage. Qin Mian’s idea was nothing more than a timely help.

Qin Mian said with a faint smile, "I told you two the idea. As for whether to tell others or not, it's up to you two."

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were very clear that he (QM) was disgusted with certain people in the old house, so they did not take offense.

Lei Tie came out of the kitchen and sat down beside Qin Mian, "One cart is not enough, borrowed another one. Go together with us every day, the ox cart can be lent to you. Just send it back before the shop closes."

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"Many thanks, eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law." Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangyi said thanks in unison.

Lei Xiangli hesitated for a moment and looked at Qin Mian, "Now there is no one selling soup by the river, but I think that once we go, it'll be hard to ensure others not to follow suit. By then, the soup will not sell unless it is better in taste. I know that there is a secret recipe for eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law's soup. Is it possible for eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law to sell some of the prepared soup ingredients for us to add to our soup?"

Qin Mian was a little surprised that Lei Xiangli could think of such a far away. He got a bit of a businessman's mind.

Lei Xiangyi also looked at Qin Mian with hope.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie said with hesitation, "You call the shots."

Qin Mian gave him a satisfied smile.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli looked away from them in embarrassment.

After Qin Mian thought about it, he nodded, "Sure. But the seasonings are not easy to prepare. I can only sell you a small jar every day. You can pay me the cost price, which is 10 Wen." Friendship was friendship; interest

was interest. Assuming an attitude of brothers settling accounts today could avoid future disputes between the two families over money. He and Lei Tie had a good relationship with Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli, so he didn't want to appear petty because of interests issue in the future.

Although he offered to pay, Lei Xiangli didn't expect Qin Mian to accept the money without even saying evasive pleasantries[1], he felt a little uncomfortable in his heart. On second thought, the two families had been separated, thus they had better be clear when dealing with money so as to avoid future conflicts and broke the bond between the brothers. Besides, the idea of making money came from Qin Mian. Thinking such, he felt relieved.

The two brothers were anxious to go back to discuss the details. They once again expressed their thanks to Qin Mian and Lei Tei, and made arrangement to go out together the next morning.

After dawn, Qin Mian was not in the slightest surprised to see that Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli appeared together with Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli's smiling expression looked a little reluctant. It was impossible for them to hide such a big move from the others and they had to get money from Du Shi to buy firewood and ingredients. Therefore, all the people in the old house knew that they are going to sell soup at the Six Bends River. Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi –husband and wife– were fond of eating, averse to work and liked to take advantage of others. Both Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli didn't want them to go together. However, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi gave them a tough attitude; they couldn't do anything about it.

Qian Shi's expression looked even worse. She could see that between Lei Xiangren, her husband, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi, eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law preferred her husband, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi. The elder sister-in-law's idea was obviously to help her husband and fourth brother. Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi's participation made her angry. At this time, the idea of separation in her mind was becoming stronger. If they were

separated at this time, the money earned would only be shared between Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli.

It was unknown what Zhao Shi was thinking as she secretly glared at Qian Shi and Lei Xiangyi from time to time.

Qin Mian turned a blind eye to their secret thoughts and handed Lei Xiangli the small pottery jar that had been prepared for a long time. There was no spiritual spring water in the seasoning jar, only ten kinds of seasoning, but it was good enough.

Qin Mian jumped onto the ox cart.

Zhao Shi wanted to sit with him in the same cart to worm her way into being friends and then secretly see what's in the big jar on the cart.

But Qin Mian had been on guard. As soon as he sat, he let Lei Tie drive away.

Zhao Shi cursed secretly. She could only give up and return to the borrowed donkey cart. There were pot, stove, two baskets of bowls and chopsticks, oil, salt, sauce, vinegar, and other items on the cart.

The two carts left the village in the morning light.

Qin Mian took out two hot bamboo tubes from his portable bag and handed one to Lei Tie, "For you."

"Use it to warm your hands first," said Lei Tie.

"I'm not cold; I put on a lot today." Qin Mian twisted off the lid of the bamboo tube and handed it to him. He got up early today and cooked a small pot of batter soup on a charcoal stove. When the water boiled, he poured in flour and stirred with chopsticks. The mixture was brought to boil before adding minced meat and tender leaves of green vegetables. Then, the mixture was brought to boil again to pour the eggs and lastly added oil, salt and a bit of hot pot seasoning. The method was simple, but the taste was

delicious. As soon as he took a sip, he tasted the rich flavor and his stomach also warmed.

The two men held the same bamboo tubes as they drank the soup. When they got to the town, they could eat three or four steamed stuffed buns and that would be enough.

Lei Xiangren and the others in the back saw it and also smelled the delicious aroma. They felt incessantly envious.

Perhaps, it was not bad for eldest brother to marry this male sister-in-law. Lei Xiangli was deeply moved in his heart and inexplicably thought that his future wife would also treat him well. His face then turned hot and he let out a dry cough to shake off the charming thoughts.

“Fourth brother, what’s the matter?” Lei Xiangren glanced at him and asked casually.

“It’s nothing.” Lei Xiangli perfunctorily answered.

Lei Xiangren wormed his way into being friends with Lei Tie, “Eldest brother, how’s your business recently?”

Lei Tie dully responded: “Satisfactory.”

Lei Xiangren said with a smile: “Eldest brother, why be modest? I heard that in your shop are full of customers every day. You can earn at least 2~3 silver taels a day, right?”

Qin Mian grinned: “What can our small shop considered as? I heard that Tasty and Satisfactory Vegetarian Restaurant in the town is making a fortune every day. It’s a pity ah, no matter how much others earn, it’s theirs. Bystanders can only envy them.”

Lei Xiangren recognized the implication of his words. He choked and glared at the back of Qin Mian’s head. Despite that, Qin Mian was right, thus he could only laugh dryly.

Lei Xiangyi helped to resolve a dispute, “Second brother, when we arrive in the town, we take separate action. You go to buy firewood, fourth brother and I go to buy ingredients.” Firewood was cheap, so it was not cost-effective to drag firewood all the way from home to the town and then from the town to the river. Therefore, they planned to buy it directly in the town.

Note:

[1] General meaning is that QM didn’t even bother to be evasive about it (it’s a kind of cultural things like the ritual refusals) [too lazy to explain much]

Chapter 054: Will Die if You Don't Take Advantage of Others

054 – Will Die if You Don't Take Advantage of Others

“Sure.” Lei Xiangren said, “After buying all the things, we’ll meet at the entrance of the town.”

In the cart behind, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi whispered to one another.

“Third brother’s wife,” Zhao Shi touched Qian Shi’s arm and whispered, “Eldest sister-in-law gave us a good idea this time. I dare say that we can earn a lot of money by selling soup. But it’s a pity that we have to give it all to mother.”

Recalling the scene in the early morning when Du Shi counted the money for buying firewood and ingredients one by one before handed it over Lei Xiangren’s hand, Qian Shi felt uncomfortable. She knew that Zhao Shi wanted to stir her up about separating from the family, but she strayed from her (ZS) plan and only uttered “en” without saying anything.

Seeing that she was not fooled, Zhao Shi had no choice but to say, “It would be great if we could also separate from the family.”

Qian Shi asked deliberately, “Who do you mean by us?”

Zhao Shi dodged the question. In fact, she was also contradictory; she wanted to separate but also did not want to. If separated, she could control the money at home, but then she was unwilling at the thought of separation that meant she also had to separate from Lei Xiangzhi. Lei Xiangzhi’s future was limitless. She was reluctant to give up this big tree. It could not

have been better if Old Three and Old Four separated from the main family and Du Shi gave her the right to take charge of the family. That old woman was too abnormal to have still controlled her sons at that old age. When Miss Wei joined the household, she wanted to see if she (DS) could still be rampant...

The more Zhao Shi thought about it, the farther it went and her eyes turned vacant.

Qian Shi coldly glared at her and leaned on her knees to take a nap for a while.

When they arrived at the town, the sun had just come out and the shadows grew long under the sunshine.

The ox cart stopped in front of the shop. Lei Tie moved the newly bought vegetables and allowed Lei Xiangli to drive the cart away.

Chen Si, the barbecue chef, came early and squatted at the side as he ate breakfast – two steamed buns.

“Good morning, big boss, small boss.”

Qin Mian nodded to him, “Good morning.”

“Don’t worry, eldest brother. I’ll buy some fodder by the way. I won’t let the ox starve.” Lei Xiangli said.

“It’s the first time we’ve come to eldest sister-in-law’s shop.” Zhao Shi hinted at Qin Mian while her eyes floated on the closed shop’s door.

“Yeah.” Lei Xiangren chimed in and said with a flattering smile, “Eldest brother, you shop—”

Lei Tie steadfastly stood on his ground as he indifferently said, “It’s late.”

Lei Xiangren and the others had to drive the carts to leave.

“That husband and wife really suited each other.” Qin Mian took out the key to open the door as he shook his head.

“Don’t have to mind them.” Lei Tie didn’t care about them very much. If other people had a bad thought, he could deal with them.

“Are you two the owners of the shop?”

An old voice sounded uncertainly from behind them.

Qin Mian looked back and saw an old man over 60 year old standing not far away with a bent waist and looked a little uneasy.

“That’s right,” Qin Mian said suspiciously, “Uncle, what can I do for you?”

The old man rubbed his hands and said, “I’m Zheng Liu’s father. Little Liu was beaten last night. He asked me to tell you that someone forced him to say something about recipe...”

Chen Si stopped chewing and inwardly considered himself lucky that he lived near, so there was nothing happened to him last night.

Qin Mian’s expression changed greatly as he looked at Lei Tie.

The light Lei Tie’s eyes were cold.

Without waiting for him to open his mouth, a young man that looked simple and honest came from the distance.

“Boss Lei, boss Qin, you two are here, my younger brother has been—”

“Beaten?” Qin Mian took over the other’s word.

The man was stunned and nodded, “Yes, he didn’t return home when it was very late. I came out to find him and discovered him lying on the roadside, injured. He’s still unconscious.”

Qin Mian’s face sank. He was furious, but he did not lose his cool. He took out his money pouch and fished out four silver ingots to give two for each

person.

“Uncle Zheng, Brother Wang, this matter started because of us. We’re truly sorry. Take the money and bring Zheng Liu and Wang Shun to see a physician. By the way, I’d like to ask you to bring them a message from me, that is, let them heal their wounds at ease and come back to work when they are well. We’ll solve this matter.”

“This...”

It really costed a lot of money to see a physician. Zheng Liu’s father and Wang Shun’s older brother hesitated before taking the money.

Wang Shun’s older brother said: “It is Shunzi’s blessing to meet bosses like you two. You two bosses can rest assured, I’ll bring the message. Many thanks.”

Knowing that Zheng Liu’s father and Wang Shun’s older brother had walked away, Qin Mian was so angry that he kicked the vegetable basket. “Fuck! Outrageous!”

Lei Tie held him. “It’s you who hurt. I’ll solve this. Open the door first.”

Qin Mian opened the door and sat down on the stool. “How are you going to solve it?”

“Rest assured.” Lei Tie said, “I’m going out for a bit.”

“Well, be careful.” Qin Mian hadn’t perfected his kung fu yet. Even if he went out with Lei Tie, he couldn’t help much. He could only charge him with the task.

Lei Tie looked around, “The shops nearby are open, people come and go, you don’t have to be afraid.”

“What am I afraid of?” Qin Mian was amused, “Go quickly, you must give them a lesson.”

Lei Tie nodded and left in a hurry.

Qin Mian took a look at Chen Si, who had never said a word, “Chen Si, are you afraid?”

Chen Si returned to his senses and laughed. He swallowed up the steamed bun in his hand and moved the vegetable basket into the shop. “Small boss, I’m not actually. Our surname Chen is also a big name in the town. What am I afraid of? But now, those people should know that only you and big boss have the seasoning recipe in our shop.” The ‘small boss’ hat fastened on Qin Mian’s head could not be taken off anymore.

His statement was logical, so Qin Mian nodded, “In case someone comes to you in the future, you can go ahead push it onto mine and big boss’s head.” Since the opening of the shop, he and Lei Tie handled the seasonings of the hot pot, spicy hot soup and barbecue in person. The three staffs in the shop – Zheng Liu, Wang Shun and Chen Si – did not know the recipe.

“Don’t worry, small boss.” Chen Si said, “However, since Little Liu and Shunzi can’t come, I’m afraid we don’t have enough manpower today.”

Qin Mian had made arrangement, “When the grocery store opens, I’ll ask Boss Zou to borrow his shop assistant for a bit.”

Boss Zou was the owner of the grocery store next door.

Chen Si curled his lips, “Boss Zou should be willing, but he’ll definitely make you write out a salary.”

“There’s no other way.” Qin Mian was helpless. “Little Liuzi and Little Shunzi must have been hurt badly. They have to rest for at least a month and a half. When your big boss comes back, I’ll go to the brokerage and hire a temporary worker.”

No longer chatting, Chen Si skillfully trimmed and washed the vegetables. Meanwhile, after Qin Mian stewed the big bone soup, he began to chop the meat.

About two hours later, Lei Tie came back.

Qin Mian looked him up and down. His expression was ordinary and his clothes were neat, as if he had just gone for a walk.

“How about it?”

“It’s solved.”

Qin Mian doubted, “All solved?”

Chen Si looked over curiously.

Lei Tie nodded.

“How did you solve it?” Qin Mian questioned closely.

Lei Tie didn’t speak; he sat down and pinched the meatball, “You chop the meat.”

“How actually did you solve it?” Qin Mian’s heart seemed to have a cat’s paw scratching on it. He was very curious.

Lei Tie still didn’t speak.

Qin Mian stared at him discontentedly. Since the man didn’t want to say it, he also didn’t want to waste his saliva. He turned to wash his hands, “I’m going to the brokerage to hire a temporary worker and a long-term worker.”

Chen Si was puzzled, “Small boss, didn’t you just say you only hire a temporary worker?”

“Look at the pitiful state of your big boss; both hands are smoked white. I’ll hire someone to cook the spicy hot soup.” Qin Mian teased.

Chen Si admiringly said: “Big boss and small boss have a good relationship, just like blood brothers.”

Qin Mian stiffened.

Lei Tie glanced at Chen Si coldly.

Chen Si shuddered. What did he say wrong?

Lei Tie opened his mouth, “He’s my—”

“Lei Tie!” Qin Mian *whooshed* over and covered the man’s mouth. It was the first time he found that his speed was so fast, almost comparable to qinggong[1].

Lei Tie raised his hand and touched Qin Mian’s face. He didn’t say anything more and continued to pinch the meatball.

Only then Qin Mian let him go. He gave the man a warning look and went out with his hands clasped behind his back, head held high and chest out.

Chen Si glanced at the minced meat on Qin Mian’s face and turned his head to snicker.

The new staff, Shi Tou was very simple and honest person. He was a bit slow in reaction, but he was diligent, energetic and didn’t talk much. His joining made this day’s business not affected by the absence of Zheng Liu and Wang Shun.

Lei Tie didn’t have to cook spicy hot soup anymore. Thus, when there were few customers, he sat at the counter with Qin Mian and helped to carry the dishes or collected money when there were many customers.

When there were few customers, Qin Mian went to the pastry shop diagonally opposite and bought two kinds of pastry, which were divided into two parts.

When the sun was in the west, Lei Xiangren and several others drove in carts appeared with a happy expression.

“Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law, we are back.” Lei Xiangren yelled from afar.

Qin Mian really wanted to strangle him. His dagger eyes flew over with a *whoosh*.

Fortunately, the customers in the shop didn't realize that "eldest sister-in-law" was meant for him.

Lei Xiangli smacked Lei Xiangren and warned him, "Don't call eldest sister-in-law in front of outsiders."

Lei Xiangren suddenly realized, "Oh, I understand."

He parked the donkey cart on the side of the road, cheerfully walked into the shop, and approached the counter with a mysterious look, "Eldest brother, how much do you think we made today?"

Lei Tie dismally took up a brush to write. He was not interested in guessing.

Qin Mian casually asked, "How much?"

Lei Xiangren laughed, "203."

Lei Xiangyi grinned from ear to ear as he said: "We've calculated. We made a net profit of 160 Wen after subtracting the cost of firewood and ingredients."

"Not bad, not bad. Congratulations." Qin Mian cupped his hands as he congratulated.

Zhao Shi looked greedily at the hot pot that others were eating, "We've been busy for most of the day, nearly starved to death. Husband, let's have something to eat in eldest brother's shop."

"Yeah." Lei Xiangren smilingly said, "The food in eldest brother's shop is delicious."

Qin Mian also smiled, "You can choose whatever you want to eat. Vegetarian dishes cost a Wen, meat dishes 2 Wen. Hot pot is more expensive and you have to wait a little longer. I'll give you a 20% discount on your first visit."

Lei Xiangren looked at him in astonish, "We're all your own brothers..." He deliberately didn't finish.

Qin Mian smiled more brilliantly as he got closer, “You all go pick the dishes first.”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli felt embarrassed.

Lei Xiangyi looked at Lei Xiangren with disapproval, “What are you talking about, second brother?”

“I’m not wrong. Eldest sister-in-law is too scrupulous.” Lei Xiangren reproached Qin Mian with dissatisfaction.

Qin Mian sneered. He had seen the meaning of “burnt the bridge after crossing it”. However, he said nothing more and counted money with a happy smile. The coppers fell into the money box and the clanking sound was very pleasant to hear. He was not anxious, not at all.

Qian Shi suddenly realized, got close to Lei Xiangyi and whispered: “Husband, we’ve to pay and tomorrow we still have to buy the seasoning.”

She deliberately let Lei Xiangren hear her.

Lei Xiangren paused, lightly hummed and said with a forced smile: “Yeah, blood brothers clearly have to settle accounts.”

He glanced at Qin Mian obliquely and walked to the wooden shelf to pick up dishes.

Do you have an illness that you need to be smug whenever something good happen? Qin Mian wanted to step on his (LXR) face.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli looked at each other with a sigh and went to pick dishes.

Qin Mian hooked his finger towards Lei Tie, signaling him to get closer.

Lei Tie walked a few steps to him.

Qin Mian pressed his shoulder and said in a low voice: “Fortunately, you ran away from home when you were 12 years old. Otherwise, if you grow

up to be as thick-skinned as he is, I'll have to step on your face to make it thin."

Lei Tie lightly blurted out an "ah" and helplessly shook head.

"Just four meatballs cost 2 Wen?" Zhao Shi picked dishes while grimacing and spittle flew over, "2 Wen can buy a large piece of meat. The vegetable dishes are also expensive; five leaves cost a wen."

Note:

[1] Lit. light-foot skill; a technique in Chinese martial arts that is visually reminiscent of parkour, despite having different training methods. (wiki)

Side's note: Hello! Hahaha.... How is the first version of this chapter? Do you like it? It's my own writing (shame I didn't get to finish it). Later, if you encounter a strange story like that, don't panic. I'll get the correct one in a few hours.

Chapter 055: The First Festival after Being Together

055 – The First Festival after Being Together

“It’s a little expensive.” Lei Xiangren wore a look of agreement, “A few thin pieces of streaky pork are also 2 Wen.”

Chen Si, who stood a few steps away outside to serve the hot pot guests, looked disdainfully at the two, speechless. *Where are these people from? Don’t eat if it’s too expensive. Moreover, the meatballs on each skewer are the same size. Is it necessary to pick and choose?*

Without looking up, Qin Mian said slowly: “Out to the right are people selling steamed stuffed buns and continue ahead are people selling noodles and sesame seed pancakes.”

Zhao Shi stooped talking.

Lei Xiangli blushed in embarrassment for his second brother and second sister-in-law. He said in a loud voice: “Another customer is coming. Hurry up, choose well and cook them first.”

Zhao Shi and Lei Xiangren did not talk anymore and sped up their selection of dishes.

Qian Shi had already chosen the dishes she wanted without a word. Anyway, all the money they made today would be given to Du Shi. Right now, she would be a fool if she did not eat.

Seeing that her husband only picked vegetable dishes, she cut a look at him and helped him to pick again. She picked more meat dishes for him.

Lei Xiangyi smiled gently.

Qian Shi's face turned red.

Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi took a look at the small baskets in their hands. Not to be outdone, they picked all meat dishes.

Once they checked out, the total was 62 Wen. It was 50 Wen after 20% discount. Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi were so distressed that they frowned. On the second thought when they recalled that this money came from Du Shi, the load in their heart unloaded.

After eating, the few people drove the cart home.

Out of town, in the quiet road, only the bell on donkey's neck jingled.

Lei Xiangren lightly shouted out "ah", which attracted the attention of Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli.

"Second brother, what's it?" Lei Xiangyi asked.

Lei Xiangren pondered: "Old Three, Old Four, I've an idea. You two listen and think about it."

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi both looked over.

"Say what you want to say, second brother." Lei Xiangyi said in annoyance.

Lei Xiangren said: "Today, we've made a net profit of 160 Wen. After taking out 50 for the meal, there is still 110 Wen left. I think, us three brothers can split 20 Wen each and give the rest to mother. What do you two think? You see, I've two children. I don't even usually have money to buy them snacks."

Lei Xiangyi sneered: "Who believe you? I don't believe you give all the money you earned previously doing manual work to mother."

Lei Xiangren glared, "If you're keen on saying that, you must be the same. Otherwise, how do you know I did it?"

Lei Xiangyi did not speak.

Lei Xiangli was secretly depressed. Could he be the only one honest enough to give his mother all the money he earned?

Lei Xiangren toned down his tone, “Who hasn’t been selfish? Aren’t you often saying that you don’t have money to buy snacks for Xinxin? As for Old Four, it’s time to get married. You need to save more money, right? When the new wife joins the household but you’ve no money to even buy a flower for her, you’ll lose face.”

Lei Xiangli’s face felt hot, he busily said: “If you want talk about things, just talk about things. Don’t talk nonsense.”

“Oh, fourth brother is still shy.” Zhao Shi laughed out loud.

Lei Xiangyi and Qian Shi exchanged a meaningful look.

“I’ve no objection,” Lei Xiangyi said with a bitter smile. “You know that mother doesn’t like our Xinxin. Up to now, we can count the number of times she eats snacks on one hand, in exception of festivals.”

After he and Lei Xiangren reached the same opinion, both looked at Lei Xiangli.

Although Lei Xiangli felt that it was not good to cheat Du Shi, he did not object to it, “Quit it... No objection.”

The few people tacitly smiled and each immediately took 20 Wen to keep. Then, they talked about other topics leisurely.

After work ended in the evening, Qin Mian gave 5 Wen to Chen Si, asking him to send snacks to Zheng Liu and Wang Shun, as to express sympathy and solicitude for them on behalf of him and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian reserved some dishes and rice for him and Lei Tie, which he used to cook fried rice on the still burning stove to fill their stomach. Only then did they drive the cart home.

At this moment, the sky was pitch-black with the nearly full moon hung in the sky. The moonlight was light and soft, and the white clouds floated quietly around, making the curtain of night even darker.

Qin Mian looked back and said, “Is it my imagination? Why do I always think there’s someone behind us?”

Not to mention, he and Lei Tie were on the mountain road. The mountains on both sides were very quiet, which was really a little horrifying.

“There are people.” Lei Tie calmly spoke.

Qin Mian was taken aback, “Who? The people who want to covet the recipe?”

“Don’t worry.” Lei Tie pressed down his (QM) hand and gently pulled the reins. The ox stopped.

The sound of ox’s hooves and the rolling of wheels disappeared. The night sky became more silent. A gust of wind blew and Qin Mian could not help but shiver.

Lei Tie motioned him to sit still in the cart. Then he jumped out of the cart silently, walked to the middle of the road, and calmly looked behind the cart.

Qin Mian inexplicably thought of the scene where the martial arts masters were about to face each other in the martial arts genre novels.

Since Lei Tie looked very calm, he was not nervous anymore. He turned around in the cart and looked at the distance curiously.

Four big stout men with sturdy rods in their hands approached quickly.

Seeing a dark figure standing in the middle of the road, they did not run away. They looked at each other and vaguely felt that something was wrong. After a moment’s hesitation, they still held up their rods while quickly approached and came to a stop two *zhang*[1] away [6.6 meter].

“Lei Tie, Qin Mian; you two must know why we came here. If you are wise, give up the soup recipe!” One of them threatened with a rod.

Lei Tie’s figure flashed. Qin Mian heard a scream before he could see any movement. When he looked carefully, the man who had just spoken was kneeling on the ground with his hands and arms stretched out behind his back in a strange shape. He was continuously shaking and his face’s muscles distorted into an ugly look. The stick in his hand had gone somewhere.

The remaining three were so shocked that they did not dare to step forward. Even Qin Mian, who had drunk the spiritual spring water, could not see Lei Tie’s movement, so the three were even less likely to see it because they were more frightened by the unknown.

With a sly smile, Qin Mian raised his voice as he said: “Lei Tie, I didn’t see it. When dealing with the next one, slow down so I could learn.”

The three men shivered at the same time.

“Alright.” Lei Tie’s right foot only briefly touched on the ground before he flashed out and stood behind the second man. His right hand right hand made three quick strokes in a certain position on the man’s arms.

The second person reacted the same as the first. He cried out in pain and fell to the ground. No matter how hard he tried, he could not stand up. He looked at Lei Tie with fear, his voice trembled, “You-you... What have you done to me?”

Lei Tie said: “This is just a small lesson. You can’t move for three days from today. Go back and tell your boss, if he dares to be presumptuous again, I’ll make him soft as dough, unable to take care of himself for a lifetime. If he doesn’t believe it, he can try at any time.” He spoke slowly and in a flat tone, but that was what made him more intimidating.

However, Qin Mian burst out laughing. *Has this guy been smoked[2] by the smell of smoke in the restaurant for a long time? He can even think of “dough” as an analogy.*

The remaining two people no longer had the courage to fight. They carried the injured two people and flee in disorder.

“Let’s go.” Qin Mian called Lei Tie to get on the cart, “It’s so cold.”

Lei Tie got on the cart and they continued to hurry on their way. “Hire another accountant instead of going to the shop every day.” He had long found that his wife was afraid of the cold. When they slept at night, he (QM) persistently drilled into his arms.

Qin Mian hesitated. It was not that he was reluctant to spend money on people from the ancient times. “Hire an accountant... What if he covets the money?”

“Slavery deed and death deed.” Lei Tie said indifferently.

Qin Mian was stunned. The slavery deed was one of the characteristic products of feudal society. It was a little hard for him, who came from modern times, to accept the concept. But after he hesitated for a moment, he accepted it. There was a so-called “when in Rome, do as the Romans do”. It would be too pretentious to live in such a society but still needed to put up with human rights.

“It’s good idea to buy an accountant. Later, we can go to the shop when we want to and stay at home in winter when we don’t want to.”

They went to the brokerage and bought a man named Yue Dong. He was twenty years old who could write and calculate. It costed 15 silver taels to buy Yue Dong. After the goods delivered and the bill settled, Yue Dong’s slavery deed also went in Qin Mian’s hands.

The shop was too small to live in. Qin Mian did not want outsiders to live at home, so he reserved a bunk for Yue Dong in the communal bed of the inn. Although it was not convenient now, everything would be rearranged after the New Year.

The staffs in the restaurant had a clearer division of labor. Before the shop opened, Zheng Liu, Shi Tou and Wang Shun were responsible for washing

and skewing dishes; Yue Dong and Chen Si were responsible for stewing and chopping meat to make meatballs. After the meatballs were ready, they also helped to wash and skewer dishes. After the shop opened, Chen Si was responsible for barbecue, Shi Tou was responsible for spicy hot soup, and Zheng Liu and Wang Shun were responsible for welcoming customers and serving dishes. Yue Dong was only responsible for collecting money.

After observing Yue Dong for several days, Qin Mian found that he was calm and careful. He simply gave Yue Dong the key to the shop and asked him to hold concurrent posts as a manager and be in charge of stocking up.

Yue Dong did not expect that the two bosses would value him so much before long. Since then, he had been more serious and responsible.

After the shop was handed over, Qin Mian and Lei Tie only needed to send enough seasonings to the shop every few days and occasionally visit the shop to check the account books.

When he did not go to the shop, Qin Mian stayed at home and wrote a plan to make a fortune in the coming year. Meanwhile, Lei Tie went to the mountain every two days and each time, he brought great harvest.

Qin Mian discovered that Lei Tie liked this current life better than going to work in the shop all the time.

These few days, the prey he caught was more than enough for them to celebrate the New Year. A portion of it was sent to the shop, and the rest were salted and hung on the beam to dry.

“Don’t go up the mountain today. It’s the winter solstice.” Qin Mian watched Lei Tie wash the ingredients for breakfast, with a smile on his face. He did not know when it started, but every time he cooked, the man would take the initiative to wash rice, trim and wash vegetables, and even cut the vegetables. All Qin Mian had to do was the last process.

“Winter solstice.” Lei Tie thought that it was no wonder he smelled all kinds of aroma in the village early in the morning.

The ancients believed that on winter solstice, the light force of heaven and earth began to develop and become stronger, which represented the beginning of the next cycle. It was a very auspicious day.

Therefore, the winter solstice was a very important traditional festival. On this day, people would make some delicious food to celebrate and at the same time, it also signified that the future would be better. The miserly and the poor also had to cook something delicious. Otherwise it would be considered unlucky.

Note:

[1] 1 zhang = 10 Chinese feet = 3.3 m.

[2] It has the same meaning as to educate.

Chapter 056: Deliver Dumplings

056 – Deliver Dumplings

“We’ll eat anything in the morning and make dumplings at noon.” Qin Mian was in high spirits. Today was the first time he was going to eat dumplings since he transmigrated.

“Dumplings?” Lei Tie looked at him inquisitively.

Qin Mian was astonished. Could there be no such delicacy as dumplings in this time and space?

“You’ll find out later.”

“Alright.” Lei Tie nodded and gave up the idea of going up the mountain. Winter Solstice was the first festival after he and his wife got together, so it should be celebrated properly.

Qin Mian made a pot of stewed noodles with the ingredients Lei Tie had dealt with. After breakfast, he asked Lei Tie to knead dough, while he prepared the dumpling stuffing. He remembered that his grandmother used to wrap the dumplings with deep-fried pork dough sticks and blindweed stuffing. The blindweed were fresh and tender and the pork was savory. When mixed together, the taste was excellent.

It was too troublesome to make deep-fried dough sticks. Qin Mian mixed the flour with water into diluted liquid, added eight eggs, stirred them evenly, spread them out in the oiled wok, fried them into thin egg pancakes, and then cut them into small pieces. Next, he chopped pork into small pieces. There was no blindweed, so instead, he used green vegetables and chopped them up. He stir-fried these with chopped scallion and ginger in

the wok until half cooked before adding proper amount of salt. After he made sure it was evenly mixed, the savory dumpling stuffing was done.

After the dough was made, Qin Mian took a lump of dough, kneaded it into a tube shape, and then cut it into small dough pieces with a knife. Next, he used a rolling pin to roll them into thin slices, making the dumpling wrappers.

Lei Tie was in charge of rolling the dumpling wrappers after he learned it. Meanwhile, Qin Mian wrapped the dumplings while warming beside the charcoal stove. He placed a dumpling wrapper in the center of his left palm, used a small spoon to scoop out dumpling stuffing and put it on the wrapper. Then, he closed the dumpling wrapper and pinched it tightly. A dumpling was wrapped in a few seconds and placed in a large clean sieve.

Lei Tie's hand quickly rolled a dozen dumpling wrappers and Qin Mian wrapped them altogether. After the dumpling wrappers were used up, he continued to roll... In this fashion, an hour later, nearly 200 plump white dumplings covered the whole sieve.

"Make fire and prepare to cook the dumplings." Qin Mian ordered.

Lei Tie ignited the stove, scooped a few ladle of water into the wok and covered it.

"How many do you eat?" Qin Mian asked. More than 100 dumplings could not be eaten by two people in one meal.

Lei Tie looked at the dumplings and said without hesitation: "50."

Qin Mian was a little skeptical, "Can you finish them?"

Lei Tie's mouth agape, "You wrapped it small."

Qin Mian's sharp eyes found that his (LT) ears were a little red, and he could not help but smothered his laugh, "What's so embarrassing? I don't dislike you eat too much. I can afford you, don't worry."

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian felt uncomfortable when he (LT) was so serious. After the water boiled, he was still unable to bear it and wanted to laugh when he picked up the dumplings to put into the wok, “*Cough*. First cook a wok for us to eat. Then cook another to send to the old house and Grandpa Jiang’s house. At that time we split from the family, Grandpa Jiang gave us eggs, which we still haven’t returned the gesture. Today is our chance.”

Lei Tie nodded.

When the dumplings were out of the wok, Qin Mian ate 35 of them. It was quite delicious. If it was not for his stomach could not be filled anymore, he would like to eat more. Lei Tie easily wiped out 50 pieces of dumpling and even added 5 more.

Qin Mian picked up the second batch of dumplings one by one to put into two large bowls and then the bowls were stored in a food box.

“Are you going or not?” Qin Mian asked.

“Together.”

Lei Tie picked up a silvery gray scarf on the back of the chair and put it around Qin Mian. He went out after Qin Mian and locked the door.

The two walked all the way surrounded by the smell of meat, fish and oil from every household. There was hardly anyone on the road, and none of the naughty children, who usually liked to run around, were seen. There was delicious food at home, so the children were reluctant to go out.

“Which house to go first?”

About to arrive, Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian said with a meaningful smile, “As someone’s children, of course we should go to our parents’ house first.”

After entering the courtyard gate of the old house, they saw the people were all sitting around the table in the central room. It looked like they were about to eat. Lei Xiangren did not sell soup today. Lei Xiangzhi took a

holiday and was at home. A large family was talking and laughing; it was very lively.

Qin Mian greeted in a loud voice: “Father, mother, we’re here. Are you all already eating?”

Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao all stood up to greet them.

“Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law.”

Lei Daqiang’s attitude today was surprisingly good. He smiled while nodding, “Eldest and eldest daughter-in-law are here.”

Lei Tie nodded blankly as a greeting.

Du Shi glanced at him and Qin Mian lightly, and without getting up, “I don’t know you two are coming. I’m afraid the food is not enough.”

Qin Mian deliberately looked at the dishes on the table, “There are so many dishes, adding two pairs of chopsticks should be no problem.”

Du Shi’s expression changed.

Zhao Shi chipped in: “What is eldest brother carrying?”

Qin Mian looked at Du Shi with a smile, “We just came here after eating. Just now I was just joking with mother. We’ve brought some food here. Please get an empty large bowl or plate.”

“Ah.” As soon as Zhao Shi heard that there was food, she straightly moved and brought a large plate.

Qin Mian took out the dumplings from the food box and poured them all into the plate.

“What is this, eldest sister-in-law?” Qian Shi asked curiously.

Qin Mian put the empty bowl back into the food box. "It's a kind of food made of flour. Like meat stuffed buns, it's wrapped with meat stuffing."

Zhao Shi stared at the food box and said with a flattering smile: "I seem to see another bowl?"

When Du Shi heard that, she stared at Qin Mian and used her eyes to tell that he'd better bring out the other bowl as well.

Qin Mian had yet to speak, Lei Xiangren already could not wait, "Is it meat stuffing? Give father to taste first." Then he took the dumplings to the men's table, picked one up and put it into his mouth. After taking a tentative bite, he chewed it eagerly, "En, it's delicious."

Qin Mian said leisurely: "The other bowl is for Grandpa Jiang next door. When we split up from the family, Grandpa Jiang gave us a basket of eggs, which could be described as a timely help. Second brother's wife, don't you think your eldest brother and I should return this favor?"

"Oh, that's so." Zhao Shi was disappointed.

Du Shi said while frowning: "Didn't you invite them to meal during housewarming? This dumpling doesn't need to be delivered, right?"

Lei Daqiang interrupted her, "Eldest and eldest daughter-in-law are doing the right thing."

Qin Mian chuckled, "Father, we've been busy a while ago, we haven't said 'congratulations' to you." He was deliberately making Du Shi uncomfortable.

Du Shi's face was as black as charcoal and her chest sharply heaved.

Lei Daqiang laughed, feeling a little embarrassed, but at the thought of Miss Wei, his pupils floated with joyous expression, "Do you want to eat some, together?"

Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi ate several dumplings in a row. Zhao Shi said in a hurry: "This dish is quite a lot. Mother, you divide it."

Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi both looked at her with a straight face.

Qin Mian snickered and stood up. “Father, mother, please eat slowly. We’ll go and visit Grandpa Jiang.”

Arriving next door, they knocked on the courtyard gate. It was a 17-year-old boy who came to open the gate, tilting his head as he looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

“Who are you looking for?”

“Is Grandpa Jiang at home?” Qin Mian raised his voice as he asked.

“Who is it?” As soon as Grandpa Jiang came out of the house and saw Qin Mian, he laughed and said: “Ah, it’s you two. Come in and sit down.”

Grandpa Jiang’s son and daughter-in-law poked their heads from inside the house, but they did not come out. It could be seen that they were not very welcome.

Qin Mian did not go in. He just brought out the dumplings. “Grandpa Jiang, we still have something to do, so we won’t go in. We haven’t had a chance to thank you for the eggs you gave us last time. It’s our homemade food. It’s just a small token to show our respect to you.”

“We’re fellow villagers, why the need to be courteous?” Grandpa Jiang was a little surprised and then he smiled that made the look in his eyes more amiable, “It’s not easy for two adult men to live together. You two keep the food for yourself.”

Qin Mian said: “Don’t be too polite, Grandpa Jiang. We’ve made a lot. This is especially for you. If you don’t accept it, it’ll be cold.”

“All right.” Seeing his insistence, Grandpa Jiang took the bowl and went to the kitchen. After a while, he took out the empty bowl with two plump Chinese cabbages.

“Yesterday, I passed by your vegetable garden and saw that the vegetables in the garden haven’t grown up. You can take these two cabbages back to

eat. It's not worth anything, don't refuse them."

"Thank you, Grandpa Jiang." Seeing his kindness, Qin Mian accepted it generously.

Lei Tie also said "many thanks".

Watching the back figures of the two men leaving, Grandpa Jiang stood for a while before entering the house.

"Father, why are you being close to them?" Grandpa Jiang's son, Jiang Dayou, complained in a low voice.

His daughter-in-law stood at the side. Although she did not say anything, she also had a look of disapproval on her face.

Grandpa Jiang sat down at the table, glanced at his wife, put a peanut in his mouth and chewed it slowly, "Ask your mother why."

Grandma Jiang laughed and put her baby grandson into her embrace. "Dayou, let me ask you. Did Lei Tie and his wife commit murder and arson?"

Jiang Dayou shook his head.

"Did they swindle people?"

Jiang Dayou said: "There is no such thing."

"That's it." Grandma Jiang said gently, "At the time when they split from the family, your father gave them a few eggs. Until now, they still remember it. One can see that they're grateful. At that time, they practically left with nothing, but now they run a shop in the town. I heard they make a lot of money every day. Even the idea of selling soup at the Six Bends River by the brothers next door came from Lei Tie's wife. One can see that they are capable people."

Jiang Dayou was absorbed in thoughts.

“All right. Let’s eat.” Grandpa Jiang laughed, “You don’t like to associate with them, but they don’t necessarily like to associate with you.”

Jiang Dayou felt helpless. Was it necessary to belittle your son like that?

When Qin Mian and Lei Tie walked into the alley where they lived, they saw Zhang Dashuan standing at the gate of their house with a plate. There was a bowl turned upside-down on the plate.

They quickened their pace.

“Brother Zhang.”

“Where did you two go?” Zhang Dashuan smilingly said, “I’ve been waiting for a while. Have you had lunch? Isn’t it a holiday today? Your sister[1] made a cabbage stew and asked me to bring you two a bowl. Now it’s still hot.”

Qin Mian opened the door and invited him in, “We’ve eaten. We went to the old house just now. You and sister are so thoughtful.”

Zhang Dashuan said: “What is this worth? We haven’t thank you two for giving the job of making bamboo sticks to me. I’ve made a lot of money recently. It’s enough for a good year.”

“Brother Zhang has taken care of us more often.” Lei Tie said.

Zhang Dashuan happily handed the plate to Qin Mian, “Fine, I won’t say anything. Our two families will take care of each other. Here, it’ll taste better if it is re-heated in the evening.”

Qin Mian took the plate to the kitchen and said Lei Tie: “You sit with Brother Zhang.”

“You went there.” Zhang Dashuan smiled ambiguously as he said to Lei Tie, “In a few days, Uncle Lei’s second wife will join the household.”

“That’s his business.” Lei Tie wore an uncaring expression.

Zhang Dashuan did not comment. Lei Daqiang was the first person to marry an equal wife, not to mention in the Green Mountain Village, but even in the Running Water Town. He and his wife were still worried about what gifts to send.

Since he had not eaten lunch yet, he just sat for a while and then went home with a bowl of raw dumplings.

Note:

[1] Not blood-related

Chapter 057: Little Mother Joins the Household

057 – Young Mother Joins the Household

In the twinkling of an eye, it came to the day Lei Daqiang married Wei Wei.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie informed Yue Dong in advance that they would not go to the shop. Since that night Lei Tie ruthlessly taught a lesson to those two men, no one looked for trouble with the restaurant anymore. There was nothing to worry about if they did not go to the shop for few days.

After breakfast, they dressed up and came to the old house together. Compared with the previous few days, there were some changes in the old house. There were two red lanterns hanging under the eaves of the courtyard gate. Several red “囍[1]” characters were pasted at different positions on the courtyard gate, the central room and the external wall, portraying the auspicious festive.

When Qin Mian walked closer, he looked at the house and wondered how the whole family would live after Miss Wei joined in? Could it be that every time Lei Daqiang wanted to be with Wei Shi, he would rush Du Shi to Lei Chuntao’s room or divide his bed in two with a cloth curtain?

At the thought of that kind of funny scene, Qin Mian laughed silently. The more he thought, the more he laughed.

“What are you laughing at?” Lei Tie patted him on the head.

Qin Mian promptly said: “Nothing, nothing.” There was still a smile on his face.

Lei Tie did not ask anymore and pulled him into the yard.

The auspicious time was near dusk, and therefore the courtyard was still relatively quiet right now. In regard of their father taken a wife, Lei Xiangren and the other younger generations were very embarrassed and quietly did things at hand.

“Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law; you two are here.” Lei Xiangli came over.

Lei Tie waved his hand, “Continue with your work.”

Lei Xiangli sighed and went out of the courtyard. “I’m going to borrow tables and chairs.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie walked around. There was no need to help and they also did not want to see Du Shi’s “everyone owed her 500 taels” face. Thus, they turned back home.

Qin Mian suggested, “Let’s go to buy some tofu and a fish.” Although Green Mountain Village was far away from Running Water Town, there were wine workshop, tofu workshop and fish farms in the village. It was very convenient to buy wine, tofu and fish. In this regard, he thought it was not too bad to transmigrate to Green Mountain Village.

Lei Tie pointed his chin to the left side of the small path to let him go that way.

“Brother Tie and sister[2] go for a walk?” Wu Di came face-to-face as he teased.

Lei Tie nodded slightly.

Quan Mian nodded politely to Wu Di and the other three villagers who were walking with him.

“We’re going to the other end of the village to buy tofu. Where are all of you going?”

Wu Di said: “I heard that Old Zhao and his wife are fighting. We’re going to ‘try to stop people from fighting each other’. Hahaha...”

Qin Mian said: “Old Zhao and his wife have a small fight every day and a big fight every three days. It’s nothing new in our village, right?” This married couple was a pair of wonder in their village. They would not feel comfortable without fighting for a day, but after each fight, they still went out arm in arm the next morning. They behaved intimately, comparable to modern people. The villager all understood that the two had a good relationship, and fighting was more like a special way for them to express their feelings for each other.

“It’s not the same this time,” said a young man beside Wu Di while laughing. “It’s said that this time is because Old Zhao didn’t go home last night, but came back this morning with a red lip’s print on his clothes! Hahaha...”

Another person urged: “Quick, go have a look!”

“Brother Tie and sister, we’re going first!” Wu Di waved his hand as he was pulled away.

Qin Mian shook his head. This Wu Di really did not look like a married man.

The two slowly swayed forward and bought fish and tofu before going home.

At noon, Qin Mian cooked three dishes: braised tofu, braised fish, and stewed cabbage with pork.

As before, after Qin Mian ate well first, Lei Tie cleaned up the rest of the rice and dishes.

Why doesn’t he get fat? Qin Mian was envious as he thought so.

After lunch, they took a walk to help digestion and then took a nap on the bed for a while. When they vaguely heard the sound of the festive suonas

approaching, they quickly tidied up and went to the old house.

As expected, it was the bride escorts returning home. The sound of firecrackers exploded outside the village crackled for a long time.

This sound of firecrackers told people that the bride was coming soon, reminded the family to prepare the welcoming of the bride, and also informed the guests that they could come.

At the old house, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi greeted the guests at the door. The three Lei brothers were responsible for male guests, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi were responsible for female guests, and Lei Chuntao was responsible for entertaining the children. All of them were busy. Lei Xiangzhi was still in school. Meanwhile, Du Shi had not appeared. She was said to be sick.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie rushed forward to help receiving gifts and inviting the guests to the courtyard.

The bride escorting procession was getting closer. At the front of the line were six men in red clothes. Some were beating gongs, some were playing drums, and some were blowing suonas with their cheeks bulging. How very festive. Behind them was Lei Daqiang, who was tied with a big red flower, grinning from ear to ear and looking like he was ten years younger. Next to Lei Daqiang was a red four manned palanquin. Naturally, the bride was sitting in this palanquin.

There were about five to six men and women behind the palanquin, in which they all carried new bamboo baskets with the character “囍” pasted on. Needless to say, the basket contained the bride’s dowry that included rice, flour, cloth, brand-new small furniture, and etc.

When the procession arrived in front of the gate, there was another burst of firecrackers, “*Crackle—*”

“Here comes the bride—” The children screamed in excitement, frolicking and blocking the palanquin to prevent the palanquin from approaching the courtyard gate.

Lei Daqiang had been prepared. He grabbed a few handfuls of sweets from a basket and threw them away.

The children cheered and ran to pick up the sweets, and the palanquin landed smoothly at the gate.

After getting off the palanquin, the bride and Lei Daqiang pulled along the red “joy” ribbon together as they entered the gate.

The guests crowded in to watch the excitement. The yard was full of people making an unnecessary racket and loudly jeering.

Qin Mian also wanted to get closer, but he could not occupy a space. On tiptoe, he saw that after the bride stepping over the brazier, she and Lei Daqiang completed the ceremony according to the instructions of “*the first kowtow is for the heaven and earth, the second for the parents and the third for each other*”. After that, she was sent to the bridal chamber.

Nevertheless, the kowtow for the parents was towards the memorial tablet of Lei Daqiang’s parents.

After the bride was sent to the bridal chamber, the bridegroom Lei Daqiang was pulled to drink by the villagers.

Whether it was the host or the guests, they tacitly did not mention the reason for Du Shi’s absence.

This was the busiest time. The hired cooks were cooking in an orderly manner. Qin Mian and Lei Tie arrange the guests to sit down and help serve the dishes.

From time to time, Qin Mian looked towards the outside of the gate and whispered to Lei Tie: “Did they miss the time?”

“Don’t worry. It’s been arranged.” Lei Tie pacified.

Almost at the same time as his words just finished, outside came the approaching sound of horse’s hooves, and then someone shouted: “Eating Savory Restaurant offers ten portions of spicy hot pot!”

The courtyard suddenly quieted down, and a few look of surprised, shocked or admiration fell on Qin Mian and Lei Tie at the same time.

Lei Tie's face was expressionless, while Qin Mian was smiling, maintaining the basic courtesy.

After a short while, ten energetic young men went into the courtyard one by one. The first two men each held five unlit charcoal stoves, followed by two men carried a sack of charcoal together, two men carried five large double-eared pots, two men carried four bamboo baskets with different dishes, which were meatballs, fillets of fish, chicken pieces, quail eggs, mushrooms, vegetables, potatoes and tofu. The last two men jointly carried a bucket-like big wok. All the ten men were hired by Qin Mian.

The crowd stood gazing at each other and talked in low voices while hardly hid their excitement.

“Old Lei's eldest son and eldest daughter-in-law have good prospects ah. This is a big spend!”

“I think all those dishes will cost 700~800 Wen!”

“Lei Tie and his wife are very kind. The father and stepmother forced them to split and move out, but they still don't forget to repay the kindness of parents' upbringing.”

Hearing these words, the corner of Qin Mian's mouth invoked a subtle smile.

After putting down the things, the ten helpers put a charcoal stove on each table in an orderly manner, lit the charcoal and put the pot on it, poured the boiled thick soup, and then skillfully divided all kinds of hot pot dishes into ten portions and distributed them to each table.

“Old Lei produced a good son, ah.” Some people admiringly said.

When Lei Daqiang's ears caught that, he felt proud. Blushing and laughing, he patted Lei Tie on the shoulder and said three good words of praise.

However, he did not know that the sick Du Shi hiding in the house looked at the people –smiling and laughing– in the yard with red eyes. When she also saw Qin Mian’s smiling face, she felt that everyone was satirizing her. Her hands clenched into fists as there was a burst of pain in her chest. The pain almost made her vomit blood. She squeezed a few words from between her teeth, “Lei Daqiang–”

Xiao Shi, her sister-in-law, sat with her and quickly comforted her: “Younger sister-in-law, there’s nothing you can do about it. You should think positively. I’ll go out and have a look.” It was said that the hot pot was very delicious, and she craved it very much. If she was a step slower, she might lose her share.

Wei Wei, who was sitting in her new room, also heard someone shouting “Eating Savory Restaurant offers ten portions of spicy hot pot” outside, and the pretty face under the red veil gave a pleasant smile.

Zhang Dashuan walked to Lei Tie and laughingly teased, “Spent a lot today.”

Qin Mian minutely smiled and looked at the direction of the house with unclear meaning, “As it should be.”

“Brother Zhang, go and sit there.” Lei Tie invited Zhang Dashuan to the table.

After the ten young men prepared the dishes, Qin Mian took out a string of money from his sleeve pocket and handed it over, “Great work. This is for you to buy wine. You all come back tomorrow morning to move things.”

“Many thanks, small boss.” The few guys joyfully expressed their thanks and left.

At this time, the fire in the charcoal stove burnt up, thus the smell of hot pot immediately became strong and attractive. The atmosphere in the courtyard seemingly spurred by the aroma and turned enthusiastic. The villagers kept toasting Lei Daqiang and wished him a happy wedding.

The Lei three brothers also did not escape the fierce toasting offensive.

Qin Mian escaped with the excuse that he could not drink. Lei Tie always had a cold face, so no one dared to pull him in. Therefore, the two men were able to dine leisurely. Occasionally, they invited young people such as Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di at the same table to drink and eat.

“Brother Zhang.” A flush-faced drunk villager at the same table patted Zhang Dashuan on the back, “I heard that you made bamboo sticks for Lei Tie’s hot pot shop. Can you make a lot of money in a day?”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other and then bowed their heads to eat, acting as though they did not hear it.

Zhang Dashuan’s chopsticks paused for a moment before he went to pick up the dishes in the hot pot. Laughing, he said, “This is because my brother Lei and his wife think highly of me. Eat the dishes, eat the dishes!”

Note:

[1] double happiness (similar to 囍) / symbol of good luck, esp. marriage

[2] Not blood-related. The common address for a friend’s wife

Chapter 058: The First Confrontation of Du Shi and Wei Shi

058 – The First Confrontation of Du Shi and Wei Shi

“Yes, yes, it’s Brother Lei.” That villager looked at Lei Tie again. He knocked the porcelain plate with his chopsticks and spoke with a smell of liquor in his breath. “Brother Lei, we’re all from the same village. If there’s a chance to make a fortune, you’ve to show consideration to fellow countrymen. Am I right, everyone?”

Lei Tie’s expression slightly sunk.

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows as he looked at that villager.

The other people at the table were embarrassed and secretly scolded that villager for eating Lei Tie’s hot pot but still running his mouth non-stop. Even if people really had a chance to get rich, they would consider their blood brothers or people who had a good relationship with them. Who did you think you are? It simply broke the harmonious atmosphere at the table.

Wu Di hooked an arm around that villager’s shoulder as he said with a smile: “Brother Qiu, don’t just talk. Come, let’s have another toast! Or are you afraid that sister [wife] will make you kneel on a broom when you go back?”

“Who is afraid of her?” The man was stubborn, raised his glass and said in a loud voice, “Come, drink a mouthful!”

“Come, drink again!” A few others also came along.

Qin Mian sped up his eating action. After finishing, he took advantage of people’s inattention to slip away, hid outside the gate of the courtyard and hooked his finger towards Lei Tie.

Lei Tie silently put down the bowl and walked over.

Qin Mian pulled him to leave for fear that someone else had drank too much and asked them to “show consideration”.

“Not full.” Lei Tie honestly let himself being pulled by Qin Mian.

The sun had just set. Most people had gone to the old house to attend the wedding reception; therefore it was very quiet all around.

Qin Mian promptly said: “I’ll make noodles with diced meat for you when we’re home.”

As soon as he finished speaking, it changed to Lei Tie who pulled him home.

Qin Mian then remembered something, “There was a woman who kept staring at us when we’re eating just now. Who is that?”

Lei Tie thought for a moment, “[Paternal] Aunt.”

“Oh.” Qin Mian’s response was flat. At the beginning of their separation from the main family, relatives from everywhere were informed, but none of them went to their house. Those relatives did not care about him and Lei Tie, let alone any of them came to help [financially], so neither did he need to care about them.

Back home, both of them felt much more comfortable than in the old house.

Lei Tie went directly to the kitchen, “What to wash and what to cut?”

“You don’t have to, I’ll do it.” Qin Mian picked a block of pork with fairly fat skin from the beam of the house. The pork was three parts fat and seven

parts lean, which was suitable for making diced meat. He cut the meat into thin pieces and asked Lei Tie to make a fire. When the oil in the wok heated up, he poured the diced meat in and constantly stirred. At 30 percent cooked, Qin Mian added ginger powder and salt to it, and continued to stir-fry. At 60 percent cooked, he added vinegar and stir-fried. At 70 percent cooked, he added soy sauce and Sichuan pepper. When it was about done, he added a proper amount of chili powder and water to simmer for a while and only then the diced meat soup could be scooped out of the wok. The meat was soft, tender and spicy, with bright red oil.

When Qin Mian looked at it, he also craved it unbearably. He took a pair of chopsticks to pick up two pieces of meat to taste and then praised himself, "I surpassed my skill; it's soft and tender."

Upon seeing Lei Tie staring at his mouth, he took a small bowl, put a few pieces of meat and handed it to him, "Here."

Lei Tie took the bowl, grabbed the chopsticks in his hand and ate the meat in the bowl.

Qin Mian looked at him in shocked, "That's my chopsticks!"

"En." Lei Tie did not even lift his head.

Qin Mian kicked him, "You can't get another pair?"

"What's the difference?" Lei Tie raised his head with a look of ignorant.

Qin Mian's mouth twitched, unable to speak. Could he tell Lei Tie that "you kiss me indirectly by using my used chopsticks"?

The noodles were cooked in another wok. When the noodles were cooked, he dredged up the noodles, poured a spoonful of diced meat soup, added a handful of scallions and stirred them with chopsticks. The appetizing aroma assailed the nostrils. The rest of diced meat soup could be kept for tomorrow. The soup would not go bad since it was cold nowadays.

“It’s ready to eat.” Qin Mian was careful not to spill the soup on the stovetop as he said unhappily.

“I’ll take it.” Lei Tie beat him to it, lifted the noodles bowl and put it on the dining table.

Qin Mian came out from the kitchen after he washed his hands and did not see a figure. After a while, he saw Lei Tie come out of the utility room with a jug of wine in his hand.

He could not help complaining, “Eating noodles and still want to drink.”

“It looks good to have with wine.” Lei Tie put down the wine jar, but did not immediately sit down, “Wife, have a drink too?”

“No.” Qin Mian shook his head.

Lei Tie then took a wine cup, poured and drank from himself. Qin Mian had nothing to do, so he sat beside Lei Tie and watched him eat.

Lei Tie seemed to be in a good mood. He tasted the wine leisurely and ate the noodles slowly.

Watching him, Qin Mian felt anxious and itched to feed him. He was really bored. He simply went to the kitchen and took a pair of chopsticks to eat the meat in Lei Tie’s bowl.

“This is my noodles.” Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian provocatively put four pieces of meat into his mouth at a time, “What’s the difference?”

Lei Tie shook his head.

Qin Mian complacently picked out all the meat in his bowl and ate it.

Lei Tie said nothing. Holding a white porcelain wine cup in his left hand and chopsticks in his right hand, he helped Qin Mian find the meat in the noodles.

Qin Mian's cheeks heated up. He put down his chopsticks and suddenly stood up. He ran to the settee and lay down – his heart was pounding. He did not dare to look at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie stared at him for a long time before taking back his eyes. He turned the wine cup upside down and concentrated on eating the noodles. The noodles had been soaked in the soup for too long and were already soggy, but he still thought it was delicious. He even drank up the soup.

At dawn, after Qin Mian and Lei Tie washed up, they went to the old house early.

In addition to Du Shi, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Zhao Shi, Qian Shi and the three children, there was also Lei Daqiang's eldest brother Lei Dagang's family – which consisted of Le Dagang, Lei Dagang's wife, their two sons, two daughter-in-law, two grandsons and two granddaughters. Lei Daqiang and Lei Dagang had some conflicts when they separated during those years. The relationship between their two families was only so-so and they also were not familiar with each other. They only paid a visit when there were festivals, weddings and funerals.

The full room of people was chatting, and when they saw two people walking in side by side, they were impressed and tandemly fell into silent. The man on the left was tall, with hair as black as ink. He wore a right-lapel azure wide robe and a black cowhide belt on his waist with a red “peace” knot[1] hung from it. He looked cold and his paces were steady where within each foot lift, it faintly revealed an unable-to-ignore aura. The youth on the right was handsome with eyes as black as lacquer. He wore a sky blue arrow sleeves robe, covered with a black overcoat which cuffs sewn with two pieces of pure white rabbit fur, and a pair of satin blue ankle boots on his foot. His presence was out of the ordinary that simply made people dazzled and wondered which family's gongzi had gone to the wrong door.

Zhao Shi, Qian Shi, Lei Chuntao and several other women were in a daze.

Lei Xiangren's eyes fell on Lei Tie, and his mood felt complex. His eldest brother was older than him, but looked several years younger than him. If he (LT) did not have that scar on his face, he would be even more handsome and charming. At the bottom of his heart, he could not help but feel a bit jealous. When he caught a glimpse of Zhao Shi in a daze, he sulked. He lifted his foot and kicked her leg hard.

Nevertheless, Zhao Shi thought he was not careful. She rubbed her leg as she grumbled, "What are you thinking?"

Lei Xiangren snorted without speaking.

After Lei Tie looked around the room, he pulled Qin Mian to an inconspicuous corner and sat down.

Qin Mian also swept a glance around and did not see the bride.

Du Shi sat anxiously on the main seat, a little absent-minded instead of staring fiercely at the closed door of the [bride] room.

This time, the door of the room creaked open and a smiling Lei Daqiang walked out together with a wholly clothed in red Wei Shi.

Qin Mian looked at Wei Shi and nodded to himself. She was indeed a beauty, but it was a pity to be paired with Lei Daqiang.

Lei Daqiang went to the main seat and sat down. He said casually: "All are here."

Wei Shi looked shy, but her manner was very natural and relaxed. She walked briskly to Du Shi and knelt down to offer her tea. Although both of them were wives and had the same status, Du Shi had married first. This cup of tea should be honored to her.

"Please have some tea, [elder] sister."

Du Shi did not respond. She stared at her coldly and said chillingly, "Oh you still know to wake up? How bold of you to have so many of us waiting for you? Is this the rule of your Wei family?"

Wei Shi did not mind the critic and apologetically said: “I asked husband yesterday and he said that sister usually gets up at the beginning of dragon hour[2]. [Younger sister] I was thoughtless. I didn’t expect sister to get up at the rabbit hour[3]. This is my fault. I apologize to sister, please have some tea.”

Lei Xiangren and the others embarrassingly bowed their heads in silent. It was true that Du Shi got up early. Before dawn, she moved tables and chairs in the house, and repeatedly knocked on the wok that woke them all up with the noise.

Qin Mian soundlessly laughed and glanced at Du Shi with a look of delight in her misfortunes.

Du Shi’s face looked rigid. What else should she say? Lei Daqiang put on a straight face, “Alright, why don’t you pick up the tea? She still has to make breakfast later.”

Du Shi had no choice but to pick up the tea slowly and put it down after a sip. Grudgingly and unwillingly, she took out two peach-wood hairpins with silver pendants, and brusquely said: “From here on, take good care of the master.”

“Many thanks, sister.” Wei Shi politely thanked, and then handed her a pair of exquisite silver bead earrings, “This is a little regard from me. I hope sister likes it.”

The two silver beads were not small and it worth at least a silver tael, which was much more valuable than the silver pendant hairpins. Du Shi felt the load in her heart slightly lifted.

Zhao Shi’s eyes brightened. She walked quickly to Wei Shi and held her arm as she said: “Little mother, I’m the second daughter-in-law. This is Eldest Uncle and Eldest Aunt. This is... ”

For the people of the same generation, Wei Shi gave them blessing ceremony one by one and handed over the shoes and purse made by her own.

For the younger generation, Wei Shi's first-meet gifts to them were also generous. There was no favoritism as each of them got a silver lock. Qin Mian and Lei Tie also got one each.

After claiming kin[4], Du Shi said impatiently, "Alright, go to cook. We're all hungry." The second day, the bride would have to cook breakfast. It was not only to test the bride's ability to manage the family, but also lay the foundation for the bride's life in the new home.

Lei Dagang's family stood up and took their leave.

Lei Daqiang held back Qin Mian and Lei Tie to have breakfast. Qin Mian wanted to see how things play out, so they stayed.

Wei Shi went to the kitchen to cook, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi took the initiative to help. Qin Mian knew that the two women must have gone to get close to Wei Shi.

Within an hour, Zhao Shi and Qian Shi began to serve dishes on the table. There were a lot of ingredients left from treating meal to guests yesterday, including meat and vegetables. Wei Shi prepared ten dishes complete with color, aroma and flavor.

"We can start breakfast." Wei Shi sat down beside Lei Daqiang with a smile.

Du Shi said with a straight face: "Wei Shi, you're sitting in the wrong place. What are you doing sitting with the adult men?"

"Sister, that's not right." Wei Shi turned to see Lei Daqiang. "Husband, I feel that since we're all one family, there's no need to separate the women. It's convenient for me to take care of husband when I sit next to you, isn't it? Old Two and Old Three sitting together with their wives can also help cultivate their feelings. In the future, they'll give birth to more grandchildren. My husband, what do you say?"

"You're right." Lei Daqiang nodded, "From here on, men and women don't have be divided into two tables for a family to eat. I'll sit with your mother,

my wife and Chuntao, and the rest will sit at another table.”

Wei Shi warmly invited Du Shi, “Sister, come to sit here.”

Du Shi looked livid. She had reached the end of her forbearance, she was about to get angry.

Lei Chuntao hurriedly walked over and pushed her to sit down on the other side of Lei Daqiang and soothed her in a low voice.

Wei Shi helped Lei Daqiang pick up dishes as she said with a smile, “Husband, mutton nourishes body, eat more. My cooking skills are not bad. Afterwards, I’ll make some dishes to supplement you.”

“Good, good.” Lei Daqiang laughed heartily and all the more felt that marrying this wife was the right thing to do.

Lei Xiangren stuffed a small fried pork into his mouth and praised, “Little mother’s cooking is really good.”

“I feel the same way.” Zhao Shi chimed in, “The vegetables are also well fried. Stir-fried vegetables even need more oil to taste good.”

Qian Shi murmured: “It would be nice if little mother cook all the meals afterwards.”

Lei Xiangyi glared at her and scolded: “Shut up!” He knew that his mother was economical in cooking, and still Qian Shi did not dare to speak out in front of so many people.

Qin Mian shot a glance at Du Shi’s glum face and then at Wei Shi’s smiling face. He was in a good mood. He was very sure that Du Shi had no time to go to trouble him and Lei Tie. As for the future of the old house, he did not care.

“Brother Tie, I’m done eating.”

Lei Tie nodded his head, put down his chopsticks and stood up.

“Father, mother, little mother, we’ve finished eating. We’ll go back. You all eat slowly.” Qin Mian was very polite.

Du Shi said nothing.

Lei Daqiang just nodded.

However, Wei Shi stood up and said with a smile: “Alright. Come to visit whenever you two have time.”

Note:

[1] Chinese knot means love, marriage and reunion in Chinese. The knot is often used for ornament, as a gift exchange, pray for good luck and ward off evil spirits.

[2] 7-9 a.m

[3] 5-7 a.m

[4] visit/greet/acknowledge new in-laws after a marriage

Translator’s side note: Thanks again for all the comments and sorry for not replying, I’m an awkward person (uwu). Also, sorry for not providing images for their clothing (I tried searching but it took time and a distraction) but here the link to have the general idea of ancient China clothing. Until next time~

Chapter 059: Go Hunting Together

059 – Go Hunting Together

There was gust after gust of wind outside the window that blasted the window until it made a slight sound like a whimper. Qin Mian had woken up early. He shrunk in the quilt and did not want to move. Without moving, he watched Lei Tie get up on time and sit on the edge of the heatable brick bed as he put on his inner clothing, cover it with cotton unlined upper garment, and put on pants before wearing cloth shoes last.

“Get up to run.” Lei Tie turned around.

“I don’t want to. Why don’t you make breakfast today?” Qin Mian suggested.

Lei Tie picked up the man and took out the nicely warm clothes from inside the quilt[1] and threw them on Qin Mian.

Qin Mian resignedly put on his clothes and said coldly: “You aren’t afraid of me catching cold!”

Lei Tie dully said: “Insist on training so you won’t catch cold easily.”

Qin Mian quickly dressed, combed his hair, and rushed out like an arrow. *Didn’t you want me run? I’ll show you.*

After Lei Tie locked the gate of the courtyard, Qin Mian was no longer visible. He ran to the right without hesitation. Soon, he saw Qin Mian’s back and caught up with him.

When Qin Mian heard the footsteps behind him, he quickened his pace.

Lei Tie also sped up. He was a *zhang* [330m] away behind him (QM).

Qin Mian curled his lips, kept moving forward at a constant speed and no longer competed with him.

Everyone in the village got up at this time. The sound of scraping ashes, the sound of opening door, and the voice of talking together formed a special symphony.

When he passed by a gate of a courtyard, a basin of water flew out of it.

Qin Mian agilely darted away.

A fat aunt held an empty basin in her hand with a look of shocked and embarrassingly said: “Lei Tie’s wife, sorry ah. Aunt didn’t mean to.”

“It’s alright.” Qin Mian casually waved his hand and continued to run.

As the autumn wind rustled in the air, the cold wind tirelessly swept over and over again, and the withered leaves fell on the ground accumulated into a thick pile, making a “poof” sound when a foot stepped on it. After running for a while, his whole body warmed up. Qin Mian quickened his speed a little.

Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di and Lei Xiangli were together somehow. They were going this way, and when they saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie, they waved.

Zhang Dashuan said: “Still running? We’ve something to look for you.”

Qin Mian kept his pace. His breath was unsteady as he said: “Morning... after running... will talk.”

Lei Tie was reticent as before, following after him.

“They run like this every day?” Lei Xiangli asked Zhang Dashuan.

Zhang Dashuan said: “Yes. Except for rainy days, they run around the village every morning.”

Wu Di had a funny face. “I heard sister (QM) said it was called ‘morning exercise’.”

Lei Xiangli nodded, feeling somewhat embarrassed. The two outsiders knew his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law better than him.

“Come on, let’s walk slowly. When we get to their gate, they should be done.” Zhang Dashuan said.

Sure enough, when the three slowly arrived at the gate of the courtyard, Qin Mian and Lei Tie just came from the small forest.

Lei Tie’s breath was steady, as if he had just gone for a walk. Qin Mian was panting, but his pace was still steady.

“Open the gate.” Qin Mian slapped Lei Tie on his shoulder.

Without saying a word, Lei Tie took out the key to open the big lock.

Zhang Dashuan and the others were secretly surprised. It turned out that the two got along like this in private. Although Qin Mian hit Lei Tie very hard, they could still tell how close the two were.

“How did the three of you come together? What’s the matter?” Qin Mian asked.

Before Zhang Dashuan had time to speak, Lei Tie asked Qin Mian as he scooped water from the well and washed his hands, “Wife, what do you want eat for breakfast?”

“Rice. It’s not like you don’t know that I dislike noodles very much. Still have to ask?” Qin Mian pulled off the cloth towel on the bamboo pole to wipe his sweat.

“I know. What about dishes?”

Qin Mian thought about it, “Half a [Chinese] cabbage, three radishes, and three pork ribs.”

Lei Tie walked towards the kitchen and glanced at Zhang Dashuan and the others: “Talk to my wife about it.”

“Eldest brother is cooking?” Lei Xiangli asked incomprehensibly.

Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di also looked surprised.

Qin Mian was taken aback, “No, he washed the rice and vegetables. His skin is thick, not afraid of cold. Haha.”

Zhang Dashuan and the others looked at each other, speechless. They found out a bit more about the male couple life of Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian invited them to sit in the living room.

“You haven’t said what you want from us?”

Lei Xiangli sat down on the settee and felt the softness of the settee with his fist.

Zhang Dashuan said: “Actually, we’re here to look for Tiezi. The three of us want to go to the mountain to hunt, so that we can have many dishes on the table during the New Year. Tiezi is the most experienced hunter, so we want him to take us.” In fact, it was proposed by Wu Di. He had a good relationship with Lei Tie and Qin Mian, but he was not as familiar with Lei Tie as Zhang Dashuan was with Lei Tie. He called Zhang Dashuan and when they passed by the old house, he saw Lei Xiangli at home and called him too.

Wu Di stood at the door of the kitchen and looked inside curiously. He was shocked to see that Lei Tie was indeed washing the rice. He looked at Qin Mian with admiration and then went back to sit down.

“Do you hear that? They invited you to go hunting.” Qin Mian shouted towards the kitchen.

Lei Tie’s voice came from inside the kitchen, “Heard it. Go after breakfast.”

“I’m going, too.” Qin Mian was idle and bored at home.

“En.”

Qin Mian laughed, and then asked Lei Xiangli, “Fourth brother, you don’t sell soup today?”

Lei Xiangli said: “Yesterday, the work of dredging up the river had been completed. Speaking of which, I’d like to thank eldest sister-in-law, we’d made a lot of money this time.”

Of course, those sitting here would not ask how much they had earned.

Qin Mian said with a faint smile, “It’s nothing. You, third brother, fifth brother and little sister have also helped us a lot. We’ve keep it in mind.”

Lei Xiangli could hear the implication of his (QM) words. He smiled and said no more.

Wu Di said: “Let’s go back and come back to Brother Tie’s house after breakfast.”

The three left together.

Qin Mian made a spicy and sour cabbage, and a stewed radish with pork ribs. After breakfast, Lei Tie wiped his treasured bow and put 20 arrows into the quiver.

Qin Mian put on his hat, fastened his scarf and was ready to go.

Not a while later, Lei Xiangli and the other two came, with each of them carrying a bow set and a basket on their back.

The five of them joked and chatted freely as they walked to the back of the mountain. It was only Qin Mian who was empty-handed.

Zhang Dashuan and the other two were well aware that Qin Mian only followed for amusement.

After entering the mountain, the few of them consciously quieted down. For a while, they could only hear the sound of foot trampling on leaves or dead

branches.

Zhang Dashuan was at the front, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were at the rear. Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di and Lei Xiangli were not experienced hunters, their archery skills were average. Qin Mian and Lei Tie intended to give them more opportunities.

In the forest, pheasants and wild hares were the most common. Soon after, Zhang Dashuan saw a big, fleshy pheasant pecking in the grass. He stopped and waved to Lei Xiangli and Wu Di. Lei Xiangli and Wu Di crept to the other two directions and the three men surrounded the pheasant in a triangle.

Zhang Dashuan took out an arrow, aimed at the pheasant and pulled the bow before letting go of the string. The arrow brushed past the edge of the pheasant's feathers and stuck in the dried up grass.

The pheasant was frightened. It clucked and fluttered its wings as it fled.

“Ah, too bad!” Wu Di was greatly disappointed. In a moment of desperation, he estimated where the pheasant fell, stretched out his hands and went over.

The pheasant probably did not expect that someone would try to catch it with bare hands. In the middle of a crisis, it burst out with great potential. Its two claws kicked on the tree trunk to turn its body around, and then it flapped its wings and flew to another place.

Wu Di fell to the ground forthwith.

Right at this time, with a “whoosh” sound, a feather arrow accurately hit the pheasant. When the pheasant died, it fell to the ground.

When Wu Di looked at the back, Lei Tie was putting down his arms. The arrow just now was shot by him.

Qin Mian, Lei Xiangli and Zhang Dashuan all burst into laughter when they saw Wu Di's embarrassed look.

Wu Di's face turned red and he quickly got up from the ground.

Zhang Dashuan kept laughing, "Wu Di, we're here to hunt, not to catch chickens. Haha..."

"I was momentarily anxious?" Wu Di patted the grass off his body.

Qin Mian picked up the pheasant and put it into Wu Di's basket.

Wu Di quickly took out the pheasant, "No, it's Brother Tie's prey."

Qin Mian threw the pheasant back into his basket and said generously, "Just take it. He doesn't care about this one."

"No." Wu Di firmly said, "It's yours since it was Brother Tie who hunted it. In case I haven't hunted anything when we go down the mountain, I'll be cheeky and ask Brother Tie for one. Sister, I'll temporarily hold this for you."

Qin Mian had no choice but to nod.

As they went on, they met another two pheasants. Unfortunately, Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Wu Dui missed them.

It was rare for Lei Tie taking the initiative to instruct them.

Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Wu Di could be considered to have been taught. Lei Xiangli shot a pheasant and a hare. Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di each hunted a pheasant.

Lei Tie had the best luck. He hunted two pheasants and a mountain bamboo-partridge.

"I want to try it, too." Watching them, Qin Mian's hands felt itchy and reached his hand to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie explained: "This is a hundred *dan*[2]-force bow, you can't pull it."

Qin Mian was irritated and felt that he had been looked down upon, “How do you know if I don’t try?”

Lei Tie had no choice but to pass the bow to him.

Qin Mian drew an arrow from the quiver on Lei Tie’s back and set it up. Learning from Lei Tie’s posture, he aimed at a leaf on the ground and pulled the bowstring. The bowstring hardly moved.

Qin Mian internally said “far from good” and peeped at other people.

Zhang Dashuan and the other two all turned their heads, looking away from him. But Qin Mian could see that they were laughing. He said with a straight face: “What’s funny? Will you be able to pull it?”

Lei Tie leaned to his shoulder and whispered: “I’ll make you a small bow some other day.”

Note:

[1] Their bed [heatable brick bed] is a warming stove, so the clothes were warmed on the bed.

[2] 1 dan = 100 kg, so then 100 dan-force = 10000 kg-force [wow]

Chapter 060: Little Black Wolf

060 – Little Black Wolf

“I’ll try.” Zhang Dashuan believed that his strength was not small, that he felt competitive. He stepped forward, took up the strong bow in Qin Mian’s hand, exerted all the strength of his arms and shook his head calmly, “Can’t.”

Lei Xiangli and Wu Di also tried out of curiosity and they could not move it either. They admired Lei Tie’s strength.

“See?” Qin Mian once again straightened up his waist as he complacently said.

Lei Xiangli handed over his own bow and arrow, “Eldest sister-in-law, do you want to use mine?” Lei Tie’s strong bow could hunt wild boars, bears, tigers and other big animals. Small bows like him could only shoot small things such as pheasants and hares.

Lei Tie gave him a look, stretched out his hand and pushed it back. He said to Qin Mian: “I’ll bring you here again after you learn.”

Qin Mian nodded happily, “Alright.”

The few men continued to go up the mountain. Suddenly, they heard a burst of sound which seemed to be something big.

Lei Tie and Zhang Dashuan both raised their bows and arrows with vigilance.

When the bushes in front of them were pushed aside, a young man in gray cloth came out with a bow in his hand, and was stunned to see them.

He stepped aside and another person came out behind him. It was also a young man with bow set on his back, wearing a white hunting suit with fox fur wrapped on his collar, silver thread in the clothes seam, and a sheep-fat white jade pendant hanging from his waist. His entirety exuded nobility and his face looked somewhat haughty.

Behind him was another man with a square face, dressed in the same clothes as the one who came out first. It was obvious that these two gray-clothed men were attendants of the white-clothed man.

Since the two sides did not know each other at all, they only made eye contact and then brushed past.

However, Qin Mian suddenly heard a sorrow and angry whine coming out of the basket of the last walking man. He felt an indescribable sense of heaviness in his heart. His steps paused, and then he shook his head amusingly. *It must be their prey in the basket. Isn't the natural law being the weak are the prey to the strong?*

“What’s wrong?” Lei Tie took his hand.

Qin Mian shook his head and said: “Nothing.”

At this time, there was a sound of heavy object fell at the back. Qin Mian looked back. On the ground lay a black prey whose limbs and mouth were entangled in ropes, struggling desperately. It turned out that the prey was unwilling to be caught. Even if it was tied like this, it jumped out of the basket!

The white-clothed man had already turned back. After he was taken aback, he applauded and smilingly said: “Good! The more powerful it is, the more I’ll feel accomplished after it is tamed!”

The square faced attendant rushed to catch the prey. Once again, the thing exerted its strength to twist its body, turned its head and looked at Qin Mian as if it knew him.

Qin Mian took a close look and was astounded. The prey was a dog with black fur all over the body. There was a pinch of white fur in the middle of both ears, like a white spot, which was exactly the same as the black dog he had saved in the previous life! The only difference was that this dog was smaller than the dog at that time, only slightly larger than an adult cat.

After being astounded, he rushed to pick up the dog. The dog was also strange, not only was it not afraid of him, but it also wriggled to his side. Qin Mian picked it up. As soon as the black dog was in his arms, it strangely quieted down, staring at the white-clothed man and his attendants with indifferent eyes.

For a moment, everyone was stunned.

The square faced attendant first reacted, sternly rebuked: “What do you think of doing?”

Lei Tie strode in large steps to Qin Mian’s side, embraced his shoulders, and looked at that attendant coldly.

Although Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Wu Di felt that things were baffling, they were not afraid. They came over and stood with Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

The smile on the white-clothed man’s face gradually disappeared. He stared at Qin Mian with a bad look.

Qin Mian also knew that things were not easy to deal with, but he could not let go of the black dog. He looked at the white-clothed man apologetically with sincere meaning, “This gongzi, sorry for my impoliteness. But as you can see, this dog knows me. To tell you the truth, he once saved me. I’m willing to pay for it, gongzi can name a price.”

The white-clothed man’s expression was cold and his eyes narrowed as he sneered contemptuously and said nothing.

The square faced attendant snorted coldly, “Is our gongzi looks like a person short of money? Put it down quick! Otherwise, don’t blame us for

being rude.”

Qin Mian frowned and tried to fight for it. “Naturally, I can see that gongzi is not short of money, but this dog is just a prey to gongzi. We’re willing to hunt a few more preys and exchange them all with you for this one. What do you think?”

Another attendant raised his eyelids and said impatiently: “What a rural boy like you know? It’s a rare and clever thing. Our gongzi chased it for three days before it was caught. We want to take it back and tame it. No other prey can match it. That’s enough, there’s need for me to be wordy with you. Quickly put it down.”

The square faced attendant glared and said fiercely: “Still not putting it down? Do you really want us to make a move?”

Seeing the situation headed to bad end, Zhang Dashuan advised Qin Mian in a low voice, “These people don’t seem simple. We ordinary people can’t afford to provoke them.”

Qin Mian’s heart sank. Momentarily, he was out of ideas and helplessly looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie gave him a reassuring look. He pinched his (QM) shoulder with his right palm and let go. He took out a small green porcelain bottle from his bosom and walked to the white-clothed man.

Just now, the white-clothed man had been looking at the man with scar on his face. His intuition told him that this was not an ordinary man.

“Has Your Excellency heard of ‘Qingli Pill’?” Lei Tie dully asked.

The white-clothed man, who originally leaned against the tree trunk, moved slightly when he heard the words and stood up straight. There was a look of doubt in his eyes, “Qingli Pill as in the legendary pill that can solve any strange poison and is called the Godly Pill by people? Is there really such a thing in this world?”

Qin Mian was shocked. He quickly went over and pulled Lei Tie's sleeve. He whispered: "We'll think of other ways."

Lei Tie used his eyes to hint at Qin Mian to keep calm and not getting excited. Then, he said in a low voice: "Good. Take this pill in exchange for your prey."

"Gongzi, be careful." The two attendants were quick to remind. How could a rural man have that magical pill?

The white-clothed man hesitated, "How do I know that this pill is real?"

Lei Tie handed the porcelain bottle to him, "That's up to Your Excellency's courage, insight and knowledge."

When the white-clothed man looked at the porcelain bottle, his look changed slightly. This porcelain bottle was not an ordinary porcelain, but superior heavenly jade porcelain. This kind of porcelain was not easy to fire [make], and could be used to detect poison. It was extremely valuable. Such a small porcelain bottle alone was worth at least 500 taels of silver. It was impossible for such a porcelain bottle to hold a fake pill. At worst, even if the pill inside was fake, it was not a loss to exchange a prey for a porcelain bottle worth 500 taels of silver.

The white-clothed man stared at Lei Tie for a long time, but Lei Tie was always calm.

The white-clothed man hesitated for a moment before putting the porcelain bottle in his bosom. "The prey is yours." With that, he left in a hurry. He wanted to find an expert to identify the pill in the bottle as soon as possible.

The two attendants looked at each other in surprise and followed quickly.

"Gongzi, wait for us!"

The three soon disappeared deep in the forest.

With Zhang Dashuan and the two as bystanders, Qin Mian could not ask about the QingLi Pill in detail, so he had to bear his question and untied the

rope on the little black dog.

The little black dog whimpered at him and lay soft on the ground, panting slightly.

Seeing it was weak, Qin Mian took out the water bag in the basket and fed it water.

Wu Di squatted on one side and asked curiously: “Sister, did it really save you?”

“En.” Qin Mian said, “I saved this dog, and this dog also saved me.” He had always believed that his rebirth and the space given to him by the black dog at that time had an inseparable relation. Although it was not clear whether this dog was the same as the previous one, but since they met, it was predestined. He could not look on unconcerned.

“This is a wolf.” Lei Tie glanced at his wife with an unknown meaning. His wife had said that he did not remember the past, but he remembered the wolf. Well, there was one more doubtful point about his wife.

“Ah?” Qin Mian was flabbergasted, “Is it really a wolf?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Zhang Dashuan and the other two men were also stunned. They looked at the little thing drinking the water in Qin Mian’s hand. They could not believe it was a wolf. Wolves had always been fierce and bloodthirsty beasts in their minds.

The little black wolf drank the water mixed with the spiritual spring water, and soon stood up.

Qin Mian rubbed its head, “Alright, it’s fine now. Go. Don’t get caught again.”

The little black wolf rubbed against his leg, then ran into the bush and disappeared.

Lei Xiangli said to Qin Mian with a wry smile: “Eldest sister-in-law, you’re really brave. You’re not afraid of it biting you when feeding water just now.”

“Right, I was also shocked.” Wu Di echoed.

Lei Tie looked cold and suddenly did not speak. If the wolf dared to bite, he had a way to stop it.

Qin Mian smiled faintly, “I always think that some animals are spiritual, can feel the kindness and malice of human beings.”

“It’s truly miraculous.” Zhang Dashuan touched his chin as he spoke, “I heard many stories about wild wolves going down the mountain to eat babies when I was a child. I never thought that wild wolves also possess human nature.”

The few of them sighed in place. Zhang Dashuan said: “Come on, continue to hunt.”

They hunted four pheasants, and also found a nearly 100 Jin wild boar. The bows and arrows of Zhang Dashuan and the other two were ineffective, but Lei Tie’s strong bow shot death the wild boar with one arrow.

Qin Mian was so happy. “Don’t have to spend money on pork for the New Year.”

Zhang Dashuan hurriedly said: “I heard that boar meat is more delicious than domestic pork. Tiezi, how about selling a portion to me?”

“I’ll buy some, too.” Wu Di said.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other and Qin Mian said: “Although the wild boar was hunted by Lei Tie, it’s thanks to the three of you for intercepting it. Don’t say about buying it, you two each get ten jin of meat. Fourth brother also took ten jin to give our parents a taste.”

Knowing that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not stingy people, Zhang Dashuan and the others gladly accepted it with few words of politeness.

“Is it noon already?” Lei Xiangli looked at the sky.

Qin Mian said to Lei Tie: “Just roast something on the mountain to eat.” He thought of the roasted chicken drumstick that Lei Tie gave him a long time ago, he missed the taste.

Lei Tie could be describe as agreeing with him in anything, thus he had no objection.

“We’re not in a hurry to go back.” Zhang Dashuan said, “Might as well eat together.”

Lei Xiangli and Wu Di also had no objection.

They followed Lei Tie to a stream. Lei Tie and Zhang Dashuan went to the water to kill the pheasants. Qin Mian, Lei Xiangli and Wu Di went to collect firewood nearby.

After the fire was lit, Lei Tie broke a branch, peeled the bark, and skewered the pheasant to roast. He took a bag of seasoning from his bosom and applied it with a small brush. Since Qin Mian invented the hot pot seasoning, he would bring a small bag of seasoning with him every time he went hunting. If he roasted food on the mountain, he could season it.

Zhang Dashuan and the other two naturally got some share.

Lei Tie was the most experienced. When the first pheasant was well roasted, he gave the whole pheasant to Qin Mian before he roasted a second.

Qin Mian tore off a drumstick for him and held the whole pheasant to gnaw at. The pheasant with seasoning tasted more tender and savory that once he took a bite, he wished he could swallow his tongue, too.

There was a rustling sound came from behind. The previously met little black wolf trotted over on the dead leaves and stood in front of Qin Mian.

Qin Mian laughed in spite himself and cut off the pheasant’s head, neck and rump with a small dagger and threw them to it.

The little black wolf swallowed it in a few bites, sat down quietly next to Qin Mian, and wagged its tail from time to time, looking like a dog again.

Only when Qin Mian, Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Wu Di almost finished eating did Lei Tie's pheasant was roasted. In a low voice, he asked Qin Mian, "Are you full?"

Qin Mian nodded, "Too full."

Lei Tie divided the roasted pheasant into two parts and threw the half to the little black wolf.

The little black wolf looked at him and bowed its head as it gnawed at it.

Zhang Dashuan, Lei Xiangli and Wu Di vaguely understood why Lei Tie did this. They all looked towards Qin Mian.

As if nothing happened, Qin Mian quietly pinched his hot ear roots.

TL's side note: Since some didn't understand/missed the points in the last few paragraphs, let me simplify. They weren't flirting, simply the act of Lei Tie more generous than Qin Mian when treating his so-called savior, the wolf, that others could perceive Lei Tie as being more grateful to the wolf on behalf of his wife. I mean, Lei Tie gave half of a whole pheasant [of his lunch] to the wolf, but Qin Mian only gave a head, neck and rump. And therefore, Qin Mian was embarrassed. Does it make sense? I hope I make sense.

Chapter 061: White Spot

061 – White Spot

After filling their stomachs, they carried the boar down the mountain.

The little black wolf followed Qin Mian quietly.

Wu Di said in surprise: “It’s not going to follow sister down the mountain, right?”

Qin Mian was more than happy. At home, it was somewhat lonely with only him and Lei Tie. He had wanted to keep a pet for a long time. If the little black wolf was willing to follow them, it would be great.

“If it wants to follow, let it follow.” Qin Mian pondered, “But Brother Zhang, fourth brother, and Wu Di, you all better not say that it’s actually a wolf, so as not to frighten the villagers.”

Zhang Dashuan and the other two complied with it.

Zhang Dashuan reminded: “But you need to restrain it, don’t catch the chicken and oust the duck.” The little black wolf was still young, he was not afraid that it would hurt people.

“Don’t worry.” Qin Mian guaranteed, and glanced at Lei Tie, “And about Qingli Pill, I hope you all don’t mention it either.” After living together for so long, he could see that Lei Tie did not want to mention the past.

Zhang Dashuan and the other two promised one after another.

Qin Mian did not want to dirty the yard, so he asked Lei Tie and Zhang Dashuan to put the boar at the river bank and deal with it there.

Wu Di initiatively said: "I'm going to invite Uncle Liao." Uncle Liao was an expert at pig slaughtering. Whenever some villagers wanted to slaughter pigs, they would ask of him.

"I'll go home and get a basin for the meat." Qin Mian said.

Lei Tie asked Lei Xiangli to guard the river and left with Qin Mian. He was going back to bring firewood.

The little black wolf closely followed the pace of the two men.

After entering the house, the little black wolf silently watched Qin Mian rubbing the dirt on the bottom of his feet on the foot mat, and imitated him. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were secretly surprised.

Without waiting for the two men to talk, the little black wolf stepped first into the house. After it unhurriedly rounded in each room, it came out and quietly squatted on the side of the settee.

Qin Mian found two basins and two bamboo baskets, while Lei Tie carried a bundle of firewood from the back of the house. The little black followed them out again.

Back at the river bank, Lei Tie had now built a simple stove and boiled water for later use.

When the villagers heard the news, they came one after another to watch the bustling scene.

Uncle Liao had not use his knife for several months, but his skill had not turned rusty. He skillfully handled the wild boar.

There were quite a few households kept smiling and wanted to buy the boar meat at the price of domestic pork. Qin Mian did not agree. Wild boar meat was more delicious than domestic pork. It costed 8 Wen per jin. If he was willing to sell at the price of domestic pork, even if these people took advantage of him, they might still call him stupid behind his back. Why

bother. True friendship could not be cultivated by a few coppers; he might as well make it loud and clear.

In the end, Qin Mian only gave Lei Xiangli, Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di 10 jin each, and gave Uncle Liao 5 jin to thank him.

Uncle Liao smilingly took the meat back, but also said to Lei Tie that if he wanted to slaughter a pig in the future, he could go to him at any time.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie took the rest of the meat home to cure and hung to dry.

After all work was done, Qin Mian had time to ask about Qingli Pill.

“What you said about the Qingli Pill is true?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian was startled and knocked over a teacup. The tea half dripped on the tea table and flowed to the ground. “That kind of thing is very valuable. Although I wanted to save the little black wolf, I could think of another way at that time.”

Seeing that the tea was going to flow to Qin Mian’s feet, but Qin Mian did not notice, Lei Tie shook his head slightly and moved his feet away. He picked up the rag under the tea table and wiped the liquid.

“Don’t think about it. A treasure is a treasure when it works; a waste when it is useless.”

Qin Mian was still very concerned, “The white-clothed doesn’t seem like an ordinary man. What do if he asks you again after using the Qingli Pill?”

Lei Tie said leisurely: “I’ve means. Don’t worry.”

Qin Mian did not know what to say for a moment. He looked at the man in a daze. After a long while, he said in a battle cry: “It’s true that I saved it, and it’s true that it saved me.”

“I believe.” Lei Tie looked at him while the corners of his lips lightly raised and his deep eyes unexpectedly carried two points of banter.

Qin Mian understood his meaning as soon as he turned it in his mind. He said he did not remember the past, but remembered the little black wolf, was it not inconsistent? There was a rush of heat from the roots of his ears. He did not know how to go through the motions, so he shouted “ah” in embarrassment, looked away, and said in a loud voice: “The little black wolf will probably live with us. What name should we give?”

“You decide.” Lei Tie picked up the teapot and poured a cup of tea for him again.

The little black wolf seemed to know that they were talking about it and looked at them with its head up.

Qin Mian looked at the white spot on its head and said with a smile: “Why not name it ‘White Spot’.”

“Proper.” Lei Tie commented concisely and comprehensively.

“Good. You’ll be called ‘White Spot’.” Qin Mian bent down and touched the head of the little black wolf.

The little black wolf did not move and let him touch it.

“By the way, it’s better to make a hole in the wall of the courtyard for it to get in and out.” Qin Mian said to Lei Tie, “I don’t think it’ll stay at home the whole day.”

Lei Tie stood up. “I’m going to do it.”

After Lei Tie went out, Qin Mian sighed slightly and fell back on the settee. Lei Tie knew that he had not lost his memory, but he (LT) did not ask. What did it mean? Lei Tie really did not mind him lying? However, now it seemed that not only he had secrets, but Lei Tie also had secrets. He had heard the white-clothed man said that the Qingli Pill was very precious,

how could Lei Tie have it in possession? The decade he left must have been hard.

He did not know why but when he thought of Lei Tie having something to hide from him, he felt very uncomfortable.

There was pounding sound in the courtyard. Qin Mian shouted out: "Don't knock down the whole wall."

"It won't." Lei Tie's voice was smooth and steady.

Qin Mian turned over to stand and walked out, White Spot slowly followed after him. Although it was still young, its posture had the arrogance characteristic of a wolf.

A few bricks at the side of the courtyard gate and closed to the ground had been shattered by Lei Tie, revealing a hole larger than a plate. Lei Tie used a hammer to break some of the protruding sharp edges and corners to prevent White Spot from getting scratched.

Qin Mian squatted beside him, pointed to the hole and said to White Spot: "White Spot, you'll come in and out from here when there is no one at home, understand?"

White Spot looked at him, lowered its body and crawled out of the hole in the wall with its belly against the ground. In a moment, it drilled in from the outside.

Qin Mian said in pleasant surprise: "I knew you're smart."

White Spot, as if it was not satisfied with his praise, shook its ears and sat quietly at his feet.

"Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law."

Lei Chuntao walked into the gate with a smile on her pretty face and with her was Wei Shi.

"You are both at home." Wei Shi said with a smile.

Qin Mian politely said: “Little mother is here.” After Wei Shi entered the household, she approached him several times, all of which were bypassed by him. He had no intention of getting close to Du Shi and neither did he have intention of approaching Wei Shi. He did not want Du Shi’s attention to return to him and Lei Tie because of Wei Shi’s action. How good it would be to *sit on the mountain and watch the tigers fight*[1]?

With a bowl in her hands, Wei Shi spoke briskly, “I’m here to thank you two for the boar meat. This is the fried dumplings made this early morning. Your little sister said it’s very delicious, so we sent some to you.” In name, she was Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s little mother, but after all, between the sexes there should be a prudent reserve. It was easy to cause gossip if she came alone, so she asked Lei Chuntao to join her.

Qin Mian held the bowl. “When we hunted the wild boar today, fourth brother also made great efforts, so we distributed some meat to him. Little mother don’t need to be so polite.”

Wei Shi’s smile stiffened. She could not help but reevaluate Qin Mian. The youth was not very old, but she did not expect he would be very difficult to deal with.

Qin Mian went into the house and poured the fried dumplings into his own bowl. He returned the bowl to Wei Shi. He said meaningfully: “Much thanks to little mother for remembering me and Lei Tie. In fact, Lei Tie and I are not small anymore. We can take good care of ourselves. As long as you take good care of father and mother, we’ll be at ease.”

Wei Shi took the bowl and gave a wee smile. She was speechless for a moment.

Lei Chuntao saw White Spot and happily walked over, “*Yah*, eldest sister-in-law, is it the little black dog you found? It’s lovely.”

“It’s called White Spot.” Qin Mian reminded, “Be careful. It doesn’t know you now. I’m afraid it’ll be very fierce.”

Facing White Spot's deep and serene eyes, Lei Chuntao felt a little scared and did not dare to approach.

Wei Shi noticed three [Sichuan] pepper trees in the courtyard and asked curiously: "What kind of flowers are these?" She subconsciously thought it was a flower.

The [Sichuan] peppers on the trees had already been picked by Qin Mian and planted in spring.

"It's planted for fun." Qin Mian pretended to be ignorant.

Wei Shi did not ask any more questions. She invited him: "In the evening, I'm going to cook some dishes with the wild boar meat. There are dry pot wild boar meat and braised wild boar meat in soy sauce. You two can also come to eat. You men can have a good drink."

Qin Mian graciously declined: "Many thanks, little mother. However, we're a little tired today, so we won't go."

Helpless, Wei Shi had to say: "Alright, let's get together when there's a chance later. Chuntao, it's time to go back."

After seeing them go far away, Qin Mian said to Lei Tie: "I can do dry pot wild boar meat and braised wild boar meat in soy sauce."

Lei Tie looked up at him and then lowered his head, "Eat these two dishes in the evening?"

"Braised pork is too greasy to eat for dinner." Qin Mian said, "In the evening, I'll make dry pot wild boar meat, steamed pork with flour, and then stir-fried green vegetable. I'm going to the vegetable garden. White Spot, go."

Lei Tie watched him walk far with the basket while yelling at White Spot and only then did he took back his gaze.

The vegetables in the garden had grown, mostly because they had been watered with spiritual spring water. The vegetables were free of insects and

grown very well.

Qin Mian picked out a basket of green spinach and looked around. Seeing no one around, he secretly poured a small amount of spiritual spring water into the field.

Back home, the same old rules applied. Lei Tie trimmed and washed the vegetables.

Because there was White Spot, Qin Mian deliberately made a bit more dry pot wild boar and steamed pork with rice flour. He put a bowl on the ground for White Spot, and then served the dishes onto the table.

“Drink a few cups?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie was surprised, but immediately said, “I’ll get the wine.”

They sat down next to each other as Lei Tie poured two cups of wine.

Qin Mian took a mouthful from the cup. It tasted so pungent that he stuck out his tongue. His brain also blanked for two seconds. *My God, this wine is much stronger than those modern ones.*

Note:

[1] (idiom) watch in safety whilst others fight then reap the rewards when both sides are exhausted

Chapter 062: Gift from Lei Tie

062 – Gift from Lei Tie

Lei Tie reproached: “Don’t drink too fast. Have food.”

After Qin Mian took a bite of spinach to dampen his mouth, he felt slightly more comfortable. He ate another piece of steamed pork with rice flour, picked up his wine cup and clanked it with Lei Tie’s as he said: “Drink.” This time, he drank slowly and tasted a bit of flavor. The heat on his face gradually became heavier and he hurriedly clipped dishes to eat.

Lei Tie drank a big mouthful and did not urge him.

As the dusk sunk deeper, and the room turned darker, he got up to lit the oil lamps in each corner of the central room, lighting up the room.

Qin Mian touched his feverish face and felt a little discontented. *If you are a male, you need to know how to drink (alcohol). How can only one sip turn your face red? Alcohol tolerance should be exercised when young.* Thinking of this, he raised his neck and drank up the rest of the wine in the cup.

Lei Tie frowned and put dishes in his bowl.

“Wine is nothing good. Why do so many people like it?” Qin Mian said that and yet he poured another cup.

Lei Tie took away his cup. “Eat more before drinking.”

“Oh.” Qin Mian’s head was a little dizzy and his reaction was also a little slow. He obediently took a few clips of dishes and dug in.

Lei Tie took advantage of his muddle-headedness to put some of the three dishes into his bowl.

Qin Mian wiped out more than a half [bowl]. Seeing the wine cup from the corner of his eye, he picked it up and took a mouthful. Then he held it up, “Another cup.”

“Drink less, eat more.” Lei Tie said.

“No, I want to practice drinking.” Qin Mian reached for the wine jar.

Lei Tie picked up the wine jar first and only poured him half a cup. Qin Mian clucked his tongue, held his (LT) hand with both hands, and then released it when the wine cup was filled up. He smiled satisfactorily and emphasized: “I can drink it.”

Lei Tie put the wine jar farther away.

Qin Mian finished his drink in one shot. Thinking that it was not a big deal, he went to pick up the wine jar again. Accidentally, he knocked down the wine jar and it dropped onto the ground. With a “pa” sound, it broke all over the floor.

“En? Not on purpose...” Qin Mian stood up, but his legs went soft and he trembled.

Lei Tie quickly supported the person with his hands, placed him on a chair at the side, and looked at him carefully. The youth’s body went soft, his eyes looked misty with an expression that was hard to make out distinctly and his cheeks were flushed.

“Drunk.”

“Is it? Oh...” Qin Mian blanked for quite a while before reacting. He wanted to stand up, “I’m going to sleep.”

Just as he stood up, he trembled. Lei Tie simply hugged him.

Qin Mian dizzily fell on him. With both hands on his shoulders and mouth dried, he subconsciously licked his lips.

Lei Tie's eyes darkened and the arms wound around the youth's waist tightened. After quite a while, he suddenly lowered his head, took an enduring gentle breath, slowly approached the youth's lips, and carefully dropped a light kiss on the youth's forehead.

The slight itch on his forehead made Qin Mian shook his head uneasily. It happened that Lei Tie lowered his head and his lip accidentally brushed the tip of his (QM) nose. The alcohol smell in their mouths intertwined together, fermenting all the more intense smell like an incapacitating drug.

All the heat in Lei Tie's body instantly spread to his chest and finally gathered into an impulse. His left palm clasped the back of Qin Mian's head and his lips sealed Qin Mian's lips without any gap.

Qin Mian's brain was in a state of chaos. He opened his eyes with great effort and opened his mouth to say something, but his tongue was suddenly caught. The hot temperature and the speed of churning dispelled his doubts and his remaining strength.

It was not until the other person had difficulty breathing that Lei Tie regained his senses. His dark eyes returned to clarity as he looked down at the person leaning on his chest meekly. He raised that person's chin and was stunned. He had actually fainted.

Lei Tie flicked the hair on the forehead of the person in his arms, pecked at it gently before picking him up horizontally and walked to the bedroom.

.....

Qin Mian opened his eyes with difficulty and closed them quickly. His head felt heavy and stuffy. There was a small hammer on both temples that kept beating. He stretched out two index fingers and rubbed them, "Hurts, hurts, hurts!"

A pair of big warm hands moved his hands away and helped him rub his temples.

Qin Mian opened his eyes and unexpectedly saw that Lei Tie was still in bed. He turned to look out of the window. It was bright outside.

“You actually didn’t get up, too?”

Lei Tie’s eyes swept down his body.

Qin Mian realized that his leg was on his (LT) lap and quickly drew it back. His stomach growled. He sighed and sat up.

Lei Tie pressed down his shoulder. “Wait.”

Qin Mian stared blankly at him when he got dressed, set a small table on the heatable brick bed, and walked out. After a while, he came in with a tray and put three dishes and a bowl of rice on the table.

Qin Mian looked at him curiously, “You made it?”

Lei Tie said: “Just warm it up, I can. Put on your outer garment.”

Qin Mian was really hungry. Regardless of whether he had not washed his face and rinsed his mouth, he took up the rice bowl to eat.

Lei Tie scrutinized his expression and knew that he did not remember about last night.

“Why are you in a daze? Don’t you eat?” Qin Mian asked in a puzzled way.

“I’m going to practice fist [boxing] first.”

Qin Mian felt that he was a little strange. He sped up, put on his clothes quickly after he was full and came to the yard.

The sun was already three poles high, but Lei Tie was still practicing fist in the yard with sweats hanging on his angular handsome face.

Qin Mian thought it was not his own illusion that the changing style's speed of Lei Tie's fist practice was faster and fiercer than before, which seemed like he was venting something. He picked up a stone and threw it over. Lei Tie, as if he was not aware of it, continued to finish his fist practice.

Qin Mian's chest felt a little stuffy and his tone was not very good, "Who provoked you?"

Lei Tie looked at him for a moment and caught the grievance that he (QM) was unaware of in his (QM) eyes and felt immediately relieved.

"No one. Going to the shop later?"

Qin Mian's heart loosened, "I'll go wash up."

When he finished washing, Lei Tie had took the food out of the room and was sitting at the table, eating.

Qin Mian saw White Spot lying in the corner and writhing uneasily. It seemed very uncomfortable. He went to squat down and kneaded its head. "Lei Tie, what's wrong with it?"

Lei Tie pondered: "Yesterday's food was a little spicy, maybe—"

Qin Mian was worried, "It's my fault. I remember that wolves don't seem to eat salt, and it should have never eaten cooked food before. Maybe its stomach and intestines aren't adapted to it?" He quickly went to the kitchen, took a bowl of water, poured it into White Spot's food bowl, and fed it.

"What are you doing?" Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian beat around the bush: "I give it some water to make it clean its stomach and intestine. It'll probably be all right." In fact, this water was mixed with the spiritual spring water, which could alleviate White Spot's discomfort more or less.

Lei Tie was noncommittal. He ate while watching Qin Mian feed it water.

White Spot slowly drank the water and then lay down for a while. As expected, it recovered its lively appearance.

Qin Mian took some boar meat, cut it into small pieces and put it in its food bowl. With its head down, White Spot ate with gusto.

“Afterwards, feed it raw meat.” Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian nodded, “This time I was negligent.”

When Lei Tie finished the meal, the two men loaded the ox cart and were ready to go out. White Spot butted out of the hole in the wall and quickly jumped into the ox cart.

There is a gate, but you insist to bore through. Did White Spot like the hole in the wall? Qin Mian closed the courtyard gate and locked it with an amusing look.

Today was a fine sunny day without wind. The sunshine was warm on the body. On the way, they met an old man and his six-year-old grandson from the same village walking to town. Qin Mian politely invited them to get on the cart.

“Grandpa, little dog.” The little child pointed to White Spot as he spoke.

White Spot was very clever. Except for watching the old man and the little child warily, it had no sign of attacking.

The grandpa squinted and looked for a long time, “Why does it look like a wolf?”

Qin Mian’s heart thumped for a moment before he said solemnly: “It’s a wolfdog.”

“Oh.” The grandpa did not doubt. After all, a wolf would not get close to human beings.

Qin Mian admired his own quick wits. Later, if some people thought that White Spot was a wolf, he would insist that it was a wolfdog.

When the ox cart reached the door of the shop, Zheng Liu and Wang Shun came to greet them and carried the things on the cart down.

Lei Tie sat on the shaft and did not go down to the ground. He said to Qin Mian, "I'm going to the county."

"For what?" Qin Mian wondered.

Lei Tie said: "Buying a thing. There isn't in town."

Qin Mian saw that he had no intention to say more. Although he was upset, he also resisted from asking and casually waved his hand, "Go."

Lei Tie nodded and drove away.

"Small boss, you're here." Yue Dong came out.

Qin Mian took back his gaze and walked to the shop. "How's business these days?"

"Not bad." Yue Dong said, "There are still a lot of hot pot customers. For barbecue customers, they mainly ask to package for take away, but there are two fewer customers who eat spicy hot soup. Because the weather is getting colder, many people are reluctant to catch a chill outside the shop."

Qin Mian frowned, "It can't be help. It's not easy to rent a bigger shop in such a small town. Well, I'll think about some new dishes, hopefully it can attract more customers."

Yue Dong revealed a smiling expression, "This method should be feasible. To be honest with small boss, I've been thinking about it with the others these days, but we couldn't come out with any."

Qin Mian was happy, "That'll do! If you come up with a feasible one, your boss I will reward you."

Yue Dong smilingly responded: "All right. I'll tell them the good news in a while."

“En, also tell them that the closer to the end of the year, the more they can’t be negligent. If everyone performs well, we’ll close our shop on the 24th and give a year-end bonus so that everyone can have a good New Year.” Qin Mian said while walking to the counter to check the account book.

There was joy on Yue Dong’s face as his response echoed.

More than two hours later, Lei Tie came back.

Qin Mian did not ask him what he bought. They sat in the shop for a while and went home together.

Lei Tie went out with his bow set, a saw and a carpenter’s plane. White Spot followed him.

Qin Mian was angry. He did not ask what he was going to do or when he would come back. Instead, he wrote and drew with a pencil and paper.

It was only when it was dark that there was movement in the yard.

Lei Tie put a pheasant on the ground.

Qin Mian took a casual glance and raised his eyebrows. “Is that tooth print?”

White Spot wagged its tail, walked to his legs and rubbed against him.

“White Spot hunted it.” Lei Tie then explained, “We can’t keep it as a dog.”

Qin Mian nodded and somewhat listless, “I understand.”

Lei Tie came up to him, took out something from behind, and handed it to him.

Qin Mian’s eyes brightened. In Lei Tie’s hand was a delicate bow. The arm of the bow was polished to be as smooth as jade, and the color was bright yellow. He did not know what kind of wood it was, but he could see faint golden threads in it.

“This is...”

Lei Tie said: “The string was bought in the county and the bow was made by me. Like it?”

The suffocation in Qin Mian’s chest suddenly disappeared. He accepted it with joy, “I like it. So you went to the county to buy a string...”

Lei Tie said: “The string sold in town is not good enough.”

Qin Mian fondly stroked the little bow and suddenly noticed that there were still some small determined and cursive characters carved on the arm of the bow. After a closer look, it was “Tie Gifts Wife”. There was a line of small characters at the bottom of the bow about a certain day, a certain month and a certain year. His heart leaped and he looked up at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie was staring at him intently.

The two looked at each other for a long time, unable to move their eyes.

White Spot raised its head, rubbed against Qin Mian’s legs and glanced at the dining table. It seemed to be asking why the meal had yet been served.

Qin Mian pulled himself together, “Right, what kind of wood is this? Why are there golden threads in it?”

Lei Tie answered: “[Chinese] Mulberry wood.”

TL’s side note: I bet y’all are squealing... *hihihi*

Chapter 063: The Meal at the Relative's House Is Not Delicious

(1)

063 – The Meal at the Relative's House Is Not Delicious (1)

“Mulberry wood.” Qin Mian was surprised and held the little bow more tightly, “So this is mulberry wood. As far as I know, mulberry is a very precious wood, equal to yellow pear[1]. It can submerge or semi-submerge in water and its texture is stable and less warped. The core material of mulberry wood is only the thickness of a finger and there are yellow-like gold threads inside. This gold thread is not an annual ring, but only grows one in three to five years. It's not easy to find such wood.”

Lei Tie said: “As long as you like it.”

Qin Mian said: “Like it very much.”

He took the bow and arrows into the bedroom and cherishingly hung it with Lei Tie's big bow. When he came out, Lei Tie had served the food on the table.

“How about going up the mountain tomorrow?” Qin Mian asked excitedly.

Lei Tie said: “Practice shooting fixed target first, then practice shooting moving target.”

“So troublesome?” Qin Mian was disappointed.

Lei Tie lightly said: “How to run without learning to walk?”

That was quite reasonable. Qin Mian had nothing to reply with. He could only concede and got up to slice meat for White Spot...

The next day, Lei Tie inserted two sticks in the yard with an old straw hat hung as a target in the middle and asked Qin Mian to aim and shoot.

Qin Mian had only got his own bow and arrows. He was full of interest. With Lei Tie's guidance, he shot again and again tirelessly. At first, he failed to hit the target. After shooting seven to eight arrows, he found the feeling that he could hit the straw hat accurately and it was getting closer to the center.

In the beginning, Lei Tie only enticed him to have fun, but seeing that he had some talent, he (LT) was a little surprised and taught more seriously. First, he made him (QM) shoot an arrow 2 zhang (6.6 m) away from the straw hat and then retreated to 3 zhang (9.9 m) away, gradually widening the distance.

Qin Mian just began to learn archery. His arms were sore after some time and finished his practice at noon.

Lei Tie said: "From now on, only practice an hour every day. Haste makes waste."

Qin Mian nodded. He also felt that it was a bit unbearable; he could not even lift his arms. "What to eat for lunch?"

Lei Tie answered: "Hot pot, I make."

Qin Mian smiled and lay relaxed on the settee, "Sure. You make it, I wait to eat."

Lei Tie was not so particular about making hot pot as Qin Mian. After the water boiled, he poured in the seasoning, tasted the flavor, added salt when it tasted light, and put in the sliced meat, meatballs, potatoes, spinach and cabbage leaves brought back from the shop yesterday. By the time the meat and potatoes cooked, the spinach and cabbage leaves had turned too soft to even pick up with chopsticks.

Lei Tie's monotonous face showed a rare look of embarrassment. Before Qin Mian uttered ridicules, he calmly picked up some vegetables and cabbage leaves and added them in.

Fortunately, the taste was not bad.

At the thought that this man rarely cooked a meal, Qin Mian only laughed silently for a moment but did not tease him.

The rice was not cooked and just eating dishes was not enough. The two men put noodles into the hot pot to cook together.

Since there was a noodle maker, it was very convenient to eat noodles. Priory, a huge mass of noodles was pressed out with the noodle maker, hung to dry, and cut with scissors. The noodles were then kept in a dry drawer and cooked whenever they wanted to. It was just that there was no drying agent in this era that the dried noodles could only be kept for a month at most. Nevertheless, this was good enough.

At the dining table, Qin Mian mentioned about the business, "There are fewer people eating spicy hot soup recently. In the afternoon, we'll stay at home and make some radish balls, fish balls, sweet potato balls and vegetable balls. Do some trial sales first. If it's good to sell, hire people to do it." If it were not for making more money to expand the business, he definitely was not patient to do this every day.

Lei Tie nodded.

After lunch, they bought some sweet potatoes, potatoes, radishes, carrots and fish from the villagers.

Making sweet potato balls were the simplest. After the sweet potatoes were peeled, they were steamed. Then they were pressed into mashed sweet potatoes, added in some flour, mixed well, and kneaded into small balls. When the oil heated up, put them in and fried until they were golden yellow, chewy and fragrant. Making radish balls were easy. The radishes were chopped and mixed together with minced meat, eggs, flour and seasoning, and kneaded into balls before frying. The main ingredients of

vegetable balls were potatoes and carrots. The potatoes were steamed and pressed into puree, then mixed with shredded carrots, egg white and various seasonings before they were also fried.

Fish balls were relatively difficult to make. After the fish were cleaned, removed the bones and scraped the fish flesh with a knife. Next, added appropriate amount of ginger, salt and water and beat it into puree with a rolling pin. Then, added egg white, stirred in the same direction with chopsticks, added a little flour according to the consistency, and kneaded the fish paste into balls. Afterwards, added water in the wok, put the fish balls in over a low heat, and then turned to high heat. When all the fish balls floated, they could be fished out, soaked in cold water, and drained.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie kept busy until dark. They made more than 100 of sweet potato balls, radish balls and vegetable balls, while fish balls were less, at about 80.

There were no beef and mutton in the village. Otherwise, they could make some beef balls and mutton balls.

Dinner was rice and hot pot. A dozen of each kind of food balls was served. Qin Mian and Lei Tie both liked fish balls the best.

Sweet potato balls were sweet and estimated to be more popular with women.

The emergence of several kinds of food balls had once again brought a crowd of people into Eating Savory Restaurant.

Time flew and in a blink of an eye, the twelfth lunar month ushered in.

The words “New Year” were mentioned more often. The villagers who had raised fat pigs for the New Year’s festival lined up for Uncle Liao to slaughter them. Every few days in the village, one could hear the shrill cry of the pigs.

When it came to New Year’s pig slaughtering, one should mention the pig-slaughter meal. As the name suggested, one should invite people for a meal

after slaughtering the New Year's pig. One usually invited relatives and friends, as well as fellow villagers who they got along well.

The first pig-slaughter meal that Qin Mian and Lei Tie ate was Zhang Dashuan's and they did not expect to have another pig-slaughter meal after a day——

Upon seeing Lei Xiangyi and an old man about 50 years old walking through the gate of the courtyard, Qin Mian was stunned for a moment before he remembered that the old man seemed to be Lei Tie's paternal uncle-in-law, Dong Daniu. They met at the time Wei Shi married in.

“Uncle-in-law, please come in.” Lei Tie took a lukewarm attitude.

Qin Mian poured Dong Daniu a cup of hot tea.

After entering the door, Dong Daniu looked around slowly and very carefully, as if measuring the value of the items in the house. After a good while, he started to talk with a smile, “I won't drink tea as I still have to go to a few more houses. My family will slaughter pig tomorrow, so I'm here to invite you two to pig-slaughter meal. Tomorrow, come a bit earlier.”

Qin Mian said: “We'll definitely go earlier. It's fine to just let third brother come to inform us, how could we have the cheek to let uncle-in-law even come in person?”

Dong Daniu cheerfully said: “When you had house warming, our family was occupied, so no one came over. Today, I just took this opportunity to have a look. Your aunt and I are relieved to see that you two are doing well.” He did not mention about “splitting from the family”, only “house warming”.

Qin Mian smiled and remained silent. It matter not if one just casually listened to these words. As far as he knew, Dong Daniu had three sons in all. Even if there was something big happen to him, did he not even have time to send someone over to sit down for a while? Now he wanted to invite them to the pig-slaughter meal, it was strange no matter how one would think.

Dong Daniu seemed to have something else to do. He sat down for a while and left.

Lei Xiangyi deliberately slowed down a few steps and said in a low voice: “Uncle-in-law’s youngest son has been in prison. You two should be careful at their house tomorrow.”

Qin Mian was taken aback.

Lei Tie was also a bit shocked. He had been away for many years, so he really did not know the affairs of his relatives.

“Why did he go to prison?” Qin Mian promptly asked Lei Xiangyi.

Lei Xiangyi sighed. “It’s said that uncle-in-law and aunt spoiled Cousin Wei too much. When he’s young, he snuck around. When he’s grown up, he even dared to steal cow. He was fined 10 silver taels and sentenced to 2 years of imprisonment. He only came back in the seventh lunar month. He’s supposed to learn a lesson after a year in prison, but who knows he still doesn’t learn well after he came out – Anyway, be careful tomorrow.”

For the peasants of Great Xia Dynasty, ploughing and harvesting were their lifeblood. Therefore, the sentence was heavy.

After Lei Xiangyi left, Qin Mian thought for a moment and said tentatively to Lei Tie: “How about you go by yourself tomorrow?”

Lei Tie fixedly looked at him and did not speak.

Qin Mian also felt that he lacked loyalty and corrected himself as he said: “Alright, go together.”

Lei Tie said: “I won’t let him bully you.”

Qin Mian leaned against the armrest of the settee and looked at him, “Who is afraid of this? Anyway, I’ve learnt Kung Fu with you for so long and surely it doesn’t mean that I can’t beat him? I just don’t think it’s going to be any good tomorrow.”

After breakfast the next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie drove the ox cart to the old house to meet with the people in the old house. All the people of the old house were outside and Lei Xiangzhi happened to be on holiday this day, so he also went together. Because of the large number of people and that the Dong's village was a little far away, Lei Daqiang borrowed a donkey cart from a villager.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi took the ox cart, while Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, Wei Shi, Qian Shi, Zhao Shi, Lei Chuntao and the three children took the donkey cart. The two families went to Dong's village in great procession.

It had not rain recently. Although the village road was a dirt road, it was easy to tread on. The donkey cart wandered for nearly an hour. After passing through the dirt road between two ponds, it entered a village surrounded by willows and locust trees. Lei Tie pulled up after it.

This was Dong's village.

Lei Daqiang's older sister Lei Xiaoyun and his older brother-in-law Dong Daniu went to the door to greet them with a young man about 20 years old.

Lei Xiangyi whispered to Qin Mian: "That's Cousin Wei."

Qin Mian looked at Dong Wei secretly. He was quite tall, slightly fat, and actually had a fair skin with a pair of small bean-like eyes that wasted on a pair of double eyelids. He whirled around and seemed dishonest at first glance.

"Third brother, Sister Du, Sister Wei, you are all here. Come on in." Lei Shi took Du Shi and Wei Shi's arms affectionately, and pointed to Qin Mian as she said to Dong Wei, "These are your Cousin Tie and Brother Mian. Why don't you greet them?"

Dong Wei looked at Qin Mian up and down with an almost unbridled look, and then glanced at Lei Tie. He smiled ambiguously and said in well-manner: "Cousin Tie, Brother Mian, please come inside."

First impressions were really important. Qin Mian did not like Dong Wei because he did not call him “cousin” in public. Dong Wei only greeted him and Lei Tie, but turned a blind eye to Lei Xiangren and the others, saying that he did not have a favorable impression on them. Even a three-year-old child would not believe him.

Note:

[1] Also known as yellow rosewood; a precious wood because it is extremely stable, it does not deform, crack, or bend regardless of cold or heat, and has a certain degree of toughness, which can be used to make all kinds of special-shaped furniture.

Chapter 064: The Meal at the Relative's House Is Not Delicious (2)

064 – The Meal at the Relative's House Is Not Delicious (2)

There were many people sitting in the house. Lei Dagang, his wife, two sons, eldest daughter-in-law, two grandsons and two granddaughters were all present. Almost all of them were in the house. There was also Lei Xiaofeng's family. Lei Xiaofeng's husband's name was Wan Yangshu, their eldest daughter Wan Xiaoxiang was married, the only son Wan Yaozu married to Chen Shi, and the youngest daughter Wan Xiaorou was engaged and would marry in the fourth month of next lunar year. Lei Xiaoyun and Dong Daniu's eldest son Dong Ying, second son Dong Xiong, eldest daughter-in-law Wang Shi and second daughter-in-law Xiao Wang were entertaining the guests. Several little mischievous kids were running around the house, creating disturbance.

Lei Xiaoyun, Lei Dagang, Lei Daqiang and Lei Xiaofeng were siblings. It was only today that Qin Mian identified all the relatives of Lei Daqiang.

With so many people in the central room, it seemed crowded. But fortunately, the central room was big enough that otherwise, it really would not fit.

Lei Daqiang and Lei Dagang still had nothing to say between them. They said two polite words indifferently and greeted others respectively. After the exchange of greetings, everyone in the room could finally be seated.

A few gazes swept between Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian appeared to be unaware of it, sat quietly against the wall, folded his legs gracefully, and sipped a cup of hot tea from time to time.

Lei Tie, who had a poker face in the beginning, still had acted as if nothing had happened.

Not a while later, someone outside called out: “Come to catch pig!”

Several male guests got up to help or watch and the children also ran out to watch the bustling scene.

Qin Mian did not move, neither did Lei Tie.

Wei Shi said to Du Shi: “Sister, why don’t we go to the kitchen to help.”

Du Shi said scornfully: “No need to tell me, say it to the old man. How would he know you’re diligent if you don’t say it to him?”

Wei Shi was neither hurt nor angry, “Sister, are you angry with me? Strictly speaking, between you and me, you are closer to eldest sister, but it turns out I’m wrong. Since sister doesn’t instruct, I dare not move.”

Du Shi suddenly stood up. “Are you saying that I’m lazy?”

Wei Shi apologized: “Sister really misunderstood me. Well, I’ll go out and have a look.” With that, she departed.

Lei Tie suddenly spoke in low voice: “Du Shi is too weak.”

Qin Mian understood what he meant — Once Wei Shi completely suppressed Du Shi, Wei Shi might keep an eye on them both.

But he was not worried about this. He nudged his chin towards Lei Xiangzhi, who quietly frowned at Wei Shi’s back. “Fifth brother won’t let Du Shi suffer.”

Among the Lei brothers, Du Shi loved Lei Xiangzhi the most and Lei Xiangzhi was also the most filial to Du Shi. It was impossible for Lei Xiangzhi to watch Du Shi be restrained by Wei Shi. Once Du Shi was

guided by Lei Xiangzhi, her “combat effectiveness” would be comparable to that of Wei Shi’s. Therefore, Du Shi’s weakness was only temporary and her “struggle” with Wei Shi’s would continue on.

Dong Wei came over, “What are Cousin Tie and Brother Mian talking about? It’s boring to wait in the house. Shall I take you two out for a walk?”

Qin Mian looked at the courtyard. There were a lot of people crowded there. In the corner was the pigsty. Several big men gathered around to catch a pig. The pig of nearly 200 Jin was running around in the pigsty, incessantly whining. The sound was piercing to the ears. He nodded to Dong Wei casually.

They went out of the courtyard and walked along the village road.

In winter, everywhere in the village was a piece of withered land, thus there was no beautiful scenery. The three unintentionally went to a pond. Several withered and yellowed lotus stalks stood upright in the clear water, short and long, presenting loneliness. Occasionally, when a gust of wind blew, the water surface fluctuated slightly.

Dong Wei stopped and said with a smile, “Cousin Tie, I heard from my mother that you’ve opened a restaurant in the town. Presumably the business must be good.”

Lei Tie said: “Satisfactory.”

Dong Wei said: “Congratulations to Cousin Tie. I hope you can make a fortune. I heard there are five staffs in your shop?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian thought that Dong Wei would ask them to arrange for him to go to the shop to help. However, Dong Wei just smiled and changed the subject, “There is a rock at the back of our village that rolled down from the mountain a few years ago. It’s very strange in shape and quite famous close by. I’ll take you two to see it.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie took a look at each other. They did not know what he was planning and followed after him.

After seeing the rock, the trio slowly went back. Dong Wei did not talk about the shop anymore, but only talked about some unimportant matters.

As soon as Lei Xiaoyun saw her youngest son, she tipped him with a wink.

Dong Wei sent Qin Mian and Lei Tie into the central room and went out again.

Lei Xiaoyun pulled him aside and asked quietly: “Did Lei Tie agree to let you work in the shop?”

Dong Wei hugged his chest and leaned lazily, “I didn’t ask.”

Lei Xiaoyun was taken aback and poked him with her finger, “You child, didn’t I tell you—”

Dong Wei interrupted her, “Mother, don’t worry. I’ve a plan.”

“What is your plan? If you can work in your Cousin Tie’s shop, you can get at least 600~700 Wen a month.” Lei Xiaoyun said unhappily and somewhat frustrated. As a matter of fact, she knew her son’s virtue in her heart. He had taken a lot of bad habits from the prison that his whole person also changed a lot. When he first came back, she almost could not recognize him. But after all, he was a piece of meat that fell from her body. How could she not worry? The son of another family usually married at 16~17 years old. Her son was 19 years old and had been matched four to five times, but they all failed. What could he do if she did not think of a way?

Dong Wei quickly grasped her shoulder and comforted her in a low voice, “Mother, listen to me. Now the New Year is coming. How much money can I earn if I get to work in cousin’s shop? Today’s main thing is to get close to Cousin Tie and Brother Mian. If I drink a few more cups of wine with them at the dinner table, our relationship will naturally be closer. When it’s New Year, we’ll visit each other houses to pay the New Year’s greetings. Isn’t it a

good time to mention it then? Even if they don't want to celebrate the New Year, it's not good to not give face to you as the aunt? What do you think?"

Lei Xiaoyun's eyes brightened. She slapped him on the shoulder and said happily: "You still have a mean. However, your youngest [maternal] aunt is also very interested in Lei Tie and his wife. Maybe we've the same plan. What if she snatched them first?"

Dong Wei hesitated: "It can't be? I heard Yaozu is a shop assistant in a tailor shop and holds a very important position. Is there really a need for him to change job?"

"It can't be said for sure." Lei Xiaoyun disapproved, "Can the business of a tailor shop be better than that of a restaurant?"

Dong Wei thought for a moment, "Mother, don't do anything for the time being. Let's keep an eye first."

In the central room, Lei Xiaofeng was talking to Lei Tie and Qin Mian as Lei Xiaoyun expected. Her words were very euphemistic, but what she meant was to ask Lei Tie and Qin Mian to arrange Wan Xiaorou's fiancé to work in the restaurant.

Wan Xiaorou's fiancé Zhang Cheng was an honest man with a simple family's population. Lei Xiaofeng was willing to marry her youngest daughter to him because of this. One of the bad things about Zhang Cheng was that his family's condition was so-so. That was why Lei Xiaofeng wanted to find him something else to do, so that Wan Xiaorou could be more relaxed after marrying.

Qin Mian told her honestly that all the employees in the shop had signed employment contracts. Once they broke the contract, they would have to pay a large sum of money as compensation. Moreover, the lease term of the small shop was only a year and would not be rented after that.

Lei Xiaofeng was very disappointed, but did not insist on it. She smiled at them and went out.

The pig had been slaughtered. Lei Xiaoyun was washing the ribs in the yard and upon seeing that she had a bad expression, she asked with concern: “Youngest sister, what’s wrong?”

They were blood sisters. Lei Xiaofeng knew Lei Xiaoyun and could guess her mind. She did not hide it at once. “Eldest sister, I asked Lei Tie to find a job for Zhang Cheng, but was turned down...” Then, she proceeded to tell Lei Xiaoyun the original words spoken by Qin Mian.

Lei Xiaoyun’s heart thumped. She suddenly stood up and forgot about Dong Wei’s instructions for a moment.

“Youngest sister, I remember something. You help me wash these ribs first.”

Lei Xiaoyun hurried into the house to find Lei Tie and Qin Mian.

“Tiezi, Tiezi’s wife, you two come in. I want to talk to you about something.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie followed her into her and Dong Daniu’s side room.

“What do aunt need us for?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Xiaoyun gave them a handful of dried fruits and fried peanuts. “You’re both smart people, so aunt won’t beat around the bush. I want to ask you two to find job for your Cousin Wei. You must all have heard about Dong Wei’s imprisonment, but in fact, it’s not what people say. Dong Wei was framed...”

Qin Mian was noncommittal.

“He’s an honest boy from childhood to adulthood. After he came out of prison, he’s more sensible than before. But everyone thinks he’s a bad boy. Thus, from his return to now, he hasn’t found any job and a wife is far from it. Don’t you think he’s treated unjustly? Of the children in your generation, you two are the most promising, so aunt wants to ask you to help him.” Lei Xiaoyun pleaded in a low voice. A caring mother’s heart made one felt emotionally moved.

Qin Mian said with a wry smile: “Aunt makes things hard for us. If aunt had told us earlier, we’d be able to hire Cousin Wei to work for us, we’d most welcome. However, when we hired those staffs, all of them signed one year’s contracts. If the period is not up but someone is driven away, we’ve to compensate 20 silver taels per person. We’re a small business, how can we afford to pay?”

“The business in the restaurant is good. You can hire more people and arrange your own people in the shop, you’ll be more reassured?” Lei Xiaoyun said again.

Qin Mian explained: “There are already five staffs in the shop, it’s enough.”

Lei Xiaoyun’s face gradually turned cold. “After all that talking, you two just think my son came out of prison, you two look down on him and don’t treat us as relatives.”

Lei Tie said: “It’s aunt who raised a problem for us.”

Lei Xiaoyun stood up, composed her expression, and left without saying a word.

Qin Mian shrugged and took Lei Tie out.

After sitting in the central room for a while, the banquet started.

In addition to Lei Xiaoyun’s relatives and Dong Daniu’s relatives, there were also the villagers they were closed with. All together were four tables of guests; two tables in the central room and two tables in the courtyard.

“Xiaoyun, those two are your nephew and his male wife?” A middle-aged woman sitting next to Lei Xiaoyun pointed to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. She laughed with her mouth covered and her eyes tilted up[1]. She did not feel uncomfortable to do this kind of action at an old age.

Lei Xiaoyun glanced at the other side and dully said: “Yes. Sister Zaohua, eat the dishes. ”

Dong Wei frowned and looked at Lei Xiaoyun at the other table. *What's going on? Why is mother's attitude like this?*

“Two men as husband and wife; Xiaoyun, don't you feel uncomfortable looking at them?” The woman shook her head as she said, “You really... Why did you invite them?”

“Anyone coming is a guest.” Lei Xiaoyun said with a smile, “They insist on being together. Although I'm their aunt, I'm still an outsider. What can I say?”

Lei Tie's expression sank. He pulled Qin Mian to his feet, went to Lei Xiaoyun, and said indifferently, “Aunt, it's your younger brother who forced us to get married. An eldest sister is like a mother. If you'd any opinion, why didn't you advise him then?”

Lei Xiaoyun's expression turned rigid.

There was an awkward silence in the courtyard.

Other people's eyes fell on Lei Daqiang's face like needles, turning his face blue.

“We've something else to do, leaving first.” Lei Tie pulled Qin Mian and left directly.

Lei Dagang laughed and took a sip of wine leisurely. “Some people become more confused as they get older.”

“Lei Dagang, what do you mean?” Lei Daqiang put the chopsticks on the table with a “pa” and asked loudly.

“Heh heh.” Lei Dagang gave his grandson a piece of crisp and tender ribs and without lifting his eyes, “I didn't put a name. Anyone who is old and confused knew it himself. Simply by listening to the words of a village sorcerer, he forced his son to marry a man. Ah, it's true that people say, *‘if there's a stepmother, there's a stepfather’*.”

“You—” Lei Daqiang could not bear it anymore and raised his fist.

“You want to hit me? Come at me if you can.” Lei Dagang also stood up and said in disdain.

Lei Daqiang rushed over, “You’re seeking death!”

The person at the side quickly stopped him, “Hey, all of you stop talking!”

The courtyard turned into a scene of chaos.

Note:

[1] The act of misbehaving, insidious and treacherous

Chapter 065: Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together (1)

065 – Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together (1)

Neither Qin Mian nor Lei Tie looked back as they drove away in the ox cart.

Qin Mian was sure that it was mostly what Lei Xiaoyun said to others that the woman would say those words.

Due to being rejected, Lei Xiaoyun wanted to take out the matter of him and Lei Tie, making them upset. As the saying went, *even the emperor had three poor relatives*[1]. It was normal for these relatives to try to get along with them and ask for help. But once the goals could not be achieved, these relatives shot cold arrows behind their backs. These relatives were really detestable.

Lei Tie suddenly said: “Afterwards, no need to come.”

“Of course.” Qin Mian had no hesitation whatsoever and could not deny his heartache for Lei Tie. Without him, Lei Tie would be lonely now. If these so-called relatives really had feelings, Lei Tie would not have been forced to run away from home in the first place. Later, he would not have been forced to marry a man, let alone forced to leave the house with nothing... Now, those people wanted to take advantage of such appellations as “Aunt” and “Uncle”, but how could there be such a good thing in this world? Since they did not care about Lei Tie, why should he and Lei Tie care about them?

“Wronged you.” Lei Tie said quietly.

It did not matter to Qin Mian, “They’re just unimportant people to me [我 wǒ].”

Lei Tie suddenly gripped his (QM) hand. “En, they’re just unimportant people to us [我们 wǒ men].”

There was one more word in the sentence. Qin Mian was taken aback and then smiled briskly, feeling a little nervous and joyful in his heart. This guy cared so much about him.

Upon seeing him smiled, Lei Tie also faintly smiled, “Wife, I’m glad to have married you.”

Qin Mian was flustered. He looked everywhere at the mountains and the trees but him. He pretended not to hear those.

Lei Tie no longer said anything, simply gripped his hand and raised the whip to speed up.

Afterwards, they would not be alone with the two of them as family.

After the 20th of the twelfth lunar month, it gradually became colder. The cold wind blew like the scrape of blades and whimpered like an angry beast. The water in the pond froze and it was not a problem for adults of more than 100 jin to walk on the ice surface. The water in the well was like ice that every time one fetched water, one had to smash the ice with the bucket first. The sun disappeared for a few days, which seemed that a heavy snow was coming.

As the New Year approached, there was a nursery rhyme singing: “23rd, sacrifice to Kitchen God; 24th, sweep the house; 25th, make tofu; 26th, stew meat; 27th, slaughter rooster; 28th, make dough; 29th, steam mantou[2]; 30th, stay up all night and rejoice on the first day of the New Year.”

On the 23rd of the twelfth lunar month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the town to buy new clothes and New Year's goods. Qin Mian was worried that if there really was a heavy snow, it would be unsafe for the staffs with families outside the town to walk home. He gave them a lot of year-end bonus and took annual leave. The business would resume operation on the sixth day of the first month.

Yue Dong was a loner and had no place to celebrate the New Year. At first, Qin Mian hesitated to take Yue Dong home. After being rejected by Lei Tie, he did not mention it again. To be honest, he did not want an outsider to celebrate the New Year with them. Anyway, Zheng Liu warmly invited Yue Dong to spend the New Year at his home and Yue Dong readily agreed.

After handling the matter of the shop, Qin Mian and Lei Tie drove the ox cart home and planned to stay at home without going out before the sixth day of the first month.

It snowed heavily the next day. Large flakes of snow fell like goose feathers, one after another. No more than a moment, a layer of white snow accumulated on the roof, on the branches, on the courtyard walls, and even on the bamboo pole for clothes drying. Soon, a thick layer was also spread on the ground, like a white carpet, spotlessly white.

This was the first snow after he came to another world. Qin Mian dressed like a bear and curiously ran out of the courtyard to look into the distance. The sky and the earth were a vast expanse of white, branches wrapped in snow, crystal clear just like carved out of jade, making the world even more prominently boundless. Snowflakes dissolved all the sounds of the world. When White Spot had enough in the mountain, it ran over joyously like a puppy while howling and leaving a trail of footprints on the snow.

Qin Mian was amused. He grabbed a handful of snow and threw at it.

With a twist of its body, White Spot skillfully avoided it, gave him a proud look, and continued to run happily.

Lei Tie stood quietly not far away and watched for a while before he said, "Go back."

“White Spot, let’s go.”

When they reached the entrance of the village, they heard cheerful laughter. The mischievous children in the village ran around in the snow, playing snowball fights. Even when they slipped, they were not afraid but giggled instead. They were carefree and without worries.

As soon as Qin Mian entered the room, he climbed on the heatable brick bed. After the twelfth lunar month ushered in, the heatable brick bed was never cold. [it’s always warm]

White Spot perceptively went to the side of heatable brick bed and lay on its stomach.

And of course, they ate on the heatable brick bed. Since the weather turned cold, they ate hot pot almost every day. Lei Tie had learned to cook hot pot beforehand. When the ingredients were cleaned, they could be eaten as soon as they were cooked in the pot. It was easy, satisfying and hot. Lei Tie was still the one to wash the dishes. Qin Mian hardly had to do anything. He assumed he would gain at least 3 Jin this winter.

24th, sweep the house. The two lived in a new house, so they were lazy and did not clean.

On the 25th, Lei Tie soaked half a bucket of soybeans and went to the tofu workshop in the village to make tofu. In the middle, he found time to come back and brought back a large bowl of soybean milk that tasted rich, mellow and delicious. Half a bucket of soybeans made over 50 Jin of tofu that appeared tender and tasty.

Qin Mian suddenly remembered the delicious fermented tofu. When he was very young, there was often an old man about 60 years old in his village who carried a shoulder pole to sell fermented tofu. The fermented tofu was said to be made by secret method. It was a small square piece with a bright red surface and tasted spicy and sweet-smelling. His grandmother would buy 5 pieces for 5 yuan every time. He particularly loved to eat it. A half a piece of fermented tofu could be eaten with a large bowl of rice.

At that time, he was young and ignorant. He asked the old man how he made the fermented tofu and why it was so sweet-smelling. The old man was also amused. It was probably because he was young, the old man really told him. Later, he told his grandmother the recipe. His grandmother was smart and successfully made the fermented tofu. Now he still remembered how to do it.

“Lei Tie, let’s go to the kitchen to make fermented tofu [fǔ rǔ].” Qin Mian jumped off the heatable brick bed and bent down to wear shoes.

Lei Tie looked at him strangely. He was under the impression that his little wife would always be on the heatable brick bed all winter.

He put down his chess[3] piece, “What is fǔ rǔ [fermented tofu]?”

Qin Mian said mysteriously: “It’s delicious and goes well with rice.”

“Not afraid of the cold?” Lei Tie asked.

“A charcoal brazier will do. Come on.” Qin Mian could stand the cold for the sake of delicious food.

Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to wash two empty clay pots and wipe dry the inside. Seeing him holding the dishcloth and reaching into the cold water with his face unchanged, Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder with admiration, pretending to be comforting. “An able man is always busy. You’ve worked hard.”

Lei Tie flicked his index finger and a few drops of clear water splashed on his face.

Qin Mian stared at him while shivering. The man was already doing things with his head bowed, as if nothing had happened. He picked up a cold porcelain plate and pressed it on Lei Tie’s face when he was unprepared. When he clearly saw the man’s face shivered, he burst into loud laughter.

White Spot, who was lying in the nest, opened its eyes, raised its head and swept a glance towards the kitchen. Then, it closed its eyes again and lay

flat.

Qin Mian lighted the fire to make some chili oil and served it in a bowl. After the chili oil cooled down, he added pepper, Sichuan pepper, star anise, measured flour and appropriate amount of rice wine to make a stewed soup for later use.

Next, he asked Lei Tie to take some paddy straws and spread it in the basket. He put a piece of white paper on the basket. The white and tender tofu was cut into square pieces and placed on the paper with even spacing.

After a few days, when the tofu grew mold, Qin Mian sprinkled a layer of salt on the tofu.

Afterwards, he said to Lei Tie: “After about eight days of pickling, put the tofu into an earthen jar, pour in the brine soup, seal it with paper and mud like a wine jar, and it’s done. Remind me eight days later.”

Lei Tie nodded, “Come over to warm your hands.”

“It’s the 27th today.” Qin Mian sat down by the charcoal brazier and arranged the tasks for the next few days, “Today make dough, stew meat and fry food balls. Tomorrow make steamed buns, dumplings and steam mantou.”

Lei Tie said: “So many things? You say, I do.”

Qin Mian chuckled, “It’s New Year, so you’ve to be busy to get the feeling of New Year. Although we’ve a small family, we should be more ceremonious in order not to be looked down upon. There are still three days to go before New Year’s Eve.” This was the first year after he was reborn, the first year that Lei Tie returned home, and the first year he spent with Lei Tie. He must be well prepared.

Lei Tie remained silent. He tightly held Qin Mian’s hands and placed them atop the charcoal brazier to warm together. His deep gaze fell on Qin Mian’s face.

Qin Mian tried to pull out his hands, but he could not. Lei Tie's hands were as tight as clamp.

"I'm not leaving, why do you hold so tightly?" Qin Mian asked with a smile.

Lei Tie wanted to ask him if he would ever leave, but he did not ask. He warmed Qin Mian's hands before letting go.

Qin Mian got on his feet, "You make dough, I stew meat."

Lei Tie stood up and scooped out the flour.

Qin Mian boiled water, added seasoning, put the washed ribs, chicken, trotters and large pieces of pork into it, covered the pot, stewed over high heat, and put more large pieces of firewood into the hollow space of the stove. He did not need to worry about it for the time being. These cooked foods were prepared in advance and it could save time by working it out a little bit when entertaining the guests in the first month. At the same time, he could steam sweet potatoes in the pot.

Qin Mian moved a small square table by the charcoal brazier, chopped meat and cut lotus root. It was too cold and everything was ice-cold. His hands were numb with cold. He had to warm by the fire even when he was cutting a few ingredients.

After Lei Tie made the dough, he took the kitchen knife in Qin Mian's hand, cut the ingredients according to his instructions. Very soon, they made three bucket of stuffing which included pork paste, lotus root stuffing and fish paste. Then, they made a bucket of pork balls, a bucket of lotus balls, a bucket of fish balls, and a bucket of sweet potato balls. There was also a bucket of tofu dregs made from tofu. After mixing minced meat and flour, it could be made into tofu dregs balls. It also tasted very delicious. Lotus root balls, sweet potato balls and tofu dregs balls were fried, while pork balls and fish balls were boiled in water.

After the meat in the pot was cooked, Qin Mian sliced a whole chicken and cut a bowl of meat for White Spot. The two of them made do with lunch

and continued to be busy in the afternoon.

The smell of fried food balls wafted in the kitchen. This was the taste of New Year.

Looking at the delicious food balls, Qin Mian felt a sense of accomplishment.

On the 28th of the twelfth lunar month, the dough was well prepared. Qin Mian and Lei Tie steamed two pots of mantou, a pot of meat steamed buns, wrapped a tray[4] of dumplings, and fried a basket of dried hemp leaves[5], dough twists, sangza[6] and dough sticks.

Lei Tie never knew that the New Year could be celebrated so sumptuously. Qin Mian prepared many foods that he had never seen before.

[TL: Me too, Lei Tie.]

Note:

[1] The relatives and friends of the rich are not necessarily all rich

[2] Steamed bun

[3] It refers to the Go board and also means various chess by extension

[4]帘子 literally means curtain

[5] The other translation is cannabis leaves [owo]

[6] Sangza [sanzi] is a deep-fried noodles in a twisted pyramid shape

Fried dough twists

Chapter 066: Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together (2)

066 – Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together (2)

“How is it?” Qin Mian said with a look as if presenting treasure, “Are they all the things you haven’t seen or eaten before?”

Lei Tie put his arm around his (QM) waist and whispered, “I’ll never forget this.”

Qin Mian did not like his expression of being immersed in memories. He waved a hand and said, “Don’t think about the past. The more people dislike you, the more you’ve to live a hundred, thousand times better than them.” He picked up a fried dough twist and put it into Lei Tie’s mouth.

Lei Tie’s two fingers held the fried dough twist and shook his head, “I didn’t think of those people.” He had long been indifferent to them. As long as there was his little wife, it was enough for him.

On the 29th of the twelfth lunar month, other villagers were still busy boiling, stir-frying, and deep-frying. Qin Mian and Lei Tie took White Spot to visit Zhang Dashuan and Wu Di’s houses.

During the New Year’s Day, the households in the village treated their guests with their own fried melon seeds, fried peanuts, and fried broad beans. People who were willing to spend money would buy fried food in the town, or buy some other snacks, dried fruits, and so on.

To save trouble, Qin Mian bought fried melon seeds, fried peanuts, and fried broad beans. That was why he and Lei Tie were so leisurely. Intentionally or unintentionally, the two did not pass by the old house.

In the morning on the 30th of the twelfth lunar month, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao walked into the courtyard gate of Qin Mian's house in cotton-padded jackets, bringing along cold air.

The snow stopped two days ago and started to fall again in the middle of the night yesterday. The accumulated snow could drown up to the ankles. The four Leis walked such a short distance from the old house to Qin Mian's home, but a layer of snow soon fell on them that their heads looked like wearing a white velvet hat.

White Spot ran over and inspected them with a scrutinizing eye before walking away.

The three Lei brothers slapped the snow on their bodies and looked at each other with a wry smile. Supposedly, a house pet resembled its owner. White Spot did not like the people from the old house. It only had a little affection for Lei Chuntao.

"Go inside the bedroom and sit on the heatable brick bed." Qin Mian waved.

As soon as they entered the bedroom, the siblings felt faint warmth and looked around secretly. This was the first time they entered this room.

The bedroom was very spacious. On the left side of the door was a wardrobe and on the right side were a two-person settee and a tea table. There were two brown cushions on the settee. The heatable brick bed was opposite the wardrobe. There were four red bolsters with black stripes and a printed thin blanket casually lying on the heatable brick bed. In the middle of the bed was a small table. On the table were chessboards with no more than a dozen pieces that had just been dropped. There were two cups of hot tea across the chessboard, braving hot steam. On the wall above the bed was a landscape painting and on the right was a bookshelf with some books scattered, one of which was opened and put in the lattice. The room was

very clean, but not neatly arranged. Even so, there was a sense of warmth and comfort in the middle of casualness.

“Sit on the bed.” Qin Mian let Lei Tie greet them first. He turned around and went out again.

White Spot rubbed its feet on the mat on the floor, leaped up, and landed on the heatable brick bed. Then, it nestled in a corner.

Lei Xiangyi and the others hesitated for a moment before taking off their shoes and climbing up the heatable brick bed. The warmth under the buttocks made them feel so comfortable that they wanted to heave a sigh. Their frozen faces also softened down.

Although they were siblings, after all, between the sexes there should be a prudent reserve. Lei Chuntao did not take off her shoes. She sat on the edge of the heatable brick bed with her legs bent as she touched the warm quilt. She enviously said to Lei Xiangyi: “Brother, if our home makes this kind of heatable brick bed, we don’t have to be scared of cold in winter.”

Lei Xiangyi rubbed his face after warming his hands on the heatable brick bed, “Yes. When the villagers heard that eldest brother made such a heatable brick bed at home, they even disapproved of it. This winter, I’m afraid that eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law have the most comfortable living in the whole village.”

Lei Xiangli shook his head. “At the beginning, father and I mentioned that we should also make a heatable brick bed, but unfortunately mother disagreed.” They were very clear that Du Shi was reluctant to spend money.

Lei Xiangzhi pondered: “This kind of heatable brick bed is really practical. When the weather gets warm, I’ll convince father and mother. They’re getting old. When the heatable brick bed is built, they can have an easy time next winter.”

Lei Tie did not join in their conversation and flipped through a book.

Lei Xiangyi and the others were used to his quiet nature and did not mind.

Qin Mian came in with a tray. Lei Tie looked up and put away the chessboard.

Qin Mian put four cups of hot tea on the small table and placed the tray directly on the heatable brick bed.

The four Leis were attracted by the plates of snacks in the tray; a plate of fried hemp leaves garnished with black sesame seeds, a plate of rounded small dough twists, a plate of crisp yellow and attractive sangzis, a plate of plump sweet guozis[1] with visible sugar granules, and a plate of tofu dregs balls with six toothpicks stuck on them.

“What are these, eldest sister-in-law?” Lei Chuntao asked curiously.

Qin Mian took off his shoes and sat down next to Lei Tie. He rubbed his feet next to him to make it warmer. “These are the snacks that Lei Tie and I made together. They’re fried hemp leaves, fried dough twist, sangzi and sweet guozi. Tofu dregs ball was originally made for cooking, but it tastes good. I like it very much. You can try them, too. But there’s meat in it, you can’t eat too much if it’s cold.” With that, he poked a tofu dregs ball with a bamboo stick and ate it. This kind of food ball was delicious and chewy.

Lei Tie said: “Eat less.”

“I know, just eat two.” Qin Mian smilingly said, “I still have to leave a space in my stomach to eat better food in the evening.”

Lei Xiangzhi also poked a ball and said with a smile: “It seems that we’ve come to the right place today.”

Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao tasted every kind of snack, and they were full of praise.

Lei Xiangyi secretly lamented that although eldest brother married a male wife, his life was much better than them.

“How is the preparation on your side?” Qin Mian asked thoughtlessly.

Lei Xiangyi reached out and took a sangzi, which was crispy and aromatic. “In the middle of stewing the meat. Everything else is ready.”

“Is there something for all of you to come here?” Qin Mian went to pick the tofu dregs ball again but was stopped by Lei Tie. He had to put down the toothpick and took a fried hemp leaf to eat.

Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao looked at each other. Lei Xiangyi took a look at Lei Tie, drank a sip of hot tea, and said hopelessly: “Father and mother asked you two to over to eat New Year’s Eve dinner and celebrate New Year together.”

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie without comment.

Lei Tie said in a low voice: “My wife and I celebrate the New Year in our own home.”

Lei Xiangyi and the others did not speak to persuade them but chatted about other topics.

Both Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi were good talkers. Qin Mian was also a glib and nimble talker. He had hundreds of years of knowledge than them. The conversation between them was very lively.

Later, even Lei Tie also occasionally put in a few words. Although he popped up with a few words, he was not being so quiet at last.

Unconsciously, the few plates of food had been completely eaten.

Lei Xiangyi and the others were a little embarrassed. Upon seeing that Qin Mian picked up the tray and was going to load food, they quickly got off the heatable brick bed.

“Don’t be busy, eldest sister-in-law. It’s almost noon. We should go back.” Lei Chuntao said first.

Qin Mian paused and nodded, “Right. Today is New Year’s Eve, it’s inappropriate to make you stay for lunch. Wait a minute. I’ll get some snacks that you can take home for the children.”

Lei Xiangyi's heart felt warm. He hastily said: "Thank you, eldest sister-in-law."

Qin Mian found a small wooden bucket and put some of each kind of food into it, adding up to half of the bucket.

On the way back to the old house, Lei Chuntao could not help but take a tofu dregs ball to eat.

Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi were unable to restrain their laughter.

Lei Chuntao was embarrassed and said in a low voice: "The tofu dregs ball is really delicious."

Lei Xiangzhi patted her on the head, "Don't worry, there's your share."

Lei Chuntao's face turned pink and promptly waved a hand, "How can I do that? Give Dabao, Erbao, and Xinxin to eat."

Lei Xiangyi also laughed, "What to be embarrassed about? In our eyes, you're also a child."

Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangzhi both nodded with a smile.

Lei Chuntao's lips could not stop rising. She had a few good older brothers.

They stepped on the snow all the way through the door. When Du Shi and Wei Shi saw the bucket in Lei Xiangyi's hands, the look in their eyes changed.

"What are you carrying?" Lei Xiangren was eating melon seeds with his legs crossed. He spat the skin of the melon seeds all over the ground. When he saw them coming back, he went over and reached out a hand.

Lei Xiangyi went to the side to avoid him, "It's given by eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law for the three children to eat."

"Let me see what good things they are." Lei Xiangren approached again.

Lei Xiangyi handed the bucket to Lei Xiangzhi.

“What’s wrong with looking? Are you afraid I’ll eat it?” Lei Xiangren’s tone towards Lei Xiangyi was bad, but he dared not snatch it from Lei Xiangzhi. Although this youngest brother was young, his appearance of fixedly looking at people without saying anything always made people had a guilty conscience.

Afraid of losing out, Zhao Shi called out: “Dabao, Erbao, come here quickly, there is delicious food.”

Qian Shi had already come out of the house silently with Xinxin in her arms.

Wei Shi asked Lei Chuntao, “Why don’t I see your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law?”

Lei Chuntao responded: “This year is their first year after they got married, it’s more appropriate to celebrate the New Year by themselves.”

Wei Shi said: “How can this be? It’s too lonely for them to celebrate the New Year. Husband, why don’t we go there in person?” She asked Lei Daqiang with a smile.

Without waiting for Lei Daqiang to open his mouth, Lei Xiangzhi smilingly said: “Father, little sister is right. This is the first year for eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law after they got married. Let’s not bother them. You try the snacks made by eldest sister-in-law and eldest brother.”

He gave one for each kind of snacks to Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren, Du Shi, Wei Shi, Zhao Shi, and Qian Shi. The rest was divided equally among Lei Dabao, Lei Erbao, and Lei Xinxin. Although the adults felt that these snacks were delicious, they were also embarrassed to compete with the children.

Lei Xiangren felt that the tofu dregs ball was delicious. After eating one, he still wished there was more. He murmured to Zhao Shi in a low voice, “Old Three and the others must have eaten a lot over there. If I knew it earlier, I’d have gone with them just now.”

Zhao Shi also nodded, “If I knew, I’d also follow.”

Lei Chuntao heard it and silently sneered.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not care who got what they gave. After lunch, they took a nap. When they woke up, they played chess for a while and begin to prepare for the New Year’s Eve dinner.

After the rice was cooked, it was kept warm on the charcoal stove. The ribs, chicken, meat, trotters, and so on were cooked in advance. After Qin Mian’s reprocessing, they were put into the pot to keep warm. Then, he made several dishes that needed to be cooked immediately.

Lei Tie was holding a bowl of sticky paste and a small bamboo brush, sticking the Door Gods[2] and Spring Festival couplets.

Qin Mian ran out while the food in the pot was still cooking and began to admire it from the courtyard gate.

He saw that the couplets at the gate of the courtyard were: “Welcoming The Spring, Welcoming Happiness, Welcoming Riches And Honor”; “Receiving Wealth, Receiving Luck, Receiving Peace”. The horizontal scroll was written with “Happy Spring Festival” and there was also a [door] push plate – “Peace Wherever You Go”.

“The couplets you selected are quite good.” Qin Mian praised Lei Tie with a happy smile.

Lei Tie looked at him for a moment with profound meaning. There was an indistinguishable emotion in his dark eyes. He nodded slightly, “They’re pretty good.”

Qin Mian inexplicably looked at him for a few seconds and stepped into the door.

The side of the well was also pasted with “A Small Stream Flows Far”. The Spring Festival couplets in the central room door were as followed: “Sweet-Tempered Family Increases All Kind Of Luck”; “The Peace Word Worth

Thousands Of Gold”; and the horizontal scroll wrote “May All Go Well With You”. The Spring Festival couplets in the kitchen were also appropriate: “Firewood, Rice, Oil, Salt, Soy Sauce, Vinegar And Tea”; “Sour, Sweet, Bitter, Spicy, Salty And Spicy”; and the horizontal scroll was “All Tastes Of The World”. Qin Mian also noticed that there were two additional red “福”[3] characters on the wall of the central room, opposite each other at a distance.

Then, he came to the door of their bedroom and saw the contents of the Spring Festival couplets. He could not help but pause and his heart trembled. He was shocked to see the spring couplets in the bedroom:

A harmonious union lasting a hundred years.

Till the seas dry up and the rocks decay, with one heart forever bound

The earth is wide and the sky is high, fly wing to wing[4]

The characters’ strokes were like swimming dragons[5], full of domineering and wanton. The font of these spring couplets was obviously different from the other spring couplets.

Qin Mian had a guess in his heart and stared at Lei Tie, who stood beside him.

Lei Tie was expressionless. His eyes scrutinized the spring couplets and nodded as to emphasize, “The couplets I chose are good.”

Qin Mian: “.....”

Lei Tie turned his head and looked towards the kitchen, “The food is scorched.”

Qin Mian looked at him in surprise, “Don’t tell me that you wrote these couplets.”

—END OF VOLUME 1—

Volume 2: Cannot Bear to Part from Each Other

Note:

[1] Literal translation is sweet fruit. A small ball of dough that was fried in melted sugar

[2] Paintings of Door Gods posted on the door during the Lunar New Year. As the guardian spirit of folk beliefs, people put their gods on the door to drive away evil spirits, guard the house and etc.

[3]福 Fú = good fortune/happiness/luck

[4] (idiom); two hearts beating as one; (of a couple) inseparable

[5] Vigorous and lively calligraphy

Chapter 067: Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together (3)

067 – Henceforth, Celebrate the New Year Together [3]

Lei Tie's ears were dyed with a layer of light red as he said like nothing was wrong: "It was written by others. I rewrote them when I saw his words were common."

Inwardly, Qin Mian felt both sweet and funny. He just thought that it was impossible for Lei Tie to write such straightforward sentences with his temperament. He was quite amused as he stared at Lei Tie's ear roots. The man who was as cold as a blade edge would blush in embarrassment.

"The food is scorched." Lei Tie pushed him to the kitchen.

Qin Mian looked at him with a smile before entering the kitchen.

Lei Tie took out the red lanterns¹ that he specially bought and hung them under the eaves of the courtyard gate. He went back to the central room and found scissors to cut wicks for four oil lamps. The room became brighter.

Entering the kitchen, he looked at Qin Mian's back, who focused on cooking. He picked up the charcoal brazier and placed it under the dining table. He moved the charcoals with tongs to make the fire more vigorous.

"Help serve the dishes." Qin Mian shouted, listening to the movement in the dining room.

They served the dishes onto the table. The whole central room was filled with rich aromas. In the middle of the table was a hot pot cooked in a charcoal stove. Meatballs, fish balls, lotus root balls, and tofu dregs balls broiled among the thin slices of meat and the emerald green leaves. Around the hot pot, there were more than a dozen of dishes, such as roasted red spareribs, “perfectly clean” tofu mixed with chopped shallot, “auspicious” chestnuts stewed chicken, “longevity” fried noodles, “surplus every year” two braised carps², “well-rounded” braised pork balls in brown sauce, “a hall of gold and jade³” corns, green peas, and diced carrots, crispy shrimps with tea leaves, sliced beef in hot chili oil, flavored duck, and soy sauce marinated streaky pork with bright color and strong aroma, making people salivated.

Lei Tie’s eyes twinkled. His wife’s cooking was like an inexhaustible treasure. There were surprises almost every day.

Qin Mian cut a large bowl of meat for White Spot. Then, he arranged the tableware, wine cups, and wine jar, and looked at Lei Tie inquisitively, “Worship first?”

Lei Tie nodded. He brought the boiled pig’s head in the kitchen to the altar, lit the thick incense joss sticks in two incense burners, knelt down, and reached out to Qin Mian, “Wife, come here.”

Qin Mian hesitated for a moment, but still walked over and knelt down side by side with him. Since he could be reborn, who could say that there was no God in this world? He simply knelt and sought peace of mind.

Lei Tie lightly stroked his head, lit a stack of yellow paper⁴, took out three incense joss sticks, and kowtowed three times. In his heart, he silently worshipped gods and deceased relatives, and then inserted the incense joss sticks on the pig’s head. It was a simple but prudent sacrifice.

They looked at each other, stood up, and sat next to each other at the table.

“Let’s eat,” Qin Mian picked up his chopsticks and greedily looked at the delicious food on the table. “If you don’t eat it, it’ll be cold.”

Lei Tie picked up the wine jar and filled two cups with wine. He handed a cup to Qin Mian and raised his cup with his eyes fixedly gazed at Qin Mian. His voice was flat and deep, “Wife, how about celebrating the New Year together henceforth?”

Qin Mian’s heart was pounding, making his action of clipping the food stopped. He looked at Lei Tie for a long time and his eyes flickered with the fluctuation of his mood. He did not deny that he had taken this man to his heart⁵ and even relied on him in these short months of getting along almost day and night. For him, who thought that his sexual orientation was normal, it was unexpected, but he thought it was reasonable. Lei Tie was very tight-lipped and taciturn to the point that sometimes it made people anxious. But once he put a person in his heart, he treated the person so well that it was hard for the person to resist. This kind of well-treatment was not intended to please, but from the heart – naturally and involuntary. It made people addicted to it. Since Lei Tie had protected him in front of Du Shi, roasted chicken drumsticks and corns for him, took him away from the old house, embraced him at night, and taught him martial arts and archery, his concern for Lei Tie grown day by day. There was even more than one occasion that appeared such that he felt it was a good idea to live with Lei Tie. However, could two men really last? He was eager to establish a close relationship with someone in this world so that he could feel that he really existed in this world. Could Lei Tie be this ‘someone’?

White Spot gnawed bones loudly, the soup in the hot pot kept gurgling, the fire of the stove was swaying dazedly, and the heat from the charcoal brazier was so warm, but Lei Tie’s heart was sinking gradually as if it was being drenched by ice and snow. It felt as though he was stabbed. The hand with the wine cup was taken back, his lips were tight, his eyes were drooping, and the black pupils abruptly dimmed.

Qin Mian had a full view of his expression and intense heartache suddenly erupted, pounding his chest with sullen pain. He hastily picked up his wine cup, causing the wine to sprinkle in half. When he clunked it against Lei Tie’s cup, a pleasant and crisp sound was heard.

Lei Tie raised his eyes and met a pair of smiling clear eyes.

“It depends on your future performance.”

The air of loneliness surrounded Lei Tie’s body instantly dissipated and the pleasant surprise in his eyes was so strong that it seemed to overflow. He took up the wine cup and drank it in one gulp with a slight smile on the corners of his lips.

Qin Mian did not expect that he could have such a great influence on Lei Tie’s mood. He sighed secretly, but at the same time, sweetness swelled in his chest, causing his face to unconsciously display a bright smile.

“If you don’t eat the food, it’ll be cold.” After taking a sip of wine, Qin Mian picked up a piece of spareribs and put it into Lei Tie’s bowl. It was very natural as if he had done it so many times.

Lei Tie clipped a chicken drumstick from the chicken stewed with chestnuts and put it into Qin Mian’s bowl before he picked up the spareribs to eat. The heat rolling in his chest would not disperse for a long time. The wife’s cooking was good. The spareribs were crisp and soft that with only a light bite, the meat could be easily separated from the bone.

“These dishes all have auspicious connotations, so every dish should be constant.” Qin Mian gave him several dishes in proper sequence: tofu mixed with chopped scallop, chicken stewed with chestnuts, and braised pork balls in brown sauce.

Lei Tie imitated and helped him clipping up dishes, “You also eat.”

Qin Mian deliberately ate only seven parts full at noon. At this time, he had a very good appetite. He loosened his belt and engrossed in eating. Noticing the scorching gaze falling on him, he raised his head helplessly, “What are you doing looking at me? Eat yours.”

Lei Tie put down his cup, grabbed Qin Mian’s waist while his right hand pressed on Qin Mian’s left face. He bowed his head and his hot lips pressed against Qin Mian’s lips. His bright and deep eyes were opened, looking straight at Qin Mian, as if they could capture his soul.

Qin Mian's heartbeat slowed down a few beats. Nevertheless, he was not a pretentious person. He was only startled. Then, he leaned over and licked Lei Tie's lips curiously without the slightest plan. He even felt a spiral of agitation and anticipation at the bottom of his heart.

Lei Tie's black pupils darkened. He opened his lips and sucked in Qin Mian's lips, deepening the kiss. The kiss was neither fast nor slow, but the temperature on the tip of his tongue was getting higher and the stirring force was getting stronger, as though he was trying to swallow Qin Mian's tongue.

Qin Mian raised his head and cooperated clumsily. He could feel that Lei Tie had no experience, and he was secretly happy. The duo groped around and learned within the practice, breathing gradually became more urgent. It was a good while before they separated.

Lei Tie was fully satisfied. He pecked at the corner of Qin Mian's lip before letting him go. He dared not look at Qin Mian again as he said in a hoarse voice, "Eat."

Qin Mian glanced at the oil stains on the corners of Lei Tie's lips but did not remind him. He laughed silently and scooped out meatballs and tofu dregs balls into his own bowl.

Looking at the wine cup, there was only half a cup of wine left in it. He picked up the wine jar to fill it up and toasted to Lei Tie. "Here, I'd like to propose a toast to you. I wish you'll have good health and may all go well with you this year!"

Lei Tie took a deep look at him and drank it all.

Qin Mian also finished in one gulp.

Lei Tie filled the two wine cups to the brim and raised them, "Toast for me and you. From hereafter, I'll make sure you are always smiling."

Qin Mian hooked his neck and took a hard suck on his face. Then, he clipped a large piece of meat from the fish's belly. After he proficiently

picked out the bones from the meat, he enjoyed it with relish. All these dishes were delicious while eating it hot.

Lei Tie was a little stunned. He shook his head and no longer talked. He also sped up his eating action and helped Qin Mian pick up the dishes occasionally.

Both of them ate a large amount of food and it took nearly an hour before they put down their chopsticks. There were still a lot of dishes left. The food would not be easily spoiled in cold weather, so it could be eaten the next day.

“So full.” Qin Mian sprawled on his chair, not wanting to move. He took a look at the sand clock on the cabinet. There were two hours before rat hour⁶.

Lei Tie went into the bedroom to take a cloak and fastened it on Qin Mian. He pulled Qin Mian up and led him outside.

“Where to?” Qin Mian did not understand.

Lei Tie remained silent, leading him to walk back and forth on the snowfield without hurries. Qin Mian was worried for nothing; it was walking around⁷ ah.

White Spot also followed them outside and looked at them inexplicably. As if it was disgusted with them for eating to the bursting point, it drilled back home through its exclusive hole in the wall.

Qin Mian stared at the hole in the wall speechlessly. They were being despised? Despised by a wolf?

After walking for a long time, Lei Tie stroked Qin Mian’s cold face and led him back to the house.

Qin Mian dragged the charcoal brazier to the edge of the settee and lay on the settee.

Lei Tie took the leftovers into the kitchen and wiped the table clean. He came out of the kitchen after he washed the dishes, “Go wash up.”

Qin Mian entered the house after he brushed his teeth. Lei Tie had already poured the water for face wash and put the footbath basin aside. He also had taken two pairs of brand-new cotton slippers from the bedroom.

After the duo washed their faces, they poured hot water into the footbath basin.

Qin Mian took off his shoes and socks. He put his feet into the basin to soak, expelling the cold and improving blood circulation.

Lei Tie moved a chair and put it opposite of Qin Mian. He took off his shoes and socks and put his feet in the footbath basin.

Qin Mian’s ears felt hot. He tried to keep his face from showing any signs. *Already kissed, what’s the big deal of taking a bath together?*

Lei Tie’s eyes flashed a smile and his two big feet stepped on Qin Mian’s feet.

Qin Mian glared at him and moved his feet away, causing the water to slosh.

Lei Tie’s feet did not chase after his, but his eyes did not move away from Qin Mian’s face.

Qin Mian was also looking at Lei Tie. This man was really good-looking. His handsome face was prominently angular like being carved by a blade. His forehead was broad, his eyebrows were thick, and his eye sockets were a little deep, making his black pupils more profound and bright. Under the tall bridge of his nose, his lips were also beautiful. The two thin lips made the rigidity on his face even stronger. Qin Mian was glad that Lei Tie had a scar on his face. Otherwise, he did not how many young girls would adore him.

Thinking so, he could not help laughing.

“What are you laughing at?” Lei Tie asked.

“Nothing.” Of course, Qin Mian would not tell.

Footnotes

1. the kind that isn't easily blown by wind
2. Eating two fish, one on New Year's Eve and one on New Year's Day, (if written in a certain way) sounds like a wish for a surplus year-after-year.
3. abundant wealth or many children in the family
4. for worshipping
5. care about
6. 11 p.m to 1 a.m.
7. walk around to help digestion

Chapter 068: Into the First Lunar Month

068 – Into the First Lunar Month

The heat of the water gradually dissipated. Lei Tie handed a blue foot towel to Qin Mian and picked up his gray foot towel to wipe his feet.

After Qin Mian went to the latrine to piss, he washed his hands and came into the bedroom. He had asked Sister Zhang in advance about the various taboos on the first day of the first lunar month¹. On the first day of the first lunar month, he should avoid opening drawers and closets, so as not to let wealth and fortune slip away. He opened the wardrobe and picked out the new clothes, shoes, and socks that he and Lei Tie would wear the next day.

Lei Tie locked the doors and windows before coming in.

“Come, play chess.” Qin Mian clapped his hands. They could not just sit there while staying up late on New Year’s Eve. They had to find something to do to kill time.

Lei Tie took out the chessboard and set it up.

“You must let me put some pieces.” Qin Mian’s level of playing chess was average, thus he said unceremoniously.

Lei Tie nodded.

In the beginning, Qin Mian could still play very smoothly. After every file² was filled with pieces, he spent more and more time thinking. His sitting posture also changed from cross-legged to sitting diagonally, with the left

arm resting on the short-legged table. His two legs stretched out with the two feet folded together, shaking. The appearance of his head down and frowning as he was thinking looked very charming.

Lei Tie's eyes glanced at his bare feet. He reached out to hold one and gently kneaded it.

Qin Mian raised his head and took a glance at the man. He tried to take back his feet but was unsuccessful and let the man have his way. Once again, he thought for a moment about dropping a piece.

Lei Tie thoughtlessly picked up a white chess piece and made a move. He looked back at Qin Mian's foot. There was no flaw on his white feet and the smooth nails glimmered smoothly under the light. His five-toe bones held up obvious protuberances. It was still too thin that he could not help pinching.

Qin Mian looked at the chessboard and acted if nothing happened, while his face was getting warmer³. *What's with pinching a smelly foot?*

As the temperature in his palm rose, Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian and found out that he was uncomfortable. He leaned close across the short-legged table, lowered his head, and pecked Qin Mian on the cheek.

The atmosphere was too ambiguous. Qin Mian pushed his head aside and said with a deadpan face, "Play chess properly."

Lei Tie pinched his foot again and let go.

Qin Mian quickly retracted his feet.

It was a long night. Qin Mian could not endure it and yawn.

Lei Tie put the picked chess pieces back onto the chessboard. "Go to sleep."

Qin Mian shook his head, "Staying up with you." This was their first New Year's Eve. He did not want to leave a trace of regret.

Lei Tie moved the short-legged table away, put his arms around Qin Mian, and wrapped both of them with a quilt, "Sleep. I'll call you when it's time."

"Alright." Qin Mian stroked his scarred cheek and drew his hand back into the quilt. He leaned against Lei Tie's chest, closed his eyes, and fell asleep in a daze.

It was unknown how much time had passed when a cluster of firecrackers crackled outside.

White Spot, who was sleeping soundly, jumped up suddenly. It looked around alertly, shook its head, and lay down again.

Qin Mian opened his sleepy eyes and asked vaguely, "It's the right time of rat hour⁴?"

"En." Lei Tie got up and wrapped him tightly in the quilt. "I'll set off firecrackers."

Qin Mian watched him go out. Soon, there was a deafening sound of firecrackers in the courtyard, crackling. It took a long time before it stopped. The village seemed to be awakened as bursts of firecrackers sounded one after another, from far or near. The regular sound of fireworks exploding from farther away could also be heard.

Qin Mian's sleepiness was blown away. He took off his thick clothes, yawned, crawled back to his old position, and covered himself with the quilt.

It took more than two moments⁵ for the village to regain its tranquillity.

Lei Tie blew out the light, undressed, climbed up the heatable brick bed, and fished out the person into his embrace.

Qin Mian groped for Lei Tie's face in the dark, went closer, and kissed him on the lips, "Happy New Year."

After they talked about it, a lot of things were done naturally.

Lei Tie clasped Qin Mian's nape and deepened the kiss, "Happy New Year."

"Good night." Qin Mian adjusted his sleeping posture and closed his eyes.

However, Lei Tie was not sleepy. He stroked his wife's back through his meager thin underclothes and sniffed at him. His wife's smell was more intense than ever before, infecting his body's temperature to turn into fiery hot. With one hand, he pressed his wife's waist close, allowing them to stick to each other intimately, while the other hand could not help reaching to the fleshy part of the hips.

The palm of his hand was suddenly grabbed, and at the same time, it was pinched hard.

Qin Mian said languidly: "I'm only 15 years old."

Lei Tie's hand returned to Qin Mian's waist. He sealed Qin Mian's lips, sucking and kissing him fiercely. He difficultly gasped for breath a few times before gradually calmed down and patted Qin Mian's back, "Sleep."

Qin Mian put his arm on Lei Tie's waist, kept his body unmoving, and soon fell asleep.

It was a good sleep all night.

When they got up in the morning, they put on new clothes. Qin Mian also tied a red cloth strip around White Spot's neck.

The leftovers were put inside the wok to heat up, and they went out together. The snow had stopped, but the accumulated snow had not melted at all. With every step of foot, it echoed with "zizi", and there were overlapping and disordered footprints everywhere. The wind was even more prominently gloomy and cold.

On the way, the villagers who were going to other villagers' homes to pay New Year's greetings, whether they were in good terms or not, all smiling and saying "Happy New Year" to each other.

A blooming⁶ young girl hid behind her parents. Seeing Qin Mian from afar, she secretly blushed with her heart palpitated. Inadvertently, she met Lei Tie's gaze as sharp as a blade, and hurriedly lowered her head.

In the old house of the Lei Family, the younger generations were kowtowing to the elders as they paid the New Year's greeting. The happy laughter and cheerful voices were incessant.

Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi were all sitting in the upper position. Lei Daqiang wore an olive-green cotton-padded jacket printed with the character “福⁷”. Thanks to Wei Shi's care for him these days, his face was ruddy and his complexion was excellent. He looked four to five years younger than before. Du Shi wore a cloud bun⁸ on her head, a silver hairpin on the left, and a golden dangling ornament on the right. She also dressed in a new suit. Her red cotton-padded jacket matched with purple flowers slit⁹ skirt made her face looked very friendly. Wei Shi was the most eye-catching. She had a snake bun¹⁰ on her head decorated with dark-green and bluish-green tassels. In between raising her hands and stamping her feet, subsequently, the earrings embellished with precious stones clipped on her ears gently swayed. Her suit of light blue cheongsam perfectly outlined her beautiful waist matched with a bright red *beizi*¹¹. Her whole person looked charming. From time to time, Lei Daqiang took a look at her.

After Qin Mian and Lei Tie entered the door, everyone's eyes involuntarily fell on them. They secretly sucked in a breath at the appearance of these two handsome men.

Lei Tie tied his hair with jasper hoops with his long black hair scattered behind his back. He wore a long indigo satin cotton-padded robe and a wide red belt to express the New Year's joy. On the outside, he was covered in a black coat with a lockstitch border of golden thread cloud patterns. The garment against his tall stature made him look majestic and extravagant. Although Qin Mian was young, his figure was tall. He wore a cloud brocade¹² cotton-padded robe embroidered with white bamboo leaves. On his waist, there was also a red belt embellished with a bulging embroidered pouch. He wore a black cloak of thigh-length sewn with velvety white fox fur on the edge. His whole person looked out of the world.

As the son and the daughter-in-law, they kowtowed to Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi.

“Father, mother, little mother, we wish you all Happy New Year.”

Lei Daqiang was in a good mood, “Alright, alright, get up quickly.”

Du Shi responded with an “en” in neither salty nor indifferent tone.

Wei Shi invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie to sit down and have tea, melon seeds, and fried peanuts.

The Lei brothers and sisters-in-law came over with three children to wish them Happy New Year.

The three mischievous kids knelt down on the ground, kowtowed, cheerfully grinned, and crisply yelled: “Happy New Year to Eldest Uncle and Eldest Auntie.”

On the surface, Qin Mian was smiling but inside, his heart convulsed. He touched the heads of the three mischievous kids and put a red envelope for each of them in their pockets.

Zhao Shi secretly opened her two sons’ red envelopes and counted the money inside, which was 16 Wen¹³. She put them away with a smile. The average people gave money to relatives’ younger generation was 6 Wen. Qin Mian and Lei Tie had money to open a shop, which in Zhao Shi’s point of view, they were rich people. If they only gave 6 Wen, she would have something to say.

Qian Shi only secretly weighed Lei Xinxin’s red envelope. Her pursed lips smiled as she put it away.

After sitting for a while, Qin Mian and Lei Tie got up and went to Lei Dagang’s house.

Lei Dagang had opinions towards Lei Daqiang but held no prejudice against Lei Daqiang’s children. His wife treated Qin Mian and Lei Tie very warmly.

Qin Mian gave each of their children a red envelope, which also contained 16 Wen.

After coming out of Lei Dagang's house, they went non-stop to other elders' and their peers' houses to pay New Year's greetings. The first place they went to was Li Zheng's¹⁴ house.

Qin Mian was eloquent and had a good time talking with Li Zheng. Li Zheng's wife also praised him and Lei Tie for their good looks....

After walking around the village, they returned home. They opened their gate/door¹⁵ and put all kinds of snacks on the table, waiting for the village's peers and younger generations to visit their house for New Year. This was etiquette. As for whether people were willing to come or not, it could not be forced on them.

Before long, a few little turnip heads¹⁶ in new clothes came in with cheerful laugh. The few of them all wore a small red *ao*¹⁷, looking so happy. They were led by Xiao Hu and Gou Dan.

“Uncle Lei, Uncle Qin, Happy New Year!”

Lei Tie nodded lightly.

Qin Mian led them into the house with a smile and gave each of them a small red envelope, which contained 1 Wen. It was the custom of the village and only intended to be auspicious. He pointed to all kinds of snacks on the table, “See anything you like, grab it yourself.”

The children's eyes lit up and started to drool. They ran to the table cheerfully, grabbed a handful of snacks, and stuffed them in their pockets. They did not even notice the small red envelopes in their pockets fell on the ground.

Qin Mian amusingly took them to pick up the red envelopes and put them back in their pockets.

Xiao Hu was the most polite kid. He shouted “thank you Uncle Qin” before he ran to grab the sweet guozis¹⁸.

Every little kid had their pockets filled up before leaving contentedly.

The adults and children came to pay New Year’s greetings one after another. Less than an hour later when no one came to visit, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had breakfast.

The lively first day of the New Year passed like this.

The second day of the first month was the day when a wife returned to her parent’s home.

Early in the morning, the sound of packing up things and berating children to not dirtying their new clothes could be heard from several nearby households. Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian and was about to speak, but said nothing.

Qin Mian was puzzled for a long time before he reacted and said to Lei Tie with a severe expression: “I really don’t remember my parents.”

Lei Tie embraced Qin Mian’s waist, bowed his head, and kissed on his lips, “Today, I’m going to pay New Year’s greetings to my maternal grandparents. You stay at home. I’ll take you when the snow melts.”

Qin Mian was surprised, “Is your maternal grandfather still alive? It’s the first time I’ve heard about it from you.”

Lei Tie was silent for a moment. “My maternal grandparents are alive. My maternal grandfather, grandmother, and second uncle are very kind to me. When I ran away from home, they secretly gave me one silver tael, and two silver taels when we split from the family.”

Qin Mian felt rather odd, “They didn’t come to our house warming...”

Lei Tie said: “My maternal grandparents live with Eldest Uncle. Eldest Uncle didn’t like me marrying a man and Second Aunt always felt that I’m

a burden to Second Uncle.”

Qin Mian understood and stood up, “I’m going to prepare...New Year’s gifts for grandpa, grandma, and Second Uncle.”

He prepared generous New Year’s gifts for Lei Tie’s maternal grandparents. Fish balls, meatballs, lotus root balls, and tofu dregs balls were wrapped in one paper bag. Fried dough twists, sangzas¹⁹ and fried hemp leaves were hard for the elderly, but they tasted good when cooked with other dishes so each was packed with some. Each of the pheasant and hare that Lei Tie hunted were also wrapped separately. Moreover, there were also two kinds of soft snacks. All of these things filled a basket to the brim.

The New Year’s gifts to the second uncle were neither meager, which was a packet of hot pot seasoning, a bag of tofu dregs balls, and a pheasant.

All the way, Lei Tie watched Qin Mian wrapped them all with oiled paper, and his chest felt warm. “Two paternal aunts will come today. If they come in, you just entertain them and don’t care about other things.”

“Don’t worry, I can’t afford to lose.” Qin Mian said, unconcerned. In this era, etiquette and reputation were highly valued, unless there was deep-seated hatred that could completely cut off the relationship between relatives. Otherwise, it was not good to speak out. Henceforth, they would not cut off contact with Lei Xiaoyun’s family, but merely maintaining feelings on the outside would suffice.

Lei Tie drove the ox cart out. Qin Mian stayed at home alone, snacking on melon seeds while reading a book. He did not feel bored. At noon, he solved all the meals they had not finished on New Year’s Day. He did not treat himself badly at all.

Lei Tie hurriedly came back after lunch at his eldest uncle’s home.

Note:

1] Cloud Bun

2] Snake Bun

3] Slit Skirt (Horse-faced Skirt)

Chapter 069: Maternal Grandparents' Home

069 – Maternal Grandparents' Home

In the afternoon, Lei Xiangren brought Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao over, and invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie to go to the old house for dinner – Lei Xiaoyun's family and Lei Xiaofeng's family had come. Lunch would be at Lei Dagang's, and dinner would be at Lei Daqiang's.

Lei Tie refused.

Lei Xiangren curled his lips and did not say anything. He helped Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao to put the fried dough twists and sweet guozis in the dishes into their pockets, while he grabbed two pieces of sangzas before leaving in a hurry with his two children.

On the third day of the first month, Lei Daqiang and Lei Dagang went to Lei Xiaoyun's house to pay New Year's greetings. Qin Mian stayed at home, while Lei Tie went with them. After the New Year's gifts were delivered, he did not stay for a meal and returned alone. Upon seeing Qin Mian sitting in front of the table with the dishes and tableware waiting for him, and White Spot also looking at the direction of the gate, Lei Tie's heart was extremely secured.

On the fourth day of the first month, the Lei Family went to Lei Xiaofeng's house to pay New Year's greetings. Lei Tie had lunch at Lei Xiaofeng's house. Lei Xiaoyun ranted and raved at Lei Tie, but he kept silent. Lei Xiaoyun could do nothing about it.

On the sixth day of the first month, Lei Tie reminded Qin Mian to add brine to the fermented tofu. Qin Mian sealed the earthen vessels after adding brine. He solemnly put the two earthen vessels in a corner of the kitchen and waited for a year to open.

On the seventh day of the first month, the Lei's kinsfolk made an appointment to visit Lei Tie's home. Lei Dagang's, Lei Daqiang's, and Lei Xiaofeng's families all came. Lei Xiaoyun's family did not come, nor did she send a New Year's gift. Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not care about it.

After the tenth day of the first month, the custom of receiving guests basically ended, and the villagers began to invite the people they were on friendly terms to dinner. Qin Mian and Lei Tie also ran around for a day to invite Li Zheng's family, Zhao Wenzhong's family (who had rented them a house), Zhang Dashuan's family, Grandpa Jiang and Wu Di to have dinner at home. The following day, Zhao Wenzhong, Zhang Dashuan, Grandpa Jiang, and Wu Di returned the hospitality¹. With these exchanges, the relationship between them had become closer. It was not strange to say that men's friendship came from the wine table.

The weather was getting warmer, yet it was still very cold in the house. However, standing under the sun for a while could get one's body burning hot.

On the twelfth day of the first month, the accumulated snow had completely melted, the warm sun hung high in the sky, and the ground was 80% dry. Lei Tie and Qin Mian prepared gifts and went to Deng's Village to visit Lei Tie's maternal grandparents.

Lei Tie drove the oxcart, while Qin Mian sat next to him eating melon seeds.

"Grandpa, grandma, and second uncle are very good people, don't worry." Lei Tie suddenly popped out a sentence.

Lei Tie did not mention his eldest uncle, eldest aunt, and second aunt. Qin Mian thought about it and knew what was going on. He put a melon seed

kernel in his mouth, “Do you see me looking like I’m worried?” Also, he was not really 15 years old.

Lei Tie tightly held his hand and took a bite of his finger.

Upon seeing that they were almost there, Qin Mian wiped his mouth, took out a bamboo cup to rinse his mouth, fixed his clothes, and patted off the melon seed shells that had accidentally fallen on Lei Tie’s clothes.

At the entrance of Deng’s Village, an old couple about 60 years old stood under a tree while raising their heads and looking around, seemingly expecting something. The old man had grey hair and a grey beard and looked very spirited. The old lady had a head full of silver hair, rosy complexion, and slightly stout. These two old people were exactly Old Master Deng and Old Madam Deng.

Lei Tie saw them and said to Qin Mian, “That’s grandpa and grandma.”

Qin Mian was slightly moved, “They must be here every day to wait for you. Otherwise, it’s impossible to know that we’re coming today.”

“They’re really good people,” said Lei Tie.

The old couple also saw them, and a happy smile appeared on their wrinkled faces. The old lady even beckoned them to her side. Qin Mian could not help remembering his grandparents.

“Grandpa, grandma.” Lei Tie jumped out of the cart, nimbly knelt down, and kowtowed.

Qin Mian did not hesitate to kneel on his side, “Happy New Year to grandpa and grandma.”

“It’s fine, get up quickly. Don’t dirty your clothes.” Old Madam Deng lifted Qin Mian up and looked at him. Seeing that the child was clean and his eyes were bright, she immediately took a liking to him. She took out a red envelope from her sleeve pocket and put it into Qin Mian’s hand. She said with a smile, “This is a little bit of grandma’s regard. Keep it.”

“Thank you, grandma!” Qin Mian had a way to get along with the oldies. He did not refuse and took it into his bosom pocket in easy-mannered. Then, he held the old lady’s arm and raised his eyebrow at Lei Tie with a smile, “I have, but you don’t. Quickly give a smile, maybe grandma will give you a red envelope.”

Lei Tie looked at him helplessly and indulgently, still unable to smile.

Upon seeing that Qin Mian was teasing deliberately, the old lady laughingly said: “I won’t give even if he smiles. He’s an adult.”

“I’ll give grandma a smile.” With that, Qin Mian smiled at the old lady.

The old lady was so happy that the wrinkles on her face deepened. “Alright, grandma will give you another red envelope.”

Qin Mian took it with a grin and passed it to Lei Tie. “Here, don’t be angry with me.”

The old lady laughed even more happily.

The old man put his hands behind his back as he watched with cold detachment. He had not acknowledged Qin Mian.

Qin Mian did not care much about it. No one could make everyone like them.

At this time, White Spot jumped out of the cart, walked to Qin Mian, rubbed against his leg, and ran ahead.

Qin Mian quickly called it, “White Spot, don’t run around.”

White Spot looked back at him and ran back obediently.

The old man stared at White Spot. A spark flashed in his eyes and he asked Qin Mian, “Is this a wolf?”

Qin Mian was startled and said, “Grandpa doesn’t have to worry. It’s very clever and won’t hurt people on its own initiative.

The old man nodded and his expression softened. He said to him (QM), “Let’s go home.”

Qin Mian was puzzled by his inconsistent attitude, but it was a good thing that the old man was willing to give him a good face. He supported the old lady to walk at the front and Lei Tie led the ox with the old man to walk at the rear.

When the old lady asked Qin Mian how old he was and where he was from, Qin Mian answered truthfully.

They went to Eldest Uncle Deng’s house first. Eldest Uncle Deng and his wife had three children. The eldest and the second were both daughters, and both were married. The only son, Deng Quan, was also married with two children; a boy [子] and a girl [女]. Both happened to make up a “好²” character. Their names were Kunzai and Xiya.

When they paid New Year’s greetings to Eldest Uncle and Eldest Aunt, Eldest Aunt appeared very warm, but Eldest Uncle looked very cold.

The two children came to kowtow to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Qin Mian gave Kunzai a red envelope of 16 Wen and a small wooden sword and gave Xiya the same red envelope and a hair string. Lei Tie was careless. He failed to mention preparing gifts for the children before the New Year. The wooden sword was what Qin Mian asked him to make while he found the red hair string from the space. In fact, it was a shoelace from a pair of new shoes that he had not had time to wear. It was a mixture of blue, purple, red, and yellow threads. It was novel and unique, which could not be found in this era. The shoelaces were very long. Qin Mian had divided the two shoelaces into four parts. In any case, besides him, no one knew that they were shoelaces.

Xiya liked the “hair string” very much. She thanked him happily and urged her mother to tie it on her head into a bowknot. It looked very beautiful.

After moving the gifts out of the cart, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the second uncle’s house.

Second Uncle Deng was kinder than Eldest Uncle Deng. While Second Aunt was polite to the point of alienation, she did not make things difficult for Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The couple had a daughter and two sons. The daughter was married; the eldest son Deng Zhong had a son and a daughter; the youngest son Deng Xiao had a son and two daughters. Qin Mian was impartial. The five children's gifts were the same as those of Kunzai and Xiya. The reaction of the three girls was almost the same as Xiya's. They happily tied the hair string to their hair.

Second Uncle Deng was a thoughtful man. As soon as he saw that the red envelopes and the gifts were given by Qin Mian, he guessed that Qin Mian was in charge of Lei Tie's household. He concluded that the two of them had a good relationship. He patted Lei Tie on the shoulder and said in a low voice, "No matter what is going on with you two, live well henceforth, and your mother can also be at ease in the Nether World."

Lei Tie said: "He is my wife." His tone was flat but firm.

Second Uncle Deng was stunned and sighed silently. He squeezed Lei Tie's shoulder hard, "You're an adult, and you've your own ideas. Second Uncle only wishes that everything goes well with you."

Qin Mian sat across them at the table, seemingly drinking tea, but actually was listening to them. He caught sight of a carrying pole and a small wooden rack in the corner. On the wooden rack hung wooden people, sewing kits, small embroidered pouches, and other small things. He asked, "Second Uncle, those are..."

Second Uncle chuckled, "Brother Tie didn't tell you? I'm a trader."

Qin Mian's heart skipped a beat. He took a look at Lei Tie and said to Second Uncle Deng, "Have you tasted the fried hemp leaves, fried dough twist, and sangza sent by Lei Tie last time?"

Second Uncle Deng nodded, "Yes, it tasted good. The children like them very much."

Qin Mian faintly smiled and said to Lei Tie: “We give the recipes of fried dough twist, sangza, fried hemp leaves, and sweet guozi to Second Uncle.”

Second Uncle Deng was startled and hurriedly said, “There’s no need to!”

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian deeply, “Listen to you.”

Second Uncle Deng still had something to say but Qin Mian interrupted him with a wave of his hand. “Second Uncle, don’t refuse. We don’t plan to make money with these snacks. At most, we usually make some for ourselves. These snacks are not complicated to make. They are very suitable to be sold from house to house. Plus, the production cost is not high. Although Second Uncle won’t make a big fortune, you can still make a small profit relying on ‘freshness’.”

“This...” Second Uncle Deng twisted his hands, still thinking he did not deserve it, “How about this: after earning money, I’ll share it with you.”

Qin Mian smiled, “Second Uncle had reached out a helping hand to Lei Tie. Lei Tie and I remember it in our hearts. Is Second Uncle unwilling to give us a chance to repay you?”

Lei Tie also said, “Second Uncle, don’t refuse anymore. My wife always keeps his words, and I listen to him.”

Second Uncle Deng laughed in spite of himself. These two children; Qin Mian returned the favor on behalf of Lei Tie, while Lei Tie praised Qin Mian in front of him.

Both did it for the other’s sake.

Speaking of it, if he refused, he would be regarded as an outsider. Thus, Second Uncle Deng nodded, “In this case, Second Uncle shamelessly accepted.”

Qin Mian described the process of the snacks in detail, and Second Uncle Deng attentively committed to memory.

After sitting there for a while, Qin Mian and Lei Tie returned to Eldest Uncle Deng's house. Lunch was arranged at Eldest Uncle Deng's house.

When Second Aunt learned that Qin Mian had given Second Uncle Deng a few recipes, she adopted a better impression of Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Lunch at the table was very peaceful, and there was nothing unpleasant about it.

After lunch, the old lady pulled Qin Mian and Lei Tie to chatter endlessly.

It turned out that in the first two years after the death of Lei Tie's biological mother, Deng Shi, Old Master Deng, Old Madam Deng, Eldest Uncle, and Second Uncle were very concerned about Lei Tie. They would visit him every two months and send him some self-made clothes, shoes, and socks. But with Lei Xiangren's birth and Du Shi's instigation, Lei Daqiang's heart was more inclined towards Du Shi. At the same time, something happened in the Deng Family – Eldest Uncle Deng and Second Uncle Deng split up. Eldest Uncle Deng was the eldest son, so the old parents followed him. On one side were the son and grandchildren, while the other side was the only grandson. Eldest Aunt believed that the old lady was partial, and she made quite a lot of mocking words. Second Aunt was not bad, but she was very stingy. She could not bear to see Second Uncle thinking of Lei Tie, and they always fought at home because of Lei Tie. These three reasons led to the complete neglect of young Lei Tie, who ultimately ran away from home.

After saying so much, what the old lady meant was to hope that Qin Mian and Lei Tie would not hate them.

Lei Tie shook his head to mean that he did not.

Qin Mian also did not think of that to the Deng family. Lei Tie was forced to run away from home, and the main culprits were his own father Lei Daqiang and Du Shi. Despite the kinship, the Deng Family was the maternal grandparents' home³. They were indeed not to blame.

Now, Lei Tie had grown up smoothly and had a small family. There was no need to worry about some small things in the past.

Dinner was at Second Uncle's house, and Second Aunt was very enthusiastic.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie knew that it had something to do with the recipes.

After dinner, the sun had set. The two went home bathed in the sunset glow.

Lei Tie had drunk wine a little too much and held Qin Mian's hand without letting go. Qin Mian worried that if he let the man drive the cart, the oxcart would run into the ditch, and so he drove the cart himself.

"Wife," Lei Tie leaned against Qin Mian's shoulder, and the puff of wine-smelling breath blew in his ear, "I always remember the day I left home..."

Footnotes

1. give a return banquet/invite back to dinner
2. means Good
3. 外家 also meant an external family. It might have something to do with being "external" which might mean that they weren't actually obligated to interfere (remember how patricidal the ancient people were) You can correct me if I'm wrong

Chapter 070: It's Good To Be A Landlord

070 – It's Good To Be A Landlord

Qin Mian held on his waist to prevent him from falling.

“I secretly went to see grandpa and grandma for the last time, but they found out and let little uncle catch up to give me a silver tael. Without this silver tael, perhaps Lei Tie would not have existed in this world. I took this one silver tael all the way north...”

Qin Mian turned his head and looked at his eyes carefully, “Are you sober?”

Lei Tie embraced him, “Very sober.”

“You never mentioned that decade, and I thought you didn't want to tell me.” Qin Mian looked at him with a faint smile. His heart was at ease.

“I won't hide anything from you.” Lei Tie pinched his chin, pecked his lips lightly, and took over the ox's rope, “I don't know where to start before. In those days...”

Qin Mian listened carefully.

It was not until they reached home that Lei Tie's story finished. Qin Mian was still in shock. He forgot to get out of the cart and was carried down by Lei Tie, who led him into the house and sat him down on the settee.

He absolutely never thought that Lei Tie's ten years were so complicated, so hot-blooded, so wonderful, and so hard.

It was no wonder he never mentioned the past.

Standing at the door of the kitchen, Qin Mian watched Lei Tie sitting in front of the stove, making a fire to boil water. He walked over, squatted down, and hugged him. Knowing Lei Tie's past, he felt even more heartache for Lei Tie, while his heart felt closer to Lei Tie. At the same time, he felt a little uneasy. Lei Tie was frank with him, but he did not immediately want to tell Lei Tie about the space. It had nothing to do with trust, but rather due to caution.

“Actually, I’ve hidden something from you—”

Lei Tie embraced his waist, slanted his head, and sealed lips. Then, he continued to watch the fire and his expression was as usual, “I know. I’ll wait until the day you want to tell me.”

Qin Mian was both relieved and disappointed. Lei Tie did not ask his secret which made him think that the man did not care about him. It was such a contradictory mood. However, they still had a long time and a good of many things did not actually have to be rush.

“When it’s 15th of the eighth lunar month, you’ll really teach me...” Qin Mian thought of the most important thing Lei Tie had said, and he could not control his excitement. His heartbeat sped up and his blood boiled.

Lei Tie nodded, “15th of the eighth month is the best time.”

Qin Mian hugged the man’s head and kissed him.

Lei Tie threw away the tongs in his hand, held Qin Mian’s waist in both hands, and lifted him up. He put the person wholly into his arms and let him straddled on his thighs. Lips and tongues easily seized the initiative.

The wine smell in Lei Tie’s mouth had not yet dispersed, filling Qin Mian’s entire mouth. Qin Mian’s body felt weak, his arms wound around Lei Tie’s neck, and he responded with all his strength, not to be outdone. Because his body was inferior to Lei Tie, he was soon defeated. He could only rely on Lei Tie’s arms to support his upper body.

“Just wait ...” Lei Tie’s lips spilled these muffled and husky words, and his tongue writhed more intensely as his right palm rubbed Qin Mian’s nape and back through his cotton-padded robe.

Qin Mian forcefully pushed him away. His pair of eyes stared at Lei Tie as he slightly gasped, and somewhat helplessly said, “My butt hurts being roasted.” In the first place, Lei Tie was close to the stove’s hearth, and he was much closer to it being in Lei Tie’s arms.

Lei Tie reached out his hand to feel it and it was really burning hot. He was stunned. Only a deep and happy laugh rolled out of his throat, “Hahaha...”

“What’s so funny—” Qin Mian looked at him and lost his mind. This man was really handsome. When he did not smile, he looked very hard to approach. When he laughed, starlight seemed to be able to fly out of his unshakable eyes, and the corners of his lips incited enigmatic curvatures, which made people unable to shift their gazes.

Lei Tie did not let Qin Mian go but shifted the wooden stump under his butt farther away from the stove while looking at his expression. Since his wife woke up from a coma, he had never shown any fear and disgust for the scar on his face. To be more precise, the scar on his face seemed non-existence in his wife’s eyes.

The water had boiled. After finishing personal hygiene, Lei Tie led Qin Mian back to the bedroom, and then he squatted in the corner of the wall and broke away a brick on the wall with his hand.

“What are you doing?” Climbing the bed, Qin Mian threw off the sandals on his feet and asked in confusion

Lei Tie took out a flat brown wooden box from the crack of the brick and put the brick back in. He handed the wooden box to Qin Mian and motioned him to have a look.

Qin Mian opened the wooden box suspiciously. There was a stack of paper inside. After a glance, he stood up and said, “Silver banknotes¹? One, two, three... Three sheets of 10,000 taels silver banknote, a sheet of 5,000 taels

silver banknote, and five sheets of 1,000 taels silver banknote. A total of 50,000² taels?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian sneered, crossed his arms in front of his chest, and looked condescendingly at Lei Tie, “Since it’s hidden so tightly, why give it to me?”

Lei Tie sat beside him and pulled him to sit down. He said in a low voice, “I didn’t it to give you before because I was afraid you would run away.”

The corner of Qin Mian’s mouth twitched. He looked up and thought about it. If Lei Tie gave the money to him in the days when he had just transmigrated and was penniless, he might have taken the money. But he would not take it all away. He would have taken at least a thousand taels.

Qin Mian deliberately said, “Right now, I may also run aw—”

His words had yet finished, his body suddenly felt heavy—he was firmly pressed on the bed by Lei Tie.

Lei Tie’s left hand pressed his (QM) right wrist, while his right hand locked his (QM) left wrist. His dark eyes firmly fixed on him (QM) as he said in a deep voice, “No matter where you run, I’ll find you.”

Qin Mian chuckled, raised his left hand, and stroked Lei Tie’s nape, “I’m joking. Since you don’t like living in the town, we’ll go to Li Zheng to buy more land tomorrow. Get up. I’ll hide the money.”

Lei Tie turned over and lay on the bed with his hands pillowed his head as he watched Qin Mian opening the wardrobe and then the secret chest inside with satisfaction on his face. In his (LT) deep and serene eyes, there was a trace of a doting smile.

Qin Mian did not feel relieved at all when he left such a large sum of money at home. He merely did it for show. Turning his back to Lei Tie, he put the wooden box into the (magical) space and locked the secret chest.

In the secret chest, apart from the 500 taels silver banknote from Lei Tie selling bear paws, there were two sheets of 100 taels silver banknote, which were the revenue of Eating Savory Restaurant.

With nothing to do, Qin Mian moved the cash box out onto the bed, and they counted the small sum of money together. Lei Tie also had the key to the cash box, but only Qin Mian had the key to the secret chest.

In the cash box, there was a silver ingot of 50 taels, which was prepared for an emergency, a silver ingot of 10 taels, four silver ingots of 5 taels, eight silver ingots of 1 tael, three strings of copper coins³, and forty-five pieces of copper coins. The total of assets upfront was 91 taels and 45 Wen.

“How much land do we buy?” Qin Mian contentedly patted the money box. All the money in it was earned by them bit by bit, which made him feel a sense of achievement.

Lei Tie said, “You decide.”

Qin Mian leaned on his pillow, thought for a moment, and said, “Buy 5 mu⁴ of paddy field, 5 mu of farmland, and 10 mu of uncultivated land for planting vegetables and fruit trees.” Since they would live in the countryside for the greater part of their lives, it was also good to be a happy landlord.

With a cheat⁵, it would not be difficult to cultivate the land. It was just that he could not buy too much land at one time so as not to be so conspicuous.

Taking words into action, the next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie come to Li Zheng’s home with money and snacks.

Li Zheng was surprised to learn that they were going to buy lands, “Aren’t you running a shop in the town? Why do you want to buy farmland?”

Qin Mian said in a high-sounding voice, “Uncle Li Zheng, between scholars, farmers, craftsmen, and merchants, merchants have the lowest status. We’re originally farmers, and we dare not forget our roots.”

Li Zheng nodded, "That's true. There're three families in our village who have come to me to sell their lands. There're a total of over 20 mu of paddy field and farmland. However, they're scattered; a piece here and a piece there. There's plenty of uncultivated land in the village."

Lei Tie said, "It's inconvenient to take care of it if it's not in a piece."

"No other way," Li Zheng took a sip of tea, "but you can exchange with other people's land."

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian inquisitively.

Qin Mian thought for a moment, "Then, we only buy 15 mu of uncultivated land for the time being, and then buy paddy field and farmland after the wheat harvest."

"Sure." Li Zheng asked, "The land that is neither farmland nor residence in the village is basically uncultivated land. Where do you want to delimit this 15 mu of uncultivated land?"

Qin Mian asked, "Is it alright to delimit a square field next to our house in the direction of the grove?"

After Li Zheng thought about the condition of that piece of land, he frowned slightly, and said in a dilemma, "Won't it take up a part of the housing site..."

Qin Mian put a small gray pouch on the table, pushed it in Li Zheng's direction, and said with a smile, "Whether or not it's a housing site, is it not a matter of uncle's words? Besides, there're seven rows of housing in our village. Aside from the row where our house is located and the row in front of our house, there are other five rows. If a villager wants to buy a house site, he can choose in the other five rows of housing. What do you think? Plus, we don't want to take whatever advantage; we mainly consider that the land which can be connected with our home is convenient."

Li Zheng felt the pouch. It was a big ingot and from the size of it, it was probably a 5 taels silver ingot. He put it into his sleeve and said with a

smile, “Alright, I’ll let you have that piece of land.”

“Many thanks, Uncle Li Zheng.” Qin Mian said happily.

Li Zheng looked at Lei Tie with a smile and joked, “Tiezi, having such a wife, you won’t suffer afterward. Haha...”

Lei Tie cupped his hands in obeisance and said, “Afterwards, we still have to ask Uncle Li Zheng to take care of us.”

“Well said, well said.” Li Zheng laughed happily. Lei Tie’s wife was good at handling people. He had already brought two bags of expensive snacks and then again gave 5 taels of silver. Even if they had something to trouble him in the future, they would not slight him.

He opened a book and looked at it, “The price of uncultivated land is 1 tael and 200 Wen per mu. If you buy 15 mu of uncultivated land, it is 18 silver taels. In addition, the cost of handling the land deed is 50 Wen.”

Qin Mian immediately took out a 10 taels silver ingot, a 5 taels silver ingot, three pieces of 1 tael silver ingots, and counted 50 copper coins.

Li Zheng received the money, stood up, and straightened his clothes. “Let’s go. Now we’ll go and delimit the land. After breakfast, I’ll go to the county to handle the land deed for you.”

“Thank you for your trouble, Uncle Li Zheng.”

Li Zheng took his two sons as helpers. They took the measuring tools to measure the land. Sticks were inserted around to mark the land with strings tied between the sticks.

After marking every corner, Qin Mian’s house fell in the middle of the east boundary. If he wanted to expand the house in the future, it would be convenient to expand to the north, west, and south.

Note:

Footnotes

1. banknote with a value in silver
2. I counted and its actually 40,000. Perhaps some notes were missed.
3. A string is 1,000 copper coins which equal to a tael
4. 畝 a unit of area equal to one-fifteenth of a hectare; a mu is 666 m²
5. refers to the spiritual spring water

Chapter 071: If You Want to Be Rich, Plant Fruit Trees

071 – If You Want to Be Rich, Plant Fruit Trees

There were hundreds of trees in the grove, such as locust, white poplar, fir, willow, and bamboo. The trees were worth a sum of money if they were cut down and sold. Qin Mian suggested buying several baskets of eggs to gift to the villagers. Whether it was an elder in his 70s or 80s, or even a newly born baby, he would give two eggs to each person that should be considered as him buying these trees, so as to avoid future disputes.

The villagers were quite happy. These trees had been there for a long time and they did not plant them. It was a surprise that they could get benefits from it. People in a farmer's household were particular about "the more sons, the more happiness". The smallest family of three members could get six eggs, and a large family could get more than 20 eggs. They could eat two eggs per meal lasting for several days.

After the land deed was obtained, Qin Mian and Lei Tie prepared tea and snacks, and put writing brush and paper on the short-legged table. Their heads were next to each other as they planned the new farmland.

"What do you think?" Qin Mian just casually asked. Lei Tie did not have high requirements for many things and the things he often said were "listen to you" or "you decide".

Surprisingly, Lei Tie opened his mouth and pointed to a place in the square drawn by Qin Mian, "It's convenient to dig a pond here to raise fish and plant lotus root. It's also convenient to water the vegetables."

Qin Mian's eyes lit up. "That's a brilliant idea. The so-called "face south with the back to the north"¹, when the wall is built on this piece of land, the entrance gate should be right in the south. The trees can't be planted from the house to the gate to avoid blocking the view. This is the most suitable place to dig a pond."

Lei Tie nodded, "I've seen a gourd-shaped lake in the south². Our pond can imitate that with a bridge at the waistline."

Qin Mian gave him a thumb up. After drawing the pond and the small bridge with his writing brush according to what was said, he pointed to a corner with the tip of the brush. "We'll have our hands full with farming and planting vegetables and fruit trees. We'll hire people later, right? Keep a piece of land next to the wall here to build a servant's quarters."

Looking at his cheerful and energetic appearance, Lei Tie's eyes softened. In that year when he was forced to marry a man soon after he returned home, his heart felt a part of sadness and three parts of humiliation, but in fact, he still had six parts of willingness. During his twelve years at home, nobody cared about him; during his ten years away from home, nobody genuinely put him in their heart, and even nobody could step into his heart. Moreover, he was used to seeing all kinds of darkness. Therefore, he longed for someone who belonged to him completely, belonged only to him, and that he could love with all his heart. At that moment, Qin Mian appeared. Although he was dark, thin, timid, and weak, he had no parents and no support. After Qin Mian married him, the boy could only rely on him. So, no matter what, he would not agree to divorce. In spite of Qin Mian was a man, (LT) he did not at all like women as he had been abused by Du Shi for many years. It was good that Qin Mian was a man. Men understood men better. At first, he only wanted to possess and control Qin Mian; now Qin Mian was the one he loved.

"Am I talking to you?" Qin Mian knocked on Lei Tie's forehead with a writing brush.

Lei Tie held his left hand, and his deep and low voice brimming with magnetism, "I'm listening. You keep talking."

Qin Mian's brush continued to slide on the paper, "This piece of land for planting vegetables, this one for flowers, this one for grapes, this one for peaches.... and this one for Sichuan peppers. This piece of land can be used flexibly depending on the season to plant watermelon, cantaloupe, and so on. The grove is reserved for the time being. It can be turned into a small garden in the future."

"You planned it very well." Lei Tie said.

They went out with a bundle of slender sticks and divided a large area of uncultivated land into pieces of smaller areas. After working for more than two hours, they were sweating.

Only when the weather was warmer could the fruit trees be planted.

After the Lantern Festival on the 15th day of the first lunar month, the New Year was considered over. The weather was getting warmer and a few trees had grown small knots alike and had yet produced tender shoots.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to their shop. After arranging all the general affairs, they focused on the newly bought land.

They first hired good tree planters in the village, and then went to the orchard in the neighboring town to buy fruit trees. Instead of buying seedlings, they bought adult trees, namely, fruit trees that had previously borne fruits. A transplanted adult tree hardly survived, but Qin Mian had a magical space. He was confident.

He bought twenty peach trees, ten yellow peach trees, ten pear trees, six cherry trees, six jujube trees, ten plum trees, twenty sweet oranges trees, and two pomegranates trees. Common people were not willing to spend money to buy fruit to eat. In addition, people at this period of time were not very skilled in taking care of fruit trees, and so the taste of fruits was very ordinary. Therefore, there was not a big market for fruits, and fruit trees were also sold cheaply. Nearly a hundred trees, Qin Mian spent less than 4 silver taels. On his way back to the village, he passed by the town and changed 10 silver taels to copper coins in the town's bank³ for the convenient of paying the workers.

Dozens of donkey carts and ox carts carrying trees drove into the village. The mighty procession attracted the villagers to come and watch the bustling scene.

“It seems that Lei Tie is really rich. He has just bought more than ten mu of land and now bought so many fruit trees.” There was a villager said with envy.

Another villager said in bewilderment, “Fruits don’t make a profit. Why do they buy so many fruit trees? It’s strange.”

Yet another villager said with a smile, “Won’t we able to buy fruit cheaper in the future?”

There was even a villager said in pleasant surprise, “I’ve taken care of fruit trees. Maybe I can find some job in Lei Tie’s orchard.”

.....

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had no time to deal with this. They directed the cart drivers to transport the fruit trees to the planned areas. On the spot, they hired ten people among the villagers who were watching the scene to dig silt in the village’s ditch, river ditch, and pond. The silt contained duck’s, goose’s, and cow’s excrement as well as fish’s and shrimp’s waste. It was relatively fertile. After the fruit trees were planted, Qin Mian would surely use the spiritual spring water to improve the quality. He did this just to cover up the spiritual spring water. The farmers of the Great Xia Dynasty did not know that the silt could fertilize the farmland. No one ever dug it out and used it. Therefore, it was convenient for Qin Mian.

Qin Mian hired Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Li Zheng’s two sons; a total of six people. After digging the tree pits, they first laid a layer of silt on the bottom of the pits before planting the trees. Finally, the pay was settled according to the number of trees planted per person, which was 10 Wen per tree. The pay was quite high. With six people, each person could plant fourteen trees on average and could earn more than 100 Wen.

When Lei Tie called Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli over, Lei Xiangren also followed. After hearing Qin Mian say that he would settle the pay according to the number of trees planted, he found an excuse to slip away.

Qin Mian deeply sympathized with Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi. If they did not separate from the family in the future, they would have to continue to support Lei Xiangren, the “young master”.

Lei Xiangyi looked at Lei Xiangren’s back, and his face darkened. He looked at the expressionless Lei Xiangli and secretly made up his mind that after Lei Xiangli married a wife, he would split up with Lei Daqiang. Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao had not been matched with a partner because Lei Daqiang and Du Shi had already said that after Lei Xiangzhi became a *Xiucai*⁴, their value would increase accordingly and that they would have a better choice when matched. Fortunately, it would not be long before Lei Xiangzhi would take part in the county level imperial exam. Lei Xiangyi could afford to wait.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not participate [in the work]. They brought tea and water to the tree planters.

While digging a hole, Zhang Dashuan asked Qin Mian curiously, “Fruit is not worth money. Can you make money by planting so many fruit trees?”

Qin Mian joked, “It’s fine if it can’t make money. The flowers of so many fruit trees are also beautiful.”

Wu Di was listening at the side and could not help rolling his eyes, “Sister⁵, Brother Zhang is serious.”

“‘If you want to be rich, plant fruit trees’. Lei Tie learned how to grow fruit trees from outside, so we’re trying it.” Qin Mian kept a straight face when he told the lie.

Lei Tie was next to him. He raised his hand to stroke Qin Mian’s ear without saying anything.

Qin Mian had a smile on his face. What's wrong with relying on Lei Tie's connivance towards him?

Zhang Dashuan and the others all laughed at his verse of jingle⁶. They did not take this sentence seriously. Planting fruit trees required money and skills. Even if they were willing to follow suit, they dared not take the risks.

Zhang Dashuan and the others were able-bodied farmers. With their great strength, the works were highly efficient. Before dark, they had finished planting all the trees. Each tree had its own mark, which made it easy to count. Qin Mian and Lei Tie gave out their wages on the spot and gifted each of them a bag of sweet guozi that they could bring back for the children at home.

Zhang Dashuan and the others felt that he was very thoughtful. They all thought in unison that they would still come if the Lei Tie Family wanted to hire in the future.

The few idle villagers, who were watching at the side, were quite envious upon seeing them each carry a heavy bag of copper coins and a bag of snacks. They were determined to be on good terms with Qin Mian and Lei Tie in the future.

After all the others had dispersed, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were preparing to go home when a bulky dark man came over, "Brother Qin, Brother Lei."

Qin Mian had a good memory. He immediately remembered who this was. He had seen him several times before but had never talked to him. They only exchanged a few words during the New Year's greetings. "You're Xiao Hu's father, Big Brother Fang."

Fang Wu said with a smile, "Yes, Brother Qin has a good memory."

Qin Mian had a favorable impression of Fang Wu. When he asked Xiao Hu to watch over the rice grains, Fang Wu did not forbid Xiao Hu. It could be seen that Fang Wu did not have any disgust towards them just because he married Lei Tie.

“What’s it?” Lei Tie asked.

Fang Wu said, “It’s like this; I’d like to ask if your orchard needs to be cared for by people. My father used to help a landlord to take care of the fruit trees for several years. He’s experienced. Now that he is getting old, my older brother and I want to let him live in ease and comfort at home, but he can’t stay idle and still follows us to cut firewood. I thought, since he’s good at taking care of fruit trees and it’s easier than farming, I want to ask for this job for him.”

Lei Tie held Qin Mian’s shoulder, “Wife, you decide.”

Qin Mian asked Fang Wu, “We really need people, but how old is uncle this year? Is he in good health?”

Fang Wu said with ease: “My old man is 61 years old this year. Brother Qin can rest assured that he is in good health.”

With that, he asked tentatively, “Why don’t I ask him to come and take a walk tomorrow?”

Qin Mian nodded with a smile. “Yes. According to Big Brother Fang’s words, Uncle Fang really suits our requirement, but it also depends on the old man’s opinion.”

Shoutout Corner: Thank you, Ellie! ʘ(' ʘ `ʘ) You just sponsored Chapter 77! And you’re da best too! ʘ(≧▽≧)ʘ

Note:

Footnotes

1. describe the orientation of the house, that is, the house is located on the north side, the back of the house faces the north, and the entrance/doors open on the south side. China is located in the northern hemisphere of the earth and the eastern part of Eurasia. Most of the land is located north of the northern latitude. In winter, the sun’s altitude angle is small, with the doors and windows of the house

face south, it allows more oblique sunlight to enter the room, thereby increasing the indoor temperature. In summer, when the sun's altitude angle increases, the sun's rays from the doors and windows are relatively small, which can keep the interior cool. Source: baidu

2. southern part of the country
3. old-style Chinese private bank
4. a person who has passed the county-level imperial exam; scholar
5. Please be familiar with this "Sister" being addressed to a friend's [male]wife or married woman.
6. A short slogan, verse, or tune designed to be easily remembered, especially as used in advertising.

Chapter 072: Digging Pond (1)

072 – Digging Pond (1)

Back at home, Lei Tie went to the well and directly scooped water from the well to pour on his face.

Qin Mian frowned, “The water in the well now is still very cold, careful or you’ll catch a cold.”

“Unlikely, my body’s strong.” Lei Tie pulled off the towel on the clothes-drying pole to wipe his face.

Strong body? Qin Mian’s gaze slipped from his broad shoulders to his thick chest, to his narrow waist, to his buttocks, and then to his long legs. He coughed and looked away.

“Did you see White Spot?”

Lei Tie said, “Probably went to the mountain.”

White Spot had not lost its wildness just because it lived with two humans. From time to time, it went to the mountain alone. Sometimes for two to three days and occasionally brought back a small prey. At first, Qin Mian was worried that it would not return home at night. Later, seeing that it was dirty, tired, and had never been hurt, he let it had its way.

Qin Mian lit up the oil lamps in the house. He went into the kitchen to take a bowl and filled it with spiritual spring water. He carried it out to Lei Tie. “You get two buckets of water, mix this bowl of water in it, and then pour some on each fruit tree.”

Lei Tie did not ask a word as he nodded and went out with the bowl.

Qin Mian could see from the kitchen's window that he bent down to lift water from the well. His arms and shoulders imbued with power, and his back, waist, and hip outlined a charming curve. When Lei Tie's back disappeared outside the courtyard, he suddenly realized that he had been watching Lei Tie all the time. He rubbed his face to pull himself together and calmly scooped out rice to rinse. They had made certain of their intentions and Lei Tie belonged to his family. Wasn't it normal that he could not help staring at Lei Tie?

When Lei Tie came back from watering, Qin Mian grabbed his neck without warning and forced a kiss on his lips. He was a little puzzled. Upon seeing his wife walk away leisurely to continue cooking with lively movement and good mood, Lei Tie was relieved and sat quietly in his usual position – in front of the stove, watching the fire and adding firewood.

“How many people should we hire to start digging pond tomorrow?” Qin Mian ladled up the well-fried twice-cooked pork into the plate, which smelled extremely savory. He picked up his chopsticks and clipped a piece of meat to eat. Then he clipped another piece of meat and sent it to Lei Tie's mouth. “Have a taste.”

Lei Tie held the chopsticks and looked at him as he bit at the meat.

Qin Mian suddenly remembered that he had not changed the chopsticks.

“Thirty people. Twenty-two people dug up soil and eight people pick up the soil.” Lei Tie spoke after swallowing the meat in his mouth.

Qin Mian began to make the second dish, which was stir-fried lean meat with dried red pepper. Nowadays, even without meat tenderizer or cornstarch, he could still fry lean meat to be tender and delicious. When he was making dumplings on the evening of the ninth day of the first month, he inadvertently remembered that there was a time in his previous life when he was cooking, the cornstarch at home was used up and he forgot to buy it. Then, inspiration struck him to use flour. After mixing with flour, the cured lean meat was very soft and tender, not tough at all.

When the oil in the wok heated up, Qin Mian stir-fried the cured lean meat and ginger together for a while before adding dried red pepper. The spicy aroma made him want to sneeze, so he quickly turned his back to the wok.

“Digging a pond is also a big event. Do you want to go to Deng’s Village and tell the grandparents? There are two uncles and three cousins, too. If we don’t ask them to help us dig the pond, they may feel that we don’t take them into consideration. As for whether they’ll come or not, depends on them.”

Country folks were very particular about this. They would inform their relatives and friends of any big events at home to show respect, which also meant that both sides were in good terms.

His wife was considerate, Lei Tie nodded, “I’ll go early tomorrow morning.”

The next day, at dawn, Lei Tie drove to Deng’s village. Qin Mian had prepared breakfast, but Lei Tie had yet come back, so he ate alone. He had just washed the dishes and tidied up the house when Lei Tie came back. Eldest Uncle Deng, Second Uncle Deng, Deng Quan, Deng Zhong, and Deng Xiao jumped down from the cart with shovels and baskets.

Qin Mian was surprised and said, “Eldest Uncle, Second Uncle, Eldest Cousin, Second Cousin, and Third Cousin are here. Come in, please.”

Eldest Uncle Deng was still indifferent as he nodded.

Second Uncle Deng had a smile on his face and very kindly said, “Brother Mian, thanks for the hospitality.”

Deng Quan, Deng Zhong, and Deng Xiao all greeted Qin Mian with a smile. It was not good to call him “cousin’s wife”, so they called him “Brother Mian”.

It was their first time here. Entering the house, they could not help but look around curiously.

Deng Quan said with a smile, “Your house is well-organized.”

Deng Zhong nodded in agreement. The most noticeable thing in the central room was the wall. Unlike the wall of the common villager’s house where there were a lot of dried mud lumps between the bricks due to extrusion, theirs was all polished and leveled. On the wall opposite the door was a pair of calligraphy and painting, a small wall-mounted flower basket symmetrically on the left and right. There were also two “Happiness” characters pasted opposite each other, and four exquisite wall-mounted bamboo candlesticks in the four corners of the room that reached up to shoulder-height – the several exquisite objects with elaborated arrangement could easily attract the eyes of anyone entering the door, thus weakening their concern for the wall itself.

Taking another look at the furniture in the central room, the dining table was covered with reddish-brown and white checker tablecloth with a complete tea set placed on it, and the two high-back chairs placed side-by-side were padded with two finely tailored gray fur seats. On the spotless tea table, there was a fruit basket with a few apples and oranges in it. The four big leaning cushions on the settee looked soft. On the right side of the settee was a three-layer wooden rack which was neither high nor low. A wooden knife holder was placed on the top layer, on which was placed a smoothly polished wooden knife, and beside it was a small bowl. In the middle layer, there were pairs of wooden carriage models and sailing boat models. At the bottom layer, there were two snack plates, containing melon seeds and peanuts, which were convenient for the owner to take when sitting on the settee.

Continuing to look to the right, there was a waist-high cupboard beside the settee, with a vase on it. There were several bright flowers in the vase, full of vitality. It made people feel refreshed. A closer look, one would discover that the red flowers, yellow flowers, green leaves in the vase and the flowers in the wall-mounted basket were all made of cloth. It made people marvel at the ingenuity of the maker. The whole central room was very warm and elegant.

Deng Xiao joked, “It’s arranged so neatly that we dare not to sit down.”

Qin Mian took out the best tea from the cupboard to make tea for them. He said modestly, "Only fiddling around while idle."

Lei Tie took the snack plates into the kitchen. After a while, he came out with several plates of snacks. The snacks in the plates were piled high.

"Eldest Uncle, Second Uncle, and cousins, please make yourself at home." Lei Tie succinctly said.

Deng Quan hastily said that there's no need to stand on ceremonies.

"Eldest Uncle and Second Uncle, it's warm now. Why don't you bring the children here to play?" Qin Mian asked. Lei Tie was too tight-lipped; he could not count on him for this kind of domestic trivia.

Speaking of the children, Eldest Uncle Deng's face softened, "We're here to work, what do we bring them for? They're too noisy." Be that as it may, he had no disdain in his eyes and obviously loved his grandchildren.

Qin Mian said, "It's good for children to be lively. The pond we're going to dig is very large. It's estimated to take two or three days to completely dig up. It'd be better to bring the children tomorrow. Aren't boys at that age like to play with soil and mud? Running and jumping more often makes the body healthier. As for the little girls, I can let little sister watch over them. It's the right time for the girls to go out and have a look while they're still young."

He arranged it very carefully and said it sincerely. Second Uncle came around first, "Well then, we'll bring them here tomorrow."

Eldest Uncle Deng also nodded.

The three Deng cousins' expressions were even gentler. For Qin Mian to attach importance to their children was the same as attaching importance to them.

Qin Mian also added, "As for grandpa, grandma, Eldest Aunt, Second Aunt, and the three cousins' wives, I'm afraid we won't be able to welcome them

well at present. When the flowering and fruiting season of fruit trees is up, I'll invite them to have a good time."

Eldest Uncle Deng and the others' faces were brimming with smiles.

"That's a deal," Deng Zhong said with a laugh, "When the fruit trees blossom, we'll bring them to see the flowers."

"That's settled then." Qin Mian nodded with a smile, "At that time, I'll let Lei Tie pick you all up."

After chatting for a while, Deng Quan took the initiative to say, "It's getting late. Shall we go now?"

Qin Mian waved a hand, "Eldest Cousin, no hurry. You all can sit down a little longer, I'll call the others first."

After Qin Mian left, there was a moment of silence in the room.

Deng Quan looked at his tight-lipped cousin and shook his head helplessly. He thought to himself: *based on temperament, cousin and Brother Mian are quite compatible.*

Second Uncle Deng was bored sitting, so he stood up. "Tiezi, please take us there first and have a look at your orchard by the way."

The few men carried their shovels and baskets and went out with Lei Tie.

They needed to hire thirty people in total. In addition to the five members of the Deng Family, Qin Mian found another twenty-five people in the village.

The digging work was harder; 80 Wen a day. The picking up work was relatively easy; 50 Wen a day. It was fairer to pay according to the amount of soil dug up and the amount of soil picked up, which could prevent people from being lazy. Considering that they were all fellow villagers, Qin Mian did not do so. Being excessively calculating in everything was not the way to deal with things.

The high wages made villagers swarm up. If Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Zhang Dashuan, and Wu Di were not informed in advance, they would not be able to seize the quota.

Qin Mian also hired two married women to move the stove to the field with the purpose of boiling water and deliver tea. The wage was 20 Wen a day.

The two married women were too happy, they grinned from ear to ear. What a wonderful thing that just by sitting there boiling water could earn 20 Wen.

After Qin Mian called people, he returned home. The gate was locked, so he did not enter and went directly to the field.

Just after two steps, an old man with his hands behind his back came across. His eyes were bright and his body was thin, but his pace was steady. One could see that he was hale and healthy.

Once Qin Mian saw that the old man resembled Fang Wu by half, he greeted with a smile, "Uncle Fang."

"Hehe..." Uncle Fang squinted as he laughed and beckoning him to walk together, "This youngster's eyes are very sharp."

Qin Mian looked at him and shook his head. "Second Brother Fang said that you're 61 years old this year. He's surely fooling me. I think you're 50 at most; hale and hearty despite the years."

"Hahaha..." Uncle Fang laughed, "You boy! He's not fooling you. I've agreed to what Fang Wu said. I'll have to ask this youngster to take care of me later."

"Uncle Fang overwhelms this junior with more than what I deserve." Qin Mian politely said, "It's Lei Tie and me who want to ask Uncle Fang to take care of us."

Old people liked people who were modest and polite. Uncle Fang stroked his beard and nodded, "Well said."

Qin Mian said, "I don't know—"

Knowing what he was going to say, Uncle Fang waved his hand, “Let’s go and see the trees first.”

Qin Mian readily accepted all good advice and made a gesture of “please”.

When they came to the orchard, Uncle Fang was a little excited when he saw the fruit trees. He quickened his pace and walked to the front unconsciously.

Based on his expression, he really understood fruit trees. Qin Mian’s heart was truly at ease and quietly followed him.

Uncle Fang used his fingernail to pick out a small piece of bark from a branch. He looked at the color of the core under the bark and went on.

After turning around in the fruit trees, he stopped, turned back to Qin Mian, and said, “You bought a lot of fruit trees. There are three trees withered a little, I’m afraid they’d be hard to survive. The other trees are well chosen. However, the transplanted adult trees are difficult to survive. Now they’d only been transplanted for a day, so there’s nothing to see. If, after five days, these trees don’t show signs of withering, there’s basically no big problem.”

Qin Mian was not worried about this. He had confidence in the spiritual spring water.

“Later on, I may trouble Uncle Fang with the labor.” Qin Mian pondered for a moment, “Generally, the fruit season is three months. During the fruit season, I’ll pay Uncle Fang 200 Wen a month. Outside the fruit season is 50 Wen a month, what does Uncle Fang think? This junior doesn’t know about the market situation of this business. If the arrangement is unfit, please let me know.”

Uncle Fang waved his hand with happy laughter, “I don’t need so much. Pay 100 Wen per month during the fruit season and 20 Wen per month outside the fruit season. It’s a deal.”

After that, without waiting for Qin Mian to speak, he went back to the place where the pond was dug up.

Shoutout Corner: Thank you, TucTuc! ٭ٓٓ!) ٓ You just sponsored Chapter 78! (* · ٓ-)☆ We shall share the joy!

Note:

Chapter 073: Digging Pond (2)

073 – Digging Pond (2)

Qin Mian also went that way. The area of the pond was marked with branches, and the workers were divided into two groups, digging from the waist of the “gourd” towards both ends. If one group’s progress was too far behind the other, it would certainly look bad for that group. Each took off their cotton-padded clothes and only wore a single unlined garment with rolled-up sleeves. They stepped on the shovels as they dug the soil, working in full swing.

Lei Tie stood not far away, glancing over the crowd without expression.

“Your idea?” Qin Mian came to his side and asked in a low voice.

Lei Tie nodded, “Has the matter of Uncle Fang settled?”

“En.” Qin Mian suddenly saw Lei Xiangren carrying a shovel on his shoulders and swaggering towards this side. He felt disgusted in his heart, “Why is he here again?”

Lei Tie’s eyes turned sterner, “No one called him.”

Lei Xiangren came over very quickly and chose a position before stepping on the shovel to dig the soil, seemingly to be full of energy.

It was just that, when he dug a shovel of soil, others had already dug three.

Not far from him, Second Uncle Deng happened to notice this and scornfully frowned.

Qin Mian raised his eyes to look at Lei Tie, and said in a low voice, “[I’m] upset.”

Lei Tie pressed on his shoulder and motioned him to watch again.

Lei Xiangren slowly dug the soil with his heart blooming happiness. He could earn more than 200 Wen if he mingled with these people for two or three days, just like picking up money.

At this time, he suddenly felt a pain in his right knee and fell to the ground.

“What’s wrong?” A villager next to him asked kindly.

“It’s nothing. It’s nothing.” Lei Xiangren rubbed his knee. Perceiving that there was nothing wrong with it, he quickly got up from the ground. Who would have known, he had yet stand firm, his knee felt numb and totally unresponsive, and his bottom sat on the ground once again.

Lei Xiangyi was perfectly clear of Lei Xiangren’s mind, so he said in annoyance, “Second Brother, if you’re not well, go home to rest.”

“I—fine. I’ll come to help the Eldest Brother some other day.” Lei Xiangren choked back his unwillingness, afraid that there was some hidden ailment with his leg. He had to use the shovel as a crutch as he left sluggishly.

A few villagers who were close to him breathed a sigh of relief. Although it was not them who paid the wages, if they did more and got the same wage as Lei Xiangren, who had done less, they would naturally feel uncomfortable.

“Did you do it?” Qin Mian approached Lei Tie with his eyes sparkled.

Lei Tie looked steadily forward and raised his hand to hold his head down.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Xiangren’s back. If Lei Xiangren dared to take advantage of his family again, he would set off¹ Lei Tie!

Not wanting to make the workers feel that he and Lei Tie were not at ease and monitored them here, Qin Mian and Lei Tie intended to leave.

“Everyone, we’ll leave it to you here. Work in the morning until the beginning of the horse period² and continue at the end of the horse period³. Take a rest when you’re tired. It doesn’t have to be too rushing.”

It was two hours from the beginning of the horse period to the end of the horse period, which was enough for them to go home to eat and rest. All the villagers responded happily.

Qin Mian also told the two women who made tea not to cut off the tea supply and left with Lei Tie.

Nevertheless, even if they were not there, most people would not be lazy since Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and the Deng family were all there.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie drove the oxcart to the town. Qin Mian wrote a list and asked Lei Tie to buy snacks and fruits that children liked to eat, to prepare for the coming little guests. Meanwhile, he went to Eating Savory Restaurant.

It was not the shop’s open hour yet. The tables had not been moved out and the door was half-opened.

Qin Mian entered the door and saw that Yue Dong was leading Zheng Liu, Wang Shun, and the others to wash vegetables, skewer food, and make food balls. In the past few months, the staff had become skilled; their movements were swift and quick. In particular, Chen Si and Shi Tou were the quickest. They put a ball of meat in their hands, closed their thumbs and index fingers, and a ball popped up and fell into the bamboo sieve. In a short time, they could make eight to nine balls. The speed was as fast as a snapshot.

With a smile in his eyes, Qin Mian looked directly at everyone, letting them see his satisfaction, “Everyone has been working hard all the time. Yue Dong, you’ll lead everyone to have dinner in the shop this evening before going off work. After you all finished with these, pick out the dishes you

want to eat for dinner before opening the shop. In the evening, you'll have a hot pot; eat till your stomach bursts. My treat."

Wang Shun, Chen Si, Shi Tou, and Zheng Liu all stood up happily and said, "Thank you very much, small boss."

Yue Dong also smiled, "Small boss can rest assured." Qin Mian saying "My treat" was precisely that. However, he still needed to charge it on the account to make it easier later when he needed to balance the accounts.

Qin Mian raised his hand to signal them to continue working and went around the shop. The kitchen and the shop were very clean. It could be inferred that the staffs were not lazy just because he and Lei Tie reduced the number of visits to the shop. He became more satisfied and planned to appropriately increase their wages after a period of time.

He wrapped some freshly made food balls in oiled paper and let Yue Dong charge it into account, too. When Lei Tie finished shopping, they went home.

At noon, Qin Mian and Lei Tie treated Eldest Uncle Deng and his party to lunch. They also invited Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli over. Qin Mian cooked a large hot pot and stir-fried five to six dishes. It was quite a sumptuous meal.

Deng Quan, Deng Zhong, and Deng Xiao were especially fond of hot pot. They kept dipping food into the hot soup and rarely moved their chopsticks to the stir-fried dishes.

After the food balls in the pot were gone, Qin Mian put in another sixty to seventy balls.

After drinking a mouthful of water, Deng Quan continued to clip the savory and spicy food ball to eat as he asked Qin Mian, "Brother Mian, did you invite Zhao Sifa and Zhou Erhao?"

"No." Qin Mian used the serving chopsticks to serve Eldest Uncle Deng and Second Uncle Deng. "When we called people, they were just there.

They'd spoken, so I couldn't say no. Are they dishonest?" There was no surprise in his eyes.

Deng Zhong shook his head. "They're more than dishonest. I think they purposely came to muddle along."

Eldest Uncle Deng said slowly, "Brother Mian hasn't thoroughly considered this matter. After living in the village for such a long time, you and Tiezi should have a general understanding of the villagers' behaviors? You should find people in private."

Lei Tie defended Qin Mian, "It's me who asked my wife to call people directly."

Eldest Uncle Deng glanced at him and said nothing more.

Second Uncle Deng however, did not think Qin Mian was such a careless person.

Qin Mian secretly patted Lei Tie's thigh and helped Eldest Uncle Deng to clip a piece of flesh on the stomach of the fish. "Thank you for your concern. Actually, I deliberately said that I wanted to invite people to dig the pond in front of so many people today. Eldest Uncle, do you think that if I find people in private, will the uninvited villagers have any opinions about me and Lei Tie? The invitation is made public. Although there may be one or two people who are lazy and slippery, the initiative is in the hands of the villagers, and they can't blame me and Lei Tie for not having a spot. The development of our house will not stay at this stage. In the future, the number of times we need to hire people will be more. As it happens, we can see who're honest and dishonest. Anyone who is dishonest can be seen by others. If we're going to invite people to do some work next time, no one will say anything if we don't invite these lazy people. Our family doesn't run a charity hall to let them take anything for free."

The faint smile on Qin Mian's face was full of self-confidence with the manner of having a card up his sleeve.

Eldest Uncle Deng slightly nodded his head and took a profound look at him.

Second Uncle Deng laughed out loud and patted Qin Mian hard on the shoulder, “I knew you boy have a clever mind!”

Deng Quan and Deng Zhong looked at each other with a smile, “You can think so thoroughly, we can be less worried.”

Deng Xiao, whose mouth had not stopped as he engrossed in eating, only spoke at this time, “I’d said that Brother Mian and cousin can take care of their own home. Do you believe me now?”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were absorbed in thought and vaguely learned something from Qin Mian.

In the afternoon, Eldest Uncle Deng and his party continued to dig the pond. After Qin Mian and Lei Tie checked the progress, they went home and took hoes and baskets to work in the vegetable field.

There were some radishes and a lot of cabbages in the vegetable field. One person dug up and the other picked up the vegetables to transport home. When the weather was warmer, new vegetables would be planted in the vegetable field.

The red radish could be made into shredded pickled radish, and the cabbage could be made into pickled cabbage. These two dishes went well with rice. In particular, the pickled cabbage could be used to make dumplings with pork and pickled cabbage, boiled fish with pickled cabbage and chili, stewed meat with pickled cabbage, and even egg fried rice with pickled cabbage.

Lei Tie saw Qin Mian licking his lips with sparkling eyes –unbeknownst to him what delicious thing Qin Mian was thinking of– and he could not help but grab Qin Mian’s head and drop a kiss on his lips.

Qin Mian blinked his eyes and conveniently picked up a basket to cover their heads and separate from the eyes that might exist in the distance.

A fleeting smile flashed in Lei Tie's dark eyes. He only intended to have a little taste but changed his mind and deepened the kiss.

After the kiss, they looked at each other in silence before lowering their heads and continued to work.

Eldest Uncle Deng and his party had dinner at Qin Mian's house and were sent back by Lei Tie in an oxcart.

Eldest Uncle Deng said that he did not have to pick them up tomorrow. They would borrow two carts to take the children over, so Lei Tie did not have to run back and forth.

The next day after breakfast, Lei Tie went to the pond. At home, Qin Mian tidied up, took out all kinds of snacks and fruits, and put seven to eight plates on the table.

Two donkey carts stopped at the gate of the courtyard, and several children dressed in new clothes jumped out of the carts like dumplings. Deng Quan's children were Xiya and Kunzai; Deng Zhong's children were Many and Yuanzai; Deng Xiao's children were Xuanzai, Yuya, and Lanya. There were a total of seven children. The oldest was Xiya, ten years old; the youngest was Yuanzai and Lanya, both five years old. The children shouted at Qin Mian: "Cousin-uncle Mian!"

Eldest Uncle Deng and his party did not enter the house.

Second Uncle Deng said, "Brother Mian, the children are handed over to you. We'll go there directly."

"Rest assured, Second Uncle." Qin Mian led several children into the house.

The children just arrived at a new place, so they were still a little shy and did not speak. When they saw the snacks on the table, they relaxed and the small children ran over to eat snacks. Xiya had the demeanor of an elder sister and spoke less. Her eyes had been paying attention to the youngest Yuanzai and Lanya.

Qin Mian carried Yuanzai and Lanya onto the chair and moved the snack plates towards them. He smilingly said, “Take whichever you like.”

“Thank you, Cousin-uncle Mian!” Yuanzai, who looked dignified and strong, said out loud.

Shoutout Corner: ($\ast \geq \forall \leq \ast$) Thank you very much, McJohnston and Elaine!!! The sponsored chapters are now up to 82! ლ(' ღ 'ლ) I'm glad you guys are enjoying it!

Note:

Footnotes

1. like leash off your guard dog to bite the intruder.
2. 11 a.m
3. 1 p.m

Chapter 074: The Leisurely Farm Residence of Qin Mian and Lei Tie

074 – The Leisurely Farm Residence of Qin Mian and Lei Tie

Kunzai and Xuanzai had a general interest in snacks. When they saw a wooden knife, sailboats, and carriages on the wooden rack, they ran over excitedly and reached out for them.

Qin Mian walked over and gently said, “These are the gifts your cousin-uncle gave to me. You can play with them, but be careful, alright?”

Kunzai nodded and took the sailboat down to have a look. He fondled it admiringly.

Xuanzai then held the model of the carriage without loosening his grip and expectantly said to Qin Mian, “Cousin-uncle Mian, I like this carriage very much. Cousin-uncle Mian, give it to me.”

“Er...” Qin Mian avoided making any reply and euphemistically said, “If you like it, I can ask your cousin-uncle to make another one for each of you.” These were the New Year’s gifts from Lei Tie. He was unwilling to give them to others.

Xuanzai held the carriage tightly, pouting without speaking.

Xiya frowned and went over. She spoke harshly, “Xuanxuan, didn’t Third Aunt¹ teach you not to ask for other people’s things? If I want your favorite bamboo dragonfly, will you give it to me?”

Xuanzai bared his teeth and cried out, “No! That’s mine!”

“In that case, how can you ask for other people’s things?” Xiya sternly asked.

Qin Mian saw the situation was turning bad and hurriedly said, “How about this. Let’s go to your cousin-uncle and ask him to make a slingshot for each of you. We’ll go to shoot birds, alright?”

Xuanzai immediately put down the carriage and said happily, “Good, good! We’ll go to shoot birds.”

“I’m going too!” Kunzai also put the sailboat back.

Even Yuanzai slipped down from the chair and tottered over, “I’ll go too!”

At long last, they were coaxed into behaving for the time being. Qin Mian secretly wiped his cold sweat and nodded his head to express his thanks to Xiya. He did not know how to entertain these few little girls appropriately. While he was embarrassed, Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao came in together.

“We’re here, eldest sister-in-law.”

“Perfect timing.” Qin Mian breathed a sigh of relief, and welcomed the two people inside, “Little sister, I’ll have to trouble you to watch over these girls.”

Lei Chuntao chuckled and lifted the small basket on her arm. “Eldest sister-in-law can rest assured to leave it to me. Last time I saw these flowers in your house and thought they were very beautiful. I tried to make some myself. I’ll teach them how to make cloth flowers today, they’ll like it. Look, I’ve brought everything.”

In the basket were bits of cloth in various colors.

Lei Chuntao took the girls to the settee. After Qin Mian brought the snacks to the tea table, he had time to talk to Lei Xiangzhi, “Fifth brother, are you on break today?”

“Yes.” With a smile on his lips, Lei Xiangzhi looked at a room full of children. “Ten days later, there will be another two days off followed by the

county-level imperial exam.”

“Based on fifth brother’s look, you seem prepared.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “I wish you all the best.”

“Thank you very much. I don’t dare say that I’ll be on the top, but I’ll do my best.” Lei Xiangzhi said modestly.

Kunzai pulled Qin Mian’s sleeve. “Cousin-uncle Mian, let’s go to find cousin-uncle.”

“Alright.” Qin Mian asked Lei Xiangzhi, “Do you want to go there for a walk?”

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, “Let’s go.”

Qin Mian informed Lei Chuntao that he was taking Kunzai, Xuanzai, and Yuanzai to the orchard.

Lei Tie saw Qin Mian and he went over.

“Why come over?”

“They...” Qin Mian looked back. The three children were gone. He turned around and saw that the three children had already slipped into the dug pit, climbing up and down. They were having fun. He could not help shrugging. Children were playful and forgetful.

Lei Tie followed his gaze in confusion.

Qin Mian pulled his wrist and said, “Let’s hurry back while they haven’t come back to their senses. You make a slingshot for each of them.”

“How did you come to think of making a slingshot?” Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian said, “They’re interested in my sailboats and carriages.”

Lei Tie immediately responded, “Don’t give.”

Qin Mian amusingly looked at him, “That’s why I’m asking you to make the slingshots.”

The neglected Lei Xiangzhi shook his head helplessly. He walked neither hurry nor slow to the pond to take a look at the bustling scene and then strolled around.

Children were really forgetful, but they also had a good memory. They came back at noon for lunch, and when they saw the carriages and the sailboats, they remembered the slingshots. They all turned to look at Qin Mian, not daring to glance at Lei Tie. Lei Tie was always expressionless and looked very frightening. The three of them could act like overlords at home, but they dared not be presumptuous in front of him.

Qin Mian gave a wee smile and turned towards Lei Tie expectantly.

Lei Tie took out three slingshots from the cabinet and handed them over to Kunzai, Xuanzai, and Yuanzai without saying a word.

The size of the slingshots varied according to the age of the three children. The three children loved it at first glance and were all smiles.

Deng Quan saw that the rubber band of the slingshot was very thin and not strong enough to hurt people. He understood that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had taken it into consideration. He patted Kunzai’s forehead, “Don’t you thank cousin-uncle and cousin-uncle Mian?”

“Thank you, cousin-uncle and cousin-uncle Mian!” Xuanzai first said, “Cousin-uncle Mian, let’s shoot birds this afternoon.”

Qin Mian glanced evilly at Lei Xiangzhi, who he had asked to stay for lunch. “Alright, let your cousin-uncle Xiangzhi take you all.” He was really not good at looking after children.

Lei Xiangzhi was surprised, “Eldest sister-in-law, me?”

“Exactly you.” Qin Mian said righteously, “Aren’t you going to take the county-level exam soon? Relaxing before the exam will be beneficial to

develop ideas when sitting on the exam.”

Lei Xiangzhi readily accepted [the task].

Eldest Uncle Deng, Deng Quan, and the others were very happy. Lei Xiangzhi was a scholar. The children of their family could get some influence from the contact with a scholar to some extent, which was good for their future enlightenment.

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Qin Mian's conjecture was wrong. It took thirty people four days to completely dig up the pond, occupying over a mu² area and about two meters deep. Such an area and depth were enough for fish-farming and growing lotus roots.

Lei Tie invited two experienced carpenters from the town, with four apprentices, to build a wooden arch bridge on the waist of the “gourd” that could allow carriages to pass. Thanks to the mountainous area near the village, Lei Tie found the strongest ironwood to make the arch beam. The two ends of the arch beam were sunk into the ground, so it was firm and safe. On the top of the arch beam, there lay sawed boards of ironwood which were even carved with decorative patterns for skid-proof. Every pillar of the railing was embedded into the arch beam, making it very secure.

After the bridge was built, Qin Mian and Lei Tie dug canals to divert water from the river. In less than a day, the pond was filled with muddy water. It would be clear in two or three days. Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to dig some silt to put into the pond while he sneakily poured some spiritual spring water into the pond.

The fruit trees were planted, the pond was dug, the bridge was built, and the wall could be built next.

This time, Qin Mian only bought over two hundred greenish-black bricks, and the rest were red bricks. It was because he thought that red brick and green trees set off each other more beautifully for artistic mood.

The Green Mountain Village seethed with excitement again, and the villagers were anxiously waiting for Qin Mian to announce the news of inviting people to build the wall.

However, this time, Qin Mian did not announce it in public but invited people one by one. Soon, it was discovered that most of the people invited this time were those who had done well in digging the pond last time. Lei Xiangren, Zhou Erhao, and Zhao Si were not among them.

It was not a simple thing to enclose 15 mu of land. Qin Mian spent 10 silver taels just to buy bricks. A total of fifty people were invited to build the wall in sections according to the marks made earlier. Several sections of the wall could be carried out at the same time. Because there were too many people, they did not provide food, so the wages were 6 Wen higher than the pay of when they built the house.

Uncle Fang had nothing to do, so he enthusiastically helped to guide and supervise. His two sons were also helping to build the wall.

“Tiezi,” Uncle Fang asked Lei Tie while looking at the pile of greenish-black bricks, “what are these greenish-black bricks used for?”

Lei Tie said, “My wife said that the greenish-black bricks will be embedded in the red bricks to ‘write’ down the words ‘Leisurely Farm Residence’.”

Uncle Fang patted his thigh and looked at Qin Mian, who was talking to a villager carrying bricks, not far away. He said, “This is a good idea! Ah, I really don’t know how your wife’s brain develops.”

A light flashed past Lei Tie’s eyes. That was his wife. Of course, he was different from ordinary people.

He went to Qin Mian and handed him the bamboo cup in his hand.

Qin Mian was thirsty. He took the cup, raised his neck, and drank it in one breath. “I want more.”

Without demur, Lei Tie went to the boiler, filled the cup with cooled water, and then handed it to him.

Qin Mian smiled at him, drank two mouthfuls, and returned the cup to him, "Let's go to the south wall and have a look."

At this time, in the old house, Zhao Shi sat by the well, rubbing the clothes in the wooden basin every once and again. It was unknown what she was thinking as she kept frowning hard. She would look up to the west of the village from time to time and did not even notice the water splashing on her body.

Qian Shi passed by and kindly reminded, "Second sister-in-law, your shoes are wet."

Zhao Shi regained her senses and looked at her trouser legs and embroidered shoes uncaringly. She stood up and stretched out her hand to pull Qian Shi. "Third brother's wife, 'that family in the west' is becoming livelier. Do we just sit still like this? Let's go take a look. Qin Mian invited a few outsiders to boil water and deliver tea but didn't invite the two of us. This is inexcusable."

Qian Shi avoided her hand seamlessly and said: "Second sister-in-law, you can go by yourself. I've something else to do." Then she turned and went into the room. Her husband told her that as long as they did not provoke Qin Mian and Lei Tie, the two men would naturally think of them if there was any good thing. Persistently pushing forward would only incur their annoyance. Previously, it was because she was stupid that she followed Zhao Shi to make trouble with them.

"Ah?" Zhao Shi was rather baffled as she thought, "Qian Shi's changed?"

Like Zhao Shi, there was another person who could not sit still, Lei Daqiang. He went out for a stroll after breakfast in the morning. He wanted to go to the west of the village several times but backtracked several times. In any case, he could not have imagined that the eldest son, who he had not taken seriously, could now become so promising. The more promising Lei Tie was, the more he regretted that he was not good to Lei Tie; and the

more he regretted, the more he realized how stupid he was. He would never admit it, but in fact, his face was burning with shame, and he was also angry. Lei Tie invited so many villagers to move bricks and build the wall, but he did not ask him, his father! It was not that he did not think of making trouble, but when he thought that Lei Xiangzhi was going to participate in the county-level examination, he did not dare to act rashly.

County-level examination?

His heart skipped. Yes, he could use the county-level examination as an excuse to go to Lei Tie. His youngest brother was about to take part in the county-level examination. Wasn't it normal to ask him, the eldest brother, for some money?

Thinking of this, he rushed to the west of the village.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood beside the south wall, making clear to the bricklayers that they must not "write" the three words "Leisurely Farm Residence" wrongly and askew, or they would have to redo it.

"Rest assured little brother." The nearly 40-year-old bricklayer said with a smile, "You'd make it clear how many bricks are used for each stroke, how many bricks are high from the ground and how far apart between the characters are. If we still make mistakes, we won't have to do this business in the future."

Qin Mian touched his nose, feeling somewhat embarrassed.

Lei Tie cupped his hands in obeisance and said, "Uncle isn't to be blamed. My wife just pursues perfection."

"Haha, understandable." The bricklayer gave a tolerant smile and said to another bricklayer, "We also want to see what it looks like after doing it perfectly."

"Yeah." Another bricklayer put up a brick and scraped off the extruding slurry with a masonry knife. "It's the first time I heard that you can write like this; don't even need to hang a plaque³."

Lei Tie saw the sweat on Qin Mian's forehead, "Go home and have a rest." His wife had been under the sun for most of the day.

Qin Mian was really tired. He nodded and turned to walk home.

"By the way, I thought I would see Lei Xiangren again. Surprisingly, he didn't come."

Lei Tie looked ahead as he said, "Sick."

Qin Mian could not help laughing, "Your doing?"

Lei Tie said, "He came. I poked his numb acupuncture point."

Qin Mian laughed heartily, "Deserve it."

Note:

Footnotes

1. Xuan's mom
2. 666 m². So huge!
3. horizontal rectangular inscribed tablet hung over a door or on a wall

Chapter 075

075 –

Lei Daqiang came over with a slight cough.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie halted and politely greeted him.

“Father.”

Lei Daqiang looked at the back of the bricklayers in the distance and affectionately looked at Lei Tie. “Do you need any more hands here? Your father, I, still have a lot of strength.”

Qin Mian was about to open his mouth when his hand that was held tightly by Lei Tie was pinched.

“There are enough hands.”

Such an attitude made Lei Daqiang angry, and his face turned cold. He endured it and changed the topic, “Have you already known about your youngest brother’s going to participate in the county-level examination? You said you’re going to provide money.”

Qin Mian understood it clearly. He came for money.

Lei Tie nodded, “I did. It’s written in the separation document that whether it’s the fifth brother’s examination or the fourth brother’s, fifth younger brother’s, and little sister’s marriage, we’ll give one share to father’s five shares.”

Lei Daqiang choked, “How can the situation be the same now? You’re well-off now, so you should give more money. It also shows your care for your

younger siblings.”

Lei Tie said with a cold face, “We’ll give that share of money and also give the fifth brother some pocket money, but we won’t hand the money to you.”

Lei Daqiang was very angry and said harshly, “What do you mean? Am I, the father, greedy for my son’s money?”

Lei Tie said indifferently, “You know yourself.”

“You...” Lei Daqiang could not help but feel guilty when he thought of the 20 silver taels that Lei Tie gave him.

Lei Tie looked at him just like looking at a stranger as he said, “I’ll increase your monthly money later, but if you all ask for trouble...”

Lei Daqiang was shocked by the look in his eyes. He very much wanted to courageously say “I don’t want your money”, but he could not give up the money. His lips wriggled for a long time, but his tongue failed him. He snorted, swung his sleeve, and strode away. The sight of his back cut a sorry figure.

All of a sudden, Qin Mian laughed.

Lei Tie looked at him inquisitively.

Qin Mian said, “I suddenly think that it’d be a good relief to tease them once in a while.”

Lei Tie touched his head, “Go home.”

Five days later, the wall of the Leisurely Farm Residence was completely built and their house became an independent small manor. Then they began to work on some details.

Before they knew it, the last ten-day of second lunar month ushered in. Two days later, Lei Xiangzhi would take part in the county-level examination. The overall atmosphere of the old house became tense. Even Lei Dagang went to the old house to visit for a while and gave Lei Xiangzhi 500 Wen so

that he could take the exam properly and be at ease. He was the only scholar in the old Lei Family's generation; they could not help but attach importance to him.

All in all, it was their younger brother, so Qin Mian and Lei Tie come to the old house together.

Before they sat down, Du Shi brooked no delay as she said, "Your fifth brother will take the county-level examination for three days this time. The old man and I gave him 10 silver taels pocket money. You give him the money, too."

Lei Xiangzhi sighed silently, "Mother."

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other in silence. *Is it necessary to ask for money in such a hurry?*

Qin Mian had no intention to argue with Du Shi. He took out a silver ingot of 50 taels from his purse and handed it to Lei Xiangzhi, "Fifth brother, keep it. The knowledge that has been truly mastered will not be easily forgotten; the knowledge that has not been mastered is too late to review now. In these two days, just have a proper relaxing time. Only by maintaining the best condition can you perform better than normal in the examination room."

Everyone looked at Qin Mian in surprise. *Didn't he forget his past? How could he understand this and say it clearly and logically?*

Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi fixedly stared at the silver, wishing that the silver was for them.

"Many thanks, eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law." Lei Xiangzhi received the silver with both hands. If he refused to accept it, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang would make trouble again. It was better to accept it generously and repay their kindness later.

Du Shi's and Lei Daqiang's faces looked much better.

Lei Tie asked, “You’ll be going together with other scholars?”

Lei Xiangzhi was flattered by his eldest brother’s rare concern. He straightened his back a little more, “Exactly. The two teachers in the school will personally lead us.”

Lei Tie nodded and resumed his indifferent appearance.

Wei Shi suggested, “It’s hard to get together today. The eldest and eldest daughter-in-law should stay for lunch. Two days later, Old Five will have an exam, and gathering with his brothers can also be a great encouragement. What do you think, Old Five?”

Naturally, Lei Xiangzhi could only nod his head, “Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law, let’s have lunch together.”

Qin Mian however, felt that Wei Shi’s smile was very reluctant today. Her right hand always touched her abdomen unintentionally, and there was some imperceptible haze hidden under her eyes.

Du Shi gave Wei Shi a triumph look. She even gave Qin Mian and Lei Tie a kind smile, and her voice was very gentle, “Stay for lunch. At noon, I’ll make you stewed pork with dried vegetables.”

Qin Mian looked at her in horror and could not speak for a moment. *Is this really Du Shi?*

Lei Chuntao guessed what he was thinking. She was amused and said, “Eldest sister-in-law, mother’s stewed pork with dried vegetables is a special dish. It’s a pity to miss it.”

No one wanted to spoil everyone’s fun on a day like this. Qin Mian nodded with a smile, “Then we can have a taste.” As for why Wei Shi and Du Shi were so strange today, he did not care, as long as the *heat* did not reach him and Lei Tie.

He agreed, and Lei Tie also did not object.

This one time of Du Shi's rare generosity, she cooked a large wok of delicious dried vegetables stewed pork, loaded on two large plates. The taste was really good. Qin Mian ate three bowls of rice, while Lei Tie ate four bowls. Du Shi and Lei Daqiang also did not give them attitude.

This meal was the most enjoyable meal in the old house.

When they were leaving, Lei Tie motioned Lei Xiang Zhi to send them off.

Out of the courtyard gate, he said to Lei Xiangzhi faintly, "You only need to concentrate on examinations and learning. Don't have to worry about money. Your eldest sister-in-law and I will support you in the future prefectural exam and college exam¹."

Qin Mian nodded with a grin.

Lei Xiangzhi deeply bowed with hands folded in front, "Many thanks, eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law."

Qin Mian thought about it and added, "It'd better not to mention it to other people, so as to avoid other incidents."

Lei Xiangzhi replied, "I understand."

A few days passed in a flash.

Lei Xiangzhi came back from the county and brought back good news. He had made a good achievement of being first place. The Lei's family members were all elated. Although it was only a county exam, obtaining first place was extremely hard to come by. It was clear that Lei Xiangzhi was indeed a good seedling at learning. After a day's rest at home, Lei Xiangzhi went back to school to prepare for the prefectural exam in the fourth lunar month. After he passed the prefectural exam, he would be an entry-level examinee. If he also passed the college exam, he would be settled a Xiucai².

.....

Under the care of Qin Mian and Lei Tie, the Leisurely Farm Residence changed from day to day. Only by the third lunar month did the two men be thoroughly busy and the Leisurely Farm Residence was officially completed.

Cacti were planted on the wall of the manor, which could be used for ornamental purposes and also to prevent thieves. The entrance gate was a vermilion lacquer gate with a width that could accommodate two carriages and reached up to 8 chi³. On the red wall on the right side of the gate were the two words “Leisurely[悠然]” composed of greenish-black bricks, and on the left side were the two words “Farm Residence[田居]”. It was of a person-height, neat and eye-catching. There was a duty room on the left side of the entrance. The manor was too big, so it was inevitable to hire a porter. It was empty at present. To the left of the duty room, was a row of servant’s quarters facing south and backing north, all of which were three-room style with a total of four sets. To the north of the servant’s quarters was the plum forest.

There was also a row of building on the right side of the gate. Among these was a warehouse used for storing firewood, farm tools, and putting the oxcart. The other four were ox house, pig house, chicken house, and stables. Ten pear trees were planted in front of this row of buildings.

Straight ahead into the gate, one could see the wooden arch bridge and the pond at a glance. There were peach trees at both ends of the wooden arch bridge; one on the left and one on the right. The newly hatched fish had already been put into the pond and lotus roots had been planted. The small lotuses only revealed pointed shoots. A stone path that could accommodate two people walking side by side surrounded the pond and three to five willows trees were scattered next to the pond. Under a willow tree near the north head of the bridge, there was a long wooden chair, and under another willow tree not far away were a round stone table and four stone benches. The gourd-shaped flowerbed, which had been carefully managed, was almost completely parallel to the path. Inside were winter jasmine, magnolia, tree peony, herbaceous peony, camellia, gardenia, and so on. Some of them were dug out from the mountain and some were smuggled

out of the space by Qin Mian. There was a small path in the east and west of the flowerbed for people to walk along.

To the north of the pond was the peach forest. From the west of the forest to the northwest corner, there were large vegetable and pepper fields. Qin Mian thought that the smell of Sichuan pepper was unpleasant. Moreover, he sometimes needed to irrigate the manure in the vegetable field, so he specially arranged the vegetable field and pepper field in the corner. To the east of peach trees were the house of Qin Mian and Lei Tie. There were two additional trees in front of the house; a ginkgo tree about 20-year-old and a maple tree about 40-year-old. Qin Mian and Lei Tie found them on the mountain and dug them out especially. It took a lot of effort to carry them. Ginkgo and maple trees were wonderful choices for ornamental plants.

There were some open spaces around the house for future expansion.

Beyond the peach forest to the north, there was a grove, which had not been transformed for the time being. Twenty sweet oranges, six cherry trees, six jujube trees, and two pomegranate trees were planted to the north and east of the grove.

It was now the third lunar month. Flowers bloomed in the Farm Residence. The white plum and pear flowers were like snow on the branches in winter. The delicate and charming peach blossoms were like pink clouds contended in beauty and fascination with the pink-purple cherry blossoms ... There were also white magnolia, yellow winter jasmine, pink peony, red camellia, and so on in the flowerbed. The splendid beautiful purples and brilliant reds⁴ attracted butterflies to dance lightly and gracefully, and bees to buzz for a long time, unwilling to leave.

Qin Mian looked at the manor he created. With his hands clasped behind his back, he faced up and looked at Lei Tie with a satisfied and complacent smile.

“How is our new home?”

Lei Tie embraced the person beside him, bowed his head, and kissed Qin Mian’s lips. He said in a low voice, “Home is where you are.”

The smile in Qin Mian's eyes deepened, feeling pleased as well as sweet, "Let's go there and sit down."

White Spot's body, like Qin Mian, had been nourished by the spiritual spring water for a long time that its black fur appeared more black and shiny. It had drilled out of the flowerbed and nimbly dodged the angry bees. Upon seeing its two masters walking away, it went to catch up with them.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Entry-level examinations have 3 stages: 1st County, 2nd Prefectural, 3rd College.
2. Xiucai "distinguished talent" who can enjoy officially sanctioned social privileges such as exemption from statute labor, access into local government facilities, and limited immunity against corporal punishments. Source Wikipedia
3. 1 chi = 1/3 meter. The gate is 2.7 meter high
4. lit. Beautiful flowers.

Chapter 076: Buying People

076 – Buying People

Qin Mian and Lei Tie planned to fill up the manor with staff. The town's brokerage was too small, and the people they were selling were jagged and lack of basic quality. The two men went to Zhaoyang County Town to survey and stroll around in passing.

The county town and outskirts town were different. The level of liveliness alone was incomparable to that of Running Water Town. The gate of the county town was full of incoming and ongoing people and an endless stream of horses and carriages. After storing the oxcart at the carriage station, the two men walked into the town. Qin Mian looked at the spacious streets, the beautiful clothes of the pedestrians, and the rows of shops; it was somewhat too much for the eye to take in.

“To Changmen Street? It's lively there.” Lei Tie sought his wife's opinion, taking pity on him. It was his little wife's first time to come to the county town, so he ought to let him have fun.

Qin Mian said, “No, let's just casually roam around.” As a transmigrator, he only saw the ancient-styled towns and cities on television and films before. Now that he was personally on the scene, it really perked his interests a bit.

The things in the county town were more exquisite, more upscale, and more diverse than those in the town. Qin Mian animatedly went to a cloth shop, a jewelry shop, an iron shop, and entered a large restaurant. After walking around inside and scanning the food on the table, they came out. The waiter, who had enthusiastically introduced them all kinds of cuisine until his mouth dried up, gloomily rolled his eyes behind their backs.

Lei Tie had been walking beside Qin Mian in silence. While Qin Mian looked east and west with interest, he looked at the various expressions on Qin Mian's face.

If the waiter also transmigrated, he might be tempted to scold both of them: "Snake spirit disease¹!"

One would not know the other, and Qin Mian by no means would care about what the waiter was thinking. He once again pulled Lei Tie to two snack shops, looking carefully and asking attentively, but he did not buy anything.

Lei Tie could see that he was thinking of some money-making ideas.

After strolling for nearly two hours, Qin Mian asked the owner of a shop the location of the brokerage and went directly with Lei Tie.

The brokerage in the county town was more stylish than in the town and there were many more choices here. As soon as the owner of the brokerage heard that they wanted to buy people, he called all the people out and arranged them into several rows, giving free rein to Qin Mian to choose.

Qin Mian was not used to choosing people like goods, but he had to do so. If he carelessly chose people with health and behavioral problems, it would be troublesome.

He first selected a couple under 40 years old. Their clothes were old and patched, but they were clean and not sloppy. The man was called Uncle Fu, who was healthy and good at farming; the woman was Aunt Fu, who could farm, cook, sew and mend, and make clothes. She could help washing dishes, washing clothes, and feeding chicken in the manor.

Qin Mian had thought that since Lei Tie was his person, he should be good to him and should not let him wash the dishes for a lifetime.

He also picked a young chap who could drive a cart, named Gou Wa. He was 20 years old. There was a drought in his hometown and he was the only one left in the family. He sold himself and stranded in Zhaoyang County.

Qin Mian chatted a bit with Gou Wa and felt that he was very smart. He could farm and drive a cart. So Qin Mian bought him as a cart driver. When he did not have to drive a cart, he would help to do farm work and miscellaneous work.

The three people were bought for a total of 300 taels silver and all of them signed an irrevocable title deed.

When they went back, it was Gou Wa who drove the oxcart, steadily.

“Gou Wa, what’s your formal name? ‘Dog Baby’ is too unpleasant to hear.” Qin Mian asked.

Gou Wa grinned, “Answering to the little young master, this little one doesn’t have a formal name. Please bestow a name, little young master.”

Qin Mian was a little awkward, “Bestow or whatever. Anyway, the name Gou Wa is really unpleasant to hear. How about I name you Xile²?”

Gou Wa happily said, “Many thanks, little young master. It’s a nice name. Afterward, this little one is called Xile.”

Qin Mian said, “Don’t use ‘little one’ and just use ‘I’. Your eldest young master and I are very easy to get along with; you all don’t have to be too formal. After all, if there is no mishap, you’ll stay in our manor for the rest of your life. I hope we can get along well. As long as you do your duty well and don’t make any mistakes, we won’t slight you.”

“Please rest assured eldest young master and little young master, I’ll do a good job.” Xile did not comment on the “eldest young master is very easy to get along with”. He did not even dare to open his eyes to take a look at the eldest young master, but he thought Qin Mian was a kind master.

Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu looked at each other and felt a little uneasy about the future, but they were also a little relieved. Although they were not free, they wished to settle down.

Qin Mian thought for a moment and said, "In a little while, buy some tableware, pots, shovels, and whatnot in the town. Before Xile gets married, he'll join Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu for meals. The future matters will be discussed in the future."

Aunt Fu immediately answered, "Yes, little young master"

Neither she nor Uncle Fu seemed to be talkative, which was more in line with Qin Mian's intention.

"Tie, do you have anything to add?" Qin Mian asked Lei Tie.

Lei Tie was taken aback, "What did you call me?"

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows, "Tie. Can't I?" He did not think it was kind enough to call his full name.

"Anything you like." Lei Tie put his arm around his waist and pressed his lips on his forehead, "Nothing to add."

Qin Mian did not push him away and paid attention to the reaction of Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu.

Aunt Fu did not seem to think much; Uncle Fu was shocked and immediately lowered his head.

Qin Mian smiled and relaxingly leaned on Lei Tie, no longer talking. He did not expect the three people to immediately accept that he was together with Lei Tie, but at least they should not discriminate against them.

When the oxcart arrived in the town, Qin Mian bought more pots, tableware, ladles, and basins. Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile had no baggage with them. He bought three sets of coarse cloth garments, some fabrics, and other daily necessities for each of them.

While at it, Qin Mian also bought some flour and rice. He and Lei Tie both like to eat rice, and the rice at home was consumed fast.

When the oxcart drove into the farm residence, Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile were shocked to see the beautiful scenery in the farm residence.

This was where they were going to live? They would live in such a beautiful place?

Qin Mian chuckled, “First, follow me to your living place. After you’ve sorted things out, you can stroll around the farm residence and get familiar with the new environment.”

Uncle Fu and his party quickly withdrew their gazes.

“Yes, little young master.”

Following Qin Mian into the servant’s house, the three people were dumbfounded again. The house was newly built, not a thatched house or a wooden house, but a house with red bricks and black tiles. The inside of the house was bright and clean, with no shortage of household furniture, and the bed was even covered with a brand-new cotton-padded mattress and cotton-padded quilts. It was several times better than they used to be in their own homes!

Qin Mian made arrangements, “Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu, you two live in the first house. Xile, you live in the second house. If another servant comes in later, you’ll share the house with him. Of course, if you get married in the future, you can also live in a house like Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu.”

Xile could not hide his excitement and said, “Yes, little young master! Many thanks, little young master!”

After Qin Mian explained the work contents of the three people clearly, he said, “You’ll be provided with food and shelter. The monthly wage is tentatively set at 50 Wen, which will be increased at every festival, New Year, and busy farming season. You’ll have three meals a day. Breakfast and lunch are noodles, dumplings or buns, and dinner is cooked white rice. Eat until full. But of course, no waste is allowed. Vegetables are homegrown, which you can take whenever. You’ll be given 10 jin of meat every month

and it's up to you whether to eat at all in one meal or save to eat for a month."

Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile looked at each other in astonishment and felt a little uneasy.

Xile spoke first, "Little young master, this arrangement is a little too good. As servants, two meals a day are enough for us."

Qin Mian said with a faint smile, "When you enter our house, you follow our rules. You don't have to think you're unworthy, just work harder."

Uncle Fu and his party answered "yes" in unison.

Lei Tie went to look at the oxcart. Xile cleverly carried a sack of flour and a sack of rice down.

Qin Mian said, "You don't have to do anything today. Go walk around. Start working tomorrow."

"Many thanks, eldest young master and little young master!"

After what should be made clear was made clear, Lei Tie led the ox, preparing to leave with Qin Mian.

Xile walked over quickly and said respectfully, "Eldest young master, let me. Is the ox house over there? I'll take the oxcart to its house after I send the things over."

Qin Mian looked at him with approval. *As expected, he is really smart.*

After the outside wall was built, the courtyard wall of the house was demolished a few days ago. The view became wider. At the door of Qin Mian and Lei Tie's house, Xile quickly moved the things on the cart into the house.

Qin Mian grabbed a piece of bacon weighing about 10 jin from the kitchen and let Xile take it back. He started to prepare his and Lei Tie's lunch.

“Wife, what are you going to do with these?” Lei Tie came in with three small bells.

Qin Mian took a look, “Oh, I almost forgot. It’s too far away from the servant’s quarters, so inconvenient to find them. Didn’t I also buy three different colors of rope? You tie the three bells to the ropes and tie them inside the house of the three with the other ends tied to our side. If you need to find them, pull the rope here and the bell will ring there. The black rope is Uncle Fu, the red rope is Aunt Fu, and the gray one is Xile.”

“Wife is very clever,” said Lei Tie.

“It’s necessary.” Qin Mian turned his head proudly and was accurately kissed by Lei Tie. Before he had time to say anything, Lei Tie took the bells and ropes and walked out without delay.

“Mensao³.” Qin Mian muttered and then hummed a song as he trimmed vegetables for cooking.

After Lei Tie came back, he tied three ropes to the window lattice of the central room.

Qin Mian mentioned another thing, “Do you remember that we said we would invite the grandparents and aunts to come and see the flowers last time we dug the pond?”

“Yes.” Lei Tie asked, “These days?”

Qin Mian nodded, “Invite them over a day earlier, so as not to think about this matter all the time.”

Lei Tie said, “I’ll go to Deng’s Village tomorrow morning.”

After Qin Mian made the fried noodles in soybean sauce, Lei Tie carried it out in passing.

Qin Mian smiled and followed with two pairs of chopsticks.

He sat down on the chair physically and mentally at ease, feeling that today's fried noodles were particularly aromatic. "So far, things in the manor have been basically handled, and we can relax for a few days."

Lei Tie said, "After grandpa and the others leave, I'll take you to the mountain."

"Alright." Qin Mian nodded while eating noodles. "It's spring now. The scenery on the mountain must be very beautiful. Bring the bow set, we can go hunt while at it."

Lei Tie nodded and suddenly asked, "Do you remember your birthday?"

"28th of the third month." Qin Mian raised his head and looked at him with a smile, "Why? Do you have a gift for me?"

"En." Lei Tie did not deny it.

"Your—" Before he finished, he suddenly remembered that Lei Tie's mother died of difficult labor, which was to say, Lei Tie's birthday was Deng Shi's death anniversary.

Without waiting for Lei Tie to speak, he said, "You'll have your birthday on the same day as mine."

"Alright." Lei Tie raised his hand and wiped the sauce from the corner of Qin Mian's mouth with his thumb.

After lunch, Lei Tie washed the dishes.

Qin Mian took out his notebook and a writing brush and wrote on the tea table.

Lei Tie came out of the kitchen after washing the dishes and sat down beside him with an arm around Qin Mian's waist.

"What are you writing?"

“Accounts.” Qin Mian said, “Previously, we didn’t have to keep accounts. But now there are three more people in our family, so it’d be better to keep a good record of our income and expenditure to be sure. If anything goes wrong in the future, there is a basis.”

“Sell them if they make mistakes.” Lei Tie indifferently spoke.

Qin Mian nodded, “If they make a big mistake, I certainly won’t tolerate them.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. In online language, “snake spirit disease” is a homophonic (shé jīng bìng) of “neuropathy”. Netizens read it as “snake spirit disease” to express the original meaning.
2. Meaning joyful; happy
3. (coll.) outwardly cold or retiring but deep and passionate inside

Chapter 077: Want to Be Closer To You

077 – Want to Be Closer To You

Brought to you by Ellie (♡♡♡♡♡)

Lei Tie took along Xile to Deng's Village to let him know the way. If there was a need to go to Deng's Village in the future, Lei Tie did not have to do it himself.

Qin Mian was alone at home. Finally, he had plenty of time to go into the space and bring along White Spot. Since he transmigrated over, the number of times he had entered the space was very few. It was not that he did not want to enter, but he did not have the chance. At first, it was because he was guarding against Lei Tie that he did not dare to enter easily. Later, it was because he was too busy in real life. Every day, he thought about how to make money and how to improve their lives, so he could not manage the space. He only entered occasionally and stayed for a short time to take more spiritual spring water or pick some fruits and vegetables. Now though, he had decided to tell Lei Tie about the space. He was just waiting for a suitable opportunity.

As soon as he entered the space, Qin Mian keenly noticed that the space was somewhat different from before. He looked around carefully and found that the area of the space had expanded. Previously, when he stood at the gate of the quadrangle house¹ and looked into the distance, the scenery in the distance was always hazy with smog. Now when he looked again, the green hills were clearly visible. He suddenly had a guess, *is the space expanding?*

To be honest, although he had owned the space for nearly two years, he did not know much about it. However, what was certain was that the space did not have any malice towards him. He could feel that he and the space were “interlinked”. When he occasionally encountered a few beasts in the space, they would be very docile and automatically avoid him.

Qin Mian pondered for a while, but he could not think any. He first watered the flower bud he named “Pink Ball”, and found that it had not changed in any way compared to before, but he was not disappointed. He turned to pick up the eggs in the chicken coop and duck cage and put them in the small warehouse of the quadrangle house. The preservation function of the space would not let them go bad.

It was White Spot’s first time in the space. It looked around for a moment before darting out like an arrow and disappeared into the woods.

Qin Mian did not worry about it. He found two baskets and loaded a basket with eggs, then went to the vegetable garden and picked a basket of fresh vegetables. He shouted, “White Spot, let’s go!”

Not a while later, White Spot jumped out of the bushes, rubbed against his legs, and let him hug its neck.

The next moment, they returned to the central room.

Qin Mian gnawed on an apple while pulling the red rope on the window lattice.

Aunt Fu quickly appeared and knelt respectfully, “Little young master.”

Qin Mian pointed to the vegetable basket by the well, “Aunt Fu, there are guests today. You go wash these vegetables.”

“Yes.”

Qin Mian stood aside and watched for a while. Aunt Fu was very quick and neat. He chewed on the apple and moved out to the recliner to bask in the sun.

White Spot suddenly jumped up and rushed forward.

Qin Mian was startled. He thought that White Spot found something threatening. He quickly jumped up from the rattan chair. However, he saw that White Spot's two forepaws pressed a stone with its teeth bared and growled a few times before releasing the stone. Next, it leaped over the stone and sprinted back with a twist of its waist. Then it pounced again with its mouth opened and bit the stone.

Qin Mian gaped for a moment before feeling relieved. *White Spot is practicing hunting prey!*

With a head full of black lines², he glared at White Spot for quite a while. He wanted to ask: White Spot, does your big master aware of your "craziness"?

Thinking that White Spot did not understand, he reluctantly laid back, crossed his legs, and then chewed the apple, watching White Spot continue to practice crazily.

Aunt Fu warily looked at White Spot as she walked around a bit farther to Qin Mian's side. "Little young master, the vegetables are ready. It's sunny today, why don't I take out your quilts and cotton-padded clothes to leave out in the sun?"

Qin Mian sat up and said, "Aunt Fu is very attentive. I'd forgotten about it. It's fine though, I can do it myself. There's nothing more to do here, you can go to your duty."

"Yes, little young master."

There were four cloth-drying poles in front of the house, similar to two parallel bars.

Qin Mian took out all the quilts, mattresses, bolsters, and cotton-padded clothes in the wardrobe, as well as the settee's seat and leaning cushions in the central room. Then, he brought out the tea set and snacks and placed

them on the stone table under the maple tree before leaning back on the recliner.

White Spot was still hunting the “prey”. It jumped over and scuttled away with all its limbs kicked off the dust to fly. Qin Mian was glad that he was situated in the wind direction.

Lei Tie led a group of people to approach and the little chubby kid at the forefront quickly ran over.

“Cousin-uncle Mian!”

“Yuanzai.” Qin Mian got up to greet the guests.

There were quite a lot of people; Old Master Deng, Old Madam Deng, Eldest Uncle Deng, and his family, and Second Uncle Deng and his family. As the group of people walked and looked around the manor, they all felt that their pairs of eyes were not enough. In particular, the few women could not move their eyes when they saw a variety of flowers.

Kunzai and Xuanzai mischievously jumped up and grabbed the branches of the pear tree full of flowers. Yuya and Lanya picked two flowers in the flowerbed before running over.

Qin Mian saw Lei Tie holding two small puppies, “These are?”

Lei Tie handed the puppies to him, “Eldest Uncle gave them.”

Qin Mian delightfully went to thank Eldest Uncle Deng, “Eldest Uncle is very thoughtful. To be honest, this farm residence is too big. We do really need a few watchdogs.”

Eldest Uncle Deng waved his hand. “They were given by others. It’s not worth a dime.”

Qin Mian looked at White Spot, who was watching the two puppies. He felt a bit worried. If White Spot was not a wolf, it certainly could accommodate two dogs.

Lei Tie noticed his concern, “Grandpa said they were born of wolfhound parents.”

Qin Mian’s apprehension slightly loosened, “You entertain grandpa and the others first.”

He did not dare to let White Spot touch the two puppies. He carried the puppies into the house, filled a bowl with some rice porridge left in the morning, mixed some spiritual spring water in, and temporarily locked the two puppies in the utility room.

When he came out of the house, he saw Lei Tie sitting at the stone table alone. The snacks and hot tea on the table were all untouched.

“Where are the people?”

Lei Tie motioned to the fruit forest, “Wandering.”

The eldest aunt snapped a flowering branch from the peach tree and handed it to Xiya; Xuanzai jumped up and stretched out his hand to pat the peach branches vigorously, and laughed as he watched the petals fall down.

Seeing this, Qin Mian frowned. Alas, this was something he had anticipated.

Lei Tie rose to his feet.

Qin Mian stopped him, “Forget it, let them. They can’t destroy all the flowers. This year is our first year of planting fruit trees. Inviting them to come and have fun is considered a dedication. Afterward, we can make excuses. Shall we go to accompany them?”

Lei Tie shook his head, “Grandpa said no need to accompany.”

Qin Mian sat still.

The two men drank tea and chatted.

They did not know that Uncle Fang was in the peach forest at the moment.

After seeing the peach branch in Xiya's hand, Uncle Fang glanced at the petals on the ground and said to Xuanzai, "Kiddy, this tree will bear less fruit due to your doing. It's a pity."

Deng Xiao and Deng Zhong were chatting. When they heard that, they quickly walked over, and embarrassingly stopped Xuanzai. "This old man is?"

"Hehe. Are you Lei Tie's guests? I was hired by Lei Tie to take care of the fruit trees." Uncle Fang said.

Xuanzai raised his chin and glared at Uncle Fang defiantly, "This is my cousin-uncle's orchard. I can play however I want!"

Deng Xiao harshly reproached, "Xuanzai!"

Uncle Fang shook his head with a smile. Without saying anything, he turned to another direction.

Deng Xiao's wife glared at Deng Xiao and reproached, "Can't you talk nicely? If the child isn't sensible, then teach him."

Old Master Deng and his wife had already gone far away, lamenting about the future of his grandson and knowing nothing about what had happened.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat for quite a while before the Deng Family came back. Kunzai and Xuanzai each held a plum flowering branch as a sword; Yuya and Lanya both held a large bunch of flowers. Old Master Deng walked at the front with a calm face. Eldest Uncle Deng and Second Uncle Deng saw the things in the hands of the children and were somewhat embarrassed.

Qin Mian seemed as though he did not see it, and warmly welcomed them.

"Grandpa and grandma, it's nice and warm outside. Why don't we just sit outside?"

"Good." The old lady smiled kindly.

The Deng family spent a day in the farm residence and bid farewell after dinner.

The children did not want to go, but they were taken away by their parents because there weren't any extra beds. Qin Mian was very glad that there was only one bedroom at home.

After seeing off the guests, he took Lei Tie around the fruit trees and flowerbeds. On the surface, the loss of the orchard was not visible, but a lot of flowers in the flowerbeds had been trampled down, and there were some messy footprints on the ground. It was clear that there were children running wildly in the flowerbed.

Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile lifted the flowers up with pity and poured some water on them.

Meanwhile, Qin Mian was in a good mood because seeing off the Deng Family was like completing a task. He would not see those bear children again for a long time. In the future, when the fruits were ripe, he did not plan to invite them to come, or else he did not know how much would be wasted. He would only give them some fruit then.

Qin Mian pulled Lei Tie to leave, "Let's go to see the two puppies."

Back at home, White Spot was scratching the door panel of the utility room with its claws, looking up and down, as if studying how to open the door.

Lei Tie picked it up with one hand and put it aside.

White Spot had always revered him. It obediently stood still at where it was put.

Qin Mian opened the door and the two puppies that lay quietly on the ground looked at them at the same time with wet eyes.

One puppy had gray fur and looked more like a wolf; the other puppy had one-third of white fur and two-thirds of black fur. It looked like a black vest was draped over its back obliquely; very cute.

Qin Mian patted the two puppies' heads gently and pushed the gray-furred one to Lei Tie. "This one, you name it."

Lei Tie said without thinking, "Gray Sheet³."

"Gray Sheet, hahaha..." Qin Mian patted his legs as he laughed heartily.

Lei Tie explained, "Same as 'White Spot'⁴."

Qin Mian's laughter stopped spontaneously.

Lei Tie pointed to the other puppy, "Its name?"

"Black Vest⁵." Qin Mian said.

Lei Tie was silent for a moment and nodded, "Nice."

Qin Mian looked at him unhappily. "'White Spot' and 'Black Vest' are nicer than 'Gray Sheet'." White Spot ran over and looked up at Qin Mian, thinking he was calling it.

Lei Tie nodded, "En."

Qin Mian was even more upset.

Lei Tie caressed his head, "Let's sleep. We're going up the mountain tomorrow."

Qin Mian's attention was immediately shifted.

After Lei Tie also went to bed, he (QM) squeezed in consciously.

Lei Tie paused before he hugged him.

Qin Mian asked curiously, "What's wrong?"

Lei Tie did not speak and held his wife's buttocks, making them fit even more snugly.

Qin Mian realized in an instant. Feeling somewhat unbearable, he lay on the man's shoulder and said in a low voice, "Otherwise, I'll use my hands..." His lips were sealed by something hot.

In the dark, the panting sound of endurance and urgency was very clear. Only after a long time did Lei Tie's voice rang out in deep and hoarse, "Sleep."

A quadrangle house. The house in the magical space looks like this.

Head full of black lines. [This is me after finishing the last couple of paragraphs.]

Note:

Footnotes

1. 四合院also courtyard house but kind of different than a normal house with courtyards. See picture.
2. See picture
3. Gray Sheet [一片灰yī piàn huī] translated as a piece/sheet/area of gray/ash.
4. White Spot [一点白yī diǎn bái] literally translated as a dot of white
5. Black Vest [黑马甲hēi mǎ jiǎ] is black vest/corset/armor for a horse (debating the use of "vest" since its ancient china. But well, Qin Mian is a modern man :P).

Chapter 078: The Romantic Couple's World

078 – The Romantic Couple's World¹

Brought to you by TucTuc (☉•••☉)♥

Qin Mian led the two puppies to walk to the gate with Lei Tie. White Spot followed them quietly, glancing at Gray Sheet and Black Vest from time to time. It did not appear to be hostile or anything.

When Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu saw them, the couple rushed to meet them. Qin Mian, with his bow set on his shoulder, was wearing a convenient white hunting suit and a pair of boots made of animal hide, looking valiant and formidable. Lei Tie was also wearing a hunting suit, but in black, which set off his reserved grandeur even more strongly. The elegant demeanor of the two masters made Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu unable to move their gazes for a moment but they hastily dropped their eyes when Lei Tie indifferently swept a glance over them.

“Where's Xile?” Qin Mian asked casually.

Uncle Fu said, “Little young master, he went to herd the ox after breakfast.”

Qin Mian nodded, “Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu, these two dogs are Gray Sheet and Black Vest. You'll be raising them.”

Aunt Fu looked at the two puppies with eyes full of affection. She took over the rope in his hand, “Yes, the little young master can rest assured.”

Lei Tie said, “Guard the gate, we'll be back before dark.”

Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu said together, “Yes!”

A few villagers nearby saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie come out of the farm residence and leave side-by-side with envy in their eyes. What about two men live together? Their lives were more than a hundred times prosperous than others. Not only could they own such a large manor, but they could even employ servants. Others were envious of them.

In the farmland, the green wheat had grown to the height of a person's calf. Stubborn weeds mingled in it, arrogantly holding their heads high. The farmers bent over and pulled out the weeds with their hands. A herding boy led an ox to walk on the ridge; and a black ox lowered its head to nibble at the grass, flicking its tail from time to time in, utterly in leisure.

Qin Mian smiled at every villager he met as he drifting away with Lei Tie.

When White Spot arrived at the mountain, it behaved like a wolf running around excitedly. The soles of its feet seemed to be equipped with springs as it bounced from time to time and yet landed leisurely and soundlessly. It was proud and aloof, but also graceful. The prominent disdainful look in its gray eyes made people never mistaken it for a dog.

With White Spot here, Qin Mian was not worried that he would lose his way and could not get down the mountain. He walked ahead in high spirits, searching for prey with both eyes.

Lei Tie had always kept a distance of four to five steps behind him. His indifferent eyes occasionally looked to the left and right, guarding him against potential dangers.

“White Spot, go look for prey nearby.” Qin Mian said to White Spot. He learned archery with Lei Tie for a long time, but his archery skill could not be regarded as excellent. Out of ten arrows he shot on the moving target, only seven hit the target. Looking back at the time when he learned to shoot a moving target which was personally held by Lei Tie, Qin Mian felt warm in his heart. Although this man did not talk much, the man actually spoiled him to the bone.

Of course, in order to avoid accidental injury, his arrows were wrapped in cloth at that time. Although Lei Tie said that even if he did not cover the arrow, he would not let Qin Mian hurt him.

Thinking of this, Qin Mian could not help looking back at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie misunderstood the meaning of this look, “Wife, don’t worry, I’m always behind you.”

Qin Mian broke into laughter, turned around, and continued to search for prey.

In front of him, White Spot suddenly stopped, made a crouching movement, and turned its head to look at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian had known of its intelligence earlier. He reached into the quiver behind his back and pulled out an arrow. He quickened his steps and lightened the movement at the same time.

It’s a bamboo rat!

During the day, bamboo rats ate less food and slept more, but ate vigorously during the night. *Isn’t it just sleeping soundly in the grass right now?*

Qin Mian stopped ten steps away, aimed at the bamboo rat, and set the arrow. The string accidentally scraped the palm of his hand. He felt a little pain. He swung his arms and pulled the bowstring before letting go.

With a cry of fear, the bamboo rat jumped up and fell powerlessly to the ground.

“A-Tie², I hit it!” Qin Mian turned his head happily as he said to Lei Tie.

A-Tie? Another new [addressing] name. Lei Tie withdrew his gaze on his wife’s waist and arms without a trace, “Wife is so awesome.”

Qin Mian felt that he was insincere. Alright, the bamboo rat stayed there motionless; it would be strange if he could not hit it.

He went to pick up the bamboo rat and put it into Lei Tie's basket.

Lei Tie stared at the corners of his smiling and rosy lips, stretched his arms to wind around his (QM) waist, bowed his head, and kissed those lips. Warm flesh deeply attached to each other.

Qin Mian put his hands on his (LT) shoulders and responded attentively. He wanted to seize the dominance but was greeted with a more fierce attack by Lei Tie. A big palm even twiddled his butt.

The essence of a hunting suit was to facilitate movement, so it stuck very closely to the body. The skin-tight cloth perfectly outlined Qin Mian's figure, while the white cloth made his butt appeared sturdier. Lei Tie could not move his hand at all.

Qin Mian was also ignited by his actions. Soon, he could not breathe steadily and his tiptoed feet were a little feeble. His chest that was stuck close to Lei Tie's clearly felt the man's chest sharply undulating.

The man's concentration had dropped significantly. Qin Mian was a little proud of himself but also a little flustered as he was not ready yet. Just as he was about to reach out his hand to push, the man had already let go of his lips. His eyes seemed to have been painted by ink as they were becoming darker and deeper, staring at him closely, just like a hunter who locked in his prey and would make a violent attack at any time.

Qin Mian's heart was pounding and his blood was boiling. He realized more than ever that this man liked him and he was also fascinated by this man. He should push the man away but his arms could not help encircle the man's waist. He lovingly dropped a soothing kiss on his lips and said with a sly smile in his voice, "You good?"

Lei Tie did not utter a word. His hot right palm moved up from his wife's waist at an extremely slow speed. It seemed that a slight mistake would cause an explosion of desire. The big palm finally stopped on the youngster's shoulder and the temperature also dropped. Then, Lei Tie nonchalantly let go of the person in his arms and took two steps back at the same time. The intense emotion on his face and the heat in his eyes quickly

disappeared and recovered their dullness. It seemed as if nothing at all had happened just now.

Qin Mian found it so amusing. He turned around and left. *You can pretend, then.*

“Awoo—” At the front, White Spot let out a howl, as if in urging them.

Qin Mian gently scolded, “White Spot, quiet down. Don’t scare the prey away.”

Two men and a wolf went on until they entered deep into the mountain.

Lei Tie was no longer behind but walked side-by-side with Qin Mian.

“There are many beasts in the mountains. Be careful.” Lei Tie said. Without a careful look, he shot an arrow into the grass on the right side, hitting a pheasant weighing more than 3 Jin.

Qin Mian looked at him with admiration. When could he also perfect his skill to this degree?

Lei Tie enjoyed his wife’s gaze very much. He did not speak, but the corners of his lips were slightly curled up.

While pushing aside the obstructing bushes, Qin Mian went on. Upon seeing an idiot-looking roe deer, he was overjoyed. He pulled Lei Tie’s arm and motioned him to stop while he raised his bow and arrow.

With a “whoosh”, it was hit!

Unfortunately, it was only shot above the right front leg of the roe deer and did not hurt the vital part. The roe deer faltered for a while before it started to run.

Qin Mian was in a great hurry. “A-Tie—”

Without looking back, he stretched his hand at the back to grab Lei Tie, and this gesture of grabbing on empty made Lei Tie’s eyes flashed with a doting

smile.

Before his wife's words were completed, he raised his arms and the sharp arrow broke through the air and hit the roe deer's abdomen.

The roe deer leaned sideways and fell on the ground, motionless.

Qin Mian picked up the roe deer and said to Lei Tie with a smile, "Roe deer meat is purely lean, with no fat on its whole body. It's rich in nutrition, tender, and delicious. It's known as the 'King of Lean Meat'. How about having roe deer meat at noon?"

"It's delicious to roast." Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian said, "Then roast it is."

His hunting mood flourished and he walked forward in big strides.

Suddenly, the smell of blood pervaded in the air. Lei Tie pulled his hand to stop and said, "Wait, there's a big animal."

At this time, the bush shook and a huge tiger's head came out from it. The tiger with yellow fur and black stripes had a mouth full of blood. When it opened its mouth, it showed its sharp teeth and there was a terrifying growl let out from its throat, "Grrr—"

"Oh mother." Qin Mian inadvertently met those tiger's eyes and his legs gave away, retreating a few steps before falling on the ground.

The tiger raised its head, lowered its waist, and leaped forward.

Lei Tie did not have time to help Qin Mian up. Instead of retreating, he blocked in front of Qin Mian.

"LEI TIE!" Qin Mian turned pale with fright. He wanted to stand up, but he had no strength.

Lei Tie was as steady as a stone and quickly took out an arrow from his quiver. Seeing that the tiger was less than five meters away from him, he

shot the arrow.

Like splitting bamboo³, the sharp arrow thrust into the tiger's throat.

Lei Tie did not even look at it as he picked up Qin Mian and moved to the side in a flash.

The tiger's huge body fell heavily on the ground. Due to its inertia, it glided forward for a zhang⁴ before stopping.

Qin Mian's eyes widened as he took a breath. If it was not for Lei Tie to take him away in time, his body would have been half-paralyzed after being crushed by the tiger.

The tiger howled and struggled for a while before it was unable to move again.

"Wife, how are you?" Lei Tie looked down at the man in his arms as he asked anxiously.

Qin Mian felt that his performance just now was very humiliating. He said in a low voice, "My legs are still a little soft."

Lei Tie continued to hold him and stroked his back up and down.

Qin Mian discovered that he was being held by Lei Tie with his butt held up like a baby, and the corner of his mouth twitched. He struggled to get down to the ground. "Let me go first."

Lei Tie put him down, but his left arm was still around his back.

Qin Mian recovered after a while. He looked at the tiger which died without closing its eyes⁵. He took a few steps to look at it. He said, "No wonder when people are angry, they often use 'glare with tiger eyes'. Such eyes are really frightening, right A-Tie? It also rushed at me so suddenly that I was shocked still." He made an excuse for himself.

The corner of Lei Tie's lips gently curved up, "En."

“Awoo awoo—” White Spot called in the distance, which eased Qin Mian’s embarrassment and he hurried over.

Lei Tie followed closely.

Behind the bush lay a large boar weighing more than 300 Jin, with a bloody hole in its stomach, apparently gnawed by the tiger.

“Ha! We gain benefits when the tiger and the pig fight against each other.” Qin Mian said happily.

Lei Tie frowned as he said, “Must move them away as soon as possible, otherwise they’ll attract other beasts.” It was impossible to move a 300 Jin wild boar and a nearly 800 Jin tiger at once.

Qin Mian rolled his eyes. He squatted down, touched the tiger with his hand, and the tiger disappeared. Again, when he touched the boar, the boar disappeared.

Lei Tie looked at him in shock. He abruptly pulled the person into his arms and held him tightly, “Wife...”

Qin Mian encircled his strong waist and looked at his eyes seriously. “I’ll tell you what happened on our birthday. Trust me!”

“I trust you.” Lei Tie slowly released him, but his left hand still held his hand.

“No more hunting. We’ll go down and roast the meat to eat at the foot of the mountain. White Spot, let’s go.” Qin Mian instead pulled Lei Tie’s hand and walked back.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 二人世界[èr rén shì jiè] means the world with only two people (usually refers to a romantic couple)

2. 阿 (ā) prefix used before monosyllabic names, kinship terms, etc to indicate familiarity
3. (idiom)without difficulty
4. about 3.3 m
5. die with everlasting regret

Chapter 079: Birthday Present

079 – Birthday Present

Brought to you by MCJohnston ♡ღ(-#~#-)ღ♡

At the foot of the mountain, after seeing no one was around, Qin Mian took the wild boar and tiger out of the space.

They slowly roasted some roe deer meat and to their fill. Lei Tie stayed behind to guard the prey while Qin Mian went home to ask for aid.

Uncle Fu drove an ox cart over to carry the boar and tiger home.

Along the way, when the villagers in the farmland saw the big tiger on the cart, they were amazed and clamors of comments ensued. They all gathered around to watch and followed the ox-cart moving forward as they complimenting Qin Mian on Lei Tie's skill, bravery, and brilliant archery.

Qin Mian felt both funny and depressed. What's funny was that these people dared not chit-chat in front of Lei Tie, but dared to approach him. What's depressing was that they were so sure that Lei Tie hunted the tiger instead of him?

He turned his head and took a look at the man's strong and slender figure with a height of 1.9 meters, and then compared with his own body that was only 1.7 meters; he decided to eat an extra bowl of rice at night!

Worried that some idle villagers and naughty children would destroy the fruit trees and flower beds when they entered the manor, Qin Mian did not let the villagers in but asked Uncle Fu to park the ox cart at the gate and let them stand and watch until they get enough.

While the villagers circled around and watched the tiger, they also wanted to follow inside and walk around the manor. From the outside, one could see white pear flowers and pink peach flowers inside the wall. They were very beautiful and they must be even more beautiful to look from inside.

Qin Mian could read their thoughts. He claimed that he was tired, let Xile brought two chairs and sat at the door with Lei Tie, being patient with the villagers.

The villagers lingered for an hour. Seeing that Qin Mian did not plan to invite them into the manor, they could only leave in disappointment.

Xile looked at the little young master with admiration and felt that he had learned a trick.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi stubbornly refused to go. Qin Mian generously let Lei Tie chop the boar's leg for them. If he had 100 Wen, he thought it was no problem to "donate" 1 Wen.

Lei Daqiang and his wife left contentedly with the boar's leg weighing nearly 10 Jin.

Lei Tie completely peeled off the tiger skin and wanted to make a fur cloak for Qin Mian.

Qin Mian was frightened and repeatedly waved his hands [in refusal]. In any case, tigers "used" to be protected animals. He could hunt and kill it, but it was really impossible to wear it on his body every day.

"If you like it, I'll make you a fur cloak." Qin Mian was a bit insincere in his words. He always thought that wearing a tiger skin cloak would look like a nouveau riche. Although, it seemed that they were indeed a nouveau riche. *Sweat.*

Lei Tie shook his head, "Make a mattress?"

Qin Mian made a decision, "Sell it. Don't forget that we spent a lot of money to build the manor. Now, we're poor again."

Lei Tie still felt that his wife would be very good-looking dressed in a tiger skin cloak, but he still listened to him and nodded.

Qin Mian kept 3 to 5 Jin of tiger meat for a taste, and the remaining tiger meat, tiger penis, and tiger skin were sent to the county town to sell. Not only the tiger meat sold at a profit, the tiger penis and skin sold for a total of 1400 silver taels!

Qin Mian was both happy and sad. It was so easy for his family (LT) to make money, so he had to make a vigorous start ah!

“My money is your money.” Lei Tie comforted.

Qin Mian nodded seriously, “Of course. Your money is my money; my money is still my money.”

Lei Tie nodded without demur.

“Look at you.” Qin Mian stuck closer to his face and offered a kiss, “You’re so honest that I feel sorry to bully you. I’ll make you a delicious meal. After the meal, we’ll go to town.”

Lei Tie motionlessly allowed him to kiss; he had a different kind of cuteness. Qin Mian’s heart softened.

They made a large plate of hot and spicy shrimp, a large plate of chicken, and a plate of fried green vegetables, which they enjoyed eating. After eating and drinking enough, Qin Mian asked Xile to send them to the town.

Instead of going directly to their shop, Qin Mian asked Xile to drive around the Running Water Town.

“Wife, you still want to open a wine house¹.” Lei Tie hit the mark with a comment.

Qin Mian nodded, “Yes.” He could not afford real estate, but the catering industry was also highly profitable. That small shop could not meet his needs.

Lei Tie paused before he said, “You can buy a big store in the county town.”

“Don’t you dislike living in the town?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie held his hand tight and lightly said, “If you like it, we can go to the county town.”

Qin Mian glanced at him with a smile, “You think about me, can’t I think about you? Don’t worry, I’ve got an idea. Even without going to the county town, the wine house can still be opened, and it’ll be the one and only.” His eyes twinkled with confidence. He, who had transmigrated, would be sorry for not exploiting the existing advantages to make a big profit.

Lei Tie asked, “Build it yourself?”

Qin Mian was surprised and looked at him with appreciation, “Correct.”

Lei Tie knew that he must have some strange and eccentric ideas and did not ask much but only said, “Say it when you need me.”

Qin Mian leaned back on him relaxedly, “En.”

At the front, Xile was listening. However, he did not understand much and simply stopped listening. Anyway, he would know when it was time.

The result of going around the town was that Qin Mian bought another large piece of land – 15 mu.

After returning home, he lay on the table to write and draw.

Lei Tie sat on one side, weaving some bark from the branches of some unknown tree.

When asked what he was doing, he did not say a word. Qin Mian glared at him discontentedly but also looked at him with tolerance. On the contrary, he ignored Qin Mian’s temper.

In a twinkling of an eye, it was the 28th of the third lunar month – Qin Mian’s birthday.

The night before, which was the night on the 27th, Qin Mian did not sleep soundly. Thinking of the poor child Lei Tie supposedly never celebrate his birthday, Qin Mian hoped that his “first” birthday would be perfect. Before he went to bed, he kept reminding himself that he should get up before Lei Tie, so that he could say “Happy Birthday” to him first, and then cook birthday noodles². All night, he seemed to be asleep and awake. Lei Tie thought he had a nightmare, so he patted him on the back with his big palm. Qin Mian’s drowsiness became even heavier, but he was reluctant to give up Lei Tie’s intimate action, so he continued to struggle and wander in half-asleep and half-awake.

In the end, Qin Mian sat up with a start as soon as the resounding and lengthen cock’s crow was heard.

Lei Tie sat up alertly and hugged the person who obviously still could not open his eyes, “Wife, I’m here. Had a nightmare?”

Qin Mian tried hard to open his sore and heavy eyelids and bitterly looked askance at him. If Lei Tie had not patted him on the back all the time, he might not be so miserable.

The spring morning was very cold. After he woke up a little, he lifted his right leg and straddled Lei Tie’s legs. He clung onto the warmth of the man’s body transferred from inside the quilt.

“Happy birthday, A-Tie.” He held the man’s chin, raised his head up, and gave a heavy kiss on the man’s lips with a “pop”.

Lei Tie held the youngster so tightly that he wanted to knead him into his body. “Wife, happy birthday.” He pulled up the quilt and wrapped Qin Mian. A hot kiss slid from his lips to his neck, sucking hard, and a big palm slipped into his undergarment.

Qin Mian squinted, softly groaned, and embraced the man’s shoulder... After a good while, the man bit on his shoulder, and the tight body gradually relaxed.

Lei Tie put his chin on his wife’s shoulder, stiffly gasping for breath.

Immediately afterward, the scent in the room raised ambiguity.

They hugged each other for a moment as they both calmed down.

“Let go. I’ll cook birthday noodles.” Qin Mian patted the man’s solid arm.

Lei Tie stretched out his long arm, picked up his wife’s clothes, and watched him put them on one by one. He looked at his wife’s swollen lips for a moment before he got off the bed and went to the wardrobe. He took off his obscene pants³ unashamedly, threw it on the seat, and took out clean clothes.

Qin Mian gave him a speechless stare, dressed speedily, and ran out of the room. Only then the scorching gaze on his back disappeared.

A wok of noodles was made and the two people each held a big bowl.

After eating the noodles, the bowls were left on the table. Later, Aunt Fu would come to wash it.

Qin Mian took out four boiled eggs which had been cooled down from the kitchen, and hooked his finger at Lei Tie as he said with a grin, “A-Tie, come here.”

Lei Tie took a look at the eggs and walked over.

Qin Mian took an egg in his hand and rolled it from Lei Tie’s forehead to his chin, then from his chin to his forehead. He chanted, “A year goes by in a breath.”

“What for?” There was still residual water on the egg. Lei Tie wiped his face, and then a second egg came.

Qin Mian stifled a laugh, “This is a blessing. I wish you all the best for the coming year.”

Lei Tie nodded and reached out to the other two eggs. “Roll on you, too.”

Qin Mian swiftly snatched the two eggs, broke them immediately, and promptly said, "I want to eat them now."

Lei Tie had to take a towel to wipe his face.

"Wife, I'm going to the town to get your present."

"I want to talk to you first—" Qin Mian wanted to talk about the space.

Lei Tie kissed on his lips and licked along with the egg yolk from the corner of his mouth. "Talk when I came back."

"Alright." It did not matter to Qin Mian. Anyway, it was all the same whether to talk first or talk later.

Lei Tie went out with two eggs.

After Qin Mian finished his eggs, he had nothing to do. He found a bamboo rod, tied a rope to the rod with a piece of wood tied at the other end of the rope, and trained White Spot's hunting skill with it.

One man and one wolf had an extremely great time.

Suddenly, Qin Mian heard the sound of the horse's hooves. He looked back and saw a man dressed in gray came galloping on a black horse from the peach blossom forest. The man saw him, raised the corners of his lips, and faintly smiled. The tenderness in his eyes was like a deep abyss, making people uncontrollably submerged in it.

He was also pulling the rein of another horse. Its hair was brown all over without a trace of variegation. It was smooth, soft, and shiny just like it was wrapped in brown silk.

Qin Mian threw away his bamboo rod and ran over happily.

The black horse ran to Qin Mian. Lei Tie pulled the rein; the black horse neighed and steadily stopped.

“This horse is for me?” Qin Mian stroked the long mane of the horse. He had never ridden one before. *What is a horse? That is equivalent to modern BMW and Rolls Royce!*

“En.” Lei Tie nimbly dismounted and handed him the wooden box that had been held on his left hand, “Change clothes first.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. 酒楼 [jiǔ lóu] is translated as a restaurant or (direct translation) wine house/building with more than a story. In the ancient era, this establishment served food, drinks, entertainment, and lodgings to customers.
2. Eating a noodle on birthday symbolizes longevity
3. The ancient's underwear. It's called obscene because underwear is a kind of clothes that the ancients saw as vulgar and irreverent, and should not be easily revealed to others.

Chapter 080: Heartstrings Knot

080 – Heartstrings Knot

Brought to you by Elaine ღ(๑'~`๑)ღ♡

Qin Mian guessed that it was a riding suit because the clothes on Lei Tie's body were not the ones he wore when going out, but a riding suit.

He took the wooden box and ran into the house. Not a while later, he dashed out again and dressed in a well-fitted white riding suit, thriving with heroism and dripping vigor. He stood in front of Lei Tie and said excitedly, "A-Tie, take me for a run first."

Lei Tie reached behind his back and handed Qin Mian another thing.

Qin Mian took it, "Isn't this something you weaved a few days ago? Is this a whip?" The whip was also brown. Although it was woven from tree bark, it was tanned to be very soft and exquisite. He looked at the wooden handle carefully and was not surprised to find a few familiar words engraved on it: Tie Gifts Wife.

He wanted to stare wide-eyed at Lei Tie but he could not help smiling.

That brilliant smiling expression made Lei Tie's mood sunny and cloudless.

"Like it?"

"Yes." Qin Mian all smiled.

Lei Tie mounted the horse and stretched out his hand.

Qin Mian handed him his hand. Lei Tie gently pulled him up and held his waist with his other hand. Qin Mian sat firmly in front of him.

“*Jia*¹!” Lei Tie’s feet stepped on stirrups, clamped the horse’s belly, and the black steed galloped.

The wind blew in the face mixed with the elegant fragrance of flowers made Qin Mian’s mood flying. Taking advantage that they had not left the farm residence and no one was around, he turned his head and pecked at the man’s side face before sitting upright and acting as if nothing had happened. Lei Tie hugged him tightly, kissed his earlobe softly, flicked the reins, and the horse galloped out of the gate.

Uncle Fu, who was chopping firewood at the entrance, felt a gust of wind passing by. When he looked up, he could only catch sight of the confident and leisure back of the two people on horseback.

The villagers on the road heard the clatter of the horse’s hooves from behind and gave way, watching the horse gallop by. A few young villagers’ eyes were full of envy.

The steed ran around the village before running into the Leisurely Farm Residence. Lei Tie led the brown horse and once again took Qin Mian to urge the horses away from the farm residence.

When they came to the grain-sunning ground, Lei Tie stopped the horses and leaped down.

Qin Mian turned over and leaped down. Unable to hold himself back, he said, “Teach me now.”

Lei Tie nodded, “Which do you like? The brown one is gentler.”

Qin Mian was not a daring person, “The brown one then.”

Lei Tie took the reins of the brown horse and taught him basic knowledge, “Before you mount the horse, you need to check whether the saddle and stirrups are firm. If it’s loose, it’ll be dangerous.”

After carefully observing the saddle and stirrups, Qin Mian nodded to show that he had remembered.

“When you get on the horse, push your toes inward. Don’t move too much to prevent the horse from being startled or refuses to be mounted...” Lei Tie said while demonstrating, “When dismounting, loosen your right foot first...”

Lei Chuntao and a girl dressed in purple similar to her age were going to dig wild vegetables with baskets in their hands. Upon seeing the people on the grain-sunning ground, they both stopped at the same time. They watched Lei Tie saying something to Qin Mian with his head lowered and then holding his waist to help him mount the horse.

The girl dressed in purple approached Lei Chuntao’s ear and said in a low voice, “Your eldest sister-in-law is really handsome, and your eldest brother’s side face is also quite handsome. If they aren’t married, there must be a lot of girls who like them.”

Lei Chuntao looked at her in surprise and immediately said, “Hongzao, don’t think about it. My eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law have a strong relationship.”

Hongzao’s face turned dignified. She anxiously patted her and stomped her feet as she said, “What are you saying? I’m just talking. Didn’t I tell you a few truths because I was being nice to you?”

Lei Chuntao knew that she had misunderstood her, so she quickly apologized with a smile, “Alright, alright, it’s my fault. Hongzao, you can hit me again.”

Hongzao lightly snorted and gently patted her on the back.

Their gazes returned to the grain-sunning ground. Qin Mian was on horseback. Lei Tie pulled the reins and slowly moved forward. He looked at the person on the horse from time to time and Qin Mian would smile back. There was a deep tacit understanding and warmth between them.

Lei Chuntao and Hongzao looked at each other with a smile and walked away with their baskets.

Qin Mian was very smart. He quickly grasped the main points of horse riding. After letting Lei Tie lead the horse for a few laps on the grain-sunning ground with, he could not help saying, “A-Tie, why you don’t let go, I’m going to try.”

Lei Tie then released his hand, “Slow down.”

Seeing Qin Mian lightly clamped the horse’s belly and the horse walked neither slow nor fast, he put his worry down and rode on the black horse to follow after him.

Qin Mian looked back at him and inquired, “Can I speed up?”

Lei Tie nodded, “Don’t worry.”

Qin Mian held the reins and kicked the horse’s belly nervously. The brown horse trotted at once; it was very docile.

Qin Mian shook the reins and pulled to the left. The horse’s speed went a little faster, running around the grain-sunning ground.

Qin Mian sat firmly on the saddle, turned back, and called out, “A-Tie, look, I’ve learned it!”

Lei Tie’s horsewhip slightly moved and the black horse quickly went forward to keep pace with the brown horse.

“Can I go faster?” Qin Mian yearned for the feeling of galloping.

Lei Tie nodded. “I’m here.”

Qin Mian raised his horsewhip and gently whipped it on the horse, “*Jia—*”

With a low neigh, the brown horse ran out of the grain-sunning ground and ran along the road out of the village.

The black horse followed closely.

“HAHAHA... It’s so cool!” Qin Mian felt the spring breeze and gave out wanton laughter.

Lei Chuntao, who was crouching on the ridge and digging wild vegetables, raised her head after hearing the laughter. Upon seeing the two back figures of gray and white in the distance, she could not help but smile.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie galloped down the mountain and directly went back to the farm residence.

When he got to the stable, Qin Mian quickly rolled off his horse with a thin layer of sweat on his face. With a smile, he combed the mane of the brown horse with his fingers. The more he looked at it, the more he liked it.

“Tired?” Lei Tie walked to his side.

“En.” Qin Mian tugged at his clothes, “I’m all sweaty.”

Uncle Fu came over quickly, “Eldest young master and little young master are back.”

Qin Mian handed the reins to him, “Uncle Fu, feed them well.”

“Yes.”

Qin Mian pulled Lei Tie home.

After entering the house, Lei Tie said, “Pour hot water and wash your face.”

Qin Mian shook his head and mysteriously smiled, “Follow me.”

He locked in the door of the central room, pulled Lei Tie into the bedroom, and closed the curtains.

“A-Tie, no matter what is strange about me, can you accept it all?” Qin Mian encircled Lei Tie’s waist, feeling somewhat uneasy. If Lei Tie could not accept it, he did not know whether he could bear the pain of losing Lei

Tie. Having been with Lei Tie for such a long time, he had always been very happy, except for those prodigals in the old house which occasionally annoy him. And this happiness was basically brought to him by Lei Tie. He liked this man and wished to be together with him earnestly.

“You are my wife. You will always be my wife.” Lei Tie hugged him. His tone was as steady as ever but it made Qin Mia calm.

“I’ll take you to a place.” With a stir in Qin Mian’s mind, the next moment, he and Lei Tie appeared in the space together, still maintaining the posture of embracing.

“Here is...” Lei Tie was slightly startled. He held his wife’s hand tightly and looked around.

Qin Mian did not see any fear or uneasiness in his eyes, so he secretly breathed a sigh of relief. He relaxed and somewhat proudly said, “This is an independent world and my portable space. Last time I put the tiger and boar here.”

“Portable space,” Lei Tie said, “which means carried on the body?”

“That’s right.” Qin Mian paused a bit and looked directly into his eyes, “What would you think if I told you that I was not the former Qin Mian?”

However, Lei Tie unexpectedly said, “I know.”

Qin Mian was shocked and incredulously turned up his volume, “YOU KNOW?”

Lei Tie caressed his face to make him stay calm and embraced his waist. “The former Qin Mian was cowardly, timid, and self-abased. He didn’t even dare to look at me directly. He trembled as soon as I approached him. But that day when you woke up from your lethargic sleep, you were only surprised to see me, not afraid. Like a changed person. At first, it was just a doubt, and then I was certain that you weren’t him.”

“Then you...” Qin Mian wanted to ask him whether he liked the former Qin Mian or the present one. He had the answer in his mind but he wanted to hear from Lei Tie himself.

“You.” Lei Tie’s chin rubbed his hair, “I used to call him Little Mian.”

When he said this, Qin Mian remembered. Lei Tie called him “Little Mian” in the first few days, and later he always called him “wife”. His ears began to burn.

“Wife, there are a lot of doubts about you, but I dare not ask, for fear that you’ll disappear. I’m glad you’re willing to tell me.” His voice had been very calm and his speech was neither urgent nor slow, like a gentle wind soothing Qin Mian’s heart.

Qin Mian’s chest felt inexplicably painful, and he could not help but hold the man closer. This man had been quietly tolerating him. He was lucky to meet him in this strange world.

He told the man about the origin of the space, “This space is...” [Omitted explanation]

“I see.” Lei Tie pondered, “Maybe it is the space that saved you and helped you to be reborn. White Spot is it [the dog he saved]?”

Qin Mian said, “Like two peas in a pod. They look the same and also give me the same vibe.”

“Whether it is or not, we’ll treat it well.” Lei Tie unconcernedly said.

Qin Mian nodded and looked at him with warm eyes. “I said that I would give you a birthday present. It’s actually a heartstrings knot. Once you bound a heartstrings knot with me, we can share the space, but we’ll also live and die together. That is to say, if I die before you, you’ll also—”

Lei Tie immediately asked, “How to bind?”

Qin Mian curved his lips in a smile and his heart felt comfortably warm. “Come with me.”

They walked into the quadrangle house together. Qin Mian pressed his right palm on the four walls of the main room. Suddenly, a white light flashed inside the room, which kept flashing, and after a while, it condensed into an illusory ring in midair at the center of the room. Qin Mian bit his finger and dripped a drop of blood on it. He said to Lei Tie, "You too."

Lei Tie also dripped a drop of blood.

The white light flashed and died out, at the same time! Lei Tie felt something was in his body. The space seemingly transformed into a small model printed in his mind. He could see it clearly.

From the corner of Qin Mian's eyes, he saw that the pink ball in the flower bed not far away also flashed for a moment. He was a little surprised but paid no mind to it for the time being. Instead, he asked Lei Tie anxiously, "How is it?" Although he knew how to bind the heartstrings knot, it was the first time to do it after all.

Lei Tie nodded gently and embraced him contentedly, "Wife, [we're] eternally together hereafter."

After determining there was nothing wrong with the heartstring knot, Qin Mian put away his worry. He broke away from Lei Tie and pulled him to the flower bed.

"This bud is very strange. It grows so full of life, but it never blooms. From the time I got the space, I take care of it very carefully, and yet it doesn't respond. But just now when we bound our heartstrings knot, a light seemed to flash across it. Hm? It seems bigger? Weird. Does it like you better?" Qin Mian suddenly discovered this and was puzzled.

Lei Tie scooped some water from the nearby bucket and poured it on the bud.

A white light flashed across the pink ball as if there was a current running around it.

Qin Mian also scooped a ladle of water to feed it.

The pink ball flashed again.

When it was watered for the third time, the pink ball seemed to be asleep and did not respond.

“That’s enough.” Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian nodded, “It should be.”

Lei Tie looked at the pink ball and his heart skipped a beat, “Later, we’ll water it together.”

Shoutout Corner: (๑••๑)๖thankS*♡ Thank you, SadieWoods! (●'▽`) ๖
♡

Note:

Footnotes

1. Like “go” to urge on (of horse)

Chapter 081: Brother Tie, Let Me Grow Up

081 – Brother Tie, Let Me Grow Up

Brought to you by Elaine །(*‘ㄣ’)ㄣㄣ~♥

“En.” Qin Mian was also curious about what kind of strange flower the pink ball would bloom. He said with interest, “Let me show you around the space first. There are many things I brought from another world.”

The space was too big. They only strolled around the nearby places. They planned to bring the horses sometime so they could go to the distant places.

Back in the quadrangle house, Lei Tie listened to Qin Mian’s introduction that this was a manual sewing machine, and that was beer, instant noodles, sportswear, sports shoes... There was always a contented smile in his eyes. Although it was not easy to detect, that kind of joy was reflected in his whole body’s aura.

Qin Mian did not notice that the smile on his face had yet disappeared.

“Look, this is the authentic hot pot soup base.” He took out a packet from a carton and offered it as a treasure. “We’ll use this to cook hot pot at noon.”

“Alright.”

In the end, both men came out of the space with each carrying two fully loaded baskets. Qin Mian’s two baskets were filled with fresh vegetables and delicious snacks. There was no season in the space. These few kinds of vegetables were not available in this season.

Lei Tie's two baskets were filled with fruits, bright red peaches, pink apples, and two clusters of purple grapes, all of which were plump with attractive radiance.

Lei Tie moved out two wooden blocks and washed the fruits and vegetables on the side of the well.

Qin Mian sat on another wooden block, holding a large bunch of washed grapes in his left hand and picking grapes one by one in his right hand. He looked behind him; there was no one else nearby.

"I think we'd better put a fence in front of the house so that no one will pass by and see something they shouldn't see."

"Wooden fence or trees?" Lei Tie asked.

"Plant shrubs, roses, brambles, juniper, and such." Qin Mian said that these plants were clusters of relatively short and small trees, which could not only isolate others from being too close to them but also would not restrict their field of view in the yard.

"Alright." Lei Tie carefully washed the mud off the pakchoi.

Qin Mian picked grape and sent it to his mouth.

Lei Tie opened his mouth, chomped his fingers, and only rolled the grape away after indistinctly lapped at them.

Qin Mian looked at his warm and moist fingers and the grapes he wanted to eat. He hesitated for a moment and continued to pick a grape to eat.

"One more." Lei Tie lowered his head and washed the vegetables carefully, looking as if the words were not uttered by him.

Qin Mian laughed in spite of himself but still picked a grape to feed him. He ate one and then fed him one...

When the two men finished eating a large bunch of grapes, Lei Tie also finished washing the vegetables.

Lei Tie brought the vegetables to the kitchen and Qin Mian followed after washing his hands. Lei Tie made a fire for cooking. He took a kitchen knife to deal with the ingredients. He cut the chicken into pieces; separated the outer leaves of the fresh cabbage¹ from the foliage and cut the outer leaves into strips, which were delicious when cooked; diced the potatoes; split the coriander in half...

After lunch, Qin Mian thought of his beloved horse. Seeing the sun was just nice, he found two small buckets to fill with water and took a small basket loaded with four apples.

“What are you doing?” Lei Tie asked when he saw it.

“Feed the horse and brush it.”

Lei Tie nodded and poured water into the water vat. He held the bamboo basket in his left hand and walked out with two empty wooden buckets in the right hand, “Use the water in the pond.”

Qin Mian followed with the brush that was used to brush his boots.

Passing by the pond, Lei Tie filled two buckets of water and Qin Mian carried the bamboo basket.

The two horses were grazing in the stable.

They led the horses to bask in the sun. Qin Mian took an apple and fed it to his brown horse. The brown horse sniffed the apple, opened its mouth, and ate it. He smiled as he stroked its neck and said to Lei Tie, “Look, I knew it would like.”

Lei Tie also picked up an apple to feed his black horse. The black horse glanced at him before eating the apple.

After feeding the apples, Qin Mian rolled up his sleeves to brush the brown horse.

The brown horse squinted happily and its head rubbed against Qin Mian's arm affectionately, which made him even fonder of it.

Meanwhile, on Lei Tie's side, Lei Tie methodically brushed the black horse but the black horse remained motionless and did not look at him, seemingly indifferent to it all. When Lei Tie finished brushing its left side, it turned around consciously and proactively but still did not look at Lei Tie. The temperament of the man and the horse was surprisingly similar.

Qin Mian watched with joy.

Lei Tie suddenly turned his head back, "When you're more skillful in horse riding, I'll teach you archery on horseback."

"Good!" Qin Mian was extremely happy, "Hey after I learned it, I can hunt on horseback."

After brushing the horse, Lei Tie brought some fodder to let the two horses graze in the sun. After the hair had dried, they led the horses back to the stable.

Uncle Fu stood at a distance, awaiting orders. It had been a while since they came to the farm residence. Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile were all diligent. At present, Xile and Uncle Fu had cut a lot of firewood. Aunt Fu had washed the dishes and clothes very cleanly and taken good care of the flower beds. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were quite satisfied with them.

Lei Tie instructed Uncle Fu and Xile to dig some shrubs in the mountain. At home, he took out the chessboard and played chess with Qin Mian under the willow trees by the pond.

When Uncle Fu and Xile came back, Qin Mian appointed a place for them to plant the shrubs and told them to plant a flower between every three or two shrubs.

In the middle of the *fence*, they made a half-person height wooden fence gate. When the sun was about to set, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went out for a

trip and brought back two grapevines, which were planted against the wall in the courtyard. When it was summer, they could pick the grapes to eat.

The daytime of the birthday passed in such leisure.

Lying in bed at night, Qin Mian became more nervous than ever before. Since Lei Tie “confessed” to him during the New Year, Lei Tie’s composure when facing him was getting worse and worse. Today could be said to be an important turning point for him and Lei Tie. Would Lei Tie be able to restraint from *attacking* him? To be honest, he often wanted to be close to Lei Tie but now he was only 16 years old. While his body was not fully developed, his desire was much weaker than that of Lei Tie.

When Lei Tie went in after locking the doors and windows, he saw his wife lying on the bed with a nervous expression on his face while being wrapped tightly in the quilt. Upon hearing the sound of footsteps, he raised his head alertly and gave him a hollow laugh.

Lei Tie’s steps halted. He slowly took off his clothes, leaving only the underclothes, gently picked up the quilt to drill in, and embraced the person into his arms.

Qin Mian stiffened.

“What are you afraid of?” Lei Tie’s voice sounded very confused.

Hm? Did he think too much? Did he flatter himself²? Qin Mian’s lips twitched. His mood was quite complicated. He could not tell whether he was happy or disappointed. However, he wound down and said, “Nothing, hehe.”

“En.” Lei Tie turned over on him, kissed his lips, took a bite, kissed his cheek, and then kissed his earlobe.

This posture is wrong! Qin Mian trembled, “What...are you doing?”

“Kissing you.” Lei Tie answered simply. He restrained Qin Mian’s arms with his two hands and pressed Qin Mian’s legs with his legs, restraining

him in a completely suppressed posture.

Qin Mian's whole body tensed up. After taking the initiative to kiss, he looked at the man with a straight face, "Brother Tie, can you let me grow up?"

Lei Tie's movement paused, "Alright."

Qin Mian took a long sigh of relief but was still kissed by Lei Tie all over his body.

Although there was no penetration interaction, the next morning, he still went to sleep until midday and only woke up when hungry. He shouted, "LEI TIE—"

Lei Tie quickly appeared, "Wife, are you hungry?"

Qin Mian glanced at him without expression and quickly put on his clothes.

Lei Tie's eyes swept across a shallow hickey on his neck, "I asked Aunt Fu to cook the egg and shredded meat noodles."

"Wait a while." Qin Mian put on his shoes and rushed out.

Lei Tie followed him out, "Wife, anxious to go to the latrine?"

Qin Mian stumbled. *Go to your head!*

"Run!"

Lei Tie raised his eyebrows and watched him run away.

White Spot howled and followed closely.

Qin Mian ran half a circle along the wall. When he came back, his legs were weak, his waist was bent, his hands were on his knees, and his mouth was opened, gasping for breath.

Lei Tie helped him up.

“Not yet.” He pushed the man away and went to the clothes-drying pole. He used the pole as a horizontal bar, holding it in both hands, pulling up his legs, and swaying about while hanging up.

Lei Tie stood by and looked on.

Qin Mian smiled smugly at him, “This can lengthen the arms, and maybe later my arms will be longer than yours.”

Lei Tie faintly shook his head.

After Qin Mian dangled earnestly for a while, he hung his armpits on the clothes-drying pole, raised his legs, and tried to hook the clothes-drying pole with his feet. He was unsuccessful after trying for a long time, and it looked rather funny.

Lei Tie strode over, dragged the person down, and patted his waist, “Nonsense.”

Qin Mian knew that he was overdoing it and did not insist, “Sigh, that’s enough. Starting tomorrow, I’ll resume morning exercise. I’m going to wash.”

He stretched both arms, swung his arms, kicked out his legs, and walked unhurriedly to the bathroom. A new mirror and washstand had been added to the bathroom, very practical.

Lei Tie went to the kitchen to serve him noodles.

Xile ran over in a hurry and called out at the gate, “Eldest young master and little young master, the fifth gongzi and miss are here.” Although they, the servants, had no relation with the people in the old house, their masters and the people in the old house were, after all, direct relatives. All the people in the old house were lucky enough to get “high, great, and above³” appellation. The “fifth gongzi” and “miss” referred to Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao.

Qin Mian spit out his mouthwash and came out of the bathroom, “Got it.”

When Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao came over, Qin Mian was eating noodles at the stone table and Lei Tie was sitting on the low wooden block beside him, repairing a plow.

“Come and sit down.” Qin Mian motioned to Lei Chuntao and Lei Xiangzhi.

Lei Chuntao did not sit, “Eldest sister-in-law, the flowers in your garden are so beautiful. I want to go and have a look to draw some embroidery patterns.”

“Oh, then you go. White Spot is there, don’t mess with it. It’s quite restless recently.” Qin Mian reminded.

“I know.” Lei Chuntao looked back with a smile and gradually walked away.

While eating noodles, Qin Mian asked, “What’s the matter, fifth brother?”

Lei Xiangzhi smiled shyly, “Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law, I’ve got a presumptuous request.”

Qin Mian said, “Let’s talk about it first.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. Chinese cabbage
2. 自作多情 [zì zuò duō qíng] to imagine that one’s love is reciprocated; to shower affection on an uninterested party
3. 高大上 [gāo dà shàng] (slang) high-end, elegant, and classy

Chapter 082: Lei Xiangzhi Is Going To Take Part in the Prefectural Exam

082 – Lei Xiangzhi Is Going To Take Part in the Prefectural Exam

Brought to you by Elaine ♥(^~^3)

Lei Xiangzhi said, “Some of my schoolmates are planning a relaxation trip before the college exam. I don’t know where they heard that the owner of Leisurely Farm Residence is my eldest brother, so they want to come to the garden and let me ask you what you think.”

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie slightly frowned, “Every blade of grass and every tree in the garden can’t be moved.” These were the efforts of him and his wife.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “That is of course. Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law can rest assured that the students I’ve made friends with are all people who know the etiquette.”

Lei Tie nodded to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian had no intention of opposing it. Their relationship with Lei Xiangzhi was good and they could not refuse Lei Xiangzhi so that he would not lose his face.

He ate the last two mouthfuls of noodles in the bowl and asked, “Our garden is more beautiful than the courtyard of ordinary households, but it is

far worse than that of the wealthy families and scenic spots. Why would they be interested in coming here?"

Lei Xiangzhi put down his teacup and shook his head. "Perhaps, they're coming for these flowers."

Qin Mian had no talent at studying and in fact, his enrollment to university was the second batch. He could not stand those gifted scholars who were fond of literary pursuits and those intellectuals who talked literary jargon all day. He wanted to avoid them in advance, so he asked casually, "When will they come?"

Lei Xiangzhi said, "Sometime tomorrow."

Lei Tie and Qin Mian had a tacit understanding, "We'll go to the town tomorrow, so you'll entertain them yourself. Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu will be there for you."

"Many thanks, eldest brother." Lei Xiangzhi gratefully said.

Qin Mian asked, "How many days before the prefectural exam?"

Lei Xiangzhi answered, "We'll depart in two days."

The next morning, Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Xile went to the town together.

About eight to nine of Lei Xiangzhi's schoolmates gathered at Lei Xiangzhi's home.

With so many young talents brought by her son, Du Shi's heart was contented. She warmly welcomed them with a smile. Intentionally or unintentionally, she pushed Wei Shi aside.

After sitting for a while, Lei Xiangzhi took his schoolmates to the Leisurely Farm Residence. Du Shi generously gave him two bags of melon seeds and fried peanuts left over during the New Year, as well as the snacks and dried fruits that were bought especially after hearing the distinguished guests would come so that he could treat the guests well. Originally, she also

wanted to go to the farm residence but was persuaded otherwise by Lei Xiangzhi.

Scholars seemingly liked to wear white clothes and the clothes set off their white faces even more handsomely. The villagers had seen many dark and swarthy rural boys who were suntanned and never seen so many youngsters with red lips and white teeth at once. They all stared at them curiously. There were even daring girls hiding in the distance, peeking while blushing.

“Fifth gongzi.” Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu had been briefed by Qin Mian earlier. They stood at the gate to meet the guests.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu, I’ll take them around first. Please prepare some tea by the flowerbed.”

“Yes.” Lei Xiangzhi was gentle and polite. Uncle Fu had a favorable impression of him.

As soon as they passed the gate, they were attracted by the cloud-like peach blossoms in front of them and incessantly gasped in admiration.

“This is really a wonderful place.” Qu Zongwen was the first to praise.

The others nodded approvingly and looked around with appreciative eyes.

Lei Xiangzhi bowed with a hand cupped in the other as he said with a smile, “My eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law have paid a lot of thoughts on every small thing inside this manor. Asking the gentlemen to only feast your eyes and don’t stretch out your hands. Xiangzhi will thank first.”

Qu Zongwen and the others smilingly said that they dare not.

“Hehe...” Ling Qiyun, the only scholar who did not speak, looked around left and right. “For this disturbance, one ought to visit the owners first to apologize. Brother Lei, are your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law here?”

Lei Xiangzhi frowned slightly. When they were at his house, he said that his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law were not there.

Qu Zongwen glanced at Ling Qiyun and gently shook his folding fan, fully displayed his youthful charm. “Just now Brother Lei said that his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law had gone to the town intentionally to make room for us. Why didn’t Brother Ling hear that?”

Ling Qiyun apologized with a smile, “I see. I was absent-minded and didn’t hear Brother Lei’s words. It’s merely due to not being able to pay the owners a visit, Qiyun is rather restless.” Today, he came first to see the flowers. Secondly, he wanted to see what the male married couple, who had been the talk of the town, looked like. No matter how good Lei Xiangzhi was at studying, his own eldest brother had married a male wife, was it not to be laughed at? But he only dared to think about it in his heart, not to speak out. All the people present were either good at studying or from a good family. He did not want to be excluded from this circle.

Qu Zongwen’s folding fan opened and closed and opened again, making a snapping sound. He said with a forced smile, “Brother Ling if you’re really restless, why should you follow us?”

Lei Xiangzhi patted him on the shoulder and faintly smiled at Ling Qiyun, “The reason why my eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are not at home is that they’re afraid we won’t fully enjoy it. If Brother Ling is restless, it defeated the good intention of my eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law. Come on, I’ll take you to the front.”

“Go.” Bu Qingyun, with thick eyebrows and big eyes, was the first to agree. He casually hooked Lei Xiangzhi’s shoulder and walked forward.

The others followed. The group of people talked and laughed.

Ling Qiyun adjusted his mood and quickly followed them.

Qu Zongwen admired the peach blossoms at the end of the bridge with a flash of surprise in his eyes, “Brother Lei, it seems that your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are really good at taking care of the fruit trees.”

“Why do you say that?” Lei Xiangzhi did not understand why he suddenly came to such a conclusion.

Qu Zongwen pointed to a peach branch stretching out diagonally in front of his eyes. “There are also several peach trees in my house. The flowers bloom brilliantly this year, but they are not as good as your eldest brother’s. You look at the peach blossom; the petals are delicate and thriving vitality. You’ll see liquid if you pinch the petals, and you’ll know that the moisture content is high. I’m sure the peaches they bore will be very sweet.”

The others nodded in consensus.

“It’s not just the peach blossom trees,” One of the scholars with the most scholarly appearance pointed to the distance, “The plum and pear trees over there are also very rich in vitality. Seeing them make one’s mood soar.”

Lei Xiangzhi did not know the secret — Qin Mian had secretly added spiritual spring water to the pond and the watering of the fruit trees, flower plants, and vegetables the farm residence came from the pond. Therefore, these fruit trees were naturally full of vitality.

He just laughed and said, “The fruit trees here are all managed by an uncle in our village.”

Qu Zongwen said to Lei Xiangzhi, “Our old lady likes to eat peaches the most. At that time [fruit season], I’ll have to buy it from here.”

Lei Xiangzhi shook his head slightly, “This is hard to say for the time being. I heard my eldest sister-in-law mention once that these fruit trees seem to have other uses. But I’ll mention it to him for you.”

“Many thanks then.” Qu Zongwen smilingly said.

“Why are we talking about fruits, there isn’t a shadow of it! Look at the flowers, look at the flowers.” Bu Qingyun stood at the edge of the flowerbed and urged, “Come here quickly. These flowers are blooming very well.”

Another gifted scholar quickly walked over, “Everyone, the scenery here is so beautiful that we shouldn’t let down this spring scenery, how about poetry fight?”

Forget the few scholars who were viewing flowers and fighting with poetry over there. Qin Mian and Lei Tie made a preliminary plan for their newly purchased 15 mu of land in the town. Just like the farm residence, branches were used to mark off each area, and the construction could start only after all kinds of building materials were purchased. After finishing their work, they went to the restaurant to take a look and then went back home.

Qin Mian enjoyed riding a horse. Lei Tie leaped onto the horse and sat behind him.

Xile, who was driving an empty cart following behind, was utterly speechless. Did the two masters take him just to drive the “cart”?

At the entrance of the Green Mountain Village, two horse-carriages were parked at the side of the road facing the outside of the village. There were several people standing by the carriages.

Lei Xiangzhi was about to send his schoolmates away.

Hearing the approaching sound of the horse’s hooves, people looked at it curiously.

The brown horse ran up to them and Qin Mian skillfully stopped the horse about a zhang¹ away, “*Hush*— Fifth brother.”

Lei Xiangzhi said, “Eldest sister-in-law, you’re back.”

Qin Mian nodded with a smile, “En.”

Lei Tie glanced at the crowd lightly. Then he gripped Qin Mian’s hand and shook the reins. The brown horse broke into a run towards the farm residence.

Xile hastily kept up.

Qu Zongwen's face was still a little surprised. He turned to Lei Xiangzhi and said, "Brother Lei, your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law don't look like country folks." In particular, the man in the back had strong momentum and an indifferent glance, fierce and domineering, just like a general who once fought on the battlefield.

Bu Qingyun looked at the direction of their departure with his mouth agape. He patted Lei Xiangzhi on the shoulder and whispered, "Hey, is that your eldest brother in the back? Is your eldest brother really your related eldest brother?" He also felt that the temperament of Lei Tie and Lei Xiangzhi did not seem like they were a family.

Lei Xiangzhi helplessly said, "Of course, he's my related eldest brother."

At the gate of the farm residence, Uncle Fu heard the sound of horse's hooves and opened the gate immediately.

Qin Mian nimbly jumped off his horse, "Uncle Fu, did something happened today?"

Uncle Fu smilingly said, "Answering to Little Young Master, the fifth gongzi restrained them very well. They looked at the flowers, wrote poems, played chess, and didn't throw away melon seeds and peanut shells anywhere."

"That's good."

At home, they cleaned up and sat down for a while. After assuming that the guests in the old house had already left, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went there together.

Lei Chuntao stood in the yard, pouting and gripping a flower in her hand. Qin Mian walked over curiously.

"What's the matter, little sister?"

"You two are here. It's nothing." Lei Chuntao's lips pouted even harder with her graceful eyebrow tightly knitted, looking extremely resentful.

Qin Mian entered the house and saw Lei Xiangzhi also wore a helpless expression. He was even more bewildered.

Du Shi patted the table and said angrily, “Am I not doing it for her own good?”

“What happened?” Qin Mian asked Lei Xiangli in a low voice.

Lei Xiangli euphemistically said, “Fifth brother’s schoolmates are handsome and highly esteemed. Two of them are excellent at studying and have a good family background.”

Without much explanation, Qin Mian already understood. It turned out that Du Shi wanted to choose a son-in-law among those scholars.

“Sister, of course, we know that you think for the sake of Chuntao, but the two gongzis said that their families shall settle the marriage for them. If you simply interfere, won’t it hurt Chuntao? A girl’s reputation is her second life. In case it ended up with egg on one’s face, the girl will be ruined for a lifetime. Husband, do you think?” Wei Shi sipped tea and slowly spoke. After a period of no news, Wei Shi’s *firepower* had increased.

In the beginning, Lei Daqiang was a little tempted. But upon hearing this, his expression changed and immediately changed his mind, “Wei’er is right. This matter can’t be done.”

Du Shi said in a voice dripping with sarcasm, “You only have her in your eyes now, so certainly everything she says is right. Chuntao is my daughter, not hers. She certainly can’t think well for Chuntao!”

Wei Shi’s face turned white and her lips trembled. She bit her lips and looked at Lei Daqiang, “Husband, I didn’t...”

Immediately after, she turned to Lei Xiangzhi and said eagerly, “Old Five, you’re a perceptive person. What I said just now is all for Chuntao’s sake.”

Du Shi’s expression changed greatly. *You sly Wei Shi, you want to bring my son to your side!*

Qin Mian secretly lamented that it seemed not easy to provoke one or two of them.

One should not stay long in a place where one was apt to get into trouble.
He quickly cut in, “*Cough.* The fifth brother will go to the prefecture center to take the exam in two days. Have everything packed up yet?”

Du Shi eased her mood and said, “It’s all ready.”

Qin Mian said, “We’re two to three days away from the prefecture center of Qingtian Prefecture. It’s a long way to go. I’m afraid some people with bad intentions will take the opportunity to make trouble. I’ve discussed it with A-Tie. We intend to send the fifth brother to the prefecture center in person.”

Wei Shi glanced at Qin Mian and Lei Tie before dropping her gaze. *The eldest and his wife care about this youngest brother.*

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi both had surprise smiles on their faces.

“Good, good.” Lei Daqiang looked at Lei Tie approvingly. His eyes contained gratification and he took on a compassionate fatherly attitude, “Eldest, you two have done well. Old Five is your youngest brother. This is exactly how you and your wife should be.”

Thank you for all the comments ♡~٩(͡▽͡)~♡

Note:

Footnotes

1. 3.3 meters

Chapter 083: Going to the Prefecture Center

083 – Going to the Prefecture Center

Brought to you by SadieWoods (♡'O'♡)*◇ ☆ 。*

Lei Tie loftily sat there in silence with his eyes on Qin Mian. As if he had not heard Lei Daqiang's words, he did not give him any response.

There was a loss in Lei Daqiang's eyes as he faintly felt that he had lost this son of his.

“Yes, yes. Old Five, your eldest brother knows kung fu. I'll be more rest assured with him sending you.” Du Shi looked at Lei Xiangzhi affectionately.

Lei Xiangzhi was also very delighted, “Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law, won't it delay your business?”

“Don't worry, everything has been arranged. I've never been to the prefecture center. Your eldest brother said that he would take me around. Sending you off is a matter of convenience.” Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie as he said with a smile.

Lei Xiangzhi stood up and said, “Many thanks. To be honest with you, the teacher also specially told us that there are some bandits who caused trouble during the examination period. He told us not to be careless on the way and even arranged four home guards to escort us. With the eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law there, little brother feels more at ease.”

Lei Tie took out a purse and handed it to him, “This is 10 taels of broken silver, keep it on you.”

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi looked even more satisfied.

“Many thanks, eldest brother.” Lei Xiangzhi did not refuse.

Lei Xiangren scratched his head. If he had been studying hard for a few years back then, Lei Tie would have provided him money too. His eyes inadvertently passed over the sniffling Lei Dabao and got an inspiration: *Dabao is six years old this year. It's time for enlightenment.*

His eyeballs circled about and the sneaky sight fell on Du Shi and Lei Daqiang before indistinctly sweeping over Wei Shi.

After finishing the matter, Qin Mian and Lei Tie got up and left.

“Mother.” Lei Xiangren went to Du Shi’s side and was about to open his mouth but closed it. He thought to himself that it was inappropriate to open his mouth now. In case it turned unpleasant that would affect Old Five’s performance in the examination room, it would be self-defeating.

“What’s it?” Du Shi frowned. This son had become more and more nonsensical. Yesterday, Old Three told her that Old Two had found work in the town, but he was driven out because he was lazy. Therefore, he had not brought any money back home.

“Nothing. I was just calling you.” Lei Xiangren grinned cheekily as he approached her and fist massaged¹ her back.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not know that the old house would soon usher in another storm.

They chatted as they walked back.

“The old house has changed a lot.” Qin Mian kicked a stone in the middle of the road into the grass beside the road.

The pigsty and chicken coop in the courtyard of the old house were gone. They should have been moved to the back of the house. Four red brick and tiled rooms were built in the courtyard, opposite each other, with a patio in the middle for people to enter and leave. Among these was Wei Shi's contribution. It was said that some time ago, she gave the old Lei family an idea of making money and made a small profit. Lei Daqiang used the money to build the four rooms. Lei Xiangyi and his wife occupied a new room and their original room was owned by Wei Shi. Wei Shi finally did not have to squeeze in the same room as Du Shi.

Lei Daqiang was very proud of himself because he was the only one in the village who had two wives. If you wanted to spend the night with Du Shi, he could go to Du's room. If you wanted to spend the night with Wei Shi, he could go to Wei Shi's room. From time to time, the two women vied for him. When he heard the village's men joked that he enjoyed the happy fate of the man from Qi², he was so proud that his nostrils turned skyward.

Among the three rooms, one was prepared for Lei Xiangzhi's marriage. The other two, one large and one small were connected. The large one was for Lei Xiangzhi's marriage and the small one was Lei Xiangzhi's study.

Lei Tie dully said, "As long as they don't come to provoke us."

"That's right." Qin Mian admired his idea of marrying another wife to Lei Daqiang. Look, for a long time, neither Lei Daqiang nor Du Shi came to be an eyesore.

Lei Tie liked to see his eyes shining. He took his hand and walked home in the sunset glow.

On the day of the scheduled departure, Qin Mian and Lei Tie got up early in the morning, casually cooked noodles to eat, took the packing baggage to put on the horse carriage, and told Xile and the others to guard the gate. When they were not at home, it was better not to let anyone in. Qin Mian was mainly on guard against the people in the old house, especially Du Shi, Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren, and Zhao Shi.

There was a chill in the spring air. The burst of wind that blew made the face ice-cold. Qin Mian lamented that it was not easy for the ancient students to seek knowledge. He had learned that the prefectural examination was presided over by the prefectural magistrate, so students from each county in the same prefecture needed to rush to the prefecture center to take the exam. Zhaoyang County was relatively closer and it only took two or three days to get there. The students from the faraway county towns took four to five days by horse carriage.

At this time, there was only the marble white color of the dawn sky in the east, but by the time they got to the town, it would surely be bright.

Lei Xiangzhi also got up early and was eating fried rice. The rest of the family got up and sat with him.

Lei Xiangzhi was much moved when he saw his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law arrived so early. He quickly finished the fried rice, picked up the baggage, and boarded the horse carriage.

The Lei family watched the horse carriage drove to the town.

When they arrived in the town, the three horse-carriages arranged by the school had arrived, and the four tall and strong home guards were also present. Another man in his early forties with a scholarly look and a short beard, dressed in a cyan scholar robe, was standing beside the preceding horse carriage with his hands behind his back.

Lei Xiangzhi jumped off the carriage, quickly walked to the middle-aged man, and respectfully saluted, "Student greets Teacher."

"En, don't be too polite." The middle-aged man's eyes fell on Qin Mian and Lei Tie. He was surprised by their unusual temperament and secretly guessed their identity, "May I know who these two are?"

Lei Xiangzhi introduced, "Mister, these two are my eldest brother Lei Tie and my eldest sister-in-law Qin Mian. Eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law, this is Teacher Gong."

“Greetings, Mister Gong.” Qin Mian and Lei Tie together cupped their hands in greeting.

Teacher Gong had guessed right. As a teacher, he was not oblivious to the outside world. Lei Tie and Qin Mian was a well-known male married couple nearby and with the addition of their famous restaurant, he had known the two for a long time, but it was the first time he saw them.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “Teacher, my eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law know some kung fu. They’ll send me to the prefecture center, will it be convenient?”

“Oh?” Teacher Gong was a little surprised and immediately cupped his hands, “Of course, it’s convenient. In this way, my other students will also follow suit. I thank you both on their behalf.”

Qin Mian went to the side to avoid [his polite gesture] and raised his hand, “Teacher is too polite. We should thank the Teacher for educating our younger brother.”

“Hehe, you flatter me. It’s a matter within one’s duties.” Teacher Gong was very approachable when he talked and laughed.

After a while, another eleven students, including Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Ling Qiyun came in one after another. Zhao Tian and Wang Shangwen got along relatively good with Lei Xiangzhi and they also had been to the Leisurely Farm Residence two days ago.

Qu Zongwen, aside from having a charming appearance, also had a very thorough etiquette. He politely cupped his hands in greeting to Lei Tie and Qin Mian, “Greetings, eldest brother Lei and eldest sister-in-law Lei.”

Bu Qingyun and the others did not expect to meet them, they also came to greet.

“Brother Lei, why are your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law here?” Bu Qingyun asked quietly.

“My eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are worried about me, so they are sending me to the prefecture center.” Lei Xiangzhi was happy from the bottom of his heart and there was even a bit of pride because the others had no relatives sending them off.

Wang Shangwen was only about 14 to 15 years old, but he was very mature. After looking at Qin Mian and Lei Tie curiously, he made a bow with hands folded in front, “In this way, we’ll be basking in the light³ following after you. Thanks eldest brother Lei and eldest sister-in-law Lei.”

“No need to be polite.” Qin Mian had been immune to the word “sister-in-law” for a long time. He was not uncomfortable when he was called that by a stranger who he had just first met, and his expression was calm.

He glanced at Lei Tie and made up his mind to accept a little brother when he had the opportunity and let him call Lei Tie’s “sister-in-law”. This way, it would be fair. Thinking of that scene, he tried to suppress the smile in his eyes.

Lei Tie felt a chill on his back and looked at his wife in doubt.

“Alright, it’s getting late. Get on the carriage.” Teacher Gong said.

There were three carriages. Four people in each carriage would be comparatively uncrowded and they could sleep for a while by leaning on the baggage.

Lei Xiangzhi saw neatly stacked sleeping pads and quilts on Qin Mian’s carriage. He knew that his eldest sister-in-law might sleep in the carriage. After all, he was a brother-in-law and it was not good to stay alone with Qin Mian. Moreover, he did not think it was noteworthy conduct and independent character, so he sat on the carriage arranged by the school with other students, which was convenient to communicate with each other on the road.

Lei Tie only carried Qin Mian. Inside the carriage, Qin Mian lay on the sleeping pads, covered with quilts, and fell asleep in the sway of the carriage.

At midday, the carriage stopped by the side of the road.

Lei Tie lifted the curtain and saw Qin Mian still sleeping. He got into the carriage and picked up the person with the quilt, “Wife, wake up. If you sleep too much, you won’t be able to sleep at night.”

Qin Mian slowly opened his eyes, beat out a huge yawn, and quickly sat up, “En. Why did it stop?”

“It’s noon.”

Qin Mian wiped his face and lifted the curtain. He saw that the three carriages at the front had stopped. The scholars got out of the carriages and stood on the roadside, eating dried food while basking in the sun.

Lei Xiangzhi stood with Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, Zhao Tian, and several others.

Qin Mian opened the baggage, took out a big apple and a small pot of homemade minced beef sauce, and handed it to Lei Tie, “Give to Fifth Brother.”

Lei Tie nodded and took the apple and beef sauce to Lei Xiangzhi. Then he went back to the carriage and had lunch with Qin Mian.

“What is this?” Bu Qingyun stared at the small pottery pot and asked curiously. He had a hunch that it must have been food.

Lei Xiangzhi first put the apple into his sleeve pocket and smilingly said, “You all have gourmet’s luck. This is my eldest sister-in-law’s homemade beef sauce. It goes well with rice.”

He went to Teacher Gong’s side and said, “Teacher, if you don’t mind, have a taste.”

“Sure.” Teacher Gong said with a smile, “Your brother’s and sister-in-law’s restaurant is well-known. The beef sauce made by your sister-in-law must taste good.”

Lei Xiangzhi opened the small pottery pot. When they saw a delicate bamboo spoon inside, they all felt that Lei Xiangzhi's sister-in-law was very attentive. Then they smelled the rich and attractive aroma, and they could not help swallowing secretly.

Qu Zongwen approached, "Smells good!"

Lei Xiangzhi first scooped two big spoonfuls of beef sauce to put on Teacher Gong's baked sesame seed-coated pancake. Then he gave each of the students a scoop to put it on their steamed bread or millet pancakes. He also gave some to the two coachmen and the four home guards.

Teacher Gong saw this out of the corner of his eye and nodded approval in secret.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Massage sb's back by pounding it lightly with one's fists
2. lit. the happy fate of the man from Qi (who had a wife and a concubine) (idiom); fig. (ironically) the joy of having several partners; the life of a pasha
3. fig. to benefit from association with sb or sth

Chapter 084: Entry-level Examinee

084 – Entry-level Examinee

Brought to you by SadieWoods ♡(｡ω｡)♡

The two coachmen and four home guards were flattered, and they quickly expressed their thanks. A bit of sauce was a small thing but the rarest thing was that someone could think of them.

After that, Lei Xiangzhi finally scooped himself a spoon.

Consequently, the smell of beef sauce wafted all over the place.

Bu Qingyun's beef sauce was sandwiched in the steamed bread. He opened his mouth and took a big bite. He praised, "Delicious! There's a lot of beef in it. It's finely cut, aromatic, and soft."

Ling Qiyun, who was absorbed in eating, repeatedly nodded.

"Brother Lei, give me another spoonful?" Qu Zongwen looked at Lei Xiangzhi with a happy smile. He had a round pancake in his hands without a trace of being bitten. This was obviously his second pancake.

Lei Xiangzhi waved his hand, "There's only such a small pot. Don't you want to eat it for the next meal?"

Qu Zongwen regretfully licked his lips, wondering if he could ask Sister-in-law Lei for another pot. However, at the thought of Eldest Brother Lei's face, he quivered and gave up this unreliable idea.

This was their first time traveling a long distance so Qin Mian would not treat himself and Lei Tie badly. Moreover, he had a magical space. His

lunch with Lei Tie was chopped scallion multi-layer pancakes and beef sauce, as well as thick vermicelli soup in a bamboo tube, which turned hot in Lei Tie's grasp. This vermicelli was taken from the space. Thanks to his love of gourmet food and eschatology, he had bought some books on homemade food, including how to make vermicelli, rice wrappers, and so on. When he had time, he would definitely make the vermicelli.

Everyone could smell the other scents in Qin Mian's carriage beside the scent of beef sauce, but they did not have the cheek to approach.

Teacher Gong said, "It's afternoon. We should speed up our journey; otherwise, we'll miss the lodging. If you all can't adapt to it, give consideration to each other."

"Yes, teacher!" All the scholars said in unison.

When everyone had finished their lunch, the carriages continued on their way.

Qin Mian had a good sleep in the morning. He accompanied Lei Tie to sit on the shaft and talked to him while basking in the sun.

In the evening, they stayed in a small inn in a small town, and nothing bad happened. Teacher Gong and the four home guards were secretly relieved.

The next day, Qin Mian found it boring to ride in the carriage. He mounted the horse and sauntered around nearby.

Lei Tie watched his wife on horseback riding forward for a while and retreating to his side after a while. He regretted not bringing Xile along. If Xile was here, he could let Xile drive the carriage while he rode the horse with his wife.

Qin Mian rode forward merrily in the spring breeze. Suddenly, as if he felt something, he looked back and bumped into the gaze of the man following him. He turned his horse's head and rode back.

"Butt hurts after sitting in the carriage for a long time." He whispered.

Lei Tie was silent for a while before unhappily said, “Riding a horse for a long time will also hurt the butt and legs.”

“Hehehe...” Qin Mian’s eyebrows danced with laughter. It turned out that this man could not be separated from him. He could even say such a straightforward sentence.

He handed the reins to the man and jumped into the carriage.

Lei Tie stretched out his long arms to catch him steadily, placed him beside him, and tied the reins to the shaft.

Qin Mian took out two apples from the space, one for each person.

He casually looked at the deep woods on both sides of the government-financed road and blurted out, “It’s so quiet.”

About two *li*¹ away was the terrain of a narrow road between two hillsides. The road turned to a corner, so the end could not be seen.

Lei Tie said, “There is a fight ahead.”

Qin Mian was surprised, “Don’t tell me, it’s really a highway robbery? What to do?”

Lei Tie kneaded his shoulder, shook the reins, and sped up, surpassing the three carriages in front.

On the first carriage, Teacher Gong came out to breathe and sat on the shaft with the coachman.

“Might there be something wrong, Boss Lei and Madam?” Teacher Gong asked suspiciously.

Qin Mian said concisely and comprehensively, “Teacher Gong, the terrain ahead looks very dangerous. A-Tie will go to explore the road first and we move slowly in the back.” He could not let people know that Lei Tie’s skill was so high that he could hear the sound from so far away.

He spoke vaguely, but Teacher Gong understood and his expression turned solemn — if there were villains who wanted to cause trouble, the terrain ahead was the best choice.

The faces of the coachman and the two home guards that were hired to lead the fleet of carriages at the front changed slightly.

“Thank you for your trouble, Boss Lei.” Teacher Gong solemnly said to Lei Tie.

Qin Mian drove the carriage. Lei Tie handed him the unfinished apple, leaped on the horse, and galloped away.

“What’s going on, eldest sister-in-law?” Lei Xiangzhi poked his head out of the carriage.

Qin Mian straightforwardly remembered a sentence, “Scholars are the least useful”. He worried that these scholars would be thrown into a panic so he said relaxedly, “Nothing, your eldest brother went to explore the way ahead.”

Lei Xiangzhi nodded and realized that the matter was rather complicated. However, seeing that his eldest brother left his eldest sister-in-law here, it showed that the matter was under the control of his eldest brother.

Qin Mian gnawed on Lei Tie’s apple. He raised his head to look up and he could barely see Lei Tie’s figure.

Everyone slowly arrived on the narrow road and saw six masked men besieging Lei Tie. Lei Tie handled them with ease.

There were two carriages by the side of the road. An old man in his fifties, who looked like a teacher, protected several scholars with panic on their faces behind him. Their two coachmen were injured and sat on the ground next to the wheels.

Lei Tie saw his wife had arrived and knocked the six masked men to the ground with several fists, making them clutching their abdomen and

grunting.

“Ow...ow...”

“A-Tie.” Qin Mian jumped out of the carriage and ran over, “Are you alright?”

“I’m fine.” Lei Tie embraced his (QM) shoulder. Upon seeing only the core of the apple left in his (QM) hand, his eyes sank deeper².

The old man collected himself and went to Lei Tie. He made a bow with hands folded in front as he said, “Many thanks to this brave man. If you didn’t show up in time, I’m afraid that my party would be brutally killed.”

“Don’t be too polite.” Lei Tie waved his hand and pulled Qin Mian back to his carriage.

Teacher Gong had to go over and talk to the old man himself. He learned that this group of people came from Changle County and also went to the prefecture center for the exam. The old man was Teacher Chen. When they arrived here, several masked men suddenly jumped out to rob them. Fearing that the bandits would be driven to desperate action, Teacher Chen did not dare to say more and took the initiative to hand over half of their belongings. Unexpectedly, the gang still did not give up. They not only robbed the remaining belongings but even hurt others. Both sides then fight; the two coachmen were injured to protect those several scholars. Fortunately, Lei Tie appeared in time and saved them.

Fortunately, neither of the coachmen was seriously injured. People who travel far away would bring some commonly used medicine in case of an emergency. Teacher Chen led his two students to help them bandage their wounds.

Teacher Gong said to Teacher Chen, “We’ll be passing by Wuwei County. It’s convenient to tie up these bandits and send them to the county authority so as not to do evil to those who came after us. What does Teacher Chen think?”

Teacher Chen's face was calm and collected as he said in the manner that one abhorred evils as deadly foes, "Rightly so."

He vacated a carriage and the four home guards took a rope to tie the six gangsters inside. In this way, Teacher Chen's carriage had not enough space.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not mean to let strangers into their carriage.

This person Teacher Gong was also interesting. He did not mention borrowing Qin Mian's carriage but took the initiative to let Teacher Chen's students and his students squeeze together.

Ancient scholars were quite loveable.

Teacher Chen could drive a carriage and Teacher Gong called a home guard to help them drive the other carriage. The crowd traveled in a group.

This time, Teacher Gong's carriage was at the front, while Qin Mian and Lei Tie's carriage was behind him.

The scholars in the other carriages were talking about Lei Tie and envied him for his skill.

Two scholars wanted to get close to Lei Tie but they only received a cold face and had to give up resentfully.

Fortunately, nothing else had happened until they arrived at Qingtian Prefecture.

Due to the approaching prefectural examination, Qingtian Prefecture was very bustling. The streets were crowded with people and eight out of ten people were scholars.

The magistrate of Qingtian Prefecture was very thoughtful. He named several inns that could only receive students and put up official notices from the four days before the examination to the day when the examination was over. The owners of these inns were not reluctant. If the examinees living in their inns got a better place in the prefectural examination, it would also be

a kind of powerful publicity for their inns. Moreover, it was not that the examinees would not be paying for staying in the inn. Hence, they would not suffer any losses at all.

Teacher Gong and Teacher Chen took their students to the inn to settle down. The exam would start the day after tomorrow which meant they still could have a rest day tomorrow.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie checked in at another inn on the opposite side of the street and informed Teacher Gong that they could go there to find them in case of anything. Teacher Gong had taught several sessions of exam candidates and had a rich experience. With him to take care of Lei Xiangzhi, they had nothing to worry about. After taking a hot bath, they changed to clean clothes and went out for a stroll.

The prefecture center was more progressive than the county town, with a dazzling line-up variety of commodities. Qin Mian and Lei Tie spent nearly two hours strolling around. They bought a lot of things, including some local specialties, to the point that their four hands were not enough. They also found out that there was a special snack in Qingtian Prefecture called silver-silk meat pancake. They went to buy two and tasted it. The taste was unique. Qin Mian bought fifty of them and let the shop assistant send it to the inn. He then put them into the space.

On the second day of their visit to Qingtian Prefecture, they spent a day sightseeing at White Dragon Temple.

On the morning of the third day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie sent Lei Xiangzhi to the examination hall. The prefectural examination consisted of three exams which held once a day.

These three days, Qin Mian and Lei Tie still spent the time to go sightseeing in carefree.

Three days later, the examinees came out of the examination hall. Some were happy and others were worried. The only thing in common was that all of them looked thinner. Lei Xiangzhi also looked thinner but his spirit was

good. His eyes were shining with confidence. He must have done well in the exam.

Teacher Gong said that the day was getting late today and if they left today, they might have to sleep in the wild, so it was better to stay one night and set off the next morning.

No one else disagreed.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not ask Lei Xiangzhi how he did in the exam. They invited him to have a good meal in a big wine house and took him to buy some high-quality Four Treasures of the Study³.

Qin Mian got along with people quite well. On the way back to the inn, he bought some exquisite snacks and asked Lei Xiangzhi to share them with his teacher and other schoolmates.

The next day, after breakfast, they set out on their way home.

It took three days to go home. Once arrived, Qin Mian asked Uncle Fu if there was anything that happened at home.

Uncle Fu replied that there was not any.

As a matter of fact, Qin Mian thought too much. Lei Xiangzhi went to the prefecture center to take the exam which made Lei Daqiang and Du Shi so worried that they could not eat and sleep well. They could care less about going to the farm residence to make trouble.

Another day later, the county released the public roll of successful examinees, and the good news that Lei Xiangzhi got the second place in the prefectural examination reached Green Mountain Village.

As an entry-level examinee, Lei Xiangzhi could enter the academy in the county to study and take part in the annual college examination. If he passed the college examination, he could become a Xiucai. At present, Lei Xiangzhi was only one step away from the scholarly honor of a Xiucai.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi were so happy that they grinned from ear to ear. Relatives and friends came to congratulate them in succession. Even Li Zheng himself went to the door to congratulate them. He also took the initiative to propose that if Lei Xiangzhi did not have enough travel expenses at the time of participating in the college examination, the villagers would help.

Du Shi appeared very proud and self-satisfied in front of Wei Shi. She wanted to feast the guests.

Lei Xiangzhi timely dispelled her idea. Although he was very happy, he was a rational person. This was not the time to relax.

Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, Wang Shangwen, Zhao Tianhe, and Ling Qiyun also became entry-level examinees along with Lei Xiangzhi. The results of Qu Zongwen and Wang Shangwen were also quite good while the others ranked relatively low.

Two days later, Lei Xiangzhi and Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, Wang Shangwen, Zhao Tianhe, and Ling Qiyun went to Zhaoyang County to study in Qingyun Academy to prepare for the college examination. After entering the academy, these students would live in the academy. Apart from major festivals, they were only allowed to return home once a month – the last two days of the month were holidays.

At the same time, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao became hot [in favor]. People in the vicinity of Green Mountain Village knew that Lei Xiangzhi was very likely to be a Xiucai and they hoped to make the three people their own family before Lei Xiangzhi became a Xiucai. Once Lei Xiangzhi became a Xiucai, the Lei family would not necessarily look up to them.

The matchmakers in the county town became active. Almost every day, matchmakers ran to the old Lei's house.

However, these had nothing to do with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They began to work with the new wine house.

Note:

Footnotes

1. ancient measure of length, approx. 500 m
2. Uhh, he's probably happy his wife ate his unfinished apple. He's not a cheapskate.
3. writing materials; writing brush, paper, ink, and ink-stone

Chapter 085: Selling Recipe

085 – Selling Recipe

Brought to you by SadieWoods (☒☐> ∪ < ☐) ° ✧♡

Qin Mian especially reminded Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli to think of making a variety of cuisines. He would not let his relatives get involved in the wine house. He could only pull Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli in this way. As for whether they would tell Du Shi, it did not matter to him.

Building a wine house required someone to buy building materials, someone to guard the materials, someone to supervise the work, and someone to take care of the food for the workers—it was certainly a big project. Qin Mian figured out which people could be employed in the village, and made a list of thirty people who were assigned jobs according to their abilities and levels. Uncle Zhao Wenzhong was literate and had been engaged in business for nearly ten years. Qin Mian specially invited him to work as an accountant to take charge of daily expenses. The workers in charge of the construction were professional craftsmen hired by Lei Tie from the county town.

This time, the project was very urgent and needed to be completed before the wheat harvest. When the busy farming season ushered in, there would be a serious shortage of manpower.

After all the work had been arranged, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were only responsible for supervising the work. Watching the money in their hands gradually became less, and the wine house transformed little by little, both of them were very satisfied. Even if they were very tired every day, they also felt it was worth it.

On the way to Running Water Town from Zhaoyang County, a luxurious carriage drove quietly, getting closer and closer to Running Water Town.

Near the entrance of the town, a hand lifted the curtain. The owner of the hand casually looked out and his eyes were swept across a construction site going ahead at full steam. He was not very concerned. When he was about to withdraw his gaze, he suddenly saw two familiar figures.

He quickly told the coachman outside, “Chunsheng, drive the carriage directly into the construction site.”

“Yes, gongzi.” Although Chunsheng took the order, he was not clear of the reason. When he inadvertently saw the two people talking at the construction site, he understood.

“The Lord of Heaven makes things easy for us.” Qin Mian said to Lei Tie with a smile of joy on his face. “It hasn’t rained these days, otherwise, the progress will be hindered.”

Lei Tie held his hand tightly. “There’s no need to rush. Even if it’s drag out until the busy farming season, we can hire people. It’s nothing more than spending more money.”

Qin Mian snorted, “You’re all very well to talk, but getting things done is another matter. The head of the house knows the cost of firewood and rice¹!”

Lei Tie handed him the bamboo tube hanging on his arm, which contained cabbage and snow fungus soup, “En, [my] wife has worked hard.”

Qin Mian pinched his burning hot ear lobes, took the tube, and drank the soup.

Nie Heng got out of the carriage, looked at the white brocade short boots on his feet, and hesitated for a moment. He still went over while carefully avoiding the bricks and gravel on the ground, and stopped in front of Qin Mian and Lei Tie. He cupped his hands in greeting and smiled, “Boss Qin and Boss Lei, how have you been?”

Qin Mian wiped the soup at the corner of his mouth with a handkerchief. He sized up the noble gongzi in front of him in doubt. He was sure that he did not know this person. He looked at Lei Tie and Lei Tie's expression also told him that he did not know.

Qin Mian felt awkward and his face did not show any inkling. He politely asked, "May I ask your excellency is?"

Nie Heng had to introduce himself again, "I'm Nie Heng. Last year, I mentioned with Boss Qin that I wanted to buy the recipe from Eating Savory Restaurant."

Qin Mian remembered. He handed Lei Tie the bamboo tube and cupped his hands in greeting as he said, "It turns out to be Nie-gongzi. I was impolite."

Lei Tie gave him a nod [as greeting].

"Boss Qin and Boss Lei are great men who are apt to have short memories." Nie Heng faintly smiled, "Nie remembers that Boss Qin once said you intended to sell the recipe after the New Year. Nie comes today for this matter. I wonder if Boss Qin and Boss Lei can take the time to talk in detail?"

Qin Mian went to the secluded place nearby, "Nie-gongzi, let's talk here."

"This..." Nie Heng looked at the noisy environment.

Qin Mian went straight to the topic, "There's nothing to discuss this matter, I'll say it directly. There are eighteen ingredients in our seasoning but I plan to sell with sixteen of them. If Nie-gongzi is interested, give me 500 silver taels and I'll write the recipe immediately. "

Nie Heng was taken aback. He thought it would take a lot of talks to persuade the other party to sell the recipe.

"Why are there only sixteen?"

"The seventeenth ingredient is very difficult to find. Even if I tell you, you won't know what it is," said Qin Mian.

Nie Heng did not believe it. “Oh? What is it?”

Qin Mian said bluntly, “Sichuan pepper; a kind of small black fruit.”

Nie Heng, who had never heard of it, believed he did not deliberately deceive.

Qin Mian said directly, “To be honest with you, we plan to grow this ingredient on a large scale next year. I can see that Nie-gongzi is an excellent businessman. If there is a need in the future, we’ll be happy to cooperate with you.”

Nie Heng looked at him with strange eyes. He had underestimated this youngster. While discussing business with him, the youngster did not forget to pull another business.

Instead of declaring his position immediately, he asked, “So, what about the eighteenth ingredient? Since both ingredients are so rare, the flavor of the seasoning will be very different from that of expensive restaurants without the two ingredients.” Nie Heng was worthy of being a businessman; he hit the nail on the head².

Without batting an eyelid, Qin Mian shook his head as he said, “These words of Nie-gongzi are wrong. If so, why should we use so many ingredients in our soup? Why not only use the last two ingredients?”

What Qin Mian said was also reasonable. Nie Heng was speechless for a moment and meditated in silence.

Qin Mian did not urge him. “Recently, some people can’t hold back looking for trouble with our restaurant. We’re weak and vulnerable, we can’t withstand any trouble. So we can’t continue to hold on to the seasoning. When the wine house is ready, we’ll release the news about selling the recipe. If you want to buy it now, you only need to spend 500 taels. We’ll sell 20 copies only. Nie-gongzi can think about it carefully. You must know, the later you buy, the less advantage you have.”

Nie Heng's face changed slightly and he frowned, "Isn't it inappropriate for Boss Qin to do this? I thought you meant to sell it for 500 taels to me alone. If everyone has this recipe, what's the difference between everyone who doesn't have it and the one who has?"

Qin Mian retorted, "Do you know the monthly net income of our small restaurant? Not less than 200 taels. Nie-gongzi doesn't look like a small businessman. As far as I know, the big wine houses in the county town make at least 1000 taels a month. If they have our seasoning, it can increase at least five times. Even if Nie-gongzi only made a profit in the first month after buying the recipe, you could still earn 5000 taels. Isn't it worth spending 500 taels? Nie-gongzi thinks about it slowly, don't be in a hurry. We've something else to do. Excuse us first."

With that, he left with Lei Tie.

Nie Heng calmly looked at their backs. As a profiteer, he involuntarily scolded them in his heart, "Profiteers."

"Gongzi, they're too bullying," said Chunsheng, unable to hold back.

Nie Heng shook his head. In fact, it was worth spending 500 taels to buy this recipe. The reason for this was more than what the little boss said. That little boss was very smart. What he could see, perhaps the little boss could see it too. It was hard to bargain with him.

"Chunsheng."

Chunsheng sighed silently and ran to Qin Mian. It was the first time he saw his gongzi at a disadvantageous position while discussing business.

"Well, think of it as making friends." Nie Heng talked to himself, which also served as self-consolation. His expression returned to normal as he watched Qin Mian and Lei Tie walk over together.

Nie Heng motioned Chunsheng to give Qin Mian 500 taels and pointedly said, "I just hope that the progress of your wine house will be slower."

Qin Mian received the silver banknote and responded to him with “hehe”. He handed the silver banknote to Lei Tie for inspection.

Lei Tie looked at the silver banknote, nodded, and returned it to him.

Nie Heng watched it with the tail of his eye. His heart knew these two people were very likely a genuine married couple.

Qin Mian put the silver banknote away and asked, “Do you have a writing brush and paper?”

Nie Heng said, “Yes.”

Chunsheng took out the four treasures of the study in the carriage without waiting for an order.

Qin Mian was not very good at writing with a brush. He handed the brush to Lei Tie.

Chunsheng then bent over to act as a table.

Nie Heng cautiously guarded against other people approaching.

Qin Mian said and Lei Tie wrote, “One tangerine peel, two cinnamons, one fennel...”

Nie Heng’s eyes flashed. There were many spices and herbs among them! No wonder the chef he brought last time could not taste all the ingredients in the soup.

Qin Mian explained in detail, “If the tangerine peel is 1 Jin, the cinnamon is 2 Jin... In short, the proportion is not changeable, otherwise, the taste will be different. Hm... Seeing that Nie-gongzi didn’t use any ill-conceived means to deal with us after leaving Running Water Town, I’ll reveal two more recipes to Nie-gongzi.”

Nie Heng felt slightly comforted, “Then, many thanks. I believe that the gift given by Boss Qin must have its special features.” He intended to goad Qin Mian to prevent him from writing the recipes of ordinary dishes.

Lei Tie looked at him faintly.

Qin Mian glanced at Nie Heng with a forced smile. *Gauge the heart of a gentleman with one's mean measure. If I indeed intended to deceive you, why do I bother mentioning to give you the recipes?*

“A-Tie, you write. The first dish is chicken with pungent aromatic sauce. Fry sesame until yellow and grind into coarse flour... The second dish is stewed pork meatballs with crab meat. Wash the scallion and ginger, wrap it with gauze, and squeeze out the water of scallion and ginger for reserve...”

Nie Heng stayed calm and collected but his eyes turned more and more bright. These two dishes were really special. These two novel dishes alone could attract many customers to his wine house. This time, he sincerely thanked, “Many thanks, Boss Qin and Boss Lei.”

“No need, no need. Happy cooperation.” Qin Mian smiled happily.

After Lei Tie finished, he handed the papers to Nie Heng.

“We’re busy. Excuse us.” Lei Tie pulled Qin Mian away.

The first thing Nie Heng noticed was Lei Tie’s writing. He was surprised. Such a confident and wanton style of writing did not come from the hands of a peasant.

He blew dry the ink, folded the papers, and carefully tucked them into his bosom.

“Chunsheng, go back.”

When Chunsheng drove the carriage on its way, he spoke, “Gongzi, I have a question.”

“Ask.” Nie Heng was in a pretty good mood. He was in the mood to chat with his personal manservant.

Shoutout Corner: Thank you, TurquoiseSquid! ♡ ~ ღ(๑ᵀᵂᵂᵀᵂ๑)ღ ~ ♡

Note:

Footnotes

1. He who takes charge knows the responsibility.
2. pierce [get] to the truth with a single pertinent remark

Chapter 086: Double Xiang House

086 – Double Xiang House

Brought to you by TurquoiseSquid ε=(♡~д~♡。)

Chunsheng said, “Don’t you think Boss Qin and Boss Lei are stupid? If they can’t find a suitable place to open a wine house in town, why don’t they go to the county town? How many customers can such a small town have? Why do they spend so much effort in building a wine house in the town? This little one can’t understand.”

Nie Heng leaned relaxedly on the carriage and pondered, “This is indeed strange. Their hometown is in a village in Running Water Town. Maybe they just don’t want to be too far away from home.”

Did Qin Mian consider things in such a simple way? For the time being, it was unknown.

One and a half months later, the wine house was completed and only left the detailing aspect of the design to be completed.

Qin Mian released the news that he was going to sell the recipe and indicated that he would only sell 20 copies. Upon hearing the news, the owners of the wine houses from nearby towns and even the county town with strong finance came over. The earliest twenty owners respectively spent 500 silver taels to buy the recipe containing sixteen kinds of ingredients.

Qin Mian made 10,500 silver taels just by selling recipes.

Afterward, the busy farming season came as scheduled. Qin Mian’s land was small, and there were three servants in the family. It took only three

days to harvest, thresh, dry, and put the wheat into the warehouse.

Taking advantage of this opportunity, Qin Mian bought 10 mu of the highest quality farmland in the village. They were all connected. Culturing paddy seedlings and transplanting paddy seedlings were left to Xile, Uncle Fu, and Aunt Fu to handle. He and Lei Tie were still inseparable from the work at the wine house.

On the 20th of the 5th lunar month, the wine house was completed. Qin Mian named it Double Xiang House, which was written by Lei Tie himself and made into a plaque. The word “Xiang[飨]” meant both “a feast to entertain guests” and “enjoyment[Xiang享]”. This name could be described as ingenious.

Speaking of which, Running Water Town was named such because there was a river passing through the town. The new wine house was situated at the edge of Running Water Town and precisely stood across the river. One building on the river surface was a wine house named Binzhi. The other building on the east of the river was an inn named Rugui¹. Semicircular walls were built outside the two buildings with the river bank as the baseline and the river as the central axis, creating bilateral symmetry. The two baselines were connected by an arch bridge in the middle over the river. The arch bridge was built very high to prevent someone from invading Double Xiang House from here.

The two buildings had three floors. The second and third floors were connected by a suspension bridge. Qin Mian deliberately left only one entrance of Double Xiang House, which was the courtyard gate of the Binzhi Building. In other words, if one wanted to go to the Rugui Building, one could only enter from the Binzhi Building.

The first floor, which was the lobby of the Binzhi Building, was divided into two parts. On the left was an ordinary dining place that included two-person seats, four-person seats, and eight-person seats, as well as rectangular dining tables with square benches for individual customers. On the right was a strange-looking dining platform, which was the distinguishing feature of Double Xiang House – a revolving buffet. It was inspired by the revolving belt sushi (restaurant). On the second floor, there

were twelve private rooms with different calligraphy and paintings that had different poems on them. The third floor was the honored guest lounge with only four rooms in total, that not only one could view the scenery but there were also interesting recreational facilities. On top of the third floor, there was a rooftop with a big parasol erected. This place was only used to entertain a group of guests at a time. It was a unique and unmatched place.

Behind the Binzhi Building, there were four elegant places. The four pavilions could also be used for banquets. They were separated from each other by rockeries, brambles, flowering shrubs, and grape trellis. People could breathe fresh air and enjoy the beautiful scenery at the same time. It also gave people a pleasant feeling of enjoying private space.

The first floor of the Rugui Building was the ordinary guest rooms that were divided into single rooms and double rooms, with complete furniture. The second floor housed four luxurious suites that could accommodate multiple family members and friends. Each suite had its unique furnishings with calligraphy and paintings. There were four honored guest rooms on the third floor, three of which were open to the public. The other room was privately owned by Qin Mian and Lei Tie which could be reached by the private stairs on the second floor to avoid meeting the guests on the third floor. There was a large bathtub on the rooftop. In the spring and autumn season, it was a special enjoyment to soak in a hot bath and bask in the sun while drinking wine.

There was a small side door in the backyard of the Rugui Building, which was only for the use of internal staff to transport garbage, purchase ingredients and firewood, and so on.

There were also gardens, fruit trees, stables, and staff quarters that did not need to be described in detail.

On the 27th of the 5th lunar month, the wine house was fully equipped with staff. In such a large wine house, it was impossible for Qin Mian to personally be the cook. He had to hand over the recipes to the chef in batches. Four chefs were recruited by Lei Tie from the faraway Qingtian Prefecture and all of them signed the irrevocable title deed. Four female workers in their forties were responsible for the processing of ingredients

and the cleaning of the kitchen. Eight waiters, two gardeners, eight cleaners, four purchasers, two stable keepers, and eight self-training usable staff signed the irrevocable title deed before they could be employed with ease. The wine house was a little big, so Qin Mian also provided the manager with an assistant for him to order around.

By the way, because Zheng Liu, Wang Shun, Chen Si, and Shi Tou in Eating Savory Restaurant were more experienced, Qin Mian transferred them to the wine house to be the waiters and sent four new staff to the restaurant. Eating Savory Restaurant was rented for only one year and would close down when it was due.

Qin Mian had never done business in his previous life. Large wine houses were not as easy to manage as small restaurants. If there were any unsatisfactory areas, he could only adjust it later.

Before the wine house opened, Qin Mian first held a staff meeting. He implemented a strict reward and punishment system and a reporting system.

The four chefs were a group and a team leader was selected. The four female workers were a group and a team leader was also selected. The eight waiters were a group that was responsible for entertaining guests.....the eight home guards were a group. The manager was directly in charge of the purchasers.

The monthly salary of the team leader was 25% higher than that of the team members, meant as an encouragement. However, the position of the team leader was not fixed. If the work was not well done, the position would be removed, and another capable person would occupy it.

All staff could supervise each other. If a staff was found to have failed work, the other staff could report it to the report box anonymously. If it was verified, rewards would be given according to the level of merit. Those who made mistakes would be given oral criticism for the first time, fined for the second time, and dismissed for the third time. If they made a big mistake, they would be dismissed directly, and those with serious circumstances would be sent to prison.

As soon as such strict and meticulous regulations were issued, all the staff inwardly quivered. They felt awe for this seemingly insignificant little boss and secretly determined that they must not be careless in the future.

Qin Mian tempered justice with mercy, “Besides, all staff has a holiday on every 1st, 11th, and 21st of the month. Because the wine house can’t suspend operation, we’ll carry out holiday rotation system...”

“What? There are holidays every month?” Everyone was overjoyed. They had never heard of this!

“Be quiet. Listen to me first.” Qin Mian raised his hand as a signal, “For the four chefs, only one person can take a day off at a time, and the same goes for the four female workers... As for the eight waiters, two people can take a day off each time... The manager also has a day off. The big boss and I will temporarily take the place of the manager.”

“Many thanks, big boss and little boss.” Sun Maosheng, the manager of the wine house, said gratefully, “It’s my honor to follow the two masters.”

“When the wine house is really busy, if you are willing to give up your holiday and stay in the wine house to help, you can get twice the pay for overtime. For example, the monthly payment of the manager is 200 Wen. On average, it is about 7 Wen a day. In that case, you can get 14 Wen for an extra day’s work. If you give up your three holidays, you can get 42 Wen more every month.”

Everyone’s face grew happier and happier. Never underestimate this 42 Wen. It was enough to buy salt for a few months.

“A-Tie, do you want to add something?” Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie on his left.

Lei Tie finished the tea in the cup. His pair of sharp eyes ran slowly across everyone’s face. He said plainly, “Loyalty is the most important when working for us. If someone divulges the secret of the wine house...”

With a crack, the cup in his hand turned into a heap of fragments.

Everyone was shocked. They stood still and did not dare to move. They did not even dare to breathe.

Qin Mian smiled at them with an approachable smile, and said gently and honestly, “As long as you don’t make a mistake, nothing will happen, right? Alright, I’ve said everything I have to say. You can get familiar with the wine house’s environment in these two days. It’ll be very busy when it opens on the 30th of the 5th month.”

“Yes!”

“Manager Sun, I’ll leave it to you.” Qin Mian looked at Sun Maosheng.

Sun Maosheng cupped his hands and said, “Don’t worry, little boss.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie rode home on horseback. Xile was cleaning the stable. When he saw the two masters coming back, he trotted to meet them and pulled the horse. There was a weird smile on his face.

“Little Young Master, there is a fight at the old house today.”

Despite Xile suppressing his excitement, Qin Mian could still hear it in his voice. Although Xile talked a lot, he had a very tight mouth. He never talked about the farm residence outside. So after discovering that Xile’s inquisitive hobby, he kept one eye closed. He was interested in what Xile said and immediately asked, “What’s happened?”

Xile spoke clearly, “The second-gongzi told Old Madam Du that he wanted to send Lei Dabao to the school for enlightenment. Old Madam Du thought it was a bit early and refused. The second-gongzi was unwilling and took his wife to make a lot of noise² in front of the old madam and the old master. The third-gongzi then took the opportunity to mention the separation and the fourth-gongzi followed along. Old Madam Du was very upset. While Madam Wei instigated disharmony, the second-gongzi and his wife followed to create a disturbance. Old Madam Du was driven beyond the limits of forbearance and slapped the second-gongzi’s wife.”

Qin Mian asked, “What happened afterward?”

“They had made trouble for nearly an hour and were suppressed by the old master. Lei Dabao’s enlightenment fell through and the separation didn’t happen.” Xile said neatly. He had long noticed that his masters and the few people in the old house were not getting along, so he paid special attention to the movement there.

“En.” Qin Mian was very satisfied with the news he got and gave Xile some money.

“Many thanks, Little Young Master.” Xile accepted the money happily.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie walked on the wooden bridge.

“A-Tie, if they split up, is it good or bad for us?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei Tie said spot on, “Split or not, Du Shi and Wei Shi will not split.”

Qin Mian said happily, “Exactly. So, let them make trouble.”

“Awoo awoo—” White Spot ran out of the woods. Its body stood upright and its two forepaws clung onto the front of Qin Mian’s chest as it rubbed him with its head.

Qin Mian patted its head. It put its forepaws down obediently and ran around Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Two men and a wolf went around the orchard. The fruits were grown very good; big and juicy. Some of the peaches had already turned red and would mature in a few days. The cherries were already mature. The red cherries hung in the branches were like agate. Qin Mian and Lei Tie tasted it fresh. It was very sweet.

Upon hearing the movement, Uncle Fang took a wary glance at White Spot. White Spot had grown up. When it landed on all fours, its height was higher than that of an adult man’s knee, which made it quite a difference from that of dog kind. The villagers now knew that White Spot was not a dog but a wolf and they usually stayed away from it. Uncle Fang was no exception.

He looked at the cherry trees in front of him and reminded them, “Lei Tie and Lei Tie’s wife, the cherries here should be picked, or it will go bad.”

Qin Mian looked at the trees full of agate. A sense of achievement rose in his chest, “It’s time to pick. We’re going to use these cherries for cherry jam and cherry wine. But, we’re going to be very busy these days. I’ll think about how to arrange it first.”

“Cherry jam and cherry wine?” Uncle Fang strangely asked, “What is a cherry jam? Cherries can even be made into wine?”

Qin Mian only smiled and did not answer, “Uncle Fang has been working very hard recently. I’ll give you some to taste when it’s ready.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. The names bīn zhì rú guī mean guests feel at home (in a hotel, guest house, etc)
2. argue

Chapter 087: Advertising in Qingyun Academy

087 – Advertising in Qingyun Academy

“Well then, this old man won’t stand on ceremony.” Uncle Fang cheerfully laughed, “It’s noon, I should go home.”

After Uncle Fang left, Qin Mian said, “A-Tie, let’s pick some cherries and I’ll make cherry juice and cherry jam for you to taste.”

“I’ll take the basket.”

Lei Tie directly flew over to leave. His back looked confident and at ease without losing its might.

Qin Mian murmured jealously, “Acting so cool. Right, White Spot?”

“Awoo,” White Spot cried out as it looked at him, very much like in agreement.

Qin Mian could not help but squat down and rub its head.

Lei Tie soon showed up with a basket.

Qin Mian held the basket while Lei Tie was responsible for picking cherries. No pesticide was sprayed on the fruit trees. Qin Mian picked a cherry and casually rubbed it on his clothes. After he dug out the pit, he was ready to eat it but was stopped by Lei Tie. Lei Tie took out a handkerchief from his bosom and carefully wiped Qin Mian’s hands. Then he picked a cherry again and handed it to Qin Mian.

“You touched White Spot just now.”

“Woo?” White Spot’s ears drooped as it raised its head and looked at him with drooping eyelids.

Qin Mian laughed heartily and directly said, “It seems to despise you.”

Lei Tie’s insipid eyes swept over White Spot.

White Pot’s ears erected again before it turned around in the other direction acting as if nothing had happened.

This made Qin Mian laughed again.

After they picked half a basket of cherries, they went home.

Making cherry juice was simple: washed the cherries clean, removed the stems and pits, and put into the manual juicer. This juicer was invented by Qin Mian, which was similar to the noodle maker.

It was not difficult to make cherry jam. Similarly, washed the cherries, removed the stems and pits, cut into pieces, and put into a pot with water. Stirred and cooked with medium heat until the juice came out before turning the heat low when it was soft and mushy. Added sugar and cooked until it thickened. It tasted sweet and not oily, with excellent texture.

Qin Mian filled two small bowls and handed one to Lei Tie, “We should also build an icehouse. If we can keep summer fruit juice, jam, and canned fruit for winter, they will surely sell at a good price.”

Lei Tie shook his head, “Take it slowly, or it will be offensively conspicuous. We aren’t short of money.”

“That’s true.” When Qin Mian was reminded like that, he realized that he was indeed advancing in rush. He said, “Listen to you.”

Lei Tie took him into his embrace, “Wife, I have an idea. When the wine house is on the right track, buy a group of youngsters, and teach them kung

fu. After one or two years of training, they will be able to take on an important task. At least, they can protect our home and business.”

Qin Mian believed what he said was right, so he went closer and kissed him on the lips. He said, “Only you can think of that. I’m afraid that our business will grow bigger and bigger in the future. We really need to train our own people.”

Lei Tie’s lips still had the sweetness of the cherry jam that he couldn’t help but stick the tip of his tongue in.

Lei Tie locked Qin Mian’s arms and body with his arms and put him on the back of the settee, deepening the kiss.

Men were not only aggressive, but they also wanted to take control. Qin Mian was in a completely suppressed position. Unaccustomed to it, he struggled and tried to suppress Lei Tie. In return, Lei Tie made a stronger attack, sucking the tip of his tongue until it numb. He could only give up the struggle. However, his lips and tongue hadn’t admitted defeat and fought back, unwilling to be outdone.

Until the last trace of sweetness in their mouths disappeared, the two parted while panting. Qin Mian noticed that Lei Tie’s lips were swollen. He looked away, feeling a little embarrassed, and bumped into a pair of dark and deep eyes. His chest felt tickled. He raised his head to get near and kissed the man’s eyebrows.

Lei Tie wiped the saliva on the corner of his wife’s mouth with his sleeve before slowly moving away and pulled at his robe as a disguise.

Qin Mian jumped up from the settee, his back to Lei Tie, and he made similar movements, “Cough... I’ll get the rest of the cherry jam. Tomorrow, we’ll go to the academy to see Fifth Brother and give him some by the way.”

Lei Tie suddenly raised his head, “Looking for him? What for?”

What's with the big reaction? Qin Mian was stunned before he realized and said amusingly, "Of course, it's to publicize our wine house. What else?"

He went into the kitchen, knowing that the man would follow him. He took out a clean bamboo tube from the cupboard, carefully scooped up the cherry jam, filled it up, and put the bamboo tube into the space. It was easy to be spoiled if left outside in this hot weather.

Then, he put the rest of the cherry jam into a bowl.

"I have thought about this. How about listening to my idea..."

The next morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie made 20 jars of cherry wine. When the time was almost up, they took a lunch box, a basket of cherries, and a stack of leaflets and rode on horseback to Zhaoyang County.

One person would always be left behind in the Leisurely Farm Residence to watch over it. After Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu went to the farmland, Xile locked the gate, moved a stool, and took a bamboo pole to drive away birds from the cherry trees. Suddenly, someone knocked at the door.

Instead of opening the door rashly, Xile called out, "Who is it? Our masters aren't at home. If you need anything, come back another day."

"Xile, it's me. Why don't you open the door?"

Outside the door came the arrogant voice of Du Shi.

Xile sneered and said politely, "It turns out to be the old madam. Our Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master aren't at home."

"Xile, it's like this. I'm going back to my mother's house today. I want to go in and pick a few Jin of cherries for my mother to taste. Open the door quickly." Du Shi called out. Upon seeing a few villagers standing not far away watching with a lively expression, she flew into a rage out of humiliation.

"Old madam, our young masters just left for a short time. If you're in a hurry, there's still time to catch up. This little one has something else to do,

I'm going first." As soon as Xile finished saying, he ran away.

"Xile! Xile!" Du Shi called out several times outside the door, but no one responded. She was so angry that she smacked the gate hard. The gate didn't open but her hand hurt instead. She cursed and left angrily.

The few villagers whispered among themselves.

"Ah, thinking of how cruel Du Shi was to the Lei's eldest son before, now she regretted it, right? Unfortunately, there is no regret medicine in this world."

"Yeah." Another villager said with crossed arm, "Lei Daqiang too. A few days ago, he wanted to go in and pick cherries, but he didn't succeed."

"I think the Lei Tie's couple make a clear difference between what one likes and what one hates. They remember whoever is good to them. At that time they split from the family, Zhang Dashuan, Grandpa Jiang, and Uncle Zhao stretched out their hands. A few days ago, the young couple gave each of them a basket of cherry, which was at least 5 to 6 Jin! I even tasted some. It's sweet!"

.....

White Spot ran no slower than the two horses, like a galloping black arrow. After entering the county town, Qin Mian and Lei Tie slowed down and went to Qingyun Academy.

The passers-by on the street all stared at White Spot curiously. A few people recognized that it was actually a wolf and the frightened passers-by hastened up to their pace.

White Spot raised its eyes, glanced at them arrogantly, and followed Qin Mian's brown horse. The two horses' courage had been raised, so they weren't afraid of it. It was because they had drunk the spiritual spring water.

The academy was quiet before the class finished in the morning.

Qin Mian went to the old man who was sitting at the gate of the courtyard.

“Uncle, we’re here to find someone. Can we go in?” Qin Mian grabbed a handful of cherries from the basket and handed it to him, “These cherries are homegrown. It’s not sour at all. Would you like to taste?”

“Oh, many thanks! Your cherries are really big.” The uncle happily accepted the cherries and asked, “Who are you looking for?”

Qin Mian replied, “We’re looking for Lei Xiangzhi, the new student in the academy this year.”

The old uncle went inside with cherries in his hand and came out empty-handed. “Usually, no visitor is allowed into the academy. I’ll take you in. The horses can also go in and tie to the tree over there. It’s safe.”

“Thanks for the trouble, uncle.”

The old uncle led them in and took them directly to the lecture hall where the freshmen were taking classes. He pointed to the other side and said softly, “The class hasn’t finished yet. You can wait here.”

Qin Mian said thanks and went with Lei Tie into the pavilion to take a rest. From the open window, he could see the rows of students in the lecture hall.

White Spot lay obediently at the side.

Bu Qingyun sat at the same table with Lei Xiangzhi in the position that faced the window. The breakfast had already been digested, so he was hungry and looked out of the window, feeling bored stiff. His eyes then lit up. He poked Lei Xiangzhi with his finger and whispered, “Brother Lei, look, isn’t that your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law?”

Lei Xiangzhi was pulled out of the world of books. Upon seeing Qin Mian and Lei Tie, he was surprised and nodded.

When Bu Qingyun saw that the teacher on the dais didn’t notice the movement here, he lowered his voice excitedly as he said, “I see they’re carrying a food box. Could they be sending you delicious food?”

Lei Xiangzhi was a little speechless. *Even if they send me food, what does it have to do with you?*

“*Dang dang dang—*”

Three rings of bell rung and the teacher picked up the book, “Class is finished.”

Lei Xiangzhi put the books and the four treasures of the study into the book chest under Bu Qingyun’s urging voice and quickly trotted to the pavilion.

Huo Sirui curiously walked over, “Xiang Zhi, where are you going?”

“Sirui,” Lei Xiangzhi said, “my eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are here.”

Qu Zongwen had sharp eyes. He rolled his eyes and went to catch up. Wang Shangwen and Zhao Tianhe met him and also hung behind him. They all went to the academy from the local school in the town, so they were very close.

Thereupon, Lei Xiangzhi brought a group of people into the pavilion.

“Eldest brother, eldest sister-in-law.”

Bu Qingwen and the others made a bow with hands folded in front, “Greetings, Eldest Brother Lei and Eldest Sister-in-law Lei.”

The few people’s eyes were staring at the red cherries in the basket. Qin Mian was so amused.

Lei Tie pushed the food box to Lei Xiangzhi, “Lunch for you.”

“Many thanks, eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law.” With a smile on his face, Lei Xiangzhi sat down on the stone bench next to him. As soon as he opened the food box, a delicious aroma wafted out. He put the food on the stone table and found out that there was more than one dish. He felt very moved.

Qu Zongwen and the others stared at the steaming twice-cooked pork, red-cooked fish, minced eggplant, scrambled egg with tomato, and fried tofu, as well as a large bowl of white rice.

The amount of the few dishes was quite a lot. Lei Xiangzhi said to them, “I can’t eat so many dishes by myself. If you don’t mind, go to the dining hall and buy some rice to eat together.”

“Many thanks, Brother Lei.”

Qu Zongwen and the others were about 16 to 17 years old. They still had a little bit of a child’s temperament. They all laughed and ran while outdoing one another.

Chapter 088: Grand Opening

088 – Grand Opening

The dining hall of the academy sold meat and vegetable dishes but the taste was very ordinary. Huo Sirui, Qu Zongwen, and Bu Qingyun could not get used to certain food. However, the dishes sent by Qin Mian were all full of flavors and much better than those from the academy's dining hall with just a look. Zhao Tianhe and Wang Shangwen were from a family with an average financial situation; they could buy three to four good dishes a month. Hence, it led to the present scene. The monthly expense that Lei Daqiang and Du Shi gave to Lei Xiangzhi was not small, but he was a diligent and thrifty man, and seldom bought meat dishes.

“The new wine house must have been very busy. How can Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law have the time to come and see me?” Lei Xiangzhi asked. It had been two months since he entered the academy and this was the first time that Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to see him.

Qin Mian said, “Besides visiting you, we're here today to ask for your help regarding the wine house. I'll talk about it later.”

Just as they chatted a few words, Qu Zongwen and the others came quickly with bowls of rice. The students passing by looked at them curiously.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood up to give their seats but Qu Zongwen and the others quickly refused.

“How could that be proper?”

Qin Mian unconcernedly chuckled, “It's more than proper for you all to sit and eat. A-Tie and I have one more thing to trouble you all with.”

“What’s it? You two are Xiangzhi’s eldest brother and sister-in-law. Therefore, you two are also our eldest brother and sister-in-law.” This was said by a new face.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, this is my new friend, Huo Sirui. He’s the first top scorer of this year’s prefectural examination.”

Huo Sirui and Lei Xiangzhi were the same age. He had the temperament of a gongzi from an influential family, yet not at all haughty but refined and courteous, “Greetings, Eldest Brother Lei. Eldest Sister-in-law Lei.”

Qin Mian nodded, “Nice to meet you, Huo-gongzi. You all eat first, and we’ll talk after that.”

Everybody looked at each other, “This... Won’t you two have to wait a long time?”

Before Lei Xiangzhi opened his mouth, the few others no longer refused and sit down to eat.

“There’s a cherry jam in it. It can’t be kept for a long time.” Qin Mian handed the bamboo tube to Lei Xiangzhi.

While they ate, Qin Mian and Lei Tie wandered around not too far away. After a while, the two came back when Lei Xiangzhi and the others had finished the meal. The plates were also properly put in the food box.

Lei Xiangzhi and Bu Qingyun rose to their feet to give up their seats to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian took out a folded piece of paper from his sleeve pocket. “It’s about this matter. Our new wine house, Double Xiang House, will be opened on the 30th. It happens that the 30th and the 31st are days off for Qingyun Academy. We’re going to take this opportunity to hold small talent competitions in Double Xiang House such as poetry, painting, and calligraphy. In each competition, the top three places will be awarded 12 taels, 5 taels, and 2 taels respectively. Firstly, it’s to publicize our wine

house; secondly, it's to create an opportunity for self-reliance for some talented but poor students. The excellent poetry, calligraphy, and painting will also be hung in the wine house to help make a name for them."

Huo Sirui clapped his hands and praised, "It's a good idea. Maybe I can persuade my father to be a judge."

Qin Mian asked, "May I know who your father is?"

Bu Qingyun said, "Sirui's father is the dean of our academy."

Qin Mian was noncommittal, "It would be a great honor to invite Dean Huo. However, the original intention of this competition is to attract customers; more or less mixed up with philistinism. I'm afraid it'll be hard to attract your father's favor."

Huo Sirui shook his head and said with a smile, "Eldest Sister-in-law Lei must have thought that my father should be a scholarly, superior, even... Hehe, pedantic and outmoded person. He's actually not. I'm sure my father will be interested in it."

Qin Mian said joyfully, "If you can indeed invite your father, we'll send you 20 Jin of every kind of fruit in our orchard this year."

Lei Xiangzhi smiled at Huo Sirui as he said, "You've tasted the cherry just now. Isn't it good? The fruits in my eldest brother's orchard are excellent, plump, and sweet."

"Alright, it's a deal," Huo Sirui confidently said.

Qin Mian continued, "Also, all the students participating in the competition can have a free meal in this wine house."

Wang Shangwen said in shock, "Like this, your wine house will inevitably lose a lot."

Qin Mian smiled faintly, "I haven't finished yet. To avoid people coming to eat and drink freely, or even pretending to be a student, only the intellectual

who can make a poem on the spot can participate in the competition and have the opportunity to eat and drink for free.”

Lei Xiangzhi and Qu Zongwen both nodded slightly.

Huo Sirui looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with admiration. He didn’t know who came up with such a method.

“The details are in this flyer.” Qin Mian handed the leaflet to Lei Xiangzhi. “What we want to trouble Fifth Brother and everyone to do is to help us publicize this in the academy. If interested, can also come to participate. If I remember correctly, the college examination is in the 10th lunar month. This will be good a warm-up for you all, right?”

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, “Yes. You can count on us now, Eldest Sister-in-law.”

Qin Mian took out another piece of paper. “This is our menu. You are welcome to bring your relatives and friends to dine in. 30% discount will be given on the first three days of opening.”

When Qu Zongwen and the others saw that there were many dishes on the menu that they had never heard of, they secretly drooled and decided to take their relatives and friends to dine.

Qin Mian stood up. “Your next class is very soon, right? We won’t delay your study. A-Tie and I have to go to other places to distribute leaflets. We’ll take our leave.”

“Please.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie left Qingyun Academy with White Spot. Instead of handing out leaflets in person, Qin Mian and Lei Tie found four 12-year-old children who were playing at the entrance of an alley. They distributed 200 leaflets to the four of them and asked them to give it to the owners or shop assistants on the roadside stalls. They paid the children a deposit of 10 Wen and gave another 40 Wen each after all the leaflets were distributed.

The people who got the leaflet looked at it curiously. In addition to the introduction of Double Xiang House's wine house and inn, special dishes, preferential activities, talent competitions, and other contents, there was a striking line of reminder at the foot of the leaflet: Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant belong to the same family. In such a sentence, people who knew of Eating Savory Restaurant could draw a strong conclusion that the food of Double Xiang House would not be bad.

When they returned from the county and passed through Running Water Town, Qin Mian bought six large vats and asked people to transport them back.

Back at home, he and Lei Tie hired four flexible young men and four quick-witted women to work in the orchard. The men climbed up the herringbone ladder to pick cherries, while the women washed and removed the stems and pits of the cherries. Removing the pits was easy with a stab of the chopstick.

Out of the six cherry trees, three were picked for the time being. When settling the wages for the villagers, Qin Mian gave each of them half a Jin of cherries.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie steeped three vats of cherry wine and squeezed half a vat of cherry juice with the picked cherries. The cherries had yet been completely used up. Qin Mian made cherry jam and filled it into two basins for Double Xiang House's opening.

After dark, Qin Mian transferred the few large vats to the space to keep fresh.

On the 30th of the 5th lunar month; the opening day.

As soon as the auspicious time arrived, firecrackers crackled continuously. Qin Mian and Lei Tie uncovered the red cloth on the plaque together, revealing the three elegant and confident gold [word] characters of "Double Xiang House".

Guests that had heard the news flocked to the entrance. Some people in the scholar's robes but didn't have the scholar's temperament cried out, "I want to compete!"

Lei Xiangzhi blocked at the entrance and smilingly said, "You may. However, please compose a poem with the "spring" theme. The qualified one will get a little red flower to be eligible for the competitions and enjoy free food and drink. I'm not a talented person, only the second top scorer in the current prefectural examination."

As soon as the last word came out, some people who wanted to sneak in to eat and drink freely under the name of competition immediately gave up their plans and mixed into the crowd with shame and disappeared. The second top scorer in the prefectural examination was not easy to fool. Those who were unwilling could only pay out of their own pockets even if they went in. The real scholars lined up to compose poems.

The waiters dressed up in uniform were busy leading other guests in.

"Dear guest, do you want to eat or stay?"

"Eat."

"Alright, please come in." The waiter had a warm and befitted smile on his face, "Do you want to sit in the boisterous lobby or the elegant private room on the second floor, or the comfortable honored guest lounge on the third floor?"

"Just sit in the lobby. It's boisterous."

"Yes, this way, please. Dear guest, this is our menu. The price is clearly stated. What would you like to eat? Sweet, salty, sour, and spicy. There is always something to your taste. If you don't want to read the menu, I can give you the name of the dishes. If you eat in our wine house on the first three days of opening, not only you can get a 30% discount, but you'll also be given a plate of cherry jam dessert."

“Your wine house has a lot of dishes. Well, I’ve no dietary restriction. Please give me three meat dishes, one vegetable dish, and one soup dish.”

“Alright, I’ll serve you right away. You’ll have tea and try our cherry jam dessert. This is unique in the whole county.”

.....

“Dear guest, would you like to eat or stay?”

“Stay.”

“Alright, please follow me. There are three kinds of guest rooms in our Rugui Building. Ordinary affordable rooms are divided into a single room and double room; they are clean and tidy, with complete furniture and exclusive private space. A luxury elegant room has an independent washroom. An honored guest suite is spacious and comfortable and has a variety of interesting entertainment facilities, which most suitable for staying with relatives and friends. Here is the price list. 30% off on the first three days of opening. If you can’t make up your mind, I can show you around the rooms first.”

.....

There were more and more guests in the lobby.

The entrance of Double Xiang House was the liveliest place. The gate was nearly two zhang¹ wide. On the left, Lei Xiangzhi tested the students who came to participate in the competition. On the right, Qin Mian and Lei Tie welcomed the guests who came to dine and stay.

A horse carriage came to a stop. Qu Zongwen jumped out of the carriage and walked quickly to Lei Xiangzhi, “I’ll help you.”

“Thanks for the trouble, Brother Qu,” Lei Xiangzhi gratefully said.

With the help of Qu Zongwen, the scholars were divided into two teams and progress became much faster.

A scholar fluently recited, “The plants all know that spring will soon return, all kinds of red and purple contend in beauty. The poplar blossom and elm seeds are not beautiful, they can only fill the sky with flight like snow².”

“Good poetry!” Lei Xiangzhi praised as he nodded and handed him a red flower, “Brother, please come in.”

There was a lot of excitement here. Over there, Qin Mian welcomed the guests in with a smile while Lei Tie stood a few steps away with four guards to guard against pickpockets making trouble when there were too many people.

Suddenly, a man called out, “Boss Nie of Drunk Immortal House in Zhaoyang County presents a congratulatory gift—eight earthen jars of excellent old wine to wish a thriving business and long-standing!”

Qin Mian looked up and saw that the man who got off the luxury carriage opposite was Nie Heng, dressed in green robes with graceful bearing. He came over slowly, “Boss Lei and Boss Qin, congratulations. May great prosperity attend the opening of the business!”

They all did the catering business. When Nie Heng came back, Qin Mian was not surprised. He just didn’t expect that he would send a congratulatory gift. *Isn’t there a saying that two of a trade can never agree?*

“Many thanks, Boss Nie. It’s an honor to receive you as our guest. I hope Boss Nie can enjoy yourself to the fullest. A-Tie, you accompany Boss Nie to go in.” Qin Mian didn’t trust to hand over the reception to Lei Tie alone.

Lei Tie nodded to Nie Heng, “Boss Nie, this way please.”

Over there, there was a staff to take care of the carriage.

The waiter respectfully asked, “Dare to ask Boss Nie comes to eat or stay?”

Nie Heng smilingly said, “I’ll stay for one night.”

Light flashed past in Lei Tie’s eyes.

“May I know if Boss Nie wants a luxury room on the second floor or an honored guest suite on the third floor?”

Nie Heng said without hesitation, “Honored guest room.”

“Alright. I’ll check you in.”

Outside, Qin Mian continued to greet the guests while smiling until his face ached slightly.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 2 zhang is 6.6 m
2. Late Spring by Han Yu

Chapter 089: Why Is There No Martial Arts Competition

089 – Why Is There No Martial Arts Competition

Huo Sirui came over with two middle-aged men.

“Boss Qin.”

The middle-aged man walking at the front was dressed up as a scholar. He looked half alike Huo Sirui with a big belly, a kind face, and a smile like Maitreya Buddha. The other middle-aged man was older, dressed in a grey scholar robe and a black turban. He looked thin and cultured, with wisdom in his eyes.

Huo Sirui said to the man who looked like Maitreya Buddha, “Father, this is one of the owners of Double Xiang House, Boss Qin. Boss Qin, this is my father. Respectful name is Yongcheng.”

Dean Huo that Qin Mian imagined was completely different. He didn’t cover up the astonishment in his eyes properly but quickly adjusted his expression and went forward to greet him, “This junior greets Dean Huo.”

If Huo Yongcheng could become the dean of an academy, he must have a reputation. However, Huo Sirui didn’t introduce him as such. It was probably the meaning of Huo Yongcheng not wanting to oppress others with his fame.

Dean Huo saw the surprise in Qin Mian’s eyes, but he gave a modest smile and didn’t take it to heart. “Boss Qin doesn’t need to be polite. It is also

beneficial for students to participate in such talent competitions. My contribution is only a matter of lifting a finger.”

Huo Sirui also introduced the other man, “This is Teacher Liu of our academy. Respectful name is Jingxian.”

“Greetings, Teacher Liu,” Qin Mian said as he bowed with hands folded in front.

Teacher Liu said, “I come here without an invitation, Boss Qin doesn’t need to mind me.”

Qin Mian said quickly, “I dare not. My humble wine house is honored by Dean Huo and Teacher Liu’s presence. Gentlemen, please come in!”

He accompanied Dean Huo and Teacher Liu to Binzhi Building.

In the lobby on the first floor, Dean Huo and Teacher Liu saw that the hall was almost full. Some students crowded in front of a wall, praising and commenting on something. The two approached curiously. When their eyes fell on the poems on the wall, they could not help but take a close look.

“Spring. Up to your crown, O’willow, dressed in the green of jades; myriads of twigs so verdant, droop like your silken braids. Who knows who the tailor is, who’s cut your leaves so fine? It’s the vernal winds past February, sharp as the scissors’ blades¹. Good poem!”

After Teacher Liu finished reciting, some people excitedly praised.

Dean Huo didn’t expect to see such quatrains in the wine house. He nodded with approval and amazement in his eyes.

The two didn’t communicate with each other. They looked at the other three poems.

“Summer. Summer day lengthens under the shady green trees, the pond reflects pavilions and terraces. Crystal-bead curtains flicker with the rise of a breeze, full arches of climbing roses fill the garden with fragrance².”

“Autumn. Over green hills a limpid brook flows, sky mirrored in the water of autumn hue. Away from the distant earthly world, maple leaves and velvet clouds leisurely float³.”

“Winter. Not a bird in a thousand hills, not a soul on ten thousand trails. An old man on a raft in straw quilts, fishes alone with snowy chills⁴.”

After reading, Huo Sirui eagerly asked, “Boss Qin, who are these four poems from? None of these four poems are continuous. Those who can make these poems must have great talents!”

These words were also what Dean Huo and Teacher Liu wanted to say, but Huo Sirui took the lead. Both of them looked at Qin Mian with bright eyes.

Qin Mian laughed and said, “It was when A-Tie went out that he overheard what people said. He thought it was pretty good, so he wrote it down.”

“Oh?”

The three of them were disappointed with this answer. However, there was nothing they could do.

“Dean Huo, Teacher Liu, and Huo-gongzi, please come here.” Qin Mian took them to a square table for four people.

Soon, the waiter offered them excellent tea, a dish of cherry jam dessert, a glass bottle of cherry juice that looked more attractive through the translucent glass, and four glass cups matched with the glass bottle. There was also a delicate fruit basket made of thin bamboo branches with the content of fresh cherries embellished with water beads, gleaming, and appealing.

“Please enjoy it slowly,” The waiter bowed down respectfully and retreated.

Huo Sirui sat with Dean Huo and Teacher Liu for a while and ate some snacks and fruits. Then he sat with his schoolmates.

As soon as the time of the competition arrived, the guests in the wine house were all quiet. The reason why they came here today besides dining was to watch the talent competitions.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood beside Dean Huo. Qin Mian cupped his hand in front of the other and said, “Everyone, I’m Qin Mian and this is Lei Tie. We are the owners of Double Xiang House. Welcome everyone to Double Xiang House. I hope everyone has a good time eating and staying. The talent competition will begin soon. Before that, I’ll introduce two distinguished guests, Dean Huo and Teacher Liu of Qingyun Academy.”

Dean Huo and Teacher Liu cupped their hands in obeisance to the crowd.

Qin Mian continued, “These two are the judges of the talent competition. Therefore, all contestants need not worry about any unfairness in the competition.”

Everyone nodded. People from Zhaoyang County knew that Dean Huo was not only the Dean of Qingyun Academy but even a Jinshi⁵ who had been filial for 20 years. His character, talent, and reputation were trustworthy.

Qin Mian nodded as a signal to Manager Sun.

Manager Sun walked to the middle of the hall. He said with a smile on his face: “I’m Sun Maosheng, the manager of Double Xiang House. Many thanks to everyone for your support. The talent competition will start—”

“Wait!” A tall and strong scholar suddenly stood up. Based on his white student robe, he was also a student of Qingyun Academy.

There was a sudden silence in the hall as everyone’s eyes fell on him.

When Qin Mian noticed that there was no red flower in his hands or body, his eyes sunk. Did someone want to kick a fuss even before it begins?

Lei Tie pressed his shoulder and the calm look in Lei Tie’s eyes soon calmed him down. *Right, even if this person wants to make trouble, A-Tie is here. What is there to be afraid of?*

Dean Huo asked Huo Sirui in a low voice, "Is he also a student of our academy? Do you know him?"

Huo Sirui nodded with an odd expression, "I know. He... He is probably the student with the biggest appetite in our academy." Up to now, he still remembered that time when he went to the dining hall to eat, he saw five empty bowls piled on the table in front of Bao Xu, who even had an empty bowl in his hand.

"Oh? Hehe." Dean Huo stroked his beard as he laughed strangely.

Lei Xiangzhi recognized the scholar and hurriedly walked over to him. He said mildly, "Junior Bao if you have any questions, it would be well to wait until the competition is over."

"No," Bao Xu urgently said, "it'd be too late to talk about it after the competition. I want to say, the competition is all about literary art. Why is there no martial art? I also have talent. I know kung fu!"

It turned out to be the same thing. Qin Mian said, "This matter is indeed our negligence."

His calmness was well received by the guests present.

Bao Xu had slightly chubby cheeks that when he smiled, he looked very simple and honest. He asked happily, "Can I take part in the competition?"

Qin Mian raised his hand to hint at him not to be impatient. He raised his voice and asked, "Do any other students want to take part in the martial arts competition?"

Two more scholars stood up.

Bu Qingyun was overjoyed and spoke to Wang Shangwen, "This is good. Even if those three aren't good at kung fu, they can be ranked one, two, or three."

Beside him, Wang Shangwen was dumbfounded and said, "Lower your voice."

Qin Mian said to himself, *this is easy to deal with*. He said with a smile, “Because there are too few people taking part in the martial arts competition, the three of you will compete with me after the literary art competition. If all three of you win against me, you can continue the competition to determine the number one, two, and three. If defeated, you are unqualified to participate in the ranking. What do the three of you think?”

“Ah?” Qu Zongwen asked Lei Xiangzhi in surprise, “Does your sister-in-law know kung fu?”

Lei Xiangzhi was also surprised, “I don’t know. Must be taught by my eldest brother.”

The guests were all excited. They didn’t expect to have a meal and see a wonderful competition. Great Xia Dynasty had always put mental training above physical training⁶. Thus, few people knew martial arts.

Bao Xu agreed without hesitation and naively said, “Boss Qin, look at your small body... The cherry jam here is delicious—I’m not going to be merciful.”

The corner of Qin Mian’s mouth twitched, but his face remained calm and his lips were smiling. With an enigmatic posture of an expert from beyond the mundane world, Qin Mian said leisurely, “Let’s talk about it when you beat me.”

This expression subdued Bao Xu. His expression became serious as he clenched his fists.

Li Shan and Zhou Hai, two other scholars, also came.

Manager Sun then went on with his previous remarks, “The first competition is to compose poems with the theme of “eating” or all kinds of food. Any food material, dish, wine, or fruit can be used. The brush, ink, paper, and inkstone are ready. Please write down your poems. Time given is a lit incense stick⁷.”

Dean Huo looked thoughtfully at Qin Mian and Lei Tie. To promote the wine house, the two owners truly spared no effort.

Lei Xiangzhi briefly pondered before wielding the brush to write.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood in an inconspicuous corner and seamlessly looked at all the people in the hall. They were not surprised to see a few familiar faces—the people who had bought the recipe. Their purpose was obvious.

“Wife, are you going to compete with them?” Lei Tie asked.

With a smile, Qin Mian said in a low voice, “You want to compete with them? Isn’t it as easy as flipping a hand for you to win against them?”

Lei Tie’s face was expressionless, but a little smile appeared in his eyes.

Qin Mian could see it clearly and stifled a laugh. *Does this guy also like to hear praises?*

A whisper came out Lei Tie’s mouth, “I only like to listen to your praises.”

Qin Mian’s eyes were full of laughter as he continued to say formally, “Anyway, there are only three of them. Even if the rank is arranged, it is only a matter of a few silver taels. It’s all for fun.”

Nie Heng, Qu Zongwen, Huo Sirui, and the others all looked at the two people who whispered to each other. It could be seen that their feelings were extremely good.

“Nie Heng has reserved the honored guest room. The young man and the manservant who followed him have respectively reserved the luxury room and the ordinary room,” Lei Tie said.

Qin Mian uncaringly said, “No mishap [will happen]. There’s nothing shady about Double Xiang House, so just let them see. The uniqueness of our wine house lies in the soul, not in these external forms.”

His wife’s proud appearance was so dazzling. Lei Tie held his hand quietly.

Note:

Footnotes

1. An Ode to The Willow by He Zhizhang (Tang poet) translated by Andrew W.F. Wong
2. A Summer Day at a Pavillion in the Mountains by Gao Pian (Tang Poet) translated by Crystal Tai.
3. Autumn Moon by Cheng Hao translated by Xiao-zhen
4. Snow on the River by Liu Zhongyuan (Tang Poet) translated by Ying Sun
5. lit. “advanced scholar”, a graduate who passed the triennial court exam.
6. emphasize civil administration at the expense of national defense.
7. Depends on the length, between 15 to 30 minutes

Chapter 090: Amaze the World with A Single Brilliant Feat

090 – Amaze the World with A Single Brilliant Feat¹

After a stick of incense burnt, the scholars stopped writing one after another. Dean Huo and Teacher Liu asked them to recite their poems in turn.

“One can eat a meal without meat, but cannot live without bamboo. Without meat makes people thin, without bamboo makes people vulgar²,” the first contestant recited his poem confidently.

The crowd roared with laughter.

“Hahaha...”

Dean Huo and Teacher Liu shook their heads. A few of the guests who knew a little poetry and lyrics also shook their heads.

Teacher Liu simply commented, “This poem can be recited smoothly, but it is a pity that it has lost the ‘elegance’ of the ‘poem’.”

Contrarily, Qin Mian thought that this poem was very good and suitable for hanging in the wine house. Therefore, he gave the scholar a favorable smile and decided to talk to him after the contest.

The second scholar recited, “How flavorful is your golden-hued Zhaoyang wine! You fill my cup of jade in amber, it will glow. It’s enough if you can make me drunk, host mine; no more nostalgia in your house shall I know³.”

“Good!” Dean Huo nodded approvingly, “The language of the entire poem has a wonderful meaning, like drinking wine and enjoying spring breeze. It’s a masterpiece.”

Dean Huo and Teacher Liu commented very quickly, and the poetry contest ended soon. The first, second, and third winners were Huo Sirui, Wang Shangwen, and another poor junior.

Lei Xiangzhi’s poem was very good too, but unfortunately, he didn’t make it to the top three. However, he was second in calligraphy and chess contests.

.....

The last literary arts competition was guqin. Huo Sirui’s song was amazing and he easily won first place. Dean Huo couldn’t stop smiling.

After the literary arts competition, Qin Mian asked people to hang several excellent poems. Then, he took out the brand-new silver ingots that had been prepared in advance. He let Dean Huo and Teacher Liu serve as the awarding guests to give the prize money to the students who won the competition.

The students who didn’t get the rank were not disappointed. They still could enjoy free food and drink.

“Boss Qin, it’s time for martial arts competition!” Bao Xu shouted, afraid that Qin Mian might forget.

Qin Mian said, “Let’s go outside to compete. This way, please.”

The open space in front of the building was large enough for people to compete in martial arts. All the guests followed them outside to watch.

Qin Mian and Bao Xu, Li Shan, and Zhou Hai were surrounded in the middle.

“Who comes first?” Qin Mian asked as he loosened his wrists.

Bao Xu stepped out with chest held high, “I’ll come first.”

Qin Mian nodded, “Alright, please.”

Lei Xiangzhi walked to Lei Tie and asked worriedly, “Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law will be alright?” Bao Xu was tall and strong. He was not only a head taller than Qin Mian, but his body was also at least as thick as two Qin Mian. Furthermore, it was not fat but solid flesh on his body that made him appear like a young calf.

Lei Tie remained silent.

Dean Huo reminded, “The time is up to you two.”

Bao Xu nodded vigorously, “Don’t worry, Dean Huo. Whoever can throw the other on the ground will be the winner. What do you think, Boss Qin? ”

Qin Mian gave him a silent glance. *Are you the sponsor or am I the sponsor?*

“Sure.”

“Competition begins,” Teacher Liu said.

Bao Xu rushed to Qin Mian. His right hand clenched into a fist and swung at Qin Mian. His big fist was like a hammer. Qin Mian nimbly slipped and leaned sideways to dodge. Then, his right palm attacked Bao Xu’s lower rib.

Experts could see from this fight that both of them were good.

Bao Xu was a little surprised. With a loud shout, he sped up his attack. Every gesture and motion were heavy and powerful. Qin Mian’s advantage lay in his flexible body. He dodged and skillfully made a move at the same time. Bao Xu was a real kung fu expert. His movements were not slow. It was Qin Mian who ‘cheated’. The spiritual spring water improved his dynamic vision. His eyes keenly caught the angle and direction of Bao Xu’s moves to prevent them in time.

Neither of them could get the upper hand for a while, and the crowd cheered from time to time.

After more than 50 moves, Qin Mian discovered that he was at a disadvantage. After all, he lacked the experience of fighting with others. He soon revealed a flaw and was caught by Bao Xu. Bao Xu buckled his right arm. Remembering that he had to throw the other party to the ground to win, he pushed Qin Mian to the ground.

Everyone couldn't help but cry out in alarm.

Seeing that Qin Mian was about to land on his face, a dark shadow flashed by. Lei Tie put his arm around Qin Mian's waist in time. He lifted him and helped him to stand firm.

"Wife?" Lei Tie checked him up and down.

"I'm fine," Qin Mian gently raised the corners of his lips.

"Hey, you are so loathsome! Why did you push our Little Young Master to the ground after winning?" Xile pointed to Bao Xu as he said in dissatisfaction.

Bao Xu scratched his head and helplessly said, "I... I didn't mean to."

"It's fine, Xile," Qin Mian waved his hand, unconcerned. "Bao-gongzi should not have intended it. Congratulations, Bao-gongzi. "

Bao Xu said gladly, "Hah-hah, you let me win!"

Qin Mian looked at Li Shan and Zhou Hai.

"Which of you will come first?"

Li Shan went first and was defeated in less than 20 moves; Zhou Hai was slightly better and was subdued by Qin Mian after 32 moves.

Bao Xu easily got the first place.

Bu Qingyun muttered, “Alas, fortune *indeed* favors fools.”

“Hah-hah,” Qu Zongwen laughed. “Alright, let’s go and eat.”

Bu Qingyun immediately became spirited, “Right, let’s go!”

Everyone went back to the lobby and continued to eat and drink. Soon, the lobby became lively. Bao Xu sat at a table alone and ordered six dishes at one go, “Two more bowls of rice.”

The waiter reminded him, “Dear guest if you can’t finish eating, you will be fined.”

“I know.” Bao Xu patted his chest, “I’m just afraid I don’t have enough to eat. Don’t worry, if I can’t finish eating, you can fine me!”

The waiter wiped his sweat and cheerfully said yes.

Upon seeing Qin Mian coming, Bao Xu writhed uneasily on his chair. “Boss Qin, you said that I can eat and drink for free.”

Qin Mian chuckled. “I came here to say that as long as you don’t waste food, you can eat at ease.”

“Many thanks, Boss Qin!” Then and there, Bao Xu had a good impression on him.

“Enjoy it slowly.” Qin Mian looked around and found the scholar who wrote the poem “without meat makes people thin”.

“Gongzi, the poem you wrote can arouse people’s appetite as soon as they read it. Our wine house is very interested in it. I wonder if you would like to sell the poem to us? We’ll hang it in the wine house.”

The student was pleasantly surprised and frankly said, “Of course. It’s just that you don’t have to buy it. If possible, can Boss Qin give me some cherry jam? My brother and sister will love it.”

“No problem,” Qin Mian said with a smile. “I’ll give you a jar of cherry jam in a moment. I wonder if you mind adding your name to the poem?”

“I don’t mind.” This scholar was open-minded, “Even if the writing is not good, I wrote it. Perhaps I can be well-known with it hanging in your wine house? Hah-hah!”

Qin Mian came to Dean Huo’s table again.

“Are you satisfied with our service, Dean Huo and Teacher Liu? If you need anything, you can always call the waiter.”

Dean Huo put down his chopsticks and laughed heartily, “The food of Double Xiang House is mouth-watering and leaves a rich aftertaste. No dissatisfaction, Boss Qin. One of my life’s interests is fine food. I’ve been to all the wine houses in Zhaoyang County, but I enjoyed the food here the most.”

Teacher Liu also nodded, “It is so. No wonder Boss Qin dare to open the wine house in this small town.”

Qin Mian modestly said, “Dean Huo and Teacher Liu over-praised. You two, be sure enjoy to your heart’s content.”

After half a day, he was also tired. He told Manager Sun to send the fruit baskets prepared for Dean Huo and Teacher Liu when they were leaving. Then, he went into the lounge on the first floor to have a rest.

Lei Tie came back after he inspected Rugui Building. When he did not see his wife, he directly came to the lounge and saw his wife lying on the settee. He went over to massage his wife’s arms and legs.

Qin Mian raised his leg and put it on his lap. He said, “A-Tie, looking at today’s situation, our grand opening sales is a great success. Although there will be some losses, after those excellent writings are spread out, the reputation of Double Xiang House will be more prominent. We don’t have to worry about customers in the future.”

“En.” Lei Tie said, “When Manager Sun can take charge, my wife doesn’t have to work as hard as today.”

“That’d be great.” Qin Mian languidly said, “Everything is difficult at the beginning. After that, it will be easy.”

Lei Tie put his big palm on Qin Mian’s eyes, “Sleep for a while. I’ll call you up if there’s anything.”

In the honored guest suite of the Rugui Building, Nie Heng sat on the settee in the sitting room and looked around with a complex expression.

The honored guest suite, Qin Mian made it according to the apocalypse’s design of three-room-two-hall-one-bathroom: three bedrooms, one sitting room, one entertainment room, and one bathroom.

In the three bedrooms, there were wide and soft double beds, brand-new and exquisite wardrobes, comfortable and warm settees, smooth and flat ground with soft rugs on the floor, all of which made of fine materials.

Exquisite paintings were hung on the wall. Although the painting style was strange, it gave people a very comfortable feeling. The most worth mentioning was the tall window with an abundance of illumination. It had a wide view to gaze into the distant scenery that caused one’s heart untroubled and spirit pleased⁴.

The sitting room also had a spread of the same rug that gave people the impulse to lie down. A whole set of settees was arranged in a circular shape. Besides a tea set, there was also a flower vase, fresh cherries, and peaches on the tea table in the middle.

The arrangement of the entertainment room was following the principle of pleasing the eye. Pai gow⁵, dice, Go chess, seven-stringed guqin, and other recreational items that all one could think of was on hand.

The bathroom was equally special. Although it was not advanced to the degree of automatic flushing, after using the chamber pot, the chamber pot would slowly drop down with a press of the button on the side. After a short

while, a clean chamber pot would come up. Also, the guest could take a hot bath in a big tub. Two cylindrical objects stood side by side in the corner: one filled with cold water and the other filled with hot water. The hollow cylinder filled with hot water went all the way to the first floor. There was a boiler room that boiled water 24 hours a day on the first floor. When the guest wanted to take a bath, it was sufficient to put hot water first and then add cold water. Not only that, but there was also a faint sweet scent floated in the washroom.

Besides these “hardware”, the honored guest suite also had on-call service. On the wall of the sitting room, there were three different colored tags to pull: red tag for tea, cake, and fruit; blue tag for food; yellow tag for other services. The staff on the first floor would go upstairs immediately to serve the honored guest.

The sound of knocking on the door awakened Nie Heng from his deep thought.

“Come in.”

Nie Qing and Chunsheng pushed open the door. Upon seeing the smooth and clean ground, they did not dare to step forward for a moment.

“Not coming in?” The depression in Nie Heng’s heart dissipated because of their funny reaction.

Nie Qing and Chunsheng came into the room and saluted Nie Heng first, “Greetings, gongzi.”

Nie Heng relaxed on the settee, “You two look around first.”

Nie Qing and Chunsheng walked around the room, sighing to themselves while looking. After looking around, they returned to the sitting room.

“How?” Nie Heng asked.

Nie Qing said, “The luxury suite on the second floor is roughly the same as this room gongzi lives in. However, the floor is covered with wood, no rug.

The furniture and decoration are chosen and arranged very attentively, but not as luxurious and dignified as this room. Of course, it is much better than the upper room in an ordinary inn. Besides, the bathroom in the luxury suite is relatively simple. If you want to take a bath, you have to ask people to send the water.”

Chunsheng said, “Gongzi, the ordinary room isn’t bad. It’s divided into a single room and a double room. The single room is a single bed and the double room is a double bed. The furniture inside is new and each room has a set of calligraphy and painting. There is no wide bed⁶.”

Nie Heng was silent for a long time before he said, “Double Xiang House will amaze the world with a single brilliant feat.”

Nie Qing and Chunsheng dared not say anything. The lodging environment of the Rugui Building was second. The dishes of Binzhi Building were new and odd with great smell, taste, and look. People who loved to eat would certainly not miss such a good place. By contrast, the remote location had become secondary.

Nie Heng stood up, “Let’s go down to take a stroll.”

T/N: A translated Chinese poem never could live up to its original beauty/rhythm.

Trivia: the author described the honored guest suite in a paragraph of 455 words. Of course, I split it afterward. T_T

Note:

Footnotes

1. (idiom) an overnight celebrity
2. In Wuqian, Visit a Buddhist Monk’s Green Bamboo Pavilion by Su Dongpo (Tang Poet) translated by Larry Elder.
3. For My Host by Li Bai translated by hjenglish. It’s Lanling instead of Zhaoyang in the original poem.
4. (idiom) carefree and relaxed

5. gambling game played with dominoes
6. It is just one wide bed for several people and the cheapest communal bed without privacy.

Chapter 091: Deliver Cherries

091 – Deliver Cherries

From the suspension bridge to the third floor of Binzhi Building, and then from the third floor to the lobby on the first floor, Nie Heng saw that there were several more calligraphy and paintings on the wall. It was the work that won the prize in today's talent competition. Under the calligraphy and painting, the words like 'a certain someone from Qingyun Academy was in Double Xiang House on a certain day, a certain month and a year' were added.

“Look, gongzi.” Chunsheng pointed to a painting and calligraphy on the wall facing the front door of the lobby.

Nìng kě jū wú zhú [I'd rather live without bamboo]

Bù kě shí wú ròu. [But cannot eat without meat]

Wú zhú lìng rén sù [Without bamboo, people are brusque (vulgar)]

Wú ròu lìng rén shòu. [Without meat, people are reed (thin)]¹

Nie Heng smiled with admiration on his face. It was unknown whether he admired the person who wrote the poem or the person who hung the poem. Then, he briskly walked to the garden.

After dark, when the last diner left, Qin Mian summoned all the staff to the lounge for a meeting. He looked at the tired faces of the staff and motioned for Xile to pour tea for them.

Everyone was overwhelmed by the superior's favor.

After making sure that their attention was back on him, Qin Mian said, “Everyone has been working hard today, especially the chefs and waiters. There are too many guests today, so you are the busiest. However, our Double Xiang House is situated in a small nameless remote town with few local customers. This is a fact. After the three days of discount, there may not be as many customers as today. The big boss and I are not going to hire more chefs and staff for the moment. Let’s wait and see the situation first. The four chefs and all the waiters will have to work hard for another two days. So are the others. But everyone’s hard work has paid off. The big boss and I have discussed and decided that today, everyone will be rewarded with 50 Wen as encouragement.”

Everyone was all overjoyed and said, “Many thanks, Big Boss and Little Boss!”

Qin Mian smilingly added, “We also decided to set up three awards, namely: the best smile award, the most diligent award, and the most thoughtful service award.”

“Little Young Master, what are the best smile award, the most diligent award, and the most thoughtful service award?” Xile ‘butt in’.

Qin Mian explained, “The best smile award is to smile with enthusiasm when entertaining the customers. The person with the most favorite smile will receive the best smile award, which will be evaluated once a month, and be awarded 50 Wen. The most diligent award, as the name suggests, is the award for the most diligent staff, which is also rewarded with 50 Wen. For example, if a cleaner always cleans the floor and cleans the table in time, he will get the most diligent award.

As the most thoughtful service award, whether it’s a waiter or a cleaner or even a gardener, they should greet the customers warmly when they need help. For example, when a gardener is pruning flowers and trees in the garden, a guest asks you “where is the stable?”, you have to tell him the location of the stable in detail. If you take him to the stable in person or even find a stableman for him, it can be said the most thoughtful service.”

His explanation was so easy to comprehend that everyone showed a look of understanding.

Qin Mian said, “If you understand it, I’ll let people make a detailed list of rewards and punishments tomorrow. If you receive a reward, you’ll be marked a little red flower; if you make a mistake, you’ll be marked a little black flower. By the end of the year, Double Xiang House will select two best employees. Whoever gets the most red flowers and the least black flowers will get a huge bonus.”

The staff was in high spirits and their faces were beaming with joy.

Qin Mian didn’t want to say too much in case they couldn’t digest it for a while.

“For now, things will stay that way. After Manager Sun gave out today’s reward, everyone can go to have dinner. Have a good rest after dinner. It’ll be busy tomorrow.”

Everyone was high spirits and shouted, “Yes!”

In the morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie worked out in the back garden dressed in their white kung fu garment. After running, Lei Tie practiced boxing regularly, while Qin Mian, who had many workouts, did push-ups first.

Lei Tie was absent-minded. His eyes always drifted to his wife’s butt which fluctuated along his body. Through the drooping lapel, Lei Tie could see his smooth chest.

“Wife, what kind of training is this?” Lei Tie asked while his movements continued. Although his mind was not at peace, his boxing was still calm and powerful.

“Huu... huu...” Qin Mian gasped for breath, looked at him with some pride, and said, “Don’t you understand? This way can toughen the waist and abdomen muscle. Especially pectoral muscle!”

Lei Tie was deep in thought, “Hm... the waist should be toughened up nicely.”

“What do you say?” Qin Mian didn’t hear clearly.

“Nothing.” Lei Tie continued practicing boxing.

Qin Mian did leapfrog after 20 push-ups. Currently, his body was still developing so he didn’t dare to do too many leapfrogs. He only did 20 times each.

Nie Heng took his manservants through the back garden. When he saw Qin Mian jump forward like a frog, he didn’t know what kind of appropriate expression to put on.

“Nie-gongzi. How did you sleep last night?” Qin Mian nodded his head in greeting and asked as he finished the frog leaping training.

Nie Heng told the truth, “Very good. It’s truly worth 20 silver taels for a night. It’s comfortable, quiet, and fragrant.”

“That’s good.” With a faint smile, Qin Mian stood up after jumping.

Lei Tie handed him a face towel and continued practicing boxing as if he didn’t know there was a third person present.

Nie Heng knew Lei Tie’s character and didn’t care about his impoliteness. He said to Qin Mian, “Boss Qin, I’m here especially to bid farewell. I hope we will have opportunities to cooperate in the future.”

Qin Mian accepted his offer and smilingly said, “It’s a great honor. However, Nie-gongzi may regret missing the breakfast only provided for residents and internal staff.” Double Xiang House only served lunch, dinner, and light refreshments.

“Oh?” Nie Heng raised an eyebrow, “Then, I must go to taste the breakfast of your wine house. I’m leaving first.”

“We shall meet again someday. Take care, we won’t send you off.”

After Nie Heng walked far away, Qin Mian continued to practice arm hanging and hanging upside down that was bound to lengthen his height. Since the New Year, he grew about two to three centimeters tall, which he thought was related to his persistence in morning workouts.

The staff working on the second and third floors shook their heads when they saw the scene in the garden through the window, and thought that their little boss was really strange.

“Wife, it’s enough.” Lei Tie was worried that Qin Mian would hurt himself if he trained for a long time, so he reminded after a half stick of incense burnt.

Qin Mian was hung upside down without moving. He gave a smile to Lei Tie, “A little bit more.”

Lei Tie held him down directly, “Go back to take a bath and have breakfast. Eat more to grow tall.”

“All right, all right.” Qin Mian forgot for a moment that the people on the second and third floors could see here. He leaned on Lei Tie’s shoulder and kissed him on his face. “If I can’t grow taller than you, I’ll press you so much every day until you’re short.”

Lei Tie was unsatisfied with his *tiny sip*. He hugged him and gave him a deep kiss.

They wore only a thin kung fu garment. When they clung to each other, the doubled body temperature scalded the other’s blood.

Lei Tie’s breath was hot. He whispered to Qin Mian’s lips with a hoarse voice, “Wife, I want—”

“Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. Breakfast is ready.” Xile came running forthrightly.

Lei Tie let go of Qin Mian and looked at Xile without expression.

Xile was shocked. He peeked at the little young master, unable to make any sense of the matter. *What's going on?*

Qin Mian stifled a laugh and did not speak.

“Xile, if you are too idle, stay here today and tomorrow.” As soon as Lei Tie finished saying, he motioned Qin Mian to leave together.

Xile suddenly realized something and wanted so much to slap himself. He followed them with a sullen face while scolding himself in his heart: *don't you know that the two masters are in a good relationship? If you disturb the masters' alone time, you deserve to be left in the wine house. Maybe you will miss the cherry-picking.*

As Qin Mian expected, on the fourth day of opening, the net income of Double Xiang House decreased by 30% compared with the first three days.

Qin Mian was not disappointed with this result. He could predict that after about ten to fifteen days when those excellent poems and paintings were eulogized everywhere, the business of Double Xiang House would enter a new climax.

When Manager Sun had taken charge, Qin Mian and Lei Tie returned to Green Mountain Village with Xile.

As soon as they entered the gate, they were surrounded by the fragrance of flowers and fruits. Xile silently rejoiced. He liked to stay in Leisurely Farm Residence. The two young masters were good and the orchard was also good. He could sleep in the fragrance of fruit every day. It seemed that even his dream was sweet.

Qin Mian jumped off his horse and hurried to the cherry grove. “A-Tie, we haven't been home for several days. The rest of the cherries are probably over-ripe.”

Uncle Fu said, “Little Young Master, don't worry. Except for a few drops, most of them are still fine.”

Lei Tie ordered, "Go find the previously hired people to come over."

"Yes." Uncle Fu took the order and left.

"Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master, I'm going to bring the ladder." Xile ran fast.

Passing by the wooden arch bridge, Qin Mian observed the honey peach trees by the way. The trees were emerald green and within the slender leaves were nearly round fruits, half-covered in the leaves. Almost each of them weighed half a jin. Its pale green color vaguely suffused with pink and gave off a faint smell of peach pulp.

"The peaches are almost ripe." Lei Tie embraced Qin Mian's shoulder, "Tomorrow, I'm going to Qingtian Prefecture."

Qin Mian hesitated, "I won't go with you." Right now, the orchard was bound to have many people. Moreover, in case there was an emergency in Double Xiang House, it would need people with enough importance to step in.

"En, you stay at home." Lei Tie didn't plan to take Qin Mian. He had too many things to do. Even if Qin Mian went to Qingtian Prefecture, he wouldn't have time to take his wife to play. He would come back as quickly as possible.

After the cherry-picking helpers arrived, they were busy in an orderly way. Since they had experienced it last time, their action had become more skillful.

As before, Qin Mian made most of the cherries into cherry juice, cherry wine, and cherry jam.

The next morning, Lei Tie rode off to Qingtian Prefecture.

After Qin Mian sent him until the entrance of the village, he returned home and took people to deal with the cherries.

"Xile, come over."

Xile put down his chopstick that was used to dig out the cherry pit, shook off the water on his hands, and ran over, “Little Young Master, what can I do for you?”

Qin Mian filled one big basket and two small baskets with cherries. He called Xile to his side, “This big basket is about 20 jin. You send it to Qingyun Academy and give it to Dean Huo. The small basket is sent to Deng’s Village for grandpa and grandma. Also, don’t forget to tell them that they won’t be invited to come because there are many things at home recently and Lei Tie is away. Remember to speak nicely.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. My attempt of trying to make it rhyme somehow

Chapter 092: Wife Said...

092 – Wife Said...

Qin Mian didn't mention who the other small basket was for.

"I understand. Rest assured, Little Young Master." Xile washed his hands in the basin, picked up two baskets, and left quickly.

When the sun was setting, all the cherries were finished. Qin Mian settled the wages for the helpers. After they left, he picked up the remaining basket of cherries and pointed to the three or four jin of cherries specially reserved as he said to Aunt Fu, "Aunt Fu. This is for you, Uncle Fu, and Xile to have."

"Many thanks, Little Young Master." Aunt Fu was used to the little young master's generosity, and her respect for Qin Mian was the same as before.

Qin Mian waved his hand and went out with his basket. Out of the gate of the courtyard, he took a glance at the mountain forest in the distance.

On the evening of early summer, the villagers came out of their homes and gathered in twos and threes to enjoy the cool air and chat while waiting for the dinner to be cooked.

Upon seeing Qin Mian, they all greeted him in a friendly way.

"Lei Tie's wife, where are you going this late?"

Qin Mian said with a smile, "Going to send some cherries to my parents."

"So much." The villagers cheerfully said, "You and your Lei Tie are truly filial to your parents!"

“Hah-hah,” Qin Mian only laughed.

“I heard that your cherries are not only big but also sweet. It’s a pity that you don’t sell them. Otherwise, we’d like to buy some. Hehe, our children talked about it every day a few days ago,” said an aunt regretfully.

Qin Mian said apologetically, “It’s the first time for A-Tie and I planted fruit trees. We didn’t expect that those fruit trees grew better than others, fortunately. That’s why we want to sell them at the wine house and make more money. However, it won’t be the case for next year. Next year, we’ll only keep part of it for cherry juice and cherry jam, and sell the rest. Aunties and uncles can buy them if you want to.”

The few villagers were very delighted.

“Good, that’s a deal.”

Zhao Shi was collecting the laundry in the yard when she saw Qin Mian come in with a basket of cherries. She could care less for the laundry and rushed to welcome him with a face full of smiles. Her tone was cordial, “Eldest Sister-in-law, you are here. It’s heavy, isn’t it? I’ll carry it.”

This basket of cherries weighed at least 8 to 9 Jin. It’s not light. Qin Mian let her grab the basket.

“Father, mother! Eldest Sister-in-law is here!”

Zhao Shi shouted toward the house. She grabbed three to four cherries, put them into her mouth, and called out vaguely, “Dabao, Xiaobao! Where the hell are you?”

Qin Mian shook his head and walked into the central room.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi smiled at Qin Mian when they saw the basket in Zhao Shi’s hand.

Lei Daqiang said, “Eldest’s wife, come in and sit down.”

“Eldest Sister-in-law.” Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao appeared one after another.

Lei Xiangren ran to Zhao Shi’s side and grabbed a bunch of cherries before Du Shi grabbed the basket. He greeted Qin Mian, “Eldest Sister-in-law.”

Qin Mian nodded without a word.

“Father, I want to eat!” Lei Dabao stood on tiptoe and grabbed the cherries from Lei Xiangren’s hand. He didn’t even notice his snivel ran down to his mouth.

Qin Mian quickly averted his eyes. It seemed that his impression of Lei Dabao was someone who always had a running nose.

“Mother. Mother, I want to eat too.” Lei Erbao was too young to reach Lei Xiangren’s hand and so he grabbed Zhao Shi’s dress.

Wei Shi showed a befitting shallow smile to Qin Mian, “Eldest’s wife, thank you for remembering us.”

“As it should be,” Qin Mian said politely.

“It’s sweet,” Lei Daqiang nodded while eating and soon spat out a few pits.

Du Shi first grabbed some and put them on a plate. Everyone knew that this was what she wanted to leave to Lei Xiangzhi.

“These are not enough for our big family. Eldest’s wife, I’ll go back with you to pick more later,” Du Shi said as she ate.

Qin Mian said, “Mother, the cherries on the tree are all picked and made into cherry juice and cherry jam to be sent to the wine house to sell.”

Lei Daqiang frowned, “You—”

Qin Mian stood up and said, “Father and mother, it’s getting late. I have to go back to cook. I’m leaving.”

Du Shi snorted and said nothing as she looked at the cherry's portion.

When she didn't see the shadow of Qian Shi and Lei Xinxin, she sneered and glanced at Lei Xiangyi coldly, "Since the third daughter-in-law is not feeling well, let her rest. Everyone comes here to eat. This thing can't last long."

Lei Xiangren bit the cherry in his mouth and looked at Lei Xiangyi with gloat.

Lei Xiangyi said nothing. Since he had proposed to separate from the family, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang had been much colder toward him, and even more dissatisfied with Qian Shi. However, he didn't regret it. This was the price for him to separate from the family.

When Qin Mian had walked halfway, he suddenly recalled that he didn't see Qian Shi and Lei Xinxin today. He had some doubts, but he didn't think much about it as he rushed home. He didn't know where Lei Tie was now. It was the first time that he and Lei Tie separated since they were officially together. Although he knew that nothing would happen to Lei Tie, he still worried about him.

Lei Tie, who was a few hundreds of *li*¹ away, passed through a forest. There was a four-cornered ancient pavilion near the edge of the forest and a pond not far away.

The four-cornered pavilion was surrounded by long wooden chairs, and in the middle was a worn-out stone table and four stone benches. The pavilion was quite old. A finger long crack was found on the stone table and a corner was missing at one end of a long wooden chair.

Lei Tie had been on the road continuously and didn't care at all about missing a lodging because he wanted to go early and return soon. He looked up at the western sky filled with sunset glow and stopped his horse before landing on the ground. After leading the horse to drink water, he tied the horse to the tree and walked into the ancient pavilion.

Looking at his new clothes, he couldn't help but touch it. His wife made it for him with a manual sewing machine. The top was a white slanting long robe with the length stopped at the butt, and the sleeves were loose and not tight, giving a cool and cozy feeling. The bottom was a pair of bound-feet trousers of the same color that made his body slenderer. The fabric of the clothes was just an ordinary cotton cloth. The black shallow boots on his feet were also cloth boots, but they fit him well. His wife said that when they went out to have fun, they shouldn't wear too well to avoid being watched by robbers and thieves. Although he was not afraid of thieves and rascals, the fewer complications the better.

This was the first time he wore a white outer garment. He thought that he would not get used to it, but he liked it very much.

His hand then reached to his neck. There was a black rope hanging from his neck. Hanging on the rope was a sheep-fat white jade Guanyin². His wife also bought this for him.

Feeling a little hungry, Lei Tie went to the black horse that was grazing leisurely and took off the pouch on the girdle of the horse's back. Inside the pouch was a bamboo tube as long as a calf, two relatively small and slightly shorter bamboo tubes, a water bag, a small net bag containing six honey peaches, and a wine gourd. They were all placed on the stone bench.

He sat on the stone bench, opened the big bamboo tube, and poured out a pancake which was almost as thick as the palm of his hand. He took a bite and could see several layers of delicious minced meat sandwiched in the pancake. He chewed slowly. When the pancake was finished, he opened one of the small bamboo tubes and appreciatively sipped the thick soup. The scene of Qin Mian packing his bags came to his mind.

Would his wife be in the space at this time?

"Clip-clop clip-clop—" Horse's hooves sounded in the distance. Three fast horses, carrying bulging baggage, drew closer and closer.

On the leading horse, a youngster in his early twenties wearing a duanda garment called out to the others on the two horses, "Eldest Brother, Second

Brother! I know there is a four-cornered pavilion not far ahead! Let's spend the night there tonight!"

Following closely behind him, a rough-faced big man swung his whip with a crisp sound and said in loud voice, "Good! *Jia*—"

The last man was also very young, about 25 or 26 years old. His hair was very long and only a hairband tied in the middle. He squinted and said, "There seems to be someone there."

"Even if there is a person, what are we afraid of?" The youngster said indifferently and urged the horse forward, "The pavilion is not his home."

In a moment, the three horses reached the four-cornered pavilion.

"*Sh*—"

Lei Tie was eating the second piece of pancake and didn't even lift his eyelids.

The three men did not go in immediately upon seeing Lei Tie's indifference and silent appearance that seemed not easy to communicate with.

When the rough-faced big man saw that there were red peaches on the bench, a scallion soup in the small bamboo tube, and also the pancake bitten by the white-clothed man, he couldn't help swallowing his saliva. He whispered to the long-haired man, "Old Two, the man also went out on a trip, but look at how good his rations are. Shall we buy some from him?"

"Drop it." The long-haired man was very helpless and lowered his voice, "Eldest Brother, look at his clothes. Although it's made of cotton, it's well-cut. The style is a novelty and the needlework is fine. The jade Guanyin on his neck is made of sheep-fat white jade. His pancake is also unusual. We've never seen such a pancake since we've traveled all over the country. Lastly, let's look at the honey peaches—the peaches in Qingtian Prefecture are not ripe yet, right? His peaches may have come from the south. It's very expensive. Can ordinary people afford it? I think the man is a wealthy and respectable person. It's better not to make trouble with him."

The youngster also approached them and whispered with suspicion, “Wealthy and respectable person? Unlikely, right? Does a rich person make cups out of bamboo tubes?”

Lei Tie’s eyes fell on the bamboo tube. The bamboo tube was not worth money, but his wife said that the bamboo wares had the functions of eliminating thirst, clearing the lung, and resolving phlegm and diuresis. Using bamboo wares regularly was good for health.

“What do you know?” The long-haired man slapped him on the head. “Bamboo has a medicinal effect. The bamboo wares are good for health. This is called ‘low-key fastidiousness’, understand?”

The rough-faced man touched his stomach in disappointment. “Forget it. I’m hungry too. Old Three, take out the ration quickly.”

The three men tied their horses, went into the pavilion, and sat down on the stone bench opposite Lei Tie.

The youngster fished out a small cloth bag from his baggage and took out a few dried pancakes; one for each.

Three pairs of eyes uncontrollably flew to the meat pancake and the soup in the bamboo tube in Lei Tie’s hands. It smelled too good!

Lei Tie ate the last bite of the pancake and finished the soup. Except for the unopened small bamboo tube, all of his other things were put into the pouch. Then, he took out a rolled bean pancake from the small bamboo tube and went to the black horse to feed it.

The youngster curled his lips. He went closer to the long-haired man’s ear, “Second Brother! I think I understand what is called ‘low-key fastidious’! His horse eats bean pancake that tastes better than our pancakes.”

The long-haired man amusedly said, “Eat yours. Don’t worry about such things when you’re out on a trip. When we arrived at our destination, let Eldest Brother treat you to eat delicious food.”

The rough-faced big man nodded, “That’s a must.”

When Lei Tie turned around after feeding the horse, the three men discovered the scar on his other cheek. They looked away rigidly and were glad they didn’t provoke him just now. A person with such a long scar on his face must have had some dangerous experience.

Lei Tie wiped his hands clean and walked around the pavilion. His wife said that taking a walk after eating could prolong life until ninety-nine.

The three men used their peripheral vision to see Lei Tie walk around the pavilion. Their nerve stretched so tightly. *What is he doing? Is he thinking about which direction to hit them?*

When Lei Tie went on the second lap, he still didn’t look at them. They suddenly realized that he was just taking a walk.

After walking for about half an hour, Lei Tie returned to the four-cornered pavilion. He lay down on the stone bench he had sat in before and closed his eyes. His wife said that keeping early hours made the body double in strength.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 1 li is approx. 500 m
2. the Bodhisattva of Compassion or Goddess of Mercy

Chapter 093: He's Three Brothers

93 – He's Three Brothers

Qin Mian made two servings of fresh and tasty soy sauce noodles with shelled shrimps, crushed peanuts, and a handful of vegetables. He locked the door and held the noodles before he entered the space in high spirits but was disappointed to find that Lei Tie was not there. After waiting for a while, he still didn't show up. Qin Mian had to eat both bowls of noodles and left the space after pouring some water on the pink ball.

In the four-cornered pavilion hundreds of *li* away, there were four people in two groups, where each occupied one side. Lei Tie lay on the stone bench with eyes closed and remained motionless. The rough-faced man, the long-haired man, and the youngster ate their pancakes in silence for fear of disturbing his sleep.

Outside the four-cornered pavilion, four horses quietly nibbled on the green grass and swung their tails from time to time. They looked extremely leisurely and comfortable.

After the sun had set, the western sky left a faint yellow radiance with thick shadows.

“Clip-clop clip-clop—”

Another clatter of horse's hooves came, urgent and speedy.

The long-haired man frowned slightly and whispered to remind the rough-faced man and the youngster, “From the sound, it seems to be a lot of people. Sleep lightly.” When going out on a trip, they might encounter all kinds of dangers. It was very important for them to be vigilant at all times.

The youngster stood up and took two steps forward, looking curiously into the distance.

“*Jia, jia!*” The sound of men urging the horses was reverberating and resounding. In a moment, dozens of fast horses drew near. Everyone on the horseback was tall and big. Except for the leading man, all the others carried machetes.

When the youngster saw the face of the leading man sitting on the horse, his face radically changed. He threw the unfinished pancake on the ground and rushed to his horse. At the same time, he yelled at the rough-faced man and the long-haired man, “Damn it! It’s the Panacea Hall! Let’s go, Eldest Brother, Second Brother!”

The faces of the rough-faced man and the long-haired man abruptly changed. They rushed to their horses without hesitation. However, before they could untie the reins, the people on the horsebacks recognized them and quickly surrounded them with derisive laughter.

The middle-aged man on the horseback looked down contemptuously at the rough-faced big man and the long-haired man, shot a glance at the youngster, and said in a cold voice, “Catch them all for me!”

His followers heeded his order and besieged the rough-faced man and the long-haired man.

The youngster who had first mounted the horse had already dashed out for several *zhang*. Two other followers chased after him.

The rough-faced man and the long-haired man fought back fearlessly. Their skills were not bad. However, they were outnumbered and defeated.

The youngster saw that his eldest brother and second brother were trapped. He roared and galloped back to join the fight.

“Old Three, are you stupid? What are you running back for?” The long-haired man furiously glared at him.

Before he could speak, the youngster received a punch in the chest. The rough-faced big man rushed to help him.

Unfortunately, it was hard to beat the enemies' four hands with two fists. The three brothers were only passively beaten.

"Sir, there's another one sleeping there," an underling reported after seeing Lei Tie.

The rough-faced man hurriedly spoke, "Ma Renjie, don't mess around! That man is not with us!"

Lei Tie opened his eyes and looked at a spider crawling on the beam of the four-cornered pavilion.

The middle-aged man who had not dismounted sneered and disdainfully said, "Beat him together!"

Two underlings laughed as they rushed to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie lay still. Suddenly, he lifted his left leg and swept across them.

The two underlings screamed as they flew out of the four-cornered pavilion and fell heavily on the ground. One of them rolled a few times and happened to stop in front of the black horse.

Seeing the tender grass in front of it was crushed, the black horse looked down at the underling. It puffed out air from its nose, raised its left front hoof, and kicked him.

The poor underling let out a shrill cry and flew out again before lying on the ground, unable to move.

The black horse wagged its tail and continued to graze as if nothing had happened.

The youngster looked at Lei Tie with admiration. *The man has personality, so does his horse!*

Ma Renjie's face turned dark. He said, "What are you stupefied for? Go!"

Immediately, more than half of the underlings charged toward Lei Tie.

Lei Tie sat up. Without his butt leaving the bench, his two fists attacked. Four of the underlings were beaten to the ground, forming a human pyramid.

Two crafty followers quietly crept up behind him.

Lei Tie reached behind him as though he had eyes on behind his back and timely grabbed the two sneaky fists and twisted them at will.

"Arghhh—"

The miserable scream struck the terror into the heart of the listeners.

The remaining three followers put on an attacking posture and stared at Lei Tie warily, but they dared not go forward.

Ma Renjie's face sunk as deep as water. He was aware that he had encountered a hard obstacle today. He didn't dare to court his ruin. He could only stare at Lei Tie with hatred and gritted his teeth as he said, "Pull ___"

As if receiving amnesty, the underlings quickly mounted their horses and fled. The sound of the horse's hooves soon disappeared into the distance.

With a sigh of relief, the three men exchanged a look and walked into the four-cornered pavilion. They bowed with hands folded in the front toward Lei Tie.

"Much thanks for your help, brother!" The rough-faced big man cupped one fist in the other hand as he said, "I'm He Sanzhou¹."

The long-haired man cupped his hands in greeting and said, "I'm He Sihai²."

“I’m called He Wuhu³,” the youngster said lively.

The rough-faced man asked, “May I ask this brother’s name?”

“Lei Tie,” said Lei Tie.

“It’s a Brother Lei. Nice to meet you.” He Sanzhou solemnly said, “That man and we are enemies that cannot live under the same sky. If Brother Lei wasn’t here today, us three brothers would surely die. If there is a chance in the future, we will surely repay Brother Lei’s great favor!”

He Sihai and He Wuhu said in unison, “Please accept our brothers’ worship.”

Lei Tie lightly said, “No need. It’s simply a slight effort.”

He got up and went into the woods.

“Er... Uhm... Is Brother Lei angry?” Sanzhou and Wuhu looked at Sihai together.

Sihai casually said, “Gone to relieve himself.”

Sanzhou said nothing.

Wuhu pulled Sihai as his eyes were glued to the black horse. “Second Brother, Second Brother. Do you think that horse is a rare breed? That horse is very smart. I saw it deal with Ma Renjie’s men just now.”

Sihai half-heartedly glanced at the black horse and said simply, “No. It’s a common local horse.”

Wuhu knew that the so-called “local horse” was a kind of horse that was very common in terms of coat color, body shape, speed, and blood lineage.

“Unlikely, right?” He didn’t believe it. “Second Brother, take a look again. You can see its body shape, its temperament, and especially its coat color. It’s so beautiful, just like it’s wrapped in black silk. How can it be an ordinary horse?”

“I, am, very, sure!” Sihai touched his chin as he carefully looked at the black horse, “It may have been well raised by its owner, so it looks like an outstanding horse.”

Sanzhou helplessly sighed, “You two, your bodies don’t ache? Do you want some medicine?”

“Yes.” Wuhu felt the pain all over his body and rushed to grab the ointment in Sanzhou’s hand.

“Second Brother, we owe a life-saving grace to Brother Lei. What do you think we can do to repay Brother Lei?” Sanzhou asked.

Sihai shook his head, “Wait for an opportunity.”

Lei Tie entered the woods and went far away before he quietly entered the space. He looked around and did not see Qin Mian. Noticing that the soil in the flower bed was wet, he knew that he had missed his wife. He scooped up a ladle of water and watered the pink ball before leaving the space.

The He’s three brothers watched Lei Tie approach. They were about to say something but Lei Tie lay down on the bench and closed his eyes.

The three brothers could only shut up and decided to wait until he woke up.

The whole night passed in silence.

On the first glimmer of dawn and dew, Lei Tie opened his eyes. He jumped on the horse and continued the journey.

The three brothers were still sleeping.

As the sun rose, the long-haired man opened his eyes first and found that the man had disappeared. He quickly woke up Sanzhou and Wuhu.

“Eldest Brother, Third Brother, get up quickly. Brother Lei is gone!”

“What?” Sanzhou sat up and looked around. He was incomparably disappointed, “How can he just go? Uhm... We don’t even know where he

comes from.”

Wuhu regrettably scratched his head, “If I knew it, I would not sleep.”

“Forget it.” Sihai stretched out. “If there is fate, we will meet again.”

.....

Lei Tie galloped all the way and rushed into Qingtian Prefecture before the city gate closed. He stayed in the inn where he lodged last time.

There might be people with high martial arts skills in the inn. If they perceived his breath had disappeared, they would be suspicious. Therefore, although Lei Tie had the opportunity to enter the space, he did not enter.

After dawn, he bought fifty silver-thread meat pancakes and went to the biggest brokerage in Qingtian Prefecture after breakfast. The four chefs of Double Xiang House were bought through this brokerage.

The owner of the brokerage was a very shrewd old man. He still had the impression of the reticent young man who had a scar on his face and warmly invited him into the hall.

“Gongzi, please have tea.” The owner asked, “What kind of people are you going to buy this time? You had come once and presumably know that our brokerage is the largest one in Qingtian Prefecture. There are almost all kinds of people. If you can’t buy the right one here, it’s even more impossible to buy in other brokerages of Qingtian.”

Lei Tie said concisely and comprehensively, “Call out all healthy teenagers with irrevocable title deed about 12 to 14 years old.”

“Yes, just a moment, please.” After the owner instructed a staff, he invited Lei Tie, “Have tea.”

Not a while later, the staff came with more than forty teenagers between 12 to 14 years old lined up in a few rows. Some were tall, short, fat, and thin. The teenagers were looking at Lei Tie nervously, not knowing what this

man was going to do to buy them. But in any case, they were not eligible to refuse.

“Are you satisfied?” The owner asked. “Don’t worry. These children are in good health. If you don’t believe me, you can ask for a doctor to check.”

Lei Tie didn’t pay him any mind. His sharp eyes swept over the teenagers one by one. He asked in a low voice, “What’s the important thing for a servant to have?”

The owner wisely stopped talking.

The teenagers were puzzled and looked at each other. Some were silent, some answered “cleverness”, some answered “obedience”, some answered “competence”, and some answered “loyalty”.

Note:

Footnotes

1. third province
2. fourth sea
3. fifth lake

Chapter 094: Coming Home

094 – Coming Home

Lei Tie kept a total of fourteen people who had answered “loyal”.

“Take the rest with you,” the owner instructed the staff.

Lei Tie stood up and said to fourteen teenagers, “I’ll do a few moves and you’ll follow.”

He demonstrated the first ten moves of a boxing set.

The fourteen teenagers looked at each other as they failed to understand it. A very clean teenager first came up and neatly finished the ten moves. Except for his movements were not too ideal, he hardly made any mistakes. Then, the rest came forward to demonstrate one by one.

Lei Tie kept a total of nine teenagers that was able to remember more than half of the moves and hinted at the owner.

The owner quickly came over, “Nine people, each for 8 silver taels.”

Lei Tie nodded. He took out a 100-tael silver banknote and handed it to the owner.

“Thank you for your patronage.” The owner received the banknote and returned 28 silver taels to him.

Lei Tie took out a 2-tael ingot and threw it at him, “Buy ration for ten people for two days and hire two fast carriages.”

The owner said, “Rest assured, gongzi. We will adequately prepare them for you!”

Lei Tie sat for a short while before the owner said it was done. The two carriages were sturdy two-horse carriages and the coachmen were expert cart-drivers.

Lei Tie told the newly bought nine people to get on the carriages with their belongings. He mounted his horse and led the way in front of them to go out of the city directly.

It was already the snake hour¹. The street was very busy with an endless stream of horses and carriages, and people hurrying to and fro. There was a strong smell of medicinal herbs floating in the sky of Qingtian Prefecture. When Lei Tie overheard the conversation of several passers-by, he knew that there was a large-scale auction of medicinal materials in Qingtian Prefecture these days. All the rare herbs were sold at the auction. Herbal medicine merchants from all over the country came after hearing the news. It was a good thing if one could buy precious medicinal materials to make it as the treasure of the shop.

He Sanzhou, Sihai, and Wuhu led their horses along the stream of people as they looked around and multifariously sighed at the prosperity of Qingtian Prefecture.

Lei Tie glanced at them faintly. With a sway of the reins, the black horse trotted away.

The sky of the sixth lunar month had the face of a child². Less than an hour after departure, the dark clouds gathered in the sky. In a moment, it rained heavily. Although there was a canopy over the heads of the two coachmen sitting on the shaft, the rain still wet their clothes during the galloping of the carriage. They hurriedly took out straw-woven raincoats and put them on.

Lei Tie took out his bamboo hat and rain cape from his pouch on the girdle.

“Boom!” A lightning-struck overhead. The rain turned heavier and rapid, making the vision a little fuzzy.

Old Zhao, the coachman, had wanted to suggest the employer find a place to rest until the rain receded, but upon seeing Lei Tie did not have the slightest mean to stop, he could only continue driving the carriage but with a much slower speed.

Lei Tie turned his head and galloped back to the side of the carriage. "Go as fast as you can. I'm paying 5 taels more."

Old Zhao gritted his teeth and stake it all. Anyway, they often worked, so their bodies were strong and not easily sick. It's worth it if they could earn 7 silver taels for this trip.

"Alright, gongzi can rest assured!"

Lei Tie said the same thing to the other coachman. The speed of the two carriages did not decrease at all as the four horses galloped forward.

In the afternoon, the rain stopped. After resting for an hour, the party continued the journey.

The next afternoon, the party arrived in Zhaoyang County. They didn't expect that it was raining much heavier in Zhaoyang County than that in Qingtian Prefecture. The road was muddy and hard to tread on.

In the county town, Lei Tie let everyone drink a bowl of hot tea in a tea house before going on the road again. The two coachmen looked at each other with bitter smiles and hastily got on the carriages.

In Leisurely Farm Residence, Qin Mian stood at the door of the central room. His left hand held a fruit plate and his right hand held a bamboo stick inserted into the peach picked from the space to eat. Looking at the direction of the gate through the rain curtain hanging from the eaves, he felt uneasy. *Such a heavy rain, that guy Lei Tie won't rush in the rain, right?*

White Spot squatted at his feet. Its two ears sometimes perked and drooped, and its tail swept the ground, swaying left and right. It looked bored to death.

Qin Mian inadvertently saw it, making the corner of his lips curled. He also squatted down and joked, “White Spot, are you truly a wolf?”

White Spot raised its head and opened its mouth wide, “Awoo~”

Qin Mian:

After White Spot finished howling, it turned to look at him.

“Fine, fine, you are a wolf. A wolf.” Qin Mian stood up helplessly, ate the peach unconcernedly, and looked at the direction of the gate.

At this time, White Spot suddenly stood up, turned its head to howl at him, and ran into the rain curtain. It wagged its tail more happily than usual.

Qin Mian’s heartbeat quickened. *Lei Tie is back?*

He put the fruit plate on the windowsill and hurriedly caught up with it.

When passing through the gate, Gray Sheet and Black Vest barked as greeting to Qin Mian. Not receiving a response, they turned around and ran back to their house.

“Where is Little Young Master going? Why doesn’t he even take a parasol?” Aunt Fu worriedly said, “Husband, quickly take the parasol and catch up.”

“Aunt Fu, I’ll go. I’m strong.” Xile took the parasol in Aunt Fu’s hand and ran outside.

Before Qin Mian ran to the entrance of the village, he saw a black horse coming amidst the heavy rain. On the black horse sat the man who had been weighing on his mind. Two carriages followed after him.

“*Neigh—*”

As soon as Lei Tie saw Qin Mian, he frowned. With a press on his horse’s belly, the black horse galloped forward and didn’t stop when it came to Qin Mian. Lei Tie leaned over, easily picked up Qin Mian, and placed him at the

front. His left hand pulled off his rain cape and wrapped him up. He scolded, “What are you doing running out?”

“Are you silly? Not waiting until the rain stops?”

They spoke almost at the same time.

Lei Tie hugged his wife and rubbed his lips on his wife’s side face. He didn’t say anything else, “*Jia!*”

Seeing a familiar black horse running over, Xile slowed down and stood on the side of the road, smiling. *It turns out that Eldest Young Master has come back. No wonder.*

“Xile, I’ll leave them to you,” Qin Mian left a sentence.

“Rest assured, Little Young Master!”

The black horse galloped straight to the door before stopping.

After getting off the horse, Qin Mian and Lei Tie reached out to pull the other into the bedroom at the same time.

“Change your clothes,” Qin Mian said.

He found Lei Tie’s clean clothes and threw them at him. He also found his own. He took off his wet clothes and wiped his body with a dry cloth towel.

In front of him was a shining white piece [of meat], somewhat dazzling. Lei Tie’s Adam’s apple rolled. He strode over and embraced the person.

“You—uhm!”

Qin Mian was soon brought into the midst of passion by Lei Tie. He yielded to his heart, hugged the man’s waist, and responded enthusiastically.

“Creak~” the door was pushed open.

Qin Mian was shocked and quickly pushed away Lei Tie.

White Spot ran in from the door and shook its body, swinging countless drops of water. Its brown eyes looked curiously at the two masters.

Lei Tie looked at it with his eyes narrowed.

Qin Mian stifled a laugh, quickly wiped the water off his body, and put on his dry clothes.

“Get out,” Lei Tie pointed to the door.

White Spot glanced at him, turned around, and left slowly. It was unknown whether it was intentional or unintentional that its butt hit the door panel, making the door panel creaked again. Slowly, it moved backward before touching the wall and stilled.

“Hahaha...” Qin Mian couldn’t help laughing. Sitting on the bed, he picked up Lei Tie’s clothes and threw them on him, “Put them on. Be careful not to catch a cold.”

Lei Tie saw that he was dressed neatly and put on his clothes sullenly.

Qin Mian went over and gave him a comforting kiss on his lips. “Did you have a good meal throughout the way? What do you want to eat? I’ll make it.”

“Noodle.”

Qin Mian dragged him out. “I’ll make you a noodle soup.”

They went to the central room and saw Xile standing under the eaves.

“Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master.”

“Are they all properly arranged?” Qin Mian asked.

Xile said, “They’re all arranged. There are bunk beds in the servants’ quarters, so they all live together. I asked Aunt Fu to cook noodles for them. The two coachmen are still waiting.”

Lei Tie fished out fourteen pieces of silver from his money pouch and gave it to Xile.

Qin Mian listened to the sound of rain and said, “It seems that the rain won’t stop for a while and it’s getting dark. Xile, if the two coachmen don’t mind, let them stay for a night and go back tomorrow at dawn.”

“Little Young Master is very kind.” Xile nodded in agreement, “The two coachmen are also worried about this. I’ll let them know.”

Xile pulled the horse to leave and went to arrange it without hassle.

Qin Mian made Lei Tie eat a peach first. He fried two poached eggs, took out four bags of instant noodles from the space, and cooked them in a pot. Instant noodles were easier to cook than noodles. He peeled a tomato, cut it into pieces, and added them into the noodles for flavor. He also added thin slices of meat and a few pakchoi.

Lei Tie dazedly looked at the noodle soup that was emitting a delicious aroma.

Qin Mian sat down beside him and urged, “Aren’t you hungry? Quickly eat it.”

It was still raining, so the indoor was a bit cool. However, Lei Tie felt a warm current rolling in his chest. He picked up the chopsticks and ate the noodles with his head down.

Qin Mian brought in the fruit plate on the windowsill, sat back at the position beside Lei Tie, and ate the fruit with his cross-legs swaying. After Lei Tie finished the noodle, he urged him to go back to the bedroom and have a rest.

Lei Tie pulled him to lie on the bed together.

Qin Mian obediently let Lei Tie hold him. The days when Lei Tie was away, he did not sleep well. It was best to sleep on rainy days and a nap was good too.

Suddenly, Lei Tie got up from the bed and locked the door.

Qin Mian was amused. *Is he afraid that White Spot will run in again?*

Lei Tie kissed the tilted corner of his lips, “Wife, how is our home these days?”

“Business as usual.” Qin Mian lay sideways, stroked the man’s side neck with his right hand, and yawned, “What about you?”

“Very good.” Lei Tie gripped his hand and hugged him tightly, “Sleep.”

“I’ve been missing you these days,” Qin Mian said frankly. He raised his head and rested it on the man’s shoulder. He also lifted his right leg and put it on the man’s legs. “What about you?”

Lei Tie’s temperature that had just cooled down, flared up again, “En.”

“En what?” Qin Mian asked deliberately.

“Don’t make trouble.” Lei Tie kneaded his (QM) waist and tilted his head to look at the wall.

Qin Mian stifled a laugh and stopped teasing him. He hugged the man’s waist and closed his eyes. The familiar smell and reassuring breath made him snore in a short time.

Lei Tie turned his head, imprinted a kiss on his lips, closed his eyes, and soon fell asleep.

When the sound of the rain suddenly stopped, Qin Mian abruptly woke up from his dream. He was in a trance for a moment. He didn’t know whether he was dreaming or awake.

“Awake?” A man’s magnetic voice rang in his ear.

Qin Mian then remembered that Lei Tie was back. He looked out of the window. It was dark. The rain did stop and there was no sound outside.

“Hungry.” Qin Mian lay on Lei Tie’s body, “What about you?”

“A little hungry, too.” Lei Tie’s waist moved slightly.

Qin Mian’s ears turned hot. He jumped up, “I’ll go—”

His mouth was sealed...

The two men crumpled up the sheets with their tossing around. It was a good while before they got their clothes straightened out properly and walked out of the room.

Lei Tie, wearing only his trousers and shoes, went to the central room. He raised his long arm and lit up four wall-hanging candlesticks with a fire holder³.

“What do you want to eat?” Qin Mian looked at his strong and powerful arm with appreciative eyes. “I want to eat rice.”

Lei Tie didn’t mind, “Then cook rice.”

“Alright, let’s cook the rice.” Qin Mian went to the kitchen, “Then fry another instant noodle. I haven’t eaten it for a long time, I really miss the taste.”

Lei Tie’s footsteps paused, “Try to make it yourself later.”

Qin Mian was stunned and then laughed, “Good idea! Try it when I have time. Maybe I can do it.”

“En.” Lei Tie said, “What kind of vegetable to eat? I’ll go pick.”

“Pick some purple eggplant, some peppers, and some pakchoi.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. 9.00 am to 11.00 am

2. It is a metaphor for the rapid change of weather
3. Previously made a note of “fire fold”. It is made of a stack of papers or burnable materials that was compressed tightly into a small cylindrical container with ember at the tip; like a burnt cigarette. The fire will lit when blowing the ember.

Chapter 095: Armed Servants

095 – Armed Servants

When Lei Tie came out of the space after picking vegetables, Qin Mian asked him about his experience in the past few days while cooking. Lei Tie said it one by one. Although he said it succinctly, Qin Mian knew that he galloped without stopping to come home as soon as possible, which made his heart warm. *Hey, such a good man is his!*

He swiftly made a serving of eggplant with minced meat, a serving of golden garlic spare ribs, a serving of sweet-sour pork slices, a serving of scrambled egg with instant noodles, and a serving of braised pakchoi.

“Awoo.” White Spot was unwilling to be left in the cold and rubbed against Qin Mian’s legs.

Qin Mian smiled and chopped some meat bones for it.

Qin Mian slept too much in the afternoon that when he lay in bed at night, he couldn’t sleep. Lei Tie also wasn’t sleepy and embraced him from the back with his right palm disorderly move on his (QM) body.

Qin Mian was agitated and anxious for further intimacy. However, he was afraid to lead an X-life at this young age, which was not good for his health. Why did he consciously think he’s the bottom? However, looking at Lei Tie’s height, body, and sturdy tight muscles, could Qin Mian press him down?

Lei Tie lifted his nightclothes, the hot breath behind him inched closer, and finally stayed in his ear. Then, a hand pushed aside his hair before a hot kiss fell on his nape, sucking heavily.

Qin Mian squinted and was seized with an impulse to moan, “Uhm...”

Lei Tie seemed to be encouraged and raised his left leg to lock the other’s body, “Wife, I want you.”

Qin Mian hesitated for only two seconds before turning around and took the initiative to hold the man. Since both sides were willing, why made both sides suffer? As for being young – once in a while, it shouldn’t matter. X-life was a harmonious affair and good for physical and mental health.

“A-Tie...”

In the dark, Lei Tie let out a low growl like a starving wolf and pounced on him.

.....

When Qin Mian woke up, his body felt like being crushed by a stone roller. Recalling that the guy seemed to have endless energy last night, he would like to kick him immediately. Fortunately, his body felt refresh, which meant Lei Tie had cleaned him up. The smell of chicken wafted in from the outside. He rubbed his waist and sat up slowly.

“Wife.”

Qin Mian looked at the man standing at the door, whose eyes were full of tenderness. Suddenly, he couldn’t say any blame words, but the corners of his lips rose uncontrollably.

Lei Tie sat down on the edge of the bed and encircled his back, “Wife.”

The man had no clothes on top. Qin Mian patted him on the chest as he leaned against him. He first made basic rules, “Later, three times a month at most!”

To his surprise, Lei Tie nodded without hesitation. He surprisingly looked at Lei Tie.

“You are still young.” Lei Tie changed the topic, “I stewed a chicken. I’ll bring a bowl over.”

Qin Mian had a smiling expression as he glanced at him, “Today, I must eat light food.”

Lei Tie immediately stood up, “Lie down for a while. I’ll cook porridge.”

Qin Mian shook his head, “I’ve woken up, so I don’t want to lie down.”

Lei Tie took out a suit of clothes from the wardrobe and handed it to him. He lowered his head and kissed him before going out.

After Qin Mian had dressed up, he took Lei Tie’s upper clothes and walked out of the room.

Outside the house, the hot sunshine shone on the ground was dazzling yellow. The soil looked almost dried. Supposedly, it was afternoon.

Qin Mian walked into the kitchen and threw the clothes to Lei Tie. “Why are you half-naked? Lest others don’t know?”

Lei Tie took the clothes and put them on, shaking his head, “It’s hot in the kitchen.”

Qin Mian hugged his waist and said lazily, “It’s a little hot today. Now it’s fine. When we’re in the seventh and eighth months, I’m afraid our house will be hotter, especially our room. There’s no ventilation.”

His wife took the initiative to get close, so Lei Tie quickly reached out and embraced him for fear he would withdraw. “I thought about it. Expand the house as soon as possible.”

“How to expand it?” Qin Mian also had this idea, but he didn’t have time to think about it.

Lei Tie motioned him to sit down. “I’ll cook porridge first. We’ll talk about it later.”

Qin Mian shook his head and let him go. "I'll wash first."

After washing, Qin Man returned to the kitchen. Lei Tie had already cooked the porridge. Unexpectedly, this guy knew to add some ingredients, vegetables, and minced meat to the porridge.

Lei Tie handed him a cup of water.

Qin Mian took a drink. He then leaned on the kitchen stove and resumed the previous topic, "You said about expansion, how?"

Lei Tie pulled him to the central room. The front and back doors of the main room were open, so it was very cool.

"Expand to the west. Build a house of the same size as this house next to the west wall. Then, make a passage from our room. The new house divides into two rooms; one for our bedroom and the other for the storehouse."

Qin Mian nodded as he listened. "It's good. But I want to make the new house two stories. Just like you said, make a passage from the present room. There are going to be two rooms on the first floor; one guest room and one storehouse. We'll set the door of the storehouse outside, no need to go inside. The whole second floor is going to be a shared bedroom and study, spacious and comfortable. We'll make the windows in the north and south larger, so it would be cool to live in the summer. Then, we'll make a small terrace where we can drink tea and see the scenery in our spare time. In winter, we can move back to our bedroom on the first floor."

His wife planned better than him. Lei Tie nodded, "Listen to you."

When Qin Mian finished his porridge, they rang Xile and asked him to bring Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and the nine newly bought people.

The nine newly arrived people had gone through a night and a morning of rest. Provided with the briefing from Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, and Xile, the nine new people had a general understanding of the situation of Leisurely Farm Residence. Upon seeing Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat at the stone table, the nine people saluted them respectfully.

“Greetings, Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master.”

At the side, Xile stood at ready with hands behind his back and looked at Lei Tie and Qin Mian. As usual, the Eldest Young Master was expressionless, and Little Young Master was gentle. However, he always felt that the atmosphere between the two masters was different and closer than ever. Even if their limbs did not touch, their eyes collided from time to time, revealing an undescribable fit.

Anyway, if the two masters had a good relationship, it meant a good thing for their servants. When the masters were in a good mood, they also worked in relaxation. Xile then stopped contemplating it.

“Masters, please bestow them names,” Xile said with curiosity. When a master gave the family servant a name with a surname, it usually followed the surname of the master. Although the two masters were husband and wife, they were men after all, and Qin Mian was always in charge of the family. Which young masters’ surname would the new nine people follow?

The nine youths said at the same time, “Please bestow us names, Masters.” By bestowing them names allowed them to integrate into Leisurely Farm Residence as soon as possible.

Qin Mian understood that naming was a way for servants to start a new life as soon as possible and to enhance their bond with their masters. Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu were husband and wife, and they were old, so he did not want to deprive them of their original names. But this time, these teenagers were still young, which most inexperienced, and had strong mouldability. Later on, they would be his and Lei Tie’s capable helpers. Resounding names were necessary.

Qin Mian also thought of Xile’s curiosity. After thinking for a moment, he decided to use both his and Lei Tie’s surnames. As their family’s business grew bigger and bigger, the fact that Lei Tie and he were husband and wife would surely spread further. Instead of waiting for people to make a joke of them in the future, it was better to build momentum now. A matter known to all was not worth mentioning.

Qin Mian took a look at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie's eyes fixed on him with only brand-new trust.

He gave a light smile, looked at the nine teenagers in turn, and said, "Line up from the oldest to the youngest."

After the nine people stood still, Qin Mian said, "From left to right, your name is Lei-Qin Zhong[loyal]..."

Lei Tie grabbed his wife's hand to put it on his leg and covered it with his big palm.

Xile beamed with a smile. The two masters had a great relationship.

Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu also had smiles on their faces.

"Lei-Qin Gong[respectful], Lei-Qin Shun[obey], Lei-Qin Cheng[sincere], Lei-Qin Xin[truthful]." Qin Mian turned his head to look at Lei Tie and said discontentedly, "Don't just sit, help me think of a few names."

Lei Tie looked at the remaining four, "Lei-Qin Hui[benevolence], Lei-Qin Jian[resolute], Lei-Qin Li[reason], and Lei-Qin Yuan[tactful]."

These names all sounded great, not like the names of servants. Happiness shone on the faces of the nine teenagers. They said in unison, "Many thanks Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master for bestowing our names."

Qin Mian asked faintly, "You all must already know the rules of Leisurely Farm Residence?"

"Yes!"

"Good. As long as you do not violate the rules of Leisurely Farm Residence, I believe we'll get along very well." Qin Mian smiled faintly, "We bought you to be cultivated as armed servants. From today on, you'll learn martial arts with Eldest Young Master. If you do well, you can take on more important responsibilities in the future."

“Yes!”

Xile’s expression changed slightly. Learn martial arts? He also wanted to learn it.

Qin Mian faintly looked at him. “Xile. From now on, you also train with them and serve as the team leader for the time being.”

Xile was overjoyed. He knelt on the ground and kowtowed, “Many thanks, Little Young Master! This little one will live up to Masters’ trust!”

“Get up.” Qin Mian looked very pleased.

Xile didn’t get up. He smiled as he bowed to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, “Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master. May I be bold to ask Masters to change my name? I also want to be surnamed Lei-Qin. Once heard, people will know that I belong to Masters’ family.”

Qin Mian felt very comfortable with this flattery.

Lei Tie looked at Xile with appreciation.

Because of this look, Xile nearly jumped up with excitement.

Qin Mian thought for a moment and said, “You will be called Lei-Qin Le. What do you think, A-tie?”

Lei Tie nodded.

“Thank you very much, Masters!” Lei-Qin Le was so happy he grinned from ear to ear.

Qin Mian asked Lei Tie, “Start today?”

Lei Tie shook his head and told Lei-Qin Le, “Take them to run around the courtyard wall first and then run another circle after half a quarter of rest. After running, do farm work.”

“Yes. I’ll take my leave.” Lei-Qin Le was more spirited than ever before. With a wave of his hand, “All follow me.”

Chapter 096: The Small Mansion Gate

096 – The Small Mansion Gate

“Servants will take our leave.” After the nine people saluted together, they went running with Lei-Qin Le.

Lei Tie said to Qin Mian, “I’ll accompany you today.”

Qin Mian smiled, “Good, I’ll accompany you too.”

Aunt Fu and Uncle Fu lowered their heads and looked down.

“Are the two coachmen gone?” Qin Mian asked Uncle Fu.

Uncle Fu said, “Yes. They left early this morning. They asked me to convey their gratitude to the young masters.”

Lei Tie saw Qin Mian’s unconscious action of supporting his waist. “Uncle Fu, go contact the building materials shop in the town and ask them to send some bricks and tiles.”

Uncle Fu asked, “Yes. May I know how much Eldest Young Master needs?”

Lei Tie said, “Based on the house where Little Young Master and I live now.”

“I’ve got the estimation. Will go at once.” Uncle Fu left in a hurry.

“Forget one thing.” Qin Mian said to Aunt Fu, “Aunt Fu, the new people are treated the same as you three. You tell them all. Besides, if they need any

daily items, let them report to Uncle Fu to purchase them together.”

“Yes.”

“That’s all. You can leave.”

After Aunt Fu left, Qin Mian stood up in a somewhat awkward posture, “A-Tie, I want to go soak.”

“Together,” Lei Tie said.

White Spot, who lay in the corner, seemed to hear a sound and came running with its tail wagging.

Qin Mian then brought it together into the space.

As soon as they entered the quadrangle courtyard gate, he and Lei Tie simultaneously stunned. Their eyes fell on the pink ball in the flower bed. It seemed that overnight, the pink ball had doubled in size. The previously round flower bud finally split into a very hierarchical, tightly clustered petal tips.

“I didn’t expect that the flower would grow very fast. Is it suddenly enlightened?” Qin Mian joked and went over to touch it. The flower bud was slightly elastic and very comfortable to touch. Suddenly, his hand stopped. A trace of surprise appeared on his face. Was that his illusion? He felt a vague sense of delight from the flower bud. Did it like his touch?

“What?” Lei Tie had a keen observation.

Both of them didn’t notice that White Spot didn’t run around as soon as they entered the space as before. Instead, it looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie in turn, with a very strange expression. Then, it ran away with its tail wagging.

Qin Mian shook his head. He didn’t know how to answer, so he said, “You touch it.”

Lei Tie’s big palm covered the flower bud, and he was also surprised.

Qin Mian knew that it was not his illusion just then, so he took Lei Tie's hand with a smile and let him touch the flower bud again. "I'm sure this flower must be a wonderful flower when it blooms! Since it likes it, we'll touch it when we water it later."

Although Lei Tie felt that touching a flower was a little weird, he still nodded, "Go soak."

They no longer paid attention to the pink ball and went to the spiritual spring.

Lei Tie filled a barrel of spiritual spring water with a bucket, which was directly heated by an internal force. Qin Mian lay inside and sighed comfortably. Lei Tie rolled up his sleeves and massaged his wife's waist.

The spiritual spring water cured Qin Mian's discomfort. After soaking for a while, he recovered his energetic appearance.

"Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. The second gongzi's wife came and said there is something urgent."

From outside the space, the two men heard Aunt Fu report at the door. They quickly left the space.

When Qin Mian opened the door, he saw Zhao Shi holding a not-so-ripe peach and gnawing at it. The corner of his mouth twitched.

"Second Brother's wife, what's the matter?" Qin Mian asked dully. Seeing that Zhao Shi was not anxious, he knew that nothing was wrong.

Zhao Shi gave him a fawning smile, "Eldest Sister-in-law, it's like this. Little Mother is pregnant. Father asked me to tell you two."

"Oh?" Qin Mian raised his eyebrows. It was indeed a major event in the old house. It had been more than half a year since Wei Shi married Lei Daqiang, and yet there was no news. Wei Shi was still very anxious some time ago, but unexpectedly she got pregnant. Heh. The excitement in the

old house could make a major drama series, titled “The Small Mansion Gate”¹.

“It’s a great joy event.” Qin Mian said, “A-Tie and I will clean up first. Then we will go over.”

“No hurry, no hurry. Take your time. I’ll wait for you.” With that, Zhao Shi forced her way into the central room.

Qin Mian made an eye signal at Aunt Fu.

Aunt Fu straightened her sturdy chest, went to Zhao Shi’s side, and stood still.

“Second Brother’s wife, wait a moment.”

When Qin Mian and Lei Tie entered the kitchen, Zhao Shi stood up, wanting to look around.

Aunt Fu took a few steps and blocked in front of her. She said with a happy smile, “Second Gongzi’s wife, sit down. It’s very tiring to stand.”

Zhao Shi snorted. Since the servants of Eldest’s family called Lei Xiangren the Second Gongzi, she should be called Second Nainai². What’s more hateful was that they always called her the Second Gongzi’s wife; it was truly annoying.

She didn’t have to think about it. The relationship between the two Masters of Leisurely Farm Residence and some people in the old house was not amicable. They already gave Lei Xiangren a lot of respect by calling him the Second Gongzi, so why would she call her the Second Nainai?

Qin Mian had always been quick to do things, and soon picked up some of the snacks in the snack cabinet and put them in the food box, which Lei Tie carried.

They went out with Zhao Shi.

When passing by the peach tree at the end of the bridge, Zhao Shi stood on tiptoe and grabbed a large honey peach with one hand. She then pulled hard, plucking two peaches off.

Qin Mian was in a good mood and didn't bother to argue with her.

Out of the gate, Qin Mian saw Qian Shi standing not far away. He was surprised.

"Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law." Qian Shi very politely greeted Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian nodded to her, "Third Brother's wife." He had a better impression of Qian Shi not only for the relationship with Lei Xiangyi but because she also never bothered them again.

Zhao Shi and Qian Shi fell behind Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Qian Shi gave Zhao Shi a bad look. It was not proper for men to talk about Wei Shi's pregnancy after all, so Lei Daqiang originally asked her to go to Leisurely Farm Residence to inform Lei Tie and Qin Mian. She planned to take this opportunity to ask the two men to help her family separate from the old house. Since Lei Xiangyi couldn't speak about it, she had to. But she didn't expect Zhao Shi to come first and made her miss the opportunity. It was very aggravating.

"What's wrong with your eyes, Third Brother's wife?" Zhao Shi asked aloud.

"Nothing!" Qian Shi took two quick steps, not wanting to talk to her.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had gone far away, walking briskly.

Zhao Shi gnawed on the honey peach while secretly looking at the harmonious figures of the two men. Why did she think these two men were not the same as usual? They were closer than ever, and their shoulders would touch from time to time.

When she couldn't come up with anything, she stopped thinking about it and hastily caught up.

"Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law have skills. This peach is so sweet, even unripe. When it's ripe, it must be sweeter. Eldest Sister-in-law, since we're family, can we buy it cheaper?"

Qin Mian took a meaningful look at her; *she learned to be smart ah. Instead of taking it for free, she wants to "buy"*. Unfortunately, he still wouldn't believe her.

Without waiting for him to say anything, Qian Shi said, "Really, Second Sister-in-law! Who in our village doesn't know Elder Sister-in-law's fruits are to be supplied to their wine house this year. Aren't you putting Eldest Sister-in-law in an awkward position?"

Zhao Shi gave her a cold stare and dared not entangle more because Lei Tie was present, "Haha, I forget for a moment?"

When they arrived at the old house, they heard Lei Daqiang's happy laughter before entering the door.

Wei Shi caressed her abdomen that hadn't shown yet, with a smile on her lips. Occasionally, she raised her eyes to look at Lei Daqiang.

Qin Mian looked at her for a moment and admired her in his heart.

"Eldest and Eldest Daughter-in-law, you two are here." Wei Shi stood up to greet them.

Lei Daqiang quickly helped her, "Be careful."

"She's not obviously pregnant yet! Old man, you can accompany Little Sister every day later, lest she is careless and breaks like porcelain." Du Shi's shrill voice came from the door. Her eyes fixed on Wei Shi's abdomen, hoping to gouge out a hole in it.

"Thanks for your concern, Sister." Wei Shi's subconsciously put a hand on her abdomen and smiled very amicably toward Du Shi. She had been very

anxious not getting pregnant after being married to Lei Daqiang for half a year. She was afraid that Lei Daqiang had some physical problems, and it would be too late to have another child. Now, her wish had finally come true. Ever since Lei Xiangzhi became an entry-level examinee, Du Shi was arrogant in front of her every day; she probably never heard of “fortunes rise and fall”. Having a child at an old age, Lei Daqiang would certainly give special treatment to her child. From now on, Du Shi could not think of being rampant in front of her.

Wei Shi said to Lei Daqiang, “Husband, it’s time to plant paddy seedlings now. You and Sister have many things to worry about. How can I let you accompany me every day while Sister works alone? So, I thought, why not we buy a maid? The maid can take care of me. Since I’m unable to share Sister’s burden now, I feel very sorry. The maid can also help Sister in her spare time. It’s best for both sides.”

Du Shi’s expression drastically changed. She clenched her right hand until the palm hurt, but she wasn’t aware of it.

“No way!” She objected at once, “We are just a family of pheasants. Why should we buy a maid? Don’t make others laugh.”

Zhao Shi, Qian Shi, and Lei Xiangren were not good at interrupting the affairs of their elders, and so they all kept silent.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie wouldn’t even want to interrupt. They sat at the side as the background.

Unconcerned, Lei Daqiang dismissed her, “What about it being a good laugh? I even married an equal wife, and still afraid of being laughed at for buying a maid?”

Wei Shi had her own money, so it was not feasible to stop Wei Shi with the excuse that there was no money at home. After restraining herself for a long time, Du Shi said, “If you buy a maid, where is she going to live?”

Wei Shi smiled, “Sister doesn’t have to worry about this. It’ll be fine to let the maid sleep on the floor in the room. Now it’s hot, not easy to catch a

cold. The future matters are for future discussion. There will be a solution.”

“It’s settled then.” Seeing that his old wife was so angry, Lei Daqiang didn’t want to be too heartless and comforted her, “Alright, this matter is not only for Wei’er but also for you. Isn’t it better for our family to be harmonious than anything else?”

Du Shi did not say anything at all. She sat down with a cold face. From the gloomy look in her eyes, she certainly was unwilling to drop the matter.

After watching a full-scale drama, Qin Mian stood up and motioned Lei Tie to pass the food box to Lei Daqiang.

“Father, Mother, and Little Mother, congratulations. This is my and A-Tie’s little regard. We hope you don’t dislike it.”

“Well, you and Eldest has taken a lot of trouble.” Lei Daqiang opened the food box and looked at it with a smile. “Your Little Mother is pregnant now, so her taste in food will be strange. If she wants to eat some fruits from your orchard, can—”

Wei Shi interrupted with a smile, “Husband, their business in the wine house is important. I heard pregnant women prefer sour or spicy food.”

Qin Mian smiled without saying anything.

Wei Shi gave him a kind look. Whether it was Lei Xiangzhi, Lei Tie, or Qin Mian, they were all the targets she wanted to draw to her side.

Qin Mian gave a noncommittal smile. “Father, Mother, and Little Mother, it’s not too early. A-Tie and I are going back.”

Wei Shi nodded, “Alright, come to visit when you are free.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie left side by side. Du Shi didn’t even look at them.

Out of the old house, Qin Mian laughed, “Haha!”

“Happy?” Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian raised his head high as he said, “Of course! I’m glad to see Du Shi humiliated!” Lei Tie was often abused by Du Shi when he was young, but Qin Mian hadn’t known how serious it was until last night. The old wounds on Lei Tie’s back were so intensive and shocking.

Lei Tie held his hand and looked ahead, “Wife, having you is enough for me.”

“En.” Qin Mian breathed a sigh of relief and calmed his mood. “The situation of the old house is becoming more and more complicated. It’s a pity that Third Brother, Fourth Brother, Fifth Brother, and Little Sister still have to stay in the muddy water.”

Then again, how did the matter of separating the family came to nothing?

Shoutout Corner: Thanks a lot TucTuc! That’s a very nice message! 😊

Two more chapters left from me and one bonus.

Note:

Footnotes

1. There is a drama series called The Grand Mansion Gate. It’s about a big family and you know, family drama.
2. (respectful) mistress of the house

Chapter 097: Being an Elder Sister-in-law Is Hard Ah...

097 – Being an Elder Sister-in-law Is Hard *Ah...*

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli came from the farm with hoes on their shoulders, sleeves rolled up to the arms, and sweat on their flushed faces.

“Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law.”

Qin Mian nodded and casually asked, “You went to the farm?”

“Yes. We went to the vegetable garden to weed. Our family planted vegetables on three mu of land. The crops are growing well.” Lei Xiangyi’s face filled with joy.

Lei Xiangli was very calm. *Without separating the family, the money earned is not your own.*

Qin Mian touched his chin. He seldom saw Lei Xiangren go to the farm, so he sympathized with Lei Xiangyi. However, it was the old house’s affair, after all. He and Lei Tie had no right to intervene since they had separated.

“If you have time, you can pick some good vegetables and send them to our wine house. A-Tie and I will inform the management in advance,” he said kindly.

“Aye,” Lei Xiangyi responded. Instead of saying too much “thank you”, which might hurt their relationship, it was better to remember in the heart.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had just taken a few steps when Lei Xiangyi quickly caught up after hesitating for a moment.

Lei Xiangli halted and also walked over.

“Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law.”

Qin Mian turned around and asked suspiciously, “Is there anything else?”

Lei Xiangyi said with a bitter smile, “Eldest Sister-in-law, I won’t beat around the bush with you. Fourth Brother and I, we want to separate from the family. I have mentioned it with our parents several times, but they disagreed. I know that Eldest Sister-in-law has always been a man of ideas. I wonder if you can show us the way?”

Qin Mian frowned. Lei Xiangyi asked them for help, which was understandable, but he should not mention it on the way. If others saw them and told Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, at that time, when Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli talked about separation again, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi would surely suspect him and Lei Tie. He didn’t want to draw Du Shi’s and Lei Daqiang’s attention back.

Lei Xiangli was more alert. He looked around and said to Lei Xiangyi disapprovingly, “Second Brother, you are too bold. If other people see us talking with Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law for such a long time, they will get into trouble.” The brothers tacitly knew what kind of people Du Shi and Lei Daqiang were.

When the realization came over Lei Xiangyi, he was stunned and quickly apologized, “Eldest Sister-in-law, it is my negligence.”

Qin Mian looked around to make sure there was no one else nearby. He shook his head and said, “Tomorrow morning, you will pick some vegetables and send them to the wine house with us.” *Ah, being an elder sister-in-law is hard.*

Lei Xiangyi secretly breathed a sigh of relief. In this way, Qin Mian agreed to give them advice. In the name of delivering vegetables, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi had no reason to suspect.

“Thank you very much, Eldest Sister-in-law,” Lei Xiangli said happily.

To avoid being noticed, the four men quickly separated.

After returning home, Qin Mian enthusiastically gave Lei Tie training ideas.

—

After dawn and morning exercise, Lei Tie took Lei-Qin Le and the armed servants to start training. Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu picked vegetables in the garden and piled them up to transport to the wine house.

Qin Mian made a few pancakes for breakfast and left them in the wok covered with the lid. He would eat it together with Lei Tie when he came back. In the meantime, he took White Spot to the garden.

In the open space beside the grove, Lei Tie instructed the future armed servants to bind 2 Jin of sandbags to their wrists and ankles and run three circles around the open space. Tied with heavy burdens, Lei-Qin Le and the others were not used to it, but they gritted their teeth and persisted. It was their honor that the master was willing to teach them skills. It was also a rare opportunity, so no one was willing to give up.

After the run, Lei Tie showed a set of boxing. Lei-Qin Le and the other nine people attentively watched him while taking the opportunity to rest.

“Practice half of it today,” Lei Tie said with an expressionless face and demonstrated the first half of the boxing set at a relatively slow speed.

After the demonstration, he said in a low voice, “Try it.”

Lei-Qin Le and the nine people repeated the memorized boxing technique together.

Lei Tie discovered that Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Hui were the fastest learners, so he slightly nodded. He remembered that Lei-Qin Hui was the most outstanding teenager at the time he bought them; he could cultivate as an important subordinate. “Are you literate?” Lei Tie asked.

Lei-Qin Hui came forward and said, “Back to Eldest Young Master¹, I’m literate.”

Lei Tie took out a piece of paper from his sleeve and handed it to him, “Afterward, train according to these contents. Lei-Qin Le is in charge of supervision.”

Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Hui said respectfully, “Yes, Eldest Young Master!”

“Today’s boxing. Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Hui are responsible for teaching others. The inspection will be the morning after tomorrow.”

Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Huiqi said, “Yes!”

Lei Tie didn’t personally supervise, which made them felt more pressure after a little relief.

Qin Mian watched from afar. He didn’t go over but went to the garden.

Lei Tie strode over and stood by him. In addition to imparting boxing and palm techniques, the rest of the training did not require him to be present all the time. He also couldn’t spend all his time training the armed servants.

Aunt Fu and Uncle Fu squatted in the garden, harvesting vegetables. At the side of the vegetable plot, there were several large baskets filled with eggplant, tomato, cucumber, chives, and green pepper.

Uncle Fu patted off the mud on his hands and came over, carefully avoiding the vegetables on the ground. “Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master, we harvested a lot of vegetables. It’s just that we only have one cart. I’m afraid it’s not enough.”

Qin Mian looked at the fresh and tender vegetables and was very satisfied, “No fret. You go to the village to borrow a cart for an emergency. I’ll buy another cart when I get to town.”

“Yes, I will go.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went back through the peach forest.

Qin Mian chatted with him, "I haven't been to the wine house for several days. I don't know how the business is." Although he had confidence, he still worried if he didn't see the situation in the wine house with his own eyes.

Lei Tie's calming voice contained the power to calm him down. He said, "It won't be bad. Two new dishes launch every day in the first month of business. It will surely attract customers."

Qin Mian restored his confidence, "En, I'm confident!"

He patted Lei Tie on the back, "You're sweating. Go home and take a bath. After breakfast, we're going to town."

They went to the gate after breakfast. Uncle Fu had loaded all the vegetables into the carts where more than a dozen baskets filled in.

Uncle Fu and Lei-Qin Le each drove a cart, while Qin Mian and Lei Tie rode on horsebacks.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli waited at the entrance of the village early. There were also several baskets of green vegetables on the borrowed donkey cart.

"Eldest Sister-in-law, check our vegetables first," Lei Xiangli said. Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law took good care of them, so they were very grateful. They did not cheat and carefully picked out the rotten and damaged ones.

"No, I believe you," Qin Mian said with a smile.

He signaled Lei-Qin Le and Uncle Fu to drive ahead.

Lei-Qin Le was a person with tact, and Uncle Fu was not silly. Seeing that they had something to say, the two drove the carts and pulled their distance apart.

"Eldest Sister-in-law, we've troubled you and Eldest Brother with what we said yesterday." Lei Xiangli cupped his hands in obeisance first.

Qin Mian waved his hand and did not beat around the bush, “The actual reason why you want to split up is mainly because of Second Brother?”

Neither Lei Xiangyi nor Lei Xiangli denied it.

“Yes.”

Lei Xiangli explained, “We are naturally affectionate with Second Brother, but Second Brother and Second Sister-in-law often go too far. Once or twice, we brothers can tolerate, but in the long run, they will polish the rest of our affection. It is better to divide our family as soon as possible.”

Qin Mian said slowly, “You have two options now. First, only separate Second Brother’s family.”

Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangyi were shocked. They had only wanted to thresh themselves out and didn’t think that they could make Lei Xiangren split instead. If Lei Xiangren did, it would be great, but it would difficult with Lei Xiangren’s character.

Lei Xiangli asked, “What about the second option?”

Lei Xiangyi didn’t speak as he looked down and wondered. He felt a little excited. Truthfully, he didn’t want to separate from Lei Xiangzhi. It would be fine if only the Second Brother split. Lei Xiangzhi had a bright future. It didn’t matter whether he and Qian Shi could bask in his light, but he still hoped that his children could receive Lei Xiangzhi’s light. He was sure to have a son in the future. Whether his son took the imperial examination or his daughter got married, they would not have a bad life if they had an influential uncle.

“The second option is both of you split.” Qin Mian’s lips flashed a scornful smile. His tone was very flat as he said, “I believe you also understand that Second Brother can’t agree to separate from Fifth Brother.”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli had a helpless look and nodded at the same time. Lei Xiangren was a mindless person, but he was not stupid. On the

contrary, he was a bit clever. It was impossible not to see that Lei Xiangzhi had a bright future.

“What should I do if I choose the first option?” Lei Xiangyi asked.

Qin Mian chuckled, “The reason why Second Brother is so unscrupulous in the family is that he is the only one of your brothers who gave the old man and the old lady two grandsons, and the other reason is Mother.”

Lei Xiangyi’s voice was a little dull as he said, “Yes. Mother thinks *highly* of Second Brother.” It was a euphemism. Among Du Shi’s four sons, she liked the fifth son the best and followed by the second son.

“So, as long as you can change Mother’s view on Second Brother...” Qin Mian didn’t say it in detail. He couldn’t teach Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli hand in hand. It was up to them to decide what to do.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were thoughtful.

Lei Tie didn’t speak all the time but looked at Qin Mian. His wife was so smart.

Qin Mian continued, “Of course. You still have a strong helper.”

Lei Xiangli’s heart jolted, “Wei Shi.”

“Right.” Lei Xiangyi also started to see solutions, and his spirit rose. “Wei Shi, I’m afraid that she dislikes Second Brother more than we do. If we want to separate Second Brother, she will be happy to help us.”

Regardless of their specific plans, Qin Mian only said what he could say, “It is more difficult for you to choose the second option. Mother is very clear of Second Brother’s character. If you both also separated from them, who would do the work at home?”

Lei Xiangyi hesitantly said, “Then, we can only choose the first?”

Lei Xiangli frowned. He wanted to be by himself. The days in the house were too noisy. He was afraid that when he married, the family might

become more “lively”.

“Not really...”

With a sentence from Qin Mian, both Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli looked at each other.

Note:

Footnotes

1. He used the subordinate way of talking to the superior.

Chapter 098: Kiss on The Tree

098 – Kiss on The Tree

“If you can make Father and Mother believe you can give them a lot of allowances every month after the separation...” Qin Mian pointed until there.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli looked at each other with sudden realization. The reason their parents didn’t want to divide up the family was so the family would not scatter, and the other reason was money.

Qin Mian reminded, “Of course, the worst case is that Father and Mother are unwilling to divide up. If so, you can strive for financial independence first. Henceforth, your income belongs to your own. But every month, you take out some to give Father and Mother. In other words, each time you make money, you hand it in at a certain proportion. For example, if you earn 100 Wen from a job, you can give 10 Wen and 8 Wen to Father and Mother.”

Both Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were capable and diligent people. If they worked alone, their monthly income should not be less. Imagine that when the third son and the fourth son gave money to Du Shi and Lei Daqiang every month while the lazy second son didn’t even give a coin, could Du Shi and Lei Daqiang not be angry with him? Haha. By then, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang would look very much embarrassed. Thinking of that good scene, Qin Mian couldn’t help laughing.

“Wife, the sun is high,” Lei Tie spoke in time.

“En, let’s go.” Qin Mian raised his whip and urged his horse forward. He had said it all, so the rest depended on Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli.

After galloping far away, Lei Tie looked at his wife's face, "Wife, it's been hard on you." How could he not know that his wife helped Third Brother and Fourth Brother for his sake?

Qin Mian spread out his hand and sighed helplessly, but his lips hung with a smile, "Uh, who make me a good man?"

Lei Tie gently raised his lips.

The two raised their whips together, and the horses galloped like a blast, even the sound of the horse's hooves was light and quick.

Once arrived at Double Xiang House, Qin Mian let Manager Sun take up the vegetables that Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli delivered according to the market price. This batch of vegetables costed a total of 165 Wen. In tacit agreement, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli each withdrawn 20 Wen from it. Besides, they also prepared 20 Wen for Lei Xiangren. They could do nothing about this. Lei Xiangren knew about their private savings, and it was Lei Xiangren who first proposed it.

After seeing off Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi, Qin Mian said to Manager Sun, "Afterward, collect all vegetables according to the rules." A few Wen was a small matter, but breaking the rules was troublesome. He could not let a tear open.

Manager Sun said, "Rest assured, Little Young master. I understand."

Lei Tie said to Qin Mian, "Wife, I'll see the guards."

"Alright."

Lei Tie was not good at business. He was responsible for the security and sanitation of the wine house, and Qin Mian was in charge of the rest.

It was still early. There were only a dozen customers in the lobby before lunch hour.

"How's the business recently?" Qin Mian asked.

As soon as he asked, Manager Sun's face began to smile. "Although it's unlike the first few days of opening, it's much better than before. Almost every day, there are customers from afar who had heard of our Double Xiang House. Besides, quite a lot of traveling merchants that passed through Running Water Town are willing to stay in our Rugui Building for a night. The ordinary rooms are clean and tidy, quiet, and inexpensive. Very much well-liked. Have you seen the customers in the lobby? They are traveling merchants. They checked in last night and ordered a lot of things for breakfast. They also asked the waiters to pack a lot of it. Moreover, two distinguished guests lived in luxurious suites for five consecutive days. They ordered a large table of dishes for each meal."

Speaking of this, he paused for a moment, "I think these two are perhaps..."

Qin Mian waved his hand, "It's fine. As long as they don't use any despicable means, treat them well. Our Double Xiang House is not an ordinary wine house. On the premise of not harming our interests, we should act more magnanimous."

Little Young Master was not too old, but he looked at an issue to such a high degree. Manager Sun had even more confidence in him, "Yes."

After taking a look at the account books, he went around Binzhi Building and Rugui Building before going to the lounge to wait for Lei Tie.

As he was drinking tea, Lei Tie pushed the door and entered.

"Wife."

"How is it?" Qin Mian gave way to let him sit.

Lei Tie fell beside him. "The business is good, but there are too few guards."

"Hire four more guards." It took so much money to build a wine house. Qin Mian was not reluctant to spend money on small things.

"En, let Manager Sun handle it."

Qin Mian got up. "It's been a long time since I went to our restaurant. Let's go and have a look."

Eating Savory Restaurant hadn't opened yet, but it was busy inside.

Yue Dong was counting accounts, and upon seeing Qin Mian and Lei Tie, he quickly stood up and greeted, "Greetings, Big Boss and Little Boss."

Qin Mian nodded and opened the account book.

Lei Tie went to the kitchen to check the hygiene.

The accounts were as detailed as ever that one could see Yue Dong was still so serious about his work. Qin Mian cast an appreciative look at Yue Dong, "You have done well. Our business will be bigger and bigger in the future, and you won't always be the manager of a small restaurant. So, Yue Dong, don't let me and Big Boss down."

Yue Dong was delighted. He cupped his hands in salute and seriously said, "Yue Dong will never fail to live up to the trust and teaching of the two bosses."

"En." Qin Mian continued to look at the account books.

As soon as he closed the account book, Yue Dong said, "Little Boss, the weather is getting hotter now. Hot spicy soup, hot pot, and barbecue business are not as good as when it is cold. A lot of customers come back to eat only once in a while."

Qin Mian nodded without showing a worried look. "I had expected this situation for a long time. I was too busy some time ago, so I didn't pay attention to this side. You put the news out that after another five days of selling hot pot, hot spicy soup, and barbecue, Eating Savory Restaurant will change to selling convenient products such as steamed stuffed buns, pancakes, noodles, and so on. Those who want to eat them can seize the opportunity to eat it."

Yue Dong hesitated, “As far as I know, there are more than a dozen noodle shops in the town.”

Qin Mian said with a smile, “Things in our business are naturally different from others. Just let the news out. I’ll send you something tomorrow. You’ll know when you see it.”

“Yes.”

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie inquisitively.

Lei Tie nodded. The shop’s hygiene was also up to standard.

When it was nearly noon, they went home after having lunch in Double Xiang House. In passing, Uncle Fu and Lei-Qin Le bought the daily necessities that Lei-Qin Zhong’s group of people needed.

On either side of the village road, the villagers bent over while planting paddy seedlings and heard the sound of horses’ hooves. They took a chance to glance at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, who leisurely rode on horses and let their horses run at ease. Some were envious, and some were jealous.

Zhou Erhao Family’s paddy field was next to the village road. He and his wife were planting paddy seedlings. Their mood felt very complicated when they watched the retreating back of Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Before Leisurely Farm Residence was built, their house and Lei Tie’s house were only a few steps away. Now, a perimeter wall separated the two houses, and it took half a walk around the village to reach the gate of Leisurely Farm Residence. They both regretted not making a good relationship with them at the first opportunity. Lei Tie Family was so wealthy that with just a dip of a finger, it was enough for them to eat a few meals of meat!

All the way through, Qin Mian felt needle-like eyes on his back. He could not help looking back and saw Zhou Erhao’s grudging eyes.

Zhao Sifa swung his hands. When he directly bumped into Qin Mian, he stared at him with an unknown meaning for a long time before looking away.

Qin Mian frowned slightly.

Lei Tie's voice rang in his ear, "Don't worry."

Qin Mian nodded his head.

It was not yet time to deal with some things.

Aunt Fu was in charge of the gate when Lei-Qin Le and Uncle Fu were away. Lei-Qin Zhong's group of people had just arrived, and because they were young, Aunt Fu was not reassured to let them guard the gate.

Upon seeing Uncle Fu and Lei-Qin Le came back with Little Young Master and Eldest Young Master, Aunt Fu was relieved. She picked up the dirty laundry and went to the river to wash.

By the river, several village women chatted while washing their clothes.

Zhou Cuihua first saw Aunt Fu with her sharp eyes and warmly called out, "Aunt Fu has come. There is a spot at my side."

With a smile, Aunt Fu walked over.

"Aunt Fu comes to do the laundry, too?" Several other village women also greeted her kindly. Although Aunt Fu was only a servant, she had a close relationship with Lei Tie Family, so they dared not offend her.

Women always had a lot of topics. They talked and laughed, very lively.

After a while, Fang Hongliu said in a clear voice, "By the way, Aunt Fu, I heard that Old Three and Old Four of Second Lei Family¹ sent a lot of vegetables to the town today. Was it delivered to Double Xiang House?"

Aunt Fu shook her head, "I don't know about other people's business."

"Why not?" Zhou Cuihua said with a smile, "This morning, many people saw three carts carrying fresh vegetables out of the village."

“Yes,” said another woman, “Old Three and Old Four of Second Uncle Lei Family harvested vegetables in their garden early in the morning.”

Aunt Fu only lowered her head to wash the clothes and did not speak.

Fang Hongliu got frustrated. Lei-Qin Le talked a lot, but he could make people confused. Uncle Fu was also slippery. In contrast, Aunt Fu shook her head in answer to all questions. *Why is it so difficult to deal with the servants of the Lei Tie Family?*

Without any better option, she spoke directly, “Double Xiang House uses up a lot of vegetables every day, right? Our vegetables are also very fresh. Do you accept it or not?”

“Little Sister truly makes things hard for me.” Aunt Fu said apologetically, “Whatever the two young masters are going to do, why should they tell us, the servants? If you want to know, you may as well ask the two young masters.”

“I...” Fang Hongliu had nothing to say. She didn’t even dare to look at Lei Tie. Qin Mian was young, but he had tricks. She didn’t dare to provoke any of them.

Qin Mian was so thirsty that as soon he entered the gate, he rode directly home.

“Return the cart. There’s a bag of snacks. Take it along.” Lei Tie instructed Uncle Fu. Being with his wife for a long time, he also learned to experience social exchanges. In this way, he could share the worries with his wife.

“Yes.”

“Teach the newcomers what they should know. Don’t let Little Young Master worry about.”

“Yes.” Uncle Fu said, “Eldest Young Master, I’ve been thinking. When they are not training, they should take turns weeding, harvesting vegetables,

carrying water, cutting firewood, herding, and so on. In any case, we should let them do all kinds of manual work at home.”

“It’s up to you.” Lei Tie said, “Afterward, you are the steward of Leisurely Farm Residence.”

“Yes!” Uncle Fu was a little excited. “I will live up to the trust of the two young masters!”

Lei Tie urged his horse and immediately disappeared in the distance.

Qin Mian poured cooled water from the well and looked out of the hedge. He beckoned Lei Tie, “What did you do? What took you so long?”

The horse stopped outside the hedge. Lei Tie jumped straight from the horseback to him.

Qin Mian put down his cup, put his arms around the man’s neck, and looked at him with a smile, “Fly again, brother?”

Lei Tie bowed his head and pecked on his lips, “Lift your legs.”

Qin Mian immediately lifted his legs and clamped them around the man’s waist.

As soon as Lei Tie moved, they flew up.

“Hahaha...” Qin Mian began to laugh joyously. *Even if you take a plane, you can’t enjoy flying yourself!*

Lei Tie landed on the maple tree. Then he bent a little lower and flew up again before landing steadily on the taller ginkgo tree.

Qin Mian looked down curiously. Looking at Leisurely Farm Residence from a different height, it appeared more three-dimensional, more vivid, and wider. It made him want to laugh heartily.

He looked back at Lei Tie. Lei Tie gazed fixedly at him with a silent deep love look.

He cocked up the corner of his mouth, took a bite on the man's lip, and gently licked it. His tongue boldly poked into the man's mouth to seek the man's tongue.

Lei Tie turned and pressed him on the tree trunk before kissing him deeply.

Lei-Qin Le came to lead the horses and said in a loud voice outside the hedge, "Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master, I come to ask if you want vegetables?"

Not receiving an answer, he scratched his head as he said, "Not here?"

A green leaf fell from the tree and landed on his shoulder. He patted it away and led the horses to the stable.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Lei Daqiang is the second son, so the villagers called him Second Lei or Second Uncle Lei

Chapter 099: Getting Rich First to Drive Others to be Rich

099 – Getting Rich First to Drive Others to be Rich

Brought to you by TucTuc <3

After careful consideration, Qin Mian decided on the types of food to sell after halting the selling of spicy hot soup, hot pot, and barbecue in the restaurant. They were noodles, dumplings, steamed stuffed buns, meat burgers, steamed dumplings, steamed sponge cake, and daily soup. The noodles were the first unique colored noodles. Colored noodles were not difficult to make. For example, to make green noodles, squeezed the juice of green vegetables into the flour, kneaded them into a dough, let it rest for about a quarter of an hour, and then pressed them out with a noodle machine. Other than that, pumpkin made into yellow noodles, purple amaranth made into purple noodles, and even fruit juice could add appropriately into these. Besides containing rich nutrition, it had an exquisite taste while giving the diner a beautiful visual to enjoy. Dumplings and steamed stuffed buns were popular with children and mainly focused on the stuffing. The meat burgers, steamed dumplings, and steamed sponge cakes were not yet available in this world.

As for the soup, the seasoning was the most important thing. Eating meat burgers, steamed dumplings, and steamed sponge cake made one feel thirsty. After buying soup, one could also immensely enjoy eating. The business of the restaurant would be good with these special menu put on the signboard.

After writing all the details on the paper, Qin Mian asked Lei-Qin Le to give it to Yue Dong in the town.

It was the first ten days of the sixth month. The families that had cultured paddy seedlings early had already planted them; those who were late still trampled on the mud in the paddy field.

After buying all the bricks, tiles, and timber needed to build the house, Qin Mian let Steward Fu ask the villagers who had finished farming to help build the house. The villagers were very happy. They had been getting along for such a long time, so they all knew that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were generous. The payment for working for them should not be bad.

The construction started in the bedroom as they needed to make a passage from the bedroom on the first floor. Qin Mian and Lei Tie temporarily moved to the central room; it was for outsiders to see. At night, they would rest in the space. The modern double bed in the space was more comfortable than the heatable brick bed outside.

Looking at the workers enthusiastically working in the distance, Steward Fu carefully explained to Lei-Qin Zhong's group, "During this time, people come and go in Leisurely Farm Residence. We must watch out for these. Don't let them harm the things in the garden."

Lei-Qin Zhong was the eldest and also the calmest of the nine armed-servants. "Steward Fu, don't worry. We will secretly watch them."

Over there, Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di, Fang Wu, and Jiang Dayou chatted while building the wall. It was the first time they came in after the walls of Leisurely Farm Residence were built. Envy and admiration wedged in their words, but there was a sense of pride in their hearts. It was not the first time they worked for Lei Tie Family. So what did it mean? It meant that Qin Mian and Lei Tie valued them the most from among other villagers. As long as they got along well, they could surely benefit from the association in the future.

Uncle Fang led Qin Mian and Lei Tie to check the peach trees in the orchard. The weather was good recently. The peaches were turning more pinkish.

Uncle Fang laughed cheerfully and affirmatively said, “Tiezi and Tiezi’s wife, it can’t be wrong. We can harvest the honey peaches in four or five days.” Ever since he started working in the orchard, his spirit got increasingly better. Occasionally, he got some fruits from the owner. He also felt comfortable in body and mind and even appeared younger. His peers in the village were envious of him.

“Then, we have to get large baskets and ladders ready in advance,” Qin Mian said to Lei Tie.

Lei-Qin Shun said, “I will inform Steward Fu later.” There were only six cherry trees. When they harvested the cherries, they only made six double ladders temporarily. It was not enough now, so they had to go to the town to order it in advance. There were many fruit trees in the garden, but the double ladders were too few.

After finishing the main issue, Uncle Fang pondered for a moment and then looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, “There is one more thing. Many people asked me to inquire. This old man wants to ask for them.”

Qin Mian chuckled. He motioned to Uncle Fang to walk under the shade of a tree, lest he caught in the heat. “Uncle Fang, you want to ask the matter about vegetables?”

“Haha.” Uncle Fang said, “I say, Tiezi’s wife is clever. Tiezi and Tiezi’s wife, you don’t blame the villagers for thinking like this. They are people who have been poor for most of their lives. Naturally, they want to find a way to earn more money.”

Lei Tie nodded lightly.

Qin Mian said, “Uncle Fang, don’t worry. We understand. But you have *crossed more bridges* than we did; you are an experienced elder. You must be able to guess what’s going on in Double Xiang House. It’s an indisputable fact that local customers are limited. Currently, Double Xiang House does need a lot of vegetables. As you also know, we grow a lot of it in our house.”

Uncle Fang nodded his head, "That's so. Rest assured, I will make it clear to them so they will understand. You're busy. I'll go there again."

Qin Mian stood in the shade of the tree, frowning slightly.

Lei Tie lifted his (QM) head and gently rubbed between his eyebrows with his thumb, "Worry?"

Lei-Qin Shun sensibly fell behind.

Qin Mian held Lei Tie's other hand and carefully said to him, "A-Tie, besides Eating Savory Restaurant, we have Double Xiang House. If we do other profitable businesses, the imbalance in the hearts of the villagers will intensify. Some people will surely think so. We are from the same village, and we used to farm like everyone else. But why are we so rich now and they are so poor? Those who are not in the right mind may even sabotage us secretly. We can't expect to be as close as family with all the villagers, but at least we should live in peace with them. So, I have a plan. When we have a firm foothold, I will give other villagers an idea and drive the whole village to be rich together. In this way, they don't have time to envy us. It's just that it's not the right time for us. But some villagers seem unable to hold back."

Lei Tie said, "Start from Li Zheng [the village head]."

The remark awakened Qin Mian with a start. There were too many things that happened in this time that Qin Mian had forgotten Li Zheng. He stroked his chin and thought.

Lei Tie pointed out, "Li Zheng's two sons are good."

Suddenly, Qin Mian laughed. Seeing that no one was around, he gave the man a quick kiss on the lips, "I have an idea! First of all, we help Li Zheng Family, Brother Zhang Family, and Wu Di Family to get rich, making the three families and our family form a four-footed balance of forces. Later, we can let them distract the villagers' attention from us. Secondly, it is also good for us to get rich first and drive others to be rich in the future. What do you think?"

“Four-footed balance of forces. Good.” After Lei Tie nodded, he frowned, “But, it’s hard for you to think of ideas to help the three of them to make money.”

Qin Mian’s eyes glowed with self-confidence. “Don’t forget where I came from; this is not a problem. We know the situation of Brother Zhang Family and Wu Di Family, but I don’t know much about Li Zheng Family.”

“Lei-Qin Shun,” Lei Tie called Lei-Qin Shun.

“What is your command, Eldest Young Master?”

Qin Mian said, “Find out things about Li Zheng Family as soon as possible. If you don’t know how to do it, you can ask Uncle Fu.”

“Yes. Thank you for your advice, Little Young Master.”

“Go ahead.”

After laying down his worry, Qin Mian felt much better. He took Lei Tie to the flower bed and said, “I don’t know what’s going on in the old house. If the Third Brother and Fourth Brother have separated, we must support them first. They are pitiful.”

Lei Tie saw Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Xin just come back from herding.

“Ask Lei-Qin Le.”

“Yes, that fellow is the most inquisitive.” Qin Mian also saw Lei-Qin Le. It was unknown what he said with Lei-Qin Xin that made them laugh. Qin Mian waved him over.

Lei-Qin Le saw it and handed the ox rope to Lei-Qin Xin and came running.

“Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master!”

“What’s the situation at ‘that side’?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei-Qin Le said in a low voice, “I was about to report this to Young Masters. Yesterday morning, ‘that side’ bought a 15-year-old maid.”

“I know that.” Qin Mian said, “How’s the maid?”

Lei-Qin Le said, “The maid is called Xiaoxi. Old Master bought her to take care of Madam Wei. As soon as Xiaoxi came, Old Madam Du tried to win her over. Yesterday afternoon, she not only secretly gave Xiaoxi a big chicken drumstick but also gave her 10 Wen. This morning, she asked Xiaoxi to take advantage of Madame Wei’s inattention and let her fall accidentally...”

Qin Mian was shocked, and his heart turned cold. He knew that Wei Shi’s pregnancy had an impact on Du Shi, but he never thought that Du Shi would dare to have such an idea!

Lei Tie stared at Lei-Qin Le as he said in a cold voice, “Presumptuous! Do you know what you can say and what you can’t say?”

Qin Mian pushed aside the willow twigs in front of him and kept silent. He understood that A-Tie wasn’t speaking up for Du Shi. After getting along for such a long time, he and A-Tie both believed that Lei-Qin Le was not a person who didn’t know the gravity of things. However, they still needed to knock some senses into him, lest he made mistakes due to carelessness.

Lei-Qin Le’s face drastically changed. He knelt on the ground with a plop and anxiously said, “Eldest Young Master, what I said is true. If there is half a lie, you and Little Young Master may sell me off.”

Lei Tie looked cold and silent.

Qin Mian asked again, “Afterward, what happened?”

Lei-Qin Le said, “Xiaoxi disagreed and told Madam Wei about it. Madam Wei was angry. In front of Old Master, Madam Wei said she had arranged Xiaoxi earlier, for fear Du Shi would bribe anyone they bought. It turned out that Xiaoxi was the younger sister of Madam Wei’s good friend when she was a maid.”

Qin Mian shook his head slightly. As expected, Du Shi and Wei Shi were not on the same level. “How do you know such a secret thing?”

“The sound of their quarrel was so loud that the neighbors could hear Madame Wei’s words clearly,” said Lei-Qin Le.

Qin Mian squinted; it’s kind of interesting. In other words, Wei Shi intended to make the matter known to all. This way, Du Shi not only dared not to harm her child but also helped to take good care of them. Otherwise, once something went wrong with Wei Shi’s stomach, even if Lei Daqiang believed it was not Du Shi’s doing, many people in the village would not believe her. By then, Du Shi’s reputation would completely discredit.

As expected, Wei Shi was smart. However, Du Shi’s failure to see Wei Shi’s weakness did not mean that Qin Mian couldn’t see it either. Therefore, he was not worried that Wei Shi would come to provoke him and Lei Tie.

Chapter 100: New Room Exclusive for Summer

100 – New Room Exclusive for Summer

Brought to you by MCJohnston <3

Qin Mian asked, “Do you know why Eldest Young Master made you kneel?”

Little Young Master spoke while smiling, which meant he and Eldest Young Master was not seriously criticizing him. Lei-Qin Le nodded his head, “I understand. Eldest Young Master wants to tell me that a loose tongue may cause a lot of trouble.”

“Good if you understand.” Qin Mian walked to the stone table and sat down, enjoying the gentle cool breeze.

“Get up.” Lei Tie shot a glance at Lei-Qin Le and walked to his wife.

“Many thanks, Eldest Young Master.” After that, Lei-Qin Le shouted to Qin Mian, “Many thanks, Little Young Master!”

Then, he left like a wisp of smoke, still in that lively appearance.

He was a smart man. Qin Mian believed that he would be more cautious in the future.

He leaned on Lei Tie, groped his chin, and teased, “Next time, I play the role of the villain. Otherwise, everyone will be more afraid of you.”

“It doesn’t matter.” Lei Tie hugged him, unconcerned.

Qin Mian had people sent a letter to Double Xiang House. Five days later, Double Xiang House launched new desserts and drinks. When Manager Sun received the news, he naturally released it.

Uncle Fang was right. Four days later, one-third of the honey peaches were ripe. The red fruits on the trees looked as if they were smeared with rouge, really beautiful. And not only each of them was big, but it was also heavy.

Qin Mian plucked a peach and peeled it. The flesh inside was bright red in white. He took a bite. it was moist and sweet, that could make his heart sweet. Although it was not as good as the one in the space, it also tasted awesome.

“It’s delicious. A-Tie, taste it too.”

Lei Tie lowered his head and took a bite near the nick he had bitten. He nodded, “It’s delicious.”

Qin Mian was speechless, “I was asking you to pick another one.”

“Aren’t they all the same?” Lei Tie said with a puzzled expression.

Qin Mian’s lips twitched, “There are so many fruits on the tree, must you grab mine?”

“Save those to sell.”

Qin Mian wiped his sweat.¹ Had he fallen to the point where he couldn’t support his man?

Lei Tie’s head leaned over and took another big bite.

Qin Mian opened his mouth and took a bite on the man’s lips, leaving a tooth print.

Lei-Qin Le saw it. He hurriedly stepped back a few steps and reported loudly without squinting, “Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master.”

Lei-Qin Shun and a few others behind him, carrying baskets and ladders, very perceptively lowered their heads.

“En,” Qin Mian quickly pushed Lei Tie’s head away, “Pick the reddest fruits for two baskets and make peach jam later.”

“Yes.”

Lei-Qin Hui, Lei-Qin Jian, Lei-Qin Li, and Lei-Qin Yuan carried the baskets, while Lei-Qin Gong, Lei-Qin Shun, Lei-Qin Cheng, and Lei-Qin Xin climbed up the ladders to pick peaches.

The villagers who were building the wall in the distance could vaguely see the peach-picking happening here and felt a little regretful. Now that Lei Tie Family had bought so many people, there was no need to ask the villagers to pick fruits.

“Oh, this old man is too late. You’re already picking them.” Uncle Fang strode with a vigorous pace.

“Uncle Fang is here. I’ve agreed with the wine house to deliver fruit jam tomorrow, so we have to make it today.” Qin Mian picked a big honey peach from the tree and gave it to Uncle Fang along with a small fruit knife. “Taste it. Half of this is your contribution.”

“This old man doesn’t dare to claim it. I’m merely doing my duty.” Uncle Fang took the peach and the fruit knife, “But I still want to taste it.”

His hands were very dexterous. The fruit knife flexibly turned on the peach for a few laps before it was completely peeled. Not only that, the peeled skin that fell on the ground was whole.

Uncle Fang took a bite and praised without cease, “Mm! It is juicy and sweet! Good!”

Lei-Qin Shun and the others inwardly drooled.

Qin Mian handed the fruit knife from Uncle Fang to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie silently took the fruit knife, picked the reddest and biggest one, and also peeled off the whole fruit skin before handing the skinless peach to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder in praise.

Uncle Fang watched them to the point he laughed.

After plucking two large baskets of peaches, Qin Mian let Lei-Qin Le give two peaches to each of the servants. He picked up a basket of peaches based on the number of people in Uncle Fang's family to give him and then told Uncle Fu to send a basket to Li Zheng.

The method of making peach jam and cherry jam was practically the same. There was no secret. After Qin Mian showed it to Aunt Fu once, he gave her the task of making peach jam and assigned Lei-Qin Shun to watch the fire for her.

Early the next morning, the couple personally delivered peaches and peach sauce to Double Xiang House.

Manager Sun bought some ice cubes in advance and chilled the peach jam. After having the staff squeezed the peaches into juice, it was also served with ice cubes.

No more than a quarter of snake hour², the number of customers increased. As soon as the customers entered the door, they were attracted by the round table in the middle of the lobby. In the center of the round table was a huge round tower-shaped steamed sponge cake. There were six tiers. From below to top order was yellow, brown, pink, purple, red, and white. The top layer was painted with a bright and attractive peach jam with unique patterns. There were flowers and birds. It was both artistic and unique. There were eight dessert plates placed around the cake. Each plate was filled with different colored sponge cakes cut into different shapes, such as triangles, parallelograms, squares, and circles. What these sponge cakes had in common was that each piece was laden with pink peach jam. It made people want to swallow and taste as soon as they saw it.

There was also a ceramic glaze cup on the round table with peach juice, filled inside until 70% full. One could vaguely see the ice cubes inside. Now that the weather was getting hotter, wouldn't it be a pleasure to drink a refreshing drink right away after coming in from under the sun?

Qin Mian and Lei Tie deliberately chose a two-person dining table closer to the door. On the table were two meat dishes, a vegetarian dish, a soup, two plates of dessert, and two glasses of peach juice with ice. It looked simple but their carefree dining manner made eyes attracted to their table as if it was a great enjoyment to have such a meal.

Immediately, the impatient customers hurriedly took a seat, ordered a few dishes, and added a few desserts and a glass of peach juice.

Dean Huo brought a woman into the door. Upon seeing that there were no empty seats in the lobby, he inwardly clicked his tongue. Madam Huo saw the sponge cake tower and walked over in surprise.

“Husband, this Double Xiang house is very extraordinary. This is the first time I have seen this kind of dessert. Just looking at it like this makes me feel great.”

Dean Huo laughed, “Hahaha. After you have tasted the dishes here, you will feel that this trip is even more worthwhile. Madam, since there are no seats in the lobby, let's go to the private room.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie saw them. The two did not go to welcome them in person but avoided them. Lei Xiangzhi was still studying in the academy. They had better avoid arousing suspicion when they ought to.

When Dean Huo and his wife went to the second floor, Qin Mian instructed Manager Sun to give them the same desserts as theirs and a small basket of fruit. The basket was small and exquisite, which could hold three to four peaches.

“The response is good,” Lei Tie said to Qin Mian.

“Yes. I heard from Manager Sun just now that the private rooms on the second floor are almost full.” Qin Mian looked pleased, “Afterward, we don’t have to come in person to send the fruits and jam. We can just be the arm-flinging shopkeepers³.” Ever since Double Xiang House sold cherry jam and cherry juice, there had been wine houses in town and county town imitated them, but the taste was very different. Moreover, Double Xiang House did not specifically set a high price. Thus, they did not cause a significant impact on Double Xiang House.

“If you don’t want to come afterward, I will.” Lei Tie led him to the lounge.

“En.” Qin Mian nodded with a smile.

A week later, the new room was built. Besides paying the helpers enough wages, Qin Mian gave two big and red peaches to each of them. The helpers all left happily.

On the occasion of having a newly built room, Qin Mian had Uncle Fu distributed three peaches to each of the servants.

Since it was just an addition to the house, there was no need to host a house-warming party this time. After the new room dried, the couple placed the furniture one by one.

A passage about 1.5 meters wide was made inside the original bedroom. At the end of the passage was a half-room-sized entrance hall. On the left side of the entrance hall was the guest room, and next to the wall on the right was a wooden ladder leading to the second floor.

On the second floor, there was a small reception hall, which acted as a buffer area between the stairs and the large room. It would be a bit awkward when one climbed the staircase and directly saw the bedroom’s door. The layout of the small reception hall was mainly simple with only a set of settees and two potted plants.

The big room on the second floor was precisely Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s bedroom, so they emphasized on it.

The floor was covered with wood, the door was in the north, and there were floor-to-ceiling windows with white curtains on the north and south walls. The indoor was both airy and bright. A large wardrobe inlaid with a full-length mirror leaned against the north wall; the headboard of the double bed was also next to the north wall with its end faced the south. A tall bookshelf leaned against the east wall, with a total of six layers – there were not many books on it at the moment. Two rattan chairs and a rattan table were placed in front of the bookshelf, making it convenient to read here.

The south floor-to-ceiling window could be opened by sliding to the left or right, which also could be used as a door. Outside was a balcony with two clothed lounge chairs, a round wooden table, and a few potted flowers. In the summer evenings, it couldn't be more relaxing to drink tea, chat, and cool off here.

Also, the original bathroom was demolished, and the original utility room was converted into a bathroom because a large storehouse was built.

That night, Qin Mian and Lei Tie moved to the new bedroom. In summer, the south wind blew. They didn't have to paste papers on the hollow carved windows. Not to mention, it was pleasantly cool.

Qin Mian had just taken a shower. He threw off his shoes and fell on the soft bed with his limbs wide open as he let out a pleasing sigh. He smuggled out this king-size bed out of the space and put on a bedsheet so that no one would notice the difference in the bed itself. Besides, no one would dare to come into their bedroom. If he had clothes, bedsheets, or quilts to wash, he would put them downstairs in advance.

He turned his head and beckoned Lei Tie, "Come. Try it."

Before he could say the third sentence, Lei Tie pounced on him. He turned him over, easily grabbed a large pillow, and placed it under his wife's waist.

"Woah! The throw-pillow is not used like that." Qin Mian was like a frog on its back, unable to get up after struggling for a good while.

“Isn’t my wife saying to be diligent and thrifty? Make the best use of everything.” Lei Tie faintly said and lowered his head to start eating.

“Awoo?”

Lei Tie turned his head to look.

White Spot opened its mouth, and the wolf’s lair it bit fell to the ground. Its wolf’s lair was designed by Qin Mian and he commissioned Lei Chuntao to make it. It was made of brown soft cloth and cotton. It looked like an upside-down shiitake mushroom without the pedicle. White Spot silently used its two forelegs and pushed the “mushroom”. After carrying it to the side of the big bed, it looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with innocent eyes.

“Hahaha...” Qin Mian was overjoyed.

Lei Tie expressionlessly jumped out of bed. The index and middle fingers of his right hand clamped the mushroom, and with a quick throw, the mushroom flew out of the floor-to-ceiling window.

“Awoo!” White Spot howled at him before it bravely chased after it and bit the shitake in midair. Then, it landed smoothly and looked up at Lei Tie in triumph.

Lei Tie faintly glanced at it, then he closed the floor-to-ceiling window and the door.

Qin Mian lay down on the bed and sympathized with White Spot, who was locked outside. But soon, he no longer sympathized with it.

“Ah... gently... uhm...”

Woohoo! It’s the 100th chapter! Thanks, MCJohnston!

Also, a million thanks to SadieWoods!

Note:

Footnotes

1. it meant to be speechless (out of helplessness, embarrassment, etc)
2. 9-11 a.m
3. sb who asks others to work but does nothing himself

Chapter 101: Someone Wants to Buy the Honey Peaches

101 – Someone Wants to Buy the Honey Peaches

Brought to you by SadieWoods 😊

If they wanted to help Zhang Dashuan Family, Wu Di Family, and Li Zheng Family, they couldn't help them openly. The advantage of living in the countryside was that the villagers could help each other. The disadvantage was that they knew the economic conditions of others as they knew each other too well. Once the gap between the rich and the poor became too large, it was easy to lead to contradictions.

If other people knew that the sudden rise of the Zhang, Wu, and Li Zheng families was related to the Qin Mian, the village would certainly be restless. To avoid trouble, Qin Mian decided to stay behind the scenes.

Zhang Dashuan couldn't do any craftsmanship work, but he was young and vigorous, and his mind was flexible. Previously, he made a small profit by making bamboo skewers for Eating Savory Restaurant and bought a donkey cart before the busy farming season. Qin Mian thought that he could do "cart service".

The business of Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant was getting better and better. Many people came to Running Water Town from Zhaoyang County for a meal every day. Even the merchants, who passed through Zhaoyang County, heard that Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant were very famous, and would likely take a detour to have a meal there. Not only to satisfy their appetite but could also be an idle conversation topic when they got home.

More people meant more transport. Picking up and dropping off customers, he could earn at least 30 Wen per day. In a month, it could be almost a thousand Wen, which was a tael silver. Plus, there had not been a cart service yet.

Not only limited to this. Many girls and married women in the village could weave ornament knots, embroider insoles, embroider handkerchiefs, and make embroidered pouches, right? Women were inconvenient to go out and usually had to take care of the housework and did not have much time to go to the market. While running the service, Zhang Dashuan could help them sell these small items. And perhaps, people from other places liked the local embroidery style? Every time he sold an item, he earned some money, which was another income.

The Wu Family was a little more difficult to handle. Wu Di himself didn't know any craftsmanship. Qin Mian didn't want to take Wu Di into his business, so he gave this family an idea to raise earthworm-fed chickens. Currently, people raised chickens as their food and only knew how to feed the chickens with rotten vegetables and leaves. At most, they gave some leftovers of brown rice. The cost of breeding earthworm was low, so it was suitable for a family with an average financial situation as his.

He discovered from the inquiry that Li Zheng's eldest son was a bamboo craftsman, and his second son was a cotton craftsman. Li Zheng had foresight after his two sons were born. To avoid them competing for family property in the future, Li Zheng arranged for the two sons to learn different skills when he found out that they were not gifted in learning. Unfortunately, these days, life was not easy. Craftsmen were only a little better than ordinary people, but the competition between them was also big. When the two sons grew up, they were still mainly engaged in farming. When it was not farming season, they found some casual jobs to do and earned money enough to buy oil and salt.

Normally, when the villagers wanted to weave baskets or fluff up their old quilts again, they usually asked for these two men. Qin Mian's idea for Li Zheng's eldest son was to weave bamboo into various designs, or dye them with different patterns to make them more exquisite and artistic, including large bamboo baskets, bamboo cylindrical baskets, bamboo mats, and reed

mats. At the same time, he also gave away some drawings of woven products he had seen in his previous life for free. For more patterns, it relied on the eldest son to fumble about.

Qin Mian gave Li Zheng's second son a drawing of a cotton gin that could be operated by hand or by foot. Namely, a cottonseed remover. It was also regarded as keeping his old profession. The principle of the ginning machine was not complicated. Qin Mian remembered that when he was very young, his grandfather had an old manual seed remover, and he had seen his grandfather dismantle and clean it. This machine was one and only. It could certainly make a lot of money.

Of course, Qin Mian asked Uncle Fu to inform the three families in private. The three families did not know that one of Qin Mian's intentions was to distract the villagers' attention. They only thought Qin Mian and Lei Tie offered it to them because of their good relationship (Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di) and status (Li Zheng). They were both grateful and moved. They would not leak such a good money-making idea even without anyone reminded them. Everyone understood the principle of "the rarer something was, the greater its value".

After settling the matters, Qin Mian went to Zhao Wenzhong's home with a basket of peaches.

It was hot in the summer. The villagers usually kept their gate/doors open to cool off. Qin Mian arrived at the courtyard gate, and before he could open his mouth, Zhao Wenzhong's wife, who was sitting at the door of the central room trimming vegetables, stood up in surprise. She warmly welcomed him as she wiped her hands on her clothes.

"Lei Tie's wife is here. Such a rare visitor. Come in and have a seat." She called out to the side room, "Family head, a guest is here."

Qin Mian handed her the basket and said with a smile, "Sorry for intruding, aunt. This is a little gift. I hope you don't dislike it."

"Just come if you want to come, why do you bring something, too? Still regard us as outsiders?" Zhao Wenzhong's wife put the basket aside and

quickly poured him a cup of herbal tea. “Here, have a cup of tea to cool off the heat.”

Zhao Wenzhong sat on the summer sleeping mat, playing with his three-year-old grandson. After putting on shoes, he went out carrying his grandson.

“Uncle Zhao.” Qin Mian’s eyes fell on the child, “Is this your grandson? He looks very strong.”

“This kid is skinny.” Zhao Wenzhong patted the child on the buttocks and handed him to his wife.

“Grandpa, I want to eat the big peach!” The child’s hands clung on the basket. He licked his lips.

“You only know to eat,” Zhao Wenzhong’s wife scolded with a smile. “Grandma washes it first. Lei Tie’s wife, you two talk. Excuse me for a moment.”

“Help yourself, aunt.”

Zhao Wenzhong’s wife picked up her grandson, carried the basket, and went to the kitchen in the courtyard.

“You and Lei Tie are the most popular people in the village now. It’s a great honor to have you sit in my home, so you don’t have to bring anything,” Zhao Wenzhong joked. Long ago, he was very polite to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Facts had proved that he did the right thing. Later, he truly benefitted from association with the Lei Tie Family.

Qin Mian smilingly said, “Uncle Zhao is joking. I wouldn’t come to you for nothing.”

“Oh? Is there anything else I can help you with?” Zhao Wenzhong guessed in his heart but could come out with anything, “Tell me. As long as it is within my ability, I will not refuse.”

“It’s really within your ability.” Qin Mian said bluntly, “I want to buy your old house.”

Zhao Wenzhong felt strange. *Lei Tie Family’s house is not small. They are buying an old house for what? It is definitely not for living in. Is it for business? This small village already has tofu shops, wine shops, and fish farmers. Can there be other business opportunities?* After thinking for a moment without an answer, he did not hesitate, “Sure. It is a waste to leave the house empty. I will sell it to you. The pond belongs to us too. If you want it, you can buy it together.”

“I have that intention. How much does it suit you?” Qin Mian knew this meeting would be very smooth. His expression remained unchanged that some people could not see the depth of his profound temperament.

Zhao Wenzhong was very frank, “3 silver taels will be enough.”

Qin Mian was surprised, “That won’t do. Let’s forget the pond. Although the house is old, its wall and tiles also are not too damaged. It’s worth more than this price.”

Zhao Wenzhong intended to have a deep friendship with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. After hearing that, he appreciated Qin Mian’s conduct more. He cheerfully laughed, “Speaking of the roof tiles, you replaced a lot of them with the new ones when you lived there. Selling the house with the pond for 3 silver taels is not a loss at all.”

Seeing that he was not pretending to be generous, Qin Mian no longer refused and happily said, “Then, I’ll take up Uncle Zhao’s favor. Since your grandson likes peaches very much, I’ll send you another basket when I go back later.”

Zhao Wenzhong gladly said, “That would be nice.”

Qin Mian gave him 3 silver taels and got the title deed of the old house.

As soon as he left, Zhao Wenzhong’s wife went back to the central room with her grandson in her arms. After asking what it was about, she also

thought it was a good deal. The empty house therein slowly broke down. They could even get another basket of peaches, which meant giving them a lot of honor!

At the gate of Leisurely Farm Residence, a horse carriage came from afar slowly stopped before a coachman and a manservant jumped down from the shaft. The manservant moved a footstool and put it on the ground.

A middle-aged man with a long black beard dressed in a grey robe with slanting lapels came down from the carriage. His bright eyes flashed a spark as they swept across the “Leisurely Farm Residence” on the walls and nodded slightly.

The manservant came forward and knocked at the gate.

“Is anybody there?”

Lei-Qin Zhong opened the gate, “Who are you looking for?”

The manservant took out a small money pouch from his sleeve pocket and put it into his hand. His mouth was very sweet, “Big brother, may I ask if Boss Lei and Boss Qin of Double Xiang House live here?”

Lei-Qin Zhong’s face remained unchanged as he received the small pouch. Steward Fu taught them that they could accept the tip from the people who came visit – not accepting it would be regarded as foolish.

“Yes. Who are you?”

“I’ll have to trouble you to inform them that Manager Wei from Zhaoyang County came to visit.”

“Hold on, I’ll report to Master.” Lei-Qin Zhong closed the gate and ran to the grove.

Lei Tie led the armed servants to train. Lei-Qin Shun and the others stood in the sun, all sweating profusely. Even basking under the sun, they worked hard. Still, training like this for a long time also showed a significant result.

Compared to before, everyone had become stronger and sturdier. They stood very upright, just like small poplars.

Lei Tie was dressed in all black, brisk as usual.

Lei-Qin Zhong walked to him and said, “Reporting, Eldest Young Master. There is a manager, who claimed to be from Zhaoyun County, asking to meet. He wants to buy some fruits from Leisurely Farm Residence.”

“Not meeting.” Lei Tie said, “Next, horse stance for an hour.”

“Yes!”

Lei-Qin Zhong quickly ran back to the gate. He opened the gate and said, “Our Master said that our fruits are not for sell.” Then he closed the gate.

“Hey—you!” Before the manservant finished his words, the gate was closed. He could only go back to Manager Wei, “Manager, did you see that?”

Manager Wei frowned. He had heard that the fruits of Leisurely Farm Residence were only for Double Xiang House, but he didn’t expect they didn’t even give him a chance to discuss.

Qin Mian strolled back under the shade of the trees and puzzledly saw several people standing in front of his house. But he asked nothing, went straight to the gate, and knocked. Since Lei Tie did not invite these people in, there must be some reasons. He hadn’t realized that his relationship with Lei Tie had reached a very deep level. Their trust in each other was just like breathing itself – without any doubt.

“Open the gate.”

Chapter 102: Made Vermicelli

102 – Made Vermicelli

Brought to you by SadieWoods 😊

Lei-Qin Zhong opened the gate and deeply bowed with folded hands, “Little Young Master, you are back.”

“En.”

Qin Mian was about to enter the gate when he was stopped.

“Please wait.”

Manager Wei¹ had just secretly measured up this young man. Hearing Lei-Qin Zhong called him “Little Young Master”, he immediately confirmed his identity. Instantly, he cupped his hands in salute and let out a hearty laugh. For businessmen, perfecting laughter that made people feel comfortable must also be a type of skill.

“You must be one of the owners of Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant: Boss Qin.”

Qin Mian had to stop and nodded his head.

“I’m Wei Fugui, the second manager of Taibai² House in Zhaoyang County. I’ve heard a lot about Boss Qin for a long time, like thunder piercing the ears.” Sun Fugui was determined to accomplish his goal for this trip. Taibai House was one of the three famous wine houses in Zhaoyang County. There were three managers in total. The chief manager was now old and had decided to step down in half a month. The new chief manager was to be chosen between him and the third. If he could negotiate the purchase of

fruit from Leisurely Farm Residence, he was sure to be the chief manager. Although they were managers, their authorities and salaries were quite different.

“It turns out to be Manager Wei. You have overpraised me.” All businessmen valued harmony. At this moment, Qin Mian couldn’t ignore him.

Manager Wei suddenly realized that Boss Qin was open to persuasion compared to Boss Lei. He said with a smile, “I’ve heard of the beauty of Leisurely Farm Residence for a long time. May I be lucky enough to enter Boss Qin’s farm residence for a look?”

Qin Mian shook his head and looked apologetic, “Manager Wei makes it awkward for me. Since A-Tie didn’t invite you in, he has his reasons. Please don’t blame me.”

At this time, Wei Fugui also felt that he had said something inappropriate. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were a married couple. Lei Tie had already refused him. If Qin Mian let him enter, it would inevitably dishonor Lei Tie. Now, he intuitively realized that the two owners of Double Xiang House had a deep companionship, and secretly reminded himself to pay attention to this point when dealing with them.

However, he was not a person who gave up easily. He talked and laughed as usual, “I was very thoughtless. It’s my first time coming to the countryside and experiencing such beautiful rural scenery. I honestly envy Boss Qin and Boss Lei for living in such a peaceful village. I wonder if Boss Qin can take a walk with me, considering I came from afar?”

Qin Mian was not interested to stroll on the embankment of the paddy field with a stranger. He didn’t answer the question, “Could it be that Manager Wei comes for my family’s fruit?” It was not hard to guess. At present, besides the seasoning recipe, the only thing their family could cooperate with others was fruits.

“Precisely. It would be well if—” Manager Wei was a bit annoyed that this Boss Qin was also very difficult to deal with.

Qin Mian smoothly responded, “Manager Wei, to tell you the truth, it’s not only Taibai House in Zhaoyang County who wants to buy our fruits. Two days ago, a guest from Anding County even offered a high price of 50 Wen per Jin of peach, but we did not consent. Firstly, we don’t lack money. Secondly, our fruits are one of the characteristics of Double Xiang House. Thirdly, once we agree to sell fruits to one person, it will surely lead another. Will we sell or not sell it then? Therefore, we’re not going to set a precedent. Manager Wei is also a businessman, so you must be able to understand.”

His smiling face was so welcoming that it would not be good for Manager Wei to pull a long face.

“Next year, part of our fruits will be sold to outsiders. Maybe, there will be an opportunity to cooperate with Manager Wei.” Qin Mian said sincerely, “Manager Wei has come from afar; Qin is unworthy of this. Lei-Qin Zhong.”

“Your servant is here.” Lei-Qin Zhong came forward.

“Go to pick a basket of peaches and give it to Manager Wei. I wish the business of Manager Wei’s Taibai House scales new heights.”

When he did this, Manager Wei could only cup his hands and said, “Then, many thanks to Boss Qin. I hope we have a chance to cooperate in the coming year.”

Qin Mian nodded with a smile. As soon as he entered the gate, he saw Lei Tie standing not far away with his hands behind his back. He immediately smiled at the man. The man came because of worry but didn’t approach because of the trust in his (QM) ability. *You have to tightly hold on to such a man.*

He quickly walked up to Lei Tie, hooked his shoulders, and went in together.

Their paces were brisk. After closing the gate, Lei-Qin Zhong saw it and also followed after them with a brisk mood.

“Lei-Qin Zhong, don’t be too honest to outsiders. Find a nice small basket and put eight peaches in will be enough. 888; get rich.³ What a good metaphorical meaning.”

“Yes, Little Young Master!” Lei-Qin Zhong left, running.

“How are things with the Zhao Family?” Lei Tie led Qin Mian to the tree shade.

“It went very smoothly. I also bought the pond. It’s convenient to use the water later. Anyway, I have to look at the account book first. In the afternoon, I still have to see if there is anything in the house that needs to be renovated.”

“I don’t have to watch the training in the afternoon. I’ll accompany you.”

“En.”

Upon seeing Lei-Qin Li weeding grass in the orchard, Qin Mian asked him to pick a basket of peaches and send it to Zhao Wenzhong’s home.

Due to the struggle between Du Shi and Wei Shi had reached its peak, Qin Mian had never let people send honey peaches over there, even though Wei Shi was pregnant. It was to avoid Wei Shi from misunderstanding they were trying to rope her in. Before the battle situation of the old house cleared, they better stayed away from that side. Just like the cherries, he would send some over when the honey peaches stopped producing.

Back home, Qin Mian ran to the room on the second floor and opened the drawer of the desk. After he found the account book, he sat at the head of the bed and flipped it.

Lei Tie poured a cup of herbal tea and brought it upstairs. He put the cup on the table and sat beside his wife.

“By the way, we need to add more summer clothes.” While Qin Mian said this, he turned his head and his lips inadvertently rubbed against the man’s cheek. He licked his lips, “Salty.”

Such a move was no doubt an invitation to Lei Tie. He clasped his wife's nape, sealed his lips, and vigorously stirred in his mouth. His other hand, *as facile as traveling along a familiar road in a light carriage*, probed into the lapel of his wife's clothes. He pressed and pinched, sometimes gently and strongly.

Qin Mian's lips were sealed, so he could only blink to show his helplessness. *We're talking about business; how did he get into the mood?* The summer was good; the body felt lightweight. The summer was also bad; the light clothing could be taken off quickly. He had yet raised strength to resist, the man on his body had impolitely started to eat. He could only throw away the account book and hugged the man's neck.

"Hasn't it been three times this month?"

His wife still had the leisure mood to count, so Lei Tie thought that he had not done enough. He swept all the obstructing pillows on the floor and his whole person enveloped...

Nearly two hours later, Lei Tie was finally full for the time being. He picked up the exhausted Qin Mian and let him lean on his shoulder as he caressed his back.

Qin Mian panted with mouth open wide. He pushed aside the man's hair and bit hard at the side of the man's neck, "Told you to slow down, but you don't listen!"

Lei Tie gasped in surprise. His body tensed, and he asked in a deep voice, "Want to do it again?"

Qin Mian conscientiously loosened his bite, "I don't want to eat too light today."

"White gourd balls, steamed tofu, fried eggs with chives, and fried vegetables."

"You actually order food, isn't it still me who cooks?" Qin Mian drowsily rested his head on the man's shoulder.

Lei Tie was silent for a moment, “I do the dishes?”

“Don’t rob Aunt Fu’s work.”

From the past to the present, neither of them mentioned about inviting people to cook at home. They didn’t want too many outsiders. Every cooking time, one washed and one cooked, which was also a kind of delight.

“Teach me how to cook?”

Qin Mian repeatedly shook his head, “No, no.” This guy honestly had no talent in cooking. He could only cook dishes such as boiled pork slices and boiled tofu. He just added water to boil in the pot, poured some oil in, and then threw all kinds of ingredients into it. After it was thoroughly cooked, he added salt a little bit and then continued to add if it tasted bland. Stir-fry, pan-fry, and deep-fry was totally out of the question. A few days ago, the two men also tumbled about in the daytime. It was unknown whether it was a whim or something, this guy went to stir-fry dishes. As a result, he accidentally invented a new dish: quick-fried “black charcoal”.

“Pff...” Thinking of that day, Qin Mian burst into laughter.

Lei Tie massaged him, being as silent as grave.

When Qin Mian had enough rest, he went downstairs to take a bath and then made lunch.

After lunch, Lei Tie pressed him to take a nap for more than an hour before they went out.

The old house of the Zhao Family did not need much renovation compared with last year. Only a part of the tiles was crooked due to the wind, rain, snow. It could be done with little effort.

As soon as they got home, they started making homemade vermicelli. Qin Mian bought the Zhao Family’s old house as a vermicelli workshop.

The most common vermicelli was sweet potato and potato. Today, they were going to make sweet potato vermicelli. It was not difficult to carry out because there was a guide book in the space.

The first step was to make sweet potato flour. Washed and peeled the sweet potato. After mashing it into a paste, added a proper amount of cold water. Kept grasping and pinching the sweet potato paste by hand until the water turned turbid. Took out the sweet potato paste with a spoon and drained it. What was left in the basin was starch water. Put the sweet potato paste into another basin, added water, and repeated the previous steps until all the starch was washed out, which left the starch slurry water. Let it rest for about half an hour until the water became clear. Then, slowly poured out the water. What remained in the basin was starch slurry. The starch slurry was then placed under the sun to dry. Later, pounded it by hand and made it into sweet potato flour. Next, added some cold water into the sweet potato flour to make it mushy and mixed until it was well-blended into a dough. Used the noodle machine to press the dough into strips and boiled it. While boiling, simultaneously added water and stirred.

Near noon the next day, the first made vermicelli dried under the sun. At noon, it was cooked to see how it turned out.

The most common dishes made with vermicelli were “Ants on the Tree”⁴ and braised pork with vermicelli and cabbage. Summer was not the season to eat cabbage. Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to pick a cabbage from the space. He also cooked a small serving of hot pot and threw a handful of vermicelli into the hot pot – it must taste good.

The homemade vermicelli was clean and hygienic. It tasted almost the same as those bought in the previous world. The two men loved it and cleanly wiped out the three dishes.

The production method of potato vermicelli and sweet potato vermicelli was practically the same, and the taste was good too.

Note:

Footnotes

1. the said 魏掌柜 Manager Wei, but here and below, he's 孙掌柜 Manager Sun. But since we already have a Manager Sun, I corrected it. FYI, this book has a lot of typos.
2. ancient name for Venus
3. Original is 八八八[ba], 发发发[fa]. In Cantonese, the number 8 [八] and rich [发] sound alike, therefore "888" is just like "I will get rich".
Source: clspod.com
4. a Beijing dish of spicy ground beef sauce poured over deep-fried tofu skin

Chapter 103: Purchasing Sweet Potatoes and Potatoes

103 – Purchasing Sweet Potatoes and Potatoes

Brought to you by SadieWoods <3

Qin Mian hired eight women in the village to make sweet potato starch and potato starch from sweet potatoes and potatoes. Two people for peeling and the other two for cutting. Another four people mashed and made the starch. This time, he didn't hire the people he had been hired before. Instead, he changed to several other people, who were also of good character and diligent in work. This way, he could maintain the balance in the village. The latter step was more critical. Qin Mian made the servants be in charge of it, not afraid of them revealing the secret.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were responsible for the purchase of the potatoes and the sweet potatoes. Lei Tie checked and weighted, while Qin Mian kept accounts and paid the money.

After the matter was planned properly, Qin Mian had people release the news. If they purchased too many, it would be inconvenient to store. Therefore, they purchased once every two days.

This day, he came to the gate with his writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone. Meanwhile, Lei Tie carried a box of copper coins that he specially went exchange in the town. Uncle Fu brought a set of tables and chairs and put them under the shade of the trees.

Early in the morning, the villagers harvested sweet potatoes and potatoes from their houses before coming to Leisurely Farm Residence and lined up

at the gate. Summer was not the fruiting period of sweet potatoes. Most of these sweet potatoes were stored in their cellars in winter. The price was a little higher. The sixth lunar month was the ripening period of potatoes, and potatoes brought by many villagers were still stained with a bit of soil. At this time of the year, the farmers harvested potatoes. Having too much of it wouldn't worth money, so they never thought of selling. They just served it as a dish on their table. But now, Leisurely Farm Residence wanted to buy the potatoes, which they could exchange with money without even going out. Everyone was smiling.

The villagers happily chatted, asking each other how many potatoes and sweet potatoes they had brought, what they were going to do with the money, and so on. At this time, the Leisurely Farm Residence's gate was bustling like a grand gathering. A few naughty boys eagerly wanted to run to the farm residence, but they were scolded by their parents and obediently played at the gate.

"Everyone, please be quiet. Let me first talk about the price of the sweet potatoes and the potatoes," Qin Mian said in a loud voice as he stood on his chair.

Lei Tie saw that his wife was only half a head higher than him, and a smile flashed past in his eyes.

The villagers immediately quieted down for fear of losing money if they missed the pricing.

Qin Mian said, "Sweet potato is 1 Wen for half a jin; potato is 1 Wen for a jin. Because it's impossible for the weigh to be in a round number, I can't break a copper into several pieces either. Therefore, if there is any remnant at the time of checking out, we will give you the round number."

"What does it mean? The remnant... is denied?" A villager asked what everyone was doubting.

Qin Mian smiled, "For example, the weight of your potatoes is 20 jin and 7 liang, so the rounding is 21 jin. In short, if there is any remnant, it will be calculated to 1 Wen."

The villagers praised Qin Mian and Lei Tie for their kindness.

Qin Mian modestly said, “You have overpraised. Everyone is a fellow villager, so we will not fool you. I will write down your name, the weight, and the total price in the account book. If there are illiterate people, you can remember the numbers and ask the literate people.”

The villagers all nodded.

“That’s good.”

“Also,” Qin Mian made clear of things, “because everyone brought different baskets with different weights, everyone will use our basket to weigh. The weight of your harvest is the total weight excluded from the weight of our basket.”

The villagers nodded again; they understood this.

Qin Mian jumped down from his chair and sat at the table. He put his brush and paper in place. “A-Tie, you weigh our basket first.”

Lei Tie weighed the basket in the presence of all, “6 liang.”

Most of the households in the village could read the scale. The two women who looked at it nodded to show that there was no problem.

“Good, now it’s time to weigh. Line up and come one by one,” Qin Mian said.

Zhou Erhao had come very early, so he was the first in the line. His potatoes were in the basket. Lei Tie picked up the potatoes one by one to check whether there were rotten places. If they were good, he put them into their family’s basket.

Some of the villagers at the back, who had thought of deceiving, quickly found a place to secretly pick out their rotten potatoes and sweet potatoes.

Zhou Erhao felt that Lei Tie’s inspection insulted him, but he didn’t dare to protest against Lei Tie. He pulled a long face and muttered, “My family’s

potatoes are good; newly dug and fresh.”

Qin Mian smilingly said, “Of course. However, there will be villagers from other villages sending potatoes and sweet potatoes in two days. By doing this way, we treat people equally and avoid unnecessary trouble. Don’t take offense, Brother Zhou.”

Zhou Erhao had nothing to say.

Checking until the bottom, Lei Tie picked out four rotten potatoes and put them aside. A few of the villagers saw it clearly and sneered.

Zhou Erhao haltingly spoke, his tongue failed him.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn’t say anything. Lei Tie hung the basket on the hook of the steelyard, and the sliding weight of the steelyard moved, “40 jin and 4 liang.”

Qin Mian truthfully wrote it down and repeated it to Zhou Erhao. “Zhou Erhao, potatoes, 40 jin and 4 liang which counted as 41 jin, 41 Wen.”

“That’s right,” Zhou Erhao said.

Lei-Qin Le quickly counted forty-one copper coins from the money box and handed them to Lei-Qin Hui. Lei-Qin Hui said it again to confirm that it was correct and gave the money to Zhou Erhao.

The weighed potatoes were loaded on the cart by Lei-Qin Zhong. After the cart was full, it was transported to the workshop.

Zhou Erhao happily took the money and put it in his pocket.

A villager at the back of the line joked with him in a loud voice, “Erhao, let’s go to the town to drink today!”

Zhou Erhao picked up the rotten potatoes back into his basket. “Another day. The potatoes on the farm haven’t been completely dug yet.”

“Next.”

Du Shi and Zhao Shi each carried a basket and put them on the ground. There were sweet potatoes in one basket and potatoes in the other.

The villagers all fell silent and craned their necks. There was a feeling in their hearts that this pair of mother-in-law and daughter-in-law would cause trouble again.

Lei Tie also checked hers one by one.

Du Shi put on a dead face and snorted coldly. Her voice was sharp, “Eldest, we are your family. Surely, I won’t use the rotten ones to deceive you? Doesn’t it look bad for you to check one by one?”

The couple acted as though they did not hear her. Qin Mian looked down at the account book while thinking *if there are rotten ones, the one who looks bad is you*. The movement of Lei Tie’s hands was ceaseless.

Zhao Shi thought of the rotten potatoes and sweet potatoes mixed at the bottom and felt a little flustered. All of a sudden, she became clever and quietly pushed the basket to Du Shi’s back. Anyway, she just helped to carry the basket.

As expected, there were six rotten potatoes and four rotten sweet potatoes at the bottom of the baskets, all of which could add up to 7 or 8 jin.

Quite a few of the villagers clicked their tongue.

Du Shi’s expression sunk, “It’s just rotten a bit. If you cut off the rotten parts, won’t you still eat them all the same?”

Qin Mian stood up. With a polite attitude, he said in a serious tone, “Mother, you are wrong. We buy these sweet potatoes and potatoes to sell to others for eating. Isn’t it harmful to sell rotten products to others?”

“You... It shouldn’t be that serious.” Du Shi was afraid of being found out, so her voice was much lower.

Qin Mian sat down without a comment.

“Sweet potato is 52 jin and 4 liang; potato is 60 jin and 8 liang.” Lei Tie’s indifferent voice was like hail hitting the ground.

Du Shi shuddered and did not dare to entangle with this anymore.

Qin Mian wrote with fluency as he reported, “52 jin and 4 liang of sweet potato are counted as 53 jin; it should be 79 and a half Wen but counted as 80 Wen. 60 jin and 8 liang of potato are counted as 67 jin; 67 Wen. The sum is 147 Wen.”

Lei-Qin Le took out a string of money and counted out 147 Wen.

Du Shi frowned and did not immediately receive money, “Eldest daughter-in-law, say it again.”

Qin Mian repeated it without delay.

After pondering for a long time, Du Shi nodded and took the money.

“Your Little Mother wants some peaches. I’ll go in to pick some.” With that, she went to go inside.

Qin Mian leisurely called out, “Lei-Qin Le.”

Lei-Qin Le took a basket from the back of the cart and ran to Du Shi. He cheerfully said, “Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master have prepared it earlier, Old Madam. Shall I help to carry it for you?”

Du Shi saw the basket was full, but she couldn’t sustain the weight as each peach was very big. There should be more than a dozen. Each person could only get one at most (she guessed it correctly. Qin Mian gave according to the headcount of the family). She was dissatisfied. However, Qin Mian’s preparation was exactly within the limit of “filial piety”, so she could not nit-pick a mistake. When she discovered that the villagers’ eyes fell on her, her vanity was greatly satisfied. She held up her head high as she walked out of the gate, and scolded Lei-Qin Le, “Why aren’t you keeping up with me?”

Lei-Qin Le quickly followed.

“Hey, there are still the baskets!” Zhao Shi cried out.

Lei-Qin Le pretended not to hear and attentively said to Du Shi, “Old Madam, slow down. Be careful or you’ll step on the stone and hurt your feet.”

Zhao Shi had no choice but to carry the two big baskets by herself and quickly caught up with them. She stared at the basket of peaches, for fear that there would be one less.

As soon as they left, the villagers burst into laughter.

Qin Mian bowed his head as he wrote, but the corners of his lips quietly curved.

Before noon, the villagers in several nearby villages received the news and rushed over with their sweet potatoes and potatoes.

They were busy until the evening. After seeing off the last person, Qin Mian shook his wrist. Lei Tie went over, took his hand, and massaged it.

Qin Mian leaned on the back of his chair like an idle rich man, with his legs on the table, and said to Lei-Qin Hui’s group, “You all will take over the next purchase following today’s steps. Lei-Qin Hui is responsible for the bookkeeping. Lei-Qin Zhong arranges people to take turns weighing and counting the money.”

“Yes!”

Qin Mian pondered for a moment and looked at Lei-Qin Hui. “There’s another thing.”

Lei-Qin Hui came forward, “Please tell me, Little Young Master.”

“How many words do you know?” Qin Mian asked.

Lei-Qin Hui answered, “I’d once studied in a private school for four years. I can recognize common words.”

Qin Mian said, “It’s always inconvenient for our people to be illiterate. How about you teach others to read?”

Uncle Fu, Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and the others were surprised. Lei-Qin Le’s hands even trembled. For them, learning to read was an unreachable thing, but they could have a chance now!

Thank you JuBr! 😊

Chapter 104: Vermicelli Workshop Opens

104 – Vermicelli Workshop Opens

Brought to you by SadieWoods 😊

The two masters were not the sort of people who criticized others harshly, while Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu were kind, so the servants of Leisurely Farm Residence got along well. Lei-Qin Hui was also happy for others, and said without hesitation, “I’m willing!”

“En.” Qin Mian said, “The third set of the servant’s house will be temporarily used as a school for you. Afterward, use two hours after lunchtime to study. It doesn’t have to be too complicated. First, teach some simple and commonly used words, as well as basic arithmetic.”

“Yes.” Lei-Qin Hui responded.

Uncle Fu and the others suppressed their excitement and knelt together, “Many thanks, Little Young Master and Eldest Young Master!”

Qin Mian hastily said, “Quickly get up. It’s not something that can’t be done. Uncle Fu, tomorrow you’ll arrange for people to go to the town to buy writing brushes, ink sticks, papers, and inkstones.”

Uncle Fu happily said, “Yes.”

“All right, tidy up this place.” Qin Mian stood up and felt a little hungry, “A-Tie, what do we eat in the evening?”

“There are fresh carps.”

“Then, make braised carps.”

The two said these and walked away.

Lei-Qin Le carried the money box and followed after in quite a distance.

“Awoo.”

Qin Mian glanced over his shoulder and saw a big and fleshy grey-furred rabbit in White Spot’s mouth.

“Hah-hah. White Spot came back at the right time. Let’s also make spicy rabbit meat.”

When White Spot ran up to him, he rubbed its big head in appreciation.

“Awoo.”

“Don’t worry. I’ll give you half, and the rest is made into spicy rabbit meat.” Qin Mian patted it on the head.

White Spot bit the rabbit and ran away, sending the rabbit to the kitchen.

The atmosphere between the two young masters was not so ambiguous because of the appearance of White Spot. Lei-Qin Le found a chance to speak, “Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master. There is news from the old house.”

When he said this, all three understood that it was the news of “separation”.

Qin Mian asked, “How’s it?”

“After a big fight, Old Master and Old Madam Du disagreed to separate the family. In the end, they came to a compromise that they still have to eat and do farm works together. Henceforth, the money earned by individual casual work should be owned by themselves. However, every month, Second Gongzi, Third Gongzi, and Fourth Gongzi have to give 150 Wen support money to Old Master, Old Madam Du, and Madam Wei.” Lei-Qin Le said.

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows. A monthly of 150 Wen was not a small amount for Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli.

Lei-Qin Le added, "Little Young Master, I also heard that the original agreement was to give 100 Wen to Old Master and Old Madam Du, but Madam Wei disagreed."

This was not hard to understand. Although Wei Shi had money and now pregnant, the child had yet been born. Du Shi had four sons and a daughter to which she could never compare with. If she could get more money for herself and her child, then she should grab it.

Seeing that Little Young Master had nothing else to ask, Lei-Qin Le stopped talking and sent the money box to him before excusing himself.

Lei Tie went into the kitchen to trim vegetables for cooking.

Every morning, Aunt Fu would pick some fresh vegetables from the garden. Actually, these vegetables were replaced by Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The vegetables picked from the garden were used to feed the chickens and ducks in the space. After all, the quality of the vegetables in the space was higher than that in the garden outside.

"A-Tie, what do you think Third Brother and Fourth Brother can do?" Qin Mian moved a wooden block and sat beside Lei Tie, shaking a folding fan in his hand. He helped Zhang Dashuan, Wu Di, and Li Zheng, who were neither relatives nor friends. It was inexcusable if he didn't help Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli to find a way to make money.

Lei Tie had no clue, "The two of them have no craftsmanship."

Qin Mian used his feet to hook the dustbin made by Lei Tie and brought it to his front. He put down the fan, and there were a honey peach and a fruit knife in his hands. Then, he peeled the peach with the knife.

In fact, there was still a lot that could be done in the food and drink field, but he did not want Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli to venture into the food and drink field. Since food and drink were going into the stomach, it was

better to avoid it in case there was a problem in the future and they blamed him.

“Or else, I’ll give Third Brother and Fourth Brother a recipe for charcoal burning. Most of the charcoal on the market now smoke heavily, which makes the eyes sting. The existing smokeless charcoal on the market is expensive; ordinary people can’t afford it. My recipe can guarantee that the charcoal is almost smoke-free. Third Brother and Fourth Brother are diligent people. With the recipe in hand, they will certainly make a lot of money this winter. It’s just, Lei Xiangren...” Qin Mian frowned. He didn’t have a good opinion of Lei Xiangren and his wife. But then, if he ignored Lei Xiangren, it might cause Lei Xiangren to rebound.

Lei Tie said, “Give it to Third Brother and Fourth Brother and let them call up Lei Xiangren. Also, have them make it clear that the earnings are distributed according to the amount of firewood they individually cut. The rest has nothing to do with us.”

Qin Mian nodded. Giving this recipe was like giving extreme benevolence toward the old house. Afterward, it depended on their abilities.

The next day, Qin Mian gave Lei Tie the recipe for charcoal burning and let him talk to Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. Meanwhile, he took Aunt Fu to the Vermicelli Workshop.

It was the first day for the eight female workers. They came early and cleaned up very thoroughly. Seeing Qin Mian’s arrival, they all welcomed him.

“Boss.¹”

Qin Mian did not correct their address for him. Sometimes, it was necessary to set him apart from them.

“Everyone came early.”

“Boss gave us such a good chance to make money, so we dare not be late,” said a cheerful aunt with a smile.

Qin Mian nodded and signaled Aunt Fu to open the door.

Inside the workshop, the purchased potatoes and sweet potatoes had been piled up into hills. The necessary tables and chairs, kitchen knives, peelers, wooden basins, water vats, and so on had also been properly prepared.

Qin Mian took them into the kitchen. "Henceforth, you will work in this room. In the morning, work from the fourth quarter of the dragon hour to the end of the snake hour (8:00 to 11:00); in the afternoon, work from the end of the horse hour to the end of the monkey hour (1:00 to 5:00). There's plenty of time left for you. You've got enough time to do your housework, and there's still time to make dinner before it gets dark."

The women all nodded and gratefully said, "Boss has arranged it very carefully."

Qin Mian faintly smiled, "So, let's be frank. I hope you don't be late for work every day. As you know, many people in the village want to do this work."

The women looked apprehensive.

"Your monthly salary is 300 Wen. 5 Wen will be deducted every time you are late. You should have seen the little bell under the eaves just now. The first ring of the bell is in the third quarter of the dragon hour (7:30). When you hear this sound, you must start to rush here. If you don't enter the door before the second ring in the fourth quarter of the dragon hour (8:00), it means you are late."

The women secretly admired his method and were also relieved. If they didn't pay attention to the time when they were doing things at home, they still had time to come when the bell rang.

Qin Mian threw a look at Aunt Fu.

Aunt Fu took out some gauze masks from a small basket she was holding on her arm and handed out two masks to each person.

“You have to wear masks when you are working. You are allowed to speak, but don’t delay your work. Aunt Fu will stay here. If you have any problems later, you can ask her.”

“Yes.”

After Qin Mian finished the explanation, he left.

The few women knew that Aunt Fu’s stay must have meant to monitor them. They had wanted to get close to her, but when they thought that Aunt Fu was very loyal to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, and would never say anything that should not be said, they gave up. They put on their masks, took the tools to be used, and began to get busy. 300 Wen a month was more than some men earned by carrying goods for a month outside. Thus, no one wanted to lose the job.

Qin Mian walked home and saw Lei-Qin Shun picking up eggs in the henhouse.

“Little Young Master.”

“How much did you pick up today?” Qin Mian went over to take a look.

Lei-Qin Shun answered, “31. The chickens eat well. Almost every hen lays an egg every day. Aunt Fu has already saved more than 200. I heard her saying that some will need to be sold later. Nowadays, the weather is hot, so the eggs may get spoiled after some time.”

Qin Mian stroked his chin. Spoiled? He could make salted eggs. People here could also make salted eggs, but they didn’t know how to pickle the eggs, so the taste was strange. In the past, he and Lei Tie had tasted it while eating noodles in a noodle shop, and they never ate it again.

“Well then, you go and see who else is not busy. After that, go outside and find me some loess.”

The chickens in his space could also produce eggs. Now, he had saved more than 800 eggs. He and Lei Tie couldn’t eat them all. Fortunately, the space

could keep them fresh. Since he was free today, he should just make salted eggs.

When Lei Tie came back from outside, he saw Qin Mian sitting in front of a big wooden basin full of yellow mud water. His two sleeves were pulled up and his hands were stirring in the muddy water.

“My wife, you are still playing with mud at this age.”

The corner of Qin Mian’s lips twitched, “Who’s playing with mud?”

“What are you doing?”

“Making salted eggs. You, come and help too.” Qin Mian turned his head and shouted at Lei-Qin Shun, “Bring over all the washed eggs. Lei-Qin Li, you bring over the earthen pots from there.”

“Aye.”

Lei Tie paused for a moment and then rolled up his sleeves before walking over.

“Add salt and mineral oil to the yellow muddy water. Put the washed eggs in and evenly dip them in the mud. Then put them into the earthen pot. Take them out after about 20 days, wash off the mud, and thoroughly boil to eat. This way of preserving will make the egg yolk oily, which tastes very good. The rest is also good.” Qin Mian glanced at him as he spoke.

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian raised his hand and quickly drew a dot on his (LT) face with his index finger.

Lei Tie looked at him and slightly shook his head. His hands skillfully rolled the eggs around the mud and put them in the pot.

“Little Young Master, the eggs are all washed. Leave this work to us.” Lei-Qin Shun and Lei-Qin Li rolled up their sleeves to join.

“En. After you have finished, move them to the storehouse.”

Qin Mian went to the well to wash his hands. “Is everything going well?”

Lei Tie followed him and helped him rub the mud off his hands. “En. Afterward, you don’t have to care about them.”

“Of course, we have a lot of things to do ourselves.” Qin Mian said, “I came back from the vegetable garden over there just now. The earliest batch of chili has turned red. I need to harvest them as soon as possible. Then, make them into dried chili or chili sauce, so they can be stored for a longer time.”

Lei Tie said, “Take an afternoon nap first, and then go to harvest.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. i.e. employer

Chapter 105: Whole Vermicelli Feast

105 – Whole Vermicelli Feast

Brought to you by SadieWoods 😊 😊

However, it rained for two consecutive days.

After the sky cleared, Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to the vegetable garden with baskets and straw hats. In the chili field, the first batch of chili planted accounted for about half of the land, divided into three plots. Green chili trees could reach knee-height. Each of the chilies was thin and long, hanging on the branches with its bright red color exuded warm vitality.

The two were carrying baskets in one hand and plucking chili with the other hand.

At this time, the class was still ongoing in the farm residence. The voice of Lei-Qin Shun and the others reading aloud clearly transmitted. Everyone cherished this hard-to-come-by opportunity.

Once the class ended, Lei-Qin Zhong led Lei-Qin Shun and the others to run over, carrying baskets. They saluted Lei Tie and Qin Mian and picked the chilies together.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went back with two baskets of chilies and picked another two baskets in the space. Qin Mian instructed Lei Tie to remove a basket of chili's stalks, wash them, and chop them into pieces. After that, he added a proper amount of minced garlic and salt, and put them into a clean

and dried earthen pot before sealing it. This was a simple chili sauce that could be stored for a long time.

Qin Mian also made some pickled chilies. The method of pickled chilies was simple. Washed the chilies and dried them. In a cleaned pickle jar, poured in the appropriate amount of salt, sprinkled a little Sichuan pepper powder, and then poured in the cold boiled-water. Next, put the chilies in. Lastly, added a little white wine and sealed the jar. It could be eaten in about six to seven days.

“Wife, since Aunt Fu stays in the workshop, let’s buy another person.” Lei Tie took a look at the remaining chilies.

Qin Mian only thought for a few seconds before he agreed, “Buy. Perfect timing, since we’re going to town in a few days.” After Aunt Fu went to the workshop, the work originally belonged to her in the farm residence was dropped. For example, he and Lei Tie had to work in the vegetable garden themselves. Since they had the capability, why not made themselves more comfortable?

After more than 200 jin of vermicelli were produced in the Vermicelli Workshop, Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to Double Xiang House with 100 jin of vermicelli.

When Manager Sun Maosheng saw the two owners came with something, he guessed whether it was a new dish.

“Manager Sun, how’s the business recently?”

The smile on Sun Maosheng’s face was a little reluctant, “Reporting to Little Young Master; the business is not bad. It’s just that, since it’s getting hotter now, it’s a little bit worse than before.”

Qin Mian understood that a lack of customers was Double Xiang House’s flaw. This problem had been considered before he built the wine house, and he had the countermeasure for dealing with the situation long ago. Therefore, he looked not at all conflicted, but tranquil and calm.

Manager Sun was certain of his guess, upon seeing this.

Lei Tie said something to Qin Mian before he went to make rounds of inspection.

“Since it’s hot, we’ll launch more cold dishes; pot-stewed dish, or make a cold dish feast, or a pot-stewed dish feast, and whatnot.” Qin Mian said as he walked inside. As he passed by the lobby, he glanced. He arrived late in the afternoon. At this time, one-third of the seats in the lobby was still empty.

“I’m clear about the cold dish. What is the pot-stewed dish?” Manager Sun’s eyes brightened. Anything that was specially mentioned by Little Young Master must be extraordinary.

“We’ll talk about this later. We’re launching a new dish today.” Qin Mian handed him the lottery box that had been prepared earlier. “Today, Double Xiang House is holding a lottery to reward new and old customers, with a winning rate of 30%. You tell the customers at each table to take out a card from the box. The blank card means ‘thank you for your patronage’; the card with a pattern means to win a prize. The winners will get a new dish ‘Flourishing Blossoms on the Branches’ personally made by this boss, I.”

In actuality, what he said was ‘Ants on the Tree’¹, but he thought that the name was not elegant enough, so he changed it to a new name ‘Flourishing Blossoms on the Branches’, which complimented the image.

From the name, Manager Sun couldn’t make out anything. However, when he heard it was a ‘new dish’, he was excited and immediately went out with the lottery box in his arms.

Qin Mian hurried into the kitchen and asked people to use boiling water to soften the vermicelli for later use. Not a moment later, he heard noises in the lobby.

Soon, a waiter came to report, “The customer at Table 12 won the prize.”

Qin Mian motioned to Chef Li to step aside.

The other three chefs understood that Chef Li would be in the charge of the new dish. They were not envious, because each of them was good at different cuisines. Moreover, Little Boss always treated the four of them evenly, so much so that when they performed well, Little Boss would give some recipes. One should know, this also affected their monthly commission.

Qin Mian rolled up his sleeves and washed his hands. Chef Li stood aside to observe and learn.

When the oil in the wok heated up, Qin Mian added minced ginger and minced garlic to stir-fry until it smelled fragrant. Next, he added well-marinated ground meat and stir-fried. Following that, he put a little salt, a little liquor, and fresh soup. Then, he added soft vermicelli and stir-fried. Afterward, he put a little soy sauce. Lastly, he added chopped scallion and stir-fried for a bit before serving it on a plate.

The waiter picked up the dish and delivered it to Table 12, quickly and steadily.

Over there, a waiter ran over and yelled, “Private Room 4 won the prize!”

“Dear honored customers, the new dish ‘Flourishing Blossoms on the Branches’ is delivered. Please enjoy it!”

When the four customers in Table 12 saw the vermicelli on the plate to which they had never seen before, they looked forward to the dish even more. They immediately moved their chopsticks and carefully tasted it. Their faces showed satisfaction as they repeatedly nodded.

Among them was an older person, who couldn’t help but praise, “Delicious! This noodle-like ingredient perfectly absorbs every flavor of the seasonings and the lean meat. It is soft, sleek, and tender but still slightly resilient. It’s a refreshing taste that is delightful. Good!”

Once the rest of the customers heard it, they secretly swallowed their saliva and felt upset that their luck was not good enough to win the prize.

A customer regrettably looked at the card in his hand with the stamped words 'thank you for your patronage' and the words 'Double Xiang House' on top. In the lower right corner of the card, there was a stamp of a tiny little mouse behaving like a thief. It was strange, but he didn't pay it any thought. He put the card into the lapel of his clothes and impatiently called the waiter to ask, "Waiter, what's the price of this dish? Can I order it now?"

The waiter warmly and kindly smiled, "Dear customer, this new dish is only launched today. You must give the chefs time to learn? However, our boss just said that a vermicelli feast that smells, looks, and tastes great will launch tomorrow. The whole set of dishes are made of vermicelli. If you are interested, you may as well come back tomorrow."

He spoke in a loud voice, which of course, not only for this person to hear.

The rest of the diners got the answers they wanted to hear and were satisfied, but some of them didn't know what to eat. They wished that the sky darkened and then immediately lighted up².

At dusk, the number of customers going in and out of Double Xiang House tremendously increased. Most of them came to inquire about the vermicelli dish, and the two families were rich enough to book the vermicelli feast in advance. One needed to know that a table of vermicelli feast cost 8 silver taels! It was not cheap!

Some of the old customers who decided to have dinner in Double Xiang House also pestered Manager Sun for a lottery draw. Therefore, in the evening, Qin Mian made more than a dozen 'Flourishing Blossoms on the Branches', which made him very tired.

Other restaurants and wine houses in the town could only say a few sarcastic remarks in a sour manner when they saw this situation, as they were extremely exasperated. They just couldn't beat it.

After the dinner order, Qin Mian carefully taught Chef Li how to make some dishes with vermicelli. Chef Li had been a chef for more than 20 years. He had a keen sense of cooking, so he learned quickly.

After teaching, Qin Mian asked him to serve each dish for him to taste.

“How does it taste, Little Boss?” Chef Li wiped a handful of sweat as he asked somewhat uneasily. Inwardly, he respected Little Boss. It was said that this kind of ingredient – vermicelli – was invented by Little Boss and Big Boss. Because this was a new ingredient, he was not confident even if he was experienced.

After Qin Mian tasted one by one, he showed a smile on his face and nodded, “Pretty good. If the full score is 10, you get 9 points.”

Chef Li had a reassuring smile on his face, “Then I can rest assured.”

Lei Tie, who had been standing quietly at the door, said, “Wife, have a meal.”

“Coming.” Qin Mian put down the chopsticks and quickly walked over. His stomach was already growling with hunger.

In the lounge, there were three dishes, one soup, an exquisite bamboo bucket filled with cooked rice, and two served bowls of rice on the round table. Qin Mian knew that it was Lei Tie who asked the chef to make the meal for them in the small kitchen.

After turning around and seeing no one at the door, Qin Mian boldly hugged Lei Tie and offered a burning hot kiss.

“You haven’t eaten yet? Come and eat together.” He pressed Lei Tie on the chair as he also sat down, picked up a rice bowl, and ate with big bites. “I’m so hungry.”

“Slow down.” Lei Tie picked up a piece of flesh on the fish belly, removed the bones, and put it into his (QM) bowl.

“You also eat.” Qin Mian gave him a piece of sweet and sour sparerib.

“I just had a fruit.” Lei Tie scooped out a bowl of soup and stirred it with a spoon to cool it down. His eyes were always on Qin Mian. He said again, “Slow down.”

“Um!” After Qin Mian finished a bowl of rice, his stomach felt a little more comfortable, “You also eat.”

Lei Tie scooped half a spoonful of soup to test the temperature and then pushed the soup bowl to his wife before picking up his rice bowl to eat.

Qin Mian took a sip of the soup with a smile and gave Lei Tie a spoonful.

Lei Tie looked at him as he sipped it.

In the evening, the two of them rested at Rugui Building. They idly strolled on the suspension bridge as the night gently breeze blew. It was refreshing and comfortable.

“Wife.”

“Um?”

“Double Xiang House’s daily launch of new dishes can attract a lot of customers. But in this way, you will be very tired,” Lei Tie said. Although those recipes were recorded in the books inside his wife’s space, he didn’t want his wife to spend too many thoughts on it.

“Rest assured,” Qin Mian embraced the man’s shoulders, looked up at the stars, and briskly said, “I have means. You will know tomorrow. But it’s involved you too.”

He looked back and smiled at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie nodded, “Listen to your arrangement.”

Qin Mian pulled the man’s wrist, “No more of this talk. Let’s go. I’ve been busy all day today, I’m sweating. I want to go back and take a bath.”

In the honored guest suit exclusive for the two men on the third floor, the lights had been lit. The inside was clean and tidy as if no one had ever lived in it. Qin Mian took off his shoes and socks, stepped on the floor barefoot as he rushed into the bathroom, and closed the door a ‘bang’, “A-Tie, I wash first.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. a Beijing dish of spicy ground beef sauce poured over deep-fried tofu skin
2. They wish tomorrow comes sooner

Chapter 106: Membership Card System

106 – Membership Card System

Brought to you by JuBR 😊

Lei Tie picked up the shoes and socks, put them on the shoe rack, and went to the window. The splashing sound of water transmitted out through the door was like it fell on his heart, making it itched. He went over and knocked on the door.

“What?” Qin Mian yelled from inside.

Lei Tie opened the door and went in, “Wife, you said water should be saved.”

Sitting in the tub, Qin Mian looked back in bewilderment, “We are not so poor to this state – OH!”

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After the snake hour (11:00), all kinds of carriages drove into Running Water Town. The people in the town withdrew their gazes after a glance and kept busy with their business, knowing that Double Xiang House launching a new delicious dish was the cause. Most shop owners were very happy because more people coming to town could boost their business.

Nie Heng also came to Double Xiang House with his younger brother, Nie Xuan, and three good friends, Zhao Yunxiang, Mu Chen, and Chu Han.

As soon as they entered the lobby, the waiter, who was familiar with Nie Heng, invited them to the private room upstairs.

Nie Heng waved his hand in refusal, “We’ll eat in the lobby today.”

“All right. Honored customers, this way, please. Today, our Double Xiang House is offering a whole vermicelli feast. Would Nie Gongzi and the honored customers be interested to try it?”

“We came today precisely for the vermicelli feast,” said Nie Heng. It was also the reason why he brought so many people here. There must be more than one course for the whole vermicelli feast. If he came alone, he couldn’t finish it. Even if he was rich, he would not waste money.

“Great. Table 3, whole vermicelli feast.”

“Some fresh fruits and drinks too.” A look at Nie Heng’s posture showed that he was a frequent customer here. So, the other four did not speak out of turn.

“Yes.”

The waiter came soon with fresh fruits and cold peach juices.

“Eldest Brother, here’s really different as you said,” said Nie Xuan as he looked around. Some time ago, he had been away from home. This was his first time to visit Double Xiang House.

“Whole vermicelli feast,” Chu Han pondered. “Waiting to see.”

They ate some peaches and talked for a while before they saw several waiters coming in line, each holding a tray in hand. They were stunned. The speed of serving was not slow.

The waiters arranged the dishes one by one and then bowed in respect.

“Please enjoy it, honored customers.”

There were nine dishes in the whole vermicelli feast. In the middle was a large serving of chicken served on an extra-large plate filled with vermicelli. The soft and moist vermicelli, the glutinous potatoes, and the strong fragrance of chicken meat complemented each other well, sprinkled with bright red chili and green coriander – not lacking in color, aroma, and flavor. The other eight dishes were Flourishing Blossoms on the Branches, Spicy Diving Fillets, Shredded Three-ingredient Salad with Dressing, Spicy and Sour Vermicelli, Spring Rolls with Sauce, Braised Diced Eggplant with Vermicelli, Emerald Vermicelli Soup, and Fried Vegetarian Balls.

The aroma pervaded and invaded one's nose. Nie Heng picked up his chopsticks.

The other customers, who were still waiting for their meal, enviously looked at them.

“Table 9, whole vermicelli feast!”

“Private Room 1, whole vermicelli feast!”

.....

The waiters' shouts rose one after another as they ran back and forth. Although busy, their faces showed an excited smile.

Nie Heng tasted the Spicy and Sour Vermicelli nearest to him. The chopsticks in his hand were almost unstoppable. His eyes flashed with complex emotions.

Nie Xuan's mouth did not stop chewing as his free hand comfortingly patted his eldest brother's shoulder. He understood his eldest brother's mood at the moment. The dishes of Double Xiang House were really good. No wonder his eldest brother was under pressure. Fortunately, Running Water Town was not close to Zhaoyang County, and not everyone could run so far to eat here every day. Therefore, Double Xiang House did not have a great impact on their wine house.

“Eldest Brother, didn’t we buy the seasoning recipe from the owner of Double Xiang House? Maybe you can buy their vermicelli too?” Nie Xuan finished his words very quickly and went to pick dishes again, afraid that he would miss them if he was a step slower.

“Talk later.” Nie Heng saw that they were all focused on eating, so he quickly put off his thoughts and wholeheartedly ate.

Soon, there was no empty seat in the lobby.

Manager Sun stood on the high platform with a happy smile and said in a loud voice, “Dear customers, I want to announce that Double Xiang House will implement a membership card system three days later. When your consumption in Double Xiang House has reached a certain amount, you will get different privileges and rewards. For more information, please pay attention to the notice board at the Double Xiang House’s entrance. I won’t delay your mealtime.”

Nie Heng and the others’ manservants sat at the next table. Nie Heng immediately made an eye signal at Chunsheng.

Chunsheng wiped his mouth and ran out. After a while, he came back with a bit of shock on his face.

“What’s the matter?”

Chunsheng replied in a clear and orderly way, “Reporting to Gongzi, the notice stated that after three days, all the customers who eat in Double Xiang House will get a numbered membership card for free, which is called ‘Ordinary Member’. When a member dines and stays in Double Xiang House, he/she has to show this card to record his/her consumption. When the consumption reaches 100 silver taels, the member will be upgraded to Silver Member and can participate in the lucky draw held by Double Xiang House once. When it reaches 1000 silver taels, the Silver Member will be upgraded to Gold Member. Gold Member can enjoy a 20% discount in Double Xiang House, can participate in the lucky draw once a month, and will be provided with an exclusive waiter for personal service. When it reaches 10000 silver taels, the Gold Member will be upgraded to Diamond

Member. Diamond Member has the most benefits: enjoys a 30% discount, can draw a lottery after each consumption, will be provided with two exclusive waiters, and get an annual gift of 10 jin of seasonal fruits from Leisurely Farm Residence. If it is a male customer, he can also participate in the ‘Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh’ held at the end of the year. If it is a female customer, she will get a unique set of jewelry as a present. Also, if the customer is from Zhaoyang County, Double Xiang House will send someone to inform the customer in advance once a new dish will be launched.”

Light flashed in Nie Xuan’s eyes, and he asked with interest, “What’s the meaning of ‘Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh’?”

Chunsheng replied, “The notice doesn’t elaborate, but it stated that the ‘Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh’ is different every year, and can ensure that the customers have a good time.”

“Oh?” Mu Chen suddenly spoke, “One can only upgrade slowly?”

Chunsheng shook his head and said, “No, it’s stated that one can make an advance deposit. It’s called ‘recharge’ something.”

“Changjian,” the man dressed in purple called out to the manservants’ table.

A tall and thin manservant immediately ran over, “Master.”

“Three days later, I’d like to have Double Xiang House’s membership card with the number 1. Deposit 10000 silver taels for me.”

Chunsheng quickly added, “Mu Gongzi, I forgot to say that the money is not allowed to be taken out after it has been deposited.”

Mu Chen looked unperturbed, which clearly showed he had made up his mind.

“Brother Mu Chen, are you serious?” Nie Xuan looked at him in surprise, “Even if you come to Double Xiang House to eat every day, you have to eat

for 200 days even if it cost 50 taels a day.”

“Interesting, isn’t it?” Mu Chen nonchalantly said.

Nie Heng motioned to Chunsheng, “I want the number 2.”

Nie Xuan, Zhao Yunxiang, and Chu Han were all speechless. *There’s more money to burn, isn’t it?*

Chunsheng hastily spoke, “Gongzi, there is one more thing.”

“Say it.”

Chunsheng said, “Double Xiang House has decided to make a tea room in the lounge on the first floor. It will open in two periods: from the beginning to the middle of the monkey hour (15:00 to 16:00) and from the middle to the end of the dog hour (20:00 to 21:00). Tea, fruits, and snacks will be served, and a storyteller will be invited for story-telling. By the way, there is a rule that food and drink from outside are not allowed in.”

“It’s nothing unusual, is it?” Nie Xuan disapproved, “Don’t many tea houses have storytellers?”

Zhao Yunxiang shook his head, “A-Xuan’s words are wrong. Neither of these two periods is the regular time for meals. If the story is good enough, won’t the customers, who have had lunch and dinner, stay?”

“We’ll know when we see it in three days,” said Mu Chen.

Nie Heng did not speak. He was shocked by the means of Double Xiang House’s owner. If Double Xiang House was located in Zhaoyang County, he really did not know whether he would deal with Double Xiang House with bad means.

Mu Chen said, “I’m honestly interested in meeting those two owners.”

Nie Heng said, “Those two don’t come here very often. Maybe, they will turn up in three days.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't know that people were talking about them, but even if they did, they didn't care. In the afternoon of the same day, they hired a carriage to Zhaoyang County and went to the brokerage to buy people.

Due to a distinction between men and women, it was hard to buy a single woman. Qin Mian bought a family of three. They were Uncle Quan and Aunt Quan, a couple in their early thirties, with their five-year-old daughter, Miao Miao.

After that, Qin Mian asked the brokerage's owner to call out all the males aged 14 to 20, explaining that he wanted to buy two people to be storytellers.

Then he told a story and had everyone to repeat.

This move and Lei Tie's method of selecting the armed servants then had the cleverness of different tunes played with equal skill¹. Lei Tie looked at his wife with his dark eyes full of smile.

Qin Mian noticed it and raised his eyebrows to express his inquiry. Lei Tie shook his head.

The most outstanding ones were a 14-year-old Qiangzi, who spoke strongly, and a 17-year-old Ye Fengqiu. Qiangzi had lost both parents, and he was sold by his cruel uncle. He not only had a good memory but also had a loud voice. Ye Fengqiu was gentle and literate. He was good at exaggerating the atmosphere when he was telling stories, which was in line with what Qin Mian had in mind. The only regret was, he had a problem with his right leg, so he walked with a limp.

Ye Fengqiu nervously looked at Qin Mian as he tightly clenched his two fists in his sleeves. He could not find work because of his inconvenient leg and almost starved to death before he sold himself.

He had been in the brokerage for almost a month, and no one had been interested in him. If there was no one to buy him—

At this time, Qin Mian's voice sounded in his ears. To him, it was like heavenly music.

“Boss, it's the two of them.”

Not only Ye Fengqiu, even the brokerage's owner was stunned and took a glance at Ye Fengqiu.

“Are you sure, gongzi? He...”

Qin Mian waved his hand and lightly glanced at Ye Fengqiu, with an expression without disdain or disgust, like he was treating normal people. “Storytelling is about speaking with a mouth, not with the legs.”

Ye Fengqiu's heart abruptly fell to the ground. He took a long sigh of relief and looked at Qin Mian gratefully.

Since the customer had no objection, the owner naturally wouldn't have any objection. He cheerfully asked people to get the title deeds of Qiangzi and Ye Fengqiu.

Note:

Footnotes

1. (idiom) different approach but equally satisfactory outcome

Chapter 107: Expanding Production

107 – Expanding Production

Brought to you by JuBR <3

Back in town, Lei Tie first went back to the village to send Uncle Quan, Aunt Quan, and Miao Miao.

Qin Mian took Qiangzi and Ye Fengqiu to Double Xiang House. He had the waiter to take them to wash, while he took Manager Sun to the lounge.

“Manager Sun, find someone to make clothes for two storytellers as soon as you can; make them the same clothes and two sets per person.”

“Yes, Little Young Master.” Manager Sun was no stranger to this process. Their Double Xiang House’s work clothes were uniformed and all had the ‘Double Xiang House’ logo. However, the colors of the clothes were different for each division of work. Nowadays, many wine houses in other places imitated their practice. Yet, they could never erase the fact that Double Xiang House was the first place to uniform the work clothes. Manager Sun was proud of Double Xiang House.

“Little Young Master, how are you going to decorate the tea room?”

Qin Mian took out a piece of paper and handed it to him, “Separate the lounge with shuttering, build a higher platform on the north side, and put a lecture table on it – that is the storyteller’s seat. The bottom is arranged with a row of long tables and benches. This is the blueprint. There will be fruits, drinks, snacks, and pastries in the tea room. I’ve written all the prices on it.”

Manager Sun took it and looked at it.

Leisurely Farm Residence's seasonal fruits cost 68 Wen per portion; other fruits cost 18 Wen per portion. Tea was priced according to different tea grades and charged per cup. Juice drinks cost 28 Wen per cup. Melon seeds in half a jin per serving; five-flavored melon seeds cost 28 Wen, plain melon seeds cost 18 Wen, and fruit-flavored melon seeds cost 38 Wen (Note: the fruits were produced in Leisurely Farm Residence). Peanuts in half a jin per serving; five-flavored peanuts, plain peanut, spicy peanut, and green tea peanuts varied in price, which was surprisingly high. There were five kinds of unique pastries; glazed fried egg cake cost 68 Wen per portion, water-chestnut pudding cost 68 Wen per portion, and small pastries such as egg tarts, egg pudding, and tea cupcakes cost 28 Wen each.

"Little Young Master, the prices are not low." When Manager Sun saw the list, he sighed.

Qin Mian disapprovingly laughed, "The tea room is only open to Double Xiang House's customers. The price of the dishes in Double Xiang House is higher than that in other wine houses. Since the customers can afford the dishes, they can afford the fruits and snacks. Besides, many drinks are unique only in our wine house. Worthy of the high price."

Manager Sun repeatedly nodded. He knew that five-flavored melon seeds and peanuts were made of five spices, but he had never heard of the glazed fried egg cake, water-chestnut pudding, egg tart, and so on.

"Also," Qin Mian tapped on the table, "three days later, all the dishes made with vermicelli will be 500 Wen per dish for vegetarian dishes and 2 silver taels per dish for meat dishes."

Manager Sun made obeisance and said, "Yes!"

"Since a tea room is added to Double Xiang House, more staff is needed to pour tea and serve snacks. You see how many people to hire. Just let me know when you're done." Qin Mian added, "At present, each of the five kinds of pastry can only be supplied for 50 portions a day. I will have people send them over every morning."

“Yes.”

“You call Qiangzi and Ye Fengqiu in.”

“Yes.”

Qiangzi and Ye Fengqiu came in, looking somewhat restrained. Ye Fengqiu looked down because he was not used to the new environment, which one could see that he still had some inferiority complex. When he entered Double Xiang House, the staff and customers kind of stared at his leg.

Qin Mian leaned on the back of the chair, crossed his arms, and frowned at Ye Fengqiu, “Ye Fengqiu, look at my eyes.”

Ye Fengqiu was taken aback. He raised his head to look at Qin Mian but his eyes unconsciously dodged. The little young master looked up to him, but he felt the pressure from the little young master.

“If you look down on yourself, why do you want others to look up to you?” Qin Mian gazed at him with a pointed look, “I don’t want to regret buying you one day!”

Ye Fengqiu looked apprehensive. He straightened up and respectfully said, “Little Young Master, this servant knows his mistake. Please believe in this servant again!”

Influenced by Qin Mian’s imposing manner, Qiangzi unconsciously stuck out his chest.

Qin Mian nodded and turned to Qiangzi.

“What’s your full name, Qiangzi?”

Fearing that the little young master would not be satisfied with him, Qiangzi replied in a loud voice, “Answering to Little Young Master, this servant’s full name is Lin Qiang.”

“Afterward, you two will stay in Double Xiang House to be storytellers, which include food and accommodation. There are two storytelling sessions

every day with different stories. Qiangzi takes the session in the afternoon, and Ye Fengqiu takes the session in the evening. Your work is not hard. You two only need to work for an hour every day. The rest of the time, you will recite and ponder the content of the next session. Still, it is not heavy manual work. Lin Qiang, your monthly payment is tentatively set at 50 Wen per month; Ye Fengqiu, your monthly payment is tentatively set at 80 Wen per month.”

Story-telling in the same period, but the monthly payment was different. Both Lin Qiang and Ye Fengqiu were puzzled.

Qin Mian asked Lin Qiang, “Do you know why your monthly payment is less than Ye Fengqiu?”

Lin Qiang only shook his head, “This servant only knows that Brother Ye is more excellent than me. He can read, while this servant can’t read.”

Qin Mian approvingly looked at him, “Smart. He gets 30 Wen more because that is the tuition fee I paid for you. He will read to you the story that you need to tell every day, and you will memorize it. Also, in leisure time, he’ll teach you how to read. When you can read normally, your monthly payment will be the same as Ye Fengqiu.”

“Many thanks, Little Young Master!” After that, Lin Qiang gave a simple and honest smile to Ye Fengqiu, “Brother Ye, I’ll be troubling you later.”

Ye Fengqiu returned with a friendly smile, “Don’t mention it. We have to help each other.”

Qin Mian handed him several sheets of paper. “Three chapters on top are Lin Qiang’s story, and the following three chapters are yours. Every day, I will send new stories. You have to memorize the story in advance and try to figure out what tone and expression to use when telling a story. In short, you must not tell a story in a flat tone to avoid dissatisfaction from the customers.”

Lin Qiang and Ye Fengqiu answered in chorus, “Yes.”

“If there is anything else you don’t understand, ask Manager Sun.”

Qin Mian motioned them to withdraw and said a few words to Manager Sun before he rode on horseback home. The sun was about to set, so he sped out of town.

“Lei Tie’s wife!”

Zhang Dashuan waved his whip and drove the donkey cart to catch up.

“*Shh—*” Qin Mian stopped to wait for him. “It turns out to be Brother Zhang. Such a coincidence.”

“I just sent some passengers back to Zhaoyang County.” Zhang Dashuan smiled with eyes full of gratitude toward Qin Mian. “Thanks to you and Tiezi, I can earn 50 to 60 Wen every day just to pick up and see off the passengers. Sometimes, I can earn more by selling some ornamental knots and pouches!”

“That’s what Brother Zhang is capable of. Otherwise, it doesn’t work no matter how good an idea is, isn’t it?” Qin Mian looked at the sky, “Brother Zhang, it’s late. Let’s talk while we go?”

Zhang Dashuan nodded. “Right, let’s go.”

As they approached Green Mountain Village, the sun had set, and half of the sky painted with a faint sunset glow. On the grain-sunning ground, children who didn’t want to go home were still playing, catching dragonflies with bamboo sticks stuck with spider webs.

Seeing a tall figure standing motionless on the side of the road with a black wolf quietly crouched at his feet, the corner of Qin Mian lips spilled out a smile. He shook the reins.

“*Jia—*”

Zhang Dashuan slowed down, knowing how to behave in a delicate situation.

The brown horse ran to Lei Tie and stopped. It affectionately snorted toward him.

Lei Tie grabbed the reins and handed over a bamboo tube to Qin Mian. With a nod to Zhang Dashuan, he led the horse to the west of the village. Leisurely Farm Residence was too big, so they had to go around the west side to get home.

“A-Tie, nothing happens at home?” Qin Mian was too lazy to dismount. He opened the bamboo tube, which contained mung bean soup.

“Uncle Quan helps Uncle Fu, and Aunt Quan takes over Aunt Fu’s previous work. If you feel that this arrangement is not appropriate, you can make another arrangement.”

“There’s nothing wrong with it.” Qin Mian finished the mung bean soup in one breath and smacked his lips.

Lei Tie added, “The day after tomorrow is the old man’s birthday. Du Shi wants it to be lavish.”

Qin Mian was stunned, “If I remember correctly, the old man is going to be 41 years old, not the round decade¹?” Du Shi was going awry again?

Lei Tie shook his head.

Qin Mian thought about it for a while and soon decided, “Let them do whatever they want. There are a lot of things to do these days, so neither of us will go there. Just let the steward go in person with generous gifts. I believe the people in the old house will have nothing to say.”

“Listen to you.”

As they passed the Vermicelli Workshop, they went to have a look.

Qin Mian thought of the lively scene in Double Xiang House today and discussed with Lei Tie, “A-Tie, eight people are still too slow to work. Do you think we should hire some more people to work in the evening?”

Lei Tie nodded, “Doable. Wife, I’m worried about another matter.”

“What matter?”

Lei Tie flipped over on the horse and sat behind his wife. He pulled the reins, not letting the horse grazing, and clamped its belly to urge it.

“The appearance of vermicelli is bound to cause a sensation, and there will be people coming to inquire for information. The workshop is a little far away from home, so it may not be safe.”

Qin Mian sat cross-legged and touched his chin. The reason why he didn’t open the workshop in the farm residence was that he didn’t want too many outsiders to enter. Alas, he had ignored the issue that Lei Tie was worried about.

“Well then.” He immediately came up with a solution, “Open a corner gate at the north wall. The starch extraction is originally done by our servants. Afterward, it will be done in the residence and only adds a transportation procedure.”

Lei Tie nodded.

The next day, they settled the matters of hiring people and the corner gate. Safety factors should be taken into consideration when working in the evening, so male workers were hired – a total of eight men. The work started at the beginning of the dog hour (19:00) and ended at the beginning of the dragon hour (7:00). Qin Mian did not intend to exploit them. Because the male workers worked longer hours than the female workers and working at night for a long time was not conducive to their health, their monthly salary was 20 Wen more than that of the female workers. Every three days, the eight men were divided into two shifts and took turns to have a day off. Lei-Qin Le and Uncle Quan took turns to supervise the work.

Note:

Footnotes

1. advanced age in round decades (e.g., 80/90)

Chapter 108: Another Culmination

108 – Another Culmination

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the town ahead of time to avoid Lei Daqiang's birthday.

An oven was needed to make egg pudding, egg tarts, and tea cupcakes. Instead, Qin Mian used a metal box to bake over the fire as an oven. However, it was easy to heat unevenly, so some pastries were burnt and uncooked. Inspired by the stovetop burner of the gas stove, he had a blacksmith to forge a large conical lid with nine iron tubes in the middle that were arranged in a circle next to each other. When using the oven, the lid was attached to the fire. The large conical lid was able to centralize the flame and distributed it through the nine iron tubes so that the heat was much more uniform. After a few attempts, Qin Mian was able to skillfully use this simple version of an oven. He could smoothly make the pastries, and the taste was quite good.

On the day of Lei Daqiang's birthday, guests from all walks of life gathered in the old house, including the Lei Family, Du Family, and Wei Family. However, Lei Tie and Qin Mian did not appear. Lei Daqiang remained calm all the time.

Strangely, Du Shi was not at all discontented. She warmly welcomed the guests while her eyes were secretly searching in the crowd, appearing absent-minded.

In Leisurely Farmhouse¹, Uncle Fu deliberately delayed for a while. When he estimated that all the guests of the Lei Family had arrived, he took Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Yuan to the old house.

At the first sight of Uncle Fu, who dressed like the steward of the rich and influential family in the town, and the two boys, who dressed in the same servant clothing, standing straight behind Uncle Fu, the guests in the courtyard whispered with different expressions.

“The eldest son of the Lei Family is really prosperous. Look at his well-trained servants and his big and small bundle of gifts.”

“Paying respect to the old man!” With a smile on his face, Uncle Fu went forward and bowed, “May the old man’s happiness be as immense as the East Sea, and live as long as the Zhongnan Mountains!”

Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Yuan said in unison, “May the old man’s happiness be as immense as the East Sea, and live as long as the Zhongnan Mountains!”

As if Uncle Fu didn’t see the displeasure on Lei Daqiang’s face, he presented the congratulatory gifts one by one, “Look, these are six kinds of pastries, six chi² of cloth, six jin of fresh peaches, and six jars of good wine. The eldest young master and the little young master can’t leave the wine house, so they send us to celebrate the old man’s birthday. [We] hope the elder doesn’t take offense.”

All the relatives came, but only his own son and eldest daughter-in-law were absent. Lei Daqiang was still harboring anger, but when he saw the congratulatory gifts were a few standard higher than the others, he could only swallow his dissatisfaction. He squeezed out a laugh, “Hehe, it’s fine. Business matters are important.”

Uncle Fu said a few more nice words before he took Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Yuan to leave on the pretext that there was still work to do in the farmhouse.

The next day of Lei Daqiang’s birthday was the day when Double Xiang House opened an application for membership cards. At dawn, some rich people rushed their servants to grab the membership cards. Regardless of whether they would come to Double Xiang House to dine later, this membership card was unique in Zhaoyang County, and even in the whole

prefecture – *I have it, but you don't, so I have more identity and insight than you.*

The first to grab was of course Mu Chen's manservant, Changjian. He applied for a Diamond Membership Card that was in a noble purple color. The middle of the card was inlaid with a square piece of pure gold, the top was engraved with 'Double Xiang House' with the incomprehensible serial number '001' at the most top, and a line of 'Running Water Town, Zhaoyang County, Qingtian Prefecture' words at the bottom of the card with a slightly smaller font. Along with the card, a set of passwords was given in case of careless loss of the Diamond Membership Card. As long as one remembered the password, one could still use this membership card.

Chunsheng and Changjian were the same; they waited outside before dawn. After depositing ten thousand taels of silver, they both got the same Diamond Membership Cards.

The Gold Membership Card was gold plated. The Silver Membership Card was light green and designed the same as the Diamond Membership Card, but with a piece of pure silver. Gold and Silver Members also had passwords. The ordinary membership card was made of solid white paper with the logo and address of Double Xiang House, as well as a seal printed on it. In terms of design, it was very exquisite. It was also numbered but started from 00001.

Since there were too many people, Manager Sun placed a set of tables and chairs at the lobby entrance of the Binzhi Building. Two staff were placed specifically here, responsible for handling ordinary membership cards, silver membership cards, and gold membership cards. The diamond membership card enjoyed the most respected service – handled by Manager Sun himself at the counter.

Manager Sun and the staff were busy but not disorderly. Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood not far away, watching for a while before they walked away.

Just now, both of them took note that five people had applied for diamond membership cards, which was to say, Double Xiang House had made an

income of 50000 taels today. Afterward, if they wanted to expand the business, they didn't have to worry about the capital turnover problem.

It was not only them who saw the situation, but also the staff in Double Xiang House. They suppressed their excitement and kept busy in an orderly manner. The better the business of Double Xiang House, the better their salary would be.

Qin Mian was in a good mood and decided to hold a lottery in the middle of the horse hour (12:00).

At noon, Nie Heng, Mu Chen, Nie Xuan, Zhao Yunxiang, and Chu Han appeared together in Double Xiang House.

As soon as Nie Heng and Mu Chen showed their Diamond Membership Cards, the welcoming waiter immediately called out their exclusive personal waiters. The exclusive waiters looked pretty, courteous, and well dressed. Their style of clothes was the same as that of other waiters but in solid white color with a bowtie on the collar.

Four exclusive waiters went to stand behind Nie Heng and Mu Chen. Occasionally, the envious eyes of the customers floated over them.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen looked at each other. They had to admit that this really satisfied their sense of vanity to a certain extent because having exclusive waiters signified their identity.

The group of people still chose to sit in the lobby. Nie Heng asked his exclusive waiter, "Are your bosses here today?"

"Answering³ my patron; both of the bosses are here."

"Oh? I wonder if the two bosses can take the time to meet us?" Mu Chen asked.

After the waiter saluted respectfully, he said, "My patron is a Diamond Member. Your waiter will try the best to meet all your requirements without violating the interests of the bosses. Please wait for a moment."

Mu Chen nodded with satisfaction, “Great.”

The group sat for a while before Mu Chen saw his exclusive waiter leading two extraordinary young men over. He carefully looked at the two men. The youngster on the left was dressed in a new style of a white long shirt with an elegant demeanor, no more than 15 or 16 years old. However, from his steady eyes and leisurely pace, one could see that he was not as simple as his outward appearance. Meanwhile, the man on the right was dressed in light green long shirts with wooden expression and unshakable eyes, making his reserved grandeur too profound to be understood.

“I was wondering who? Turns out, it’s Nie-gongzi.” Qin Mian approached with a smile and cupped his hands in greetings, “Hope Nie-gongzi is well?”

Nie Heng said, “Thanks to your blessing. This is my younger brother Nie Xuan. These three are my good friends; Mu Chen, Zhao Yunxiang, and Chu Han.”

“Many thanks for your patronage, Nie-gongzi, Mu-gongzi, Zhao-gongzi, and Chu-gongzi.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “Nie-gongzi brought his family and friends to patronize my business, it will be inexcusable if I don’t convey [the gratefulness]. Are all of you interested in participating in the lottery?”

“What’s in it?” Nie Heng and Qin Mian were considered to be familiar with each other, so they spoke casually.

Qin Mian said, “Today, we have prepared 200 lottery cards, and each card has a prize. The first prize, one place, get an overnight stay in the luxury suite of Rugui Building; the second prize, three places, get a 50% discount on today’s consumption; the third prize, ten places, get one free dish from any dishes on the menu. The rest is a consolation prize of one free dish of minced beef sauce.”

Mu Chen raised his eyebrow as he said, “If we all only win the consolation prize, Boss Qin’s ‘convey’ certainly appears to be somewhat petty.”

Qin Mian chuckled and said, “These words of Mu-gongzi are wrong. Luck is also a kind of capital.”

Mu Chen was silent for a moment, unable to deny, and looked at him with profound meaning. *It's no wonder that Nie Heng always says that this Boss Qin is not a simple person.*

Lei Tie intensely glanced at him, “Wife, the matter in the tea room is still waiting for you.”

Qin Mian nodded and said to Nie Heng and the others, “Please take your time to enjoy. The staff in charge of the lottery will be here in a minute. Excuse my absence.”

“Please.”

Mu Chen looked at them walking away shoulder-to-shoulder, and turned to Nie Heng, “The relationship between the two bosses is pretty good.”

Nie Heng thoughtlessly said, “I heard that all of their servants are surnamed Lei-Qin. Do you think their relationship is good?”

Chu Han patted Mu Chen's shoulder and joked, “Are you asking *that*?”

Mu Chen shook off his hand, “Don't make a joke. I was just casually expressing my opinion.”

They did not continue to talk about Qin Mian and Lei Tie. After all, the four exclusive waiters were the staff of Double Xiang House. In the afternoon, when the storytelling time arrived, 60% of the customers dining in Double Xiang House chose to enter the tea room.

The walls of the tea room were glued with wooden planks and arranged with some potted plants. The storyteller's speech table was placed on the high platform with a stack of manuscript paper, a pot of tea, and a gavel. Storyteller Lin Qiang calmly sat behind the table.

Below, the audience's tables were very distinctive, all of which were thick cut-half woods, and wooden block benches wrapped with green cushions.

The whole tea room was in a fresh and cool tone, brimming with natural scent. The menu list was hung on the wall, indicating the names and prices of tea, pastries, and so on provided by the tea room, so that customers could read it easily. Upon seeing all kinds of prices, some people were speechless, while some did not react.

Nie Heng and his group sat in the same row and very tacitly ordered the unique pastries and drinks of Double Xiang House.

The waiters on the side went to get them immediately.

Soon, the tea room was full.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood at the back, needing to see Lin Qiang's live performance with their own eyes before they could rest assured.

When it was time, Lin Qiang struck the gavel on the table, "My surname is Lin. I'm the storyteller in the afternoon story-telling session. Welcome to Double Xiang House. Today, I'd like to tell you a heart-rending heroic tale, called the Legend of the Condor Heroes. It is said that in the distant Qiantang River, the vast river majestically winds through and around Ox Village, on its journey to the sea, day in and day out..."

Qin Mian slightly nodded. Lin Qiang had some shortcomings in rendering the atmosphere, but he had a good memory and good at using gestures. Over time, he could become an excellent storyteller.

Note:

Footnotes

1. I changed it (at last)
2. 1 chi = 1/3 meter
3. This is the way of an inferior talk to the superior. i.e: reporting or answering

Chapter 109: New Carriage

109 – New Carriage

“.....Qiu Chuji was just going to answer before his expression abruptly changed and said, ‘someone is here for me. No matter what happens, you two stay inside and don’t come out, understand?’ Guo and Yang nodded. Qiu Chuji bent over to pick up the human head, walked out of the door, jumped on a tree, and hid among its branches and leaves. Who is this incoming person? Why did Qiu Chuji’s expression change? Predict what will happen and listen to the for an explanation.”

With a ‘pa’, the gavel struck again.

At this time, the tea room customers collected their thoughts from the tale after being surprised, and could not help feeling that time passed too fast.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen looked at each other in amazement. They had heard a lot of story-telling, but this was the first time they were so absorbed in hearing it. All the pastries were eaten but the tea was forgotten – they didn’t drink even a mouthful.

A customer disgruntledly shouted, “Storyteller Lin, today’s tale is too little! Please tell us a bit more! It’s not easy for us to come from far away!”

“Yes, Storyteller Lin, it’s still early. Please tell us the !”

“Storyteller Lin...”

Seeing this situation, how could Lin Qiang not understand that today’s storytelling was very successful? He was so excited but he didn’t dare to show it on his face. He cupped his fist and said, “Ladies and gentlemen, please come again tomorrow, please!”

There was another sound of protest.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie slipped out while no one was paying attention to them.

“I thought Lin Qiang would have some stage fright but didn’t expect this boy to perform so well. It seems that I have a pair of eyes that are good at discovering [talents]!” With hands clasped behind his back, Qin Mian took measured steps and lifted his head, aiming an incline look at Lei Tie with a smile in his eyes, “[Am I] right?”

Lei Tie nodded.

“Lin Qiang has no problem, so Ye Fengqiu should also have no problem.” Qin Mian felt a little worn out after being in a state of nerve-racking for most of the day, “Let’s go home after taking today’s large amount of income?”

“There’s no hurry to return home. Go to the carpentry shop and change the carriage.” Lei Tie added, “The old carriage doesn’t work well.”

He was not a professional carpenter. The carriage that he made was used too often that the boards frequently loosened and shook several times, very likely to fall apart. It was troublesome to constantly repair it.

“Sure. Since it needs to be made, let’s make the best one. Go back to the lounge and I’ll tell you in detail.” Qin Mian had another idea. He pushed the man’s back and urged him to go quickly. Back in the lounge, Qin Mian began to draw.

The main problem with ancient carriages was that the wheels were not very good at shock absorption because it was either made of wood or iron without tires. The basic function of the tire was to buffer the vibration. It was fine if the road was level, but if one encountered an uneven road surface, one’s internal organs could change positions while sitting in the bumpy carriage. Qin Mian thought that rubber could be obtained from rubber trees. Rubber trees liked high temperature, high humidity, calm wind, and fertile soil, belonging to subtropical plants. In his understanding,

the climate of Green Mountain Village was like central China, which most likely didn't have rubber trees. He didn't plan to spend time on the mountain near Green Mountain Village, so he decided to go directly into the space to look for it when he was home.

After completing the drawing of the carriage, the two came to the Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop.

When Liao Zhifu saw them, he got up to greet them warmly, "Boss Lei and Boss Qin; such rare visitors! You two have not come to patronize my business for a long time." It seemed that not long ago, the two men were still wearing patched clothes to sell their small inventions in his shop. At that time, who could have thought that they would become the famous big bosses in the whole county? From this, one could see that no matter what, one should not look down on anyone. Liao Zhifu was very glad that he did not offend Qin Mian and Lei Tie at the beginning, and even had a few pleasant associations.

Upon hearing Manager Liao's tone sounded a little intimate, Qin Mian took advantage of that and walked as he said with a smile, "How can Manager Liao say that? Am I not here?"

"Please have a seat, gentlemen." Liao Zhifu nodded to Lei Tie as a greeting.

Lei Tie nodded.

Although he didn't speak, he also gave a response. Liao Zhifu cheerfully called the shop assistant to serve tea.

The shop assistant stepped back after serving tea.

"Do you want to buy furniture or order a custom-made?" Liao Zhifu asked.

Qin Mian took out the drawing and handed it to him, "We want to order a custom-made carriage."

After looking at the drawing in detail, Liao Zhifu looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with admiration and said, "Our shop can do it. But since Boss Qin

requires the wheels to be made of iron with notches in the middle, it may take more time. Does Boss Qin in a hurry to get it done?"

"No hurry. If there is no mishap, this carriage will be the exclusive carriage of mine and Lei Tie. It must be solid and fine," Qin Mian emphasized his statement.

Liao Zhifu knew that these two were rich people now, so they paid more attention to the quality of things, and the price was secondary. Thus, he guaranteed, "Rest assured. I will ask the master carpenters to do their best! In case some places don't meet your requirements, we'll redo it at any time until you are satisfied."

"Also, I hope Manager Liao will not disclose the drawing." Qin Mian said with a smile, "I've had so many contacts with Manager Liao that I can absolutely trust your moral standing."

"Don't worry, Boss Qin." Liao Zhifu was interested in the drawing, but since Qin Mian had said so, it was not good to discuss other things.

Qin Mian told him to send the carriage to Leisurely Farmhouse of Green Mountain Village when it was ready. Then, he left with Lei Tie.

After seeing them out, Liao Zhifu rushed to the workshop at the back of the shop with the drawing and told the master carpenters to start working on it as soon as possible.

Four days later, the staff of Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop sent the carriage to Leisurely Farmhouse.

The new carriage had four wheels, 8 *chi* (2.7 m) in length and 6 *chi* (2 m) in width. The decorative carved patterns were extremely exquisite – let's not mention it for the moment. There were two hooks on the left and right sides of the front awning of the carriage. Above each hook was a square wooden placate. On the left was the word 'Lei' and on the right was the word 'Qin' in gold. Wind-proof lanterns could be hung on the hooks to facilitate the trip at night. The doors on both sides of the carriage had three-layered steps suspended in midair, unlike ordinary carriages, and had to be equipped with

a footstool that could be retracted to the bottom of the carriage when not in use. There was a small window on the front wall of the carriage with a screen curtain, convenient for people inside to communicate with the driver, and a large window was on the rear wall. The front wall of the carriage could slide up and down. In summer, the front wall could be opened for cool ventilation.

In the carriage, under the small window was a vertical cabinet fixed on the carriage floor, with three drawers for storing snacks, books, and other small items. There were two rows of seats close to the left and right walls respectively, with three compartments under the seat. In the middle of the carriage was a long table with the same length as the seat, which could be lifted and lowered. In normal times, the long table was left as it was. When one wanted to rest, one had to lower the long table and flipped it over to turn into a big bed combined with the two seats. There were two luggage racks above the two seats for storing bedding, baggage, and other things.

The small carriage was practically a small room.

When the carriage was completed, the master carpenters of Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop, all without exception, admired it. However, the construction cost of the carriage was not low. This carriage cost nearly 15 silver taels and sold to Qin Mian and Lei Tie for 22 silver taels.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very satisfied with the new carriage and paid the money in a frank and straightforward manner. They repaired the old carriage for the servants to use.

After sending off the staff of Rich and Honor Woodcraft Shop, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went into the space to look for rubber trees, bringing along knives, buckets, and irons that were wrought into tubes.

Although all the dangerous animals in the space avoided Qin Mian, the space was too large that it was quite lonely to walk in it alone. Therefore, he had never walked too far. This time, he imagined himself standing at the foot of the mountain. In the next moment, he and Lei Tie appeared at the foot of the green mountain.

“Wife, do you recognize the rubber tree?” Lei Tie asked.

“Yes.” Qin Mian taught him, “The leaves of rubber tree are oval with a glossy surface and the fruit is also oval. There is a longitudinal groove on the top and a beak tip at the peak. If you can’t recognize it, you can slice the tree bark with the knife. If there is a white emulsion coming out, it is most likely a rubber tree.”

Lei Tie nodded and went in the other direction. White Spot followed Qin Mian.

After searching for more than an hour, Lei Tie was the first to find the rubber tree. When Qin Mian heard the call, he ran over.

From the piece of bark of the rubber tree that was cut off obliquely, milky juice flowed down in a gush. Lei Tie inserted the iron pipe, making the juice flowed along the iron pipe and into the bucket below.

This area was all rubber trees. Qin Mian picked the thickest one for rubber tapping.

Eventually, they collected two buckets of rubber.

Qin Mian only knew that the main raw material for making rubber was natural rubber. Natural rubber was made by solidifying and drying latex from tapping the rubber trees. However, it was unclear what method was used to solidify and dry latex. He hadn’t paid attention to this point before.

With no other choice, he and Lei Tie had to think about it themselves. Solidification could be done by airing or cooling, while drying can be done by air-drying, sun-drying, or roasting... There was so much latex in the space that they tried one by one and truly succeeded after struggling for several days.

They had prepared a thick bamboo. The diameter of the bamboo was close to the width of the wheel. After clearing out the bamboo, the latex was poured into the bamboo tube. Next, it was solidified and dried with the

methods they had tested. The freshly made functioning rubber was quite elastic.

The two men installed the ‘tires’ into the notches of the wheels and reinforced them before harnessing the horses. Lei Tie test-drove the carriage on the uneven road in the village.

The villagers watched the carriage running back and forth in wonderment.

“Old Four Lei, your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are amazing. We old folks have never seen such a beautiful carriage,” said Uncle Jiang to Lei Xiangli.

Sister Zhang jokingly said, “Hey Fourth Brother, when is your mother going to betroth you? Later, it will be a great honor to pick up the new bride with this carriage!”

Lei Xiangli’s face was red, “What are you saying, Sister Zhang?”

The villagers all burst into laughter.

“Why are you blushing?” An aunt said to Lei Xiangli with an ambiguous smile, “If I remember correctly, you are 18 years old this year, right? It’s time to get married. Do you want us to rush your mother for you?”

Lei Xiangli’s red face was on the verge of bursting flames, “*Cough*, you don’t have to worry about it.”

The crowd laughed again.

Qin Mian personally experienced it in the carriage. He could hardly feel the vibration, which was quite apart from the previous carriage that was able to toss people around.

Chapter 110: New Money-making Plan

110 – New Money-making Plan

The driver's seat was also very unique. It was designed to look like an armchair with a special place for feet, so the driver would not be uncomfortable when driving for a long time. In addition, there was a semi-circular rod around the awning above, with a rainproof cloth hung on both ends of the rod that could be opened and closed like a sliding curtain. There were two fixed planks on the shaft on both sides of the armchair; when the passengers wouldn't sit in the carriage, two could sit here.

Lei Tie slowed down and asked, "Wife, how is it?"

"Very comfortable." Qin Mian lifted the curtain of the small window and said, "A-Tie, I want to drive. Why not you experience it too?"

Lei Tie stopped the carriage, climbed into the carriage, and looked down at the long table, "What about the bed?"

In Qin Mian's mind, a disharmonious¹ image involuntarily emerged, making his heartbeat skipped a beat, "Didn't try."

Without saying a word, Lei Tie pulled it up and pushed open a mechanism. After the long table slowly flipped over, it lowered and very closely joined together with the two seats.

With a push from Lei Tie, Qin Mian fell on the bed. He immediately jumped up and nervously looked out of the window, "W-what are you doing? There are so many people out there."

A ghost of a smile flew past in Lei Tie's deep eyes. His big palm caressed his wife's face before he turned and got off the carriage.

Qin Mian opened his mouth but words failed him for a long time. In other words, he was under the hallucination that the other party was willing?

Seeing Lei Tie was back to the driver's seat through the screen curtain, Qin Mian crawled over, lifted the curtain, and called out, "A-Tie."

Lei Tie looked back, "What's it?"

Qin Mian hooked his finger to indicate that the man should get closer. Then, he took a bite on the man's thin lips and quickly backed away.

Lei Tie looked at the shaking screen curtain and took a deep breath before he turned his head and looked ahead.

Qin Mian pushed open the door, crawled to the man's side, and sat down.

Lei Tie shook the reins, and the sound of horse's hooves clattered, slowly approaching the crowd under the big locust tree. A few curious villagers looked over.

Qin Mian jumped out of the carriage and greeted the villagers, "What are you chatting about?"

Sister Zhang said with a smile, "We're chatting about when your fourth brother will marry a wife."

Qin Mian laughingly looked at the uneasy Lei Xiangli, "Fourth Brother's marriage should be done within the year, right? Let your eldest brother lend you the new carriage to pick up the bride at that time."

It was a matter of great honor to be able to pick up one's bride with this unique carriage. Lei Xiangli was very moved. He didn't feel embarrassed as he said, "Then, that's a promise, Eldest Sister-in-law, Eldest Brother. There's still some work left at home, so I'll go first." After leaving that sentence, he ran away as fast as he could.

The villagers laughed even louder.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't stay much longer. They got on the carriage and went home.

"Hey," Fang Hongliu bumped into Sister Zhang with her arm. "When do you think Du Shi will be able to fix the marriage of her family's Old Four?"

Before Sister Zhang said anything, Zhou Cuihua disdainfully curled her lips and tucked the soles of her shoes in her hands, "Ever since her Old Five become an entry-level examinee, haven't there been eight matchmakers arranging marriages for Old Four? However, Du Shi has been picking and choosing, none of them she likes. I'm waiting to see what kind of fourth daughter-in-law she will find."

"I feel that it'll be hard," said an aunt mysteriously. "Don't you know? All kinds of troubles in their family have spread to other villages. The Lei's Old Four is good – he is capable and can bear hardships; the eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law are promising; the youngest brother is also promising. But if one can't stand that he has a mother like that, it won't be easy to be their family's daughter-in-law."

"Stop it, don't talk so much," Sister Zhang stopped her. "The new bride will be married to Old Four, not to the mother-in-law."

The villagers knew that Sister Zhang and Qin Mian were close, and they were also willing to keep propriety in speech for the sake of respect toward Qin Mian and Lei Tie, so they chatted about other things.

Back at home, Qin Mian changed into a short-sleeved shirt and shorts and lay in bed that was covered with a bamboo mat. The floor-to-ceiling windows were fully opened, and the gentle summer wind slowly blew into the room, dispelling a bit of heat.

Qin Mian relaxingly spread out his four limbs while his empty eyes fell on the beam without blinking.

"Thinking about what?" Lei Tie grabbed his ankle.

“Thinking of how to spend money.” Qin Mian faced him sideways, “Can’t keep fifty thousand silver taels to grow mold. Money has to be spent to make more money. There’s so much business to do, but I can’t think of what is best to do first.”

“Wine,” After Lei Tie spat out a word, he lay down beside Qin Mian and raised the youngster’s head to let him rest on his arm.

“Wine? That’s a good idea!” Qin Mian was absorbed in thought, “What kind of wine is made in that small winery in our village?”

“White wine and rice wine.” Lei Tie held Qin Mian’s hand and kissed from the fingers to the arm, gradually went upward.

Qin Mian breathed unsteadily and glared at him, “Don’t want to do it. It’s hot.”

Lei Tie rolled up Qin Mian’s clothes. His breath puffed on Qin Mian’s neck was scalding hot.

“It won’t be hot after doing it. Wife, in the carriage before, I was—”

Qin Mian covered the man’s mouth and hesitated. Lei Tie tore off his clothes in a sweeping manner. Qin Mian saw that the situation was beyond salvation, and could only obediently put his arms around the man’s neck.

.....

Qin Mian had to admit that it was a great pleasure to take a bath after sweating in the hot summer, and after changing into fresh clothes, there was a person beside him to fan and feed him grapes.

“If we want to open a winery, we’d better notify the owner of the small winery. After all, we’re fellow villagers; we don’t want to accidentally get into a feud.”

Lei Tie said, “Maybe you can hire him to handle the winery. The business is getting bigger, it’s impossible to do everything by yourself.”

Qin Mian was enlightened, “That’s plausible.”

He turned over and lay on Lei Tie. It was a little hot, but he liked to be close to the man. “There are so many things I want to do. I also want to make instant noodles, manage a vineyard, build a mountain resort...”

“No hurry, we have a lot of time.” Lei Tie stroked his hair, “I’ll be with you.”

“Of course!” Qin Mian put his arm around the man’s waist. “What do you think about buying a large piece of land behind our farmhouse? Then, connect it to Leisurely Farmhouse and build a perimeter wall around it, including the vermicelli workshop. Afterward, the winery, food processing workshop, and so on are built here.”

Qin Mian was mainly responsible for mental work, while Lei Tie was mainly responsible for physical work, “Listen to you.”

They did what they discussed. After reorganizing, they went out to Li Zheng’s home first. When Li Zheng’s family saw the two men, they all smiled happily and very enthusiastically served them tea.

Li Zheng had both status and position in the village, so he was quite respected. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not pretentious at all. After saying a few polite greetings, the two men took the tea.

Qin Mian explained his intention. Li Zheng was happy and straightforwardly sold him a large open space behind the village at the price of the uncultivated land.

“Are you still going to plant fruit trees this time?” Li Zheng asked.

Qin Mian said, “No, we plan to open another workshop. The specific work is still under discussion.”

Li Zheng nodded, “It’s good to run a workshop. The more business you do in the village, the more workforce you need, so the villagers don’t have to go far to look for work. This is a good thing for the whole village.”

“Li Zheng can rest assured that A-Tie and I will do our best to make allowances for the villagers.” Qin Mian didn’t want to say too much. He didn’t mind hiring people in the village for ordinary jobs, as long as the key technologies were in his own hands.

After coming out of Li Zheng’s house, they went to visit the owner of the small winery. Before they entered, they smelled the aroma of wine, but the door of the small winery was locked.

Their trip was in vain. They went to ask the neighbors, and it turned out that the eldest brother-in-law of Chen San, the owner of the small winery, had a newborn son. Chen San and his wife went to attend the feast.

The next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to visit again. Chen San and his wife were busy. Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s arrival surprised both husband and wife.

Seeing that they didn’t come to buy wine, Chen San wiped his hands and asked in a puzzled way, “What is it?”

“Sorry to disturb Uncle Chen and Aunt Chen.” Qin Mian handed over the pastries in his hand and directly pointed out his intention, “It’s like this. After some time, our family plans to open a winery, and most of the wine will be exported. I’m afraid that Uncle Chen will misunderstand, so I came to notify you. I hope Uncle Chen doesn’t take offense.”

Chen San and his wife were stumped for words.

Chen San’s expression carried a sense of loss as he shook his head, “Nothing to take offense for. Opening a winery doesn’t break the law. It’s very remarkable of you to think of informing us.”

Sitting at the side, Chen San’s wife sighed. The wine in their winery was not very good, but the villagers would come here to buy it when they wanted to drink. They earned 50 to 60 Wen a month, or more than 12 silver taels a year. When Lei Tie Family’s winery opened, there would be fewer people coming here to buy wine; their income would be less. However, she

was not an unreasonable person and would not say anything to blame others.

The husband and wife did not show any resentment. Qin Mian discovered that they were sincere people and said to Chen San, “Uncle Chen, I want to be honest with you. A-Tie and I have some good wine recipes, but we know almost nothing about brewing wine. We’d like to hire you to oversee our winery. What do you think?”

Immediately, Chen San’s wife looked happy. They had just lost sesame seed and never expected to pick up a watermelon soon!

Chen San was a little excited. If he worked in Lei Tie Family’s winery, his salary was paid monthly, which meant a stable income. Moreover, the salary for managing their business was not low and much better than running a small winery.

“For you to think highly of me, how can I be unwilling? It’s just, I still have a lot of wine here...”

Qin Mian said with a smile, “That’s easy. It will take about half a month for our winery to start operating. Uncle Chen can take this opportunity to deal with your remaining wine.”

Chen San’s wife asked with some embarrassment, “If my husband works in your family’s winery, how much... How much is the salary per month?”

Qin Mian frankly said, “Because I don’t know how good Uncle Chen’s craftsmanship is, I can only pay 100 Wen a month at most in the beginning. If Uncle Chen performs well or makes important contributions to the winery, his salary will increase. Besides, those who work for our family, whether they’re our servants or hired workers, have their own bonuses at every festival.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. 和谐 means harmony and euphemism to censor. So disharmonious can mean uncensored.

Chapter 111: The Hapless Lei Xiangli

111 – The Hapless Lei Xiangli

“Everyone in the village knows that you are kind to your servants and employees.” Chen San’s wife had a firmer smile on her face and a softer voice, “I heard that your servants are given meat every month; they’re better than some villagers.”

Qin Mian didn’t admit to her words and just smiled.

“Uncle Chen, does this mean you agreed? I’ll let you know when the winery starts operating.”

“All right, all right.” Uncle Chen rubbed his hands and smiled.

After Qin Mian and Lei Tie left, a few villagers went to Chen San to inquiry about the news.

The two passed by the tofu workshop on the way back. In actuality, the workshop was based on the opened window in the back room of a house. Tofu, dried tofu, fried tofu, and so on were placed there where the passers-by could see.

Qin Mian saw the lady owner of the tofu workshop brought out a plate of freshly-made tofu, “I haven’t eaten tofu for a long time.”

The lady owner cheerfully said, “Then buy 2 jin to bring home. It’s delicious whether pan-fry, deep-fry, or boil!”

Qin Mian walked over and inquiringly said to Lei Tie, “Buy 2 jin of tofu and 2 jin of dried tofu?”

Lei Tie took off the pouch hanging on his belt.

The lady owner chuckled at Qin Mian with a significant meaning.

Qin Mian kept a straight face, utterly calm.

The lady owner skillfully cut the tofu and weighed the dried tofu, “Accurate 2 jin of tofu. 2 jin and 2 liang of dried tofu, count as 2 jin. The total is 7 Wen.”

Lei Tie took out seven copper coins and put them on the counter. He picked up the packaged tofu and dried tofu. These actions made the lady owner smiled with goodwill.

“Be careful on your way.”

The owner of the tofu workshop came out of the room, rubbing his stomach with a drowsy look, “I’m starving. Why haven’t you cook?”

“Eat, eat, and eat. You only want to eat all day!” The lady owner’s slender finger stabbed on his forehead with bitterness, “You look at how good Lei Tie treats his wife, not even letting his wife hold things. And you? Your wife is a delicate and charming woman, but you don’t know how to cherish it!”

The owner avoided her hand. He looked at her thick waist and fat buttocks, and then chuckled, “Delicate and charming? I don’t see it.”

“What did you say?” The lady owner put her hands on her hips as her apricot eyes¹ glared.

“N-nothing.” The owner suddenly withered and said with a dry laugh, “You’re delicate and charming. Are you going to cook?”

“Humph!”

Qin Mian raised his eyebrow and stared at Lei Tie. Lei Tie looked steadily forward, being ignorant.

Qin Mian couldn't help laughing. He heard the conversation behind him and didn't believe that Lei Tie didn't hear it.

Today, there was no wind at all. The hot sunlight shone down made the wilting leaves on the trees shining with a golden radiance. The ground was scorching hot, appearing as if smoke could come out from it.

The cicadas were chirring tirelessly amid the leaves; one sound was higher than the other.

Qin Mian's face was scorched by the sun. He quickened his paces, "Let's eat cold dishes and pot-stewed dish for lunch."

Lei Tie walked on his right side, blocking part of the sun, "Pot-stewed beef is good."

Qin Mian's heart was softened, how could he disagree? He held the man's big palm and pulled him to go home quickly, "I'll make you a dish of pot-stewed beef, and then a dish of red-cooked beef."

After entering the courtyard gate, Lei-Qin Yuan informed them that Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao were here.

Qin Mian remembered that Qingyun Academy was on holiday at the end of the month. He ordered Lei-Qin Yuan to pick a few peaches and send them over.

Lei Chuntao and Lei Xiangzhi stood in the shade of the maple trees as they chatted.

"Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law."

Qin Mian pushed the door open. "The door is not locked, why didn't you go in and sit down? Come in."

“Feeling the blow of the wind outside is also good.” Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao followed in. This was a polite remark. There was no one at home, how could they go in at will?

Lei Tie went to the kitchen and put the dishes away.

“A-Tie, soak the tofu in water and sprinkle some salt,” Qin Mian told him.

From inside, Lei Tie asked, “How much salt?”

“Just a handful.”

Aunt Quan quickly came over and put the washed and cut fruits on the table. “Fifth-gongzi, miss, please enjoy the fruits.”

Lei Chuntao said thanks. She was in a very melancholy spirit. Meanwhile, there were shadows hidden in Lei Xiangzhi’s eyes.

Qin Mian first went to change to straw sandals. After handing them two plates of fruit, he sat down at the table, shook his palm-leaf fan, and asked, “Why are you looking so sad?”

“Thank you, Eldest Sister-in-law. It’s too noisy at home. We went out for fresh air.” Lei Chuntao took the fruit plate and sighed. She secretly looked at her eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law. Their clothes were very strange, but it gave her a kind of free and leisurely feeling, making her very envious.

“What kind of noisy?” Qin Mian casually asked.

Lei Chuntao was a person who couldn’t hide her words, “Mother and Fourth Brother. Mother wants Fourth Brother to marry Second (maternal) Cousin² of Eldest (maternal) Uncle’s family. But Fourth Brother didn’t want to, so they quarreled. Second Cousin, she— I really don’t understand what Mother is thinking!” When she said this, her expression had a trace of disgust toward Du Shi.

Of course, the ‘Eldest Uncle’ she spoke of was not the same person as Lei Tie’s Eldest Uncle, but Du Shi’s eldest brother.

Qin Mian truly sympathized with Lei Xiangli. He took a look at the calm Lei Xiangzhi and lightly said, “You don’t understand it, but your fifth brother should understand.”

Lei Chuntao looked at Lei Xiangzhi in surprise and asked, “Fifth Brother, why is Mother doing this?”

Lei Xiangzhi was not necessarily willing to talk about Du Shi’s fault in front of him and Lei Tie, so Qin Mian was ready to change the subject.

Lei Xiangzhi sighed and opened his mouth. His voice was calm, “It’s related to Fourth Brother wanting to separate. Mother worried that Fourth Brother... be at odds with her, so... ”

Lei Chuntao scrunched up her nose, “What? For this reason, Mother wants Fourth Brother to marry Second Cousin? Although Second Cousin is beautiful, she is spoiled and lazy. It’s harmful to Fourth Brother to marry her! Mother is overthinking. Fourth Brother is her son, how can he be at odds with her?”

Lei Xiangzhi bitterly smiled. He also wanted to know what his mother was thinking. Not only she forced Eldest Brother away, but did she also want to force her own son away?

“Mother is only in discordance for a while. I’ll persuade her.” He profoundly said, “If we let the Second Cousin marry in, she’ll ruin Fourth Brother.”

Qin Mian did not make any comment.

With head lowered, Lei Tie cut fruits for his wife, appearing as if he didn’t hear the dialogue between Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao.

At this time, Lei Chuntao was in the mood to eat the fruits.

Lei Xiangzhi put aside his negative emotions, “Eldest Sister-in-law, I have another thing to talk about today. Some of my schoolmates want to buy fruits from Leisurely Farmhouse. I told them that the fruits of Leisurely Farmhouse are not for sale, but they insist that I ask you again. So, I’m asking them for them.”

“Those students have a good relationship with you, right? However, since the business of Double Xiang House is getting better and better, the daily picked peaches are basically sent to Double Xiang House. Even your eldest brother and I seldom eat it.” Qin Mian was a little embarrassed, “How about this: I’ll spare some for them before the fruits stop yielding in the eighth month. But the price is not low.” Everyone knew that the fruits of Leisurely Farmhouse were expensive, but these students still wanted to buy them. It could be seen that these students were rich people who wouldn’t care about the price.

Lei Xiangzhi knew that Eldest Sister-in-law was doing it for the sake of his honor. He said with a smile, “Many thanks, Eldest Sister-in-law. They said the price is not a problem.”

Qin Mian softly nodded.

Lei Xiangzhi fished out a scroll from his sleeve pocket. “Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. This is a recent painting of mine. If you think it’s good, you can hang it at home.”

Qin Mian took the scroll and unfurled it. It was a painting of a fraction of Leisurely Farmhouse. The hue was bright and colorful and the strokes were vivid. The butterfly on the flower looked lifelike as if it was about to fly out of the painting.

“Good painting!” Qin Mian praised, “Why isn’t there an autograph? When Fifth Brother becomes the Number One Scholar, this painting will increase in value.”

Lei Xiangzhi’s face was slightly red, and his eyes looked confident and contented. “I’m very grateful for Eldest Sister-in-law to think highly of me. I will try my best.”

Lei Tie fetched the Four Treasures of the Study, and Lei Xiangzhi filled in his autograph. Qin Mian hung the painting in the living room.

“It’s rare for you two to come here, would you like to have lunch here?”
Qin Mian said.

Lei Chuntao repeatedly nodded, “Eldest Sister-in-law has a good culinary skill, so this little sister won’t stand on ceremonies.”

Lei Xiangzhi cupped his hands in obeisance to Qin Mian, “We’re troubling Eldest Sister-in-law.”

Qin Mian got up, “A-Tie, you go to the garden to pick some vegetables.”

Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao also stood up.

“We’ll go with Eldest Brother.”

“Sure, you can pick whatever you like to eat. A-Tie, you pick a pumpkin.”
Qin Mian found two baskets and gave them to Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao.

“En.”

In the garden, there were eggplant, cucumber, green pepper, white gourd, potato, loofah, bitter melon, tomato, pumpkin, lettuce, chives, and whatever one would need. The cucumbers were long and green, and the tomatoes were like red lanterns... All the vegetables were full of vitality. Lei Chuntao thought that a pair of eyes was not enough to see it all.

“Look, Fifth Brother. The vegetables in Eldest Sister-in-law’s garden are so good that they don’t even have a hole caused by worms.”

Lei Xiangzhi looked around and nodded with approval, “I think so, too. Otherwise, the business of Double Xiang House will not be so prosperous.”

Lei Tie picked a big pumpkin and held it in one hand. “I’ll go back first. Pick whatever you like to eat.”

“Thank you, Eldest Brother.” Lei Chuntao flew over like a yellow butterfly and picked her favorite tomato first.

At home, Qin Mian first made dried tofu slices, pot-stewed beef, and stir-mixed preserved egg with tofu. When Lei Tie came back with the pumpkin, Qin Mian boiled the pumpkin and prepared to make pumpkin pies. It was not yet noon, so there was plenty of time.

“Eldest Sister-in-law, we are back.” Lei Chuntao’s spry voice arrived as she came in first.

Lei Xiangzhi carried the two baskets, walking at the back.

“Eldest Sister-in-law has already cooked three dishes?” Lei Chuntao looked at the table and shyly said, “We picked too many vegetables.”

Qin Mian looked at the vegetables in the two baskets, “It’s alright. Since it’s something you like, eat more later. Sit down for a while. If you’re hungry, eat some fruit.”

Lei Chuntao was about to help when she saw Lei Tie carrying the two baskets and following Qin Mian into the kitchen, so she sat back.

After making a pumpkin pie, Qin Mian made red-cooked beef, beef soup with tomato, hot and sour vermicelli, chives omelet, stir-fried pork with cucumber, and sour and spicy shredded potatoes. In addition to the pumpkin pie, there were a total of ten dishes, comparable to the Lunar New Year’s meal.

Lei Chuntao and Lei Xiangzhi helped to bring the dishes to the table.

“Smells good.” Lei Chuntao praised with a smile.

“Awoo.”

White Spot’s voice came from the door. Qin Mian noticed that Lei Xiangli was standing outside the door, looking blank. It was unknown how long he had been standing there.

Standing behind him, Lei-Qin Yuan quickly stepped forward. “Please forgive your servant, Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. Your servant had wanted to report...”

Lei Xiangli hurriedly said, “Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. I didn’t let him report. I was going to stand for a while and leave.”

Qin Mian motioned Lei-Qin Yuan to withdraw and said, “Fourth Brother, why don’t you come in?”

Lei Xiangli rubbed his face and walked in, a tired expression remained on his face. He was embarrassed, “Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. I didn’t want to stay at home, but I didn’t know where I could go. I just walked and ended up here...”

Qin Mian sympathetically patted him on the shoulder, “Have you eaten yet?”

Lei Xiangli shook his head as he said, “No.”

Lei Tie went to the kitchen to get a pair of chopsticks and a bowl.

“Many thanks, Eldest Brother.” Lei Xiangli sat down beside Lei Chuntao.

“Fourth Brother, are you alright?” Lei Chuntao asked in a low voice.

“I’m fine.” Lei Xiangli silently sighed.

Qin Mian motioned, “Let’s eat.”

Lei Tie first gave his wife dried tofu slices before he started to eat. Qin Mian gave Lei Tie pot-stewed beef.

Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao were all stunned for a moment. Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law’s movements were extremely natural, they obviously had done it so many times. This was a real home where the whole family be kind and loved each other. Unlike in their home, everyone ate fast at mealtime, afraid to eat less than others. Sometimes, they even fought for food. There was not a trace of a family’s warmth.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 杏眼 [xìng yǎn] large eyes of a beautiful woman
2. I believe this second cousin is the eldest uncle's daughter

Chapter 112: Like Your Taciturn

112 – Like Your Taciturn

“You three, help yourselves. If you have to be polite, it’s you who won’t be full.” Qin Mian scooped himself a bowl of preserved eggs and tofu.

Lei Xiangli said thanks and ate with his head down. Presumably, he wanted to turn his unhappiness into ravenousness.

“Eldest Sister-in-law’s cooking is very delicious. I won’t be polite,” Lei Xiangzhi said with a smile.

Lei Chuntao was also very ‘fierce’. She was embarrassed to get a second helping of rice, but Lei Xiangzhi helped her.

After the meal was finished, she rushed to wash the dishes.

Qin Mian wanted to say that Aunt Quan will come to wash the dishes but he could not speak in time, so gave up. Then, he sat down on the settee with Lei Tie, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi.

The settee was covered with a cooling mat, making it pleasantly cool.

The person concerned was here, Qin Mian couldn’t help but care.

“Fourth Brother, what’s going on?”

Lei Xiangli tersely said, “Mother wants me to marry my cousin from Eldest Uncle’s family. I don’t like her.” There was another sentence he did not say: *if I marry my cousin, she will be the second Zhao Shi.*

“What are you going to do now?” Qin Mian asked.

“After talking to Father for a while, he didn’t seem willing. So, this marriage shouldn’t work.” Lei Xiangli’s low mood calmed down a little, “I’m worried that even if Mother gives up the idea of asking me to marry my cousin, she’ll find for me... another wife, which also unreliable.”

On the topic of marriage, the unmarried maiden Lei Chuntao couldn’t join in the conversation. She ate the fruits with her head down.

As a man, Lei Xiangzhi carried himself with ease and confidence, “Fourth Brother doesn’t have to be too worried about this. Mother will not deliberately find you a bad wife. No matter who she settles on, it won’t be bad if you try to find out in secret.”

Lei Xiangli looked quite helpless, “I’ve thought about it. Since Eldest (paternal) Aunt is warm-hearted but not as gossipy as other women in the village, when worst comes to worst, I’ll shamelessly ask her for help.” Marriage was a lifetime thing, he had to be meticulous.

Lei Xiangzhi nodded and said nothing. As the saying went, “Thou shalt not share family scandals”. Even if their Eldest Aunt was a close relative, she was also an outsider. Now, his fourth brother’s marriage was reduced to the point of asking for help from an outsider, making Lei Xiangzhi felt even more powerless toward his mother.

After a moment of silence, he made up his mind, “Fourth Brother, don’t you and Third Brother want to separate? I can’t mediate this matter now, but I promise you, after taking the college examination, I will persuade our parents to separate the family.”

Lei Xiangli suddenly stood up with a surprised expression, “Really?”

“A gentleman’s word [is trustworthy],” Lei Xiangzhi earnestly said.

“I thank you first.” Lei Xiangli was much more at ease.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “We’ve been disturbing Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law for a long time. Shall we go back?”

Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao both nodded.

“Not going to sit for a while more?” Qin Mian asked.

“No more.” Lei Xiangli was embarrassed as he said, “We’ve bothered Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law today. We’ll see you some other day.”

Qin Mian didn’t ask them to stay again, “Alright, be careful on the way.”

Coming out from Leisurely Farmhouse, Lei Xiangli suggested, “Fifth Brother, Little Sister. Let’s take a detour from the back to home.”

Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao had no objection. The three walked slowly along the perimeter wall to the back of the village. Although the sun was very bright, the three were in a good mood, walking briskly.

“Fifth Brother. Third Brother and I, we really want to separate, but your exam is the most important thing now. Don’t get distracted by this, and better focus on your study,” Lei Xiangli said, as he was worried for his youngest brother.

“Don’t worry, Fourth Brother. I have been attentive.” Lei Xiangzhi felt a lot of emotion in his heart, “Over the years, my elder brothers have taken good care of me. Sometimes when there are good things at home, even Little Sister prioritizes me. I feel ashamed. No matter what, I have to do something about this matter [separation].”

Lei Xiangli patted his youngest brother on the shoulder, “It’s good that you have been attentive. If you are affected by my affairs, I won’t have peace of mind.”

“Fourth Brother is right.” Lei Chuntao interjected, “Fifth Brother, you have a promising future. We’ll also get to bask in your light, don’t we?”

.....

In mid of the seventh month, after the winery and its wall had been built, the winery opened operation. Uncle Chen was in charge of the winery, and

others were hired from the village. Qin Mian only needed to master the last step of brewing and added the spiritual spring water.

When Qin Mian was worried about the name of the winery, he suddenly realized that he should create a brand. A brand was a sign of distinction that could provide the symbol of authenticity and the guarantee of consistency. Moreover, a brand was a kind of standard sign. He hoped to see that one day when people mentioned certain goods, the first thing they thought of was their family's brand.

He gave Lei Tie a firm definition of "brand" and asked him to help thinking of a name.

After a long time of silence, Lei Tie blurted out a few words, "Can't think of any."

Qin Mian rudely gave him a word, "Stupid!"

Lei Tie nodded, "En, my wife is smart."

Qin Mian had nothing to say in reply. Should he say "I'm not smart"?

Anyway, he eventually made up his mind, "Then, just name it 'A Glimmer of Paradise'. As for the logo of the brand, make it a full moon that has been bitten, symbolizing that using our goods will make life perfect. What do you think?"

Lei Tie nodded, "Good."

Qin Mian suddenly got upset and went downstairs without saying a word. Out of the hedge gate, when he did not hear the sound of footsteps following, he was completely angry and sped up his paces. Very soon, he passed through the corner gate and went into the new processing yard. There was also a gate to the east of the processing yard for the convenience of the employees to enter and leave. This corner gate was only for the use of people who lived in Leisurely Farmhouse.

Unconsciously, Qin Mian went to the vermicelli workshop.

Lei-Qin Le was walking fast, presumably on his way out. Upon catching sight of the little young master's stiff face, he hastily restrained his smile and respectfully saluted, "Greetings, Little Young Master."

Qin Mian uttered an 'en', and wordlessly walked in and went around.

The female workers, who were chatting while working, turned silent in a split second when they noticed his expression. They didn't dare to be lazy. They secretly guessed whether Qin Mian had quarreled with Lei Tie.

When Qin Mian noticed their eyes were curious and inquisitive, he was even more irritated. He walked out of the workshop and stood by the pond, feeling depressed.

It was not that he didn't know Lei Tie's taciturn personality. Why would he be so angry? He knew it in his heart. It was not because Lei Tie didn't help him to think about the brand name, but because Lei Tie had been sneaking around a few days ago. He didn't know what the man was doing behind his back. He had been patiently waiting for Lei Tie to take the initiative to tell him, but until today, Lei Tie had not confessed to him.

He wasn't suspicious that Lei Tie was doing something that would offend him. He just didn't like the feeling of being left aside by the man.

"Wife."

Lei Tie's voice sounded behind him, but Qin Mian turned a deaf ear and squatted down to watch the small fish swimming in the pond.

Lei Tie walked over and pulled Qin Mian's wrist.

"Let go. What does this pulling and pushing look like?" Qin Mian struggled hard to get free before something was put on his wrist. He looked up and saw a bracelet on his wrist. There were sixteen round dark purple beads strung on the bracelet, which looked like wood and gave off a faint elegance scent.

He was about to speak when he saw a trace of blood on the back of his own hand. He quickly stood up and grasped Lei Tie's hand. As expected, he saw a shallow knife mark on the man's left index finger, "How did you get it?"

Lei Tie shook his head, "It's nothing."

Qin Mian understood what probably was going on. The reason why Lei Tie was secretive should be to cut and polish this bracelet. Feeling a bit guilty, he grumbled, "Tell me whatever it is you're doing. You don't need to hide it from me."

"Many cuts were damaged," Lei Tie mindlessly said.

Qin Mian understood. A man always wanted to keep a good face¹.

"Go back. I'll rub medicine for you." His anger completely disappeared and turned to sweetness. Holding the man's hand, he walked a few steps and inadvertently saw that the shoes on the man's two feet were both different. At once, he burst into laughter, unceasingly.

Lei Tie looked down. With a calm expression, he led Qin Mian to walk, "Go home. Sunlit²."

"En." Qin Mian raised his wrist and looked at the bracelet. "What kind of wood is this? The surface is even engraved with a word?"

"Red sandalwood from 'inside'³. It's the 'Fortune'⁴ word."

Qin Mian touched the beads. He liked the bracelet very much. "You also make one for yourself some other day."

Lei Tie nodded.

Back at home, Lei Tie went upstairs to change his shoes, and Qin Mian took out the medicine box to apply for medicine on the man's wound. When he imagined Lei Tie putting on the shoes in a flurry with an expressionless face, the corner of his lips curled up.

“Wife, what’s funny?” Lei Tie raised Qi Mian’s chin.

Qin Mian put his arms around the man’s neck, smiling, “You think?”

“Don’t know.” Lei Tie grasped Qin Mian’s waist to lift him and placed him on his legs. He said in a low voice, “Wife, don’t resent me being taciturn.”

Qin Mian’s chest pained as though it was clutched by someone. He vigorously shook his head. It turned out that this man was not so confident sometimes. He tightly hugged Lei Tie’s waist and looked at his eyes as he seriously said, “No resentment. I like your taciturn! I wasn’t really angry just now.”

Lei Tie’s eyes were filled with tenderness as he clasped the other person’s head and gratefully rubbed his lips and tongue against the other person’s lips as if worshipping. The kiss was not fierce, but was rather slow, and yet it attacked Qin Mian’s heart inch by inch, making him lose his voice and senses. Then, he wholeheartedly responded.

Lei Tie lifted one of the other’s legs and sat him astride his lap. His arms that wound around the other’s waist seemed like they were about to crush it.

The sun gradually went to the west. When there was only a touch of golden radiance left to illuminate through the floor-to-ceiling window, the sound in the room finally stopped.

Qin Mian’s senses gradually returned. He rubbed his forehead and burning his ears. They didn’t even take off their clothes...

Can’t go on thinking downwards! He raised his head and threw it hard⁵.

Lei Tie pressed the other’s head on his chest and stroked his back. This person was his wife; his only beloved.

He stood up with Qin Mian in his arms. He went to the bookshelf, opened the third drawer, and took something out of it. Then, he put it into Qin Mian’s hand before returning to the bed and sat down.

“What is this?” Qin Mian smelled a familiar scent and knew that it was also made of red sandalwood. He tossed and turned it, and found his name was engraved on the bottom.

“Is this a seal? It looks very fine. Then, I’ll just use this seal.” He opened his pouch and put the seal in its pocket.

Lei Tie kissed his lip and put him on the bed, “Lie down for a while, I’ll heat the water.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. respect; honor; reputation
2. He meant that the sun is so blaring they shouldn’t bask for long. Sigh, Lei Tie, and his short words.
3. the space
4. 福 = good fortune; happiness; luck
5. He threw away the dirty thought 😊

Chapter 113: Concern about Thieves

113 – Concern about Thieves

The name of the processing yard became “Glimmer of Paradise Processing Yard”. The vermicelli and wine produced in the processing yard were all marked with a “bitten moon” logo. The logo was drawn by Qin Mian himself. The words of “Glimmer of Paradise” were printed on the packaging bags of the vermicelli. Qin Mian also signed a contract with a pottery kiln workshop to produce many wine jars with the logo and brand name.

Plum ripened later than honey peaches. Qin Mian made the plums into dried plums and plum jam. Some of them were left in the space for use in autumn and winter, while the rest were sent to Double Xiang House. A lot of customers liked the taste of dried plums and plum jam, sweet and sour. Every time they came to dine in Double Xiang House, they bought more to bring home for their families to eat.

In terms of taste, Double Xiang House’s food, fruit, and jam were better than other places. The customers had already understood this fact. Even Double Xiang House’s competitors bought them in large quantities and resold them. In any case, Qin Mian and Lei Tie made money either way.

As the vermicelli workshop increased in production, it was more than sufficient to provide for Double Xiang House’s demand. Qin Mian simply expanded the production again and sold sweet potato and potato vermicelli for 100 Wen per jin. Not only that, like the noodles, he also produced green vermicelli, red vermicelli, and purple vermicelli, all of which for 150 Wen

per jin. In the first month of export, the vermicelli workshop made a net profit of more than 700 silver taels.

The operation of the winery was also on the right track. Regardless of white wine or fruit wine, the Glimmer of Paradise's wine had more ineffable aroma than others' wine, so that the drinker could better taste the pleasure of slight drunkenness. Therefore, 90% of the people who liked to drink the Glimmer of Paradise's wine believed it was more expensive than others' wine but worth the money.

As for the situation of Qin Mian and Lei Tie's family, considering that milk was needed to make many cakes, Qin Mian had Lei Tie buying five milk cows from the prefecture town.

In mid-late of the eighth month, the honey peach trees stopped fruiting. Qin Mian stopped supplying honey peaches to Double Xiang House. The last batch of peaches, he sent 20 jin to Deng Village, 20 jin to the old house, two to each of his servants, and the rest were sold at the price of 100 Wen per jin, earning him another fortune.

At this time, the grapes and the yellow peaches began to ripen.

There were only two grapevines, and the grapes were enough for Qin Mian and Lei Tie to eat for themselves.

Yellow peaches were not suitable for storage, but they were very suitable for canning. It tasted very sweet. Even Qin Mian, who strongly disliked anything sweet, liked it very much. He and Lei Tie went to the county town to order a thousand small earthen jars with a capacity of about one and a half *sheng*¹ to make canned yellow peaches. Of course, they used the same brand name.

The two hired a group of dexterous women in the village and picked the ripe yellow peaches. After washing the yellow peaches, they peeled, cut in half, removed the pits, and then cut the flesh into pieces. A pot of water was brought to boil and added with sugar. When the sugar dissolved, the flesh of the yellow peaches was poured in. After it started to boil, turned to low

heat, and cooked until the flesh was soft and firm. Lastly, the flesh was put in the clean jar and filled until 4/5 parts full before sealing it.

After a thousand canned yellow peaches were ready, Qin Mian used the excuse of sending them to the ice storehouse in the town, but actually stored all of it in the space. In autumn and winter, when he sold them at the price of 1 silver tael per can, he could make a net profit of 1000 silver taels!

The rest of the yellow peach was mainly supplied to Double Xiang House.

The customers of Double Xiang House had noticed that after eating Leisurely Farmhouse's fruits for a long time, their physical condition had obviously improved. Especially for the women, they discovered that the spots and lines on their faces were much lighter and their skin was whiter. This statement made Double Xiang House's fruit, juice, jam, and pastry sell like hotcakes.

The orchard of Leisurely Farmhouse not only brought wealth to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, but also provided the villagers with the opportunity to do odd jobs by picking, washing, cutting, and transporting fruits. If one worked for a day, one could earn at least 10 Wen! For the women who spend two days embroidering a pouch before selling it but only earned 1 to 2 Wen, this money was like a steal! The lives of the villagers became much better than in previous years. Therefore, they were kinder to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

However, fortune and misfortune correlated with each other. In the meantime, Leisurely Farmhouse also drew some new people's attention.

In the middle of the night, Qin Mian was sleeping soundly. After hearing the fierce barking of dogs coming from the processing yard, Qin Mian woke up with a start. In the darkness, he got up and nearly fell out of the bed, but was caught by Lei Tie.

"A-Tie, there is a thief?"

"Go back to sleep. I'll go and have a look." Lei Tie quickly put on his clothes. His figure flashed and disappeared after jumping out of the window.

Outside, moonlight and starlight mingled while the sounds of frogs and summer insects lingered in the ears but still could not cover up the barking of the dogs.

Qin Mian sat on the bed and yawned, not fully awake. He was not very worried. There were two servants on duty every night at the processing yard, and the six dogs in the processing yard were not ordinary; two of them were wolfhounds and the other four were vicious rural dogs. The six dogs were very vicious. Most people dared not get close to them. After Qin Mian fed them spiritual spring water, they became more intelligent and extraordinarily acute. When work finished in the evening, the servants on duty would untie their ropes. Even if the thieves successfully entered, they would be caught by the dogs.

Qin Mian put on his clothes, carried a lantern, and entered the processing yard from the corner gate. Seeing the torch and swaying shadows in the distance, Qin Mian quickened his pace and called out, "A-Tie, are you alright?"

"I'm fine."

Two thieves were restrained with their hands held on their backs by Lei-Qin Li and Lei-Qin Jian. There was also a man pressed by a wolfhound, lying on the ground, trembling and scared to move. At the side, there were five other dogs with their mouths opened.

On the wall not far away, there was a long wooden ladder. On a closer look, it turned out that two wooden ladders were connected with ropes. There was another wooden ladder that appeared outside the wall.

Qin Mian brought the lantern near the three thieves, and was stunned, "Zhou Erhao, Zhao Sifa, and Li Sanlai?"

Zhou Erhao glanced at the dog's mouth, which was only three inches away from him. He turned his head and begged for mercy. His voice trembled, "B-brother Qin, please spare me this time. I was egged on by those two!" Inwardly, he sighed at his misfortune. He didn't expect these dogs to be so alert. Not long after the three of them climbed over the wall and came in,

they were found out by the dogs. However, they had been prepared and dropped some steamed stuffed buns with knock-out drugs, wanting to incapacitate them. Yet, these dogs did not eat the steamed stuffed buns, not even sniffed at them.

How could he have known that these dogs were so full to have eaten three meals a day and also ate very well? Moreover, they were intelligent. Having simply trained by Lei Tie, they would not eat food given by strangers.

“Nonsense, you frick!” Li Sanlai broke out into curses. “You made the idea of putting knock-out drugs in the steamed stuffed buns!”

“That’s right!” Zhao Sifa chimed in, “It’s Zhou Erhao who egged me and Li Sanlai on!”

“Frick, it was you two who egged me on!” Zhou Erhao fiercely glared at them, “Brother Qin, believe me. Zhao Sifa has always hated you for hiring others to work, but Li Sanlai is even more detestable because he wants to steal your vermicelli recipe.”

“No, it’s him who wants to steal the recipe!” Li Sanlai raised his foot to kick Zhou Erhao, but Lei-Qin Jian exerted force, making him screamed in pain and didn’t dare to move again. He was shocked that the boy, who was only a teenager, had such great strength.

“Shut up!” Qin Mian stopped them and said in a cold voice, “I thought the thieves were from other villages. I honestly didn’t expect it would be you three. Zhao Sifa, if I remember correctly, your wife is working in the vermicelli workshop?”

Zhao Sifa’s head drooped, not making a sound.

“Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. It’d be better to send them to see an official!” Lei-Qin Jian angrily said, “Fortunately, our dogs are smart, otherwise they will succeed.”

Qin Mian frowned. Stealing could either be a big or a small matter. In any case, everyone was from the same village. If they were sent to the official,

their families would certainly hate them (the victim), which might cause more trouble. But if they did not deal with them, these people would regard him and Lei Tie as the sort to be easily bullied.

He asked Lei Tie, “A-Tie, what should we do?”

Lei Tie indifferently said, “Take to see Li Zheng tomorrow morning.”

“No!” Zhou Erhao and the other two turned pale at the same time. The countryfolks were simple, they despised those who resorted to trickery. Once they were sent to see Li Zheng, their reputation would be completely ruined.

“Brother Qin, Brother Lei—”

Lei Tie coldly said, “Take them away.”

After dawn, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to Li Zheng’s home with Lei-Qin Li, Lei-Qin Jian, and Lei-Qin Zhong escorted Zhou Erhao and his other two accomplices.

Seeing this situation, the villagers immediately guessed that something had happened last night, and they all followed behind to watch.

The wives of Zhou Erhao, Li Sanlai, and Zhao Sifa found out their husbands were missing in the middle of the night yesterday. At this time, they realized that their husbands had been caught by Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They rushed over to find people and asked what had happened.

Zhou Erhao and his two accomplices yelled out their grievances.

“Brother Qin, is there any misunderstanding?” Zhou Erhao’s wife was both anxious and worried, as well as a little wary.

Qin Mian said, “Whether or not it’s a misunderstanding, you’ll know after seeing Li Zheng.”

The procession was getting bigger and bigger. Some villagers speculated whether the three people went to the processing yard to steal things last

night. They didn't know that it was the right guess.

Li Zheng saw the group and asked everyone to enter the courtyard. The courtyard of Li Zheng's house was quite large, which was used for discussion meetings when major events happened in the village.

“Lei Tie, Lei Tie's wife. Tell me, what's going on? What's wrong with the three of them?” When Li Zheng saw the village's three good-for-nothing people together, he immediately guessed that the matter was very difficult to handle.

Since Qin Mian was the one who ‘married in’, in the eyes of the villagers, Lei Tie was the master of Leisurely Farmhouse and the processing yard. Thus, Qin Mian signaled Lei Tie to speak.

Lei Tie cupped his hands in obeisance and said, “Li Zheng, thank you for your hospitality. In this matter, Lei-Qin Li and Lei-Qin Jian are the clearest. You may as well listen to them.”

After bowing respectfully, Lei-Qin Li said, “I'd like to report to Li Zheng that last night, these three people climbed over the wall to enter the processing yard and tried to steal things. They were caught by Lei-Qin Jian and me. At this time, there are certainly wooden ladders and stuffed buns with knock-out drugs as evidence.” The explanation was concise and comprehensive, straight to the point.

As soon as the villagers heard this, their disdainful eyes fell on Zhou Erhao, Li Sanlai, and Zhao Sifa. Particularly Zhao Sifa, whose wife was diligent and still working in the vermicelli workshop in the processing yard.

Note:

Footnotes

1. ancient measurement (differ in each dynasty); 1 sheng is about 200 ml. source Zh.wiki

Chapter 114: Two Pink Balls

114 – Two Pink Balls

“Zhao Sifa, you villain!” Zhao Sifa’s wife glared at him, threw herself at him, and beat him hard. She looked at him with despair while her tears were streaming in grief and heartbroken, “Do you want to force our daughter and me to death before you are satisfied? Ah?”

“Calm down, sister.” The women at the side hurriedly pulled her as they soothed her.

The faces of Zhou Erhao’s wife and Li Sanlai’s wife were red, wishing they could drill into the ground.

“Li Zheng, there is no such thing at all!” Zhou Erhao quibbled, “The whole village knows that there are dogs in the processing yard. How could we be foolish to run to death by ourselves?”

“No such thing?” Qin Mian calmly retorted, “Were the three of sleepwalking at the same time? Even carried ladders and brought steamed buns? Or, should I ask someone to find out who bought the knock-out drug, where was it bought?”

Zhou Erhao was tongue-tied. He knew it from the bottom of his heart that once everything was cleared out, he would be even more disgrace.

Li Sanlai coldly snorted and held his head high with an attitude of having been discovered. “I was in the processing yard out of curiosity. Couldn’t I be allowed to walk in and have a look?”

Without Qin Mian’s opening his mouth, some villagers disdainfully spoke out, “Going in at night? Li Sanlai, if you want to make excuses, find a

decent one!”

Zhao Sifa pushed aside his wife and fiercely said, “You’re lucky that nothing was stolen this time!”

Everyone was in an uproar, looking at him in disbelief.

“Qin Mian and Lei Tie, who told you to look down on people? You hired others to work, but not us. You are heartless, don’t blame us for being mean!” Zhao Sifa yelled in justification and confidence.

Qin Mian laughed instead of being angry, and said in a low voice, “We didn’t hire you because when we hired people to dig the pond, you only dug one time after others dug ten times. I can’t hire a man like you. Uncles, this is not my fabrication, right? There were a lot of people there.”

Some villagers chimed in one after another.

“That’s right, I was there, and Uncle Liu too, right? We all clearly saw it!”

Zhao Sifa shrunk his neck, “People can change! How do you know I haven’t changed since?”

Qin Mian smiled even colder as he looked at Zhao Sifa with a mocking look. “You think I don’t know that it was you who made my ox nearly disappeared last time? I didn’t say it because I was giving you a face, but somebody didn’t *appreciate* it.”

Zhao Sifa’s face abruptly changed, and his eyes were evasive.

“What!” Other villagers were shocked. About half a month ago, Qin Mian’s ox disappeared, and everyone helped to find it. They all thought that it was the ox that lifted the stake it was tethered to and ran by itself. At that time, they also thought it strange because Qin Mian’s ox was very docile. How could it suddenly run away?

Lei-Qin Li raised his voice to expose Zhao Sifa’s shameful deed, “Li Zheng, everyone. The matter of our ox almost disappeared back then was precisely done by Zhao Sifa. This event was witnessed by Grandpa Seven.

Zhao Sifa, the old man is your grandfather. He pleaded for you and begged our eldest and little young masters to give you a chance. Unfortunately, you don't cherish it." In the Great Xia Dynasty, stealing and killing oxen were capital crimes¹.

The villagers' comments became louder as their disdainful eyes swept around Zhao Sifa.

Zhao Sifa's face darkly sunk. He tightly closed his mouth, not saying a word.

Qin Mian turned to Li Zheng and politely asked, "Li Zheng, how do you think it is appropriate to solve this matter?"

Li Zheng was in a dilemma. They could not be sent to the government. These three men had children; the oldest was less than ten years old and the youngest was over two years old. If they were sent to see the official, their wives and children would lose support. But if they were not punished, how could he (Li Zheng) continue to manage the village in the future? Nothing could be accomplished without rules. Besides, he still owed a big favor to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

He pondered for a long time before he said, "What do you think of this? Since you found out this matter timely and there was no loss in the processing yard, let the three of them tour the village as an admonishment and forbid them to eat and drink for a whole day."

Qin Mian had expected that the punishment would not be too heavy, so he could only nod his head.

Lei Tie's cold eyes passed over the three men before looking around the other villagers. He said with a cold voice, "If there is another time, [they'll be] send off to the official. If anyone thinks that you can find someone to act against Leisurely Farmhouse next time, try harder."

Everyone was shocked. This was not only a warning to three men but also a reminder to them.

“Thank you for your trouble, Li Zheng.” Qin Mian cupped his hand in obeisance to Li Zheng and left with Lei Tie.

Li Zheng looked at three men in exasperation. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not bad-hearted people. If the three truly wanted to get rid of their bad habits, Qin Mian and Lei Tie might not be unwilling to hire them. But it was a pity that these three people were good-for-nothing. Others couldn't even sympathize with them.

Li Zheng instructed a few strong villagers, “The few of you, escort these three people to tour the village.”

“Yes, Li Zheng.”

Qin Mian told Lei-Qin Zhong and the other two, “I don't think Zhou Erhao, Li Sanlai, and Zhao Sifa are the kind of people who will change after being taught a lesson. Afterward, be sure to guard against them.”

“Yes, Little Young Master.”

Qin Mian said to Lei Tie with some worry, “Zhou Erhao said that Li Sanlai was hunting for the vermicelli recipe. Do you think it's true?”

Lei Tie said, “Have someone to watch him.”

Lei-Qin Jian had been watching Li Sanlai for several days and did not see him contact with suspicious people. It was concluded that Zhou Erhao deliberately misled people. To be cautious, Lei Tie arranged for four people to work the night shift in the processing yard.

Zhao Sifa's wife was an honest woman; the event had nothing to do with her. Qin Mian didn't fire her but reminded her once in front of all the people in the vermicelli workshop that she was not fired because her child was still young. However, if Zhao Sifa did it again, he couldn't accommodate her anymore.

This matter was considered over and done with.

.....

Throughout the morning, Qin Mian was busy compiling the story of The Butterfly Lovers². The storytelling in the afternoon session, Lin Qiang narrated a heart-rending heroic tale; in the evening session, Ye Fengqiu narrated a sad and sentimental love story. Almost every time, the tea room was full. Even many small teahouses copied these two stories, but their progress could only fall behind Double Xiang House. Due to this, a clamoring funny event occurred.

It was said that a rich gongzi surnamed Zhao believed that he had more knowledge than others. No matter what was new, he had seen and experienced it earlier than most people. Once, he listened to a chapter of The Butterfly Lovers in a teahouse out of town, making him clapped his hands, and then cheerfully took his good friend, Zhang-gongzi, to listen to a new one. In the end, he was laughed at by his good friend. It turned out that the story was passed over from the tea room of Double Xiang House! This Zhao-gongzi was so ashamed. From then on, he practically went to Double Xiang House to listen to the storytelling in the evening. Then, he lived in Rugui Building at night, making an important contribution to Double Xiang House's income. Due to these genuine people and true events, Double Xiang House became more famous.

Lei Tie came back from the farm, took a bath, and went upstairs with his hair still wet.

“Wife, take a rest.”

“In a moment, only the finale of The Butterfly Lovers is left. I'm going to finish it all at once.” Qin Mian did not lift his head. To avoid suspicion, he used a writing brush instead of a felt-tip pen or ballpoint pen, making it very difficult to write. Naturally, the writing of the characters was not very good. When he encountered the traditional characters he couldn't write, he still had to ask Lei Tie.

Lei Tie took away the brush in Qin Mian's hand and took over his work. Qin Mian spoke, he wrote.

“What's the next story?”

Qin Mian mischievously chuckled, “Fairy Couple³; a fairy travels to the mortal world and falls in love with a mortal man. After the story of The Butterfly Lovers is over, the evening show will be suspended for three days to keep their appetite hanging.”

Lei Tie took a look at him as he wrote very quickly.

Lei-Qin Le called out from downstairs, “Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. Your servant has come back from delivering fruits.”

Qin Mian was too lazy to go downstairs and went to the balcony, “How is everything in the wine house?”

“All good. Business is very prosperous.” Lei-Qin Le wiped the sweats on his face and looked up, “There is still one thing to report. A new transport line has started in the town, full of luxury carriages, which specially pick up and drop off people from Zhaoyang County and several nearby counties who come to dine in Double Xiang House.”

“Oh? The owner of this transport line is a smart man.” Qin Mian asked, “Do you know who the owner is?”

Lei-Qin Le mysteriously said, “Little Young Master, it’s that boss you and Eldest Young Master are familiar with.”

Qin Mian thought of a man, “Nie Heng?”

“Exactly.” Lei-Qin Le flattered him, “Little Young Master is really amazing, accurately guessed once!”

Qin Mian gave a faint smile.

“That transport line’s business is very good!” Lei-Qin Le regretfully said, “Little Young Master, if we had known that earlier, we should have started our transport line, and he wouldn’t have benefited from us!”

Qin Mian laughed and did not speak. The appearance of the transport business was in his expectation. Apart from Lei Tie, he didn’t tell anyone

that the purpose of his wine house was not only for the wine house itself but also to promote the economic development of Running Water Town. Nie Heng's transport line was only the first one to invest. When more and more businessmen invested, the business of Double Xiang House would be better. Although this was a relatively long-term process, it was not hard for him who had enough chips in his hand. Besides, he could afford to wait. At that time, the existence of Double Xiang House would be more than just a wine house and a guest house.

“Lei-Qin Le, you go there again. With Nie Heng's shrewdness, he certainly won't say that his transport line directly sent the customers to Double Xiang House for dining and accommodation. But our Double Xiang House must show our attitude. You tell Manager Sun to make it clear to him that in case of accidents happen to the customers coming to Double Xiang House while in their carriages, it has nothing to do with Double Xiang House. Also, ask Manager Sun to find a way to buy a shop in the town as soon as possible. It can't be too small and doesn't have to be too big, but good enough if it is twice as big as Eating Savory Restaurant. The location should not be too far apart.”

“Yes!”

Lei-Qin Le turned around and ran.

“Hold on!” Qin Mian amusingly said, “You don't have to be in such a hurry. Pick a few yellow peaches to eat on the road.”

“Thank you, Little Young Master!” The masters treated them so well that when doing tasks for the masters, Lei-Qin Le was very energetic.

Lei-Qin Le came back in the afternoon and said that everything was going well. Manager Sun asked him to pass on Nie Heng's words. Nie Heng wanted to meet Qin Mian to make clear about the matter of the transport line sending the customers of Double Xiang House directly.

Tomorrow, Qin Mian planned to take a trip to the town and deliver the manuscripts by the way.

After dinner, the couple entered the space and watered the pink ball as usual. Recently, without knowing why, White Spot was very concerned about the pink ball, so Qin Mian brought it in together.

Qin Mian slowly watered the pink ball. He touched the pink ball, squinted, and beckoned Lei Tie. “A-Tie, was there a ‘line’ like this on the ball when we came in yesterday?”

There was a shallow groove slightly sunken on the ball, looking as if the pink ball was gradually splitting into two.

Lei Tie scrutinized it, and shook his head, “No.”

To confirm their conjecture, they decided to pay close attention to the pink ball’s changes in the next few days.

The next day, Qin Mian came to the town and met Nie Heng in Double Xiang House.

Nie Heng’s meaning was that he hoped his transport line could be linked to Double Xiang House. In this way, the customers from other places who came to Double Xiang House to dine would return with words of wonder, riding in his carriage. Of course, this was also good for Double Xiang House. Many customers from out of town were very interested in coming to eat at Double Xiang House, but they were too far away to drive or hire a carriage by themselves. Now, there was a ready-made carriage to pick up or send them off directly to their destination, saving them a lot of trouble. Besides, ‘exclusive transport’ sounded very high-class.

Because Bon Voyage Transport Line was dispensable to Double Xiang House, but Double Xiang House was of great significance to Bon Voyage Transport Line, Nie Heng’s reason for starting this transport line clashed with the source of Double Xiang House’s customers. After a heated debate, Qin Mian and Nie Heng reached an agreement that 10% of the monthly income of Nie Heng’s Bon Voyage Transport Line was owned by Double Xiang House.

After this incident, Qin Mian and Nie Heng understood and admired each other's business skills even more, so they became friends.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie paid close attention to the changes of the pink ball day by day. In the early of the ninth month, it changed into two identical pink balls, like a mirror image of each other.

Qin Mian was looking forward to the day when the pink balls were in full bloom. Even Lei Tie was a bit enthusiastic about the pink balls; he would go in and have a look when he had time.



Note:

Footnotes

1. because oxen are used for farming, the essence of a country
2. Chinese folktale of the tragic love between Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai
3. also known The Legend of Dong Yong and Seventh Fairy or Cowherd and the Weaver Girl

Chapter 115: Secrets of Lei Tie's Past (1)

115 – Secrets of Lei Tie's Past

After breakfast, Lei Tie arranged the festival gifts at the house gate. Today was the eighth of the ninth month in the Gregorian calendar of the Yunzhou Continent and the fifteenth of the eighth month in the calendar of the Great Xia Dynasty. It was the Mid-Autumn Festival.

The Mid-Autumn Festival was one of the important festivals of the Great Xia Dynasty. Therefore, Qin Mian's family did not only give gifts to the servants, but also the employees in the processing yard. Each of the servants was given a bonus of 50 Wen and 5 jin of meat. Autumn was the harvest season, and this time was the busiest. It was necessary to improve the treatment of the servants. Meanwhile, each of the employees was given a jin of meat and a bonus, varied according to the level of performance; 8 to 10 Wen for lower and 30 Wen for higher.

Lei Tie held a book in his hand and read out the names and rewards that one deserved. Uncle Fu counted the money and put it into small purses; Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Zhong were responsible for chopping and weighing meat; Lei-Qin Yuan and Lei-Qin Xin tied the small purse and meat together with a straw for easy distribution.

Uncle Quan helped Uncle Fu on the side. Uncle Quan and Aunt Quan were sincere people. Qin Mian allowed Miao Miao to learn to read with others in his Leisurely Farmhouse's school, making the two felt grateful and were very loyal toward Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

There were many people in the yard, but it was very quiet. Only the voice of Lei Tie, the clinking sound of copper coins, and the sound of cutting meat could be heard. No one dared to mess around in front of Lei Tie – everything was in order.

It was a good opportunity to show one's face properly in front of the servants to enhance their loyalty to their employers. It was also a kind of reminder that the servants should not behave without discipline by relying on the master's friendliness. Therefore, Qin Mian had Lei Tie to arrange for the festival gifts himself.

In the evening, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had an important event. At this time, Qin Mian was preparing dried food in the kitchen. He made 30 pieces of each kind of baked sesame pancake with meat stuffing, scallion pancake, cream custard bun, barbeque pork, and even cooked a pot of light soup to be put in the space.

White Spot's two forepaws rested on the stovetop with great interest. It couldn't eat any of these foods, and neither one knew what it was looking at.

Presently, when White Spot was on four, its height could reach Qin Mian's waist; its body was almost twice that of an ordinary adult wolf. The old people in the village secretly said that this wolf was not an ordinary wolf but a wolf king. For a time, the villagers did not dare to get close to Leisurely Farmhouse, and those who went to work in the processing yard did not dare to make a sound when they walked. Later, they found that White Spot paid no heed to them, so they returned to normal behavior.

After Qin Mian finished his work, he washed and dried his hands. He carried a cup of hot tea into the living room, "A-Tie, are you finished?"

He brought the cup to Lei Tie's mouth.

Lei Tie bowed his head and took a sip. "Soon."

Qin Mian sat at the side, waiting for the man to finish his work. He said to Uncle Fu, "Uncle Fu, Eldest Young Master and I are going on a long

journey. We will come back in three or five days. The household affairs are left to you to manage. It's time to harvest the paddy, soybeans, sweet potatoes, and peanuts. Uncle Fu, you should make an arrangement as soon as possible. If the weather changes, it will be bad."

"Yes, Little Young Master can rest assured."

After the servants left, Qin Mian and Lei Tie cleaned up and prepared to go out.

Lei-Qin Zhong hurried back, "Reporting, Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master. The old man has come."

Lei Daqiang? Qin Mian raised his eyebrow. Since Wei Shi's pregnancy, Lei Daqiang put almost all of his attention on Wei Shi's body. Why would he come here today?

Lei Tie motioned Lei-Qin Zhong to withdraw.

Lei Daqiang had come, the Leisurely Farmhouse's servants could not stop him outside the gate. Lei-Qin Zhong went to report first. After a short while, Lei-Qin Le brought Lei Daqiang over.

Lei Daqiang slowly strode forward along the cobblestone path, looking around, unable to contain his jealousy and indignant. This was his son's farmhouse, but he hated that he couldn't benefit from any of it. This son, Lei Tie, was truly unfilial and didn't how to send more of whatever was produced in the orchard to the old house. Remembering the purpose of his coming today, he put aside these thoughts for the time being. With a kind smile on his face, he looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

"Old man¹ is here." Qin Mian was neither hostile nor friendly.

Lei Tie dully looked at Lei Daqiang and didn't even get up. He picked up the bow placed on one side and carefully wiped it.

"Eldest, eldest daughter-in-law, you are both at home. Isn't today the Mid-Autumn Festival? I came to tell you that we're having dinner together in the

evening.” Lei Daqiang sat down on the soft settee, frowned, and glanced at Lei-Qin Le, “Why don’t you serve tea yet?”

Lei-Qin Le had his head and hands lowered, looking as if he didn’t hear it.

Qin Mian secretly snorted. *He makes a show of authority even in someone else’s home.*

“Lei-Qin Le, aren’t you going to dig peanuts today? What are you doing there?”

Lei-Qin Le said in a panic, “Please forgive, Little Young Master. Your servant didn’t hear your instructions just now, so I dare not act rashly. I’ll leave now.”

With that, he quickly left, and soon disappeared into the dense fruit-bearing forest.

Lei Daqiang pulled a long face.

Qin Mian apologetically said, “Old man, you can see that we are packing up. We’re about to go on a long journey, I’m afraid we can’t spend the Mid-Autumn Festival with you. My family wishes you a Happy Mid-Autumn Festival!”

“Do you truly think you can be the master of the house?” Lei Daqiang unhappily glared at Qin Mian, looked at Lei Tie, and indisputably said, “Lei Tie, you and your wife will have dinner with us tonight. It’s been decided.”

“Not going. My wife’s opinion is exactly my opinion.” Lei Tie did not lift his head.

Lei Daqiang frowned and adopted a fatherly attitude. “Eldest, Father isn’t telling you off, but you, because of this unknown origin feral little—”

Before he finished speaking, he was cut off by a pair of cold eyes. In an instant, his back was cold, his legs trembled, and he broke out in cold sweat. Lei Tie’s eyes were like two cold blades, appearing as if they would fly out at any time to stab him.

All of a sudden, his superiority died out. He dared not look directly at Lei Tie's eyes as he mumbled, "You..."

"You can go," Lei Tie coldly said.

Lei Daqiang summoned up his courage and slapped on the tea table. Then, he yelled, "How dare you speak to your father in this tone?"

Lei Tie stood up, a head higher than him, and looked down at him with indifferent eyes, "Why not? Since the day I was forced to run away from home by you and Du Shi, I am no longer your son. Do you want me to make it clearer?"

"You..." Lei Daqiang looked terrified and beyond belief. He actually wanted to take the opportunity of the Mid-Autumn Festival to reconcile with his eldest son. Why was he so cold-blooded and ungrateful? He suddenly recalled that Lei Tie had not called him "father" for a long time.

Qin Mian thought the hurt in the old man's eyes was ridiculous. If Lei Daqiang truly wanted to reconcile, why did he drag on until now? His sincerity was too cheap.

Lei Daqiang stood up, sighed, and reached out his hand to pat Lei Tie on the shoulder, "Eldest, you have to believe that Father still cares about you..."

Lei Tie avoided his hand. The disgust in his eyes made Lei Daqiang stiffen.

Unable to bear it anymore, Qin Mian wanted to speak, but Lei Tie embraced his shoulder and shook his head slightly. He looked at Lei Daqiang, "I believe."

Before Lei Daqiang rejoiced, he heard him say, "I care about you too, so I found an equal wife for you. Are you satisfied?"

Lei Daqiang was stupefied and took a long time to digest the words. Did Lei Tie find Wei Shi for him? Why? He looked at Lei Tie, whose face was expressionless and his estranged eyes looked at him like a stranger. Then, he looked at Qin Mian, whose ironic smile was unpleasant to look at.

Lei Daqiang's face was red and burning. He turned around in confusion and fled.

Qin Mian coldly watched him gradually walk away, tightly holding Lei Tie's hand.

That year, the 12-year-old Lei Tie left Running Water Town with one tael silver given by Youngest Uncle Deng. He did not know where to go and decided to go north. After being abused by Du Shi for a long time, Lei Tie turned a bit clever and converted the silver into two pieces of broken silver and two hundred copper coins to hide them well. However, his luck was so bad that he caught the attention of some people. Before he went too far, he was stopped by a few scoundrels. At that time, the 12-year-old Lei Tie was thin and weak, he was not the opponent of four adults. The copper coins and the broken silvers were robbed. In the end, Lei Tie begged and did temporary jobs so that he wouldn't die of starvation. Lei Tie's first employer was a kind-hearted peasant woman, but her husband had a twisted heart – the man beat and scolded him. The old wound on Lei Tie had not healed, new ones were added.

If it were not for Lei Daqiang conniving Du Shi and neglecting Lei Tie, how could Lei Tie be so miserable? As long as he thought of the abuse that Lei Tie had suffered, Qin Mian couldn't contain his hatred for Lei Daqiang and Du Shi. If it was not for the sake of Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao, he would have thought of countless ways to deal with Lei Daqiang and Du Shi. It was even a small favor to find him an extra wife.

“Wife?”

A warm big palm covered his face, pulling Qin Mian back to his senses. He said, “I'm fine. A-Tie, was it alright to tell Lei Daqiang what happened? Will he tell Wei Shi and Du Shi? Wei Shi's very clever, very likely to guess what we did back then. Will she join hands with Du Shi to deal with us? And Du Shi – once she knew it, she's going to have a deep hatred for us.”

Lei Tie shook his head, “For self-respect, Lei Daqiang won't say it.”

Qin Mian understood after thinking about it. Lei Daqiang cared about Wei Shi very much. Telling Wei Shi about this meant that he had to admit he was manipulated by his own son, and his past might be revealed. Therefore, Lei Daqiang would not tell Wei Shi about it. Neither would Lei Daqiang tell Du Shi. Du Shi had a big mouth. If she knew about it, the whole family and the whole village would know. By that time, it would only attract more people to see the old house's embarrassment. Lei Daqiang also had to consider Lei Xiangzhi.

In the tenth month, Lei Xiangzhi was going to take part in the college examination.

Qin Mian leaned on Lei Tie and pondered for a while about how should he and Lei Tie deal with it, in case Lei Daqiang told Du Shi and Wei Shi about this.

After he thought of a way, his expression turned to relax. He stood up. "Leave them alone. Let's go."

Note:

Footnotes

1. Fun fact: The couple never again used the usual word “爹/father” as the other Leis did, but “Lao Ye Zi” which used to address an elderly man/or one's father in respectful (or estranged in this case).

Chapter 116: Secrets of Lei Tie's Past (2)

116 – Secrets of Lei Tie's Past (2)

Qin Mian and Lei Tie took their ration and rode on horsebacks, galloping at full speed out of the village. White Spot, like a flash of black lightning, followed closely. After surveying the mountain slope, looking around, and saw no one, the two men and a wolf turned in direction and entered the mountain forest.

Once entering the mountain forest, Qin Mian and Lei Tie sent their horses into the space.

Two men and a wolf walked slowly in the mountains. Lei Tie and White Spot hunted prey from time to time.

Qin Mian had been very excited since he went out. He seemed absent-minded and just dilatorily followed Lei Tie. Lei Tie had said that he would teach him the Cultivation of Trueness¹ on the night of the full moon on the fifteenth of the eighth month! Cultivation of Trueness, which was only seen in TV dramas, movies, and novels! How could he not get excited?

When Qin Mian got the magical ring by chance back then, he deluded that there were treasures such as manuals of Cultivation of Trueness, miraculous panacea, mystical celestial soldiers, and so on inside. However, he searched in the quadrangle courtyard and found nothing. Of course, he was not disappointed. After all, he was very lucky to have such a portable space. He was not greedy.

At that time, when Lei Tie told him that he was a cultivator and would teach him to practice, he was so surprised that he could hardly restrain himself. However, Lei Tie said that the ‘‘Immortal Mantra of Examining One’s Conscience’’ that he practiced had the best foundation building effect and the least pain on the full moon night of the fifteenth of the eighth month, so he had been waiting until today.

During those years that Lei Tie ran away from home, he wandered alone for over a year and suffered a lot. Later, he saved an old man who was down and out. It was the old man who taught him the ‘‘Immortal Mantra of Examining One’s Conscience’’ and built the foundation for him. Unfortunately, the old man did not wish to let Lei Tie know of his name and left without saying goodbye after half a year. Fortunately, Lei Tie was very talented in cultivation. By the virtue of his innate talent and a few cultivation manuals left by the old man, he reached the Golden Elixir period in just a few years.

This lucky event, combined with the torturous experience of Lei Tie, made Qin Mian sigh with emotion. There were several words suitable for explaining Lei Tie’s experience, ‘‘Heaven will bring great responsibility to humans; first of all, bring suffering to his will, toil his flesh and bone, starve his body, and destitute his life.’’

He was so lost in thought that his footsteps stopped, unknowingly.

Lei Tie went over and worriedly put his big palm on his wife’s forehead, ‘‘Wife, uncomfortable?’’

Qin Mian returned to his senses and hurriedly shook his head, ‘‘No.’’ He looked around. At the moment, they were by a shallow stream. The water flowing down from the mountaintop was so clear that one could see the stones and water plants underwater, as well as chopstick-long fish leisurely swimming in the water. There were two crossing logs next to each other on the stream, probably placed by the hunters who passed by. The meadow beside the stream seemed to have been trimmed very evenly, but in the ninth month, some weeds had turned slightly yellow.

Qin Mian enthusiastically said, ‘‘A-Tie, let’s stay here until it gets dark.’’

Lei Tie nodded, took a chair from the space, and put it beside him.

“There are other good things.” Qin Mian ran into the space, brought out a thin blanket, and spread it on the grass. Then he took out several fruit plates from the space, filled with grapes and bananas he loved to eat and apples that Lei Tie loved to eat. Finally, he took out two large pillows. He lay on the blanket, supported his chin with one arm, ate the fruit, and beckoned Lei Tie, “Come here.” The world was boundless. It felt so great that no one would disturb them.

Lei Tie sat down beside his wife and put his arms around him.

White Spot saw that the camp had been settled and excitedly ran into the deep woods. It was unknown what small animals it disturbed when the rustling sound of the trees came from the distance.

Qin Mian picked up an apple and handed it to Lei Tie while he ate the grapes with relish.

Lei Tie took the apple but did not eat it. He held his wife’s nape, bowed his head, and covered his wife’s lips. The tip of his tongue first licked the grape juice on his wife’s lips.

Qin Mian felt numb as though he was electrified. He looked up at the man and saw that the man was just staring at his lips. He did not know what the man was thinking. Could he still be distracted at this time? He felt uncomfortable and opened his mouth to speak, but his lips were sealed. The hot temperature on the tip of his tongue showed that the other party’s mood was not as calm as his paralyzed face. Pride burst forth from Qin Mian’s heart. He put his hands on the other party’s nape so that they got closer.

After entangling for a long time, the two separated. Lei Tie’s thumb still lingered on Qin Mian’s face, and the eyes fixed on him were deep and profound, seemingly wanting to suck his whole person in before letting go.

Qin Mian was fully satisfied. He comfortably leaned on Lei Tie’s bosom, grabbed a grape, and put it into his mouth.

Lei Tie picked up the grapes in the fruit plate and fed them to him one by one.

Qin Mian accepted the feeding with ease, “A-Tie, we’ll plant more grapes next year. The wine in our winery sells well. It will certainly be more well-received.”

“Listen to you.”

A drop of grape juice flowed down the corner of his mouth, making him itchy. Qin Mian had wanted to wipe it with his hand, but something moist and warm stuck on his face and licked the juice away.

This kind of reverie action with a paralyzed face suddenly stabbed Qin Mian’s *meng*² spot. He rolled over, pressed Lei Tie under his body, and unscrupulously kissed him.

Lei Tie’s pupils darkened. He tightly hugged his wife’s waist and slipped his hand into his wife’s clothes.

Qin Mian immediately thought of today’s business. He quickly got up from the man’s body and reminded him, “Today, can’t.”

Lei Tie froze and lowered his eyes. His Adam’s apple rapidly rolled and his chest fluctuated sharply several times before calming down. Then he slowly sat up and sorted his disordered clothes while pretending to be calm.

Qin Mian suddenly felt that he was very mean. He buried his head in the soft pillow and laughed, “Hahaha...”

Lei Tie stared at him for a moment before slapping his upturned buttocks. Then, he picked up a twig and pared it with a hunting knife.

After Qin Mian laughed enough, he crawled over, leaned on the man’s shoulder, and asked curiously, “Doing what?”

Lei Tie inclined his head and pecked his wife’s lips, “Stick in fish.”

Qin Mian then jumped to his feet with great interest, "I'm going to pick up twigs."

"Don't go too far," Lei Tie advised.

"Rest assured." Qin Mian waved his hand and picked up the dried twigs nearby.

When White Spot had played enough, it ran back, rushed to the thin blanket, and rolled on it. After that, it stretched out its four limbs and lay down.

Lei Tie frowned, grabbed its nape, and lifted it. White Spot looked up at him, maintaining the stretch-out posture, unmoved.

Lei Tie put it on the grass without saying a word and continued to pare the twigs.

White Spots shook the grass off its body, ran back to the thin blanket, and lay down.

With a poker-face, Lei Tie picked it up again and put it on the grass.

Speechless, White Spot stared at him for a long time, and resignedly lay down there, no longer moving.

Qin Mian came back with a bundle of dried twigs. Lei Tie had cleaned up five fish, threw one fish to White Spot, and set fire to roast the other four. Qin Mian took out the food he had made at home.

Lunch was settled simply.

In the afternoon, two people and a wolf took a nap for nearly two hours and then took a look around.

As the sky darkened, the round moon hung in the sky, like a jade plate.

Lei Tie looked at the sky and pressed Qin Mian's shoulder, "Wife, sit cross-legged."

Qin Mian did so.

Lei Tie sat down behind Qin Mian, pressed his hands on the other's middle back, and then moved away, "Wife, it will be very uncomfortable, endure it."

"A-Tie, don't worry. You can do it, so can I." Qin Mian looked at him with firm eyes. No matter how painful it would be to build a foundation, he would stick to it. He could not imagine what the young Lei Tie went through at that time, but he was older.

"I won't let something happen to you." Lei Tie kissed him and pressed his palms on his middle back again.

Foundation Establishment was a process of removing impurities and broadening meridians. When Lei Tie's hands stuck to his back, Qin Mian's body was immediately affected by two opposite impacts: pain and comfort. The pain was because Lei Tie used his vital spirit force to open up the meridians in his body; the comfort was because that vital spirit flowed in his body like a warm current, making his whole body warm.

Lei Tie watched Qin Mian's expression carefully; although he frowned, he didn't seem to have any difficulty. Lei Tie put down his worry and moved his palms down to continue to expand the other party's meridians.

The process went so smoothly that both of them were surprised. Lei Tie remembered that when the "master" built the foundation for him, there seemed to be countless searing irons stirring in his body, almost pained him to the extent of wishing to die. If his willpower was not strong, he would have collapsed physically and mentally.

They immediately surmised that it was because Qin Mian's body had been nourished and nurtured by the spiritual spring water and various high-quality vegetables and fruits in the space for a long time that he became very strong.

The fact was exactly so. Qin Mian had never been ill because of this reason.

About an hour later, Qin Mian felt something invisible in the air entered his body gently through his numerous pores, making his whole body languid. This should be the spiritual qi. Unknowingly, his consciousness gradually drifted and his whole person seemed to have been put under a fixed body spell, absolutely still.

A trace of surprise flashed through Lei Tie's eyes. His wife entered the state of "Enlightenment" in the process of building a foundation, indicating that his wife was as talented as he was in cultivation. In this way, the gap between him and his wife would soon be shortened.

The moonlight was like the surface of the water, and the Lord of Heaven was cooperating³.

Lei Tie withdrew his scattered mind and continued to slowly and carefully input his vital spirit into Qin Mian's body.

He didn't notice that White Spot, which lay on the side with its eyes closed, was enveloped in faint white light that disappeared into its body soundlessly like water flowing into the dried ground.

After about four hours, the full moon gradually sank to the west. Only then Lei Tie withdrew his hands.

As if awakening from a dream, Qin Mian blinked somewhat blankly. For a while, he didn't know where he was.

"Wife?"

"A-Tie?" Qin Mian suddenly remembered that he was building a foundation, "I just..."

Lei Tie bowed his head and pecked his lips, "Went smoothly. I'm going to teach you the Immortal Mantra of Examining One's Conscience."

He put his big palm on Qin Mian's forehead. Instantly, a lot of content flowed into Qin Mian's mind. He knew that this was precisely the "Immortal Mantra of Examining One's Conscience".

Lei Tie said, “Today’s a good time to practice. We’ll start to practice now. I’ll guide you first, and then you’ll follow the flow path of the vital spirit.”

Qin Mian nodded his head to show that he understood. After remembering the path, he guided the spiritual qi of the universe into his body according to the method. Then he refined the spiritual qi into a vital spirit and stored it in the dantian, over and over again...

After the sun rose and set, Qin Mian finally opened his eyes. He seemed to have lost 10 jin of weight. Feeling somewhat unaccustomed, he got up with a jump. He was overjoyed.

A ghost of a smile flashed in Lei Tie’s eyes as he watched his wife silently. His wife was originally handsome. At this time, he had more spiritual qi, which made his eyes bright and deep and his whole person even more charming.

“Wife.”

Qin Mian raised his smiling face, walked up to the man in a few steps, hugged his waist, and offered a kiss, “I feel great—ah! Why are your lips black—” He suddenly realized. He looked down and saw that his hands were black, his white clothes had turned grey, and there was an obvious foul smell. He wailed and escaped into the space.

The corner of Lei Tie’s lips curved, and he disappeared instantaneously.

By the time the two reappeared in the woods, they had cleaned up so neat and fresh.

Lei Tie brought out a plate from the space, which contained two baked sesame pancakes with meat stuffing, two scallion pancakes, two barbecued pork crisps, and two cream custard buns, as well as a bamboo tube filled with soup.

“Eat something first.”

Qin Mian was so hungry that he didn't care to talk. He took a baked sesame pancake with meat stuffing and ate it.

Lei Tie handed a handkerchief to him, picked up a scallion pancake, and slowly chewed it. His action was so graceful it could drive someone to death.

Qin Mian squinted and looked at the only mouthful of pancake left in his hand before putting it into his mouth when Lei Tie didn't pay attention.

Both sides of Lei Tie's cheek were bulging, and in the blink of an eye, he had chewed the food well before swallowing it.

Qin Mian burst into hearty laughter and then worried, "Slow down, don't choke."

Lei Tie shook his head and patted his wife's head placatingly.

Note:

Footnotes

1. In Taoism, learning the Dao (path) and practice Buddhism or Taoism is for seeking true self. "Cultivation of Trueness" is to discard the false and retain the true. Commonly called Dao Cultivation (cultivate oneself according to a religious doctrine).
2. (JP)moe; slang describing affection for a cute character.
3. (idiom)the weather is favorable for the planned activity. The whole sentence meant such.

Chapter 117: Wife is Mighty

117 – Wife is Mighty

The mountains and rivers were full of spiritual qi. For four days, Qin Mian had been practicing. He was very talented in cultivation. In a few days, his accomplishments reached the middle stage of Enlightenment. It was no problem for him to leap over the treetops and across the rivers.

To shorten the gap between them, Lei Tie did not practice but accompanied him at the side. Occasionally, he entered the space and bustled about, collecting eggs, harvesting vegetables, growing vegetables, picking fruits, and so on. Also, he used the grapes in the space to brew six jars of wine. When he was away, Qin Mian was guarded by White Spot.

Four days later, two men and a wolf appeared in the public's sight.

Outside the village, the golden paddy looked more dazzling in the sun. When the old farmers touched the ears of the paddy, their wrinkled faces showed a satisfied smile.

The two deliberately went around their paddy field. Uncle Fu and four servants were working hard to harvest the paddy. From time to time, they wiped the sweat slipping down their chins with the towels hanging around their necks.

“Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master are back!”

Lei Tie waved his hand to stop them from saluting. He turned over and dismounted, walked to the edge of the paddy field, and cut off an ear to check.

“A-Tie, how is the paddy this year?” Qin Mian came to him and asked.

They dared not to have a big gap with other people's paddy fields, so they did not use the spiritual spring water in the paddy field. However, before transplanting the paddy seedlings, they had their servants fertilize the paddy field. Therefore, both men were concerned about the paddy's harvest.

Lei Tie nodded, "Pretty good, the grains are fuller and less shriveled."

Uncle Fu happily chipped in, "Eldest Young Master, Li Zheng passed by here just now and also praised that our paddy is one of the best in the village this year."

In the beginning, Qin Mian had people to put farmyard manure into the paddy field, which the villagers did not understand. In the past, the careful villagers found that vegetables that had been accidentally spilled with manure grew better than other vegetables, so they pondered whether the manure could fertilize the field. The bold villagers tried it on the whole field, and all the vegetables died. Since then, no one dared to try. Farmyard manure naturally had the effect of fertilizing the soil, but because they did not dilute the farmyard manure, it "burnt" the vegetables to death.

"Uncle Fu, you find a time to talk with Li Zheng that the farmyard manure can only be used for fertilizing after being diluted," Qin Mian said.

"Yes, Little Young Master." Uncle Fu reported the household's affairs in detail, "Uncle Quan takes four people to dig peanuts in the peanut field. My wife and Uncle Quan's wife are cutting the soybean pods."

"Got it."

Farmers dreaded rain during the harvest season. After Qin Mian and Lei Tie went home, they put on straw hats to help in the peanut field.

Lei Tie pulled up the peanut vines one by one and piled them together, while Qin Mian sat on a small bench and picked the peanuts off one by one and put them in the basket. Qin Mian had secretly sprinkled diluted spiritual spring water on the peanut field in Leisurely Farmhouse. The peanuts were white and plump, making him very satisfied. He had already thought of what to eat for lunch.

They were busy until noon. Qin Mian went back to cook an hour earlier. He cooked a dish of shelled peanuts with vinegar and a dish of boiled five-flavored peanuts, trying something new.

The peanuts in half a *mu* of field were picked in a day. After the peanut vines were pulled out, they still had to till the field to close up the holes, conveniently turned the soil to prepare for the next round of planting.

After digging peanuts, they dug sweet potatoes. Digging sweet potatoes required experience. If not careful, the sweet potatoes under the ground would break, thus looked bad and inconvenient to store.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't have much experience so they didn't interfere. They left it to the servants. Lei Tie took a sickle and went to harvest the paddy. At home, Qin Mian made overall arrangements for Double Xiang House, Eating Savory Restaurant, the processing yard, and the farmland. The workers in the processing yard still had to plant in their own families' fields. Within the half month after the Mid-Autumn Festival, the winery and vermicelli workshop only operated for half a day. Naturally, the wages were only calculated by half. The villagers praised Lei Tie and Qin Mian for their consideration.

Qin Mian was also responsible for another thing — delivering a meal to Lei Tie. The hot spell during autumn in the ninth month was fierce. After walking under the sun in such weather, Qin Mian's head hurt a little. He regretted that he didn't wear a straw hat when he came out. He hastened his pace.

Seeing his wife carrying the food box and gradually getting closer as he walked along the ridge, Lei Tie's heart softened, recalling the similar situation last year. Unconsciously, he and his wife had been together for a year.

"Why are you in a daze?" Qin Mian was a bit shy. In public, Lei Tie still looked at him with such undisguised tenderness, nearly throwing him out of order.

Lei Tie pulled his wife to sit down on a bundle of paddy, took off his straw hat, and put it on his wife's head. "Eat yet?"

"Yes." Qin Mian first handed him the water bag to let him wash up. Then he took down a board which was buckled at the bottom of the food box. This board was a folding tray. He unfolded the tray, put the tray on his legs, and then put the meal out of the food box onto the tray.

A dish of twice-cooked pork, a dish of steamed meat with rice flour, a dish of scrambled eggs with chives, and a bowl of soup were all home-made dishes and tasted delicious.

After washing his hands and face, Lei Tie picked up the tray and put it on his legs to eat.

Qin Mian drew out the folding fan in his waist to fan him.

"Wife, I'm not hot."

Qin Mian continued to fan, "I'm fanning myself and you by the way."

"En." Lei Tie asked, "Want some?"

Qin Mian shook his head, "I'm full."

In the paddy field next to them, the villagers, who were also eating, glanced at them with envious eyes from time to time.

Uncle Fu and the other four servants sat not far away and were also eating. Their meals were brought by Aunt Fu and Aunt Quan. A pot of scrambled eggs with green peppers and a pot of stewed eggplants with fat meat was an excellent treatment. They needed fat and water to do physical work. Generally speaking, the stewed eggplants with sliced fat meat was the most delicious dish for them.

The biggest paddy field of Lei Daqiang's family was not far away from here. Lei Xiangren had already seen Qin Mian come to deliver food. With a rice bowl in hand, he quickly walked over and loudly greeted them in a friendly tone, "Eldest Brother, are you eating?"

Lei Tie glanced at him. Without a sound, he picked up a piece of steamed meat and put it into his mouth. The steamed meat made by his wife was soft and delicious, not greasy at all.

Lei Xiangren squatted down beside Lei Tie and looked straight at the tray. "Eldest Sister-in-law's cooking is so good. Look, these dishes are colorful and smell good. I'll taste."

He licked off the rice grains on the chopsticks and stretched them toward the steamed meat.

In a split second, Lei Tie's face sunk heavily.

Qin Mian looked at the chopsticks still stained with Lei Xiangren's saliva and frowned. Before Lei Xiangren's chopsticks touched the steamed meat, Qin Mian stopped him and said to Lei Tie with a happy smile, "A-Tie, Second Brother must be shy to take more. You help him."

Lei Tie nodded and paused for a bit. After he turned the chopsticks around, he gave Lei Xiangren a few pieces of steamed meat and a clip of scrambled eggs with chives.

Qin Mian snickered behind the fan.

Lei Xiangren was unaware of Qin Mian and Lei Tie's dislike of him, so he retracted his chopsticks with satisfaction and ate with big bites, smacking his lips noisily.

"Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. Father and Mother are exhausted these days. There are more than a dozen servants in your family. How about lending some to us?"

Lei Tie showed firm determination, "No."

Qin Mian said, "As you know, our family grows paddy, peanuts, sweet potatoes, and fruit trees... Also, have to herd the cows, feed the chickens, and guard the processing yard. I'm afraid we won't be able to lend any manpower for a while."

Lei Xiangren opened his mouth to speak, but Qin Mian spoke again with a surprise in his tone, "If I remember correctly, your family has 12 mu of paddy field. Your family now has the old man, the old lady, Second Brother, Second Brother's wife, Third Brother, Third Brother's wife, and Fourth Brother as the labor forces. There are seven people in total. Normally, you can finish harvesting the paddy in three to four days at most, right? Did your family buy another farmland? Otherwise, how can the manpower be insufficient? Buying farmland is a good thing, but you keep it from me and A-Tie."

Blocked by Qin Mian, Lei Xiangren couldn't utter a word. Only after quite a while did he spoke in embarrassment, "Didn't buy it. I was just saying it casually."

"Oh." Qin Mian looked convinced and took some meat with Lei Tie's chopsticks. "By the way, Second Brother, I heard that you and your wife are going to enlighten Dabao. The old man and the old lady must have agreed? That child Dabao looks smart. He will surely have the same future as his fifth uncle."

Lei Tie raised his eyes and looked at his wife. A ghost of a smile flashed away before he silently buried his head to eat.

Lei Xiangren's deep dissatisfaction with Du Shi and Lei Daqiang was aroused by Qin Mian's words. He said in a deep voice, "This matter... Neither Father nor Mother agreed."

"No way!" Qin Mian said in surprise, "Dabao is six years old. Everyone knows that children at this age are the most intelligent and most suitable for intellectual development. Besides, Dabao is the eldest grandson! How can the old man and the old lady..." Speaking of the last sentence, he lowered his voice as if he was talking to himself, with a tone that carried a bit of doubt and a sudden understanding of something.

Lei Xiangren's curiosity was suspended by Qin Mian, and his heart buried some doubts, "Eldest Sister-in-law, what do you mean?"

“Nothing,” Qin Mian glossed it over with a change the topic, “Second Brother, have some more of the steamed meat.”

Lei Xiangren thought a lot from Qin Mian’s half words. *That’s right, Dabao is the eldest grandson of the old man and the old lady. He is smart. Why do the old man and the old lady disagree to enlighten him? Do they only care about their youngest son? Do they want to set aside all the money they usually save and withhold to the youngest son? Why?*

“Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. I remember that I have something else to do. I’ll go first.” Lei Xiangren stood up and left in a hurry.

Lei Tie picked up a piece of tender meat and handed it to Qin Mian’s mouth.

Qin Mian opened his mouth and ate it. He urged the man, “Eat it quickly. The food is going to be cold.”

Uncle Fu and the others, who also heard the dialogue between Qin Mian and Lei Xiangren, admired Qin Mian from the bottom of their heart. *That’s what one called invisible killing. Little Young Master is mighty!*

Chapter 118: Anti-Seasonal Vegetables

118 – Anti-seasonal Vegetables

Lei Tie carried two big fish into the hedge yard, “Wife, eat fish for lunch.”

Qin Mian draped the clothes in the laundry basket on the clothes hanger, and then hung it on the clothes drying pole. Shaking off the water on his hands, he took a look at the fish in the man’s hand and said, “Where did you get it?”

“In the pond.” Lei Tie came to him and said, “Don’t you like to eat—”

“Ugh—” a strong fishy smell rushed into Qin Mian’s nostrils, stirring a disgusting feeling in his stomach. He hurriedly ran to the wall, covered his chest, and opened his mouth to spit out a mouthful of filth.

Lei Tie’s expression changed. He strode over to support the other person, “What’s wrong?”

“Ugh—” nausea stirred up again. Qin Mian stepped back and looked at the fish in the man’s hand with disgust. “Isn’t the fish smelly?”

Strung together by the rice straws via the gills, the two fish were thrown on the ground by Lei Tie, and they were still swinging their tails in deathbed struggle. Anxious, Lei Tie embraced Qin Mian and clasped the other’s wrist with his right hand to check his pulse.

“There’s nothing wrong with me.” Qin Mian also wondered. As soon as the fishy smell disappeared, his nausea disappeared.

Lei Tie frowned, “Pulse is fine.”

“I’m really fine.” Qin Mian looked at the bouncing fish on the ground suspiciously, “It’s strange. Don’t you sense the two fish smell very fishy?”

Lei Tie shook his head and scrutinized his wife’s complexion – a healthy ruddy complexion and no abnormality. “Go in.”

He picked up the two fish and put them in the corner, scooped water to clean his hands, and then hung the remaining clothes.

Qin Mian felt a little tired. He went back to the house and lay down on the settee. He beat out a yawn and was gradually swept away by sleepiness.

Lei Tie finished hanging the clothes and went into the living room. Qin Mian was already asleep. His eyebrows wrinkled again. *Just woke up in less than two hours, [he’s] sleepy again?* He silently walked over, lowered his head, and stuck his forehead to Qin Mian’s. There was no fever, which let his worry down a little, but the wrinkles on his eyebrows did not unfold. He dropped a dragonfly kiss on Qin Mian’s lips, went to the windowsill, and pulled the rope.

Uncle Fu came over. He saw Lei Tie’s figure through the open window and saluted at the door. “Eldest Young Master, what can I do for you?”

“Go and invite Doctor Liu.”

Is Little Young Master sick? Uncle Fu didn’t dare to delay and went away.

Doctor Liu was the village’s doctor. He was in his early 40s. His family had been practicing medicine for three generations and his medical expertise was profound, handed down from his father’s generation. He could diagnose common diseases.

Doctor Liu came very quickly. While he was worried about the patient, he was also curious about Leisurely Farmhouse. After he came in, he walked quickly and did not stop to look at the scenery of the farmhouse.

Lei Tie politely invited him into the living room, "Doctor Liu, my wife is a little uncomfortable. Thank you for your trouble."

"You're welcome." Doctor Liu went over to check Qin Mian's pulse. He looked at Lei Tie suspiciously, looked back at Qin Mian's complexion, and put down his wrist. "Your wife's pulse is very normal."

Lei Tie felt more uncertain. He stroked Qin Mian's face with his big hand and said, "These days, he is sleepy and lethargic. He can't stand the fishy smell. Just now, he vomited when he smelled the fishy smell."

Uncle Fu was taken aback.

Doctor Liu was confused for a moment. His doubtful eyes swept around the boy on the settee. A man of Lei Tie's character would never crack a joke. Why did this sound like a pregnancy symptom? However, as everyone knew, Qin Mian was hundred-percent a man.

Lei Tie called in a heavy tone, "Doctor Liu?"

Doctor Liu regained his senses. For the first time, he was unconfident in his medical expertise. He took up Qin Mian's wrist again and awkwardly said, "I'll check again."

Lei Tie did not speak.

Doctor Liu closed his eyes and felt the pulse carefully. He then said in certainty, "Your wife's pulse is neither unstable nor slow, but gentle and vigorous; fit as a fiddle and absolutely has no ailment. As for the fact that he can't stand the fishy smell, maybe it's because he had too much breakfast... made him churn."

Lei Tie was noncommittal. He took out a few coppers from the pouch, "Thank you, Doctor Liu."

Doctor Liu declined, "No fee since I don't provide a prescription."

Lei Tie nodded, "Uncle Fu, send Doctor Liu out and pick some pears for Doctor Liu."

“Yes.” Uncle Fu made a gesture to Doctor Liu, “Doctor Liu, please.”

Doctor Liu had yet refused but when he saw Lei Tie holding Qin Mian ready to leave, he closed his mouth wisely and followed Uncle Fu to leave.

Lei Tie carried the person in his arms carefully, but he woke up after just taking a few steps.

“A-Tie, I fell asleep?”

Lei Tie’s eyes filled with worry, “[Let’s] go to see a doctor in town.”

Qin Mian put his arms around the man’s neck and said in amusement, “What for? I’m really fine. Put me down first.”

Lei Tie frowned and didn’t speak. His eyes stared at Qin Mian without blinking.

“Really fine!” Qin Mian held the man’s shoulders and lifted his upper body. “Believe me. Don’t I know my body? I don’t feel sick at the moment.”

Lei Tie quietly put him back on the settee.

Qin Mian scratched his head and realized that something was wrong with him recently. He was easily tired and sleepy and he ate more than before.
Are they the indications of growth?

He stretched out his arms and smacked his lips. “Hungry. I want to eat spicy and sour vermicelli with tofu in it.”

“I’ll buy [tofu].” Lei Tie stroked Qin Mian’s head and went to the kitchen to get a big bowl.

Lei-Qin Le was feeding the horses in the stable. There were four horses in the stable. The brown horse and the black horse were the exclusive horses of Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The other two horses were bought after for the carriage.

“Lei-Qin Le.”

Lei-Qin Le obediently ran over. "Greetings, Eldest Young Master!"

"Go to the best doctor in town at once."

"Yes!"

When Doctor Liu came, Lei-Qin Le saw it. Feeling somewhat worried, he quickly pulled out a horse, mounted it, and galloped away.

Thinking of Qin Mian's abnormality, Lei Tie's vibe became oppressive than before as he walked to the tofu workshop in the south of the village. The villagers who met him on the road did not dare to approach him and stayed far away.

The window of the small tofu workshop was open. The lady owner was sitting lazily behind the counter, basking in the sun.

Lei Tie took out some copper coins and put them on the counter, "2 jin of tofu."

The lady cheered up and said with a smile, "Why is Brother Lei come here to buy in person?"

Lei Tie didn't speak, and she also didn't mind. She weighed the tofu with deft hands and put it into the bowl for him, "2 jin, accurate."

Lei Tie nodded and left in a hurry.

Back at Leisurely Farmhouse, upon seeing Qin Mian doing stroke and stick training with Lei-Qin Zhong's group in high spirits from a distance, Lei Tie's expression slightly eased up. He quickly walked over.

"Wife."

"A-Tie, come back so soon?" Qin Mian threw away his stick and ran over, "Let's go home and make spicy and sour vermicelli."

In the kitchen, he instructed Lei Tie to chop up the fresh lean meat, wash and cut the coriander, remove the stalk and seed of the green and red

peppers before cutting into shreds, and peel and mince the garlic.

He stir-fried the minced meat and put the tofu in the boiling soup. After the sweet potato vermicelli was cooked, he drained and poured them into the bowl. Next, he added the stir-fried minced meat, coriander, green and red pepper shreds, salted fried soybeans, and minced garlic. Then, he poured the soup and added vinegar, soy sauce, and chili oil. Lastly, he sprinkled chopped green onion and stirred well.

Qin Mian ladled up two bowls; one for Lei Tie and one for him.

Qin Mian tasted it, but it was not sour enough. He went to the kitchen and brought the vinegar jar. He added three teaspoons of vinegar to his bowl and also Lei Tie's bowl.

"Eat." Qin Mian picked up the vermicelli with his chopsticks and ate with gusto.

Lei Tie took the first bite and sourness made him gasp.

"What's wrong?" Qin Mian raised his eyes to look at the man while still slurping the vermicelli.

Lei Tie looked at his wife's bowl in silence. He stretched out his chopsticks, picked up a few pieces of vermicelli, and tasted it. His cheeks caved in.
"Sour."

"Not sour." Qin Mian looked at him strangely. *Did this guy learn to be funny?*

Lei Tie paused for a while before pushing his bowl toward his wife, "You eat."

"You don't enjoy it. I'll cook noodles for you in a moment." Qin Mian glanced at him with regret. He continued to eat the spicy and sour vermicelli, happily. After finishing the vermicelli in his bowl, he wiped clean the vermicelli in Lei Tie's bowl.

After the meal, Lei Tie accompanied Qin Mian to take a nap for a while before Lei-Qin Le brought home the most famous doctor in the town.

Qin Mian knew that Lei Tie was still worried about him and obediently allowed the doctor to check his pulse.

After the doctor checked the pulse, he lightly said, “The pulse is neither unstable nor slow, but gentle and vigorous; there is no ailment.”

With that, he asked uncertainly, “Is there anyone else who needs to see a doctor?”

Qin Mian cast a “’relieved now?” look at Lei Tie and said to the doctor, “Thank you for your trouble, doctor. Uncle Fu, pay the fee and send the doctor back.”

“Yes.”

As soon as Uncle Fu and the doctor left, Qin Mian hugged Lei Tie and said, “Already said I’m fine.”

“It’s good then.” Lei Tie tightly hugged him, “If you feel unwell, don’t hide it from me.”

“En.” Qin Mian mentioned about business, “Have they bought all the vegetable seeds?”

Lei Tie nodded, “Cucumber, pepper, eggplant, bitter gourd, tomato, loofah, and so on are all bought. What are you going to do?”

Qin Mian had a mysterious and complacent look on his face. “Growing anti-seasonal vegetables!”

The so-called anti-seasonal vegetables were actually the spring and summer vegetables grown in the autumn and winter seasons. To put it simply, it was to create a climate similar to spring and summer during autumn and winter seasons, so that vegetables originally grown in spring and summer could grow in autumn and winter when the temperature was very low.

Qin Mian didn't know much about the anti-seasonal vegetables, but he knew something about it. Currently, he and Lei Tie had a stable economic power to afford a trial. If they were successful, it could bring them another great fortune.

He asked Uncle Fu to call all the off-duty servants. He told them in detail the basic principles, conditions, and requirements of planting anti-seasonal vegetables. He also told them some examples that he had seen before. Lastly, he gave them a sum of money and let them go to work. If anyone made an important contribution in this aspect, he and Lei Tie would give him a sum of money as a reward.

This greatly stimulated the enthusiasm of the servants and kept them busy.

Qin Mian didn't completely cast this matter aside. From time to time, Qin Mian went to see their progress. He suggested that they prepare nutrient soil with warm attributes. Chicken manure was warm manure and cow manure was mucus and permeable manure. After the two were decomposed and mixed with fine soil according to the ratio of 2:2:4, the nutrient soil could have good heat absorption and heat generation attributes, which made the plants more resistant to cold and sturdy. Besides that, the anti-seasonal vegetable planting site required a convenient water source and wind barrier around to avoid direct cold wind.

After the servants got the knack of doing it, Qin Mian truly left the matter alone and did other things.

By the end of the ninth month, Qin Mian's abnormal constitution gradually disappeared. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were both relieved. At this time, it was time for dredging the river. However, it was the river in the village that needed to be dredged up this time. The river was the main source of irrigation for the villagers. Li Zheng asked each family to send a volunteer to clear the silt. Dredging up the river was for their own sake, so no one was dissatisfied. The villagers were very proactive. If anyone dared to be lazy, he would surely receive censure and criticism from other villagers.

Although Qin Mian's family had servants, it was unconventional to send a servant for such collective action. Therefore, Lei Tie personally went to

represent Qin Mian's family. Qin Mian wanted to take turns with him, but Lei Tie disagreed.

It rained a lot in the tenth month. If the water level of the river rose, it would be bad. Consequently, dredging up the river was a race against time. Li Zheng asked the villagers to dig from sunrise until sunset. They were not allowed to go home for lunch but had their families deliver the meal to them.

Qin Mian expressed his heartache for Lei Tie in his meals. Every meal contained two meat dishes. He also delivered a bowl of hot soup to the man an hour later. The villagers were envious and jealous before they were used to it.

The village's married women were stimulated. Not to be outdone, they also cooked a bowl of soup at home to send to their men. Even if it was just a vegetable soup, the men happily drank it. When the men came home at night, they were more considerate to their wives. During the day, they worked and chatted, becoming more energetic.

This morning, the river was lively; more than ten big fish were caught.

An older married woman ran this way in a mad rush, out of breath. "Brother Xiangyi... quick, quickly go back and see... your... your wife... is... is pregnant..."



Chapter 119: College Examination Has Arrived

119 – College Examination Has Arrived

The villagers stood in the river digging silts, the river water was turbid and muddy. Lei Xiangyi was so surprised that threw away the shovel in his hand and ran to the riverbank, but his foot stepped on empty and he fell on the mud pile. His eyes were red as he muttered to himself, “My wife is pregnant again, my wife is pregnant again...”

He forgot to notify Li Zheng as he got up and rushed home, leaving a streak of wet muddy footprints on the ground.

The villagers looked at his back with a sigh. They knew more or less about Lei Daqiang’s family. It was because Lei Xiangyi and his wife did not have a son that he practically had no position in the family. This dredging event had been going on for three days, but it was only Lei Xiangyi or Lei Xiangli that came. Lei Xiangren had never appeared. Lei Xiangyi must be looking forward to having a son this time.

After sunset, the temperature of the water lowered. Standing barefoot in the muddy water that submerged the calves, the bone-chilling air which invaded the body from the soles and the calves caused people to shiver uncontrollably.

Li Zheng raised his voice as he announced, “Alright, that’s all for today.”

As if given amnesty, the villagers rushed to the riverbank with their shovels and silt baskets or wooden buckets. They hurried to their homes as they urgently needed a basin of hot water to soak their cold feet.

When Lei Tie was on the ground, Uncle Fu and Lei-Qin Le immediately took away his shovel and bucket.

Back at Leisurely Farmhouse, Lei Tie simply washed his muddy legs by the pond before going to the house.

Qin Mian was reading at the door of the main room. Seeing the man's figure, he put down the book and went to the kitchen to carry the hot water into the bathroom and then poured it into the bathtub.

Lei Tie heard the movement in the bathroom. He stood at the door and watched Qin Mian bend over to test the temperature of the water, and went to embrace him from behind.

“Wife.”

Qin Mian didn't look back but the corners of his lips were tilted up. He took some spiritual spring water from the space and poured it into the bathtub, “Take a bath first. I'll get your clothes.”

Lei Tie wanted to hold him for a while more. But when he looked down and saw the smudge on his body, he let the person go.

Qin Mian closed the bathroom door, went to the bedroom on the second floor, opened the wardrobe, and took out Lei Tie's inner clothes, middle clothes, a silver-black long robe, a vest, and a pair of thick socks. The shoe rack was by the stairs; he grabbed a pair of clean cotton shoes.

Back on the first floor, he knocked on the bathroom door before pushing it open. He put the clothes, shoes, and socks on the chair and looked at the man in the bathtub. “You've been standing in the cold water for too long. Soak for a while.”

Lei Tie nodded. Only his head, neck, and wet hair could be seen, which weakened his oppressive and cold aura, and unexpectedly looked a little cute.

Somehow, Qin Mian to make fun of him, so he stepped over and leaned on the edge of the tub with his arms crossed. He teased, “I want to watch a beautiful man take a bath.”

The muscles on Lei Tie’s face twitched for a moment. He was very serious as he said, “Mandarin duck bath¹ is better.”

Mandarin... Mandarin duck bath! Qin Mian’s face was hot at once. He fled and closed the bathroom door with a bang.

He ran too fast and missed the slight but charming smile on his man’s lips.

By the time Lei Tie came out dressed neatly, Qin Mian was putting the dishes and tableware on the table. He went into the kitchen and picked up the steaming hot corn and spareribs soup. “Wife, Li Zheng said that it can be finished by tomorrow afternoon.”

“It’s should be. You’ve been soaking in the cold river for four days.” Each of Qin Mian’s hands carried a dish as he went out of the kitchen, “This year is the first time, not good to make an exception. In the future, let the servants go.”

“Don’t worry,” Lei Tie bowed and kissed him, “I have the vital spirit in my body, so I’m not afraid of cold. There’s another thing.”

“What’s it?” Qin Mian asked while he ladled up food.

“Qian Shi is pregnant.”

“Really? That’s a good thing.” Qin Mian was a little pleased, “If only she could have a son this time. Thinking of the way Lei Xiangren and his wife always acted smug because they have two sons, make me unhappy. In a while, we’ll go over and give them some good things.”

Lei Tie nodded without a shadow of a doubt.

After dinner, they went to the old house together. Qin Mian carried a wind-proof lantern, while Lei Tie carried an old hen in his left hand and a basket

of pomegranates, pears, and two packages of pastry in his right hand.

The people of the old house had eaten dinner. They sat in the courtyard.

Wei Shi was now seven months pregnant. With a big belly, she looked a bit out of shape. Her face was a bit chubby, but it was not ugly. On the contrary, it added a bit of beauty. Lei Daqiang sat with her and looked at her stomach with a smile. Many old people said the baby might be a son. In three months, he would have another white and fat son.

The maidservant stood obediently behind Wei Shi, waiting for orders.

Du Shi sat opposite Wei Shi and Lei Daqiang, fixedly staring at Wei Shi's stomach with a gloomy face.

Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi sat on the other side. Zhao Shi was peeling melon seeds for Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao. Lei Xiangren had a handful of melon seeds in his hand; the sound of him eating the melon seed was like that of a mouse.

Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao sat together. They were talking in low voices.

Lei Xiangyi was holding Lei Xinxin and sat next to Qian Shi, looking at Qian Shi with a silly smile. Qian Shi's right hand covered her stomach with her head slightly bowed with coy.

"It's like no one's ever been pregnant," Zhao Shi murmured, her right hand unconsciously touched her abdomen. Since Erbao's birth, she never got pregnant again. It would be great if she could have a son again.

"Eldest and Eldest Daughter-in-law are here." Wei Shi was the first to discover Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian politely said, "How are you, Little Mother?"

Wei Shi stroked her bulging abdomen, and her face was full of maternal brilliance. She said in a soft voice, "Thank you for your concern. I'm fine. My baby is very well-behaved."

When Qin Mian and Lei Tie entered the gate, Lei Daqiang's expression sunk and he turned a blind eye to them.

As soon as Lei Dabao and Lei ErBao saw the basket in Lei Tie's hand, their eyes turned bright. They only took a timid look at the basket and did not dare to get close to it.

Lei Tie went to Lei Xiangyi and handed him the items in his hands.

Qin Mian nodded to Lei Xiangyi with a smile, "Congratulations to Third Brother and Third Brother's wife. These things are for Third Brother's wife to supplement the body."

Lei Xiangyi said with a happy smile, "Thank you, Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law."

"Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law are considerate." Qian Shi stood up and was courteous to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Her bright eyes were quite elated. Even though it was unknown whether the baby was male or female, she was pregnant before Zhao Shi after all.

Du Shi's hands reached out to Lei Xiangyi as she said, "Old Three, give it to me. I'll kill the chicken tomorrow and cook soup for your wife."

Lei Xiangyi didn't move, "Mother, I'll take it first. I'll stew it for my wife tomorrow."

"Third Brother, what can a man like you cook? Better leave it to Mother," Zhao Shi chipped in.

"I can learn. Mother and Second Sister-in-law don't need to worry." Although Lei Xiangyi spoke with a smile, there was a little coldness in his eyes.

Qin Mian turned a blind eye to the undercurrent between them, "You talk, we're going back."

Not long after Qin Mian and Lei Tie left, Lei Xiangyi stood up and said to Qian Shi, "Wife, I remember that Eldest Brother asked me to send some

vegetables to Double Xiang House a few days ago. I'm going to ask him when it's appropriate to deliver it."

Qian Shi gently smiled, "Husband, you go."

Lei Xiangyi went out of the courtyard and quickly caught up with Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

"Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law." Lei Xiangyi said it directly, "Fifth Brother said that he would help me and Fourth Brother to separate from the family after he finished the college examination. I want to ask you about something."

Lei Tie nodded slightly and motioned him to say it.

"By that time, my wife and I want to move out. But..." Lei Xiangyi's face was a little red, "we don't have much money in hand, so I want to ask you to lend me some. At that time, we'll build a mud-brick house to live in. I can pay back after selling coal."

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian; Lei Xiangyi also looked at Qin Mian, with a teasing meaning.

Qin Mian angrily glared at Lei Tie. What did this mean? Did he not allow Lei Tie to even make decisions for such a small matter?

Lei Tie gently stroked his wife's head and asked Lei Xiangyi, "How much?"

Lei Xiangyi said, "5 taels are enough."

Qin Mian frankly said, "Third Brother, you can have the money tomorrow. We'll lend you 10 taels. If there is money to spare, use it to supplement your wife's body. You don't need to pay it back in a hurry. Just pay whenever you have more money."

Lei Xiangyi thought that soon, he could finally dispel the clouds and see the sun. The rims of his eyes were slightly red as he said gratefully, "Thank you, Eldest Sister-in-law and Eldest Brother."

Since they were Lei Tie's younger brothers, it was not good for Qin Mian to favor one over the other, so he added, "You can secretly mention this to Fourth Brother. If he wants to move out after the separation, we can also lend him some money."

Lei Xiangyi sighed with emotion, "Fourth Brother and I have trouble Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law a lot."

"It's fine, go back." Qin Mian waved his hand, not to mind.

The sky was getting dark. Lei Tie took out the fire holder from his bosom, lit the lantern, took it from Qin Mian's hand, and held his hand with the other hand.

In the dusky night sky, a dot of flame flickered, quiet and leisurely.

"Is this alright, in the open?" Qin Mian shook the hands they held together.

Lei Tie said, "The ground has pits."

Qin Mian raised his eyebrow. He had walked this road multiple times, how could he not know if there was a pit? But the man's big palm was very warm, he was reluctant to let go.

"Fifth Brother's college examination is in a few days, should we do something?"

Lei Tie thought for a moment, "Give money?"

Qin Mian glanced at him with amusement. "Typical. But I can't think of what to give him. Might as well give him a set of writing brush, ink, paper, and inkstone."

In the mid of the tenth month, the day of the college examination arrived. The college examination was held in Qingyun Academy and presided over by the academic administration sent from prefecture town. There were two tests, one test per day.

Lei Daqiang took Du Shi and Lei Xiangli to stay in Zhaoyang County one day in advance. They would accompany him outside the academy during the college examination.

Qin Mian's family was busy fishing in the pond, so they didn't go together. To not let people in the old house feel that they were uncaring toward Fifth Brother, Qin Mian gave Lei Xiangzhi 5 taels and offered to pay for the accommodation of Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Lei Xiangli in the county town – they gave 5 taels to Lei Daqiang.

Thank you, Elaine!

Note:

Footnotes

1. taking a bath together as a couple, a form of *ehem* 😊 foreplay.

Chapter 120: Passed the County Level Examination and Become a Xiucai

120 – Passed the County Level Examination and Become a Xiucai

The smallest fish caught in the pond was over a jin and the largest was about 3 to 4 jin. Some were sent to Double Xiang House and Double Xiang House immediately launched a whole fish feast; it also attracted countless diners.

Many villagers thought that the fish of Qin Mian's family was good and wanted to buy some to make into salted fish for the New Year. Qin Mian decided to sell 200 fish to the villagers. The rest was not only for his family to eat, but also to supply Double Xiang House.

To the surprise of Qin Mian and Lei Tie, almost every household in the village came to their house to buy fish; most of them bought one and a few others bought more. From Uncle Fu's mouth, they heard that many villagers believed one could get sprinkled with their family's fortune if one bought something from their family. Qin Mian was very amused.

His family's fish was so fleshy that Qin Mian certainly wouldn't treat himself badly. He cooked the carp, crucian carp, and grass carp in various ways; steamed, braised, sweet and sour, boiled... He and Lei Tie ate fish for several days.

Every day, Leisurely Farmhouse exuded an attractive aroma. Zhou Erhao and his wife, who were only separated from them by a wall, drooled three times a day, but they could only continue to be jealous.

This morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie checked the growth of the vegetables in the greenhouse. With Qin Mian's suggestions, Uncle Fu and Uncle Quan led others to ponder for several days and eventually made the greenhouse. The greenhouse was made of straw mats, reed mats, and waterproof cloths to prevent freezing. Occasionally, firewood was burnt to warm it up. Today, some of the vegetable seeds sown had sprouted.

At this time, outside the village came the sound of festive gongs and drums, getting closer and closer.

"A-Tie, listen to the sound. Can it be that Fifth Brother has passed the exam and become a Xiucai?" Qin Mian guessed.

Lei Tie pulled out the weeds in the seedling plot, appearing very calm, "Will know it in a moment."

A moment later, Lei-Qin Le rushed in with a happy expression.

"Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. Fifth-gongzi has passed the examination and become a Xiucai! Second place in the first class!"

Qin Mian pulled Lei Tie to go out, "Let's go to join the joyous scene, too."

Once a Xiucai, one was considered to have an official rank and entered the officialdom hierarchy, which had the privilege of exempting from compulsory services, such as didn't have to kneel in front of the county magistrate and couldn't be punished casually. Lei Xiangzhi was second in the first class. He belonged to the "Granary Student" in the Xiucai's class; he could receive government-issued rations. At the gate of the old house, many villagers came to see the excitement after hearing the news. There had been no scholar in Green Mountain Village for nearly ten years. It was not only a happy event for Lei Daqiang's family but also a happy event for the whole village. Children were also affected by this kind of joyous event; they playfully drilled around among the adults.

Qin Mian walked to the gate of the courtyard. He couldn't squeeze in for a moment. He only heard the loud voice of Du Shi and Lei Daqiang in the courtyard, and the laughter of Li Zheng.

Almost everyone was bursting with happiness and speaking joyous words. Consequently, a sarcastic voice was particularly prominent.

“What if Lei Daqiang’s family has a Xiucai? The officials from the county came all the way to give them the good news but they couldn’t even give some tips¹.”

As soon as this was said, someone immediately agreed, “That’s right. This is a great event, but Lei Daqiang and Du Shi made the messengers left with gloomy faces. Isn’t it a disappointment?”

A witty young man followed to heckle, “Yeah. I ran ahead of the messengers, and not even a cup of water was served to me.”

The corner of Qin Mian’s lips twitched. As expected, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang were truly outrageous that no explanation was needed.

Lei Xiangzhi hurried out of the courtyard with a smile on his face and bowed to the crowd. He said politely, “Thank you for everyone’s concern. Xiangzhi is very grateful. There are many visitors today that my parents couldn’t care for everyone. Xiangzhi apologizes on their behalf, please forgive them. In three days, my father will host a banquet at home. Hope everyone does me the honor!”

The few sentences were both intimate and polite. The dissatisfied villagers were appeased and happily exchanged amenities with him.

After a good while, the villagers gradually dispersed.

Lei Xiangzhi quickly invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie into the house. “Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law saw an embarrassing sight. Please come inside.”

“Don’t worry about it. Congratulations to Fifth Brother for becoming a Xiucai.” Qin Mian smiled and cupped his hands in obeisance toward Lei Xiangzhi.

Lei Xiangzhi bowed with hands folded and said, “Without the support of Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, I wouldn’t have this achievement.”

As they spoke, they entered the central room.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi sat at the seat of honor. Lei Daqiang grinned from ear to ear, and lightly swept his eyes over Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Du Shi held her head high and chin up, a little higher than before.

Qin Mian had a faint smile on his face. After Wei Shi married in, he came to the old house several times, but this was the first time that Du Shi sat alone with Lei Daqiang.

Wei Shi sat on a soft chair at the side. No dissatisfaction whatsoever could be detected on her face. She had a smile in her eyes as if she was happy from the bottom of her heart for Lei Xiangzhi’s success.

Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi, Lei Xiangyi, Qian Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao all sat on the bench with happy expressions.

On the dining table in the middle of the room were several plates of food; a plate of melon seeds, a plate of fried peanuts, a plate of osmanthus cake, and a plate of dried fruits, all of which should have been served to entertain Li Zheng and the messengers. It was very rare that Du Shi didn’t immediately put these away after Li Zheng took his leave.

Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi, and Lei Dabao were eating the melon seeds like it was a competition.

“You’re just in time.” Lei Daqiang’s finger pointed to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, “Eldest, it’s a great event that brings glory to our ancestors for your fifth brother to be a Xiucai. I have discussed it with your mother and decided to hold a banquet in three days.”

Du Shi said, “At that time, we have to invite Old Five’s dean and teachers, and our relatives. As for those short-sighted villagers...”

Qin Mian smiled. Du Shi saw it and frowned with an unhappy face, “Eldest daughter-in-law, why are you smiling?”

Qin Mian’s expression was innocent and sincere. “I’m happy for Fifth Brother!”

Du Shi didn’t believe him, but she couldn’t do anything about it. She continued, “Those short-sighted people will certainly bring their whole family to come. This number adds up to a lot. There should be about two upper-class tables, four medium-class tables, and ten ordinary-class tables. It must cost a lot. We have roughly calculated that it will cost about 7 to 8 silver taels.”

Lei Xiangzhi frowned, “Father and Mother, isn’t that too much? Everyone knows our family’s condition. There’s no need to put on a facade.”

It was appropriate for Lei Xiangzhi to say these. If it came from Lei Tie, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang would surely think that they didn’t care for their youngest brother’s great event. As for Lei Chuntao, it was even more impossible for her to say anything – a girl who had yet married was not qualified to participate in family events.

“Old Five,” Lei Daqiang looked at Lei Xiangzhi angrily, “you’re the only Xiucan in the five generations of our Lei family, so we should do it grandly! Eldest, you’re the eldest in the family, what do you think? The guests we have to invite this time are not only our relatives and villagers but also your fifth brother’s dean and teachers. You can’t let your fifth brother lose face!”

Lei Xiangren chipped in, “Father and Mother, simply host the banquet in Double Xiang House!”

Zhao Shi’s eyes brightened. She quickly agreed, “That’s right, hosting the banquet in Double Xiang House give more face! Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law are our family members, and they can afford it. Isn’t it, Father and Mother?”

Qin Mian looked cold as he re-evaluated whether he was too kind to Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi.

Lei Tie looked at Du Shi and Lei Daqiang indifferently, waiting for their statement.

Lei Daqiang also felt that Lei Xiangren's idea was good. He was about to nod his head when his eyes met Lei Tie's cold and merciless eyes. He quivered and glared at Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi as he angrily rebuked, "No one treats you as mute if you don't speak!"

Lei Xiangzhi sighed.

Lei Tie said, "My wife and I will give 5 silver taels, 20 jars of good wine, and also cover two upper-class tables."

Lei Daqiang nodded slightly, "You can still keep your fifth brother in mind, very good. Also, send over a chef from Double Xiang House."

"Father, this is inappropriate," Lei Xiangzhi immediately objected. When he met with Lei Daqiang's angry eyes, he patiently explained, "None of the customers in Double Xiang House can be offended. If Double Xiang House misses a customer due to lack of a chef, it will be a big deal far from good. The upper-class tables mentioned by Eldest Brother must also come from Double Xiang House. This has already given enough face."

Lei Daqiang thought so, too. Later, Old Five still had to take part in the provincial examination. He should not get into a deadlock with the eldest son now, so he nodded, "Father listens to you."

Du Shi added, "Eldest should also send over your family's fruit and fish."

Lei Tie ignored her.

Lei Xiangzhi stood up and said, "Mother, you should discuss the banquet with Father first. I'll talk to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law."

Nowadays, whenever Du Shi saw her fifth son, she had a soft spot for him. She repeatedly nodded, "Fine, go."

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Lei Xiangzhi left the courtyard together.

Lei Xiangzhi let out a long sigh, "I can take a breath at last."

Qin Mian understood the meaning of his words. It was hard to say anything.

The three walked slowly to the back of the village.

"Fifth Brother, there is still the provincial examination in the ninth month next year, don't slack off," Qin Mian joked.

Lei Xiangzhi smiled, "Eldest Sister-in-law can rest assured. It's nothing more than being a Xiucan, so I didn't intend to host a banquet at first. But the messengers weren't handled properly, and some people were offended. I might as well take this opportunity to relieve their dissatisfactions."

Qin Mian nodded to himself. Lei Xiangzhi appeared to have a bit of a scholar's idiocy, but he was a wise person. He observed many meddlesome things and was able to make the correct analysis and find appropriate solutions. Such a person was very suitable for officialdom. Perhaps in the future, Lei Xiangzhi could walk on a glorious path. As long as his heart did not change, it was worth to keep a relationship with him.

"You can come back with us to get the money now and bring back some fruits by the way," Qin Mian said.

Lei Xiangzhi deeply respected his eldest sister-in-law and even admired him from the bottom of his heart. He replied with a smile, "En. Thank you, Eldest Sister-in-law."

After entering Leisurely Farmhouse, Lei Xiangzhi said, "Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, this time, I can stay at home for ten days before returning to the academy. I'm going to suggest family separation to Father and Mother after dinner."

"How do you plan to separate?" Qin Mian asked.

Lei Xiangzhi said, "Since we have to separate, Second Brother, Third Brother, Fourth Brother, and I are going to separate. Father, Mother, and Little Mother will follow whoever they want."

“Will your second brother like it?” Qin Mian didn’t think so.

Lei Xiangzhi said, “I might as well speak honestly to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law. I want to be an official. Only by being an official can I have the opportunity to realize my dream. I’m not afraid to have the family follows me, but I’m afraid that some people will drag me down. If Second Brother and Second Sister-in-law are always like that, they will only bring trouble if they continue to follow me. The least is causing trouble; the worst is getting some lawsuit. It’s going to be hard to separate from them by then. So, I’m going to take this opportunity to separate from Second Brother. After the separation, they won’t be able to depend on others and can only rely on themselves. For them, this is not a good thing.”

Qin Mian looked at him with admiration. “It’s good that you can understand this. Only, it’s hard to separate Second Brother from you.”

This was the truth. Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi usually boasted in front of the villagers how amazing the fifth brother was. When the fifth brother became a high-ranking official in the future, they would follow him. They were all family members, so it was normal for them to benefit from another. However, they might not only take the benefit but also cause trouble.

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, “Right. Therefore, I need you to help me.”

“What can we do for you?” Qin Mian did not understand. He and Lei Tie had separated from the old house; they had no position to interfere in the old house’s affairs.

The people in Leisurely Farmhouse were all Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s people, so Lei Xiangzhi was not afraid that his words would be spread out. At this moment, he said frankly, “I want to borrow 100 taels. At that time, I’ll give Second Brother two options: live with me and have no money or live by himself and have 100 taels.”

Qin Mian laughed. It was truly a good idea. 100 taels was not a small sum. Take the old house for an example; if they spent a lifetime digging food in the ground, they couldn’t even earn 100 taels in two lifetimes. Moreover, Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi were both short-sighted people. They might not

be able to withstand the temptation of 100 taels since they were not well fed and dressed at home.

So frustrated! (ノ 益 益) ノ 彡 一 一

Note:

Footnotes

1. It's normal to tip the messenger who brings good news with money

Chapter 121: Different Species, How to Love Each Other

121 – Different Species, How to Love Each Other

“Sure.” Qin Mian agreed, “A-Tie, go get the money.”

Lei Tie looked at him blankly, “Wife, aren’t you in charge of our family’s money?”

Lei Xiangzhi laughed despite himself.

Qin Mian slapped Lei Tie on his thigh and got up to get the money.

Lei Tie followed in.

A moment later, they came out.

Qin Mian handed Lei Xiangzhi a banknote of 100 taels, a silver ingot of 50 taels, and a silver ingot of 10 taels.

“Your eldest brother said that you will have to socialize with other Xiucai students later, which will cost you a lot. You keep the 10 taels.”

Lei Xiangzhi took a look at Lei Tie and felt a slight sting around the rims of his eyes. “En... I also want to borrow your writing materials to write down the acknowledgment of the debt.”

Writing down the acknowledgment of the debt could make both sides feel at ease and be more comfortable to associate in the future. Qin Mian didn’t say anything like ‘I believe you, there’s no need to write an acknowledgment of a debt’ but told Lei Tie to get the writing materials.

Lei Xiangzhi wrote down on the paper that he borrowed 100 silver taels from his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law and should pay it back within five years at the latest. Lastly, he pressed his thumbprint.

Before Lei Xiangzhi left, Qin Mian asked Lei-Qin Le to pick a basket of pears for him.

Lei Tie took out his bow set and carried a basket on his back. “Wife, I’m going to the mountain.”

“Alright, don’t return too late.” Qin Mian knew that the man wanted to go hunting again. Recently, his taste became strange and changeable. He always wanted to eat something so abruptly. Once, he suddenly wanted to eat sour jujube cake, and Lei Tie went to the town on horseback to buy it without saying a word. Consequently, Lei Tie had developed a habit. When there was nothing to do at home, he took his bow set to hunt and conveniently picked some fresh wild vegetables and fruits in the mountains.

“Got it.”

Lei Tie was tall and strong, dressed in a maroon duanda and grey trousers with mid-high leather boots. His simple and fit dressing made his figure even slender. Such a back figure walked neither too slow nor too fast in the village was an unusual sight.

His oppressive and indifferent vibes made the villagers dared not approach him easily, but it did not stop them from paying close attention to him.

Sister Zhang teased Aunt Xiulan, who was nearly 50 years old, with a smile on her face as she scrubbed the dirt on her son’s clothes, “Auntie, stunned?”

“You woman!” Aunt Xiulan splashed water on her body, not in a good mood. She was entranced just now but felt a great pity. Lei Tie and his wife Qin Mian were both capable people. Why did they marry each other? Otherwise, anyone of them was suitable for her second daughter. But of course, she was just thinking to herself and would not truly pursue it.

There were only Aunt Xiulan and Sister Zhang by the river. Aunt Xiulan knew Sister Zhang was not a gossip person, so she was at ease to speak out her mind, "Sigh, I'm worried about my second daughter."

"Your second daughter? Ah, Xiaoyu." The image of a young girl appeared in Sister Zhang's mind. "Xiaoyu is beautiful, dexterous, and filial to you. She's a rare young girl. There will be a lot of people coming to your house to ask for her hand. What do you have to worry about?"

"I'm not bragging as the mother but that girl is truly excellent." Referring to her second daughter, Aunt Xiulan appeared proud. "Since her eldest sister has gotten married, she has been in charge of our family and manages the family in an orderly way. It's just... Sigh, that girl's character is really..." Aunt Xiulan shook her head dejectedly.

Sister Zhang nodded in agreement. If one must say that there was something wrong with Xiaoyu, it was that she was too shy. When others talked to her, she only called out to people most of the time and then smiled shyly with nothing else to say. Such a girl looked somewhat "soft".

"She's almost seventeen. She'll be an old girl if I let her be. I'm not at ease to marry her off in another village, and there is no suitable man to marry her in this village. Worrisome ah."

Sister Zhang hesitated for a moment. "Actually, the Lei family's Old Four is not bad ah."

Aunt Xiulan frowned. Thinking that the other party had no bad intention, she suppressed her displeasure and said, "Du Shi and Wei Shi are not qualified to be my Xiaoyu's mothers-in-law! I only want to find a man from a simple family for Xiaoyu."

Sister Zhang was an open-minded person. Seeing that Aunt Xiulan was a little angry, she said with a smile, "My bad. Auntie, don't take offense ah." Her family was close to Qin Mian's family, so she knew more than other villagers. Qin Mian and Lei Tie not only took care of her family but also Wu Di's family and Li Zheng's family. A few days ago, the Lei family's brothers, including the laziest Lei Xiangren, often went to the mountain to

chop firewood. It was obvious that they had something big to do. She surmised that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had given them a money-making idea. If Xiaoyu married Lei Xiangli, she would surely live comfortably with Lei Xiangli. However, between Aunt Xiulan and Qin Mian's family, she was certainly closer to Qin Mian's family. Therefore, she would not say these words to Aunt Xiulan. It was already her limit to imply such a sentence.

"How could I?" Aunt Xiulan hurriedly said, "You're right, the Lei family's Old Four is not bad. By the way, I heard that your Dashuan is working in the vermicelli workshop and even works as a foreman?"

"En, Brother Qin and Brother Lei Tie have a good opinion of my Dashuan." Sister Zhang smiled. Zhang Dashuan used to drive a carriage between Zhaoyang County and Running Water Town to pick up and drop off customers eating in Double Xiang House. However, since a transport line started operating in the town, he lost customers and was not able to drive anymore. When Qin Mian and Lei Tie learned of this, they asked Zhang Dashuan to work in the vermicelli workshop and made him a foreman. Sister Zhang and Zhang Dashuan were grateful to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Therefore, Zhang Dashuan was very dedicated to the work. It was thanked Qin Mian and Lei Tie that their family now could afford the few children to study.

Aunt Xiulan was very envious. Zhang Dashuan only helped Lei Tie and Qin Mian when they separated from the family, but Qin Mian and Lei Tie had taken care of his family until now. It was clear that good deeds paid off well.

On Lei Tie's side, when he got to the mountain, he searched around for fresh wild vegetables and fruits with sharp eyes. Occasionally, he saw a few mushrooms. He carefully dug them up and put them into the basket.

In less than an hour, his basket was almost full, which was mostly filled with green wild vegetables. His wife said that this kind of wild vegetables was very delicious for dumpling stuffing. Besides that, there were also a lot of chestnuts. He remembered that his wife loved chicken stewed with chestnuts and sugar-fried chestnuts.

“Awoo!”

A wolf howl came from behind. Lei Tie turned around with vigilance.

White Spot jumped out from a bush and rubbed against his legs, appearing a little anxious, “Awoowoo.”

Lei Tie was puzzled.

“Awoo awoo!”

Lei Tie frowned and looked in the direction it turned its head to.

White Spot bit his trouser leg and pulled him forward. Lei Tie patted it on the head and quickened his pace. Feeling the master’s comfort, White Spot’s agitation retreated a bit.

The man and the wolf soon came to a big tree. As soon as Lei Tie saw what the giant lying on the ground was, his pupils shrank.

The animal on the ground was covered in golden fur and had a strong muscly body; it was estimated to be about 400 kg. On its huge head was a pair of ears which appeared slightly small, and its opened mouth showed two rows of sharp teeth. Due to the bloody hole in the abdomen, its four strong feet were motionless but its grey eyes stared at Lei Tie, full of ferocity and vigilance.

It was a golden furred brown bear.

“Awoo!” White Spot pulled Lei Tie to the side of the bear.

Lei Tie stepped forward. The brown bear raised its eyes on guard and wanted to attack with its two forepaws, “Grr...” Lei Tie’s body suddenly emitted a kind of compelling force. The strong pressure shocked the brown bear. Although it still stared at Lei Tie in alert, it didn’t dare to move.

White Spot scornfully glanced at the brown bear as it slowly walked on the brown bear’s body. Strangely, the brown bear indulged in it as if it didn’t feel the weight on its body.

Lei Tie took some spiritual spring water from the space and smeared it on the brown bear's wound. After a moment of pause, he slowly closed the wound with his vital spirit.

The blood stopped a while later. When the brown bear was relieved from pain, its alertness dissipated. It lay the ground and lightly called out to Lei Tie, perhaps to thank him.

Lei Tie hesitated for a moment before he put the brown bear into the magic space.

White Spot ran in front of him and rubbed against his legs. Lei Tie also put it into the magic space and continued to hunt.

The sun gradually set to the west. Lei Tie hurriedly climbed down the mountain and returned with a full load.

Qin Mian leaned on the railing on the second floor and raised his hand to the man, "Just got back? The rice is ready, just waiting for your gains. What did you get?"

Lei Tie opened the basket for him to see.

Qin Mian saw that there were a lot of wild vegetables inside, and smilingly said, "I'm coming down now."

Lei Tie put the basket at the door, went into the house, bolted the door, and brought Qin Mian into the magic space.

"Wife, look."

Qin Mian looked at the huge thing lying on the ground in surprise, "A golden furred brown bear? Good, it looks so impressive!"

Lei Tie nodded to himself. He knew his wife would like it.

White Spot happily ran to rub against Qin Mian and ran back again, trampled all over the brown bear's back. Then, it lay down in front of the brown bear and rubbed its snout with the brown bear's snout.

Qin Mian was struck dumb with astonishment. After a good while, he reprimanded it with heartache and a headache, “White Spot, don’t be confused. Different species, how to love each other?”

A solid smile surged in Lei Tie’s eyes for a jiffy. He touched his wife’s head, bowed his head, and pecked at his lips, “Must be accidental.”

White Spot probably understood Qin Mian’s words. It lifted its eyelids and looked speechless.

Qin Mian looked at the brown bear’s velvet golden fur, his fingers felt a bit itchy, “A-Tie, it looks very soft.”

Lei Tie pulled him to the brown bear and deliberately stood on his right side, skillfully blocked the brown bear’s head.

Unexpectedly, the brown bear was completely indifferent to Qin Mian and even lukewarmly looked at him. Perhaps, it sensed that his aura was similar to that of the space.

Qin Mian squatted in front of the brown bear. Avoiding its wound, he happily rubbed its back. The brown bear’s fur was at least two inches long and felt soft.

“A-Tie, will it be willing to let our family raise it?” Qin Mian expectantly looked at Lei Tie. *Raising a bear at home sounds very domineering!*

Chapter 122: Lei Xiangzhi's Opinion about Family Separation

122 – Lei Xiangzhi's Opinion about Family Separation

“Certainly willing.” Lei Tie nodded and looked at the brown bear while thinking: even if it doesn't want to, make it willing.

The brown bear's back felt chill.

White Spot nodded its head approvingly.

Lei Tie watched Qin Mian play with it for a while and thought that it would be better if his wife's hands were touching him.

“Wife, I'm hungry.”

Qin Mian stood up and gave Lei Tie a hard kiss on his lips. Then, he looked at Lei Tie with a profound meaning, “How about that?”

Lei Tie was puzzled.

“As the saying goes, ‘when you're in love, drinking water can make you full’. Are you full?” Qin Mian embraced the man's shoulders and looked at him with a grin.

Lei Tie nodded and kissed him back. This time, the kiss was a little longer.

Qin Mian felt pleasingly sweet in his heart. He hugged the man's waist.

Although Lei Tie used the spiritual spring water and his vital spirit to help the brown bear deal with the wound, because the brown bear was severely

injured and lost too much blood, it would take a few days to recover.

Qin Mian grabbed a few chickens in the space to make rations for the brown bear and temporarily left it in the space with White Spot.

Out of the space, Lei Tie asked Qin Mian, “Wife, what to cook tonight?”

“Want to eat spicy diced chicken.” Qin Mian turned over the things in the basket, “You first clean up the pheasant, scrape the meat off the bone, and dice the meat. Then, trim the groundweed cleanly to eat with dumplings tomorrow.”

“Alright.” Lei Tie brought a small bench to kill the pheasant by the well.

Qin Mian went to the kitchen to soak the peanuts first.

.....

Two days later, the old house hosted a banquet.

The old house was built with several rooms in the courtyard. The central room and patio could not accommodate a large number of people. Due to a large number of guests, more than one chef was hired, and one stove in the old house was not enough, so they had to build another stove. The grain-sunning ground was spacious enough that Lei Daqiang arranged the place for the banquet there.

The sun didn’t show up, and the sky was overcast. Fortunately, there was no sign of rain.

After breakfast, the villagers – who agreed to come and help – moved firewood, bricks, food ingredients, tables, chairs, benches, pots, and woks to the grain-sunning ground. One trip after another, the grain-sunning ground soon became lively. Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli built a simple kitchen stove with logs and bricks.

At dragon hour (07:00), the chefs, who were specially hired from the neighboring village to cook for the banquet, arrived with helpers to deal with the ingredients. After a while, the smell of stewed bones, fried

dumplings, roasted meat, and other ingredients wafted from the grain-sunning ground, which made the children whirled around outside the kitchen and didn't want to leave. A few daring ones rushed in to steal a few dumpling balls but were caught by Zhao Shi, who then cursed and drove them away. As soon as she turned around, she reached out to steal the fried dumpling ball from the bucket.

Several chefs: Shameless.

Qin Mian sent Aunt Fu and Aunt Quan to help and hinted that they could find an excuse to leave if any of the people in the old house showed any excessive behavior.

At this time, three carriages came from outside the village and stopped at the gate of the old house. Lei Xiangzhi got off the carriage with Dean Huo, Teacher Gong, and Teacher Liu, as well as several schoolmates who had a good relationship with him. Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi welcomed the guests into the house politely and warmly. After a while, Lei Xiangli appeared with Li Zheng and also entered the house. With such a few respected figures inside, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi did not make any disgraceful acts at all.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were still at home.

Qin Mian was busy cultivating feelings with the brown bear. He carried water and fed it, working hard to keep it, while Lei Tie watched his wife and the brown bear cultivate feelings.

Near noon, when the banquet was about to begin, the two men went to the grain-sunning ground together.

There were more than ten tables on the grain-sunning ground; it looked quite spectacular. All the relatives came, from the oldest to the youngest, and none of them was absent. On one hand, they came to eat at the banquet. On the other hand, they took the opportunity to worm their ways into being friends with the Xiucais and teachers. The villagers came a little late. None of them was empty-handed. Some were carrying a handful of vegetables, while others were carrying a few eggs... Everyone dug the ground for

food¹, not some rich people. This was how they pooled resources together to return the treatment.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie hadn't sat for a while when the carriage sent by Double Xiang House arrived on time. One after another, the staff took out several multi-layered food boxes from the carriage and put the steaming dishes on the two upper-class tables. At the same time, Qin Mian's servants appeared with twenty wine jars.

One look at the "Glimmer of Paradise" on the wine jar, everyone understood that this was the "expression" of Lei Xiangzhi's eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law. While envying Lei Xiangzhi, they were also a little excited – who didn't know that the Glimmer of Paradise's wine was good and expensive. Today was a rare opportunity.

After putting down the things, the staff of Double Xiang House and the servants went to Qin Mian and Lei Tie and saluted them in unison before leaving.

After a short while, Lei Daqiang led Dean Huo, Li Zheng, and the others over to the grain-sunning ground. With a smiling expression, the slick and smooth master of ceremonies went to arrange everyone to their seats.

With one look, Dean Huo and the others knew that the dishes on the upper-class table were from Double Xiang House. The dishes on this table included four cold dishes [hors d'oeuvre], four desserts, and eight hot dishes [main course]; a total of sixteen dishes. In Double Xiang House, it cost at least 15 silver taels.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had several associations with Dean Huo, Teacher Liu, and Teacher Gong, so the two went over to greet them.

Dean Huo had a very deep impression of them, and cheerfully said, "Don't be too polite."

Lei Daqiang looked around, quite angry. He specially sent a letter to the Deng family, and yet none of them came. He didn't mind when Deng Shi's relatives didn't come in the past, but now his son had become a Xiucai, and

they still wouldn't come. It was clear that they didn't attach importance to him.²

Thinking such, he couldn't help but glare at Lei Tie secretly; he was not happy with this son.³

What kind of person was Lei Tie? He immediately noticed the old man's glare and met it with indifference and calmness.

Panic, Lei Daqiang withdrew his line of sight.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were seated on the medium-class table. At the same table were Lei Dagang and his son, as well as Lei Xiaoyun's husband and son. Lei Xiaoyun's husband and son were waiting for Lei Xiangzhi wholeheartedly and gave the cold shoulder to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Qin Mian and Lei Tie also didn't go to court a rebuff. After they toasted a cup of wine as a gesture of goodwill, they ate in silence.

The culinary skills of the few chefs were not bad; the dishes had distinctive flavors. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very relieved to eat. When they were full, they walked home. In the evening, they came over again for dinner.

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Chapter 123: The Separation of the Old House

123 – The Separation of The Old House

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Lei Xiangzhi didn't seem to notice their uneasiness. "So then, our family now has 15 *mu* of paddy field and 10 *mu* of farmland. Father, Second Brother, Third Brother, Fourth Brother, and I can each be allocated 3 *mu* of paddy field and 2 *mu* of farmland. How to divide the rest is up to father."

Lei Daqiang pondered for a moment and said, "As for the house, at present, everyone still lives in their rooms. The vegetable garden and the kitchen can be shared. The money at home... won't be divided for the time being. Your fourth brother's marriage must be settled this year. It will cost a lot of money to get married in spring at the latest. Only after your fourth brother gets married, can the money be divided. Old Five, what do you think?"

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, "It's reasonable. Fourth Brother is not anymore younger, it's time to get married."

"En." Lei Daqiang was very satisfied with his son's filial obedience. He said with a smile, "As for other small things, it's easy. Farm tools, tableware, and whatnot can be divided according to the headcount."

"Good, I'll go and invite Li Zheng now," said Lei Xiangzhi.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were standing at the gate of the yard. They could guess what Lei Xiangzhi, Lei Daqiang, and Du Shi were discussing.

As soon as Lei Xiangzhi came out, they both looked at him nervously for fear of hearing the answer they didn't want to hear.

Lei Xiangzhi smiled and nodded at them.

Lei Xiangyi breathed a sigh of relief, "Fifth Brother, you stay at home. I'll go to invite Li Zheng."

"I'll go and ask Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law to come over," said Lei Xiangli.

"Alright. Thank you, Third Brother and Fourth Brother," said Lei Xiangzhi with a smile.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli quickly left.

"Hey? Where are you two going?" Lei Xiangren came out of the central room, just in time to see Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli happily leave, and quickly called out.

However, no one paid attention to him.

"Fifth Brother, what's going on?" Lei Xiangren hastily asked Lei Xiangzhi.

Lei Xiangzhi answered, "It's a good thing, Second Brother. Do you want to go and find Second Sister-in-law to return home?"

"Oh, I'll go now." Lei Xiangren ran away and went to find Zhao Shi, who was chatting in another person's house.

"Fifth Brother." Lei Chuntao came out of her room and looked at Lei Xiangzhi with some worry.

Lei Xiangzhi loved his twin sister very much. He rubbed her head and said with a gentle smile, "Don't worry, Fifth Brother will handle it well."

When Lei Xiangli arrived at Leisurely Farmhouse, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were making dumplings at home. Lei Tie made the dumpling wrappers, and Qin Mian wrapped the dumplings; the two cooperated very well.

Seeing Lei Xiangli with a smile on his face, Qin Mian teased, “Fourth Brother, did you pick up money?”

“Made Eldest Sister-in-law laugh at me.” Lei Xiangli rubbed his head with embarrassment, “Fifth Brother has already convinced Father and Mother to separate. I came to ask Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law to be the witnesses.”

“Sure.” Qin Mian patted off the flour on his hands and stood up, “Fifth Brother is straightforward as expected. Do you know how it’s going to be?”

Lei Xiangli shook his head. “I didn’t have time to ask, but I believe Fifth Brother will handle it well.”

Lei Tie poured out the hot water in the kettle for hand washing. Qin Mian’s hands would be cold in autumn and winter, and since then, he never let Qin Mian touch cold water.

After washing their hands, they went to the old house together.

On the other end, Lei Xiangyi also led Li Zheng to the old house.

Seeing this movement, the villagers had some guesses. A few married women went to Lei Daqiang’s neighbor’s house to get the first-hand information in time.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Li Zheng, Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, Wei Shi, Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi, Lei Xiangyi, Qian Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi sat in the central room. Lei Chuntao and the maid Xiaoxi were watching over the three children – Lei Dabao, Lei Erbao, and Lei Xinxin.

Lei Xiangren was certainly not an idiot. As soon as he saw them and even Li Zheng was called over, coupled with the happy expressions of Lei Xiangyi, Qian Shi, and Lei Xiangli, he immediately guessed that this was a family separation! His face abruptly changed color. With a gloomy face, he planned to listen first.

Zhao Shi and he were worthy of being husband and wife. She also saw the clue and looked at him nervously, “Husband...”

Lei Xiangren patted her hand, motioning her to stay calm. His eyes twinkled as he surveyed all of their faces on alert. If separated, so be it. However, he would not leave it at that if something was not to his satisfaction.

Lei Daqiang first saluted Li Zheng. “Trouble Li Zheng yet again.”

Li Zheng waved his hand as he said, “Haha, it’s a small matter, not worth mentioning.”

Lei Daqiang raised his voice, “Now that everyone is here, listen to me. As you can see, there are only a few rooms in our house. Now, both Wei Shi and Qian Shi are pregnant, and soon there’ll be two more people in the family. When Old Four is married, the house will be more crowded. Like the so-called ‘the tree has branches’, today, I’ve decided to separate the family. Li Zheng is here as a witness and writes down the separation document.”

Since they hadn’t talked about the key points yet, no one intervened.

Lei Daqiang continued, “Since we’re on it, then separate all at once. Old Two, Old Three, Old Four, and Old Five are all separated. I, Du Shi, Wei Shi, and Chuntao will stay with Old Five.”

Lei Xiangren immediately jumped out, “Father! What do you mean? We brothers have done so much to support Fifth Brother to become a Xiucai. How can we separate when we haven’t benefited even a little? Isn’t it inappropriate?”

“That’s right!” Zhao Shi curled her lips, her stern eyes cast sidelong glances at Lei Xiangzhi. “Fifth Brother. You, Father, and Mother have been whispering in the room for a long time – the matter of separation shouldn’t be your...” In the end, she still remembered that Lei Xiangzhi’s identity was different now, and so she didn’t dare to offend him too bluntly.

Li Zheng kept his head lowered without interrupting.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked straight ahead, seemingly absent-minded.

“Fifth Brother, it’s actually you?” Lei Xiangren looked hurt as he stared at Lei Xiangzhi in disbelief.

Lei Xiangzhi kept a straight face. “Second Brother, can you listen to me first?”

With a woody face, Lei Xiangren waved his hand, “You talk!”

“I did bring up the separation to Father and Mother.” Lei Xiangzhi said, “Besides the reasons that Father had just said, there is another important reason. With so many people living together, there’ll always be a blunder. On the contrary, once separated, we’ll be closer. Naturally, I remember that I could go to school without any worries because of everyone’s support. Without you all, there won’t be me, the Lei Xiangzhi of today.”

Lei Xiangren’s face looked slightly cordial, “As long as you understand that.”

“I knew Fifth Brother isn’t an ungrateful person.” Zhao Shi seemed very satisfied with Lei Xiangzhi.

Qin Mian disdainfully swept a glance at Lei Xiangren and his wife. Who wouldn’t understand [from those words] that the gratitude meant for Lei Xiangzhi to take along Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi?

“I’d asked Third Brother and Fourth Brother’s opinion. Both are willing to separate.” Lei Xiangzhi said leisurely, “If Second Brother agrees to separate, I’m willing to give Second Brother 100 silver taels to support Dabao and Erbao’s study; if Second Brother wants to take care of our parents with me, I’m very happy too. This way, I can use the 100 silver taels for study without worry.”

Except for Qin Mian and Lei Tie, everyone was shocked.

100 silver taels!

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi's first reaction was regret, they shouldn't have agreed to separate. However, after thinking that their youngest son would have more money as an official in the future, their anger sunk.

Wei Shi looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with a profound meaning before quickly withdrew her eyes. She didn't intend to get involved in the separation. Regardless, she followed Lei Daqiang; Lei Daqiang would never be separated from Lei Xiangzhi. She wouldn't suffer a great loss. At present, the most important thing for her was to give birth safely.

Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi shivered with joy, their hearts pounding.

Qian Shi's heart also skipped a beat, and she was restless with anxiety. In her opinion, the fifth brother was too partial. Since he offered Lei Xiangren 100 silver taels, he should also offer her husband 100 silver taels.

Lei Xiangyi pressed her hand and gave her a warning look.

Lei Xiangli was as calm as Lei Xiangyi. Both brothers saw through it. Lei Xiangzhi offered Lei Xiangren 100 silver taels not because he was more intimate with Lei Xiangren, but for the opposite reason.

As for where the 100 silver taels came from, no one actually wanted to ask.

"Second Brother, what do you think?" Lei Xiangzhi sipped a cup of tea and asked with a grin.

Lei Xiangren hesitated. 100 silver taels were quite a lot, but after Lei Xiangzhi became an official, he could get more.

Zhao Shi was flustered, afraid that he would refuse. She tugged his sleeve, lowered her voice, and said eagerly, "Husband, what are you still hesitating about? Agree! We can't earn 100 silver taels in our two lives! With these 100 silver taels, we can build a big house and send Dabao and Erbao to school. As long as we groom them well, they can become officials in the future!"

The last sentence moved Lei Xiangren and made him see another brighter and broader road in front of him. That's right, why would he fixate on Fifth Brother? After all, the relationship with a younger brother was not deeper than with the sons. It was better to rely on the sons than the younger brother!

Qin Mian pretended to drink tea – there was a smile on his lips. He silently praised Zhao Shi and lit a candle for Lei Xiangren.¹

Zhao Shi kept urging on that Lei Xiangren didn't have time to think carefully. He sighed in pretense and nodded in mourning, "Dabao will be late for education, so I truly need this money – fine, I agree. It's just that, if separated, we can't be filial to our parents anymore..."

"That's right, Father and Mother." Looking at Lei Daqiang and Du Shi with a reluctant expression, Qian Shi wiped the corner of her eyes as tears rolled down her cheek.

Qin Mian had seen her secretly pinching her thigh hard. He suppressed his laugh, so much so that his body was shaking.

Lei Tie supported his back in silence.

Lei Daqiang continued to preside over the family separation. "Old Five bought a few *mu* of farmland for our family. Now our family has 15 *mu* of paddy field and 10 *mu* of farmland. Old Two, Old Three, Old Four, Old Five, and I each get 3 *mu* of paddy field and 2 *mu* of farmland... house... (blabla)... chickens, ducks, and pigs are divided this way...(blabla)... farm tools...(blabla)... Lastly, since Old Four, Old Five, and Chuntao have yet married, the family's money is not divided for the time being. Only after Old Four is married will it be divided."

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli had no objection. As for Lei Xiangren, since he could get 100 silver taels immediately, he didn't care so much about this 'small money', and therefore, he nodded in a frank and straightforward manner, whilst unable to cease the smile on his face.

Thank you, SadieWoods! 😊😊😊

Note:

Footnotes

1. Candles are lit for **prayer intentions**. To “light a candle for someone” indicates one’s intention to say a prayer for another person, and the candle symbolizes that prayer. In this case, QM showed sympathy to LXR for having such a pit-wife. 🙏

Chapter 124: Making Money in Winter

124 – Making Money in Winter

Brought to you by SadieWoods 🤪🤪🤪

When Lei Daqiang finished, Li Zheng wrote down what he said on the document and read it again. No one objected. Li Zheng, Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi all pressed their thumbprints, and each kept a copy.

Lei Xiangzhi did what he said; he gave a 100-tael banknote to Lei Xiangren.

Both Lei Daqiang and Du Shi cast covetous eyes at the banknote.

Lei Xiangren could read a few big [Chinese] characters, but he still gave it to Li Zheng for confirmation before he was relieved and put it into his clothes. He and Zhao Shi looked at each other with a grin and held their heads high while looking at people with their noses turned skyward, showing a totally changed attitude.

When Li Zheng got up to leave, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took the opportunity to leave with Li Zheng.

Lei Xiangren spoke without delay, “Father, Mother. Little Mother will give birth in a few months and Third Brother’s wife is also pregnant; it’s too crowded to live together. I’m going to buy a homesite right now. I’ll strive to complete the house before the New Year and move out.”

Lei Daqiang looked at him for a long time before he nodded.

Lei Xiangyi said in a low voice, “Father, Mother. I’ll also move out as soon as possible.”

Lei Daqiang frowned, “Moving out to where?”

Lei Xiangyi smiled, “Many thanks for Father’s concern. I’m going to build two mud-brick rooms first, and the rest will have to wait until I save more money.”

All in all, Lei Xiangyi was his son, so Lei Daqiang still had some concerns. “How can two rooms be enough? Well then, Old Two, lend some money to your third brother so he can build two more rooms.”

“Father, don’t think that 100 silver taels are a lot. I want to build a house, buy furniture, and send Dabao and Erbao to study. Which one doesn’t cost money?” Lei Xiangren gave Lei Xiangyi an idea, “Third Brother, you’d better go to Eldest Brother’s house to borrow money. Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law don’t lack money.”

“Yeah,” Zhao Shi chimed in.

Lei Xiangyi shook his head and said, “No need. I’ve decided to build two mud-brick rooms first.”

Qian Shi didn’t interrupt. Qin Mian and Lei Tie had lent 10 silver taels to them, and she would not disclose it.

After Qin Mian and Lei Tie went home, they continued to make dumplings. The dumpling filling was made of groundweed, lean meat, and deep-fried dough sticks – flavorful and delicious. After eating, they came into the space.

The brown bear was still recuperating in the space. Its injury was almost good. It had fun playing with White Spot in the space.

Lei Tie thought that Qin Mian wanted to go and see the brown bear first, but contrarily, he went straight to the flower bed and reached out his hands to gently stroke the balls.

The two pink balls had completely split and looked plump and lovely. When Qin Mian and Lei Tie touched them, their colors immediately became vivid – very fascinating.

Qin Mian couldn't tell what he felt now. The two pink balls seemed to be connected with his heart. Even outside the space, he could also feel their "emotions".

Lei Tie scooped a ladle of spiritual spring water and handed it to Qin Mian. He stared thoughtfully at the two pink balls for a moment and turned his head to look at Qin Mian.

The man's stare gave Qin Mian the creeps, "What are you looking at?"

"You."

Qin Mian said calmly, "Go ahead. Now that the brown bear's wound is healed, we'll send it back to the mountain." It was just a joke when he said he wanted to keep the brown bear.

They went out to the back of the mountain. Since the brown bear was saved, it was impossible to kill it anymore. To prevent it from going down the mountain and hurt people, they went all the way to the deep mountain before bringing out the brown bear and White Spot.

As soon as White Spot found that the surrounding scene had changed, it knew it was out of the space and understood that the masters were going to release the brown bear. It howled a few times at the brown bear and then left with Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

The brown bear stood still for a moment, turned, and walked away. Its huge body disappeared into the dense forest.

The next morning, Qin Mian was awakened by Lei-Qin Le's scream. After asking about it, it turned out that at dawn, the brown bear lay quietly at the gate with a 40 to 50 jin wild –broken neck– goat on its back. Lei-Qin Le had gotten up early. When he opened the gate to clean up the fallen leaves, he got a big fright.

Since then, the brown bear had become “domesticated” like White Spot. Every time the villagers mentioned Leisurely Farmhouse, they had strange expressions. In the past, they would gather together to chat under the big trees near the gate of Leisurely Farmhouse. However, ever since the brown bear settled in Qin Mian’s house, they wouldn’t want to come even if they were beaten to death.

At first, the people in Leisurely Farmhouse were also frightened. Later, they found that as long as they didn’t provoke the brown bear, the brown bear ignored them. Only then they were relieved.

And White Spot got a companion – they were often not at home.

At the end of the tenth month, the sweet oranges in the orchard began to ripen. The fruiting period of sweet orange was from the tenth month to the twelfth month, and the late-ripening varieties could last from the second month to the fourth month of the next year. Leisurely Farmhouse had entered another busy season.

Qin Mian hired people to make 5000 canned sweet oranges, 5 large jars of sweet orange sauce, and 20 large vats of orange juice to sell in spring and summer. At the same time, Double Xiang House launched orange cake, orange soup, and orange rice wine juice.

The eleventh month was the harvest season of the lotus root. For several months, Lei-Qin Zhong and his group had trained not only in self-defense skills but also archery, horsemanship, and swimming. The work of digging lotus roots was handed over to them.

There were a few more dishes on Double Xiang House’s menu and Qin Mian’s table such as lotus root and spare ribs soup, deep-fried lotus root, osmanthus glutinous rice filled in lotus roots, sweet and sour lotus root, diced assorted lotus root with chili, lotus root balls, and so on – all of which caused people to have a deep attachment.

Due to many works at home, Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not go to help Lei Xiangren and Lei Xiangyi building their new houses. It was not until Lei

Xiangyi invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie to his housewarming banquet did Qin Mian vaguely recalled that the separation of the old house had been settled.

The homesite that Lei Xiangyi bought was in the south of the village. On the three-room homesite, two mud-brick rooms had been built. In one room, half part was a kitchen and the other half was a side room of Lei Xiangyi and Qian Shi. The other room was the central room. There was a heap of firewood outside the house.

When the housewarming banquet ended, Lei Xiangyi sent off the guests and asked Qin Mian and Lei Tie to stay for a while.

Qian Shi served tea to Qin Mian and Lei Tie and then sat quietly aside to sew an article of small clothing.

Qin Mian asked about the charcoal's business¹, "I heard that you have already started charcoal burning. Have some been sold?"

Lei Xiangyi looked very relaxed, "Started it a month ago, and the first batch of charcoal was about 3200 jin. Because it's good smokeless charcoal, it sold at a high price of 8 Wen per jin. The first batch of charcoal sold for 25 silver taels. Second Brother cut less firewood, so he was given 5 silver taels, while Fourth Brother and I got 10 silver taels each. It's all thanks to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law. I can't even begin to say how grateful I am. Afterward, if you two need me, just say it! By the way, I have discussed with Fourth Brother that when the second batch of charcoal comes out, we will send 500 Jin to you."

Qin Mian nodded, "Since Third Brother and Fourth Brother have this intention, I will accept it. However, the recipe is given to you all, so it is yours. It has nothing to do with us. The matter of the recipe is over and done with."

Lei Xiangren's homesite was bought in the east of the village, which was the first house in the village and separated by four houses from the old house. The area of the homesite was not small. Qin Mian estimated that the homesite alone cost at least 15 silver taels. Lei Xiangren's house construction started almost at the same time as Lei Xiangyi's, but his house

was bigger, more complex in structure, and slower in progress – it still needed four to five days to finish. However, the layout could be seen. There was not only a front yard but also a backyard. The gate of the front yard was very imposing – very similar to that of the rich families in the town. Both sides of the gate had a room opposite the main house. In the middle of the main house was the central room. On the left side of the central room was a kitchen and a side room, and on the right side of the central room were two side rooms. A small door in the central room led to the backyard. The chicken house, pig house, latrine, and vegetable garden were all in the backyard. Zhao Shi had already told the villagers that she wanted to make a small flower garden in the front yard, and invited everyone to be her guests when it was done.

After the house was built, it looked quite imposing and considered to be unique in the village. As expected, Zhao Shi made a flower garden in the front yard and even ran to Leisurely Farmhouse to ask for flowers. Qin Mian was too lazy to deal with her and directly let White Spot and the brown bear guard at the gate. Zhao Shi left with resentment. She spent money to buy some flowers in the town and asked Lei Xiangren to dig some in the mountain.

Lei Xiangren gladly and diligently dug flowers at the foot of the mountain. However, he mistook a snake for a stick and was bitten. Fortunately, the snake was not poisonous, but Lei Xiangren's leg was swollen. He lay in bed for several days. This incident became a laughing stock that circulated in Green Mountain Village for several days.

The new house had been drying for less than half a month when Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi couldn't wait and moved in.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie once passed by and looked at the house from outside. They concluded that Lei Xiangren had already spent at least 40 silver taels out of the 100 silver taels. Alas, it had nothing to do with them.

Two days later, Lei Xiangzhi was on school break. Lei Xiangren set the day of his housewarming on this day.

The reason why Qin Mian and Lei Tie kept in touch with the old house before was only for the sake of Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao. Now that Lei Xiangren was separated and moved out, his relationship with Lei Tie became further away. Qin Mian and Lei Tie had no intention of making a deep friendship with Lei Xiangren. They went to the town on the pretext that they had something to do and didn't attend the housewarming banquet, but only had Lei-Qin Le send over a basket of sweet oranges.

After returning from the town, Qin Mian listened to Lei-Qin Le saying that Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi had said some sarcastic words after receiving the congratulatory gift. The gist of it was that they thought the gift was too poor coming from Qin Mian and Lei Tie who were rich.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't care. Qin Mian felt that talking with Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi was a waste of saliva. He dared to bet, with Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi's temperament, sooner or later they would cause big trouble. He had already thought to gradually weaken the relationship between their family and Lei Xiangren. Afterward, as long as there was an opportunity, they would completely cut off the relationship, so as not to be implicated later.

Lei-Qin Le also mentioned another thing: Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli had broken up on their joint efforts in the charcoal business, mainly because Lei Xiangren was always lazy and cut less firewood, and he often didn't help during charcoal burning. Lei Xiangzhi suggested that they sell the charcoal burning recipe and divide the money directly. The quality of the charcoal made with this recipe was very good. Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli didn't want to sell the recipe. Later, they were convinced by Lei Xiangzhi and planned to make another batch of charcoal before selling the recipe.

Qin Mian did not ask much about this matter.

Fast forward to the twelfth month, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli sent 500 jin of charcoal to Leisurely Farmhouse.

They took the initiative to mention about selling the charcoal recipe to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. It was sold for a total of 200 silver taels. Lei Daqiang and Du Shi believed that the recipe was given by Qin Mian and Lei Tie before the family separation, so it should be counted as collective finance. The 200 silver taels were divided into five parts: Lei Daqiang, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi each got 40 silver taels. Lei Xiangzhi did not at all want this money but insisted to divide it among Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao. Lei Chuntao got 10 silver taels saving for her dowry, and Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli each got 15 silver taels. Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli had no choice but to accept them. However, they both inwardly decided to give the money to Lei Xiangzhi when he took part in the triennial provincial examination.

In the twelfth lunar month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie transported canned yellow peaches and canned honey peaches made in summer to Double Xiang House. One jar was priced at 1 silver tael and sold for a limited amount every day. Those who wanted to buy it would have to hassle with others.

The vegetable in Leisurely Farmhouse's greenhouse also began to mature – red tomatoes, green chives, three-colored amaranths, green peppers, bitter gourds, fresh cucumbers, plump eggplants, and huge white gourds thrived. There were only a few kinds of vegetables in winter. Everyone couldn't stand eating those kinds of vegetables every day. When these summer vegetables appeared on Double Xiang House's menu, the whole of Zhaoyang County was sensational. Even if a plate of fried amaranth was sold at a high price of 100 Wen, Double Xiang House was still a full house every day. Even the rich and noble families in the neighboring counties often came to Double Xiang House to eat.

On this day, Manager Sun was off work. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were going to the town to stand in for him. In passing, they would send over a hamper of tomatoes, a hamper of cucumbers, and a hamper of eggplants.

Lei Chuntao came in a hurry, with a happy face. "Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. Fourth Brother is going to be engaged."

Note:

Footnotes

1. In case you don't know, the modern version of charcoal burning is the pyrolysis process

Chapter 125: The End of the Year Approaches

125 – The End of the Year Approaches

Brought to you by Elaine & SadieWoods 🧡🧡🧡

Several servants in grey cotton-padded jackets and grey winter hats efficiently carried hampers of vegetables onto the carriage.

White Spot lay on the side of the carriage, two paws playing with a tomato like a ball.

“Which family’s girl?” Qin Mian took a big and red tomato from the hamper and handed it to Lei Chuntao.

“Thank you.” Lei Chuntao’s face was red due to the cold as she took the tomato, but because it was too cold, she took out a handkerchief to wrap it. “It’s the second daughter of Aunt Xiulan, called Xiaoyu.”

“Fellow villager? That’s good.” Qin Mian was surprised. Very few people in Green Mountain Village were willing to find a daughter-in-law or son-in-law in the same village, mainly considering that living in the same village would make it more awkward in case of conflicts between the husband and wife.

It was getting colder and colder, so much so that the white air puffed out when one spoke almost formed icicles. As they chatted, Lei Tie put a hat, a scarf, and gloves on Qin Mian’s body, one by one.

Seeing this, Lei Chuntao was envious and couldn’t help imagining whether her future husband would treat her as well as her eldest brother treat her

eldest sister-in-law.

“Xiaoyu is a good-natured girl. She is good to be my fourth sister-in-law.” Lei Chuntao’s eyes had a touch of playfulness, “Mother had mentioned a few girls to Fourth Brother, but he wasn’t interested. Today, as soon as the matchmaker introduced, Fourth Brother agreed!”

Ever since Lei Xiangzhi became a Xiucai, Du Shi was even more supercilious. Qin Mian remembered that Aunt Xiulan’s family was only average, would Du Shi agree?

“Has the date of the marriage been fixed?” asked Qin Mian.

Lei Chuntao said, “Not yet, only passed the first of the six etiquettes¹. I was so happy that I couldn’t help running here to tell Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law first.”

Qin Mian was just about to tease her if she was anxious to get married because she was so concerned about Lei Xiangli’s marriage, but then he remembered that this was a conservative era. He only smiled and left it at that.

“Are you two going out? I won’t delay you anymore. I’m leaving.” Lei Chuntao waved her hand and quickly ran away.

Lei-Qin Shun then came forward, “Eldest Young Master, Little Young Master. The vegetables and fruits for transport have all been loaded.”

“Set out,” Lei Tie concisely ordered and boarded the exclusive carriage with Qin Mian. White Spot jumped up and looked out from the back window.

The carriage in winter was quite different from that in summer. Thin blankets were hung on all sides of the carriage wall to wholly block the wind. Only one part was reserved at the window to receive the ray of light.

Even so, there was still darkness in the carriage. To remedy it, one could only hang a wind-proof lantern. Qin Mian had an impulse to invent glass.

The transparency of glass was good but the manufacturing cost was too high after all.

Lei Tie closed the door and sat down beside Qin Mian.

Lei-Qin Le drove the exclusive carriage at the front, and Lei-Qin Shun drove the carriage with vegetables at the rear. The two carriages drove smoothly out of the village.

On a winter morning, the sun was somber; between the sky and the ground, there seemed to be a layer of gauze, with mist and drizzle. When the biting cold wind blew in fits and starts, the bare branches incessantly shook, bleak and lonesome. The villagers who used to be chatty no longer hung around outside; they closed the doors and windows and stayed at home. Even the chickens hid in the corner with their necks shrunk, and at the sound of the wheels, they jumped up in surprise, so much so that several pieces of chicken feathers fell away with the wind.

Qin Mian had yet perfected his cultivation, so he still felt cold even though he was wearing a woolen hat, scarf, and gloves. Lei Tie stretched out his long arms and embraced Qin Mian. Then, he took off his wife's gloves and pressed his (QM) hands under both of his overcoat's armpits.

Face to face, eyes to eyes, both men's breath entangled together. The atmosphere in the carriage suddenly became ambiguous. Qin Mian's breathing was a little hurried, but he was unwilling to pull his gaze out of the tenderness within Lei Tie's eyes.

Lei Tie lowered his head to approach. Soft and warm kisses gently fell on Qin Mian's forehead, nose, and finally lips, where it was gently licked, nipped, and sucked. Qin Mian also opened his mouth to lick the man's lips but was caught in a gap, and deep kissing ensued.

The enthusiasm of the two was finally cooled by the fact that they wore too much clothing.

"You're warm." Qin Mian leaned comfortably on Lei Tie's shoulder; his fingers deliberately scratched the man's armpits. After he acutely sensed

that Lei Tie's body shrinking away and the man then clamped his hands, he burst into a fit of laughter.

Lei Tie's lips lightly rubbed on his wife's face, "Eat something?"

Qin Mian shook his head, "No."

"Ate too little breakfast." From the space, Lei Tie took out a plate of lovely small steamed meat-filled dumplings, about a dozen, still piping hot.

Qin Mian lay on his stomach, motionless. He opened his mouth and looked at Lei Tie with the corner of his lips dyed in a light color of a smile, revealing his innermost joy and satisfaction.

Lei Tie wiped his hands with a handkerchief and picked up the small steamed meat-filled bun to feed his wife.

"You eat too."

Lei Tie ate one, and the rest was fed to Qin Mian. After that, he took out a bamboo tube from the space.

Qin Mian refused, "No, I don't want to grow into a fatty."

"Won't." Lei Tie unfastened the lid and sent the tube to his wife's lips.

He could only open his mouth and drank two mouthfuls before he shook his head, "No more."

Lei Tie didn't force him to drink the rest of the soup. He put away the tube and plate, and held his wife tightly again, not letting a little bit of wind drill in.

"A-Tie, it's now the twelfth month. When will our shops and workshops be on holiday?"

After Eating Savory Restaurant's one-year rent expired, Qin Mian decided to continue renting the shop, selling quick meals as before. Since the tenth

month, hot and spicy soup, barbecue, and hot pot were added back to the menu.

Lei Tie said, “Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant close on the 24th of the twelfth month and open on the 8th of the first month; the workshops close on the 24th of the twelfth month and open on 16th of the first month.”

Qin Mian had no objection. “When is the ‘Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh’?”

“Let Manager Sun send people to inform the Diamond Members and try to arrange it before the New Year.” Lei Tie had a plan in mind. It was very busy this winter, so much so that his wife seemed to be a little thinner. Dealing with the trivial matters earlier could let his wife have a good rest for a few days.

“Alright, I’ll come along with you too.”

“En.”

The two talked about this all the way, and time passed quickly.

The carriage stopped at the gate of Double Xiang House. When the staff saw the “Lei” and “Qin” on the carriage, he quickly came forward.

Qin Mian reluctantly took out his hands from Lei Tie’s armpits. Lei Tie then covered his hands with warm gloves.

Qin Mian asked the staff to take the vegetables to the kitchen. A few baskets of sweet oranges for the Diamond Members were also taken away.

“Wife, I’m going to make rounds.” After Lei Tie said it to Qin Mian, he went to Rugui Building first.

Qin Mian entered the lobby. Manager Sun was still busy behind the counter.

“Manager Sun, you are off work today. Go back earlier and have a rest.”

Manager Sun laughingly said, "Greetings, Little Young Master. Our shop is busy these days, so I won't be off work today."

Since he voluntarily offered, Qin Mian would not refuse, "Sure. Thank you for your hard work, Manager Sun. Next year, we will hire an assistant manager. By then, Manager Sun can be more relaxed."

As soon as Manager Sun heard "assistant manager", he understood that the two masters were still very appreciative of his ability. He felt grateful and decided to put more effort into work.

"Thank Little Young Master for your consideration."

Qin Mian asked, "Have some Diamond Members been here recently? If they don't come, let someone send them the fruits and ask them which day they have free time before the 24th of the twelfth month. It's almost the end of the year. Double Xiang House is about to launch the 'Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh'."

"Yes." Manager Sun said, "Nie-gongzi and Mu-gongzi are here today. I'll let them know in a little while. There is one more thing to report."

His expression was a little grim. Qin Mian motioned him to go to the lounge.

"Little Young Master, it's like this. We limit two jars of canned fruits for each person. But yesterday afternoon, I learned that the canned fruits we sold were actually bought by Nie-gongzi. As far as I know, he sold all that he bought to Qingtian Prefecture, with the price of 3 silver taels for each jar. Because he sent different people to buy it, we didn't notice at the beginning. Please forgive my mistake, Little Young Master."

Nie Heng was indeed a "profiteer". Qin Mian shook his head slightly, "So that's the case. No problem. We have our 'Glimmer of Paradise' brand on the jars. Even if he sells it to the capital of the country, he also helps us to promote. But... our main source of customers is around Zhaoyang County, so it's better to sell it to nearby customers. Even if Nie Heng went to the prefectural capital to give us publicity, people in the prefectural capital

might not want to go all the way to Double Xiang House to eat. Therefore, we should not let Nie Heng continue to take advantage.” Nie Heng’s advantages over him and Lei Tie laid in that he was more powerful in business and more flexible in cargo transportation. Qin Mian was very clear about these. The development of their business should be based on the principle of ‘safety’; a great many things should not be done in a hurry.

Manager Sun was worried, “Well then, what should we do now?”

Qin Mian thought for a moment. Then, with a sly smile on his face, he said, “From today on, people can only buy the canned fruits with membership cards. If Nie Heng can find the members who bought it and persuade them to resell it to him, then it is his capability.”

Manager Sun praised, “Little Young Master is brilliant.”

On the other end, Lei Tie just crossed the bridge when Nie Heng and Mu Chen came from the opposite side.

“Boss Lei.” Nie Heng cupped his hands and greeted, “Haven’t seen you for a long time.”

Lei Tie nodded, “Hope that you two are well.”

“Thanks to your lucky influence²,” said Nie Heng.

“Boss Lei and Boss Qin have always been inseparable.” Mu Chen came forward at this time and looked behind Lei Tie. “Since Boss Lei is here, Boss Qin must have come too. May I know where is he now? We want to talk with him about a business we have.”

Lei Tie looked at him, “Same as talking with me.”

Mu Chen was taken aback, not knowing how the man’s sudden precaution came about.

Nie Heng lightly coughed as he secretly patted Mu Chen’s back, and asked Lei Tie, “Do Boss Lei and Boss Qin have time to talk things out?”

Lei Tie leaned sideways, gestured a “please” sign, and turned back to go to the bridge.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen looked at each other and kept up. Mu Chen mouthed “too reticent” to Nie Heng.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 六礼 refers to the six steps of marriage negotiation until marriage completion – proposing, birthday matching, presenting betrothal gifts, presenting wedding gifts, selecting the marriage date, and wedding ceremony
2. 托福 is a polite reply to health inquiries. FYI, it also translated as TOEFL (Test of English as a Foreign Language) because of the sound “’tuo fu” 😊

Chapter 126: Selling Formula for Growing Anti-seasonal Vegetables

126 – Selling Formula for Growing Anti-seasonal Vegetables

Double Xiang House's lounge had always served as a meeting room. On the center of the table was a basket of sugar-fried chestnuts. Qin Mian sat at the table while peeling the chestnuts to eat. There were a charcoal brazier and a small stove beside him. A kettle of water was heating on the stove. White smoke constantly emitted from the spout of the kettle, floating upward.

White Spot lay on the settee with its head on Qin Mian's legs.

When Lei Tie opened the door and saw Qin Mian's appearance of eating chestnuts on his legs, his eyes turned warm, "Please come in."

However, he did not enter the door immediately. Only after Qin Mian had sat up properly did he walked into the room.

Qin Mian wiped his mouth clean and regained the elegant bearing of a gongzi. He gave Nie Heng and Mu Chen a wee smile and said as he cupped a fist, "So it's Nie-gongzi and Mu-gongzi. Please sit down."

"Sorry to bother." Nie Heng and Muchen sat down opposite Qin Mian.

Mu Chen attentively watched White Spot in amazement. He had heard that the two owners of Double Xiang House raised a wolf. It was the first time he saw it. This wolf had a strong and muscly body with an arrogant attitude; it was truly extraordinary.

White Spot jumped out of the settee and stretched out. It went to lean over the table and stared at the chestnuts on the table.

Qin Mian picked up the kettle and steeped two cups of tea.

Lei Tie pulled back White Spot's head and sat down beside Qin Mian. He moved the small basket of sugar-fried chestnuts to his front and peeled the chestnuts quietly. The shelled chestnuts were placed on the plate in front of Qin Mian.

After the exchange of greetings, Qin Mian asked, "What brings you two here?" Because he was no stranger to Nie Heng, his tone was more casual.

Nie Heng smilingly said, "We are sending you money."

"Oh?" Qin Mian was noncommittal. "That's good indeed. As long as Boss Nie doesn't want to make money from me, I'm relieved."

Nie Heng surmised that he knew about the canned fruits. He coughed dryly, "Boss Qin overstated. Qin Mian, knowing that you dislike beating around the bush, I'll tell you the truth. Mu Chen and I want to buy a lot of your summer vegetables. The price is negotiable." According to his estimation, Double Xiang House had made at least 5000 silver taels since it had these vegetables. How could he not be envious? Not only that, but Double Xiang House also took away many customers in Zhaoyang County with these vegetables, which had a significant impact on the business of Nie's wine house.

Qin Mian motioned to them to drink tea. "You ought to know that our vegetable production is not big, only enough to supply Double Xiang House."

"I do know that." Nie Heng reminded him, "However, you should also aware that no one has ever been able to grow summer vegetables in winter before. You can imagine how eye-catching your vegetables are. According to my intelligence, the news has reached the prefectural city. I believe it will not be long before people will come to inquire for information. If you cooperate with me and Mu Chen, it will not only bring you rich profits but also break down most of the pressure for you. What can you have against it?"

“Most of the pressure?” Qin Mian keenly grasped the keywords.

Qin Mian’s appearance of showing an interest made Nie Heng more confident in persuading him. He nodded his head and said, “Yes. My Nie Family’s root is actually in Qingtian Prefecture. We have engaged in business within five generations, our influence is deep-rooted. And Mu Chen’s family is even better. He’s not from Zhaoyang County but Capital City. I can’t tell you his identity for the time being, but I can say that if someone covets your formula for growing anti-seasonal vegetables, Mu Chen can stop it.”

Light flashed past in Lei Tie’s black eyes. This was why he was wary of Mu Chen. From the first time he saw Mu Chen, he vaguely felt that Mu Chen’s identity was not so simple. Mu Chen was born with a noble aura. No matter how he suppressed it, some still leaked out.

Qin Mian was silent. He had hesitated for a long time before growing the anti-seasonal vegetables. As Nie Heng said, the anti-seasonal vegetables were indeed eye-catching. Some shrewd people might think about whether summer fruits or grain crops could also be grown in winter through the same method. If someone thought he could grow grain crops in winter, it would be very troublesome. The reason why he made up his mind later was that he did not have much involvement in growing anti-seasonal vegetables. It could be said that Uncle Fu and the others figured out how the anti-seasonal vegetables could be grown successfully. Even if people were to investigate, they could not suspect him and Lei Tie.

Nie Heng’s words made Qin Mian suddenly think of another idea.

He looked at Lei Tie inquisitively.

Lei Tie tightly held his wife’s hand on the table, looked directly at Mu Chen, and said in a slow voice, “I have a good friend who is very familiar with Capital City, but I haven’t heard him mentioned a prominent family with the surname Mu in Capital City.” If Nie Heng’s words were true, “Mu Chen” was just a pseudonym. Still, this probing was necessary.

Mu Chen took out a token¹ from the inside of his clothes and showed only half of it to Lei Tie. Noticing a sharp glint passing through the man's eyes, he was surprised and bewildered. As if nothing had happened, he put away the token. "Boss Lei should believe it now?"

Qin Mian didn't see what it was; he looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie gripped his wife's hand and nodded slightly.

Qin Mian thought of the word "safety" that he had been following and smiled with relief. His line of sight went to Nie Heng and Mu Chen. "Since it is so, are you two interested in the formula for growing anti-seasonal vegetables?"

Nie Heng was so happy that he almost knocked over the teacup. He solemnly asked, "Qin Mian, are you serious?" He had thought about buying the formula directly but didn't mention it as he believed Qin Mian would not sell it. To his surprise, aimlessly planting willow became a shade.²

"The formula for anti-seasonal vegetables can turn into a hot potato; your decision is wise," said Mu Chen as he looked at Qin Mian directly. At this time, he had completely put aside the contempt for Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said everything that should be said clearly, "But there is one condition. After selling the formula to you, my family can continue to grow anti-seasonal vegetables."

Nie Heng picked up the teapot to replenish the tea for four people, "How many *mu*³ of vegetables does your family plan to grow?"

Qin Mian said, "No more than 10 *mu*."

Nie Heng and Mu Chen exchanged a look. "Sure. You have to make sure that you don't disclose the formula, or else you have to compensate us according to the number of leaks."

As spectators, neither Lei Tie nor Mu Chen allowed the other to take advantage of the negotiation.

“Of course.” Qin Mian asked, “Now, can you tell me what price are you willing to offer?”

Before Nie Heng was ready to open his mouth, Qin Mian raised his hand to stop him, “The formula may also be suitable for growing fruits, flowers, and even grain crops. So, Boss Nie, you should think clearly before you open your mouth.”

Nie Heng was rendered speechless and sighed in frustration. The profiteer would not leave him any chance to exploit the loophole.

“Qin Mian, you and I are somewhat considered friends.”

Qin Mian drank the tea calmly, “There are no fathers and sons on the battlefield, no brothers in the affair of love; how can there be friends in the business world?”

Mu Chen laughed as he applauded. “Good one, ‘no fathers and sons on the battlefield, no brothers in the affair of love, no friends in the business world’. Boss Qin is right.”

“Which side are you on?” Nie Heng speechlessly glared at him. Then, he pulled Mu Chen to the corner, discussed in low voices for a while, and came back.

“50,000 silver taels, how about that?” asked Nie Heng. A business was all about bargaining. He said 50,000 as a way of probing.

Qin Mian shook his head. “Our family has two aspects that are not as good as yours. One: we have not as many people as you. Two: our influence is not as big as you. Otherwise, we will keep the formula and try to grow flowers, fruits, and grain crops later. Just imagine, how much wealth will it bring? Boss Nie and Mu-gongzi, it seems that you two don’t have much sincerity.”

“You can make an offer,” said Nie Heng with a smile.

Qin Mian bluntly said, “Fixed price: 80,000 taels.”

“60,000.”

“80,000.”

“65,000 taels.”

“75,000 taels.”

“70,000.”

Qin Mian unhurriedly said, “80,000.”

Nie Heng helplessly shook his head, “Fine, 75,000 taels. But we don’t have so much money on us. We’ll come back tomorrow morning.”

There were writing materials on the side of the desk. Qin Mian fetched them. “Let’s draw up the document first. Tomorrow morning, I’ll send someone to pick you up from Double Xiang House to my house. After signing the document, I’ll let people show you around the greenhouse and tell you in detail how to grow anti-seasonal vegetables. If you don’t understand anything, you can ask on the spot.”

Nie Heng and Mu Chen both appreciate his magnanimity.

Nie Heng said, “You are very considerate. Then, it’s a deal.”

The two agreed on the terms and wrote them down one by one with careful consideration. After making sure that there were no loopholes, they made three copies.

When the business talk was over, Qin Mian mentioned the ‘Big Adventure of Sweeping Away the Old and Starting Afresh’ activity. “Both of you are Diamond Members. May I know when will you have leisure time?”

Only then Nie Heng recalled this matter, “Oh! After I get the formula, I have to find people to work on it. I’m afraid I have no leisure time.”

Mu Chen regrettably said, “In a few days, I’ll have to return to Capital City.”

Qin Mian inwardly said *we'll be more relaxed if you two don't go*. "That's regrettable."

Mu Chen bluntly put forward his opinion, "Boss Qin, I don't think it's appropriate for you to set the time for the 'great adventure' in winter. It's so cold in this season, I'm afraid few people are willing to go out."

Qin Mian wore an expression of humbly receiving advice, "Mu-gongzi's words are reasonable. We will consider Mu-gongzi's opinion and strive for improvement."

Nie Heng said, "Since neither of us has time to participate, can we get compensation from Double Xiang House as a Diamond Member?"

Qin Mian shook his head in disapproval, "That's not right. It's your reason that you can't take part in the great adventure, not our fault. Therefore, please forgive us for not being able to do anything about it."

Nie Heng and Mu Chen could do nothing about it. In any way, they couldn't take back 20,000 silver taels. Double Xiang House had said earlier that the deposit couldn't be withdrawn.

"Well then," Qin Mian thought for a moment and said, "you can pick some sweet oranges in the orchard tomorrow."

Nie Heng and Mu Chen looked at each other with a smile, "Sounds good to me. It's getting late; we'll go back to Zhaoyang County. See you tomorrow."

"Please."

Sat in the carriage leaving Double Xiang House, Mu Chen said to Nie Heng, "I'm afraid that Boss Lei is not just a farmer."

"Why do you say that?" asked Nie Heng.

Mu Chen said in a low voice, "First of all, it's because of his imposing manner. Besides, when I took out the token, I only showed him the decorative pattern on the lower part of the token. He seemed to recognize

what it was. One might well ask; how could a farmer have seen such a token?"

Nie Heng nodded, "You also know that I have always been cautious. Back then, when Eating Savory Restaurant suddenly rose, I sent someone to investigate Lei Tie. I only knew that he ran away from home at the age of 12 and came back less than two years ago. Almost nothing has been found about the ten years since he left. However, their Lei Family has been in Green Mountain Village for generations, so there is no need to worry too much about it."

"As long as you are well aware of it."

Since the autumn harvest, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had been busy at home. They seldom came to the town and thus accumulated a lot of account books. They had people send over the account books of both shops and checked the account books together. At noon, they had a hot pot in Double Xiang House. In the afternoon, the two continued to check the account books. When the sky darkened and the lanterns were lit, they finished the last account book.

The final total amount uplifted their mood. It was worth it to be busy for a year.

As soon as Qin Mian stretched out, Lei Tie's hands fell on his shoulders and gave him a massage.

"A-Tie, from the establishment of Double Xiang House to now, it made a total income of 13,000 taels, and Eating Savory Restaurant made 1,300 taels this year. We can be regarded as having a small asset, right?" Qin Mian's face lit up with happiness, and a row of neat white teeth was displayed.

"En." Lei Tie nodded. "Wife, I'll take you to the prefectural city on the Lantern Festival."

"Great!" Qin Mian's heart felt warm. *Is this a make-up honeymoon?* He rubbed his flushed face and looked at the sky. "It's getting late. Are we

going home this evening?”

“Go home.” Lei Tie’s fervent eyes stared fixedly at him, “The honored guest suite is not home no matter how good it is.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. (long name) wooden token of authority
2. The broad meaning is that success or failure often has nothing to do with deliberate planning.
3. (memory refresh) 畝 [mu] is a classifier for fields; a unit of area equal to 1/15 of a hectare = 670 sq.m

Chapter 127: Lei Xiangli's Betrothal

127 – Lei Xiangli's Betrothal

To have a warm home had been Lei Tie's desire for many years. Qin Mian understood his insistence on a home. He hugged the man firsthand and stuck his face onto the man's waist. "I also prefer to stay at home."

"Sit, I'll have people serve the food." Lei Tie rubbed Qin Mian's head, poked the fire in the charcoal brazier into ablaze, and opened the door to go out.

Dinner was still hot pot, but with a herbal hot pot soup base. The weather was too cold for fried dishes since they turned cold very quickly.

It was dark after they finished dinner. Lei-Qin Le lit two wind-proof lanterns hanging on the eaves and drove off. White Spot ran along the carriage, full of vitality.

Lei-Qin Shun had gone back earlier after transporting the vegetables. There was only Lei-Qin Le driving the carriage on the road. The wind-proof lanterns swayed along the carriage, which also swayed the lights, adding a little warmth in the night when the wind was howling. Lei-Qin Le tightened the winter hat on his head and hummed in a low voice.

Qin Mian was full and languidly shrank in Lei Tie's bosom. As a cultivator, he should not have been so afraid of the cold. However, his cultivation was still shallow, and he didn't know why only a small part of the spiritual Qi absorbed during the practice had refined into the vital spirit, and the rest was missing. For him, using vital spirit to maintain body temperature

consumed too much, so he simply used Lei Tie as a human heater, convenient and intimate.

With his eyes closed, his quiet appearance exuded another temptation.

Lei Tie's throat was tense. Only when he called out "wife" did he realize that his voice was burnt to hoarse by strong desire.

"What's it?" Qin Mian opened his eyes.

Lei Tie's hand masterfully drilled into Qin Mian's lapel.

Qin Mian put his arms around the man's neck, "En... Ah... A-Tie, slow down..."

The ambiguous sound was blown away by the cold wind. Lei-Qin Le was not at all aware; he raised the whip and drove the carriage fast and steadily. "Ding-ding-dong, ding-ding-dong..." The small bell on the carriage also sounded very lively.

When Qin Mian regained consciousness, he was already lying on the warm heatable brick bed. The light that came through the gap in the curtain was harsh to the eyes. He closed his eyes in discomfort and opened them again.
It is the next day?

A familiar noise sounded behind him before a big warm palm fell on his cheek and caressed it. He turned around, Lei Tie's strong facial features and clear bright eyes came into view.

Lei Tie lay on his side with a quilt up to his chest. He wore only white inner clothing with the lapels opened in dishevel, revealing his wheat-colored clavicle.

"Awake? Still sleepy?" Lei Tie leaned over as he asked in a low voice.

Qin Mian pulled the quilt up to cover the man's clavicle and tucked the corner of the quilt in. Then, he wrapped himself in the quilt, turned his back to the man, squeezed into the man's chest, and said lazily, "Lie down a little longer."

Lei Tie pushed away his hair and kissed his earlobe. Then, a soft kiss fell on his nape, the big palm slid slowly down his waistline...

Qin Mian moaned comfortably and suddenly thought of something, “A-Tie, did we forget something?”

“Nie Heng and Mu Chen have come. I let Uncle Fu take them around the farmhouse first. Wife, think only of me.”

What else could Qin Mian say? His whole person was covered in the quilt.

After a good while, the undulating quilt finally calmed down. Lei Tie’s head emerged first.

In a moment, Qin Mian’s head also came out with red cheeks and slightly swollen lips. He tilted his head to look at Lei Tie. Owing to the pleasure just now, the man’s face added a hint of sexiness, which made him unable to move his eyes away. In a hurry to divert his attention, he asked in a hoarse voice, “When did you wake up?”

Lei Tie said, “An hour ago. Hungry?”

Qin Mian nodded his head, “En.”

Lei Tie pecked his wife’s lips, put on his clothes, and went out.

Only then Qin Mian noticed that White Spot and the brown bear – who knew when they had returned – lying on the ground and sleeping soundly.

Bored, he picked up a clothes hanger and poked the bear’s head. The brown bear raised its head and looked at him with groggy eyes. It raised its leg to get on the bed, but Qin Mian hurriedly pushed it down. The brown bear grunted, crawled back, and stayed motionless like a hill.

Hearing the approaching footsteps, Qin Mian sat up, put on his cotton-padded jacket, and leaned against the backrest.

Lei Tie came in with a tray, bypassed the two “obstacles” on the ground, and walked to the side of the bed. He placed a small table well on the bed

and put the tray on the small table.

In the tray was a steaming hot bowl of delicious lean meat with vegetable porridge.

“A-Tie, the brown bear still has no name. So, called it ‘Golden Fur’.”

“You decide.” Lei Tie handed a spoon to him, “Wife, eat slowly. I’m going out for a while.”

“Go ahead.” Qin Mian knew that he was going to visit the greenhouse.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen were following Uncle Fu to visit the orchard in Leisurely Farmhouse, watching with lively interest.

Seeing Lei Tie coming, Mu Chen excitedly asked, “Boss Lei, can we pick the sweet oranges first?”

With a poker face, Lei Tie said, “After, I still have something important to do.”

Mu Chen had to change his mind, “Well, go to see the vegetables first then.”

As soon as the few people reached the vegetable garden, they could see four high and long greenhouses at a glance.

Uncle Fu lifted the curtain at the entrance of the greenhouse and led Nie Heng and Mu Chen to visit.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen were deeply impressed by the many kinds of vegetables growing in fine form, which made them more confident and nodded to Lei Tie to express that there was no problem.

Nie Heng put his thumbprint on the three documents on the spot. Lei Tie took out Qin Mian’s seal and stamped it. Lei Tie and Nie Heng each kept one copy.

Lei Tie told Uncle Fu, “Steward Fu, later, you will take Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun with Boss Nie and Mu-gongzi to the county town and send the document to the local authority for filing.”

Uncle Fu bowed his head as he replied, “Yes, Eldest Young Master.”

Lei Tie turned to Nie Heng and Mu Chen, “The greenhouse is built by Steward Fu with other servants. If you have any questions, you can ask them. Steward Fu will speak without reserve.”

Although Nie Heng didn’t know Qin Mian and Lei Tie very well, he could see that they were very honest people, so he wasn’t afraid of them playing tricks.

“If there’s any question, have someone to call me over.” With that, Lei Tie made an obeisance gesture toward Nie Heng and Mu Chen to excuse himself and turned to leave.

Mu Chen patted Nie Heng’s back with an ambiguous expression, “Surprisingly, Boss Qin didn’t show up. Is he not afraid that his man will suffer in our hands? Do you think he hasn’t got up yet?”

Nie Heng shot a glance at him and pulled him deeper into the greenhouse. “Do you need to worry about these? Get down to business. Steward Fu, first tell us what we need to build a greenhouse like this...”

When Lei Tie returned to the house, Qin Mian’s bowl of porridge had finished. Qin Mian handed the empty bowl to him, “Want more, is there some?”

“A lot.”

Lei Tie came back with the porridge and watched Qin Mian eat. When Qin Mian had finished eating and made sure he was full, Lei Tie said, “Wife, Lei-Qin Le brought Manager Sun’s news. The other three Diamond Members also give up participating in the great adventure.”

“Really?” Qin Mian looked regretful. “I thought that hunting in the mountains would be very attractive to those rich people. It’s a lapse of conjecture. That’s fine, save us the trouble.”

“En. Read a book?” asked Lei Tie.

Qin Mian shook his head. “I’m arranging New Year’s gifts first.”

From inside the drawer, Lei Tie took out his wife’s felt-tip pen and notebook before taking the bowl out of the room.

When he returned home after sending Nie Heng and Mu Chen out of the gate, Qin Mian had written several pages in his notebook.

Qin Mian handed the notebook to him and discussed with him, “A-Tie, see if my arrangement is appropriate. Our servants are good. We haven’t found anyone who is lazy or tries to shirk. I think, this New Year, compared with last year, each person will be given 50 Wen more bonus and 5 jin more meat. Also, starting from next year, the monthly payment of all servants will be increased by 20 Wen. As for the four seasons’ clothes, add a set each for the ordinary servants, and two sets each for the managing servants. What do you think?”

Lei Tie looked over it carefully and nodded, “Do as you say. Wife, Lei-Qin Le and Steward Fu are good. Later, let Lei-Qin Le manage the vermicelli workshop, and Steward Fu manages the winery. This way, you don’t have to work so hard.”

Qin Mian said with a smile, “I think the same. I’ll arrange things after the New Year. Uncle Quan’s character is also trustworthy. If there is no mishap, we can leave the vineyard to him.”

“Doable.” Lei Tie said, “Their sale deeds are in our hands, I believe no one will do stupid things.”

“En.” Qin Mian continued to write down other arrangements in his notebook. “The New Year’s gifts for workers in the winery and vermicelli

workshop are still graded according to their usual performance, lest their appetites give birth to wickedness.”

Lei Tie said, “I’ll personally send out the New Year’s gifts.”

On the 18th of the twelfth month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to the old house again. This was the day when Lei Xiangli and Sun Yu were betrothed. There were six etiquettes of marriage: making a proposal, requesting birthdate, sending news of divination results and betrothal gifts, sending wedding gifts, requesting the date of the wedding, and fetching in the bride in person. Proposing was the matchmaking. Requesting birthdate was requesting the eight cyclic characters to determine fate, and after exchanging the birthdate characters, the man expressed willingness to go on to the next step. Sending news of divination results and betrothal gifts was to talk about marriage. If the eight characters of both parties were compatible, the marriage could be established and the date of marriage could be set. The date of Lei Xiangli’s marriage with Sun Yu was set on the 18th of the fourth month of next year.

When the marriage had been decided, it was a custom for the family members to have a meal together.

Lei Xiangli was standing at the gate of the courtyard with a smile on his lips.

Qin Mian raised his voice, full of teasing, “Fourth Brother, congratulations! A load on the mind has been lifted, isn’t it?”

“Cough!” Lei Xiangli blushed, “Don’t make fun of me, Eldest Sister-in-law. Please, come in.”

Qin Mian fished out a red small pouch that was prepared earlier from his sleeve pocket and handed it to him. There were 5 silver taels in it.

“This is a little regard from your eldest brother and me, take it.”

Without waiting for Lei Xiangli to speak, he pulled Lei Tie into the central room.

As he had anticipated, as soon as Lei Daqiang saw them coming in, his patience ran out.

“Eldest and eldest daughter-in-law, you two must have not forgotten what you said before during the separation. When Old Four gets married—”

Lei Xiangli hurriedly said, “Father, Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law already gave me 5 taels. I have received it.”

Du Shi looked displeased. Qin Mian and Lei Tie gave the money to Lei Xiangli, not to her and Lei Daqiang, obviously on guard against them.

Qin Mian laughingly said, “Old man, old lady, and second old lady, we are here to congratulate you. But today’s really unfortunate. Today, we have something important to go to town, so we won’t have a meal.”

Wei Shi rushed to talk before Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, “It’s fine, go ahead if you have an urgent matter. Old Four, send off your eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law.”

Before the three men had gone far away, Du Shi began to attack Wei Shi, “Wei Shi, Old Four is my son! My son is betrothed. When was it your turn to make a decision?”

Wei Shi gave a pleasant smile and said in a soft voice, “Sister, didn’t you see that Old Four looked embarrassed just now? I do it for your own good, lest your third son will be at odds with you.”

Du Shi blew her top, “You!”

“All right, all right.” Lei Daqiang gave Du Shi a discontented look, turned his back to her, blocked her fierce eyes, and looked at Wei Shi with concern, “Wei’er, you’re about to give birth, don’t be too agitated.”

“I’ll listen to my husband.” Wei Shi gently smiled at him, “Husband, accompany me to go out for a walk.”

“Alright. I’ll help you. Slow down.”

As soon as they walked out of the central room, the sound of broken cups transmitted out from within.

Chapter 128: A New Year

128 – A New Year

A month too early for that $q(\geq \nabla \leq q)$

As the new year approached, Lei Tie had not slackened the training for the armed servants. He got up very early. After completing the daily training tasks, Lei Tie took solid food and brought the armed servants to the back of the mountain for field training. Great snow fluttered about these days, but the training did not stop at all. Lei-Qin Shun's group of nine did not understand why the Eldest Young Master trained them so strictly, yet no one asked questions. They all understood one truth: What they truly learned belonged to them.

The door of the house was tightly shut. Golden Fur lay beside the settee, sleeping in the dark. Qin Mian nestled in the settee with his back against Golden Fur and legs covered with woolen blankets serving as a table as he wrote on his notebook. A charcoal brazier was placed not far away. The charcoal was burning well and the flame was ablaze. The white residue of the burnt charcoal floated along with the flame and was blown away by the wind. The candles on the four corners were lit, setting off a warm and comfortable hue in the living room.

When there were too many things to do, Qin Mian used to write all the things on paper, which was more convenient to make the most reasonable arrangement. What he was arranging was the preparation before the New Year: who was responsible for the residence's sanitation, who was responsible to decorate Leisurely Farmhouse, who was responsible for purchasing New Year's goods, who was responsible for killing chickens and ducks, and so on. It was all clearly written. Last year, he and Lei Tie

personally worked on all these things. This year, they just needed to be the Eldest Young Master and the Little Young Master.

The door of the central room was knocked before Aunt Fu's voice sounded, "Little Young Master, this old woman has something to see you."

"Come in."

As soon as Aunt Fu opened the door, the cold wind carrying snowflakes poured in. Qin Mian tightened the woolen blanket around his body.

Aunt Fu lowered her eyes and did not look around. After she dropped a curtsy, she said, "Little Young Master, recently, many people are asking about Lei-Qin Le, both overtly and secretly. After thinking about it, this old woman thinks you should be told as soon as possible."

"Lei-Qin Le?" Qin Mian's eyes moved away from the notebook and looked at her in puzzlement, "What's wrong with Lei-Qin Le?"

Aunt Fu discovered that the Little Young Master hadn't realized it. "Little Young Master, this old woman guesses this is what happened. The New Year's gifts for the workers in the winery and vermicelli workshop have been sent. Many villagers feel that our family is very generous to the employees and servants. That is, some families with the poor condition still have girls who haven't been matched..."

Qin Mian suddenly realized. Although he was the "master's wife", he was not a woman after all. He never considered this aspect. He remembered that Lei-Qin Le was 20 years old and would be 21 after the New Year. In this era, he was considered as an unmarried older young man. He clicked his tongue inwardly. It was not easy to be a master and still had to be responsible for the servants' marriages. Fortunately, Lei-Qin Le was the only one who had reached the age of marriage. Lei-Qin Shun and the others were still young; there were still a few years more for this talk.

"Did Lei-Qin Le ever mention it to you?"

"Never actually."

Qin Mian nodded, "I'm well aware of the situation. If people ask you again, you can tell them that Lei-Qin Le's wife must enter our family's servant registry. Aunt Fu, you can also understand without me saying it. There are so many secret recipes in our family that not anyone can come in."

Aunt Fu understood. "Little Young Master, please rest assured. This old woman knows how to say it."

"En. Also, you can mention this matter with Lei-Qin Le to see if he has any thoughts on it. A-Tie and I are both adult men; it's not good to directly take care of this. You and Aunt Quan pay more attention."

"Yes," replied Aunt Fu. "If there is nothing else, this old woman asks for leave."

"En, go."

The door was closed. A sense of loneliness suddenly surged into Qin Mian's heart, and at the same time, he felt that his home was so terribly quiet. These days, Lei Tie had been going out in the morning and coming back when it was getting dark. As for him who was used to go in and out with Lei Tie, he was not used to this.

He simply put down his pen, put on warm rabbit furred boots, draped on a cloak, and called Golden Fur to follow him out. He did not forget to fasten the lock hoop above the door panel, lest the wind blew in and raised the flame in the charcoal brazier to cause a fire.

In Leisurely Farmhouse, aside from the cobblestone path that had been swept by the servants, everywhere was a vast expanse of white. On the ground, the white snow was like a white feather cushion, and the footprints left by chickens and ducks were like flowers embroidered on it – serene and elegant. On the fruit trees, the white snow wrapped like silk, just like locust trees blooming with silver flowers, piled up layer upon layer, beautiful like a scroll painting.

With a steady pace, Golden Fur walked forward, playfully hitting a peach tree. With a rustle, the snowflakes fell and covered its face. It

discontentedly swayed its clumsy body; its posture was spoilt and naïve, yet amusing.

Qin Mian walked along the path to the gate. Golden Fur wobbly followed him, shaking the snowflakes on its head from time to time.

Qin Mian was amused. As far as he knew, some brown bears didn't hibernate. Unexpectedly, Golden Fur was one of them. It stayed at home and only left when it was hungry to look for food.

Qin Mian believed that one of the important reasons was that Golden Fur hated to part with Lei Tie, because almost every few days, Golden Fur would challenge Lei Tie to fight with it. As a bystander, he couldn't understand the significance of Golden Fur's fighting with a human.

Uncle Quan was on duty in the gatekeeper's room. He also lit up a charcoal brazier, but instead of charcoal, he burned firewood, which was very nice and warm.

Seeing Qin Mian approaching, he ran out of the room, "Little Young Master, are you going out?"

"Taking a walk."

"Your servant will open the gate for you."

With Golden Fur following him, Uncle Quan had nothing to worry about. After Qin Mian went out, he closed the gate.

Qin Mian walked forward, aimlessly. The sky was boundless and the ground was also boundless. It was actually interesting to enjoy the snow scenery the whole journey. When he regained his senses, he found himself standing at the foot of the mountain, and spontaneously broke into laughter.

Golden Fur rolled several times on the ground and stood up, finding joy in its own way.

The cold wind was howling in the ears. Qin Mian suddenly felt that his behavior today was somewhat silly. He raised his voice and called Golden

Fur, “Golden Fur, go home.”

As soon as he turned around, a brief howl of a wolf sounded behind him. He looked back and saw a black figure leaping on the snowfield as fast as lightning, and soon came to him.

“Awoo.” White Spot put its forepaws on Qin Mian’s shoulder, and its warm tongue licked his face.

Lei Tie, who came out of the forest, happened to see this scene and quickened his pace.

Lei-Qin Shun and others amazedly watched him seemingly floating on the snowfield where not even a footprint was left. Their veneration for him went to even a higher degree.

“Wife, waiting for me?” Lei Tie stood in front of Qin Mian, pushed White Spot away, and gained ground to brush away the snowflakes on Qin Mian’s cloak. His black as ink eyes smeared with a smiling expression of joy and contentment; his voice was deep and gentle.

The joy in the man’s eyes made Qin Mian feel even more that he did a foolish thing. He was unaware that the corner of his lips was tilted, “No, I was strolling.”

“En.” Lei Tie took his hand.

In the distance, Zhao Sifa’s eyes full of disdain and resentment fell on the two people. For fear that he attracted the other party’s attention, he quickly moved away and his figure soon disappeared.

Qin Mian looked at Lei-Qin Zhong and the others. The originally slender poplars had now grown into upright China-firs.¹

With bows and arrows on their backs and prey in their hands, Lei-Qin Zhong’s group of people stepped forward and saluted together. The orderly voices were powerful and resounding with high momentum as if it could run through the rainbow. “Greeting to Little Young Master!”

Qin Mian was worried that due to Lei Tie's taciturn personality, he didn't say what he should have said. Therefore, he spoke words of encouragement, "It's a great honor for your Eldest Young Master to lead you all to the mountain for training in the snowy weather. You must not let down the cultivation and trust that your Eldest Young Master and I have given you."

The nine armed servants looked serious as they said in unison, "Your servant dares not!"

Qin Mian smiled and nodded, "Very good. You all go back first."

"Yes."

When they had gone far away, Qin Mian and Lei Tie also slowly walked home.

"A-Tie, you have been in contact with them for a long time. What do you think of their characters?"

Lei Tie said, "Wife, don't worry. All nine of them are good."

"That's good." Qin Mian hesitated for a moment, "Still going up the mountain tomorrow?"

Lei Tie, who had originally scheduled the training period for 10 days, immediately changed his mind, "There will be training for tomorrow and the day after tomorrow, but I don't need to personally lead the team."

Only then Qin Mian's expression looked a bit better.

Lei Tie held his face and gently kissed him on the lips, "Go home."

Four days later was New Year's Eve.

Lei Daqiang wanted to have Lei Tie, Lei Xiangren, and Lei Xiangyi come to the old house for the family reunion dinner on New Year's Eve. As if they had discussed in advance, they all refused.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi quickly realized that their control over the three sons was getting weaker and weaker.

Inside Leisurely Farmhouse, colored festoons and red lanterns were hung, and red Spring Festival couplets were also pasted. The New Year's Eve dinner was still prepared by Qin Mian himself. The table was full of dishes. The New Year's Eve dinner for White Spot and Golden Fur was also very sumptuous. White Spot had a whole wild goat, while Golden Fur had a large basin of fish, sweet potatoes, and honey.

Two people, a wolf, and a bear spent a lively New Year's Eve.

On the first day of the first month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie put on new clothes and went to the old house to pay the New Year's greetings.

Very surprisingly, they were the first to arrive. After paying the New Year's greetings, the two men sat together with Lei Xiangli, Lei Xiangzhi, and Lei Chuntao and chatted while eating melon seeds.

“Eh? Are we late?” Zhao Shi pulled Lei Dabao in her left hand and Lei Erbao in her right hand, as she stepped into the room with her chin slightly raised and her mouth delicately opened with a smile.

As soon as the three people entered the door, Qin Mian thought a bright light flashed in front of him – so dazzling!

Zhao Shi was dressed in bright red nichang². The clothes were embroidered with hidden silver threads, which glittered when shone under the light. She had a gold dangling ornament in her cloud bun, a silver headband on her forehead, pearls hanging from her earlobes, a silver necklace around her neck, and a silver dangling ornament on her waist. Both Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao were dressed in red cotton-padded jackets with silver long-life locks on their necks. They were as proud as their mother at a young age.

Lei Xiangren walked at very back with a straightened waist. He wore a winter hat with a curved brim, a tailored cloud brocade beizi³ sewn with tiger hide, and a piece of blue jade on his waist.

Du Shi touched the silver earrings she had worn for several years as her eyes wandered to the accessories on Zhao Shi's body, not knowing what she felt inside, and regretted that they had separated too soon.

Note:

Footnotes

1. LOL, Mian viewed those boys like trees.
2. 霓裳 is rainbow-colored clothes worn by the Eight Immortals. It also refers to Hanfu's laudatory name.
3. 褙子 is a kind of Hanfu, which dates back to the Sui Dynasty. It has a straight collar and a pair of lapels. The sides are not sewn from the armpits.

Chapter 129: Celebrate the Lantern Festival in the Prefectural City!

129 – Celebrate the Lantern Festival in the Prefectural City!

As soon as everyone's eyes fell on his family, Lei Xiangren's eyebrows displayed a sense of pride. He strode to Lei Daqiang and Du Shi and knelt with Zhao Shi, "Happy New Year to Father and Mother." He ignored Wei Shi.

Wei Shi's expression was flat as if she didn't pay attention. Lei Daqiang was a little unhappy, but Lei Xiangren was his son, it was hard to say anything.

Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao knelt and very sweetly said, "Happy New Year to Grandpa, Grandma, and Little Grandma. May you be happy and prosperous and bring red envelopes!"

"Alright, alright, get up." Lei Daqiang was still very fond of his two grandsons that he repeatedly told them to rise and took out two red envelopes. He gave one to each of them, "Come, take the red envelope. I hope that our Dabao and Erbao will grow up taller and clever this year."

Lei Dabao opened the red envelope on the spot and counted the money one by one.

"Oh, our Dabao can count?" Du Shi looked at Dabao lovingly.

“Yes, Mother. Dabao is so clever! He only attended the school for a few days and can already count from one to twenty.” Zhao Shi had a look of arrogance.

Du Shi nodded with satisfaction, “Good, he’s promising!”

After counting, Dabao ran to Zhao Shi. His voice was very loud, “Mother, don’t you say that Grandpa and Grandma have a lot of money and will give us silvers for the New Year’s money? I want silver!”

Silence overtook the room.

Qin Mian was almost choked by the tea and quickly put down the cup. Lei Tie patted him on the back and pulled him to get up.

Qin Mian took out three red envelopes, two of which were handed to Lei Xiangren and the other to Lei Xiangzhi, “This is for Xinxin. We still have to visit other villagers’ homes to pay New Year’s greetings. We’re leaving first.”

Du Shi came back to her senses and immediately blew her top. She roared, “Zhao Shi! That’s how you taught my grandsons? Ah?”

Qin Mian quickly pulled Lei Tie to speed up the pace. Out of the courtyard gate, he couldn’t hold back from shaking his head, “Dabao and ErBao; these two children are dangerous.” A six-year-old child couldn’t possibly concoct that kind of conversation. It could only be learned from his parents. With parents like Zhao and Lei Xiangren, the possibility of Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao to grow up crookedly was very high.

“People who don’t belong together, don’t get to live together¹,” said Lei Tie, indifferently.

“That’s insightful!” Qin Mian gave him a thumbs-up.

The snowfield was full of exploded firecrackers and scraps of red paper. When they met a few villagers, who went out to pay New Year’s greetings, they cupped their hands in obeisance and said “Happy New Year”.

With Lei Xinxin in his arms, Lei Xiangyi and Qian Shi came across them in a hurry.

“Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, Happy New Year! Are you going back?”

Qian Shi curtsied with folded hands at her lower right side and said, “Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, Happy New Year.”

“Happy New Year.” Qin Mian cupped his fist in the other hand and then rubbed Xinxin’s head, “Why so late?”

Lei Xiangyi said, “The child’s mother got up early feeling somewhat uncomfortable. Therefore, we delayed for a while.”

“Are you all right?” Qin Mian expressed concern.

“Thank you for your concern. I’m fine.” Qian Shi shook her head with a smile.

“I gave Xinxin’s red envelope to her Fifth Uncle. You go ahead. Be careful when you go in. It’s not very peaceful inside,” hinted Qin Mian.

Lei Xiangyi understood and anxiously told Qian Shi, “Later, you just follow by my side.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie continued to pay New Year’s greetings. They sent several red envelopes to Lei Dagang’s house. Just after coming out of Lei Dagang’s house, they saw Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao running over in a hurry. They looked anxious.

Qin Mian curiously asked, “Fourth Brother and Little Sister, what are you running for?”

“Eldest Sister-in-law, Little Mother had a fetal Qi movement²; she’s going to give birth!” Lei Chuntao replied without stopping her feet, “I’m going to call the midwife!”

“Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, I’m going to call for a doctor!” Lei Xiangli also quickly ran away.

Since they could do nothing by going to the old house, Qin Mian and Lei Tie continued to pay New Year’s greetings. When they returned home, they discussed what gifts to give.

“What should be given to a woman who had given birth?” Qin Mian had no idea.

Lei Tie shook his head, “Ask Aunt Fu?”

Qin Mian called Aunt Fu over.

Aunt Fu said, “Answering to Little Young Master; it’s usually brown sugar and eggs.”

Qin Mian thought for a moment and said, “Prepare 2 jin of brown sugar, 2 jin of eggs, and 6 jin of red jujube.”

“Yes.”

Near noon, Xiaoxi came to announce the good news: Wei Shi gave birth to a daughter and the washing third-day³ ceremony was set on the third day of the New Year. Xiaoxi conveyed the meaning of Lei Daqiang, which was to have Lei Tie, Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli send congratulatory letters to their relatives’ homes. Each of them was responsible for a few families.

Lei Tie only gave Xiaoxi two words: Not going.

Xiaoxi didn’t dare to say a word and quickly left.

On the second day of the first lunar month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to Deng Village to pay a New Year’s visit.

Ever since the Deng family came over to enjoy the flowers last spring, Qin Mian and Lei Tie never invited the Deng family members to visit their

home anymore. They just had people sent some fruits to them on every fruit season.

Eldest Uncle Deng and Second Uncle Deng were both smart people. They guessed that some of their family members left a bad impression on Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Later, they went to Lei Tie's house several times without bringing their wives, daughters-in-law, grandsons, and granddaughters. They never blamed Lei Tie and Qin Mian for this. It was already hard on Lei Tie and Qin Mian to be concerned about sending them some fresh fruits from time to time. It was more comfortable for both sides to associate just like ordinary relatives.

Old Man Deng and Old Lady Deng enjoyed the special treatments. At every festival celebrations, Qin Mian and Lei Tie gave them ample gifts. Lei Tie respected the old man and the old lady from the bottom of his heart, while Qin Mian respected them because of Lei Tie's respect.

The third day of the first month was the washing third-day ceremony of the Lei's youngest daughter.

Early in the morning, Qin Mian asked Aunt Fu to deliver 2 jin brown sugar, 2 jin eggs, and 6 jin red jujube. When it was near noon, he and Lei Tie then went over to have lunch and learned that the name of the Lei's youngest girl was Lei Yaqing, which was chosen by Wei Shi, and Qingqing was her childhood name.

The washing third-day ceremony required a basin where people added copper coins, gold or silver ingots, as well as gold or silver banknotes, and also longans, red jujubes, peanuts, chestnuts, and other festive fruits. Even Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi both added a handful of copper coins. Lei Daqiang was very dissatisfied with the gifts given by Qin Mian and Lei Tie. From time to time, he pointedly glanced at them. Even more, Du Shi incessantly spoke with scathing remarks.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had unobtrusively drifted apart from the old house. Naturally, they didn't take their attitudes seriously. They sat at the banquet and only ate two mouthfuls of food for appearance's sake before finding an excuse to leave.

A few days later, a rumor circulated in the village. The gist of it was that Lei Tie had forgotten his parents' nurturing grace after he had flourished. It was easy to know that this rumor was spread by someone among Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, Lei Xiangren, and Zhao Shi. Wei Shi was a smart woman; she was unlikely. The most likely was Du Shi and Lei Daqiang.

Lei Tie was a man of few words and usually didn't even bother to talk. So of course, he would not argue with those gossiping villagers. However, his wife was not easy to bully – he immediately summoned all the servants to publicize what Du Shi and Lei Daqiang had done in the past, and also publicize what Du Shi had done to Wei Shi.

They were all from the same village; they knew each other. Moreover, not a few villagers worked in the processing yard. Public opinion soon inclined toward Lei Tie. In Green Mountain Village, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang, the stepmother and stepfather⁴ couple, once again became the man and the woman of the moment⁵.

Unfortunately, Sun Daneng's family was slightly affected. Sun Daneng was Sun Yu's father. His wife, Aunt Xiulan, was so unbearably angry. If she didn't know that Lei Xiangli and Lei Daqiang had separated, she would never have betrothed her daughter to Lei Daqiang's family. Aunt Xiulan met Lei Xiangli in secret and asked him to solve the housing issue in the first lunar month. This way, after Sun Yu and he got married, they didn't have to live in the old house.

With Qin Mian adding fuel to the flame, the storm was especially fierce. For several days, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang did not dare to wander around the village. They even went to their relatives' homes to pay New Year's greetings at the first glimmer of dawn.

On the 7th day of the first lunar month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie set out on their journey to Qingtian Prefecture. They were going to celebrate the Lantern Festival in Qingtian. It was said that the Lantern Festival in the prefectural city was especially lively, and there was nothing that one couldn't think of whether it was to eat, drink, have, and play. Lei-Qin Le,

Lei-Qin Shun, Lei-Qin Zhong, Lei-Qin Li, and Lei-Qin Xin accompanied them.

Owing to the early departure, there was plenty of time, so the carriage drove neither too fast nor too slow along the way. Lei-Qin Le's group of five took turns driving the carriage. Qin Mian and Lei Tie just needed to sit in the carriage, nice and cozy.

In the first lunar month, many vehicles and pedestrians were coming and going on the public road. The pedestrians dressed in festive new clothes and the vehicles were hung with red cloth strips symbolizing auspiciousness. From time to time, some fragments of exploded firecrackers were seen on the roadside. The spirit of the New Year was strong.

After driving for four days, the carriage arrived in Qingtian Prefecture. The street was full of people and vehicles. It was obvious that wanting to stay in the inn would be hard. Qin Mian simply gave up looking for an inn and asked Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Li to find a private residence to rent a courtyard.

To celebrate the Lantern Festival, Qingtian Prefecture had greatly changed its look. Under the veranda of the buildings, colorful festoons fluttered and red lanterns hung high, extending until the end of the street, looking like two red dragons from afar. On both sides of the street, there were roadside stalls selling sugar figurines, soup noodles, barbecues, spicy hot soup, colored lanterns, as well as stalls for riddles guessing, ring toss, acrobatics show, storytelling, and fortune-telling... How lively. Rich families' gongzis with escorts in front and behind, warm and harmonious family of three ... all of them were smiling. As though the pedestrians were knitted, their heads crowded together as they moved back and forth.

This was the first time that Qin Mian saw the night market in the ancient era. He was very excited but also felt extremely novel. He took Lei Tie to walk around one stall after another. He also bought novelty snacks and various kinds of things. In his words: *Money is earned to be spent!*

He didn't carry the things he bought; it was all foisted off on Lei Tie.

Lei Tie handed over the things to the five escorts and closely followed by Qin Mian's side to prevent from being separated. He was disgusted when the crowd touched him from time to time. However, when he saw Qin Mian's excited eyes, all the discomfort disappeared. In his eyes, he only saw his wife's smiling face; in his heart, he only felt his wife's joy.

Note:

Footnotes

1. (idiom)/ marriages are predestined/ people marry because they share common traits
2. Fetal Qi movement refers to the abdominal pain, vaginal bleeding, and other symptoms due to the mother's constitution or affected by external factors.
3. On the third day after the baby is born, a bathing ceremony will be held to gather relatives and friends to wish good luck to the baby.
4. Lei Daqiang is the biological father but his behavior is like a stepfather, so he is named thus.
5. It means people who make a headline; the talk of the town, etc.

Chapter 130: False Alarm

130 – False Alarm

“A-Tie...” Qin Mian noticed Lei Tie’s frown and understood it. He quickly came back to the man’s side and blocked him from the stream of people.

Lei Tie caught sight of a woman tripping after being pushed in their way and immediately changed places with Qin Mian. The aura on his body turned gloomy and a piercing cold feeling came out of thin air.

The people around him shivered for no reason and unconsciously kept away from the source of danger.

“Are you all right?” Lei Tie disliked the throng of the crowd, and it would also be meaningless for Qin Mian to stroll around alone. He thought that it was better not to stroll around, but there was some hesitation on his face.

“I’m fine.” Lei Tie saw through his wife’s mind and changed the topic, “Wife, what did you call me for?”

“There are clay figurines over there.” Qin Mian took his hand and looked at him with a grin, “Will this be better?”

Lei Tie tightly held his hand. “En. Don’t want a clay figurine?”

“Follow me.” Qin Mian excitedly pulled him to the stall where the clay figurine was kneaded. He watched with fascination as a ball of clay turned into a lifelike child in the hands of the old man. There was a look of incredulous on his face. He had only seen the art of kneading clay figurines on TV before.

As soon as the clay child was done, he spoke before others had a chance to, “Boss, knead one of me and one of him.”

“No problem.” The old man carefully looked at them up and down, making a detailed inspection. When his gaze fell on their clasped hands, he was a little surprised but remained calm as he laughed, “Gongzis, please wait a moment.”

He tore a small lump of clay from a big lump in the bucket. His ten fingers were like playing piano, changing movements skillfully and quickly. The lifeless clay gradually deformed. In less than a half quarter of an hour, two clay figurines holding hands appeared in his hand, exactly like Qin Mian and Lei Tie. So much so that even the tenderness in Lei Tie’s eyes was portrayed, as vivid as though it was given life.

With great care, Qin Mian took it and exclaimed, “Old man has great skill!”

“Haha, little gongzi overpraises me. Good that you like it.” The old man was very kind.

Lei Tie was also surprised by the similarity between the clay figurines and them. He asked, “Is there a wooden box?”

“Oh, yes.” The old man took out a wooden box about the same size from under the table. After Qin Mian put the clay figurines in, the old man covered it and handed the wooden box to him.

Feeling pleased, Qin Mian hugged the box. His brain involuntarily visualized Lei Tie’s appearance when he was a child. He enjoyed himself with that.

Lei Tie took a silver ingot from his pouch, regardless of whether it was 1 or 2 or 5 taels, and put it on the table in front of the old man.

“Ah?” Shocked, the old man picked up the silver ingot worth 5 taels, “Gongzis, 20 Wen is enough. This is too much...”

Before he finished saying, the two men had gone far away and were soon blocked by the crowd. He could only see the man with his face slightly sideways as he stared down at the youth beside him, still expressionless, but his deep eyes filled with tenderness.

Qin Mian saw a barbecue stall at the front and rubbed his stomach, “A little hungry. A-Tie, let’s go eat barbecue.”

“Alright.”

Qin Mian looked behind him and was surprised, “Lei-Qin Le, why are there only three of you?”

Lei-Qin Zhong promptly said, “Little Young Master, we discovered earlier that Lei-Qin Li and Lei-Qin Xin are missing. We’re afraid of ruining your and Eldest Young Master’s enjoyment, so we didn’t say anything. But Little Young Master can rest assured. When we came out, I told them to remember the way. In case they can’t find the way, they will wait at the Great Fortune Inn’s entrance.”

As the eldest of the nine armed servants, Lei-Qin Zhong was careful and steady. Qin Mian was at ease with him and nodded, “Go and eat something first. You’ll pack some food for Lei-Qin Li and Lei-Qin Xin later.”

“Yes.”

The few of them walked along the stream of people to the barbecue stall. Who would have known, at this time, someone at the front screamed, “Fire, fire!”

The course of the sound was like the undercurrent of the seabed gushing out in the crowd without warning. Stream of people instantly surged; women’s screams and children’s cries came and went one after another. Losing their mind out of fear, people crowded in different directions, and several turbulent streams of people pushed against each other, making the scene all the more chaotic.

A child fell in front of Qin Mian and was about to be trampled on by an adult. Qin Mian immediately moved and lifted the child. The surging stream of people pushed him a few steps forward and he quickly stabilized his center of gravity.

The father of the child tightly hugged the child and gratefully expressed his thanks to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian looked back and was dumbstruck. Where was his family's poker face?

A frightened man ran past him and stepped on his feet. Qin Mian uttered a "hiss" sound of pain. He knew that he could not panic at this time. He could only move forward along the stream of people. Seeing an opening, he pushed toward the edge of the crowd. After struggling for a moment, he finally squeezed out. He leaped onto the roof and searched for Lei Tie's figure in the crowd, holding the wooden box containing the clay figurines tightly in his hand.

In the throng of the crowd, Lei Tie's hand suddenly felt empty, making him startled. Before he could react, the pedestrians on the left side were suddenly pushed by a strong force. Seven or eight people fell into a pile in front of him. By the time he bypassed them, he had lost the trace of Qin Mian. At once, his chest seemed to have been hollowed out. The possibility of losing Qin Mian made him lose his senses. He pushed aside the people who hindered him and anxiously searched in the crowd, "Wife! Qin Mian!"

Qin Mian stood on a high place and looked far away. In a short time, he found Lei Tie's figure. Seeing the man's blank and despairing expression, he felt pain as though a knife had been plunged into his heart. *Did that fool completely forget he has cultivation?*

"A-Tie! A-Tie! I'm over here!" Qin Mian yelled as he waved.

On the second floor of a wine house beside the street, Nie Heng stood by the railing and patted the head of the girl beside him as he said in rejoice, "See that? Fortunately, I didn't listen to you and stroll around downstairs."

Just then, he heard a familiar voice and looked across the street.

Lei Tie had a sharp hearing. When he heard Qin Mian's voice, he turned his head. His pupils shrank and his lips wriggled before he leaped up, his figure flashed, and fell in front of Qin Mian.

In the wine house, Nie Heng was astounded. What a fast qinggong skill. Lei Tie's martial arts had reached the acme of perfection level!

Qin Mian didn't have time to say a word and was embraced by Lei Tie; a pair of iron arms wrapped around his waist so tightly as if wanting to break him.

"Wife... Don't leave me."

The man's body trembled, uncontrollably. Qin Mian's eyes irrepressibly stung. He also forcibly hugged the man's and patted the man's back with his right hand as he continuously appeased, "It's fine, it's fine. Fool, I won't leave you."

Qin Mian leaned against the man's chest and listened to his rapid heartbeat slowly return to stability. His heart throbbed; the heartache he felt for the man was like a tide billowing in his chest. That blank and despairing expression of Lei Tie, he never wanted to see it again. He raised his head and glared at the man, "Idiot! Did you forget that you have cultivation? Did you forget that we could meet again in the 'old place'?"

Lei Tie knew that he had made his wife feel distressed and silently allowed his wife to reproach him without saying a word.

Seeing him looking like this, Qin Mian's heart was pulled again. How could he be willing to continue scolding? After he raised his hand and gently caressed the man's cheek, he held out his hand to him.

Lei Tie held it tightly.

The local authority soon intervened in the great disturbance in the street. The crowd broke up after being dispersed and the street gradually calmed

down. The fire in the distance was also extinguished. Fortunately, it did not lead to disaster. However, many people were trampled and crushed and were taken to the medical building for treatment.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie then jumped down from the roof.

Nie Heng and the girl, as well as Nie Heng's attendant Chunsheng, came out of the wine house and timely stopped the two people who were about to leave.

“Qin Mian and Boss Lei.”

“Nie Heng? What a coincidence.” Qin Mian was very happy to meet an old friend in a distant land.

“Yes. Did you forget that I said the Nie family's root is in the prefectural city?” Nie Heng ruefully looked at him and Lei Tie. Just now, he could see the scene clearly on the second floor. Double Xiang House was under Qin Mian's name. When he signed the document of the secret formula for the anti-seasonal vegetables, if Lei Tie pressed his thumbprint instead of Qin Mian, Nie Heng would ask for Qin Mian's thumbprint or seal to be added. It was because he never thought that there would be serious feelings between two men and he did not think that the feelings between two men could last for a long time. But tonight, he had to admit that he was wrong. He even envied Qin Mian and Lei Tie – they both were wholeheartedly concerned for each other. He didn't know whether he could meet a lover who could sincerely promise a lifetime with him in the future.

“Yes, but I didn't expect such coincidence,” said Qin Mian.

“Eldest brother, these two gongzis are?” The girl's voice sounded bashful. Her eyes wandered on Qin Mian and Lei Tie's faces, somewhat fascinated. She noticed a scar on the other side of Lei Tie's face. When her eyes finally fell on Qin Mian, her pretty face was dyed with a layer of blush. This young gongzi not only wore precious clothes and ornaments, but he was also outstandingly handsome, so much so that he even outstripped her eldest brother.

Lei Tie's aura turned cold and heavy.

Nie Heng noticed his sister's gaze and was alert. He hurriedly said, "Qin Mian and Boss Lei, let me introduce you. This is my younger sister. Little Sister, these two are Boss Lei from Zhaoyang County and his madam, Boss Qin."

"M-madam?" The girl's apricot eyes opened so wide. With a light hum, her gaze cooled off.

Qin Mian gave Nie Heng a silent glance. He was very grateful that Nie Heng eliminated the peach blossom¹ for him, but there was no need to say that he was Lei Tie's "madam". Why did Nie Heng think he was Lei Tie's madam instead of Lei Tie was his madam?

Nie Heng helplessly spread out his hands. *Otherwise, how to introduce you?*

"Just call me by name," said Lei Tie to Nie Heng.

Nie Heng smiled, "Alright. Qin Mian and Lei Tie, since we are brought by fate to meet, I ought to act as a host. How about finding a place to sit down?"

Qin Mian regretfully said, "Today won't do. We went out with five attendants. I'm afraid they are still looking for us. How about tomorrow?"

Nie Heng nodded his head as he said, "Sure, it's a deal. I happen to have another business to talk to you about, but no rush."

They agreed to meet at Seven Fortunes Wine House at noon the next day and parted ways.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went back along the way they came to and they came across the five attendants who walked in their direction looking for them.

The two parties smoothly reunited and returned to the previous barbecue stall.

After having a hearty meal, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not in the mood to stroll again and returned to the rented courtyard.

As soon as they entered the room, Lei Tie carried Qin Mian horizontally and pressed him on the bed.

The two men had undergone a rather major ups and downs mood tonight. They needed to get over the shock. Very soon, they rolled into a ball and lingered for a whole night.

At noon the next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to Seven Fortunes Wine House to meet Nie Heng. Nie Heng treated them to a sumptuous lunch, enthusiastically and attentively.

What Nie Heng wanted to say was that there were several waves of people who tried to go to Zhaoyang County to inquire about the anti-seasonal vegetables, but they were stopped by Mu Chen's people. Three days ago, the news that the formula for anti-seasonal vegetables was in Mu Chen's hand was released. Afterward, no one would find Qin Mian and Lei Tie to make trouble because of this.

Qin Mian thanked him and asked him to pass on their gratitude to Mu Chen.

"No need to thank. If you still have canned peaches, send me some. My grandmother especially loves to eat it," said Nie Heng, half-jokingly.

Qin Mian said with a smile, "Lucky for you, we indeed brought two canned peaches when we went out this time, supposedly to keep for ourselves. They aren't opened yet. You'll come back with us later and take them home by the way." Lei-Qin Le and others didn't know what kind of things were loaded in the carriage. He would look for an opportunity and take two out of the space.

Nie Heng cupped his hand in obeisance and said, "That would be disrespectful to decline."

After finishing the lunch, Nie Heng went with them.

Qin Mian gave him two canned peaches and bid farewell at the same time.

Returning home later, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were about to enter a busy new year.



Note:

Footnotes

1. love affair

Chapter 131: Oh Mom, Bun!

131 – Oh Mom, Bun!

After returning from Qingtian Prefecture, Qin Mian asked his servants to find out where to buy a large number of grape seedlings. Uncle Fu brought back the news that a household owned a small vineyard in Lin County. Lei Tie took four people to Lin County to negotiate with them. By the time the weather turned nice and warm, the grape seedlings could be transported back.

The work in the first few days when Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant resumed business was loaded in trivial details. Qin Mian oversaw Double Xiang House and also had people to clean up the shop he instructed Manager Sun to buy last year – it would open in a few days. When the shop owners in the town saw the “Glimmer of Paradise” trademark hung on the shop, they knew that this shop’s owner was the same owner of Double Xiang House. However, they knew nothing about what business it ran.

After a busy month passed by, it was Lei Yaqing’s one-month-old birthday. Lei Tie only had people prepare an ordinary gift to send; he and Qin Mian did not attend.

Although there were two old ladies in Lei Daqiang’s household, Du Shi had more seniority than Wei Shi. Moreover, her relatives were more than Wei Shi. Usually, whatever kind of happy occasion Lei Daqiang’s family did, the money and gifts were basically received through Du Shi’s grasp. One could imagine how resentful Du Shi was when she did not receive Lei Tie’s gift money for Lei Yaqing’s one-month-old birthday banquet.

Lei Daqiang was a little disappointed when Wei Shi gave birth to a daughter instead of a son. Du Shi thought that Lei Daqiang's heart would turn to her immediately. Unexpectedly, Wei Shi's means were powerful. In a month, Lei Daqiang had spent the night in Wei Shi's room for at least 20 days. Moreover, he also treated the little girl well.

Meanwhile, Lei Xiangli began to work on the housing issue. He would move out of the old house after the house was built. For Du Shi, it meant that this son would also be out of her control.

A few unsatisfactory things happened together. Du Shi's heart was holding back a fire; it was unknown when the flame would burst.

The residents of Leisurely Farmhouse were busy in a strained and orderly way. Uncle Quan and several servants drove the oxen to plow the farmland, while also leveled the soil for the vineyard in advance, and applied decomposed farmyard fertilizer, which was divided into two layers of fertilizer with soil and fertilizer mixture.

In the first ten days of the third lunar month, the weather turned warm again after a cold spell.

Qin Mian told Lei-Qin Shun and Lei-Qin Cheng to buy two peach trees, two pear trees, two plum trees, two cherry trees, two pomegranate trees, and two sweet orange trees to plant in Double Xiang House. In the future, the Silver, Gold, and Diamond Members who came to Double Xiang House could have another pleasure: they could personally pick fruits to eat, freely, however many they wanted to but not allowed to waste or take home.

Lei Tie took people to Lin County to transport back a large number of grape seedlings. The grape seedlings were transported back by fast carriage and planted in rows of fences. Qin Mian had already said that the vineyard was to be handed over to Uncle Quan. Uncle Quan was very dedicated and personally participated in every step of grape planting. Qin Mian and Uncle Quan were inexperienced. They went to the county to buy two servants, who knew how to do business, as Uncle Quan's helpers.

Uncle Fu and Lei-Qin Le had also taken over the winery and vermicelli workshop respectively. The unmarried Lei-Qin Le immediately became hot in Green Mountain Village.

Yes, he was a slave, but he was also a manager. He was very much promising. As long as he had money, he might be able to get rid of his slavery status in the future. Besides, the rural people's requirements for life were not high. As long as they could eat and wear warm clothes, they would be very satisfied. Moreover, it was heard that Qin Mian and Lei Tie said that the servants would be allocated a separate set of servant house when they got married. Given these points, many parents in Green Mountain Village began to seek Aunt Fu and even sent gifts to Aunt Fu, hoping that she could say many good words about their daughters in front of Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Aunt Fu didn't accept the gifts. Lei-Qin Le was a sweet-mouthed and decent person. He came to Leisurely Farmhouse at the same time as she and Uncle Fu. Therefore, Aunt Fu regarded Lei-Qin Le as her nephew. She was very devoted to Lei-Qin Le's personal affairs. After inquiring about the characters of a few girls and asking for Lei-Qin Le's opinions, the person selected as Lei-Qin Le's wife was Xiao-Xu from the same village.

When Aunt Fu reported the matter to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had no objection. After Xiao-Xiu signed the sale deed, they set the date for Lei-Qin Le and Xiao-Xiu to get married.

As long as the servants were loyal and dedicated, Qin Mian did not mean to treat them harshly. He prepared betrothal gifts for Lei-Qin Le: betrothal money, 2 silver taels, betrothal cake, 8 jin; betrothal wine, two jars; and betrothal rice, 2 ladles. The betrothal gifts worth about 5 silver taels, which was better than other people's betrothal gifts.

However, Lei-Qin Le was a servant after all. It was not good to do a big wedding. In a few days, all six etiquettes were done and they were married ten days later. Lei-Qin Le's guests were Uncle Fu, Uncle Quan, and Lei-Qin Zhong's group; there were also not many relatives on Xiao-Xiu's side. No one from the village was invited to the wedding reception.

Xiao-Xiu married Lei-Qin Le and became “Lei-Qin Le’s wife”. She usually helped Aunt Fu and Aunt Quan doing Leisurely Farmhouse’s miscellaneous works.

When the matter at home was brought to a temporary close, Qin Mian and Lei Tie rushed to the town.

The reason why they were in such a hurry was that the two pink balls in the space had become more and more active recently, and they both had a vague sense that they were expected to bloom in the coming days. Once they made proper arrangements in the town, the two men would wholeheartedly stay at home and wait quietly.

After making rounds in Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant, they came to the new shop. The shop was decorated very meticulously; it was neat and simple yet elegant. Into the door, there were wind chimes above the head. The jingling sound of the chimes was crisp and beautiful. The shop was not big, about twice size as that of Eating Savory Restaurant, and divided into two parts by a wooden wall. Near the door were two sets of tables and chairs fixed on the floor. Inward was a chest-high counter with a square board hanging above it. Behind the counter were three custom-made shelves, all of which were three layers. The kitchen was behind the wooden wall.

“Wife, what is the new shop going to do?” asked Lei Tie.

Qin Mian said, “Sell pastries and drinks. Aunt Fu, Aunt Quan, and Lei-Qin Le’s wife are not smart but work earnestly and attentively, and also very diligent. Just doing laundry and weeding at home is not worthy of their talents. So, let the three of them make pastries and drinks at home, and transport them to the shop to sell.”

Naturally, it was on the premise that Qin Mian had to teach Aunt Fu and the other two women first. Lei Tie put his arm around his wife’s shoulders. “The money earned won’t be finished. I don’t want you to work too hard.”

“Rest assured.” Qin Mian leaned on him. “As for this shop, my main purpose isn’t to make a lot of money but to occupy a position in Running

Water Town first. Can't let this shop be empty."

Seeing the tiredness on his face, Lei Tie was worried, "For months in a row, your vital spirit's refining speed is extremely slow. If I'm not wrong, it should be related to the pink balls. Wife, we'd better go back first. In case there is a change, it's more convenient to do things at home."

Qin Mian nodded, "Actually, I also have such a guess. The space and I are one, and the pink balls are in the space. I'm afraid that most of the spiritual Qi I absorb is absorbed by the pink balls." He had a premonition that these two flowers were not ordinary.

Thinking of this, he was somewhat too impatient to wait, "We'll go back now."

The two simply put things in order and galloped on horseback to Green Mountain Village.

With hands akimbo, Du Shi stood in the middle of the only road into the village. It was obvious that she was here to wait for them. It was half a li¹ from the village's entrance.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie reined in the horses in time.

Qin Mian didn't dismount the horse. He looked at Du Shi and frowned. He didn't know what kind of lousy idea would she come out with again.

"Eldest, it's not easy for Mother to meet you." Du Shi turned a blind eye to Qin Mian. She looked at Lei Tie with loving eyes and gently said, "Come home with me first. Your father and I have something to tell you."

Lei Tie's mood did not fluctuate at all as he dully said, "Du Shi, just speak directly."

When Qin Mian saw Du Shi's eyes turning disorderly, he knew that there was something wrong with her. "Old lady, if you have anything to say, just say it. We still have a lot of things to do."

Du Shi coldly stared at him with a disgusted look and swung her arms hard as if sending away a beggar. “Qin Mian, it’s none of your business here. Go away.”

Lei Tie shook the reins and the black horse moved with all its hooves, “Wife, let’s go.”

Du Shi was in a great hurry and quickly blocked their way.

“Wait! In that case, I’ll say it straight.” With a righteous expression, Du Shi said, “Eldest, there are three cardinal offenses against filial piety, and having no male heir is the gravest of the three. No matter how good Qin Shi is, he can’t give you children. So, your father and I decided to give you a concubine—”

“What are you saying?!” Qin Mian was stunned. All of a sudden, there was a burst of sharp pain in the pit of his stomach. He grunted and reached out a hand to cover his mouth.

“Wife!” Lei Tie jumped onto his wife’s horse and embraced him. Suddenly, he turned his head and stared fixedly at Du Shi. His cold and piercing eyes seemed to be looking at a dead person.

As though she fell into an icehouse, Du Shi’s whole body was cold and unable to move a step.

Lei Tie swung his left palm.

Du Shi was hit hard by an invisible force and fell heavily to the ground with a sharp pain in her chest. She looked at Lei Tie in horror. She opened her mouth to speak, but found that she could not make a sound!

The brown horse leaped over Du Shi’s body and galloped to Leisurely Farmhouse at full speed.

“Wife, how are you doing?” Lei Tie looked down at the person in his arms, endlessly worried.

At this time, the spiritual Qi in Qin Mian's body fluctuated rapidly, and he realized that there was a change in the space. The two pink balls seemed to communicate with him; they were anxiously calling him.

“Quick, get into the space!”

Lei Tie couldn't wait to return to Leisurely Farmhouse; he directly created an illusion with his vital spirit to prevent people from peeping in the distance and disappeared with Qin Mian on the spot.

When the two men appeared in the space, they nearly fell to the ground by the fluctuation of spiritual Qi in the space. They raised their heads and were surprised to see the boundless spiritual Qi, like a small-scale tornado discharged from the quadrangle courtyard, congested in the space.

“Pink balls!” cried Qin Mian in alarm.

Lei Tie embraced him and appeared in front of the flower bed in the quadrangle courtyard. Within the rippling spiritual Qi, the petals of two pink balls gradually unfolded. The spiritual Qi leaped on the petals and seemed to emit silver radiance.

The pink petals that were bigger than the lotus leaves, unfolded piece by piece. Qin Mian did not even dare to breathe heavily. Lei Tie was not much better than him. He clenched his fists without being aware of it and locked his gaze on the pink balls.

As more and more petals unfolded, they felt the joy from the pink balls. They looked at each other in surprise, and their gazes fell back on the pink balls.

About an hour later, the pink ball on the left side was the first to unfold the last two petals. At the same time, a burst of baby's cries sounded. On the center of the flower, lay a naked baby!

Qin Mian rubbed his eyes in disbelief; the baby was still that baby. Instantly, he had mixed feelings of surprise and joy, “Oh mom, bun!”

Nearly before the sound of his voice had died away, the other flower also completely bloomed. An identical baby, with its eyes closed and legs kicked out, cried very loudly.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie hadn't had the time to make a reaction when there was a sudden change in the space. The surging spiritual Qi born out of thin air turned the space like the sea surface encountered strong wind turbulence.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were in confusion before they fainted.



Note:

Footnotes

1. (memory refresh) One li is approx. 500 m.

Chapter 132: Twin Sons

132 – Twin Sons

It was unknown how much time had passed when Qin Mian slowly regained consciousness and sat up with his head in his arms. He was a little dizzy after receiving more information about the space.

It turned out that the original owner of the ring was an artificer. This ring was made by him. The magical space in the ring was far more than a mobile warehouse, a mobile manor, and a “nourishing decoction”. After dripping blood onto the ring to establish ownership, the space only had these common functions. When the owner of the space had an offspring, the space would upgrade and truly recognize its owner. The person that the artificer loved was also a man – an alchemist. For the sake of having a joint love crystallization, the alchemist worked hard for many years to cultivate a “Union Flower” that could give birth to their offspring. From the moment when Qin Mian and Lei Tie bound their heartstrings together, the Union Flower was able to receive their joint bloodline and truly began to grow. As for why it fell into the hands of “White Spot” in the end, it was unknown.

The former space had very weak spiritual Qi; cultivating in the space could not even compare with cultivating in the deep mountains. But now, the whole space was full of spiritual Qi. Not only that, but the quadrangle courtyard also changed from one section to three sections, and the hidden pill pharmacy, spiritual instrument room, and spiritual grass garden were all revealed. Moreover, the boundless spiritual Qi promoted the cultivation of Qin Mian and Lei Tie to a higher level.

Hearing the cry of a baby, Qin Mian thought of two children and quickly got up from the ground. Lei Tie also woke up at this time.

They flew and landed in front of the flower bed, and looked at the two giant flowers.

As before, the two babies lay on the center of the flowers with their little arms waving and little legs pedaling. Their small mouths pouted as they cried very loudly; their glistening tears rolled down like pearls, causing people's heart to soften.

Both men subconsciously reached out to hold them.

Qin Mian suddenly thought of one thing and stopped Lei Tie in time, "A-Tie, we have to wash our hands first. I'll get the clothes."

He quickly took two bath towels made of pure cotton. It was so soft and very suitable for swaddling clothes.

Seeing him return, Lei Tie said in a rare impatient tone, "Wife, quickly look. They look like us."

Qin Mian's heart jolted, "Really? Wait a bit, I'll wrap them with bath towels first to avoid catching a cold."

He moved the baby to the side and spread the towel on the center. Then, he picked up the baby and put it on the towel. After wrapping the baby, he put an arm under the baby's neck while the other arm held the baby's small butt and gently held the baby up. Strangely, as soon as he held the baby, the baby stopped crying and looked at him with big black eyes opened wide.

Qin Mian carefully looked at the baby's facial features and inwardly expressed his surprise. The little guy was not like the common yellow monkey-like newborn baby. Instead, he was fair and delicate, like carved pink jade. The little guy's forehead, eyebrows, and eyes resembled Lei Tie, while his nose, mouth, and chin resembled him (QM). On the baby's left shoulder was a dark red birthmark the size of a fingernail and in the shape of a five-petaled flower.

"Hehe, they truly look like us!" Qin Mian was overjoyed, "So cute!"

He couldn't help but kiss the baby on the forehead. Another little baby's cry suddenly turned loud. He turned his head and looked over. That stupid Lei Tie had his hands under the baby's armpit and held the baby in the air. The baby's bones were very soft and the neck was not strong, so the head involuntarily drooped. Of course, he would cry bitterly.

"Wife..." Lei Tie awkwardly turned to him for help.

Qin Mian was both amused and helpless. He quickly said, "Put him down first."

Lei Tie obediently put the baby back on the center.

Qin Mian said, "Imitate the way I carry him horizontally."

Lei Tie very cautiously took the baby from his (QM) arms.

The baby was transferred to another person's arms; his mouth quirked as he curiously looked at Lei Tie.

Qin Mian wrapped the other baby in a towel and held him up. The little baby immediately stopped crying. His big eyes like black grapes stared at Qin Mian and the corners of his mouth slightly tilted as if he was smiling.

Qin Mian remembered that this was the younger brother. After careful examination, he discovered that the only difference between the two brothers was that the birthmark of the older brother was on the left shoulder, while the younger brother's birthmark was on the right shoulder.

Lei Tie went to Qin Mian, put an arm around him, and printed a kiss on his lips. His voice sounded hoarse, "Wife, thank you!" How lucky he was to have such a caring lover, and now he had such a pair of children. This intense happiness was like a steal. He was happy, but at the same time, he felt a little uneasy on the bottom of his heart; he was worried about gains and losses.

Qin Mian's cheeks felt hot. He covered up his embarrassment with a loud voice, "What are you thanking me for?! Saying as though the children are..."

born by me!”

“Haha...” Joyous and magnetic laughter rolled out of Lei Tie’s throat. He raised the corners of his lips in a gentle smile and seriously said, “Wife, they are our sons.”

Qin Mian nodded without hesitation, “Of course!” He was no less excited than Lei Tie. He had never regretted being with Lei Tie, but that didn’t mean his heart was not rueful. Being with Lei Tie meant that they could not have their own children. Unexpectedly, the space made up for his rue. Not only did it send him a child, but even two children!

The two children were born in the care of him and Lei Tie for nearly ten months, just the same as being born by them.

The brothers coincidentally burst into tears, probably hungry.

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian, at a loss of what to do.

Qin Mian was quick to think, “Look after them. I’ll milk the cow.”

The two huge blooming flowers turned into two natural cribs. He put the baby in his arms back on the center of the flower. Seeing that there was no one outside the space, he flashed out and went home to squeeze a bowl of milk in secret.

With milk and no feeding bottles, the two new fathers had to feed them with little spoons. Owing to being inexperienced, only a little of the spoonful of milk went into the brothers’ mouths and most of it spilled on their faces. Alas, the brothers were unusually well-behaved; they didn’t cry or make a fuss but smacked their lips to suck the milk.

The more Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at the children, the more they liked the children.

After drinking milk to the last drop, the two little guys fell asleep. The four little hands unconsciously clenched into small fists. So adorable.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood by for a long time with feelings of excitement and novelty. From now on, they were people who had sons!

Qin Mian first regained his senses, “A-Tie, do we have to hire two wet nurses?”

Lei Tie was silent for a long time before he said, “Wife, I don’t want outsiders to live in our house.”

Qin Mian scratched his head. To be honest, he didn’t want to either. However, the children had to drink milk. If it was not breast milk, cow’s milk would do. The only problem was that there was no feeding bottle; they couldn’t always be spoon-fed.

At the thought of the large number of materials he had collected in response to the legendary apocalypse, he left the word “wait” and ran away. He searched through many rooms. When he prepared the materials in his previous life, he had entrusted the manager of a shopping mall to help him purchase daily necessities because he had to buy too many things. In the beginning, he thought he was going to have a girlfriend, so he stressed it to the manager to prepare some necessary maternal and infant products. There must be feeding bottles, even milk powder among these products.

Sure enough, after searching for nearly two hours, Qin Mian found six feeding bottles that were not only still well wrapped in the packaging bags, but also stainless steel.

The feeding bottle problem had been solved. What needed to be solved next was the origin of the two babies, as well as the baby crib, clothing, and other articles of daily use.

After discussing with Lei Tie, Qin Mian decided to go to the county to buy some high-quality baby clothes, diapers, and soft fabrics. As for the identity of the babies, the two decided that no matter what other people asked, they just said that the children were their own. The two babies looked so much like them. Who dared to say that the children were not their own? If people asked who and where the children’s mother was, they couldn’t evade from answering others.

The two men came out of the space and left for Zhaoyang County. Qin Mian could see the situation in the space from outside, so there was nothing to worry about leaving the two sleeping babies in the space for the time being.

Only after dark did the two men rush back to the village. Carrying two swaddling clothes, they knocked on the gate of Leisurely Farmhouse.

Uncle Fu opened the gate with a lantern in hand. "Eldest Young Master and Little Young Master, you two are back."

He was greatly surprised to see the babies in their arms. "These are?"

Qin Mian opened a corner of the swaddling clothes, deliberately let him look at the child's face, "Mine and your Eldest Young Master's sons."

Lei Tie also lifted the swaddling clothes to show the little guy's sleeping face. For fear that the child was exposed to the wind, he quickly secured the swaddling clothes.

As soon as Uncle Fu looked at the two children's faces, he did not doubt it. He was so emotional and did not mention the topic related to the children's mother. "Wonderful, Little Young Master—Right, we have two little young masters, so we can't address the two masters as 'Eldest Young Master' and 'Little Young Master' from now on. We should address you two as 'Eldest Old Master' and 'Little Old Master'."

Qin Mian had black lines on his head. He and Lei Tie were still so young, must they be called 'Old Master'?

"We came back in a hurry today. Tomorrow, you send people to buy the best crib in the town."

"Yes." Uncle Fu asked, "Wet nurse..."

Lei Tie said in a low voice, "The children drink cow's milk."

Uncle Fu wanted to say that cow's milk was no better than breast milk, but he also understood the master's character, so he didn't say much. He just

showed a worried look in his eyes. He decided to have Aunt Fu go to ask Aunt Quan when he went back. Aunt Quan should know more about this since she had once given birth.

Qin Mian disagreed with it. The several cows at home were nourished by the spiritual spring water; the cow's milk was better than breast milk. Moreover, these two children had grown by the spiritual Qi's nourishment, and therefore, their physical quality was much better than ordinary babies.

Lei Tie instructed Uncle Fu, "Steward Fu, squeeze a bucket of clean milk and deliver it as soon as possible."

"Yes."

"Also," Qin Mian added, "the children's one-month-old birthday ceremony will be held in a month. Spread the news tomorrow."

"Yes." Uncle Fu was so excited that he forgot to call someone to light the way for Qin Mian and Lei Tie and ran away with the lantern.

Fortunately, the darkness had little effect on Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Besides, from the big gate to the bridge until the hedge gate, there were lantern posts every two *zhang*¹, brightly lit.

Back at home, the two fathers gently put the two children on the heatable-brick bed and covered them with quilts. Lei Tie washed the two feeding bottles with boiling water. After the milk was delivered, Qin Mian put half a bottle of milk in the two feeding bottles and kept the remaining milk in the space.

They spent the whole day bustled about and hadn't had dinner yet. Lei Tie looked after the two children, while Qin Mian went to cook two bowls of noodles in the kitchen.

After dinner, they had a rest with their two children. Qin Mian was worried that he would crush the children after he fell asleep. Therefore, he put the two children on the inside and Lei Tie next to them, while he was on the outside.²

In the middle of the night, the two children whimpered twice; the first time was because they were hungry, and the second time was because they urinated. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very surprised. They both felt that the two children were very easy to raise.

Thank you, Somebody and TucTuc!

Note:

Footnotes

1. (memory refresh) One zhang is 3.3m
2. The bed is beside the wall, so the inside here meant the position beside the wall and the outside meant the opposite.

Chapter 133: Formidable Lei Tie

133 – Formidable Lei Tie

In the master's room on the first floor of Leisurely Farmhouse's main house, the candles in the four corners were lit all night. At the first sound of the rooster's crow, Lei Tie woke up from his deep sleep. He turned his head to the side to look at Qin Mian, who had his mouth slightly open and snored. He was sleeping soundly with one arm hanging out.

Lei Tie gently moved sideways, carefully put his arm into the quilt, and gazed at his sleeping face for quite a while. Then, he lowered his head, opened his mouth, and covered those ruddy lips. The fast-asleep person was disturbed; he licked his lips and continued to snore loudly. The tip of Lei Tie's tongue took the opportunity to drill in, gently and soundlessly stirred in the other's mouth. Once he got the other party's subconscious response, he kissed more pliantly and deeper.

"Huu... A-Tie..." The youngster's face turned red from the stifling kiss and his breath was short as he vaguely mumbled.

Hearing his name, the gentleness in Lei Tie's eyes seemed to overflow like water. Fully satisfied, he let the youngster go, licked the water stains on the corner of his lips, and patted his back.

Qin Mian crooned twice in his sleep and went fast asleep.

Lei Tie looked back at the inner side of the bed. The two little ones were sleeping soundly, shoulder-to-shoulder and motionless.

Outside, the first glimmer of dawn made an appearance. He quietly dressed up and got out of bed. When he returned to the room after an hour of practice, the big one and the two small ones were still asleep.

Shortly after, Qin Mian's eyelids moved and his eyes opened in a daze. He saw the man sitting on the edge of the bed and staring at him. "A-Tie, I had a dream that we had two sons."

Lei Tie brushed away the hair on his cheek and motioned him to look at the bed.

Qin Mian turned his head to look over and immediately sobered up. *It's not a dream, they truly have two sons!*

It was unknown when the two little ones had woken up, but they didn't cry. Their two small hands grabbed on the small quilt to play with as they made the sound of babbles, quietly enjoying themselves.

The little one's face was chubby and looked soft. Qin Mian couldn't help but stretch out his hand and gently poked it.

"So soft."

Lei Tie half-leaned on Qin Mian. He also reached out his finger and poked on the baby's face.

Qin Mian looked up and saw at the gentleness in the man's eyes, he felt a little sour in his heart. *Will he still be the person this man most cares about, now that there are sons?*

Lei Tie sensed his absent-mindedness and bowed his head to look. The daze in his wife's eyes made his expression a bit silly and blank, which was rarely seen, as though his wife was hinting him to bully. His throat felt dry and tight. Complying to his heart, he pressed on Qin Mian and vehemently demanded kisses.

Qin Mian's inexplicable sadness suddenly disappeared. He put his arms around the man's neck and kissed back more fiercely than he did. The result was, they entangled for a long time before they separated. Qin Mian's lips swelled and Lei Tie's clothes were in a terrible mess by his pulling.

The man's fervent eyes were still on him. Qin Mian was feverish all over his body, while the electric-like feeling remained on his back. He quickly said, "The children are here!"

Lei Tie straightened up, slowly tidied up his clothes, and looked at two little ones.

"Wife, what are their names?"

"Uh..." Qin Mian hadn't think about it. He soon had an idea, "Character dictionary¹!"

He used to see some parents holding character dictionaries to give their children names in TV dramas. He thought it was funny. Today it was his and Lei Tie's turn. In a second, the character dictionary appeared in his hand. He kept this character dictionary when he was in senior high school, still very new.

As he turned over the pages, he asked Lei Tie, "Are the two children surnamed after me, or both of them with your surname, or one with your surname and the other with my surname?"

Lei Tie took a pillow to let him lean against it and pulled up the quilt on his body. After the birth of the children, Qin Mian's body no longer showed weakness or fatigue, nor was he afraid of the cold. It was determined that all the previous conditions were caused by the two children. However, he was used to taking care of Qin Mian; his movements were very smooth.

"Three-character names. The eldest takes your surname and the youngest takes mine. Put the same middle character will do."

Qin Mian added, "Not only the middle character has to be the same, but the third character had better be a word and expression. This way, others will know that they are brothers. "

"En." The expression in Lei Tie's eyes suddenly gloomed. He pecked on his wife's forehead, "Slowly think, I'm going out."

Qin Mian noticed that his mood was not right, “Where to go?”

“Don’t worry. Settling a long-overdue problem.”

Qin Mian thought of something and no longer asked. He cupped the man’s face and pecked him hard on the lips. “Go and come back early to eat.”

“Alright.”

When Lei Tie came out of the house, the sky was already bright.

He looked up at the clear sky and walked toward Leisurely Farmhouse’s entrance to go out.

The servants had already woken up. Before they started to work, they did the odd jobs in Leisurely Farmhouse, which comprised of sweeping the ground, feeding the chickens and pigs, and so on. The servants, who were sweeping the leaves, respectfully saluted Lei Tie and retreated to one side.

Out of Leisurely Farmhouse’s gate, Lei Tie walked toward the east of the village, neither hurry nor slow. People who were familiar with him could find out that his aura today was colder than in the past.

Old house.

When Du Shi got up in the morning, she discovered that she was still unable to speak. Furious, she knocked down the round stool in the room. After she strangely fell yesterday, she couldn’t make a sound. She believed that she couldn’t speak because she was frightened by Lei Tie’s terrible expression. Yet, a whole night had passed and she still couldn’t make a sound!

She grabbed Lei Daqiang’s shoulder in panic and shook him hard, “Un! Un! Un!”

Lei Daqiang, who was woken up by her, tightly frowned. He waved his hand and impatiently said, “What are you doing? It’d have been better to spend the night in Wei’er’s room.”

Angry and resentful, Du Shi grasped his head and motioned him to look at her, and then pointed to her mouth.

Lei Daqiang stared at her blankly for a good while before he uncertainly asked, “You want to say that you can’t speak?”

Du Shi repeatedly nodded, her eyes filled with profound fear and uneasiness. She yelled in her heart: *It’s the Eldest! It’s certainly the Eldest’s trick!*

However, she could neither speak nor write. She could only make all kinds of inexplicable gestures to Lei Daqiang, anxiously.

“How could this happen...” Lei Daqiang didn’t look at what she was gesturing at all. Although he thought it was strange, he didn’t take it seriously. “Did you catch a cold so that your throat is blocked? Don’t mind it, let Doctor Liu check you later.”

His uncaring attitude infuriated Du Shi. For the first time in her life, she glared at him with hatred. A few days ago, Zhao Sifa secretly came to find her and Lei Daqiang, suggesting that they could control Lei Tie and repel Qin Mian by giving Lei Tie a concubine, and recommended his maternal cousin. Lei Daqiang then thought it was a good idea and they agreed to this plan.

Du Shi was indignant. Lei Daqiang also had a share in dealing with Lei Tie, so why did she suffer alone! Why? She gave birth to a few children for this man and worked hard for half her lifetime, was this how the man repaid her?

She suddenly pounced on Lei Daqiang, beat, and scratched him as if her life depended on it.

Lei Daqiang was astounded for a moment and then quickly reacted. He dodged her hands, cutting in a sorry figure, and roared, “You have gone crazy!”

A man's strength was much greater than that of a woman. With a push from his hands, he threw Du Shi down on the bed and quickly got out of bed. He gloomily stared at the tearful Du Shi and said in disgust, "What madness, first thing in the morning!"

With that, he flung his sleeve as he left and turned into Wei Shi's room.

Wei Shi was leaning on the head of the bed, breast-feeding the baby girl. Upon seeing Lei Daqiang entering, she blushed and hurriedly broke off his gaze with a quilt.

"Husband, are you...alright?"

Lei Daqiang touched his scratched face and went to embrace her shoulder. After Wei Shi gave birth to the child, she became even more charming. The more he looked at her, the more he was fond of her.

"Who knows what madness she had! Making trouble out of nothing!"

Wei Shi smiled as she leaned on his shoulder, not saying anything. Without her doing anything, Lei Daqiang was disgusted with Du Shi, and that was what she would like to hear and see.

The maid Xiao-Xi made breakfast and brought the meal to the table.

Du Shi appeared with swollen eyes. It was unknown what she was thinking as her gloomy eyes glowed with cold light.

Before the few people had yet lifted their rice bowls, a tall figure appeared at the gate of the courtyard and walked into the house at an appropriate speed.

Upon seeing the visitor, Du Shi immediately got up, and maliciously rushed over. Her throat made sounds of "aah".

As soon as Lei Tie waved his hand, Du Shi fell to the ground.

With obstinacy, Du Shi stood up and ran to Lei Daqiang. She pulled his arm and pointed to Lei Tie. Her mouth kept making "aah", while anger and

hatred intertwined in her eyes.

Lei Daqiang, Wei Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao were all confused by the scene playing in front of them.

Lei Daqiang was the first to react. He didn't dare to believe it. "You mean that you can't speak because of... Eldest's doing?"

Wei Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao all looked at Du Shi in shock. *Can't speak?*

Du Shi glared at Lei Tie in indignant resentment as she repeatedly nodded.

The bewildered eyes of Wei Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao fell on Lei Tie at the same time.

"Eldest Brother, what's going on?" Lei Xiangli was at a loss. However, in his heart, he believed that Lei Tie would not attack Du Shi for no reason. Therefore, his tone was still respectful toward Lei Tie.

Yesterday, it was Du Shi's words that stimulated Qin Mian to have a sharp pain and his spiritual Qi fluctuated, which eventually led to the birth of the two babies a few days ahead of schedule. Fortunately, Qin Mian was not injured. But when he thought of the possibility of Qin Mian getting injured, Lei Tie couldn't wait to kill Du Shi. He didn't answer Lei Xiangli's words. His expression was frozen as his indifferent eyes slowly swept over Lei Daqiang and Du Shi's faces, "Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, what have you two done is clear in your mind. Today, I'm here to tell you that if you meddle in my affairs later, I will let you understand that there is something more painful than death in this world."

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi were greatly astonished.

In the central room, a perfect silence prevailed for a moment; the low pressure was suffocating.

After a good while, Lei Daqiang found his voice, but he was trembling so much that he could hardly say a complete sentence, "You... You... Do you

even dare... even dare to kill your parents?"

Lei Tie stared at him without expression. His voice was hardly indifferent, but rather very dull, and yet his eyes seemed as though they could swallow people, "You can try."

Lei Daqiang was stupefied and his legs weakened. He staggered for a moment and nearly fainted, but Wei Shi supported him in time.

Wei Shi's voice was calm and peaceful, "Eldest, don't worry. From now on, your father will never go to find trouble with your family again."

Lei Daqiang opened his mouth wide but not a word came out.

Lei Tie lightly looked at her, "Later, if your daughter is in trouble, we'll help her once."

Wei Shi greatly rejoiced. Lei Tie was a capable person, his commitment was more precious than thousands of wealth. She gave a wee smile. "Qingqing is a lucky one."

Lei Tie turned to leave. The view of his back looked silent yet dangerous.

Du Shi frantically hit Lei Daqiang with her fists and indignantly pointed to the direction of Lei Tie's leaving while she kept calling out.

"Ah! Ah!"

Lei Daqiang looked hesitant.

Wei Shi's pretty face turned to gloom, exasperated at Lei Daqiang. "Husband, you still don't understand? Lei Tie is not a person you can control. If you offend Lei Tie, he may be able to let us go, but he will never leave the matter at that if you offend his wife. His wife is his reverse scale²! Do you have to destroy our family to be satisfied?"

Note:

Footnotes

1. Chinese character dictionary 字典 containing entries for single characters, contrasted with a 词典, which has entries for words of one or more characters.
2. Just remember Hulk. You make Dr. Banner angry, Hulk will come out.

Chapter 134: Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin

134 – Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin

Once Lei Daqiang thought of the humiliation of being threatened by Lei Tie just now and that he might fall into the same situation as becoming mute like Du Shi, he turned around, slapped Du Shi's face, and hatefully said, "It's all this woman's faults!"

Du Shi was slapped to the ground and her cheek swelled in an instant.

"Mother!" exclaimed Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao before they hastily ran over to help Du Shi.

"Father, what on earth have you two done to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law?" asked Lei Xiangli with a frown.

Lei Daqiang stammered, "Zhao Sifa told me and your mother that as long as we gave a concubine to your eldest brother, then... I was thinking that after his concubine gave birth to a son, so long as we hold on to the child, their family's property... It wasn't for myself..."

When Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao looked at him with disappointed eyes, he couldn't continue to speak.

"Mother, Fourth Brother and I will help you into the room first," said Lei Chuntao to Du Shi in a soft voice.

Du Shi covered her face as she nodded, not looking a glance at Lei Daqiang; she had a vacant expression.

The mother and her children entered the room. Du Shi leaned on the bed, closed her eyes, and was silent as the grave.

Although Du Shi had many faults, she was the mother of Lei Chuntao and Lei Xiangli after all. Seeing her like this, the brother and sister felt upset. Yet, they didn't have that thick of a face to go look for Lei Tie and plead.

"Mother, I'll go and invite Doctor Liu to check on you," said Lei Xiangli.

.....

After Lei Tie entered the house, he withdrew his cold aura and entered the bedroom.

"You're back." Qin Mian was properly dressed and leaning against the heatable-brick bed. Once he scrutinized the man's expression was the same, he put down his worry. He beckoned the man and handed him the notebook. "I think these characters aren't bad, but they aren't good enough. You look at it."

Written on the notebook were: Shu, Rui, Shi, Xuan, Xi, Yu.¹

Lei Tie also thought that they were not good enough.

"It's hard to think of a good name." Qin Mian frowned and gave him the dictionary. "Now it's your turn to look for it."

Lei Tie honestly said, "I don't recognize..."

Qin Mian laughed with a puff. Although the characters in the dictionary were annotated in Traditional Chinese, they were mostly simplified characters; it would be really hard for Lei Tie to read. He was trying to embarrass Lei Tie. That dejected expression of his was very amusing.

The two babies started to whimper.

Lei Tie immediately stood up. "I'll warm the milk."

That somewhat defeated and fleeing figure made Qin Mian unable to contain his laughter. He shook his head and continued to look at the dictionary. Suddenly, a miraculous light sparked² and he thought of “Qilin”. Qilin³ was an auspicious beast. Not only was it meant auspicious, but the two characters were also very similar. Wasn’t it appropriate to use it for the last word of a baby’s name?

As for the character in the middle – a good man should be able to hold up the sky and support the earth⁴, formidable, and domineering, so the middle character could be ‘Rui⁵’. ‘Rui’ could be equivalent for ‘sharp’, ‘advance bravely momentum’, and ‘excellent’.

He wrote “Qin Ruiqi” and “Lei Ruilin” on the paper.

“Good names.” A warm breath gently exhaled and blew into his cochlea. Lei Tie, who knew when he came back, just happened to see the characters on the paper.

Qin Mian covered his ear and suspected that the man did it on purpose. He patted him hard on the shoulder, “The sons’ childhood names are left to you.”

Lei Tie held a bottle in each hand and was about to feed the two babies but paused for a moment. “Wife, I won’t.”

“No matter, you have to.” Qin Mian gently kissed the two little ones on their faces. Lastly, he gave Lei Tie a hard bite on his face to encourage him. He snickered and then intentionally sighed, “Sons, your dad I, have given you very powerful names. If you don’t think your childhood name sounds good after you have grown up, blame your ‘Old Dad’!”⁶

Lei Tie touched his face. He was eight years older than his wife, but he didn’t need to add the word “old”, right?

Qin Mian snickered.

Lei Tie had a wonderful view of his small act and gently shook his head. He deeply pondered for a moment and said, “Call them Yuanyuan and

Manman.”⁷

“Not bad.” Qin Mian gave him a look of appreciation. He was ready to go out to make breakfast but looked back, “You will be fine taking care of them alone?”

Lei Tie nodded, “Don’t worry.”

Qin Mian had nothing to worry about. Last night, when the two children were hungry and urinated, Lei Tie took care of them. He woke up a step too late and only guided on the side. Lei Tie’s movements might be unskilled and even very clumsy, but the most important thing was that he was careful enough – his movements were very light, afraid of hurting the two little babies. Therefore, the two children were still cared for very well.

After Qin Mian went to the kitchen to cook the rice, he walked back to the bedroom and took a look. The two babies had finished their milk and fell asleep again.

At the dining table, he asked Lei Tie what he did when he went out in the morning.

Once they finished breakfast, the couple held an “Infant Care Guidance” book found in the space to study. Uncle Fu led all the servants in the family to pay respects.

The two men carried both children out.

They all knelt and called out, “Paying respects to Eldest Old Master, Little Old Master, Eldest Young Master, and Little Young Master!”

“Rise,” said Lei Tie.

“Many thanks, Eldest Old Master!”

Hearing the new address, Qin Mian still felt uncomfortable. “Well, remove the word ‘old’ and just call us ‘Eldest Master’ and ‘Little Master.’”

Everyone answered yes in unison and looked at the little masters in the arms of the two masters with eager eyes.

Qin Mian ordered, “Aunt Fu and Aunt Quan, you two hold the children and let everyone see.”

“Yes.”

Aunt Quan had borne a baby; she took Manman from his arms very skillfully. Although Aunt Fu never had a baby, she had taken care of children before; she held Yuanyuan safely and firmly.

Seeing the appearance of the two babies, the two women silently expressed their surprise and were full of love for the babies.

After the rest of the servants saw them respectively, they were all happy for the two masters and congratulated in unison, “Congratulations to Eldest Master and Little Master on the children’s birth!”

“En,” Qin Mian forthrightly said, “Steward Fu, all servants are rewarded with 100 Wen.”

“Yes.”

Everyone greatly rejoiced. “Many thanks, Little Master and Eldest Master!”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie held the children back.

Aunt Fu came forward with several clothes in her hands. “Reporting, Eldest Master and Little Master. These are a few small clothes made by this old woman, Aunt Quan, and Lei-Qin Le’s wife last night. Hope masters like them.”

Qin Mian accepted the clothes and said with a smile, “You all are considerate. All three of you have good needlework. I have some cloth and clothing designs here. You take them away and make more clothes for the two babies.”

“Yes.”

Uncle Fu waited for them to finish before he reported, “Eldest Master and Little Master, your bondservant I have sent people to buy the crib in the town. They’ll be back in two to three quarters⁸. Also, the good news of the two young masters has been released.”

“Great, you all can leave.”

Not long after, the servant came to report that Lei Xiangren, Zhao Shi, Lei Xiangyi, Qian Shi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Chuntao had come.

As soon as he entered the house, Lei Xiangyi couldn’t hold back and asked, “Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, how did you two suddenly have two sons?”

These words were very impolite. Qin Mian knew that he was just curious and bore no malice, so he didn’t mind it. He led them to his and Lei Tie’s bedroom.

“How did you end up coming together? The children are still sleeping. Go in and have a look.”

Upon seeing the facial features of Yuanyuan and Manman, these few people were surprised.

“Where is the children’s mother?” asked Zhao Shi at once.

Lei Tie coldly glanced at her and Zhao Shi immediately shut up. Just now, she and Lei Xiangren had been to the old house and already knew about the birth news released this morning. However, she was truly curious as to why the two children looked like Lei Tie and Qin Mian? They couldn’t be Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s own. With Du Shi set as an example there, she did not dare to speak again.

Meanwhile, Lei Xiangren didn’t think that much. He pursued the matter, “Who is the children’s mother? Since the two children look exactly alike, it must be the same mother. But why do they look like Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law?”

“It doesn’t concern you,” warned Lei Tie.

Zhao Shi pulled Lei Xiangren’s arm. Lei Xiangren shut up in resentment and looked around; his greedy appearance was loathsome.

If he and Zhao Shi did not come with the others, Qin Mian would not let them in at all.

“Everyone, please sit outside.”

Aunt Quan served tea and retreated to one side.

Lei Xiangyi and Qian Shi told Qin Mian and Lei Tie their experiences in taking care of children.

Lei Xiangli and Lei Chuntao had helped to take care of Lei Dabao, Lei Erbao, and Lei Xinxin. They also had experiences and often put in a few words. Neither of them mentioned what happened in the old house in the morning. Thus, Qin Mian had a little more favorable impression of them. In fact, it might not be a bad thing for her to be mute for a while. As long as she didn’t make trouble, who would have the spare time to deal with her?

Lei Xiangren could not sit still at the thought of not knowing how much richer the Lei Tie family was than his. He stood up and said, “You all can keep talking. My wife and I are going to stroll around outside.”

“Right, right.” Zhao Shi knew him best; her eyes brightened.

Lei Xiangli’s attitude was a little cold as he said, “Second Brother, we won’t sit anymore. You and Second Sister-in-law will leave with us.”

“Don’t want to sit down a little longer?” It was not easy for Lei Xiangren to come in. He didn’t want to leave like this.

At this time, Lei-Qin Shun, Lei-Qin Cheng, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Xin stepped forward with swift and fierce momentum. After saluting Qin Mian and Lei Tie, they discreetly flanked both sides of the door outside.

Lei Xiangren was frightened, “Then... Let’s go.”

As soon as Lei Xiangren and his party left, Lei-Qin Shun's group also saluted and asked for leave.

Before long, Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Li came over with the crib.

The crib was made of wood, with railings on all sides, and all the planks were polished smooth; there was also a holder on top to put up mosquito nets and hang toys.

Qin Mian was not very satisfied. He had Lei Tie renovate the crib. Small wooden wheels were added in the four corners below it to facilitate pushing. At the same time, the crib could be used as a cradle.

After the renovation, Qin Mian spread the small mattress on it. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin moved to their "new home".

Note:

Footnotes

1. Respectively: 书[book; letter; document], 瑞[lucky; auspicious; propitious], 世[life; age; generation; era; world; lifetime; epoch; descendant; noble], 轩[pavilion with a view; high; tall; high fronted, curtained carriage (old)], 熙[(used in names); (bound form) (literary) bright; prosperous; splendid; genial], 宇[room; universe]
2. It means he got an inspiration.
3. 麒麟 is a Chinese unicorn. If separated, the Qi is for the mythical male unicorn and Lin is the mythical female unicorn.
4. stand tall and fear nothing
5. 锐(acute)
6. In case you're wondering; 爹爹 [diē diē] for QM and 老爹 [lǎo diē] for LT. So, I have been translating 爹 [diē] as "father" for others. But I'm going to use "dad" for our main.
7. 圆圆 (round; tactful)| 满满 (full; contented)
8. A quarter of an hour, but since the hour used here is a 2-hour period, a quarter is 30 minutes.

Chapter 135: Arrival of the Maternal Grandparents

135 – Arrival of the Maternal Grandparents

Qin Mian suddenly felt that he had made a mistake. He should buy two cribs; one to put upstairs and one to put downstairs. Afterward, when he and Lei Tie moved upstairs, they didn't have to move the crib back and forth.

He called over Uncle Fu and ordered him to send someone to buy another crib some other day.

As for the baby stroller, he figured that there was no such thing in this era. Qin Mian decided to design a model and go to the woodcraft shop to have it custom made. However, Yuanyuan and Manman were still small, so they couldn't use the stroller for the time being. It was not too late to do it later.

The whole Green Mountain Village was boiling over the news that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had a pair of lovely twin sons. People were curious about what the two little babies looked like. However, since the children were not yet a month-old, it was not good to visit them. They could only bear to wait for the little ones' one-month-old ceremony.

Qin Mian also had people sent the news to Deng Village.

When the Deng family received the news, they were equally shocked. Early the next morning, the old man Deng and old lady Deng rushed to Green Mountain Village, terribly anxious.

Both the old man and old lady accepted the fact that their grandson and a man were together. As for offspring, their original intention was to have the

Lei family member or Deng family member to give a child for adoption to Lei Tie and Qin Mian, so that at least there was a continuation of blood relationship. Never had they expected to hear the news that Lei Tie and Qin Mian had children so soon. They speculated that the two children were adopted by Qin Mian and Lei Tie. In the eyes of the older generation, even if the adopted children were not related by blood, a wall stood between them after all.

During this trip, the two old people both had the thought of persuading Lei Tie.

However, when the two old people arrived at Lei Tie's house and saw the appearance of the two babies with their own eyes, they were astonished. The two children obviously resembled Lei Tie by half, and the other half resembled Qin Mian.

Nearly noon, while Qin Mian went to work in the kitchen, the old lady Deng approached Lei Tie's ear and whispered, "Tie-ger¹, tell Grandma honestly, is the mother of these two babies Mian-ger's older sister?"

This conjecture could really solve the doubt that the two children both resembled Lei Tie and Qin Mian. However, Lei Tie loved Qin Mian to the bottom of his heart; he did not want to let Qin Mian suffer a hint of injustice. Therefore, he never allowed himself to have a relationship with any unnecessary woman.

Without hesitation, he shook his head, "Grandma, the two children are my own, and also my wife's."

The old lady Deng's eyes opened wide, "Nonsense! Don't tell that you two adult men can even give birth to children?"

Lei Tie didn't explain again and said in a low voice, "Grandma, I won't lie."

"Uh..." The old lady Deng was so anxious that she slapped her thigh.

“All right.” It was the old man Deng who restrained her, “You, this old woman, really². No matter who the children’s mother is, as long as the children are Tie-ger’s own, won’t it be enough?”

The old lady Deng thought the same. It was truly her who split hair. Right now, Lei Tie already had offspring and a smooth life with Mian-ger; these were enough. Why dragged in one more person? Besides, that child Mian-ger was a sweet-talker, filial, and attentive. She liked him very much.

“Fine, fine, I won’t ask.” The old lady Deng smiled in relief, leaning on the side of the crib and cheerfully looking at the two babies.

The old man Deng sat on the settee while absorbed in thought. He knew his grandson, Tie-ger, was a person who disdained to lie. Then, White Spot came to his mind. One of the important reasons why he accepted Qin Mian so quickly when he first saw him was that he recognized White Spot was not a dog but rather a wolf. Wolf was considered an intelligent animal. Since it was willing to follow Qin Mian, it showed that there was no problem with Qin Mian’s character. To have such a person at his grandson’s side made him feel at ease. Later, he was sure that White Spot was a wolf king. There must be something if a generation of wolf king would willingly follow two human beings. Therefore, he could not help thinking that the two babies were not really motherless, but were born by Qin Mian and Lei Tie? At the thought, he shook his head again. Anyway, how could two men give birth to children?

He didn’t know that he actually guessed half the truth. After fathoming for a while, his mind was even more confused, and he simply stopped thinking about it. Anyhow, just so long the two babies were his great-grandsons, that would suffice.

He dusted his sleeves and went to the crib to tease the two little ones.

Qin Mian had cultivation. He didn’t mean to eavesdrop on the conversation outside, but neither did he deliberately block it. Therefore, he heard the two old people’s words crystal clear.

The old lady Deng's words truly made him feel uncomfortable, but Lei Tie's reply instantly cured him. He had a big arc in the corner of his lips and a joyous smiling look on his face. He just knew that he didn't misjudge the man.

When making lotus roots with spareribs soup, he added two drops of spiritual spring water into the soup, which could build up the health of the old man and the old lady.

He raised his voice and called out, "A-Tie, come in for a bit."

Lei Tie quickly came in, "Wife."

"We have a guest room at home now. Let's have Grandpa and Grandma stay for a few more days. And—" he reached Lei Tie's ear and whispered, "you can take time to dig the ginseng in the space. Give it to Grandpa and Grandma when they go back so that they can supplement their bodies better."

With that, he stole a kiss on the man's lips, and grinningly said, "That is a reward for you."

Reward? Lei Tie didn't understand. After a moment's thinking, he understood that his wife had heard his words. Lei Tie put his arms around his shoulder and kissed him back. Then, he sat down in front of the stove hearth to add firewood.

"Ginseng is too conspicuous, not proper [to give]."

Qin Mian pondered and then thought so. The ginseng in the space was a good thing. He didn't want to leave any trouble because of one carelessness.

"Then don't give it. There are many prescriptions 'inside'. When we have time, we can study it carefully and try to refine some pills that can nourish the body. And then, give them to the two old people."

He and Lei Tie did not have time to take a close look at the alchemy room, the refining workshop, and the spiritual grass garden in the space. The only

thing that was confirmed was that there were many good things inside. Any one of them might cause a sensation.

“Alright.”

Qin Mian stir-fried the spicy diced chicken in the wok, “Enough, don’t add firewood. Can serve the table.”

Lei Tie carried the cooked dishes out. The old lady Deng looked at the dishes, which were complete in all aspects, and secretly nodded. Mian-ger was a person who knew how to make a living. Perhaps, it was Tie-ger’s luck to be able to get together with him.

After six dishes were put on the table, Lei Tie still continued to serve.

The old lady Deng hastily came over and said, “It’s just the four of us, why cook so many dishes? Mian-ger, don’t be busy. Come out and take a rest.”

Qin Mian came out carrying a dish of braised tofu. “It’s rare for Grandma and Grandpa to come here. I make more dishes to make you two addicted to eating so that you two can accompany us for a few more days.”

When the old lady and old man Deng heard that, they both beamed with delight.

“You child, you don’t need to do so much for that.” The old lady Deng affectionately patted Qin Mian’s hand.

Qin Mian glanced at Lei Tie and teased, “It’s alright, Grandma. Don’t you know? A-Tie is a rice bucket³. Let him eat what we can’t finish.”

Lei Tie didn’t mind and nodded, “I’ll eat.”

The old man Deng and old lady Deng looked at each other with emotion. Perhaps, these two children were truly a couple who were made for each other.

There was a total of nine dishes of meat, vegetables, and soup; most of the dishes were soft, very suitable for the elderly to eat. Both old man and old

lady Deng were so pleased that they were even more fond of Qin Mian.

Lei Tie brought out a jar of wine from the kitchen.

The old lady Deng hastily said, “The old man is not in good health, so he can’t drink.”

Qin Mian explained, “Grandma, don’t worry. This wine is a medicinal wine, not strong. Not only can it resist aging, but also prolong life.”

The old man Deng was eager to have a try. “Then, I must have a few drinks.”

Lei Tie said, “My wife specially brewed it.”

“Grandma, if you are interested, you can have a drink. You won’t get drunk,” said Qin Mian with a smile.

The old lady Deng waved her hand in refusal and said, “I don’t like the taste, so I won’t drink it. You two drink with your grandpa.”

Qin Mian looked at Yuanyuan and Manman in the crib first. The two babies were playing by themselves.

Lei Tie, old man Deng, and old lady Deng waited for him to return before they started to eat.

The old man Deng took a sip of wine, and his eyes brightened, “Not bad! It’s mellow and not pungent. It’s suitable for people of our age to drink it.”

He was unable to hold himself back and took a big gulp.

Lei Tie accompanied him.

Qin Mian and the old lady Deng didn’t drink wine. From time to time, they gave Lei Tie and the old man Deng dishes, so that they would not just drink.

After the meal, the guests thoroughly enjoyed themselves.

In the afternoon, he fed the two babies with milk. After the babies fell asleep, Qin Mian asked Aunt Quan to come over and look after them. He and Lei Tie accompanied the old man Deng and old lady Deng in the garden.

The garden had changed a lot compared to last year.

Walking beside the vineyard, they talked about grapes. Qin Mian and Lei Tie then knew that the old man Deng had planted grapes before. With an open mind, they asked for advice, and it was quite worthwhile. Although the spiritual spring was very strong, one could not go wrong to learn more.

As the sun set in the west, the old man Deng proposed to leave. Qin Mian warmly asked the two old people to stay for a few more days and said that he would send a letter to Deng Village.

The two old people remembered that they would start farming in the fifth lunar month and there wouldn't have a chance to stay longer later, so they agreed.

The old lady told Qin Mian a lot of her experiences in taking care of children. Although some bits of knowledge conflicted with the modern concept of child-rearing, it was the old lady's good intention. Still, Qin Mian listened with earnest.

Lei Tie sat at the side with his scorching eyes staring at Qin Mian all the time.

Qin Mian tried to pretend that he wasn't aware and secretly glared at him with burning cheeks.

Lei Tie withdrew his gaze uneasily; his ears were red.

The old lady Deng noticed it out of the corner of her eyes and was utterly gratified.

"By the way, why don't I see White Spot?" asked old man Deng, leaning on the settee.

Qin Mian said, “It’s been several days since I last saw it. It’s probably on the mountain.”

He felt a little strange in his heart. This time, White Spot left for a long time. However, perhaps because of the indescribable fate between him and White Spot, he could feel that White Spot was safe. Golden Fur should be with it.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 哥儿 [gē r] brothers; address to boys. So basically, grandma called him Tie boy.
2. It’s an expression of annoyance/displeasure
3. It means good-for-nothing but in this context, it means having a “big stomach”

Chapter 136: Qian Shi Gives Birth

136 – Qian Shi Gives Birth

In the evening, the old man and old lady Deng lived in the guest room on the first floor. They originally wanted to help Qin Mian and Lei Tie take their children for the night, but they were declined. It was not good for the two old people to wake up at night since they were too old.

The old man and old lady Deng also knew that they were not young anymore and had no perseverance. This was also the children's show of filial piety.

After staying in Leisurely Farmhouse for three days, the old man and old lady Deng insisted on leaving and would come again for the babies' one-month-old ceremony.

Lei Tie and Qin Mian did not persuade them to stay, because two days later was the day Lei Xiangli got married. They prepared two jars of medicinal wine, two jars of Glimmer of Paradise Wine, and 20 jin of vermicelli for the two old people, and dispatched Lei-Qin Le to take them back to Deng Village by carriage.

In such a small village, the villagers knew about the old man and old lady Deng lived in Leisurely Farmhouse for a few days. Naturally, Lei Daqiang also got wind of this. At the thought that Lei Tie and Qin Mian were so kind to the Deng family and so bad to their own father, he was angry and jealous. However, when he thought of Du Shi's fate, he absolutely dared not to act rashly and blindly.

Du Shi had invited several doctors to check her throat. The doctors' diagnosis concluded that it was caused by shock and she possibly could

recover in two days, or she would never speak again. Moreover, Du Shi usually did too many bad things, her “words” might not be believable. Therefore, the Lei family members, including the several who had separated, did not associate Du Shi’s muteness with Lei Tie. Although, from the bottom of her heart, Du Shi thought that it was Lei Tie’s doing. Lei Daqiang didn’t think so. He was aware that Lei Tie knew martial arts, but he wouldn’t make Du Shi mute without causing trauma, right? Wasn’t that a Daoist Immortal?

The matter of Du Shi becoming mute was concluded without a conclusion.

Lei Xiangli’s wedding ceremony was held at the old house. Owing to Lei Xiangzhi’s status as a Xiucai, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang both were more anxious to keep up appearances than before. Therefore, this time, they were not too stingy for Lei Xiangli’s wedding. On top of that, Lei Xiangli had a lot of private money in his hand, so the wedding ceremony was very lively. As the joyous firecracker sounded approximately ten times, the joyous money¹ were also scattered three times. All the children in the village went *crazy* as they snatched a lot of copper coins.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie both attended the wedding banquet in person and conferred a 5 taels silver of money gift and congratulatory gifts worth about 5 silver taels. Compared with Lei Xiaoya’s washing-third ceremony and one-month-old ceremony, the villagers vaguely discovered: Qin Mian and Lei Tie wanted to keep a distance from Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi, and they still relatively cared about this brother, Lei Xiangli.

After the bride’s homecoming on the third day, Lei Xiangli and Sun Shi moved to their new home. Lei Xiangli’s new home was next door to Lei Xiangyi’s. It just so happened that the two brothers were partners.

When all was said and done, they couldn’t ignore their mother. Lei Xiangli and Lei Xiangyi discussed with each other and bought a maid named Xiao-Cui to take care of her especially.

It was unknown whether Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi wanted to keep up with others or something was going on, but they were two days behind them and also bought a teenage maid named Zhu’er. When Zhao Shi had

nothing to do, she took along Zhu'er to drop by or strolled around the village, as though she feared that others would not know that she had a maid.

Qin Mian somehow felt that Zhao Shi might shoot herself in the foot one day.

He had no time and interest in other people's affairs. After a few days of disappearance, White Spot and Golden Fur finally came back.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were surprised to find that there was vital Qi in White Spot's dantian. In other words, White Spot had become a demon cultivator. There were also some weak spiritual Qi in Golden Fur's body.

It was unknown whether these two had a happy encounter or something during the days of their departure. Although Qin Mian and White Spot could usually communicate with each other, White Spot couldn't speak after all; he couldn't ask it.

In the end, it was a good turn of event. Qin Mian decided to send White Spot and Golden Fur to the space for cultivation when there was a chance. The current space was full of spiritual Qi, more suitable for cultivation than the outside world.

White Spot and Golden Fur were strongly interested in Yuanyuan and Manman.

At first, Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't dare to leave them alone with Yuanyuan and Manman. Later, Qin Mian and Lei Tie discovered that these two animals were aware of their guarding against them and began to deliberately avoid Yuanyuan and Manman. The two men instead let go of their worry and observed for nearly ten days. They confirmed that White Spot and Golden Fur had no malice toward Yuanyuan and Manman. These two animals even looked at the two little ones with very gentle eyes. Therefore, the two men completely rest assured. Sometimes, when they had to leave, they let White Spot and Golden Fur stay by the crib.

Due to the appearance of Yuanyuan and Manman, the new shop's opening was postponed for an indefinite time. Qin Mian didn't mind at all. He always remembered these: *there is no end to earn money and family is the most important thing.*

When the couple was taking care of Yuanyuan and Manman, they discussed to take the opportunity to deal with the grove in the garden. Since Leisurely Farmhouse had planted too many things, the grove had blocked too much sunshine. Qin Mian wanted to cut down the trees surrounding the grove and the trees that were too high, and transform the grove into a small amusement park. When Yuanyuan and Manman grew up, there would be a place to play.

Today, while Qin Mian and Lei Tie were discussing which trees should be cut down at the edge of the grove, Lei-Qin Shun came to report in a hurry, "Eldest Master and Little Master, Third-gongzi has just come to report a good news; Third-gongzi's son has been born."

Footnotes

1. tip given on a happy occasion

Chapter 137: Babies' First-Month Celebration (1)

137 – Babies' First-Month Celebration (1)

Lei Tie asked, “The person?”

Lei-Qin Shun said, “Third-gongzi ran away in a hurry, all the while not losing his smile, said to go to other relatives' homes to announce.”

“He'd been hoping for a son, it'd be strange if he isn't like that.” Qin Mian turned his head and asked Lei Tie, “A-Tie, will their family's washing-third ceremony be a little more celebrated?”

Lei Tie, who was pondering over the matter of cutting trees, raised his head, “More than Wei Shi's.”

Qin Mian said to Lei-Qin Shun, “You tell Uncle Fu what we said, he will know what to do.”

Lei-Qin Shun understood, “Yes.”

That very day on Lei Xiangyi's son washing-third ceremony, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went together, followed by Lei-Qin Le, who was carrying a gift box.

At Lei Xiangyi's house, all the guests had arrived earlier.

The baby's childhood name was Niuniu¹ and he had yet to get a formal name. Lei Xiangyi wanted to wait for Lei Xiangzhi to come back and let him draft the names.

After lunch, the midwife presided over the washing-third ceremony. First of all, an incense burner table was set up outside the labor room to consecrate Goddess Yunxiao, Goddess Cuisheng, Goddess Songzi, Goddess Douzhen², and thirteen other god statues. The censer had to be filled with fragrant rice in replacement of incense ashes to insert incense sticks, under which were pressed ritual money, mock ingots, and other god worshipping tributes. On the head of the heatable-brick bed in the convalescing woman's bedroom laid the offering for the statues of Kang Gong and Kang Mu³, three bowls of oil cakes for each deity. After the midwife prayed, she kowtowed three times.

Qin Mian felt very novel and watched on seriously. He always thought the washing-third ceremony was unscientific, so he didn't hold it for his two little babies.

As soon as the midwife held the baby, the "washing-third" officially began.

The first to begin was the member of the family in accordance to superiority and seniority, taking the lead to add a small spoon of clean water to the basin and then put some coins or fruits and so on; it was called "add to the basin". It was said that the more things added in the basin, the luckier the baby would be in the future. However, the things added to the basin belonged to the midwife.

Qin Mian was very curious about what the few outrageous Lei family members would add. He stood amongst the crowd with the mood of watching with amusement as people made a fool of themselves.

Lei Tie stood shoulder-to-shoulder with him. When he caught sight of his wife's slightly upturned lips, a trace of a smile passed through his eyes.

Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi were the elders; they were the first to add to the basin. Lei Daqiang put a handful of copper coins into the basin, about 20 of them. Not bad. The midwife smilingly sang a congratulatory speech, "A few brasses, very rich."

When Du Shi scooped a ladle of clean water into the basin without any expression, it was unknown which few guests couldn't restrain from

sneering. Du Shi went to glare at them fiercely, but she couldn't find anyone. She lifted the corner of her skirt and sat down heavily on the chair.

The midwife was used to all kinds of scenes, her face remained unchanged and she still cheerfully sang, "Long flowing water, clever and sensible."

While holding Qingqing, Wei Shi put a handful of copper coins like Lei Daqiang.

Lei Xiangren swaggered up, his right hand quickly swept over the water and the water sloshed for a while. There was a glimmer of disdain in the midwife's eyes, believed that others had not seen it – he didn't add anything at all.

The guests were not blind. They could see at a glance that there was not much in the basin. Several people murmured in low voices, and their disdainful eyes glanced at Lei Xiangren from time to time. They all thought in their hearts: *even if you are reluctant to spend money, it's a good omen to add water to the basin or add some fruits. This is your nephew's washing-third!*

Zhao Shi sashayed forward and added a ladle of water to the basin. Her face did not look even half ashamed.

Lei Xiangyi's expression was very calm, probably had not held any expectation for that couple for a long time.

Lei Xiangli and his wife, Sun Shi, both added 20 copper coins. After all, it was unseemly to outdo their parents.

Then, it was Qin Mian and Lei Tie's turn. As soon as Lei Tie put something in, there was a tinkling sound in the basin. When the crowd looked closely, it was a silver longevity lock, worth at least a tael. In terms of adding to the basin, this was a big spend.

With a sincere smile on his face, Lei Xiangyi slightly nodded to Lei Tie.

The midwife's smile, at last, became more real as she sang aloud,
“Longevity lock, lock both riches and fortune!”

Qin Mian added a string of copper coins to the basin. The crowd gauged that it was a string of hundred coins, in other words, a 100 Wen.

The midwife cheerfully sang again, “A hundred coppers, the life of a hundred years!”

Afterward, the relatives and villagers added to the basin; a few people added copper coins, while most people added some joy fruits or water.

Once adding to the basin was over, the midwife picked up a mallet and stirred it into the basin. She sang, “One stirring, two stirrings, three stirrings; the older brother leads the younger brother to run. Seventy, eighty...”⁴

After that, she used the water in the basin to bathe the baby. It was also a relatively long process of singing, saying good words without restraint.

At the end of the ceremony, the midwife congratulated the family, more or less asking for a tip. Lei Xiangyi grabbed a small embroidered pouch from his pocket and handed it to the midwife, thanking her.

The midwife weighed the pouch and nodded to herself. On the whole, this host was not a fool, but as for the one who seemed to be the host's elder brother, if she was asked to do the washing-third for him later, she wouldn't be interested in coming.

Lastly, the midwife fished out all the things in the basin – the overall gains were not small.

.....

On the 10th day of the 5th month was Yuanyuan and Manman's first-month celebration. The spring day was warm and the breeze was gentle.

Leisurely Farmhouse was decorated by the servants, full of festive atmosphere. Red lanterns were hung at the gate and couplets were pasted to celebrate the babies' first month: the first line of the couplet on the scroll was "Auspicious Sons Bestowed by Heaven Gladden the Whole Family"; the second line was "The Door Welcome the Nobles' Audience to Shine Upon"; the horizontal scroll inscribed "The Whole Family Is Joyful".⁵

Leisurely Farmhouse was big, but many things were growing everywhere. If one wanted to arrange many tables, there was still not enough space. Moreover, there must be many naughty children who attended the banquet; it would be difficult to manage many people. Qin Mian and Lei Tie decided that the place of the banquet was on the grain-sunning ground.

The main purpose of giving the first-month celebration to the two children was to announce their existence. In the beginning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie released the news mainly for the villagers in the village – those who'd like to come could come, and those who didn't, would not be forced to come. Therefore, this time, the two men intended for people to do "running water banquet"⁶ – served the food once a table was full. Even if you were from another village, simply said a few words of blessing and you could eat the banquet even without bringing a gift.

Different from the last banquet held by Lei Daqiang, the scene this time was quite magnificent. Early in the morning, the crackle of firecrackers sounded joyfully in Leisurely Farmhouse for no less than two quarters. After breakfast, the servants began to work in an orderly manner. Some were responsible for boiling red eggs, some were carrying tables, chairs, and benches to the grain-sunning ground, and some were transporting vegetables...

All kinds of food ingredients were continuously transported from Leisurely Farmhouse and the processing yard to the grain-sunning ground.

Some of the villagers, who had a good relationship with the Qin Mian family, took the initiative to help. It was very lively.

The kitchen was built in advance the night before yesterday. When the six chefs specially hired for the banquet arrived, they began to boil, fry, and

stew.

A luxurious carriage drove into Green Mountain Village. When it passed by the grain-sunning ground, someone lifted the curtain before it was lowered. The carriage went on and stopped at the gate of Leisurely Farmhouse.

A manservant clinked the gate knocker.

When Lei-Qin Le saw the visitors, he was somewhat surprised, but not disrespectful as he received the tip and saluted, "Greetings to Nie-gongzi and Mu-gongzi."

It was Nie Heng and Mu Chen who came out from the carriage. When they heard that Qin Mian and Lei Tie "gave birth" to a pair of twin sons, they couldn't sit still. With difficulty, they waited until the first-month celebration today and then reached an agreement to come to congratulate them.

"You boy have a good memory." Nie Heng said with a smile, "We're here to congratulate your masters. Are your masters here?"

Lei-Qin Le said. "Both the Eldest Master and Little Master are here. Gongzis, please come in."

He led the two men inside and called a servant to let him report to the main house first.

Mu Chen looked at the flowers and willows in front of him as he smelled all kinds of flower fragrance floating in the air, only to feel his heart untroubled and his spirit pleased⁷.

"This Leisurely Farmhouse is truly a blessed place. Every time I come in, I feel all my exhaustion is swept away."

Nie Heng walked slowly as he glanced at the small fish swimming in the pond and nodded in approval, "It's true. Qin Mian and Lei Tie are the people who can enjoy it the most."

After a while, these few people arrived in front of the main house. The white curtains on the second floor fluttered in the wind, swaying out of the window frame from time to time. Last time, Nie Heng and Mu Chen just looked at the house from a distance. As they approached, not only they looked at it up and down, but vaguely felt that the house was very special, and yet, it was not clear where in particular.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie greeted them at the door while carrying Yuanyuan and Manman.

“Nie Heng, Mu-gongzi. Hope that you are well,” came from Lei Tie.

“Nie Heng, Mu-gongzi. We are honored by your precious presence. Please pardon and excuse us for not going out to meet you,” came from Qin Mian.

“Since you two address Nie Heng by name, call me by my name too.” Mu Chen’s tone was easygoing, while his eyes fell on the baby in Qin Mian’s arms.

Qin Mian smilingly said, “Alright. You two, please come in.”

Nie Heng and Mu Chen didn’t enter but instead stared at the two babies strangely.

“These are precisely your twin sons.”

Manman was carried in Qin Mian’s arms and Yuanyuan was carried in Lei Tie’s arms. The two babies wore identical small tiger-hide hats on their heads and dressed in identical small red thin robes.

The babies changed from day-to-day. The current Yuanyuan and Manman had more defined facial features than a month ago. It made people feel that they were made in the same mold as Qin Mian and Lei Tie without having to look closely. Yuanyuan was relatively quiet and as far as personality went, he seemed to be more like Lei Tie. Manman was a living wave; occasionally, the corners of his mouth would slightly tilt up as if smiling, his eyes would rove, and his small mouth would babble from time to time.

“They look like you two!” Nie Heng laughed and took out two pure gold longevity locks to hang on Yuanyuan and Manman’s necks. Then, he sincerely said, “Congratulations on your sons’ birth.”

“Congratulations.” Mu Chen, who seemed to have corresponded with him, also took out two pure gold longevity locks.

Both of them were shrewd people with doubts in their hearts, but they asked nothing.

“Many thanks...” The corner of Qin Mian’s mouth twitched. Each of the longevity locks they gave was at least five liang⁸ in weight, which could hurt his son’s neck. However, it was a blessing for a baby to have been given a gift on the baby’s first-month celebration, and to take it off immediately would be unlucky. He placed the longevity locks on his arm with one hand to lighten the pressure on Manman’s neck. Five liang of pure gold longevity lock was equivalent to 50 silver taels; it was a big spend. Alas, since Nie Heng and Mu Chen gave them, they would not take them back. So, Qin Mian did not decline.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 牛牛 Niu means ox or bull. It is said that the humbler the name is, the easier the baby will survive.
2. Respectively: (1)One of the Holy Mothers of the Sky; (2)Goddess who gives swift childbirth and protects midwives; (3)Goddess who presides over offspring; (4)Goddess who protects children from illness
3. The male and female deities of heatable-brick bed
4. I have no idea. It’s a chant of a sort.
5. The couplets are *literally* translated by me, so might be inaccurate (actually, the whole novel translation may be inaccurate 🙄🙄).
6. Banquet where guests arrive at various times and are served with food as they arrive
7. (idiom) carefree and relaxed
8. (memory refresh)A liang/tael is a unit of weight equal to 50 grams

Chapter 138: Babies' First-month Celebration (2)

138 – Babies' First-month Celebration (2)

Lei Tie's reaction was practically the same as Qin Mian's; he held the longevity locks in his hand to avoid his son's discomfort.

Once again, Qin Mian invited, "Come in and sit down."

Into the living room, the couple put Yuanyuan and Manman back in the crib.

The two babies seemed reluctant to leave their fathers' arms; two pairs of round eyes looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Their arms moved, legs pedaled, and mouths uttered childish sounds of unknown meaning.

"Yuanyuan and Manman, Daddies will come soon." Qin Mian hurriedly patted them on the shoulders as he comforted them in a soft tone.

Lei Tie pushed the wind chime hanging on the crib. The jingling sound attracted the attention of the two babies; their eyeballs moved along the swaying wind chime.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie seized the chance to walk away.

Mu Chen secretly praised, *that cold-faced Lei Tie also has such a 'tender' side*. It made him spontaneously think of starting a family, and would be best also to have a lovely son.

While Qin Mian poured tea and Lei Tie prepared snacks, Nie Heng and Mu Chen looked at the living room; they envied Qin Mian and Lei Tie even

more. This room did not look a bit luxurious and extravagant, so much so that it counted as untidy. However, the wall decoration and interior furnish, such as the settees, back cushions, rug... everything was random, revealing a casual and comfortable atmosphere, which eventually brought a warm atmosphere that made it hard for people to part with. Unlike their influential families' homes, the only thing that made people feel the most profound was the ice-cold atmosphere.

Qin Mian placed two cups of tea in front of Nie Heng and Mu Chen before sitting down on the single settee. "I didn't expect you two to come, so there's neither Xihe's Longjing nor Yunnan's Pu'er, only homemade five-scented tea. A-Tie and I think it tastes pretty good. You two, have a taste."

After putting down the snacks, Lei Tie sat on a round stool beside the crib and gently pushed the crib back and forth to make the wind chime produce a melodious and beautiful sound.

Feeling a bit funny, Nie Heng lifted the teacup. "Why did you think Mu Chen and I are such picky people?"

Qin Mian shrugged his shoulders, "That's currently unknown."

Mu Chen looked at the floating petals and tea leaves in the tea; it did not feel anything special. After taking a sip, he was astonished. "The tea tastes sweet and fresh, has an elegant aroma, and uplifts spirit after drinking. It's not worse than those famous teas." He subconsciously wanted to ask how it was made and what secret recipe it might be, but shut up in time.

"It must be unusual to get such praise from Mu-gongzi." Nie Heng looked at him curiously; he also tasted and savored it carefully before he appreciatively said, "Really good."

He asked half-jokingly, "Boss Qin, are you interested in selling its recipe?"

Seriously, he didn't think of making money all the time. Qin Mian looked at Nie Heng with appreciation, "Thank you, we aren't short of money." This tea was made with three kinds of flowers and two kinds of tea leaves picked in the space. The taste was truly extraordinary.

“That would be a pity.” Nie Heng spread his hands.

As the three of them chatting, Nie Heng mentioned purchasing Leisurely Farmhouse’s fruits. The cherries and honey peaches seemed to be ripening again. He and Mu Chen had fixed their attention on this earlier.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie and hesitated, “This matter...”

Nie Heng put down his teacup and said in surprise, “Don’t tell me you renege on it and don’t want to sell your fruits to outsiders.”

Qin Mian waved his hand, “That’s not true. Recently, there’s a new plan, but it hasn’t been thoroughly considered. Well, I’ll talk to you two after I’ve discussed it with A-Tie. In a word, since I’ve promised to sell the fruits to outsiders, I won’t renege on it. And of course, as my friends, you two are prioritized.”

Only then did Nie Heng and Mu Chen laid down their worries.

Qin Mian looked at the sky, “It’s almost noon. A-Tie and I have to go out with our children. I don’t think you two are used to eating with strangers. If you two don’t mind, just wait a little longer. I’ll personally cook for you two.”

“Surely don’t mind.” Nie Heng stood up. “We’ll go with you and enjoy the countryside scenery in passing.”

Mu Chen didn’t want to sit in the house alone, so he also stood up, “Go.”

Qin Mian picked up the Yuanyuan. The small arm placed on his shoulder was soft.

Manman also liked to be held by his Old Dad; he bounced in Lei Tie’s arms. He might have just turned a month old, but he had great strength. One small hand waved, while the other hand grabbed onto Lei Tie’s clothes, for fear of falling. Lei Tie gently held his little hand and let him grasp one of his (LT) fingers.

The couple took off the four longevity locks and straightened the hats on the babies' heads before carrying them out of the house.

Following behind, Mu Chen made faces at Yuanyuan and Manman. Yuanyuan looked at him without expression and turned his head; Manman, however, laughed so much that his small mouth opened wide.

Nie Heng looked at Mu Chen and laughed. He thought that Mu Chen was despised by Yuanyuan. Yet, reason told him that he thought too much; a month-old child couldn't have such rich emotions.

On the grain-sunning ground, nearly all relatives and villagers were there. There were hundreds of people, and it seemed lively.

Seeing Qin Mian and Lei Tie show up with the children in their arms, everyone came over and greeted them with auspicious words. They looked at the two children's faces and satisfied their curiosity. Then, praises came one after another.

The old man Deng, old lady Deng, Eldest Uncle Deng, and Second Uncle Deng were all here. Perhaps the old man Deng told something to the others, they didn't come over for the time being.

"Brother Lei, Brother Qin, congratulations on your sons' birth!" Zhang Dashuan was truly happy for Lei Tie and Qin Mian. He hung a silver longevity lock on each baby's neck, all of which cost a tael.

Sister Zhang handed Qin Mian the bundle in her hands and said with a smile, "These are some small clothes I made for the two children. You two mustn't disdain them."

Qin Mian quickly received it, "How could we? We can't thank you enough. Many thanks, Sister Zhang."

Wu Di squeezed over and put silver bracelets on the little arms of the two babies with a broad smile. "These are a few regards from my wife and me."

Over there, leaning forward on the table, Lei-Qin Li quickly wrote down the “gifts” sent by everyone, to facilitate the reciprocation in the future, in other words, to send a gift in return.

Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Wei Shi did not appear.

To one’s surprise, Lei Xiangren gave a longevity lock worth a tael. It was not strange if one was to think about it carefully; this was not the washing-third ceremony’s “add to the basin” where something that was given wouldn’t be returned. No matter how much or little he gave, Lei Tie was going to repay it in the future.¹

After the charcoal-burning formula was sold, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli had some money in their hands, so they could spend on presentable gifts; they both gave a tael worth longevity locks and also brought a scroll of a congratulatory poem that Lei Xiangzhi asked them to pass over. Even Lei Chuntao sent gifts. Due to fewer opportunities to go out [to buy things], she just sealed a tael each in two red envelopes.

Very soon, Yuanyuan and Manman had received a large number of gifts. The smallest gift was six copper coins strung with red strings. Although it was not much, it was the villager’s goodwill.

On such a happy occasion, no one indiscreetly asked the identity of the children’s mother.

After Qin Mian and Lei Tie said a few words on the occasion, they told the chefs to start the banquet and let everyone eat and drink well; there were enough food and wine.

Carrying the children in their arms, they came to the Deng family members.

Lei Tie said, “Grandpa, grandmother, eldest uncle, and second uncle, we have neglected you all just now.”

“It’s fine. I know you two will be busy today.” The old man Deng was smiling, not at all bothered by it.

“Here, these are for the two little babies.” The old lady Deng took out two red envelopes from her sleeve pocket with a smile. Back then, she also gave red envelopes to all her great-grandsons. It’d be unseemly to favor one and discriminate against the other, so she also gave them red envelopes.

Both Eldest Uncle Deng and Second Uncle Deng gave longevity locks made of silver.

Eldest Uncle Deng said, “Henceforth, live well.”

His nephew’s demeanor was much better than before, now that he had heirs.

At this time, Qin Mian vaguely understood that Eldest Uncle Deng didn’t like him before was mostly because he couldn’t have children,  sweat². But anyhow, it was a good turn that Eldest Uncle Deng accepted them.

Qin Mian said, “Grandpa, grandma, eldest uncle, and second uncle, go home with us.”

The old man Deng waved his hand in refusal. He had seen Nie Heng and Mu Chen earlier. When he saw the two men’s clothes and manners, he knew their identities were not ordinary. Supposedly, Qin Mian and Lei Tie would entertain the guests at home single-handedly. Therefore, he was afraid that both sides would be uncomfortable if they went.

“No need, we’ll eat here. It’s livelier and warmer. Go on with the things you are occupied with.”

The old lady Deng and Eldest Uncle Deng both nodded in assent.

Second Uncle Deng said, “Go ahead, your relatives won’t pick your gifts.”

Qin Mian had no choice but to smile, “Well then, A-Tie and I will excuse ourselves. Come a bit later, we’ll make up for the four elders.”

The servants had been briefed to treat the manservants and coachman brought by Nie Heng and Mu Chen well and give the leaving guests two red

eggs per person after dinner. Qin Mian and Lei Tie led Nie Heng and Mu Chen back home.

What Qin Mian didn't know was that as soon as they left, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi appeared in an ostentatious, vain manner of walking, without bringing any gift.

"Nie Heng and Mu Chen, you two can sit down. I'm going to cook with A-Tie. The ingredients have been prepared in advance, so the meal will be ready soon." Qin Mian was about to put Yuanyuan back in the crib.

Mu Chen's heart had been itching; he reached out his hands, "I'll hold him."

Leaning sideways, Lei Tie obliquely interposed between him and the crib. Then, he asked in all seriousness, "You have a son?"

Nie Heng laughed, "Hahaha..."

Mu Chen stiffened and the corners of his mouth twitched. "Is it amazing that you have sons?"

Qin Mian restrained a smile and explained, "Mu Chen, don't take offense. He bears no malice."

Mu Chen reluctantly sat back on the settee, "I know, he's afraid that I don't how to hold a baby and hurt your baby sons, isn't it? All right, all right. Go to cook."

Lei Tie didn't make a sound.

Nie Heng was still smiling, "Lei Tie, you can rest assured. I'll watch him and certainly won't let him hold the children."

Mu Chen gave him the stink eye.

Only then did Lei Tie put Manman in the bed.

The couple prepared tea, snacks, and fruits before going into the kitchen and bustling about.

As soon as the couple walked away, Mu Chen ran to the side of the crib, shaking the toys hanging above, “Little babies, look here, look here.”

Nie Heng sat quietly in the same place, thinking that Mu Chen was very childish. After a while, when he heard the babies laughing, he couldn’t help running over and squatted beside the crib, joining the ranks of teasing.

The arrival of Nie Heng and Mu Chen was unexpected. Qin Mian had planned to entertain the Deng family at noon, so the rice was cooked in the morning and only needed to reheat, while the ingredients had been washed and cut. With Lei Tie helping to watch the fire in the hearth, he quickly made eight dishes.

Nie Heng and Mu Chen wiped out the eight dishes as clean as pins. Covering their stomach with graceless movements, they reclined on the settee.

After sitting for a while, they left. Before leaving, they reminded Qin Mian not to forget what he had promised.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie invited the Deng family to have dinner at home and made up for the neglect.

On the grain-sunning ground, everyone had a sumptuous dinner and got two lucky red eggs. They all left, happy. The babies’ first-month ceremony ended smoothly. Uncle Fu led the servants to deal with the large and small things on the grain-sunning ground.

After Qin Mian and Lei Tie fed their two children “dinner”, they lay on the bed at leisure.

“A-Tie, you also come up with ideas.” Qin Mian was a little anxious.

His wife rarely couldn’t make up his mind. Lei Tie half-pulled the other person into his arms and asked, “About?”

“Now is the period when our children need us the most. At least until they’re three years old, we can’t keep them out of our hands. I wonder whether the new shop shouldn’t be opened for the time being, or should we just cooperate with Nie Heng and Mu Chen—we come out with pastry recipes and they’re in charge of the operation, the profit is split equally. This way, we only need to take care of our family affairs, as well as Double Xiang House and Eating Savory Restaurant.”

Lei Tie pondered for a moment before saying, “With children now, we can’t open another shop. If you don’t want to give up the recipes, you can open the bakery three years later.” The reason for that was, Qin Mian had to teach how to make many of the pastries in the bakery.

Note:

Footnotes

1. It’s a Chinese culture to reciprocate with a gift of equal value as the way to say thank you.
2. perspiration; sweat; to be speechless (out of helplessness, embarrassment, etc); (Internet slang used as an interjection)

Chapter 139: Fund a School Construction

139 – Fund a School Construction

“Three years...” Qin Mian scratched his chin, still hesitant. “It’s a waste of time not to open the new shop for three years.”

Lei Tie rubbed his chin against his wife’s head. “I’ll decide. The new shop will open but temporarily won’t sell pastries, only drinks. Simple drinks, easy to teach.”

His rare emphatic made Qin Mian quickly make up his mind, “[I’ll] listen to you. So then, except for grapes, we’ll reserve one-third of our fruits and sell the rest to Nie Heng and Mu Chen.”

“En.” Lei Tie had no objection.

“*Aa yaa...*” Manman waved his little arms.

Qin Mian crawled over and picked him up. “Son, what happened? Did no one pay attention to you?”

Manman leaned on him, looking very happy, “*Yaa yaa.*”

Yuanyuan looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie also picked him up. The father and son looked at each other, both remained silent.

Qin Mian heartily laughed and went back to Lei Tie. He sat next to the man and used Manman’s small hand to touch Yuanyuan’s hand. “Here, you

brothers play together.”

“*Yaa...*” Manman smiled with eyes shaped into crescents.

Yuanyuan raised his little arms. “*Aa.*”

Watching them, Qin Mian was overjoyed, while the expression on Lei Tie’s face was flat yet gentle. Qin Mian didn’t notice that Lei Tie’s eyes fell mostly on him.

In the later part of the 5th lunar month, the cherries began to ripen. Qin Mian taught Aunt Fu, Aunt Quan, and Lei-Qin Le’s wife how to make fruit juices and milk tea. A few days later, Glimmer of Paradise Beverage Shop opened for business. Sweet drinks were more popular with women and children and soon became the most popular drinks in town. Every day near noon, there were long lines outside the shop.

It had been a whole year since Double Xiang House was established, which had greatly promoted the economic development in Running Water Town. Following Nie Heng’s transport line, there were two domesticated animal fodder shops, three vegetable shops, and two tea shops established in Running Water Town, as well as many vendor’s stalls selling local specialties, rainwear, and other goods. Not only that, even a shrewd businessman bought a piece of land next to Double Xiang House and built a two-storied general store, which gathered all kinds of goods – wasn’t it the same as a department store in the later generation? It might not be too wasteful of a trip coming to Running Water Town just to have a meal and listen to storytelling in Double Xiang House when in passing, one could buy some goods and bring them back to sell. What could one have against it?

As Qin Mian expected, Running Water Town became more prosperous than before. There were more vehicles and passers-by. Hence, the monthly profit of Glimmer of Paradise Beverage Shop was very impressive.

It was very cool and refreshing to drink a glass of juice with ice, especially as the weather got hotter and hotter. The drinks variety also gradually increased, such as cherry, peach, strawberry, watermelon...

In the 8th lunar month, the grapes in the vineyard ripened; each of them was big and purple, like clusters of beautiful purple pearls hang on the grape trellis, making one's mouth watery. After picking one to taste, the sweetness made one unable to stop even though one wanted to.

In the sweltering summer at the start of dragon hour (7 am), the sun was unusually blazing.

The servants of Leisurely Farmhouse put on straw hats and came to the vineyard with straw baskets. After finding the ripe grape clusters within the green leaves, they held the vines in one hand, cut the cluster with shears on the other hand, and put them into the basket gently. About an hour later, there would be a cart coming to transport these grapes.

Qin Mian planted the grapes to brew wine. The wine was much more profitable than the grapes themselves. He only agreed to sell 200 jin of grapes with the price of 50 Wen per jin, for the sake of the good relationship with Nie Heng and Mu Chen. This unit price was higher than other grapes, but in Qin Mian's opinion, it was only a small change [for them].

The rest of the grapes were used to brew wine. Brewing wine was easy. Since the grapes were not sprayed with pesticides, they didn't need to be cleaned; the white substance on the surface of the grape skin was conducive for fermentation. Once the grapes were picked off one by one into the basin, they were crushed by hand; left in the basin were the grape skin, seeds, and pulp. Next, according to the ratio of 6 jin of grapes to 1 jin of sugar, they were evenly mixed before the mixture was put into a clean container after the sugar had completely melted. In the fermentation process, the grapes produced a lot of gas; it must not be filled too full to guard against explosion. The container had to be sealed. In the summertime, the high temperature quickened the fermentation process. In about 20 days, it could be brewed. After filtering the grape skin, seeds, and pulp with clean gauze, the remaining was the real wine. Finally, the wine could be sold in a customized jar with a capacity of 2 jin. Each jar was priced at 2 taels.

Qin Mian supervised the process once. After he confirmed that the servants had learned it, he handed the matter to Uncle Fu. The main task of him and Lei Tie was to take care of their sons.

The four-month-old Yuanyuan and Manman had grown very strong; not only could they turn over, sometimes they could even sit. With big black eyes, white soft cheeks, and chubby little hands, they looked so adorable after putting on light blue open-crotch bodysuits embroidered with fruits, displaying their pink tender little buttocks. Whether it was a little girl, a woman, or an old lady in the village, whoever saw the two little ones couldn't help but glance a few more, while feeling their hearts melt, wanting to hold them up and kiss them hard.

Qin Mian wouldn't give them such a chance. He couldn't easily let others kiss his sons since there were so many germs.

And Lei Tie was even more unlikely to allow others to kiss his sons.

After dinner that evening, when the sun had just set, the heat dissipated a lot. In the westside, half of the sky was covered in a wide expanse of sunset glow. Countless dragonflies fluttered in the sky, diligently annihilating mosquitoes. The caress of the summer breeze was rather cool and refreshing.

After bathing the two little ones, Qin Mian and Lei Tie dressed them in clean clothes, put them in the strollers, and pushed them out of the house.

White Spot and Golden Fur dawdled at the back.

Made exactly the same, the two baby strollers were specially designed by Qin Mian; they could be separated and merged into one to facilitate the two children's emotional connection. One side of the stroller's handle was hung with feeding bottles, and the other side was hung with a handy cloth bag containing clean diapers. Meanwhile, the sunshade of the stroller was affixed with toys in the shape of fruits made from brightly colored cloth.

Yuanyuan and Manman were very smart. When they were put in the strollers, they knew that they were going to go out.

Manman was so delighted that he bounced, "*Yi yaa...*"

Although it was not obvious on Yuanyuan's expression, one could still make out happiness on his face.

Perhaps it was truly related to heredity, Yuanyuan resembled Lei Tie to the extreme, having little expression and few 'words'. When Qin Mian found out about that, he wanted to improve it sooner. Hence, he held Yuanyuan most of the time. Every time he held Yuanyuan, he would tease him a lot, but to no effect. Besides, Manman seemed dissatisfied with his partiality, so he had to give up. In fact, it was not so bad to be like A-Tie; he's just as cute.

After dinner, the villagers went out with big cattail leaf fans and gathered under the trees to enjoy the cool breeze as they chatted.

"Oh, Tie-zi and Tie-zi's wife are taking the children out for a walk again?"

Qin Mian greeted them with a smile. "Yes. These two little ones like to stroll outside, as though their pairs of eyes can't see enough."

When the villagers saw Yuanyuan and Manman's eyes turning and looking around, they all laughed.

"The children are becoming more and more adorable."

When Lei Tie saw Li Zheng, he cupped his hands in greetings as he said, "Li Zheng is also here. My wife and I have something to talk to you about."

The people of peasant households usually had nothing to entertain themselves with, so they all were somewhat gossipy. They looked over, inquisitively.

When Lei Tie said that in front of so many people, that meant he didn't mind others to know. Li Zheng directly asked, "Tie-zi, what matter is it?"

Lei Tie said, "We plan to fund a school construction in the village."

The villagers were both surprised and happy, wanting to come near, but didn't dare to get too close in the end, out of fear of White Spot and Golden Fur.

“Brother Tie, is this true?”

At this point, one had to talk about the situation of Green Mountain Village. Green Mountain Village was situated in a remote location; the soil condition was not good and there was not much yield in the farmland. That's why, before the construction of the processing yard, Green Mountain Village was relatively poor. Plus, there was no school in the village. If the children wanted to study, they could only go to the school in town. However, Green Mountain Village was an hour away from the town, which was very inconvenient. Like Lei Xiangzhi, when he was studying in the town, he lived in the house provided by the town school, lest he wasted all his time on the road. The villagers felt that it was too troublesome to pick up and send their children back and forth every day. Neither did they felt at ease to let the children go to and from school by themselves in the morning and evening. The daily cost of accommodation also was not small. Therefore, many villagers had to give up the idea of letting their children attend school. Nevertheless, the status of a scholar was always majestic. Who wouldn't wish for their children to be preoccupied with books, so much so that they embark on an official career one day? At any rate, even without expecting them to take the examination to become a Xiucai, or the Number One Scholar, or something, to be able to read a few words was already a good thing. When they grew up, it would be easier to find a job.

It was conceivable that Lei Tie's words caused a great sensation. Not a while later, the villagers who got the news came over, all talking at once to make detailed inquiries.

Nevertheless, with a sound of clearing throat from Li Zheng, who had status, everyone sat down and didn't make any unnecessary racket.

Li Zheng was equally excited, “Tie-zi, please talk about it in detail.”

Yuanyuan and Manman were having fun grabbing and groping White Spot and Golden Fur's bodies.

“It's my wife's idea, let my wife say it.” Lei Tie took out a handkerchief to wipe his sons' hands, and let White Spot and Golden Fur retreat a bit.

Qin Mian's heart warmed. All the time, his family's poker-face tried to improve his position in the village.

“In recent years, our family has been able to get a foothold in the village and live a happy life. It's all thanks to the support of our fellow villagers. To show our gratitude and make the children in Green Mountain Village more promising than our generation, A-Tie and I have decided to build a school. The school will be set up with two classrooms, one of which is for the children who only want to learn a few more words can call it an ordinary class; the other one is for the children who want to take the imperial examination, can call it imperial examination class. The desks, chairs, and benches in the school are all paid for by our family. The children in the ordinary class only need to pay 20 Wen a month to pay for the teacher's expenses; the children in the imperial examination class pay 100 Wen a month, which is also given to the teacher. If the sum is not enough to pay for the teachers' wages, our family will make up for it. As it should be, the fee collection will have to bother Li Zheng take care of.”

Chapter 140: Babies' Novel Experience

140 – Babies' Novel Experience¹

In fact, the reasons why Qin Mian and Lei Tie decided to build a school were: one, for their unique family to better integrate into Green Mountain Village; two, for their sons. Scholars, farmers, artisans, and merchants; if there was no mishap, Yuanyuan and Manman would take the road of imperial examination when they grew up. He and Lei Tie were not at ease to send them to the town to study, so they might as well place them by their side. On one hand, they could take care of their children's livelihood; on the other hand, they could guide their children's schoolwork. As for hiring people to teach them alone and whatnot, Qin Mian didn't think of that; he didn't want to deprive the children of the fun of studying together with other children.

After listening to Qin Mian's words, the villagers began to talk in twos and threes, with a happy expression on their faces.

"This is indeed a wonderful thing. The fee for the school in the town is 200 Wen a month, no matter whether you just want to read characters or take an examination. That's more than 2 taels a year!"

"You aren't wrong!"

"The fee for the ordinary class is only 20 Wen a month – if the children are diligent and smart enough, they can learn hundreds and thousands of words with only 20 Wen. Absolutely cost-effective!"

"Lei Tie and his wife are really honest and kind people!"

“When the school is built, I’ll have to send my two boys to learn to read. Otherwise, they bully the cats and dogs in the village, making trouble every day.”

“Hehe, I want my boy to take the imperial examination. How good it would be to be a senior official in the future!”

“Hahaha, delusional?”

“Screw you!”

.....

The villagers talked loudly, making the atmosphere very enthusiastic.

Li Zheng burst out laughing. Not daring to pat Lei Tie’s shoulder, he exerted all his strength to pat Qin Mian’s. “Good, good, good. I thank you two on behalf of all the villagers. I believe that our Green Mountain Village will get better and better in the future.”

“Uncle Li Zheng is too polite. We’re simply doing something within our limit.” Qin Mian took out a 50-tael silver ingot from his small pouch and handed it to Li Zheng. He sincerely said, “Uncle Li Zheng, you know that I and A-Tie are busy people. I’m afraid we can’t manage the matter of school. Therefore, we have to trouble you to bear responsibility. Take the money. If it’s not enough, just let us know.”

With so many villagers present, Li Zheng candidly accepted it, “Alright, since you can trust me, I’ll take it. As for the land, the village will give a plot for free. I’ll take care of it. The teacher for the ordinary class doesn’t need to possess scholarly honor, only find someone who is patient and responsible; I’ll find a way. As for the teacher for the imperial examination class, that needs a bit of an effort to find. Tie-zi and Tie-zi’s wife, I remember that you two have some friendship with Dean Huo in the county. I wonder if you can ask him if there is a suitable candidate? There are a lot of children in our village who want to take the imperial examination. Since the school is going to be built, they should be well taught. We mustn’t hold them up.”

Qin Mian thought for a moment and said, “Dean Huo is the head of the academy and has a busy schedule; it’s not easy to see him. However, A-Tie and I will go to the academy tomorrow to tell our fifth brother. His good friend is Dean Huo’s son, so it’ll be more appropriate to find Huo-gongzi to act as the go-between.”

Li Zheng nodded his head as he said, “Right, as expected of you to think it through. Then, [I’ll] trouble you and Tie-zi with that.”

In the strollers, Yuanyuan and Manman looked drowsy. After Qin Mian and Lei Tie bid farewell, they picked up the two children and pushed the strollers toward home.

Behind them, the villagers were still fervently talking.

The two little ones rested on their dads’ shoulders. With the sway of their dads’ paces, they soon fell asleep.

Back at home, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took turns looking after the children so they could bathe.

After Lei Tie took a bath, he went back to the bedroom. The two small ones were sleeping soundly in the crib, while the big one was lying on his stomach on the pillow; he seemed to be asleep. His nightclothes was hanging disorderly on his body, revealing his white back and legs. Lei Tie lightly walked over. Holding the youngster’s two calves, he dropped a wet kiss on the youngster’s back.

Qin Mian was so sensitive that he trembled, but didn’t make any move. Lei Tie took off the nightclothes he had just put on and pressed on top...

Since the two children appeared, they had less opportunity to do intimate things than before. This time, their *love affairs* were especially long. Only when Lei Tie knew that Qin Mian couldn’t endure and beg for mercy did Lei Tie let him go.

“Wife...” Lei Tie’s lips circled on Qin Mian’s neck; the temperature on his body remained high.

Qin Mian warily retreated. His voice was hoarse, “[I] really can’t do it again!”

Lei Tie drew Qin Mian back into his arms, patted his back, restrained his struggle, and dropped a butterfly kiss on his head, “Sleep. I’ll wash you again after you fall asleep.”

Qin Mian relaxed, but still couldn’t help muttering, “[I] already said no, you still...”

“Wife... miss you.” Lei Tie’s voice was close to Qin Mian’s ear. It was very depressed as though it contained grievances.

Qin Mian’s heart wildly pounded. His face felt as hot as if he had just come out of the hot spring. He turned over and hugged the man’s strong waist. He raised his head and gave the man a loud kiss on his chin, getting his lips pricked. He reached out to touch the man’s chin – it turned out that there was stubble. He couldn’t help rubbing it a few times, causing the man’s breathing to quicken again. He quickly drew back his hand, closed his eyes, and said in a fluster, “I’m going to sleep.”

Lei Tie slowly let out a breath, and then said in a low voice, “Sleep.”

Qin Mian felt that there was something wrong with his cultivation—his body recovered so fast to the extent that Lei Tie always thought his body could withstand more. When he got up in the morning, the guy’s heated gaze slowly scrutinized him up and down, making his spine numb. He gave the man a stern eye with a deadpan face.

Lei Tie pushed the crib to the kitchen door and went to the hearth to add firewood, acting as if nothing had happened.

“Wife, I can go to the county alone.”

Lei Tie was not a talkative person but neither was he a person who couldn’t interact. Qin Mian was at ease, “Horseback or carriage?”

“Horseback. Quickly go, sooner return.”

“I believe Dean Huo would be happy to help. Later, I’ll ask someone to pick some peaches and grapes. You can take them to him and Fifth Brother.”

“En.”

After breakfast, Lei Tie went out on horseback with fruits.

Qin Mian took care of the two children at home. It was hot. The father and sons stayed in the living room. The two little ones were very easy to take care of. After eating and drinking enough, they lay on the crib and obediently played by themselves – the brothers didn’t bother each other. Qin Mian was busy drawing costume designs. He wanted to make more sets of parent-child clothes for their family of four. Just by imagining the spectacle, he found it fascinating

Lei Tie came back in the afternoon.

Qin Mian had taken his two babies to take a nap in the bedroom. When he felt someone climbing the bed, he sleepily opened his eyes to look at the person and routinely asked, “Did you have lunch?”

“Yes. Sleep.” Lei Tie kissed him on the forehead.

Qin Mian went back to sleep. In his sleep, he did not forget to squeeze into the man’s arms. When he woke up from his nap, he asked Lei Tie the progress of that matter.

Lei Tie said, “I told Huo-gongzi about it. He immediately went to see Dean Huo and brought back his words. Dean Huo happens to have a good friend named Chen, who recently wants to find a quiet place to settle down. He should be willing to come to our village to teach. Dean Huo will ask Teacher Chen’s opinion first. He’ll tell Fifth Brother when he has news and let him inform us.”

“Since it’s a good friend, Dean Huo must have known Teacher Chen very well – the result is almost certain. I’ll have to tell Li Zheng some other day

that when the time comes, he'll have to especially welcome the teacher, can't fail in manners."

Li Zheng was very efficient. It only took three days to buy all the bricks, tiles, sand, and stones needed to build the school. Building a school was a great event in the village; all the idle men in the village went to help. The women also took action by sending them some cool tea, mung bean soup, and other things to relieve the summer heat.

At the end of the 8th lunar month, Lei Xiangzhi came back for his break and brought back Dean Huo's words – Teacher Chen agreed to come to Green Mountain Village as a teacher.

At this time, the school was also completed; it was called Green Mountain Village School. There were two study rooms, two classrooms, and a corridor on the side leading to the backyard – the backyard was the teacher's residence.

So as not to slight the teachers, the villagers dug some honeysuckle and wild chrysanthemum from the mountain to plant them in the yard. Although the flowers were not elegant, they also had special appeals.

Two days later, Li Zheng personally picked up Chen Feinian, who came to Green Mountain Village. Teacher Chen was about 45~46 years old, with a lean figure and expressive eyes. The way he carried himself spoke of scholarly temperament. Even the illiterate villagers could see that he was a learned scholar.

The ordinary class teacher was Luo Youde, Li Zheng's eldest son. It was not that Li Zheng favored his son, but rather because Li Zheng had previously wanted his son to become a person who was worthy of respect, so Luo Youde and his younger brother Luo Youfu had once studied for a few years. It was enough for Luo Youde to teach people to read. No one in the village had any objection.

At the beginning of the 9th lunar month, the school opened. There were more than fifty students in the ordinary class, ranging in age from six to sixteen. Eight students enrolled in the imperial examination class.

On the first day of school, parents were curiously watching outside the ordinary class window. They were all from the same village, so Luo Youde couldn't drive them away and he had to let them be. Luo Youde was smart; he taught simple characters, such as 上(upper), 下(lower), 左(left), 右(right), 天(sky) 风(wind), 雨(rain), and so on, as well as the various surnames in the whole village.

In the imperial examination class, parents did not dare to go over. It was a sacred thing to take the imperial examination, so they dared not influence their children's learning. Besides, it was said that Teacher Chen was a palace graduate², he must have possessed scholarly honor.

All in all, the school started very smoothly. Many villagers felt that since the school opened, the children were not idle and therefore, the whole village was much more peaceful. When it snowed in the afternoon, the children wrote a few words on the ground to show them and even taught them to write. At the bottom of their hearts, there was an indescribable pride.

Time flowed like water. In a twinkling of an eye, the 9th lunar month arrived and the day of the provincial examination was coming.

The provincial examination was conducted in the prefectural city of each prefecture. Therefore, Lei Xiangzhi and other students had to go to Qingtian Prefecture again.

Lei Xiangzhi had a rest at home for two days; one could see that he was slightly nervous. The provincial examination was held every three years. If he failed, he would have to take it again three years later. It was no wonder that even he, who had always been confident, was nervous. However, after two days of adjustment at home, he regained his composure.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't personally send Lei Xiangzhi this time, but they still sent four armed servants – Lei-Qin Shun, Lei-Qin Yuan, Lei-Qin Hui, and Lei-Qin Jian – to escort him to Qingtian. After more than a year's high-intensity training, Lei-Qin Shun's group of four could be called experts; one person fighting ten enemies would be a cinch.

The villagers in Green Mountain Village were also very concerned about Lei Xiangzhi that he became the topic of conversation for several days in a row.

Meanwhile, the Qin Mian and Lei Tie family's topic of conversation was: Yuanyuan and Manman had turned five-month-old. There was a custom in the village that said when babies grew to five-month-old, they could smell the fragrance of the five grains, so parents should "begin a meat diet" for them. In short, they should let the babies taste meat. Beginning a meat diet was usually served with either rabbit or fish meat, symbolizing intelligence and quick-wittedness.

For lunch, Qin Mian prepared both rabbit and fish meat.

Sat in Qin Mian and Lei Tie's arms, Yuanyuan and Manman fixedly stared at the dishes on the table and reached out to grab the dishes, seemingly too impatient to wait.

"Yi yaa..."

Qin Mian laughed, "My little ones, how did you know that these things can be eaten?"

Lei Tie said, "Our sons, of course, are clever."

Amused, Qin Mian shot a glance at him and said, "That's right!"

He dipped his chopsticks into the vegetable soup and fed it to Manman's mouth. Manman smacked his lips and a smile emerged – a very satisfied look. Then, Qin Mian put a tad of cooked rabbit meat into his mouth. The little one's lips moved, but he didn't have teeth after all, so the minced meat flowed out of his mouth. Qin Mian quickly stuffed it in with the chopsticks. The little one's lips moved again and this time, he ate it.

"A-Tie, look—what are you doing?" The corner of Qin Mian's mouth twitched. He saw Lei Tie dip his chopsticks in wine to feed Yuanyuan.

Lei Tie calmly said, "To train alcohol tolerance."

If his ears were not red, Qin Mian might believe him. Anyway, it was rare for the man to be so childish, so he chuckled and said nothing. He looked at Yuanyuan.

Yuanyuan's small mouth suddenly opened wide; obviously, the pungent taste had kicked in, but he actually did not cry. After a while, he smacked his lips while looking at the dishes on the table.

Lei Tie dipped his chopsticks into the meat soup and let Yuanyuan lick it. Then, he blew a grain of rice to cool and put it into Yuanyuan's mouth.

T/N: In case you didn't catch it, Lei Tie was actually looking at Qin Mian while feeding Yuanyuan, so his chopsticks went to the wrong bowl/cup. Or so I thought. If you have another opinion, comment below ↓

Note:

Footnotes

1. It also means to begin a meat diet, but I chose this title instead. You'll know why by the end of the chapter.
2. A successful candidate in the highest imperial civil service examination

Chapter 141: Lei Tie, You Mensao!

141 – Lei Tie, You Mensao!¹

In the evening, the villagers gathered under the trees to enjoy the cool breeze as usual. First, they chatted about the coming autumn harvest. Then, they talked about the school in the village. Naturally, they talked about the people who built the school, Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They praised the couple, endlessly.

Zhao Sifa squatted at the side as he held a bowl, eating his dinner. When heard these words, the hatred in his heart that was hard to suppress, flared up. Why should he be looked down upon, while those two clay rabbits² were respected by others? If he had succeeded in having Lei Tie take a concubine, he could use his cousin to control Lei Tie. So much so that even the property of the Lei Tie family might be his! It was such a pity that Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, those two oldies, were so useless that a good plan was wasted in vain.

The more he thought about it, the more intense his anger and hatred were, which kept stirring in his chest, making him uneasy. All of a sudden, the words “autumn harvest” flashed in his mind. His eyes drifted to the golden paddy fields outside the village, and a wonderful idea came to his mind. Since he couldn’t do anything to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, then just let them lose a lot of money!

“Sifa, what are you thinking about? Your smile is so horrifying,” asked Grandpa Jiang in suspicious, after coldly looking at him for a moment.

Zhao Sifa came to his senses and said in embarrassment, “Nothing, nothing. I’m going back to get a second helping.”

Grandpa Jiang frowned; he always felt that Zhao Sifa was going to do something bad.

As Zhao Sifa hurried home, his back felt inexplicably cold. Assuming it was his illusion, he shook his head and strode into the house.

In Leisurely Farmhouse, Lei Tie, who was collecting the diapers dried on the clothes-drying pole, seamlessly withdrew his spiritual sense. With a gentle swing of his right hand, the ropes on the window lattice moved.

Not a while later, Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu came together. They felt puzzled because Eldest Master and Little Master seldom called them together at the same time.

“Greetings to Eldest Master. What is the order, Eldest Master?”

Lei Tie folded the diaper and put it in the basket. His voice was cold, “From now on, keep an eye on Zhao Sifa. This time, I want him driven out of Green Mountain Village.”

Uncle Fu’s expression turned strict. *Zhao Sifa again!* The matter of Zhao Sifa wanting to match his cousin to Lei Tie as a concubine somehow had leaked. Therefore, the servants of Leisurely Farmhouse all hated Zhao Sifa. However, the Eldest Master and Little Master had not indicated anything. As the servants, they did not dare to act rashly. This time, since Eldest Master gave the order, they could be at ease to do it—Zhao Sifa couldn’t escape from their palms.

“Eldest Master can rest assured,” said Uncle Fu in all seriousness.

When Uncle Fu returned to his residence, he summoned all the servants who had no work in hand and gave several orders. The servants all nodded while suppressing their excitement before they dispersed.

The dim light of the night gradually sunk.

When the whole village was quiet, Zhao Sifa crept out of bed with as little noise as possible. He covered his face with a black cloth, picked up a torch

and flint, and quietly and sneakily went out toward the outside the village.

Zhou Sifa had no idea that since the day Lei Tie learned that Du Shi's idea of giving him(LT) a concubine originated from him(ZSF), Lei Tie had been watching him in secret, waiting for a perfect opportunity. Now, several dark shadows were following him without any sound.

Borrowing the moonlight, Zhao Sifa soon came to the edge of the paddy fields and darkly sneered, "Qin Mian, Lei Tie, blame yourselves for connecting your paddy fields. Humph!"

After he looked around and found no suspicious movement, he squatted down and lit the torch with a flint. Under the flickering firelight, his smile appeared extremely ferocious. He raised the torch and ignited the paddy in the field.

Not far away, Lei-Qin Shu was so angry that he jumped to his feet. They had expected Zhao Sifa to do bad things, but they didn't expect him to be so vicious.

Lei-Qin Li pressed him in time and said in a low voice, "Third Brother, don't be anxious. When Li Zheng and the others come, we can catch him. If you go now, he might shift the blame to you."

Lei-Qin Shun knew that Lei-Qin Li was right. He took a deep breath, nodded, and kept hiding.

After lighting one plot, Zhao Sifa went to another plot and continued to set fire to the paddy field, with a proud and cruel smile on his face.

At this time, a familiar roar came from the distance, "ZHAO SIFA! WHAT ARE YOU DOING?"

Zhao Sifa was greatly startled that his hands trembled and threw away the torch. The torch flew out and landed in the paddy field at the side. The fire burnt more and more vigorously.

Zhao Sifa covered his face, endlessly panic-stricken. He had masked his face, so how did Li Zheng know it was him?

He had not taken into consideration that since everyone was all from the same village, they were very familiar with each other – they could recognize others only by looking at their back figures.

At the sight of Li Zheng and two highly respected old people in the village, Lei-Qin Shun's group of people, who were lying in ambush nearby, immediately jumped out and quickly cut out an isolation area in the paddy field with the sabers they carried along. They wanted to save their family's paddy fields, so they couldn't care about the paddy field next to it, only had to let it burn for a while.

"Li Zheng..." Zhao Sifa was deathly pale as he weakly knelt on the ground, "I, I..."

Li Zheng, whose face paled due to anger, said to Lei-Qin Cheng, "You run to the village and quickly call people to put out the fire!"

Lei-Qin Cheng cupped his fist and hurriedly ran away.

Li Zheng wanted so much to slap Zhao Sifa's face.

"Zhao Sifa... You, how did you become so vicious? The grain is the root of the farmer!" Old Grandpa Liu pounded his walking stick on the ground while burning with a frenzy of rage.

Old Grandpa Wang didn't even bother to talk to Zhao Sifa.

After hearing the news, the villagers came quickly and scooped water from the river with pots and buckets to put out the fire. Fortunately, the Qin Mian family's paddy field only lost about 30% of it. The paddy field next to it belonged to the Zhao Wenzhong family. His situation was tragic; his plot of over a *mu* of paddy was half-burned down.

Once the villagers knew that Zhao Sifa set the fire, their eyes changed. They looked at Zhao Sifa with unbelievable and frightened eyes. It was not

that there was never a conflict between the villagers. For instance, snatching water when transplanting paddy seedlings; cutting more thatch grass than others on the public-used ridge; your children beat up my children; my ox accidentally trampled on your family's crops... It was normal to have these minor contradictions. After a few days of scolding or cold war, they would talk and laugh again. However, there had never been such a vicious person as Zhao Sifa. How could they not worry? Such a person with a bad mind was like a poisonous snake that no one knew when it would emerge and bite people.

A hot-tempered villager couldn't help but say, "Li Zheng, you mustn't spare Zhao Sifa."

Immediately, someone chimed in, "Right! Such a vicious person, who knows whether he will deal with us one day in the future."

Lei-Qin Zhong was waiting for this moment. He cupped his fist in obeisance to Li Zheng and said, "Li Zheng, this servant I had told you that Zhao Sifa had ulterior motives, but you didn't believe. If our Eldest Master hadn't been on guard against Zhao Sifa, our family would have lost more than ten *mu* of paddy field, same goes for Uncle Zhao's field. Look, the distance between the paddy fields is not far. Plus, the wind is strong today. If one is not careful, sparks will be blown into the fields next to it. By then, the consequences will be disastrous. Li Zheng and everyone, our Eldest Master and Little Master have been merciful to Zhao Sifa several times. If this was how he reciprocated, how can one not be chilled by that?"

The villagers' moods were stirred up.

"Li Zheng, drive Zhao Sifa out of Green Mountain Village!"

"Yes! Drive out of Green Mountain Village!"

"There is no room for such *great buddha* like him in our village!"

.....

Zhao Sifa suddenly came to his sense, hugged Li Zheng's leg, and cried hard. His tears and snot flowed together. "Li Zheng, I know I'm wrong. I **truly** know I'm wrong. Please spare me this time. I'll kowtow to you, I'll kowtow to you!"

Li Zheng coldly pushed him away. Regardless, as he took into consideration of Zhao Sifa's evil deeds and the cares of the Lei Tie's couple toward his family, as well as Green Mountain Village, he couldn't let Zhao Sifa slip away.

"No need, I can't afford it [the kowtow]. Zhao Sifa, you are given two days to leave Green Mountain Village and not allowed to enter Green Mountain Village again. Otherwise, we will drag you off to the local authority and let the county magistrate deal with you."

Zhao Sifa dejectedly seated himself on the ground with a face as white as sheet.

Li Zheng looked at two old men.

"Old man Liu and old man Wang, do you two think this way of dealing is proper?"

Old Grandpa Liu faintly sighed. He looked at Zhao Sifa with an exasperated expression. "Very good. This old man doesn't want to see the atmosphere of Green Mountain Village be damaged by him!"

Old Grandpa Wang nodded, "Deal as such."

Qin Mian was sleeping soundly. When he suddenly felt that no one was beside him, he woke up and saw Lei Tie standing in front of the floor-to-ceiling window. He rubbed his eyes and walked over, leaning his head lazily on Lei Tie's shoulder. The fire in the distance made him sober up in an instant. "What's happened there?"

Those round eyes were so lovely. Lei Tie picked him up and frowned as soon as he noticed that the other person didn't wear shoes. He put the person back on the bed, wiped his feet, and spoke of the matter in brief.

“You mean, you’ve been ‘monitoring’ Zhao Sifa for more than five months.” Qin Mian stared at him in surprise. He was not a person who returned evil with good when someone rode over his head. He also knew that Du Shi’s behavior that day was instigated by Zhao Sifa. However, Yuanyuan and Manman’s appearance occupied most of his attention and energy, so he couldn’t manage to deal with Zhao Sifa. Besides, neither did Lei Tie mention it. Therefore, he thought that Lei Tie also had no time to spare for the time being.

“Even if you have cultivation, it’ll be very tiring to stare at him with the spiritual sense for five months. Why didn’t you tell me?” Qin Mian was both moved and distressed. He opened his mouth and bit Lei Tie’s neck.

Lei Tie pulled Qin Mian to lie down, put his arm under his wife’s head, and coldly said, “I’ll never let go of those who bully you.”

Qin Mian felt his heart melt by the warmth the man had given him. He climbed on the man’s body, put his elbows on that hard chest, and held the man’s head in his hands as he looked directly at the man.

Lei Tie caressed his wife’s shoulder. Despite the nightclothes being in the way, he could still feel the smoothness and fineness of his wife’s skin. He asked softly, “What?”

“Husband, you are super!” Qin Mian smiled at him with a look of exultation, carrying a smear of banter in his eyes.

Lei Tie’s heartbeat was thrown into disorder by the new address. His two big palms seized his wife’s waist and his passionate eyes tightly locked on his wife, “Wife, call again.”

His body temperature, as hot as boiling magma, transmitted to Qin Mian in an instant. When Qin Mian realized that the joke turned to be a big deal, he turned to get off the man but couldn’t move.

“Wife, call again,” Lei Tie’s deep voice patiently coaxed as his iron arm wrapped around his wife’s waist, while the other hand clasped the back of his wife’s head, making their nose tips touched.

“Lady³,” called Qin Mian joyfully with a smile on his face. When he clearly saw several tiny spittle flopped on Lei Tie’s lips, his cheeks heated up and his heart became restless.

The tip of Lei Tie’s brow arched, and then he unscrupulously pulled off his wife’s clothes...

As though the moon was shy, it slowly hid within the clouds.

The sound astir in the bedroom became louder and louder. A good while later, after a trembling “husband” was suddenly uttered, tranquility was restored. A moment later, came an angry roar, “Lei Tie! You mensao!”

Downstairs, White Spot and Golden Fur were woken up. They glanced up at the second floor, lay back on the ground, and continued to sleep with their heads next to each other.

“*Aa yaa?*” A tender voice came from the crib.

Qin Mian turned to look at the crib. Yuanyuan and Manman had woken up; Yuanyuan sat with his back against the railing, while Manman had turned on his stomach at an unknown time. The two little ones curiously looked in the direction of the big bed.

Did the two little ones see all that happened just now? Qin Mian’s face turned red. He quickly grabbed the tattered nightclothes and put them on his body, covering however much possible. Then, he kicked Lei Tie out of the bed.

Note:

Footnotes

1. outwardly cold or retiring but deep and passionate inside
2. 兔儿爷 [tù r yé] clay rabbit for the Mid-Autumn Festival; lit. Lord Leveret, also known as the Moon Rabbit God. I don’t think ZSF meant the latter, since calling someone a 兔子 rabbit can mean a swear word. In short, it’s a double meaning.

3. 娘子 [niáng zǐ] a form of address for one's wife

Chapter 142: One Year Old

142 – One Year Old

“*Gehgehgeh*¹...” Manman clapped his small hands and laughed until his saliva flowed out. Yuanyuan suspiciously stared at his Old Dad on the ground, *is it a new play?*

Lei Tie calmly got up from the ground, let the two little ones lie down properly, and swayed the crib to coax them to sleep.

Qin Mian ran over and carried one baby in each hand. Then, he put the two little ones in the middle of the big bed and lay down on the left side of the bed.

Lei Tie stood still for a short period before shaking his head. He took out new nightclothes from the wardrobe to put on his wife but was robbed of that.

Lei Tie self-consciously lay on the right side of the bed. As he recollected the pleasant feeling of his wife’s new address for him, his eyes involuntarily fell on his wife’s face, making someplace on his body restless again.

Qin Mian unintentionally saw it. He lifted his leg to kick Lei Tie, but his foot was caught by Lei Tie’s big hand, who then pinched it gently. Feeling tickled, he shrunk away.

“Wife, stop making trouble. Sleep.”

Qin Mian used the back of his head to face the man and unknowingly entered dreamland.

Lei Tie patted the two little ones until they fell asleep and he took them back to the crib. He lay behind his wife and took the person into his arms, which only then he felt at ease. Contented, he closed his eyes.

It was unknown whether Qin Mian was aware of it, but the corners of his mouth curled up.

A few days later, in the early morning, the deafening sound of firecrackers woke up the small village. The sound of firecrackers lasted for half an hour. After stopping for about two breaths, it sounded again and mixed with the percussion sound of gongs, unceasing for a long time.

Lei Xiangzhi passed!

He obtained Yayuan² in the provincial examination, in other words, the second place.

The whole village was sensational. In private, the villagers said that Lei Daqiang and Du Shi had prayed to the Buddha a lot in their previous lives. Lei Xiangzhi had become the only Lord Juren³ in Green Mountain Village. Based on the current situation, he was very likely to get good results in the conference and palace examinations. At the thought of Lei Xiangzhi being able to obtain a Tanhua, Banyan, or Zhuangyuan⁴ in the future, the villagers could not contain their excitement. If outsiders were so excited, those in the old house were more so.

Three days later, Qin Mian and Lei Tie asked Uncle Fu to send Lei Xiangzhi six books and a red envelope with 10 silver taels in it – they did not attend the banquet.

The conference examination was also held every three years. This one would be held in the 4th lunar month two years later, also known as the spring examination. Lei Xiangzhi still had plenty of time to prepare.

After the excitement, Green Mountain Village ushered into the busy golden autumn season in the 10th lunar month.

When the servants brought back the harvested soybeans, Qin Mian inadvertently remembered the fermented tofu he had made before and forgotten. He quickly told Lei Tie to take the jar out and open it.

After two years of fermentation, the fermented tofu was still in a neat shape. It was bright red in color and smooth in texture, and had a slightly smelly aroma but tasted soft and delicious. Its spiciness satisfied a craving.

With only a piece of fermented tofu, Qin Mian ate three bowls of rice. His stomach was full but he wanted to eat it again. Lei Tie also liked the spicy flavor no less than his wife.

Qin Mian did not let go of any business opportunities. He asked Uncle Fu to order 1,000 white porcelain jars about the size of fermented tofu jars of later generations, which were also printed with their logo and trademarks. Then, he asked people to buy back a large number of fresh tofu and teach them how to make fermented tofu. The fermented tofu was put into beautiful white porcelain jars; each jar contained twelve pieces. After a year, they would be sold at the price of 1 tael per jar. When one had no appetite to eat, eating rice with fermented tofu was the best choice.

.....

Winter gave place to spring, bringing along another year. In the twinkling of an eye, it was the 26th year of Emperor Xiaohui's reign.⁵

Yuanyuan and Manman grew healthily and strongly like the small saplings sprouting; two days later would be their first birthday.

One-year-old was a small transition in the life of the two little ones; Qin Mian attached great importance to it. He started to prepare two days in advance and left the two little ones to their Old Dad. He and the steward led the servants to bustle about together.

Lei Tie sat on the soft rug in the living room with the two little ones. Yuanyuan was very athletic; his favorite thing to do was to climb up and down his Old Dad. Lei Tie supported him with a blank face, so as not to fall, and occasionally helped him climb up.

Manman was unwilling to be left out in the cold; he threw away his toys and crawled two steps toward his Old Dad before he halted as if thinking of something. It seemed that crawling was too slow, so with two hands laid on the ground, he propped himself up, and with exertion from his small buttocks, he stood up. He hobbled to Lei Tie with a happy smile on his small face as he called out, “Old Dad, Old Dad!”

Lei Tie hugged him in time and let him sit down. With a warm voice, he said, “Manman, your Dad doesn’t let you learn to walk too early.”

With his not-so-rich facial expression, bystanders might think he was angry. However, Manman was not afraid of him; he pounced forward and stood with the help of his Old Dad in a fit of giggles, climbing up his Old Dad like it was competition with his Gege⁶.

Lei Tie took the opportunity to lie down on the rug and let the two little ones crawl up and down on him and pull his hair and the front of his shirts.

He raised his head and looked out – it was almost noon. His wife hadn’t come back.

“Gege.” Manman grasped Yuanyuan’s clothes.

Yuanyuan threw a look at Manman over his shoulder and called out in deadpan, “Didi.”

“*Gehgeheh...*” Manman climbed to Lei Tie’s chest, stretched out his chubby hands, and curiously poked his Old Dad’s face, pinched his nose, and then pulled his ears.

Yuanyuan looked at his Old Dad and then looked at Manman; he frowned. As if he wanted to stop his Didi from bullying his Old Dad but also didn’t want to let his Didi down, he leaned down and hugged his Old Dad’s head. His small soft lips gently kissed his Old Dad on the cheek.

Lei Tie’s eyes were filled with warmth as he reached out to rub his son’s small head.

Qin Mian leaned against the doorframe with his arms folded across the chest and an emotional smile hung on his face. Yuanyuan talked less and Lei Tie also talked less. He had been worried that Yuanyuan and Lei Tie would have less communication with each other. Yet, it seemed that he thought too much. *The little one, Yuanyuan, is smart!*

Noticing the light at the door was partly blocked, Lei Tie raised his head to look over; his deep eyes were dyed with tenderness. His 17-year-old youngster had already grown tall, only half a head shorter than him. The moon-white robe appropriately outlined his slender and straight body shape, perfectly set off the temperament of delicate beauty. His face and neck were browned due to sun exposure for several days, making his whole person looked healthier and more seductive, which made Lei Tie practically unable to shift his gaze.

“Yuanyuan and Manman, Dad is back.” Qin Mian walked over a few steps and sat on the rug. He leaned over Yuanyuan’s face to kiss him on the cheek and then kissed Manman on the cheek, too. Seeing a certain someone’s eager eyes, his lips curled into a grin. With his back to Yuanyuan and Manman, he gave a certain someone a hard kiss.

“Dad!”

“Dad.”

Delighted, Manman crawled toward Qin Mian. Yuanyuan, who had shown a dignified bearing at a young age, followed after Manman to crawl at a steady speed.

“Dad, fruity.”

Qin Mian understood that the two little ones wanted to eat fruits. He picked two peaches from the space, giving one to Lei Tie. After peeling the skin, they scraped the flesh with a spoon and fed it to the babies.

“Wife, how is the preparation?”

Qin Mian was about to speak when Yuanyuan, with no expression, uttered a word, “Wife.”

The spoon in Lei Tie’s hand shook and the fruit flesh on the spoon fell on the rug.

After Qin Mian was taken aback, he rolled with laughter while hammering his fist on the rug, “HAHAHA...”

Lei Tie silently looked at Yuanyuan for a good while, and then pointed to Qin Mian as he said, “He is my wife, you can’t call [him that].”

Yuanyuan blinked his eyes as he looked at his Old Dad for a long time before he uttered, “Oh.” It was unknown whether he really understood it or not.

Qin Mian then laughed so much that he lost breath and even tears burst out of his eyes.

Lei Tie dotingly looked at him, wiped his tears with his thumb, and patted his back.

Grinning broadly, Manman also stretched out a small hand to pat Qin Mian’s back, “Dad, silly!”

Qin Mian stiffened, promptly stopped his laughter. He lightly coughed and continued to feed him with a deadpan face.

“Son, [we] can’t say Dad is silly. Dad is the smartest in our family.”

Lei Tie shook his head and fed Yuanyuan.

Qin Mian wiped the fruit flesh spread on the rug with a handkerchief and answered Lei Tie’s previous question, “Everything is properly arranged. The steward will take others to deal with the rest.”

Two days later, Yuanyuan and Manman’s one-year-old birthday arrived.

The two little ones wore new clothes and looked even cuter and smarter. On their heads were baby hats in the shape of a yellow duckling; on their upper bodies were blue shirts and yellow sleeveless pullover jackets with a large blue pocket on the chest embroidered with big apple; on their lower bodies were a pair of blue closed-hem trousers and tiger-head shoes on their feet.

Qin Mian fetched two similar boxes from the wardrobe; one of which was inscribed with Yuanyuan's name, Qin Ruiqi, and the other box was inscribed with Manman's name, Lei Ruilin. Then, he took out two 10-tael silver ingots and put them into the two boxes before locking the boxes.

Lei Tie was puzzled.

Qin Mian patted the boxes and explained with a smile, "We'll save a sum of money for our sons every time they celebrate their birthday. When they are ten years old, [we'll] give them these savings and let them learn how to manage money."

Lei Tie nodded with understanding. His wife always had a lot of extraordinary ideas.

Nowadays, there were more servants in Leisurely Farmhouse to manage and care in all aspects. Qin Mian arranged the place for the banquet in Leisurely Farmhouse. The grove in Leisurely Farmhouse was restructured a year ago; a large area of open space was planted with green grass, just perfect to arrange the banquet here.

Close to noon, guests came one after another.

Before eating longevity noodles, the grabbing ceremony⁷ should be carried out first.

The living room was covered with a rug. Qin Mian and Lei Tie each held Yuanyuan and Manman on the rug. Placed on the ground were a book, a brush, an ink stick, a paper, an inkstone, a stamp, an abacus, a copper coin, a silver, a scallion, a wooden sword, and more than twenty kinds of items.

The guests all gathered around in curiosity.

Qin Mian squatted on one side and said to Yuanyuan and Manman, “Yuanyuan, Manman, choose the one you like best and give it to your Old Dad and Dad.”

Yuanyuan picked up the inkstone nearest to him, turned it over, and put it down. He looked around and was attracted by the circular stamp, but he didn’t take it after looking at it for a while. His eyes rested on the wooden sword for a time before he curiously picked it up to play with.

At first, Manman crawled behind his Gege. When he saw the stamp, his eyes brightened and he quickly crawled over to pick it up. Holding it tightly, he raised his small head toward Qin Mian and laughed, “Dad, *gehgeh*...”

The guests laughed as they congratulated.

“Two sons; one literary and the other martial. Ah, masters of brush and sword. Congratulations, congratulations!”

Note:

Footnotes

1. It’s a baby’s gurgle of laughter.
2. The title of the second-placed candidate. First-placed is called Jieyuan.
3. 举人 [jǔ rén] lit. “recommended man”, a qualified graduate who passed the triennial provincial exam.
4. The title of the top scorers in the palace exam respectively: Flower Snatcher (3rd placed); Eyes Positioned Alongside (2nd placed); Number One Scholar (1st placed)
5. I checked the history and Emperor Xiaohui existed, 2nd Emperor of Han Dynasty (211-188 BC), but not personified in this novel because the real Emperor Xiaohui died at the age of 24. By the way, Xiaohui is the title, not the name.
6. I’m pretty sure you all are familiar with this word, but anyway, Gege is big bro and Didi is Lil bro.

7. a custom of placing a variety of articles (writing brush, abacus, etc) before an infant on its first birthday to see which one he or she picks up.

Chapter 143: You Refine Tools; I Refine Pills

143 – You Refine Tools; I Refine Pills

“Many thanks for your blessed words.”

Qin Mian picked up Yuanyuan and looked at his serious appearance; he couldn't help pecking at his tender small face.

The corners of Yuanyuan's mouth raised into a little smile. He cupped his Dad's face and smacked a kiss on it.

Not to be outdone, Manman put his arms around Lei Tie's neck, smacked a loud kiss on his cheek with a “pop” sound, and looked at his Gege with his small provocative eyes.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie involuntarily looked at each other and smiled.

Other people, all without exception, envied them.

Uncle Fu entertained all the guests with warmth and attention, “My guests, please come to the banquet table.”

With Leisurely Farmhouse being so elegant, coupled with its owners and servants being so polite, the guests unconsciously put away their usual rough side and changed to elegant manners; they cupped their hands and saluted each other.

“Please.”

“Please, *you* go first.”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli also helped to greet the guests.

“Dad, down.” Yuanyuan pointed to the ground.

Qin Mian hesitated before putting him down. According to the guide book, it was not good for children to learn to walk too early. However, since it was the child’s own will, he believed it was better to follow it. Moreover, as their children were not ordinary, they could not blindly follow the guide in the book.

As Yuanyuan waddled forward, Qin Mian followed after him with outstretched hands, ready to support him at any time.

Manman, who had been looking at his Gege, struggled to slip down from Lei Tie’s arms. When Lei Tie put him on the ground, he got a grin from the little one with his four lovely little teeth the size of corn kernels on display.

Then, the little one slowly walked a few steps. As if he had gained experience, his walking soon steadied. Manman excitedly trotted to Yuanyuan and held hands with him.

Qin Mian crossed his arms over his chest as he looked at the brothers with a contradictory expression of joy and worry on his face.

“What’s wrong?” Lei Tie put his arm around Qin Mian’s shoulders.

Qin Mian sighed, “If a child can walk and run, it means that the child can also be ‘harmed’.”

As soon as he finished saying, he saw Yuanyuan reach for the cup on the tea table. He quickly ran to stop him, “Son, can’t touch this, it’s hot.”

Manman let go of his Gege’s hand and grabbed a flower in the flower pot. His small hand put forth its strength and picked the flower, which he brought toward his mouth to stuff in.

“Can’t eat.” Lei Tie snatched it in time.

Manman looked up at him with a smile that was rather a bit cunning and turned around to go out. His body was small, but his pace was very firm with his small hands clenched into fists – a posture of advancing bravely.

Lei Tie slightly shook his head and kept up with him. Now he understood a little why his wife's happiness carried along with melancholy.

When Yuanyuan found out, he caught up in small steps.

“Didi.”

Qin Mian watched the two little carrots staggered forward while holding hands and their small buttocks swayed with the pace. Inwardly, he cried out “too adorable” while noiselessly laughing.

Manman turned to look at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, “Old Dad, Dad, clasp.”

Lei Tie cooperatively held Qin Mian's hand in his and pinched it from time to time.

“Shake,” said Yuanyuan. He even swung his and Manman's clasped hands back and forth to teach them.

Once again, Lei Tie did as he was told.

Qin Mian's head was full of black lines as he speechlessly looked at Lei Tie make such childish action with his cold and harsh manly face.

Manman nodded his head in satisfaction and continued to move forward.

The man seemed to be in a good mood and his two sons also looked very happy, so Qin Mian simply let it go. Together with Lei Tie, he swayed their clasped hands and strolled in the quiet front courtyard.

Not far out, they saw Lei Chuntao, who appeared hesitant as if full of worry, under the peach tree. Lei Chuntao was half a year older than Qin Mian and soon to be 18 years old. She was petite, beautiful, and lively. Usually, when she walked around the village, many young men secretly looked at her.

“Aunt.” Manman pulled the corner of Lei Chuntao’s skirt.

Lei Chuntao came back to her senses and said, “Ah! Manman is so smart to actually remember Aunt.” She picked him up with care and rubbed his little head.

“Aunt,” called Yuanyuan, too.

“Yuanyuan, good boy.” Lei Chuntao was in a dilemma; she couldn’t hold two children at the same time.

Lei Tie took Manman from her arms and Qin Mian also picked Yuanyuan up. Then, Qin Mian looked at Lei Chuntao with concern, “Little Sister, why didn’t you go to sit there?”

Lei Chuntao began to speak and then hesitated. Her face was a little pale as she said in a low voice, “Father and Mother have been worrying about my... affairs. Mother prefers a rich man in the town, while Father wants... to betroth me to a Xuicai...”

Generally, girls get married when they were 14 or 15 years old, and some even got married when they were 13 years old. Lei Chuntao would be 18 years old in autumn; it was somewhat late for her to get married. From her tone of speaking, she seemed unsatisfied with either of the two choices; there might be something hidden in it. This girl was simple and kind. Qin Mian really regarded her as his younger sister. However, to be honest, he didn’t want to mix up with the old house. Therefore, he could only say, “You have the best relationship with Fifth Brother. If you have any unhappy things, you may as well have a chat with Fifth Brother.”

After the students passed the provincial examination, the academy did not insist that they must stay in the academy; they could continue to study in the academy, or they could choose another place for self-study. Lei Xiangzhi had always been strict with himself. He still lived in the academy and came back once a month as before. Once a while, when something happened, he also came back several times.

Lei Chuntao was clever and sensible; she understood Qin Mian's meaning and her flustered self then calmed down. She curtsied to Qin Mian with ease. "Thank you for your advice. But, it's inconvenient for me to go out. I wonder if I could trouble Eldest Sister-in-law to send a message to Fifth Brother in the county? I'm afraid if it's late, something else will happen."

"No problem." Qin Mian nodded with a smile and immediately called a passing servant. He asked the servant to find someone, who had nothing to do at hand, to go to the county.

Lei Chuntao looked at the servant who ran away and felt a lot at ease. When she thought of herself as a girl who had yet married took the initiative to mention her marriage affair, she blushed.

"Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law, then I..."

Qin Mian was amused. "Quickly go to have a meal. If late, I'm afraid you can only eat leftovers."

"En, I'm going. Thank you, Eldest Sister-in-law." Lei Chuntao lifted her skirt and ran away.

That afternoon, Lei Xiangzhi came back from the county town. A few days later, it was spread in the village that a matchmaker came to match Lei Chuntao, and the match was Huo Sirui, the son of Huo Dean of Qingyun Academy! Huo Sirui was the first place in the provincial examination – a Jieyuan! Like Lei Xiangzhi, he was likely to be the Number One Scholar in the future. How could Lei Daqiang and Du be unwilling?

Later, Lei Chuntao revealed to Qin Mian that Huo Sirui had come to her home several times. She and Huo Sirui had met several times, and both of them had a good feeling for each other. Of course, the relationship was one of affection within etiquettes and mutual 'give and take' without selfishness.

What she didn't know was that when Dean Huo and Madam Huo found out that their son had taken a fancy to Lei Xiangzhi's sister, they investigated the situation of the Lei family. Madam Huo even secretly met Lei Chuntao

once and liked her very much. However, she held Lei Daqiang and Du Shi in contempt, so she had been hesitating.

Huo Sirui consoled her by stating that she would be taking in a daughter-in-law, not marrying off a daughter. Whatever Lei Daqiang and Du Shi's characters were, it had nothing to do with them. Only then Madam Huo was coaxed and sent people to match-making.

Lei Chuntao's wedding date was set on the 18th day of the 10th lunar month, half a month earlier than her birthday. She was still going to be 17 years old at that time, and it would be pleasant to hear.

Lei Xiangzhi's marriage also had been decided. With Dean Huo as the matchmaker, the bride's party was the daughter of Teacher Li of Qingyun Academy. Teacher Li also had investigated the situation of Lei Xiangzhi's family. Like Madam Huo, he had not a bit of a favorable impression on Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, but he was truly reluctant to give up Lei Xiangzhi, a good son-in-law candidate. He had to ask his daughter's opinion in person, and her daughter agreed. Considering his daughter's decision, she might be able to subdue the parents-in-law, so the matter was decided. Lei Xiangzhi's marriage date was one month earlier than Lei Chuntao, which was on the 28th day of the 9th lunar month.

Both Lei Daqiang and Du Shi's son and daughter had found a good marriage; they walked around the village with attitude. There was no need to go into details.

In the 9th lunar month, Lei Xiangzhi got married. Qin Mian and Lei Tie prepared a gift, but they didn't go to the banquet and also didn't show up for the 'visit new in-laws after a marriage' the next day. Li Shi was a wonderful woman. On the second day after her homecoming,¹ she visited them and gave Yuanyuan and Manman meeting gifts.

Li Shi was as efficient and able as Wei Shi, and could even be counted as shrewish, quite like Wang Xifeng². Qin Mian believed that the days in the old house would become turbulent again.

A month later, Lei Chuntao got married. Married far into the county town, it was hard for the bride alone in a strange place. Besides giving her two dowries, Qin Mian and Lei Tie also gave her 50 silver taels, which were pressed down at the bottom of the box.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi's love for this daughter was not much less than Lei Xiangzhi's. Lei Chuntao was married off to Zhaoyang County in a grand fashion.

After both Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Chuntao had gotten married, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had less contact with the old house. The focus of their life was not only on Yuanyuan and Manman but also on refining pills and refining tools. As Yuanyuan and Manman had turned one-year-old, it was easier for the fathers and sons to communicate with each other; the two children also were easier to take care of than before. Whenever the couple had a chance, they entered the space.

The refining room in the space not only collected hundreds of spiritual tools such blades, swords, bows, crossbows, battle-axes, hatchets, hooks, whips, and anything that one could think of, but also several pieces of tool formulas fused in jade bamboo strips. Meanwhile, the alchemy room had a collection of pills with various effects such as the heart-clearing pill, marrow-washing pill, soul-seizing pill, ageless pill, appearance-changing pill, and so on. In addition to these, there were tens of thousands of pill formulas, which were classified and collected in jade strips by the previous owner of the space. The spiritual garden was even more wonderful. There were countless kinds of spiritual grass and spiritual plants. In the space, the rarest 500-year-old ginseng in the secular world could only be ranked at the bottom.

As to not waste the resources in the space, Qin Mian and Lei Tie discussed and decided that each of them choose one to learn, either refining tools or refining pills. Qin Mian chose to refine pills and Lei Tie chose to learn refining tools.

The first pill that Qin Mian learned to refine was the ageless pill, which could slow down the aging process of ordinary people. After repeated trials, he managed to refine pills comparable to an inferior grade. Twelve pills for

one course of treatment with one pill taken monthly, after three courses of treatment, one could be at least 10 years younger. He and Lei Tie especially went to Deng Village to give one course of treatment to both Old Man Deng and Old Lady Deng. The couple said that the medicine was bought in secret at a high price, lest the old man and old lady leak the news, and told them that they would be given medicine for the next two years.

The first spiritual tool that Lei Tie had successfully refined was a protective jade pendant. When the wearer was unable to resist external attacks, such as being unconscious, it could automatically protect the wearer for nine times. He gave the jade pendant to Qin Mian. Qin Mian had been wearing it around his neck. The second spiritual tool made by Lei Tie was given to his two sons. It was a pair of bracelets, which had the function of sensing poison. Yuanyuan and Manman each wore one. The two little ones were still young and had no self-protection ability. Wearing the bracelets could prevent them from being harmed by poisons.

Being put before his sons in Lei Tie's heart, Qin Mian felt pleasantly sweet in his heart and also sorry for his two sons. After he was pressed on the bed and thoroughly bullied by Lei Tie everywhere several times, he didn't have the mind to indulge in flights of fancy.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Homecoming refers to the return of the bride to her mother's home on the third day of the wedding.
2. A villainous character with great capabilities in *Dream of the Red Mansion*.

Chapter 144: Gifted Ingenious Children

144 – Gifted Ingenious Children

Two years later...

It was sunny for two days before it began to rain. At first, it was only a fine drizzle, but it soon became heavy rain. Rainwater fell from the roof, like a natural bead curtain. The raindrops pitter-pattered on the green leaves, and soon there were more pools of water on the wet ground. Although it was the 3rd lunar month, it was still very cold because of the rain. Qin Mian got up and went to the bedroom to get Yuanyuan and Manman's cotton-padded coats.

The two boys, who were a month short of three-year-old, sat on two adjustable-height dining chairs while leaning forward on the table as they obediently scooped rice in their small bowls to eat with spoons. They also wore a blue bib around their necks.

“*Aih*, can't play happily in rainy weather.” Manman propped his chin and sighed like a small adult as he looked at the misty rain outside with melancholy.

The corner of Lei Tie's mouth curled up; he wiped the steamed egg custard on the corner of Manman's mouth with a handkerchief.

When Qin Mian came in with the two little boys' coats, he heard Manman's words and was simmered with laughter. *A small kid also knows to sigh.*

Then, he heard Yuanyuan said, “Didi, rainy weather has arrived, is sunny weather still far away?”

Qin Mian palmed his forehead. He was wrong. He shouldn’t have replaced a storybook with an essay textbook last night.

He went over and rubbed Yuanyuan’s head. “Alright, you two little boys. If you don’t eat quickly, the food will be cold.”

Lei Tie took the coats in his wife’s hand, “Wife, you eat.”

Qin Mian saw two shelled salty eggs on his plate and softly laughed. Needless to say, Lei Tie must have helped him peel them.

“A-Tie, you’ve finished eating?”

“En.” Lei Tie took off the bibs on the sons’ necks before putting on the thick coats for them, and then tied the bibs again. With his cultivation, he didn’t need to eat grains anymore, but he didn’t want to miss any of his wife’s cooking.

Manman held up his bowl with two hands and said in a clear and loud voice, “Old Dad, Manman still wants to eat egg custard.”

“Manman is awesome today,” praised Lei Tie promptly as he followed Qin Mian’s teaching. He carried the remaining half-bowl of steamed egg custard and added to Manman’s bowl until half full with a big spoon. Then, he looked at Yuanyuan, “Yuanyuan.”

Yuanyuan nodded his head, “Yuanyuan also wants.”

Qin Mian sat next to Yuanyuan and picked some tender and soft leaves from the stir-fried amaranth and put them into Yuanyuan and Manman’s bowls.

Their Dad said that they couldn’t be picky about food. So, the two little boys ate the vegetables obediently.

Lei Tie sat back on his original seat and clipped dishes for Qin Mian. “Wife, you eat. I’ll do it. ”

“En.” Qin Mian took a bite of the salted egg and the oil seeped out. Elated, he took another bite with the corners of his eyes raised into a charming smile.

It’s merely a salted egg with oil seeping out and he is so contented. The bottom of Lei Tie’s heart turned into a piece of cotton.

Manman smiled as he approached Yuanyuan’s ear and whispered, “Gege, Old Dad looks at Dad in a trance.”

Yuanyuan nodded, “En.”

The corner of Qin Mian’s mouth twitched. He said with a straight face, “Eat properly.”

At once, Yuanyuan and Manman sat upright in a well-behaved manner and ate the dishes in the bowl with single-hearted devotion.

After Qin Mian finished two salted eggs, his eyes drifted to the plate containing the salted eggs.

Wordlessly, Lei Tie picked up one and shelled it before handing it to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian received it with a smile and bit half of it. The remaining half was put into his man’s mouth.

When the fathers and sons had eaten well, Qin Mian wiped the boys’ mouths and washed their faces and hands. Lei Tie put the dirty tableware in the kitchen, kept the unfinished dishes in the cupboard, cleaned his hands, and went back to the living room. After the meal, it was playtime for the two sons.

As soon as Lei Tie appeared, Yuanyuan immediately ran and held his hand.

“Alright.” Qin Mian clapped his hands. “Let’s go and see if the bird ate the fruit last night.”

After that, he held Manman’s hand.

“Let’s go!” Manman strode forward into a run.

The fathers and sons came into the corridor.

On each step of the stairs, a card was posted on the corresponding railing pillars. On the card were all kinds of fruits pictures, including pears, peaches, sweet oranges, cherries, strawberries, watermelon, and so on.

Yuanyuan and Manman let go of their fathers’ hands and ran forward.

Qin Mian called them to stop in a disapproving voice, “Yuanyuan, Manman, what did Dad say?”

Yuanyuan and Manman halted for a moment before speaking in concert, “Can’t run after eating!”

Qin Mian nodded approvingly, “Excellent!”

The two little boys went to the stairs in a well-behaved manner and climbed up step by step with their small legs as they counted in a crisp voice, “One, two, three...”

The pigtails on the top of their heads were like two young seedlings swaying; so adorable.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie slowly followed after them.

Arriving at the room on the second floor, there were also cards of various fruits on the wooden floor.

After Yuanyuan Manman finished counting, they rushed to Qin Mian to report.

“Dad, there are twenty-two fruits!” Yuanyuan rushed first and gave no time for his Didi.

Manman was not at all offended when his Gege rushed first. He smiled at his Gege and turned to look at his Dad, knowing that his Dad would ask questions.

“Yuanyuan and Manman remember how many fruits were there last night?” asked Qin Mian with a smile as he squatted down.

This time, Manman said it first, “Thirty.”

Qin Mian motioned to Lei Tie to ask next.

Lei Tie gently spoke, “A total of thirty fruits, only twenty-two left. How many fruits did the bird eat?”

Once again, Manman took the lead. With two small hands behind his back and head raised, he said in a somewhat proud manner, “Eight oh!”

“Manman is excellent!” Qin Mian kissed once on his cheek, “Dad asks you two again, which fruits are eaten by the bird?”

Manman touched his chin. Just now, he was only focused on counting.

Yuanyuan, with a calm appearance, answered, “Dad, the bird ate two apples, three strawberries, and three peaches.”

“Yuanyuan is also excellent!” Qin Mian also kissed him. He was very proud.

The game they played today was something he had figured out. The purpose was to let the children play indoors when the weather was bad and couldn’t play outdoors. They could also learn while walking to help digestion after eating a meal.

When Yuanyuan and Manman were one and a half years old, Qin Mian and Lei Tie found that they were more intelligent than ordinary children, and began to cultivate them after they turned two years old. The two children

were excellent. The most prominent advantage of Yuanyuan was that he was careful and observant; meanwhile, the most prominent advantage of Manman was that he had an agile mind and quick reaction. Up to now, the three-year-old children in other families couldn't count from one to ten, but Yuanyuan and Manman could skillfully calculate addition and subtraction within thirty.

Lei Tie then took them to play, "Yuanyuan, Manman, let's put all the fruits [cards] into the basket."

"Alright, Old Dad."

On the bottom layer of the storage rack next to the wardrobe were two identical baskets made of bamboo in the size that could almost fit a basketball; each baskets' handle hung with either Yuanyuan or Manman's nametags. Yuanyuan and Manman could already recognize their names (couldn't write it yet). After they found their names, they carried the baskets and picked up the cards on the floor with their small buttocks perked up. Once they had finished here, they would clean up the cards on the stair railing.

Qin Mian quietly went ahead.

After the two children had picked up the cards from the top to the bottom steps, Qin Mian said, "Alright, sons, let's go up to put the cards away and place them in the drawer."

"Yes." Yuanyuan and Manman enthusiastically climbed up to the second floor while not realizing that their Dad "cheated" them.

Upstairs, Qin Mian asked the two children to sort out the picture cards and count them separately. 'Surprisingly', they found that several cards were missing. Of course, Qin Mian had stealthily taken the few missing pieces. He asked the children what fruits they had lost. The two babies answered it correctly.

After learning mathematics, Lei Tie led two little boys to practice a set of fighting techniques: arms stretching and split kick. And that concluded the

aiding digestion activity.

Next, the fathers taught their children how to write. At present, they used pencils. First, they learned Arabic numerals and some simple characters such as 天 (sky), 地 (ground), 风 (wind), 雨 (rain), 日 (sun), and so on.

The two boys yawned after learning for less than an hour. The two fathers coaxed them to sleep and put them in the crib. Only then they had their own free time.

Qin Mian lay down lazily on the bed, a little listless. “It’s no wonder that Manman doesn’t like rainy days, I don’t like it either. We can only coop up in the house, very boring.”

Lei Tie watched him quietly for a long time, and then suddenly closed the curtain, which made the room darker.

Qin Mian did not understand, “What are you doing?”

Lei Tie returned to the side of the bed, sat down on the edge of the bed, and raised his right hand. An orange spark suddenly appeared in his hand. Then, the spark grew bigger and bigger and gradually became round. It was like a rising sun floating upward. Finally, it stayed two chi¹ away from the roof. In the room, the table, chairs, wardrobe, bookshelf, and so on cast dark shadows on the walls and floor; silence yet lively.

Qin Mian quietly looked at Lei Tie and smiled. Then, he sat up, rested his body on the man’s back, and slowly wrote three words on his back with his index finger. At the last stroke, his finger was caught by a big palm.

Lei Tie kissed the slender finger and put it into his mouth. The tip of his tongue glided up and down on the pad of the finger as he licked it.

Qin Mian felt numb all over his body, just like an electric current spreading from his fingertips to his whole body. He dodged, “No, in case the children wake up...” With a wave of Lei Tie’s left hand, the curtain hanging in the middle of the room slowly unfolded into a cloth wall, separating the crib and the big bed into two small worlds.

Lei Tie made this curtain the next day when Yuanyuan and Manman saw Qin Mian and Lei Tie were intimate by chance. Every time Qin Mian saw it, he involuntarily recalled that scene and glared at Lei Tie fiercely but it had no deterrent force, only because he was looking forward to this.

A flash of a smile seemed to have passed by in Lei Tie's eyes.

Qin Mian became angry. He exerted a force, pressed the man under his body, and triumphantly looked at him, "Give in or not?"

Lei Tie touched his face, softly called him "fool", and fiercely kissed him...

Outside the window, the rain babbled and the wind was as cold as winter. Inside the house, however, was a scene of spring². Worried that they would wake up Yuanyuan and Manman, Qin Mian didn't dare to make a sound. Therefore, his five senses seemed to be ten times sensitive than usual. At the *happiest* peak, he bit Lei Tie's shoulder. Unable to suppress it, he let out a muffled yet provocative whimper.

Lei Tie hugged Qin Mian tightly, his shoulders sank as he achieved physical and mental connection with Qin Mian.

Weak and soft, Qin Mian lay on the man's body with his head rubbed against his neck and cheek plastered on his skin.

The "sun" above was gone at an unknown time.

Qin Mian pulled up the quilt to cover them both and mumbled, "It's too dark. Don't scare the children."

Lei Tie exerted his spiritual energy to make the curtain slide to one side. His hands returned into the quilt and caressed the place he liked to fondle admiringly.

"Wife."

"Hm," answered Qin Mian lazily with his eyes closed.

“After our sons’ three-year-old birthday, our family is going to the Capital for a month,” said Lei Tie.

Qin Mian suddenly raised his head, looked at him in surprise, and happily counted the days, “Great! The boys’ birthday is on the 10th day of the 4th month, which is a warm spring day. It takes more than half a month to go to the Capital and then visit the Capital for a month, so when we come back, the weather won’t be too hot. Perfect! Also, this is our family’s first trip together!”

Lei Tie propped up his chin, kissed his lips, and put his arm back in his arms. “Sleep while the children aren’t awake.” He remembered that his wife planned to continue to expand the family business when the children reached the age of three; there would be fewer opportunities to go out and play in the future. Hence, now was a good time.

Note:

Footnotes

1. (memory refresh) A chi is one-third of a meter.
2. Ehem, spring here has two meanings: the beginning of spring/thoughts of love.

Chapter 145: The Family of Four Goes to Travel

145 – The Family of Four Goes to Travel

There were many things to be arranged before leaving. Most of the employees in the winery and vermicelli workshop were from the village; apart from emphasizing confidentiality, there was no need for special attention. Eating Savory Restaurant and the bakery were arranged as per usual. Only Double Xiang House was the key point of Qin Mian's arrangement. In the past three years, Double Xiang House had hardly developed any new dishes because it had held activities almost once a month, such as a poem recitation contest, lottery drawing, collecting all kinds of cards for prizes, storytelling contest, and fruit-picking competition. All kinds of new activities emerged one after another. The business of Double Xiang House had not deteriorated at all but had become more and more prosperous. This trip would at least take two months, so in case there was any mishap in the business, there was none in the family that could take charge. Therefore, Qin Mian told Manager Sun that while he and Lei Tie were away, Double Xiang House no longer carried out activities; everything had to be secured-oriented.

Lei Tie only planned to take Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun together. As for the remaining seven armed servants, he arranged two to stay in Leisurely Farmhouse and five to oversee Double Xiang House.

The news of the Qin Mian family's trip to the Capital soon spread. Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui came when they heard the news.

In the 3rd lunar month, peach blossoms were in full bloom. The peach blossoms clustered together, woven into a pink cloud tree. It was a peaceful

sunny day and the spring breeze was gentle. Lei Tie was leading Yuanyuan and Manman to practice boxing under the peach tree with White Spot and Golden Fur followed to wobble along as they joined in the fun.

A round table, two large armchairs, and two small armchairs were placed under the peach tree not far away. On the table were a tea set, a basket of apples, and two plates of snacks. Qin Mian was leaning forward on the table as he wrote and drew.

Next to the round table, there was a rug and some toys scattered. It was unknown when a big and red apple tumbled on the ground.

As the spring breeze gently blew, a few peach petals fluttered in a carefree and leisurely manner.

“Clench your left hand and push forward,” instructed Lei Tie with a demonstration.

Yuanyuan and Manman looked very serious. Their left legs were straightened while the right legs squatted into a horse-stance, arms were raised, and small hands clenched into fists, which suddenly punched forward with a tender shout came out of their mouths.

“Stand straight, change to your right fist. Spin and strike again.”

Qin Mian watched the big one and two small ones with a smile. Only after a good while did he withdraw his eyes and continued to write the planning book.

When Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui looked at the warm and lively scene of the family of four, they could hardly bear to approach and disturb the family.

The manservant came to report to Qin Mian, “Reporting, Little Master. Fifth-gongzi and Gentleman-in-law¹ are here.”

Qin Mian beckoned Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui.

“You two are here.”

Right now, Huo Sirui’s identity was no longer Lei Xiangzhi’s schoolmate, but Lei Tie’s younger brother-in-law. He came to Qin Mian and bowed with his hands folded in front, “Sirui greets Eldest Sister-in-law.”

“Eldest Sister-in-law.” Lei Xiangzhi also greeted him.

Lei Tie brought Yuanyuan and Manman to come over.

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui saluted again, “Eldest Brother.”

The two little boys, with sweat all over their faces, cupped their fists and bowed down solemnly to salute, “Yuanyuan/Manman greets Fifth Uncle and Uncle-in-law!”

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui were amused and both laughed.

Qin Mian picked up handkerchiefs and wiped Yuanyuan and Manman’s sweat.

“Yuanyuan and Manman are truly good boys.” Huo Sirui took out two round colored stones in the size of sweet orange from his sleeve pocket and handed each to Yuanyuan and Manman. “These are the stones that Uncle-in-law picked up by the riverbank while strolling outside. They aren’t worth anything; only precious in nature and fascinating. For you two.”

Yuanyuan and Manman looked at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie nodded as he perceived that the stones were indeed ordinary.

“Thank you, Uncle-in-law!” Yuanyuan and Manman took off their shoes and went to play on the rug at the side.

White Spot rubbed its soles on the footpad and jumped on the rug, rolling the stones with its snout as it played with the boys.

Golden Fur lazily tramped at the side; it huffed and puffed, which blew away the petals floating in front of it.

After pouring two cups of tea, the manservant brought two chairs and retreated to the side.

Qin Mian casually motioned Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui to sit down, served the two cups of tea, and asked Huo Sirui, "It's rare for you to come here, why didn't you bring Little Sister too?"

After Lei Chuntao married Huo Sirui, she gave birth to a daughter, whose childhood name was Dangdang². Huo Sirui was fine with it, but both Dean Huo and Madam Huo were disappointed. Dean Huo had always dreamed of having a little grandson whom he could teach; as for Madam Huo, she also wanted a grandson the most. However, perhaps it was because Lei Chuntao had seen many conflicts between a mother-in-law and daughters-in-law in her home before she got married, she subtly learned a lot. After a while, she got along with Madam Huo like a biological mother and daughter. Even Dean Huo also changed his attitude toward her. Owing to Lei Chuntao taking good care of her parents-in-law, Huo Shirui naturally loved her more. Now, the whole family got by in a joyous and harmonious relationship.

In Green Mountain Village, the villagers who knew about it secretly envied Lei Chuntao's marriage.

Huo Sirui and Lei Xiangzhi looked at each other before Huo Sirui said, "Eldest Sister-in-law, Eldest Brother, actually, Fifth Brother and I came here to ask for something, so we didn't bring our wives here."

"Oh?" Thinking of the coming spring examination, Qin Mian vaguely guessed something.

As expected, Lei Xiangzhi said, "Eldest Sister-in-law; Sirui and I will participate in the spring examination on the 4th month this year. However, Capital City is quite far. Perhaps, it will take nearly 20 days to arrive by carriage. Both of us are very worried about encountering mishaps on the way."

"If we miss the examination date by an unforeseen event, the ten years of studying hard will fall short of completion." Huo Sirui was somewhat embarrassed as he continued, "I heard that Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-

in-law are going to take Yuanyuan and Manman to visit the Capital. We want to ask if *you* can start ahead of time and go with us? Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law are both highly skilled in martial arts. If *you* two accompany us, Fifth Brother and I can be at ease.”

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian in silence.

Qin Mian was in a bit of a quandary. If they had to hurry up for the examination date, they had to set out at the end of the 3rd lunar month at the latest. It rained a lot in the 3rd month and, to be honest, it was a pleasure to journey on rainy days from time to time. His and Lei Tie’s original intention of the trip was to bring Yuanyuan and Manman to “play”. If they were confined in the carriage all the way, where was the fun? Besides, if they set out ahead of time, Yuanyuan and Manman would not be able to celebrate their birthdays at home.

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui didn’t know that both Yuanyuan and Manman carried a spiritual tool that could warm up the wearer’s body; they thought that Qin Mian was worried about Yuanyuan and Manman’s health. The spring in the 3rd lunar month was chilly and the children would easily get sick on a long-distance trip. The two men dared not to urge and quietly waited for Qin Mian’s decision. They both knew that they were forcing the other party, but they were truly afraid of mishaps on the road. If the ten years of studying hard were destroyed at the last step, how could one be reconciled?

Qin Mian thought about it for a while and put himself in Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui’s situation; he sympathized with them. Then, he slightly nodded to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie perceived Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui’s bad presumption. He pinched Qin Mian’s shoulder and pondered for a moment, “Set out as soon as possible. In case the weather is too cold, stay somewhere temporarily for a few days.”

Qin Mian was a little puzzled. After thinking about it, he understood why the man said so. He nodded with a smile, “Alright.”

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui looked happy. Both men stood up and bowed with their fists cupped in the other hands to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, feeling embarrassed.

“We’ve troubled Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law. Not only that, but we’ve also wronged Yuanyuan and Manman; their birthday won’t be celebrated at home. We really feel bad about it.”

Yuanyuan and Manman thought the adults were calling them, so they turned their heads and looked over. However, they didn’t get any response. They shrugged their shoulders like little adults and continued to play.

Qin Mian waved his hand and said, “It’s fine. It’s the same anywhere one celebrates one’s birthday.”

Lei Tie lightly spoke, “You two go back to prepare. Is it alright to set out in five days?”

“No problem.” Lei Xiangzhi looked at Huo Sirui.

Huo Sirui responded, “I also have no problem.”

“If you have friends who are also going to the Capital to take the exam, you can invite them to go together. But it’s better not to have too many people. A-Tie and I dislike too much noise.”

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui were very happy when they heard that and thanked the couple again.

“Eldest Sister-in-law can rest assured that there are only Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Zhao Tianhe. *You* and Eldest Brother know them.”

Qin Mian nodded.

“Well then, we are going.”

After Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui left, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went busy. Qin Mian went to arrange the family business; Lei Tie was responsible for packing up the clothing and other articles of daily use for their family of

four. Many things could be put in the space, but on the surface, everything that should be prepared should not be missing, lest its aroused suspicion.

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui were very considerate. The next day, Huo Sirui had people sent a brand-new cotton-padded jacket to Yuanyuan and Manman respectively. Meanwhile, Lei Xiangzhi's wife, Li Shi, gave Yuanyuan and Manman each a soft hat, on which there was a small animal that ward off evil spirits embroidered by Li Shi herself. One could see that she was very thoughtful.

Four days later, the sky was clear and the spring sun was warm. Two carriages drove out of Leisurely Farmhouse. At the front was a double-carriage driven by Lei-Qin Le. Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, Manman, and even White Spot were all on that carriage. The poor Golden Fur's body was too large that for this trip to the Capital, it had to stay behind and guarded the house. Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun rode on horsebacks, and behind them was another double-carriage driven by a manservant, carrying the entourage's baggage and other items.

The carriages stopped at the gate of the old house. After Lei Xiangzhi bid farewell to his parents, wife, and child, he got on the first carriage with his baggage on his back. Huo Sirui's family had a carriage. When they got to the county, he would ride with Huo Sirui.

The villagers who cared about Lei Xiangzhi stood at the entrance of the village and watched the carriages go away.

Yuanyuan and Manman liked to sit on a carriage. They leaned on the window as they watched the village gradually distancing. Lei Tie held the boys in each of his powerful arms.

With their Old Dad holding them, Yuanyuan and Manman felt very safe and not afraid at all. From time to time, their hands and heads stretched out of the window. The two little boys were obviously excited as they kept chattering.

“Gege, look, there are many birds on the trees.”

“En.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. 姑爷 [gū ye] is a form of address for a son-in-law by the family of his wife. I took the liberty to use “gentleman” since the speaker is a servant. *welp*
2. (onom.) dong/ding-dong (bell)

Chapter 146: On the Road to the Capital

146 – On the Road to the Capital

Manman faced his Gege with an unusual dependency and gave him a sweet smile, “Gege, I want birds.”

“When we stop, let Old Dad catch [them].” Yuanyuan looked back at Lei Tie with inquiring eyes.

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian had seen the way his family’s big poker-face and small poker-face communicated with each other countless times, but he still couldn’t refrain from smiling. It was a pity that there was an outsider, otherwise, he would definitely pounce on them and kiss them.

When Lei Xiangzhi noticed the tender expression in Qin Mian’s eyes as he looked at Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman, his eyes were filled with happiness and joy. All of a sudden, he felt embarrassed, thinking that he was hindering the family of four.

He found a topic of conversation, “Eldest Sister-in-law, I can see that Yuanyuan and Manman are very smart. I’ll be perfectly satisfied if Chongchong¹ can be half as good as them in the future.” Chongchong was his and Li Shi’s son, only two months old.

“Fifth Brother, you’re the future palace graduate; how can your son be lacking?” joked Qin Mian.

Lei Xiangzhi laughed and cupped his hands in obeisance as he said, "Thank you for your blessing words."

Qin Mian took out a book from the drawer and handed it to him, "For you to pass the time. But the two little boys are very noisy, I'm afraid you can't enjoy reading it."

"No." Lei Xiangzhi received the book, "Children should be lively."

Near noon, the entourage arrived in Zhaoyang County. Huo Sirui, Bu Qingyun, Zhao Tianhe, and Qu Zongwen were all present. Bu Qingyun gave everyone an introduction. Among them, an escort surnamed Zhang had been to the Capital several times and could lead the way at the front of the procession, which was convenient to arrange the daily course of the journey reasonably, lest they missed the lodging place.

Qin Mian opened his mouth and said, "Well, find a wine house first and let A-Tie treat us all to a meal."

Bu Qingyun hurriedly said, "Eldest Sister-in-law, I heard from Xiangzhi that *you* and Eldest Brother especially advance your schedule for us. It should be us that treat *you* and Eldest Brother to a meal."

Qin Mian shook his head with a smile. "No hurry. When you all become palace graduates, treat us to a meal. By that time, our family of four will be very happy to be in your light."

Hearing what he said, Huo Sirui and the others had to give up. Hence, Lei Tie treated them to lunch.

The group of people had lunch in the county. While at it, they bought some dried food before setting out to the north. The group added up to four carriages and nearly 20 people; the procession was not small.

After Lei Xiangzhi went to Huo Sirui's carriage, Qin Mian's group of four people and a wolf were much more at ease. Qin Mian and Lei Tie gently rubbed Yuanyuan and Manman's stomachs to aid digestion. The two little boys were so comfortable in their fathers' arms that they hummed.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie played with the two children for a while before putting the bed together and let the children take a nap. Owing to the carriage's special "tires", it didn't jolt even though the road was not very smooth. The two little boys slept very well.

Qin Mian took off his shoes and climbed the bed, lazily leaning against Lei Tie's chest.

As soon as Lei Tie placed his hand on Qin Mian's abdomen, Qin Mian shrunk away, "What are you doing?"

"Rub, help digestion." Lei Tie said it with a poker-face, but his big palm went into Qin Mian's lapel and ambiguously drew a circle on Qin Mian's waist.

Qin Mian took out his hand and held it tightly to keep it from moving. He said with a severe countenance, "A-Tie, don't look down upon White Spot."

White Spot unenthusiastically looked at them.

Lei Tie incomprehensibly looked at it, "[I] didn't."

Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder. "Have you ever heard the word 'lecher'?² You think White Spot didn't know what we're doing?"

"Awoo." White Spot nodded its head, acting as though it was taking this matter very seriously.

Lei Tie's hand stiffened. He extinguished his intention and removed his hand before he tidied up his wife's clothes and hugged him tightly. Then, he said in a low voice, "Sleep a while if you're sleepy."

Qin Mian shook his head, "Want to eat fruit."

From the magical space, Lei Tie took out three peaches, peeled the skin, and cut it into pieces before he served it in a fruit bowl and fed it to his wife with a bamboo fork.

Yuanyuan and Manman woke up after nearly an hour's nap. Lei Tie used warm water to wash their faces and brush their teeth.

Yuanyuan crawled to the window and looked at the strange scenery outside. "Dad, where are we going?"

"To a very interesting place. It's very far away. It takes many days to get there. Is Yuanyuan scared?" Qin Mian prepared fruit for Yuanyuan and Manman.

Yuanyuan shook his head, "Not scared; Old Dad is here, Dad is here, and Didi is also here."

Qin Mian curled his lips. *Fine*. Ever since Lei Tie had shown his "qinggong" and leaped to the top of the tree in front of Yuanyuan and Manman, even if he also leaped to the top of the tree, in Yuanyuan and Manman's hearts, their Old Dad was still more powerful than their Dad.

"Our Yuanyuan is the best." Qin Mian cupped the little one's face and kissed it.

"Old Dad, I want to pee-pee." Manman squirmed in Lei Tie's arms.

Lei Tie opened the door, held Manman, and let him aim to the outside to pee. He looked at Yuanyuan.

Yuanyuan nodded, "Yuanyuan also wants to pee-pee."

Manman saw that the line of the urine coming out was crooked and thought it was very interesting. Curious, he asked, "Old Dad, why is the pee crooked?"

Mouth agape, Lei Tie didn't know how to explain it. He turned to look at Qin Mian, "Wife."

Qin Mian sweated, "Er... The wind blows it." How could he explain "inertia" to a kid under three years old?

"Why does it crooked when the wind blows it?" asked Manman yet again.

Yuanyuan also looked at Qin Mian, waiting for an answer.

Qin Mian sweated, “Because... The wind is stronger. Alright, Manman. You’re going to eat fruit soon, can’t talk about pee.”

Lei Tie curved lips as he served Yuanyuan and Manman.

After putting things in order, the family of four sat on the settee and ate the fruit.

At sunset, the fleet of carriages stopped in front of an old temple.

Bu Qingyun took the lead in jumping out of the carriage and ran to Qin Mian’s carriage. “Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, in front of us is an abandoned old temple. We will rest here tonight; it might cause Yuanyuan and Manman to feel wronged.”

“It’s fine.” Qin Mian opened the door, “Qingyun, please tell the four big brothers that there is a bed in our carriage. So, we don’t have to delay the journey for the sake of Yuanyuan and Manman’s comfort. I forgot to say it before. Those four big brothers have taken a lot of trouble.”

“It’s nothing.” Bu Qingyun said with a smile, “They like Yuanyuan and Manman. Just now, they even said that the children are so cute. Eldest Sister-in-law, let me help you to get them out of the carriage—they won’t be scared, right?”

“No. Then, I’ll be troubling you.” Qin Mian handed Yuanyuan over to him.

Bu Qingyun was very happy. He carefully took Yuanyuan, put him safely on the ground, and took Manman next before he squatted down in front of them.

“Yuanyuan and Manman can call me Uncle Qingyun.”

Yuanyuan and Manman looked at Qin Mian. After getting their Dad’s nod, they both called out “Uncle Qingyun”, very cleverly.

Bu Qingyun had not married yet; he still had a childish temperament. He held both children's hands, "Come, I'll take you two to play."

White Spot was like a guard, following them without haste.

On that side, the four escorts had gone to the temple to clean up. Qin Mian motioned Lei-Qin Le and the others to help.

Although the temple was old, its walls and roof were not broken, so there was no problem to shelter them. Several people broke off a few branches to make brooms and swept the temple. Lei-Qin Zhong, Lei-Qin Shun, and the two escorts picked up some branches nearby to make a fire.

Everyone took a break and settled their own dinner. In the first place, going out on a journey was not easy. Basically, people tried to prepare some good rations and made themselves eat better within their ability. For example, double-layered pancakes stuffed with meat, steamed stuffed buns, baked sesame seed-coated pancake, and so on could be eaten after they were roasted on the fire.

Qin Mian was more prepared because there were Yuanyuan and Manman around. He even brought a three-eared pot which could be tied with a rope to hang over the fire while cooking soup.

Simple vermicelli and minced meat soup sprinkled with a handful of dried scallions were very fragrant. Everyone, including the four escorts, swallowed their saliva in secret.

Qin Mian told Lei-Qin Le, "Go and bring over the fermented tofu we brought."

"Yes, Little Master."

Manman chimed in, "Dad, fermented tofu is delicious. Manman likes it, too."

"En." Qin Mian rubbed his little head.

After Lei-Qin Le brought the fermented tofu jar, Qin Mian handed it to Lei Xiangzhi and said to everyone, “If you’d like, try it. It tastes very good if you put the fermented tofu on the pancake.”

Qu Zongwen, Escort Zhang, and the others expressed their gratitude with a smile. Such a big jar of fermented tofu cost one tael; it didn’t mean that they couldn’t afford it, but it was not convenient to bring along. It was a wonderful thing to be able to taste the fermented tofu while one was traveling.

Each person had a share of half a piece of fermented tofu. They spread a thin layer on the pancake or steamed stuffed bun and took a bite. The fresh and savory taste was captivating, leading a person to endless aftertastes.

When the soup had been cooked, Qin Mian and Lei Tie began to bake pancakes. Qin Mian made the pancakes himself. He mixed in minced meat when he kneaded the dough before making the pancake. This way, the pancake would be easier to heat over the fire.

After the pancakes were done, Qin Mian’s family of four, together with Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, Lei-Qin Shun, and the manservant Dashan, each had a bowl. There were only eight bowls, so the rest didn’t get a share.

Yuanyuan and Manman happily sat on their Old Dad and Dad’s thighs while being fed a mouthful of fragrant meat pancake and a mouthful of delicious soup. They were very happy.

“Old Dad, eat.” Yuanyuan grabbed Lei Tie’s hand and delivered the meat pancake to his mouth.

Lei Tie bit a small mouthful and touched his son’s head. “Old Dad will eat when Yuanyuan’s full.”

Manman learned from his Gege and let Qin Mian have a bite, “Dad, eat!”

“Alright.” Qin Mian took a bite with a smile and then continued to feed him.

A warm and loving family of four was envied by others.

That night, Lei Xiangzhi and the others unrolled their own blankets to rest in the temple. Meanwhile, Qin Mian's family of four slept in the carriage; they had a good night's dream.

Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, Lei-Qin Shun, and Dashan were a group, while the four escorts were a group; every night, one person in each group were assigned to keep vigil in the first half of the night and another for the second half of the night. This was to ensure that all the scholars could have a good rest. On top of that, there was a magical wolf, so everyone was sleeping at ease.

After dawn, Lei Xiangzhi and the others were more or less suffering from backache. Upon seeing Qin Mian's family of four came down from the carriage neatly dressed and energetic, they were envious.

Yuanyuan and Manman greeted good morning to the uncles one by one. The large group of people liked the two little boys even more.

While Lei Tie prepared breakfast, Yuanyuan and Manman followed Qin Mian to do morning exercises.

Lei Xiangzhi and the others watched the two little boys doing exercises while moving their muscles and bones. Being raptured over it, they called the boys adorable.

After a simple breakfast, the group continued on their way while the weather was fine.

When all was said and done, it was inconvenient to have outsiders around. Qin Mian had expected this for a long time, so he prepared a lot of snacks in the space, such as small steamed meat-filled dumplings, steamed dumplings, glutinous rice rolls, and so on. He pretended to take them out of the cabinet and put them on the table to give "preferential treatment" to the family of four.

The boys were still too young; for fear they would make a slip of tongue, Qin Mian didn't tell them about the existence of the magical space for the time being.

Lei Tie used his vital energy to heat the food, and the family of four pleasingly enjoyed it.

White Spot also did; Qin Mian had specially made dried meat for it to eat.

It began to rain in the afternoon, but it didn't rain much. The procession continued the journey. They had been on the road for five days and it rained for five days. Yuanyuan and Manman were a little sullen. Qin Mian and Lei Tie had racked their brains to play new games with the boys. When they thought that they were about to run out of inspiration soon, the sky finally cleared up.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 虫虫[chóng] lower form of animal life, including insects, insect larvae, worms, and similar creatures. (fig.) A person with a particular undesirable characteristic. *Remember, the humbler the name, the more chances the baby can survive according to the old saying.*
2. This 色狼 [lecher] word is made up of “color” and “wolf”.

Chapter 147: A Young Man that Looks Like Qin Mian

147 – A Young Man that Looks Like Qin Mian

Several coachmen made the same choice without prior discussion – stopped the carriages. Everyone hurriedly got out of the carriages and stretched their legs.

Before dark, the procession entered a county town and stopped in front of an inn.

Two very bookish, scholarly youths walked out of the inn side by side. Upon seeing Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, and the others, the youths gave them a friendly smile. Presumably, they also must be going to the Capital for the exam.

After settling down in the inn, Qin Mian and the others went downstairs to the lobby to have a meal.

The two scholars were also eating. When they suddenly saw a giant wolf standing beside the table, they were both surprised and scared. Then, upon seeing a cute little child feeding the wolf with a chicken drumstick, they could not help crying out in alarm for fear that the child would be bitten.

Manman turned his head and made a wry face at them. His crisp voice sounded naughty, “Making a fuss about nothing!”

Lei Tie shot him a glance, “Manman.”

Manman stuck out his tongue, yet toward the two scholars, he showed a sweet smile. With his small hand patted White Spot’s head, he said in a

proud tone, “Uncles don’t have to be afraid, White Spot is raised by our family, very well-behaved.”

Yuanyuan solemnly cupped his fist in another hand and said in deadpan earnest with a soft childish voice, “My Didi is still young, please excuse him, uncles.”

Lei Xiangzhi, Qu Zongwen, Escort Zhang, and the other guests in the inn couldn’t help laughing heartily and praising their adorableness.

The two scholars’ eyes were opened wide, almost petrified. *Uh, are these two children truly only three to four years old?*

Qin Mian rubbed the heads of the two little boys and then cupped his hands at the two men from a distance. “My son is naughty, please forgive him.”

The two scholars waved their hands, “It’s fine, it’s fine.”

After they finished eating, Escort Zhang and his three men came to Qin Mian’s table. Qin Mian and Lei Tie ate slower than the others because they had to take care of Yuanyuan and Manman at the same time.

“Qin-gongzi and Lei-gongzi.”

Qin Mian stood up and said, “Big brothers, have all of you eaten well?”

“Yes. Qin-gongzi, take a seat.” Escort Zhang sat down on the empty bench beside him and said without being long-winded, “If everything goes according to plan, we’ll pass by the Burial Flower Mountain Ridge tomorrow afternoon. Burial Flower Mountain Ridge is one of the most dangerous places to encounter bandits along the way. In the past, seven out of ten times we would encounter trouble there. Tomorrow, you two must take good care of the children.”

Qin Mian calmly said, “Thanks for Escort Zhang’s reminder. A-Tie and I will take good care of them.”

Lei Tie nodded to Escort Zhang; the look in his eyes was calm and his breath was still like a mountain.

Yuanyuan and Manman, the two clever kids, thanked in unison, “Thank you, uncle!”

Escort Zhang didn’t know of Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s skills at all. In fact, he was very worried that the existence of the two children would delay them, but it was not good to say that. Now, looking at the two lovely little boys again, he put down some worries. If Qin Mian and Lei Tie had no real skills, how would they dare to take risks with their own sons?

He happily touched Yuanyuan’s little head. “You’re welcome. The uncles will protect you in due course.”

The night passed without incident.

The next day, after everyone was ready, they set out again. A trade caravan that lived in an inn with them was also packing. The two scholars they met yesterday were with the caravan.

Qin Mian knew that the two scholars probably had some scruples, which was why they traveled together with the caravan.

The two groups left the inn one after the other and went out of the town.

Taking advantage of the good weather, Qin Mian’s procession stopped once in the middle of the journey to make it convenient for everyone. Later, they never stopped. Lunch was also solved in the carriage. Qin Mian and Lei Tie each carried Yuanyuan and Manman to ride on their horses and then played games, so that the boys didn’t feel bored.

It was unknown as to why the procession at the back always maintained a fixed distance from the front procession. When the front procession stopped, they also stopped.

As per Escort Zhang’s expectation, approximately at the end of the goat hour¹, a mountain ridge appeared in front of them. The two mountains were like two parallel vertical lines, sandwiching the public road in the middle. When they raised their heads to look up, they saw that the two mountains were covered with flowers in spring; the garish display of flowers eagerly

bloomed, splendid in many postures that nothing more beautiful could be imagined. The spring breeze blew unhurriedly as the petals of every color under the sun floated and fell, accumulating a thin layer on the ground. However, the silence and gray shadows around the valley added a frightening mood. Those brightly-colored flowers also seemed not so beautiful, but instead permeated with the breath of death. It was no wonder that this place was called the “Burial Flower Mountain Ridge”.

The four carriages slowed down, unknowingly.

“Stop!” Riding on horseback at the front of the procession, Escort Zhang’s sharp eyes flickered with a glint as he surveyed both sides without batting an eyelid.

Intending to let Lei-Qin Shun and Lei-Qin Zhong display their strength, Lei Tie shot them a glance.

Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun nodded, steered their horses to Escort Zhang, and said in a low voice, “Escort Zhang, we will lead the way with you.”

Escort Zhang had a good opinion on Qin Mian and Lei Tie at the bottom of his heart. If Qin Mian and Lei Tie only let them, the four escorts, clear the way, they would feel uncomfortable at the bottom of their hearts.

“Lei-Qin Le, our carriage will be the last [in line],” ordered Lei Tie.

“Yes.”

Lei Tie kneaded Qin Mian’s hand. “Wife, you take care of Yuanyuan and Manman.”

“Rest assured.” Qin Mian let Yuanyuan and Manman sit astride on his two thighs respectively. He and Lei Tie had already caught the presence of many people in the trees on the mountain. Escort Zhang’s skill was only average to them, but his instinct for danger was highly commendable.

Yuanyuan and Manman were not afraid at all; they clapped their four little hands as to play.

“Sons, some bad people will try to bully us later. Scared or not?” Qin Mian first forewarned the two children so as not to be frightened by the clamor on the outside.

Yuanyuan and Manman shook their heads without showing a sign of fear and simultaneously looked at Lei Tie.

“Old Dad is very powerful. He can drive the bad people away,” said Manman with pride.

Yuanyuan nodded his head in agreement.

Lei Tie’s lips were slightly curved as he looked at Qin Mian with a little meaning of showing off.

Qin Mian coldly stared at him and asked the two children with a grievance, “Dad isn’t powerful?”

Manman hesitated for a moment, “Dad is also powerful... Dad can cook, but neither Manman nor Gege can.”

Lei Tie laughed in silence.

Stabbed by his son, Qin Mian ruthlessly glared at Lei Tie and muttered while fuming with rage between gritted teeth, “Afterward, I’ll teach the children skills, and you’ll be responsible for cooking!”

Lei Tie’s face turned rigid. “Wife...”

Qin Mian ignored him.

Lei Tie took advantage of Yuanyuan and Manman’s inattention to get closer and kissed the corner of his wife’s mouth, “Wife, you are more powerful, you understand that.” *You, who can conquer me, how is that not powerful?*

The temperature on Qin Mian’s face suddenly rose.

“First, don’t be anxious,” said Escort Zhang to Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun as he took a faint glance at the group behind them. Between the two processions, the bandits would know at a glance that the caravans had more benefit to earn from, so the caravans were in a more dangerous situation than them. Under this kind of situation, if the other party looked on without lifting a finger, they should not expect to get help later on. If the caravan people were smart enough, they should take the initiative to cooperate.

After a while, a man trotted over on horseback. Sure enough, he came to discuss cooperation.

After the discussion, the two groups became one. The people with combat capability were evenly distributed around the procession to protect all the carriages.

Escort Zhang told the scholars not to panic and run away all over the place no matter what happened.

It was impossible for scholars not to be nervous. Lei Xiangzhi, knowing that his Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law were powerful, comforted others without looking scared in the slightest. On the whole, everyone was very composed.

Escort Zhang was very satisfied before he and the man named Feng Cheng from the caravan led the procession in the front and entered the narrow passageway.

When the procession arrived at the middle of the narrow passageway, there was a loud rallying cry sounded on the mountain. More than 40 mountain bandits rushed down the mountain and surrounded the procession like wrapping a dumpling.

To one surprise, these mountain bandits’ skills were not weak. However, Escort Zhang and his men didn’t blindly escort them, and Feng Cheng’s eight guards were also experts. Although the fight was fierce, the mountain bandits not only didn’t get the benefit but also lost seven to eight men.

Lei Tie didn't even get off the carriage as he hit the leader with an arrow right in the middle of his brow.

The mountain bandits' morale was completely destroyed; they quickly fled without leaving traces.

Escort Zhang looked toward Qin Mian's carriage with admiration and felt even more at ease for the next journey. He raised his voice and asked, "Is anyone hurt?"

Bu Qingyun poked his head out of the carriage, "Brother Zhang, there's none. We're all fine. Thanks to all of you."

Lei-Qin Le also said in a loud voice, "It's all right over here."

Two people from the caravan were slightly injured, but it was not a big deal.

Without delay, everyone immediately went out of the passageway, lest the mountain bandits swung around and caught them off guard.

Not a while later when the procession rushed out of the passageway, several more rapid horses' hoofs suddenly sounded from behind.

Lei-Qin Zhong took a look back and reported to the carriage, "Eldest Master and Little Master, it's a small caravan of five men."

Lei Qinshun snorted, "These people are so close to us. I'm afraid that they had deliberately waited until we killed and scattered the mountain bandits before coming here."

Lei-Qin Zhong also had this thought, but nothing could be done about it. "It's a good thing that we're not hurt. We can't deal with so many of them."

The sound of the horses' hooves came nearer and nearer. In a short time, the horses came to the front of the procession and galloped past.

Lei-Qin Shun casually glanced at the people on the horses, and his whole body expressed surprise as he looked at the back of those people in astonishment.

“What’s the matter?” asked Lei-Qin Zhong casually.

Lei-Qin Shun lowered his voice and spoke in an uncertain tone, “The man on the leading horse... He looks like Little Master. I should be mistaken.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had good hearing. They overheard him and looked at each other in surprise.

The world was so big and people had similarities. Besides, Lei-Qin Shun might have been mistaken. Therefore, Qin Mian didn’t pay it any mind.

The fleet of carriages and caravans went northward. After they got familiar with each other, they learned that the caravans were going to the Capital. However, Qin Mian and his party had less load, so they traveled fast. After traveling with the caravans for a day, they separated.

Five days later, the fleet of carriages arrived in Jinshui City. Jinshui City was a big city. Escort Zhang proposed to have a good rest here for a day and everyone had no objection. It was only two or three days away from the Capital, so there was no need to rush as before.

The closer to the Capital, the stronger the atmosphere of the spring exam. The streets of Jinshui City were full of scholars and most of them were resting in Jinshui City just like Qin Mian’s party.

Escort Zhang led the procession to stop in front of the Good Luck Coming Inn’s entrance.

Yuanyuan and Manman couldn’t wait to get off.

“Dad, I want to go down!”

Lei Tie easily picked up the two little boys at the same time. “Wife, I’m taking them down first.”

“Alright.” Qin Mian took out a bundle and handed it to Lei-Qin Zhong before locking the carriage’s door and windows.

“Dear guests, please come inside!” The waiter came out to welcome people and was astonished as he took in the two impressive carriages. He greeted them warmly and upon seeing two children that were exactly alike, his mouth spoke good words, “These little gongzis look cute and smart. The two gongzis are so blessed.”

Lei Tie slightly nodded.

“Thank you very much.” Qin Mian smiled at the waiter and straightened the hats on the boys’ heads.

As soon as he got to the door, a young man came face to face.

Qin Mian unintentionally faced the other person, and both of them were stunned.

Several bystanders were also stunned because the two men were so alike that they looked almost identical except for the eyebrows and eyes. Qin Mian’s eyebrows and eyes were good-looking; his eyebrows were thick but not messy and looked very heroic, while his eyes were large and round, and seemed bright and sharp, in short, they were nice to look at. The young man’s eyebrows were rather light and his single eyelids matched with a pair of long and narrow *red phoenix eyes*²; his slightly squinting appearance looked rather gloomy. On top of that, they both were not similar in age; the young man appeared to be four or five years older than Qin Mian.

Note:

Footnotes

1. 1:00 – 3:00 p.m

2. eyes whose outer corners incline upwards

Chapter 148: Adorable Radish Costume

148 – Adorable Radish Costume

The young man's pupils suddenly shrank, thoughts unknown, and he appeared to be a little surprised.

Just in a breath, the look in the young man's eyes changed, but it did not escape Lei Tie's eyes. Lei Tie took hold of Qin Mian's hand, squeezed it, and led him forward.

Qin Mian was surprised to see a man who looked like him with his own eyes. Out of politeness, he nodded to the man and followed Lei Tie into the inn.

Lei-Qin Shun and the others quickly followed.

The young man watched them disappear on the stairs before he turned and left.

After the waiter had led them to their guest room, Qin Mian asked the waiter to send hot water over.

Lei Tie put Yuanyuan and Manman down. When the waiter left, he hesitated for a moment, but said it nonetheless, "Wife, that person is very likely to know you."

Qin Mian was taken aback, "How so?"

"He seemed shocked and suspicious when he saw you. As if... it's very unexpected to see you." Lei Tie's wording was very strict.

Yuanyuan and Manman didn't know what their dads were talking about; they ran around in the spacious guest room full of energy, chasing after White Spot. "Yuanyuan and Manman, run slowly. Be careful not to fall." While Qin Mian and Lei Tie were talking, they did not forget to pay attention to their two sons. "Could he be... a relative?"

Lei Tie went over and put his arms around his wife's waist. "Wife, do you want to find your family?"

Qin Mian took the opportunity to encircle his man's neck and shook his head. "You know where I came from." He didn't know why this body appeared alone in Green Mountain Village at the beginning, or whether it would be a good thing for him and the other party if he found the original owner's family. Therefore, he never wanted to take the initiative to go looking for them, but let nature take its course.

Lei Tie hugged him tightly, stroked his face with his big palm, pecked his ear gently, and then said slowly, "Wife, maybe I'm selfish, so I don't want other people to take away your attention. As long as I have you, you can only have me."

Qin Mian's heart was comforted, and he kissed the man on the chin. Knowing that the man had just made a slip of the tongue, Qin Mian still wanted to tease him, "Well, you! Don't you want your sons?"

Lei Tie's face flashed a bit of embarrassment, "I mean, besides our family of four, others are not needed."

Qin Mian simmered with laughter, patted the man on his back, and rubbed his cheek against the man's neck. "Well, I'm not sure if that person is related to me. Why do we have to fret over it? Maybe we're just people with similarities. We go out to sight-seeing; don't let our mood be affected by others."

"En." Lei Tie dragged Qin Mian to the back of the column¹ and kissed him for a long time. Before Yuanyuan and Manman ran over full of curiosity, Lei Tie had let go of him.

“Dad, what are you doing with Old Dad?” asked Manman as he blinked, looking very cunning.

Qin Mian pretended to be unperturbed and rubbed his little head, “Doing nothing.”

“I saw you two hugging each other. Isn’t that right, Gege?” Manman turned to look at his Gege with his pigtail flung along.

Yuanyuan nodded.

Qin Mian crossed his arms over his chest and pretended to be angry as he glared, “What? You allow Old Dad to hug you, but he isn’t allowed to hug me?”

Lei Tie looked at them quietly with his eyes full of softness and satisfaction. Having a lover and sons such as them, what more could he ask for?

Grinning, Manman took Qin Mian’s hand and shook it. “Allow Old Dad to hug Dad. Old Dad, you can hug Dad again.”

Qin Mian was embarrassed. *Isn’t it like lifting a rock and hitting yourself in the foot?*

Looking unperturbed, Lei Tie drew his wife into his arms.

Qin Mian had no choice but to look at the sky.

“My guest, your hot water is here.”

Qin Mian pushed Lei Tie away and mischievously blocked Manman, who was trying to catch up with his Gege.

“Dad, let me go!”

Qin Mian held back his laughter as he looked at the little boy leaning forward like a frog on his arms in a struggle. Seeing that his son’s mouth was about to pout, Qin Mian patted his little bottom and let him go.

“You little rascal.”

They had arrived in Jinshui City in the morning and stayed there for one night. The next morning, after breakfast, they continued the journey.

Surprisingly, the young man they had met before set out only two steps later than them. Later, he always stayed about a *li* behind them.

Qin Mian couldn't help but wonder if the other party was indeed related to him. However, he and Lei Tie both decided to be on alert and make no move. As long as the other party did not come to trouble them, they were not interested in taking the initiative to get involved with him.

Nothing happened throughout the journey.

In the morning three days later, the procession could already see the tall wall of the Capital from a distance. Everyone sighed with relief.

Escort Zhang and his men all showed a relaxing smile on their faces. The scholars they escorted, who could get the qualification to come to the Capital for the examination, were all talented people, so they had a lot of pressure along the way. If the scholars were not well protected, not only would these scholars be harmed, but their conscience would hurt too.

Eventually, they arrived in the Capital.

Huo Sirui's carriage slowed down and went side by side with Qin Mian's.

He poked his head out of the window, “Eldest brother, Eldest Sister-in-law.”

“What's it?” asked Qin Mian as he stretched out his head.

Huo Sirui said, “Eldest Sister-in-law, my father has written to his friend in the Capital earlier, asking him to make a reservation for us. It's just that I have to pay a visit first and ask which inn it is. I'll go ahead on horseback.”

Qin Mian nodded, “Alright, sorry to trouble you. Lei-Qin Shun, go with Huo-gongzi.”

“Yes, Little Master.”

Lei-Qin Zhong jumped onto the shaft of the carriage and gave his horse to Huo Sirui.

Huo Sirui and Lei-Qin Shun galloped away on horseback.

“Dad, we have arrived?” asked Yuanyuan while leaning on the window.

“Almost there.” Qin Mian pointed to the wall in the distance, “Son, do you see that? That’s where we’re going. When the time comes, ask your Old Dad to treat us a delicious meal!”

Yuanyuan’s face showed a lovely smile, “En.”

“I want to see it, too.” Manman mischievously leaned on his Gege’s back.

Lei Tie timely held him.

The two brothers were excited and began to chatter again.

Qin Mian simply gave up his seat to them and let them sit side by side in front of the window to see the scenery outside.

White Spot had been on the ride for a long time that it looked somewhat sullen, lazily lying on the ground. Qin Mian rubbed its head in comfort “White Spot, hold on for a while. We’ll arrive soon.”

White Spot nodded its head and obediently lay down.

“A-Tie, is that person still following?” Qin Mian sat next to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie embraced him with ease and nodded.

Qin Mian smiled rather amusingly. “It seems that he has some qualms about me. But as long as he doesn’t come to provoke us, we don’t have to mess with him.”

Lei Tie's voice sounded cold, "It's fine if he didn't mean any harm. If he did, I'll make him regret it!"

Qin Mian kissed his face and started to sort out their family of four's luggage. When Yuanyuan and Manman didn't pay attention, he took out some of the things that had been temporarily put in the space.

Less than an hour later, the procession arrived at the city gate. On a closer look, the city wall stood more than 30 *chi*² high, all of which were made of big gray stones, looking imposingly tall, sturdy, and spectacular. On the city wall, solemn-looking soldiers holding spears stood straight like bamboos. The gate was about 30 *chi* wide and a stone plaque above it was engraved with deep and clear "Capital City" words in vigorous touches and fine strokes, appearing grand and magnificent. Inside the city gate, pedestrians and vehicles came and went. It was very lively.

After the soldiers guarding the gate checked their travel permits, the procession followed the stream of people into the city wall. Even Qin Mian couldn't help but look out at the window and inwardly praised. The Capital City deserved to be called the country's important place. The streets were paved with stone slabs, which were clean and spacious that could accommodate at least four carriages side by side – this did not include the area of the vendors on both sides of the street. Pedestrians and vehicles, whether coming in or out, all walked on the right side. It seemed methodically arranged.

The shops on both sides of the street were not comparable to those in small counties. Most of them were two-story buildings. Even the smallest shops were very orderly sorted out and the silk banners fluttering at the shops' entrances were bigger than those in other places.

Among the people who came and went, most of them were gongzis in splendid clothes. They walked slowly with their heads held high and looks carried inherent nobility and arrogance. From time to time, there was an exquisite four-men-carrying palanquin or a luxury carriage unhurriedly passed by.

Qin Mian almost lamented. Fortunately, he and Lei Tie were rich people now. They were all neat and tidy. Otherwise, they would be embarrassed to walk on the streets of the Capital City.

Upon hearing the voices of Escort Zhang and Huo Sirui, he looked ahead and found that Huo Sirui was back. Besides Lei-Qin Shun, there was a youth dressed as a manservant, who was probably sent over by Dean Huo's good friend.

The procession followed Huo Sirui and stopped at the entrance of Swan Goose Path Inn.

The waiter, who stood at the entrance of the inn to welcome the guests, saw the incoming guests, and immediately put on a warm and friendly smile on his face as he spryly welcomed them. His eyes were unconsciously attracted by the most unusual carriage.

When that carriage stopped, the door opened from the side. The waiter was surprised. The first one to jump out of the carriage was a dog – no, a wolf, strong and powerful, with fierce eyes. It looked around in carefree and leisure and smartly sat down on the ground. It turned a deaf ear to the cries of alarm from the passers-by. Its appearance of raising its eyelids and glancing sideways permeated haughtiness.

At this time, a three-layered wooden step suddenly extended from the bottom of the carriage. A young man slowly stepped down from the carriage. The man was about 26 to 27 years old, with dashing eyebrows and bright eyes. Unfortunately, there was an ugly scar on his cold face. The black robe covering his tall and well-built body made his indifference aura more intense that people dared not approach him readily.

The man turned to face the carriage and his cold face softened as he stretched out his hands and took a child out of the carriage.

The child was about three or four years old. On his pinkish face, his big black eyes were full of agility. His dress was very unique. He wore a red hat on his head with several pieces of cloth in the shape of green leaves on the top, a small red short padded jacket on his upper body with only the sleeves

in light blue color, and a pair of trousers which was also in two colors, red from waist to the buttock and light blue below the buttock. When the red of the jacket and the trousers were connected, the whole person looked like a plump big red radish, oh-so-adorable!

Thanks for the comments!

Note:

Footnotes

1. not sure if it's a bedpost or something else like a screen or something
2. about 10 meters

Chapter 149: Old Dad, Don't Eat Dad

149 – Old Dad, Don't Eat Dad

The man reached out his hands again and unexpectedly carried out an identical child.

The two children who looked like big radishes – one with a poker face and the other with a smiling face – held hands while looking around in curiosity. The wolf stood up and brushed the back of the two children with its tail from time to time, very intimately.

The waiter's eyes stared blankly. For a moment, he forgot to step forward, thinking that he had enriched his experience today.

Noticing that the man was still looking inside the carriage, the waiter could not help but keep on watching.

Another man came down from the carriage. He was also a young man, about 18 or 19 years old, with thick eyebrows and large, round eyes. He looked heroic and tall dressed in a white robe, appearing handsome, noble, and graceful.

“A-Tie, let's go in.” Qin Mian held Yuanyuan's little hand.

Manman obediently handed his hand to his Old Dad.

The fathers and sons walked up the steps neither fast nor slow, and White Spot followed without haste. Lei Tie faintly glanced into the distance.

The young man, who looked very much like Qin Mian, watched Qin Mian enter Swan Goose Path Inn and turned his horse around to leave.

The waiter finally came to his senses and stepped forward to welcome. He looked at the wolf with vigilance and awkwardness. “Gongzis, welcome to Swan Goose Path Inn. Uhm this...”

“Sorry, I forgot for a moment.” Qin Mian stopped after two steps, “Lei-Qin shun.”

White Spot did not allow people other than its four masters to touch it. Lei-Qin Shun quickly came and handed White Spot’s tether to Qin Mian.

Lei Tie then put it on White Spot’s neck and held it.

The waiter gratefully glanced at Qin Mian. In the Capital City, high officials and dignitaries were everywhere. Many princes, dukes, and nobles were like dogs. As the inn’s waiter, he had seen a lot of arrogant and domineering patrons. A patron who treated such a big wolf as a pet must not be an ordinary person. He thought he was going to be scolded again today, but he didn’t expect that not only the gongzi spoke so nicely, he also went as far as to apologize to him, a servant.

The waiter’s smile was more sincere, “My guests, please come inside.”

When White Spot’s four feet touched the ground, its back was as high as Lei Tie’s waist – its well-built body was strong and its jet-black hair was shiny. When it slowly strode, it appeared arrogant; its gait was firm and its king’s aura fully shown. Inadvertently, everyone’s eyes were attracted to follow it looking at its two masters and the two children, praising them in secret.

Manman strode forward with head high and chest out, sweetly smiled at all the people who watched him, and waved his little hand from time to time. Many guests were amused.

Qin Mian amusedly shook his head. If this little boy was born in modern times and wore a pair of sunglasses, he might be a child star.

Although Yuanyuan was very quiet, his sense of existence was not lesser than his Didi. His expressionless little face that showed a calm and steady bearing like a little adult was praiseworthy.

Huo Sirui came over with the manservant, “Eldest Brother and Brother Mian, I’ll take you all to your rooms.”

Qin Mian rewarded the waiter with a handful of copper coins.

The waiter promptly said, “If gongzis need anything, please call this servant at any time.”

Dean Huo’s good friend had reserved heavenly-sized rooms for them on the second floor; the heavenly-sized room was a suite, which could meet the needs of some guests with an entourage. It would be very convenient for the masters to order their servants whenever. In addition to the largest room, there were four smaller rooms.

Huo Sirui gave Qin Mian’s family the room with the most abundant light and was ready to arrange the others’ rooms.

Qin Mian stopped him and said, “Sirui, Uncle Huo’s good friend has helped us a lot. Do you think it’s convenient for us to visit him and thank him face to face?”

Huo Sirui thought for a moment, “I heard from my father that Uncle Yuan pays most attention to etiquette. If it’s alright with Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, we’ll go together after lunch. I’ll let the manservant go back to inform him first.”

“That should be fine.” Qin Mian asked how much it cost to book the room and gave the money to Huo Sirui for him to deliver.

After Huo Sirui left, Qin Mian asked the waiter to bring hot water. The family of four took a good hot bath with a ladle of spiritual spring water put into the bathtub, which not only dispelled fatigue but also nourished one’s body.

Yuanyuan and Manman's favorite thing was to take a bath. They played in the tub until the water was almost cold. Qin Mian and Lei Tie picked them up, wiped them clean, and changed them into clean inner clothes. For outer clothes, they still wore the radish costumes they just changed into yesterday.

The two children's cheeks were red as apples. Qin Mian couldn't help kissing them.

Yuanyuan and Manman were so ticklish they giggled. They rushed to their Old Dad's arms to hide.

"Don't run, the little rabbit will eat the red radishes!" Qin Mian "howled" and went over. Yet, he didn't notice that his flushed face due to the hot bath was also *delicious* to Lei Tie.

"Old Dad, help!" Yuanyuan and Manman giggled and hid behind Lei Tie's body.

"Don't be afraid, Old Dad will eat up the little white rabbit." Lei Tie grabbed Qin Mian's arm, locked him in his embrace, turned his back to the two little boys, and kissed Qin Mian on the lips.

"Oh, Old Dad eats up the rabbit!" cheered Manman.

Being deeply kissed by Lei Tie, Qin Mian couldn't escape. He could only stare at the man with ferocious eyes. *Didn't this guy say that he wanted to do fewer intimate actions in front of the children?*

Yuanyuan looked up for a long time and began to cry.

Qin Mian quickly pushed Lei Tie away. He squatted down in front of the little boy and hugged him in worry, "Son, what's the matter?"

Lei Tie stood there, feeling a little embarrassed.

"Old Dad..." Yuanyuan sniffed and looked at Lei Tie in tears, "don't eat Dad."

“Pfft...” Qin Mian thought it was inappropriate to laugh when his son was sad, but he couldn’t help it at all. “Yuanyuan... Dear... Haha... Old Dad didn’t... Pfft...”

“Uwah—” being laughed at by his Dad, Yuanyuan cried even more.

Manman looked at his Old Dad and then at his Dad. Seeing that his Gege was crying so sadly, he thought that something bad that he didn’t know of had happened, so he opened his mouth and began to cry.

Qin Mian froze at once.

Lei Tie went over, took the big and two small ones into his arms, and patted their backs to placate, “Don’t cry.”

This time, Qin Mian couldn’t laugh, so he quickly explained to the two little boys, “Old Dad didn’t eat Dad. It was a game just now. Yuanyuan and Manman don’t remember?”

Yuanyuan had come back to his senses now. He closed his mouth and didn’t cry anymore. However, the tears were still rolling down and his head was lowered; he looked very embarrassed. Manman always followed his Gege’s steps. He stopped crying and hugged his Gege, comfortingly.

Qin Mian breathed a sigh of relief and slapped Lei Tie on his back. *Blame this guy!*

“Blame me.” Lei Tie honestly admitted his mistake, pecked at his wife’s forehead, and then kissed Yuanyuan and Manman’s foreheads.

Yuanyuan lowered his head and pulled Manman to walk away quickly.

Qin Mian wanted to laugh again but quickly held back. He looked at the back of the two little boys and helplessly shook his head. “The child is only a little older but already have self-esteem. Go and wash their faces.”

Lei Tie obediently went.

Qin Mian quietly took White Spot into the magical space and let it wash well. When he came out of the space, Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman had taken off their shoes and played jigsaw puzzles on the bed. Children were forgetful. Already forgotten the embarrassment from before, the two boys had a smile on their small faces.

“Are you hungry, sons? Let’s go downstairs to eat.”

After having lunch in the inn, Huo Sirui and Lei Xiangzhi went to buy gifts.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie took their two children for a walk near the inn and went back to their room. They took a long time choosing from among the items they brought and decided to give a jar of wine and a bottle of fermented tofu to Dean Huo’s good friend.

After Huo Sirui and Lei Xiangzhi came back, Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, Manman, Huo Sirui, Lei Xiangzhi, Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Zhao Tianhe went to visit Dean Huo’s good friend’s home. Since White Spot was not used to be in a dense crowd, Qin Mian was not assured to leave it in the inn, so he took it with them.

Dean Huo’s good friend had surnamed Yuan and named Anshi. The Yuan Residence was on the street behind the street where Swan Goose Path Inn was located. The spring exam was a sensitive period. It was easy for students to arouse suspicions when visiting officials. However, because Yuan Anshi was only a fifth-rank official, he was neither qualified to attend the Imperial Court nor had access to the classified affairs of the spring exam office, so there was no problem to visit him.

Owing to Huo Sirui telling the Yuan Residence’s manservant to inform in advance, when they arrived at the Yuan Residence, as soon as he gave his surname, the gatekeeper invited them in.

The Yuan Residence’s front courtyard was a small garden, planted with a few flowering trees and a variety of flowers. In the middle was a wide bluestone path leading to the front house.

On the way, they met an old woman dressed in extraordinary clothes walking in the courtyard, followed by two young maids.

The manservant bowed to salute, "Greetings, Old Madam."

Qin Mian and his party cupped their hands in obeisance, "Greetings, Old Madam Yuan."

The old madam looked kind and said with a smile, "Are you here to visit my son? No need to be polite."

As soon as her eyes fell on Yuanyuan and Manman, her face immediately showed fondness. She slightly bent down and her voice became softer, "Oh my, whose children are these? They're adorable."

Yuanyuan and Manman came forward hand in hand.

"Greetings, grandma. I'm Yuanyuan."

"Greetings, grandma. I'm Manman."

"Oh, it's Yuanyuan and Manman. Good gracious, truly charming." The old lady's eyes were filled with kindness. She couldn't help reaching out her hands as if to hold them. As if thinking of something, she stepped back a few steps and apologetically smiled at Qin Mian and Lei Tie. "Look at me: old and confused. I don't want to infect the children with my cold. I won't delay your business. Go ahead."

The old madam smiled at Yuanyuan and Manman again. One could see that she really liked them. Then, she took the two maids in the other direction.

Chapter 150: The First Day in the Capital

150 – The First Day in the Capital

Yuan Anshi was about forty years old and had no airs of an official at all. He met Qin Mian and his party with a very amicable attitude. It might have been that Dean Huo had told him about Qin Mian's family so that when he saw their family of four, his expression didn't show any abnormality.

On behalf of himself, Lei Xiangzhi, Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Zhao Tianhe, Huo Sirui presented a gift. Qin Mian motioned to Lei-Qin Le to present the gifts.

Huo Sirui said with a smile, "Uncle Yuan, *you* probably don't know, right? Eldest Brother's wine and fermented tofu are famous throughout Qingtian Prefecture. The fermented tofu doesn't smell very good, but the texture is delicate and tastes delicious. It's suitable for young and old people."

Yuan Anshi chuckled, "How can I not know? There is a wine house in the Capital that has fermented tofu, which is said to be bought from Qingtian Prefecture. A piece per dish costs one silver tael. An old fellow like me didn't expect to have a gourmet's luck today. Qin-gongzi and Lei-gongzi are too polite."

Qin Mian said, "It's just a small thing; a souvenir to show our respect to *you*. The Capital is now full of students, so almost all the inns are occupied. If it wasn't for Sir Yuan's help, I'm afraid it would not be easy for our family to find a place to stay in the Capital. If Sir Yuan thinks the wine and the fermented tofu are good, *you* can ask Sirui to bring a message to Qin at any time. Qin can send some more."

“Well then, this old fellow thanks you first.” Yuan Anshi nodded with a grin.

After sitting in Yuan Residence for a while, the group got up and took their leave.

Madam Yuan came out of the inner room and looked at her husband drinking tea with puzzled eyes, “Old Master, I don’t understand. It’s fine for you to be so polite to Huo-gongzi and his friends; after all, he and the young gongzi surnamed Lei are the popular candidates for this year’s spring exam. But why are you so polite to the surnamed Qin and surnamed Lei? They are...” Madam Yuan frowned with a look of disdain.

Yuan Anshi glanced at her, put down his teacup, and left with a flung of his sleeve, “Shortsighted views not to be taken seriously!”

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As soon as they were out of Yuan Residence’s gate, Bu Qingyun loudly boasted.

“Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, you two are truly amazing – your fermented tofu has been sold to the Capital! Why don’t you open a shop in the Capital? I’m sure you can make a lot of money!”

Qu Zongwen glanced at him askance, “Do your appearance now look like a scholar?”

Bu Qingyun crossed his arms and said, “Does it matter? I truly mean it.”

Qin Mian said in an equivocal way, “Maybe one day, who knows.”

Lei Xiangzhi asked, “Eldest Sister-in-law, we’re going back to the inn to study. Do you all want to go back or stroll around?”

Qin Mian looked at Manman in his arms. “The boys are still in great spirits, so we’ll take them to look around and then go back. You all, don’t just study in the room but go communicate with other students and learn from each other. Perhaps, you will get more understanding.”

Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, and Qu Zongwen looked as if absorbed in thought.

“Thank you for your advice.”

Several people went their separate ways. Qin Mian asked Lei-Qin Le to drive the carriage back to the inn.

Manman urged Qin Mian, “Dad, let’s go strolling the street.”

“Alright, alright.”

This street was the residence area of the rich and influential families. The family of four walked out of the street and followed the flow of people to another prosperous street. From a distance, as soon as one saw the many stalls and a stream of passers-by, one knew that this street was a “trading street”.

The crowd pushed and squeezed. Qin Mian and Lei Tie carefully protected the boys in their arms. With White Spot by their side, no one actually dared to squeeze them.

“Roasted sweet potatoes, sweet and tasty roasted sweet potatoes!”

“Come and have a look at the unique and high-quality fabrics!”

“Dough figurine, don’t pay if it doesn’t look alike!”

“Delicious sugar baked wheaten cake and baked sesame cake; past this street, you won’t find this shop!”

“Buy kites, beautiful kites!”

“Fun clay whistles and rattle-drums!”

.....

Yuanyuan and Manman’s eyes sparkled as they looked to the left and the right, only to feel that a pair of eyes was not enough to see all of it.

With a thronging crowd coming and going, many took advantage to make mischief. Not far away, Qin Mian saw two thieves stumble on two passers-by, who took advantage of that opportunity to cut off their money pouches. The two passers-by kindly asked if the thieves had been hurt without knowing at all that they were in bad luck.

Lei Tie asked, “Wife, Yuanyuan, and Manman, what do you want to buy?”

Qin Mian was surprised as he looked at him and teased, “Yuanyuan and Manman, look if the sun is setting to the east today? Your Old Dad actually knows to ask us what we want.”

No matter how clever Yuanyuan and Manman were, they couldn’t understand his jokes. They honestly looked at the sun and shook their heads. The two brothers said in unison, “Dad said that the sun rises from the east and sets to the west.”

Lei Tie calmly put his arms around Qin Mian’s shoulder, “Didn’t you ask me to treat you all to delicious food before entering the city?”

The corner of Qin Mian’s lips curled up as he solemnly nodded, “It’s good that you hadn’t forgotten. Yuanyuan and Manman, what would you like to eat?”

Manman pointed a finger and frowned – a very tangled look; Yuanyuan looked left and right, seemingly couldn’t make up his mind either.

A youth about 13 to 14 years old came face to face with Qin Mian. All of a sudden, he tripped and fell onto Qin Mian.

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows with a smile of great interest on his lips. When the thief pounced on him and grasped his pouch, he grabbed the thief’s wrist as fast as lightning.

“Ouch!”

Manman looked down with suspicion and clapped his two hands, “Ah! Thief!”

The passers-by all around looked over, and as soon as they saw the youth holding Qin Mian's pouch, they immediately understood what had happened. They swore and condemned him, and at the same time, they quickly checked whether their pouches or purses were still there.

The youth had thought that it would be easier to take action while they were talking, but he didn't expect to be thwarted at the very beginning. He glared at Qin Mian in shame and anger, "You, you... Let go of *me!*"

Qin Mian gave a wee smile and exerted force. Only when the youth cried out in pain did he loosen him just slightly. He handed over Manman to Lei Tie.

"A-Tie, wait for me here. I'm going to send the thief to the local authority."

"No—" The youth stared in horror and his exclamation abruptly stopped after his neck suddenly felt numb.

Manman curiously asked, "Dad, why do you have to send him to the local authority?"

Yuanyuan said with a severe countenance, "Didi, he is a bad person. If you do something wrong, you will be punished."

Manman nodded with understanding.

The thief drooped his head.

Qin Mian grabbed the thief's shoulder, turned into an alley not far away, and stopped. He undid the youth's mute acupoint and released his hand.

Knowing that he was in a tough situation, the youth did not dare to escape even when he was not restrained. He timidly asked, "You... What do you want?"

Qin Mian spread his hands and said, "For the sake of your young age, I'll let you go today. But you won't be so lucky if I run into you next time."

The youth couldn't believe his ears. "Are you really going to let me go? Then why do you..." *deliberately go here and let go.*

"Because I don't want to mislead my sons." Qin Mian took out a piece of broken silver from his sleeve pocket and put it into the youth's hand. Without saying a word, he turned and left.

The youth looked at the young man's back and unconsciously followed him for a few steps. As the young man walked back to the black-clothed man, the cute little boy smilingly stretched out his arms to the young man.

Qin Mian knew that many thieves were specially trained to steal – there was an organization. He couldn't sympathize with the other. This youth might have been one of them. However, it suddenly occurred to him that the former Qin Mian was also at this age when he wandered about until he came to Green Mountain Village. Therefore, he did today's good deed.

At this time, he did not expect that today's unintentional benevolent act would form good karma for him. Thus, the old saying "a good deed will be well rewarded" was quite reasonable.

Back to our story. The family of four didn't pay any mind to this small episode. They tasted a few snacks, bought some toys for Yuanyuan and Manman, and went back to the inn.

It was not dinner time yet; there was no one in the lobby. Almost all the tables and chairs were occupied by scholars, who got together to probe knowledge, recite poems against each other, and even discuss some popular candidates for this year's spring exam. It was very noisy. The inn manager's attitude was very good. He was not only not angry, but also provided them with free tea. One didn't have to think about it to understand [why]. If a Zhuangyuan, Bangyan, and Tanhua¹ were from his inn, his inn would immediately become famous.

Qin Mian saw some red papers hanging on the wall at the corner of the stairs with names on them. Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui's names were among them. There was also a number written under each person's name.

“What is this?” asked Qin Mian.

Lei Tie said, “The odds of the spring exam’s popular candidates.”

Qin Mian widened his eyes in surprise, “Laying a bet on who will win the top three?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian shook his head. “I really admire those gamblers. They can bet on everything.”

Yuanyuan curiously asked, “Dad, what is ‘bet’?”

“Aah, my stomach is hungry again so soon. Let’s go back to our room.” Qin Mian strode upstairs with Yuanyuan in his arms.

Lei Tie chuckled. He and Manman kept up, neither too slow nor hurry.

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui were away and only came back in the evening. Qin Mian learned that they also had heard about some of the spring exam’s most popular figures. In the afternoon, when they communicated with some students from other prefectures, they unexpectedly found one of the most popular candidates for the Zhuangyuan – Gu Youran from Xishan Prefecture. Gu Youran’s odds were lower than those of Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui. The three had a good talk and even made an appointment to go together to the famous Garden of Many Flowers in the Capital the next day to attend the students’ meet.

Thinking that Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui would have to spend a lot on making new friends, Qin Mian gave them 50 taels of silver each.

Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui didn’t refuse; they indeed needed the money as it was convenient to carry more money to handle matters. They silently wrote down the kindness of their Eldest Brother and his wife. Later, they would pay the couple back.

Escort Zhang and the other three escorts couldn’t stay in the Capital all the time until the end of the spring exam. They left the Capital the next day.

Qin Mian, Bu Qingyun, and the others sent them out of the city gate together.

In the next few days, Lei Xiangzhi and his friends went out early and came back late, busy with the interaction and gathering with other students.

Qin Mian's family of four were busy sight-seeing. On the morning of the first day, Lei Tie took his wife and sons to visit the Imperial Palace. Of course, they only stayed outside about half a *li* away from the wall of the Palace. Civilians were not allowed to get too close to the Palace, otherwise, they would be punished as assassins.

Qin Mian was very curious about the Imperial Palace, including what the Emperor looked like, whether the Emperor's servants were eunuchs, whether the Emperor really had many wives, and whether the Empress and Imperial Concubines were all beautiful... He whispered to Lei Tie, "When my cultivation has gotten higher, I must secretly go in and have a look."

Lei Tie stuck close to his ear, "Take you in at night."

Qin Mian's eyes brightened. How did he forget that his family's big poker face was in the Imperial Court for two years; he must be very familiar with the Imperial Palace!

Manman blinked, moved close to Yuanyuan's ear, and said in a small voice, "Gege, I saw Old Dad secretly kiss Dad's ear again."

"Shh!" Yuanyuan softly said, "Don't say it. Old Dad said Dad would be shy, so even if we saw it, pretend not to see."

Qin Mian:

Lei Tie calmly picked up the two sons and quickly walked away, "Wife, let's take them to fly kites."

He had not taken two steps when he heard a low roar fuming with rage between gritted teeth behind him, "Lei, Tie!"

Manman cackled, "Old Dad, quickly run; Dad is catching up!"

Lei Tie tightly hugged the two little boys and walked very fast.

Qin Mian relentlessly pursued, “Stop!”

Yuanyuan was also delighted, “Come on, Dad!”

“Awoo!” White Spot vigorously followed.

The lively mood of the family of four plus a wolf infected the passers-by to have a little smile on their faces.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Respectively: Number One Scholar, Second Top Scorer, and Third Top Scorer

Chapter 151: A Night Tour in the Imperial Palace

151 – A Night Tour in the Imperial Palace

It was lovely spring sunshine in the 4th lunar month. On both sides of the gurgling river, fragrant grass was abundant, the willow's young leaves stirred gently in wind, colorful butterflies and diligent bees flew about on the wildflowers, and charming yellow orioles sung on the branches.

A carriage stopped by the river. White Spot was the first to jump out of the carriage and ran to and fro on the shiny green grassland.

There were other sightseers on a spring outing by the river, who gathered in twos and threes, either taking a walk or sitting lazily in the sun on the grass. There was also a lively 13 to 14 years old girl, who was running on the grass while pulling a kite. Her spry laughter was as sweet-sounding as a silver bell.

Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun successively removed the woolen blankets, barbecue racks, charcoal, food ingredients, and so on from the carriage.

Manman raised his head and looked at other people's kites flying so high. He was envious. He shook Qin Mian's hand and said, "Dad, I want to fly a kite."

Qin Mian rubbed his small head, "Alright, no hurry. Ask your Old Dad to bring your kites."

Not far away, a teen boy and a teen girl sat together. Upon hearing what was said, they turned to look over, a little curious. *How can such a small child fly kite?*

Lei Tie took out four kites from the carriage. Once unfurled, they were two big kites and two small kites. The two small kites were a tiger and a black wolf.

A glimmer of surprise flashed through the teen boy's eyes. He had never seen such a small kite before. It was obvious that the father of two little children made it, especially for his children.

There were no stones on the grass, so Qin Mian didn't worry that the two little boys would get hurt. He put five-fingered gloves on the two little boys' hands to prevent the string from cutting their skins. Then, he gave them the two kites but didn't teach them how to fly the kites.

"Go to play."

Yuanyuan and Manman were not surprised by their Dad's attitude. If they couldn't fly a kite, they would have to find a way by themselves. They turned and watched how other people fly a kite.

Qin Mian embraced Lei Tie's shoulders and stood not far away.

The more open their actions were, the lesser others would think.

Yuanyuan pulled Manman's little hand, "Didi, drag the kite and run."

"En." Manman nodded with understanding. He grinned at his Old Dad and Dad before running with his Gege while dragging the kite.

Unfortunately, the little boys ran slow. Even if they understood how to fly a kite by looking, it was hard to maneuver. The little boys ran on the grass for a long time, but the kites didn't fly.

Both the teen boy and girl could not help laughing in a low voice. The other sightseers in the distance also looked at the two little children in amusement.

Yuanyuan and Manman looked at each other and ran to their Old Dad and Dad. Yuanyuan accidentally fell. As if nothing had happened, he got up, patted the grass on his legs, and continued to run.

“Dad, Old Dad, the kites can’t fly.”

Qin Mian squatted down in front of Yuanyuan and asked with a smile, “Does Yuanyuan know why?”

Yuanyuan said, “Didi and I are too small.”

Manman put his small hand on his head as he added, “Gege and I are so much shorter than others with short arms and short legs. Running is slow, too.”

The smile on Qin Mian’s face became more and more gratifying. Manman might not understand the real reason why the kite couldn’t fly, but he could analyze the difference between himself and other people. For a three-year-old, it was really rare.

“Really smart.” Qin Mian took turns to kiss his two sons on the forehead. “Dad and Old Dad will take you two to fly the kites.”

He let Yuanyuan sit on his shoulders and then put his hand behind his son’s back for protection, to prevent him from falling back.

“Yuanyuan, let’s compete with your Didi to see whose kite flies the highest. Hold on to the kite.”

Yuanyuan and Manman clapped their hands and cheered, “Alright!”

“A-Tie, run when I shout ‘start’.” Qin Mian gave a very sly smile at Lei Tie. “Start!”

As soon as his voice fell, he ran away and yelled, “Yuanyuan, quickly let the string out, lift it a bit.”

“Dad is stupid.” Manman laughed. Even if his Old Dad didn’t speak, he could follow his Dad’s words. His small hand pulled out the string, and

learning from other kite-flying people, he lifted the string higher. In the wake of Lei Tie's run, the little tiger slowly flew up.

"Old Dad, my little tiger is flying!"

Lei Tie said in a calm and unhurried manner, "No hurry. Count to three and let the string out."

"En."

While the father and son here cooperated very well, the father and son over there were not bad either; the little black wolf leisurely ascended.

White Spot watched the black wolf that looked like it flew higher and higher, making it so excited that it howled and scared the people around. They were relieved only when they turned to see that it was sitting on the ground and didn't move.

Yuanyuan happily cried out, "Dad, the little black wolf flies so high!"

Qin Mian laughed and looked back at Manman's tiger before turning to run back. "Can still fly higher. Son, keep letting the string out."

"Alright—*aiyah!*" Yuanyuan was so excited that he failed to grasp the string firmly in his hand. The little black wolf spurred the coil to fly higher. Yuanyuan reached out to grab it, but he couldn't. He was greatly anxious. "Dad, the little black wolf has run away!"

"Yuanyuan, don't worry." Qin Mian held Yuanyuan tightly, stooped a little, and jumped to the tree at the side. By the means of the impact, he flew into the air and raised his hand to grasp the kite's string. The white figure stepped on empty air and landed leisurely.

"Dad is amazing!" Yuanyuan hugged his Dad's head, bowed, and kissed him on the cheek.

Lei Tie came with Manman on his shoulders.

Manman proudly said, "Gege, Old Dad and I won!"

Yuanyuan nodded and calmly said, “Next time, Dad and I will win.”

When Lei Tie saw the sweat on Yuanyuan’s head, he took out handkerchiefs from his inner pocket and handed them to the brothers.

The two little boys obediently wiped the sweat on their heads.

“Still playing?” asked Lei Tie.

Manman kissed his Old Dad’s face. “Old Dad and Dad have a rest. Gege and I will play later.”

“Alright.”

The fathers and sons returned to the carriage.

Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun were making barbecue. The aroma of barbecue transmitted along with the wind. When a group of people, who went on a spring outing, smelled the aroma, they all had the same thought: *That’s what people call enjoyment.*

Yuanyuan and Manman took off their shoes and rolled about on the blanket.

“Dad, I want to eat roasted chicken wings.” Manman lay on his stomach on the blanket with his chin propped up in his hands and his feet clapped each other.

Qin Mian took a look at the roasted wings on the grill. “It’s not ready yet, wait a bit. Manman, want to eat a lamb skewer with your Gege first?”

Manman obediently nodded, “Alright.”

“Careful, it’s hot.” Lei Tie gave Yuanyuan and Manman each a skewer of roasted lamb cubes. The rest was put on the plate and handed to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian patted the place beside him, and the two shared to eat.

The teen boy and girl in the distance gathered closer and talked in low voices.

“Brother, are they from the Capital? I’ve never seen the gloves and footwear that the two children wore.”

“More than that, have you ever noticed their carriage wheels? It’s unheard of.”

“Anyway, those two little boys are so adorable.”

After playing by the river until afternoon, Yuanyuan and Manman were tired. The family of four went back to the inn.

The students gathered in the lobby on the first floor of the inn as they did a few days ago, but it was rare that there was no noise. Instead, everyone was divided into two sides. Huo Sirui and the others were there. Qin Mian watched for a while. It turned out that they were reciting poems against each other and probing knowledge.

The family quietly went upstairs.

Qin Mian was still thinking about visiting the Palace.

In the evening, after Yuanyuan and Manman fell asleep, Lei Tie transferred them and White Spot to the big bed in the magical space. Then, he took Qin Mian to quietly leave the inn and flew in the direction of the Palace.

Qin Mian was very excited to be able to see the supreme ruler of the country soon.

At this time, around the end of the dog hour, the Imperial Palace was brightly lit. The Imperial Palace’s building complex was not much different from what Qin Mian had imagined – magnificent, stately, and solemn. He was not interested in this. He was more curious about the people in the Palace.

“Where does the Emperor live?” asked him to Lei Tie in a secret channel.

Lei Tie embraced him and took him to fly again.

None of the Palace Guards patrolling back and forth in the Palace noticed two figures passing by.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie quietly stopped on the eaves of a palace.

Lei Tie hugged Qin Mian from behind. “On the opposite.”

He raised his head and looked straight. There was a table with a bright yellow tablecloth on the opposite side of the open window. Behind the table sat a middle-aged man, wearing a golden crown and a bright yellow robe. It was obviously the current’s Emperor Xiaohui, who was slightly looking down at the folding book in his hands. Emperor Xiaohui was about 42 to 43 years old. He had regular features and dignified bearing; his monarch’s prestige was like nature itself. A chamberlain stood behind him quietly with a horsetail whisk on his arms, as seen in the TV series. The chamberlain’s features looked pretty and delicate with a white face; he was probably a eunuch. Behind the spacious and gorgeous dragon chair, two beautiful palace maids stood on the left and right with their heads drooped in silence.

Emperor Xiaohui suddenly raised his head; his eyes were bright and full of expression, gloriously twinkling.

Qin Mian was startled. For a moment, he forgot that he and Lei Tie were invisible. He thought the other party had noticed them.

Lei Tie tightened his hold and comfortingly stroked his wife’s back. “Don’t be afraid, I’m here.”

Qin Mian relaxed and leaned against him. His lips awkwardly curled up as he somewhat admired Emperor Xiaohui – he indeed had the so-called “*domineering* aura”.¹

He excitedly said, “Then, go to the Imperial Harem to have a look.”

Lei Tie didn’t move.

Qin Mian thought Lei Tie didn’t hear. “A-Tie, let’s go to the Imperial Harem to see.”

Lei Tie said in a low voice, “Haven’t been there.”

“The so-called ‘Imperial Harem’ is, of course, behind the Palace where the Emperor handles official matters...” Qin Mian looked up and pointed in a direction, “should it be over there?”²

Qin Mian suddenly realized. *Is this guy jealous?* He turned his head and looked at Lei Tie. Lei Tie evaded his sight. Qin Mian extended his head in front of Lei Tie and smilingly looked at him.

Lei Tie seriously said, “There’s nothing nice to look at in the Imperial Harem.”

Qin Mian embraced Lei Tie’s shoulders and put his head on his chest. He yawned and closed his eyes. “I’m sleepy, go back.”

Lei Tie’s eyes filled with profound tenderness. After pecking on his wife’s forehead, he flew up like an eagle spreading its wings and quietly disappeared into the night.

Note:

Footnotes

1. The “domineering” word here is used in a ridiculing way.
2. Imperial Harem in Chinese is called “Rear Palace”.

Chapter 152: One's Name is on the List of Successful Candidates

152 – One's Name is on the List of Successful Candidates

In the twinkling of an eye, the two appeared in the inn room.

All of a sudden, Qin Mian suddenly opened his eyes and abruptly crushed Lei Tie on the bed. He looked at the man with a smile and moved his fingers across the man's face. "A-Tie, were you jealous just now?"

Lei Tie relaxed his body, allowing Qin Mian to lie more comfortably. The hair on his face made him itch, just like his mood at this time.

"You know."

"I want to hear it from you." Qin Mian's fingers moved downward in a mischievous way before arriving at the man's neck and slowly fell on his Adam's apple, which Qin Mian gently pressed and scratched with his fingernails.

Lei Tie's body suddenly stretched tautly and his Adam's apple rapidly rolled. He spoke in a hoarse voice, "Wife, don't play with fire."

Qin Mian didn't say anything. Pressing the man's Adam's apple with his forefinger, he leaned on the man's ear, took a breath, and whispered, "As long as you admit that you are jealous, I'll take the initiative tonight."

"I'm jealous." Lei Tie's answer was straight to the point without the slightest hesitation; his dark and deep eyes glowed under the candle flame with fervent lust rolling inside.

Qin Mian raised his right leg and sat on the man's waist. He bent over to seal their lips and waved his sleeve to extinguish the candle flame.....

“Dad's lazybones; Dad's lazybones!”

Tender childish voice jabbered on and on at the side. Qin Mian covered his head with a quilt. He so wanted to jump up and grab Manman to slap his little bottom.

“Manman, be quiet. Yesterday, your Dad played with you all day. He's very tired.” Lei Tie stopped his naughty little son and patted Qin Mian on his back to coax him back to sleep.

Qin Mian retorted in his heart: *it's obviously because of you, the scoundrel with excess energy.*

After struggling between half-asleep and half-awake for a long time, Qin Mian finally woke up. The ache on his waist reminded him how he had reaped what he sowed last night.

“Wife, awake?” Lei Tie's head leaned over without expression, but his light tone and slightly curled lips revealed his good mood.

Mensao!¹

Qin Mian glanced at him with scorn. Before he could speak, Yuanyuan and Manman rushed to the side of the bed like two small cannonballs.

“Dad, you wake up at last!”

“Dad, I want to go out to play!”

“Dad—”

“Stop!” Qin Mian raised his hand to stop the two little boys, “You two, go there obediently and wait for me to put on my clothes, wash up, and have breakfast before we go out, understand?”

“Understood!” The two little boys got the answer. They went back to the toys laid on the ground hand in hand and continued to play on their own.

Lei Tie hugged Qin Mian to sit up. With his back against Yuanyuan and Manman, he tenderly rained kisses on every inch of Qin Mian’s face.

Qin Mian raised a smile and looked at him with gentle eyes. In the past, every time after lovemaking, Lei Tie either slept with him in bed or quietly got up to cook. It was the first time that he dawdled to be lovey-dovey and didn’t leave. Nevertheless, it was undeniable that the man’s intimate action to him was like fragrant wine, making him unable to refuse.

However, his cultivation had yet reached the stage of abstaining from eating, so he still needed to solve the matter of dressing warmly and eating one’s fill first.

“I’m hungry.”

Lei Tie sealed Qin Mian’s lips sucked them for a while. Then, he said in a low voice, “I asked the waiter to make porridge for you. Bath first?”

“En.” Qin Mian kissed the man on his face. He stretched his arms, lifted the quilt, and got out of bed.

After putting things in order, the family of four went to Xiangyang Mountain to tour.

The next day, the family of four went to Wen’an Temple to pray.

The third day was Yuanyuan and Manman’s third birthday. Qin Mian let Yuanyuan and Manman arrange the whole day’s activities, while he and Lei Tie followed the two little boys’ arrangement. The family of four had a great time throughout the day.

Two days later was the spring examination.

There were three exams all together in the spring examination, three days each. It was not only a test of mental work but also physical work. It was said that during the examination, every scholar was put in a long and

narrow numbered room. During the examination, the door was locked, so it was hard to avoid feeling oppressed. Every year, some candidates fainted in the examination rooms due to poor health.

It was also unavoidable for Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui to have an unexpected occurrence. On the day before the examination, Qin Mian called them to sit in the room for a while. He let them drink a cup of tea with spiritual spring water and gave two refreshing sachets made from herbs picked in the magical space for them to wear.

Nine days later, when the last exam was coming to an end, Qin Mian and his family took the carriage to the gate of the Examination Hall. There were a lot of carriages at the gate, all of which came to wait for the candidates.

Not long after the bell rang at the end of the examination, the candidates came out of the Examination Hall one after another. Almost all of them had shed a layer of skin such that their complexions were white, their eye rims were black, and their footsteps went soft. Some of the candidates smiled in exultant with a look of victory in hands; some with a distressed look, grief-stricken as if bereaved of parents; more were so heartbroken that they couldn't help kneeling on the ground and cried mournfully with their faces covered, making the listeners felt sympathy and sighed.

Qin Mian, like the relatives and friends of other candidates, eagerly searched for Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui's figures among the thousands of candidates pouring out like flowing water. Not a while later, the two walked out side by side. Lei Xiangzhi looked bright, calm, and reserved. One could see that he was very relaxed. Huo Sirui had a smile on his lips, looking confident and happy. Their perfectly composed attitudes were particularly conspicuous within the crowd.

"It seems that they both did well in the exam." Qin Mian pulled back and turned as he said that to Lei Tie with a smile.

Lei Tie lightly patted the sleeping Yuanyuan and Manman in his arms.
"Relieved? Go back."

There were too many people. Qin Mian told Lei-Qin Le to drive away without waiting for Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui.

Not long after returning to the inn, Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui knocked on Qin Mian's door.

Qin Mian didn't mention that his family had been waiting for a long time at the gate of the Examination Hall. He laughed and joked with them, "By your expressions, your Eldest Brother and I should be able to feast twice in celebration?"

Lei Xiangzhi said with a smile, "I feel good about it myself. But I don't know the result yet."

Huo Sirui had a relaxing face. "All the exam questions are done quite smoothly, so there should be no problem. Anyway, I've tried my best. Now, I'm just waiting for the result."

Lei Xiangzhi said, "The sachet that Eldest Sister-in-law gave is very useful. After the three exams, I'm still in good spirits. Two students in the opposite rooms of me fainted and were carried out."

Thinking of the situation at that time, he was very glad that he had a capable Eldest Sister-in-law.

Huo Sirui picked up the sachet hanging around his neck and smelled it. "The weather had been bad the day before yesterday. I was still a little dizzy when I just entered the examination. As soon as I smelled the sachet, I immediately sobered up. Elder Sister-in-law, if Fifth Brother and I can truly obtain the top three, you'll have more than half of the credit."

"That's your real ability. It doesn't have much to do with me." Qin Mian asked, "I heard that the list will be released in five days. What are your plans for these days?"

Lei Xiangzhi said, "I was just discussing it with Sirui. We'll take advantage of these days to go sightseeing in the Capital. In any case, it's not a waste to come here."

“Eldest Sister-in-law, why don’t you all join us?” invited Huo Sirui.

Qin Mian shook his head with a smile, “We’re dragging a family, so we won’t accompany you, lest we disturb your mood to enjoy.”

Five days later, the list was going to be released. All the students who had fun outside rushed back to the Capital.

Before dawn, Qin Mian heard the sound of footsteps in the corridor and stairs now and then. He was so disturbed that he dived straight into Lei Tie’s bosom.

When the whole family got out of bed and had breakfast in the lobby on the first floor, they found that the whole Swan Goose Path Inn was almost empty. When they asked the waiter, it turned out that the scholars all went to the place where the list was posted early in the morning. At the moment, they hadn’t heard any special news on the street outside. Perhaps, the examination result list hadn’t been posted yet.

Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Zhao Tianhe went downstairs. Qu Zongwen and Zhao Tianhe looked tense; Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, and Bu Qingyun appeared calm.

Qu Zongwen only ate two mouthfuls of porridge and then couldn’t eat anymore. He patted the unfolded folding fan on his hand, a little restless. “My old man gave me a word. If I didn’t pass, I’ll get the caning when I go back.”

Yuanyuan and Manman secretly smiled.

“Uncle Qu is so big, but still get a beating on the butt from his Dad.”

Qu Zongwen put on a pitiful expression, “Yes, Uncle is so pitiful.”

Zhao Tianhe looked as if he sat on pins and needles. He stuffed a steamed stuffed bun into his mouth and unclearly said, “I have to eat quickly, I’m going to see [the list].”

Bu Qingyun patted him in comfort on the shoulder and said, “It’s a foregone conclusion whether you pass or not. It’s the same whether you see it earlier or later. Eat slowly, don’t choke.”

Qin Mian could understand Qu Zongwen and Zhao Tianhe’s mood. When they were at Qinyun Academy, they were all outstanding students. However, out of several thousand students in the conference examination countrywide, there were only 300 places, which was a hundred times crueller than the college entrance examination. Those on the list were called “Gongshi”, who were qualified to participate in the palace examination. Becoming a Gongshi² was almost equal to becoming a Jinshi³. In other words, if there was no accident, a Gongshi could become a Jinshi, but they were ranked in a different order.

Qin Mian asked Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun to go see the list after breakfast.

Qu Zongwen and Zhao Tianhe looked at him gratefully. They were two weak scholars who couldn’t squeeze past so many people.

After breakfast, the few people did not leave but waited in the lobby. The inn manager and the waiters were also very idle at the moment. They sat together and chatted.

About an hour later, there was a lot of commotion outside. The list must have been released!

The candidates who stayed in Swan Goose Path Inn came back one after another. Some of them were smiling, obviously on the list; if they were qualified to enter the palace for the examination, they might even meet the Emperor. Meanwhile, some of them were as pale as ashes; their names must not be among those of the successful on the list...

Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, and Bu Qingyun were also a little nervous, as they were influenced by the atmosphere in the inn.

Nearly an hour later, Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Shun, and Lei-Qin Zhong ran in from outside the door, gasping for breath. They all looked happy and yelled

as soon as they entered.

“Eldest Master, Little Master; passed, passed!”

The manager and the few waiters also looked over.

Qu Zongwen asked, “Who passed? Or everyone passed?”

Lei-Qin Le grinned and held out his hands to Lei Xiangzhi and his four friends, “Five gongzis, all five of you passed! Congratulations!”

Lei Xiangzhi and the four looked at each other happily.

“All passed? Wonderful!”

Bu Qingyun was the most straightforward person; he grabbed a lot of copper coins from his pouch and gave them to Lei-Qin Le. He laughed heartily, “For you three to buy drinks!”

Lei-Qin Le quickly thanked, “Many thanks, Bu-gongzi!”

Zhao Tianhe asked, “What’s the ranking?”

Lei-Qin Le scratched his head. “Because there are too many people, the crowd pushed about. Your servant I didn’t look at it carefully, only know that Fifth-gongzi and Huo-gongzi’s name are on the second and fifth respectively. Qu-gongzi’s name is in the middle. Bu-gongzi and Zhao-gongzi’s names are also in the middle but there are about twenty names between them and Qu-gongzi.”

Note:

Footnotes

1. outwardly cold or retiring but deep and passionate inside
2. Tribute Scholar; a recognized scholarly achiever who passed the triennial conference exam
3. Advanced Scholar; a graduate who passed the triennial palace exam

Chapter 153: Five People Suddenly Got a Strange Illness

153 – Five People Suddenly Got a Strange Illness

After hearing that, Qu Zongwen cupped his hands in obeisance to Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui, and teased, “Congratulations to Brother Lei and Brother Huo. Later, when you two parade in the street, take us along, hahaha!”

Both Bu Qingyun and Zhao Tianhe chimed in with a laugh.

Lei Xiangzhi shook his head as he laughed. “It’s too early to say that.” Then, he asked Lei-Qin Le, “Who are the other three in the top five? Is there a Gu-gongzi?”

Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun all laughed dryly.

Lei-Qin Zhong said, “Fifth-gongzi, to find your names faster, Lei-Qin Le was looking from the top to the bottom, while this servant I and Lei-Qin Shun were looking from the bottom to the top. We’re only looking for your names, so we didn’t pay attention to others.”

Lei Xiangzhi didn’t mind and said, “It’s fine, just asking. Thanks for the trouble.”

Huo Sirui looked at the door of the inn; more and more scholars came back. “We’ll know by listening to other people.”

When the inn manager saw that they had finished talking, he wore a smile on his face and quickly walked over to congratulate Lei Xiangzhi and the others. He was especially enthusiastic toward Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui.

Qin Mian lifted his teacup as he thought, *I'm afraid the odds at the corner of the stairs will change*. He suddenly felt a jolt in his heart and reached for the pouch on Lei Tie's waist.

Lei Tie didn't understand. Still, he took the initiative to raise his left arm to facilitate his wife's action.

Qin Mian took out a 50-tael silver ingot from the pouch, called Lei-Qin Le over, and quietly ordered him in a few words while Yuanyuan and Manman didn't notice.

Lei-Qin Le nodded repeatedly and ran to the counter carrying the silver ingot. After thinking about it, he followed his Little Master to lay a bet of one silver tael.

They sat on the first floor for a while. The top five in the result list were as follows: Zhao Xianzhi from the Capital City, Lei Xiangzhi from Qingtian Prefecture, Zhang He from the Capital City, Gu Youran from Xishan Prefecture, and Huo Sirui from Qingtian Prefecture. These five people were the most popular candidates to compete for the Zhuangyuan, Bangyan, and Tanhua.

The Capital City was full of talented scholars, so it was not surprising that it occupied two places in the top five, but for Qingtian Prefecture to occupy two places, it exceeded all expectations. The scholars in Swan Goose Path Inn gathered around and made friends with Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui. In a short time, the table was surrounded, very compactly.

The group lose no time to retreat and went to Qin Man and Lei Tie's room on the second floor.

When they had stood still, Lei Xiangzhi found that his sachet was torn off by someone at an unknown time; he palmed his forehead in silence. Huo Sirui and Qu Zongwen were all disheveled; they looked at each other and burst into laughter.

Qin Mian amusedly looked at them. "I haven't officially congratulated you. At noon, A-Tie and I invite you to Yingbin Building to have a meal..."

Before he finished speaking, the door was knocked. Outside, stood the manservant who had brought them to the inn.

“This servant I pay respects to the gongzis.”

“Ping’an.” Huo Sirui walked over and asked, “Why are you here? Did Uncle Yuan order you?”

Ping’an smilingly said, “Congratulations to the five gongzis. When our Old Master learned that the five gongzis were on the list, he felt honored and will hold a banquet in the residence to celebrate the five gongzis at the end of the rooster hour¹ this evening. Do the five gongzis have free time?”

By situation, Yuan Anshi had given them a lot of care. By reason, if they became officials in the future, they should continue to deepen their friendship with Yuan Anshi from now on. None of the five refused this opportunity.

“It’s our great honor to be invited by Uncle Yuan. Tell Uncle Yuan that we’ll arrive on time.”

“Yes, this servant will take his leave.”

Taught by Dean Huo, Huo Sirui was more skillful in dealing with people. He reminded Lei Xiangzhi and the others, “Uncle Yuan has taken care of us a lot, so we can’t refuse this time. Since we haven’t taken part in the palace examination, we should be more restrained in our words and deeds. Later, if someone invites, it’s better to decline.”

Lei Xiangzhi and the others nodded to express their understanding.

Near noon, the group came to Yingbin Building and asked for a private room. Qin Mian and Lei Tie treated Lei Xiangzhi and the others to a generous meal so that they could make up for the last nine days.

Lei Xiangzhi’s group of five also co-operated to gather money and gave Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Zhong, and Lei-Qin Shun a table of good food and wine. Although these three people were servants, they were not *their*

servants. Therefore, they couldn't take the three men's protection and care for granted.

In the evening, Lei Xiangzhi's group of five went to Yuan Residence to take part in the banquet.

To make them more convenient, Yuan Anshi arranged a study-attendant for each of them.

The palace examination was in a month. In the following days, Lei Xiangzhi, Huo Sirui, Qu Zongwen, Bu Qingyun, and Zhao Tianhe resumed their former days, in which they often went to participate in the students' meet to prepare for the palace examination one month later.

After Qin Mian's family had toured the Capital, they began to roam around the Capital to the surrounding towns, practically seeing all the beautiful scenery around.

The last place they went to was Four-colored Mountain. After visiting Four-Colored Mountain and resting in the Capital for another two days, they would be ready to leave for home. They had been away for nearly two months.

The scenery of the Four-colored Mountain was particularly peculiar. It had four colors throughout the year: purple in spring, white in summer, yellow in autumn, and red in winter. The reason was that the mountain was full of purple hyacinth, white jasmine, yellow chrysanthemum, and red wintersweet. As a result, the colors were different every season. What's stranger was that these four kinds of flowers were not planted intentionally; it had been like that since hundreds of years ago.

Qin Mian came at the right time. The hyacinths all over the mountain were in full bloom. The purple was like a huge purple sweater covering the mountain. When the wind blew gently, the smell of fragrance assailed one's nostrils, making one intoxicated.

There was an inn on the hillside. Qin Mian's family stayed in the mountain for three nights before they returned to the Capital.

Near noon, at the south city gate, Ping'an walked around looking anxious. When he saw the familiar carriage, he burst into tears. He was so excited that he almost got run down by the carriage.

"Hush—" Lei-Qin Le quickly stopped the carriage, "Ping'an, even if you miss us, you don't have to be so excited, do you? Don't want to live?"

Ping'an wiped a handful of tears and anxiously asked, "Brother Le, don't make fun of me. Are Lei-gongzi and Qin-gongzi in the carriage?"

Qin Mian noticed that his voice was not right. He leaned out his head and asked in puzzlement, "Ping'an, what happened?"

His calmness gradually calmed Ping'an down, who wiped his face and said quickly, "Qin-gongzi, you and Lei-gongzi, please go back to the inn and have a look. Lei-gongzi and Huo-gongzi are very ill. The doctor said, said..."

"What?" Qin Mian's face abruptly changed and he made a quick decision. "You get on the carriage and tell us in detail. Lei-Qin Le, go back to the inn immediately."

Ping'an hastily said, "Qin-gongzi, go to Yuan Residence. Our Old Master has taken them to the residence."

Qin Mian nodded to himself, *Sir Yuan is very thoughtful.*

As soon as Ping'an got on the carriage and sat down, Qin Mian said in a low voice, "Ping'an, don't be anxious. Let me ask you first; why are they both fell ill at the same time? Or is it contagious, are the others ill?"

Yuanyuan and Manman seemed to be aware of the seriousness of the atmosphere and sat quietly in Lei Tie's arms. Yuanyuan even gave Ping'an a handkerchief.

"Many thanks, Yuanyuan-gongzi." Ping'an smiled at Yuanyuan and answered Qin Mian's question, "Huo-gongzi's group of five are ill. The other scholars are not ill."

Qin Mian had a lot of doubts in his heart. “Are the five of them sick at the same time, or is there a sequence?”

Ping’an replied, “They fell ill at the same time.”

At the same time, and only five of them are sick. Qin Mian felt even more strange, “Now, you’re to tell me the cause and effect of the whole thing.”

“Yes.” Ping’an calmed down completely and narrated in an orderly way, “Qin-gongzi, this is what happened. Three days ago, Huo-gongzi’s group of five went to the Garden of Many Flowers to attend the students’ meet. When they came back, they all felt a little uncomfortable. Just because it was windy that day, they thought it was cold and didn’t care. Who knows, the next day near noon, they were still asleep. Their study-attendants felt that it was not right, so they called in a doctor. The doctor said that five of them were infected with a cold. He prescribed two doses of medicine, but they didn’t improve. The study-attendants were not at ease and reported the matter to our Old Master. Old Master sent someone to Rejuvenation Hall, the largest medicine hall in the Capital, and invited a highly experienced doctor. The doctor concluded that it was not cold, but he could not find out why they remain unconscious. Old Master then spent a large sum of money to invite the Imperial Doctor. The Imperial Doctor said that they were afflicted with a strange poison. The antidote requires several rare herbs, which can only be collected from the Medicinal Storehouse in the Inner Palace. He also said that if they don’t wake up within five days, they will never wake up again... Huo-gongzi and the others are so young and knowledgeable; this servant I envy them. If they just... How unfortunate ah...” He kept shaking his head and sighing as he spoke, and then began to wipe his tears.

Qin Mian’s face turned cold, and he said to Lei Tie, “A-Tie, it seems that someone had cast a poison. However, their interpersonal relationships are extremely simple, so they should not have formed such a big feud with others. Could it be accidental?”

Lei Tie’s eyes were full of cold glint. He grabbed his wife’s shoulder and shook his head slightly. “Wife, you are too simple-minded.”

This was the first time that someone thought he was simple-minded; Qin Mian felt strange. “What do you mean?”

Lei Tie said in a dull voice, “I can’t think of any other reasons except for the palace examination.”

Qin Mian was taken aback.

Ping’an sighed, “To tell you the truth, our Old Master also has this suspicion. Qu-gongzi, Bu-gongzi, and Zhao-gongzi are most likely implicated by Huo-gongzi and Lei-gongzi. Now, this matter has spread all over the Capital. There are all kinds of rumors. Some people said it was done by the gamblers, some said it was done by someone in the top ten, and others said it was the five gongzis who refused to be rope in by a certain Sir... Even more, some said that they can’t bear the pressure and poison themselves... Really... Public opinions are divergent, a mixture of true and false. The more people think about it, the more confused they are.”

Qin Mian had a look of dumbfounded and endlessly sighed. The water in the Capital was very deep. It was no wonder that his A-Tie preferred rural life.

While talking, the carriage arrived at Yuan Residence.

As Ping’an leading the way, Qin Mian walked fast in front. Meanwhile, Lei Tie, who was carrying the two children, had not fallen behind at all.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Rooster Hour is from 5:00 PM to 7:00 PM. The end is 6:30 PM.

Chapter 154: Display One's Talent for the First Time

154 – Display One's Talent for the First Time (Part 1)

When Yuan Anshi learned that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had come back, he quickly went out to welcome them. From a long distance, he cupped his hands and sighed, “Eldest Lei-gongzi and Qin-gongzi, this old fellow feels ashamed for not taking good care of Lei-gongzi and Sirui.”

“Sir Yuan is overstating. It has nothing to do with Sir Yuan.” Lei Tie asked, “Where are they?”

Yuan Anshi raised his hand as he said, “This way, please.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie followed him into a winding corridor.

“If you two have the right social connection in the Capital, there may be a way. If we could invite the Imperial Doctor to appear personally, maybe...” Yuan Anshi had a deep sense of shame in his eyes. If something happened to Huo Sirui in the Capital, he couldn't explain it to his good friend of many years.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had no comment. Everything had to wait until they had seen Lei Xiangzhi with their own eyes.

In a moment, they arrived at the east courtyard.

Yuan Anshi looked at Yuanyuan and Manman, worried that they would be shocked. “Lei-gongzi's appearance is not very good... The children should stay out.”

Lei Tie handed Yuanyuan and Manman to Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Zhong, “Take good care of them.”

“Yes, Eldest Master can rest assured.” Lei-Qin Le and Lei-Qin Zhong held the two soft children with care.

Yuan Anshi called a maidservant and asked her to prepare some snacks for the two children.

Walking into Lei Xiangzhi’s room, Qin Mian was startled to see his face. Lei Xiangzhi’s face was white, his lips were pale, and his breath was shallow. At first glance, Qin Mian thought he was a dead man.

Qin Mian sat down on the edge of the bed and picked up Lei Xiangzhi’s wrist to feel his pulse. [Magical] Pill and medicine were a group. The premise for him to learn concocting magic pills [alchemy] was to identify medicinal materials. It was a piece of cake for him to feel the pulse.

Yuan Anshi was a bit surprised. He had never heard that this Qin-gongzi possessed medical skills before.

After a few breaths, Qin Mian put Lei Xiangzhi’s wrist back into the quilt, looking slightly relaxed.

“How is it, wife?” asked Lei Tie.

Yuan Anshi nervously looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said, “It’s really poisoned.”

Yuan Anshi immediately asked, “Is there any solution?”

“Yes.” Qin Mian said, “I’ll go to see if the others are afflicted with the same kind of poison.”

When Yuan Anshi saw that Qin Mian seemed to be confident, he did not urge Qin Mian.

Qin Mian felt Huo Sirui and the others' pulses respectively and determined that they had the same kind of poison.

“This poison seems mild, but in fact it's overbearing. Fortunately, we came back in time. Even more fortunate that I have five antidote pills with me. Otherwise—” Qin Mian shook his head and cupped his hands in obeisance to Yuan Anshi, “Sir Yuan, the antidote pills will expel the poison from their bodies in two hours. I'll have to trouble you to arrange people to take care of them.”

Yuan Anshi was very happy, “As long as it can be detoxified, this old fellow will arrange it.”

Qin Mian took out a small white porcelain jar from his pocket that could be held in one hand. He didn't let outsiders interfere. He personally fed each of them a detoxification pill. After waiting for a while, he felt their pulses again and nodded slightly.

“The pills are starting to work. Let's go out first.”

Yuan Anshi nodded as he said, “Gentlemen, please. We'll talk in the main hall.”

The three men sat down in the main hall.

Yuan Anshi wore a lamenting face and cupped his hand as he said, “Qin-gongzi, this old fellow wants to thank you. Yongcheng trusts me, so he entrusts Sirui to me. If something happens to him, this old fellow won't be pardon even if I die ten thousand of death.”

Qin Mian cupped his hands to return the salute, “Sir Yuan regarded me as an outsider. Sirui is my and A-Tie's brother-in-law; it's my duty to save him. It's also their luck, otherwise, even the Daoist Immortal Daluo can't save them. As the saying goes, ‘one is bound for good fortune after surviving a great disaster’. Sir Yuan doesn't have to worry about it.”

Yuan Anshi repeatedly nodded, “That's right. May I know the name of this poison?”

Qin Mian said, “if I guess it correctly, the first two days of their poisoning were typhoid symptoms.”

“Correct,” said Yuan Anshi, firmly.

Qin Mian added, “This is the specialty of this poison. The symptoms of the poisoned person on the first two days are exactly the same as that of typhoid, which often does not cause the attention of the poisoning. On the third day, when the person feels something is wrong, the toxicity has spread to the whole body. If the person fails to take the antidote within three days, either he spends time in an unconscious state or dies in poor health; the weak will go off like the snuff of a candle. Therefore, this poison has a terrible name: Gate of Hell.”

“Indeed, the name is terrible.” Yuan Anshi was angry and struck the table. “I’ve reported this to the local authority. We must find out who actually dared to attack the Gongshi(s)¹ in the Imperial City.”

After that, he looked worried. “The palace examination is in three days. I don’t know if they can still catch up.”

“Rest assured, Sir Yuan.” Qin Mian said, “When they wake up, I’ll prepare a medicinal bathwater for them to soak in, and that’ll do.”

He immediately wrote a prescription for Lei-Qin Shun to fetch. Because the time was too short, the effect of ordinary herbs was too mediocre, so he had to secretly add a little spiritual spring water to the bathwater.

Yuan Anshi was still a little uneasy at the bottom of his heart. After two hours, his servants came to report that all five of them had woken up and their faces had recovered some vitality. Only then he was relieved and had more confidence in Qin Mian’s medical skills.

The few of them were talking when a manservant came in in a hurry.

“Reporting to the Old Master: there is a man who calls himself Lei-Qin Cheng outside the gate. He said he wanted to see Eldest Lei-gongzi and Qin-gongzi for an urgent matter.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie's faces changed slightly at the same time.

"Sir Yuan, he's a servant of ours, coming from our hometown."

Yuan Anshi noticed the looks on their faces and quickly told the manservant, "Invite him in."

Qin Mian was ill at ease. Not long after they arrived in the Capital, he had asked Lei Tie to write home a letter confirming their safety. Something must have happened at home, otherwise, Lei-Qin Cheng would not have come all the way to the Capital.

Lei Tie held his wife's hand. His calming voice made one feel at ease, "I'm here."

In a short time, the manservant led Lei-Qin Cheng in.

Lei-Qin Cheng was travel-worn and weary. He knelt and said, "Greetings to Eldest Master and Little Master."

Yuan Anshi stood up. "Lei-gongzi and Qin-gongzi, this old fellow remembers that something needs to be dealt with. Please excuse me."

"Please go ahead, Sir Yuan."

"Make yourselves at home." Yuan Anshi left with the manservant.

Lei Tie asked Lei-Qin Cheng in a heavy tone, "What's the matter?"

Lei-Qin Cheng answered, "Eldest Master and Little Master, nine days ago, famous chefs from all over the country came to Double Xiang House one after another, declaring to have a competition with the chefs of Double Xiang House. If Double Xiang House loses, it has to publish the secret recipes of thirteen spices and eighteen delicacies to the public. Manager Sun declined on the ground that the two Masters were not there and he could not be the master himself. However, those people were not reconciled and said that they were willing to stay in Running Water Town and wait for the two Masters to be back. Manager Sun knew that this matter was far from good, and immediately sent your servant to hurry to the Capital. Your

servant went to Swan Goose Path Inn first. After asking the people in the Inn, your servant found out that the two Masters were in Yuan Residence, and so came over.”

Click to continue to Part 2 🤪

Note:

Chapter 155: Play Big If You're Going to Play

155 – Play Big If You're Going to Play

“Manager Sun, when will your bosses come back? We’ve been waiting for nearly half a month.” A fat man leaned on the counter, seemed as if he didn’t see Manager Sun’s ugly face, “Going to the Capital or whatever is just your excuse, isn’t it?”

Manager Sun took a look at the other diners in the lobby and said with patience, “Chef Wu, I have already said that I’d sent someone to find our bosses a few days ago. The Capital is at least half a month away from Running Water Town. Our bosses can’t fly. Or, why don’t Chef Wu demonstrate it to me?”

Greatly embarrassed, Wu Dewang put down his arm but his mouth still didn’t spare anyone, “Who knows if your bosses are deliberately delaying? We’re not from small shops. We’re all famous chefs in big wine houses. It doesn’t make sense to let us wait like this, does it?”

Zheng Xiangui squared his shoulders with hands behind his back as he added fuel to the fire, “You don’t say! I think, your bosses really went to the Capital, but instead to hide out of fear after receiving the news?”

Several waiters had their faces covered with fury, but due to the rules of the wine house, they dared not act rashly.

Manager Sun was very angry but smiled instead, and said with a drawl, “If your distinguished selves had sent a notice in advance, our bosses will respectfully wait for your distinguished selves here in any way. In other

words, your distinguished selves didn't send any notice, but all arrived in Running Water Town almost on the same day. Was it really not an agreement made in advance? That's a bit of a coincidence."

As soon as the customers in the lobby heard it, they immediately understood that these people were deliberately making an appointment to make trouble together in the absence of Double Xiang House's bosses.

Wu Dewang, Zheng Xiangui, and the other five chefs all had a slight change in their looks and flatly denied it.

Manager Sun waved his hand and said, "I don't care whether you have made an agreement or not. Either you step back, or find a place to sit down. Don't delay my work here. Please."

"Manager Sun, you don't have to stall any longer. I think it's better to do it today." Wu Dewang wrinkled his brows and said in a raised voice, "In fact, you, Double Xiang House's staff, don't have to be so afraid. Maybe you can win? Brother Zheng, don't you think so?"

"That's right!" Zheng Xiangui and the others laughed heartily.

"You!" Chen Si was so angry that he wanted to come forward but was stopped by Manager Sun.

Manager Sun was about to open his mouth when a familiar clear and bright voice came from outside—

"It's no fun just to compete with a few people. If you want to compete, make it bigger!"

Manager Sun and the other staff looked so happy and excitedly exclaimed, "Little Boss is back!"

Wu Dewang and the others turned to look. A figure of a young man dressed in white like a ghost came in from the door and fell quietly in front of them.

A short moment later, a man dressed in black came in floating with two sleeping little children dressed in red in his arms, just like a fallen leaf, and

stood side by side with the white-clothed young man. His cold eyes looked around the people in front of the counter with indifference. There was a nip in the air.

White Spot poked its head out from behind them with an arrogant look and cold eyes.

“Big Boss is back, too!” Manager Sun and the others looked even happier and high-spirited that their backs were straighter than before.

Qin Mian glanced coolly at Wu Dewang’s group and walked over slowly with Lei Tie.

Manager Sun led the group of staff to salute with great momentum.

“Greetings to Big Boss and Little Boss!”

Wu Dewang and the others were frightened and puzzled. Why did the bosses of Double Xiang House come back so soon? Even if they rode fast horses, it would take them at least six days to get from the Capital to Running Water Town. When Lei-Qin Cheng was sent out, they all knew about it. According to the calculation of time, it should take another three days for Qin Mian and Lei Tie to come back from the Capital.

They couldn’t have known that Qin Mian was so worried about Double Xiang House that after a few days in the carriage, he and Lei Tie went ahead first – Lei Tie directly flew the father and sons back. Lei-Qin Le and the others were left behind with the carriage.

Qin Mian hinted at the staff to continue their work with a wave of his hand. To Wu Dewang’s group, he smiled politely and saluted, “I’m Qin Mian, the Little Boss of Double Xiang House. I haven’t asked you your distinguished names, have I?”

The customers in the lobby looked at his smile and inwardly shivered. They all felt that there was going to be a good show. They slowed down their eating paces and perked their ears to eavesdrop.

Wu Dewang's group didn't attach importance to Qin Mian at all. They revealed their origins, such as coming from a certain wine house in a certain city or a certain county, before they finally told their names.

"It turns out that all of you are chefs from famous wine houses. I'm sorry for my bad manners. This way, gentlemen." Qin Mian wanted to make things bigger. Instead of taking them to the meeting room, he invited them to sit down at the biggest round table in the lobby.

Lei Tie sat next to him with Yuanyuan and Manman in his arms, and Qin Mian took Yuanyuan from his arms.

Wu Dewang and the others looked at each other and said, "Boss Qin, we're here to—"

Qin Mian interrupted with a light smile, "I know. You want to have a match with our Double Xiang House."

"Correct. If—"

Qin Mian interrupted him again, "It's boring to compete with only eight wine houses. In my opinion, since we want to compete, we might as well hold a large-scale cooking competition. Call in the chefs from all over the country who are willing to participate in the competition and bring all kinds of bargaining chips. If Double Xiang House loses, I can make public the recipes of our thirteen spices and eighteen delicacies for free. What do you think?"

Wu Dewang and the others took a breath of cold air. *What a big declaration!*

"It seems that Boss Qin is very confident." Zheng Xiangui gave a cold smile.

"Confidence or not isn't a matter of talk." Qin Mian patted Yuanyuan on the back in case he was woken up. "If you are interested, I'll let the news out and hold the cooking competition in Double Xiang House a month later. If you are not interested in a big competition, I can also provide a venue for

the seven of you to have a competition. As for our Double Xiang House, we are not interested in small-scale competition.”

Wu Dewang’s group of seven had an unsightly look. It was already been said up until now, so if they didn’t accept the challenge, the reputation of their seven wine houses would be ruined.

Qin Mian looked at Manager Sun in reproach, “Manager Sun, what are you doing in a daze? Serve tea for these chefs, and it’s better to be the kind that can decrease internal heat.”

It was unknown which diners couldn’t help laughing before they quickly covered their mouths.

“Yes, Little Boss!” Manager Sun appeared very proud and self-satisfied as he instructed the waiter, “Hurry up and serve the tea. Our newly launched chrysanthemum tea is pretty good.”

“Yes!”

Wu Dewang looked at the other six people and said with gritted teeth, “On behalf of Floating Fragrance Wine House in Wenyuan County, I agree to participate in the competition. As for the bargaining chips, I have to discuss it with my employer.”

Zheng Xiangui nodded and said, “I’m the same.”

“Me too...”

.....

All seven of them agreed to participate.

Qin Mian looked at them with appreciation, “I’m looking forward to competing with you. I’m going to ask people to let the news out. How about setting the competition on the 22nd day of the 6th lunar month?”

Wu Dewang’s group of people had no objection and left in a hurry. The closer ones had to go back quickly; the long-distance ones had to write a

report to their employers.

After the seven men went away, all the waiters couldn't help cheering.

"Little Boss is mighty!"

Qin Mian had no time to stop it. He helplessly shook his head as he watched Yuanyuan and Manman open their eyes in a daze.

The waiters realized that they were in trouble and bowed their heads in shame.

Qin Mian waved his hand, "Well, it's no big deal. Go do your work."

The waiters hurriedly excused themselves.

Qin Mian winked at Lei Tie in triumph, "A-Tie, my prestige is higher than yours."

Lei Tie calmly said, "Even if your prestige is higher, you're still my wife."

Qin Mian:

"Hee hee!" Yuanyuan and Manman looked at their Dad's speechless appearance and snickered.

"You've got guts to laugh at your Dad." Qin Mian stretched out his hands to tickle their armpits.

"Hahaha... Old Dad, help!" Yuanyuan and Manman hid in Lei Tie's arms.

Lei Tie held each of the boys in one hand and walked to the lounge very quickly.

Qin Mian closely kept up with him, "It's coming, it's coming!"

Manager Sun came to the lounge with hot tea and fruit juices. He didn't ignore White Spot and also prepared a large plate of bones for it. When he heard that the *roughhouse* in the lounge was over, he knocked on the door.

“Come in.”

“Big Boss, Little boss. The two little gongzis must be thirsty?”

Yuanyuan and Manman thanked in unison, “Thank you, Grandpa Sun.”

The two children were still young, so they called the servants at home grandpas, uncles, and so on. Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not deliberately correct them.

“Oh.” Manager Sun beamed with joy.

Lei Tie touched the glasses of juice, which were not hot, and he handed them to Yuanyuan and Manman.

Qin Mian asked, “Manager Sun, is there nothing else that happened here during this period?”

Manager Sun answered, “Don’t worry, Little Boss. Except for today’s incident, everything is normal. The first time Wu Dewang’s group came to find fault with us was known to Boss Nie. Boss Nie came over and helped us to persuade them. He even sent four helpers to be on night watch for us. Besides that, Boss Nie will get married on the 8th day of next month.”

“Oh? Then, we have to present a big gift.” Qin Mian said, “Each of the four helpers will be given a red envelope. Double Xiang House’s staff will get double monthly payment this month.”

“Yes. Your servant I thank the two bosses on their behalf.” Manager Sun asked, “Little Boss, based on your meaning, you will take part in the competition in person?”

“Yes.” Qin Mian had a face full of self-confidence and his bright eyes were spirited. “I want to take this opportunity to make Double Xiang House famous all over the country!”

Manager Sun could not help but wear a look of anticipation.

Manman climbed up and stood on Lei Tie's thighs. He went closer to kiss Qin Mian on his face and said with a grin, "Dad is the most amazing!"

Qin Mian deliberately asked, "What about Old Dad?"

Manman said without the least hesitation, "Old Dad is the most most amazing."

Clearly, he added one more "most". *Stabbed* by his son again, Qin Mian covered his chest and looked up at the sky: *Alas, I'm used to the stabbing.*

Lei Tie chuckled and gripped his wife's hand under the table, which was gripped back.

Yuanyuan's small hand comfortingly patted Qin Mian on the chest, "Dad, Yuanyuan adores you."

Manager Sun took his leave wisely without disturbing the interaction of the family of four.

Thank you, Elaine!

Chapter 156: Home

156 – Home

Qin Mian and Lei Tie first asked Manager Sun to take care of Yuanyuan and Manman before they went to Eating Savory Restaurant and the drinks shop to show their faces and ask about the recent developments.

Afterward, they went back to Double Xiang House. Once they had lunch in Double Xiang House, they asked a waiter to drive their family back to Green Mountain Village.

Yuanyuan and Manman saw familiar scenery outside from the window and said with understanding, “We’re back.”

Qin Mian chuckled and asked, “Sons, are you happy playing outside for so long these days?”

“Happy!” Yuanyuan raised his little face as he asked, “Dad, can we still go out to play in the future?”

“Of course.” Qin Mian nodded with affirmative, “As long as Yuanyuan and Manman are obediently listening to Dad and Old Dad’s words, whenever there is a chance, we will take you out to play.”

“Alright!” Manman incessantly nodded.

“Golden Fur!” Yuanyuan pointed to the outside.

Not far from the village road, a huge golden figure was running up their way.

Yuanyuan and Manman happily yelled, “Golden Fur, Golden Fur!”

It was not far from the village. Qin Mian asked the staff to stop the carriage. They got out of the carriage and planned to walk back. The staff then drove the empty carriage back to town.

White Spot ran the fastest and touched noses with Golden Fur as a greeting.

Yuanyuan and Manman ran to Golden Fur with their short legs and giggled as they wound their arms around Golden Fur's legs.

Golden Fur carefully rubbed its head against the children's small chests.

Yuanyuan stretched out his two small arms toward Lei Tie, "Old Dad, I want to ride on Golden Fur's back."

Lei Tie lifted the two brothers and put them on Golden Fur's back. He and Qin Mian protected them at the right and left sides.

Golden Fur took steady steps, walking safely and securely. The two little boys grabbed on Golden Fur's fur. They were so happy that they laughed heartily while making a "*jya-jya*"¹ sound from time to time.

The villagers who were planting paddy seedlings in the field took the initiative to greet their family of four.

Aunt Xiulan stood in the paddy field and called out, "Tie-zi's wife, did your Fifth Brother and brother-in-law passed the exam? Why didn't they come back with you?"

Qin Mian also raised his voice, "We came back first. They will come back a few days later."

On behalf of all the curious people, Aunt Xiulan asked the most concerned question, "Did they pass the exam?"

He couldn't make it clear to explain to them what Gongshi and Jinshi were in a few words. Qin Mian only said, "I'm not sure. When we came back, they hadn't taken part in the palace examination."

Grandpa Jiang's eyes brightened, "Palace examination? It's said that if one takes part in the palace examination, one can see the Emperor."

"Yes. When they come back, we can properly ask them." Outwardly, Qin Mian smiled but inwardly, he felt cocky. Could he say that he has met the Emperor?

While chatting with different villagers, the family of four and two beasts walked slowly through the village road and across the village. All the children in the village looked at Yuanyuan and Manman with envy.

Yuanyuan and Manman raised their heads high proudly, an appearance of showing off that overwhelmed people with laughter.

Not a while later, Uncle Fu opened the gate. When he saw them, he loudly exclaimed with excitement, "Eldest Master, Little Master, Eldest Young Master, and Little Young Master are all back!"

"Uncle Fu, how's home?" Qin Mian raised his hand to excuse Uncle Fu from saluting.

"All is well, all is well." Uncle Fu said incoherently, "I'm going to tell people to heat water."

Qin Mian walked through the countless rich fruit trees and saw the *red agates* under the cherry trees. The two children clamored about wanting to pick cherries. Lei Tie went back to get the baskets. He and Qin Mian each held up a child and let them pick enough. After having enough fun, they went home. The hot water was ready. The family of four took a hot bath and cleaned up until they were fresh and cool.

A servant came to report, "Eldest Master and Little Master, the Third-gongzi and Fifth-gongzi's wives are here."

"Invite them in."

When Li Shi heard that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were back, she called Qian Shi to accompany her to Leisurely Farmhouse to ask about Lei Xiangzhi.

Li Shi was born in a scholarly family and knew about the imperial examination. Except for Lei Xiangzhi's poisoning, Qin Mian talked about the rest in detail.

Li Shi was overjoyed to learn that both Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui were on the examination result list.

Qian Shi was still a little at a loss. After Li Shi explained it to her, she was also very happy. "That is to say, even if Fifth Brother can't get the Zhuangyuan, Bangyan, and Tanhua, he is still a Jinshi?"

Li Shi said with a smile, "Yes, most of the Jinshi(s) are Hanlin Officers². In anyhow, they live in the Capital. Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, I also know how much you have taken care of my husband along the way, which has caused you trouble. When my husband returns, we will come together to extend our gratitude to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law."

Qin Mian said with a light smile, "You don't have to regard us as outsiders."³

Li Shi pulled Qian Shi to leave in a hurry with a smile on her face and told Qian Shi in a low voice not to disclose this news first.

Note:

Footnotes

1. The sound one makes when urging a horse.
2. refers to academics employed as imperial secretaries from the Tang onwards, forming the Hanlin Imperial Academy
3. The gist of this phrase is: you don't have to be too polite/formal to a relative/close friend.

Chapter 157: Bangyan and Tanhua

157 – Bangyan and Tanhua¹

After Uncle Fu sent Qian Shi and Li Shi out, he hesitated outside the door with an expression that he had something to say but could not say it.

Lei Tie frowned, “Steward Fu, what’s the matter?”

Qin Mian looked at him with suspicion.

Uncle Fu bowed his head as he pleaded guilty, “Forgive me, Eldest Master. During these days, there are some gossips in the village – the workers employed by the vermicelli workshop and the winery are people in the village, but none of Eldest Master’s brothers are hired... The Second-gongzi’s wife is a little uneasy, and the Third-gongzi’s wife seems to have some complaints.” In any case, the Eldest Master and his brothers were blood-related brothers. For a servant like him to speak of these words would seem as if he was sowing discord, so he had hesitated.

Qin Mian said nothing. His mind remained unchanged. He didn’t want to be directly involved with any of Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi in business. If they had been arranged in the workshops, would they be treated as relatives or workers? Nevertheless, it was not surprising for the villagers to gossip about it. In their opinion, relatives were more reliable than outsiders, so it was unreasonable not to draw in one’s brothers.

“The villagers don’t know about the charcoal burning?” asked Lei Tie.

Uncle Fu said, “As soon as your servant, I, heard those gossips, I had someone released the news that Little Master had given them [the Lei

siblings] the secret formula of charcoal burning.”

Lei Tie said, “You find an opportunity to talk with Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. If they want to do a small business, we can lend them money. Don’t say anything superfluous.”

Qin Mian heard it and nodded to himself, *It’s a good idea.*

Uncle Fu also understood, “Your servant will go now.”

After Uncle Fu left, Qin Mian gave Lei tie a look of appreciation.

Lei Tie took the opportunity to put his arms around his wife’s waist. He would not allow anything that might embarrass his wife.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli lived next to each other. Both brothers were there. Upon seeing Uncle Fu, they welcomed him in.

“Steward Fu, did Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law have something to tell us?” asked Lei Xiangli.

Uncle Fu said with a smile, “Third-gongzi and Fourth-gongzi, our Eldest Master sent this servant to ask what you plan to do in the future. If you want to do some small business, our Eldest Master said that he can lend money to the two gongzis.”

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli understood as soon as they heard that. Lei Tie and Qin Mian would rather lend them money to do business than let them get involved in the processing yard. They certainly had some discomfort in their hearts, feeling that they were not as good as outsiders in their Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law’s minds. But on the second thought, they could understand why Lei Tie and his wife did that. Even the teeth would bite the tongue sometimes, not to mention between people? If brothers were less involved in each other’s interests, their relationship would last longer. Besides, an upright person should be grateful and content with one’s lot. For a long time, did Qin Mian and Lei Tie take little care of them?

Thinking so, the two brothers were relieved and told Uncle Fu that they had to think about it carefully. If they decided to borrow money, they would visit Leisurely Farmhouse in person.

As for Lei Xiangren, the two brothers ignored him as if nothing had occurred in their minds.

.....

Qin Mian started to expand his family's business as he had planned. Because there were going to be a cooking competition in a month, he only started on the beverage shop for the time being; he added various kinds of pastries to sell in the beverage shop, including sweet and salty ones, such as candied jujube pudding, sweet-scented osmanthus jelly, red bean cake, crisp-fried rolls, egg cakes, custard tarts, puddings, biscuits, and so on. Many of the varieties could be made into different flavors with different fruits. In particular, egg cakes and biscuits could be made into different shapes, such as stars, moon, animals, flowers, and the likes. As soon as the new products were launched, "Glimmer of Paradise" had once again caused a sensation in Zhaoyang County.

Yuanyuan, Manman, and Lei Tie were always the first to enjoy these new varieties. Yuanyuan and Manman even shouted out in happiness every day.

The two little boys were now over three years old. Qin Mian and Lei Tie no longer kept them at home. As long as they completed their daily learning tasks, either Qin Mian and Lei Tie, or their servants would take them out to play with other friends of similar age in the village.

Yuanyuan and Manman were likable and smarter than their peers. In a group of small friends, they were quite popular.

Qin Mian designed a cute waist bag for the two children and had Aunt Fu and the other women make two of each color with different animals embroidered on them. Every time the boys went out to play, they fastened their waist bags and filled them with all kinds of wonderful snacks. The two little boys were also generous and often gave the snacks to other little friends.

A few days later, the good news that Lei Xiangzhi and Huo Sirui respectively scored Bangyan and Tanhua spread to Green Mountain Village like the wind. The officers from the Capital personally escorted them back to Green Mountain Village.

Lei Xiangzhi was appointed by the Emperor as the seventh-ranked Junior Compiler², joining the Imperial Hanlin Academy and taking office within two months; Huo Sirui was appointed by the Emperor as the seventh-ranked Magistrate of Chong'en County, taking office within three months. The real power of a Junior Compiler was obviously less than that of a County Parental Officer³. On the surface, Lei Xiangzhi's official position was not as good as that of Huo Sirui. However, Lei Xiangzhi was employed in the Capital. Relatively speaking, he had more opportunities to be promoted and more convenient to develop interpersonal relations than Huo Sirui.

By the way, Zhuangyuan was Zhao Xianzhi. The Emperor really liked him, so the Emperor directly appointed him as a fifth-ranked Reader-in-waiting⁴ of Imperial Hanlin Academy.

Magistrate of Zhaoyang County, County Aide, and County Officers all came to Green Mountain Village in person to congratulate Lei Xiangzhi. Seven of the rich and influential families in the county all sent presents.

Having both the son and son-in-law with great prospects, Du Shi and Lei Daqiang were in the limelight in Green Mountain Village for a while. The people who were not envious of the couple could be counted on one hand. The villagers secretly made a joke that the most correct thing Du Shi and Lei Daqiang had done in their life was to have a pair of twin children.

Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi regretted that they split from the family for the sake of 100 silver taels and shamelessly moved back to the old house, which they described euphemistically that they should cultivate a good relationship with the fifth brother before he took office. It was unknown what Lei Xiangzhi said to them, but the next morning, the husband and wife moved back to their own house.

After three days the old house had entertain guests at the banquet, Qin Mian and Lei Tie only sent people to deliver the gifts while they themselves

didn't show up.

Two days later, the Lei Xiangzhi couple and the Huo Sirui couple both made an appointment to come together to Leisurely Farmhouse to thank Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Huo Sirui returned the previous 50 taels of silver and gave Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman each a lavish gift. So did Lei Xiangzhi.

Qin Mian asked about the result of the poisoning case with concern. It turned out that it was the work of the gamblers. The local authority was reasonable and fair – they compensated each of Lei Xiangzhi's group of five with 50 taels of silver.

Chong'en County was more than a month's drive away from Zhaoyang County. In two days, Huo Sirui and Lei Chuntao would leave. At present, both Dean Huo and Madam Huo were still not old; they could take care of themselves. Moreover, they so wanted to have a grandson, so they supported Lei Chuntao to follow Huo Sirui to take office.

Lei Xiangzhi also would leave for the Capital in a few days. The Imperial Hanlin Academy originally provided special dormitories for junior officers, but they were all in a unified layout and were not big, which were more suitable for single people. Du Shi and Lei Daqiang had long wanted to follow their youngest son to live in ease and comfort, so they decided to go to the Capital together. Where Lei Daqiang went, Wei Shi naturally didn't want to be left behind. Therefore, Lei Xiangzhi wanted to go to the Capital ahead of time.

The Lei Xiangzhi couple and the Huo Sirui couple had lunch at Qin Mian's home and sat down for a while before leaving together.

Lei Tie sent them out.

Lei Xiangzhi deliberately lagged behind the other three and said to him in a low voice, "Eldest Brother, going to the Capital this time, Father and Mother want to buy a residence in the Capital and then settle down. Actually, before I came back, I already asked Eldest Brother Yuan to help me rent a small residence. Entering the Capital is just a beginning, but they

think things too simply. I didn't want to spoil them, so I lied that I only had enough money to rent a house. I'm afraid they'll come to you and Eldest Sister-in-law again, so I'm telling you first that I'll trouble you and Eldest Sister-in-law to bear with Father and Mother for a few more days." In fact, Lei Xiangzhi didn't have the nerve to speak honestly. When he told Lei Daqiang and Du Shi that he didn't have any money, they asked him to borrow from Lei Tie and Qin Mian, but he refused. That's why he was worried that Lei Daqiang and Du Shi were not reconciled and would come to their door in person.

Lei Tie lightly nodded.

Sure enough, as Lei Xiangzhi had expected, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi came to Leisurely Farmhouse in the afternoon. The guard at the gate didn't let them in. The couple probably thought that since they were going to leave Green Mountain Village soon, they were not afraid of losing face, so they simply made a big ruckus. After calling out Lei Tie and Qin Mian for a long time without any response, Du Shi went as far as to secrete outside the gate. Lei Daqiang then pointed out, word by word, that Lei Tie was unfilial.

Qin Mian instructed Lei-Qin Le to refute Lei Daqiang's words, word by word. Lei-Qin Le was a clever person. He scolded them without using obscene words, making Lei Daqiang and Du Shi angered and fled in disorder. The couple's reputation in Green Mountain Village was thoroughly rotten.

Qin Mian sympathized with Lei Xiangzhi and hoped that he wouldn't be implicated by Du Shi and Lei Daqiang in the future.

Two days later, the Huo Sirui family left Zhaoyang County and went to Chong'en County. Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to see him off.

Another two days later in the old house, all that should be sold were sold and all that should be packed were packed. In the end, only a house and a few *mu* of land were left.

Before leaving, Lei Xiangzhi and Li Shi went to Qin Mian's house again, saying that they would invite them to the Capital City after settling down.

Lei Xiangzhi entrusted the old house to Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli and the land was rented to them for planting. He took Li Shi, Chongchong [his son], Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, Wei Shi, Qingqing [Wei's daughter], Du Shi's maid Xiao-Cui, and Wei Shi's maid Xiao-Xi to leave Green Mountain Village for the Capital.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't want to see Du Shi and Lei Daqiang at all. Therefore, the two didn't see them off.

Without Du Shi and Lei Daqiang, Qin Mian felt that the air in Green Mountain Village was a bit fresh. In the past, he didn't want to pass by the old house, and so he never passed in front of their gate. Now though, he felt so very comfortable to take whichever road he wanted.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Second Graduate and Third Graduate with Honors in the Palace Examination
2. Junior Compiler in the Historiography Institute, the True Records Institute of the Academy of Scholarly Worthies, and even the Bureau of Military Affairs. In Ming and Ching times, the 2nd and 3rd ranking new Metropolitan/Conference Graduates (Jinshi) were normally appointed to this post in the expectation they would rapidly move into higher Hanlin positions and finally into the Grand Secretariat.
3. a popular term for a county magistrate
4. an attendant skilled in reciting classical texts; a prestigious title added to a regular title when an official was delegated to provide tutorial services in the establishment of the Heir Apparent or in another Princely Establishment; regular member of the Imperial Hanlin Academy

Chapter 158: Countrywide Cooking Competition

158 – Countrywide Cooking Competition

Lei Xiangren passed by the gate of the old house. He had already gone far and couldn't help looking back at the locked gate.

Zhao Shi understood his thoughts. She sighed and said between gnashing teeth, "Family head, we had been cheated by Old Five back then. If he had not coaxed us with that 100 taels of silver, how could we have decided to separate? If there had been no separation, we would have been eating and drinking lavishly in the Capital by now."

Lei Xiangren thought the same as what she said. However, he felt very disgraced getting grumbled at by his wife that he had to retort, "Old Five is just a junior officer now. How much profit can he dredge up?"¹

Zhu'er stood behind them with two heavy hoes on her shoulders. She secretly looked at the calluses on her hands and sighed in silence.

"It's better than staying in the recess of the mountains!" Zhao Shi curled her lips, "We're running out of money. What should we do in the future, ah?"

"What? It's going to run out so soon?" Lei Xiangren stared at her, not daring to believe it.

Zhao Shi put her hands on her hips and stared with round eyes, "Can I even cheat you? Back then, Old Five gave—"

Lei Xiangren immediately interrupted her, "Go back first and talk later! Don't you see where it is?"

The three of them quickly walked home.

“Zhu’er, bar the gate!”

“Aye.”

Lei Xiangren looked back at Zhu’er, and his eyes fell on her upturned butt. He swallowed a mouthful of saliva.

Zhao Shi didn’t notice as she took out the key to open the door of the main hall.

“Family head, go get a basin of water for me to wash my face. I’ll get the money box.”

“Get it yourself.” Lei Xiangren came to his senses and remembered that matter. He ran into the bedroom and took out a wooden box from the bottom of the suitcase and opened it with the key hanging around his neck. When he saw that there were only two pieces of broken silver and twenty pieces of copper left in the box, he narrowed his eyes and yelled out, “What are you wasting time for, smelly woman! Why don’t you come in?”

“Coming, coming.” Zhao Shi wiped her face with a towel and said with dissatisfaction, “What’s so urgent?”

“Where did you hide the silvers? I don’t believe that’s all the money left at home.” Lei Xiangren coldly stared at her as he spoke with suspicion.

Zhao Shi was taken aback. Then, she was so aggrieved she slapped her thigh and uttered cries of anguish, “You villain! When did I hide the silvers? Don’t you know how many times you take the money? *Aiyah*, there’s no way to live...”

“Enough!” Lei Xiangren had a headache when she quarreled with him. He started to count the account with his fingers. He and Zhao Shi were always lazy. Before they separated from the old house, they seldom found odd jobs and had no money to save. At most, they just took advantage to deduct some money when Du Shi gave them money to buy some commodity or

food for the family. They didn't save the money. They bought snacks and ate them in a few days. After the separation, they had Lei Xiangzhi's 100 silver taels plus 40 silver taels from selling the charcoal burning formula, all of which added up to 140 silver taels. Aside from building the new house, buying furniture, digging well, he bought Zhao Shi jewelry, bought a long-life lock for each Dabao and Erbao, bought a jade pendant for himself, paid for Dabao and Erbao's school, and made clothes for his family...

The more Lei Xiangren calculated, the more frightened he was. His body froze and his eyes were round. After calculating all of that, they only had 2 silver taels at most! To him, who had formed the bad habit of spending money lavishly, and Zhao Shi, who liked to look good in the eyes of others, this was as good as a thunderbolt out of a clear sky.

Zhao Shi was still delusional that maybe it was this villain man who hid a part of the money to make bogus accusations against her. But looking at his expression that didn't look fake, Zhao Shi's heart tightened. She asked in a worried voice, "How is it, family head? Is our family truly run out of money?"

Lei Xiangren's face was overcast as he said in a deep voice, "It's all that's left in the money box..."

Zhao Shi panicked, "You, you did not hide the money? So, what should we do in the future?" At the thought of the future where she had to be as frugal as she had been a long time ago that even those uncouth village women would look down at her, she felt pain like thorns growing all over her body.

Lei Xiangren had nothing to say in reply.

Zhao Shi said in weeps and sobs, "Why did I follow you, such a useless person? If only we had known it would be like this, we shouldn't have sold the charcoal burning formula back then, or we would have sold it secretly ourselves..."

Lei Xiangren had a flash of inspiration in his mind and began to laugh, "Hahaha..."

Zhao Shi raised her orchid fingers to wipe her tears with a handkerchief and said with distaste, “You can still laugh?”

Lei Xiangren picked up the teapot on the side of the table and poured himself a cup of tea with leisure. His eyes twinkled with cunning dark light. “Back then, it’s our lost to sell that charcoal burning formula – what if we sell the formula further away again, won’t we make some money?”

At first, Zhao Shi rejoiced, but then looked worried, “Can it be done? I remember that Old Five asked you to press your thumbprint on the document that said it’s sold to one person only and mustn’t be sold again to other people.”

“If you’re as timid as a mouse, you won’t be able to do something big.” Lei Xiangren glanced at her and disapprovingly said, “We’ll sell it to a farther place. As long as you and I don’t tell anyone, who will know? What’s more, our Fifth Brother and youngest brother-in-law are government officials now. Even the County Magistrate came to congratulate them personally. If we are found out, we have them. What are we afraid of?”

Zhao Shi lost her mind at the thought of the money she was about to get. She repeatedly nodded, full of joy. “Right, right, my husband is very thoughtful!”

Don’t mind Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi who took the road to ruin.

After Qin Mian finished the matter of the bakery, he began to prepare for the cooking competition.

Strictly speaking, Qin Mian couldn’t compare with other “professional” chefs in terms of the cooking skill itself. However, compared with other chefs, he had several obvious advantages: first, his dishes would be more novel than others; second, his seasoning was better than others; third, he had spiritual spring water; fourth, his ingredients were produced in the magical space; fifth, since he began to practice, his senses of smell and taste were more sensitive than before, so he would be more precise in the use of seasoning than others. With all of that, he was fully confident in this competition.

Still, what should be prepared still had to be prepared. He wanted to make all the contestants and judges marvel at his dishes.

He spent five days observing the four chefs in Double Xiang House to make sure that he left at least some impression of a “chef” on others.

Then, he spent a day setting down the menu for the competition and practicing over and over again to make sure that his cooking moves and steps were skilled and fluent...

Time went like lightning. In a twinkling of an eye, it was already the middle of the 6th lunar month.

There were more and more outsiders in Running Water Town. They all had heard that Double Xiang House was going to hold a countrywide cooking competition and wanted to see the show. The inns in Running Water Town were full, and even people's homes were rented. The owners of all the shops in the town went practically crazy with happiness. Some small shops in the recession were already satisfied to be able to earn tens of Wen a day. But now, their daily net profit at least exceeded 200 Wen, which was more than five or six times their previous net profit.

Famous chefs from wine houses all over the country had arrived at Double Xiang House one after another.

Starting from the 17th day of the 6th month, Double Xiang House was no longer open to the public. It only received participants.

On the 19th day of the 6th month, the registration was closed.

Manager Sun looked at the registration list and clicked his tongue. There was a total of 79 wine houses participating in the competition, all came from the Western Mountains, Eastern Mountains, North Rivers, and South Lakes... and even from the Capital. One could imagine how sensational this cooking competition was.

Qin Mian was very clear that the main purpose for most wine houses to be willing to participate in the competition was still the seasoning recipe.

Anyway, it didn't matter why these people come to the competition. The important thing was that they came and spared no effort in the competition for the seasoning recipe – that was enough.

On the morning of the 20th day, the persons-in-charge of all [participating] wine houses sat together to discuss the rules of the competition.

Qin Mian directly asked Lei Tie to write a hundred copies of the competition rules in advance and asked him to send one to each persons-in-charge.

The persons-in-charge looked at the calm young man dressed in blue with some uneasiness in their hearts and accepted the copy of the competition rules to examine in detail.

One person read out loud, “All contestants must come up with enough [gaming] chips. If they can't win the top five places, the chips belong to the top five wine houses. For example, the chips of Double Xiang House are the secret recipes of the thirteen spices and the eighteen delicacies. If Double Xiang House can't win the top five, the top five wine houses can get the secret recipes of the thirteen spices and the eighteen delicacies. If gold and silver are used as chips, the chips are equally 600 taels for every participant... There are three items in the competition. First, distinguish the seasonings in a certain dish; second, make a vegetable dish; third, make a meat dish... In order to avoid people from sabotaging, the food materials and cooking utensils should be provided by oneself... The dishes are evaluated by anonymous selection for fairness and acknowledgment...”

After reading the two pages, everyone spontaneously wanted to wipe their sweat. *Nicely detailed rules, almost no loopholes to drill in!* Inexplicably, they all believed that these rules were made by Qin Mian, the Little Boss of Double Xiang House. Although the poker-faced man looked frightening, he didn't seem to have such an intricate mind.

Qin Mian said with a faint smile, “If you have any requirements, you can add them. If you have any suggestions, you can also mention them.”

Zheng Xiangui said, “If gold and silver are used as chips, how can they be allocated to the top five? Split it equally?”

“Of course not.” Qin Mian said, “We’ll divide all the gold and silver into fifteen equal parts. The first place gets five parts, the second place gets four parts, the third-place gets three parts, the fourth-place gets two parts, and the fifth-place gets one part. And of course, if you think it’s unfair for all the top five to get the complete recipes of the thirteen spices and the eighteen delicacies if my Double Xiang House loses, I can modify the recipe. The first place gets the complete recipes, the second place can get a few less—”

Before he had finished, someone waved to stop him.

“No, no, just follow the original rules. If your wine house, unfortunately, falls outside the top five, the top five all get the complete secret recipes.”

The rest echoed in succession. They didn’t take the rising Double Xiang House seriously, but there was no lack of wine houses with a long-established reputation in the competition. No one dared to say that they must take the first place. It was better to share with all the top five.

Another person raised a suggestion: “Cooking skill is not limited only to the standard of making a dish, but also the requirements for knife work. Shouldn’t knife work be added to the contents of the competition?”

Many people echoed this statement.

Qin Mian shook his head. “No matter how good the dish is cut, it will still be unpalatable if it doesn’t taste good. So, I don’t think it’s necessary. If you insist on adding this item, my Double Xiang House can only stand down regretfully.”

The corner of everyone’s mouths twitched. *Doesn’t this show clearly that it’s not allowed to add knife work?*

Everyone had no choice but to compromise on this point.

Jin Chang'an, from the wine house in the Capital, stood up and said, "About the judges of the competition, Jin would like to introduce three people to everyone first."

Everyone had long noticed the three old men sitting behind him.

Jin Chang'an cupped his hands in obeisance to one of the 50-year-old men, "This person has worked as the Imperial Chef for more than ten years; Old Liu with the name Yunwei. I think you've all heard of him."

As soon as his voice fell, many looked surprised and happy. In the wine house business, few had never heard of Old Liu's formal name. No one doubted that someone was pretending. After all, one had to be convincing when commenting, lest one made a fool of oneself.

Everyone stood up and bowed with hands folded in front to salute.

Old Liu laughed warmly and kindly and cupped his hands as he said "You don't have to be polite. This old fellow, I, happened to be in the Capital when I heard the news, so I came to join in with Boss Jin. If everyone can trust this old fellow me, I'll shamelessly be the judge."

One by one, everyone said that they trusted him but simultaneously looked toward Qin Mian for fear that he would be "an annoying troublemaker" again.

Qin Mian cupped his hands in obeisance and said, "It's our blessing to have Old Liu overseeing this competition. Hope Old Liu gives this junior a chance to entertain *you*."

"You flatter me," said Liu Yunwei with a smile.

Jin Chang'an also introduced two other elders: one was Old Gu and the other was Old Wen, both of whom were good friends of Old Liu. They were once a generation of famous chefs, and now they had retired.

After they discussed some details, the final rules were determined, copied, and pasted on the wall.

The afternoon of the 20th day and the 21st day were reserved for participants to familiarize themselves with the venue and order food ingredients.

By the way, I open the coffee shop. Feel free to stop by. 😊

Note:

Footnotes

1. He's implying that being a low-ranked government officer can't get many ill-gotten gains.

Chapter 159: The Competition Begins

159 – The Competition Begins

After the meeting ended, Qin Mian called Manager Sun to the lounge.

“Manager Sun, take this instruction: all the guests in Double Xiang House must be treated with care during these days. Tea, snacks, fruits, and three meals a day all should be served most exquisitely. Let them experience for themselves that our small region also has a noble grade enjoyment. Also, get some copies of the pastry list from the bakery. We’ll provide them whatever they order. Of course, the prices are still charged as usual but give them a 10% discount. As for Old Liu and the other two, they all receive a 20% discount.”

“Yes! Don’t worry, Little Boss. We’ll do our very best!” Manager Sun left with high morale.

A waiter knocked on the door and reported, “Reporting, Little Boss. Nie-gongzi is here.”

“Invite in.”

Dressed in white, Nie Heng came in with a face wreathed in smiles.

Qin Mian looked him up and down and teased, “How can you be willing to go out today?”

“You dare to mention it.” Nie Heng willfully sat down and consciously took the cherry in the fruit plate to eat. “You and Lei Tie didn’t show up at my

wedding. I wanted Yuanyuan and Manman to be my bed-rolling boys¹. What a pity.”

“You, show understanding and sympathy for us, too.” Qin Mian complained, “Our Double Xiang House has to accept the challenge of many wine houses at the same time. Is it easy for A-Tie and me? We certainly have to seize the time to practice more.”

Nie Heng went straight to the heart of the matter, “It’s your Double Xiang House that challenges all wine houses at the same time, isn’t it?”

Qin Mian smiled but said nothing.

“You should already know? My wine house also participated,” added Nie Heng.

Qin Mian nodded, “Yes. You have the right to join. You probably don’t know that Liu Yunwei is here. I heard he used to be an Imperial Chef?”

Nie Heng’s spirit was boosted, “Really? Of course, Old Liu is always a legend in the realm of chefs. Rumor has it that at first, Old Liu was just setting up a stall on the roadside. When the current Emperor was young, he went out on an inspection tour in disguise and accidentally discovered Old Liu and brought him into the Palace. Later, Old Liu became famous overnight. Although I don’t know whether it’s true or not, Old Liu is a man of real ability. This competition, even if we don’t win, if we can get Old Liu’s advice, we’re considered very lucky.”

Qin Mian very much agreed with it. As he was about to speak, the door was pushed open.

“Wife...” Lei Tie came in carrying two sleepy-eyed little boys. Upon seeing Nie Heng, he nodded, “Congratulations. Give birth to a son soon.”²

Nie Heng’s forehead twitched. *Are these words truly not meant to flaunt?*

“Many thanks...”

“Dad.” Manman coquettishly called out. His just-woke-up voice was so soft it stirred one’s soft spot.

Yuanyuan stretched out his hands to Qin Mian. His face was as red as an apple because he had been asleep for quite a while.

Qin Mian walked over quickly, “What’s the matter?”

“They want you as soon as they woke up.” Lei Tie handed Yuanyuan and Manman to Qin Mian.

At the side, Nie Heng snickered. The cold and stiff-man seemed to have become a nursing father now.

Qin Mian held each boy in one arm. In his arms, Yuanyuan and Manman rubbed against him as drowsiness crept over them.

Nie Heng stood up. “You are busy. I’m going out to eat.”

“Sorry for our poor treatment.” Qin Mian wore an apologetic look. ” A-Tie and I will treat you to a meal another day. By the way, is Mu Chen still in Zhaoyang? If so, call him over later.”

Yuanyuan and Manman slept so uneasily that they frowned. Lei Tie patted them on the back.

The scene of the family of four together exuded infinite warmth.

Nie Heng said, “He has returned to the Capital because of an urgent matter half a month ago.”

Qin Mian felt very regretful.

After Nie Heng went out, Qin Mian sat down on the settee and adjusted his posture so that the two little boys were comfortable. Lei Tie patted them with patience.

When Yuanyuan and Manman fell asleep, the two men talked in low voices.

“Wife, did you have a smooth meeting?”

“En.” Qin Mian smilingly nodded with a look of satisfaction on his face. “A-Tie, we truly get help from Heaven this time. I didn’t expect that Liu Yunwei, the former Imperial Chef, and his two famous chef friends would show up. The three of them will make the result more convincing. This time, it’s hard for our Double Xiang House not to be famous!”

“So confident?” Lei Tie leaned over and kissed him.

“Of course!” Qin Mian leaned slightly on him. “Tomorrow night, prepare the ingredients with me.”

Lei Tie nodded and deepened the kiss.

After Nie Heng left the lounge, he planned to eat in the private room on the second floor. When he passed the lobby, he noticed that some of the guests had exquisite pastries on their tables that he hadn’t seen before, so he changed his mind. He casually chose a single-seat table and beckoned a waiter.

“If you have any new pastries today, please give me one portion of each.”

“Yes.”

Old Liu, Old Gu, and Old Wen sat by the window, looking at the pastries on the table. For a while, they were speechless. The first kind was a rainbow cake that was sliced into rhombus and placed on a white porcelain plate. The cross-sectional cut part generously exposed seven colors of red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and purple, which made one’s felt happy just looking at it. The second kind was biscuits in rose red, light green, peach red, and pear yellow colors, which exuded sweet fruit fragrance. The third kind was purple yam blossoming rose steamed buns, which had an exotic aroma that assailed one’s nostrils. Whichever kind, all were pleasing to the eye. The appearance alone had given them a good impression.

After quite a while, Old Liu chuckled with a thoughtful look and said, “The two bosses of Double Xiang House are truly people with extraordinary

talent.”

Old Gu spoke with a relatively strict manner, “At present, it can’t be certain.”

Old Wen picked up a biscuit and put it in his mouth. “We’ll know soon.”

.....

The night before the competition, after Yuanyuan and Manman fell asleep, Qin Mian and Lei Tie entered the magical space to prepare the ingredients for the competition. There were only four kitchen stoves in Double Xiang House, excluding the small kitchen. Therefore, with a large number of contestants, the competition adopted an elimination system. Every chef had to compete at least twice, so they had to prepare more ingredients.

The ingredients for the vegetable dish had to be prepared specially, while the ingredients for the meat dish took more time to prepare. The required sheep shoulder, chicken breast, duck breast, duck gizzard, winter mushrooms³, winter bamboo shoots, and so on were all taken from the space.

After dawn, Lei Tie got up first and cooked porridge before he roused the big and two small ones from sleep. After breakfast, he packed all the ingredients and put them on the carriage. The family of four came to Double Xiang House together.

Yuanyuan and Manman knew that their Dad was going to take part in the competition today, so they had been unusually well-behaved.

The place where the participating chefs cooked would be in Double Xiang House’s kitchen. After cooking, they would bring the dishes to the lobby and ask Old Liu and the other two men to comment in presence of all.

To avoid too many people interfering with the competition, except for the contestants, the contestants’ exclusive fire-watchers, and the persons-in-charge of the [participating] wine houses, only the first hundred audiences

were allowed to enter Double Xiang House to watch the competition. Those who came later were not qualified to enter.

Qin Mian had considered things very carefully. Everyone who came later could get a packet of pastry from Glimmer of Paradise Bakery for free. As the saying went, the mouth was soft-spoken after getting the benefits of others. These people were too embarrassed to complain about anything.

At dragon hour, the competition began. The first competition was to identify the ingredients used in a certain dish. In front of all the chefs laid writing brushes, inks, papers, and inkstones. After tasting the dish, they had to write down its various seasonings on the paper.

Old Liu and the two went to the kitchen and they brought out a pot of soup. The soup looked more like water added with various seasonings. It had been clearly filtered so that no seasonings or ingredients could be seen.

Two waiters distributed a few dozens of small bowls to the participants.

Old Liu said with a smile, “This soup is made by this old fellow me, Old Wen, and Old Gu with various seasonings. It may not taste very good. The three of us only know what seasonings we ourselves have added, not knowing what the other two have added. We’ll announce the answers together after you have distinguished them all. Also, please write your full name on the paper. Please.”

Qin Mian ladled up a spoonful of soup, took a small mouthful, and kept it in his mouth to taste each flavor. Then, he picked up the brush and wrote it down.

Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman sat by the wall to watch.

“Old Dad,” whispered Manman in Lei Tie’s ear while covering his mouth with his little hands when he saw his Dad writing, “Dad’s handwriting is bad.”

Lei Tie threw a look at his wife with a smile in his eyes. It was not surprising that Manman and Yuanyuan idolized him more. His wife’s

calligraphy had not improved so far. Maybe he should teach his wife well later.

“How about letting Dad practice calligraphy with you later?”

Yuanyuan and Manman nodded again and again. The two identical small faces wore a mischievous smile which looked no different than when their Dad smiled mischievously.

Qin Mian didn't know at all that he had been plotted by his own man and sons. He wrote very fluently that he soon wrote out all the spices and was the first to stop writing.

Old Liu and the other two old men looked at each other, each with their own thought.

Another moment later, everyone stopped writing.

The waiters collected the papers and gave them to Old Liu and the other two old men.

The three old men first revealed the seasonings they had added.

“I added star anise, soy sauce, cardamom...”

“I added tangerine peel, wine, salt, cinnamon...”

“I added sugar, ginger, garlic...”

A chef cried out involuntarily, “There can't be wine. I didn't taste it.”

The three old men shook their heads with a smile, quickly looked through all the papers, and picked out the ones with the correct answers.

“Why didn't you taste it when so many people did?”

The chef had nothing to say in reply and sat down dejectedly.

Old Gu read out a list of those who answered correctly, “Wang Fusheng, Liu Zongxian... Wu Dewang... Qin Mian... Zheng Xiangui...”

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman.

Yuanyuan and Manman gave him a thumbs-up with their faces wreathed in smiles and then signaled Lei Tie to do the same with urging eyes.

Lei Tie gave a thumbs-up with a wooden face.

Qin Mian’s face blossomed with smiles, glowing and charming.

Out of 79 participants, only 22 passed the first level. Anyway, it didn’t matter if they had not passed the first level. They could still redeem themselves in the second and third levels.

The second competition was to make a vegetable dish. Four people were assigned to a group to have a competition, where two people would be eliminated in each group. Those who were eliminated had another chance to compete after everyone had finished the first round. If they were eliminated once again, the next round would be considered a loss. Therefore, no matter whether the third round was a win or lose, they would not be able to recover the losses.

Note:

Footnotes

1. (custom) young boys are invited to roll on the bed to bless the couple with an abundance of children in their marriage
2. It’s a propitiatory compliment to the newly-weds.
3. The other name is donko shiitake.

Chapter 160: Absolute Soup

160 – Absolute Soup

The grouping was done by drawing lots. Qin Mian was in the fourth group.

The first group was Wu Dewang, Zheng Xiangui, Zhao Xiang, and Zhang Shun.

In less than two moments¹, four waiters came out with four dishes and put them in front of Old Liu, Old Gu, and Old Wen.

The four vegetarian dishes were Coconut-styled Bamboo Charm, Garlic Purple Eggplant, Golden Silk Greenish Jade, and Spinach Egg Roll. The chefs who made these four dishes were all famous wine houses' chefs. These four dishes were all extraordinary and had their own advantages. The Coconut-styled Bamboo Charm was made up of celery stems and green vegetable leaves as the coconut trees, tomatoes as the sand beach, and emerald green cucumbers with round vegetable balls in the center of the porcelain plate – the appearance warmed the heart and delighted the eye. The Garlic Purple Eggplant was bright in color and attractive in the aroma. The Golden Silk Greenish Jade was a cold dish of appetizing bean paste shredded bamboo shoots sprinkled with green coriander. The Spinach Egg Roll was small and delicate, just like an ornamental.²

After Old Wen commented on the appearance, both Old Liu and Old Gu nodded with approval.

Manman stood on Lei Tie's thighs and watched from a distance. He said as though he evaluated them, "Not bad."

Yuanyuan said, "Dad will be more amazing."

Manman had confidence in his Dad, so he nodded in all seriousness, “En.”

After tasting the four dishes, Old Liu commented, “The Coconut-styled Bamboo Charm and the Golden Silk Greenish Jade have the most harmonious flavors. When you eat them, you can imagine the two chefs cooking in a smooth flow. This old fellow I, am sure they have at least ten years of cooking experience. The Garlic Purple Eggplant is also quite remarkable. However, the heat control was slightly over, which then unable to perfectly bring out the tasty flavor of the eggplant. The Spinach Egg Roll appeared fairly well-done, but perhaps the chef was nervous. Some spinach in the egg roll is still raw. Therefore, this old fellow, I, think that Coconut-styled Bamboo Charm and Golden Silk Greenish Jade pass.”

Old Gu and Old Wen seconded after having tasted the four dishes respectively.

Wu Dewang and Zheng Xiangui looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian cupped his hands in a congratulatory gesture to them with a smile on his lips, extremely calm.

The complacent look on Wu Dewang’s and Zheng Xiangui’s faces receded.

The waiters served the rest of the dishes to other chefs and the audience for them to taste at will.

The busybody people asked Wu Dewang and Zheng Xiangui and learned that both of them had indeed been chefs for more than ten years. Thus, they admired Old Liu even more [because he’d said so].

The second group soon entered the kitchen.

Another waiter put away the dishes and chopsticks used by the three judges and replaced them with the clean ones.

After the second and third groups were judged without a hitch, it was Qin Mian’s fourth group turn.

Whether it was the three judges, the contestants, or the audiences, they all paid more attention to Qin Mian. When Qin Mian entered the kitchen, they unconsciously watched his back and secretly guessed what dish he would make.

Not long after that, four waiters came out with four plates of dishes, namely, Pumpkin-tangerine Pancake, Fried Three Shredded Veggies, Mashed Potato Balls, and Woven Cucumber.

Pumpkin-tangerine Pancake was pumpkin made into an open-peeled tangerine. Fried Three Shredded Veggies was shredded carrot, shredded kelp, and shredded potato arranged into a circle with each color stood alone. Mashed Potato Ball was made of potatoes kneaded into round balls. Woven Cucumber was sliced cucumbers placed layer upon layer. These four dishes all paid attention to the appearance, arranged artistically.

The three judges did not evaluate the appearance but tasted them directly.

The three judges' eyes changed slightly when they tasted the Fried Three Shredded Veggies. There was an inexplicable feeling that this dish must have been made by Qin Mian. It was made with the most ordinary ingredients, but it had an indescribable "fresh" flavor. Was this the special feature of Double Xiang House's seasoning? It was very obvious that the dishes one usually ate in Double Xiang House had been tone down.

Old Gu nimbly made a decision, "Fried Three Shredded Veggies and Pumpkin-tangerine Pancake pass."

Qin Mian and the Pumpkin-tangerine Pancake chef stood up, bowed to the judges with their hands folded in front, and sat down again.

Old Gu added, "If both chefs of the Mashed Potato Ball and Woven Cucumber have any objection, you can also taste the Fried Three Shredded Veggies and the Pumpkin-tangerine Pancake."

Both chefs of the Mashed Potato Balls and Woven Cucumber were very confident in their cooking skills, so they naturally walked over, unconvinced [with the result].

The waiter handed them two pairs of clean bowls and chopsticks.

The rest of the contestants looked nervously at the two chefs.

After they had tasted the Fried Three Shredded Veggies, they went to taste their own dishes and said with some reluctance, “The Fried Three Shredded Veggies is good indeed.”

Zheng Xiangui and Wu Dewang also tasted the Fried Three Shredded Veggies and felt a little threatened. However, both of them had retained their strength and were still full of confidence in defeating Qin Mian.

Toward noon, the competition was suspended.

After lunch and an hour’s rest, the competition continued. After all, if everyone’s stomach was full, even if a top-quality wine entered their mouths, it wouldn’t taste delicious.

At the end of the day, Qin Mian, Wu Dewang, Zheng Xiangui, Zhang Shun, and Jin Chang’an were the top five in the vegetarian dish competition. The next day, they would have another final to decide their places.

The audiences fully enjoyed the feast of visuals and gustation. When they left Double Xiang House, they were still discussing all kinds of dishes they experienced today. They all decided to come back tomorrow.

The next day, more people wanted to enter Double Xiang House to watch the competition, almost blocking the street in front of Double Xiang House. Some of them pretended to join in the fun but actually wanted to get a pastry from Glimmer of Paradise Bakery. The Glimmer of Paradise Bakery would lose a lot if everyone was given a pastry.

All the contestants thought with schadenfreude to see Double Xiang House in trouble. Little did one know, not a moment later, four baskets of honey peaches came from Leisurely Farmhouse – as it turned out, the Double Xiang House’s management had already expected today’s situation.

Double Xiang House handed out a honey peach to each of those who failed to enter until all had finished. No one could find fault with Double Xiang House.

At dragon hour³, the competition began.

In addition to the small kitchen, each of the five chefs occupied a kitchen stove.

In less than three moments, five vegetarian dishes were brought out by the waiters.

The audiences stretched out their necks to look and guessed which dish came from which chef.

The reason why the chefs were not allowed to carry their own dishes was to avoid the prejudices by preconceived ideas of the judges and audiences. By letting the waiters served the dishes, the judges and the audience couldn't match the chefs with their dishes.

The five vegetarian dishes were Pan-fried Tofu, Green Jade Full Hall, Absolute Soup, Mixed Vegies Jelly, and Crunchy Vegetarian Pancake.

The Pan-fried tofu was poured with yellow soy sauce, neat in appearance, and dotted with chopped red pepper and chopped scallions. Its rich color and aroma appealed to people's appetite. The Green Jade Full Hall was actually lotus root balls and cowpeas that were arranged into a fan-shaped in fan-shaped plate. The Absolute Soup was very special. The whole bowl of soup had two colors: milky white on the left and lustrous green on the right, just like rivers Jing and Wei separated clearly. It was light in colors and smelled good. On the surface of the Mixed Veggies Jelly, one couldn't see what it was made of, but each piece was transparent. Inside, one could see the fine carrot shreds and fine vegetable leaves, just like a natural fine jade, making people incomparably astonished. The Crunchy Vegetarian Pancake was obviously a vegetarian dish but was made into the color and aroma of a meat dish, which equally caused people to gasp in surprise.

Everyone suddenly understood something. *Perhaps, this is the real strength of the chefs.*

There was almost no sound in the lobby. Everyone was nervously waiting for the three judges' comments.

Wu Dewang made the Mixed Veggies Jelly, which was his exclusive secret recipe. He thought that it was better than the Pan-fried Tofu, the Green Jade Full Hall, and the Crunchy Vegetarian Pancake, but he had no confidence to be better than Qin Mian's Absolute Soup. It was hard to shape things like soup. Even the laymen knew that it was never easy to completely separate two different colors of soup. In the first place, Qin Mian's seasonings were better than others, but now, his dish was better in appearance and technique, so one could imagine the result.

Zheng Xiangui thought that his Crunchy Vegetarian Pancake was better than the Green Jade Full Hall, the Mixed Veggies Jelly, and the Pan-fried Tofu, but he feared that it was slightly inferior to the Absolute Soup.

Nie Heng guessed that the most peculiar Absolute Soup was made by Qin Mian. He said with a smile to Lei Tie, "It seems that your Double Xiang House even has something to keep from us, the Diamond Members."

Lei Tie dully said, "Double Xiang House has never forgotten to inform the Diamond Members when new dishes are launched." That sentence implied that the Absolute Soup had not yet been launched.

Nie Heng had nothing to say in reply. He stared at the Absolute Soup, wishing so much to replace the three judges to taste it.

Old Liu, Old Gu, and Old Wen first looked at the five dishes and then nodded their heads. Then they picked up the bowls and chopsticks and tasted them separately. Every time they tasted a dish, they had to change a set of clean bowls and chopsticks to prevent cross flavor that could influence the optimum tasting.

Everyone attentively stared at the three judges' expressions and noticed that they stared at the Absolute Soup for the longest time. Everyone knew then

that the Absolute Soup was going to come out on top.

After Old Wen tasted the Absolute Soup, he couldn't stop taking another spoonful. The Absolute Soup was the only dish that the judge took a second taste.

Sure enough, the three judges murmured for a moment before Old Gu announced the result, "Absolute Soup, first; Mixed Vegies Jelly, second; Pan-fried Tofu, third; Crunchy Vegetarian Pancake, fourth; Green Jade Full Hall, fifth."

Old Wen brought the Absolute Soup directly in front of him and lifted the spoon. Old Liu quickly took the Absolute Soup away and handed it to the waiter.

"Can't drink it anymore. We'll continue to judge meat dishes later."

If they were full, it would affect their comments on other dishes.

With a regretful look on his face, Old Wen looked at Qin Mian and said, "Boss Qin, after the competition, I'm going to stay in Double Xiang House for a few more days."

Qin Mian cupped his hands with a smile, "It's a great honor."

Old Gu said, "Everyone, after resting for a time it took for an incense stick to burn off, we'll have the meat dish competition."

The waiters served the five dishes to other chefs and audiences.

Yuanyuan and Manman waved to Qin Mian. Qin Mian walked over and bent down to kiss each of them.

Lei Tie pulled Qin Mian to sit beside him.

The family of four gathered close and whispered to each other. Yuanyuan and Manman squirmed in their Old Dad and Dad's arms and gave out melodious laughter from time to time.

The warm scene made many people envious. The people around Running Water Town had long ago stopped caring about the “Qin Mian and Lei Tie are both men” thing, so there was no one that did not envy their family and business.

Wu Dewang and Zheng Xiangui sat in the corner. The smiles on their faces were so fake they disgusted people, but their eyes, however, were occupied by shadows.

“Brother Zheng, if Qin Mian is in the top five in the meat competition, you and I will never get the thirteen spices and the eighteen delicacies recipes.” Wu Dewang spoke of their current predicament.

“Right.” Zheng Xiangui felt tired and spiritless. “Although I didn’t want to admit it, Qin Mian did have strength. Unless he doesn’t take part in the competition, otherwise, you and I can’t stop him from winning.”

Wu Dewang quietly made an obscure gesture under the table and lowered his voice, “Why not...”

Zheng Xiangui immediately shook his head and nudged his chin toward Lei Tie on the opposite side, “Have you seen Qin Mian’s man? Those eyes are like ice blades. Previously, he had stopped many of my colleagues’ ideas about Leisurely Farmhouse and Double Xiang House. I dare say that on the first moment you and I act against Qin Mian, he will make your life worse than death the next moment. I don’t want to gamble my life.”

Wu Dewang inwardly scolded him for being as timid as a mouse.

Zheng Xiangui took a sip of tea to refresh himself. “Now, I don’t expect to get those two recipes. Whether I get the second, the third, the fourth, or the fifth place, I can at least get my employer’s 600 silver taels back.”

Wu Dewang was still a little reluctant. His voice sounded grim, “I don’t believe he can actually get into the top five! Wait and see!”

Lei Tie raised his eyes, and his indifferent eyes flitted past Wu Dewang and Zheng Xiangui. When they returned to Qin Mian, they became calm and

gentle. He handed Qin Mian a cup of tea.

“Wife, drink water.”

Done my quota. I’m taking a break and then do the bonuses.

Note:

Footnotes

1. A moment is equal to a quarter (hour)
2. Please excuse my inaccuracy in translating those dishes’ names.
3. 7:00 AM

Chapter 161: Famous All Over the Country

161 – Famous All Over the Country

After a column of incense had burnt, the meat dish competition began. The contestants were still divided into groups by drawing lots first. This time, Qin Mian was the first group. The ingredients were already prepared, so it didn't matter if he was in the first group.

The meat dish he wanted to make was steamed meat with rice flour and fermented tofu. After the competition ended, he would open a fermented tofu workshop. By chance, he used this opportunity to advertise the fermented tofu. In the first step, he added chili powder, minced ginger, fine white sugar, salt, pepper, and rice flour into fermented tofu juice and stirred well. After washing streaky meat, he cut it into thin slices and put them into the well-prepared powder. He held and pinched the meat slices with his hands to make them adhered to the powder and seasoned them evenly. Then, he evenly spread the meat slices and marinated them for about a period of a column of incense burnt so that the flavor was well absorbed. After that, he placed the meat slices onto a plate and put an appropriate amount of water into a pot over high heat. When the water was boiling, he put the plate into the pot and left it to steam for a period of a column of incense burnt before taking it out. He used chopsticks to clip out the meat slices, put them on a new plate in a beautiful arrangement, and then garnished with chopped scallions.

The procedures for making a meat dish were more than that of a vegetarian dish. Hence, in the beginning, the chefs chose relatively simple dishes. About four moments or so, all the four dishes were ready and brought to the lobby.

Stewed Chicken with Three Cups Sauce, Fragrant Spicy Duck in Pot, Peacock-styled Steamed Fish, Steamed Meat with Rice Flour and Fermented Tofu, and Sweet and Sour Spare Ribs all gave off a strong aroma, causing many people involuntarily swallowed their saliva.

Old Liu commented on the Steamed Meat with Rice Flour and Fermented Tofu, “Fat but not greasy, tender but not mushy, rich with five spices, suitable for young and old, simply a unique dish.” Steamed Meat with Rice Flour and Fermented Tofu easily passed.

Qin Mian had his eyebrows raised in delight and eyes laughing. When he decided to launch the Steamed Meat with Rice Flour and Fermented Tofu, he would use these five sentences as a slogan.

The five dishes were divided for the rest of the chefs to eat.

In the afternoon, Qin Mian entered the second round of the competition and made a plate of Squirreelfish. Squirreelfish was named after its similar shape. It was bright in color, tender, crisp, sweet, and sour. It was highly praised by Old Gu, Old Wen, and Old Liu.

At this time, the participants vaguely realized that this cooking competition was practically like a publicity campaign for Double Xiang House, while they acted as Qin Mian’s foils. Nonetheless, it was too late to regret. Under the circumstances, they could only continue to compete and try to get a better place in the competition.

In the third round, Qin Mian made Beggar’s Chicken...

Due to many meat ingredients needed to be marinated for the flavor to absorb before cooking, the preparation took a long time. The competition only reached the finale on the morning of the third day.

The final competition was between Qin Mian, Wu Dewang, Jin Chang’an, Zheng Xiangui, and Wang Fusheng.

Wu Dewang had thought to let someone mess with Qin Mian’s ingredients on the sly, but unfortunately, the Lei Family’s armed servants had been

watching him so tenaciously that he didn't even have the chance to instruct his subordinate in private for a few words. Helplessly, he watched Qin Mian go to the last step smoothly.

Qin Mian tried his best to surprise everyone. For the last dish, he decided to make "Buddha Jumping Over the Wall".

The cooking process of this dish was very complicated and he would be using multiple pots at the same time, so he tried to discuss with the other four contestants and three judges to let the other four contestants cook first and he cooks last.

At this stage, there was no hope of getting the secret recipes. The chefs still wanted to see Qin Mian's higher cooking skills, so they didn't care about this little thing and agreed to his request.

Wu Dewang, Jin Chang'an, Zheng Xiangui, and Wang Fusheng took the lead in the final competition. Wu Dewang made Chrysanthemum Fish, Jin Chang'an made Crystal Hoof, Zheng Xiangui made Drunken Chicken, and Wang Fusheng made Three Sets of Ducks, all of which allowed everyone to feast their eyes and feel happy to chance upon fine food.

Next, it was Qin Mian's turn.

Buddha Jumping Over the Wall required eighteen kinds of raw materials: sea cucumber, abalone, shark fin, dried scallop, shark's lip, fish maw, razor clam, ham, pork tripe, lamb shoulder, hoof tip, tendon, chicken breast, duck breast, chicken gizzard, duck gizzard, winter mushroom, winter bamboo shoot, and so on. Almost all of Qin Mian's ingredients came from the magical space.

Its cooking procedure was extremely complicated. First, all the eighteen kinds of raw materials were processed into various dishes with their own characteristics by pan-frying, stir-frying, boiling, and deep-frying. Then, they were stacked in a large wine jar layer by layer. An appropriate amount of soup and 20-year-old wine were poured in so that the soup and wine were fully fused with the dishes. Lastly, sealed the mouth of the jar with lotus leaves and heated it over the fire.

The fire was also very particular when making the Buddha Jumping Over the Wall; it required solid sinking and smokeless white charcoal. First, it was boiled over a big fire, and then it was slowly simmered over a small fire.

Nearly six hours later, Qin Mian came out of the kitchen.

By this time, the sun was about to set. Old Liu, Old Wen, and Old Gu were already hungry. When they saw two waiters carrying a big jar out, they knew it was Qin Mian's dish, but they couldn't smell any aroma. They looked at each other in wonder and became more curious about it.

As soon as the lotus leaves at the mouth of the jar were uncovered, the rich aroma quickly filled the whole lobby and directly into the hearts of everyone. Everyone was shocked!

Some people spontaneously exclaimed, "Smells so good!"

This kind of aroma was strong but not cloying. Merely by smelling it made people have a big appetite. It seemed that one didn't need to taste it to judge that "Buddha Jumping Over the Wall" was the first place in this cooking competition.

After the three judges tasted it, as everyone expected, they agreed undesignedly to decide that Qin Mian seize the win.

Old Liu laughed as he clapped his hands and even praised "Good" three times. "Sure enough, the younger generation will surpass the older! Brother Wen and Brother Gu, how about having dinner with this Buddha Jumping Over the Wall?" There was another sentence he didn't say. It was obvious that this "Buddha Jumping Over the Wall" was the original creation of Double Xiang House that had never been tasted even today.

Other chefs also wanted to experience the charm of this dish, but before they could speak, Old Gu and Old Wen echoed Old Liu's words. The three old men picked up the chopsticks to eat. While eating, they urged the waiters to bring them a few bowls of rice, making others helpless and amused.

The famous chefs from all over the country, including Jin Chang'an from the Capital, were sincerely convinced of Qin Mian's cooking skills.

"Here, divide it among you." Old Gu handed the money box to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian and the other four chefs took out the money and divided it according to the ratio of 5:4:3:2:1. Aside from Qin Mian's two recipes, the other 78 wine houses all paid 600 taels of silver each. Therefore, as the first place, Qin Mian received 15,600 taels of silver, practically a gloveless white wolf¹! Everyone admired and envied him.

To avoid being *assassinated* by their eyes, Qin Mian quickly said that everyone's dinner was 70% off.

Nie Heng looked at Old Liu and his two companions and enviously licked his lips. He walked to Qin Mian.

"Qin Mian, when will you launch the "Buddha Jumping Over the Wall" in Double Xiang House? Be sure to send someone to let me know."

Qin Mian folded the banknotes and put them into his pocket. He shook his head, "Frankly speaking, I haven't considered whether to launch this dish."

Nie Heng, for fear that he would not be able to taste it, quickly said, "Why not? Since the process of this dish is quite complicated, just set the price higher."

Qin Mian still shook his head, "More than the complexity? I have to teach the chefs first before I launch this dish. So, you probably won't be able to eat it within a short period. But you can rest assured that I will send someone to inform you."

Nie Heng got a satisfactory answer and let him go.

Qin Mian quickly ran to Lei Tie before more people come around. Yuanyuan and Manman had fallen asleep in Lei Tie's arms. He picked up Yuanyuan and went to the lounge with Lei Tie. For the time being, they let the two little boys sleep on the settee and covered them with blankets.

Today, not only Qin Mian worked hard, but Yuanyuan, Manman, and Lei Tie all worked hard to accompany him.

Qin Mian first kissed the big poker-face on his hips and then on Yuanyuan and Manman's foreheads.

"Haven't had dinner yet?"

"Waiting for you," said Lei Tie.

"I knew it. Let's go. I'll make you something delicious." Qin Mian took him to the kitchen...

The cooking competition came to a successful end. The next day, the chefs from all over the country took their leave one after another. Qin Mian was very generous. He gave each of them a bottle of "Gimmer of Paradise" fermented tofu and a delicately packaged pastry.

Old Liu, Old Wen, and Old Gu stayed in Double Xiang House for six days before they left. Before they left, they even invited Qin Mian to go to the Capital when he had a chance, so that they could compare notes in cooking skills.

Qin Mian seized the time to hand over the methods of all the dishes he had cooked in the competition to the four chefs. The prices of each dish were extremely high, especially Absolute Soup and Buddha Jumping Over the Wall. Absolute Soup was 5 taels of silver per serving and Buddha Jumping Over the Wall was 20 taels of silver per serving.

Even so, those who were "rich and willful" came to Double Xiang House in an endless stream to taste Absolute Soup and Buddha Jumping Over the Wall. It could be said that for those non-local who came to Double Xiang House for the first time, Absolute Soup and Buddha Jumping Over the Wall were the necessary dishes, even if they had to wait six hours for them.

Since then, Double Xiang House had become famous with profits pouring in from all sides.

Qin Mian confidently handed Double Xiang House over to Manager Sun to handle. When he returned to Green Mountain Village, he was ready to plan for the fermented tofu workshop.

Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman pulled him to the table and arranged for him to sit.

“What for?” Qin Mian didn’t understand and said with a smile, “Are you going to give me a surprise? Nu-uh, my birthday is long past.”

Yuanyuan brought a binding book over and put it in front of Qin Mian.

Manman said in all seriousness, “Dad, from today on, you will learn calligraphy with us.”

“What?” Qin Mian gaped, “Me? I’ll learn calligraphy with you?” He looked at Lei Tie inexplicably and blinked: *What’s happen?*

Lei Tie said honestly, “The children said your writing is... ugly.”

Qin Mian’s face turned glum at once. His pencil writing, ball-point writing, and gel-pen writing were all beautiful standard style of handwriting. Who dared to say that his writing was ugly?

Lei Tie soothed, “Wife, don’t you always think that Yuanyuan and Manman idolize me more?”

Yuanyuan and Manman nodded heavily to express that they really idolized their Old Dad.

Qin Mian struck the table as he said, “I don’t want you to see my greatness. You don’t know that Old King Ma has three eyes²!” He picked up the brush, wrote down a few lines in the book, and handed the book to Lei Tie, “Read it to the two little boys.”

Thanks, Britener!

Note:

Footnotes

1. The words are used in the business battlefield, presumably to mean that a person has gained a great deal for a small amount of money (or implied that he has not paid it). This a performance that maximizes the return on investment. So, that's why people use the word as a slur in private. –baidu
2. A metaphor that this person is very powerful. Old King Ma is an important Dharma protector of Taoism. (There's folklore behind this but I'm lazy to type.)

Chapter 162: The End of Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi

162 – The End of Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi

Lei Tie read, “There are a total of 30 chickens and ducks in a cage. Each chicken is 4 Wen and each duck is 2 Wen. If you sell all the chickens and ducks, you will get 80 Wen. How many chickens and ducks are there respectively?”

Yuanyuan and Manman spread their fingers to count, but they discovered that there was nowhere to begin with.

Qin Mian relaxed and leaned back in his chair, smiling and glancing at Lei Tie, “Yuanyuan and Manman, your Old Dad is powerful! Ask him if you don’t understand.” It was a quadratic equation of two variables. He didn’t believe that Lei Tie could solve it.

The corner of Lei Tie’s mouth twitched almost imperceptibly and his eyes stared at his wife. His wife’s smug appearance was too attractive.

Manman turned to Lei Tie for help with an expectant look, “Old Dad?”

Lei Tie lowered his head and looked at the trusting little boy. He remained silent as his ears turned red.

Qin Mian snickered so hard his shoulders unceasingly shook. After laughing enough, he turned around and urged with a pair of ridiculing eyes, “A-Tie, the son asked you, help them quickly. You are the most most amazing!”

Lei Tie sighed silently. The son only praised him once as the “most most amazing”. How long did his wife have to remember it?

“Old Dad.” Yuanyuan also urged him.

“A-Tie, you are their most powerful Old Dad.” Qin Mian stood up, went in front of Lei Tie, and leaned on his shoulder as he looked at Lei Tie with a grin.

Lei Tie suddenly embraced his waist, turned his back to Yuanyuan and Manman, and kissed his wife fiercely, “Wife, you are more powerful than me.”

Qin Mian smiled with satisfaction and squatted down in front of Yuanyuan and Manman. “Do you want Dad’s help?”

The two little boys nodded.

Qin Mian announced the answer with a smile, “There are 10 chickens and 20 ducks. The calculation is right or wrong?”

Yuanyuan said, “10 chickens and 20 ducks are 30 in total.”

Manman calculated very fast, “Each chicken is 4 Wen, 10 chickens are ten ‘4’, so the total is 40. Isn’t that right, Dad?”

“Each duck is 2 Wen, 20 ducks are twenty ‘2’, so the total is 40.” Yuanyuan affirmed, “40 plus 40 is 80.”

Qin Mian nodded with appreciation, “Yes.”

“How did Dad count?” Yuanyuan had a strong thirst for knowledge.

Qin Mian rubbed his head, “When you grow a little bigger, Dad will teach you.” After he finished saying that, he still didn’t forget to ask, “Is Old Dad powerful or Dad more powerful?”

Yuanyuan and Manman understood why he became like this today. They laughed and said in chorus, “Dad is more powerful.”

“Hahaha! That’s right.” Qin Mian finally raised his eyebrows and gave Lei Tie a smug look.

“Wife, how did you count it?” Lei Tie was very curious. He guessed that there must be some way.

For him to be willing to learn, Qin Mian naturally was willing to teach. They educated Yuanyuan and Manman with a combination of ancient and modern education. Lei Tie could also help him teach Yuanyuan and Manman after he learned. So, he pulled Lei Tie back to the table and wrote to him on the paper, “We use O and Δ to stand in for the chickens and ducks. Look, $O + \Delta = 30$. Like so, $O = 30 - \Delta$ And then, like this.... understand?”

Lei Tie nodded with understanding.

Yuanyuan said with a deadpan face, “Hm, knowledge is boundless.”

Qin Mian laughed despite himself. With the advantage of transmigration, he successfully got away.

The fermented workshop was built half a month later and officially opened a month later.

Qin Mian also set his sight on daily necessities. He spent nearly a month working on perfumed soap, toothpaste, and washing powder in the space and successfully made soap, toothpaste, and washing powder. He found Nie Heng and cooperated with him. He invested in technology and Nie Heng invested in capital. For the profits, he accounted for 40% and Nie Heng for 60%.

Amid hustle and bustle, the 9th lunar month arrived.

After a period of silence, Zhao Shi began to wear gold and silver again and took Zhu’er to walk around the village every day.

“Yah, Lei Old Two’s wife, the style of your dress is very novel. It looks good on you.” Fang Hongliu looked at Zhao Shi’s dress enviously and

reached out to feel it.

Zhao Shi pretended to stop her hand unintentionally and said with a proud and self-satisfied look, “That’s right. This was custom-made when my Family Head [husband] took me to the county town. It’s said that it’s a new style from the Capital.”

Fang Hongliu curled her lips and put down her hand.

“Must cost a lot, isn’t it?” A young married woman cast covetous eyes at the dress.

“What do you think? This dress cost me 2 taels of silver!” Zhao Shi smiled happily, “But it’s worth the money. This material is very comfortable to wear.”

Fang Hongliu wore a look of disdain. She winked and cast a glance as a signal at Zhou Cuihua, who always had a good relationship with her: *no matter how beautiful the dress is, it looks like rags on Zhao Shi’s body.*

Zhou Cuihua covered her mouth as she laughed.

Standing behind Zhao Shi, Zhu’er suddenly made a nauseous sound. She ran to the side and supported herself on a tree as she vomited.

“Oh, what’s the matter with Zhu’er?” asked Sister Zhang with concern.

Another married woman asked, “Did she eat something bad?”

There was no time for Zhu’er to speak when another retching sound was uttered, and she vomited a mouthful of filth.

Fang Hongliu noticed that her face was pale and her eyes were a little flustered. She said half-jokingly, “Why do I see it like she’s pregnant?”

It was rare for Zhao Shi to be keen; she examined Zhu’er’s expression, which flashed a burst of anger and embarrassment. She rushed over and grabbed Zhu’er’s ear and asked fiercely, “Zhu’er, you say it! Is that true?” If

it was true, the one who could have a chance to do something to Zhu'er was Lei Xiangren.

"No, no, your slave just ate bad things..." Zhu'er pleaded in panic, but her right hand involuntary covered her abdomen betrayed her statement.

Zhao Shi screamed and ruthlessly slapped her in the face.

Zhu'er fell to the ground and covered her stomach with a scream. "It hurts. My stomach hurts..."

Seeing her light-colored dress dyed red, Zhou Cuihua cried out in alarm, "She's bleeding!"

Was there anything else that one still couldn't figure out?

Zhao Shi was so angry that she could care less for Zhu'er. She turned around and ran home, crying at the top of her lung, "LEI XIANGREN, YOU VILLAIN. I'M GOING TO KILL YOU..."

The women over there were afraid that the fall could be fatal, so they had to carry Zhu'er to Sister Zhang's house first, which was nearby, and then went to call the village doctor.

This matter soon spread to Qin Mian's ears, who dismissed it with a laugh.

However, what he didn't expect was that the trouble of Lei Xiangren's family was not over.

Two days later, a well-dressed man in his early thirties came to Green Mountain Village with a group of thugs. Without saying a word, he broke the door of Lei Xiangren's house.

"Who are you? What do you want to do?" asked Lei Xiangren warily.

The well-dressed man smiled faintly, "I'm Liu Baofu. Lei Xiangren, you should be familiar with my name."

Lei Xiangren was so terrified that his face turned pale. Liu Baofu!

Back then, only Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli knew the contents of the charcoal burning formula – Lei Daqiang only focused on Wei Shi and did not interfere with it; Lei Xiangzhi was busy studying and also did not interfere with it. Before the formula was sold, Lei Xiangren did the least work but shared the money equally with Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. The reason why Lei Xiangzhi advocated selling the formula was that Lei Xiangren was not agreeable to his eyes and he was outraged by an injustice for Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. When they agreed to sell the charcoal burning formula, Lei Xiangzhi was worried that Lei Xiangren might do something after the formula was sold. Lei Xiangzhi read the contents of the document to Lei Xiangren, Lei Xiangyi, and Lei Xiangli, and asked them to press their thumbprints. He also explained in the document that in the case that the formula was leaked, only the person who leaked it would be investigated; it was not a joint liability. This was actually to protect Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. Lei Xiangzhi's worry was not unreasonable. For the money, Lei Xiangren went as far as doing something stupid.

Lei Xiangren was a bit quick-witted. He soon calmed down and asked as though nothing had happened, "So you are Sir Liu. What can I do for you?"

Liu Baofu was neither anxious nor angry, "*Sir?* Well then, *this Sir* would like to speak frankly with you. Recently, there is a charcoal shop in Wanliu County that produces the same smokeless charcoal as my Liu's shop. You sold the charcoal burning formula to him, right?"

"How could that be?" Lei Xiangren immediately denied, "Absolutely not me! Sir Liu, you should know that it was not only me who knew the formula, but also my third and fourth younger brothers – could it be them?"

Liu Baofu was so angry he laughed. "I've heard that Lei Xiangren of Green Mountain Village is shameless. Today, *this Sir* I have seen it. Lei Xiangren, do you think that if *this Sir* I didn't make a clear investigation, will *this Sir* I beat the grass to scare the snake? Do you want *this Sir* I find all the people who have seen you in Wanliu County? Hm?" He kicked Lei Xiangren down.

Lei Xiangren hurt so much that his face paled and couldn't speak for a long time.

"It was clearly written in the original document that once the secret formula was leaked, either 10,000 taels of silver would be compensated or the leaker would go to jail for a lifetime. *Second Sir Lei*, which way are you going to choose?" asked Liu Baofu coldly.

Like a dead duck's mouth, Lei Xiangren stubbornly denied, "Sir Liu, it's really not me..."

"Catch him!" Liu Baofu was too lazy to talk with him.

The two thugs immediately lifted Lei Xiangren like a chick.

"No, you can't catch me! My fifth brother is an official in the Capital and my brother-in-law is the Magistrate of Chong'en County!"

Amused, Liu Baofu laughed so much that he fell on his behind; his thugs also doubled up with laughter.

One of the thugs laughed with tears and kindly reminded Lei Xiangren, who was stunned by their laughter, "Your fifth brother is just a seven-ranked petty official and your brother-in-law is also far away. Our Sir's cousin-uncle is a fourth-ranked senior official in the Capital! What a reckless person. Pah!"

Lei Xiangren's legs trembled. In a split second, a foul smell came out of him.

Zhao Shi came back from the outside and still didn't know what had happened. As soon as she saw that some people wanted to catch Lei Xiangren, she immediately ran to protect him.

"What do you want to do? Isn't there a law under the land of peace and prosperity?"

Liu Baofu lost his patience and said, "Take him away!"

“Someone, help—” screamed Zhao Shi.

A thug waved her away with a slap.

Zhao Shi fell sitting on the ground. She had a burst of abdominal pain. When she looked down, her light green dress was red with blood. After a moment of stupefaction, she came to a realization. With anger and resentment, she lost control and cried out loud, “YOU KILLED MY CHILD, MY CHILD...”

Liu Baofu gave her a cold look. With a fling of his sleeve, he said, “Go!”

The two thugs held Lei Xiangren’s arms with a face of disgust and frowned at the smell of urine.

Lei Xiangren hit on an idea in desperation, “You catch her. It’s her who told me to sell the formula to others!”

Liu Baofu and his party all stopped and looked at Lei Xiangren like a piece of dog excrement, full of contempt and disdain.

Lei Xiangren thought that he had stirred them up and said with an obsequious smile, “Catch her, catch her. It’s all the fault of that woman!”

Zhao Shi stared at Lei Xiangren in disbelief. Her eyeballs did not move, but the muscles on her face were completely twisted, looking horribly ferocious.

The thugs continued to drag Lei Xiangren.

“Sir Liu, please let me go. I don’t want to sit in prison...” Lei Xiangren shed streams of tears and mucus. If one plan failed, another would come up. “Wait, wait! I compensate, compensate! Do you know my Eldest Brother Lei Tie? He’s the owner of Double Xiang House. He’s rich!”

“Oh?” Liu Baofu doubtfully looked at him, “This Sir I have investigated the situation of your family. The relationship between you and your eldest brother is not very good.”

Lei Xiangren confidently said, "He and I are blood brothers, will he dare to be unconcern of me?"

He didn't know that when his neighbors heard of the trouble in his house, they ran to Leisurely Farmhouse and told Uncle Fu about it. Uncle Fu reported the matter to Lei Tie.

When the party was halfway along the road, Lei Tie appeared and stood in the middle of the road with no expression on his face.

"Eldest Brother, help me!"

This call of "Eldest Brother" was the only time that Lei Xiangren used with genuine feelings.

Unfortunately, Lei Tie didn't look at him at all and said to Liu Baofu, "I have nothing to do with him. You don't have to take him to Leisurely Farmhouse to be an eyesore to my wife and my sons."

"Your distinguished self is Boss Lei of Double Xiang House?" Liu Baofu was a shrewd businessman. He had no intention to be an enemy and was very polite, "I've been looking forward to meeting you for a long time."

"Nice to meet you." Lei Tie slightly nodded and flew away. His qinggong skill had reached perfection.

Liu Baofu was glad that he had made the right choice.

Lei Xiangren looked in the direction of Lei Tie's departure in despair. His eyeballs turned upward before he fainted.

None of the onlookers sympathized with him. Their hearts had long been on Qin Mian and Lei Tie's side.

That same night, when the neighbors heard the cry of Dabao and Erbao, they found out that Zhao Shi's anger was so intense that she died while sitting down.

Chapter 163: Lei Old Three, Lei Old Four, and Lei Old Five

163 – Lei Old Three, Lei Old Four, and Lei Old Five

Although Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi were very annoying, the villagers did not expect that the couple would end up like this. Poor Dabao and Erbao lost their parents at a young age.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli could only invite their Eldest Aunt to take care of Zhao Shi's funeral and delivered a letter to the Capital at top speed to inform the other family members of the funeral. It was more than ten days when they received the other's reply.

The letter was written by Lei Xiangzhi. It had been hard for Lei Xiangzhi in the Capital, too.

After Lei Daqiang and Du Shi knew of Lei Xiangren's situation, they asked Lei Xiangzhi to write to Lei Tie, wanting Lei Tie and Qin Mian to pay to get Lei Xiangren out. Lei Xiangzhi didn't do it. He thought it was a good thing to let Lei Xiangren stay in prison for a few years. Maybe he would get a lesson if he suffered some hardships. If Lei Xiangren made progress in two or three years, he would try to find a way. If Lei Xiangren didn't make any progress, he would give up, just as if he didn't have this kind of brother. Lei Daqiang and Du Shi weighed the matter and decided to listen to their youngest son. After all, they depended on their youngest son, not their second son. As for Zhao Shi's death, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi merely sobbed without making whatsoever justification. As for Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao, Lei Daqiang and Du Shi meant to let Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli adopt them. At this point, Lei Xiangzhi expressed regret. In the letter, he confessed that he had not established himself in the Capital and could not

take care of Dabao and Erbao. Attached with the letter, he sent 20 taels of silver.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli were unwilling to adopt Dabao and Erbao. If it was only to bring up the two children, there would be no problem, but it was a great responsibility to teach them to be a person. The character of Dabao and Erbao had long been raised crookedly by Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi. Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli believed they could not pull the boys back. They were also worried that Dabao and Erbao would bring bad effects on their children. People were selfish.

After discussing with each other, the brothers wrote to Lei Xiangzhi and told him their worries. While waiting for Lei Xiangzhi to reply, the two brothers did not take Dabao and Erbao home. They only gave the children three meals a day and urged them to go to school. In terms of food and clothes, the two brothers did not treat Dabao and Erbao badly. Whatever their children had, Dabao and Erbao would have them. However, Lei Dabao and Lei Erbao had not realized that they were not protected by Lei Xiangren and Zhao Shi anymore – they had lost the qualification to be headstrong. The two young brothers were still as stubborn and arrogant as before. They even scolded Qian Shi and Sun Shi when they were slightly dissatisfied with the food, practically learned from Zhao Shi. Consequently, the Lei Xiangyi couple and the Lei Xiangli couple were even more unhappy with them.

Before long, Lei Xiangzhi wrote back. Lei Daqiang and Du Shi asked Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli to send Dabao and Erbao back to Zhao Shi's family and asked Lei Tie, Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Lei Xiangzhi to give 2 taels of silver to Zhao Shi's family every year until Dabao turned sixteen years old.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli, as Dabao and Erbao's uncles, ought to give some money to help the children grow up, so they had no objection. However, they tacitly didn't raise the issue about money to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

They took the time to go to Li Zheng to explain that they wanted to send Dabao and Erbao back to Zhao Shi's family. Lei Xiangren's house could be

rented out if possible. After all, if the house was uninhabited for a long time, it would wear out quickly. The income from renting the house naturally belonged to Dabao and Erbao. Lei Xiangyi kept the account for the time being. Lei Xiangren's land property was also rented out, and the income also belonged to Dabao and Erbao. When the children grew up, it would be returned to them. Li Zheng was needed to be the witness to all these things.

Zhao Shi's family didn't separate their family. They didn't want to adopt Dabao and Erbao, but when they heard that there were 6 taels of silver to receive every year, they agreed.

After Dabao and Erbao were sent away, the matter of Lei Xiangren's family was over.

A few days later, Lei Xiangli came to Qin Mian's house to borrow money from him and Lei Tie. He planned to open a grocery store at home.

Qin Mian was very supportive of this. Before, he found that Lei Xiangli had a bit of a business mind; now, it seemed that he really had it. In these few years, due to the existence of the processing yard, the financial situations of the villagers' families were much better than before. Every so often, they were willing to spend money on some side dishes to add to their tables. Many villagers were willing to give their children a copper or two from time to time. When a peddler came, the children could buy some snacks. Besides, some people from nearby villages came to work in the processing yard. If there was a grocery store in Green Mountain Village, it would be much more convenient for them to buy bits of thread and needles for their families and didn't have to go all the way to town. Therefore, Lei Xiangli truly profited in opening a grocery store in the village.

Qin Mian generously lent Lei Xiangli 20 taels of silver and taught him some knacks of doing business.

Lei Xiangli had gained a lot. Ten days later, Li's Grocery Store opened for business. It sold all the things that villagers often used, such as oil, salt, soy sauce, vinegar, tea, sugar, wine, needle, thread, and so on. There were also some side dishes, such as fried shelled peanuts, salty fried soybean, pickled

vegetables, marinated meat, and all kinds of cheap and delicious snacks. For the villagers, the goods were very complete and basically, everything was sold cheaper than in the town for half a Wen or a Wen. Not only that, but Li's Grocery Store also allowed the local villagers to buy on accounts once a month, but if someone failed to pay up three times in a row, he would not be allowed to buy on accounts in the future. Also, the store helped the villagers sell their handicrafts, such as baskets, handbaskets, embroidered pouches, and so on. It was convenient for the villagers.

To solicit customers for Lei Xiangli, Qin Mian even told Lei-Qin Le to take out his jar of salted eggs that he made for personal use to sell on consignment. Each salted egg was sold for 1 Wen. It was very well-received.

Sun Shi had a keen mind and dexterous hands. Occasionally, she gave some frequent buyers her homemade snacks. Lei Xiangli was a warm-hearted man and Sun Shi was a kind-hearted woman. The local villagers and the neighboring villagers had gotten used to shopping here. The children would go to buy some snacks after school, such as fried melon seeds that weighed a lot for a Wen, which they could eat to their satisfaction. In less than half a month, Li's Grocery Store was firmly established and its business was booming.

As soon as Lei Xiangyi and Qian Shi saw that their fourth brother had a way to make money, they couldn't sit still. They didn't know how to do business and only knew how to farm. It was hard for them to come up with a money-making idea for a while. In the end, Qian Shi got an idea. Wasn't Wu Di make a fortune by raising chickens in the village? They could raise ducks. There were several large ponds and a river in the village, completely qualified for raising ducks. However, there was another question: *raising chickens can make a lot of money because many people eat eggs and chicken meat; if they raise ducks, can duck eggs and duck meat sell?*

Thinking that Qin Mian was a businessman, the couple went to Qin Mian for advice.

Qin Mian expressed his appreciation and supported their idea. He suggested that they should raise less and accumulate experience first, because both of

them were young and had enough time and energy to try, so there was no need to worry at all. After learning through experience, it was not too late to increase the number of breeding. As for the sale of duck eggs and duck meat, there was no need to worry. As long as they developed a variety of ways to eat duck eggs and duck meat, they would be able to sell them.

The couple trusted Qin Mian's business mind very much and accepted his advice.

Qin Mian also lent them 20 taels of silver.

It wasn't long before the 12th lunar month arrived.

Lei Xiangzhi continued his habit of writing one letter to each of his three elder brothers every two months. He wrote another letter before the end of the year. This New Year was his first New Year in the Capital, so he had to stay in the Capital to make a good impression by paying New Year's greetings in time. In his letter, he apologized to his elder brothers and paid New Year's greetings in advance, and with the letter came the New Year's gifts for the whole family of his three elder brothers.

As for Lei Daqiang and Du Shi, it was easy to guess. After seeing the prosperity of the Capital, would they be happy to go back to the recess in mountains?

Without Lei Daqiang, Du Shi, and Lei Xiangren, Lei Tie's family, Lei Xiangyi's family, and Lei Xiangli's family were more cordial to each other. Their families were also closer to Lei Dagang's family than ever. In the first month of the Lunar New Year, the four families visited each other and took turns hosting a banquet. It was very lively.

Yuanyuan and Manman were the most popular among the younger generation. In the first month, more than 20 red envelopes were received from relatives alone, plus the red envelopes from the villagers, the total was more than 80.

The two little boys happily took out their money boxes and put all the money from the red envelopes into their boxes. They even asked Qin Mian

and Lei Tie to prepare a special account book for them and solemnly wrote their names on the first page of their account books.

There were many strokes in the two little boys' names. They had only learned to write their names not long ago. Three words filled the page. The "Rui", "Qi", and "Lin"¹ were written more like two words. Qin Mian snickered for a long time.

Lei Tie was forced by his two sons to press Qin Mian on the bed, and the three of them tickled him together.

After the Lunar New Year, there were a group of yellow ducklings in the village, a total of 50, staggering around behind a mother hen's butt, fluffy like yellow cotton balls.

In the 4th lunar month, Lei Xiangzhi wrote a letter back, saying that he had been promoted to the sixth-ranked Senior Compiler of Imperial Hanlin Academy.

Qin Mian was a bit surprised. Lei Xiangzhi was promoted too fast. But anyway, the promotion was a good thing. He and Lei Tie wrote a letter in reply to congratulate him.

It was almost the 7th lunar month after the busy farming season. The weather was too hot to go out to play. Besides, their family would be very busy for the whole year. Yuanyuan and Manman were four years old. Apart from studying, they also began to learn cultivation with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Four years old was one of the most suitable age stages for building a foundation.

Yuanyuan and Manman did not need to build their foundation like Qin Mian built his foundation last time, but rather directly built their foundation by taking a building-foundation pill refined by Qin Mian. Moreover, Yuanyuan and Manman were born in the magical space, so there were practically no impurities in their bodies. There was practically no pain during their process of building a foundation.

There were 12 stages of cultivation, including Foundation Establishment, Enlightenment, Fusion, Tempting Heart, Golden Elixir, Nascent Soul, Astral Projection, Distraction, Unification, Hollowness, Mahayana, and Overcoming Tribulation.² Each stage was divided into early stage, middle stage, and late stage. Qin Mian was now in the early stage of Tempting Heart, while Lei Tie was in the middle stage of Nascent Soul. With the two of them teaching Yuanyuan and Manman, the cultivation of Yuanyuan and Manman would go very smoothly.

Note (by Author): This is not a bug. Ducks can't hatch eggs. Ducklings are hatched by hens. When they are young, they will run around with hens.

Footnotes

1. 锐, 麒, 麟
2. I'm not so sure about the stages. I did search glossaries but I couldn't find half of the stages. Since the novel isn't focused on cultivation, let me skip the glossary, please.

Chapter 164: To be Rich, Mend the Road First

164 – To be Rich, Mend the Road First

Yuanyuan and Manman were still young; if they were not careful, they might slip their tongue. Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't tell them that what they taught was the method of Cultivation of Trueness¹. They only said that it was a profound secret of martial arts. There was plenty of spiritual qi in the space, which was the best place to practice. Every time Qin Mian and Lei Tie brought Yuanyuan and Manman into the space to practice, they waited until the boys fell asleep. When Yuanyuan and Manman woke up and asked, they just said that it was a mysterious place in the mountains of Green Mountain Village. The reason they were so cautious was to protect their family. Yuanyuan and Manman didn't doubt it. After the foundation was built, they entered the early stage of Enlightenment without a hitch.

White Spot and Golden Fur had changed a lot in the past year. Qin Mian didn't know how Demon Cultivation was classified, but based on the condensation degree of White Spot's vital spirit in its dantian, it could be judged that its cultivation today was equivalent to a human's early stage of Fusion – it was not small progress. It seemed that Golden Fur and White Spot could communicate with each other. At present, Golden Fur was also on the road of cultivation; its cultivation was equivalent to a human's mid-stage of Enlightenment.

White Spot and Golden Fur could live longer [because of cultivation] – it was good news Qin Mian's whole family.

In the new year, Qin Mian's development focus was not only on his own home but also on Green Mountain Village. Green Mountain Village had

enchanting scenery. It would be a pity if it wasn't developed well. However, after all, he was just a common man in Green Mountain Village. He still had to talk with Li Zheng about this.

As soon as Li Zheng saw Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman coming to his home, he guessed that something good was coming. He welcomed them into his home happily and urged his wife to prepare snacks for Yuanyuan and Manman.

Li Zheng's house had changed its appearance. The gate and wall of the courtyard were all new. He also imitated Qin Mian's house by planting a fruit tree and a flowering tree in the courtyard. Since Qin Mian's family had planted fruit trees and flowering trees in their yard, the villagers had followed suit. Almost every family planted flower trees and fruit trees in their yards. This seemed to have become a distinguishing feature of Green Mountain Village. Not to mention, planting flowers and fruit trees in the yard was more pleasing to the eye than when it was bare. It was also comfortable to live in the house, especially in spring when one could smell the fragrance of flowers.

Quite a few villagers saw that it took nearly an hour for Qin Mian's family to leave after they entered Li Zheng's house. Li Zheng's expression was odd, looking both happy and worried, as he walked back and forth in the yard with his hands clasped behind his back.

The villagers wondered: What on earth has happened?

On the way back, Yuanyuan and Manman began to sing the children's song that Qin Mian taught them, "I'm Not Fooled by Your Knocks".

Manman sang, "I'm not fooled, not fooled, I'm not fooled by your knocks. I'm not fooled, not fooled, I'm not fooled by your knocks..."

Yuanyuan sang, "The morning of no school, I accompany Dad to buy vegetables. Dad says I'm really obedient, more and more well-behaved..."

Manman sang again, "Dad has to leave for something, tell me to wait in place..."

The two little boys cooperated very well. They took turns to sing a few sentences. When they sang “I”, “you”, “no” and other words, their little hands presentably made corresponding gestures, while their faces wore the expressions of joy or coldness. It was very fun.

Qin Mian didn’t teach them to do this, so he was very surprised. He wanted to laugh but was afraid of provoking the two little boys. He put his hands on Lei Tie’s shoulders and hid behind him to laugh in secret.

The warm breath spurted out while he laughed blew on Lei Tie’s nape, vaguely teasing. Lei Tie couldn’t bear it and pulled the person to his side. He whispered in his wife’s ear, “Wife, if Yuanyuan and Manman know you’re secretly laughing, maybe they will make you learn with them.”

Qin Mian immediately shut up and put on a serious face.

A ghost of a smile flashed in Lei Tie’s eyes. He patted his wife’s head gently.

After singing a song twice, the foursome entered the courtyard.

Yuanyuan looked up at Qin Mian, “Dad, we want to go to the amusement park.”

“Sure,” Qin Mian nodded, “but, you have to learn ten more words today.”

“Alright.”

The two little boys rushed forward hand in hand.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie followed, neither in a hurry nor slow.

The amusement park was actually the former grove. It was redesigned by Qin Mian and transformed by Lei Tie to become a small world of its own that was fully built of the wooden logs left by the cut trees. It was full of fun. There was not only a seesaw, swing, slide, swivel chair, single-log bridge, but also a climbing net. The climbing net was long and wide that could be changed in design. Qin Mian sometimes hung it up as a net wall, sometimes folded it into a three-storied tower, and sometimes made it into a

small labyrinth.... Yuanyuan and Manman's favorite was the climbing net. Every time, they played the climbing net until they were tired out.

"Old Dad, I want to play climbing net." Manman broke no delay to speak.

Lei Tie tied safety ropes to the two boys.

The boys rushed to the climbing net immediately. In a short time, laughter came from the amusement park.

The servants brought fruit, tea, and snacks, while Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat by and watched over the two children...

Two days later in the morning, Li Zheng's second son beat the gong and yelled to the whole village, "After breakfast, go to Li Zheng's house for an official meeting, one representative from each household; after breakfast, go to Li Zheng's house for an official meeting, one representative from each household..."

After breakfast, the villagers went to Li Zheng's house in twos and threes. It was said that each household only needed to send one person, but the villagers were very concerned about the major events in the village. As long as they had nothing important on hand, they all went to Li Zheng's house.

After breakfast, Qin Mian and Lei Tie told Yuanyuan and Manman to stay at home to review the previous day's lessons before going to Li Zheng's home together.

The villagers entered the gate and purposefully squatted in a place.

Elder Liu and Elder Wang were also invited – they sat on two armchairs under the eaves.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were also assigned two chairs.

Li Zheng's eldest son, Luo Youfu, called the names first. No matter who came to attend the meeting, he only called the head of the household, which if present, answered the roll call.

After the roll call, Li Zheng said, “It’s still the old rule. I’ll talk about things first. If you have any questions, ask you after I’ve finished.”

The villagers were used to Li Zheng’s way of doing things, so they had no objection.

After sitting down, Li Zheng said, “Today’s meeting is to discuss the road construction in Green Mountain Village. Why was Green Mountain Village so poor before? Why was there no school before? It’s all because Green Mountain Village is too remote and the road is too uneven. If the road can be mended, it will be much more convenient for us to sell the grain in the field or buy things from outside. If you don’t understand the reason, I’ll give you an analogy. Nowadays, if we want to sell a cart of grain, if it is 400 Jin, we need one person to drive the cart and six people to push the cart. It takes more than an hour from the village to the town, and we have to give salary to the six people who push the cart. If our road is easy to tread, maybe two people will be enough to push the cart. It only costs two wages and can save a lot of time. Everyone, think whether this is reasonable. Not only that, if the road is good, more girls are willing to marry into our village. Do you think a good girl is willing to marry to a village with a good road or a bad one? Therefore, road construction is not only beneficial to us but also to our future generations. While we can still work, we must do something good for future generations. Isn’t that right?”

His words were so simple that the villagers could understand them and nodded their heads one after another.

Li Zheng took a sip of tea and continued, “Before planting seedlings in the mid of the 5th month, everyone is basically idle. I thought, take this opportunity to mend the road out of the village. Every household must lend one strong manpower. But if there is really no strong manpower in the household, the young [married] woman, old woman, or half-adult son also must lend power to do easy works such as bring tea and water to the guys and so on. I will arrange this matter properly. In short, as a member of Green Mountain Village, every household has to contribute. Otherwise, you don’t walk on the road built by others.”

Someone opened his mouth to talk but Li Zheng waved his hand to stop him. “I haven’t finished yet. You must have guessed that Tie-zi and his wife proposed the road construction. Their household is the richest in Green Mountain Village, but they didn’t forget to take care of the villagers. They told me that they would teach everyone to bake bricks for free, and then our village would have a flat road paved with bricks. We have to thank Tie-zi and his wife for this. That’s what I want to say. Do you have any objection?”

Elder Liu nodded, “The road, really need to mend. It’s just that most of the men in our village work in the processing yard. If they go to mend roads, will the work on the other side of the processing yard be delayed?” He looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie with concern.

Li Zheng said, “That’s why Tie-zi and his wife are virtuous and sincere. When we mend the roads, the men stop working.”

“Exactly.” Qin Mian looked around and said, “Road construction is a major event for the whole village. Naturally, our household will give full support to it.”

The villagers endlessly admired him and Lei Tie. Others even suggested that Qin Mian’s household did not have to lend manpower during the road construction.

The road construction was settled very smoothly.

Baking brick needed fuel, clay, water, and kiln. For fuel, the trees all over the mountain near Green Mountain Village could be made into fuel; for clay, there was a mountain depression in Green Mountain Village with deep ground level and good clay quality, which was very suitable for making bricks from clay; for water, there was no shortage of water if there was a river; for kiln, just built one now would do.

Qin Mian guided the villagers to build a brick kiln and make brick molds. There was a brick kiln in [previous world] Qin Mian’s grandfather’s village, which was abandoned after less than two years of operation because of conflicts between partners. Qin Mian and his playmates in the village often

went to play in the brick kiln. He remembered the structure of the kiln very clearly.

After the road was mended, the brick kiln could still be used as a public property in the village. No matter who wanted to build a house in the village, they could bake bricks here without spending money to buy it. Therefore, the villagers were very dedicated. It took only a day to build the small brick kiln.

Qin Mian remembered that the size of a standard brick seemed to be 240mmX115mmX53mm, which seemed to be because this proportion could play out the optimum load-bearing capacity of the brick, so Qin Mian made the brick mold into the same size as he remembered.

Very soon, Li Zheng had made arrangements for the whole village. Now, there were 80 households in the village, each of which lent out one strong manpower, making the total of 80 manpower. Li Zheng arranged for 20 people to cut firewood, 30 people to dig clay, 10 people to pick pine resin, 10 people to bake bricks, and 10 people to transport.

It took nearly a month to produce enough bricks in a small kiln. During the baking of bricks, other villagers first used shovels, hoes, and other tools to smooth the road or paving or filling the pit with soil. Then, they compacted the road with a stone roller, laid the bricks neatly, and rolled the stone roller again to make the bricks embedded in the soil. Lastly, the gaps between the bricks were watered with melted pine resin to achieve the bonding effect. If the pine resin was not enough, tung oil, glutinous rice juice, and lime juice were mixed to be used for grouting.

With the help of the whole village, they had been busy for nearly two months. The road from Green Mountain Village to the outside of the mountain had become flat and beautiful.

After Li Zheng announced that the road could be used, the whole village, may it be adults or children, could not hold back from stepping and walking on the brick road. Everyone without exception, was happy and excited, glowing with vigor.

Teacher Chen of the imperial examination class witnessed the whole process of road construction in Green Mountain Village and wrote to his several friends about it.

When the villagers in the surrounding villages learned about it, they all came to watch the excitement and were envious. They realized very clearly that Green Mountain Village was getting better and better.

What people in Green Mountain Village didn't expect was that a few days later, the incident even reached the ears of the County Magistrate of Zhaoyang County. The County Magistrate summoned Li Zheng of Green Mountain Village and rewarded him with 50 taels of silver.

Li Zheng was in a high mood. He didn't take the 50 taels of silver for himself. He took out 20 taels and invited the whole village to have two meals. The remaining 30 taels would be kept for the village's use in the future.

Note:

Footnotes

1. Previously, I translated it to Truth Cultivation (修真 direct translation is to cultivate truth; other resources translated it to Cultivation of Perfection and Cultivation of Reality), the most common synonym is Dao Cultivation.

Chapter 165: Qilin Summer Mountain Villa

165 – Qilin Summer Mountain Villa

After the road was mended, the villagers threw themselves into the busy farming season and the work in the processing yard.

Qin Mian made use of the small brick kiln and had his servants baked some black bricks. He also mended and reorganized the road in front of Leisurely Farmhouse. The black bricks were laid from the gate of Leisurely Farmhouse, along the wall to the west, around the north of the processing yard, to the place bordering the village road. Afterward, when it rained, the family carriage would not roll through the mud.

The black brick road was about ten *chi*¹ wide. On the outside of the road, a tree and a flower were planted every ten *chi* or so. May it be winter jasmine, jasmine, chrysanthemum, or plum blossom, all were dug out from the mountain.

After the busy farming season, the villagers suddenly found the changes outside the walls of Leisurely Farmhouse. They thought their own house gates would be more beautiful like this. They also joined hands in twos and threes to make some black bricks to pave the road of their own houses. Some villagers were quite creative. When they paved the ground, some round stones were mixed between the bricks to form a pattern of flowers or animals. It was particularly beautiful.

After the brick roads in front of each house were connected together, the villagers suddenly realized that the whole Green Mountain Village was much more beautiful than before.

This was Qin Mian's purpose – imperceptibly led the villagers to transform Green Mountain Village and finally made Green Mountain Village a land of idyllic beauty.

On a pleasantly cool morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie came to Li Zheng's home again. Lei Tie even had a scroll in his hand.

Quite a few villagers who accidentally saw them followed curiously. It was not easy for Li Zheng to drive them away.

"Tie-zi's wife, what good idea is there still?" Li Zheng recalled being summoned and praised by the County Magistrate last time, so he was still excited that his face flushed with vigor.

Qin Mian said with a smile, "Uncle Li Zheng, A-Tie and I came this time for two things. First, we want to ask if we can buy the mountains around our village?"

"You want to buy mountains?" Li Zheng thought to himself: it's hard to understand what rich people think. In his opinion, those mountains were of little value since they couldn't grow food.

Qin Mian nodded.

Li Zheng said, "There's nothing that can't be bought. I'll go to the county to get you the title deed."

Qin Mian said, "We want to buy Mount Eagle at the back of the village. How much does it cost, do you think?"

Li Zheng pondered, "Mount Eagle... That mountain is not small. I remember that a few years ago, a landlord of a village in Running Water Town bought a mountain near their village and spent more than 300 taels of silver. Mount Eagle should not exceed 500 taels."

"We'll buy Mount Eagle." Qin Mian said, "Later, A-Tie and I will follow you to the county. I've been bothering you so many times. We must treat you to a meal in any way."

“Haha, alright.” Li Zheng was only too glad to accept it.

A villager asked curiously, “Tie-zi’s wife, what do you buy that mountain for?”

Qin Mian did not conceal, “We plan to build a summer villa on the mountain.” He was not afraid that others would follow suit. On one hand, other people’s design of the summer villa could not surpass his; on the other hand, he had a cheat device – his well-built summer villa must be better than others’ summer villa.

The few villagers were both amazed and admired them.

Li Zheng asked, “What’s the second thing?”

Qin Mian asked with a smile, “Uncle Li Zheng, do you want to make Green Mountain Village more beautiful? Do you want to make the villagers of Green Mountain Village richer?”

Li Zheng’s expression was serious, “Of course!”

Qin Mian looked at the five villagers who were so excited that their eyes were shining. “Elder brothers, please leave us.”

Although the five villagers wanted to know what good idea Qin Mian had, they changed their minds for fear of making him unhappy. They all smiled and politely cupped their hands in obeisance to him and Lei Tie before leaving.

Only then Qin Mian said, “To make our village more beautiful, first, plant flowers; second, plant fruit trees, so that there are flowers and fruits in four seasons. Flowers and trees are not planted randomly but in a planned way. For example, flowers should be planted on this piece of land and trees should be planted on that piece of land. Also, not everyone grows the same fruit trees, but one household plants peach trees and another household plants pear trees. It is convenient to take care of and can ensure that every household has income. Just imagine, if everyone grows peach trees, it will

be difficult to sell the fruits when there is a lot of it. Besides, the variety is too solely.”

Li Zheng nodded, incessantly.

Qin Mian unfolded the scroll in Lei Tie’s hand and put it on the table. “This is the transformed Green Mountain Village. Have a look.”

Li Zheng looked at the neat housing, the spacious roads, the beautiful sea of flowers, and the fertile fruit trees within the painting... perpetually wondered at the scene.

“Good! These fields?”

Li Zheng saw the name of the painting.

Qin Mian nodded, “That’s right, the fields in the painting are no different from those in our village in both quantity and location.”

“You painted it? It must have been a lot of work.” Li Zheng patted him on the shoulder.

Lei Tie said, “Four days.”

“You two have taken a lot of trouble,” said Li Zheng with emotion.

“Just a little bit of planning. If we really want to transform Green Mountain Village, some villagers’ fields need to be replanted with fruit trees.” Qin Mian hesitated, “This is only our idea. Whether it can be realized or not depends on Uncle Li Zheng’s ability. The only thing we can guarantee is that we will do our best to teach the villagers to plant flowers and fruit trees.”

Li Zheng frowned for a long time. If he could make Green Mountain Village more beautiful and the villagers richer, he would certainly like to. But it was not that simple. It was useless for him to agree because he had to consider the villagers’ opinions. Farmers had to pay a certain amount of land tax every year. If some of the fields used to grow grain were used to grow fruit trees, the grain output would be lower. If the output was not

enough to pay the land tax, the villagers would have to pay with money to make up. If they couldn't make money from planting flowers and fruit trees, wouldn't he drive the villagers to a dead end?

Qin Mian understood his concerns, "There's no need to rush to decide on this matter. Uncle Li Zheng can think about it slowly. Even if you don't agree in the end, it's alright."

Li Zheng's anxiety slowly receded, and he laughed at himself, "On the contrary, I'm inclined. That's right, it's not urgent. Let's solve the problem of you buying the mountain first. How about going to the county tomorrow?"

"No problem."

Other villagers heard from the five villagers that Qin Mian wanted to give the whole village a good idea to make money. They were excited and went to Li Zheng's and Qin Mian's houses to ask for information. Unfortunately, both Li Zheng's and Qin Mian's gates were closed. The villagers had to restrain their anxiety and waited for Li Zheng to call them for a meeting.

The next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took Yuanyuan, Manman, and Li Zheng on the family's carriage to Zhaoyang County.

Li Zheng also brought his six-year-old grandson, Little Luobo². The Luo Family taught Little Luobo very well. He was young but sensible and clever. He was a qualified small elder brother in front of Yuanyuan and Manman.

When they got to the county town, they went to the County Office first and spent 450 taels of silver to buy Mount Eagle and 10 taels of silver to handle the title deed and bribed the commissioner.³

After finishing their proper business, the three adults and three children strolled in the street, bought some small toys for the three children, and had lunch in Nie Heng's wine house near noon.

Nie Heng happened to be there.

His wife, who was now more than two months pregnant, kept nagging in Qin Mian's ear several times before when she went to Double Xiang House to borrow Yuanyuan and Manman to live in her house for a while. It was a pity that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not free. If they allowed Yuanyuan and Manman to go by themselves, they wouldn't feel at ease. So then, they didn't go.

"If Yuanyuan and Manman are willing to stay with me for a few days, my wife will surely get a boy," said Nie Heng with regret.

Qin Mian laughed at him, "Do you want a son so much? Be careful, if your wife knows, she will make you kneel on the washboard."

Nie Heng smilingly said, "It's just that Yuanyuan and Manman are so adorable. I hope to have a son as adorable as them."

Manman took out a piece of fruit candy made by Qin Mian from his big pocket and handed it to Nie Heng. He said with a serious face, "Uncle Nie, this candy is for Aunt. Aunt will surely give birth to an adorable little brother."

Nie Heng was taken aback but felt warm in his heart. He rubbed Manman's little head, took the candy, and put it into his pocket. He laughed, "Alright. Thank you, Manman. I will definitely give this candy to your Aunt to eat."

Nie Heng came home and put the candy into his wife's mouth. Young Madam Nie thought that her husband finally knew how to coax people. She smiled continuously for several days...

Back to Green Mountain Village from the county town, Qin Mian and Lei Tie started building the Qilin Summer Mountain Villa.

Three days later, Li Zheng called all the villagers to his home again to discuss an official matter. He relayed Qin Mian's words and asked them to think it over.

Qin Mian and Li Zheng did not expect the reaction of the villagers. No one opposed or hesitated. Everyone believed in Qin Mian's ability and was

willing to gamble with him.

Qin Mian was moved and felt that these villagers also had a lovely side. He had more confidence in the transformation of Green Mountain Village.

At the same time that Li Zheng was gratified, his decision also firmed up. Even the villagers believed in Qin Mian and Lei Tie so much, and thus he should believe in them. As long as they all worked together, they would be able to succeed.

The best season for planting flowers and trees was spring, so the plan to transform Green Mountain Village was put on hold for a while.

Before dismissing them, Li Zheng told the villagers to keep it secret so as not to cause other side issues.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie continued to work on Qilin Summer Mountain Villa – went uphill to cut things, dug trees, dug earth, built roads, bought stones and materials... From the beginning of construction to the completion of the project, more than 100 workers were employed. They were busy from the 7th month to the end of the 12th month, which took nearly half a year for Qilin Summer Mountain Villa to take on a complete look.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie became the first people to live in Qilin Summer Mountain Villa along with Yuanyuan, Manman, White Spot, and Golden Fur.

The whole Qilin Summer Mountain Villa was basically made of wood. There were six establishments in total, and due to it being a “summer” mountain villa, their names had a refreshing flavor. Their names were Clear Spring Pavilion, Cool Summer Residence, Cold Autumn Building, Chilly Winter Courtyard, Left Frost House, and Right Snow Park. The style of the six establishments was totally different. The pavilions and kiosks arranged in picturesque disorder; insects, fish, birds, and beast, stirred the brush tip to fly⁴. Inside and outside the summer mountain villa, tall trees stood in great numbers and vegetation was serene and hidden in-depth – it was such a nice quiet place. One could imagine that in summer, this place would be a well-known summer resort.

T/n: I'm the only one. Not guys either, I'm a fish.

Note:

Footnotes

1. one-third of a meter. 10 chi = 3 m
2. Luo is the surname, but Luobo translated as radish is the boy's nickname.
3. it's not an illegal thing they did, but it's kind of common at that time [at present too (please don't take or give bribe)] to bribe some officers to dredge up a relationship and trust them [officers] to take care of them.
4. Taken from Chen Renjie's poem 《沁园春·诗不穷人》 which meant that a good poem can make all the natural scenery vivid—baidu

Chapter 166: Land of Idyllic Beauty + Grand General Lei

166 – Land of Idyllic Beauty + Grand General Lei

Should have done all the bonuses, so no updates or the rest of the month, but I'm diligent ~~or more like bored of staring at the wall of my aquarium.~~

Qilin Summer Mountain Villa was not suitable for ordinary people to live in winter. It was chilly everywhere. Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not afraid of the cold, while Yuanyuan and Manman had heating spiritual tools with them. Therefore, it was fine for them to stay there for a few days.

When Yuanyuan and Manman found out that the name of the mountain villa was the combination of their names, they were so happy they explored everywhere with White Spot and Golden Fur. White Spot and Golden Fur especially liked it here – it felt like they were back in the mountains.

“White Spot; Golden Fur,” called Lei Tie.

White Spot and Golden Fur ran back quickly.

“Look after Yuanyuan and Manman.”

White Spot nodded and returned to Yuanyuan and Manman's side with Golden Fur.

Lei Tie grabbed Qin Mian's hand and went in another direction.

“Where to?” Qin Mian didn't understand. He guessed that Lei Tie couldn't wait to do something. His heart beat faster. In recent months, both of them had been busy with the summer villa, so they hadn't been on intimate terms

with each other for some time. It was not hard for him to admit that he missed Lei Tie, so very much. Just thinking about it, his whole body felt hot and dry.

Lei Tie didn't speak. His steps were still very steady but he was obviously eager.

Qin Mian faced Lei Tie and put his arms around the man's waist. After he kissed Lei Tie's lips, he looked at him with a smile on his face.

Lei Tie hugged him and flew up. He flew through the branches that stretched out, flew higher and higher, and after a few breaths, they both appeared in a treehouse.

"When did you do it?" Qin Mian was so pleasantly surprised. He looked around, not forgetting to pull the man's hand.

The treehouse was about 2 zhang long, 2 zhang wide, and 1 zhang high [6.6mX6.6mX3.3m]. It was very spacious. The roof, wall, and floor were made of green bamboo with the thickness of an adult's arm. There were doors and windows. It was a marvelous creation excelling nature; green, sparkling, and clean. If one lived here in summer, it must be especially cool.

In the middle of the floor was a thick rug about the size of a bed. Qin Mian gave a deep meaningful look at Lei Tie. He came to the door, stretched out his head, and looked down. The treehouse was nearly 8 chi away from the ground. He could see Yuanyuan and Manman in the mountain villa, happily running around Golden Fur and White Spot.

As he watched them, Lei Tie held him from behind and said with a hoarse voice coated with a suggestion, "Wife, miss you."

As though Qin Mian fell into a hot stove, he turned around and pushed down Lei Tie hard.

The two men rolled onto the rug and soon got entangled.....

Yuanyuan and Manman had been playing for a long time. When they didn't see Qin Mian and Lei Tie all of a sudden, they didn't panic. They came to Cool Summer Residence they were going to stay in tonight. After eating some snacks in their bags, they felt a little sleepy. They took off their shoes, climbed the bed to lie down, and even covered themselves with the quilt consciously.

White Spot and Golden Fur lay down beside the bed, closed their eyes, and guarded the children.

The noise in the treehouse took a long time to cease.

At the end of a *hearty* movement, Qin Mian felt as if some raw embroidered part in his body had been reactivated. He was energetic and full of strength. He turned his head to look at Lei Tie. Like him, from inside to outside, the man exuded pleasure and satiety. He couldn't help but pounce on the man and kissed his lips. His body unconsciously rubbed against the man.

Lei Tie let out a low roar in his throat. Beyond endurance, he overturned Qin Mian on the rug and pressed him again.....

“Wife?”

Qin Mian buried his head in Lei Tie's chest with his limbs all wrapped around the man tightly – a silent protest. *Really can't come a third time.*

Lei Tie didn't struggle while being bound by his wife. Only his head could move. He lowered his head and pecked a few times on his wife's soft hair.

“Wife, this is our [two people] place.”

Qin Mian opened his eyes, raised his head, and teased, “Can't even say to the sons?”

“En.” Lei Tie looked steadily at him.

“Alright.” Qin Mian chuckled and put his arms around Lei Tie's neck. Even if Lei Tie asked him to tell his two sons about the existence of this place, he would be ashamed.

After a little while, they dressed up and went back to the ground.

Yuanyuan and Manman had woken up. As soon as they saw their two fathers, they ran over.

Yuanyuan looked up and down at his Dad and Old Dad. His Dad was smiling, which was not odd, but his Old Dad's eyes seemed to be smiling, which made him quite curious, "Dad, Old Dad, where have you been?"

"*Cough...*" Qin Mian looked away with a guilty heart and said, "Just walking around to see if there is any place that needs to be modified."

Manman crossed his arms and meaningfully uttered, "Oh—"

He and Gege were not stupid. Other little friends lived with a father and a mother. He and Gege had two Dads and no mother. Nevertheless, their Dad was ten times more powerful than the father of all their little friends, and their Old Dad was one hundred times more powerful than the mother of all their little friends!¹

If Qin Mian and Lei Tie knew that the two little boys were thinking like this, Qin Mian would be so complacent that he would laugh with a swagger because the two little boys obviously put Lei Tie in the position of a "mother", while Lei Tie, who wouldn't speak up, could only be depressed in his heart.

Lei Tie effortlessly picked up Yuanyuan and Manman at the same time, "Wife, go back to the house."

"Dad, Little Luobo's family is already preparing New Year's goods. When will our family do it?" Sitting on Lei Tie's shoulder, Manman asked Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said, "Tomorrow. Your Old Dad and I will take you to town tomorrow."

As time went by, the new year had come again.

Lei Xiangzhi, the fifth extended family of the Leis, and the others still wouldn't come back this year.

Winter gave place to spring. Yuanyuan and Manman had reached five years old.

In the middle of the 2nd month, Qin Mian and Lei Tie began to lead the whole village to transform Green Mountain Village. Qin Mian also had to lend money to some farmers who had poor financial conditions and could not afford too many flowers and fruit trees. As long as the farmer's character was alright, Qin Mian would lend money and write down a debit note.

Having less time for Yuanyuan and Manman, the couple sent the boys to the imperial examination class in Green Mountain Village. The two boys became the youngest students in the imperial examination class.

In the beginning, Teacher Chen was reluctant. He felt that the two boys were too young and worried that they would not be well disciplined. Qin Mian did not argue with him but suggested that he allow Yuanyuan and Manman to attend two days of class.

Two days later, Qin Mian wanted to take Yuanyuan and Manman away, but Teacher Chen was not happy again. This was because he discovered that Yuanyuan and Manman were not only obedient but also very smart. In this way, Yuanyuan and Manman, like other children in the village, went to school after breakfast, carried a small schoolbag, went home for lunch, went to school again after an hour's rest, and finished class at the beginning of rooster hour [5:00 pm].

Although Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very busy, they still spent an hour every day tutoring the boys' studies and teaching them some modern knowledge.

By the beginning of the 3rd month, all the flowers and trees in Green Mountain Village had been planted. Qin Mian quietly sprinkled diluted spiritual spring water to ensure the survival of all flowers and fruit trees. Then, he hired four people, who knew how to take care of flowers and fruit

trees, and Grandpa Fang to teach the villagers how to take care of flowers and fruit trees.

In the late of the 3rd month, all kinds of flower trees and fruit trees bloomed one after another in pink, white, yellow, purple... beautiful flowers, splendid in many postures. Green Mountain Village suddenly changed from an *ordinary girl* to a *descending celestial maiden*. The villagers walked in the brocade of luxuriant flowers and smelled all kinds of fragrance that were so refreshing their waists and backs were straighter than before. From a distance, Green Mountain Village was even more beautiful. The houses with different heights and continuous undulations were hidden in the red flowers and green willows, like a fairyland on earth.

The changes of Green Mountain Village attracted the villagers of other villages. They were all envious. Almost every day, people came to see the flowers. They could look but absolutely not allowed to pick it. Otherwise, the dogs in the village would chase people out for a few li away before they gave up.

In the 6th month, the peaches ripened and tasted sweet. Li Zheng and the villagers were completely relieved.

Apart from a few of the matured fruits was transported to the town to sell, the rest were transported to other places. Qin Mian did not teach the villagers to make jam or canned fruit. In this respect, he had selfish motives. Merely by the means of his family's power alone, he couldn't supervise all the villagers. If a villager sold inferior jam and canned fruit as goods, it would lead to big trouble. It was not that no villagers had figured out a way to make jam, but because the brand of Glimmer of Paradise was so powerful, they couldn't open up the market at all. The jam they made was mostly sold to local people to taste fresh, and couldn't be sold to other places as far as Glimmer of Paradise's jam was. However, because the fruits tasted very sweet, the villagers still made a lot of money by selling fruits alone, which was much better than planting only grains.

Besides that, the fruits of Green Mountain Village were sold to the villagers at an internal price. For example, Family A grew peach trees and Family B grew pear trees. For people outside the village, they bought the peaches for

3 Wen per Jin and pears for 4 Wen per Jin, but Family A bought Family B's pears for only 1 Wen per Jin and Family B bought Family A's peaches for only 1 Wen per Jin. In this way, the villagers could eat cheap fruits. The children could also fully absorb all kinds of nutrition, which made them significantly whiter, tenderer, and healthier than the children in other villages.

Flowers were also sold to other places at different prices with different varieties. A pot of wild chrysanthemum was only 10 Wen, but a pot of crown-mold double-petal white camelia could be sold for 200 Wen.

The life of the villagers in Green Mountain Village got better and better, and the relationship between the villagers was more harmonious.

Li Zheng was right. In the past, girls from other villages didn't want to marry into Green Mountain Village, but now they all wanted to. So much so that even the girls' parents secretly picked certain young men in Green Mountain Village and then hired the matchmaker to mediate. The local young men were happy. Even if they looked crooked, as long as they were hardworking, there were still girls who liked them. The local girls were not willing to marry out of the village. They preferred to marry fellow villagers. The parents also hoped that their daughters could live a good life. They were no longer unwilling to marry their daughters to fellow villagers as before.

Not only that but some people from other villages who shared relatives and friends with the local villagers even secretly gave gifts to Luo Li Zheng², hoping to move to Green Mountain Village. Li Zheng didn't agree. Teacher Chen was an exception; he planned to move his family to Green Mountain Village, where he was warmly welcomed by the villagers.

In the 7th month, when the weather began to get hot, Qilin Summer Mountain Villa officially opened. Almost all of the guests came to Qilin Summer Mountain Villa for their trust in Double Xiang House's strength. When they came, they found out that the accommodation, meals, drinks, pastries, and leisure activities in the mountain villa were the most special experiences that other summer mountain villa had never had. In just five days, a total of fourteen small courtyards in the six establishments were full.

The arrival of these people had also led to the economic development of Green Mountain Village. For example, when some guests wanted to go to some family's flower garden to pick some flowers, or to some family's orchard to enjoy the fun of picking fruits in person, or to some family's pond to pick lotus seeds or dig lotus roots, they had to pay not only for the flowers, fruits, and lotus roots but also for "picking". What the rich people bought was enjoyment. How would the people who could even afford to live in the expensive Qilin Summer Mountain Villa be reluctant to spend money on flowers and fruits? In this way, those who spent money were happy, so were those who earned money.

Until the hot summer was over, people still came to Qilin Summer Mountain Villa one after another, not to avoid the summer heat, but to enjoy the beautiful rural scenery.

Amid bustle and joy, another year had passed.

In the 3rd month, spring had come and the flowers were in bloom.

Li Zheng called on the villagers to plant what Qin Mian called "made green with trees" on both sides of the road out of the village, making the road into Green Mountain Village more beautiful.

Qin Mian's whole family, who had made important contributions to the development of Green Mountain Village, was exempt from all collective actions.

It was the Green Mountain Village School's holiday once every seven days. Yuanyuan and Manman wanted to see the trees. Qin Mian and Lei Tie took them, White Spot, and Golden Fur to the mountain behind the village to see the villagers planting trees.

On the mountain, iron hooves clanked. A squadron of dignified armored soldiers galloped on their fast horses and stopped in front of the villagers who were buzzing with activity.

The villagers stopped working and peeped curiously at them.

Li Zheng put down the spade in his hand and walked over quickly, “Excuse me—Xiangzhi boy?”

Lei Xiangzhi didn’t pay attention to Li Zheng. His complicated eyes fell on Lei Tie, who stood side by side with Qin Mian and watched Yuanyuan and Manman play.

Lei Tie looked over without a thought and slightly frowned.

The leader of the armored soldiers was about 40 years old with a white face and looked somewhat arrogant. He looked around and upon seeing Lei Tie, he looked happy and urged his horse to go over. He turned quickly upon his saddle and dismount, bent with hands cupped in obeisance to Lei Tie and politely yet flatteringly said, “This inferior one pays respect to Grand General Lei! Hope that Grand General Lei have been well since we last met?”

——End of Volume 3——

Note:

Footnotes

1. Let me slip in emojis 🤔🤔🤔
2. Luo Li Zheng here means Village Head Luo

Chapter 167: Two Imperial Edicts

167 – Two Imperial Edicts

“This inferior one pays respect to Grand General Lei! Hope that Grand General Lei have been well since we last met?”

The villagers were stunned and looked at Lei Tie with eyes filled with suspicion. Their first reaction was: could it be a wrong person? However, seeing that Lei Xiangzhi didn’t refute the middle-aged man’s words, everyone understood right there that Lei Tie was truly a Grand General. At once, their eyes were full of shock and awe.

Yuanyuan and Manman looked over curiously. Without batting an eyelid, Qin Mian walked over and took them aside. He hid behind the crowd and looked at Lei Tie. His eyes glazed with worry and vigilance. *Why does the eunuch next to the Emperor suddenly come to Green Mountain Village to see A-Tie?*

He turned to Lei Xiangzhi with an inquiring look and Lei Xiangzhi slightly nodded to him. He breathed a sigh of relief – it was good as long as it was not bad news.

Li Zheng’s lips trembled and lost his voice for a moment. The news that Lei Tie was –to everyone’s surprise– a Grand General was too shocking.

Lei Tie turned away from the eunuch’s salute and lightly said, “Eunuch Li doesn’t need to be courteous. I’m not a Grand General anymore.”

Yuanyuan looked at Qin Mian with his eyes shining and asked in a low voice, “Dad, is Old Dad a Grand General?”

Manman’s eyes were also shining.

Qin Mian nodded. When the two little boys learned that their Old Dad was once a Grand General, they would certainly idolize him even more.

The two little boys' eyes shone even brighter. Nonetheless, they were very clever. Knowing that things were not simple, they stood quietly beside Qin Mian and did not speak again.

"You are, of course, still!" Eunuch Li took out a pair of bright yellow scrolls from his sleeve pocket and held them out respectfully and carefully with both hands. "Grand General Lei, His Majesty asked this inferior one to pass the Imperial Edicts."

Where had all the villagers ever seen this kind of posture? When they heard the words "His Majesty", they were so scared they knelt on the ground.

Qin Mian's mind wandered a little as he thought: *when one accepts the imperial edict, one has to set up an incense table. This kneeling is useless.*

Lei Tie nodded his head without expression and gestured to them to follow him.

Eunuch Li was not surprised by his cold reaction, as if he had been used to it. Without a change of expression nor did he mount the horse, he followed with the imperial edicts in his hands.

Lei Xiangzhi and the soldiers who followed them all dismounted and walked behind.

Lei Tie gave a meaningful glance at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian made a "silent" gesture to Yuanyuan and Manman, picked them up with both hands, mingled with the villagers, and slipped away when people didn't pay attention.

The villagers also stopped working and followed.

Li Zheng was a little worried. He quietly moved closer to Lei Xiangzhi and asked in a low voice, "Xiangzhi boy, what's happening? It's not anything bad, is it?"

Lei Xiangzhi whispered, “Li Zheng doesn’t have to worry. It’s a good thing.”

Li Zheng took a long breath; his heart was still beating fast. Their Green Mountain Village was amazing. They had Lei Xiangzhi, an official in the Capital, Qin Mian, a powerful businessman, and now a Great General.

Following Lei Tie down the mountain, Eunuch Li had a panoramic view of the beautiful village and was filled with admiration. When he entered the village, he looked at the roadside flowers and fruit trees and smelled the fragrance of flowers. His expression of admiration showed not only in words but also on his face.

“Grand General Lei lives in such a beautiful place. This inferior one is really envious.”

He wasn’t embarrassed at all for not getting Lei Tie’s response. He looked around, left and right.

Lei Xiangzhi hadn’t been back to his hometown for three years. He was so shocked and couldn’t see enough with his pair of eyes. He had a hunch that the changes in Green Mountain Village were greatly related to his Eldest Sister-in-law.

After entering Leisurely Farmhouse, Eunuch Li and the soldiers unconsciously slowed down and looked around, incessantly envious.

Lei Tie invited Eunuch Li into the house and ordered the servants to set up an incense burner table.

Eunuch Li stood in front of the incense burner table and unfolded the Imperial Edict.

Headed by Lei Tie, everyone kneeled.

Eunuch Li read in a sharp voice, “By the grace of Heaven, the Emperor ordered that Lei Tianren, the former General of the West Order, who was brave and good at fighting, led the army like a God, be appointed and

conferred as the Defender Grand General of the State¹, to command the front, middle, and rear army. These, by the Emperor himself.”

Lei Tie’s heart sank. He had no choice but to accept the imperial edict with both hands, “Your subject accepts this edict with gratitude. Long live His Majesty, absolutely long live!”

After Lei Tie put the imperial edict on the incense table, Eunuch Li said with a smile, “Grand General Lei, there is another imperial edict.”

Lei Tie’s eyes flashed cold light and died away. He slightly nodded and knelt again without a sound.

Eunuch Li read aloud, “By the grace of Heaven, the Emperor ordered that Lei Tianren, Defender Grand General of the State, who had brilliantly outstanding military service and made great contributions to the country, to be conferred as State Defender Duke, bestowed a State Defender Duke Establishment, and granted an iron certificate² and 10,000 taels of gold to express His Majesty’s benevolence. These, by the Emperor himself.”

When Qin Mian, who was eavesdropping on the second floor, heard the second imperial edict, his eyes narrowed, showing a sharp cold light. His mind was incessantly bewildered. According to his understanding of the Great Xia Dynasty, Defender Grand General of the State was a second rank [official post] and State Defender Duke was the first rank! Not only that, the title of State Defender Duke could be inherited. As long as the future generations did not make a grave mistake, they could always inherit the title of nobility. The Emperor’s favor for A-Tie was too sudden and too strong that it made him doubt whether there was any conspiracy.

What he thought of, Lei Tie also thought of. However, the imperial power was supreme; Lei Tie couldn’t refuse. Once again, he received the edict with gratitude.

Eunuch Li congratulated him with a smile, “State Defender Duke, the State Defender Duke Establishment has been put in order appropriately. His Majesty ordered this inferior one to escort State Defender Duke and family to the Capital as soon as possible.”

After that, without waiting for Lei Tie to speak, he said in a casual tone, “It’s heard that State Defender Duke does not only have a good wife [?], but also a pair of lovely young gongzis. Congratulation. But why aren’t they here?”

As soon as these words came out, Lei Tie understood that the Emperor had a basic understanding of his affairs. He could perceive that Eunuch Li was deliberately hinting at him. He nodded to Eunuch Li and accepted his affection.

Eunuch Li’s smiling mood was slightly concentrated. *The State Defender Duke is now a new nobility in the Capital. It’s only good to make friends with him.*

“Uncle Fu, go to the entrance and see if the Little Master and the Little Young Masters are back.”

“Yes, Eldest Master.”

As soon as Qin Mian, who was upstairs, heard Lei Tie’s words, he picked up Yuanyuan and Manman, flew out of the floor-to-ceiling window, landed outside the wall, and walked toward home.

Lei Tie invited Eunuch Li to take a seat. “Eunuch Li, there are many trivial matters at home that will take some time to arrange for. Did His Majesty ever mention a deadline?”

Eunuch Li said with a smile, “His Majesty only said that the sooner the better. State Defender Duke doesn’t have to worry too much. After all, to settle down in the Capital, one would better arrange everything properly.”

Lei Tie said, “So then, trouble Eunuch Li to wait for some time. Does Eunuch Li want to live in Double Xiang House or the summer mountain villa?”

Eunuch Li answered, “Just live in Qilin Summer Mountain Villa. This inferior one truly likes the scenery of this mountain village.”

As they spoke, Qin Mian led Yuanyuan and Manman into the room and paid respect to Eunuch Li with his hands cupped in obeisance.

Eunuch Li attentively looked Qin Mian up and down and secretly thought: it's no wonder. Then, he sized up Yuanyuan and Manman and immediately was very fond of them. He took out a pair of jade pendants from his sleeve and gave it to Yuanyuan and Manman as a meeting gift.

Qin Mian understood that settling down in the Capital, for the time being, was irreversible and these social exchanges were inevitable. He nodded to Yuanyuan and Manman.

Yuanyuan and Manman softly thanked Eunuch Li and accepted the jade pendants.

Eunuch Li secretly praised the upbringing of the two children.

Qin Mian ordered Uncle Fu to take Eunuch Li and the others to Qilin Summer Mountain Villa.

Eunuch Li let Lei Xiangzhi stayed with good consideration.

After Eunuch Li and his party left, Qin Mian and Lei Tie sent the villagers away and asked Aunt Fu to take Yuanyuan and Manman out. Only then they talked to Lei Xiangzhi.

Lei Xiangzhi congratulated Lei Tie with a smile, "Eldest Brother, congratulations! Today, it's the first time I know that Eldest Brother has another name called 'Lei Tianren'."

Qin Mian said, "'Lei Tianren' was a name given to your Eldest Brother by his master. We'll talk about it later. Fifth Brother, tell us first, what actually happened? Why would the Emperor suddenly resume your Eldest Brother's official position and even make him the State Defender Duke?"

Lei Xiangzhi gave a bitter smile and completely bewildered, "I'm also confused about this matter. Half a month ago, I suddenly received the Emperor's order, commanding me to lead Eunuch Li the way back to

Running Water Town of Zhaoyang County to pass a decree to General Lei Tianren. At that time, I didn't think that Lei Tianren was Eldest Brother. I thought that Grand General Lei happened to live in seclusion near Running Water Town. In fact, I didn't know that Eldest Brother was Lei Tianren until Eunuch Li paid respect to him on the mountain." His mood at this time was no less complicated than Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Worried that he bore some thoughts, Qin Mian explained, "Your Eldest Brother's affairs during those years had been very complicated. In a word, he had many unhappy memories of being an official that he didn't want to mention again. I hope Fifth Brother doesn't mind."

Lei Xiangzhi hastily said, "Eldest Sister-in-law underestimated me. I can understand. Eldest Brother certainly has his reasons."

Knowing that Qin Mian and Lei Tie must have a lot to say, he got up and took his leave, "Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, I'll go visit Third Brother and Fourth Brother first."

Lei Tie nodded.

After Lei Xiangzhi left, Qin Mian hugged Lei Tie's waist and gave him a comforting kiss on the lips. "A-Tie, don't think too much. We'll figure it out when we reach the Capital. It may not be impossible to resign again."

Lei Tie gently shook his head. He lifted Qin Mian, embraced him into his arms, and faintly said, "Wife, as long as you and the children are there, I don't care about other things. I've long been indifferent to the things of the past. Now, it's no different for me whether I live in the Capital or not. I just worry that you and the children are not used to it. *The water in the Capital is very deep.*"

Qin Mian could feel that Lei Tie didn't say it just to appease him, so he let go of his worry. "I didn't think about moving to the Capital before. I thought that I would have to wait until Yuanyuan and Manman take the imperial examination to enter the Capital again. Now I think it's fine to move to the Capital. We've been in Green Mountain Village for so many years, so it's good to go out for a change of air. Yuanyuan and Manman are

growing bigger and bigger. It's time they go out and see the world. As for the complexity of the Capital, I believe that with my mind and your ability, our family will be able to stay together."

Lei Tie inexplicably felt that Qin Mian's body had a whiff sense of fighting excitement. The corners of his lips gently perked up, "As long as you don't feel aggrieved, if we have to go to the Capital, then so be it. I'll protect you and the children."

Note:

Footnotes

1. A prestige title for rank 3 to 2 military officers, especially used to rank members of the Imperial Clan (note that the Emperor went out of his way to confer this title).
2. Ancient emperors gave meritorious officials a certificate to enjoy preferential treatment or immunity from crime for generations. It was a sheet of iron, a certificate wrote with cinnabar.

Chapter 168: Into the Capital

168 – Into the Capital

Everything was decided like such.

The Emperor ordered Eunuch Li to escort Lei Tie *and* his family back to the Capital, apparently to prevent Lei Tie from leaving his family in Green Mountain Village. Thinking of this, Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't have much time to delay. They asked the servants to call the persons-in-charge of their several workshops and shops.

This hometown was the headquarters of Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They had no intention of giving it up. The bakery, restaurant, and Double Xiang House were still handed over to the current persons-in-charge. In order to encourage the three persons-in-charge to work harder, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had decided after a discussion to give them 10% of the profits of the stores they were responsible for.

Leisurely Farmhouse and Qilin Summer Mountain Villa were taken care of by Uncle Quan. Uncle Quan was to be the steward of their old home and responsible for everything. Lei Dahe was in charge of the winery, Lei Dashan was in charge of the vermicelli workshop, and Lei Dashu was in charge of the fermented tofu workshop. Uncle Quan's monthly salary was raised to 5 taels of silver, while Lei Dahe, Lei Dashan, and Lei Dashu's monthly salary were raised to 1 tael of silver. For the rest of the servants, the monthly salary of the third-class was increased by 50 Wen, that of the second-class by 100 Wen, and that of the first-class by 150 Wen.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie wanted to bring Uncle Fu, Aunt Fu, Lei-Qin Le, Lei-Qin Le's wife, and the nine armed servants to the Capital. After all, they

also needed confidants in the Capital. The rest of the servants stayed in Green Mountain Village.

It took Qin Mian and Lei Tie five days to settle everything in their home.

When it was time to leave, the whole family was very reluctant. Leisurely Farmhouse was built by Qin Mian and Lei Tie, where every place had their footprints and was full of their memories. Yuanyuan and Manman were also reluctant to leave. The home in the Capital would not be as full of fruit trees and flowers as their home in Green Mountain Village, let alone a unique amusement park.

The family of four took a last stroll in Leisurely Farmhouse. Lei Tie entrusted Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, and Li Zheng to take care of the house/family. The family got on the carriage and set off for the Capital. They brought a lot of special local products, so there were seven carriages in total.

Almost all the people in the village came out to see them off. They watched the carriages go up the mountain along the village road and disappear after climbing over the mountain slope.

It was impossible for Golden Fur and White Spot to like and get used to the life in the Capital. Qin Mian, Yuanyuan, and Manman could only bear the pain to leave them very reluctantly.

White Spot and Golden Fur seemed to know that they would be separated from the four masters for a long time; they looked very sullen. They sent the family all the way to the town and were driven back by Qin Mian.

Leaning on the window, looking at White Spot and Golden Fur's figures gradually disappeared, Yuanyuan and Manman started to cry out, almost out of breath as tears rolled down their faces.

“Golden Fur—White Spot—”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie couldn't coax them for a long time. The two little boys cried until they were tired and fell asleep.

The next day after departure, Lei Xiangzhi came to Qin Mian and Lei Tie's carriage to inform them of the situation in the Capital, especially the forces in the officialdom. However, Lei Xiangzhi was only a sixth rank official now; he did not qualify to attend the Imperial Court. He only knew something about it.

The day before entering the Capital, Eunuch Li spurred his horse next to their carriage and chatted with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Only then Qin Mian and Lei Tie had a general understanding of the Imperial Court.

After entering the Capital, with so many new things there were, Yuanyuan and Manman had temporarily pressed their yearning for White Spot and Golden Fur to the bottom of their hearts.

Eunuch Li came to their carriage and said, "State Defender Duke, the State Defender Duke Establishment is in Chong'en Street ahead of us. Almost all the people living in this street are first-class nobility and ministers. It's not far from the Imperial Palace. It's convenient for State Defender Duke to attend Imperial Court in the future. This inferior one first sends everyone back to the establishment to wash up, and then into the Imperial Palace to see His Majesty."

"Thank you, Eunuch Li." Lei Tie nodded to him as a signal.

"State Defender Duke is welcome."

Chong'en Street was clean and spacious. It could accommodate four to five carriages. The carriage moved and stopped after about two quarters [of an hour].

Lei Tie got off the carriage first and carried Yuanyuan and Manman down. Qin Mian got off the carriage last.

In front of the compound of connecting courtyards, above the vermillion gate hung an impressive plaque of "State Defender Duke Establishment". The gate was open wide. A short-bearded man ran out from inside with a smile and bowed to Lei Tie and Qin Mian.

“This servant is Chen Fu, sent by Commandery Prince¹ Mu to take care of the State Defender Duke Establishment. This servant greets the State Defender Duke and the Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

Qin Mian’s countenance betrayed nothing. He had been called “wife” and “sister-in-law” for so many years. It was no big deal to be called “lady”.

“Forego the formalities. Commandery Prince Mu is?” Qin Mian thought of Mu Chen. *The Imperial Household’s surname is Chen. If Commandery Prince Mu is indeed Mu Chen, then Mu Chen’s real name may be Chen Mufeng.*

Sure enough, neither servile nor overbearing, Chen Fu said, “Answering to the Lady of the State Defender Duke; our Commandery Prince’s respected name is Chen Mufeng. The Commandery Prince said that when the State Defender Duke and the Lady of the State Defender Duke have settled down, he will invite the both of you to a meal and make amends.”

“Commandery Prince Mu has been thoughtful.” Lei Tie said, “My wife and I will pay him a visit some other day.”

“Yes, this servant will relay it to the Commandery Prince.”

Eunuch Li was still waiting, so they didn’t say much. Chen Fu brought them in.

There were many servants in the yard; who knew where they came from. Some were sweeping the floor, some were pruning sprigs, some were watering flowers.....

Chen Fu led them to the washroom and left.

The family of four took a bath and changed into clean clothes.

Lei Tie had been reinstated to his official post. The official uniform was the principal uniform when one had an audience with the Emperor. He wore the official uniform of the Defender Grand General of the State. His black

military uniform made him even taller and straighter, looking majestic with a compelling aura.

Qin Mian wore a black short unlined garment, a light blue wide belt around his waist, a vest of the same color on the outside, a pair of black slim-fit trousers on the bottom, and a pair of light tan ankle boots on the feet. His long hair was set free. He looked bright and brave in the manner of delicate beauty.

The two men measured each other. Unconsciously, they were somehow completely absorbed in seeing each other.

Yuanyuan and Manman's hair had reached the shoulders. The top of their heads was arranged in a sheep's horn braid. They each wore a lavender robe and a belt with an exquisite embroidered pouch on the left side and a white jade ornament on the right side – such a good pair of golden boys with graceful bearing. They looked at Lei Tie with eyes filled in admiration as a child would its parent.

Eunuch Li coughed softly, and the four of them came to their senses. Eunuch Li crammed them with the basic protocol of having an audience with the Emperor. What he didn't know was that Lei Tie had taught Qin Mian, Yuanyuan, and Manman at home. Never judge Lei Tie who usually didn't talk much. He was actually very careful. He quietly protected the people he cared about in his own way.

The foursome got into the carriage. The carriage drove steadily toward the Palace and stopped at the main entrance of the Palace, namely, the South Gate's entrance.

There were three gateways in the South Gate: one main gate and two side gates. The foursome got out of the carriage, followed Eunuch Li through the east side gate, walked along the winding corridor of the Palace for a long time, and stopped at the Brilliant Palace where the Emperor resided.

Eunuch Li smilingly said, "State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke, after walking for such a long time, the two little gongzis

must be tired. The four of you can go there to have a rest for a while. This inferior one will go and report to His Majesty first.”

Inwardly, Qin Mian and Lei Tie knew that Eunuch Li must first report to the Emperor what he had learned along the way.

“Please go ahead, Eunuch Li.”

Lei Tie put Yuanyuan and Manman down. Qin Mian fixed their attires. He had been worried that they would be scared, but he saw them standing upright with clear and bright eyes. They only appeared curious and not in the least fear, proving themselves to be his and Lei Tie’s sons.

Lei Tie held Qin Mian’s hand and looked at him with concern.

Qin Mian returned with a smile to express that he was fine.

Eunuch Li walked carefully into the palace hall.

Emperor Xiaohui sat behind the imperial table, reading over the memorial to the throne.

“Your servant pays respect to His Majesty.”

Emperor Xiaohui glanced at him, then quickly wrote a few words before he put down the imperial brush, folded the memorial, and put it on the pile to the right.

“Return quite early. Rise. ”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty.”

Emperor Xiaohui asked, “What about State Defender Duke?”

Without concealing anything, Eunuch Li narrated everything from the moment he met Lei Tie.

Emperor Xiaohui asked with interest, “Is Green Mountain Village, Leisurely Farmhouse, and Qilin Summer Mountain Villa really like a

fairyland on earth? If so, isn't it better than Zhen's Imperial Palace?"

One might well say that this last sentence was a criticism, but Eunuch Li did not panic. He had been serving Emperor Xiaohui for so many years; he knew when to tell lies and when to tell the truth.

"It can't be compared with Your Majesty's Imperial Palace. Green Mountain Village, Leisurely Farmhouse, and Qilin Summer Mountain Villa are not noble-spirited [low class]. However, their charms lie in nature and novelty. One can pick flowers in every three steps and fruits in every five steps. On top of that, there is a wide expanse of verdant wheat fields. Spring is evident everywhere; truly interesting."

Emperor Xiaohui didn't get angry. He nodded slightly and said in a gentle tone, "Listening to you—a servant—saying so, Zhen is interested to go and have a look."

Eunuch Li smilingly said, "Reporting to Your Majesty: the youngest Lei-Daren hadn't been to his hometown for three years, and this time back to Green Mountain Village, he was very emotional. On the way, your servant heard that he had made a painting of the 'Land of Peach Blossoms'. Now, it's half-finished."

Emperor Xiaohui nodded with satisfaction, "When he finished the painting, have him present it [to the Emperor]."

"Yes."

Emperor Xiaohui again said, "Announce them in. Zhen wants to see what kind of person can conquer my Grand General."

The palace hall was deep and quiet. The order from the Emperor was passed down to the palace maids until the palace attendant standing at the gate of Brilliant Palace, who then called out, "Announcing the present of State Defender Duke and his family—"

Lei Tie and Qin Mian walked into the hall carrying Yuanyuan and Manman. Their eyes drooped as they walked forward at an appropriate speed.

Sat in the dragon chair, Emperor Xiaohui looked at Lei Tie as they approached. When his eyes swept over the scar on Lei Tie's face, a trace of displeasure flew away from his eyes. Then, his eyes fell on the young man beside Lei Tie. His sharp eyes flashed, looking pensive. Lei Tie, dressed in his official uniform, looked extensively might and sternly fierce. However, Qin Mian, an ordinary rural man, who stood beside him, was not only not affected by this kind of grandeur in the slightest, but his attire also vaguely conformed well with Lei Tie. From a high point of view, their figures were harmonious and connected at a deep level with each other. It could be deduced that this young man was not so simple. It was no wonder that he caught the eyes of this cold-hearted general.

Emperor Xiaohui's eyes were also attracted to the two little boys. He looked at their facial features carefully. He inadvertently gave the two pairs of big curious eyes a wee smile and got two lovely smiles in return. The smile on his lips then turned deeper.

Qin Mian's family stopped five or six steps away from the altar and knelt together.

"Your humble subject/This commoner greets Your Majesty the Emperor. Long live Your Majesty, absolutely long live!"

"Rise."

"Many thanks, Your Majesty."

Emperor Xiaohui said, "Li Fushou, give seats to the State Defender Duke and his family."

"Yes."

If you can't do anything to prevent it, you might as well sit back and enjoy it. Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat down in the armchairs brought by the attendants. Yuanyuan and Manman were given brocade stools. Upon seeing their fathers sat down, the two little boys also calmly sat down.

Emperor Xiaohui's eyes flashed a ghost of a smile, and he looked at Lei Tie.

“Hope that State Defender Duke is well? Replying while sitting is fine.”

Lei Tie cupped his hands and said, “Living in the mountains and plains for a long time, [I’m] carefree and contented. How is Your Majesty?”

Emperor Xiaohui was glad for his second sentence. He didn't try to figure out whether the previous sentence had a different meaning. Guilt shown in his eyes, “Your face... Zhen will order the Imperial Institute of Medicine to prescribe some good medicine for you.”

Lei Tie said, “Thanks to His Majesty's care, but your humble subject would like to keep this scar.”

“Oh?” Emperor Xiaohui smiled faintly, too profound to be understood, “Why is that?”

Lei Tie lightly said, “This scar can block many troubles.”

Emperor Xiaohui gave him a meaningful look and looked at Qin Mian.

“It's heard that Qin-gongzi has good medical skills. The accidental poisoning of State Defender Duke's younger brother was solved by Qin-gongzi.”

“Qin-gongzi?” There was a haze floating in Lei Tie's eyes.

Footnotes

1. Jun Wang –a high title of nobility, ordinarily prefixed with a place-name designating the noble's real or nominal fief; normally granted to sons of Imperial Princes (Qin Wang) by their principal wives, except for the eldest son; a prince of the 2nd degree. –Hucker

Chapter 169: First Rank Mandated Lady

169 – First Rank Mandated Lady

Qin Mian got up to reply, “Answering to Your Majesty: yes.”

Lei Tie also stood up and stood side by side with Qin Mian. Yuanyuan and Manman followed to stand up.

Emperor Xiaohui gazed at Lei Tie for a moment with cryptic eyes as he renewed Qin Mian’s importance in his [LT’s] heart. He said in a light voice, “All sit while replying. There’s no need to be nervous. We’re just talking casually like ordinary people.”

Qin Mian and the others sat down again.

Emperor Xiaohui took a sip of tea and said slowly, “Zhen always feels a little tired recently. Zhen wonders if Qin-gongzi can diagnose Zhen.”

Eunuch Li’s face changed and he whispered, “Your Majesty?” *When one does a diagnose, one has to get close to the body. It’s too risky for Your Majesty to allow people [we] aren’t familiar with to approach.*

Emperor Xiaohui glanced at him fiercely. Eunuch Li bowed his head in revere and no longer spoke.

Lei Tie, seemingly unaware of it, said to Qin Mian, “Wife, I’ve been away from His Majesty for many years; I’m worried about His Majesty’s imperial body. Why don’t you take His Majesty’s pulse by hanging a thread?”

When the two looked at each other, their intentions interlinked. One must know, an attack was the best defense. Since they entered the Palace, they had stepped into the deep water of the Capital. Only by properly showing some advantages could they better protect their family. Blindly hiding strength would only make people think that they were weak and could be deceived.

“Qin-gongzi can even take a pulse by hanging a thread?” Emperor Xiaohui was surprised; his dim eyes were full of doubt. “Zhen heard that many years ago, there were doctors with excellent skills who could do this. But now, almost no one in Zhen’s Imperial Institute of Medicine has such skill.”

Qin Mian didn’t argue. His respectful smile exuded a confident and happy look. “It’s better if Your Majesty calls an ill attendant to let this commoner have a try.”

Emperor Xiaohui cast a look at Eunuch Li.

Eunuch Li quickly called a junior eunuch.

Emperor Xiaohui asked him to write down his experiences [of illness] on the paper. He noticed that Yuanyuan and Manman feel tired and spiritless. When he remembered that they had been on the road for more than ten days, he had some pity on them. He told Eunuch Li to prepare some snacks, fruits, and drinks that children like to eat. Fruit juices and other drinks had already spread to the Capital, but the fruity taste might not be as good as Leisurely Farmhouse’s.

Cautiously without any noise, two attendants brought a small round table and put it in front of Yuanyuan and Manman. The palace maids put snacks, fruits, and juices on the table.

Yuanyuan and Manman stood up, cupped their hands, and showed a pure smile to Emperor Xiaohui, “Thank you, Uncle Emperor.”

Qin Mian was secretly shocked and looked at Emperor Xiaohui without leaving any trace.

Lei Tie's aura was slightly cold.

After Emperor Xiaohui was taken aback, he laughed and waved his hand to them. "Being called by Yuanyuan and Manman as such, Zhen suddenly felt that Zhen was a teenager. Yuanyuan and Manman, if you like to eat them, Zhen will ask the Imperial Kitchen to make more for you to take home."

"Many thanks, Uncle Emperor." Yuanyuan and Manman thanked him again and each picked a piece of pastry to give Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian gave a little smile and said in a soft voice, "You two eat; your Old Dad and I are not hungry."

Yuanyuan and Manman ate by themselves.

Emperor Xiaohui saw that all four of them did not doubt if there was something wrong with the pastry; the smile in his eyes became a little more real.

When the junior eunuch finished writing, Eunuch Li tied a piece of thread to his wrist and handed the thread to Qin Mian.

Emperor Xiaohui and Eunuch Li then attentively stared at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian straightened the thread and put his fingers on it.

There was no worry on Lei Tie's face; Yuanyuan and Manman ate the snacks with ease.

Qin Mian immersed in sensing it and said with confidence, "Reporting to Your Majesty: this junior eunuch should have been caught in the wind the night before yesterday. At this time, his body is weak, his mind is bleak, the inside of his mouth is tasteless, and he has slight nausea. He only needs to drink two doses of medicine to recover completely."

Emperor Xiaohui took a close look at the paper on the desk and almost all of it was on point. He praised, "Good! It seems that those old beans in the Imperial Institute of Medicine should have a proper review of themselves."

He didn't ask Qin Mian to feel his pulse again. An Emperor would not easily let people he did not trust know his physical condition. Qin Mian naturally would not mention it with unknown interest.

Emperor Xiaohui put down his concern for Qin Mian and beckoned Yuanyuan and Manman, "Yuanyuan and Manman, come to Uncle Emperor."

When Yuanyuan and Manman got the nod of their Old Dad's approval, they ran up the steps and came to the dragon chair.

Emperor Xiaohui held one boy in each arm and asked them with a smile how old they were, whether they could read, what they usually liked to do, and what they liked to eat. Seeing that they were not afraid of him as others were, he was happy and liked them even more.

Yuanyuan and Manman were purely simple and honest, but also inherently intelligent. Occasionally, they came out with a few words of a child daring to do great mischief, which forced Emperor Xiaohui to burst into hearty laughter.

Emperor Xiaohui had a steelyard in his heart¹. Qin Mian and Lei Tie should not know what questions he wanted to ask in advance; they couldn't have taught Yuanyuan and Manman how to answer in advance. Yuanyuan and Manman's answers could only come from their consciences, so he believed they were pure and lovable.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie became supporting roles instead.

Eunuch Li had his head drooped while his eyes filled with surprise. It was the first time that he saw the Emperor was on intimate terms with children. Once again, he affirmed in his heart that the Defender State Duke was truly worthy of his reputation as the new noble in the Capital.

About two or three moments later, Emperor Xiaohui asked Qin Mian's group of people to kneel in peace².

“State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke, when you have time, often bring Yuanyuan and Manman into the Palace to see Zhen. Are Yuanyuan and Manman willing?”

Yuanyuan did not speak, only nodded.

Manman grinningly said, “Gege and I will also bring snacks for Uncle Emperor.”

Qin Mian inwardly sweated.

“Hahaha... Alright!” Emperor Xiaohui laughed out loud. “You all kneel in peace. State Defender Duke has just returned to the Capital; Zhen will give you three days off-duty.”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty. Your subject asks for leave to withdraw.”

Eunuch Li arranged a junior eunuch to send off Qin Mian’s family to the Palace’s entrance.

In the carriage, Qin Mian looked at Yuanyuan and Manman, worried. As the saying went, to be in the king’s company was tantamount to living with a tiger. Yet, he couldn’t directly ask Yuanyuan and Manman whether they like the Emperor or not, let alone ask them to guard against the Emperor. Once the two children showed their guarded stance in front of Emperor Xiaohui, something that priorly would not happen *would* happen.

Lei Tie took his hand and appeased him, “Wife, don’t worry. Yuanyuan and Manman can feel who is really good to them. They are smarter than we know.”

Qin Mian thought of the words “one’s conscience” and laughed with relief. He and Lei Tie had always been forward and positive in their education of Yuanyuan and Manman. He should believe in Yuanyuan and Manman, for no reason at all. The two children were not likely to say offensive words – it was better to let nature take its course. Even if something happened, he and Lei Tie could hold up a sky for the two children³.

“I understand.”

Lei Tie gently kissed his eyebrows. His indifferent voice contained reassuring power, “You and the children can do whatever you all feel happy about. Leave the rest to me.”

“Alright!” Qin Mian raised a natural and unrestrained smile, “We want to live in the Capital as happy and comfortable as when we were in Green Mountain Village!”

As the two communicated, the two little boys –who knew when– had fallen asleep in the swaying of the carriage.

The carriage stopped at the entrance of the State Defender Duke Establishment. Uncle Fu and Chen Fu came out together. Although Chen Fu only came to help temporarily, he was as considerate as a real steward, which was clearly because of his master’s instruction. Qin Mian noted Chen Mufeng’s friendship in his heart.

Chen Fu led them to the main courtyard of the inner chambers. Lei Tie put the soundly asleep Yuanyuan and Manman on the bed and was pulled by Qin Mian to have Chen Fu and Aunt Fu show them around their new home.

The State Defender Duke Establishment was located in the north and faced the south, covering an area of about 100 mu. The whole compound had pavilions, terraces, and open halls – richly ornamented buildings in ancient styles. After entering from the front gate was the foreyard. The council office, reception room, storehouse, and stable were all in the foreyard. There were a small garden and a large-scale training ground in the yard. The opposite buildings on the left and right of the front gate were the gatekeeper’s residence and the servants’ residence. Passing through the training ground was a festooned gate.

The festooned gate was the only passage between the inner chambers and the outer courtyard.

After the festooned gate was the inner chambers. The winding corridors on both sides surrounded three courtyards: the main courtyard, the east

courtyard, and the west courtyard. The main courtyard covered the largest area, with a garden and a small training ground. It was unknown if Emperor Xiaohui gave this house to Lei Tie because of his military officer status. For the Qin Mian family with a relatively small population, this kind of house was just the right size. The main courtyard was Qin Mian and Lei Tie's residence; after Yuanyuan and Manman had grown up, they could live in the east courtyard and the west courtyard respectively.

The most praiseworthy thing was that the furniture in the house was complete. Qin Mian hardly needed to worry about it. If he felt something was inadequate, he would just change it.

In the back of the inner chambers, there was a small courtyard with a row of rear-covered buildings⁴. The open space in the courtyard was not small.

As Qin Mian strolled around with Lei Tie, he also excitedly talked to him about the plan of redesigning the State Defender Duke Establishment. Concerning Qin Mian's plan to open up a vegetable plot in the third courtyard they entered, Lei Tie's expression didn't change as he nodded in agreement and chimed in. Chen Fu's footing stumbled.

Just as they were about to ask Chen Fu what was the matter with those servants, the manservant came to report that there was an imperial edict.

The few people quickly went back to the main hall of the foreyard. Chen Fu told the servants to quickly set up the incense altar.

Qin Mian mulled to himself what the hell Emperor Xiaohui was doing. In a short of a month, he gave them three imperial edicts. In certain parts of the Capital, he feared that some storms had brewed.

Noticing Lei Tie's thoughtful expression, he asked, "A-Tie, do you know what's going on?"

Lei Tie asked, "Wife, do you know that the mother or wife of the first to fifth rank officials will be granted an imperial mandate if there is no unforeseen event?"

Qin Mian's steps paused, and his mouth twitched. "Do you mean that this imperial edict is to confer upon me the First Rank Mandated Lady?"⁵ If so, he must reassess Emperor Xiaohui.

Lei Tie nodded.

There was no time for them to say more. The messenger of the imperial edict had already come in. Indeed, it was the imperial edict to confer upon Qin Mian as the First Rank Mandated Lady. Along with the imperial edict, there was a red Mandated Order Document in the shape of a scroll with jade shafts and a set of the First Rank Mandated Lady's dress and personal adornment.

Footnotes

1. As the Chinese take no coin but gold and silver by weight, they [merchant] carry with them a small steelyard, by which they weigh those metals taken in exchange. In other words, the Emperor was very calculative in every sense.
2. It's a euphemism for the Emperor to ask people to leave.
3. It means to protect them.
4. It is a row of courtyard houses with a fully enclosed courtyard behind and parallels to the main courtyard. This is where the concubines live
5. A lady with an honorary title conferred by imperial mandate.

Chapter 170: Settle Down

170 – Settle Down

Lei Tie ordered Uncle Fu to give a reward to the messengers and asked him to send people out.

Chen Fu retreated outside the door and waited for orders.

As a modern transmigrator, Qin Mian was very interested in the “historical” commodities such as imperial edicts and imperial mandate document. Seeing that there were no outsiders in the room, he opened the imperial mandate document and found that the words “Lei-Qin Shi”¹ and “First Rank Mandated Lady” were written in neat traditional Chinese characters along with the date of the year and a bright red seal at the very bottom.

He looked again at the Mandated Lady’s clothes neatly stacked in the wooden tray. On the topmost was the crown. To be exact, it was a headband made of bluish-green jade inlaid with gold and adorned with a blue gem in the middle. Owing to the design being simple, elegant, and stylish, it wouldn’t make people feel tacky. He shook open the Mandated Lady’s clothes and felt relieved that Emperor Xiaohui was not bad; at least the Emperor didn’t give him a woman’s dress on purpose. The indigo-almost-black brocade long robe was tailored with first-grade cloud-brocade. Its wrought surface was suffused with radiance. The front chest was embroidered with an ethereal cloud pattern and flying phoenix pattern. The corners of the robe were crisscrossed with gold thread, showing a sense of solemnity and seriousness. There was also a matching wide belt.

The comparison between Qin Mian’s ordinary clothes and this Mandated Lady’s clothes was akin to the difference between casual wear and a Western-style suit.

Even Lei Tie couldn't help but praise, "Not bad. Wife, have a try?"

Qin Mian glanced sideways at him and directly put on the Mandated Lady's clothes. In the past, he used to dress mostly based on the principle of comfort, giving himself the perception that was more like a soft and moist jade. Now, he was more like a gem that was brilliantly dazzling, honorable, and elegant.

Lei Tie only found that there was a light in front of his eyes². His gaze burned hot. He walked two steps closer and tied the belt for Qin Mian.

When Qin Mian was encircled by Lei Tie's arms, his cheek was pressed by two warm lips and munched for a few breaths before they retreated. Qin Mian raised his eyes and his gaze intertwined with Lei Tie. For quite a long time, they didn't shift away.

Lei Tie freed Qin Mian's long hair, then pulled it up again, and bound it up with the new headband.

Qin Mian softly coughed, breaking the ambiguous atmosphere, "How do I look?"

"Very good-looking," said Lei Tie in earnest.

Qin Mian rubbed his cheek, turned his back to Lei Tie, and quickly took off the clothes. It was because he had a hunch that if he didn't take it off quickly, Lei Tie would take it off for him and take off more than that.

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian's back regretfully and said to himself that he was not in a hurry. The fire in his body gradually cooled down.

Qin Mian returned to him and sat down, "A-Tie, let's talk about the big issue. Look at the elaborate and fine workmanship of this headband and set of clothes. It should take at least five to six days from designing until they take form. From this, we can see that this set of clothes was made in advance. But why didn't His Majesty issue the third edict when he issued the first and second edicts, instead of waiting until now? It made me feel like he made up his mind after he had seen me."

At this mention, he squinted at Lei Tie and said in a sour tone, “Why should he? It’s like if I didn’t pass his test there, I wasn’t worthy to be with—”

Lei Tie abruptly kissed Qin Mian’s lips, blocking up his last word. He sucked hard and then let go, gazing deeply into Qin Mian’s eyes, “Worthy or not, I have the final say.”

“Toward you, is he... Hm?” Qin Mian narrowed his eyes as he interrogated.

Lei Tie pulled a wry face, “Don’t talk nonsense.”

Qin Mian couldn’t help laughing and stretched out his hand to rub the corner of Lei Tie’s rigid mouth. To be able to make Lei Tie show a wry face gave him a sense of achievement.

Lei Tie patted him on the shoulder to express that he was serious.

“Wife, the reason His Majesty suddenly started using me again is unknown. But for now, the title of First Rank Mandated Lady is good for you. The State of Great Xia is rigidly stratified. Most people dare not offend you for having titled the First Rank Mandated Lady.”

“Understood,” said Qin Mian. It was uncomfortable for a man to be officially named “Lady” by the Emperor, but he didn’t mind. Ever since the beginning of cultivating Trueness, he had gradually become a little detached of worldly affairs. He had been indifferent to many things in the secular world, and ordinary matters absolutely couldn’t stir his heart. As long as Lei Tie, Yuanyuan, and Manman were by his side, he was invincible.

He asked in a low voice, “Could it be that the frontier is going to war? Otherwise, His Majesty wouldn’t suddenly reinstate a general who had resigned for many years.”

“I also have this suspicion. I’ll find out when I have a chance.” Lei Tie comforted, “Leave this matter to me; you don’t have to worry about it.”

Qin Mian nodded. He barely had a usable connection in the Capital. Even if he wanted to worry, he had nowhere to start with. It was better to work

separately with Lei Tie.

Lei Tie went to arrange for Lei-Qin Le and the nine armed-servants. Lei-Qin Le had a sharp tongue and was experienced in handling affairs. Later, he would be Qin Mian's attendant. Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Hui, one was steady and the other was smart; they would be Lei Tie's attendants. The other seven armed-servants would still be armed-servants.

Qin Mian called Uncle Fu in. He learned that all the servants in the State Defender Duke Establishment, besides those sent by the Commandery Prince Mu, were sent by the influential officials who wanted to be on friendly terms with Lei Tie. They even sent the title deeds.

Qin Mian took care of the matter himself and gave Chen Fu 5 taels of silver as a reward and 200 Wen to each of the people sent by the Commandery Prince Mu to help, and asked Uncle Fu to send them away. Then he asked Lei-Qin Le to call a servant and sell all the remaining servants because no one could tell if anyone else had been planted as a spy. For those influential officials who sent the servants, he sent a thank-you letter and a return gift.

Henceforth, Uncle Fu was the steward of the State Defender Duke Establishment, Aunt Fu was in charge of the kitchen, and Lei-Qin Le's wife was in charge of needlework. The establishment still needed manpower. Qin Mian decided to invite a broker over to buy people after he completed the plan.

On that day, Uncle Fu and Aunt Fu led all the servants to place every baggage in its proper place. Qin Mian cooked for a family of four, while Aunt Fu and Lei-Qin Le's wife cooked for others. After having dinner, everyone had an early rest. The first day passed as such.

The next day, Qin Mian ordered Lei-Qin Shun to ask Lei Xiangzhi which school and academy were the best in the Capital. He also asked Lei-Qin Le to call in a broker to fill up the manpower in his house, such as gatekeepers, kitchen maids, and manservants who would be responsible for driving, sprinkling water and sweeping the floor, taking care of the horses, and other handiwork. Among them, the six people hired in the kitchen and the sewing room were all women. Two of them were married women and the other four

were young girls between the age of 14 and 18. All of them were ordinary in appearance and honest-looking. In other words, there were only eight women in the entire State Defender Duke Establishment.

Qin Mian wrote down the rules of the State Defender Duke Establishment for the steward to read to everyone and asked them to memorize the rules.

Besides that, Qin Mian planned to provide two study-attendants for each of the two children. If there was no unforeseen event, the four study-attendants would grow up together with Yuanyuan and Manman. Therefore, Qin Mian spent a lot of time on the selection of candidates. He visited several big brokerages in person and finally selected four boys aged between 8 and 10.

He asked Yuanyuan and Manman to name the four study-attendants.

Yuanyuan's study-attendants were called Paibing and Buzhen³, which made Qin Mian palm his forehead in speechlessness. Manman's study-attendants' names were not normal; they were called Feiyue and Liuxing⁴. Adults couldn't understand the children's thinking, but Qin Mian respected the two little boys' ideas and settled down their names.

Lei Tie put a ban on each of the four study-attendants' sea of knowledge. Once they revealed any secrets about Yuanyuan and Manman, the ban would be triggered. In the eyes of outsiders, they would appear to be in a coma for no reason and could no longer regain consciousness.

Yuanyuan and Manman now lived in the main courtyard of the backyard with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They each lived in a wing room, while their study-attendants lived in the side room of the wing room. The task of the four study-attendants was not only to study with Yuanyuan and Manman but also to get up early every day and practice with Yuanyuan and Manman. They didn't need to protect Yuanyuan and Manman, but they at least needed to be stronger, so that they wouldn't be tired even if they were just doing errands.

The second day passed by in a bustle.

In the early morning of the third day, after breakfast, Qin Mian and Lei Tie tidied up Yuanyuan and Manman. The family of four went to visit Cao

Zhongshan, the Dean of Dongyang Academy. The four study-attendants also had to enter a school, so they went together.

The most famous academies in the Capital were Xilin Academy and Dongyang Academy. Xilin Academy was famous for its strict teaching in which many gifted scholars came forth – the current Prime Minister Wen and four ministers out of the six ministries were all from Xilin Academy. Dongyang Academy was not bad either. Its academic atmosphere was relatively relaxed. Every “first” day [of the month] was a holiday and the last three days of every two months were long holidays. Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s main purpose in sending Yuanyuan and Manman to study was to enable them to learn knowledge, rather than to make them be the Number One Scholar or high-rank officials. Therefore, they preferred Dongyang Academy. The most important thing was that Dongyang Academy was not far from Chong’en Street. It was about a moment by carriage, very convenient for Yuanyuan and Manman to go to and from school.

The carriage stopped at the entrance of Cao Zhongshan’s house. Yuanyuan and Manman jumped out of the carriage by themselves. The two little boys seemed to be in the first rebellious period of their lives. They felt that they had grown up and were no longer willing to let their fathers hold their hands or pick them up and down.

Naturally, Qin Mian let them have their ways and walked leisurely behind them; Lei Tie carried the gift himself.

The four study-attendants followed Yuanyuan and Manman.

A manservant ushered them in.

Cao Zhongshan was a gray-haired old man in his early fifties. He had a serious face. After Qin Mian’s group greeted him appropriately for the first meeting, he stared at Yuanyuan and Manman without expression.

Yuanyuan and Manman were not afraid of him. They sat upright and looked back with their eyes blinking.

As long as the two children weren't impolite, Qin Mian and Lei Tie usually didn't interfere. They raised their teacups and drank the tea.

There was a moment of silence in the hall.

After a good while, Cao Zhongshan laughed like an old child. He patted them on the shoulders and asked them some questions, such as how many of the Four Books and the Five Classics⁵ they had read, whether they could read, and so on.

Yuanyuan and Manman had clear enunciation, not in the least timid.

Cao Zhongshan constantly nodded and finally told Qin Mian and Lei Tie that he would put the two children into Class 1 of Beginner Level Class. Meanwhile, the four study-attendants with no educational foundation would be in Class 3. They would begin to attend school the next day.

Qin Mian took the gift from Lei Tie after paying one year's fee. "Many thanks, Dean Cao. This is a little of our—"

Cao Zhongshan frowned, held his beard, and said coldly, "Didn't State Defender Duke and Lady inquire before coming here? This old fellow doesn't accept gifts."

Not taking it to mind, Qin Mian smiled, "Dean Cao, don't worry. These are not valuable things. They are our homegrown fruits and our homemade snacks as well as two jars of fermented tofu."

At a young age, Yuanyuan already had the demeanor of the eldest son and elder brother. He cupped his fist and said, "Why don't Grandpa Dean accept them? This student and Didi also helped to make the snacks."

Manman repeatedly nodded, "They taste sweet and salty. Grandpa Dean should like them."

"Oh?" Only then Cao Zhongshan's face softened. He said with a smile, "Fine, then I'll take them."

When they came out of Cao Zhongshan's house and got on the carriage, Qin Mian picked up the water cup on the table and put it down again. After a while, he picked it up again, looking a little anxious. When they were in Green Mountain Village, their children also went to school, but the village was their sphere of influence, everything was under their control, so there was no need to worry about it at all. However, the Capital was different. He was uneasy at the thought that the two children were not around him and Lei Tie for so long every day. He was not only worried about this aspect but also worried about.....

“Hand it over to me.” Lei Tie fully understood his concerns and held his hand tightly.

“Old Dad, what's the matter with Dad?” asked Manman with concern.

Lei Tie replied in a steady voice, “Your Dad is worried about you.”

“Worried about what?” Yuanyuan didn't understand, “Dad, don't worry. Didi and I are just going to school like before.”

Lei Tie motioned Qin Mian not to open his mouth and looked at his two sons. “Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin. You know, you are the only children who have two fathers in the entire Dongyang Academy and even the entire Capital. In the eyes of others, this is not normal. Maybe other students will make fun of you for this. Will you be scared?”

Author's Note (probably): In ancient times, a moment/quarter was about 15 minutes.

Footnotes

1. In case you forgot, Shi refers to clan/maiden name.
2. Okay, this one is like the moment in anime when someone transforms or something. It's that kind of *lighting*. ✨ ✨ ✨
3. 排兵 [pai-bing]: rows of soldiers | 布阵 [bu-zhen]: array troops for battle
4. 飞月 [fēi-yuè]: flying moon | 流星 [liú-xīng]: shooting star

5. The Four Books are The Great Learning, The Doctrine of the Mean, The Confucian Analects, and The Works of Mencius. The Five Classics are The Book of Songs, The Book of History, The Book of Changes, The Book of Rites, and The Spring and Autumn Annals.

Chapter 171: Commandery Prince Mu

171 – Commandery Prince Mu

Qin Mian's heart almost jumped to his throat. It might be cruel to say this to the children so early, but it was really a problem that two children have to face.

Yuanyuan raised his little face, disapprovingly, "Old Dad, we know we don't have a mother. We've known that since we were one-year-old."

Qin Mian was so amused that he thought to himself: Son, are you sure you're sensible when you're one-year-old?

"So what? Old Dad and Dad are so powerful. Other people can't have two fathers even if they want! We don't need a mother. It's enough to have Old Dad and Dad." Manman stuck out his small chest with a proud look.

Yuanyuan went to Qin Mian and stood on tiptoe to kiss his cheek. The small *paralyzed* face was dyed with a layer of blush, "Dad, don't worry."

Manman, unwilling to be outdone, kissed Qin Mian on the other cheek.

Qin Mian was instantly cured by his two sons. He gathered them in his arms and laughed, "Good, as expected of my sons! You remember this: if someone calls you names, you will return it with no swearwords!"

Lei Tie shook his head slightly and didn't interrupt.

"If someone hits you, hit back without being polite!" Qin Mian looked angry as if his sons had been beaten.

A smile flashed past in Lei Tie's eyes.

Yuanyuan patted his agitated Dad placatingly and said with a calm manner, "Dad knows what is 'subdue the enemy without fighting'? Rest assured."¹

"Fighting is a disgrace to the educated class." Manman waved his hand and said, "Dad knows what is 'murder a person with a borrowed knife'? Rest assured."²

The corner of Qin Mian's mouth twitched.

Lei Tie patted the two small ones' shoulders in compliment and held the big one in his arms. "I've said it: the sons are very smart."

Qin Mian was quite at a loss for a reply, but he finally laid down his worry.

Early the next morning, just after the rabbit hour began [5 AM], Qin Mian heard the sound of Lei Tie wearing clothes. He half-opened his eyes in a daze, but his brain still hadn't woken up. "A-Tie, what..."

Lei Tie leaned over him and gave him a kiss on his lips. "Sleep on. Going to Court today."

"Oh, take care..." Qin Mian obtusely remembered that Emperor Xiaohui only gave Lei Tie three days off. He hooked the man's neck and kissed him on the lips. After he wriggled into the quilt, he closed his eyes. His foot was exposed outside the quilt.

Lei Tie put it back into the quilt, finished dressing, and went to the outdoor training ground to practice two sets of boxing. Then, he went back to the washroom to bathe and change clothes, put on his court dress, and went out with his two attendants.

Qin Mian listened to his steps gradually distancing, opened his eyes, lifted the quilt, and got up. After he had washed up, practiced [martial], bathed, and changed clothes, it was already the beginning of the dragon hour [7 AM]. Afterward, he went to the two children's rooms.

Although the two children were young, they developed good living habits just like their fathers. When Qin Mian arrived, they both had gotten up, dressed, and finished washing up.

Qin Mian watched them finish practicing [martial] with the four study-attendants. After they bathed and put on clean clothes, he had breakfast with them.

By this time, the sky had already brightened.

Considering that the boys were to be raised roughly, Qin Mian only sent them to the carriage. The carriage was allocated by the Imperial Court to the State Defender Duke Establishment according to the regulations. Afterward, it was especially used to transport Yuanyuan and Manman to and from school. When passers-by saw the carriage of the State Defender Duke Establishment, they would step aside and not likely affront it. It was kind of a safeguard for Yuanyuan and Manman.

Henceforth, Lei-Qin Gong and Lei-Qin Shun were responsible for transporting the six children. It was too troublesome to go back and forth in a carriage. Therefore, Yuanyuan and Manman wouldn't go home at noon. Lei-Qin Gong and Lei-Qin Shun would send them lunch.

After seeing the carriage go away, Qin Mian turned to enter the door. Yesterday, he had written a notice to the Commandery Prince Mu Establishment to explain that he would visit today, and received a reply. When Lei Tie came back from the Court, they were going to go out.

At the beginning of the snake hour [9 AM], Lei Tie came home. He came galloping on a horse with an impressive presence. Qin Mian's eyes were full of appreciation and praise. Lei Tie still had to go to the army camp to be handed over the general-in-command of the army. After exchanging a few words with Qin Mian, Lei Tie hurriedly rode away with Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Hui. In the first part of the horse hour [11 AM], he stepped into the house again and brought back twenty tall and straight soldiers from the barracks. These twenty people were his personal guards henceforth.

Qin Mian told the manservant at the door to go to the kitchen and bring breakfast. Then he grumbled about Emperor Xiaohui, “The time of going to court is too unreasonable. Breakfast is delayed until this time.” Fortunately, Lei Tie didn’t need to eat grains, otherwise, he might write a complaint to the Palace.

Lei Tie said, “Today is mainly about the handover of the army, so it’s a little late.”

Qin Mian opened the wardrobe and picked out clothes for him. “How about you wear white, too?”

“En.” Lei Tie looked at his wife’s white robe and nodded.

Qin Mian chose a white inner garment and a white lined robe with a slanting lapel for him, in which the lapel of the lined robe was light blue and matched with a light blue belt. Lastly, he wrapped a white overcoat for the outermost layer. Within his frosty grandeur, it brought up some kinds of supernatural aura, which intensified his charm.

Aunt Fu soon brought piping hot small steamed meat-filled buns and warm soup.

Qin Mian then asked, “Is it going well in the Court?”

Lei Tie replied, “Everything seems normal.”

Qin Mian slightly frowned. Emperor Xiaohui called Lei Tie back to the Capital so suddenly, but everything in the Court was normal. Alas, he didn’t care too much. Foxes always showed their tails. It was useless to be anxious now.

When Lei Tie finished his breakfast, they rode on horses to the Commandery Prince Mu Establishment. Riding a horse was much more comfortable than riding a carriage. The streets in the Capital were spacious enough. Both of them preferred riding a horse. Lei-Qin Le followed with the big carriage they brought from their hometown, which contained gifts for Chen Mufeng.

The fact that Lei Tianren, the former General of the West Order, was appointed the Defender Grand General of the State and the State Defender Duke had spread all over the Capital. And Qin Mian, who was appointed as the First Rank Mandated Lady by the Emperor, had also attracted much attention. The two men were watched by innumerable pairs of eyes as they rode on horsebacks down the street, but they still kept a straight face. They calmly arrived at the Commandery Prince Mu Establishment.

Chen Mufeng was the eldest son to the principal wife of Chen Guangming, the younger brother of Emperor Xiaohui of the same parents. Chen Guangming was granted the title of Imperial Prince Ming by Emperor Xiaohui. Chen Mufeng fully deserved the title of Heir of the Imperial Prince. His status had been very noble. Later, he was granted the title of Commandery Prince by Emperor Xiaohui along with an official residence. It was thus clear that Emperor Xiaohui and Chen Guangming were very close.

This was also the reason why when Mu Chen showed his token of authority to Lei Tie, Lei Tie believed Mu Chen's power was strong enough. Although he did not see the token wholly back then, he recognized the unique signet of the Imperial Clan.

The middle gate of the Commandery Prince Mu Establishment was wide open. Chen Fu—who knew how long—waited at the entrance. He respectfully invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie into the establishment.

When Chen Mufeng received the news, he welcomed them with a laugh. His eyes swept over Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Lei-Qin Le, and Lei-Qin Zhong. He cupped his hands and said, “Hope that State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke are well? Anyway, both of you are the first rank; isn't it too shabby to take only two attendants while out? There're many people in the Capital waiting to see you make a fool of yourselves.”

As he said this, he invited Qin Mian and Lei Tie inside.

Chen Mufeng was Qin Mian and Lei Tie's friend, but also Emperor Xiaohui's nephew. Qin Mian evaded serious matters and took up trifles,

“It’s not like you don’t know that A-Tie and I are used to be casual and not used to travel in great style.”

Lei Tie said, “Thank you for your hospitality. I hope my wife and I won’t cause you any trouble.” Lei Tie was now in command of the army, which included 30000 soldiers in the front army, 30000 soldiers in the middle army, and 30000 soldiers in the rear army. He was the commander-in-chief with the largest number of generals. No matter who he was close to, he might arouse the Emperor’s suspicion, even if Chen Mufeng was the Emperor’s nephew.

Chen Mufeng motioned his servants to step aside and poured tea for them in person. “Won’t be any. His Majesty knows that I’ve known you since I was in Zhaoyang County. No need to be guarded to talk about our old relationship.” He looked at Lei Tie and said with a smile, “Back then, I felt that State Defender Duke was extraordinary, unlike ordinary man, but I didn’t expect that you were the famous General Lei Tianren. Looking back, my father used to tell me stories about Lei Tianren’s three defeats of Western Barbarian, and I could recite them all the time.” Chen Mufeng was four years younger than Lei Tie. Lei Tianren entered the army at the age of 16 and became famous at the age of 17. At that time, Chen Mufeng was only a medium-sized boy.

Lei Tie lightly said, “The past is dead.”

Chen Mufeng only heard that the scar on Lei Tie’s face had something to do with the Imperial Family. Naturally, he changed the topic and raised his teacup. In his words, he joked, “I had no choice but to hide my identity back then. State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke, please don’t take offense.”

Qin Mian shook his head and proposed a toast. “Commandery Prince Mu overstated. We haven’t thanked you for sending people to clean up the State Defender Duke Establishment. If it were not for Chen Fu, we would be very busy when we first entered the Capital. Many thanks!”

“It’s not worth mentioning.” Chen Mufeng broke the spell first, “Come on, when there is no outsider, we should call each other by names, otherwise, it

sounds really awkward. With you in the Capital... there will be a lot of excitement in the future. You should take care of yourselves, especially Lei Tie. On the drill ground, the blade of the sword is blind. You should be more careful when you conduct the drill.”

Qin Mian’s eyes glinted sharply.

“Thank you for your concern.” Lei Tie made obeisance to Chen Mufeng calmly.

After that, they only talked about some interesting things about other people.

At noon, Qin Mian and Lei Tie had lunch in the Commandery Prince Mu Establishment before they left. In addition to Emperor Xiaohui, there must be other people who knew that Chen Mufeng and they had known each other for a long time. If they left without having lunch, some people might think they were being sneaky. It was better to be poised and open.

They chatted while riding the brown and black horses.

“A-Tie, I remember that the Commandery Prince Mu is four years younger than you. This year, he should be 26. Why do I see that his house is quite empty?”

“He’s like us.”

“Hah?” After Qin Mian was taken aback, he said with a smile, “How did you know? Did you gossip with other people?”

Lei Tie lightly coughed and helplessly glanced at him, “Overheard.”

“What happened?” Qin Mian asked curiously. He pulled the reins and the brown horse was almost close to the black horse.

Lei Tie was not used to gossiping, but when his wife asked, he had to answer. He said in a low voice, “I heard that the reason why he stayed in Zhaoyang County for so long was to avoid a person. As for who it is, I don’t know.”

Qin Mian let go of the matter when his curiosity was satisfied. He didn't ask any more questions. It was hard for him to ask a gossip about his friends.

Footnotes

1. In Sun Tzu's The Art of War, he told that it is a greater skill to subdue the enemy without actually having to resort to fighting. The word "subdue" means to pacify or control.
2. It means to harm someone through the hands of another.

Chapter 172: Lei Tie Takes Action

172 – Lei Tie Takes Action

Back at the State Defender Duke Establishment, the gatekeeper came quickly to lead the horses for the two men and raised his voice, “The Old Lord and Lady have returned—” Why did he shout this? This was to inform other servants that those in charge of preparing hot water should prepare hot water, those in charge of preparing tea should prepare tea, and those in charge of taking care of horses should prepare to take care of the horses....

Qin Mian made a jest at Lei Tie, “A-Tie, in the end, you’re inescapable from walking on the ‘old’ road.”

Lei Tie was calm, “En.”

“You’re pushing 40!” Qin Mian stressed it badly and laughed heartily. Lei Tie was 30 years old this year; wasn’t he pushing 40?

Lei Tie was helpless. Being eight years older than his wife meant he was doomed to be teased by his wife. Alas, he was going to teach his wife a *lesson* when it was time.

Unaware of the impending crisis, Qin Mian continued to move forward briskly and then joked, “As the old saying goes, ‘three years gap is a generation gap’. Between the two of us, isn’t it almost three—ah!”

Before he finished speaking, his waist was wrapped and his whole person suddenly flew up. He quickly grabbed Lei Tie’s neck, “What are you doing?”

“Proving that I’m not old.” Lei Tie took Qin Mian’s hand and put it on his thigh.

Steward Fu came in a hurry, only to see a figure flying away. “Old Lord, your servant has something important to report—”

In the air, there were only Lei Tie’s chilly four words: “Talk about it later.”

More than an hour later, Lei Tie appeared alone in the main hall of the foreyard. There was still a light languidness after lovemaking on his body.

The old man Steward Fu bowed his head, looking uneasy.

“What’s it?”

Steward Fu reported, “Today, Old Master has received more than ten invitation and visitation notices. One of them is an invitation notice from Princess Yanqing, inviting the Lady to go—”

“Give it to me.”

“Give it to me.”

Lei Tie looked at the door. Qin Mian’s face was covered with two parts of sneer and eight parts of scorn as he came at a brisk pace; his momentum was overwhelming.

Lei Tie walked over, “There’s no need to be angry with that kind of person.”

Qin Mian’s cold aura dissipated. He sat down on the old-fashioned wooden armchair and lightly laughed. “You should say, ‘I’ll support whatever you want to do’.”

Seeing that he was no longer angry, Lei Tie nodded, “I’ll support whatever you want to do.”

Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder and told the steward, “Reply to tell Princess Yanqing that this Lady will go to the appointment as scheduled; also, go check out the exact details of Princess Yanqing. The more detailed the better.”

“Yes.” Steward Fu said, “Old Lord and Lady, there is one more thing. The old lady sent someone here today to urge Old Lord and Lady to go over.”

As for the purpose of asking Qin Mian and Lei Tie to go over, they all understood it without saying. Lei Tie was now a first-rank senior official. Could Lei Daqiang and Du Shi sit still at home?

Lei Tie said coldly, “I’ll go in a moment.”

“Yes. This old servant asks to withdraw.”

After Steward Fu left, Lei Tie sat down in the armchair beside Qin Mian and hugged him, “Sleep a little longer? I’ll be back to accompany you when I’m done.”

Qin Mian jumped up and sat astride Lei Tie’s thighs. He then grasped the back of the armchair with both hands and put his legs through the gaps under the armrest of the armchair, locking himself in the chair. “You, are mine. If anyone dares to steal, they will be humiliated!”

“En. I’m not going. Sleep.” Lei Tie’s heart almost melted into water. He kissed Qin Mian on the cheek, raised Qin Mian’s head, and put it on his shoulder. He embraced the man and he caressed his back.

Qin Mian had just deliberately locked him from leaving, but dozed off in a daze and fell into a dark dreamland.

Lei Tie quietly took the man back to the bedroom and placed him on the bed. Afterward, he took the twenty bodyguards and rode to Lei Xiangzhi’s house.

Lei-Qin Zhong raised his voice and called out, “State Defender Duke has come—”

The servants of Lei Xiangzhi’s residence had been elated when they learned that their Master’s eldest brother was the State Defender Duke and the Grand General of the State. When they heard that the State Defender Duke

had arrived, they immediately opened the gate and invited the visitors inside with all smiles.

“Servants greet State Defender Duke. Please come in!”

However, Lei Tie and his party did not move.

Per Lei Tie’s instructions, Lei-Qin Zhong asked, “Where is your Old Master?”

The gatekeeper said, “My Old Master hasn’t come back yet. The old man, the two old ladies, and the madam are all here.”

Lei Tie then urged his horse into the door. Lei-Qin Zhong, Lei-Qin Shun, and the twenty bodyguards followed with an aggressive posture.

Lei Daqiang and Du Shi were in the house when they heard that Lei Tie had come. Their faces lit up with happiness.

“Old man, now the eldest has become the first rank senior official and even Qin Mian has become the First Rank Mandated Lady. We can’t be angry with them anymore.” Du Shi reminded Lei Daqiang, “When he comes, we’ll make amends for what happened before. As long as we win him back, I’ll be granted an imperial order to become the Grand Lady¹!” Thinking that she could also put on her noble Mandated Lady’s clothes, Du Shi grinned from ear to ear.

Wei Shi sipped the tea lightly, with contempt in her smile. To this day, Du Shi was still dreaming. If the hurt one had suffered could be made up so easily, there would not be so many sad things in the world. The fact that Du Shi sent people to the State Defender Duke Establishment today must have infuriated Lei Tie. Otherwise, he would not be willing to see Du Shi and Lei Daqiang again.

Wei Shi covered her stomach and frowned in pain, “Old man, my stomach hurts.”

Lei Daqiang quickly helped her and said, “Wei’er, are you pregnant again?” The second year after they came to the Capital, Wei Shi gave birth to a son, which Lei Daqiang dearly loved like the apple of his eye.

“Can you help me back to my room, old man?” Wei Shi leaned weakly in his arms.

Lei Daqiang held her carefully, “Alright. Come, slowly.”

“Old man!” Du Shi was very clear. Without Lei Daqiang, Lei Tie wouldn’t give her respect.

“*Aiya—*” Wei Shi let out a painful groan.

In a hurry, Lei Daqiang picked her up and walked out quickly. At the same time, he told the servants, “Quick, go invite a doctor.”

Only Du Shi was left in the main hall.

A servant girl walked in a hurry, “Reporting, Old Lady: State Defender Duke is here.”

Du Shi could only face Lei Tie alone. She straightened her clothes and pretended to be calm.

Lei Tie strode into the door and stood in the center of the main hall, condescendingly looked at the old woman sitting on the head’s position.

“I heard you’re in a hurry to see me?”

Du Shi didn’t get up. She raised her hand to the chair beside her and said, “Yes. Sit down. Lei Tie, I called you—”

Lei Tie asked Lei-Qin Zhong, “Lei-Qin Zhong, what’s the punishment for being disrespectful to the State Defender Duke?”

Lei-Qin Zhong said in a loud voice, “Flog with a stick for 10 times and sentenced to prison for 10 days!”

Du Shi was furious, “Lei Tie, you dare?”

“Take her away!” Lei Tie waved his hand without expression.

His two bodyguards suppressed Du Shi and dragged her out the door. Du Shi’s shrill cry sounded similar to a person stabbed with a knife.

“Let me go! Let me go! Ah! This old lady will fight you.....”

The servants were terrified. They went blank and at a loss of what to do.

“Tell Lei Xiangzhi that if he can’t manage his family well, this officer will manage it for him!” Lei Tie coldly dropped a sentence and left, flinging his sleeve.

Back at the State Defender Duke Establishment, Qin Mian was still sleeping. Lei Tie leaned over his lips and pecked him gently. He took off his shoes, went to bed to lie down, and took the man into his arms. It was unknown whether Qin Mian was aware of it or not in his dreamland, but he wiggled closer, groped for Lei Tie’s waist, hugged him, and continued to sleep.

When they woke up, they took a look at the chime-clock in the corner. It was more than 4 pm.

After washing up, they had tea and cake in the reception pavilion. Lei Tie mentioned going to Lei Xiangzhi’s house.

After a while, the servant reported that Lei Xiangzhi had come.

The two men met the guest in the main hall of the outer courtyard.

Lei Xiangzhi put down his teacup and got up to bow with his hands folded in front. “Greetings to Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law.”

“Fifth Brother doesn’t have to be courteous. Sit down.” Qin Mian asked directly, “Fifth Brother is here for the old lady?”

“Exactly.” Lei Xiangzhi sighed, “After all, she is my biological mother.” He was in a dilemma, caught between his biological mother and his eldest brother/eldest sister-in-law to who he was indebted.

“Fifth Brother, you can rest assured that the old lady won’t be wronged in prison. A-Te just wants to scare her and give her one last warning. You’ve been in the officialdom for three years, so you could imagine how many waves A-Tie’s presence will set off in the Capital. We’ve always wanted to live in peace and it will be the same henceforth. But if anyone comes to trouble and make us upset, we’ll fight back without hesitation. The same goes to the old man and the old lady,” said Qin Mian lightly.

Lei Xiangzhi nodded, “I understand. Eldest Sister-in-law and Eldest Brother have tolerated the old man and the old lady many times in the past years, all in the consideration of me, Third Brother, and Fourth Brother.” Their feelings could not help the old man and the old lady for a lifetime. Once the last bit of feelings was used up, the brothers would become strangers.

“I don’t have the face to ask Eldest Brother to let go of the old lady. I just hope that Eldest Brother can excuse her from physical pain in consideration of her old age.” Lei Xiangzhi said with a bitter smile, “The old man is fine; Wei Shi can manage him. On the old lady’s side, I’m a bit hapless sometimes. However, today’s matter seems to have spread. I’m afraid that Eldest Brother’s reputation... Eldest Brother, did you intend to make this matter big?” Lei Xiangzhi guessed.

“What is a reputation?” Lei Tie did not deny it. “I don’t need a good reputation.”

For a moment, Lei Xiangzhi could not understand the meaning of this remark.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not mean to explain.

When Lei Xiangzhi returned home, Lei Daqiang immediately asked him, “How is it, Old Five?”

Li Shi frowned, “Father-in-law, my husband is now an official. You have to change the way you address him.”

“Used to call that. What’s so serious with an appellation?” Lei Daqiang disagreed and then asked, “How did it go? That Lei Tie, he actually dares to put your mother in prison?”

Lei Xiangzhi said coldly, “Why not? Father, don’t you understand? Eldest Brother’s status is not only your son but also the first rank State Defender Duke and the important minister of the Emperor! Between ‘your son’ and ‘State Defender Duke’, which of these two statuses do you think is the most important?”

Lei Daqiang was speechless. After a while, he said with regret, “If only your official position could be higher, your mother could be granted an imperial order... Who could have imagined that Lei Tie turns to be the Grand General...”

Wei Shi’s heart jolted. She took a look at Lei Xiangzhi’s face, and as expected, it was unsightly.

Li Shi inwardly sneered, then she sighed and said, “If only there were no separation in the first place, father-in-law and mother-in-law can still live with Eldest Brother. Won’t it be a matter of course that mother-in-law can be directly granted imperial order? Father-in-law’s identity will also be on a higher level. Father-in-law, don’t you think so?”

Lei Daqiang wasn’t aware that her words were ironic. He chimed in, “Ah yes.”

Lei Xiangzhi’s face was livid and his hands were tightly held into fists in his wide sleeves. He yelled at Li Shi, “Li Shi!”

Li Shi made a face at him and left with floating steps, “Husband, I’ll go to see the child.”

When the sun fell to the west, the carriage of the State Defender Duke Establishment drove into Chong’en Street, entered through the middle gate,

and stopped in the courtyard.

Yuanyuan and Manman jumped out of the carriage and saw their Old Dad and Dad standing side by side not far away. Smiles bloomed on their faces and they ran over quickly.

“Dad, Old Dad!”

“Yuanyuan and Manman, how did it go at the academy today? Were you being bullied?” Qin Mian asked and looked at his two sons. He didn’t find any traces of abuse on them. He was relieved.

Manman spoke first, “Nope. Don’t worry, Dad.”

Yuanyuan said with a poker face, “Dad, we’re big kids now. You can’t call us ‘Yuanyuan’ and ‘Manman’ anymore.”

“Fine.” Qin Mian amusingly rubbed the heads of the two little boys. “Your Old Dad and I will call you ‘Ruiqi’ and ‘Ruilin’ henceforth, alright?”

“En. Also, can’t rub our heads,” said Qin Ruiqi with all seriousness.

Qin Mian reluctantly released his hand, “Fine, fine.” *Alas, my sons are not so cute after they grow up.*

“Dad, all the students in the academy were envious of the schoolbags that Dad designed for me and Gege.” Lei Ruilin quickly coaxed his Dad to be happy.

Qin Ruiqi chimed in, “They also envied mine and Didi’s oversleeves².”

Qin Mian chuckled, “Is that so?”

“Yes. Dad, also... ”

The family of four walked back to the inner courtyard while talking and laughing.

Footnotes

1. An honorific designation granted to mothers and grandmothers of various high-ranking officials through the imperial order.
2. Oversleeve is a protective (detachable) sleeve covering an ordinary sleeve. Since they write with brush and ink, the sleeve will get dirtied, so the oversleeve is used for that.

Chapter 173: Single Out as a Point of Attack

173 – Single Out as a Point of Attack

Two days later, Steward Fu sent a detailed investigation result of Princess Yanqing.

Princess Yanqing's mother was Empress Jingxian, the first Empress of Emperor Xiaohui, who died to save Emperor Xiaohui after an assassin invaded the palace. Empress Jingxian was also the niece of the Empress Dowager. Therefore, both the Empress Dowager and Emperor Xiaohui doted on Princess Yanqing, which led to her arrogant and unreasonable personality. This was what Lei Tie told Qin Mian a long time ago after Qin Mian and Lei Tie got to know each other.

Princess Yanqing was now 24 years old and had yet to marry. In modern times, of course, it was nothing, but in this dynasty, she already belonged in the old maid category. The Emperor had chosen seven to eight son-in-law candidates for her, yet she was dissatisfied. Because of Empress Jingxian, it was hard for the Emperor to force her to marry anyone. Thus, she could only continue to be kept in the Palace.....

This Princess Yanqing was a discontented person. Qin Mian had finished reading her investigation report for nearly two moments and already knew roughly how things stood. A sneer appeared on his lips.

Lei Tie didn't ask him what his plan was. He said that no matter what his wife did, he would support him. Even if his wife rushed to misfortune, he would peddle him.

The next day, Lei Tie got up early and went to court. He rode to the South Gate of the Palace, dismounted, and threw the reins to his bodyguard.

At this time, there was only a glimmer of dawn in the east. Many ministers of civil and military still had lanterns on their carriages. The ministers got out of the carriages, and those with lower official rank than Lei Tie politely bowed to him.

Lei Tie nodded slightly and said nothing.

The ministers gathered together and whispered among themselves. The words “stepmother”, “prison”, and so on were vaguely heard.

After entering the Palace, they came to the Hall of Supreme Harmony. All the ministers entered into the hall and gathered together in twos and threes, chatting in low voices while glancing at Lei Tie from time to time.

A good few officials, who had been in the Court with Lei Tie a long time ago, exchanged greetings with Lei Tie in a friendly way. Lei Tie gave a brief reply. These ministers knew his temperament and didn’t mind it.

After a while, Eunuch Li’s announcement sounded in the hall, “Here comes His Majesty——”

All the ministers quickly divided into two groups of civil and military and stood in the hall. After hearing the Emperor sitting on the Dragon chair, they knelt neatly and shouted out, “Long live His Majesty, absolutely long live!”

“Stand up.”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty!”

Eunuch Li announced again, “Present a memorial if there is, adjourn if there isn’t——”

The Imperial Guard Commander, Liu Tiande, made a signal to a rank four minister from behind the line of the civil ministers.

The minister immediately stepped out and said, “Reporting, Your Majesty. Your subject heard a rumor about State Defender Duke yesterday. State Defender Duke is the cornerstone of the government, how can he be slandered? Therefore, your subject thinks that investigation ought to be done to give justice to State Defender Duke.”

A good few ministers looked at Lei Tie with gloating looks.

Lei Tie remained calm as if the subject of conversation was not him.

“Oh?” Emperor Xiaohui looked very interested, “What is the rumor?”

“Reporting, Your Majesty. It’s said that State Defender Duke ordered his bodyguards to send his stepmother to prison yesterday afternoon. A stepmother is also one’s own mother. It’s unfilial to disrespect one’s own mother. How can Defender Grand General of the State do something unfilial?” The minister’s face was indignant, outraged by the injustice in Lei Tie’s stead.

Emperor Xiaohui looked at Lei Tie and asked, “My dear subject Lei, is this true?”

“Yes,” said Lei Tie.

Emperor Xiaohui looked interested. Unintentionally or intentionally, his gaze flitted past Liu Tiande, the Imperial Guard Commander. “Do you admit your guilty?”

Lei Tie lightly said, “The State of Great Xia’s law stated: If one disrespect the first rank official of the Imperial Court, one will be flogged for ten times and sentenced to ten days’ imprisonment. However, if Du Shi had not done many evil things when your subject was young, your subject might not run away from home as a child, or else, there would not be Lei Tianren. As far as this point is concerned, Du Shi is truly without faults and instead has rendered great service.”

The whole hall was speechless.

Emperor Xiaohui laughed, “So then, there is nothing wrong with what State Defender Duke did. My dear subject Jiang, Zhen will discourse a better joke next time.”

Jiang-daren’s face was deathly pale. Shamefaced, he said, “Yes, your subject is guilty.”

“No, you have rendered great service.” Emperor Xiaohui said with a smile, “It’s the first time Zhen has heard State Defender Duke say so much at once. Zhen should reward you.”

Jiang-daren’s face turned green and red.

The rest of the ministers were secretly surprised. It seemed that the State Defender Duke was really going to be the most favorite person around the Emperor.

After the Court adjourned, Emperor Xiaohui came to Empress Dowager’s Palace of Mother’s Consolation to chat with her. Unwittingly, the conversation turned to State Defender Duke.

“My Imperial Son, this widowed empress still thinks it’s too risky to let the State Defender Duke command the army. In case he... Duanning is already 16 this year, why not——”

“Absolutely not.” Emperor Xiaohui quickly waved his hand, “Imperial Mother, the State Defender Duke now is a family of four that get along very well. If anyone dares to squeeze in people into the State Defender Duke Establishment, that person in his family isn’t an easy person to deal with. Imperial Mother just waits and sees. This morning’s Court Session came such a scene. Someone must have already informed you; it didn’t come to a good end. Your Son has a sense of propriety in the affairs of the State Defender Duke. Imperial Mother, so long you help your Son watch over Yanqing, you lighten some of my worries.”

“Is that male-Lady of the State Defender Duke really so great?” Empress Dowager put down her scissors and asked curiously. Empress Dowager was the Empress of the late emperor and the biological mother of Emperor

Xiaohui and Imperial Prince Ming. She was more than 60 years old this year, yet she looked like she was only in her early 40s, dignified and graceful. Her appearance of picking up the egg showed a mature and charming charm. It could be imagined that she must be extremely beautiful when she was young. However, from the sharp glint in her eyes, one could see that she was not as kind as her appearance made out to be.

Emperor Xiaohui nodded, "That's right."

"Such being the case, this widowed empress won't supervise you." Empress Dowager smiled, "If there is an opportunity, this widowed empress would like to meet the Lady of the State Defender Duke."

Emperor Xiaohui said, "There will be opportunities in the future."

.....

Qin Mian planned to build a pharmacy and a silverware shop in the Capital. Although he and Lei Tie had a real salary to get now, they couldn't afford to consume without producing and earn from the few industrial for their two children. And yet, as he walked around the Capital all morning, he didn't find a suitable shop. It was thus clear how difficult it was for outsiders to get involved in the Capital.

Depressed, he returned home. Steward Fu came to report.

"Reporting, my Lady. Chancellor of the Directorate of Education, Yangdaren has just sent a.... gift to the Old Lord."

"Hm?" Qin Mian noticed that something was wrong with his look. "What gift?"

Steward Fu fumbled for words, "It's... two young women."

"Oh?" Qin Mian was not angry but smiled, "They must be two great beauties?"

Uncle Fu was unable to perceive that he *was* angry. "Your servant didn't look carefully."

Qin Mian pulled out the folding fan hung in his belt and said, “Steward, did you say that our family doesn’t accept this kind of gift?”

Steward Fu said, “Of course, your servant said that, but the two misses weren’t willing to leave. Your servant has no way to go about it...”

“Unwilling to go? Fine then.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “Escort them out and stuff them on the carriage. Do you know where Yang-daren’s residence is?”

Steward Fu didn’t hesitate, “To answer my Lady’s question, your servant already told someone to ask about it.”

Qin Mian looked at him approvingly, “Very good!”

In a short time, the servant brought the two women. As expected, they were young, beautiful, and charming. Without explanation, Qin Mian stuffed a pill into the mouth of each of them.

The two women turned pale with fear.

“Y-you, what did you give us to eat?”

“What you take is a disfigurement pill, which will take effect in six hours. If you don’t want to disfigure your face, find a way to feed this pill to Yang-daren.” Qin Mian took out a small porcelain jar. He had expected that there would be today’s event, and so he refined the pills in advance. Since someone was not able to hold back, he couldn’t let that someone down.

“No, no,” the two women trembled with fear. “Yang-daren is the official of the Imperial Court. Can’t kill...”

Qin Mian was speechless. “Who told you that this is a medicine that can kill people? It’s a panacea that will give men powerful endurance to last for three days and three nights.”

Uncle Fu and the few servants shivered at the same time. *Oh Mother, the Lady is fearsome!*

The two misses were stunned.

“This Lady doesn’t lie to you. If you aren’t willing, this Lady won’t force. Just wait for the disfigurement then.”

Qin Mian finished his sentence and shook the folding fan leisurely, ready to leave.

“Wait!”

Qin Mian smilingly handed the small medicine jar to them, “So long I receive the news from Yang-daren, I’ll send someone to deliver the antidote to you immediately. It’s not easy for women to make a living in this world. I’ll have someone give you 5 taels of silver by the way.” He patted them on the shoulders with a comforting look on his face.

Glistening teardrops gathered in the eyes of the two women. More than half of their resentment against him disappeared immediately.

“Uncle Fu, escort them to Yang-daren’s house.”

“Yes!”

Qin Mian shook the folding fan, hummed a song as he walked away with a smile.

The servants looked at each other, determined not to offend the Lady most of all.

Lei Tie returned from the army camp. He unfastened his combat uniform and saber, handed them to Lei-Qin Zhong, and returned to the inner courtyard.

“Wife, I’m back.”

“Back already?” Qin Mian put off his smile and went to hold Lei Tie’s face.

“What?” Lei Tie didn’t know what happened at home. He hugged Qin Mian and let his wife shake his head.

“Nothing. Why are you so handsome?” Smiling, Qin Mian kissed him on the lip, “Wash first, and then have lunch.”

When his wife was in a good mood, Lei Tie was in a good mood. A faint smile floated from the bottom of his eyes. “En.”

The servants outside sent hot water in, saluted, and retreated without a sound.

Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian, who was sitting back at the table, and washed his face as he asked, “What are you doing?”

“Interior design.” Qin Mian said, “By the way, tomorrow’s court session, Chancellor of the Directorate of Education, Yang-daren, may ask for leave. My husband, I wonder if you can find a way to prevent him from taking leave?”

The corners of Lei Tie’s mouth perked up. Without asking the reason, he said in a spry tone, “Alright.”

“There’s more.” Qin Mian propped up his chin, turned his head, and looked at Lei Tie with a grin, “If he uses something to block a certain part of his body, you find a way to ruin it.”

Lei Tie felt uncertain but responded the same, “Alright.”

The next day in the court session, Lei Tie specially searched the civil minister group for Chancellor of the Directorate of Education, Yang-daren. Owing to the different official uniforms of each position, Lei Tie soon found him and saw that he was dressed too thick to move. Lei Tie had some understanding.

Many ministers had heard that the beauties sent by Yang-daren to the State Defender Duke Establishment had been sent back by the Lady of the State Defender Duke, who seemed to make some counterattack. They stared at Yang-daren and couldn’t guess what was wrong with him for a while.

Yang-daren shrank behind the minister in front of him, trying to reduce his sense of existence.

Emperor Xiaohui took a look at Yang-daren and then at Lei Tie – a shadow of a smile on his face.

As usual, Eunuch Li announced, “present a memorial if there is, adjourn if there isn’t”. Lei Tie secretly waved out his vital spirit and slapped the minister behind Yang-daren without any trace.

The minister’s legs suddenly weakened. He fell forward and accidentally pushed Yang-daren down.

Caught off guard, Yang-daren fell on his stomach to the ground and let out a shrill cry, “AH——”

Emperor Xiaohui was startled, nearly spilled his tea. His face was overcast, “My dear subject Yang!”

Yang-daren turned pale with pain. He turned over and covered his lower side awkwardly. For a long time, he couldn’t get up and kneel. His face turned red with anxiety and tears were almost streaming out. “Y-Your Majesty... p-please forgive your subject’s crime for the... failure of etiquette.”

Emperor Xiaohui was stunned. Once he saw it, he was simmered with laughter, laughing aloud.

As if everyone had been given order, they all burst out laughing.

“Hahahahaha...”

Chapter 174: Princess Yanqing

174 – Princess Yanqing

Emperor Xiaohui thought of Qin Mian's medical skills. After laughing, he pretended not to know, "My dear subject Yang, you muddleheaded! If you have an unmentionable disease, you should go to the Imperial Doctor of the Imperial Institute of Medicine. You can't go to those itinerant quacks outside. What should you do if it gets worse... *sigh*."

Almost all the ministers used the ceremonial tablets to block their faces as they snickered, stifling it so much that their faces turned red. The older ministers looked at Yang-daren with heartache and headache and muttered to themselves that he was a disgrace to the educated class. Of course, there were also some ministers, who had also saved money to send beauties to the State Defender Duke Establishment, turned grey-faced and were dissatisfied with the State Defender Duke and his Lady.

A minister kindly helped Yang-daren up.

"Reporting, Your Majesty. Your servant didn't have [disease]..." Yang-daren's face was as red as a monkey's buttocks. His fingers trembled as he pointed to Lei Tie – he was very angry. "It's, it's the Lady of the State Defender Duke. He..."

Lei Tie asked in a cold voice, "Yang-daren, speak cautiously! What does it have to do with my wife?"

Some ministers were good at figuring out His Majesty's meaning. When they saw Emperor Xiaohui smiling but not saying anything, they knew that the emperor was happy to see this. Someone boldly created a disturbance, "Yang-daren, do you mean to say that you're like this because of Lady of

the State Defender Duke? You can't simply accuse Lady of the State Defender Duke. Without rhyme or reason, why would Lady of the State Defender Duke create trouble with you?"

One of the emperor's most taboo things was that the ministers formed cliques for personal gain. How could Yang-daren say that it was because he sent beauties to the State Defender Duke Establishment, trying to win him over? He glanced at Emperor Xiaohui in fear. He rebuked himself and swallowed his pride, "This is just a misunderstanding."

Emperor Xiaohui was well aware of the ministers' shady methods, but he would not take it seriously when his ministers occasionally made some minor mistakes. If he had investigated everything, he would have been dead tired.

"Alright, if it's a misunderstanding, solve it. What's the point of making trouble in the court! Adjourn." Emperor Xiaohui flung his sleeve and left.

When Emperor Xiaohui was far away, the ministers all burst out laughing. Some people deliberately asked Yang-daren if he really had an unmentionable disease, they could recommend a famous doctor.....

Yang-daren's face was ghastly pale. When he looked back, he discovered that Lei Tie was gone and went after him.

"State Defender Duke, please stop! It's a disrespect of this lowly official to have offended your honorable Lady, unintentionally. Can State Defender Duke ask your honorable Lady to give this lowly official the antidote?"

The other ministers dallied as their eyes peered furtively.

Lei Tie indifferently stared at Yang-daren, "Yang-daren, everything needs to be based on evidence. My wife is the First Rank Mandated Lady; how can you slander [him] at will? And this officer's first rank is certainly not a decoration. Excuse my absence."

With that, he walked away.

Yang-daren was so angry that his body trembled.

At noon of the same day, Qin Mian received a 1000-tael silver banknote asking for an antidote. He accepted it calmly and gently said to the manservant of Yang-daren's household, "Tell Yang-daren that there is no antidote. It will be fine after three days."

It was none of his business how Yang-daren threw things around in his house. Anyway, since then, no one had dared to squeeze in people into the State Defender Duke Establishment.

After a few days, it was the 15th day. On the 1st day and the 15th day of the month, the women of the Imperial Clan and the women of rank all went to the Palace to greet the Empress Dowager and the Empress.

As the First Rank Mandated Lady and also the first paying-respect day after the title was sealed, Qin Mian inevitably had to enter the Palace. In fact, he had been waiting for this day for a long time.

In the morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie got up together. Qin Mian hummed a song as he put on the official clothes – his fighting spirit soared aloft. At first, Lei Tie wanted to say not to be afraid and he would take care of everything, but seeing that, he simply shut up. He gave his wife a kiss and lent him a hand.

After getting ready, the couple went to the Palace in a carriage. The ministers entered the Palace through the South Gate, while the women of rank could only enter the Palace through the North Gate. Lei Tie got off first, and the carriage took Qin Mian to the North Gate.

There were other women of rank in front of the gate. Qin Mian turned a blind eye to other people's measuring gazes. After the palace attendants checked their belongings, he followed the other women of rank inside.

Since they were going to the Imperial Harem, Qin Mian couldn't take Lei-Qin Le with him. Therefore, he took a junior maid from the sewing room into the Palace with him. The junior maid was very clever and followed behind Qin Mian with gifts.

They went to the Palace of Mother's Consolation first. Qin Mian looked at the clothes of the women of rank and judged their ranks. After entering the Palace of Mother's Consolation, he ignored other people's ridiculing eyes and stood calmly behind Imperial Princess Consort Ming.

When Empress Dowager came out, Qin Mian knelt helplessly. He had no other choice. Unless his man was the Emperor, otherwise, as long as they did not leave the Capital, he had to kneel so frequently in the future.

Qin Mian was not surprised to feel a sharp gaze from above looking at him.

"Rise. Be seated."

"Thank you, Empress Dowager."

Empress Dowager looked at all of them and was surprised that she didn't see Princess Yanqing. Yet, she was relieved. She looked at Qin Mian and said in a very gentle tone, "Are you Lady of the State Defender Duke?"

Qin Mian got up and left his ranks. He cupped his hands and said, "Replying, Empress Dowager. Yes, I am. It's a great honor for the humble me to be able to pay respect to Empress Dowager. I've brought a humble gift and hope Empress Dowager kindly accept it."

Empress Dowager said with a slight smile, "Present it."

Qin Mian took the red brocade box from the junior maid's hands and handed it to the awaiting palace maid.

"Reporting, Empress Dowager. This product is a beauty cream this humble me had concocted. Not only has it the effect of nourishing the skin, but it can also retain the elegant fragrance for a long time when applied once."

"Oh? It has such efficiency?" Empress Dowager's expression was dull. As an empress dowager, what kind of good things had she never seen? She didn't take Qin Mian's words to heart. However, Qin Mian was the Lady of the State Defender, so she still had to give him some face. She motioned to the palace maid.

The palace maid opened the box. Inside were eight small and exquisite porcelain jars: four white and four blue in the same shape.

“There are eight different fragrances. Just smear a little on your face and rub it over.”

Empress Dowager said with a smile, “Lady of the State Defender Duke is very thoughtful. Reward.”

After that, nothing unpleasant happened as Qin Mian had imagined before. Empress Dowager chatted with several other people and then asked them to withdraw.

They then went to the empress’s Palace of Earthly Tranquility.

The empress was only seven points beautiful, yet she was noble and generous, making others very comfortable. She had a talk with several high-ranking women of rank, including Qin Mian.

Qin Mian presented six jars of beauty cream. The empress also rewarded him with a lot of good things.

Qin Mian marveled at his successful entrance to the Palace. He could not help suspecting that the reason why Lei Tie was recalled to the Capital was very complicated. He warned himself that he should be more cautious in the future.

Anyway, his goal of entering the Palace had been achieved.

Three days later was the day Princess Yanqing invited Qin Mian to a gathering. Princess Yanqing was not married and still lived in the Palace. Emperor Xiaohui and Empress Dowager were on guard against her provoking people of the State Defender Duke Establishment. Since she was a woman, the place where she invited Qin Mian was not in the Palace, but in the Second Prince Establishment.

There was a garden in the Second Prince Establishment, which collected more than fifty kinds of exotic flowers in the world. In the fourth lunar

month, all kinds of flowers were in full bloom. Holding a small gathering in the name of appreciating flowers would not arouse people's suspicion.

Qin Mian picked out two items from the rewards given by Empress Dowager and the empress and asked someone to wrap them nicely. Afterward, he rode on horseback to the Second Prince Establishment.

The servants of the Second Prince Establishment respectfully invited him in and took him to the main hall to pay an official visit to the master.

Second Prince, about 25~26 years old, had a handsome face and a gentle look. Meanwhile, Second Princess Consort had an excellent charm and was demure and courteous.

Alas, since they were willing to help Princess Yanqing *build a bridge*, Qin Mian was hostile toward them. No matter how approachable they were, he only talked about some events. There was one thing that he always found strange. Since Princess Yanqing chose the Second Prince Establishment as the meeting location, she could have let Second Princess Consort send the notice to Qin Mian in her name. Why was the signature on the notice in the name of Princess Yanqing? Was Princess Yanqing really so brainless, or was the relationship between Second Prince and Princess Yanqing not really close?

The emperor's affairs were complicated. Qin Mian put this question in his mind and stopped thinking about it. When the time was ripe, he would find the answer.

After the greetings, Second Princess Consort took Qin Mian to the garden to admire the flowers.

Second Princess Consort introduced the identities of the ladies to Qin Mian. Qin Mian found that they were all third and fourth ranks, and none of them was higher than him. Perhaps, Princess Yanqing or Second Princess Consort had some scruples.

Those who were ranked lower than Qin Mian did not dare to bother Qin Mian. Qin Mian enjoyed the flowers leisurely for a while. The other people

around him unconsciously went away, leaving him alone. He sat down at the stone table and shook the folding fan.

When Princess Yanqing arrived, she saw a handsome and charming young man sitting at the stone table calmly. The gentle long-drawn breeze fluttered his black hair and white clothes together. He seemed very leisurely and comfortable.

The jealousy and hatred in Princess Yanqing's heart suddenly rolled up. No matter how good his facial features were, he was just a villager. Lei Tianren didn't even pay attention to her, a dignified princess, but then he lived with a man like a husband and a wife, which was equivalent to ruthlessly slapping her in the face for the second time. How could she not hate him?

"Are you Lady of the State Defender Duke?" Princess Yanqing raised her head and approached with an arrogant face.

"Exactly. Who are you?" Qin Mian guessed the identity of the person who came but feigned ignorance as he asked. He measured her secretly and almost laughed. He always thought that the woman who dared to woo his man must have extraordinary capital, but this princess obviously let him down.

The maid behind Princess Yanqing immediately scolded, "Audacious! Why haven't you salute when you see Princess Yanqing?"

"What?" Qin Mian looked up and down at Princess Yanqing with disdainful eyes, and truthfully sneered, "This Lady thinks you don't want to live anymore. Look at you; neither a beautiful face nor a beautiful figure. Yet you dare to pretend to be Princess Yanqing?"

Second Prince and Second Princess Consort, who were eavesdropping behind the flowers, looked at each other in amazement. For a moment, they didn't know what kind of mood they were in.

It was the first time that Princess Yanqing was criticized in this way. She was stunned and looked down to check herself.

Chapter 175: Regressive Dispersion of Cannon Fodder

175 – Regressive Dispersion of Cannon Fodder

In the past, who did not praise Princess Yanqing for her beautiful appearance and ingeniously and delicately wrought figure? This was the first time someone had said that she did not have a single good point. When she realized that Qin Mian dared to be disrespectful to her, she burst into a rage.

Qin Mian didn't give her a chance to speak as he sneered, "And the most important thing is that this Lady heard Princess Yanqing is 26 years old. Looking at you 'miss', aren't you at least 30 years old this year? A word of advice from this Lady: it's a grave crime to pretend to be a member of the Imperial Clan, so leave now while no one is looking," said Qin Mian with a caring and compassionate manner.

"I look like 3...30 years old?" Princess Yanqing was stabbed several times. Steaming in rage, she glared at Qin Mian. Her chest unsteadily heaved.

Qin Mian faintly darted a glance at her and turned to admire the flowers.

Princess Yanqing touched her face in disbelief. All of a sudden, she turned around and threw a slap at her nearest maid. She said angrily, "You, speak! Does this princess really look 30 years old?"

Qin Mian frowned, "Hey miss, if you force your maid, she won't dare tell the truth. If you want to hear the truth, this Lady will tell you. Your eyebrows are thin and curved, but they are too sparse to look energetic; your eyes are too small and not bright enough; your skin is dull and dark,

the face powder can't hide the spots; your hair is dry and split, not lustrous enough..."

All the maids had the same incomprehensible look on their faces, looking at Qin Mian in a dumbstruck. When they suddenly came to their senses, they fell on their knees in fear and trepidation.

Hearing this, Second Princess Consort felt uneasy. She covered her chest and secretly congratulated herself that it was not her who was criticized. She sympathized with Princess Yanqing and looked at Second Prince in consultation, "Your Highness, aren't we... getting out to stop Lady of the State Defender Duke?"

Second Prince shook his head slightly and looked at Qin Mian in the distance from the crack of the flowering branches. There was an obscure and strange smile in his dim eyes.

Princess Yanqing was so angry that she trembled all over, even the dangling ornaments on her bun shook and swayed. Her venomous eyes were fixed on Qin Mian. "You, shut up for this Princess!"

Qin Mian said clearly, "No wonder your skin is bad. Why do people who are easy to get angry get old quickly? That's the reason. Enough, this Lady has been long-winded with you. Not afraid to tell you that Princess Yanqing will come to the Second Prince Establishment today. If you're sensible, hurry to leave."

Princess Yanqing had many ways to prove her identity, but she was so angry that she couldn't remember anything for a moment.

Qin Mian leisurely turned to leave. As he walked, he continued to admire the flowers.

When Princess Yanqing saw his figure was about to disappear, she finally thought of a way to prove her identity. She raised her voice and cried out, "Someone, come! Bring my Imperial Second Brother here!"

Qin Mian raised an interesting smile on his lips. If today's play ended like this, he would be disappointed.

After a while, he heard the flurried footsteps approaching behind him. He turned around and saw Second Prince and Second Princess Consort coming together. He bowed and cupped his hands as he said, "Greetings, Your Highnesses Second Prince and Second Princess Consort. Princess Yanqing hasn't appeared up to now, presumably she won't come. Wonder if this Lady can return home?"

Second Prince couldn't see whether he really didn't make out the identity of Princess Yanqing, or pretended. He took a look at Princess Yanqing and could only introduce her, "Lady of the State Defender Duke, this *is* Princess Yanqing."

Princess Yanqing had a sullen face as she raised her chin haughtily.

Qin Mian put on a surprising look. He deliberately tried to cover up his previous impoliteness to Princess Yanqing in front of the Second Prince and Second Princess Consort. He looked at Princess Yanqing with sincere eyes and said with a sincere tone, "So, this is Princess Yanqing. Sure enough, the rumors are true: fish sink, goose alights¹; hiding the moon, shaming the flowers². She is proven to be the golden branch, jade leaves³. This humble one has been discourteous."

Second Prince opened his mouth awkwardly. He didn't know how to react for a moment.

Princess Yanqing did not look happy because of Qin Mian's praise. Instead, her face was a mix of green and red. Having heard what Qin Mian said before, what he said now was a kind of naked irony to her. Yet, what Qin Mian said now was good words, so she couldn't punish the other party for saying good words to her. In front of Second Prince and Second Princess Consort, she also couldn't question the other party as to why he said those ugly words. That would only make her lose face.

She understood that she had to suffer this concealed loss. She looked at Qin Mian with hatred. She suppressed her anger and mildly asked, "Are you

Lady of the State Defender Duke?”

“That I am.” Qin Mian respectfully asked, “Venture to ask, what can I do for Princess?”

Princess Yanqing looked at him coldly and said to Second Prince and Second Princess Consort, “Imperial Second Brother and Imperial Second Sister-in-law, don’t you say you still have something to do?”

“Yanqing, we’ll leave it to you. We’re going to entertain other guests.” Second Prince and Second Princess Consort said “excuse our absence” to Qin Mian and turned to leave.

Princess Yanqing went to the stone table and sat down. She looked at Qin Mian meaningfully. “Lady of the State Defender Duke, how’s the State Defender Duke? Presumably, Lady of the State Defender Duke didn’t know that this Princess and State Defender Duke were acquainted with each other over a decade ago.”

Qin Mian said in surprise, “Really? Seeing that Princess cared so much for my husband, your relationship must have been quite close before. I’d like to ask Princess to help me with something. Wonder if Princess willing to help?”

When Princess Yanqing saw that he didn’t find the hole she had dug, she inwardly sneered. With a sweet smile on her face, she said with an arrogant attitude, “What’s it? Speak about it first.”

“I heard that eight years ago when my husband was an officer in the Capital, a woman with a higher status forced him to marry her.” Qin Mian’s face showed anger and hatred. “In order to get rid of the woman, my husband had no choice but to ruin his appearance. Princess is innately intelligent; you must be able to understand how humiliating it is for a man to be forced to such a state by a woman? However, I asked him many times who the woman was, but he didn’t want to tell me. I venture to ask Princess to help me find out the woman’s identity. Once I know who she is, and I won’t let her go! Of course, if Princess is willing to help, I will be very grateful to you.”

Behind the rockery, Second Prince heard it very clearly and shook his head to himself. *Yanqing is not an opponent of Lady of the State Defender Duke at all.*

Second Princess Consort also showed two points of fear toward Qin Mian.

Looking at Princess Yanqing again – her face turned pale and her left hand trembled so much that the teacup she held fell to the ground with a “pa”. The tea soaked her embroidered shoes.

“Princess, are you alright?” Panic-stricken, the maids ran to support Princess Yanqing.

“Princess?” Qin Mian looked at her suspiciously and considerately said, “I’ve been bold. If Princess thinks it’s difficult, just take it as if I hadn’t said that.”

Princess Yanqing shook off her maids’ hands and asked calmly, “How will you ‘not let her go’?”

Qin Mian gave a wee smile, “Princess probably doesn’t know who I am – I’m a doctor. A few days ago, a man sent two beauties to my husband. Did Princess know how I fight back— Ah, Princess is noble. Can’t let those dirty your ears.”

Princess Yanqing was flustered and asked, “What’s it? Just speak out what is on your mind. This Princess will forgive you for your misconduct!”

“Uhm... Obedience is better than politeness.” Qin Mian carefully worded, “I’ve given the man a kind of medicine so that within three days he will... In short, be overwhelmed to the extent of wishing to die. Some of the words, I really can’t tell Princess. However, this matter should have been spread all over the country. If Princess wants to know, you can make a little inquiry.”

In her heart, Princess Yanqing was afraid yet curious and unrequited. She looked coldly at her maid beside her and asked, “Do you know this?”

The senior maid beside her hesitated for a while, but still went to her ear and whispered.

Princess Yanqing gave a low cry; her eyeballs rolled up and she fainted to the ground.

Qin Mian was very surprised. “Is Princess sick? Quick, go to report to His Highness the Second Prince.” After that, he quickly retreated to stand one *zhang* [3.3m] away.

Second Prince and Second Princess Consort already had a good view of everything. They were afraid that something might happen to Princess Yanqing in their residence. As soon as they heard the maids shouting, they quickly walked over.

Second Prince gave Qin Mian a profound look with inquiring eyes. Qin Mian looked back blankly.

Second Prince withdrew his line of sight and told the maids, “Help the princess back to the room to rest.”

“Yes!”

The maids supported Princess Yanqing to leave with Second Princess Consort following. Only Qin Mian and Second Prince were left there.

“Your Highness, this matter has nothing to do with me!” Qin Mian quickly got rid of any suspicion; he looked only somewhat panicked.

Second Prince felt a profound sense of powerlessness. On the surface, it really had nothing to do with Qin Mian. Anyhow, Yanqing was a member of the Imperial Clan; he was obliged to express an attitude.

He was about to open his mouth when a manservant trotted over, “Reporting, Your Highness. State Defender Duke is here.”

Second Prince turned and looked over. Lei Tie, dressed in black, strode forward with vigorous and steady steps. He had no expression on his face.

As soon as his indifferent eyes saw Qin Mian, they were replaced by a simple yet unforgettable tenderness.

“Salute, Your Highness the Second Prince.”

Second Prince cupped hands and returned the salute, “State Defender Duke.”

“I come for my Lady.” Lei Tie went to Qin Mian and stood still, “Wonder if we can leave now?”

Second Prince said with a smile, “Certainly. The garden tour is about to come to an end. State Defender Duke and the Lady can do as you wish.”

Lei Tie nodded to him.

Qin Mian cupped his hands in obeisance to Second Prince and left with Lei Tie.

“Wife?” asked Lei Tie to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said with a smile, “Do you think I’ve been bullied?”

Seeing that Lei Tie came to pick up Qin Mian in person, the rest of the Ladies knew that it was not groundless to hear that the State Defender Duke and his wife were deeply in love – they were envious. Even though they married well, their husbands had never been so attentive and considerate.

Footnotes

1. An idiom, from Zhuangzi which means female beauty captivating even the birds and beasts
2. An idiom which means female beauty exceeding even that of the natural world.
3. (idiom)a person of noble birth; descendants of royal families

Chapter 176: Lei Tie's Intimidation

176 – Lei Tie's Intimidation

Out of the Second Prince Establishment, Qin Mian told Lei Tie about how to deal with Princess Yanqing. He never believed in the idea that “men should be gentle with women”. As long as people tried to destroy his relationship with Lei Tie, whether it was men or women, they all should be dealt with as cleanly as the autumn wind swept away the fallen leaves.

For Lei Tie's previous experience, he was still worried. Back then, A-Tie ran away from home and wandered alone for more than a year. He suffered a lot. Due to predestined fate, he had a chance to save a dejected elderly man and began to practice Cultivation of Trueness. The elderly man taught him and left without a farewell six months later. Fortunately, A-Tie was very gifted in the Cultivation of Trueness. In just two years, he reached the Golden Elixir stage. A lone person's journey was too solitary. At that time, A-Tie's desire to become an Immortal was not particularly strong. He wanted to stand out and let Lei Daqiang and Du Shi regret it. As a result, A-Tie entered the military camp at the age of 16 and became famous at the age of 17. In the army, he was needed and found the motivation to survive. But what happened later gave him a heavy blow. The emperor and the empress dowager forced him to marry Princess Yanqing. The most excessive part was that Princess Yanqing not only uttered lies but went so far as to force him by a death threat. Because of Du Shi, A-Tie was disgusted with women – Princess Yanqing's behavior made him even sick and disgusted. He had no choice but to ruin his appearance to save himself.

That's right, Lei Tie made the scar on his face. He entered the military camp after he had the Cultivation of Trueness. How hard would it be for others to injure him, who had profound cultivation? Only he could do it to himself.

Qin Mian never thought of letting Princess Yanqing go. Today, he felt no guilt for what Princess Yanqing had done. If Princess Yanqing didn't get better, he had plenty of means to deal with her. Emperor Xiaohui and Empress Dowager were not good in Qin Mian's eyes. Shouldn't loyal officers with outstanding military achievements be treated better? After Lei Tie ruined his appearance, Emperor Xiaohui and Empress Dowager still didn't give up the idea of having him marry Princess Yanqing – really loathsome. If it wasn't for Yuanyuan and Manman still needed to live in the secular world for a long time, even if Emperor Xiaohui promised to give the throne to A-Tie, Qin Mian and Lei Tie would not enter the Capital.

It wasn't long before Qin Mian and Lei Tie left the Second Prince Establishment. What happened in there was written as a secret memorial by Emperor Xiaohui's spy and sent to Emperor Xiaohui's imperial table.

After Emperor Xiaohui read it, he burned it with a dull expression on his face. He couldn't and wouldn't do anything to Qin Mian. First of all, Qin Mian didn't mention Princess Yanqing's name directly from the beginning to the end – it was not a great disrespect to his betters. Secondly, he needed Defender Grand General of the State now. Thus, there was no need to annoy the Defender Grand General of the State because of some small things. However, Emperor Xiaohui doubted whether Qin Mian had seen through this second point to be so bold.

From the Second Prince Establishment back to the State Defender Duke Establishment and into the entrance, Qin Mian jumped off the horse. From the pocket inside of his clothes, Lei Tie took out two sheets of paper and gave them to Qin Mian.

“What's that?” Qin Mian asked.

“Open up and look.”

As soon as he opened up the two sheets of paper, two bright red words of “Title Deed” had Qin Mian raise his eyebrows.

“These two buildings...”

Lei Tie looked attentively at him, “Don’t you want to open a medicine shop and a silverware shop?”

The two buildings were the same size, very suitable for opening a medicine shop and a silverware shop. Qin Mian so wanted to jump and kiss him. This guy quietly solved his big problem.

“Found a connection?”

Lei Tie said, “Left Grand General of the Imperial Guard. I’d saved him before.”

Qin Mian said, “Military officer? We’d better pay as much as they cost.”

Lei Tie nodded, “Of course.”

Qin Mian couldn’t wait to go to the buildings to have a look, but Lei Tie held him.

“Eat first.”

Qin Mian dryly laughed in embarrassment, “I almost forgot. Ruiqi and Ruilin even complained last night that I hadn’t cooked for a long time. Come, let’s cook.”

Lei Tie walked side by side with him. Even now that he was the highly respected State Defender Duke, he had not changed his habit of helping Qin Mian tend the kitchen fire.

There was still an hour before the afternoon recess of Dongyang Academy. Qin Mian cooked a large wok of mixed fried rice and a pot of white gourd and spare ribs soup. After he packed Yuanyuan and Manman’s portions, he and Lei Tie wiped out the rest.

They rested for a while after lunch. Qin Mian planned to visit the shop buildings.

Lei Tie was going to accompany him, but Lei-Qin Zhong came to report in a hurry, “My Lord, something happened in the army camp!”

Lei Tie frowned, "Wife, I..."

"One's proper duty is important." Qin Mian fully understood and said, "Be careful. Lei-Qin Zhong, you and Lei-Qin Shun have to keep your eyes open."

"Please rest assured, my Lady."

Qin Mian took Lei-Qin Le to see the shop buildings.

Lei Tie puts on his combat uniform and rushed to the army camp. Along the way, Lei-Qin Zhong told him the whole story in detail.

The army under the command of Lei Tie included the front army of 30000, the center army of 30000, and the rear army of 30000. The front was the vanguard force; the center army was under the command of the commander-in-chief and also the main force; the rear was mainly responsible for covering and guarding. The front army, center army, and rear army each had a commanding general from the second rank, respectively: General of the Front Dragon Army, General of the Center Supervision Army, and General of the Rear Militant Army. These three people had certain abilities and connections to climb to such a high level. Long before Lei Tie entered the Capital, they knew that the commander-in-chief of the army would be replaced. It was unknown who spread the news that there was a good chance that one of the three would be promoted to command the three armies. Little did they know that in the end, this position actually fell in the hand of Lei Tie. Many veterans in the army camp had heard of Lei Tianren's prestige, and many new recruits and new generals were full of awe for Lei Tianren. However, Lei Tianren had been out of the army for eight years. Tong Dibao, General of the Front Dragon Army, Fang Shoujiang, General of the Center Supervision Army, and Ding Wenchang, General of the Rear Militant Army, all believed that Lei Tianren belonged to the past and were unconvinced of him. Today, this kind of contradiction completely broke out.

Lei Tie had led the army for many years that he wasn't surprised this thing happened. If everyone showed deference and reverence to him, he would be suspicious.

The horse galloped into the army camp. From a distance, Lei Tie saw that the drill ground was in chaos. The soldiers who were convinced of Lei Tianren fought with those who were not – it was like a hornet’s nest had been stirred.

Tong Dibao, Fang Shoujiang, and Ding Wenchang were like provocateurs. They stood aside and didn’t stop the soldiers. When they saw Lei Tie, they didn’t show any panic. Instead, they boldly looked at him and even expected him to get angry.

Yet, Lei Tie did not – he was still calm. The rhythm of the horse’s hooves did not change.

The gallant horse galloped and stopped in front of Tong Dibao’s group of three. Lei Tie looked down at them and lightly said, “For indulging your subordinates creating a disturbance, each of the commanding generals shall be flogged 30 times. Do you obey?”

Tong Dibao was born with a loud voice and said aloud, “Obey! But we obey the military law, not you!”

His one word “obey” made Lei Tie look at him with a different look. Tong Dibao was nearly 40 years old. He had a strong-built and a rough face and was forthright in a naïve fashion. But from that pair of eyes with sharp glints from time to time, one could see that he was not so careless as the surface, otherwise, he would not be able to climb the high position of the General of the Front Dragon Army.

“What do you want?” Lei Tie’s eyes swept over the three men’s faces.

“Simple. Take on our challenge to battle.” Fang Shoujiang, General of the Central Supervision Army, had a bear’s loin and a tiger’s back¹, and a head of grey hair. He was nearly 50 years old and could still fight for another two years on the battlefield at most. Due to his age, he was the most eager for the position of the Defender Grand General of the State. If he couldn’t be promoted to another level within two years, it was impossible to be promoted to another level in the future.

General of the Rear Militant Army, Ding Wenchang, was also over 40 years old. He was wiry, capable, and experienced. Lei Tie was only 30 years old, that in which he considered just weaned. He had won no fewer battles than Lei Tie. Therefore, he had no problem with it. He stepped forward and expressed the same position as Tong Dibao and Fang Shoujiang. If they could defeat Lei Tie in front of so many soldiers, even if the emperor intended to defend Lei Tie, Lei Tie would lose his prestige in the army. At that time, the emperor would be forced to replace him even if he did not want to. This was his plan with Fang Shoujiang and Tong Dibao.

Lei Tie slightly nodded, “Restrain your subordinates. Come to the appointing platform.”

Seeing that he took the challenge, Tong Dibao’s group of three immediately spurred the horses to the drill ground to stop their subordinates.

In accordance with the superiors’ instructions, the soldiers quickly dispersed and returned to their ranks. The speed of their action could reflect that the prestige of Tong Dibao’s group of three in the army was not low.

Lei Tie stood on a high place. His eyes absorbed all of it without a change of expression.

Tong Dibao’s group of three rode to the appointing platform and saluted Lei Tie.

“Reporting, Grand General. The soldiers have assembled.”

Lei Tie motioned them to get on the appointing platform.

Tong Dibao’s group of three intended to frighten Lei Tie – they nimbly leaped from the horses directly to the front of the appointing platform.

Lei Tie lightly said, “You three come up together.”

The expressions of Tong Dibao’s group of three greatly changed.

“Grand General underestimates us!” Ding Wenchang said in a glum voice.

Lei Tie asked, “Aren’t you underestimating this General?”

Ding Wenchang was taken aback and had nothing to say in reply.

Tong Dibao hastened to mediate, “Grand General, General Ding didn’t mean it. He was just a little impatient. Please don’t mind it, Grand General.”

Lei Tie was noncommittal and repeated, “Come up together.”

Insult the man to excess! This thought flashed through the minds of Tong Dibao’s group of three at the same time. They looked at each other and surrounded Lei Tie in the middle.

“Grand General, [we’ll] offend you.” Fang Shoujiang took the lead.

Lei Tie signaled that they could start.

Tong Dibao was the most hot-tempered one. He leaped to Lei Tie and quickly and fiercely kicked toward Lei Tie’s right armpit with his right foot.

Lei Tie folded his left arm into an elbow, agilely rammed down, and ruthlessly struck the opponent’s instep.

The entire of Tong Dibao’s right leg felt pain, so much so that it shook slightly. He was greatly alarmed. Knowing that there was no need to continue to probe, he cast a warning look to Fang Shoujiang with a grave expression.

Fang Shoujiang was a veteran – how could he miss Tong Dibao’s reaction? Even if Tong Dibao didn’t say it, he also realized that Lei Tie really was not an easy opponent. He nodded to Tong Dibao slightly behind Lei Tie.

The soldiers below saw the situation on the appointing platform. They all restrained their excitement and kept their eyes glued on the match.

Ding Wenchang stood aside and did not put on an offensive stand. When Lei Tie, Tong Dibao, and Fang Shoujiang fought again, he quietly changed his pace and always kept the position on the left behind Lei Tie. What he

was going to do was obvious. No one would think that his sneak attack was despicable because on the battlefield, every soldier had only one goal: to kill the enemy and save himself by all means.

However, until more than 20 moves later, Ding Wenchang was shocked to realize that he had never found a chance to start! Lei Tie seemed to be careless, but in fact, he had a tight defense.

He did not hesitate to give up the plan of sneak attack and joined the battle.

Some of the soldiers could not help muttering, “The generals are going too far. They are three against one.”

Others had no idea that Fang Shoujiang’s group of three were more and more frightened. When they exerted 30% of strength, Lei Tie used 40% of strength to suppress them; when they exerted 40% of strength, Lei Tie used 50% of strength to suppress them²..... In any case, he was always 10% higher than them. He was not just suppressing them so they didn’t have the strength to fight back, but also made them completely unable to find out his limitation.

Until nearly an hour later, Ding Wenchang was the first to let go of the idea of resistance and convinced of Lei Tie [strength]. If they continued to fight, he, Fang Shoujiang, and Tong Dibao would only be disgraced.

Fang Shoujiang was still not resigned, but Ding Wenchang’s opinion wavered his thoughts, which also affected Tong Dibao.

Ultimately, Fang Shoujiang and Tong Dibao could only look at each other and stopped at the same time.

Not all of the soldiers below were able to discern the profound mystery within this [battle]. When they saw Tong Dibao’s group of three knelt respectfully to salute Lei Tie, they all understood.

Lei Tie raised his hand to the three people and made a “please get up” gesture. He sank the qi to his dantian and said in a deep voice, “Continue to drill.”

It was just three words, but it was like thunder in everyone's ears. From this, they could see the depth of Lei Tie's skills.

None of the soldiers was not wearing a look of awe and veneration as they landed on one knee in unison, and uniformly shouted "Grand General is mighty", imbued with a spirit that could conquer mountains and rivers.

Footnotes

1. thick powerful back (and shoulder), tough and strong
2. The strength here is based on their [the three men] strength, not Lei Tie. They didn't know LT's strength capacity. So they measured it with theirs.

Chapter 177: White Spot and Golden Fur Search for Masters

177 — White Spot and Golden Fur Search for Masters

The two newly bought stores were on the same prosperous street. One was on the side of Pear Blossom Alley, the other was on the opposite side – they were not far apart. One could see the other store by standing at the door of one store. Qin Mian had people decorated the two stores at the same time. The drugstore was called “Ruyi¹ Pharmacy” and the silverware store was called “Jewel Pavilion”.

About ten days after decoration, the drugstore and the silverware store opened on the same day. The layout of the drugstore was very simple; into the entrance was the counter and the seats of the two doctors. Behind the counter, two medicine cabinets were placed against the wall, and more than a hundred small drawers of the same size were filled with different herbs. The name of the herbs was written on the drawers. The medicine cabinet was tall and had a top. When one grasped some of the herbs, one even needed to use a double-ladder. In the drugstore, two experienced doctors were hired to see the patients, two assistants were in charge of the prescription, and then a manager.

The layout of the silverware shop was also characterized by simplicity and style. Customers could see all kinds of jewelry behind the counter at a glance as soon as they entered. All jewelry was priced clearly. Besides, Jewel Pavilion also had a type of honorable service. As long as customers could afford the expensive price, the master designer could even design unique jewelry for customers according to their requirements. It was unique not only in the whole Capital but also in the whole country.

Since Lei Tie's identity was special, the two stores opened quietly, with only one round of firecracker each. Even so, there were still a lot of people sending gifts. Even the emperor, the empress, and the empress dowager gave gifts. Qin Mian ordered the servants to go and make a list of all the gifts. Except for those sent by the emperor, the empress, and the empress dowager, all the expensive gifts were sent back to avoid being talked about.

Ruyi Pharmacy opened at the beginning of the dragon hour [7 AM] and closed at the beginning of the rooster hour [5 PM]; Jewel Pavilion opened at the beginning of the snake hour [9 AM] and closed at the beginning of the rooster hour [5 PM]. Both stores had a day-off on the first day of the month and a holiday on the last three days of every two months. The attentive customers found that the holidays of the two stores were the same as those of Dongyang Academy.

After opening for more than half a month, the business of the silverware store was quite good because the designs of the jewelry were relatively novel and unique. On the other hand, the business of Ruyi Pharmacy was average; it was unknown whether it was because of the lack of publicity, but most of the customers came in to buy prescriptions instead of seeing a doctor. The two doctors were bored and could only read medical books every day. The drugstore manager could hardly retain his composure. He noticed that the situation was not good and quickly reported the matter to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian was very calm and told the manager to do his duty well and that no matter the business was good or bad, it would not affect his salary. Since the employer was not worried, the manager had to drop it.

The business of the store was not good, Qin Mian couldn't ignore it. He was just waiting for an opportunity – an opportunity to make his mark at the first shot. The development of a drugstore was different from that of other stores – it was not enough to rely on mere lip service.

After the two stores operated normally, Qin Mian focused on the transformation of the State Defender Duke Establishment. After living in Leisurely Farmhouse for a long time, the standard requirements of the family of four for the living environment were high. They were not used to

many places in the State Defender Duke Establishment. Qin Mian devoted two days to draw the transformation plan, mainly changing all the trees into fruit trees and replanting flowers and plants in some open spaces.

When Lei Tie came back from the army camp, he rolled up his sleeves and took up a shovel to help Qin Mian. He was not completely unconcerned about the mud on his clothes.

The newly bought servants in the household saw it and silently admired the rare scene. Knowing that the two masters didn't like them go on gossiping, they were clever enough to keep silent.

"A-Tie, Ruiqi and Ruilin have a holiday tomorrow. In the afternoon, we'll go to Dongyang Academy to pick them up." Qin Mian held on the fruit tree that had been put into the tree pit.

Lei Tie filled the pit with soil. "En."

Fearing that Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were hungry, Qin Mian managed to find time to make some snacks in the afternoon.

At this time, on the public road about a *li* away from the South Gate of the Capital, a black shadow and a golden shadow ran side by side toward the Capital. The black shadow was as fast as lightning, and the golden shadow was as smooth as a meteor. After seeing what they were, the passers-by on the public road turned pale with fright. They made a hasty retreat to both sides and sat down on the ground with weakened legs. They opened their mouths wide and watched the two dreadful beasts gallop toward the South Gate.

These two shadows were actually White Spot and Golden Fur.

For them, their four masters had been away for a long time, so the two made up their minds to travel thousands of *li* to the Capital to find their masters. For humans, they were too threatening. They had been besieged many times along the way. Although both of them had great abilities, they still suffered a lot. White Spot's black fur was dirty and tangled out of

several knots. Golden Fur suffered no less; its dazzling golden fur was covered with dry mud. Fortunately, neither was injured.

Thanks to White Spot acting as the guide and that the two had intelligent, all the way from Green Mountain Village to the Capital, they had not gone the wrong way. After half a month of running, they finally arrived without a hitch.

Upon seeing the familiar South Gate, White Spot uttered “awoo” to Golden Fur, and the two sped up at the same time.

They knew that the soldiers guarding the city gate would be threatened. Thus, when the two entered the city, they swept by like a gust of wind. The soldiers only saw two shadows passing by. After a careful look, they found nothing unusual.

Yuan Anshi had a spell of bad luck. Until now, he was still a fifth rank official. Recently, he was hesitating whether he should go to greet the State Defender Duke. Lei Tie was, after all, his junior [younger generation]. He was still pulled by saving his face, so he had been hesitant over what to do. He was walking to and fro in his study with a worried face when he heard the noise outside. His face turned glum and he cried out, “What’s the noise outside? What a scandal to make an unnecessary racket!”

A manservant came in stumbling with a pale face, “O-Old Master... W-Wolf... a-and a bear!”

“What?” Yuan Anshi frowned and said, “From whose house did they escaped... No one in the Capital’s raised—” Speaking of this, he remembered that Lei Tie’s family had a wolf and he didn’t hear that Lei Tie had brought his wolf to the Capital this time.

“Come, take me there.”

The manservant was shocked: Old Master doesn’t want to live?

“Why don’t you lead the way?” shouted Yuan Anshi anxiously.

“Yes, yes!”

The manservant ran forward in a slip.

Shortly, they came to the entrance gate. A wolf and a bear squatted quietly facing the gate of Yuan Residence. The eight servants of the Yuan household had sticks in their hands aimed at the wolf and the bear, but they did not dare to approach them, only shivered, fearing that if they were careless, one of them would be torn to death.

As soon as Yuan Anshi saw the white spot between the wolf’s eyebrows, he understood. He found that both the wolf and the bear were so tame, so he tentatively stepped forward and said the name of Qin Mian’s family, “Are you here to find Qin Mian and Lei Tie, as well as... Yuanyuan and Manman?”

Upon seeing White Spot’s ears perked and head slightly lowered, which was very similar to a nod, Yuan Anshi said in haste, “I’ll take you to find them.”

White Spot stood up, took a step forward, and looked back at Yuan Anshi as if it was signaling him to lead the way. Golden Fur also stood up – a simple and naïve look.

Yuan Anshi bravely walked over and peeked at White Spot and the golden bear from the corner of his eyes. They didn’t show any means of attacking, so he became even more relaxed as he led the way.

At this time, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were on horseback to Dongyang Academy.

When they arrived at Dongyang Academy, they were surprised to see several rows of carriages stopped in front of the academy and many waiting adults came to pick up their children from school.

Qin Mian dismounted his horse and looked around casually. Unexpectedly, he found Chen Mufeng shaking a folding fan next to a carriage opposite him and staring at the gate of the academy. Obviously, he was waiting for

someone. He poked Lei Tie's back and pointed his chin to hint him to look over there quickly.

A smile flashed through Lei Tie's eyes and he looked along his wife's line of sight.

Chen Mufeng didn't notice that some people were looking at him – he focused on looking at the front.

“Is his other half still studying?” Qin Mian was extremely curious.

Lei Tie said, “Maybe.”

At this time, the bell of Dongyang Academy rang. After a while, the students of the academy swarmed to the gate from different directions.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie no longer paid attention to Chen Mufeng and kept a close eye on the stream of people.

In a moment, Qin Mian saw Qin Ruilin and Lei Ruilin walking out side by side with their small schoolbags. Qin Ruiqi was the silent type and rather had the demeanor of an elder brother. From time to time, he stretched out his little arm to block the flow of people to prevent Ruilin from being bump into. Lei Ruilin was also very considerate of his Gege. He pulled his Gege aside and let others go first. When the crowd was a little looser, they walked toward the gate.

Qin Mian was very pleased to see it clearly. As the two sons came near, he raised his voice and called out, “Ruiqi, Ruilin.”

When Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin saw them, their faces expressed surprise, and they ran to that side quickly. It was the first time that their two fathers came to pick them up from school in person. The two boys were very happy.

“Dad, Old Dad!”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, as the only twins in the academy and the only students who have two fathers but no mother, were already celebrities of

Dongyang Academy. When they called out “Dad” and “Old Dad”, the students around them immediately looked out of the gate and their eyes fell on Qin Mian and Lei Tie. As soon as they saw the two men’s elegant demeanor and temperament, they couldn’t say anything bad and even moved to make way for Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin quickly cupped their hands to express their gratitude and ran to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. The two brothers grinned at the same time, “Dad, Old Dad!”

“En.” Qin Mian touched the heads of his two sons and looked behind them as he said with a smile, “Are they your friends?”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin turned around and saw several students standing behind them.

“Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, these two are your fathers?” A 13~14 years old boy looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie curiously. While he spoke, he bowed with his hands cupped toward them politely.

Footnotes

1. 如意 [rú yì] as one wishes; as one likes it; ruyi scepter, a symbol of power and good fortune

Chapter 178: Reunion

178 – Reunion

“Exactly.” Qin Ruiqi nodded calmly and introduced them, “This is my Dad and this is my Old Dad.”

Lei Ruilin knew that his Gege didn’t like to talk, so he said, “Dad, Old Dad. This is my and Gege’s friend Feng You, and these are our classmates...”

From his look, Qin Mian could basically tell which of the five students had a better relationship and a general relationship with his sons. Without exception, he smiled back at them and then took off the food box in the saddle and opened the lid.

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, invite your friends to have a snack.”

Lei Tie took off the schoolbags on the back of his two sons and held them in his hands easily.

“You have a gourmet’s luck. My Dad’s snacks are very delicious.” Lei Ruilin took out a bamboo tube from the food box and held it out to Feng You and the others.

Feng You and the others didn’t understand. He didn’t seem to invite them to drink.

Lei Ruilin showed some helpless look on his face and reminded them, “Wash your hands.”

Feng You and the others understood and inwardly thought that Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin’s Dad was very attentive. They stretched out their hands and let Lei Ruilin wash their hands.

After they washed their hands, they said thanks and took a piece of cake from the plate. Once they took a bite, their eyes brightened – Lei Ruilin spoke the truth.

The snacks were shared among the seven children. Except for Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, the rest of the five people had faces of wanting more.

After Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin said farewell to their friends, Qin Mian and Lei Tie carried them to their horses.

Qin Mian looked back in the direction of Chen Mufeng. When Qin Mian called out to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, Chen Mufeng discovered him and Lei Tie. He happened to see a 6~7 years old little boy standing beside Chen Mufeng who didn't look like him.

The two men's eyes bumped into each other. Slightly embarrassed, Chen Mufeng smiled at Qin Mian smile, his right hand uneasily moved away from the little boy's shoulder.

Qin Mian's eyes were full of teasing as he raised an eyebrow at Chen Mufeng.

Chen Mufeng helplessly shook his hands at Qin Mian and then held the little boy again.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie nodded to him and rode away.

On the way, Qin Mian suddenly noticed the fluctuation of vital spirit in the distance. He was surprised. His first reaction was: *Are there any other cultivators in the Capital besides them?* However, it was impossible. Back then, A-Tie's master said that he just fell into this space by accident. There were no other cultivators in this space except him.

“A-Tie?”

A bit of shock revealed from within Lei Tie's eyes and he also thought of going over quick, “Go have a look.”

Just then, a familiar wolf's roar came from the distance.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were shocked again and looked at each other in surprise and bewilderment.

“Could it be White Spot and Golden Fur?” Qin Mian cried out involuntarily.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin’s eyes turned round.

Lei Ruilin anxiously urged, “Dad, let’s go and have a look. It must be White Spot and Golden Fur!”

Qin Mian had suspected it too. It was thousands of li from Running Water Town to the Capital. Even if White Spot and Golden Fur wanted to find them, could they get to the Capital smoothly?

He picked up Lei Ruilin, abandoned his horse, and flew away, “A-Tie, I’ll have a look first!”

Lei Tie took out a spindle of broken silver from his inner pocket and handed it to a passer-by, “Excuse me, send the horses to the State Defender Duke Establishment.”

Before the passer-by could speak, he saw that the man with cold temperament was flying up as lithe as a swallow, the tip of his toe touched the roof beside the street, and soon he could not be seen.

With a bitter face, Yuan Anshi kept White Spot and Golden Fur behind him and looked awkwardly at Liu Tiande, the Commander of the Imperial Guard.

“Liu-daren, both the wolf and the bear have masters. You see...”

Liu Tiande wore a merciless face as he spoke with stern dutifulness, “Yuan-daren, since this officer is responsible for the safety of the Capital, this officer ought to be responsible for the people in the Capital. Don’t make it hard for this officer. Onward, kill them!”

His subordinates immediately raised their sabers and cautiously surrounded White Spot and Golden Fur.

Hiding in the distance, the onlookers yelled, “Kill them!”

“That’s right! Such ferocious beast can’t be kept alive!”

.....

Yuan Anshi went up to Liu Tiande and reminded him in a low voice, “Liu-daren, they are most likely from the State Defender Duke Establishment.”

Liu Tiande’s eyes flashed a touch of gloomy and inexplicable mood. Seamlessly, he passed a meaningful glance to one of his subordinates.

That subordinate yelled, “So what if it’s from the State Defender Duke Establishment? Will State Defender Duke not pay attention to people’s lives? Brothers, onward!”

White Spot opened its mouth and bared its teeth to them angrily. All of a sudden, it turned around and howled at the distant place, “AWOO—”

Golden Fur also turned and looked in the same direction. It excitedly jumped in place and its mouth made a strange puffing sound.

The crowd looked over in puzzlement, only to hear a childish voice full of excitement, “White Spot—Golden Fur—”

Qin Mian floated in the air and landed just between Liu Tiande and White Spot. Just now, he heard what Liu Tiande and his subordinates said clearly.

Lei Tie and Qin Ruiqi were only a step behind. Standing beside Qin Mian, Lei Tie dully glanced at Liu Tiande.

Liu Tiande’s movement paused.

Qin Mian saluted Liu Tiande with cupped hands. “Daren overstated. Our family has kept this wolf and this bear for almost eight years – they have never hurt anyone. Please rest assured.”

“Greetings, State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke.” After saluting Qin Mian and Lei Tie, Liu Tiande said in embarrassment,

“This officer naturally believes what Lady of the State Defender Duke said, but wolves and bears are fierce beasts. Them staying in the Capital will only cause people’s panic. State Defender Duke, you see this?”

He easily incited the people to yell that either kill White Spot and Golden Fur or drive them out of the Capital.

Lei Tie put Qin Ruiqi down and pressed him on the shoulder.

Qin Ruiqi glanced at Liu Tiande and held Lei Ruilin’s hand. When they looked at each other, they had a tacit understanding. Qin Ruiqi went to White Spot and beckoned it. White Spot immediately squatted down and let him ride on it back.

Lei Ruilin’s eyes turned for a bout. He pointed to Golden Fur and ordered, “Golden Fur, sit down.”

Golden Fur naïvely complied.

“Turn a somersault... Stand up... Roll on the ground... Jump... Lie down...”

Liu Tiande, his subordinates, and the common people were stunned to see that Golden Fur did exactly what Lei Ruilin said – they stared openmouthed. Some of the little kids were so amused they clapped their hands and giggled.

Lei Ruilin climbed on Golden Fur’s back, grabbed its fur, and played with it. He smiled sweetly at the onlookers, “Uncles and aunts, Golden Fur is very obedient and never hurt people at will.”

Lei Tie looked directly at Liu Tiande, “This officer came to the Capital without bringing them. Obviously, they came to the Capital by themselves to find their masters. This officer believes they will not hurt people at will. If Liu-daren is not at ease, do go investigate. If they did hurt people, this officer will take responsibility.”

The people watched the two children playing while on White Spot and Golden Fur's bodies and suddenly changed their minds.

"This wolf and bear are obviously domesticated – they won't hurt people."

"They must have suffered a lot on the way. They are as loyal as our dogs. It's very touching."

.....

With a calm face, Liu Tiande cupped his hands, "Many thanks for State Defender Duke's consideration. We're going."

Since White Spot and Golden Fur had come, the Qin Mian family could not send them away. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin intended to make the people less afraid of White Spot and Golden Fur. They each sat on the beast's back and let White Spot and Golden Fur carry them.

"Golden Fur..." Lei Ruilin lay on Golden Fur and embraced him. He was greatly distressed at the thought that it and White Spot had traveled thousands of li to the Capital to find them.

Although Qin Ruiqi didn't speak, his right hand caressed White Spot's back.

Qin Mian had long since noticed the difficulties of White Spot and Golden Fur. His heart ached for them and he was also very moved. He kneaded Golden Fur's big head. Golden Fur rubbed its big head against him affectionately.

Lei Tie was also quite moved in his heart and patted White Spot on its neck with appreciation. White Spot brushed his leg with its tail as a greeting. When it arrived in front of Yuan Anshi, it gave a low howl to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian still remembered Yuan Anshi, "Yuan-daren, hope that you're well? Many thanks for helping White Spot and Golden Fur."

Yuan Anshi said with a smile, “Greetings, Lady of the State Defender Duke. It’s only a little effort. In fact, it’s due to White Spot’s intelligence – it still remembers the location of my (polite) home.”

After that, he turned to Lei Tie, “Greetings, State Defender Duke.”

“No need to be polite,” said Lei Tie.

Qin Mian said, “I’ll go to your (honorific) home another day to thank Yuan-daren personally.”

Yuan Anshi was happy and hastily said, “I don’t deserve it.”

Qin Mian’s family of four, together with a wolf and a bear, went home unhurriedly, followed by a large group of people.

Outside the crowd, a man in his early thirties followed Qin Mian’s family, looking as if he was absorbed in thoughts. The man was dressed in a purple qipao robe¹, full of noble air, followed by two attendants.

“My Lord, something’s wrong?” One of the attendants asked cautiously. This master lord was the current empress’s younger brother, the Maternal Uncle of the State² Zhangsun He. He was the empress’s only younger brother of the same parents and thus deeply loved by the empress. He was also the emperor’s favorite because he was extremely versatile in all kinds of music, chess, calligraphy, and painting. He could be said to be the most popular person in the Imperial City. Could such a person be served carelessly?

Zhangsun He said casually, “It’s nothing. I just thought two men were familiar and seemed to have met them somewhere. Go to Dongyang Academy.”

“Yes.”

When Qin Mian’s family of four returned to the State Defender Duke Establishment, the two horses had been sent back.

Qin Mian ordered the servants to prepare food and hot water for White Spot and Golden Fur. When White Spot and Golden Fur had eaten and drank enough, the large quantity of hot water was done. The family of four bathed White Spot and Golden Fur together.

White Spot and Golden Fur lay obediently, letting them scrub their bodies. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin talked to them from time to time, as if they were talking to people normally. White Spot and Golden Fur were either nodding or making a few sounds occasionally. Qin Mian had already sent the others away, but neither was he afraid that anyone would find something unusual.

“Dad, we need to prepare a room for White Spot and Golden Fur,” said Lei Ruilin as he brushed White Spot’s fur.

Qin Mian said, “Don’t worry, I’ve already sent people to prepare. Ruilin, careful. Don’t get your clothes wet.”

“Dad, is their room in the main courtyard?” asked Qin Ruiqi.

Qin Mian said, “Yes, next door to your and Ruilin’s room.”

Seeing that Qin Ruiqi’s rolled-up sleeves were loosened and wet for the most part, Lei Tie bent down and rolled them up for him again.

The family was busy when Steward Fu came over.

“Reporting, my Lord. People from the Palace has come.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood up and saw a eunuch standing beside Steward Fu.

The junior eunuch came forward and saluted them respectfully. “Greetings, State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke. This servant came to pass on His Majesty’s verbal instruction.”

Lei Tie asked, “What is His Majesty’s instruction?”

The junior eunuch said, “Tomorrow is the rest day of Dongyang Academy. His Majesty said that the two young gongzis have not been in the Palace to

see him for a long time. Also, His Majesty wants to see the two pets of the State Defender Duke establishment.”

Lei Tie nodded as he said, “Report to His Majesty on behalf of this officer: [we] will enter the Palace tomorrow to pay respect.”

“Yes. The servant will take his leave.”

Qin Mian hinted at Steward Fu with his eyes. Steward Fu understood and gave the eunuch a good reward and sent him away.

Qin Ruiqi asked, “Old Dad, are Didi and I going to the Palace tomorrow to see Uncle Emperor?”

“En.” Lei Tie asked, “Do you want to see the emperor again?”

Qin Ruiqi nodded slightly, “The emperor is still not bad.”

Qin Mian laughed to himself. The word “still” was subtle.

Lei Ruilin asked him, “Last time, Uncle Emperor invited us to eat snacks. Gege and I also want to give some to Uncle Emperor.”

“Sure,” Qin Mian said, “I’ll teach you after washing White Spot and Golden Fur.”

Footnotes

1. the sign of an official position
2. Since the empress was the Mother of the State, her brother was given the (unofficial) title Maternal Uncle of the State. By the way, I can’t find a relevant source (may also be due to laziness), so if I’m wrong, excuse me.

Chapter 179: The Death of Du Shi

179 – The Death of Du Shi

After the bath, White Spot and Golden Fur knew how to use qi to dry their furs. Looking at their energetic, clean, and refreshing appearances, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin loved them even more and embraced them.

Lei Ruilin looked at Qin Mian pleadingly, “Dad, I want to sleep with Golden Fur at night.”

Qin Mian nodded, “Sure.” After White Spot and Golden Fur had cultivation, lice and other things couldn’t get close to them. It was fine to let children sleep with them for a night.

After dinner, Qin Mian laid a thick rug on the floor of Lei Ruilin’s room. After the two children had a bath, they jumped on the rug happily and had a tussle with White Spot and Golden Fur. When Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were younger, most of the time, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were too busy to take care of them. It was White Spot and Golden Fur who took care of the children. Therefore, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin’s feelings for White Spot and Golden Fur were extraordinary deeper. In White Spot and Golden Fur’s hearts, the two little masters were also particularly important. Both of them obediently let Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin embrace and knead them. When two children were about to fall because they ran too fast, they would be dragged up back in time.

Qin Mian told the two children not to play until late at night and then went back to his room with Lei Tie.

Lei Tie had bathed. He was dressed only in his nightclothes, leaning on the head of the bed with a book in his hand.

Qin Mian went into the washroom and saw the clean nightclothes on the chair beside the bathtub. He knew who put them there; he gave a wee of a smile. After he took a quick bath, he came to the side of the bed and pounced on the reading man.

Lei Tie pecked on his lips, put the book on the cabinet on the bed, and lay down with him.

Qin Mian pressed on Lei Tie's body and lightly rubbed his leg with Lei Tie's, "I'll also go to the Palace tomorrow. [We] don't know what Emperor Xiaohui is up to. I'm not at ease if I don't follow."

"En. I'll pick you up when I come back from the Court." Lei Tie's hand stroked into his nightclothes.....

The next day, when Lei Tie came back from the Court, Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin had packed up some snacks for Emperor Xiaohui and put them in a round food box. White Spot and Golden Fur also had dressed up. White Spot wore a black and red striped twill vest and a red bowtie around its neck – it looked purely proud and elegant. Golden Fur also wore clothes, which was a sleeveless blue round-neck shirt that just perfectly wrapped its huge body – it looked mighty, elegant, and unconventional.

After Lei Tie changed his clothes, the family of six went out together. Qin Mian and Lei Tie rode horses; Lei Tie carried the food box with unknown weight in his hand. Since White Spot and Golden Fur had come to the Capital, it was impossible to keep them in the space or the State Defender Duke Establishment all the time. Qin Mian intended to let the people in the Capital get used to their existence. Thus, he let Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin ride on White Spot and Golden Fur respectively.

It was not surprising that humans could tame wolves and bears. There were animal trainers in the Capital, who often performed with all kinds of animals. However, it was strange that two horses, one wolf, and one bear could coexist so harmoniously without being specially controlled and even dressed like a human – people couldn't help but feel strange. On both sides of the street soon gathered a large group of people with strange looks on their faces.

With a smile on his face, Lei Ruilin kept waving to the crowd on both sides. He even hinted at Qin Ruiqi with his eyes, signaling him to wave.

Qin Ruiqi's eyes flashed a helpless look so similar to Lei Tie. Taking White Spot and Golden Fur into consideration, he waved his hands nonetheless. His appearance of waving hands with that small wooden face not only made people love it but also made them amused.

The people looked at the lovely appearance of the two little brothers – one was smiling and the other was expressionless – and waved to them happily.

Qin Mian's eyes overflowed with smiles.

It was not good to cause blockage on the street, so he and Lei Tie raised the whips to let the horses trot up. White Spot and Golden Fur hopped easily and followed after them.

At the gate of the Palace, four palace attendants had been waiting for a long time. As soon as they saw the big wolf and bear from a distance, they inwardly trembled. Upon clearly seeing the two children sitting on the back of the wolf and bear, they calmed down.

“Greetings, State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender!”

“Don't stand on ceremonies.” Lei Tie and Qin Mian jumped off the horses and passed the reins to a palace attendant.

Another palace attendant said respectfully, “State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender, His Majesty is in the imperial garden. Please follow this servant.”

Lei Tie instructed another palace attendant, “You go report to His Majesty first.”

After saluting, the palace attendant ran away and informed the emperor that White Spot and Golden Fur were not sent in a cage.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin jumped off White Spot and Golden Fur's backs and landed smoothly.

When Qin Mian's family arrived at the imperial garden, they were shocked to find that almost every *zhang* [3m] in the garden stood an upright, fully armed Imperial Guard, staring at White Spot and Golden Fur on alert.

White Spot and Golden Fur seemed not to notice – their gaits were still calm and unhurried.

In the spacious quadrangle pavilion, gauze curtains on the eaves fluttered. Emperor Xiaohui, the empress dowager, and the empress were all here. Qin Mian thought to himself that the empress and the empress dowager's skins were much better than when they met last time. It was obvious that they already used the beauty cream he gifted.

Besides them, there was also a young miss in the pavilion about 16~17 years old and looked six points similar to Emperor Xiaohui – she had a pair of shrewd eyes. She was holding onto Emperor Xiaohui's arm intimately. At the sight of White Spot and Golden Fur, there was a look of surprise in the young miss's eyes and an expression of itching to do something on her face. This was Princess Duanning, who was 16 years old. She was favored by Emperor Xiaohui because her looks were similar to Emperor Xiaohui.

Qin Mian made White Spot and Golden Fur lie down and went forward with Lei Tie and his two sons to give a salute.

Emperor Xiaohui laughed in a clear loud voice, "Rise."

"Thank you, Your Majesty."

Emperor Xiaohui beckoned Yuanyuan and Manman, pretending to be angry, "Yuanyuan and Manman, didn't you promise to see Uncle Emperor? What took you so long?"

Yuanyuan and Manman walked over without fear and each leaned close to him on both sides.

"Forgive us, Uncle Emperor. My Didi and I have just entered Dongyang Academy. It took some time to adapt," said Qin Ruiqi.

Lei Ruilin added with a smile on his face, “My Gege and I made snacks for Uncle Emperor.”

“Oh? Present it. Did Yuanyuan and Manman make them by yourselves?” Emperor Xiaohui put his arms around them. The joy on his face didn’t seem to be fake.

The empress dowager, the empress, and Princess Duanning had carefully looked at Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin – this was not surprising. The two children themselves were lovable. They weren’t afraid to face so many noble people. They had such courageous hearts at a young age that anyone would come to love them more.

Just then, a palace attendant took the food box from Lei Tie and presented it to Eunuch Li.

Eunuch Li opened the food box – there were three layers. Emperor Xiaohui, the empress dowager, the empress, and Princess Duanning all showed a look of wonder. The first layer was a rice bowl-sized cake, with a rich aroma and bright colors, a total of nine pieces; the second layer was an attractive pizzeria, which was also nine pieces; the third layer was double-layer steamed milk custard, which was also nine pieces. The snacks on each layer were quite distinct from each other. The six on the left were beautiful, and the three on the right were not very good-looking.

Lei Ruilin gave a toothy smile to Emperor Xiaohui in embarrassment, “These ugly ones are made by Gege and me. The others are made by Dad.”

Emperor Xiaohui laughed and patted his small shoulder, “It’s fine. The ones that Yuanyuan and Manman personally made must be delicious.”

Eunuch Li swallowed his saliva secretly, but he didn’t forget his duty. He was about to try it first, but he was blocked by Emperor Xiaohui. Eunuch Li hurriedly opened the emperor’s special cutlery box and handed him the silver spoon with both hands.

Emperor Xiaohui took the spoon, dug a piece of the ugliest cake, tasted it, and nodded, “En, delicious.”

Qin Mian admired Emperor Xiaohui's courage – surprisingly, he didn't worry that they would poison him.

Emperor Xiaohui did not act thusly until he thought about it clearly that Qin Mian and Lei Tie would not use their sons even if they wanted to harm him.

After eating, Emperor Xiaohui gave each of the small cakes to the empress dowager, the empress, and Princess Duanning. The three did not even look hesitant as they tasted the cake. Words of praise were uttered without ceasing.

Emperor Xiaohui gave another each to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin.

The few people ate until they were satisfied.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood by calmly.

After eating the cake, Emperor Xiaohui looked at the wolf and the bear which had been lying on the ground and looked very obedient. He asked Qin Mian how long he had kept them, what he usually fed them.....

Qin Mian was afraid that Emperor Xiaohui would covet White Spot and Golden Fur, so he answered very carefully.

It was not known whether Emperor Xiaohui saw his (QM) worry so that he lamented, "For White Spot and Golden Fur to go find their masters from afar, their loyalty is commendable – more reliable than some people. Li Fushou, pass on Zhen's order: henceforth, send some food to White Spot and Golden Fur every day."

"Yes, Your Majesty."

Qin Mian didn't know whether Emperor Xiaohui's saying "more reliable than some people" had another meaning. He and Lei Tie just bent over to express gratitude.

"Reporting, Your Majesty. The Young Marquis is here." A palace attendant came from a distance, stepped forward, and informed him.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie questioningly.

Lei Tie relayed it inwardly, *“Zhangsun Yun, the father of the empress, was granted the title of Marquis of Weiyuan by His Majesty. The Young Marquis is the legitimate son of Marquis of Weiyuan – Zhangsun He, the younger brother of the empress.”*

In a moment, a young man was seen coming with vigorous steps, wearing a jade crown and a purple robe.

Zhangsun He first greeted Emperor Xiaohui and the others.

Emperor Xiaohui was very gentle to Zhangsun He and beckoned him to get closer, “A-He, no need to be ceremonious. What brings you to the Palace today?”

When the empress saw that her younger brother received the emperor’s favor, the corner of her lips was filled with smiling expression and pride.

Zhangsun He looked at White Spot and Golden Fur and said with a smile, “I heard that the State Defender Duke had brought the beasts into the Palace. I was very curious, so I came to have a look.”

Based on the rank, his rank was lower than that of Lei Tie. After he said that, he saluted Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

White Spot arched its body slightly and growled in a low voice to Zhangsun He.

Qin Mian was very surprised. He quickly raised his hand and made a gesture. White Spot obediently lay down again.

Lei Tie promptly said, “Hope Young Marquis do not blame it.”

Zhangsun He made nothing of it. He said with a smile, “State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke, we’ve met before.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie look at each other, failed to understand so.

Zhangsun He looked at White Spot and smilingly said, “Back then, if nothing had happened, this wolf should have been mine.”

Qin Mian suddenly remembered, “It turned out that the man back then was Young Marquis.”

Emperor Xiaohui was curious, so Zhangsun He told about the matter of him catching White Spot by chance back then.

Emperor Xiaohui lamented at the wonder of fate.

Zhangsun He turned his head to look at Lei Tie and said, “State Defender Duke has better hurry back.”

Lei Tie’s expression turned cold, “Young Marquis, please speak bluntly.”

Zhangsun He sat down on the stone bench and said casually, “Before coming, I heard that your mother was killed less than a moment after she left the prison.”

Chapter 180: Commandery Prince Mu and the Young Marquis

180 – Commandery Prince Mu and the Young Marquis

Qin Mian was astounded. *Du Shi's dead? Who'd have attacked a woman of the inner chambers?*

“Your Majesty, [I] beg your forgiveness [to leave].” Lei Tie looked at Emperor Xiaohui.

Emperor Xiaohui's eyes were gloomy. He was also thinking about who would attack Du Shi. In the eyes of the emperor, Du Shi was not only a woman of the inner chambers but also “the mother of the State Defender Duke”. He could not help suspecting that there was something else behind Du Shi's murder. He did not doubt Lei Tie. If Lei Tie wanted to attack Du Shi, he would not wait until now.

“En, my dear subject Lei shall be excused.”

Qin Ruiqi sensibly said, “Ruiqi and Ruilin will come to see Uncle Emperor some other day.”

Emperor Xiaohui said with a smile, “Alright.”

After Qin Mian's group of four asked for forgiveness, they left with White Spot and Golden Fur.

Princess Duanning regretfully watched White Spot and Golden Fur go away. Golden Fur seemed simple and honest while carrying cuteness. She had wanted to be close to it.

“A-He, stay in the Palace for lunch today. You haven’t been in the Palace for a long time, accompany Zhen for a good chat,” said Emperor Xiaohui to Zhangsun He.

Zhangsun He naturally agreed, “Obedience is better than politeness.”

The empress dowager, the empress, and Princess Duanning saw that the men had something to say, so they made excuses to leave.

Princess Duanning walked along the cobblestone path with her senior palace maid and six junior maids. Her eyes flitted past the colorful flowers. She was in a good mood and her steps were light. Just as she passed by the moon-shaped gate, she saw her eldest imperial sister, Yanqing, standing there with a gloomy face, just like a ghost. She was so frightened her heart almost jumped out.

“Why are you here alone, Eldest Imperial Sister?” Princess Duanning didn’t like this eldest imperial sister, but she had to smile at her for the Imperial Clan’s propriety.

Princess Yanqing coldly curved the corner of her lips and raised her chin, “Imperial Father summoned State Defender Duke’s family and actually let you be present. Did they want to marry you to State Defender Duke? Right now, you must have felt complacent, right?”

Princess Duanning laughed angrily and sweetly. She took Princess Yanqing’s arm and said, “Eldest Imperial Sister~~ do you think this Imperial Sister doesn’t care about reputation like you? This Imperial Sister is a person of noble birth and has an honorable identity. Whatever kind of husband [I] want to find, [I] won’t lean toward shamelessly getting involved in other people’s marriage? Eldest Imperial Sister~~ you have treated this Imperial Sister unjustly.” Every word was satirizing Princess Yanqing. After she said that, she even stamped her foot in a grievance.

Like master, like servants. The palace maids behind her were not afraid of Princess Yanqing. They all lowered their heads and pursed their lips as they snickered.

Princess Yanqing was so angry that her eyes seemed to be bursting with fire.

“Duanning, you impudent!”

Princess Duanning released her arm. She pursed her mouth and blinked her eyes, fanning her long and curly eyelashes. Playful and cute, the sound of her laughter was as clear as a silver bell. “Is Eldest Imperial Sister confused? This Imperial Sister and you are of the same rank. What ‘impudent’ are you talking about?”

She looked up at the sky and said, “Oh my, the sun today is really poisonous. This Imperial Sister has to go back earlier to avoid sunburn. Eldest Imperial Sister, this Imperial Sister I will leave first.”

Princess Duanning curtsied and went off with a swagger. After two steps, she turned back. “Oh, forgot to tell Eldest Imperial Sister. Imperial Grandmother and Imperial Mother have used the beauty cream sent by Lady of the State Defender Duke. The result was remarkable. If Eldest Imperial Sister needs it, this Imperial Sister I can go to Imperial Grandmother and Imperial Mother to ask them to spare a jar to give Eldest Imperial Sister. If it’s not maintained properly, it’ll be too late. This Imperial Sister leaves first!”

Fury broiled endlessly in Princess Yanqing’s chest, which then exhausted all of her strength. Princess Yanqing could only support herself on the wall weakly. The hatred in her eyes was mixed with strong unwillingness. However, when she thought of Qin Mian’s means, she turned pale and could only stamp her foot and fling her sleeve.

In the quadrangle pavilion, the breeze was gentle and the tea fragrance was faint.

“A-He, who do you think has attacked the State Defender Duke’s mother?” asked Emperor Xiaohui.

Zhangsun He said with a smile, “Isn’t brother-in-law aware that I’ve never cared about these things? Today is just a coincidence.”

How could Emperor Xiaohui not notice his avoidance? He slightly shook his head and gave a faint smile with a hint of tolerance. Back then, a war broke out between the State of Great Xia and Western Barbarian. The soldiers of Great Xia suffered heavy casualties. The highly-skilled doctor Zeng Shuyi couldn't bear it and went to the battlefield at the age of 70 to heal the soldiers of Great Xia. He even used strange medicine to save the commanding general Huang who had only a thread of life left. Doctor Zeng was famous all over the country for his righteousness. He stayed on the battlefield for three years and eventually died of overwork. It wasn't long before there was a rumor among the people that Doctor Zeng saved General Huang with a Qingli pill¹ and gave the last Qingli pill to a predestined person before he died.

What was the Qingli pill? According to historical records, more than 200 years ago, Wei Lianzhi, a famous contemporary doctor, used a Qingli pill to save the life of the old emperor whose body was inflicted with a strange poison. In order to thank Wei Lianzhi, the emperor especially married down² a princess to Wei Lianzhi's son. But later, unknown of what misfortune had happened, the prescription of the Qingli pill was lost. Over time, more doctors tended to think that the Qingli pill only existed in legends. After all, the saying "can solve any strange poison" was too incredible.

However, eight years ago, Zhangsun He unexpectedly got a Qingli pill. Zhangsun He went all the way to find the military doctor who had treated General Huang together with Doctor Zeng and confirmed that the Qingli pill had the miraculous effect of detoxifying hundreds of poisons. Therefore, he presented it to Emperor Xiaohui. It was no wonder that Emperor Xiaohui extremely trusted Zhangsun He.

Back then, the reason why Lei Tie dared to take out the precious Qingli pill was that folk legend confirmed that there was only one Qingli pill. If the white-clothed man really knew what Qingli pill was, he would have heard of this legend, and naturally would not insist Lei Tie, a rural villager, to give him more Qingli pills.

Zhangsun He and Emperor Xiaohui both only knew today that the current State Defender Duke was the original owner of the Qingli pill.

Emperor Xiaohui thought that since the highly-skilled Doctor Zeng was willing to save General Huang with a Qingli pill, it was not surprising that he gave the other Qingli pill to another general. Back then, he was still a bit resentful toward Zeng Shuyi. He was the emperor and had supreme status. Yet, Zeng Shuyi did not present the treasure to him, but gave it to some “predestined person”. Unexpectedly, with twists and turns, the Qingli pill still fell into his hands.

Emperor Xiaohui changed the topic, “Are you and Mufeng still in trouble?”

Zhangsun He’s face first showed a little smile, but also showed a bit of exasperation, “Yesterday, it was Mufeng who picked up Minzhi after school. Nevertheless, Imperial Prince Ming is still unrelenting.”

“You are both the people Zhen cares about. Zhen isn’t in the position to take care of your affairs.” Emperor Xiaohui shook his head with a helpless expression. Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He – one was the younger generation of the Imperial Clan and the other was the Maternal Uncle of the State. Both were Emperor Xiaohui’s taboo people, so the two men mingled together was in line with his intention. Zhangsun He already had an offspring, but Mufeng had not. That was why, Imperial Prince Ming never let go of their affairs and made a request that unless Chen Mufeng had an offspring, he would agree to Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He to be together. But Zhangsun He disagreed to let Chen Mufeng get involved with women. Therefore, the three were still in a deadlock and it seemed that they would continue to be in a deadlock for a long time. Emperor Xiaohui didn’t care about these details. He just wanted to make sure that Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He were no threat to him.

Meanwhile, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went back to the State Defender Duke Establishment directly after leaving the Palace. As expected, Steward Fu came to report that Lei Xiangzhi had come to inform of the funeral. When he learned that their family had entered the Palace, he left in a hurry.

After Qin Mian's family of four changed into plain clothes, they got on the carriage and went to Lei Xiangzhi's home.

On the way, the couple communicated in mind.

"A-Tie, what do you think went wrong?" asked Qin Mian. Generally speaking, Du Shi had only herself to blame. Originally, when ten days came, Lei Tie would have her released. But Du Shi was used to arrogance. For her ten days in prison, Lei Xiangzhi spent money on the prison guards. Although the living condition wasn't good, she had good food and drink. Thereby, Du Shi thought that Lei Tie was not enough to be afraid of. Every day, when she had eaten to her fill, she started to curse Lei Tie. She also said that when she went out, she wanted Lei Tie's family of four to be humiliated. When Lei Tie learned of this, he prolonged Du Shi's prison time and forbid Lei Xiangzhi to help her. Du Shi suffered a lot and realized that it was not good. She had been well-behaved and was killed not long after she was released from prison. If she had not hurled curses and threatened Lei Tie's family and left the prison as soon as the ten-day deadline arrived, she might have escaped the disaster.

Lei Tie said, *"It should be aimed at me."*

Qin Mian nodded, *"I feel the same way. The other party's purpose is probably to stir up the relationship between you and Fifth Brother. The ultimate purpose is to deal with you. But what I can't figure out is, why would they provoke your relationship? Fifth Brother is just a fifth rank official, not enough to pose a threat against you."*

"I don't care." Lei Tie's eyes were filled with cold light, *"However, if someone dares to attack you, Ruiqi, and Ruilin, I'll make his life worse than death!"*

Qin Mian narrowed his eyes and said in a heavy tone, *"Emperor Xiaohui might know."* He always felt that Emperor Xiaohui was playing a big game of chess.

At the entrance of Lei Xiangzhi's residence, white silks had been hung on the gate. The spirit tablet must have been arranged inside and there were

faint bursts of crying.

Qin Mian's group of four was about to enter when they were stopped by the servant of Lei Xiangzhi's residence.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie did not insist on getting in. Firstly, they were unwilling to worship Du Shi on bent knees. Secondly, since Lei Tie sent Du Shi to prison, almost all the people in the Capital knew that State Defender Duke and his stepmother were at odds with each other. If they insisted on going in to kowtow, they would make people feel that they were pretending. So why bother.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie led the two children to bow three times in the direction of the house and be done with it.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin never enjoyed Du Shi's care and affection. They didn't have the slightest feeling about Du Shi's death and merely didn't like the glaring white silks hanging all over the places.

The family got on the carriage and went back to the State Defender Duke Establishment.

Lei Tie changed his clothes and went out to investigate the murder of Du Shi. At home, Qin Mian cared for the two children's studies and taught them a modern curriculum.

That night, when the couple was asleep, the door was suddenly knocked by the servant.

Lei Tie got up to open the door. After a moment, he came back with a sealed letter.

"What's wrong again?" Qin Mian was speechless. Since arriving in the Capital, there had not been any good things.

Lei Tie said, "It's from the servant of Fifth Brother's residence."

Qin Mian's interest perked up and he leaned on Lei Tie's arm to read the letter together.

The letter was indeed written by Lei Xiangzhi. The content was very rational. Lei Xiangzhi believed that Lei Tie didn't have a hand in Du Shi's death and neither did he blame Lei Tie. He admitted that he was partly responsible for Du Shi's death. In the letter, Lei Xiangzhi also analyzed the purpose of the person behind the scene. Like Qin Mian, he thought that the purpose of the person behind the scene was to stir up the relationship between him and Lei Tie. Lei Xiangzhi suggested that the two brothers fall out with each other, hoping to find out the real murderer and avenge Du Shi.

The letter from Lei Xiangzhi made Qin Mian feel unusual. He turned over and hugged Lei Tie, "Sleep. Big things have to wait until tomorrow."

Footnotes

1. The literal translation is purging sin pill.
2. (of a woman) to marry a man of lower social status

Chapter 181: Public Display of Affection

181 – Public Display of Affection

Thank you, Elaine, for the ❤️! (How fitting with the title)

On the second day, Emperor Xiaohui decreed that Lei Tie and Lei Xiangzhi were “to be in mourning and disregard of reasons” and given seven days’ leave. If the parents of an official of the Imperial Court die, no matter what the official post was, he must return to his ancestral home for 27 months from the day he learned of the funeral – that was to be in mourning. As for “disregard of reasons”¹, he did not need to comply with this regulation, nor did he need to be removed from the official post.

With the identity as the State Defender Duke, it was very convenient for Lei Tie to act and he found some things – two bodies were discovered in the mass grave on the outskirts of the Capital. Through the coroner’s examination, they were identified dead by poisoning. One of them still had a quiver on his back. The arrows inside were just the same as those that were used to shot Du Shi dead. The clue was broken here.

It was a bit tricky because they didn’t even have a suspect. If they couldn’t find out who was behind the scene, there might be other troubles in the future.

Qin Mian believed that Emperor Xiaohui must know something.

“I’ll probe into the palace.” Lei Tie made up his mind.

Qin Mian hesitated. With his and Lei Tie's ability, there would be no problem in probing into the palace with the soul sense without being detected. But his and Lei Tie's movement must have been controlled by Emperor Xiaohui. If they got clues from the Palace and followed the new clues, it would be a problem to answer if Emperor Xiaohui asked them.

Lei Tie didn't want him to worry, "Get the clue first."

Qin Mian also felt that he thought too much. At present, the most important thing was to find a breakthrough.

"Alright, be careful. I'll go to the drugstore as usual to avoid suspicion."

Due to them pretending to fall out with Lei Xiangzhi, besides showing his face in Lei Xiangzhi's residence on the day of Du Shi's death, Qin Mian went to Ruyi Pharmacy and Jewel Pavilion as before after a few days. People who paid close attention to the State Defender Duke Establishment now knew that Lei Tie and Lei Xiangzhi were truly falling out.

Qin Mian rode on horseback on the road, still wondering why Lei Daqiang didn't rush to the State Defender Duke Establishment to fight for Du Shi's injustice or take advantage of Du Shi's death.

He still overestimated Lei Daqiang's sense of shame. Lei Daqiang wanted money and life, but he wanted life more. Du Shi's death scared him. He had made up his mind to disown Lei Tie. However, he didn't give up the idea of taking advantage of Du Shi's death. He wanted Lei Xiangzhi to ask Lei Tie for a large sum of money as compensation. As a result, Lei Xiangzhi's heart turned so cold that he was depressed for several days. Some people saw that he was a lot thinner than before, which consequently cemented the brothers' conflict between him and Lei Tie.

In the State Defender Duke Establishment, Lei Tie sat on the bed with his knees crossed and eyes closed as he skillfully controlled his soul sense to enter the palace. After entering the palace, he began to look for Emperor Xiaohui. Luckily, he found Emperor Xiaohui in the imperial study.

Together with Emperor Xiaohui was Imperial Prince Ming.

Imperial Prince Ming was about 3~4 years younger than Emperor Xiaohui. Contrarily, his appearance was scholarly and less rigid than Emperor Xiaohui. He sat upright in the elegant fan-shaped armchair.

These days, Emperor Xiaohui was also investigating the death of Du Shi. At this time, his face looked cold and his mood was in a bad state.

“How’s the investigation of the State Defender Duke’s stepmother?”

Imperial Prince Ming frowned slightly and said in a cold voice, “Answering, Your Majesty. It’s most likely the doing of Loyalty Prince. Loyalty Prince is hiding too deeply. With the State Defender Duke has just entered the Capital, it’s impossible to find him for the time being.”

“Heh!” Emperor Xiaohui’s face was livid. With a sweep of his hand, the cup of hot tea on the table fell to the floor. The crushing sound was very clear in the quiet imperial study. “Loyalty Prince, what a good ‘loyal’ prince! When Zhen was still Crown Prince, he repeatedly used black hands² against Zhen. After Zhen ascended the throne, for the sake of blood relationship, Zhen not only spared his life but also made him a “Loyalty Prince” – look at how he rewarded Zhen!”

Eunuch Li was so scared that he fell on the ground, “Your Majesty, please calm your anger and take care of the dragon body!”

Imperial Prince Ming stood up and drooped his head, keeping silent. Even if he was Emperor Xiaohui’s younger brother, there were some words he couldn’t say.

In front of his younger brother, Emperor Xiaohui showed his true temperament. At this time, he lost his temper and didn’t care about it too much. He calmed down, “Sit down. Does my eldest imperial son take part in it?”

Imperial Prince Ming carefully said, “At present, no clue has been found to point to His Highness.” Imperial Prince Ming was a little distracted. His imperial brother ascended the throne at the age of 16. Now, it was the 31st year of Emperor Xiaohui’s reign. His imperial brother was 47 years old this

year. Due to good maintenance, it looked like he was only 35~36 years old. There was almost no secret in the palace. Although he hid his great health very well, one could still see that he was in good health from his daily life. Conservatively speaking, his imperial brother could sit on the throne for at least ten years more. However, his imperial brother's eldest son with the first empress was 28 years old and the youngest son was 14 years old. It was not surprising that *some people* couldn't wait.

How could Emperor Xiaohui not understand this? But once the supreme power was in hand, he didn't want to let go. This was the first reason. Secondly, every emperor had ambition in his heart, and he was no exception. He still had a lot of great ambitions that had not been realized. He couldn't give up his power – even divided out a part of the power was out of the question. Therefore, he had never established a Crown Prince.

At the Court today, some people asked him to establish a Crown Prince. This was one of the reasons why Emperor Xiaohui was quite upset at this time.

“Yet, your subject-brother can't figure out what Loyalty Prince's purpose was to kill Du Shi?” asked Imperial Prince Ming in puzzlement. No matter how much he knew, he couldn't know more than Emperor Xiaohui. Thus, he asked.

Neither Imperial Prince Ming nor Emperor Xiaohui found a pair of “ears” paying attention to their conversation.

This question of Imperial Prince of Ming was also what Lei Tie wanted to know.

Emperor Xiaohui pondered for a moment, “When State Defender Duke was General of the West Order, Loyalty Prince was in the border province – he didn't know much about State Defender Duke. In Zhen's opinion, it's mostly to test the strength and influence of State Defender Duke. Many of the State Defender Duke's former subordinates are still in the army – they are most loyal to him. How can Loyalty Prince abstain from him?”

With that, he changed the subject. Imperial Prince Ming wisely followed along.

Lei Tie took back his soul sense. He knew exactly how things stood. He ordered someone to bring out the horse and went out on horseback to Pear Blossom Alley.

When he didn't see a certain someone in the drugstore, he went to the silverware shop. Before he entered the door, he saw a noblewoman and a young lady of 16~17 years old standing in front of the counter. His wife was behind the counter, holding a brocade box in his hand and saying something. The young lady's eyes glanced at his wife from time to time, her cheeks flushed.

Lei Tie's aura abruptly gloomed and bursts of coldness swept into Jewel Pavilion.

The noblewoman and the young lady inexplicably shivered. The young lady turned her head unintentionally and met a pair of cold black eyes; her heart abruptly jumped and her face turned white. She quickly lowered her head and whatever beautiful thoughts she had were no more.

"A-Tie, you're here." Qin Mian also saw Lei Tie and waved.

Lei Tie's expression was profoundly cold.

"A-Tie?" called Qin Mian again, feeling puzzled.

Lei Tie nudged the horse closer. He didn't even get off the horse as he stretched out his right hand to Qin Mian and gazed fixedly at him with a pair of abstruse eyes, bearing unprecedented tyranny.

"Wife, we're going home."

The customers in the store turned to look over curiously; the passers-by seemed to be surprised by Lei Tie's action, unconsciously slowing down and paying attention.

Qin Mian's heart beat like a drum. This strong force of Lei Tie didn't make him feel disgusted. On the contrary, his heart was filled with sweetness and at the same time, he couldn't help but scold himself for being as hopeless as a young lad. Layer upon layers of smiles rose on the corners of his lips and in the inside of his eyes. Without hesitating, he gave the brocade box to the assistant and told him to well entertain the customers. Then, he strode across the threshold, his hand stretched out to Lei Tie.

“Work's over?”

“En.” The corner of Lei Tie's lips almost imperceptibly curved up as he simply answered. Holding the hand in his palm, he pulled up the weight in his hand with little effort, and cherishingly placed it within his arms. He wrapped his iron arm around it and his legs gently pressed the belly of the horse. The horse moved forward steadily and leisurely.

Because the speed was not fast, more passers-by crowded on the street to look.

Is it alright to make a public display of affection like this? Qin Mian thought so in his heart. Unwilling to break away from the man's arms, he indifferently leaned back against the man's chest and didn't urge him to leave quickly.

His wife was so docile that it greatly pleased Lei Tie – the corners of his lips were completely curved up. He put his chin was on his wife's shoulder and listened quietly to their rapid heartbeat thumped one after the other, completely synchronized in a moment.

Out of Pear Blossom Alley, the horse did not run in the direction of Chong'en Street but turned to Minggu Street.

Qin Mian had some doubts. Minggu Street was practically a “food street” with restaurants, teahouses, wine houses, bakeries, noodle shops, and the likes on both sides of the street. What were they doing there?

He had a vague conjecture but he did not ask anything, still quietly leaning on the man. As the gallant horse shuttled through the crowd, with a smile on

his lips, he casually looked at the streetscape ahead.

Into Minggu Street, the gallant horse stopped at a bakery's entrance.

The shop owner looked strangely at the two men riding together. However, since there were many high-ranking officials in the Capital and that the two men were well-dressed, he would not speak out of turn. He warmly greeted them, "What do the two gongzis want to buy?"

With the gesture of embracing Qin Mian, Lei Tie untied Qin Mian's purse, took out a piece of broken silver, and passed it to the shop owner. He dully said, "A basket of husband and wife cakes, take away."

The shop owner was stunned and quickly responded, "Alrighty. Gongzis, please wait a moment."

Qin Mian's eyes were full of laughter. Because he restrained his laughter, his upper body vibrated slightly in Lei Tie's arms, like a cat's paw gently scratching on the apex of Lei Tie's heart. He tightly fastened his arm to warn the man in his embrace.

Qin Mian felt the hard object behind him and took a breath silently. He pinched his right hand on Lei Tie's hand holding the reins. Acting as if nothing was wrong, he held the reins and calmly looked straight ahead with an upright appearance.

"Quick."

Lei Tie picked up the food box that the shop owner handed over. "Go."

Qin Mian pressed the horse belly and the horse started to run.

Footnotes

1. This is an ancient custom where the officials who mourned their parents should abandon their government offices and go into mourning. Once they completed the mourning period, they can come back and resume posts.

2. manipulating sb. or sth. from behind the scenes; evil backstage manipulation; fight dirty

Chapter 182: Western Barbarian Diplomatic Mission

182 – Western Barbarian Diplomatic Mission

Upon seeing the two masters coming in, the manservants quickly brought hot water and hot tea.

After Qin Mian washed his hands, he came to the table, opened the food box, and slightly smiled. This husband and wife cake was a round, evenly thick meat cake that had a straight groove pressed out from the middle and coated with sweet spicy sauce – it had the metaphorical meaning of auspicious. Plus, the taste was pretty good. It was famous in the whole Capital.

Lei Tie was still washing his hands. Qin Mian picked up a cake and tasted it. “It’s really tasty.” He picked up another one and went to Lei Tie. He leaned against the screen and sent the husband and wife cake to Lei Tie’s mouth.

Lei Tie’s eyes were fixed on him. Nevertheless, he went closer and bit the cake his wife had bitten.

They shared the six husband and wife cakes. Lei Tie talked about the information he got in the palace.

As soon as he heard it, he knew that Loyalty Prince who coveted the throne was a troublesome character. If one was targeted by such a person, one couldn’t be put in the passive position of having to receive blows.

“Wife, when you’re free, concoct some knockout drugs.” Lei Tie produced a soundproof array – people outside couldn’t hear the sound from inside.

Qin Mian was taken aback. “What are you planning to do?”

Lei Tie’s flat voice said firmly, “It can be roughly concluded from the words of His Majesty and Imperial Prince Ming that His Majesty and Loyalty Prince were in a deadlock for some reason – they did not dare to act rashly. Make Loyalty Prince unconscious and take the opportunity to see the situation.” What he didn’t finish was that if Emperor Xiaohui called him to the Capital for the purpose of putting him on the battlefield, it would be the right time after the domestic unrest was solved. He would finish the battle as soon as possible and find a way to resign afterward.

Qin Mian nodded. In any case, Emperor Xiaohui’s sovereignty came within his jurisdiction. If Loyalty Prince rebelled, the Capital would immediately set off winds carrying an offensive smell of blood. Even if they didn’t like Emperor Xiaohui, they couldn’t act against Emperor Xiaohui. They could only act against Loyalty Prince.

“I’m going in to look.”

A few days later, after the Court adjourned, Emperor Xiaohui had just left the Hall of Supreme Harmony and came to the imperial study when the palace attendant reported to him outside the door, “Reporting, Your Majesty. State Defender Duke seeks an audience.”

Emperor Xiaohui was surprised, “Permit.”

A moment later, Lei Tie came in from the door and gave a formal salute.

“State Defender Duke can stand up.” Emperor Xiaohui asked, “What brought State Defender Duke to seek an audience with Zhen?”

Lei Tie said, “Reporting, Your Majesty. Your subject ventures to ask Your Majesty – why suddenly summoned your subject back to the Capital?”

Emperor Xiaohui's movement of intending to take the teacup paused. He laughed, "Zhen thought State Defender Duke could keep equanimity all the time."

Lei Tie said, "Your subject has a family now. The cause of Du Shi's death has yet been found out."

Since Du Shi's murderer had yet been found out, he was worried that the murderer would threaten the people he cared about, so he could not calm down – this was equivalent to putting the weakness in front of Emperor Xiaohui. Emperor Xiaohui's smile became more sincere and he put more trust in Lei Tie.

"Li Fushou, give a seat to State Defender Duke."

"Yes."

Lei Tie sat down in silence.

Emperor Xiaohui asked, "My dear subject Lei, how's the army?"

Lei Tie said, "Everything is under control, ready at Your Majesty's command."

Emperor Xiaohui pondered, "In half a month, a diplomatic mission procession sent by Tuluo State will arrive in the Capital and ask to marry the princess of Great Xia State for their sixth prince. As far as Zhen knows, the sixth prince is in the entourage. In recent years, Tuluo State has been in a state of unrest... In case something happens to the sixth prince while in Great Xia State — my dear subject Lei should be fully prepared in advance to meet the sixth prince. No mistake is allowed."

Tuluo State was the country that Great Xia State called "Western Barbarian" which bordered on Great Xia State. Although the territory was wide, the winter was severely cold and there were many deserts. Since ancient times, Tuluo had been coveting the vast and abundant territory of Great Xia. That was the reason why there were many wars on the frontier.

Back then when Lei Tie was the General of the West Order, he defeated the Western Barbarian three times and greatly pleased the people. However, the Western Barbarians were fierce and bloodthirsty – they might not be reconciled.

The implication in Emperor Xiaohui's words was obvious. He was worried if the sixth prince was actually the sacrifice of the emperor of the Western Barbarian. Once something happened to the sixth prince in Great Xia, Tuluo would dispatch troops for justice – the smoke of gunpowder would resurge in the frontier, people would be destitute.

Lei Tie's heart turned cold. Emperor Xiaohui's plan wouldn't be so simple. Could it be.....

“Yes, your subject at Your Majesty's command.”

Emperor Xiaohui expressed concern, “As for Du Shi's case, Zhen will investigate with the force of the Ministry of Justice. My dear subject Lei should not worry too much.”

“Yes, your subject thanks His Majesty.”

Lei Tie had no other words to say. He asked for leave and left the imperial study.

“Reporting, Your Majesty. Loyalty Prince is critically ill!”

Eunuch Li raised his eyebrows, extremely suspicious. *Loyalty Prince is His Majesty's sore point, how coincidental that he is critically ill at this time?*

“What?” Emperor Xiaohui was shocked and slapped the table. He successfully restrained his inner joy and said angrily, “How can that be? Isn't every three days the Imperial Doctor will go to check pulse? Why did Loyalty Prince suddenly become critically ill?”

The palace attendant was quick and eloquent, “Reporting, Your Majesty. About an hour ago, Loyalty Prince was walking in his garden and somehow suddenly fell unconscious. The Loyalty Princely Heir immediately invited

doctors. Unexpectedly, even the four doctors could not see what ailment he was suffering from.”

Emperor Xiaohui sat down slowly and asked about the details. “Suddenly fell unconscious, like a deep sleep? It sounds more like poisoning than an acute ailment. How’s the Loyalty Prince Establishment?”

The palace attendant said, “The Loyalty Princely Heir also suspected that Loyalty Prince was poisoned. He interrogated with torture all the people who were together with Loyalty Prince within four hours before the incident. None of them was suspicious.”

Emperor Xiaohui was surprised and looked at Eunuch Li, “This is indeed odd. Could it be a strange ailment?”

After a moment of pause, he said, “At once, order Imperial Doctor Qin to go to the Loyalty Prince Establishment.”

“Yes.” The palace attendant withdrew in a hurry.

Emperor Xiaohui pondered for a while. “Come.”

A dark shadow loomed in the imperial study. It had a mask on and knelt in front of the imperial table, wordless and uncommunicative.

“Where is State Defender Duke?”

The voice of the person in black was monotonous and plain, “At the South Gate.”

Emperor Xiaohui calculated in his heart how long it had been since Lei Tie had left. He said to himself, “It can’t be him...” Then he asked, “What’s Lady of the State Defender Duke doing lately?”

The person in black answered, “He went to Ruyi Pharmacy and Jewel Pavilion every day. Besides that, he seldom went out. There’s also nothing unusual about the people in the State Defender Duke Establishment.”

Emperor Xiaohui nodded. He completely trusted the secret guard he had cultivated himself – not in the least suspicious.

“Withdraw.”

After the secret guard withdrew, Emperor Xiaohui gave a meaningful glance at Eunuch Li.

Eunuch Li bowed with understanding and hurriedly left.....

When Lei Tie returned to the State Defender Duke Establishment, he saw Qin Mian practicing martial arts on the training ground. He stood there quietly, watching until the last move ended.

As the couple spoke, they walked into the inner courtyard side by side. In fact, they were communicating in mind at the same time. What they talked about in mind communication was the most important thing.

“How is it, A-Tie?”

“Everything is going well. The emperor said, in half a month...(bla-bla)... in case something went wrong with the sixth prince in Great Xia.”

Qin Mian was surprised, *“Why do I think Emperor Xiaohui and the emperor of Tulu have the same plan?”*

Lei Tie nodded, *“I thought so too.”*

“So to speak, Emperor Xiaohui certainly has to sacrifice a princess.” Qin Mian said, *“As far as I know, only Princess Yanqing and Princess Duanning are left.”*

He burst out laughing, *“Is Emperor Xiaohui going to have Princess Yanqing marry for peace?”*

“Does the sixth prince like her?” Lei Tie doubted it.

“Hahaha...” Qin Mian couldn’t help laughing. Why didn’t he find out that his family’s poker face had such a poisonous tongue? After drinking a big

mouthful of water, he confidently analyzed, *“Princess Yanqing and Princess Duanning are both the legitimate daughters of the empress – their identities are both honorable. But Princess Duanning’s mother is the current empress; the empress will try her best to protect her. So, she has more advantages than Princess Yanqing. The possibility of the emperor letting Princess Yanqing marry for peace is not low.”*

Two days later, a piece of definite news spread out in the Capital: After Loyalty Prince’s strange ailment was cured by a mediocre doctor in the Imperial Institute of Medicine, he went crazy.

Qin Mian immediately guessed what Emperor Xiaohui did. It was not hard to deal with the knockout drug he concocted. The purpose was to win an initiative for Emperor Xiaohui. But he didn’t expect that Emperor Xiaohui would take this opportunity to drive Loyalty Prince crazy. Loyalty Prince was Emperor Xiaohui’s half-brother. If Emperor Xiaohui killed him, his reputation would be damaged, so he chose to make him crazy, no longer a threat.

On the afternoon of the day when Loyalty Prince went mad, another news spread in the Capital: A plague broke out in a secret iron mine ten *li* outside the Capital with nearly one hundred death.

Qin Mian heard from Lei Tie that these people were actually soldiers cultivated by Loyalty Prince in secret. The main ringleaders were all captured by Emperor Xiaohui with nearly 20,000 loyal people. The Loyalty Prince’s faction was greatly undermined.

The common people didn’t notice the undercurrent in the Capital. Simply after hearing about the plague, some people were in a panic. After three to five days, they calmed down when they saw that the officials and dignitaries in the Capital didn’t make a move.

It was the 7th lunar month when the Tuluo diplomatic mission arrived in the Capital.

The frontier army escorted the diplomatic mission to Misty Mountain City, which was ten days away from the Capital. The diplomatic mission was

successfully handed over to Lei Tie, who would be escorting the diplomatic mission to the Capital.

Two days before arriving in the Capital, on the streets of the Capital, a dispatcher rode on a fast horse to the Imperial Palace and reported to the emperor on the latest movement of the diplomatic mission every hour or so.

Upon hearing this movement, the people in the Capital all knew that Tuluo diplomatic mission was coming. They had no good impression for the Western Barbarians in their hearts, but on their faces, they tacitly smiled politely to show their welcome to the diplomatic mission of another country. The main street of the Capital was decorated with lanterns and festoons as though it was a festival.

On the day of the diplomatic mission's arrival in the Capital, Qin Mian specially asked for a leave of absence for Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to watch in the crowd. It was not that he didn't attach importance to the two children's studies, but he didn't want the children to miss some interesting experiences in their childhood so that they could have more beautiful memories when they grew up. It wasn't a serious matter if one day's school lesson was delayed.

Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin rode on the back of Golden Fur, so no one could jostle them. Such a big bear, at least a thousand jin, and also extremely fierce, who dared to jostle it? Besides, there was an imperious giant wolf nearby.

The father and sons were all dressed in handsome camouflage. The people around them only stared at the city gate for some time and mostly stared at the dazzling father and sons.

The festive sound of gongs and drums was getting closer and closer.

Some people shouted, "It's here!"

Both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin raised their heads in expectation.

Amused, Qin Mian touched the heads of the two little boys. He didn't expose their thoughts that what they wanted to see was their Old Dad. Well, he admitted that what he wanted to see most was also the children's Old Dad.

The procession was getting closer and closer, headed by two men riding on tall and big horses. The man on the left was about 22~23 years old, young and handsome, and luxuriously dressed – the jewels on his crown dazzled under the sun. He was the Sixth Prince of Tuluuo, Li Qingman. The man on the right had dashing eyebrows with bright eyes, cold and resolute bearing, dressed in a suit of armor, mighty and imposing. Who else if not Lei Tie?

“Dad, it's Old Dad!” Both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin cried out excitedly.

Lei Ruilin even jumped up, so excited that his small face was flushed. “Old Dad is so mighty!”

“Shh, keep your voice down. You can't steal the limelight from the guests.” Qin Mian gently reminded his son, while his eyes obsessively watched the man who was getting closer.

Lei Tie saw his wife and sons in the crowd. While there was no expression on his face, his tender eyes looked at his wife and the two sons in turns for a long time.

Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin all understood that he meant to say that he was alright during their parting days.

The father and sons nodded to him with a faint smile.

Lei Tie only withdrew his gaze when the horse passed by.

Golden Fur walked out of the crowd and followed the procession.

Across the street, Chen Mufeng looked at the father and sons on Golden Fur's back, envied them from the bottom of his heart. He had clearly seen the interaction of the family of four just now.

“Mufeng?” Zhangsun He followed his line of sight and looked over. With a controlled expression, he gently asked, “What?”

Chen Mufeng lightly said, “Nothing.”

“Envious?” Zhangsun He stared straight at him. “We can be like them.”

“My princely father only has me as his son [heir],” said Chen Mufeng in a light tone.

At once, Zhangsun He’s face gloomed.

Chapter 183: Warm and Harmonious Family

183 – Warm and Harmonious Family

At the thought that his beloved would entangle with a woman, Zhangsun He felt like a knife stirred in his heart, blood unceasingly spilled. He wanted to kill that fabricated woman. He also loved Chen Mufeng so much that he wanted to eat him, but he wasn't willing to do anything drastic because he knew that Chen Mufeng's pressure was no less than him.

Right hand clenched into a fist in his sleeve, he breathed evenly, stared at Chen Mufeng's eyes, and then said in a steady voice, "In that case, we'll continue wasting time. I've plenty of time."

For fear of losing control in front of Chen Mufeng, he turned around and left in a hurry – the figure of his back showed profound loneliness and desolation.

Chen Mufeng's heart ached, but he didn't follow.

Zhangsun He walked forward in a trot. His cold face frightened the passers-by, who then consciously gave way to him.

The two attendants had to jog to keep up with him, not daring to breathe out loud.

On the street opposite, a middle-aged man with natural, graceful, and poised temperament rode a black horse slowly toward him. The middle-aged man was followed by six other attendants, who also rode on horses.

Zhangsun He halted and went over. The owner of the horse saw him, too – there was no fluctuation in his expression. The distance between them got closer and closer.

Zhangsun He bowed with a cupped fist and said with a smile, “Greetings, Imperial Prince Ming.”

Imperial Prince Ming nodded slightly and said with a light smile, “No need to be courteous, Young Marquis.” The reins moved gently, and the horse went on.

Zhangsun He caught up with a few steps. His respectful tone was full of sincerity, “Imperial Prince Ming, this junior would like to invite you to have a cup of tea. Venture to ask if Imperial Prince Ming have the time to spare?”

“Forgive me, Young Marquis. This prince has been burdened with official business these days. There’s no time to spare.” Then Imperial Prince Ming nodded and directly left.

Zhangsun He was silent for a long time – there was nothing he could do.

.....

Qin Mian brought Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin back to the State Defender Duke Establishment. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin wanted to wait for Lei Tie in the foreyard, so Qin Mian first went back to the inner yard to pick out a change of clothes for Lei Tie and then took the opportunity to enter the space to pick some fresh fruits. Without permission, the servants would not enter their rooms at will. Thus, he wasn’t afraid of being found out.

After picking the fruits, he went to the quadrangle courtyard to see White Spot.

White Spot had advanced recently. These days, it lay on the ground in the space with its eyes closed, motionless – it looked like it was sleeping, but in fact, it was cultivating. The spiritual qi in the space entered its body slowly just like a snowflake fell into the water, faded without traces. The spiritual

threads flashed and died out like electric currents on its fur; its dark fur then became brighter and smoother.

Out of the space, Qin Mian went back to the foreyard.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were practicing martial arts on the training ground, surrounded by a group of servants.

The servants knew that the Lady had a good temper. As long as they didn't delay their work or break the rules, the Lady wouldn't scold them. When they saw Qin Mian coming, they didn't panic and saluted him properly.

After Qin Mian nodded, they stepped aside and continued to watch the two young masters practicing.

Golden Fur stood by and also watched with relish.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were seven years old this year. Their heights had reached Qin Mian's waist and their bodies were slender and strong. At a young age, they had manifested a modest and light-hearted temperament. No matter where they went, they were the targets of admiration by parents alike.

It was surprising to see the two boys sometimes flew to the air to fight and sometimes fell to the ground – their footwork was faintly discernible and their figures were agile. They didn't yield to each other at all, unusually brilliant. As they fought, their eyes swept to the main gate now and then.

Qin Mian shook his head and held his chin as he mused. *This Dad I are pretty good, too? Why do the two sons never look at me with adoring eyes?*

After a short while, the sound of approaching horse's hooves came from outside the gate.

Qin Mian easily recognized that the sound of the horse's hooves belonged to Lei Tie's black horse.

Sure enough, in a flash, Lei Tie rode into the main entrance.

“Old Dad!”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin immediately stopped and ran to meet him.

Lei Tie jumped off his horse, patted his two sons on the shoulders, and handed them a birdcage-sized brocade box.

Lei Ruilin happily asked, “Old Dad, is this a gift for Gege and me?”

Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin both focused on the brocade box.

After saluting to Lei Tie, the servants voluntarily withdrew. There was only the family of four left on the training ground.

Lei Tie went to Qin Mian and naturally put his arms around Qin Mian’s shoulder. He bowed his head and dropped a kiss on Qin Mian’s lips – it was as warm as he had fondly remembered.

“Was your trip smooth-sailing?” Qin Mian touched his prickly chin and patted the dust off his sleeves in passing.

Lei Tie nodded, took out a palm-sized brocade box from his inner pocket, and handed it to Qin Mian.

The brocade box was warm, immersed in Lei Tie’s body temperature. Qin Mian was not in a hurry to see it. Instead, he embraced Lei Tie’s shoulder and said, “Go have a bath first and rest.”

They didn’t care about the sons who were still studying how to open the brocade box. They went to the backyard first.

“That box is?” Qin Mian was curious. A box couldn’t take that long to open.

Lei Tie said, “There are contrivances. Let them ponder by themselves.”

Back in the bedchamber, Lei Tie went to the washroom to take a bath. Qin Mian took out the box in his inner pocket, lay on the bed, and

subconsciously opened the lid. Unexpectedly, he couldn't open it. It turned out that there were contrivances in this brocade box. He couldn't help but smile. His heart itched even more, eager to know what Lei Tie bought for him.

The box could be broken by force and what's inside could be found out by soul sense. However, that would not only disappoint Lei Tie but also make it less fun. Qin Mian first observed the six sides of the brocade box and noticed that each side was made up of many small squares. The mystery must be in these little squares.

He enthusiastically got ready to try when his back felt heavy, accompanied by the smell of bath soap. Next, his ear was bitten.

“Wife...”

Qin Mian curved his lips, placed the brocade box next to the pillow, and closed his eyes as he lay prone on the soft pillow. The feeling of his clothes being taken off became more distinct.....

The lovemaking was intense and without inhibitions. Paralyzed on the bed, Qin Mian gasped for breath for a long time before he calmed down. His eyes suspiciously floated toward that man's lower body, and his temples throbbed. *Is that thing continue to grow in adulthood?!*

Lei Tie had a trace of a smile in his eyes as he held Qin Mian's sweat-stained face, kissed his dried petals of lips, and moistened them with saliva.

Qin Mian reciprocated, not to be outdone. Only when breathing became unstable again that the couple separated.

Lei Tie raised his hand, and the teacup on the table flew over. He caught it, drank a sip of tea, and lowered his head to slowly feed it into his wife's mouth. His obsidian eyes focused on his wife without blinking.

Qin Mian had regained his normal body temperature with great difficulty and yet it began to rise again. He put his arms around Lei Tie's neck and opened his mouth to suckle. Another entanglement occurred.

“Be honest, where did you learn all of this?!”

Lei Tie looked at him in puzzlement, “Instinct.”

Qin Mian had nothing to say in reply.

Lei Tie got off of Qin Mian’s body and embraced him, letting Qin Mian pillowed his arm. Then he pulled the thin blanket at the side and covered them up until the waist.

“Did you fight with anyone on the way? Not hurt, are you?”

“No.” Lei Tie said, “Three waves of killers returned without accomplishing anything.”

Qin Mian guessed, “When the time comes to send the Sixth Prince away, you are most likely asked to escort.”

Lei Tie said, “Very likely. There’s a royal banquet tonight. Rank four and above Mandated Ladies are required to attend. His Majesty allowed Ruiqi and Ruilin to go too.”

Qin Mian was very interested, “So, go it is. We haven’t eaten the food from the imperial kitchen yet.” He grabbed the brocade box and continued to study it.

Outside, two familiar steps were approaching.

“Dad, Old Dad~~”

They were both still naked. Qin Mian was in a hurry to get up.

Lei Tie hugged him and didn’t let him move. He looked at the closed door and spoke in a deep voice with impressive fatherly authority, “Play by yourselves.”

Lei Ruilin made a meaningful sound “Oh~~” and then ran away with Qin Ruiqi with a giggle.

“Mischievous kid.” Qin Mian found it both funny and annoying.

The couple stayed in the bedchamber for the rest of the day.....

Thinking of the many inconveniences at the palace banquet that it was unknown when they could eat, Qin Mian made a wok of fried rice. The family of four enjoyed a small bowl. It didn't matter to him and Lei Tie, but Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were growing up – they hadn't mastered the cultivation yet, so they couldn't stand hunger.

After the meal, the family of four took a bath. After changing their clothes, they went into the palace by carriage.

Because it a carriage customized by the imperial court, when they arrived at the palace gate, the palace guards let the carriage passed after they had inspected inside and out and found no suspicious person.

Into the palace, the carriage stopped in a special parking lot. The family of four got out of the carriage and followed the palace attendants. On the way, they met other Appointed Officials and Mandated Ladies. Every now and then, they saluted each other.

Banquets held in the palace were either in the imperial garden or in the reception hall. Due to the hot weather in summer, tonight's banquet was in the imperial garden.

In the imperial garden, colorful flags fluttered and decorated lanterns hung high, just like the daytime; the sounds of stringed and woodwind instruments were ceaseless – relaxing and mellow. The emperor and the empress were not here yet. As the most honorable people, they were the last to appear. The Tuluo's envoys also had yet arrived.

Qin Mian originally thought that he would be arranged at the Mandated Lady's seat. Unexpectedly, the palace attendant arranged him next to Lei Tie. He secretly let out a sigh of relief. He would not be comfortable sitting among women.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin naturally sat with them.

Chen Mufeng's seat happened to be opposite them. With a smile from far away, he waved at them.

Qin Mian picked up his teacup as a greeting to him. He noticed that there was a gaze staring at him. He looked over. It was Zhangsun He, sitting on the right side of Chen Mufeng.

Zhangsun He nodded to Qin Mian and turned to talk to Chen Mufeng with a gentle look in his eyes.

Qin Mian was surprised. *Chen Mufeng's partner turns out to be Zhangsun He!*

As if nothing was wrong, he looked straight ahead and raised his right hand to poke at Lei Tie sitting on his right side. His several poking didn't find the target. Puzzled, he turned his head to take a look – Lei Ruilin had his lips pursed, restraining a peal of laughter. It turned out that he deliberately pulled Lei Tie aside to avoid Qin Mian's hand. Qin Ruiqi drank a cup of tea, the corner of his mouth curled up. Lei Tie looked at Qin Mian with calm but doting eyes.

Chapter 184: Give Suggestion to Chen Mufeng

184 – Give Suggestion to Chen Mufeng

Qin Mian helplessly looked at his youngest son and flicked his forehead.

“Go the side!”

“Hehe!” Lei Ruilin made a funny face at him and obediently sat down beside Qin Ruiqi.

“Wife, what did you want to say?” asked Lei Tie.

Qin Mian motioned him to look at the opposite side and communicated in mind, “*They’re both members of the Imperial Clan. Can His Majesty tolerate them?*”

Lei Tie said, too profound to be understood, “*Perhaps, His Majesty would be glad to see it happen.*”

Qin Mian understood what he meant when he thought about it.

Princes, noblemen, courtiers, mandated ladies, and so on entered the venue one after another. It was still early. People either stood or sat together to chat.

At the beginning of the dog hour [7 PM], the palace eunuch’s announcement came from outside the garden’s gate, “Here comes His Majesty the Emperor~~ Here comes Her Majesty the Empress~~”

The sounds of stringed and woodwind instruments stopped. Everyone stood and retreated to both sides.

Emperor Xiaohui and the empress ascended the dais together.

Everyone knelt and cried out, “Long live Your Majesty the Emperor; long live Her Majesty the Empress~~”

“You may rise.” Emperor Xiaohui’s voice was as loud as a bell.

“Many thanks, Your Majesty!”

They all stood at the appointed seats and waited until Emperor Xiaohui said they could sit down.

Shortly, the palace eunuch announced again, “Here comes His Highness the Sixth Prince of Tuluo and the envoy officials~~”

Liu Manqing, the Sixth Prince of Tuluo, marched in with his six envoy officials.

Liu Manqing stopped two *zhang* [6.6m] in front of the dais, bowed with his right fist on his left chest, and said in a loud voice, “This foreign envoy greets His Majesty of Great Xia.”

All the people behind him saluted in unison, “This foreign minister greets His Majesty of Great Xia.”

Emperor Xiaohui gave a hearty laugh and raised his hand and he said, “My honorable envoys may rise!”

“Thank you, Your Majesty.”

Emperor Xiaohui said, “My honorable envoys may take your seats.”

When Liu Manqing and the others sat down, Emperor Xiaohui said, “Coming from afar, it has been a long journey. Zhen specially ordered people to hold this banquet to welcome you and help wash off the dust¹.

Your Highness Liu and your honorable envoys must enjoy it to your satisfaction.”

Liu Manqing said, “Many thanks, Your Majesty.”

Emperor Xiaohui raised his voice and said, “Start the banquet~~”

The sounds of stringed and woodwind instruments began again. All dancers from the Music and Dance Office of the Inner Palace specialized in music and dance, came floating with flowing sleeves along with the melody, trippingly dancing.

The beautiful palace maids and the nimble palace eunuchs carried trays in their hands as they walked in, in a line. Good wine, fine food, fruits, and pastries were served one by one, filling the entire table.

It was probably because Qin Mian had been running a restaurant for several years, he developed an occupational disease and habitually looked at the dishes on the table. He didn’t know the name of the dishes from the imperial kitchen, but from the ingredients, he could roughly see that they were five-flavored chicken, duck with assorted combination, steamed crab, braised dried abalone, fried shrimp in hot spicy sauce, and soup simmered inside a whole winter melon. They were all beautiful and exquisite in appearance, which made people eager to start eating. They were worthy of being the cuisine from the imperial kitchen.

Emperor Xiaohui raised his cup and said, “Your Highness Liu, Zhen would like to propose a toast to you first.”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty.” Liu Manqing stood up and downed the cup in one gulp.

As the mother of the state, the empress also made a toast.

After Liu Manqing returned the toast to Emperor Xiaohui and the empress respectively, the banquet officially started. When Emperor Xiaohui picked up the chopsticks, everyone moved their chopsticks.

Qin Mian was very curious about the dishes from the imperial kitchen. He unscrupulously tasted them separately. The fried shrimp in hot spicy sauce surprised him the most.

Lei Tie put down his chopsticks and shelled a plate for him, which made many people look over.

In fact, the main purpose of most people attending the palace banquet was not to eat but to show their faces. In particular, since the emperor was the supreme in the country, a breach of etiquette couldn't be tolerated in the presence of the emperor. Therefore, most people just ate a few mouthfuls at the palace banquet. When they saw the emperor putting down his chopsticks, they put theirs down. When they saw the emperor picking up his chopsticks, they picked theirs up again.

Thus, Qin Mian and Lei Tie's table appeared particularly eye-catching. Yet, no one could say that they were wrong. The emperor had invited them to dinner and the meal was served to be eaten – there was nothing wrong with eating happily.

Qin Mian soon realized that something was wrong, but seeing that Lei Tie was calm, he also calmed. Anyway, it was the emperor's treat; not eating it was the same as dishonoring the emperor.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin had proved themselves to be Qin Mian's sons. They had similar preferences as Qin Mian – they also liked the fried shrimp in hot spicy sauce best. They could take care of themselves. They ate with relish with graceful manner.

Zhangsun He noticed that Chen Mufeng's eyes would occasionally float to the opposite side. His heart intermittently ached. He drank the wine cup after cup.

Liu Manqing had been forced to smile tonight. As a man who grew up in the Imperial Palace, after seeing many intrigues, how could he not understand that he had become a sacrifice? Even if he did not die in Great Xia, there would still be people coming to kill him before he left Great Xia.

The two opposite men didn't act out of line, but others could feel the intimacy between them. The invisible tacit understanding made him envious. Inexplicably, he felt a little better and his thoughts cleared up. He thought to himself whether the princess he was going to marry could become a breakthrough for him to survive.....

However, it was a tacit understanding between the two sides that they wouldn't talk about business at the reception. Emperor Xiaohui and Liu Manqing chatted freely about some idle and interesting things. Some civil officials with good eloquence inserted a few words from time to time to manoeuver the atmosphere.

Nearly two hours later, the grand banquet ended in a good atmosphere.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were full and drowsiness thus crept in. Qin Mian and Lei Tie each held one boy. The two brothers lay on their fathers' shoulders and fell asleep in a daze.

Chen Mufeng looked at the drunken man beside him and lifted him with a silent sigh.

"There's nothing I can do with you..."

Zhangsun He leaned on him in a dizzy spell, his steps were unsteady.

"Mufeng... Don't leave me..."

Worried that his words would be heard by others, Chen Mufeng took him along a remote path.

"Mufeng..."

"I'm here." Chen Mufeng patted him on the back.

"I love you... love you..."

Chen Mufeng said in a low voice, "Me too..."

Zhangsun He was in a trance; his mouth only murmured Mufeng's name.

Imperial Prince Ming looked at the back of the two men, who were entangled in each other and stumbling forward. With a cold snort, he told his attendant, "Tell the Commandery Prince Mu to return home early."

"Yes, Your Imperial Highness."

At the parking lot, Qin Mian unexpectedly saw Chen Mufeng coming from another direction while having some difficulties supporting Zhangsun He. Chen Mufeng had a weary expression. He was a little puzzled. Mu Chen that he knew of was lively and cheerful, totally different from Chen Mufeng of the Capital.

"A-Tie, wait a bit."

Lei Tie saw Chen Mufeng and understood, "Don't be too long."

Qin Mian nodded and went to Chen Mufeng.

"Commandery Prince Mu, need help?"

Chen Mufeng said in certainty, "You know."

Qin Mian nodded and patted him on the shoulder. "Look at your weary appearance. If you need any help, please let me know. We are friends."

"Qin Mian, to tell you the truth, you and Lei Tie are a devoted couple with deep affection, but A-He and I are a hell of a mess. I envy you very much. Therefore, I don't know how to tell you about A-He." Chen Mufeng was embarrassed when he remembered what happened outside Dongyang Academy last time.

Qin Mian saw that there was a big problem between him and Zhangsun He, so he comforted him, "Where there's a will, there's a way."

Chen Mufeng pondered for a moment and said, "When will you be free? To talk."

Qin Mian jokingly said, "I'm free after dawn and before dark."

A person nourished by love was different. Chen Mufeng glanced at him, “How about I visit your residence tomorrow?”

Qin Mian saw Lei Tie sticking his head out of the window and quickly waved to Chen Mufeng as he walked over.

“No problem. I’m leaving. See you later.”

The next morning, not long after breakfast, Chen Mufeng came to the door.

Qin Mian received him in the garden. After tea, cakes, and fruits were served, he waved away all the servants.

Chen Mufeng looked at the surrounding scenery. “I always think you are a very enjoyable person. Indeed, you are.”

“Life is too short. So of course, make merry while one can.” Qin Mian poured him a cup of tea and did not ask him about Zhangsun He until he spoke of it himself.

Chen Mufeng had been wedged between Imperial Prince Ming and Zhangsun He for many years. He was really eager to find someone to talk to. He trusted Qin Mian’s character, so he was the most suitable choice.

With a sip of tea, Chen Mufeng gradually spoke, “It’s been six years since I’d known him...”

After hearing about him and Zhangsun He, Qin Mian concluded, “So, your problem now is that your father doesn’t object to you and the Young Marquis on the premise that you have to have a son first, but Zhangsun He doesn’t allow you to have a child with a woman.”

Chen Mufeng slightly nodded and heavily sighed.

“Toward Zhangsun He, you...” asked Qin Mian.

Chen Mufeng was slightly uncomfortable, “But my princely father only has me as his son...”

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows and asked another question, “Why does your father have only one son?”

For a moment, Chen Mufeng didn’t understand why he asked.

Qin Mian said, “I’m thinking that since your father doesn’t want to cut off your family’s lineage and Zhangsun He doesn’t agree with you having children with a woman, maybe you can ask your father to have another son.” Imperial Prince Ming was younger than Emperor Xiaohui – he could have another son.

Chen Mufeng was stunned for a moment. All of a sudden, he stood up and somewhat incoherently said, “Why didn’t I, he... Why didn’t I think of that?!”

Qin Mian was speechless and didn’t know what to say. This was the so-called “blind are those concerned; a bystander sees through everything”.

Chen Mufeng soon calmed down and asked Qin Mian, “My princely father is over 40 years old. Can he still...”

Qin Mian nodded in affirmation, “Of course! Over 40 is the prime of life. ”

“Qin Mian, thanks a lot! I’m right to be here today.” Chen Mufeng was so excited that he grabbed Qin Mian’s hand. Suddenly, he felt a hidden weapon coming to attack – he was shocked. He stepped back quickly and turned his head. Lei Tie stood a few steps away with no expression on his face. His sharp eyes stared at Chen Mufeng’s hand as if he was thinking about cutting it off.

The corner of Chen Mufeng’s lips twitched, “State Defender Duke, this commandery prince also has a beloved, alright?” *This jealousy makes no sense.*

Lei Tie ignored him and sat down beside Qin Mian. “Wife, [I’m] hungry.”

Qin Mian was amused but he still said, “What would you like to eat? I’ll cook for you.”

“Tsk tsk...” Chen Mufeng had lifted off the load on his mind, so now he was all smiling. He looked at them with disdain, “Alright. I’m leaving, not staying to get in your way.”

Qin Mian waved his hand, “Go, go. I know you can’t wait to see your Young Marquis.”

Having his intention exposed, Chen Mufeng was even more embarrassed but remained calm, “Farewell.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the kitchen together.

“What would you like to eat?”

“Egg, fish.”

“Then we’ll make egg foo yung², red-cooked fish³, tea-flavored ribs, and moo-shu pork⁴.”

The couple got to work together. Qin Mian cooked rice and Lei Tie killed fish.

“Has the person for the peace marriage been selected yet?” asked Qin Mian.

Lei Tie replied, “Not yet.”

Qin Mian guessed, “Will Emperor Xiaohui be reluctant to give up Princess Yanqing and choose a princess from the imperial clan instead?”

Lei Tie shook his head. “It’s hard to fool the people of Tulu. They have already investigated how many princesses Great Xia has.”

Qin Mian’s imagination was greatly enriched. “Will the empress send her daughter to marry for peace for the sake of her virtuous reputation?”

Lei Tie shook his head.

It’s been six years and the boy is also six years old something...So they fell in love when the other half already has a kid.

Footnotes

1. to treat sb. to dinner on arriving
2. Chinese dish similar to an omelet
3. fish simmer-fried in soy sauce
4. stir-fried shredded pork and vegetables served in a pancake

Chapter 185: Lend a Hand Again

185 – Lend a Hand Again

Qin Mian didn't ask anymore. Princess Yanqing was no longer a threat to him. Whether she would be sent to marry off had nothing to do with him in the end. He was just curious.

“By the way, A-Tie, there's one thing I can't make up my mind about.” Qin Mian thought of a very important thing.

Lei Tie looked at him inquisitively while the knife in his hand continued to scrape off the fish scales. There were some fresh fish in the kitchen but this fish was from the space. It's not good to let others see the difference, so he could only do it himself.

“Ruiqi and Ruilin's recent cultivation progress is quite fast – the time of advancement is not far. I'm thinking whether we should tell them about the space? It's easier to advance in the space. But I'm also worried that they'll make a slip of tongue.” Qin Mian really hesitated for a long time. Right now, their family lived in the Imperial City, under the influence of Emperor Xiaohui. If they were careless, the secret of the space might be revealed, which would bring a series of troubles. As for putting on a ban, he and Lei Tie were reluctant to impose a ban on their sons.

Lei Tie thought for a moment and got an idea, “Wait until I find time to refine a spiritual tool, compress the spiritual qi in the space into the spiritual tool, and let them wear it with them.”

Qin Mian slapped his forehead. “I even thought of feeding them with spiritual qi. Why didn't I think of this method?”

It was rare for Lei Tie to tease his wife, “[You] can't do without me.”

“Conceited!” Qin Mian gave him an angry look; his ears were burning. In fact, he found that during the time Lei Tie was away, his brain really couldn’t function. Usually, whether he had something on his mind or not, he didn’t have to think too much. He also didn’t have to raise an effort to handle matters.

Lei Tie understood it clearly, so he didn’t argue. After cleaning the fish, he stood up and pecked on Qin Mian’s cheek as he passed behind him. He put the fish on the plate, went to the hearth, and sat down in front of it. He picked up a piece of dry wood and put it into the hearth.

Although Lei Tie didn’t say anything, Qin Mian understood that Lei Tie saw through his own thought. He was somewhat embarrassed and somewhat complacent. This man, who he thought almost perfect, was his! He bent down, grabbed the man’s chin, met his eyes provocatively, and kissed hard on his thin lips with a “pop”. Then he straightened up and hummed a song as he whisked the eggs using the chopsticks.

Lei Tie’s heart was like soaking in a hot spring.

.....

At this time, Chen Mufeng reappeared in the State Defender Duke Establishment. Qin Mian was about to make fun of him when he discovered that the other person’s face didn’t look right.

“What? Not settle yet?” As he asked, he signaled to all the servants to withdraw.

Chen Mufeng was too embarrassed to speak out.

To talk about the affairs in the Imperial Prince Ming Establishment would make one sighing. Chen Mufeng’s father, Imperial Prince Ming, had a principal consort, two side-consorts, and a concubine. The principal consort had given birth to a son, a daughter, and then another son. The first son was Chen Mufeng. The second son also was born intelligent. Unfortunately, he was killed by the concubine when he was five years old. The principal consort was inconsolably heartbroken that consequently harmed her health

and made her unable to conceive again. The concubine was dead. It was also very coincidental with both side-consorts – they unexpectedly did not give birth to a son. The first side-consort gave birth to two daughters; the second side-consort gave birth to three daughters, two of which died of illness prematurely. Therefore, Chen Mufeng was the only son of Imperial Prince Ming. The reason why Imperial Prince Ming insisted Chen Mufeng have a son was also related to the fact that he had lost a son – whether it was for the continuation of lineage, consolation, or other reasons, there was nothing to be said against him wanting a grandson. Chen Mufeng understood this, so it made things harder.

Back at home that day, Chen Mufeng politely asked Imperial Prince Ming if he could have a younger brother. Unexpectedly, Imperial Prince Ming told him that when he learned about Chen Mufeng's fatal attraction with Zhangsun He, he wanted to have another son as soon as possible. At that time, he was more diligent in the affairs of husband and wife, but his principal consort and the younger side-consorts didn't get pregnant again. He realized that something was wrong. After seeing the imperial doctor, he also learned that his health had deteriorated and it was unlikely that he would beget another child.

Imperial Prince Ming could see that Zhangsun He was good to his son. It wasn't that he didn't care about his son's happiness. He only insisted Chen Mufeng have a son because there was no other way.

When Chen Mufeng learned the whole story, he felt ashamed. However, if he was asked to go against his and Zhangsun He's mutual determination to have a child with a woman, he really couldn't do it. In desperation, he came to Qin Mian for help.

"It's unlikely that your father will beget another child – in other words, it's still possible?" Qin Mian grasped the key point.

"That's exactly what my father meant." Chen Mufeng looked at him eagerly, "Your medical expertise is also top quality, can you find a way to cure my father? Or is there any way I can beget a child without touching a woman?"

The corners of Qin Mian's mouth twitched, but he replied, "Can cure or not, I need to feel your father's pulse before I can make a diagnosis. As for whether there is any way for you to beget a child without touching a woman... I'm not a God." The combination of sperm and ovum was a complex knowledge, which was not known to the ancients.

Chen Mufeng was speechless for a moment. To personally feeling the pulse meant that his father's private affairs would be exposed in front of Qin Mian – his father would be very embarrassed. It would be unfilial for him if he wronged his father for his own sake. He couldn't be so selfish.

Qin Mian fully understood his thoughts. Let alone an ancient man, even a modern man would be very embarrassed to be told that he might be infertile.

However, he truly wanted to help Chen Mufeng. For one thing, Chen Mufeng was his friend. After selling the anti-seasonal vegetable formula in Zhaoyang County, although it was mostly for business interests, if Chen Mufeng and Mu Chen didn't protect them, his family would not have lived a peaceful life. For another thing, he and Lei Tie were happy, but Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He were in misery – it truly made him sympathize.

But Zhangsun He couldn't stay aloof from the affair. He had to fight for more advantages for his friend.

"I understand your concerns. You need to find a way to let me feel your father's pulse without his knowledge."

"Without my father's knowledge? Do you want to knock him out?" Chen Mufeng ridiculed himself.

Qin Mian gave a lousy idea, "You can let Zhangsun He knock him out."

Chen Mufeng looked at him, at a loss whether to cry or to laugh. All of a sudden, he realized that Qin Mian's words seemed to have a deeper meaning. When he understood, his eyes revealed a sly and relaxed smile, "You're right. Let him solve this problem."

With that, he took his leave in a hurry.

Less than two hours later, Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He appeared together in the State Defender Duke Establishment.

In terms of rank, Qin Mian's position was higher than that of Zhangsun He. Zhangsun He bowed with hands folded to Qin Mian rather politely to greet him, "Greetings, Lady of the State Defender Duke."

"Young Marquis doesn't have to be courteous. Have a seat." Qin Mian drank his tea slowly and did not take the initiative to ask their intention.

Chen Mufeng, as though he had turned into a closed gourd, crossed his legs and grabbed the fruit in the fruit plate to eat.

Zhangsun He said, "Many thanks, Lady of the State Defender Duke. Wonder if Lady of the State Defender Duke can help take a trip to Huifeng Winehouse to the end? When it's done, I'll be very grateful."

Qin Mian gave a wee smile, "Grateful isn't enough, Young Marquis owes me a favor."

Zhangsun He took a deep look at him and said without the least hesitation, "Sure!"

After Qin Mian informed Steward Fu he went to the private room on the second floor of Huifeng Winehouse with Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He. Imperial Prince Ming lay on the table, motionless as if he was asleep.

Qin Mian reminded them, "His Imperial Highness wasn't knocked out with a knockout drug, right? The drug will affect the pulse."

Chen Mufeng chuckled.

Zhangsun He looked at him with a faint look of helplessness and connivance. He was a little depressed as he said, "I hit him."

Qin Mian sniggered and said nothing more. He came forward and grabbed Imperial Prince Ming's wrist.

Both Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He were nervous and held their breath.

As soon as Qin Mian released his hand, Zhangsun He's face showed an anxious look, "How is it?"

Qin Mian cupped his hands toward the couple and said, "Congratulations. The problem isn't serious."

"Real—" Chen Mufeng exclaimed in surprise but shut up in time and looked cautiously at Imperial Prince Ming.

The poor Imperial Prince Ming was still unconscious.

Qin Mian said in a low voice, "Talk outside."

Zhangsun He sent them to the door – he had to stay in the private room to bear the wrath of Imperial Prince Ming.

Out of the winehouse, they went to a corner. Chen Mufeng asked, "My father's body can be cured?"

Qin Mian nodded, "Believe me. When I go back, I'll prescribe the medicine myself. Take one pill a day. After taking it for a month, I guarantee that he can have as many children as he wants in ten years. Besides that, your father's body is outwardly strong but inwardly weak. I'll write a prescription and give it to you."

Chen Mufeng breathed a sigh of relief as if to unload the heavy burden. With hands cupped, he solemnly said, "Words cannot express my appreciation for what you have done."

"Don't be so formal." Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder.

They borrowed brush, ink, paper, and inkstone from a nearby shop. Qin Mian gave Chen Mufeng a prescription and told him to pick up medicine from the State Defender Duke Establishment the next day.

Chen Mufeng arrived as promised and brought two pots of shy grass with him. He said that the flower was very interesting – it would close as soon as

someone touched it. He gave it to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to play with. Shy grass was actually Mimosa. It was presented by the Tulou's envoy. It was really a rare plant in Great Xia. A pot was worth at least 100 taels of silver. He did not know that Qin Mian's space was full of Mimosa. Alas, Qin Mian was a man after all – he was not so attentive and never thought to dig out plants for his sons to play with. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin would like these two pots of the plant. Generally speaking, this gift was quite proper.

At the same time, Chen Mufeng also sent a 1000-tael silver banknote provided by Zhangsun He for the consultation fee. Chen Mufeng insisted that Qin Mian take it. So, Qin Mian took it. The medicinal materials in his space were of high quality. This 1000 taels of silver that Zhangsun He spent was worthwhile.

He gave the refined pills to Chen Mufeng, a bottle of 30 pills, which could be taken continuously for a full month term.

After they were done talking about the important matter, Chen Mufeng was in a good mood to talk about what happened later in the winehouse.

Imperial Prince Ming would have known that he was hit. Zhangsun He took the initiative to admit that he had hit the wrong person. Imperial Prince Ming, who originally disapproved of him, had an even less good opinion of him. He gave Zhangsun He a fierce beating. Zhangsun He endured it without a word. Imperial Prince Ming felt dull and left with a fling of his sleeve.

Qin Mian was amused, “He was hit, and you can still be happy?”

Chen Mufeng was all smiles, “He has thick skin anyway.” He had been entangled with Zhangsun He for so many years and went through a lot. He just wanted to let Zhangsun He know that he had a backing.

Chapter 186: Exchange of Views Between the Two Countries (1)

186 – Exchange of Views Between the Two Countries (1)

Zhangsun He came to the palace to accompany the Sixth Prince of Tuluo with a face full of smiles, which surprised Emperor Xiaohui. He didn't purposely investigate, but he had heard that Zhangsun He was beaten by Imperial Prince Ming, so he asked curiously.

Zhangsun He took the opportunity to tell him that Imperial Prince Ming would have another son. He did it on purpose. Properly exposing his own affairs to Emperor Xiaohui would make Emperor Xiaohui be more at ease with him.

As expected, Emperor Xiaohui was completely unconcerned as he congratulated Zhangsun He with a smile on having things worked out. The matter of Imperial Prince Ming having another son had no influence on him. He could sit on the throne for 20 years more at most. After 20 years, it would be the next emperor's business to guard against the Imperial Clan's children. He didn't need to be overcautious.

Two days later, the palace held another banquet. Whether or not Great Xia wanted to count on Tuluo, they were guests from afar, after all, so Great Xia had to entertain the envoys of Tuluo. If things were done carelessly, Tuluo would be suspicious.

Besides, the issue of candidates for the peace marriage also needed to be put on the agenda today.

The banquet was held at noon in the Hall of Reception.

Both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin liked the dishes from the imperial kitchen. Qin Mian asked for leave for his two sons and took them to the palace. Lei Tie supported this, but his sons still needed education. He straightforwardly told them that another purpose of taking them to the palace was to let them see the various aspects of society. If they were slacked in studies, they would be punished. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were young, but they knew about very troublesome things. They calmly promised.

The rest of the ministers and ladies looked at them with unusual gazes.

Qin Mian didn't care. Chen Mufeng asked him what he was thinking. He directly replied so smugly, "My sons are smart. It's fine if they miss class all day."

Chen Mufeng had nothing to say in reply. He made up his mind that when his younger brother was born, he would love him dearly like a son.

This banquet was different from the last one. In addition to the mandated ladies, there were also unmarried daughters of dignitaries and nobilities.

Great Xia paid more attention to the prevention between [unmarried] males and females. If the parents of the female were present, the requirements for prevention between males and females were not strict. Moreover, there were so many palace maids and palace attendants at the banquet that the possibility of underhanded secret dealings was very low.

The ministers and ladies had long known that the Tuluo delegation came to Great Xia for the purpose of courtship. They couldn't help guessing that the purpose of Emperor Xiaohui's asking them to bring the unmarried girls to the banquet was probably to confer a suitable woman the title of a princess to be sent to Tuluo for the peace marriage. Some parents were delighted to hear about it – if their daughter became a princess, they would also get some rewards. Some parents were particularly upset about it – they were unwilling to let their daughter marry in foreign countries. But the emperor's order must not be violated. Thus, there were so many beauties in the Hall of Reception, mostly young girls aged between 14 and 18 who had not yet been engaged.

This time, the seats were not divided between men and women but according to family arrangements. The married couple sat in the front while their daughters sat behind them. Some married couples had only one daughter behind them, some had three or four. They were legitimate daughters and concubine-born daughters.....

Emperor Xiaohui sat on the throne with the empress and the empress dowager sat on the left and right of the throne respectively. Princess Yanqing and Princess Duanning were present; Princess Duanning sat together with the empress, while Princess Yanqing sat with the empress dowager.

First Prince, Second Prince, Third Prince, Fourth Prince, and Fifth Prince were all present. This was the first time Qin Mian had seen five adult princes at the same time. Among them, First Prince was born by the former empress, Second Prince and Third Prince were born by the current empress, and Fourth Prince and Fifth Prince were born by Worthy Consort and Honored Consort respectively. The order of the imperial harem of Great Xia was one empress, one noble consort, four principal –worthy, honored, pure, and virtuous– consorts, and six imperial concubines. The rest of the ranks were unlimited. The empress was the only one in the imperial harem to bore two sons, which one could conclude that the means were unusual.

Qin Mian looked around and wondered: Are Princess Yanqing and Princess Duanning not the candidates for the peace marriage?

After three rounds of wine, Emperor Xiaohui instructed Prime Minister Wen out of the corner of his eye.

With a smile, Prime Minister Wen stood up and bowed in respect to Emperor Xiaohui, “Reporting, Your Majesty. Your subject thinks that since His Highness Liu is a rare guest, just serving food and wine is rather too dull.”

“Oh? Can it be that my dear subject Wen have a good suggestion?” asked Emperor Xiaohui with interest.

Prime Minister Wen said, “Your subject has heard long ago that people of Tuluo are good at literature and martial arts. Our Great Xia has no lack of great talent in literature and martial arts. Why don’t we take this rare opportunity to have a competition? On one hand, we can learn from each other; on the other hand, it can live up His Highness Liu and the envoys.”

Qin Mian understood. It seemed that Emperor Xiaohui was very confident in his subjects’ talents, so he had to show off.

Few of the officials who could achieve the fourth rank and above were confused. Seeing that Emperor Xiaohui and Prime Minister Wen were collaborating, they profusely agreed. In between modest words, they hoped they could ask the people of Tuluo for some advice.

After Emperor Xiaohui heard what was said, he naturally supported it strongly, “My dear subjects said it with solid judgment. But what does Your Highness Liu think on it?”

When Liu Manqing went to Great Xia this time, he only placed two of his own people in the envoy group, while the rest were arranged by Tuluo’s emperor. Even if he didn’t care about Tuluo’s reputation, the rest of the people wouldn’t let him bow out. So of course, he had to smile in agreement.

The envoy group’s Ye Yunwen was the ambassador of the diplomatic mission. He was about 40 years old and refined in manner. His gentle eyes were always flickering with calm and wise radiance. He said in a leisure manner, “We’ve been admiring the culture of Great Xia for a long time. Your Majesty’s words are exactly our thoughts. How does Your Majesty want to compete?”

This was the case with the exchanges between different countries – there was competition all the time. They had come prepared – there were many martial experts and gifted scholars in the envoy group.

It was really boring just to eat and drink. The young men and women in the banquet all had their interests perked up.

Emperor Xiaohui pondered for a moment, “Since it’s a competition, of course, it has to be enjoyable. How about this? The first is literary competition and the second is martial arts competition.”

Ye Yunwen glanced at the young girls behind the ministers and the mandated ladies, thinking that Emperor Xiaohui might want to choose one of these girls to be a princess and marry to Tuluo. They were not easy to fool. If they could defeat Great Xia in today’s competition, they could better make a demand.

He looked at Liu Manqing and respectfully asked, “What does Your Highness Liu think?”

Liu Manqing said, “Your Majesty said it with solid judgment.”

Emperor Xiaohui was about to speak when a clear female voice rang out in the hall.

“Imperial Father, your subject-daughter has a suggestion; wonder if it’s proper to say?”

The speaker was Princess Yanqing.

Emperor Xiaohui gave her a warning look but gently said, “What does Yanqing want to say?”

Princess Yanqing’s eyes flashed over Qin Mian as she said with a smile, “Your subject-daughter thinks that for the literary competition, how about both our Great Xia and Tuluo come out with three questions and pick the people to answer them. The same goes for the martial arts competition so that it’s more interesting.” Although today’s seating was not separated by gender, the civil and military officers were still separated. Besides, the civil and military uniforms were different. The people of Tuluo would be stupid if they didn’t know how to take advantage of it. Today, she wanted Qin Mian to be humiliated!

Emperor Xiaohui slightly nodded, “It’s a good idea.” Great Xia had always attached great importance to literature and art. Even many military officers

could compete in poem recital. Therefore, he had nothing to worry about.

It seemed that the people of Tuluo came prepared, so they agreed with Princess Yanqing's suggestion without a twitch.

Qin Mian noticed Princess Yanqing's gaze just now. He was very curious about how the other party would aim at him.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin both looked at Princess Yanqing. The brothers had similar cold expressions and their gazes were so sharp that they frightened people.

Princess Yanqing's heart jumped, subconsciously avoided their gazes, and then looked over with indignation. The two brothers had already looked away and talked in low voices.

Emperor Xiaohui drank a mouthful of fine wine and then smilingly said, "Your envoys of Tuluo are our distinguished guests, you may ask the questions first."

Liu Manqing suggested, "Your Majesty, how about this: my country and your country ask a question alternately?"

"That'll do, too." Emperor Xiaohui raised his hand and made a "please" gesture, "Then you go first."

The envoys of Tuluo all looked at Ye Yunwen.

Ye Yunwen stood up and bowed in respect to Emperor Xiaohui. He pondered for a moment. As he spoke, he glanced over the line of military officers. "It's midsummer now. For the first question, this foreign official asks you to compose a poem with the theme of midsummer."

Everyone came to understand. The other party knew that Great Xia attached importance to literature and art, and yet he came up with such a simple question – this was obviously just a probing.

Ye Yunwen looked at an Assistant Regional Commander with a stocky and imposing build in the line of military officers and said, "This daren, please

answer.”

The Assistant Regional Commander stood up and cupped his hands in obeisance. Scratching his head, he pondered with his head down.

Ye Yunwen looked not too excited and not at all urged him.

Of course, it was not good for the Assistant Regional Commander to delay for a long time. After thinking for a moment, he recited, “No warmth in the east window at night, cool and windy in the north door. I sit and lie back the whole day, leave not from the room. My heart which does not worry, is the same as going out.”¹

Some people nodded; others shook their heads.

Ye Yunwen commented simply, “Although the poem is simple, it’s quite interesting. Your country really has an abundance of talented people.”

Emperor Xiaohui laughed out loud.

Liu Manqing said with a smile, “Your country’s turn to set a question.”

Everyone looked at Prime Minister Wen.

Prime Minister Wen stood up rather benevolently and said, “Then, please compose a poem with the theme of wine.” He also pointed to one of the other party’s military officers.

It was unexpected that the military officer had a great talent. After standing up, he just pondered a little and recited, “I lift my drink and sing a song, for who knows if one’s life is short or long? Man’s life is like the morning dew, past days many future days few. The melancholy my heart begets, comes from cares I cannot forget. Who can unravel these sorrows of mine? I know of only one man, the God of Wine.”²

All of Great Xia’s people were shocked. *It’s a wonderful poem!*

Without hesitation, Emperor Xiaohui praised, “Good poetry! The first round is your country’s win. Here’s to you!”

After the toast, Tuluo set the second question.

It was still Ye Yunwen who came with the question, “Now, there are chickens and rabbits in the same cage; 35 heads and 94 feet. The question is, how many chickens and rabbits are there respectively?”

After listening to this question, Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin’s faces changed slightly. Wasn’t this the “quadratic equation of two variables” taught by Qin Mian? When Qin Mian taught Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, Lei Tie followed suit, so all four of them could solve this problem. However, by the looks of the others, almost all of them appeared tense.

Qin Mian said to himself that Ye Yunwen proceeding very ruthlessly. This problem was very difficult for ordinary people – it was not that they couldn’t solve it, but they might take a long time to solve it.

Many people wrote the calculations on the table with their fingers dipped in wine.

Ye Yunwen swept a glance around and looked at Prime Minister Wen, “Trouble Wen-daren to answer.” He could still try to probe again because the first round was won by Tuluo. He thought that Prime Minister Wen had the highest position among the civil officers and should be the most outstanding one.

Prime Minister Wen stroked his short beard and ordered someone to bring a brush, paper, and abacus.

Sheng Xuhao, the commander of the envoy group, said, “Your Majesty, should this question be time-limited?”

Emperor Xiaohui was also a man of profound knowledge. Naturally, he could see the difficulty of this problem. From above, he had a good view of people’s faces. He had no confidence, but he didn’t show it. He said with a

smile, “It should be so. How about within the limit of a single stick of incense takes to burn off?”

Liu Manqing’s party had no objection.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at Qin Mian inquiringly. Qin Mian slightly shook his head.

Prime Minister Wen was as steady as a mountain. After writing for a while, he put down his brush and answered, “23 chickens and 12 rabbits.”

Ye Yunwen praised with his hands cupped in obeisance, “I admire the great talent of Prime Minister Wen!”

“Haha, I don’t deserve such a compliment.” Prime Minister Wen took a look at Emperor Xiaohui, seeming somewhat unconfident.

Emperor Xiaohui’s smile was brief.

Ye Yunwen was pleased and said aloud, “What is your country’s second question?”

Footnotes

1. Summer Day by Bai Juyi. I couldn’t find an English translation of it. But the gist is that on the night of midsummer, he lay in the room, feeling at ease (going out here meant to have summer vacation something like that from the forum I read *la*). *I wasted so much time trying to find it uwu.*
2. Short Song Style by Cao Cao. Taken from https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Poetry_of_Cao_Cao

Chapter 187: Exchange of Views Between the Two Countries (2)

187 – Exchange of Views Between the Two Countries (2)

Great Xia had also prepared.

Zhangsun He stood up and said, “Just a few days ago, a friend of this gongzi encountered a problem. This gongzi wants to ask the respected envoys for a piece of advice. My friend is a manager. He wants to hire a worker to work for seven days. His boss gave him a gold bar and told him to give the worker a gold bar at the end of the worker’s daily work, but he was only allowed to break the bar twice. Sheng-daren, how to solve this problem?”

Ye Yunwen and the others’ faces were covered with a layer of dignified. This was a tricky problem. A gold bar was the seven days’ wage and the wage were required to be paid daily. The simplest way was to divide the gold bar into seven sections and pay one section every day. But this problem required that the gold bar could only be broken twice, which meant, it could only be divided into three sections – this was the difficulty.

Chen Mufeng deliberately said: “Your Majesty, for the sake of fairness, should this question be time-limited?”

Emperor Xiaohui said with a smile, “It’s only right and proper – the time is limited to a stick of incense burnt out. If you spend less time than our country, you win.”

Emperor Xiaohui kindly asked his attendants to send writing materials to the people of Tulu.

Sheng Xuhao was so angry as he calculated on the paper with a wooden face but couldn't figure out the solution.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin took out small pencils and notebooks from their pockets, then wrote and drew. The two brothers put down their pencils almost at the same time.

Lei Ruilin came to Qin Mian's ear and whispered a few words.

Qin Mian nodded approvingly.

Princess Yanqing saw it clearly. Although she didn't know what they were whispering about, Qin Mian seemed to know the answer. She told herself to calm down. The last question was the most difficult one.

The time for a stick of incense to burn out was quite fast – it soon burnt out.

Sheng Xuhao said with a wooden face, "This foreign official has no capability."

Zhangsun He saw that Ye Yunwen had finished written a moment ago and thought he had solved the problem. He cupped his hands to Ye Yunwen and said sincerely, "Venture to ask: perhaps Ye-daren has a solution to help my friend?"

Ye Yunwen noticed that they intended to give Tuluo some face, so he said with a smile, "You can divide the gold bar into seven parts with a carpenter's ink marker. For the first time, can cut one-part; for the second time, can cut two-part. The whole bar becomes a 'one-part', a 'two-part', and a 'four-part'. On the first day, pay one-part to the worker; on the second day, pay two-part to the worker and get one-part back; on the third day, pay one-part to the worker; on the fourth day, pay four-part to the worker and get one-part and two-part back; on the fifth day, pay one-part to the worker; on the sixth day, pay two-part to the worker and get one-part back; on the seventh day, pay one-part to the worker."

Zhangsun He applauded as he said, "Wonderful! Many thanks for Ye-daren's teaching."

All the ministers, without exception, applauded and praised.

Emperor Xiaohui laughed, “What’s your third question?” The second question went without saying – of course, Great Xia won.

As before, Ye Yunwen spoke on Tuluo’s behalf. He slowly said, “The third question is what this foreign official saw in an ancient book and couldn’t find the answer after much contemplation. Hope that the great talents of Great Xia can solve this foreign official’s doubts.”

All the people of Great Xia sat upright. Whether it was true or not that Ye Yunwen said that he didn’t know the answer, one could imagine the difficulty of this question.

Ye Yunwen said, “It’s dark and five spies need to cross a bridge. The bridge is in disrepair – It can only allow two people to walk at a time and one person needs to hold a light. The light will go out within 30 breath¹. It takes 1 breath for A to cross the bridge, 3 for B, 6 for C, 8 for D, and 12 for E. How should the five people cross the bridge?”

Ye Yunwen’s eyes scanned the military officers again.

After thinking for a moment, all the military officers had no answer. They were afraid of being named. Some young gongzis were interested – they calculated on the paper. No matter how they solved it, it took more than 30 breaths. They couldn’t help suspecting that this problem was wrong. But no one dared to question it. If it was not wrong, Great Xia would make a fool of itself.

Emperor Xiaohui’s brows also wrinkled – it was twice as difficult as the second question.

Unexpectedly, Princess Yanqing looked directly at Qin Mian and opened her mouth again with a surprised tone, “It seems to this princess that Lady of the State Defender Duke has the answer?”

Qin Mian just wanted to reply “har-har” to her. *If you don’t seek death, you won’t die.*

One had to say that Princess Yanqing was indeed a bit quick-witted. Just now, it was heard that Ye Yunwen didn't know how to solve this problem. He said that he hoped that the great talents of Great Xia would solve his doubts. If he really wanted to know the answer, he should call Qin Mian's name after listening to Princess Yanqing.

Ye Yunwen was experienced and astute. Although he didn't know that there was an enmity between Princess Yanqing and Lady of the State Defender Duke, it was inevitable that Princess Yanqing was a princess and didn't want to marry to Tuluo. The person she was targeting must be beneficial to Tuluo's win.

Therefore, a smile of joy immediately floated on Ye Yunwen's lips as he said to Qin Mian, "In this case, this official asking Lady of the State Defender Duke to grant an advice."

Emperor Xiaohui stared at Princess Yanqing coldly. If the occasion was right, he would have slapped her in the face. Needed not to mention the usual, but she inclined to help the foreigners at a state banquet, did she still deserve to be a princess?

The empress dowager and the empress still smiled elegantly and gracefully, but the smile did not reach the bottom of their eyes. The empress dowager, in particular, wanted to strangle Princess Yanqing – If she had some pity for Princess Yanqing in the past, she had nothing left at this time. She secretly scolded Yanqing as a white-eyed wolf.

The empress noticed the empress dowager's face, and her smile became more real.

There was disdain for Princess Yanqing hidden in Princess Duanning's eyes.

Lei Tie pinched Qin Mian's hand.

Qin Mian pinched back and stood up composedly. With calmness, he bowed in respect to Ye Yunwen, "Grateful to your respected envoy to think highly of this lady."

Ye Yunwen said to Emperor Xiaohui, “This problem is difficult to solve. It’s better to limit it to two sticks of incense.”

Emperor Xiaohui knew that Qin Mian was 14 years old when he suddenly appeared in Green Mountain Village; he didn’t know how much education Qin Mian had received before. He was about to find a way to buy more time for him when Qin Mian said with a smile, “No need.”

Ye Yunwen was stunned.

The others were taken aback. *Is Qin Mian going to admit defeat in front of so many people?*

Qin Mian looked at Ye Yunwen, “This lady can answer it now. You may need to take notes.”

The entire audience was shocked.

Princess Yanqing narrowed her eyes, pinched her palm with her right sharp fingernail so hard it bled but she didn’t care. She inwardly yelled: It’s impossible!

Ye Yunwen had a look of solemnity, “Please say it, Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

Inwardly, Qin Mian laughed in a sneer. *Although I didn’t get into a good university only because I didn’t do well in liberal arts, my science department was the best. On this problem, you underestimated this lady too much!*

“First, A and B cross the bridge, and A return with the light – it took 4 breath. Then, A and C cross the bridge, and B return with the light – it took 9 breath. Next, D and E cross the bridge, and A returns with the light – it took 13 breath. Lastly, A and B cross the bridge – it took 4 breath. The total time it took is 30 breath.” Qin Mian finished and asked Ye Yunwen modestly, “Wonder if this lady’s answer is right?”

Ye Yunwan made a careful calculation and praised him unceasingly while his heart was heavy, “There is no mistake, this official has been taught.”

In disbelief, Princess Yanqing opened her mouth to speak but the empress dowager pinched her arm hard. She turned her head to a pair of cold and strict eyes. As though she fell into an icehouse, she was so frightened that she did not dare to say anything.

Emperor Xiaohui laughed heartily, “State Defender Duke, your lady is a hidden gem!”

Lei Tie said modestly, “Your Majesty overpraises.”

The empress proposed a toast with a smile and said in a sweet and girlish voice, “State Defender Duke has martial capabilities and Lady of the State Defender Duke has literary capabilities – It can be said that they are a perfect couple. This empress would like to propose a toast to you both and wish you both a harmonious union lasting a hundred years.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie raised their cups together. After saluting, they said in unison, “Many thanks for the kind words of Your Majesty the Empress.”

All the ministers smiled and honored them from afar.

Liu Manqing was not satisfied with this and said, “I wonder what your third question is?”

Qin Mian just sat down and stood up again, “Reporting, Your Majesty. This humble one ventures to ask the Tuluo envoys a question. Hope Your Majesty approves.”

Emperor Xiaohui straightforwardly said, “Approved!”

The people of Tuluo solemnly waited.

Qin Mian slightly smiled, “This strange thing happened in an inn. Three people stayed for a night in separated rooms and a room cost 10 taels of silver. Therefore, they paid the innkeeper 30 taels. The next day, the innkeeper remembered that some minor problems in the three rooms had

not been repaired, so he thought that the three rooms should be charged 25 taels. He asked the assistant to return 5 taels to the guests. Who would have known, the assistant was greedy – he embezzled 2 taels and returned 1 tael to each of the three guests. In this way, it means that each of the three guests spent 9 taels – a total of 27 taels. 27 taels plus the 2 taels stolen by the clerk is 29 taels. Where did the remaining 1 tael go?”

“Eh?”

All the people who followed to calculate were surprised – they nodded one after another and discussion ensued.

“Yes, that’s right. The three people spent a total of 29 taels. What about the remaining 1 tael?”

“This is really strange. It’s clearly 30 taels, so why is the sum turned out to be 29 taels?”

“.....”

The Tuluo gentlemen were a little disheartened. This question was really strange.

Emperor Xiaohui was in a good mood when he saw this. “How about this? Any of your envoys can answer this question, and any of Great Xia’s officials and young ladies can also solve it. No matter who solved it, Zhen will reward greatly. The time is limited to two sticks of incense.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin calculated in the small notebooks.

Qin Ruiqi first realized and came to Qin Mian’s ear, “Dad, there is a miscalculation on this money.”

Qin Mian gave him a thumbs-up under the table.

Lei Tie handed the cup to his wife.

Lei Ruilin’s realization was no slower than his Gege’s. He pulled Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s clothes and motioned to the two fathers to see his calculation.

Qin Mian also gave him a thumbs-up. He was proud of his two sons.

Footnotes

1. Breath: Take a breath. A breath is a period of taking a breath.

Chapter 188: The Candidate for the Peace Marriage

188 – The Candidate for the Peace Marriage

“A-Tie, do you know what’s going on?” Qin Mian asked Lei Tie in a smug tone.

Lei Tie took a funny look at his wife and held his hand on the table. He pondered for a moment, “Steal the beams and change the pillars.”¹

His calm expression and steady manner exuded reassuring charm. Qin Mian so wanted to jump over and kiss him, but too many people got in the way. He picked up a piece of pastry and took a bite. He deliberately frowned, pretended it was not to his taste and handed it to Lei Tie.

Lei Tie took the pastry and ate it in two bites as he looked at him.

Qin Mian looked away with the corners of his lips curved.

Emperor Xiaohui was amused when he saw it and shook his head to himself. *Lady of the State Defender Duke and State Defender Duke are a perfect match.*

Some of the people had given up and continued to eat and drink; others were not resigned and continued to solve the odd question.

After a long time, the first incense was burnt out. The attendant silently went over and put on the second incense.

Chen Mufeng gently smiled as he put down his writing brush, “So, that’s the case.”

A light flashed in Emperor Xiaohui's eyes and he asked with a smile, "Oh? Does Mufeng understand what's going on?"

Every Tuluo person had a somber expression; they looked over at Chen Mufeng.

Chen Mufeng got up and explained, "Answering, Your Majesty. It's like this. The innkeeper returned 5 taels, in other words, the three guests only paid 25 taels. Then, on average, each person should pay 8 and $\frac{1}{3}$ taels of silver. With the addition of 1 tael returned, the total should be 9 and $\frac{1}{3}$ taels. But the next sentence said, 'each of the three guests spent 9 taels' – this sentence cleverly confused the thinking of the respondents, so it led to the problem of 1 tael lost."

Everyone suddenly understood at the same time; they all admired the questioner.

"So, that's the case..."

Ye Yunwen and Sheng Xuhao looked at each other and suddenly understood why their Tuluo emperor was so afraid of Great Xia. It seemed to be a kind of disadvantage that Great Xia paid more attention to literature arts than to martial arts, but on the battlefield, a military advisor with a quick-witted mind could be worth tens of thousands of armies.

Emperor Xiaohui was overjoyed, "Well then, Commandery Prince Mu will be greatly rewarded."

"Many thanks, Your Majesty."

Tuluo came all the way to Great Xia not to be disgraced but was defeated in the literary arts contest. Liu Manqing and the others all forced their faces to smile and could only hope for the martial arts contest.

Sheng Xuhao gave a meaningful look to Liu Manqing.

Liu Manqing said toward the upper seat, "Your Majesty, congratulations on your victory. Venture to ask how to carry out the martial arts contest?"

Emperor Xiaohui thought about it and said, “This way: my country and Tuluo present three people each; two wins in three sets are the winner. How about it?”

“That’s very good.” Liu Manqing looked at Sheng Xuhao and said, “General Sheng, in your opinion, which three people should we send to compete?”

Sheng Xuhao looked around the people with him and pointed out the three valiant generals.

Lei Tie introduced them to Qin Mian through mind transference, “*Li Yuanming and Huyan Lie are both famous generals of Tuluo, but Abu is unheard of.*”

Emperor Xiaohui wanted to hide the strength of Great Xia, but he couldn’t do it too obviously. He picked a left general, an official gatekeeper of the city, and a brigade vice commander.

Tuluo won the first set, lost the second, and won the third. The martial arts contest was won by Tuluo. Lost the literature arts contest but won the martial arts contest – it was not too disgraceful.

By this time, the banquet had come to an end.

The two sides still did not mention the candidates for the peace marriage, but they already knew each other well.

After the banquet, compared with before, the civil and military ministers and the mandated ladies were much more enthusiastic toward Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie coped with the situation smoothly, and as before, they remained indifferent whether granted favors or subjected to humiliation.

On the other side, when Emperor Xiaohui returned to the back palace, his face gloomed.

The empress dowager and the empress sat by and looked at Princess Yanqing faintly.

Emperor Xiaohui was in uncontrollable anger that he struck the table hard, “Evil woman, kneel!”

Princess Yanqing obediently knelt. Her beautiful eyes were full of crystal tears. She pouted and said, “Imperial Father, Yanqing knows she is wrong~~” Imperial Father and Imperial Grandmother always fell for this trick of hers.

Emperor Xiaohui calmly asked, “Oh? You tell Zhen, what have you done wrong?”

Princess Yanqing said without the least hesitation, “Your daughter should not target Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

The empress dowager’s eyes only glanced at her lightly, then she looked away and sipped the fragrant tea without saying a word.

The empress pretended to wipe the tea on her lips with a silk handkerchief – there was a mocking smile on her lips.

“Imperial Father, Imperial Grandmother, and Imperial Mother. Yanqing truly knows her mistake... *sob sob*...” Yanqing knelt on the ground and cried very sad.

Unfortunately, Emperor Xiaohui did not intend to forgive her this time. What Emperor Xiaohui was annoyed about was not the matter of Princess Yanqing involving Lady of the State Defender Duke, which might lead to Great Xia’s loss in the literary arts contest. What made him feel bitterly disappointed was that Princess Yanqing didn’t have an appreciation of a thing’s importance that regardless of the occasion, she pulled her own leg before other people. He realized very clearly that his daughter was a hopeless case.

He and the empress dowager looked at each other, and the empress dowager slightly nodded.

It was time to decide the candidate for the peace marriage.

Emperor Xiaohui was reluctant to marry off Duanning and Princess Yanqing was also his own daughter. The reason why Emperor Xiaohui asked the dignitaries to bring their unmarried daughters was that he really planned to choose a suitable person to confer a princess title among them. But now, he changed his mind. Princess Yanqing had given up her chance.

However, he knew his daughter's temperament and didn't plan to tell her now. Like many times in the past, Princess Yanqing made mistakes and admitted them, so he softened his expression and lovingly said, "Alright, get up. You can't be so willful next time."

Princess Yanqing honestly kowtowed and promised. The smile on her lips was so complacent and aware that things would turn out this way.

Emperor Xiaohui clearly saw her expression – his face turned colder. He stood up and said in a light voice, "Imperial Mother, your son is a little tired. Going to have a rest first."

The empress dowager stood up and nodded, "Today's government affairs are tedious. The emperor needs to take care of his health. Empress, be more attentive."

"Yes, Imperial Mother, your daughter-in-law sincerely abides by your teaching."

Not long after Emperor Xiaohui left, the empress also left with Princess Duanning.

When she was about to leave the hall, Princess Duanning looked back and saw that Princess Yanqing threw herself in the empress dowager's arms just as coquettish as before and not at all noticed the coldness of the empress dowager's expression. She felt very sympathetic, but she wouldn't do anything.

It takes more than one cold day for the river to freeze three feet deep.²

“Duanning?” prompted the empress.

Princess Duanning quickly picked up her skirt and kept up. She took the empress’s arm, “Imperial Mother, wait for your daughter.”

“Hey, you. You aren’t allowed to interfere in your eldest sister’s affairs,” warned the empress as she lovingly poked her forehead.

“Don’t worry, Imperial Mother. Your daughter understands.”

The empress patted her arm with a slight smile and said in a low voice, “If your Imperial Mother is right, your Imperial Father will bestow marriage to you today.”

Princess Duanning’s face turned red, “Imperial Mother~~”

Two flowers blossomed, one on each side.³

Not long after the Qin Mian family returned to the State Defender Duke Establishment, the rewards from the emperor, the empress dowager, and the empress arrived. The reason for the rewards was unclear.

The Qin Mian family was not short of money. They didn’t care about the value of these gold and silver jewelry. They just gathered around to admire the attractive design of some rare items.

Less than an hour later, Emperor Xiaohui’s decree spread out in the palace: Princess Duanning is matched by the emperor to marry. Next year, she will be married off to the Heir of Martial God Marquis.

As soon as this edict was issued, the shrewd people understood that the one likely to be decreed to the Sixth Prince of Tuluo was Princess Yanqing.

The Tuluo people might know that Princess Yanqing was an old maid, but Great Xia’s attitude was very obvious: It’s fine if you don’t want Princess Yanqing, but then you can marry any made princess in the family of a minister or marquis.

Under the weight and consider balance, it was only natural for the Tuluo people to choose Princess Yanqing, who was the real descendant of royalty. Even if a woman in a minister or marquis's family was conferred a super-rank princess, she had no blood relationship with Emperor Xiaohui.

The marriage between Liu Manqing and Princess Yanqing was a foregone conclusion. Emperor Xiaohui himself issued a ban order, forbidding anyone to tell Princess Yanqing about it, otherwise, they would be punished according to the crime of treason.

In such a big palace, only Princess Yanqing was kept in the dark.

Six days later, the Tuluo envoys set out to return to Tuluo.

Emperor Xiaohui had a deep understanding of his eldest daughter's character. On the day of the departure, he had Princess Yanqing knocked out with drug. Princess Yanqing was delivered to an elegant red carriage in her sleep.

In order to express Princess Yanqing's value, Emperor Xiaohui prepared 160 dowries for Princess Yanqing. Among them were an arched-stone crown, 10 second-grade eastern pearls, 5 golden phoenixes, 25 fifth-grade eastern pearls, 7 dull pearls, 120 fragmented small pearls, 2 black pearls, a golden long-tailed bird, an inlaid ornamental knot, a gold-encrusted peach blossom ornamental accessory... and so on – it was truly a ten *li* of female adornment.

On this day, almost all the people crowded on both sides of the street to watch the grand occasion of the princess's trip. The Capital was like boiling water.

The empress was thoughtful and arranged for a palace maid in the princess's carriage. She put on a veil, lift the curtain from time to time, and smiled, nodded, or wave to the people. The people were even more excited.

Because there were too many dowries and to show Great Xia attached great importance to the marriage with Tuluo, Emperor Xiaohui sent 5000 elite soldiers to escort the princess and protect the envoy group.

It happened that Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were on holiday. They sat on Golden Fur with Zhangsun Hong, the son of Zhangsun He, and watched the excitement on the street.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Chen Mufeng, and Zhangsun He stood behind them.

“When I marry a wife in the future, the parade won’t be small,” said Lei Ruilin in all seriousness.

“*Cough cough...*” Qin Mian choked on his saliva making him coughed until he was red. *Just this old and this stinky son is thinking of marrying a wife!*

Lei Tie patted him on the back.

Zhangsun Hong made fun of Lei Ruilin, “How old are you now?”

Qin Ruiqi straightforwardly flicked Lei Ruilin’s forehead without expression.

“Ge!” Lei Ruilin covered his forehead.

“Nonsense,” said Qin Ruiqi lightly.

Lei Ruilin still wanted to say something but upon seeing his Old Dad stared at him coldly while pacifying his Dad, he was startled. He stuck out his tongue and turned his head to continue watching.

Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun He laughed.

Lei Tie took a look at Zhangsun He, “I’ll leave it to you.”

Zhangsun He understood, “Rest assured.”

Lei Tie took Qin Mian by the hand and went to the sparsely populated street. If nothing changed in Emperor Xiaohui’s arrangement, Lei Tie would take the army to the west in half a month at most. Their time was running out.

“A-Tie, I think we have to secretly go to Dongyang Academy to see how’s our sons doing every day. Look at what Ruilin said!” Qin Mian didn’t know whether to laugh or cry.

Lei Tie said, “Tomorrow’s matter is for tomorrow. Today, you just need to listen to me.”

Qin Mian went up shoulder-to-shoulder with him, incomparably cooperated, “All right. I’ll go wherever you want to go. The husband sings, the husband (wife) follows. Hahaha...”

“The husband sings, the husband follows?” Lei Tie looked as if he was deeply thinking. Then, he clasped the back of Qin Mian’s head and kissed him on the forehead before pulling him forward.

Footnotes

1. (idiom) to perpetrate a fraud; substitute the fake for the genuine
2. (meaning) the trouble has been brewing for quite some time.
3. It’s a narrative technique of ancient chapter novels which means, the story developed in two (plot?), we’ll uncover it one by one.

Chapter 189: The War Begins

189 – The War Begins

The place Lei Tie took Qin Mian to was not special, but within three days, they went through almost all the places worth visiting in the Capital and various refreshments such as baked rolls, pea flour cakes, sweetened baked wheaten cakes, sweet-filling glutinous rice cakes, fried haws, seasoned millet mush, pear tea, ma doufu, fried sesame egg cakes, kidney bean rolls, honey date wrapped with lotus leaves, toad spit honey¹, yam cakes, glass noodles, and sweet fried-pan desserts..... practically ate everywhere.

Qin Mian felt like he was on honeymoon again.

Every day, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin came home from school to see a different kind of snacks at home – they knew that their Old Dad bought them from outside with their Dad. They were so fond of good food that they also wanted to go. Unfortunately, Qin Mian could never ask them for leave to take them along. The children were older. He and Lei Tie should have a proper good time in their married life.

Three days later, Lei Tie began to get busy and often went home after dark.

Qin Mian took the time to enter the space. He planned to grab an eagle for Lei Tie and let him take it to West Pass. An eagle had a keen vision, was ferocious, and flew at a fast speed and long duration. It was good even if it was only used to send messages.

It was not difficult to catch an eagle in the space. Qin Mian finally caught a golden eagle on a high mountain – it was 5 *chi* long and could reach more than 8 *chi*² when its wings were spread out. He didn't dare to catch one with an enormous body because it would be hard to explain to outsiders.

He pretended to take a few armed-servants to the deep mountains to hunt and amuse themselves and brought the golden eagle back two days later. The armed-servants personally saw him “shot down” the golden eagle, so they were not suspicious about it.

The golden eagle was given to Lei Tie and Lei Tie liked it very much. He suppressed the golden eagle with spiritual qi. After fake-training it for several days, he placed a beast-control talisman into the golden eagle’s internal. The golden eagle then recognized him as the master – it was submissive and intelligent.

In recent days, State Defender Duke and his wife had made a public display of affection. The people in the Capital had seen them and became inured to the unusual. Therefore, they were not surprised to see the golden eagle sending Lei Tie to court for the first time.

After that, Qin Mian also put himself into the busy work, refining batch after batch of high-quality effective medicine in the space.

Half a month later, a large number of officers and soldiers left the Capital at night, escorting food and fodder westward. There was a saying in the Art of War: Before the troops and horses move, food and fodder go first. Food and fodder included not only grains and forage, but also salt, spices, herbal medicines, weapons, tents, and other military supplies.

Half a month later, a piece of shocking news came back from the frontier juncture: Princess Yanqing, who volunteered to go to Tuluo in peace marriage for the sake of peace between Great Xia and Tuluo, was brutally killed by the ruthless Tuluo people within the Tuluo border, about 20 *li* away from the Heroic Duo Stronghold of West Pass, Great Xia!

Emperor Xiaohui was devastated by the news of his daughter’s tragic death. He was seriously ill and did not go to court for three days.

The people were indignant and recalled the scene when Princess Yanqing waved her hand to them on her wedding day – their hatred for Tuluo became stronger. They hoped that the imperial court could teach a heavy lesson to the incorrigible Tuluo people.

Emperor Xiaohui went to court in a bad health and conferred a posthumous title to Princess Yanqing – Yanqing the First Virtuous Princess. He denounced Tuluo for trampling on Great Xia's sincerity to mend with them. The crime was unforgivable; he issued an order to attack Tuluo. This was not only to seek justice for Princess Yanqing but also to thoroughly crackdown on the arrogance of Tuluo. The past several disputes between Tuluo and Great Xia told them that tolerance to the enemy would only bring more cruel revenge.

Before the dawn of the next day, Defender Grand General of the State, Lei Tianren led 100,000 vanguard soldiers with His Highness the First Prince as the supervisor and moved the army north, followed closely by Grand General of South Order, Yuan Gang with 40,000 soldiers.

Qin Mian stood on the city wall with Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin. He watched Lei Tie disappear at the end of the public road.

As soon as Lei Tie left, his heart felt empty.

“Dad?” Qin Ruiqi was very worried and held his father's hand.

Qin Mian returned to his senses and said with a smile, “I'm fine. It's just that this is the first time your Old Dad will be away for so long.” Even if Lei Tie went to the battlefield as soon as he arrived at West Pass, it would take only two days to win the battle and another two months to return home. Besides, the Tuluo people were cruel and insidious. Once the battle between Great Xia and Tuluo began, it was impossible to end too soon.

Lei Ruilin took his father's other hand and said firmly, “Dad, Old Dad will return with glorious victory!”

“En.” Qin Mian nodded with a smile, “Let's go home.”

Back at the State Defender Duke Establishment, he asked the servants to send his two sons to Dongyang Academy and sat alone in the study as he pondered. Most of the ancient wars took place in spring, autumn, and winter. One of the important reasons was that the summer was hot. If the corpses on the battlefield couldn't be disposed of in time, the corpses would

rot and lead to a large-scale plague. The plague in ancient times was the most difficult to control. Once it broke out, it would not benefit both warring sides.

Even if Qin Mian was not particularly good at and understood politics, he could infer that the reason why Emperor Xiaohui let the army go immediately after the death of Princess Yanqing was just to show his “passive” position in the war. It was very unlikely that Lei Tie would go to war immediately after he arrived at West Pass and most probably had to wait when the weather was cooler. This meant that the imperial court would have to spend more on military resources.

Since Emperor Xiaohui dared to initiate war on his own initiative, the imperial court must have sufficient military expenditure. However, his man was the commander-in-chief. If Qin Mian wanted him to come back earlier, Qin Mian had to consider all aspects for him. The first thing he considered was to prepare more military expenditure, making provisions against emergencies. However, it was not the time yet.

After arriving at West Pass, Lei Tie immediately found a chance to enter the space and met Qin Mian to exchange information. When the Tuluo people learned that the emperor of Great Xia wanted to avenge Princess Yanqing, they immediately sent troops to the border. Today, nearly 200,000 troops of the two armies confronted each other in West Pass. Lei Tie took the initiative to launch a tentative small-scale battle on the second day when the army was well-rested and won a big victory. Because both sides were worried about the plague, there was no battle later, but confrontation. If nothing happened, as soon as the 9th lunar month came, he would launch a large-scale attack.

Qin Mian told him to be careful because the blades had no eyes.

In the 9th lunar month, the messenger rushed to the Capital; Great Xia and Tuluo officially went to war.

Qin Mian also went into action. His identity as “Mandated Lady” was a bit awkward at this time. Because a mandated lady was not allowed to interfere in politics, he couldn’t directly tell Emperor Xiaohui what he planned;

meanwhile, the empress was a woman, he needed to pay attention to restrictions between male and female. After thinking about it, he handed a memorial to the empress. If the empress valued it, the empress would hand it over to Emperor Xiaohui.

The day after the memorial was handed over, the imperial edict came from the palace, praising Qin Mian's idea of recommending officials and merchants in the Capital to donate money. Less than an hour later, the empress's oral instruction arrived, which stated that three days later, she invited all the mandated ladies to dinner in the imperial garden.

The theme of the empress's banquet was fund-raising.

The mandated ladies were reluctant, but after the empress took the lead in donating 1000 taels of silver, they had no choice but to loosen their purses, ranging from 600 to 800 taels. The consorts and concubines were unwilling to be outdone and donated as few as 100 taels and as many as 900 taels – as long as they did not surpass the empress. The empress dowager donated 1000 taels, and even Princess Duanning Gong donated 600 taels of silver.

Qin Mian was the first person to donate 800 taels of silver.

After all the mandated ladies finished donating, the empress said with a smile that how much they donated would be recorded on the gold-plated list and posted at the gate of the city for a proclamation.

This thereupon was a philanthropic act, which not only brought good reputation to one's husband but also brought benefits to one's children. The mandated ladies were so happy that they felt that they had not donated enough before, so they quickly added a few hundred more.

When the merchants in the Capital heard about this, one after another donated money.

This time, nearly 5 million taels of silver were raised.....

Whenever Lei Tie had a chance, he would go into the space to meet Qin Mian. Qin Mian was not very worried about Lei Tie's fighting in a place of

thousands of *li* away. However, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin couldn't see Lei Tie. Every few days, the father and sons would write a letter to Lei Tie and send them to West Pass by the official relay station.

In West Pass, the war was raging.

Dressed in a combat uniform, Lei Tie stood on the city wall with hands on his back, looking at the enemy camp less than five *li* away.

Lei-Qin Zhong rushed over, took out a letter from his inner pocket, and handed it to him with both hands.

“My Lord, it's from my Lady.”

When Lei Tie saw two small handprints on the letter, the cold aura on his whole body scattered, and faint warmth infused in his eyes. The two small handprints were from Ruiqi and Ruilin. On the day of their one-month-old, he made molds for Ruiqi and Ruilin's small hands and carved them into seals. His wife said they were “commemorative seals”.

When First Prince Chen Chuang came up, he happened to see the change of Lei Tie's expression and was internally bewildered. Seeing that Lei Tie opened the letter, he didn't walk over immediately. His sight on Lei Tie's back was profound and absent-minded.

Lei Tie carefully read the letter. The first page was written by his wife, the second page was written by his eldest son, and the third page was written by his youngest son.

In the letter, besides asking him to take care of himself, there were bed talks and trivial matters. He still read it very seriously.

Over ten years ago, he was also here. He was like a lone wolf fighting with the enemy and could only watch others read letters from home.

After reading the letter three times from beginning to end, he folded it again and put it in his inner pocket in a cherishing manner. Then, he faintly looked at Chen Chuang.

Chen Chuang came to his senses and walked over.

“Your Highness the First Prince,” saluted Lei Tie.

“Don’t stand on ceremony, Grand General.” Chen Chuang stood beside him and said with a smile, “Just now, Grand General must be reading a letter from home, right? Grand General and your wife are very affectionate. Truly enviable.”

Footnotes

1. Toad spit honey is a cake with red bean stuffing and a crack on the surface.
2. The bird here can be any bird of prey, not necessarily an eagle (I just can’t decide). Also, it’s kind of BIG. 1.67~2.67 m.

Chapter 190: Two Foals

190 – Two Foals

Lei Tie nodded in silence and inquired if Chen Chuang needed something by the expression in his eyes.

The mighty golden eagle unhurriedly flew over and landed quietly on the guardrail of the city wall like a fallen leaf. Its pair of black bean-like eyes watched Lei Tie with loyalty.

Lei Tie raised his hand and gently held it on its back.

Chen Chuang looked at the enemy camp in the distance, “Our army suffered many casualties in the first battle yesterday. What’s Grand General’s plan next?”

Lei Tie stared at him for a moment, “This general has his own sense of propriety; Your Highness the First Prince doesn’t need to be troubled.” The so-called “military inspector” had two responsibilities: one, to supervise the commander-in-chief; two, to manage the meritorious deeds in the army and audit rewards and punishments. For Lei Tie, the prince had only the right to supervise, but not the right to intervene in the war.

Chen Chuang didn’t think he would be disobedient. He looked annoyed and ashamedly said, “Oh dear, this prince went overboard in a moment of desperation, asking Grand General not to blame. Grand General, it suddenly occurred to this prince that there is still business to be dealt with. Excuse my absence!”

“Your Highness the First Prince, do as you please,” said Lei Tie as he raised his hand in a “please” gesture.

After Chen Chuang left, he called in a subordinate and instructed, “Keep a close eye on His Highness.”

“Yes!”

Chen Chuang stepped down the wall along with the stone steps; his gentle eyes were full of bitterness. He was not only the son of the first empress but also the eldest son of the emperor. The Crown Prince’s position, even the throne, could only be his. How could State Defender Duke dare not pay attention to him? He would wait for Lei Tie to kneel in front of him one day!

.....

The Capital was located to the north of Great Xia. The first snow of winter fell in the late 11th lunar month. The cold wind whistled at the corner of the wall, making a terrible whimper; the window lattices which were not secured enough were rattled by the wind. Large snowflakes fell like goose feathers floating in the wind. The sky was covered with dense snowflakes, and a thick layer of snow soon accumulated on the ground. Almost all shops hang heavy curtains to keep out the wind. The street vendors did not dare to set up stalls in this weather, so the streets were much wider than usual. The pedestrians on the road were sparse – they hid their hands in their sleeves, shrunk their necks in, and slightly squinted their eyes as they sped up their pace. When they lift the thick curtains of the tavern, a burst of heat wrapped in the attractive aroma of wine pounced on their faces. They were so comfortable that they couldn’t help moaning.

In the dining room of the State Defender Duke Establishment, however, it was very hot. The windows were closed and four charcoal braziers were placed in the four corners of the room. The charcoal burnt so well that the fire was blazing. On the round dining table in the middle of the room, in such a huge hot pot, the hot and red soup gurgled and the meatballs, chicken nuggets, and mushrooms kept disappear and reappear. On the side of the long table, the servants deftly cut all kinds of washed-clean ingredients, put them in white porcelain plates, and served them on the table. Sliced beef, sliced mutton, fish balls, meatballs, stuffed balls, lotus root balls, vermicelli, potato chips, spinach, cabbage, coriander, crab meat, tofu... it was

extremely sumptuous. It was not appropriate to eat hot pot in the morning, but eating it in this weather was the most enjoyable. And, the family really hadn't eaten hot pot for a long time.

Qin Mian was lying lazily on the settee with an account book in his left hand and a notebook on his knee – the writing brush in his hand scribbled on it from time to time.

Qin Ruiqi was sitting on the opposite single-settee diagonally with a chessboard in front of him. He was playing chess with himself. His small face was serious and his gaze was indifferent.

Qin Mian inwardly sighed. *This appearance is exactly like his Old Dad.*

Suddenly, he noticed that his youngest son was not there. He half-stood up and looked out the door.

Dressed in a white robe, Lei Ruilin stood in the corridor with his hands on his back. He looked up at the snowy sky with a melancholy expression and walked step by step. He leisurely recited, "The north wind sweeps the land white, breaks grasses; and the Capital City greatly welcomes the flying snow. It's as if a spring breeze had blown overnight, blowing open the petals of ten thousand pear trees."¹

Qin Mian burst out laughing; Lei Ruilin's lips also burst into a faint smile.

"Alright, Great Poet. If you don't come in, we'll eat first." Qin Mian put down the account book, stood up, and stretched out as he looked at the food on the table – he estimated that the food was enough for three people.

"Wait!" Lei Ruilin's gifted-scholarly demeanor disappeared without a trace as he scurried to the table like a monkey, greedily looking at the gurgling hot pot, "Dad, can eat now?"

"En." Qin Mian motioned the servants to retreat. "Your favorite chicken is cooked and Ruiqi's favorite meatballs are cooked, too."

Lei-Qin Le was the last to go out – he closed the door.

The two young brothers sat down beside their father.

Qin Mian took out the two cooked chicken drumsticks and put them in his sons' bowls. "You're hungry, right? Eat it."

White Spot and Golden Fur had been "served a meal" earlier – there were two basins in front of them, and they ate with gusto.

Qin Ruiqi gave Qin Mian a clip of his favorite vermicelli.

Lei Ruilin scooped a few delicious balls into Qin Mian's bowl with a colander. "Dad also eats."

Qin Mian slightly smiled and didn't forget to tell them to slow down and be careful of the heat.

Lei Ruilin bit the chicken drumstick. He was so happy that his eyes squinted, "It's delicious. It'll be nice if Old Dad is here."

Qin Ruiqi looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian's chopsticks paused. He comforted, "Don't worry, your Old Dad will come back safely. When he comes back, our family can eat hot pot together."

"En!" Lei Ruilin repeatedly nodded.

Qin Ruiqi asked, "Dad, can Old Dad rush home to celebrate the new year?"

Qin Mian confidently said, "Certainly. When he comes back, let ask him to take us to hunt. Then, our family will make a hot pot with the game we've hunted."

The eyes of both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin brightened, and they said, "Alright!"

"But Dad, Ge and I must have a foal first." Lei Ruilin was excited when he thought of hunting.

“Sure.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “It’s said that the Western Barbarian has some breeds of horses which are much stronger than those in Great Xia. After eating, let’s write a letter to your Old Dad and ask him to catch two foals for you as the New Year’s gifts.”

“Oh, great!” Lei Ruilin couldn’t help cheering.

Qin Ruiqi smiled.

Qin Mian urged, “Quickly eat.”

After eating the hot pot, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin ran to the side of the table and wrote a letter to Lei Tie. Head to head, the two brothers muttered to themselves. Lei Ruilin was in high spirits, and needless to say, even Qin Ruiqi, who had always been steady, was in high spirits.

Qin Mian shook his head with a smile and continued to look at the account book.

The servants cleaned up the table and quietly retreated.

The squeaking sound of feet treaded on the snow came closer and closer.

Steward Fu tightened his winter hat and stamped the snow on his feet in the corridor before knocking on the door.

“Reporting, my Lady. A person from the Weiyuan Marquis Establishment had just sent a piece of visitation note.”

Weiyuan Marquis Establishment was the home of the emperor’s father-in-law.

“Come in.” Qin Mian opened the note and read it. It turned out that the next holiday was Zhangsun Hong’s 8th birthday. Zhangsun Hong invited Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to his home.

Because of Chen Mufeng’s friendship with Qin Mian and Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin got closer to Zhangsun Hong in Dongyang Academy. They were happy everywhere and became good friends later.

Qin Mian had always attached great importance to the cultivation of two children's independent and decision-making abilities. He handed the note to Qin Ruiqi.

“Son, you decide to go or not.”

Qin Ruiqi had read the note and nodded to Qin Mian, “Go.”

Lei Ruilin had no objection.

Qin Mian then let Steward Fu reply to the note.

Lei Ruilin leaned on the back of the settee Qin Mian sat on and asked with his head crooked, “Dad, what gifts do Gege and I give to Zhangsun Hong?”

“What do you think?” Qin Mian teased him.

Lei Ruilin said in all seriousness, “Your son thinks that since we're still young, the gifts don't need to be too expensive; kindly feelings will suffice.”

Qin Mian admiringly stroked his little head.

“Well said. You discuss it with your Gege. If you can't make up your mind, ask Dad again.”

“Alright.” Lei Ruilin ran back to his Gege.

It snowed until dark. Qin Mian thought of Lei Tie; he didn't know if it was snowing at the border. Lei Tie was not afraid of cold, but when it snowed, it was prone to many problems – managing the army would be more troublesome.

After Qin Mian locked the door and turned off the light, he appeared in the space. Lei Tie could only find a chance to enter the space to meet him in the evening. He was just taking a chance tonight.

He first went to the garden to pick some vegetables, washed them by the river, and then went to the kitchen to clean up the other ingredients.

Whenever Lei Tie came in, he could cook hot pot at any time. Lei Tie couldn't eat any good food at the border – afraid that his sense of taste had been dulled. It was fortunate that he was a cultivator. Otherwise, he would become as thin as a bamboo pole after a few months in the western pass.

Imagining Lei Tie became as thin as a bamboo pole, Qin Mian couldn't help laughing.

“Wife, what are you laughing at?” Lei Tie had been watching him from behind for a long time, and only then he softly spoke.

Qin Mian abruptly turned his head back. The pleasantly surprised mood made his eyes brighter. “I thought I wouldn't see you today!” His nose caught a faint smell of blood – it was obvious that the battle occurred again today. He measured the man up and down and made sure the man was not hurt before he let go of his worry.

“How long can you stay? I'll cook you hot pot.”

Lei Tie went to embrace him and gave him a hard kiss on the lips. He was reluctant to part, but he had to. “I've to go in a moment.”

Qin Mian put down his kitchen knife and hugged Lei Tie's waist.

“Your sons want foals.”

Lei Tie's chin brushed on Qin Mian's side face. “What about you?”

“It's enough for me if you come back unscathed.” Qin Mian rubbed against his shoulder socket; he didn't want to let go.

“Worry not, I won't let myself get hurt.” Lei Tie kissed him again. “There's another important thing.”

“What is it?” Qin Mian recognized the gravity of his tone.

“In today's battle, Tuluo seemed to know every move of our army. I suspect that First Prince colluded with Tuluo and revealed the marching formation of our army.” A cold light flashed from Lei Tie's eyes. “First Prince is very

ambitious. I'm afraid that if he doesn't succeed, he'll send someone to deal with you and the children. Be careful these days."

T/N²

Footnotes

1. A Song Of White Snow In Farewell To Field-Clerk Wu Going Home by Cen Shen. But the second verse is made up by the author.
2. I don't have a set of schedule but I do have a set number of chapters to do monthly. 12 is what I set. But I do more sometimes (not coffee) if I'm well ~~mentally and physically~~.

Chapter 191: Assassination

191 – Assassination

Qin Mian was deeply surprised. If First Prince really colluded with the enemy, it was treason. But when one thought about it carefully, First Prince's move was unsurprising because his status was too awkward. Since ancient times, the custom of establishing a Crown Prince of Great Xia was set to the eldest son of the emperor and the empress. First Prince was the eldest son of the empress. In the first place, he had the most advantage. But the problem was that the empress died before he was crowned. Even if his mother's clan had the intention to support him, no one in the imperial harem wanted to cooperate with them, so First Prince's journey was a struggle. Second Prince Chen Shan was different – he was the eldest son of the current empress. He had a much greater advantage than Chen Chuang and was Chen Chuang's most powerful competitor. If Chen Chuang lacked patience, he could easily make the wrong choice.

“Don't worry, I will protect myself and the children.”

Lei Tie released him. “It's time to go.”

Qin Mian reluctantly loosened his arms. Although they met in the space from time to time, to be able to kiss was already luxurious, let alone do something they like.

Lei Tie understood what the tumbling emotion in his wife's eyes meant. He kissed his wife's eye in a passion and said in a hoarse voice, “Wife, wait for me to come home.”

He was afraid that if he didn't go any time soon, he couldn't refrain from pressing a certain someone.

Qin Mian was stupefied – the man had disappeared. Helpless, he curled his lips and left the space after dealing with all the remaining ingredients.

Time was like running water. In the blink of an eye, Zhangsun Hong's birthday arrived.

After breakfast, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin put on a new pair of clothes and asked the study-attendants – Paibing and Feiyue – to carry up the presents they prepared for Zhangsun Hong. Then, they got into the carriage together.

Four guards were divided into front and rear line-ups to protect the carriage.

Qin Mian mounted the horse and personally escorted his two sons to Weiyuan Marquis Establishment.

Although it was a sunny day, the sun was like being covered by a layer of yarn – obscure and no heat. The cold wind was dry and harsh; the pedestrians' faces were flushed by the wind, so stiff that they had no other expression. They only kept their heads down and moved on. It snowed the second time in winter three days ago. Although only one day, a thick layer of snow had accumulated. The snow on the ground had been cleared, but the road seemed to be frozen so hard that the sound of horse's hooves was crisp.

As soon as they got out of the State Defender Duke Establishment, Qin Mian noticed that there were several ill-intentioned glances in the obscure corners coming their way. A sneer filled his eyes.

“Dad.” Qin Ruiqi poked his head out of the window, to indicate something.

Qin Mian smiled, “Rest assured.”

Qin Ruiqi's head shrunk back.

“I can display my skill to the full.” Lei Ruilin was ready to fight.

Qin Ruiqi said, “Don't overdo it.”

“Don't worry, Ge.” Lei Ruilin raised his head, “I'm not a three-year-old.”

Qin Ruilin, “.....”

The carriage drove for about two quarters and arrived at Weiyuan Marquis Establishment. The steward greeted the guests at the door. Most of the guests were the children who had made friends with Zhangsun Hong; they took the chance to gather together on the holiday. After all, it was a child's birthday, so most of the adults sent their children and left after greetings.

Two 8 to 9 years old children in fined clothes saw the coach of the State Defender Duke Establishment and came over to welcome them.

“Ruiqi and Ruilin are here.”

After the carriage stopped, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin jumped from the left and right doors.

The steward trotted over, “Greetings to Lady of the State Defender Duke, Little Qin-gongzi, and Little Lei-gongzi.”

“Don't stand on ceremony.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “This lady has something else to do; [I'll] trouble your home to take care of my sons.”

The steward hurriedly said, “Please be at ease, Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, you are the guests at your friend's house, so you aren't allowed to be mischievous.” Qin Mian told his two sons.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin promised, “Please rest assured, Dad.”

“Dad will pick you up this afternoon.” Qin Mian spurred the horse and went away.

“Little gongzis, please come inside.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin nodded, followed the steward into the house with the other two little guests.

Seven to eight guests were already in the main hall. As the little host, Zhangsun Hong chatted with them. Weiyuan Marquis, Zhangsun He, and Chen Mufeng sat by and looked at them with a smile, chatting about domestic trivia.

The servant girls went in and out with tea, fruit, and snacks.

Upon seeing Qin Ruiqi's group of four little guests coming in, Zhangsun Hong quickly welcomed them.

"Ruiqi, Ruilin, Shifang, and Yueshan, here you are."

"Happy birthday, Brother Zhangsun. Gege and I wish you to have this day every year and to have this present [day] every age." Lei Ruilin cupped his hands to Zhangsun Hong.

The mischievous utterance made Weiyuan Marquis, Zhangsun He, and Chen Mufeng laugh.

"Those two are the two sons of the State Defender Duke?" Weiyuan Marquis was over sixty years old and a little plump. Although his hair was grey, he had a ruddy complexion and bright eyes. One might as well say that he was old but vigorous.

Zhangsun He spoke without flattery, "That's right. The two boys are no more than six years old but can already distinguish themselves. Their conducts in society are quite like their fathers'."

Weiyuan Marquis smiled but said nothing. He looked at his grandson and thought that his grandson was not bad either.

Zhangsun Hong took Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to Weiyuan Marquis and introduced them to his grandfather.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin bent over and cupped their hands in obeisance. "Ruiqi/Ruilin greets Weiyuan Marquis, Commandery Prince Mu, and Young Marquis."

“Come up, don’t stand on ceremony,” said Weiyuan Marquis with a kind smile.

“Many thanks, Weiyuan Marquis.”

Zhangsun Hong said, “Grandfather, I’ll take them to play.”

Weiyuan Marquis nodded, “Go and treat your friends well.”

“Yes.”

Weiyuan Marquis reminded Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng in a low voice, “Now the situation is delicate. We must take good care of the two children of the State Defender Duke Establishment. We must not let them be harmed in our house.”

Zhangsun He said, “Father, don’t worry. We have made careful arrangements.”

“That’s good,” said Weiyuan Marquis.

Worried that some adults were overcautious with their children, Weiyuan Marquis, Zhangsun He, and Chen Mufeng let the little guests have a good time to their hearts’ content before leaving together.

Zhangsun Hong led Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to other little guests.

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, let me introduce you. This is Chen Bonan, the second gongzi of the First Prince Establishment; Chen Peiwen, the legal wife’s eldest son of the Second Prince Establishment; Yang Jinxian, the legal wife’s eldest son of the Zhongyi Count Establishment.....”

Only two of the ten little guests present were the sons of the common people, and the rest were the descendants of high officials and dignitaries.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin made no distinction of them and returned with a fist and palm salute.

They were, after all, young children. They soon got to know each other, played together, ate and drank, talked and laughed, and had a lot of fun.

Not a while, another eight servant girls continued to enter and presented purple-colored pastries.

Zhangsun Hong spoke as though he presented a treasure, “Try my home’s six-flavored purple cloud cake. It’s a unique craft of my family’s chef.”

“Why is it called ‘six-flavored purple cloud cake’?” asked Chen Peiwen curiously.

Zhangsun Hong said, “Because this kind of cake only tastes one flavor at first bite but six flavors if you savor it, leading a person to endless aftertastes.”

“Oh? Then I’ll try it.” Yang Jinxian waited for the servant girl to put down the plate and couldn’t wait to reach out.

Qin Ruiqi’s eyes flashed and he suddenly waved his hand. The small plate in Yang Jinxian’s hand fell to the ground, smashed to pieces, and the snacks scattered all over the ground.

“What are you doing?” Yang Jinxian furiously grabbed his lapel.

Zhangsun Hong was stunned. Then he rushed forward, “Jinxian, don’t be angry. There must be some misunderstanding.”

Lei Ruilin knocked Yang Jinxian’s hand away. “You should be glad that my Gege saved your life!”

Qin Ruiqi dully said, “The cake is poisoned.”

Everyone was shocked.

“What?”

Zhangsun Hong was shocked and speechless. He looked at the cakes on the ground suspiciously.

Zhangsun He's bodyguard, who stayed outside, quickly went to report the matter to Zhangsun He. Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng came in a hurry.

“What's happened?”

Lei Ruilin raised his voice, “The cake is poisoned.”

Chen Mufeng squatted in front of Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, and asked calmly, “How do you know, Ruilin?”

Lei Ruilin raised his wrist and also pulled up Qin Ruiqi's wrist. “These are the bracelets that Old Dad gave us. When there is poison nearby, they will turn black.”

Chen Mufeng had seen this pair of bracelets. His impression of them was milky white, but at this time, with a clear look, the bracelets had become slightly black.

Zhangsun He took out a silver needle and inserted it into the cake on the ground. Sure enough, the silver needle quickly turned black. His expression greatly changed.

The servant girls were so scared that they knelt on the ground.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at each other and realized that they were most likely the targets.

Yang Jinxian's bottom hit on the ground.

After all, they were children. It was unknown who was the first to cry. Soon, all the little guests cried.

“Mufeng, you take care of them.”

Zhangsun He flashed out.

Chen Mufeng quickly comforted the guests; he frowned. The identity of the little guests was not common – no matter which one got harm, it wouldn't be a small problem.

Weiyuan Marquis came over upon hearing about the incident and saw the little guests crying. Even his eldest grandson looked very pale. Only Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin sat down on the chairs with a straight face. He couldn't help admiring them.

Zhangsun He soon returned and whispered in the ear of Weiyuan Marquis, "A kitchen maid in the kitchen is missing. It's likely a disguise."

Weiyuan Marquis nodded and told the servant girls to take the rest of the little guests out to comfort them, leaving only Zhangsun Hong, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin.

"Little Qin-gongzi, it's said that you noticed the cake was poisoned first?" asked Weiyuan Marquis to Qin Ruiqi with gentleness.

Qin Ruiqi nodded.

Weiyuan Marquis looked at his wrist. Perhaps because the child was too calm, he could not help but treat him as an adult as he probed, "It's the first time this marquis has heard that there is a marvelous item that can detect poison without touching the poison." In a disrespectful word, even the emperor had no such treasure.

Qin Ruiqi said in a low voice, "Dad said that any poison has a smell, but some smells are beyond the human sense of smell. This bracelet contains a special material that can sensitively detect poisons. It's like the sound of a dog whistle. People can't hear it, but dogs can hear it."

"So that's what it is." Weiyuan Marquis smiled.

Chen Mufeng frowned to himself. *Now is not the time to look into the bracelet.*

Weiyuan Marquis praised, "You two little boys are not afraid at all?"

Lei Ruilin said with pride, "Why should we be afraid? Dad said that no matter who dares to bully Gege and me, he and Old Dad will avenge us."

Weiyuan Marquis laughed, hollowly.

Zhangsun He had tried all the cakes with the silver needle, “It’s all poisoned.”

“That is to say, it’s not aimed at Little Yang-gongzi. Is it aimed at our Weiyuan Marquis Establishment?” Weiyuan Marquis frowned.

Qin Ruiqi pulled his Didi to his feet and said, “Lord Marquis, it’s time for Ruiqi and Ruilin to leave.”

Zhangsun He said, “Father, I’ll send them back.”

Weiyuan Marquis nodded. The Weiyuan Marquis Establishment ought to go to people’s homes to apologize and thank them for today’s incident.

Chen Mufeng followed.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin got on the carriage of the State Defender Duke Establishment. Not long after the carriage started moving, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin noticed several lines of sight in the obscure corner again.

From Weiyuan Marquis Establishment to State Defender Duke Establishment, there was an old alley. Because of the Capital’s expansion a few years ago, many residents of this old alley had moved away, so there were very few pedestrians in the alley.

When the carriage reached the middle of the old alley, Zhangsun He felt a sense of impending danger in his heart and quickly said, “Not good! Mufeng!”

Almost at the same time, more than twenty people, dressed in white attire and wrapped in white headcloth, sprang out from behind the roofs on both sides with knives and swords in hands. It was because they were all white that they could perfectly hide on the roof and behind the snow. Zhangsun He was the first to notice their murderous aura.

“Protect the children!” Chen Mufeng dropped a sentence to the four guards of the State Defender Duke Establishment before he pulled out his double-edged sword and flew to fight.

However, Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng were both mediocre in martial arts because they took precaution against Emperor Xiaohui. They were driven farther and farther away from the carriage by four of the white-dressed men.

Chapter 192: Reveals One's Origin

192 – Reveals One's Origin

Zhangsun He's heart sank – the targets of these killers turned out to be Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin. In a flash, he guessed the purpose of the master behind the scenes to deal with Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin: State Defender Grand General.

The four bodyguards of the State Defender Duke Establishment were not inferior in martial arts. However, the killers had the advantage of number and that their martial movements were ruthless, so they soon forced their way to the carriage.

Chen Mufeng was so terrified. If something happened to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, let alone Qin Mian would not let them go, but once the news reached the ears of the State Defender Grand General, the situation at the border station would be very bad.

Fortunately, both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were calm enough – they didn't cry or made a lot of noise. The carriage was very quiet all the time.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were ready to fight. When they were about to start, a familiar aura came like a flash of lightning. The two brothers looked at each other in extreme disappointment. *Dad's here.*

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, close your eyes.” Qin Mian dashed on empty air and fell in front of the carriage. He waved his sword and slashed out with a flashing brilliance.

The four white-dressed killers who were closest to the carriage screamed before they collapsed on the ground and died. Bright red blood sprayed on the carriage – it was horrifying.

Qin Mian nodded to Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng and continued to deal with the other white-dressed killers.

These killers were excellent in martial arts, but Qin Mian tore them apart. No more than two quarters later, except for two seriously injured ones, the rest of them died. The smell of blood filled the streets.

“These two should be enough?” said Qin Mian to Zhangsun He.

Zhangsun He nodded and breathed out, “Fortunately—”

“*Guh.*” Blood gushed out from the two seriously injured killers’ mouths and then they died.

Qin Mian’s expression turned extremely ugly. “Commit suicide by taking poison.”

Zhangsun He tightly frowned and said nothing for a long time.

“Fortunately, you came in time, otherwise, our two families would start a feud.”

Qin Mian explained, “On the way to Weiyuan Marquis Establishment, I noticed some people were following us. I’d been protecting Ruiqi and Ruilin in the dark.”

Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng looked at each other. Sure enough, the master behind the white-dressed killers was targeting State Defender Grand General. The purpose was not to kill Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin but to hold them hostage to threaten State Defender Grand General.

“Lady of the State Defender Duke, let’s take a trip to the palace together,” said Zhangsun He.

Qin Mian nodded, “I’m sending the children home first.”

He got into the carriage and gathered his two sons in his arms, “Good boys, you alright?”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin shook their heads and showed no fear on their faces or in their eyes.

Qin Mian gave each of the two little boys a kiss on the forehead.

Qin Ruiqi whispered about the disclosure of the bracelet; he could imagine that the emperor would want such a treasure. However, at that time, he couldn't ignore the life of others.

Qin Mian set up a sound-proofing barrier and comforted him, "It's fine. My precious son, this is not a problem you need to worry about. The two bracelets are indeed precious, but even your Old Dad and I don't have it. In any case, the emperor can't be very shameless to ask for it from two children. Moreover, your Old Dad is now the commander-in-chief of the battlefield. Soon, the emperor will have to curry favor with us."

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin nodded in understanding and dropped the topic.

After sending the two children home, Qin Mian took care of domestic affairs for a moment before he went to the palace with Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng.

The emperor had received the news. He nicely comforted Qin Mian for a while and didn't mention a word about the bracelet. In addition to giving many treasures to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, he also sent a hundred elite soldiers to guard the State Defender Duke Establishment and assigned six imperial experts to protect Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin. Whenever Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin went out, the imperial experts would protect them.

It was unknown whether Qin Mian's superb martial arts scared the master behind the white-dressed killers, or whether Emperor Xiaohui's actions made the master behind the scenes think that he couldn't make a move against Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin so that later, there were no assassination attempts against Qin Mian and his sons.

About half a month later, Qin Mian saw Lei Tie in the space again.

Lei Tie's expression looked very unsightly.

“A-Tie, what happened?”

Lei Tie coldly snorted, “Chen Chuang’s collusion with the enemy to betray the country has been solidly proven. His men poisoned our food. Now, more than 10,000 people in the army have been poisoned. The situation is grim.”

Qin Mian was shocked, “What kind of poison is it?”

Lei Tie said, “I don’t know. The military doctors said that the skin ulceration of the poisoned person after death is infectious. At present, more than 20 people have died and more than 100 people have been infected. The military doctors can only suppress the poison temporarily and have no idea how to detoxify it. I’ve sent a message to the Capital, but it’d be too late for the emperor to send over detoxification experts.”

Qin Mian said, “I can see that you have a plan. What do you want me to do? Say it.”

Lei Tie touched his face, “You give me a kind of antidote pill that can temporarily suppress the poison. It’d be better if it can eliminate the infectivity of the poison. I’ll arrange for a fake doctor over there, pretending that he came up with the idea. When the urgent report arrives in the Capital, the emperor will certainly consult you on how to detoxify. You’ll come to the border station in person.”

Qin Mian was a little worried, “The Tuluo people will certainly take this opportunity to launch a large-scale attack. Can you hold on before my arrival?”

Lei Tie nodded, “Don’t you believe your husband’s ability?”

Qin Mian’s ears were hot as he glared at the man.

“Don’t worry.” Lei Tie hugged him and said, “Trust me.”

Qin Mian took out a bottle of pills from the alchemy room and gave it to him. “First, according to the ratio of 1 to 1000, mix the spiritual spring

water with plain water, and then according to the ratio of 1 to 1000, dissolve the pill in the solution. Just let the poisoned people drink it will do.”

Lei Tie nodded. There was no time to say more, he disappeared after he kissed Qin Mian’s lips.

Three days later, Emperor Xiaohui summoned Qin Mian to the palace.

Qin Mian changed into the Mandated Lady’s formal suit and rushed into the palace.

The palace attendants led him directly to the door of the imperial study.

“Reporting, Your Majesty. Lady of the State Defender Duke has arrived.”

“Announce.”

“Announcing the present of Lady of the State Defender Duke~~”

Qin Mian walked into the imperial study and saw that there were other people in the imperial study, all dressed in imperial doctor’s suit.

“Wish Your Majesty long live, absolutely long live!”

“Rise.”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty.”

“Give a seat to Lady of the State Defender Duke.” Obviously, Emperor Xiaohui had no intention of exchanging conventional greetings as he directly ordered the palace attendant, “Show the urgent report to Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

“Yes.”

The military report was the oral account of the military doctors and written by Lei Tie. They described in detail the symptoms of poisoning and several effective or ineffective treatments.

Qin Mian read it carefully, but he didn't notice that a surprised and bewildered gaze of an imperial doctor opposite him was on him, endlessly flickering with an astonished expression solidified on his face.

After Qin Mian read it, he returned it to the palace attendant.

Only then Emperor Xiaohui spoke, "Now, 10,000 soldiers have been poisoned at the border station; the morale of the troops is in turbulence. The situation is extremely unfavorable for Great Xia. Does anyone know how to deal with the poison?"

All the imperial doctors were silent.

Emperor Xiaohui tightly frowned, dissatisfiedly pointed a name, "Imperial Doctor Qin, what's your opinion?"

Imperial Doctor Qin Wencai instantly got up and knelt. He spoke with deliberation, "Reporting, Your Majesty; your subject has no opinion. Although the urgent report clearly described the symptoms of the poisoned person, your subject and the others have, after all, never seen the patient personally. Therefore, your subject and the others dare not say anything baseless. In case of a wrong step, the detoxification methods will only become the written Taoist voodooos¹ of the soldiers..."

The rest of the imperial doctors knelt and nodded in agreement.

Emperor Xiaohui coldly snorted. Had he not understood these imperial doctors yet? They just feared the responsibility. Emperor Xiaohui was disappointed and looked at Qin Mian with a calm face.

"Lady of the State Defender Duke is also proficient in medicine. Do you have any ideas?"

Qin Mian got up and cupped his hands in obeisance, "Reporting, Your Majesty. I [humble] have 90% confidence that I can detoxify this poison. However, as Imperial Doctor Qin said, since I [humble] haven't seen the poisoned person personally, [I'm] afraid to make fool of myself if careless.

Therefore, I [humble] would like to seek Your Majesty's permission to go to the border station in person."

"90% confidence?" Emperor Xiaohui was greatly rejoiced, "Alright! Zhen confers you the "Subsidiary Second-rank Special Case Military Inspector" title to facilitate you to walk into the army. If you can save the lives of tens of thousands of soldiers at the border station, Zhen will greatly reward you!"

Qin Mian was secretly happy, but he didn't expect to get a subsidiary second-rank official post as soon as he entered the palace, which was only half a rank lower than the "State Defender Grand General".

"Your subject follows your decree. Many thanks, Your Majesty!"

"Zhen will give you one day to arrange your family affairs. Tomorrow, hastily set out to the western pass."

"Yes!"

Qin Wencai unexpectedly asked, "Reporting, Your Majesty. Lady of the State Defender Duke also needs an assistant. Your subject is willing to go with Lady of the State Defender Duke to render service on behalf of Your Majesty."

As Emperor Xiaohui considered that Imperial Doctor Qin was his personal imperial doctor, going to the border station personally was also conducive to boosting morale, so he nodded, "It can't be any better to have Imperial Doctor Qin over there. But my dear subject Qin is not young anymore – can your body hold on?"

"Thank you for the concern, Your Majesty. There is no problem with your subject's body."

"In that case, you'll go with Lady of the State Defender Duke."

"Yes!"

One day's time was too limited. Qin Mian went back home as soon as he got out of the palace.

Qin Wencai wanted to catch up to him several times, but he restrained his excitement with rationality. He quickly returned to his residence and ordered his servants to pack up.

"Father, what's this?" Qin Jian, the eldest son of Qin Wencai, came back from the outside. He noticed the movement in the house and was completely puzzled.

Qin Wencai was busy packing the medicine case. Without lifting his head, he said, "You're home, Jian'er? Your father is going to the border station."

Qin Jian was greatly surprised, "Father, at this time now? Not to mention how dangerous it is to go to the border; can your body hold on after such a long journey?"

Qin Wencai laughed – he was in high spirits. "This time, your father is going to the border station with Lady of the State Defender Duke. If your father is right, your father will bring your little brother home soon."

"What? You... you said Lady of the State Defender Duke?" Qin Jian's expression greatly changed. He accidentally bumped his right hand into the teacup on the table. The teacup fell to the ground and the tea splashed.

"Correct." Qin Wencai excitedly said, "As soon as I saw him, I recognized him as your little brother who has been missing for many years. Now, all I need is evidence..."

Qin Jian's body felt chill and his hands and feet were ice-cold. *Qin Mian!* Never would have he thought, he had tried his best to cut off any news of Lady of the State Defender Duke, but his father still ran into him (QM) head-on. *Damn it!* The idea of killing Qin Mian hovered in his mind for a long time.

Qin Mian had three things to arrange. First, the two children were sent directly to Chen Mufeng's house, trusting him to take care of them. He

believed that whether it was Commandery Prince Mu Establishment or Imperial Prince Ming Establishment, the emperor would adequately protect the two children like the apple of his eye – he was not worried about the safety of his children. Second, the drugstore and the silverware shop; third, the State Defender Duke Establishment.

Besides the two children wanted to go to the western pass with him which Qin Mian had a lot of trouble persuading them, everything went smoothly.

The next morning, Emperor Xiaohui personally selected 100 elite soldiers to escort Qin Mian and Qin Wencai to the western pass.

The carriage was the Qin Mian family's big carriage which had an excellent shock absorption effect. Also, Qin Mian inscribed acceleration formation on the carriage, so the speed was not much slower than [riding] a horse.

The trip went on a whole day. Only when it was dark that the procession stopped. The group of people, out in the countryside, lit a bonfire and could only make do with the rations.

The ambush in the forest made Qin Mian sneer in silence.

A hidden arrow "*swooshed*" from the forest, straight to him.

Qin Wencai was so terrified and subconsciously rushed over, "Careful!"

The one hundred elite soldiers weren't useless – they immediately went to search and easily dealt with ten killers. The leader of the escort sent an elite soldier back to the Capital to report the incident to Emperor Xiaohui.

"Imperial Doctor Qin, why are you?" Qin Mian was surprised by Qin Wencai's action.

The whole day, Qin Wencai shared the same carriage with Qin Mian. He had hesitated several times and didn't ask the question brewing in his mind. The killer's act of assassinating Qin Mian made him make up his mind.

"Lady of the State Defender Duke, please forgive this old fellow for taking the liberty to ask where is your parents' native place?"

Qin Mian shook his head. “I have no parents.”

“Is it?” Qin Wencai’s hands trembled with excitement, “You... you don’t think you look similar to this old fellow?”

Qin Mian was taken aback. He carefully looked at Qin Wencai and was flabbergasted. Both of them really had a 40~50% similarity in the looks. He thought of an incident a long time ago where he met a man from the Capital who looked similar to him – he had a guess in his heart.

“What do you mean?”

Qin Wencai took a deep breath and slowly said, “If you have a light mole behind your left waist and right shoulder, then you’re my legitimate son who has been missing for many years. He is also called Qin Mian.”

Chapter 193: Reunion

193 – Reunion

As early as that year, when he met the young man who looked similar to him in the Capital, Qin Mian imagined that he would meet the family of the body's original owner in the future. Therefore, he was not surprised or excited at this time. It was even more impossible to say if he had any feelings for Qin Wencai.

He was very calm, "The left side of my waist side does have a mole; as for whether there is on the right shoulder, I don't know."

Qin Wencai almost blurted out "just see it at a glance", but although the other party was a man, he also had the identity of Lady of the State Defender Duke. Therefore, Qin Wencai could not be sudden and brusque.

"There must be... You look so much like me, and you happen to have a mole on your left waist. These two points alone are enough to explain the question." Qin Wencai's tone was firm; his eyes glistened with moisture as they fell on Qin Mian, reluctant to part.

Qin Mian was a little uncomfortable that he frowned. After Qin Wencai's real son died, he just happened to occupy his body. It was somewhat impossible to have him genuinely and sincerely accept Qin Wencai as a father. First of all, he wouldn't take advantage of a dead man and enjoy something that didn't belong to his kinship; second, he couldn't call a stranger his father; third, he was selfish – like Lei Tie, he didn't want to give rise to a more complicated household. Back then, the young man mostly doubted his identity but did not take the initiative to recognize him. It could be seen that he was not welcome back to the Qin family. The situation in the Qin family must be very complicated.

Qin Wencai sighed, “You haven’t taken the initiative to go home since you’ve been in the Capital for so long. I guess that you most probably don’t have the memory of the past. Sure enough... you...”

Qin Mian interrupted him in polite and estranged manner, “Imperial Doctor Qin, it’d be better to wait until we arrive at the western pass to talk about it. How about it?” He had to ask Lei Tie if he had a mole on his right shoulder before he thought of a plan.

Qin Wencai was nine out of ten sure that he was indeed his son – half of the load on his mind had laid rest. In a good mood, he nodded, “Alright, alright...”

A few days later, the group arrived at Solemn City, Western Pass near noon. There was no snow in Solemn City, but the climate here was much worse than that in the Capital. The cold and dry wind blew on the face was like blades. The faces of pedestrians on the road were all red with cold. As long as the face, neck, hands, and ankles were not covered, the cold wind would fiercely invade, and the chill bit into the bone.

Qin Mian originally thought that because of the war, the doors of the houses and shops in the city would be tightly closed and the city would appear cold and desolate. When he entered the city, he found that it was still bustling. The flames of war at the border station seemed to have no impact on them. On the roadside, stalls sold various snacks, steaming smoke came from the woks and flew away with the wind carrying the smell of steamed stuffed bun, sesame seed pancake, baked sweet potato, and other food, which made one’s mouth salivated and body felt warm.

The shop assistants wore felt hats and thick cotton-padded jackets and tightly tied their waists with either a rice straw or cloth strips. With their hands in their sleeves, they opened their mouths wide and shouted out, exhaling clouds of white steam.

“Steamed stuffed buns, hot steamed stuffed buns!”

“Sweet and fragrant roasted sweet potatoes. I’m sure you’ll want a second after one taste!”

“Beef noodle, it’s delicious and spicy. A bowl can keep you full until night!”

“.....”

Qin Wencai praised, “Thanks to State Defender Grand General, who is brave and skillful in warfare, under his strict control, the common people can live and work in peace and contentment as before.”

Proud, Qin Mian modestly smiled, “Imperial Doctor Qin overpraised.”

The leader of the escort rode to the side of the carriage and politely said, “Qin-Daren and Imperial Doctor Qin, please bear it for a while. We’ll go directly to the military camp.” Along the way, Qin Mian never complained, let alone made things hard for them. Moreover, he gave them fermented tofu to mix with their rations. The whole escort team had a very good impression of Qin Mian.

Qin Mian knew that these people also needed to report the leadership after accomplishing a task, so he would not make things hard for them. He nodded, “Alright, thank you for your hard work.”

The procession went straight to the gate of the western city wall. When the passers-by saw that they were soldiers, they consciously retreated to both sides of the street to make way for them.

Solemn City now had two military camps – one outside the city and the other inside. According to the victory report sent back to the Capital, the army at the border station had penetrated the territory of Tuluo for nearly 50 *li*, defeated 200,000 troops of Tuluo, and conquered four big cities of the enemy country. Currently, the two armies were in a standoff at Tuluo’s strategic pass and might launch an all-out attack at any time. The camp in the city was now especially used to house the poisoned soldiers.

Because of the tension of the war, Lei Tie needed manpower. Apart from six military doctors, Lei Tie only arranged one hundred soldiers to help the military doctors take care of the wounded.

After the leader of the escort showed his token to the chargehand of the camp, the chargehand immediately sent two people to the camp outside the city to report to State Defender Grand General Lei Tie.

Although Qin Mian was eager to see Lei Tie, it was important to treat the poisoned soldiers. He sat down with Imperial Doctor Qin for a while, drank a cup of hot tea, and then went to see the soldiers.

More than 10,000 people were huddled in over twenty tents, critically ill with a little breath. No matter who saw it, one could not help feeling down. Fortunately, although the soldiers could not move, their complexions looked better. The pill Qin Mian gave to Lei Tie had a remarkable effect.

Surprisingly, every time the battle drum was heard in the distance, all the soldiers were anxious and wanted to get up immediately to join the battle, however, their physical conditions didn't allow them – they fell into morbid depression, more or less.

When they learned that Qin Wencai was the imperial doctor who specially treated the emperor, everyone's eyes lit up. Qin Mian was young. Although he came to treat them specially, almost no one care about him.

“Imperial Doctor Qin, in your opinion, what kind of poison is it?” Doctor Yu was one of the military doctors who stayed in the camp in the city. He looked tired because of long-term hard work, but the city was short of manpower, so he had to endure it.

Qin Mian carefully observed the symptoms of the poisoned person – his face was white, his lips were black, and his skin was blue and slightly swollen with bulging blood blisters. The poisoned person mainly felt fatigued and had a slow reaction.

Another military doctor, holding his sore shoulder, said, “A few days ago, Grand General found a miracle-working doctor who successfully suppressed their poisoning. Since taking the medicine, no one's skin has festered and no one is infected. It's a pity that the miracle-working doctor has an eccentric nature. He just disappeared after half a day in the camp.”

Qin Wencai inquiringly looked at Qin Mian. Although Emperor Xiaohui didn't say it clearly, Qin Mian was in the leading position when they came to the western pass this time. He just assisted him (QM).

Qin Mian knew that he was too young to be convincing. However, he didn't care, so he nodded to Qin Wencai.

Qin Wencai said, "No wonder this old fellow noticed that these people's complexions are not bad. The symptoms are actually very similar—let this old fellow takes the pulse first."

He didn't mind and knelt on one knee at the edge of the sickbed, picked up the wrist of the wounded, and closed his eyes for nearly half a moment. He felt the pulse for several other people nearby and it took a long time for him to feel the pulse every time.

The soldiers nearby nervously watched him, praying in secret that the imperial doctor could cure them and let them return to the battlefield.

Imperial Doctor Qin said, "If this old fellow's diagnosis is correct, they were inflicted with a kind of strange poison called 'halving life' by the people of Tuluo. This old fellow would like to ask you, do the poisoned people feel that there is an invisible monster sucking their blood in the body at first, and the body gradually becomes cold?"

Doctor Yu was overjoyed. "Exactly, Imperial Doctor Qin is worthy of being the descendant of the medical family! Since Imperial Doctor Qin knew of this poison, there must be a way to detoxify it?"

Several other military doctors gathered around in pleasant surprise.

Imperial Doctor Qin was very prudent. Instead of making a statement immediately, he said to Qin Mian, "Qin-Daren, please have a try."

Qin Mian was too young. The several military doctors looked at him with disapproval as he felt the pulse of a few soldiers.

Qin Mian stood up and said, “I don’t know the name of this poison, but I know how to detoxify it. I’ll write a prescription first and Imperial Doctor Qin can check it if it’s feasible.”

Doctor Yu opened his mouth to speak but was stopped by Qin Wencai.

“Alright.”

Doctor Yu gave up the idea of objecting to it. If Qin Mian and Qin Wencai put people to death, it didn’t have much to do with him. Since Qin Wencai wouldn’t let him chip in, why should he get into trouble?

On the desk at the side, there were writing materials. The medical assistant cleverly ran over to polish the ink.

Qin Mian picked up the brush and wrote down a prescription and handed it to Qin Wencai.

Several military doctors came to see that there were more than twenty herbs in the prescription, one of which was cow urine!

“This...”

Qin Wencai’s expression did not change as he slightly nodded. “Cow urine can cure dropsy and abdominal distension. It’s suitable to use for this disease. It’s once recorded in the Thousand Golden Prescriptions of Huainan Dynasty.”

Several military doctors had nothing to say. Imperial Doctor Qin was born in a medical family. It was said that the Qin family had seen the illness of an emperor for eight generations – they had the foundation of profound learning inherited by the family. It was not uncommon for them to have the Thousand Golden Prescriptions and other medical books that others only heard but could not see.

Qin Wencai looked at Qin Mian with approval. He went to the table and also wrote a prescription.

“Qin-Daren looks at it. This old fellow thinks it works faster. Unfortunately, one of the herbs –chaste tree– grows only in Tuluo and is rarely used in Great Xia.”

After Qin Mian read it, he looked around with a hesitant look.

Qin Wencai felt odd, “This old fellow tells all there is to say. It’s fine if Qin-Daren has something to say.”

Qin Mian still motioned him and several military doctors to go to the corner, out of the soldiers’ hearing.

“If the prescription of Imperial Doctor Qin is aimed at ‘halving life’, I can say for sure that the poison in them is not the ‘halving life’. If Imperial Doctor Qin really used chaste tree, the body and spirit of the patients can indeed recover to the normal appearance within an hour, but after an hour, they will be poisoned to death.”

“What!” The military doctors were shocked.

Qin Wencai couldn’t believe it. “You mean...”

Qin Mian said, “This poison is obviously tampered with ‘halving life’. If we really use the chaste tree, we’ll fall into the enemy’s trick.”

Outside the tent, the resounding voices of the guards echoed.

“Greetings, Grand General!”

Qin Mian’s heart pounded; he turned to look at the tent’s opening.

The curtain of the opening was lifted. Lei Tie, dressed in a combat suit, strode in with his deep eyes gently fell on Qin Mian’s face.

Chapter 194: Detoxification

194 – Detoxification

“Greetings, State Defender Grand General,” saluted Qin Wencai and the several military doctors.

“Don’t stand on ceremony.”

Qin Mian took out Emperor Xiaohui’s designated document for his “Special Case Military Inspector” and handed it to Lei Tie with teasing in his eyes: “State Defender Grand General, this is this lowly official’s proof of document.”

Lei Tie looked at the official document and slightly nodded. Standing opposite him, he spoke in a business tone, “Qin-Daren, how are the soldiers?”

Qin Mian talked of his and Qin Wencai’s judgments separately.

Doctor Yu said, “Grand General, the problem now is that both opinions of Qin-Daren and Imperial Doctor Qin are not unified. You see?”

Lei Tie said, “In a few days, this general will launch an all-out attack on Tuluo. If more than 10,000 soldiers can recover, it’ll be the best way to boost others’ morale. Therefore, this general can only give both of you two days at most.”

Qin Mian and Qin Wencai looked at each other.

When all said and done, Qin Wencai had decades of experience. After a little meditation, he came up with a method and said to Qin Mian, “Qin-Daren, what do you of this? This old fellow makes the ‘halving life’ poison.

After the poison is made, feed it to the animals. Then, try to detoxify with my prescription to see if it is effective. That way, we don't have to risk the soldiers' lives."

Qin Mian nodded, "Imperial Doctor Qin has a point. Let's do as you say."

Several military doctors had no objection. Right now, no one else knew how to detoxify the poison; they could only do it that way.

Lei Tie said to the six military doctors, "You have to work hard for a few more days. When this matter is over, this general will personally present the memorial to the emperor so that everyone will be rewarded for your contributions."

The military doctors were overjoyed and said in unison, "Yes, thank you, Grand General!"

Lei Tie assigned several soldiers to Qin Wencai to do some errand work. He gave Qin Mian a meaningful glance, and they left the army tent together.

The leader of the escort, who had been waiting outside, saw that Lei Tie had finished his important work. He then came forward to salute and reported on the completion of the task.

"You've worked hard. Someone, lead the escorts to have a rest. "

"Yes." Lei-Qin Zhong quickly stepped forward.

Qin Mian stopped Lei-Qin Zhong and said, "There are some special local products in the carriage. You give some to the escorts and treat them well."

"Yes!"

After the leader of the escort cupped his hands in obeisance to Qin Mian and Lei Tie and asked to be excused, he followed Lei-Qin Zhong to leave.

Lei Tie pulled Qin Mian to another smaller tent.

Qin Mian had yet come to a stop when his mouth was sealed by hot lips. He raised his arms wrapped them around the man's neck and responded with equal fervor.

A good while later, the couple separated, out of breath. A wisp of silver thread attached to their lips, reluctant to part. Qin Mian's pulse sped up even more and he quickly extended his hand to wipe it off. His ear roots were red like they were on fire.

Lei Tie tightly hugged him and pinched his earlobe with his two fingers. "Wife, was the trip well?"

"It went well. What about you? You're not hurt, are you?" Qin Mian's eyes were on him.

Lei Tie shook his head, "Did the emperor say how long you can stay here?"

"He didn't say. So, I can stay as long as I want, right? If you can get rid of the Tuluo before New Year, we can go back together," said Qin Mian with an anticipation look.

Lei Tie nodded without hesitation, "En."

"Is there a final verdict about First Prince?" asked Qin Mian.

Lei Tie said, "Just received the emperor's secret order the day before yesterday. To prevent the army's agitation, First Prince is in house arrest for the time being."

Thinking of First Prince, Qin Mian said with disdain, "You must tell people to watch him closely. Don't let anything happen at this border station and delay our return."

"Don't worry." Lei Tie touched his stomach. "Have you eaten yet?"

"We came straight to the camp as soon as we enter the city." Qin Mian leaned on his chest, "Don't you know? Imperial Doctor Qin and I were in the same carriage all the way; it's not convenient to sneak eating anything."

Lei Tie chuckled, “It’s been hard on you. I’ve sent someone to prepare the meal. I’ll accompany you for a bit.”

“You aren’t in a hurry to go out of the city?” asked Qin Mian happily.

Lei Tie stroked his face, “I still have time to accompany you to eat.”

The couple ate a simple hot pot in the tent. Then, Lei Tie rushed out of the city and went back to the camp in the territory of Tulu.

Qin Mian was also busy. He asked people to prepare all the herbs on the prescription and then helped Doctor Yu and the others to take care of the patients.

In addition to Qin Mian and Qin Wencai, there were only eight doctors in the camp. There would not be enough hands to detoxify more than 10,000 people later. Qin Mian simply paid a sum of money in advance and hired twenty doctors and one hundred medical assistants from every medical shop in Solemn City as soon as possible.

Qin Wencai told people to prepare all the medicinal materials he needed. He ate a hot meal and slept for two hours. After he had enough spirit, he stayed in a small tent to concoct “halving life” poison. No one was allowed to disturb him.

Nearly two hours after dark, he came out of the tent and asked people to call Qin Mian.

After hearing the news, the six military doctors and the chargehand of the camp came over together.

Qin Wencai pointed to a red-brown soup in a white porcelain bowl and said, “This is ‘halving life’. The final ‘halving life’ is a powder, but because it will be fed to the animal later, this old fellow omitted the last procedure. It won’t affect the poisonous attribute.”

“Then let’s try it.” Doctor Yu asked a soldier to grab a living rabbit from the kitchen.

Qin Wencai also brought his cure, which was also like soup.

Everyone in the tent could not help holding their breath.

Qin Wencai motioned to the soldier. The soldier carried the rabbit and opened its mouth.

The medical assistant scooped up a spoonful of poison and poured it carefully into the rabbit's mouth. After all, the rabbit was much smaller than a human, so it didn't drink much.

The soldier slowly put the rabbit on the ground.

In a moment, the rabbit limped and fell to the ground.

Qin Wencai immediately ordered, "Detoxification."

The medical assistant gave the rabbit another mouthful of the cure.

After taking the cure, the rabbit gradually recovered its vitality. Nearly an hour later, its vitality greatly recovered – it jumped happily in the tent. Unexpectedly, about an hour later, it fell on the ground without warning. Its seven orifices bled as it lay motionless!

Dead!

Qin Wencai took a breath of cold air. He gratefully pulled a smile to Qin Mian. It was fortunate to have Qin Mian here, otherwise, the lives of more than ten thousand soldiers would end in his hands!

The six military doctors were stunned. At this time, they were completely convinced of Qin Mian.

"Qin-Daren, I admire you!"

"You all speak highly of me." Qin Mian seriously said, "I've instructed people to prepare the medicines needed for detoxification. This matter shouldn't be delayed. We'll immediately have the hired people from outside detoxify all the soldiers."

“Yes!”

Qin Mian told the chargehand, “Take this news to the State Defender Grand General at once; also, send people to closely monitor the place where the medicine is decocted, in case the villain takes the opportunity to make trouble again.”

“Yes!” The chargehand took the order accordingly and left.

Qin Mian was a little uneasy. Hiding in the dark, he personally monitored the people concocting the medicine in hundreds of large pots, and when people were not paying attention, he dripped a drop of spiritual spring water in each pot to help the soldiers recover their vitality and physical strength faster.

After the medicine was ready, he sent all the doctors and the medical assistants to feed the soldiers the medicinal soup.

When the hustle and bustle were over, it was already midnight.

Early the next morning, Qin Mian was awakened by the excited shouts outside the tent. When he went out to have a look, more than ten thousand soldiers gathered on the drill ground. On the appointing platform, stood a general with a smiling face – he was talking.

Qin Wencai came over and said with a smile, “Just wake up? All the soldiers are recovering very quickly. They can go to the battlefield in two days. The State Defender Grand General sent a message: you, this old fellow, and the other six military doctors are going to have a good rest today and move to the camp outside the city to help tomorrow morning.”

Doctor Yu and the others came over and were very warm to Qin Mian.

“At last we can relax. Qin-Daren and Imperial Doctor Qin, we’d like to treat you to lunch as a welcome ceremony. Wonder if you two can let us have the honor?”

Qin Mian had planned to go to the military camp outside the city after breakfast. Upon seeing that some of them wanted to make friends, it was hard to refuse.

“Alright, [I’ll] let you treat.”

After the six military doctors left, Qin Mian and Qin Wencai wrote a letter on the detoxification together and then had the soldier rush to the Capital.

At noon, Qin Mian had a meal with Qin Wencai and the six military doctors in a winehouse in the city.

Qin Mian simply packed up and asked someone in the camp to send a soldier to lead him to the camp outside the city.

When Qin Wencai learned about it, he offered to come along.

Qin Mian surmised that Qin Wencai was anxious to know whether there was a mole on his shoulder, so he didn’t refuse. He informed the six military doctors that they were going to first.

At the gate of the city wall, once the ruler’s jade seal was uncovered to the guards of the city walls as the official proof, they immediately opened the gate.

The carriage traveled for less than an hour when Qin Mian saw mushroom-like military tents in the distance from the window. A smile rose on his lips.

Qin Wencai knew that he must have remembered Lei Tie. He was quite uncomfortable about his son being with a man. But at present, Qin Mian did not admit that he was his son. He couldn’t say anything about it and could only sigh in his heart.

Closed up, there were more “mushrooms”. In front of the camp, there was a fence made of sharp wooden poles with a gate in the middle. Four soldiers stood on both sides and stopped them with pikes.

“Who’s coming?”

Once again, Qin Mian showed his proof of document and surmised that Lei Tie had briefed them before – one of the soldiers took him to a military tent in the middle of the mushroom cluster with a friendly air. There were four soldiers in front of the military tent.

“Qin-Daren, this is the Grand General’s tent – make yourself at home. Imperial Doctor Qin, your tent is this way, please.”

Qin Mian entered the military tent. There was a long table in the middle with a huge sand table on it and ten high-back chairs beside it. Most probably, this military tent also served as a place for military discussion. On each side of the long table was a charcoal brazier, in which there was no ember. A bed was placed in the tent, which was, to be exact, a makeshift bed – it was covered with soft hides and a quilt but in a somewhat messy manner. It looked like the owner left in a hurry.

Qin Mian asked two soldiers to help move the contents of the carriage into the tent and then gave them some fermented tofu. As soon as the two soldiers went out, he lay down lazily on the makeshift bed and could keenly smell the unique cool odor of Lei Tie on the quilt. At this time, Lei Tie must be on his proper duty. He could only wait for Lei Tie to come back.

When Lei Tie returned to the military tent after he was done with his duty, he saw a man lying sideways in the quilt, sleeping with a pillow in his arms and his lips were slightly open with saliva at the corner of the lips.

He gently walked over, put his hands on both sides of his wife’s body, bent down, and sealed his lips.

“Oh...um?” Qin Mian didn’t have to open his eyes to know who he was. He hugged the man’s shoulders and intently responded.

They both moved with passion.

At this time, the sound of Qin Wencai’s voice asking the guard outside the tent was heard.

“Is State Defender Grand General here?”

Qin Mian quickly pushed Lei Tie away and expressed to him in simple language that Qin Wencai spoke of his guess about his (QM) identity.

Lei Tie frowned and didn't speak. Qin Wencai said in a loud voice, "Grand General, this old fellow Qin Wencai seeks an audience."

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood up and helped each other tidy up.

Qin Mian licked his lips. There should be no suspicious traces on his lips. He nodded to Lei Tie.

Only then Lei Tie said, "Come in."

They sat down at the long table. Qin Wencai looked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

"Grand General, pardon this old fellow for being bold. Regarding this old fellow's guess about your wife's identity, your wife must have mentioned it to you?"

Lei Tie dully nodded.

Qin Wencai nervously asked, "Then, venture to ask Grand General, does your wife have a mole behind his right shoulder?"

Lei Tie didn't respond. After a while, he nodded.

Excited, Qin Wencai abruptly stood up and the chair fell to the ground. He stared at Qin Mian with tears in his eyes. "I knew you must be my son! Mian'er..."

"Don't get too excited." Qin Mian helped him sit down and calmly said, "Although we can be sure that I'm your son now, as you are aware, I don't remember anything before I appeared in Green Mountain Village. So... I hope you can give me some time."

Chapter 195: Final Battle

195 – Final Battle

“This...” Qin Wencai looked at him in disappointment. He thought a bit and changed the topic, “Fine. You should know that your mother also misses you so much. When we go back, your father will take you—”

Lei Tie suddenly stood up and coldly said, “Imperial Doctor Qin, my wife said to give him time.”

Qin Wencai also got really angry and said in a heavy tone, “Grand General! This matter is between us, father and son. You don’t have the qualifica—”

“Imperial Doctor Qin!” Qin Mian interrupted his unreasonable words. He defensively embraced Lei Tie’s waist, “Lei Tie is my spouse. Whatever happens to me, he is qualified to make the decision.”

Qin Wencai looked at him with a wounded expression. He stretched out his right hand, wanting to touch Qin Mian, “Mian’er, your father just...”

Lei Tie pressed on Qin Mian’s shoulders to let him sit down. He coldly looked at Qin Wencai.

“Imperial Doctor Qin, have you thoroughly investigated why your son was stranded outside back then? Four years ago, this general [I] and my wife met a young man in the Capital who looked similar to my wife. By the man’s look, he obviously recognized my wife, and yet he did not acknowledge my wife. If one is to say that there is no reason for this, this general [I] won’t believe it. Presumably, your Qin Family isn’t peaceful? You think this general is going to let my wife get involved in your Qin Family’s trouble?”

“What...” Qin Wencai’s expression abruptly changed and changed again as he calmed down, “A young man who looked similar to Mian’er? Besides Mian’er, this old man also has two sons named Qin Jian and Qin Xue. Jian’er is older than Mian’er and Xue’er is the youngest. May I know if the young man you saw is older or younger than Mian’er?”

Back then, the young man was obviously a few years older than Qin Mian – he was most likely Qin Jian. Qin Mian didn’t want Qin Wencai to blame him for trying to provoke Qin Wencai’s relationship with his two other sons, so he said, “Didn’t pay attention.”

Lei Tie indifferently said, “These are the problems that Imperial Doctor Qin should find out.”

Qin Wencai was unable to respond and secretly regretted it– he should not say that Lei Tie was not qualified to manage Qin Mian’s affairs. He was uncomfortable with the fact that the son he pampered since childhood was together with a man, but he should not show this kind of discontented expression. Qin Mian had no previous memory and many years’ worth of feelings with Lei Tie – they even raised sons together. It was only natural for Qin Mian to stand on Lei Tie’s side.

He stood up and bowed with hands held in front as he apologized to Lei Tie in a frank and straightforward manner, “Grand General, this old man I have just recovered my son. In a moment of excitement, my speech has become inappropriate. Still, this old man I ask Grand General not to be offended considering my ten years’ loss of a son.”

“This general hasn’t seen my wife for a long time; there’s a lot to say.”

Qin Wencai tactfully asked to be excused.

Qin Mian rested on Lei Tie’s shoulder and kissed that cold wooden face.

Lei Tie put his arms around him, picked him up, and pressed him on the floor.....

The night sky spread its curtain; the silent stars twinkled. Thousands of bonfires were lit in the camp; the flames swayed within the gale. In the morning, a large wok hung above the bonfire – the smell of steamed bread floated over the whole camp. In a heavy pot, meaty bones, meat cubes, cabbage, radish, and potatoes churned inside – the seductive aroma was mouth-watering.

In Lei Tie's military tent, Qin Mian was sound asleep with a pillow in his arms.

“Wife, wife...”

Qin Mian immediately woke up and sat up so suddenly that the quilt slipped off his shoulder, “Going to battle?”

Lei Tie pulled up the cotton-padded quilt to wrap him in and softly kissed him on the lips, “Not yet. I need you to add some spiritual spring water into all the pots. When the soldiers have enough food and drink, I'll immediately launch an all-out attack on Tuluo.”

Qin Mian nodded and put clothes on his body. At the side, Lei Tie picked up the underwear and socks and helped him put them on. Noticing that his wife's feet sensitively shrunk away, he could not help but bow his head and kissed the big toe.

Qin Mian stared wide-eyed at him and quickly retracted his feet, “I'll wear it myself!”

After getting dressed, he took out half a bucket of spiritual spring water from the space, mixed it with half a bucket of water, and then poured a large packet of seasonings into it. He stirred the mixture evenly using his vital spirit before carrying the wooden bucket out of the tent and had someone get the camp chargehand to call the meal chief.

“Chief Chen, you must have heard of Double Xiang House. This is our homemade eighteen-flavored seasoning. You help me add a spoonful to each soup pot so that all the soldiers can eat to their hearts' content and have more energy to attack the enemy.”

Since a major poisoning case occurred in the camp, the people in the meal department had become very cautious. As the person in charge of the meal department, Chief Chen was even more cautious. He politely smiled and glanced at Lei Tie in an inquiring manner. Upon seeing Lei Tie nodded, he took the bucket with gratefulness and cheerfully said, "Thank you, Qindaren. This lowly one will do it at once!"

"So many campfires?" Qin Mian hinted at Lei Tie.

Lei Tie said, "Don't worry, I used an illusion to cover it."

Qin Mian nodded and followed Chief Chen.

The soldiers soon learned that the seasoning Chief Chen brought came from the country-wide famous Double Xiang House – they were both delighted and excited. In order not to attract the enemy's attention, everyone was rationally restrained and did not dare to make a cheer.

The bucket of seasoning was properly distributed to each soup pot. When the pot was stirred with a large ladle, the aroma of the broth smelled more fragrant and richer as it wafted over the camp. Many people swallowed their saliva.

Outside the camp, the soldiers in charge of vigilance had drool steadily flowed out, but they did not dare to act rashly because they were on duty.

Deputy General Liu walked over with a small squadron of ten and a smile on his face.

"Everyone doesn't have to worry. The grand general has specially ordered this general to deliver a message to you saying that he left you a few big pots of food with more meat in it!"

Smiles of expectation appeared on the guarding soldiers' faces.

"Thank you, Deputy General Liu!"

Deputy General Liu inspected the outside of the camp and brought the words of the grand general to every soldier on guard.

When the meaty bone stew in the pot was nicely cooked, everyone began to eat.

While on the battlefield, Lei Tie had always eaten with the soldiers and this time was no exception – he sat around the soup pot with a dozen other soldiers.

One scooped up a large serving of food and soup into the bowl, took a bite of a thick steamed bun and a bite of meat, and then drank a mouthful of soup – one's stomach was full at once. Or, one torn the steamed bun into pieces and soaked in the soup – it was also very tasty.

Qin Mian sat on the ground next to Lei Tie, holding a big bowl. This was the first time he had a meal with hundreds of thousands of people. He couldn't help but look around, feeling very novel.

Lei Tie scooped up the food with the ladle for him and rubbed his head. The intimate action, gentle expression, and doting gaze made the nearby soldiers secretly exhaled. They must have misinterpreted it. How could that kind of expression appear on the face of their grim-faced grand general?

Qin Mian turned his head and focused on eating. The meaty bones were simmered long enough that the overcooked meat could completely detach from the bones by gently scraping it with chopsticks. When one put the meat in one's mouth and chewed while savoring it, it was extremely delicious.

Everyone ate very fast; Qin Mian couldn't help but speed up.

Lei Tie finished eating first and hurriedly left after leaving Qin Mian with a sentence, "I'm going ahead."

After the rest of the soldiers quickly finished their meal, they put the bowls and chopsticks on the ground, swiftly sprang up, and gathered on the simple drill ground next to the military camp without a word.

In a short while, only Qin Mian, Qin Wencai, the mess cooks, and over two hundred military doctors with their medical assistants were left in the

vicinity.

The military doctors also did not eat slowly. After filling their stomachs, they picked up their medicine boxes and hurried to the drill ground. Qin Mian and Qin Wencai quickly followed.

In contra, the mess cooks didn't have anything to be anxious about. After eating, each took two big baskets, picked up the tableware and chopsticks on the ground, and cleaned up the camp in an orderly manner.

After the tens of thousands of soldiers were assembled, they sneaked into the enemy's camp in the dim light of the night, preparing for a night attack.

The military doctors followed behind neither close nor far.

About an hour later, from the front direction came a strong smell of blood. About three quarters later, sky-shaking war drums and high-pitched marching voices rose steeply from the ground. The torches were also lit. The soldiers of Great Xia flooded into the camp of Tuluo like a turbulent tide.

“Forward—”

“Attack—”

“.....”

At this time, the military doctors quickly chased up and rushed to the fallen soldiers. By the light of the torches, they judged whether the soldiers were dead, then inspected the wounds on the wounded soldiers, skillfully stopped the bleeding, applied medicine, and bandaged them.

The fallen soldiers were either seriously injured or killed in action, otherwise, they would not easily topple over.

Qin Mian used his vital spirit to shield against the strong fishy smell. He treated the wounded soldiers with an extremely fast movement. He sprinkled medicinal powder and bandaged; sprinkled medicinal powder and bandaged...

...

Doctor Yu squatted beside a wounded soldier. He wiped the sweat from his face and looked left and right, “Eh—Qin-daren and Imperial Doctor Qin, you know, every time we went to the battlefield previously, we could only helplessly watch the soldiers fall one after another and feel very unbearable. Today, there are fewer wounded soldiers than before!”

Only Qin Mian who was present understood that it was the spiritual spring water that had made the soldiers stronger, their five senses sharper than ever, and naturally they were much quicker to dodge the enemy attacks.

“Speaking of which, both Qin-daren and Imperial Doctor Qin are surnamed Qin.” Another military doctor curiously asked, “Are you relatives?”

Qin Wencai opened his mouth but said nothing.

Qin Mian dully smiled, “It’s just a coincidence...” He stayed away from other military doctors without a trace and sealed the meridians of the wounded soldiers with his vital spirit when no one paid attention. This method was much faster to stop the bleeding.

“Dong—Dong—Dongdong—” The pounding of the war drum was intermittently high and low, intermittently swift and slow, but continued to sound. The shouts at battle in front were like waves coming after another.

Over time, the military doctors gradually became tired and no longer had the energy to talk – their hands repeated the actions of treating wounds over and over again as if they had their own consciousness.

Qin Mian fished out a bottle of pill from his inner pocket and took out a pill. He gave it to the medical assistant under him, “Dissolve this pill with three pots of boiling water and give all the military doctors and medical assistants a cup.”

“Aye!”

Doctor Yu curiously asked, “Qin-daren, what is that?”

Qin Mian explained, “It’s a pill that I made myself. It can rejuvenate one’s spirit to freshen up. Because the effect is too strong, it needs to be added with more water.”

Chapter 196: Return in Triumph

196 – Return in Triumph

“I see.”

No one harbored suspicion – Qin Mian’s ability to detoxify more than 10,000 poisoned soldiers had proved his skill.

After the medical assistant brought the medicinal soup, everyone had a drink. Sure enough, their spirit and physical strength recovered a lot. They gave Qin Mian a grateful smile and after thanking him, they continued to be busy.

The whitish color of a fish’s belly appeared in the east. It’s almost dawn!

The war drums of Great Xia sounded more intense; influenced by the zealous drumbeat, the soldiers launched even fiercer attacks.

After the period of two incense sticks burnout, a strange horn suddenly sounded on the ground. The tune was also very strange, from high to low until it was almost inaudible.

Qin Wencai, Doctor Yu, and the others were shocked; their eyes were filled with profound surprises.

Not understanding, Qin Mian asked, “What’s the matter?”

“Surr... Tuluo army has surrendered!”

“That’s great. If the speed is fast enough, I can go back to celebrate the New Year!”

“Finally, I can go home!”

“.....”

An hour later, the exact news came back from the front. Lei Tie led his six valiant generals to capture alive the enemy’s three commanding generals. They were Liu Manhui, the Third Prince of Tuluo, Sheng Xuhao, the valiant general of Tuluo, and Yin Xiangzhao, the valiant general and concurrently the military adviser of the Tuluo army who had given the evil idea of poisoning the soldiers of Great Xia.

Then, the campsite was relocated. Five thousand soldiers were sent back from the front to help the military doctors arrange the wounded soldiers and dispose of the dead soldiers’ bodies. Qin Mian and the other military doctors stayed in the new tent to take care of the wounded soldiers.

As if the Heavens wanted to congratulate the compatriots of Great Xia, it began to snow in the afternoon.

Lei Tie had been busy for half a month handling all the military affairs in the military camp. He received the imperial decree of Emperor Xiaohui to withdraw the troops from the front and escort Chen Chuang, Liu Manhui, Sheng Xuhao, and Yin Xiangzhao to the Capital in the next few days.

Lei Tie told Qin Mian that in this battle, Tuluo lost nearly 200,000 soldiers. Besides, Liu Manhui and Yin Xiangzhao were practically equivalent to the right-hand men of the Tuluo emperor. Emperor Xiaohui certainly would make good use of this to ask Tuluo to cede territory and pay indemnities. Tuluo would be sapped of its vitality and would not dare to start a war with Great Xia for at least ten years.

The day before departure, it began to snow again. Snowflakes fell like catkins – it added a bit of romance.

Qin Mian was packing their luggage in Lei Tie’s army tent. Suddenly, he thought of something and looked at the man sitting at the table and writing on the booklet.

“Family head, did you forget something?”

“Family head?” Lei Tie’s movement paused, thinking that his wife did the best to attract him. Remembering that the memorial had to be sent out as soon as possible, he refrained from looking up, “Catch foals?”

Qin Mian smiled, “Fortunately, you still remember. Otherwise, your sons won’t forgive you.”

When Lei Tie finished writing the memorial, he ordered someone to rush to the Capital to deliver the memorial. He put a cloak on Qin Mian, pulled him out of the tent, and asked people to bring two horses. The two men then galloped out of the camp.

With a clear cry, the golden eagle merely flapped its wings and caught up with them by borrowing the strong wind. It always hovered two *zhang* [6.6m] above their heads.

It snowed heavily. The willow catkins turned into cotton, drifting profusely and disorderly.

After running around for more than an hour, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went deep into the grassland of Tuluo. Herds of wild horses and mountain sheeps walked in silence on the grassland, leisurely nibbling the hay on the ground.

Lei Tie’s soul sense brought the whole grassland into sight as he carefully searched for the healthiest foals.

Qin Mian patted off the snow on him and casually said, “It’ll be great if we can find a pair of twin horses.”

The corner of Lei Tie’s mouth twitched. His wife was too frightening in action that it was hard for him.

Qin Mian laughed and patted him on the shoulder, “Hahaha... I’m kidding!”

Lei Tie was absorbed in thought, “There are many wild horses here. It’s not difficult to find two identical ones.”

“Right.” Qin Mian came to a realization, “Two horses of the same birth actually aren’t exactly alike.”

They galloped forward for a while and saw a herd of wild horses in the distance.

The luck of the two men was really good. They found two very similar foals in that herd of horses. They were not too big, assuming they were just born no more than two or three months ago – they were small and adorable. Their pair of watery big eyes were like round and bright glazed stones. Although they had dirt on their bodies, one could still see that the fur all over their bodies was white. They were beautiful and walked with a firm and steady steps.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other, pleasantly surprised.

Qin Mian cried out, “Great!”

“I’ll do it.” Lei Tie took out two ropes from the space. Like a robust person of great power, he flew up straight to the two white horses.

The golden eagle followed with an itching heart.

One person and one bird together separated the two white horses from the herd. Then, Lei Tie held back with force the nape of the two foals in each hand.

The two foals called out in low voices and obediently lay down on the ground to let Lei Tie put ropes on them.

Qin Mian spurred his horse over and chanted out a cleaning mantra. The two horses became clean in an instant – the snowy white fur had not a speck of motley.

It was a long way from the western pass to the Capital. Qin Mian fed each of the two foals a pill to build up a good physique and improve their health.

They led the foals back to the military camp.

Almost everyone in the camp knew that the State Defender Grand General couple had a pair of adorable twin sons. When they saw the two foals, they knew who the foals were to be given to. Naturally, the people in charge of the stable dared not to be reckless in taking care of them.

That night, the whole camp had a celebration dinner around the bonfires.

At daybreak of the next day, Lei Tie and the few generals first led 5000 vanguard troops to escort First Prince Chen Chuang and Liu Manhui's group of three. The rest of the army closely followed behind.

The banner embroidered with the word "Lei" fluttered in the front of the procession. Everywhere they went, the ordinary people beat the drums and clanged the gongs, dancing for joy.

In order to get back to the Capital as soon as possible, Qin Mian and Lei Tie quietly added spiritual spring water to the soldiers' meals, so all the soldiers were in high spirits along the way – they didn't feel the slightest hardship as they hurried up.

Only Chen Chuang, Liu Manhui, Sheng Xuhao, and Yin Xiangzhao suffered, not knowing what medicine Qin Mian gave them. They were sapped of strength and whenever the carriage jolted, they practically vomited several times a day. They lost at least ten jin of weight in less than four days. Along the way, no one tried to save them. It was hateful that Lei Tie and Qin Mian's martial arts were too good. With the two men, none thought it could be successful.

With the hurrying, the procession finally entered the Capital on the 20th day of the 12th month. Early in the morning, Emperor Xiaohui personally led the empress, the Second Prince, the princess, and other important civil and military officials to wait on the city wall.

Dongyang Academy had a winter holiday on the 10th day of the 12th month. Naturally, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin could not miss this important day – they were on the city wall, too. Because Emperor Xiaohui was very fond of the two little boys, they occupied the most conspicuous position. The brothers each wore the same red cotton-wadded gown, a winter hat, a

scarf around the neck, and gloves. Emperor Xiaohui held one boy in each hand.

White Spot and Golden Fur were also there – they leaned on the guardrail like humans.

Near noon, a group of armored soldiers appeared at the end of the public road in dark masses.

Eunuch Li excitedly said, “Your Majesty, they’re here!”

“Dad and Old Dad are back at last!” Lei Ruilin jumped up and waved a hand to the distance.

Emperor Xiaohui jokingly said, “Don’t get excited, little guy. They’re so far away. Your two dads can’t see you.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at each other and smiled: Dad and Old Dad surely can see [us].

“Ge, I wonder if Old Dad will forget to catch the foals for us.” Lei Ruilin propped up his chin, squeezing the meat on his face together. He was chubby but very cute.

Qin Ruiqi said, “He won’t.”

Princess Duanning curiously asked, “What foals?”

With an arrogant look, Qin Ruiqi said, “Caught from Western Barbarian.”

Lei Ruilin explained, “Dad said that he would take our family to hunt when Old Dad came back. Gege and I told Dad that we needed two foals, so Dad asked us to write to Old Dad and let him catch two from Western Barbarian.”

Second Prince slightly nodded as he said, “The environment in Western Barbarian is relatively worse than that in Great Xia. Therefore, the horses in their country are generally stronger than ours.”

Thinking deeply, Emperor Xiaohui patted Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin on the shoulder, “Hunting? Good idea. Ruiqi and Ruilin, Uncle Emperor will invite you to hunt in the imperial hunting ground someday.”

While they talked, Lei Tie’s procession was getting closer and closer. Qin Mian and Lei Tie’s horses were at the top front of the procession, on par with one another.

Both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin happily waved their hands.

Qin Mian saw the two children waving; he softly smiled and also waved back.

Lei Tie, still with that poker face, only looked at Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin for a moment.

“Old Dad doesn’t wave back,” said Lei Ruilin with regret.

Emperor Xiao Hui, the empress, Second Prince, and the ministers were unable to restrain their laughter when they imagined Lei Tie waving his hand.

The procession soon arrived outside the city gate. When the soldiers heard the celebration beats of the drums and gongs and crackles of the firecrackers inside the city, their faces displayed smiles of pride.

Being the lead of everyone, Lei Tie dismounted the horse, faced the city wall, and knelt on one knee.

“Your subject and the others pay respect to Your Majesty. May Your Majesty live longer, absolutely long live!”

All the people on the city wall also knelt and shouted “May Your Majesty live longer, absolutely long live!” with great momentum that rushed straight to the sky.

“You may rise!” Emperor Xiaohui’s hearty laughter was filled with proudness, “Well done, State Defender Grand General. You have lived up to Zhen’s trust in you!”

Lei Tie said, “Thanks to Your Majesty’s great fortune, luckily your subject and the others didn’t dishonor our commission.”

Emperor Xiaohui brought everyone down from the city wall.

When Emperor Xiaohui got on the imperial carriage, Lei Tie led his subordinates to keep up. The other civil and military ministers followed behind in the cheers of the common folks.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Qin Wencai, and several other generals went directly into the palace and came to the imperial study to formally report on the completion of their tasks to the emperor.

Emperor Xiaohui simply asked about the course of the war with Tuluo and how Qin Mian detoxified the poison before excusing them and telling them to have a good rest. In the court session the next day, they could tell the details.

When everyone took leave, Emperor Xiaohui only retained Qin Wencai.

Emperor Xiaohui looked at Qin Wencai from the upper position and directly asked, “My dear subject Qin, the Lady of the State Defender Duke is your son?”

Qin Wencai was stunned. He knelt and replied in truth, “Yes, Your Majesty. Lady of the State Defender Duke is your subject’s legitimate son, who had unexpectedly disappeared ten years ago. At first, when your subject saw the appearance of the Lady of the State Defender Duke in the imperial study, your subject was suspicious of his origin. Your subject dare not hide it from Your Majesty that half the reason why your subject was eager to go to the western pass was to confirm this. May [I] be bold to ask, how did Your Majesty know of this?”

Emperor Xiaohui’s tone was meaningful, “My dear subject Qin, in addition to Lady of the State Defender Duke, you still have another good son *ah*.”

Qin Wencai was puzzled. Suddenly, he felt some uneasiness, “Please forgive, your subject is slow-witted.”

Emperor Xiaohui motioned to Eunuch Li to give the information he found to Qin Wencai. Qin Mian was sent to the western pass by Emperor Xiaohui to save the soldiers. The most important thing was that someone dared to assassinate him on the way. This was tantamount to opposing Emperor Xiaohui and the imperial authority! Emperor Xiaohui naturally wanted to find out the crux of the matter. Unexpectedly, this investigation actually led to Qin Jian, the eldest son of Qin Wencai. Emperor Xiaohui had investigated Qin Mian's identity before, but his men only found the information about Qin Mian after he was fourteen years old. After interrogating Qin Jian, Emperor Xiaohui realized that Qin Mian was actually Qin Wencai's legitimate son.

Chapter 197: Bask in Happiness

197 – Bask in Happiness

After reading the information, Qin Wencai's face paled and his hands trembled. He had never thought that Qin Jian, his eldest son, had secretly assigned killers to nab Qin Mian, who was only 12 years old at that time ten years ago! Fortunately, the two killers met their foes before they had time to start on Qin Mian. The clever Qin Mian took the opportunity to escape. It was a pity that he still couldn't fight against bad luck. He was sold to a wealthy family by human traders to be a page. Two years later, he found a chance to escape again. He fled to Green Mountain Village and fainted because of illness. Later, he was forced to marry Lei Tie as a wife. Not long after, he had "memory loss" due to an unexpected incident.....

Qin Jian started on his brother for the sake of two medical books handed down from generation to generation by the Qin Family's ancestors. One was the "Thousand Golden Prescriptions" inadvertently obtained by the ancestors, and the other was the "Collection of Qin's Art of Healing" compiled by the Qin Family's ancestors. These two medical books not only collected nearly a thousand miraculous prescriptions that the world didn't know of but also contained nearly a thousand real medical cases, including some rare disease cases with their curative treatments.

In the Imperial Institute of Medicine, Qin Wencai had not the highest rank, but the highest status. He was also the personal imperial doctor of Emperor Xiaohui. The most important reason for these was that Qin Wencai had these two medical books – he could identify many diseases that other imperial doctors didn't understand.

There were two extremely important rules in the Qin Family: first, before one's first legitimate son is born, one can't have a concubine-born son;

second, these two medical books are only passed on to one's legitimate son. However, Qin Wencai made a mistake when he was young. Compared with the justified legal wife, he preferred the gentle concubine, which led to the birth of the concubine-born son before the legitimate son, and even four years older than the legitimate son.

However, Qin Wencai did not dare to violate the second family rule even if he was a scoundrel. It was because he was very clear that the Qin Family's ability to maintain its glory for generations was closely related to this rule. After his legitimate son was born, he was quite fond of his legitimate son because he was smart and quick-witted. Therefore, his attention gradually returned to the legal wife and his legitimate son. Even when his legitimate son was four years old, he began to teach him how to identify herbs, intending to put a lot of effort to train him. But unexpectedly, this caused the elder son Qin Jian to be jealous and unwilling to take things laying down. Before Qin Mian was born, his father's most favorite son was him! As Qin Jian was getting older, with the concubine inflamed and agitated him from time to time, his heart became more and more distorted. Finally, at the age of 16, Qin Mian reached the end of his forbearance.

When Qin Mian happened to meet him that year, Qin Jian discovered that he had lost his memory. Besides, he was afraid of Lei Tie – he only secretly guarded against Qin Mian and tried his best to prevent Qin Mian from meeting Qin Wencai. After Qin Mian and Lei Tie left the Capital, Qin Jian left the matter behind.

Later, Qin Mian and Lei Tie entered the Capital again and he learned that Qin Mian was actually the Lady of the State Defender Duke. Qin Jian was really shocked and always on tenterhooks for a long time. Seeing Qin Mian did not have the intention of coming to the door, he could only restrain and try his best to prevent Qin Wencai and Qin Mian from meeting each other. Because he was afraid of Qin Mian and Lei Tie's identity, he dared not deal with Qin Mian, but only dared to start from Qin Wencai's side, even paid a high price to buy Qin Wencai's attendant, so that he could report every particular gesture and behavior of Qin Wencai to him.

Unexpectedly, Qin Wencai and Qin Mian still met. To confirm Qin Mian's identity, Qin Wencai even went to the western pass with Qin Mian. Qin Jian

was truly afraid at that time. Once Qin Wencai knew Qin Mian's real identity and that his disappearance were related to him, he would not only lose standing and reputation but also lose hope for the two medical books and miss the wealth accumulated by the Qin Family over the past few generations. As the result, Qin Jian secretly contacted killers and hired them to assassinate Qin Mian at a high price. He thought that when he contacted the killers, he had hidden his true identity very well. One didn't have to think about it – the emperor was a man who covered the country with one hand and besides, the Capital itself was at the foot of the emperor. Wasn't it easy for the emperor to find the person behind the curtain?

The booklet slipped from Qin Wencai's hand. Qin Wencai knelt on the ground with a pale face. For a moment, he didn't know what to say. "Your Majesty, your subject..."

Emperor Xiaohui sighed, waved his hand, and said in a light tone, "Zhen left him life for your sake. You're excused." After all, the inside information found by Emperor Xiaohui could be regarded as Qin Wencai's family affairs. If it wasn't for the fact that the person Qin Jian dealt with was the Lady of the State Defender Duke, who was also the meritorious official that had saved more than 10,000 soldiers, he would not have told Qin Wencai the information he found. This was also an account for the State Defender Duke couple to deal with.

"Your subject thanks Your Majesty. May Your Majesty live longer, absolutely long live!" Qin Wencai choked with sobs and withdrew with a confused mind.

Two flowers bloomed, one on each side. [On the other side]

After leaving the palace, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went directly back to the State Defender Duke Establishment.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were not afraid of cold – they were playing with Golden Fur and White Spot at the gate of the State Defender Duke Establishment.

As their temporary guardian, Chen Mufeng accompanied them. Back then, Qin Mian entrusted his two sons to him in person, so now he naturally wanted to return the children face to face.

Zhangsun Hong was also there – he played together with Golden Fur and White Spot.

At the side, Chen Mufeng watched the three little boys playing, yet he didn't feel bored.

Steward Fu and all the servants in the State Defender Duke Establishment stood at the side in preparation to welcome the two masters.

“Clip-clop-clip-clop...”

The approaching sound of the horse's hooves made everyone looked up.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin rushed over.

“Dad! Old Dad!”

Golden Fur and White Spot happily followed.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie bent while mounted, and each picked up a son and put at the front.

“Son, do you miss Dad?” Qin Mian kissed Qin Ruiqi on his cheek with a “pop”.

Qin Ruiqi's paralyzed little face suddenly tinted with blush.

Qin Mian spontaneously laughed, “Hahaha...”

Lei Ruilin looked at Lei Tie with curled lips filled with hints, “Old Dad.”

Lei Tie's movement stiffened.

“Hahaha...” Qin Mian buried his head on his son's small shoulder and broke into laughter.

Qin Ruiqi looked at his Didi's act like a spoiled child and Old Dad's embarrassed expression – a sliver of a smile emerged on the corner of his lips.

Not far away, Chen Mufeng saw Lei Ruilin's pathetic expression and burst out laughing.

Lei Tie lightly coughed, put his hands under his youngest son's armpits to lift him, and handed him to his wife – the meaning was self-evident.

Qin Mian smiled as he kissed his youngest son's cheek very loudly, "Satisfied?"

Only then Lei Ruilin giggled and was taken back by his Old Dad and placed at the front.

Zhangsun Hong had never seen Lei Ruilin with that kind of look. He made a funny face at Lei Ruilin, wouldn't admit that he was envious – his dad would never kiss him.

When the horses ran into the gate, Qin Mian and Lei Tie jumped off with their sons in their arms.

"Respectfully welcome Old Lord and Lady back home!"

"Forego formalities."

Lei Tie slightly nodded and went to Chen Mufeng.

"[We] have troubled you to take care of Ruiqi and Ruilin – thank you very much."

Chen Mufeng said with a smile, "I'm returning the two little boys to you completely intact."

Qin Mian felt the small faces of the two sons and laughed heartily as he said, "I can see that you really took care of them very well. Their faces are chubby."

Both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin subconsciously felt their faces.

Qin Mian and Chen Mufeng laughed.

Lei Ruilin said, “Dad, Old Dad. I want to see the foals.”

“Didn’t your Old Dad send the two foals back? You haven’t seen them yet?” Qin Mian was a little surprised. He thought the two little boys could not wait and ran to see them first.

Qin Ruiqi said, “Didi and I want to see them with Dad and Old Dad.”

Qin Mian gave a wee of a smile and gratefully hugged his son’s shoulders. “Then let’s go. Together we go. Hong’er, do you want to come with us?”

Zhangsun Hong nodded, “En, thank you, Uncle Qin.”

Thereupon, three big ones and three small ones went inside together.

Both of Qin Mian’s hands held Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin. Although the two little boys previously thought that they didn’t need adults to hold their hands as they had grown up, because they had not seen their father for a long time, they wanted to be close to him. Not only they did not protest, they even held their father’s hands tightly.

Lei Ruilin looked at Lei Tie beside him, then held his hand and smiled at him.

Lei Tie slightly nodded.

Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun Hong walked at the back. Looking at the family of four enveloped in a joyful atmosphere in front of them, they inexplicably felt that they were somewhat superfluous.

Not a while later, they came to the stable.

The two foals had been placed in the stable and cleaned by the servants. They were eating the fodder in the trough with their heads down.

“So beautiful!” exclaimed Zhangsun Hong when he saw the two foals; his eyes full of envy.

The eyes of both Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin brightened. They let go of their father’s hand and ran to the stable.

Chen Mufeng carefully measured up the two foals and commented, “The bones of these two horses are really good. Caught in the Western Barbarian?”

“Yes.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “A-Tie and I went to the grassland of the Western Barbarian to catch them.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie combed the bones of the two foals with spiritual qi. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin sensed the familiar aura on their bodies. When they reached out to touch the foals, the foals not only didn’t dodge but also had docile looks.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin felt the white and soft mane of the foals and loved it.

Zhangsun Hong couldn’t help reaching out to the foal in front of him.

Little did he know, the foal snorted, glanced at him, and hid its head.

Zhangsun Hong’s stretched hand stiffened in midair; a wounded expression on his face.

“Hahaha...” Lei Ruilin simmered with laughter. He hugged the neck of the foal, feeling proud that it was only close to him.

After all, Zhangsun Hong was a child of an influential family – his upbringing was not ordinary and therefore, his bearing was not ordinary. He took back his hand after he was temporarily stunned. Holding back the aggrieved mist in his eyes, he calmly said, “Didn’t you say that you’re going to hunt with your Dad and Old Dad after getting the foals? The two horses are so small; they must not run very fast.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin both had cultivation. How could they not see that the two foals have been improved by their father? Qin Ruiqi confidently said, “[They] run very fast.”

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198 – The Family of Four is “Officials”

Lei Ruilin also vigorously nodded, “These are what my Old Dad captured from Western Barbarian. They must be the best!”

Zhangsun Hong was even more envious and suggested, “We’ll know when you try.”

Qin Ruiqi inquiringly looked at Qin Mian.

Qin Mian said, “Son, not yet. You and Ruilin haven’t learned how to ride a horse. ”

Lei Ruilin pleaded, “Dad, it will be fine with you and Old Dad here. Let me and Gege try it?”

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie, and Lei Tie immediately nodded. Qin Mian was speechless. In fact, strictly speaking, although Lei Tie was strict with both children, Lei Tie was no worse than him in terms of spoiling the sons.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin happily led the two foals out.

Because there was no set of stirrup and saddle, for the time being, Qin Mian and Lei Tie could only carry their sons up.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were truly bold. They held the reins and recalled the way their fathers used to ride. Their legs clamped the belly of the foals, and the foals happily ran. The speed might not be fast, but the vigorous hooves, the snow-white mane fluttering in the wind, and the energetic

momentum simply set off the two happy children on the horsebacks to look even more high-spirited.

Zhangsun Hong was even more envious. At this time, he didn't care about the speed of the foal – he so wished that the one on the horseback was him.

Chen Mufeng affectionately rubbed his head.

The more Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin rode, the more they felt it. They gained some experience with trials and errors. With a slight shake of the reins, the foals ran faster and more smoothly. They both laughed in joy.

Lei Ruilin proudly threw a smug look at Zhangsun Hong.

Zhangsun Hong was, after all, a child. He finally couldn't hold it back and burst into tears.

Chen Mufeng hurriedly coaxed him, "Don't cry. Going back later, ask your father to get one for you."

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were taken aback. They stopped their horses, easily jumped down and ran to Zhangsun Hong. They were at a loss of what to do.

"A-Hong, I'm sorry." Lei Ruilin apologized in a frank and unhurried manner.

Zhangsun Hong wiped his tear in embarrassment, "[I] don't blame you. I'll ask my father to find me a foal, too!"

Lei Ruilin smiled, "Good! Then we'll go hunting together."

Qin Mian and Chen Mufeng spontaneously burst out laughing.

Chen Mufeng said, "Qin Mian, Lei Tie – it's time for us to leave. You're tired after such a long journey, we don't want to delay your rest."

"Alright." Qin Mian nodded, "Let's get together another day."

After Chen Mufeng and Zhangsun Hong left, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin felt sorry for the foals and did not ride again. They asked the servants to bring the foals back to the stable to look after with great care.

Qin Mian instructed Steward Fu to order two sets of soft saddles as soon as possible.

The family went back to the house holding hands.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to take a bath to get rid of travel fatigue, and then the family had a sumptuous lunch together.

After lunch, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were very considerate of their fathers and told them to have a good rest. They left with Golden Fur and White Spot.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie enjoyed their son's thoughtfulness very much. They went to bed and did a certain thing they liked before they properly went to sleep. With their cultivation, although it did not affect their health even if they didn't sleep for a long time, sleeping was also a kind of enjoyment. What was there to be against it?

It was the latter part of the monkey hour [4.30 pm] when they woke up. They checked their sons' homework and the family of four had a chat together.

The next day, Lei Tie got up at dawn to go to the court session. Qin Mian also had to go to the court session. The first reason was that his official position had not been revoked. Secondly, he had made great achievements in the western pass, so Emperor Xiaohui would certainly reward him in the court. Even if he did not go to the court, Emperor Xiaohui would summon him to the palace.

After the couple took care of domestic affairs, they rode to the palace in the dim light of dawn. At the gate of the palace, the civil and military officials, who were also going to the court, saw them and greeted them warmly and politely.

Into the Hall of Supreme Harmony, more people greeted them. As the only married couple to go to court at the same time, they calmly accept the public attention.

After Emperor Xiaohui appeared, the monarch and his subjects greeted appropriately. There was no need to say more than was needed.

Emperor Xiaohui asked Lei Tie about his battle with Tuluo in detail. He generously praised Lei Tie. “In this battle with Tuluo, State Defender Duke’s contribution cannot be left unrecognized – granted a suit of a yellow buttoned mandarin jacket, bestowed 100,000 taels of gold, and conferred Qin Ruiqi, the eldest son of the State Defender Duke, as the Heir of the State Defender Duke [title].”

The ministers were not surprised by this result. Lei Tie, as the State Defender Duke, was a principal first-rank official – it was already the highest rank and could not get promoted anymore. He could only be rewarded from other aspects. After the New Year, Tuluo would cede territory and pay indemnities to Great Xia. Emperor Xiaohui didn’t care about the 100,000 taels of gold.

Lei Tie kowtowed to express gratitude.

Emperor Xiaohui also added, “Lady of the State Defender Duke has saved the lives of more than ten thousand soldiers at the border station. His contribution cannot be left unrecognized – revoked the duty of Special Case Military Inspector, appointed as the Palace [inner] Principal Practitioner¹ of Imperial Institute of Medicine, bestowed 100,000 tales of gold. Also, conferred Lei Ruilin, the second son of the State Defender Duke, as the Duke of Anping County.”

To his surprise, Emperor Xiaohui officially granted him an official position – Qin Mian was taken aback, but he could not refuse this occasion and was forced to kneel to express his gratitude.

All the ministers sighed to themselves. Now, the four members of the State Defender Duke family were all “officials”. One could describe it as extreme glory.

Before the court adjourned, Emperor Xiaohui announced that he would hold a grand banquet in the palace at night and reward the victorious army.

After the court adjourned, everyone congratulated Qin Mian and Lei Tie one after another.

They got out of the palace with great difficulty and avoided other people's sight. Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other with a dignified look.

Lei Tie said in a low voice, "It seems that the emperor intends to keep us in the Capital all the time. I'm afraid it's not easy to resign."

Qin Mian was also worried, but he was always optimistic. He was not particularly anxious, "I saw that the emperor is in a good mood. Besides, the New Year is coming, we'd better not talk about resigning at this time. We'll talk about it later, at least until the negotiation between Western Barbarian and Great Xia is over."

Lei Tie nodded.

Not long after they got home, their rewards and the imperial edicts to confer titles on Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin arrived.

Although Qin Ruiqi was the eldest son of the State Defender Duke priorly, he could not be the Heir of the State Defender Duke without being conferred the title. Now, he was the legitimate Heir of the State Defender Duke. The common people had to salute whenever they saw him. He could inherit the title of "State Defender Duke" in the future. Lei Ruilin was not bad either. The rank of "Duke of Anping County" was the same as that of the Heir of the Duke, Marquis, and Count nobility. Later, Anping County would be his fiefdom. When he reached the age of 16, only half of the taxes of Anping County would be paid to the imperial court, and the rest would be his.

Although Qin Mian and Lei Tie were respectively Lady of the State Defender Duke and State Defender Duke, they usually did not make any actions of relying on authority. This attitude also influenced Qin Ruiqi and

Lei Ruilin. The two little boys were just new to their new identities. Besides that, they were very calm.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were very satisfied with their sons' behavior.

On that day, many people sent gifts – if one was not able to hold the thigh, at least one had to *weave a favorable fate resulting from contributions to the temple*². It was easy to avoid these disasters to remember. Qin Mian simply accepted them, but on another day, he asked people to exchange the gifts for money whichever that could be changed, and donate it to the imperial court while frankly expressing that it was for military expenses. This was naturally to eliminate Emperor Xiaohui's fear of Lei Tie (the fundamental purpose was to avoid trouble). *You think, you just hold the military power, but you are even close with so many ministers, how can the emperor not be afraid of the consequences?*

Emperor Xiaohui was very satisfied with this and trusted Qin Mian and Lei Tie even more. The people who sent the gifts were not very satisfied, but they also understood that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were people with principles. When they sent the gifts later, they just tried their best not to pick up expensive gifts – the future events shall not be mentioned here.

In the evening, the celebration banquet was held as scheduled.

In addition to eating and drinking and awarding rewards to all those who had made contributions to the campaign, the important thing to mention was that Emperor Xiaohui decided to hold a hunting activity in the imperial hunting ground from the 26th to 28th of the 12th month. The first reason was to have a good time with the ministers, and the second was to reward the ministers with the prey so that they could have a bumper new year.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin had been looking forward to hunting since they got the foals. After they learned that the emperor wanted to invite them to hunt, they carefully took care of their foals for several days. They also understood that it was not necessarily possible to hunt on this foal, but hunting was not only for prey but also for fun. So, they were both in high spirits.

Qin Mian also specially made hunting suits and bows suitable for them.

On the 26th of the 12th month, it snowed heavily, which added some fun to the hunting activity in winter. Hunting in the snow was much more interesting than hunting on dry ground.

Early in the morning, after breakfast, the family of four rode on horsebacks to the imperial hunting ground. The foursome wore the same red hunting suit – it was red because red was more conspicuous in snow so that if something happened, they could find each other faster. The two foals also wore red brocade around their necks. The foursome was all equipped with the same equipment – bows and arrows on their backs and the same type of waist-bag with wound medicine, water tubes, and dried food.

The family of four was outstanding in appearance and temperament. They rode on horsebacks in the streets of the Capital. The pedestrians on the street couldn't stop looking at them. In Qin Mian's words, "the rate of turning head is 100%".

When they arrived at the imperial hunting ground, the imperial bodyguards and the ministers who had arrived early all looked at them. They envied Qin Mian and Lei Tie for their two excellent sons, but they also envied their special clothes – they were really eye-catching.

The eight imperial bodyguards at the entrance of the imperial hunting ground respectfully saluted when they came back to their senses.

"Greetings, State Defender Duke, Lady of the State Defender Duke, Heir of the State Defender Duke, and Duke of Anping County!"

Even people who didn't know their identity knew that this family was unusual just by listening to this string of titles.

Lei Tie lightly nodded, "Don't stand on ceremony."

The foursome spurred the horses to enter.

Because Emperor Xiaohui liked it lively, not only the civil and military ministers but also their sons came to participate in the hunting. Hence, at this time, the hunting ground was full of people and many of them were sons of princes and officials in splendid clothes.

At first, when some people saw two children riding foals to participate in the hunting, they thought it was funny. They planned to come over to ridicule. But when they heard what the imperial bodyguard called them, they quickly gave up their ideas. The family of the State Defender Duke couldn't be provoked by ordinary people.

Several tents had been set up on the hunting ground. The family of four rode to the biggest and most guarded tent.

Emperor Xiaohui, Imperial Prince Ming, and Chen Mufeng were chatting inside.

Eunuch Li lifted the curtain door and walked in with a smile on his face. "Reporting, Your Majesty. State Defender Duke's family has arrived."

Emperor Xiaohui was surprised and asked, "Are Ruiqi and Ruilin really riding the foals that the State Defender Duke gave them?"

Eunuch Li replied, "Exactly. The two foals are all white – really beautiful."

Emperor Xiaohui was interested, "Let's go out and have a look."

Several people went out of the tent. Qin Mian's group of four just arrived on horseback and quickly dismounted to salute.

"Paying respects to Your Majesty."

"You may rise." Emperor Xiaohui saw the scene of Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin riding on the horses just now and involuntarily laughed as he spoke, "Haha... Sure enough, they are two good horses. The appearance of Ruiqi and Ruilin riding on the horses just now was very domineering. But, can such a small horse able to hunt prey?"

Lei Ruilin confidently said, “Certainly, Uncle Emperor! Ruilin and Gege will send a portion to Uncle Emperor after we hunted a prey!”

Emperor Xiaohui was greatly rejoiced, “Alright! Zhen will be waiting. ”

At this time, Zhangsun He and Zhangsun Hong came over on horseback.

Footnotes

1. 3rd rank
2. get good karma from doing good i.e send gifts

Chapter 199: The Family of Four Goes Hunting

199 – The Family of Four Goes Hunting

“Ruiqi, Ruilin!” Zhangsun Hong waved to Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin from a distance with a smile on his face. He really asked Zhangsun He to find him a foal with brown fur. Although it was not as strong as the two white foals, it was also very strong. However, Zhangsun He wasn’t at ease to let him sit on the horse alone and tied a rope around his waist with the other end of the rope in Zhangsun He’s hand – it looked very funny.

Emperor Xiaohui burst into laughter; everyone else also could not restrain from laughing.

Zhangsun Hong’s face turned red. After Chen Mufeng took him off his horse, he paid respect to Emperor Xiaohui in a good manner.

“Hong’er may rise. This foal is also very good.” Emperor Xiaohui patted the foal on its back as he praised it.

Zhangsun Hong’s face turned redder, but Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin didn’t laugh at him – it made him feel better about these two good friends.

After the stipulated gathering time, everyone formally paid respect to Emperor Xiaohui.

With the victorious battle of Great Xia and the coming New Year, Emperor Xiaohui was in a good mood these days. He said with a smile, “During these three days of hunting, all of you should enjoy yourselves to the fullest.

By the beginning of the monkey hour [3 p.m] in the afternoon of the day after tomorrow, Zhen will greatly reward whoever hunted the most prey!”

The emperor’s reward was not necessarily a very valuable thing, but it had a different significance – it was sort of a rare honor. Everyone made great efforts to win the first prize in the hunting competition. Especially for the young people without official rank, if they got the emperor’s attention, they might get an official position.

Emperor Xiaohui put on his hunting suit and set out with his imperial bodyguards.

The empress and the three consorts who followed Emperor Xiaohui could only stay in the tent. Even Princess Duanning went hunting. Emperor Xiaohui and the empress were very concerned about this daughter. They wanted to take the opportunity to let her cultivate feelings with the Heir of the Martial God Marquis. Since there were so many followers, it would not be called private meetings.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie led their two sons after choosing a direction and spurred the horses into the distance.

Zhangsun Hong wanted to follow them; Zhangsun He and Chen Mufeng flanked him for protection. However, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin’s white foals were much faster than Zhangsun Hong’s – they had run far not a while later. There were so many horseshoe marks on the ground that he couldn’t find out which direction they had gone for a short time.

The imperial hunting ground was a place for the Imperial Clan to hunt and have fun. The game inside was specially put in by the person in charge of the hunting ground. There were no beasts such as tigers, leopards, and wolves. The most dangerous one was probably wild boar, but it was not too big. The rest were small games such as wild sheep, sika deer, hare, pheasant, and fox. To let everyone enjoy themselves to the fullest, there was a lot of prey.

Qin Mian’s family of four had not gone far away when Qin Mian and Lei Tie found a fat hare behind the snowy grass. The couple tacitly agreed to

give the opportunity to their sons.

Qin Mian whispered, “Ruiqi, Ruilin.”

Qin Ruiqi always gave consideration to his Didi, “Ruilin, you do it.”

Lei Ruilin nodded without a sound and spurred his horse forward. Unfortunately, because of his inexperience, the little horse moved too much. When the hare heard the sound, it was startled – it jumped up and ran far away.

“Ge!” Lei Ruilin shouted in distress and he spurred his horse to pursue it together with Qin Ruiqi.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie always stayed two zhang [6.6 m] behind them.

Just then, a sika deer rushed out from the other side of the grove in panic.

Qin Ruiqi took an arrow out of the quiver, pulled the bowstring, and let go. The feathered arrow shot as fast as lightning and pierced the belly of the sika deer.

“Gege is so amazing. You hit such fast prey.” Lei Ruilin had run far away. He turned around and continued to search for prey.

“A-Tie, take care of Ruiqi.” After Qin Mian finished saying that, he followed his youngest son.

Qin Ruiqi raced to the sika deer and looked at Lei Tie as if he was presenting a treasure.

“Pretty good.”

Lei Tie’s praise was very simple but Qin Ruiqi was still very happy with it.

Lei Tie picked up the prey, pulled out the feather arrow, and put it back into his eldest son’s quiver. He then tied the prey on the horse.

“Old Dad, let’s continue.”

“En.”

The father and son randomly picked a direction and went over.

In the distance, Lei Ruilin relentlessly pursued a wild goat of about 50 Jin – he and Qin Mian had blocked it.

Lei Ruilin was about to set off an arrow when a red-headed feathered arrow suddenly flew from afar and shot the wild goat a step ahead.

Qin Mian frowned and looked back. A boy about 11~12 years old dressed in purple sat arrogantly on the horse, leisurely put down his bow. Beside him, there was a man in splendid clothes, about 24~25 years old, with a helpless look on his face.

“Greetings, Lady of the State Defender Duke and Duke of Anping County.” The young man cupped his hands in obeisance while mounting.

Qin Mian said in a light voice, “No need to be so formal.”

Lei Ruilin stared wide-eyed at the boy and said in discontented, “Who are you? Why did you take my prey?”

The boy spurred his horse over and picked up the prey. He handed it to the young man and said in a loud voice, “Chen Bodong. Your prey? You blame others for your own incompetence?”

“Chen Bodong?” Lei Ruilin calmly lifted his eyebrows, “Chen Bonan’s gege?”

Chen Bodong’s face gloomed and he shouted, “Audacious! How dare you call me by my name?”

Lei Ruilin crossed his arms in front of his chest and sneered as he said without haste, “Why not? Although you’re the eldest son of His Highness the First Prince, you have no title. This gongzi I, am the Duke of Anping County who was conferred by the emperor himself. Maybe you can ask the emperor who is audacious here.”

Qin Mian gave a wee of a smile.

“You!” Chen Bodong’s expression abruptly changed. His hand holding the reins turned blue and white because of too much force. He gritted his teeth and said, “Lei Ruilin, we’ll wait and see (who is right)!”

In the end, he still had some rationality – he turned his horse and galloped away.

Lei Ruilin made a face at him and winked at his father before spurring his horse with leisure to keep up with him.

Qin Mian guessed his son’s plan and laughed to himself.

The young man looked back and swept his gaze over Qin Mian, not say anything. He’d be better not to intervene in the children’s disputes, otherwise, the small problem would become a big problem.

Chen Bodong soon noticed that Lei Ruilin was following him – his face turned very blue.

At this time, a fleeing beautiful silver-black fox entered everyone’s line of sight.

Chen Bodong was overjoyed and quickly drew out a feathered arrow. Unexpectedly, before he had the time to set off the arrow, a sharp arrow whooshed from behind him and pierced through the silver-black fox’s fragile neck. The silver-black fox breathed its last.

Chen Bodong abruptly turned his head and saw Lei Ruilin’s closing movement. He was flustered and exasperated, “Lei Ruilin! You dare to take my, this gongzi’s, prey!”

“You blame others for your own incompetence?” replied Lei Ruilin in no hurry. He spurred the foal over, picked up the prey, and handed it to Qin Mian.

Chen Bodong was extremely aggrieved, “You!”

Qin Mian put the prey in the pouch on his girdle, acting as if there was no one else present.

Lei Ruilin stuck out his tongue at Chen Bodong and went away with a press on his horse's belly.

“Argh!” Chen Bodong became angry from embarrassment and hit the nearby pine tree with a fist, and the accumulated snow fell. He pulled the reins in an attempt to catch up with Lei Ruilin.

The young man quickly stopped him, “Bodong, calm down! Don't look at that boy's small age – his strength isn't small. Didn't you see the arrow he just shot went through the silver-black fox's neck? He must have used internal force.”

“Uncle, do you really think Lei Ruilin is the one who shot the arrow just now?” Chen Bodong did not believe it, “It must be the Lady of the State Defender Duke.”

The young man shook his head. “The Lady of the State Defender Duke was two zhang [6.6 m] away from the Duke of Anping County – he couldn't complete the actions of getting close to the Duke of Anping County, taking the arrow from the quiver of the Duke of Anping County, shooting the arrow, and returning to the horse two zhang away in just a few breaths.”

Chen Bodong had nothing to say in return. He turned and said, “His father caught my father, so he is my enemy – how can I let him off?! Besides, Imperial Grandfather has been very indifferent to me recently... I wanted to hunt that silver-black fox to present it to Imperial Grandfather.”

The young man sighed to himself and said nothing. First Prince's treason was a grave crime. It was fortunate that the emperor didn't implicate other people in the First Prince Establishment. If Chen Bodong continued to target Lei Ruilin, he would only make the emperor unhappier.

Qin Mian and Lei Ruilin did not pay attention to this episode. After running in the groves for nearly four hours, Lei Ruilin had hunted a silver-black fox,

five hares, and a pheasant. Qin Mian was mainly accompanying his son and did not hunt anything.

“Dad, I’m hungry.” Lei Ruilin also felt distressed for the foal. He jumped off from his horse and rubbed its head.

The foal rubbed against his chest, intimately.

Qin Mian asked, “Do you want to go back to the campsite or eat here?”

Lei Ruilin replied, “Go back to the campsite; let the foal eat some fodder.”

Qin Mian carried his son onto his horse and led the foal back to the campsite.

In the camp, people were cooking. The aroma wafted around.

Lei Tie and Qin Ruiqi had been back for a long time. They got a pile of firewood from somewhere, cleaned up an area in a remote corner, and lit a bonfire. There were four pheasants on the fire that had been roasted for a long time. The color was crisp yellow with oil oozed out, causing people to drool.

Qin Ruiqi sat opposite Lei Tie with two fish skewered on two sticks in his hands. He probably got them from the meal department – no more than a tiny part was scorched.

“Old Dad, I’m hungry!” Lei Ruilin jumped off the horse and ran over.

Qin Mian threw the reins to the imperial bodyguard and kept up, neither fast nor slow.

“Wait.” Lei Tie glanced at his wife and youngest son to make sure they were not injured before withdrawing his sight. He took out a bottle of seasoning from his waist-bag and sprinkled it on the roasting pheasants. He spread the seasoning evenly with a small brush and then continued to roast.

Qin Mian sat down next to him. Holding his chin in both hands, he looked at the man with a smile as he waited for the food.

Lei Ruilin took out two packages of beef jerky, handed one to his Gege, and fed one to each of his fathers. Head to head, the two brothers ate the snacks and chatted in a whisper. It was mainly Lei Ruilin telling Qin Ruiqi about Chen Bodong.

Chapter 200: Come to a Conclusion

200 – Come to a Conclusion

When Qin Mian and Lei Tie heard that Lei Ruilin had a wicked idea to teach Chen Bodong a lesson, Qin Ruiqi persuaded him with a sentence: “No need to lower yourself to a bereaved dog’s level”. Therefore, they didn’t intervene in the dialogue between the two brothers.

Snow was still falling – the snowflakes were like dandelions continuously falling but disappeared without a trace once nearing the bonfire.

“Wife, are you hungry?” Lei Tie raised his hand to flick away the snowflakes on his wife’s eyelashes.

“A little bit.”

Lei Tie looked at the four roasted pheasants, tore off one of the drumsticks, and handed it to his wife.

Qin Mian held out the drumstick to Lei Tie’s mouth to let him take a bite before he ate it. Qin Mian nodded approvingly as he chewed, “It’s delicious. It’ll be good if I can drink wine.”

His original plan was to have only the four of them go hunting on a snowy day. When they got any prey, they would deal with it together, drink wine, and have barbecue such as roasted meat, mushrooms, potatoes, fish, and so on – it would certainly be delightful. He didn’t expect that the plan was disrupted by Emperor Xiaohui. There were so many people around that he didn’t feel comfortable at all.

Lei Tie perfectly understood his wife’s thoughts and comforted him, “There’ll be opportunities in the future.”

“En.” Qin Mian chewed the drumstick clean. His man’s craft was great. The bone and meat easily separated, and the meat was tender and fragrant – none got stuck in between the teeth.

“Old Dad.” Upon seeing that his Dad had already eaten, Lei Ruilin came over with an eager look.

Lei Tie tore off two drumsticks and handed them to his two sons.

Eunuch Li came out of Emperor Xiaohui’s tent holding a tray with four bowls of steaming soup in his hands. He looked around and upon seeing Qin Mian and his family, he walked over with a smile on his face.

“State Defender Duke, Lady of the State Defender Duke, Young Heir, and Duke of Anping County; His Majesty asked this servant to bring you soup. This is the soup that the imperial chef has just made. It’s hot. His Majesty exempts all of you from expressing gratitude.”

Lei Tie cupped his hands in obeisance toward Emperor Xiaohui’s tent and said, “Many thanks, Your Majesty, for the reward.”

Qin Mian received the tray.

Lei Ruilin smilingly tore off a drumstick and handed it to Eunuch Li, “Eunuch Li, please eat this. My Old Dad roasted it. It’s delicious.”

Eunuch Li received it with a beaming smile, “Oh, thank you, Duke of Anping County!”

Qin Mian had a taste of the soup. It was delicious and nutritious. He told Lei Tie and his two sons to finish the soup.

Although they deliberately stayed in a secluded place, they still attracted the attention of many ministers, who could not describe their mood with the word “envy” alone.

“That’s what one’s called to live one’s life.”

An old minister uttered those words as he lamented. Many people around him agreed with him.

During the three days of hunting, Qin Mian's family of four had a very happy time. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, as they promised, gave Emperor Xiaohui a share of the prey, which made Emperor Xiaohui laugh a peal of hearty laughter.

Many ministers did not understand why Emperor Xiaohui liked the twin boys so much. In terms of appearance, there were many more lovely children than Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin; in terms of intelligence, there were many smarter children than the young brothers. Or, the reason why Emperor Xiaohui preferred to be close to these two children was just to win over the State Defender Grand General? However, this matter was not so complicated. Emperor Xiaohui just liked Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin get along with him as the ordinary "Uncle". Only in front of these two children could he be as relaxed as an ordinary person.

After returning from the hunting ground, Qin Mian began to work hard for the New Year. Although there were servants in the household, some New Year's products still needed to be prepared in person, so that the New Year's celebration would be more enjoyable. For example, he made various kinds of snacks for his family.

On the morning of the 29th day of the 12th month, Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli arrived in the Capital with their families.

Lei Xiangzhi sent a person to the State Defender Duke Establishment to inform them.

Qin Mian's family tidied up and took the carriage to Lei Xiangzhi's house.

Lei Xiangyi's family included Lei Xiangyi, Qian Shi, their daughter Lei Xinxin, and son Niuniu. Lei Xiangli's family included Lei Xiangli, Sun Shi, and their son Zhuantou. There were seven people in total and with luggage, they came with three carriages. When Qin Mian's family arrived, they had neatly tidied up. The main hall was lively.

Lei Xiangzhi and Wei Shi had been guarding against Lei Daqiang saying some words without thinking again.

It was unknown whether Lei Daqiang was enlightened or had other plans, but his attitude toward Qin Mian's family was unexpectedly normal – neither cold nor warm.

Qin Mian was very relieved.

They had lunch at Lei Xiangzhi's home. No one caused any unpleasantness.

In the twinkling of an eye, the Lunar New Year ushered in. The Qin Mian family was as busy as before. Qin Mian had many strange ideas. The entertainment programs of the family were very rich and delightful.

On the first day of the Lunar New Year, the civil and military officials and the mandated ladies entered the palace to pay the New Year's greeting. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin got many good gifts.

Starting from the third day, people went to relatives' and friends' homes one by one to celebrate the New Year according to the close or distant relationship with the relatives and friends. One could not do without receiving and presenting gifts.

On this third day, the three Lei brothers and their families paid the New Year's visit to Qin Mian's home. Qin Mian generously gave all the young people a longevity lock worth 5 taels of silver and a red envelope sealed with 20 taels of silver. It was also considered as compensation for not being able to entertain Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli's families to have a good time in the Capital.

On the fourth day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie visited Lei Xiangzhi's home. They didn't take Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin with them as they worried that something unpleasant would happen.

What happened later made Qin Mian admire his foresight.

As expected, Lei Daqiang couldn't settle down. It turned out that when Lei Tie became the State Defender Duke, he had always worried about it. When Lei Tie and Qin Mian came back from the battlefield, even Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin both gained titles. In terms of rank and even status, they were higher than Lei Xiangzhi. How could Lei Daqiang be at ease?

At first, everyone sat around the table as they ate, drank, talked, and laughed. The atmosphere was very pleasant. Suddenly, Lei Daqiang demanded Lei Tie and Qin Mian to use their connections to upgrade Lei Xiangzhi's rank. It was not difficult for Qin Mian and Lei Tie to do it with their status, but how could Lei Xiangzhi not be embarrassed by Lei Daqiang's words? It was like Lei Xiangzhi couldn't get promoted if he didn't find connections. But the fact was, Lei Xiangzhi was a man with real talent and practical ability. Moreover, even if Lei Tie and Qin Mian didn't take the initiative to find connections for Lei Xiangzhi, the other officials gave him fewer obstacles and more opportunities since he was the younger brother of the State Defender Duke – it was a matter of time before he got promoted.

As soon as Lei Daqiang's words came out, Lei Xiangzhi's face turned dreadfully pale. Anger, disgrace, shame, and indignant intricately brewed in his eyes, but he eventually hid them with rationality.

It was the first time Qin Mian saw his face looked so unsightly, which showed that this gentle and refined young man was really angry.

In order to avoid awkwardness and being affected, Qin Mian quickly found an excuse to drag Lei Tie and ran away.

Lei Ruilin, who competed with his Gege on the martial arts field, asked Qin Mian with a puzzled face, "Dad, what are you doing? Why are you lurking and sneaking around like a ghost?"

"Lei Ruilin, is that how to talk to your Dad?" Lei Tie had a wooden face.

Lei Ruilin quickly restrained his expression, clasped his hands in obeisance, and solemnly asked, "Dad, what are you doing? Why do you look like running for your life?"

Qin Mian raised his hand and flicked his son's forehead, "Stinky boy! Your Dad, I, like walking like that – can't I?"

Lei Ruilin pitifully covered his forehead, "Can~~"

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On the fifth day, Qin Wencai paid a visit to the State Defender Duke Establishment and told Qin Mian and Lei Tie the inside story of Qin Mian's disappearance and the fate of Qin Jian. Qin Jian was still locked up in the Sky Prison¹ – he couldn't come out in this life. In order to give Qin Mian an account, Qin Wencai crossed out the name of Qin Jian in the family genealogy, namely drove him out of the Qin family.

Qin Wencai asked Qin Mian to acknowledge his ancestry and return to his clan, but Qin Mian declined. It was unknown what Qin Wen thought but he surprisingly didn't insist on it. He just said that it was alright long as Qin Mian was happy. He left after chatting with Lei Tie for nearly an hour.

Qin Mian asked Lei Tie what they had talked about.

Lei Tie did not hide from him. It was simply Qin Wencai feeling sorry to Qin Mian and telling something about Qin Mian before he was 12 years old. Besides that, he warned Lei Tie that if he was not good to Qin Mian, the Qin family would take Qin Mian away.

It could be seen that Qin Wencai really loved his legitimate son. Qin Mian felt that it was the right choice not to acknowledge the family. At the worst, if the Qin family was in trouble, he and Lei Tie would help them – it could be regarded as repaying the favor of using the original owner's body.

On the 6th day of the 1st month, the emperor began to write his first work and resumed to hold court. First, he dealt with First Prince Chen Chuang.

The case of the First Prince involved the honor of the imperial family. Hence, when he dealt with it, he only said that the First Prince had committed the crime of treason without mentioning the matter of collusion with the enemy. In the end, Chen Chuang was locked up in the First Prince

Establishment and could only live under surveillance day and night, never leaving the house for life.

The second important thing was to discuss how to fight for the best interests of Great Xia in the negotiation with Tuluo. In the 4th month at the latest, when spring came and ice defrosted, Tuluo would send a delegation to Great Xia.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had made up their mind to resign when the negotiation with Tuluo was settled. Though, it could be difficult.

Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli's families returned home after spending the Lantern Festival in the Capital. Qin Mian prepared four carriages full of special local products for them. Besides giving them, it was also to give the villagers in the village who had a good relationship with his family.

Surprisingly, Lei Daqiang and Wei Shi also went back to Green Mountain Village with them.

Qin Mian was surprised and asked Lei Xiangli about that. He found out that Lei Xiangzhi and Lei Daqiang had a fight and completely fell out. Lei Xiangzhi made it clear to Lei Daqiang that if he was willing to stay in Green Mountain Village honestly, he would give him 100 taels of silver to support him every year. If Lei Daqiang still wanted to stay in the Capital, he would only give 2 taels of silver a month henceforth. Besides that, he shouldn't think of getting a copper coin.

Neither of the two options Lei Daqiang wanted to choose. Lei Xiangzhi set up a situation to have Lei Daqiang made a mistake. He was arrested by the patrolling soldiers and thrown into prison.

Only then Lei Daqiang realized that he had already frozen his youngest son's heart. With Wei Shi's persuasion on the side, he had to choose the first option.

Wei Shi now regretted marrying Lei Daqiang. It was not a problem for Lei Daqiang to be contented or lazy. The problem was that he was too stupid that he pushed his two most promising sons farther and farther away. If Lei

Daqiang knew how to win over his two sons, he would not come to this end.

In Qin Mian's words, it was precise that a boneheaded teammate could do you more harm than the most formidable opponent.

Less than three days after they left, Lei Daqiang and his party came back in a messy appearance. Unexpectedly, they met robbers on the way. Lei Daqiang was petrified and stupefied. Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli had no other choice and could only send him and Wei Shi with their two children back.

Lei Xiangzhi found a famous doctor to treat Lei Daqiang. He learned that Lei Daqiang was really stupefied. The possibility of recovery in the future was only 50%. Lei Xiangzhi couldn't convince himself. At that moment, there was no sense of relief. In the past four years in the Capital, he was more tired than the past ten years of staying up late to study hard. Now, he felt liberated.

Wei Shi also seemed to take off a heavy burden. Lei Daqiang's stupefaction was the best result for her. As long as she maintained the relationship with Lei Xiangzhi and found a chance to mend the relationship with Lei Tie's family in the future, her son and daughter would have a bright future.

Since then, Lei Daqiang could only live like an overgrown baby and wouldn't give anyone any more unpleasanties.

Qin Mian didn't feel a wee of sympathy for him at all. He only lamented with a sentence: "Sure enough, a scourge lasts for thousands of years²."

The End

Not really. There are 20 more chappies. The number of people bookmarked this is the same as the number of chapters ~~if I'm not wrong~~ la.

[collapse] Footnotes

1. 天牢 often refers to the prison set up in the Capital under the direct control of the imperial court. Different from the 地牢 [literal translation is Land Prison] (cell below the ground – dungeon), it refers to the cell above the ground, where the felons are held.
2. There's a saying: A good person won't live long, a scourge lasts for thousands of years.

Chapter 201: Tender One's Resignation

201 – Tender One's Resignation

Years hurried away – time passed quickly like a white foal's shadow across a crevice.

In the mid-third of the 3rd month, the news that the Tuluo envoy had already set out reached the Capital – they would arrive in the mid-third of the 4th month.

It was probably to express the sincerity of Tuluo or that the Tuluo emperor was not reassured by others so that this time, it was surprisingly the Tuluo emperor, Emperor Renguang, who came out in person.

Emperor Renguang was similar in age to Emperor Xiaohui, but he was not as good as Emperor Xiaohui in terms of maintenance – he looked distinctly older than Emperor Xiaohui. However, he was tall and strong with a body as tough as nails. Only based on the outer appearance, he looked more like a general. The envoy's cavalcade was extremely grand. Emperor Renguang's imperial carriage was gilded with gold and silver with a quail egg-sized gem also hung on the four eaves of the roof every few inches. Under the warm spring sunshine, the resplendent dazzle could blind people's eyes. More than that, a rank of 2000 people, all of which were soldiers, rode on tall horses and looked very imposing.

Qin Mian, who had altered his appearance, was behind the crowd. He put his arms around Lei Tie's waist and whispered in his ear, "I think Emperor Renguang is a big-stupid-c*nt. Isn't he plainly saying to His Majesty, 'come and kill me, come and kill me'?"

The smile in Lei Tie's eyes thickened – he extremely loved his wife's high-spirited appearance. “En, he's stupid.”

Inside the imperial carriage, Emperor Renguang put on a gentle smile as he sneakily looked at the people of Great Xia cheering on both sides of the street. He was secretly puzzled. It was said that the people of Great Xia would throw rotten vegetable leaves and smash fruit and eggs at the loathsome people. He had been prepared for it. Hence, he had people changed the muslin hanging around the carriage with solid boards. He didn't expect that it was unnecessary. Surprisingly, the people of Great Xia were so happy with their arrival.

He didn't know that in the past two days, news had spread among the people that His Majesty the Emperor would certainly *peel off the skin* of the Tuluo emperor in this negotiation. So of course, the people were happy!

Emperor Renguang, who had been sitting on the throne for 30 years, was certainly not a fool. He sent people to inquire about the situation in the Capital two days in advance, lest they were unable to deal with unexpected incidents. But he did not know that this was the Capital – the territory of Emperor Xiaohui. Except for the secrets of Qin Mian's family, almost any disturbance or trouble was under the control of Emperor Xiaohui. What Emperor Renguang's people could or couldn't hear was controlled by him. One had to say that as an emperor, Emperor Xiaohui's ability was indeed not bad.

Qin Mian looked at another luxury carriage behind the imperial carriage and said to Lei Tie, “Look at the appearance and decoration of that carriage. It should be a female visitor inside.”

When a young man at the side heard what he said, he spontaneously interjected, “There are even eight palace maids beside the carriage. Is it the Western Barbarian's princess? Western Barbarian brings her to unite by marriage?”

This statement immediately aroused many people's agreement.

“I guess it is!”

When the Tuluo cavalcade was over, the civilians gradually dispersed, but they still talked about the fact that the Tuluo emperor actually came out in person. The whole Capital, from the high officials of the imperial court to the staff of teahouses, all talked about it.

After watching the excitement, Qin Mian and Lei Tie slowly walked home. Before they entered the entrance gate, they heard the sound of the horse's hooves quickly approaching. They turned around and saw Chen Mufeng galloping on his horse.

“*Shu—*”

Qin Mian asked, “What’s the matter? *Spring breeze has obtained its wish that the horse’s hooves are swift?*”¹

“Qin Mian!” Chen Mufeng jumped off the horse and held Qin Mian’s shoulders in excitement. “My mother, my birth mother, is pregnant, for more than two months!”

Without an expression, Lei Tie flicked away Chen Mufeng’s arms and simultaneously pulled his wife back to distance him from Chen Mufeng.

The corner of Qin Mian’s lips curved and he leaned against Lei Tie.

Chen Mufeng didn’t mind. He sincerely said, “Brother, thank you!”

It was better to have the formal consort gave birth to Imperial Prince Ming’s son. First of all, Chen Mufeng naturally preferred the formal consort to the two side consorts, which was his birth mother. Secondly, if the little brother Chen was the legitimate son, his future identity could be higher. Back then, after Imperial Prince Ming’s body was well nurtured, Princess Consort Ming could not get pregnant for a while. Later, Qin Mian prescribed medicine for her for a month after taking her pulse. Only then her body was nursed back to health. Now, good news had finally come out.

“Congratulations!” Qin Mian was also happy for Chen Mufeng that he teased, “Now, Zhangsun He has to give me the most substantial gift.”

Chen Mufeng laughed despite himself, but after laughing, there were some concerns, “I’m afraid, it’s not necessarily a younger brother.”

Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder, “Don’t worry. Now, both Imperial Prince Ming and Princess Consort Ming have a health that is equivalent to that of 35 years old. Even if this baby is a daughter, they can beget another.”

Chen Mufeng nodded and took the initiative to say, “My father is also very happy. He relented the affairs of me and Zhangsun He. He even comforted me that if this baby is a daughter, he’ll have another one.”

At this time, another fast horse came. Because the street was spacious enough, it didn’t bother the pedestrians.

It was Zhangsun He who came.

“Mufeng!”

“What are you doing here?” The smile on Chen Mufeng’s face had yet faded.

Zhangsun He took his hand and said, “I, I, I already knew about your family’s affairs. I came to thank the State Defender Duke and his Lady.”

It was rare for this man to stammer with excitement. Qin Mian and Chen Mufeng burst out laughing.

When Chen Mufeng finished laughing, he looked at Zhangsun He in suspicion. “It wasn’t long since I knew of this; how did you know?”

Zhangsun He squeezed his hand. “I didn’t put my man in the princely establishment, but I got a guy in the store opposite. When he saw your steward go to the direction of the drugstore with a happy face, he guessed that there was good news.”

Chen Mufeng saw that Zhangsun He really cared about him. He softly snorted and didn’t inquire further.

Zhangsun He said to Qin Mian and Lei Tie, “I came in a hurry today, so I didn’t prepare for anything. Mufeng and I will invite you to drink some other day.”

“Deal.”

The negotiation between Great Xia and Tuluo was a matter of the two emperors and also the civilian court officials. It had nothing to do with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They only attended a few banquets, eating and drinking.

Due to Emperor Xiaohui’s tough attitude and the Tuluo emperor’s extreme unwillingness, the negotiation went on very hard. Until the first ten-day of the 5th month, Emperor Renguang worried that his princes would be uneasy if he did not return to Tuluo, so he had to loosen his mouth and ceded the four big cities near the border of the two countries to Great Xia, as well as compensated one billion taels of silver in three years. Otherwise, Great Xia didn’t mind directing troop movements to the west again.

Emperor Renguang really feared Lei Tianren. Under the circumstances that Tuluo lost three defender generals, Lei Tianren might directly attack the imperial city of Tuluo.

Besides that, Tuluo’s Princess Ziluo stayed as the side consort of the Fourth Prince conferred by Emperor Xiaohui.

On the same day, Emperor Xiaohui ordered people to distribute the imperial announcement which stated that a part of the indemnity payment from Tuluo would be taken out as the compensation money for the dead soldiers’ bereaved families.

After the news came out from the palace, the whole Capital was as lively as the New Year. The winehouses under Chen Mufeng’s name took the lead in giving all customers a 70% discount. Other businesses, whether they were winehouses, teahouses, grain stores... all of them gave a discount, no matter it was 70%, 20%, or 10%. Be it the bosses, the customers, or the shop assistants, everyone was happy and proud that Great Xia had the upper hand – they were proud to be a citizen of Great Xia. Even people who were

usually reluctant to spend money to eat in restaurants were willing to call on three or five friends to celebrate.

Two days later, the Tuluo envoy set out on its way home.

The civilians in the Capital bid them farewell with the uncles of the lion dance team banged the big cymbals.

Emperor Renguang looked at their happy faces only to feel offended, but he had nothing to say besides sighing.

Both Qin Mian and Lei Tie were relieved that the negotiation was successfully completed.

After Qin Mian quietly sold the drugstore and the silverware shop, he and Lei Tie finished their works as if nothing had happened every day. No one else could figure out that they were about to resign.

By early of the 6th month, when it was estimated that the Tuluo envoy had returned to Tuluo, Lei Tie and Qin Mian went to the palace together to seek an audience with Emperor Xiaohui.

“Reporting, Your Majesty. State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke asks for an audience.”

Emperor Xiaohui was very puzzled. He put down the memorial and said, “Announce.”

“Announcing the presence of State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke~~”

“Paying respects to Your Majesty. May Your Majesty live long, absolutely long live!”

“You may rise.” Emperor Xiaohui asked with a smile, “For you two to come together is unexpected – what’s the reason?”

Lei Tie went straight to the point, “Reporting, Your Majesty. Both of your subjects came to tender our resignation.”

Eunuch Li, who was ready to go forward to pour tea for Emperor Xiaohui, staggered and fell on the ground upon hearing what was said. He quickly got up and knelt, “Beg Your Majesty’s forgiveness for your servant has failed etiquette.”

His drooping face was full of shock and disbelief. The emperor had bestowed honor and favor on the four members of the State Defender Duke’s family, who were now the most glorious people in the Capital with exception of the emperor. He even heard that many ministers were thinking about marrying their daughters to the two little gongzis of the State Defender Duke Establishment! It was absolutely unexpected that the State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke wanted to resign at this time.

Emperor Xiaohui was also shocked. His mouth involuntarily opened wide and yet he couldn’t speak for a long time. Emperor Xiaohui knew Lei Tie. Since Lei Tie requested to resign, it showed that he was really determined. Because of this, he believed all the more that Lei Tie was disinterested in power and fame. Such a person was more worthy of his trust – he would not be willing to let go. Of course, that was just one of the reasons. Another reason was that, before the battle with Tuluo, Great Xia had not been in a battle state for a long time, so few generals in the court could really be of great use – Lei Tie was the reassurance of Emperor Xiaohui. The third reason was related to Qin Mian. Qin Mian had excellent medical skills and was a well-deserved highly-skilled doctor. The imperial palace was full of people with shady means. With Qin Mian being there, Emperor Xiaohui was more at ease.

Such two people, how could Emperor Xiaohui be willing to let go?

Footnotes

1. From Meng Jiao’s Upon Passing the Imperial Examination (my attempted translation)

Chapter 202: Emperor Xiaohui's Condition

202 – Emperor Xiaohui's Condition

Qin Mian and Lei Tie knew that Emperor Xiaohui would not let them go easily, but they had to go.

Emperor Xiaohui soon calmed down, “If my dear subject Lei and your (honorable) lady have suffered any sort of injustice, please don’t hesitate to tell Zhen. You can’t joke about this ‘resignation’ matter.”

Eunuch Li on the ground was covered in sweat, praying that Lei Tie would *push the boat along the current*¹ and take back what he had just said.

Lei Tie firmly said, “Your Majesty, your subject I and my wife have decided.”

The atmosphere in the imperial study was frozen for a moment.

At this time, outside the door came a nervous voice, “Reporting, Your Majesty. Prime Minister Wen has something urgent to seek an audience.”

“Announce!”

Prime Minister Wen strode in with a rare dignified and anxious face.

Emperor Xiaohui frowned.

Prime Minister Wen noticed that Eunuch Li was profusely sweating while on his knees, the State Defender Duke couple looked very serious, and

Emperor Xiaohui's face also appeared very unsightly. He was so surprised that he didn't care to explore and strode to the front of the imperial table.

Emperor Xiaohui waved his hand to stop him from saluting. "Forego the formalities. What happens for my dear subject to be in such a hurry?"

Prime Minister Wen said with a heavy tone, "Reporting, Your Majesty. Your subject has just received an urgent report from Lingzhou. A few days ago, there was a big earthquake in Kui County, Lingzhou!"

"What!" Emperor Xiaohui was shocked, "What's the situation?"

Prime Minister Wen presented the memorial [report] with both hands and explained, "According to the statistics of the local officials, at least 50,000 people have been missing or injured, and 80% of the houses in the county have collapsed. The local officials quickly responded and immediately dispatched soldiers to the rescue, but the situation is not optimistic."

Eunuch Li quickly scrambled to take the memorial and passed it on to the emperor.

After reading the memorial, Emperor Xiaohui's expression looked profound as he considered it a lot in an instant. Needless to say, the earthquake was bound to cause huge losses, but the time and place of this earthquake were very unfavorable. Shortly after the end of the battle between Great Xia and Tuluo, with a little carelessness, it might be used by observant people who wanted to make an issue of it. For example, spreading the rumor that Emperor Xiaohui was not protected by Heaven might cause civil unrest. In history, similar things were not uncommon.

"Your Majesty, what should we do now?" Prime Minister Wen anxiously said, "Kui County is at a peculiar location. The longer the action of the imperial court is delayed, the more unfavorable the situation will be."

Emperor Xiaohui pondered for a long time. When his keen eyes passed over Qin Mian and Lei Tie, his expression suddenly relaxed. He waved to Prime Minister Wen.

“Zhen knew. My dear subject Wen, go to the side hall first to take a seat.”

“Yes.”

After Prime Minister Wen left, Emperor Xiaohui finally noticed that Eunuch Li was still kneeling on the ground, “Li Fushou, get up.”

“Thank you, Your Majesty.” Eunuch Li quickly stood up and kneaded his knees in secret.

Looking at Qin Mian and Lei Tie, Emperor Xiaohui said in a deep voice, “State Defender Duke and Lady of the State Defender Duke, Great Xia can be considered strong, but there are still many hidden dangers. You have heard what Prime Minister Wen said just now. Even so, are you still asking to resign?”

Lei Tie cupped his hand and said, “Why don’t Your Majesty think about it from another angle? Only when the two of us leave, can others have the chance to grow up.”

Qin Mian also said, “Your Majesty, the medical skills of the imperial doctors in the Imperial Institute of Medicine are better qualified – your humble subject [I] is in fact, dispensable. Besides, your humble subject [I] has sorted out the prescription of Qingli pill and handed it over to the Administrative Assistant of Imperial Institute of Medicine.”

Emperor Xiaohui frowned in disappointment, “It seems that you have made up your mind... You can resign if you want, but Zhen has one condition.”

Qin Mian had a bad feeling.

Lei Tie said, “Please speak, Your Majesty.”

Emperor Xiaohui stood up. With both hands on his back, he walked out slowly from behind the imperial table and down the steps.

He said in a solemn tone, “Kui County of Lingzhou is near the border of Great Xia and Tuluo. So, why has Tuluo never chosen to attack Great Xia from Kui County since ancient times? That’s because Kui County’s

mountain range is overlapped and the mountain path is rugged, which can be said to be a natural barrier of Great Xia. Since the earthquake occurred, Zhen worries that the people in Kui County will choose to move instead of rebuilding their homeland. If so, it is tantamount to having the gateway of the country opens wide – needless to say about the consequences.

Therefore, Zhen wants you two to go to Kui County at once and rebuild Kui County in three years at most. As long as you can do this, Zhen will allow you to resign. How about it?”

Qin Mian inwardly cursed Emperor Xiaohui for being an old fox. He exchanged a look with Lei Tie and then asked, “Venture to ask, Your Majesty, how many times has an earthquake occurred in Kui County?”

Emperor Xiaohui looked at him in surprise. After a pause, he replied, “This is the second time in ten years.”

Qin Mian was shocked. There were two earthquakes in just ten years, but Emperor Xiaohui still didn’t approve of the civilian migration. This practice made him feel bitterly disappointed.

Emperor Xiaohui didn’t seem to care what he thought. After returning to the imperial table, he had calmed down. He took a sip of tea and asked in a low voice, “Have you considered it well?”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie look at each other.

Lei Tie said under his breath, “Listen to you.”

The corner of Emperor Xiaohui’s lips twitched. He pretended not to hear it.

Qin Mian thought for a moment, then asked, “Venture to ask, Your Majesty, if both of us find a more suitable location to guard the border nearby, is it possible to migrate Kui County?”

“Yes.” Emperor Xiaohui reminded, “But, in this way, three years is not enough.”

Qin Mian inwardly cursed him for being brazen.

“Good. We accept this condition. ”

Emperor Xiaohui nodded, “Zhen is going to draw up the decree. You can set out as soon as possible.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie went out of the Palace separately. Lei Tie went to the military camp; Qin Mian went to drop his two sons out of school. All that was left was some trivialities.

For the convenience of Lei Tie and Qin Mian, Lei Tie’s identity as the State Defender Duke and the State Defender Grand General was preserved; Emperor Xiaohui dismissed Qin Mian from the official post in the Imperial Institute of Medicine and appointed him the new magistrate of Kui County.

As soon as the imperial edict was issued, the people in the Capital were in an uproar. No matter how capable Qin Mian was, his main identity was the “Lady/wife” of the State Defender Duke. How did he become a magistrate?

When the imperial decree that stated the emperor ordered Qin Mian and Lei Tie to rebuild Kui County was out, people suddenly realized: So that’s how matters stand.

Qin Mian was very interested in being a magistrate. He was also a man. Not to mention doing a meritorious service, he also wished to devote himself to work and make an all-out effort. He could develop Green Mountain Village, so he might also have the ability to develop a county.

It took Qin Mian and Lei Tie a day to deal with everything in the Capital. They took their two sons, a wolf, a bear, a golden eagle, nine armed servants, and ten thousand elite soldiers to set out. It was good to have a magical space. Gold, silver, pearls, and other treasures, as well as the gold and other rewards given by Emperor Xiaohui, were put in the space – there was no need to use carriages to carry them that would attract people’s eyes.

Steward Fu and Aunt Fu were old. They stayed to take care of the State Defender Duke Establishment.

On the day of departure, Chen Mufeng, Zhangsun He, Zhangsun Hong, and Lei Xiangzhi's family all came to see them off.

The “cry baby” Zhangsun Hong's tears flowed like a stream. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were both moved and amused. They simply entrusted him the two pots of shy grass which were gifted by Chen Mufeng to show that their friendship was still there. Only then Zhangsun Hong stopped crying and smiled.

Emperor Xiaohui stood in the crowd in casual clothes and watched Qin Mian and Lei Tie go away.

Imperial Prince Ming sighed under his breath, “Elder Brother, I truly didn't expect you to let them go.”

Emperor Xiaohui said with a faint smile, “Zhen—I certainly can't bear it, but what Lei Tie said also has some truth. With them here, no one else has a chance to stand out. I just hope their ability can make some people feel more sense of crisis.”

Imperial Prince Ming slightly nodded, “Elder Brother's words are reasonable.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie rode at the top front – one was high-spirited and the other was majestic-looking, causing the pretty faces of the girls tinted in red, who then became more daring to throw down the handkerchiefs smoked in fragrance from the second floor [of some buildings].

The fan in Qin Mian's hand seamlessly flapped several times; the handkerchiefs fluttered leisurely to the rear of the procession.

Qin Mian casually glanced at the crowd and saw Qin Wencai standing side by side with a middle-aged woman – both had eyes on him. Qin Wencai's eyes were red while the woman had tears in her eyes.

Qin Mian was taken aback. He put on a faint smile and slightly nodded [to them].

The woman's tears flowed even rapidly. She waved with the look of blessing and relief.

The procession began to speed up when they got out of the Capital.

Several horses in the household had been raised with the spiritual spring water for a long time – they were strong, healthy, robust, and swift. They ran fast and steadily as they dragged two carriages.

All the ten thousand elite soldiers were chosen by Lei Tie himself. They were all his followers who were convinced of him.

They spent the first daylight hurrying all the way.

After sunset, the procession stopped and camped in an open space. The soldiers had their own division of labor. In a short time, the campfires in the camp lit up, and the smell of rice-flour noodles floated along with the evening wind, shrouding the whole camp.

The skills of White Spot, Golden Fur, and Golden Eagle were particularly noticeable at this time. They ran/flew into the distant mountain forests and brought back more than a dozen prey after several trips back and forth.

Qin Mian left only half a deer for his family and asked Lei-Qin Zhong to bring the rest to the soldiers.

The soldiers had heard that the general's wife was approachable. Now that they saw it with their own eyes, they thought so, too. They even felt a little bit closer with Qin Mian.

While waiting for the meal to be ready, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, like birds out of a cage, ran with White Spot and Golden Eagle into the woods to play. It seemed that Golden Fur was quite fond of fireflies. It stood alone in the distance, with a pair of innocent little eyes chasing the luminous spots. After aiming, it reached out its claws and accurately grabbed them. It carefully stared at them for a while before letting them go. Grabbed and let go.....

Not to mention them, even Qin Mian felt relaxed after he left the Capital. He was dressed in white and sat on the branch of a tree, holding a green flute in his hand. The melodious sound of the flute floated in the woods, which made people feel like they were coming out for sightseeing.

“My Lord and Lady, there is a river not far away.” Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun came back with sweat, holding torches.

“Just in time, I can give the two ‘little monkeys’ a good wash later.” Qin Mian helplessly looked at the two sons who madly ran around.

Thanks for the treats! 😊

Footnotes

1. make use of an opportunity to achieve one's end; make use of the favorable current situation to push matters through with little effort

Chapter 203: Arrive in Kui County

203 – Arrive in Kui County

Lei Ruilin's hearing was sharp. He laughed as he shouted, "Gege and I are not monkeys, Dad!"

"If not monkeys, then what are you?" Qin Mian easily jumped from the tree, fell quietly beside Lei Tie, and took the cup Lei Tie handed over.

Lei Ruilin's eyeballs shifted around and he pulled his Gege to go over. "If Gege and I are monkeys, you and Old Dad—Hehe!"

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows. He got interested in these words.

Lei Ruilin lay on Qin Mian's back and leaned close to his ear as he said in a low voice, "Gege and I have known for a long time that you gave birth to us, Dad."

"Pfft—" the water Qin Mian had yet swallow gushed out. Flabbergasted, he stared at his son.

"Don't worry, Dad. Didi and I won't tell anyone." Qin Ruiqi patted Qin Mian on the shoulder, comfortingly.

Lei Tie lowered his head; the corner of his lips obviously curved.

"Lei Tie! Manage your sons!" roared Qin Mian with gritted teeth as he suddenly jumped up. He kicked Lei Tie's foot hard. His face was very red, unknown whether it was the reflection of the fire.

"En." Lei Tie nodded. He easily pulled the two sons over, put them over his knees, and slapped them on the butt once. Yet, not even a sound was heard.

He then looked up at Qin Mian, expressing: Wife, I've managed them.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin snickered and hastily ran away.

Qin Mian crossed his arms in front of his chest and looked down at the innocent-faced man. After a good while, he gave a wee of a smile before he went to a tree not far away and sat down against the trunk.

After Lei Tie was done roasting the venison, he cut it into slices and served it on the plate. "Wife, you can eat it."

Qin Mian went over, took the plate, and ate with relish.

Lei Tie was disappointed when he didn't hear his wife saying it was delicious after waiting for a while.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin ran over and each got a plate.

"Old Dad's roast is truly delicious." Lei Ruilin was always straightforward.

Qin Ruiqi nodded in agreement.

"Right, Dad?" Lei Ruilin turned to ask Qin Mian.

Qin Mian nodded and said nothing.

Lei Tie did not feel good and asked, "Is it enough?"

Qin Mian nodded, still not making a sound.

Lei Tie immediately understood that his wife was angry.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at each other. They were not used to their Dad not talking.

Lei Tie looked at Qin Ruiqi, then at Lei Ruilin, "I'm the one who gave birth."

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were dumbfounded.

“Pwahahaha...” Qin Mian laughed and patted his two sons on the shoulder. “Now you understand, who is the boss in our family?”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at each other with a smile. They put down the plates, knelt one knee, and cupped their fists toward Qin Mian, “Paying respect to Boss!”

“Don’t stand on ceremony.” Again, Qin Mian was amused by his two sons.

Although the people sitting a little far away could not hear what the family of four was saying, they could see. Infected by the family, they had a faint smile on their faces.

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Lingzhou was a little south to the west of Great Xia, not close to the capital. Relying on Qin Mian’s spiritual spring water, the party of humans and horses hardly stopped in the daytime and entered Lingzhou in less than eight days.

The prefect of Lingzhou, Prefect Cai, got the news earlier and led the officials of all ranks to welcome them at the gate of the city. The family of four all had their own ranks, so no one dared to neglect them.

Lei Tie always disliked dealing with officials. He only exchanged greetings and ordered Prefect Cai to take them to Kui County at once. It took them two days to get to Kui County. When they got there, they could see nothing but ruins.

The critical care provided in Kui County was timely. At least, Qin Mian found a lot of temporary sheds built by the roadside to act as food relief centers in a glance. Practically, all the victims looked to be dressed in miserable rags and tatters. Although they were a little thin, their complexion looked pretty good.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie walked around to make sure that there was no problem for the time being. Then they told the soldiers to camp on the spot first, and then had a good meal and a rest.

Prefect Cai brought Qin Mian's family into an intact house. The house was built of stone bricks and therefore survived the earthquake.

"State Defender Duke, County Magistrate Qin, Young Heir, and Duke of Anping County, please wait a bit. I've ordered people to prepare the meal."

"Sorry for the trouble, Prefect Cai." Qin Mian said, "Prefect Cai doesn't have to be formal. Just call our two sons 'little gongzi', lest they become conceited."

Lei Ruilin said with a smile, "En. Prefect Cai can also directly call us 'Ruiqi' and 'Ruilin'."

Prefect Cai followed the well-intentioned advice like water flowing swiftly and smoothly downward, "Well then, I'll call you two 'little gongzi'."

Qin Mian said, "Prefect Cai, please, let's sit down and talk."

"Yes, please." Although Qin Mian was only a county magistrate, he still had another identity. Prefect Cai did not dare to slight him. After he made a gesture of "please", he sat down.

"Prefect Cai, what's the situation of Kui County now?" asked Qin Mian.

Prefect Cai sighed, "Now, all the people in the county depend on the grains transported from other places to survive. If this continues, the prefecture won't be able to support so many people. Moreover, because many fields have been destroyed, many people have set out to go to their relatives and friends in other places. What I'm most worried about is that it is summer – it's easy to trigger a plague with any carelessness."

Qin Mian had not carefully survey Kui County, so he could not say anything. He only said, "After lunch, I'd like to ask Prefect Cai to take us around." Naturally, he had no right to ask Prefect Cai to take them in person, but Lei Tie was here. Prefect Cai dared not to reject even if he wanted to.

"This is a matter within my duty."

Before long, the meal was served with two vegetarian dishes and two meat dishes of bacon fried with green pepper and potato stewed chicken. The people who cooked these had average craftsmanship, but Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not picky. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin had always been sensible – none of them complained and there was no waste of food.

Prefect Cai had a good impression of them. He thought to himself that it was no wonder the emperor trusted the State Defender Duke couple so much. He also heard that the emperor liked the twin sons of the State Defender Duke very much.

After lunch, Qin Mian told the two children to obediently stay in the black-brick house. He and Lei Tie followed Prefect Cai to leave. Incidentally, the former magistrate of Kui County was still alive, but seriously injured and unable to work. Thus, the handover was not urgent.

It was reasonable for Prefect Cai to worry. Some corpses under the bricks and stones had not been disposed of in time, so they had given off a foul smell. The county was dirty and chaotic everywhere; the sanitary conditions were obviously not up to standard. Due to the cracks in the ground, the water in the ponds and rivers had dried up, so the people didn't have much water to take a bath every day; the crops in the fields lacked water irrigation.....

Qin Mian was shocked by everything he saw. He said to Lei Tie, "A-Tie, it's not easy to clean up such a big place. I think we should consider the possibility of migrating Kui County first."

Lei Tie nodded.

Prefect Cai was flabbergasted. However, since the emperor entrusted Qin Mian with the task of rebuilding Kui County, there was no need for him to intervene.

Qin Mian pondered for a while before he said, "I'll make a prescription first, let people concoct the medicinal soup, and give everyone a bowl to increase immunity as prevention against plague."

Lei Tie said, “Since Prefect Cai is familiar with the situation here, leave this matter to him. We’re going further ahead.”

Prefect Cai naturally concurred with him.

After Qin Mian wrote the prescription, he gave Lei-Qin Zhong a small bottle of spiritual spring water and asked him to add two drops to all the medicinal pots. Then, he galloped away with Lei Tie.

As soon as they left everyone’s sight, Qin Mian and Lei Tie directly flew into the distance, overlooking the terrain around Kui County in mid-air.

The source of the earthquake was not far from Kui County. That was why it seriously affected Kui county. Fortunately, there were mountains all around and no other towns, otherwise, there would be more casualties.

Qin Mian looked into the distance. The plain less than 20 li [10km] away was the territory of Tuluo. From Kui County to the east, about 30 li, the terrain gradually changed and towns and villages were denser.

“No wonder Emperor Xiaohui said that Kui County is the gateway of Great Xia. Once Kui County is conquered, the people of Tuluo can indeed march in easily.”

Lei Tie nodded; his face tinged with faint grim, “In other words, it’s not appropriate to migrate Kui County to another place.”

Qin Mian frowned, “Yes. But there have been two earthquakes here within ten years. In the previous ten years, it probably happened, too. Do you want people to live here and wait for the next earthquake?”

Suddenly, Lei Tie said something puzzling, “These mountains don’t look like they cracked ten years ago.”

Qin Mian followed to look into the direction Lei Tie was looking at and nodded with approval. “True. This can be judged from the number of hundred-year-old trees on the mountains—do you mean to migrate Kui County to the mountains?” He looked at Lei Tie in disbelief.

Lei Tie nodded, "What's wrong with this?"

Qin Mian said, "Sure can, but it'll take a lot of time. We'll think about it later."

After returning to the county, Lei Tie sent several teams to look for water. He and Qin Mian had seen a river and a lake in the mountains when they were in the sky, but it was inconvenient to say so. They could only point out several different directions and send people to look for them. Later, he sent several teams to hunt in the mountains. According to the preliminary estimation, the number of people living in Kui County was about 30,000. With the addition of 10,000 elite soldiers consuming the grains sent by the prefectural government, the food was not enough at all.

Qin Mian drew the situation of the whole county in order to make a more comprehensive analysis.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were very good. After playing for a while, they went to take a nap. Now, they were sleeping soundly. White Spot and Golden Fur were on guard. Golden Eagle was nowhere to be found; it probably went to play in the mountains.

Chapter 204: Rebuilding Kui County

204 – Rebuilding Kui County

The river that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had discovered was a little far away; meanwhile, the lake was relatively near and was soon found.

When the civilians learned that there was a lake nearby where they could wash up, they didn't have to be urged by others and took the initiative to ask where the lake was. Lei Tie arranged a team to guide them and bring some water back by the way.

Qin Mian pondered for an afternoon before he decided to migrate Kui County, just beside the lake. Most of the civilians were farmers. Being close to the water source was convenient for irrigation. Afterward, they only needed to open up a large area of farmland.

Early the next morning, Qin Mian went to find the original county magistrate to take office. After he formally became the county magistrate, he changed into the county magistrate's suit – it made him look more handsome and awe-inspiring.

However, it was not the time to exchange feelings. The couple discussed and went into the work of rebuilding Kui County.

Qin Mian first asked people to gather all the civilians together and frankly said that he would migrate Kui County to a nearby lake. Some of the civilians were willing and some were unwilling. They were willing because Kui County was obviously a dangerous place – if they didn't move away, weren't they just waiting for the next earthquake? They were unwilling

because they had lived here for generations, hence, it was hard to leave their hometown.

Qin Mian, however, ignored their various opinions and straightforwardly said, “From today on, we will start rebuilding Kui County. All those willing to stay in Kui County will be divided into two teams – one team is responsible for making the road outside the mountain smoother and wider; the other team is responsible for opening up wasteland and building houses in the new Kui County. By then, the cultivated land will be distributed equally according to the headcount. Also, from today on, the implementation of three meals a day will be distributed according to work. That is to say, only when you work can you get food. You not only have enough food but also meat and vegetables. If you don’t work, you should find a way to solve the food problem yourself. As for those unwilling to leave, this official will give each person 2 taels of silver, and henceforth, you won’t have anything to do with Kui County.”

Due to the huge amount of compensation from Tuluo, Emperor Xiaohui granted Qin Mian a lot of relief money. Therefore, giving 2 taels for each person was not really much. However, it was not that Qin Mian wanted to be ruthless, but that he was confident that Kui County could be built better, so he hoped to keep people in such a way, so that they would not have to go far away to relatives and friends for shelters, relying on others’ charity. Secondly, some civilians were feudalistic and obstinate. It might be better to use this tough manner to frighten them than to waste time disputing and explaining to them. One had to know that delaying one day meant one day more of danger. If it rained, the situation would get worse. When Kui County was built, the civilians would naturally understand his good intentions.

Indeed, as soon as his voice fell, the civilians began to clamor. Most of them lost their loved ones in the earthquake, so they were already grieving. Now that the new county magistrate wanted to send them away with only 2 taels of silver, they felt angrier and dissatisfied. Some people even cursed him, dog official.

Lei Tie frowned and wanted to do something but was stopped by Qin Mian.

Qin Mian had expected this situation, but he didn't persuade them. He ordered several loud soldiers to shout out.

“Those who want to stay, come and line up. Get ready to work.”

Only a small part moved.

Qin Mian assigned tasks to them, completely unconcerned.

At noon, when no one prepared food for the protestors, they finally realized clearly what Qin Mian's identity was now – the county magistrate, which meant the parental official¹, as well as the Lady of the State Defender Duke and the Prefect Cai's escort! They were so flustered that they quickly found the soldiers brought by Lei Tie. They agreed to move and were willing to stay and work.

Of course, there were still people who didn't want to stay.

In order to prevent some people from cheating him out of money, Qin Mian also made it clear that those who left could come back only for the first ten days after leaving. While others could eat two steamed buns at each meal, including meat and vegetables, the returnees could only eat one steamed bun and drink a small bowl of soup at each meal.

It was true that some people were going to cheat him out of money first and leave for a few days before coming back and pretending that they hadn't found relatives. However, as soon as Qin Mian said that, they immediately gave up this idea and went to line up honestly.

Even so, a few people still chose to leave. Qin Mian didn't lie. In front of all the civilians, he asked Deputy General Cheng to give each person who wanted to leave 2 taels of silver. He wrote their names on the paper and asked them to stamp their thumbprints.

Only a few people left – a total of six families, adding up to less than 30 people. Qin Mian had people inquired thoroughly in secret, not only making sure that these six families had relatives in the prefectural capital, but also that the relatives would most likely be able to help them. Only then he was

relieved and asked people to secretly give 10 taels of silver to each family to ensure that they had enough travel expenses to reach their relatives.

These people realized that the new county magistrate was not as bad as they thought. They left with gratitude.

“To be rich, build the road first.” This sentence was true. Hence, Qin Mian arranged for one-third of the people in Kui County to build the road. For the time being, they first built a level dirt road. When the new Kui County was properly built, they would be reorganized to dig sand to lay the road or use bricks to pave the road. As for the remaining two-thirds of the manpower, one part was responsible for leveling the ground of the lakeside to facilitate building houses, while the other part was responsible for carrying usable bricks in the [ruined] county town to the lakeside.

Luckily, it was in ancient times. Most of the houses were one-floor, which was convenient for excavation. The civilians pulled farm tools out of the collapsed ruins and then threw themselves into work in a frenzy.

But of course, the 10,000 elite soldiers brought by Lei Tie were not idle. He sent a team of 500 people every day to hunt, improving the food for everyone. A small part was responsible for supervising the work to prevent the civilians from being lazy on purpose. The other part also helped to cut down trees, dig soil, and so on.

There were many children in the county. Qin Mian found four entry-level scholars among the civilians and arranged two rooms for them to teach the children to read and also prevent the working adults from worrying about them.

In this way, after Qin Mian’s careful arrangement, nearly no one in the county town was idle. Even the old women and old men, who couldn’t do physical labor, helped mend clothes, looked after the children between one to five years old, or dug wild vegetables.

Prefect Cai didn’t leave. He admired Qin Mian for arranging all the important things for the reconstruction of Kui County in less than three days. In the case of Kui County, he originally had the thought of “a wise

man looks after his own hide”. At this time, his mind suddenly *became intelligent at the approach of happiness* – he thought that he could never miss this opportunity. There was practically no problem with Qin Mian’s arrangement. It was a matter of time before Kui County was properly built. If he could help Qin Mian from time to time, Qin Mian and Lei Tie would certainly say a few good words for him in the accounts they gave the emperor. By that time, the distance from being promoted and gain wealth was not far away.

After he was convinced of this, he began to actively cooperate with Qin Mian’s work.

Qin Mian secretly sent someone to the prefectural capital to inquire about Prefect Cai’s character. Before the information came back, he arranged for Prefect Cai to be responsible for the road construction, mainly to supervise the road construction process and the laborers’ food to ensure the civilians were enthusiastic about the road construction and that they could eat enough every meal. Of course, he also arranged for Lei-Qin Jian and Lei-Qin Yuan to assist Prefect Cai. It was said to assist, but both parties understood that this was to prevent Prefect Cai from taking advantage of the opportunity to deduct the laborers’ food.

Prefect Cai didn’t mind that very much. Qin Mian didn’t know him, so it was not unusual to be on guard against him. He, Cai Yongxin, might not be a good official, but he would not steal food from the affected civilians.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were responsible for all the affairs of the new county. Qin Mian tried his best to recall the curved mould-board plough he had seen in his previous life. After few days of pondering, he asked the craftsmen to try making a few and eventually made the curved mould-board plough. The curved mould-board plough was composed of ploughshare, mould-board, heel, pressuring trowel, horizontal support, vertical support, beam, handle, regulator, hitch, and ploughing plate. The installation of a freely rotating ploughing plate at the thrush not only made the plough frame smaller and lighter but also made it easy to tune and turn. The operation was flexible and saved manpower and animal power.

Once the plough was produced, Prefect Cai was shocked. The plough with long straight beam, which was used by the civilians, was difficult to turn and laborious – extremely inefficient. How could it not be surprising that this curved mould-board plough only made a few changes on its foundation and could do half the work, twice the effect? If this plough was generalized to the whole country, would not the productivity level of Great Xia be improved? However, looking at Qin Mian, he didn't seem to realize the significance at all.

Before this, Qin Mian didn't have the “grand” idea of improving the productivity of Great Xia, so he didn't think about it. If not for the reconstruction of Kui County, he would still be unlikely to have this idea. Now though, he naturally knew the importance of the curved mould-board plough to the farmers, but he still refused Prefect Cai's suggestion to report the matter to the imperial court immediately. He dared to say that once Emperor Xiaohui learned about the plough, he would send high officials for an on-the-spot investigation. In Kui County, he and Lei Tie had the highest statuses. Therefore, no one would make indiscreet remark or fuss about the reconstruction of Kui County. It was unnecessary for any more high officials to come, which surely would hinder the progress.

Hence, his idea was not to tell the emperor about the new plough until all the land near Kui County was opened up for farming. Anyway, the civilians had used old plough for hundreds of years, so it didn't matter to wait for a few months.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had imperial edicts on them. Lei Tie also had the imperial sword² which allowed him to execute first and report later. Prefect Cai dared not oppose their unanimous decision.

Qin Mian promised Prefect Cai to record his contribution later, and so, Prefect Cai calmed down.

Thereupon, the curved mould-board plough was not mentioned in the accounts of Qin Mian and Prefect Cai to Emperor Xiaohui for the first report on the progress of the reconstruction of the new county.

With the curved mould-board plough, the progress of opening up the land was faster. The civilians looked at the square farmland by the lake increasing day by day, with heartfelt smiles hung on their faces and hope of life rekindled in their eyes.

At the lakeside, rows of houses had gradually taken shape. From a distance, they looked neatly arranged, much prettier than the old county.

Footnotes

1. officials who take parental care of the people: throughout history a common generic reference to officials in charge of local units of territorial administration, most particularly District Magistrates but sometimes including even the heads of Prefectures
2. imperial sword gives the bearer arbitrary powers / in fiction, the Chinese version of 007's license to kill

Chapter 205: Distribute the Houses and Farmland!

205 — Distribute the Houses and Farmland!

At present, the most important thing was to solve the accommodation problem of nearly 30,000 people. It was impossible to build the houses in such high-grade. Therefore, except for the county government office and the school, the structure of each house was the same — it was a three-large-room house. Despite that, enough space was left behind each house so that after the house was distributed, if the householder had enough financial resources, they could add or renovate the house with their own money. All the houses were sturdy with no cheat in work or cut down on materials.

When all the farmland and houses had been taken care of, the first cultivated land could not be left unattended for at least another three to four months. This season was not suitable for planting wheat. After asking the local farmers, Qin Mian had people buy seeds suitable for planting in that season from other counties, including sweet potato, corn, cucumber, water spinach, wax gourd, celery, tomato, pepper, and so on. The planting was done on a proportional base of 3 mu of corn field, 1 mu of sweet potato field, and 1 mu of vegetable field in every 5 mu of farmland. *The mountain is high, the emperor is far away*. Having nothing to worry about the imperial court finding any abnormality, he and Lei Tie quietly used some spiritual spring water to improve the soil quality, at least to ensure that all the seeds could grow smoothly.

In the beginning, the civilians had a very bad impression of the new magistrate. After a period of time, they discovered that the new magistrate truly did things for them. They respected him from the bottom of their hearts and worked harder and more willingly.

During the day, the civilians worked together, and at night, they rested in the houses that had been built. Perhaps it was because they had experienced the great disaster together that they got along very well. Even if there were some big or small contradictions, they could quickly let go of their heart knots after being advised by others.

Great things might be done by mass effort. In the middle of the 7th month, the road from the new Kui County to the outside of the mountain was completed; in the middle of the 10th month, all the farmland had opened up for farming and all kinds of crops had been planted. In the first seed-planted fields, vegetables had already been picked several times. By the end of the 12th month, all the houses in the new county had been built.

Standing on the mountainside overlooking the new county, everyone's eyes were full of joy, surprise, and pride. One could see that the large and small blocks of well-planned farmlands were like the squares on a chessboard, surrounded by a wide lake. On the outskirts of the chained farmlands, twenty-four rows of houses formed six “□” shapes of different sizes in a close fitting, parallel to each other and very neat. Among them, there were sixteen rows of brick houses, four rows of wooden houses, and four rows of bamboo houses. On the account that the wooden and bamboo houses were less warm than the brick and tile houses, their area was increased — there were two floors. The design drawing was provided by Qin Mian. It was beautiful in appearance and very likable. In addition, there were four watchtowers in the four corners of the county, which was to better play the role of Kui County in guarding the country. The open area to the east was the military camp.

In short, the new Kui County was more well-liked than the former Kui County.

The next important thing to do was to distribute the farmland and houses. There were some households that only had one person left and some had five to six people. Therefore, Qin Mian carefully considered how to distribute the farmland and houses before he made the final decision.

The farmland would be distributed according to the headcount, whether it was a dying old man or a newborn baby, male or female, everyone could

get 1 mu of farmland. As for who got which farmlands, it was decided by drawing lots. Since the first-planted farmland had already yielded and the seeds sown later had not germinated yet, the county government would give the people who drew up the later-sown farmland certain subsidies according to the actual situation, at least to ensure that they could survive until the next spring. After all, there were nearly 30,000 people, so it was impossible to achieve absolute fairness. For example, the farmland close to the lake were more convenient for irrigation.

The houses would be distributed by drawing lots. The population of the county was counted before the reconstruction. If there was only one person in the household, the person had no right to own a house exclusively and had to share a house with others. It was not unfair since a household with only one member certainly had less capabilities than a household with a large population. To make an example, if there were several households with only one unmarried girl or one widowed woman or one old lady, they all could share a house. If a certain household wanted two certain adjacent houses, it was also fine. After the distribution, the household could discuss with the neighbors, whether to rent or buy the houses. That's their own business; it was not under the jurisdiction of the county magistrate.

There were other more detailed rules. Qin Mian made it clear and told people to write them in detail and put up the official notices on the four bulletin boards specially set up in the county. All the people naturally went to think about them carefully. The next day at the beginning of the dragon hour [7 a.m], they had to gather at the drill ground to be distributed to houses and farmland.

The next day, all the civilians of the county had a whole breakfast and came to the drill ground early. This was the first major event after the establishment of the new county. The school also gave the students a holiday. There was a lot of noise and excitement in the drill ground.

Prefect Cai knew a few days in advance that Kui County was going to conduct the distribution of farmland and houses, so he also came.

There were three sets of tables and chairs on the drill ground. Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Prefect Cai were all there. In front of Lei Tie were two big boxes

for drawing lots, one with red cloth and the other with blue cloth. Qin Mian had a list and a map of the new county in front of him. This list was, of course, to prevent people from fishing in troubled waters. The official notice stated that if someone lied about the population of his/her household, there would be a reward for reporting it and those who intended to cheat would be severely punished.

Qin Mian looked around. When he estimated that almost all the people had arrived, he went to the front.

“All quiet.”

It soon quieted down below.

“Now, it’s time to distribute the farmland and the hou—”

Before Qin Mian finished his words, the civilians began to clamor.

“County Magistrate, you pick a house and a few mu of land first.”

“Yes, the County Magistrate is a good official. It should be so!”

“That’s right, the County Magistrate has two children. He should pick two houses.”

“.....”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin stood by and smiled at each other. They were proud of their Dad being treated in such admiration.

Qin Mian’s heart felt so warm that his gaze became gentle. This period of hard work with energy and time invested was worth it.

“In this case, this official I, won’t be polite. I’ll pick a house. As for the farmland, no need. After the farmlands have been distributed to everyone, if there is any extra, I’ll pick a few mu to plant.”

One after another, the civilians asked him to pick a few mu of farmland. Qin Mian waved to stop them. “No need to say anymore. Our family

chooses the first bamboo storey house in the first row in the south. Alright, now it's time to draw lots. Whoever comes up, please state your names, as well as the number of people in the household."

He spoke with the aid of vital spirit. It was loud enough to make sure everyone could hear him clearly. Then, he returned to his seat.

"Number one." At the top of the list was a man in his early thirties. With a happy face, he quickly ran up the steps. Because he was too excited, he almost fell down. Everyone could not restrain from laughing.

"Hehe..." With a simple and honest grin, the man ran to the table, knelt, and kowtowed. "Paying respects to the three officials. This lowly one is called Chen the First. There are five people in the household."

"Don't be formal. Get up." Qin Mian said, "Grab one paper ball in the red clothed box and five paper balls in the blue clothed box." The red clothed box was used to distribute houses, while the blue clothed box was used to distribute farmland.

"Yes." The man grabbed the paper balls out and handed them to Qin Mian.

Qin Mian opened the six paper balls, which read "East 0211", "South 0511", "West 0304", "West 1023", "West 1023", "West 1024", and "North 0101". Qin Mian said, "Chen the First. House is the 11th in the second row in the east; farmlands are the 11th in the 5th row of south farmland..... and the 11th in the 1st row of north farmland."

Lei Tie and Prefect Cai each kept a record. One was kept to handle the house deed and land deed. The other one was handed to the soldiers on standby to lead the Chen household to identify their house and land.

Chen the First's eyes were filled with tears. Now, they owned a house and more land than they used to have; how could he not be excited? He called his awaiting family and happily followed the soldier to leave.

"Next."

More and more people were assigned houses and land. The atmosphere on the drill ground became more and more warm.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin watched for a long time and found it very interesting.

“Ge, if only we could go a draw lots once,” said Lei Ruilin with regret.

Although Qin Ruilin didn’t open his mouth, he seemed very interested by the look on his face.

At the side, an old man standing in line heard it and beckoned them with a smile.

“Come.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were very polite and didn’t at all put on the air of a noble young master. Only a few people in the county didn’t know them. They were very popular.

When they heard someone calling, they walked over in quick steps.

“Great-grandfather.” [T/n: Not blood-related]

“Ah.” The old man stroked his beard. “This old man is old and [my] arms are not flexible. Later, how about you two help this old man draw lots?”

Qin Ruiqi understood that the old man intended to let him and his Didi satisfy their curiosity. “I’m afraid if we draw a bad location, we’ll disappoint Great-grandfather.”

The old man was still smiling, “It doesn’t matter. This old man and my family are capable. Even if you draw a bad location, we won’t live worse than others.”

The two brothers looked at each other and smiled.

“Well, my Gege and I will draw good ones for you.” Lei Ruilin grinned at him.

The two brothers had been changing their teeth recently. There was only one upper incisor left. Yet, Lei Ruilin's smile did not make people think it was unsightly, rather, it was full of innocence and loveliness.

Chapter 206: Return to One's Hometown and Live in Seclusion

206 – Return to One's Hometown and Live in Seclusion

Soon, it was the old man's turn.

When Qin Mian saw his two sons running up, he raised his eyebrows.

With his hands behind his back, Lei Ruilin assumed an air of self-approbation as he said, "Dad, we're here to help Great-grandfather Chen Youyu draw lots. There're six people in Great-grandfather's family."

Qin Mian took a look at the old man, who nodded with a smile. He then signaled that the two sons could do it.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin had a tacit understanding. Qin Ruiqi grabbed a paper ball from the red-clothed box, while Lei Ruilin grabbed six paper balls from the blue-clothed box.

Qin Mian opened the paper balls and read, "Chen Youyu. House: 3rd house of the 1st row on the west. Farmland: 5th plot of the 1st row in the east, 9th plot of the 1st row in the east... 1st plot of the 2nd row in the south."

The others all looked at Chen Youyu with envy. Almost all the six plots were in the 1st and 2nd rows, which were near the lake. Later, irrigation would be very convenient.

Chen Youyu was also very happy and laughed, "Many thanks, little gongzis."

Others felt that the two sons of the county magistrate's family were rich in fortune. They asked Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to draw lots for them. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin enthusiastically helped more than a dozen people. The location of the houses and farmlands was really good. But the two kids soon lost interest, so they apologized and ran away.

In order to draw people's goodwill, Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Prefect Cai assumed personal command all morning. The armed servants all knew Arabic numerals. Therefore, in the afternoon, Qin Mian handed over the work to Lei-Qin Zhong and others to do it.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie took their two children home first. There were two floors in the bamboo house. The kitchen, main hall, Qin Ruiqi's and Lei Ruilin's study, and Qin Mian's and Lei Tie's study were on the first/ground floor. Qin Mian's and Lei Tie's bedroom, and Qin Ruiqi's and Lei Ruilin's room were on the second/top floor. However, due to limited conditions, the layout of the house was not comparable to their previous house.

When it was near dark, all the civilians had been distributed houses and farmland. Their enthusiasm was so high that they could not wait to move into their new homes. They lit the torches and moved. The dark county was filled with the gleam of the fire.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had been busy for a day; Only after they had a bath and lay in bed did they enjoy leisure.

"Tired?" Lei Tie pulled the person who shared his bed into his arms.

With his chin on Lei Tie's shoulder, Qin Mian nodded, "More tired than before." As a cultivator, the recent labor intensity was nothing, but compared with the previous life, these months were indeed the most tiring. Yet, undeniably, they were very substantial.

Lei Tie's hand slowly went into Qin Mian's nightclothes. As soon as they moved, the bamboo bed squeaked and the whole bamboo house wobbled. They were both stunned.

Lei Ruilin's crisp childish voice sounded across the corner. "Dad, Old Dad; you haven't slept yet? Gege and I aren't asleep yet, too."

Qin Mian lay on Lei Tie and laughed on his chest.

"Shouldn't pick a bamboo house." Lei Tie said in a depressed tone, "The soundproofing isn't good."

Qin Mian laughed despite himself, "Ruiqi and Ruilin, quickly go to sleep. Your Old Dad and I are going to sleep."

Lei Tie created a soundproofing spiritual array and took a certain someone into his arms.....

This was not to say that things were over after the farmland and houses had been distributed into the hands of the people. Qin Mian recruited some upright and resilient young people to work as bailiffs in the county, and asked Lei-Qin Zhong and Lei-Qin Shun to take them to the farmland for an on-site investigation. In case that a certain household was too unlucky that most or possibly all of the plots distributed were sown last, the county would take out some money to compensate them.

In addition, Qin Mian also asked Lei Tie to lend some people who were good at hunting, and opened a hunting training class in the county to teach people to hunt, so that those with poorer family conditions could support their families through hunting. In any way, they had to pass the winter first.

Because everyone was busy making a living, there was almost no criminal activity in the county. Qin Mian, as the county magistrate, was quite relaxed.

He and Lei Tie also took time to run outside the mountain, "bought" a lot of good things for their sons, and decorated their rooms nicely.

In a twinkling of an eye, the New Year came.

This year, most of the people in Kui County had a relatively plain New Year's celebration. Although Qin Mian's family had *that* conditions, it was

neither as eye-catching. On New Year's Eve, they only cooked two meat dishes and two vegetable dishes, a total of four dishes, but they were fulfilling.

On the first day of the Lunar New Year, everyone still went out to pay a New Year's visit. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin received a lot fewer red envelopes than in previous years. These red envelopes were given by the civilians, almost all sealed with 1 Wen. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were very sensible. They originally refused to accept them. However, everyone believed that it was not appropriate to push others' blessings out during the Lunar New Year, so they simply pressed the boys to accept. The boys could only accept them.

When people went to pay the New Year's visit to Qin Mian's house, Qin Mian didn't treat anyone badly. As long as they were under the age of 16, he would give them a 20 Wen red envelope in the name of him and Lei Tie.

The 1st month passed in a plain yet lively atmosphere.

At the beginning of the 3rd month, spring returned. The civilians seized the time to plow and prepare to plant spring wheat and other crops.

Qin Mian also launched the next step in the development of Kui County. The current Kui County had only rows of houses and farmland. There was not even a tree in the county, so it had no aesthetic feeling. Qin Mian called on the surplus labor force to follow him up the mountain to dig some wildflowers and fruit trees such as duckbill, winter jasmine, rhododendron pulchrum sweet, pennywort, azalea, amur rose, wild jujube, wild peach, wild pear, wild apple, wild grape, and so on, and then planted them in every corner of the county in a planned way.

Qin Mian did not plan to stay in Kui County, so he did not spend too much thought on his bamboo house. He only planted two fruit trees in front of the door and a few potted flowers on the balcony on the second floor.

Not wanting to treat his two sons badly, Qin Mian occasionally took out some fruits and vegetables from the space. When Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin saw it [things appearing out of nowhere] for the first time, they asked their

father how was that possible. Their father only laughed and did not answer. The two children guessed that it might not be suitable for them to know, so they wisely chose not to ask anymore. In fact, the two children had long suspected that their “martial arts” were not an internal force type of martial arts, but since the two fathers needed to hide it from them, there must be a reason. They would know when the time came.

The other was road construction. Lei Tie sent 5000 people to find limestone within 20 li of the nearby area. After it was transported back, Qin Mian made a simple version of cement, which was not as strong as concrete, but more than enough for road construction.

They were busy until the 7th month.

With wide and smooth roads, it was much easier for the people of Kui County to get in and out of the city, and the development of agriculture and commerce was faster and efficient.

Everyone could see that their lives were getting better and better.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie sent the third memorial asking for resignation to the Capital, but there was still no reply.

Qin Mian began to get impatient.

“A-Tie, Chen Guanghui isn’t getting fat from to eating his words¹, is he? What’s the point of his forcing us to stay here?”

Chen Guanghui was the name of Emperor Xiaohui. Normally, no one dared to address him disrespectfully by name.

Lei Tie had a plan in his heart. He comforted, “Wife, wait another half a month. If there is no result after half a month, we’ll publicize the deal we made with him.”

“Good idea.” Qin Mian agreed without hesitation. They couldn’t deal with an emperor directly, but they could use the power of public opinion.

At this time, a soldier in a panic outside the door shouted, “Grand General and Qin-daren! This lowly one has something urgent to see you both.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie look at each other in suspicion and went downstairs together. The situation of the whole county was under their control. What else could be called an “urgency”?

“What’s the matter?”

The soldier said in an urgent voice, “Reporting, Grand General. Prefect Cai send someone to deliver a message that the Imperial Carriage has arrived and order Grand General and Qin-daren to prepare for the welcoming immediately!”

Emperor Xiaohui came? Qin Mian was very surprised and said to Lei Tie, “it’s not close to the Capital. He’s really brave.”

“Wife, it won’t be long before we can go back to Green Mountain Village,” said Lei Tie in a calm and composed manner.

“Oh?” Qin Mian was not in a hurry to ask him why.

They put on their official uniforms and directly performed their “qinggong”, going to the county government office and the military camp respectively. They took all the bailiffs and soldiers to the entrance of the county to prepare for the welcoming.

After waiting for nearly an hour, a long procession getting closer and closer was seen. The emperor’s unique golden canopy was shining under the sun. Dressed in a bright yellow robe, Emperor Xiaohui sat on the spacious throne as he looked at the scenery on both sides of the road at will. The majestic Imperial Guards guarded the imperial carriage in the middle, sharp eyes looking around from time to time.

When the imperial carriage arrived in front of them, Qin Mian and Lei Tie knelt together to pay respect.

“Your subject(s) gladly welcomes Your Majesty the Emperor; may Your Majesty the Emperor lives long, absolutely long live!”

Emperor Xiaohui looked at them for a long time. Just from seeing the road outside of the mountain, he had expected that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had never lie about the completion of Kui County’s reconstruction in the reports. Because of this, he was more reluctant to let go of such two outstanding talents. But he knew from the bottom of his heart that this time, he couldn’t keep Qin Mian and Lei Tie. It was not that he didn’t have any means to use, but he had a premonition that once he really used the dark means to deal with them, it would only lead to the confrontation between them and him. It was better to let them go happily, in case, if the imperial clan encountered hard strife again, he could still reinstate them.

After thinking about it, Emperor Xiaohui took a deep breath in silence and said in a warm voice, “My two dear subjects, you may rise.”

“Many thanks, Your Majesty!”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie stood up and retreated to the side, awaiting orders.

Emperor Xiaohui gently dusted the non-existent dust on his sleeve and slowly stepped down from the imperial carriage to Qin Mian and Lei Tie. With a look of kindness, he gently spoke, “Hahaha... Hope that my two dear subjects are well?”

“Thanks to Your Majesty’s great blessing, your subjects and everyone are well,” replied Lei Tie concisely and comprehensively.

Emperor Xiaohui said with a smile, “That’s good. In the memorials, Zhen first was curious when my dear subjects kept mentioning the new appearance of Kui County. Secondly, Zhen yearned for the idyllic scenery, so Zhen decided to come and see it for myself. If the new Kui County pleases Zhen, Zhen will allow you two to return to your hometown [and seclude] in the countryside.”

Qin Mian was overjoyed and exchanged a look with Lei Tie.

“Thank you, Your Majesty! This way, please, Your Majesty.”

“Lead the way.” With a broad smile on his lips, Emperor Xiaohui waved his hand and walked forward with Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Eunuch Li, Prefect Cai, and several other officials quickly followed.

Huh? When did Vol. 4 even started?

Footnotes

1. break promises

Chapter 207: Return to One's Hometown in Glory

207 – Return to One's Hometown in Glory

It was said to lead the way, but of course, Qin Mian and Lei Tie could not walk in front of Emperor Xiaohui. When they entered the county, Emperor Xiaohui was in front of them, while Qin Mian and Lei Tie followed him.

The well-arranged houses, green farmland, and clear blue lake gave Emperor Xiaohui a panoramic view. He looked satisfied and nodded from time to time. In the distant farmland, the farmer, with his hoe on his shoulder, chatted with the farmer in the next plot while laughing heartily. His face was facing the sun; the satisfaction of life in his smile touched people's hearts. Under the willow trees, children of different ages played a chasing game; the clear and tender children's voices were full of joy. From time to time, the housewife, who was washing clothes on the bluestone slab by the lake, scolded them loudly. Although she was scolding them, her voice was absolutely full of love for the children.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie didn't use resplendent words to tell Emperor Xiaohui how much thought and energy they spent on rebuilding Kui County. They looked calm and indifferent, unmoved either by gain or loss.

Eunuch Li could see it clearly and could not help but feel sorry for the emperor, who was going to lose his two great officials.

Emperor Xiaohui was infected by the quiet and peaceful atmosphere in the county. He forgot the incoming resignation of Qin Mian and Lei Tie and laughed a few times from the heart.

“Good, good. Follow Zhen ahead to take a look.”

Emperor Xiaohui took the lead entering the farmland and others kept up.

At this time, the weeding farmers in the farmland finally noticed a large team in the distance. They knew that only the emperor could wear bright yellow color. After being taken aback, they quickly guessed the identity of the man. They were so terrified that they turned pale and knelt on the ground in confusion.

Emperor Xiaohui stepped forward and said to the nearest old man in kind, “Old man, quickly get up.”

The old man felt overwhelmingly flattered that his legs gave way; he stood upright after a good while.

Emperor Xiaohui gently called the nearby farmers to ask about their age, the harvest in the farmland, the family, and so on.

The few young men were more daring; they summoned up courage as they answered. Several old people were encouraged and joined in the conversation.

It was hard to dislike Emperor Xiaohui’s closeness. For a time, one person with a heavenly identity and several people with an earthen identity had a good talk.

An eight-year-old child even ran over after picking a big red peach from a tree.

Eunuch Li’s face changed slightly. He was about to step forward but was stopped by Emperor Xiaohui.

Emperor Xiaohui believed that Qin Mian and Lei Tie had managed Kui County well. He peeled the peach with a smile and bit it, “En, sweet.”

That was only natural. The living standards of the people in the mountains were indeed much worse than those in the plain. Qin Mian intended to help them. When he planted these fruit trees, they had been transformed with the

spiritual spring water properly. Therefore, Kui County's fruits tasted very sweet.

“Thank you very much for your hospitality, kid.” Emperor Xiaohui kindly rubbed the child's head.

The child returned with a pure smile and a face of ignorant.

The father of the child was so emotionally moved that his hands trembled and he nearly fainted.

Qin Mian tried hard to suppress a smile. He was afraid that the father would not let his son wash his hair for the next ten days.

After walking around the farmland, Qin Mian and Lei Tie led Emperor Xiaohui into the streets. Emperor Xiaohui randomly selected several households to visit and was very satisfied.

At this time, Emperor Xiaohui was also a little tired. He asked Qin Mian and Lei Tie to take him to their home.

Lei Tie instructed the Imperial Bodyguards to organize a defense first.

By the time Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Emperor Xiaohui arrived, Qin Mian's house was surrounded as solid as an iron cask.

Qin Mian arranged for Emperor Xiaohui to take a rest in the master bedroom, accompanied by Eunuch Li.

Qin Mian asked the two imperial chefs, who came with Emperor Xiaohui, what food ingredients they needed to prepare. He bought various meat and then went to the vegetable garden to pick some vegetables.

Emperor Xiaohui had a rest for nearly two hours. Qin Mian and Lei Tie had lunch with him.

In the afternoon, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took Emperor Xiaohui to visit the school and several skills training classes in the county. Emperor Xiaohui praised Qin Mian's measures. Although the “merchant” was ranked (class)

last among the “scholar, farmer, smith, and merchant”, Emperor Xiaohui never thought that merchants were unimportant. For example, in the battle of Tuluo, the total amount of donations from merchants alone was more than 10 million taels, and the annual trading tax was one of the important sources of tax revenue in the imperial court.

Since Emperor Xiaohui had come all the way, he couldn't leave after the on-spot inspection. The next morning, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took him to experience the fun of picking fruits and vegetables in person.

When he saw that someone was farming in the field, Emperor Xiaohui went to experience it. He scared the accompanying officials into a drastic change of expression, who feared that the ox would suddenly go mad and hurt Emperor Xiaohui.

Emperor Xiaohui knew that Qin Mian and Lei Tie would guard him, so he was very calm. He had a great time.

At the sight of Emperor Xiaohui, many people were even fonder of him. The emperor was always superior in their heart. Who would have thought that they would not only see the emperor in their lifetime but also teach the emperor how to plow?

After four days in Kui County, Emperor Xiaohui was going to set out to return to the Capital.

This time, Emperor Xiaohui brought Kui County a new county magistrate and directly kept him there. Emperor Xiaohui asked Qin Mian and Lei Tie to return to the Capital with him for the formal resignation.

Emperor Xiaohui had a good intention. If Qin Mian and Lei Tie returned to Green Mountain Village directly from Kui County, he was afraid that the officials in the court would think that they were “forced into the cold palace” by Emperor Xiaohui. If Qin Mian and Lei Tie were in trouble later, they might be bullied by an official. It was different if they went back to the Capital with Emperor Xiaohui, which showed that Emperor Xiaohui still attached importance to them.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie were not stupid. They had thought of this. Thus, they accepted Emperor Xiaohui's favor.

On the day of departure, when the civilians learned that Qin Mian and Lei Tie would leave Kui County, they were so shocked that they knelt in tears, reluctant to part. Qin Mian was a good county magistrate. Although Lei Tie had not spoken much and seemed cold, the amount of effort he had made to rebuild Kui County was not unknown to them.

"Qin-Daren and General Lei, we can't bear to part with you!"

"Qin-Daren and General Lei, have a smooth journey!"

"Qin-Daren and General Lei, both are good officials!"

"....."

Emperor Xiaohui was surprised and sighed, "If all the officials of Great Xia are like my dear subjects Lei and Qin, how can Great Xia worry about not being strong?"

The accompanying officials all agreed with their heads down.

The new County Magistrate Su watched the civilians send Qin Mian and Lei Tie one *li* after another. The blood in his chest suddenly boiled; his fists involuntarily clenched tightly. If one day he could make these people willing to do so for him, he believed that he would die without regret.

There was no need to say more on the way back to the Capital.

After returning to the Capital, Qin Mian and Lei Tie formally handed in their resignations.

Emperor Xiaohui removed Lei Tie from the post of State Defender Grand General, Qin Mian from the post of Kui County Magistrate, and retained Lei Tie's title of State Defender Duke and Qin Mian's title of Lady of the State Defender Duke. Qin Ruiqi was still the Heir of State Defender Duke and Lei Ruilin was still the Duke of An County. Not only that, but he also

ordered the Imperial Bodyguards to escort Qin Mian's family back to their hometown, which was a great honor.

Chen Mufeng, Zhangsun He, and Lei Xiangzhi saw them off on the tower over the city gate.

"I don't know why, I always feel that once they leave, the Capital will become more boring." Chen Mufeng was holding a six-month-old baby in his arms, whose chubby appearance was adorable.

Zhangsun He gently poked Little Brother Chen in the face, "So what? If it's boring, we'll go to Zhaoxian County."

"Then, that's a promise," said Chen Mufeng.

Lei Xiangzhi faintly smiled as he watched Qin Mian and others drifting farther away. He hoped that his eldest brother and eldest sister-in-law would get better and better in the future. Last year, he was promoted to a subsidiary fourth-rank Grand Secretariat Academician Reader-in-waiting. He believed in himself that he would get better and better in the future.

After leaving the Capital, Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin were relaxed in both body and mind. In the spacious carriage, the family played "Quick Escape" with Qin Mian's "invented" card game. "Quick Escape" as the name suggested, whose card was the first to finish was the winner. Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin joined hands, so Lei Tie's forehead was pasted with slips of paper. The father and sons laughed merrily from time to time.

The armed servants outside the carriage could not refrain from smiling in understanding when they heard the laughter.

Laying on Qin Mian's legs, White Spot tilted its head to look at the cards in his hand. Sometimes, its ears perked up and folded, and sometimes it tilted its head. It seemed that it clearly understood. Standing on the top of the carriage, Golden Eagle flapped its wings at will. Now and then, it flew up and circled in the air, then it landed and looked around lazily. Golden Fur's body was too big, so it was in another carriage.

It took Qin Mian's family more than a month before entering Zhaoyang County.

Nie Heng, an old friend, received the news long ago and met them at the intersection.

After lunch at Nie Heng's house, the procession continued to set out and entered Green Mountain Village in the evening.

The summer's day was long. The villagers gathered under the trees at the entrance of the village to enjoy the cool breeze. Some were reinforcing the sole of a shoe, some were eating, some were playing chess, and some were chatting.

Wu Di keenly saw the approaching familiar carriage, which made him abruptly stood up. He was surprised and said, "Isn't that Tiezi's family?"

"Oh, that's true!"

"The soldiers even escorting them? This is returning to one's hometown in glory!"

As they talked, they went over to welcome and warmly greeted the family.

"Tiezi's wife, you're back, huh?"

"You've had a long day, isn't it?"

"You're back; everyone misses you so much."

Some children could not wait to ask, "Uncle Qin, are Yuanyuan and Manman back?"

"Yuanyuan, Manman..."

"Even Golden Fur and White Spot!"

Chapter 208: Comfort

208 – Comfort

As soon as the carriage stopped, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin jumped steadily out of the carriage and were immediately surrounded by joyful friends.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie get off the carriage afterward. Qin Mian greeted the villagers with a smile.

“Hope that everyone is well?”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had been officials for a long time. The villagers had heard about it. At this time, they saw that Qin Mian had no airs of an official and was as polite as before. They were very comfortable and had a more sincere smile on their faces.

“Good, we’re all good.” Wu Di was happy to see them again and asked with a smile, “How are you?”

“We’re good, too.” Qin Mian said with a smile, “Thank you for your concern for our family. You see, we have a lot of guests today – please excuse us. We’ll invite the villagers to dine another day.”

The villagers said, one after another, “Ah, alright, alright, we won’t hold you up. You do what you need to do first.”

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, are you going to play here or come home with us?” Qin Mian asked his two sons.

Lei Ruilin said, “Gege and I will play here for a while, Dad.”

“Alright.” Qin Mian took a packet of confectionery from the carriage and handed it to the two brothers, “Invite everyone to have some snacks.”

Qin Ruiqi promised, “Dad can rest assured.”

White Spot, Golden Fur, and Golden Eagle followed him and Lei Ruilin.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie got back on the carriage and led the Imperial Bodyguards to Leisurely Farmhouse.

When Uncle Quan, Aunt Quan, and the others received the news, they quickly ran over. They were very excited to see the two masters again.

Qin Mian told Steward Fu to arrange for the Imperial Bodyguards to stay in Qilin Mountain Villa.

As the carriage drove into Leisurely Farmhouse, Qin Mian couldn’t wait and jumped out of the carriage, looking around in yearning.

Lei Tie came up to Qin Mian and put his arm around Qin Mian’s shoulders.

Qin Mian pulled him forward, walking briskly and looking cheerful. He went to the pomegranate tree and picked a big pomegranate and handed it to Lei Tie.

“A-Tie, now I feel really free.”

Lei Tie gently kissed his lips, “Wife, I have wronged you. Don’t worry, no one will disturb us ever again.”

“En.” Qin Mian hugged him back and gave him a big hard smooch on the lips. “On the way back, I’ve already thought about it. We’d better hire a [homeschool] teacher for the two children. Like Dongyang Academy, we can arrange winter vacation and summer vacation for the children, and then we can take them out for sightseeing.”

Lei Tie pursed his lips. “We haven’t been out alone for a long time – you and me.”

Qin Mian rubbed his hot face and looked directly into the man's eyes with a smile, "Well then, let the children study in school this year and hire a [homeschool] teacher for them next year."

Lei Tie immediately nodded; his eyes became incomparably scorching hot.

Qin Mian held Lei Tie's head in both hands and kissed him.

Lei Tie's eyes flashed and responded with the same vehemence.

They finally broke away from the bondage of the imperial court; the kiss was the release of their inner feelings. After a good while, when they were aware that there would be *fire* if they continue, they released each other. Staring at each other's ruddy and swollen lips, their hearts agitated once more and their fervent eyes entangled for a long time.

Standing in the distance, Uncle Quan and Aunt Quan could feel the ambiguities around the two masters even with their heads lowered.

Lei Tie silently kissed his wife's eyebrows and then held his hand as they walked to their home.

Aunt Quan came to clean the house every two days. The house was almost spotless, as if the people who lived here had never left.

Qin Mian nodded with satisfaction and told Uncle Quan, "Uncle Quan, today is a good day. Pass my words: All servants in the household will be rewarded with a month's salary."

"Yes! Many thanks, Eldest Master and Little Master."

Lei Tie lightly said, "Henceforth, just call Old Lord and Lady."

Qin Mian glanced at him with a forced smile, not saying anything.

Uncle Quan replied, "Yes."

Aunt Quan said, "My Old Lord and Lady, this old woman is going to prepare the meal."

Qin Mian waved his hand and said, “No need. Uncle Quan, go to see if Steward Fu needs any help. Aunt Quan, go pick some fresh vegetables. I’ll prepare the meal myself.”

“Yes, my Lady.”

Aunt Quan was very quick in her work, and soon she came with a vegetable basket. Besides some fresh vegetables and fruits, there were two strips of cured meat and a dried salted duck in the basket.

After putting down the basket, she left purposely.

Qin Mian caught a fish from the space, took out some fresh meat, and prepared the meal with great interest. When he was in Kui County, he was busy from morning to night, so he had little time to cook for his family. Now that he came home, he had to make up for his family.

Lei Tie didn’t have to be ordered; he went to deal with the ingredients.

Lei Xiangyi, Lei Xiangli, Qian Shi, and Sun Shi walked quickly into the hedge yard, carrying things in their hands.

“Eldest Brother and Eldest Sister-in-law, you are finally back.”

Qin Mian went out, shook the water on his hands, and said with a smile, “You’re all here. Come in and sit down.”

Lei Xiangyi put down the sausages and cured meat in his hands, “Eldest Sister-in-law. Since you and Eldest Brother haven’t been at home for such a long time, we figured that there shouldn’t be much meat in your house, so we took some from home and sent them to you.”

“You’re just in time. I’m cooking.” Qin Mian invited the four people inside, “Come in and sit down.”

Lei Xiangli said, “You’re busy; we won’t sit here. We’ll come back tomorrow to talk with you two.”

Qin Mian didn’t insist, “Alright, I won’t keep you. Careful.”

“Continue what you’re doing, Eldest Sister-in-law.”

After sending off Lei Xiangyi and the others, Qin Mian continued to cook.

Seven dishes later, which consisted of crystal sweet and sour meat, sweet and sour carp, mushroom and chestnut chicken, braised lobster, lettuce with minced garlic, stir-fried spinach in soy sauce, and corn ribs soup, the setting sun had set behind the mountains.

Qin Mian asked Lei Tie to call their two sons to come back for dinner.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin ran into the house covered in sweat.

“Dad, how fragrant! Can we start eating now?” Lei Ruilin looked at the dishes all over the table with admiration.

Qin Mian saw the sweat on the faces of the two little boys. “A-Tie, wipe the sweat on their bodies. Don’t let them catch a cold.”

“En.” Lei Tie scooped up a basin of cold water, heated it directly with vital spirit, and motioned to his two sons to wash their faces and hands.

“Son, what about White Spots and the others?” Qin Mian asked casually.

Lei Ruilin said, “They went to the mountain.”

Qin Mian responded with a sound, expressing that he got it and was not worried about their safety.

After Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin washed, Lei Tie wrung out the face towel with warm water and put it into their clothes to wipe the sweat on their backs.

Qin Ruiqi couldn’t bear it and burst out laughing. Leaning on his father’s thigh, he turned his head and said, “Old Dad, it tickles.”

Qin Mian came out with bowls and chopsticks. When he saw this, he smiled. This child laughed less; at this time, he looked especially cute.

“When you’re done, we can start dinner.”

“Dad, I’ve washed. Let me scoop dishes for you and Old Dad,” requested Lei Ruilin.

“Alright.” Qin Mian sat down at the table with a smile. “Today, your Old Dad and I are waiting for you and your Gege to serve us.”

“No problem.” The two brothers answered with a clear and melodious voice. One person carried a bowl, while the other loaded rice into the bowl.

Qin Ruiqi held the rice bowl in both hands and handed it to Qin Mian, “Dad has worked hard. Have a meal, Dad.”

“Alright, my sons are truly good boys.” Qin Mian was warm in his heart. He put his arms around his son’s small shoulders and gave him a kiss on his forehead.

The two brothers then gave Lei Tie a bowl of rice and also got a word of praise, “Good boys.”

The family enjoyed a delicious dinner in a warm atmosphere.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were also tired today. After taking a bath, they went to bed and soon fell asleep one after another.

After taking a bath, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to the bedroom on the second floor. After some affectionate moments, they embraced each other and fell asleep.....

The next morning, Qin Mian woke up amidst the sound of birds and the fragrance of fruits. He heard the heave-ho of Lei Tie and his two sons practicing in the yard. He put on his nightgown at the head of the bed and went to the verandah. He smiled as he looked at the three figures below.

Lei Tie was the first to find him. He looked up, with calm and profound tenderness flooded in his eyes.

Qin Mian gave him a flying kiss, went into the room, got dressed, and went downstairs.

The pot was warm with delicious beef and spinach porridge. Qin Mian had a taste; the delicious taste made his eyes smile. There was no need to say that although his family's poker-face couldn't cook rice or dishes, his level of cooking porridge even made him concede that the man was better qualified. As for how his skill of cooking porridge came about, well, let's not mention it.

After breakfast, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to Qilin Mountain Villa together to ask the Imperial Bodyguards to have another day off and return to the Capital the next day.

The leader of the Imperial Bodyguard also planned to take a day off, so he stayed with his subordinates. Qin Mian instructed Steward Fu to entertain them with care.

Thinking that they had just returned to the village, Qin Mian didn't immediately send the boys to the village school. In the morning, the family of four went together to deliver gifts brought back from the Capital to the villagers, and then went to visit their farmland.

Near noon, Lei Xiangyi's family and Lei Xiangli's family came. The adults of the three families chatted about the recent situation together, while several children played together. It was very lively.

The lunch was eaten at Qin Mian's home, with Aunt Fu and Aunt Quan cooking together. Both of them had good craftsmanship. Qin Mian and Lei Tie drank a few glasses of wine with Lei Xiangyi and Lei Xiangli. Everyone enjoyed the meal.

In the afternoon, Qin Mian and Lei Tie took a look at the account books of several workshops at home, and then went to see several shops in the town together. During the period when the family was away, the operation of the workshops and the shops was normal and nothing upsetting happened. Qin Mian was very satisfied and generously gave all the persons-in-charge red

envelopes sealed with 100 tael, while all the employees were rewarded with 1 tael.

The next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie personally sent the Imperial Bodyguards away from Green Mountain Village and took their two sons by the hand to school.

Chapter 209: The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (1)

209 – The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (1)

It was not just a casual talk when Qin Mian said about inviting the villagers to dine. After all, he left Green Mountain Village for so long. In the eyes of the villagers, his family was truly flourishing; it would not make sense not to invite them to dine.

Qin Mian passed on the orders in an orderly way. His servants went to buy ingredients, prepare tables and chairs, hire chefs.... When all the arrangements were made, the banquet was set up on the grain-sunning ground. After chatting with the villagers, drinking and dining for lunch and dinner at the banquet, Qin Mian's family returned to be on friendly terms with the villagers.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin quickly adapted to school days.

In the evening, when the family were having dinner, Golden Eagle suddenly darted inside like a golden arrow. Because its action was too urgent, its two downies fell directly onto Qin Mian's face.

“What's the matter, Goldie?”

Golden Eagle looked at him and made an anxious cry. It flew out less than half a zhang [1.5 m] away before coming back. It seemed to be urging Qin Mian to go with it.

With a tense look, Qin Mian suddenly stood up and rushed out, “Something must have happened to White Spot and Golden Fur! A-Tie, let's go and

have a look!”

“Wife, don’t panic.” Lei Tie caught up with him, held his hand tightly, and was ready to fly away.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin didn’t slow down and ran after each other. “Dad, Old Dad; Didi and I want to go and see White Spot and Golden Fur, too!”

Without a word, Qin Mian and Lei Tie grabbed the boys each.

The family of four followed Golden Eagle and flew to the back of the mountain in speed. After a few breaths, they flew over the mountain forest before Golden Eagle went to land.

White Spot rolled in agony on the ground. Silver spiritual qi flashed on its body like lightning. Its black fur was wet and bloody, dying the withered grass on the ground with light red.

Golden Fur stood at the side with its eyes fixed on White Spot and its mouth growled from time to time.

“White Spot!” Qin Mian put down his son and quickly ran over with panic in his voice. White Spot had a different meaning to him that he couldn’t imagine the possibility of losing White Spot.

Lei Tie hurriedly went over and pressed his shoulder while calmly said, “Wife, don’t worry. White Spot should be going to ascend.”

“Ascend?” Qin Mian calmed down. It was no wonder that he was flustered. White Spot was a beast, so its way of cultivation was different from that of human beings. For a moment, he honestly didn’t think of that.

“We put the vital spirit into it to help it,” said Lei Tie as he turned his palms. Abundant vital spirit gushed out from the palms, which slowly and steadily entered White Spot’s body.

Qin Mian followed suit.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin quickly ran over and squatted beside White Spot in worry.

“Dad, White Spot will be fine, right?”

Qin Mian firmly said, “Yes, your Old Dad and I won’t let anything happen to it.”

White Spot gave out a whimper full of gratitude as its gentle eyes glided over the four masters one by one. It did not dare to be distracted for too long and immediately withdrew its attention and focused on ascending. More and more spiritual qi gathered in the surrounding area, frantically rushed into White Spot’s body. All of a sudden, White Spot jumped up from the ground, looked up to the sky, and let out a long cry, “AWOO~~”

As if the spiritual Qi seemed to be stimulated, it rolled and turned. All of a sudden, White Spot let out a painful wolf roar again. The pressure as heavy as Mount Tai came out of the void; it seemed that a giant hand suddenly tore the whole space. Before Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin could react, they were overturned by a powerful force and thrown into the air.

“Wife!” Lei Tie quickly caught his wife, who was the nearest to him.

Qin Ruiqi reacted quickly and caught his Didi’s wrist.

“Ruiqi, Ruilin!” Qin Mian watched Qin Ruilin and Lei Ruilin fly to the other direction. He was shocked and wanted to fly over to catch them. However, it was as if he was trapped in quicksand. The pressure from all sides kept him in prison without mercy.

Lei Tie couldn’t move either. As he watched his two sons getting farther and farther away from him and Qi Mian, his expression radically changed.

In the blink of an eye, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin disappeared, leaving only two panicked shouts in the air, “DAAAAAAD—OLD DAAAAAAD—”

At the same time, Qin Mian and Lei Tie were also thrown out by the invisible big hand. Before they fainted, they only saw a black and a gold lightning following Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin.

.....

“Ruiqi, Ruilin!” Qin Mian suddenly opened his eyes and broke into a cold sweat.

“Wife, awake?”

Qin Mian noticed that he was on Lei Tie’s back and asked, “Sons?”

Lei Tie’s big palm patted his thigh, “Don’t be afraid, I can sense that they are all right. However, the spiritual qi here is too thin to determine their specific locations.”

Qin Mian carefully sensed it. As expected, he was able to vaguely catch the spiritual sense of Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin; he breathed a sigh of relief. He looked up and stared with his mouth agape. Were the high-rise buildings in the distance and the bullet train on the track his illusion?

“Wife, this is the world you used to live in?” Lei Tie had heard Qin Mian talk about the living environment in his previous life, so he asked.

Qin Mian foolishly opened his mouth as he squeezed Lei Tie’s arm hard, “Does it hurt?”

Lei Tie shook his head in connivance, “It’s not a dream.”

Golden Eagle flew to Qin Mian and looked at him with concern.

Qin Mian was taken aback, “Goldie also came?”

Lei Tie nodded, “If my guess is correct, White Spot and Golden Fur are with our sons.”

With White Spot and Golden Fur there, the safety of the two sons was more guaranteed. Qin Mian released a long exhale and then thought of jumping

off Lei Tie's back. "If there is no mistake, this is the world I used to live in. Let me think on how we can find our son..."

Lei Tie could see that Qin Mian was impatient. He held Qin Mian's face and printed a kiss on his lips. "You are most familiar with this place. We'll depend on you to find our sons; don't be anxious. Besides, our sons are very smart and they can take care of themselves."

Qin Mian's anxious heart immediately settled down and nodded, "En, I ain't anxious. Follow me."

.....

Seeing that the child was about to fall to the ground, White Spot narrowed its eyes as its dark shadow flashed over in speed. Before he fell to the ground, it put itself under him accurately.

Qin Ruiqi didn't feel it. He lay on White Spot's back and didn't wake up.

White Spot lay quietly on the ground, afraid to wake up the child. It didn't move. It only moved its head once in a while, looking around with alert eyes, and finally watched the light of dawn in boredom. When a gust of wind blew, its shiny black hair lifted up like black gold.

It was unknown how long it had been when the child on its back finally moved. As soon as he raised his head and saw the environment with clear eyes, he was momentarily confused.

"Yuanyuan." A young voice sounded out of thin air.

"Who?!" Qin Ruiqi sprang to his feet and looked around warily.

White Spot stood up and looked at him in a placating manner, "Yuanyuan, it's me."

"White Spot?" Qin Ruiqi stared at it in suspicion.

White Spot nodded, "I can speak because of the ascension."

Qin Ruiqi was stunned for a while and then calmly nodded. There were many strange things in his family, so he was only surprised for a moment before accepting the fact that White Spot could speak.

“Do you know where Dad, Old Dad, and Didi are?”

White Spot explained, “Don’t worry, they are all in this world like us. This is where your Dad lived previously. He’ll find us.”

When Qin Ruiqi heard those words, the panic in his heart suddenly dissipated. In his heart, his Dad and Old Dad were omnipotent. He thought that the “previous” that White Spot meant was before he and Lei Ruilin were born. He didn’t think much about it. He rubbed his empty stomach and the bracelet on his wrist.

This bracelet was refined by Lei Tie after he was proficient in weapon refining. It integrated the triple functions of poison detection, defense, and storage. The storage space was not large, about eight cubic meters, but it was enough to be a backpack. Unfortunately, there were only some pills, a spiritual double-edged sword, a money box, toys, and a few books. Usually, he and Lei Ruilin had what they wanted to eat at home, so they never thought to put some food in the storage bracelet. There were a lot of gold, silver, and banknotes, but these were not suitable for use in this strange world.

White Spot lifted its left forepaw and also made the move of rubbing its stomach. It said, “I’m hungry, too.”

Qin Ruiqi very quickly assessed the current situation. Before his Dad found them, he just needed to make sure that he and White Spot were safe.

After pondering for a short while, he walked forward.

White Spot hastily followed, “Where to?”

At this time, they were in a quiet alley. There was no one around but them.

Qin Ruiqi stroked its back and said, “Fill our stomach first.”

White Spot reminded, “The currency here is not the same.”

Qin Ruiqi said, “Make money first.”

“How?” ask White Spot.

Qin Ruiqi reached the end of the alley. After a long silence, he thought of the acrobatics show he had seen in the street before and spat out two words, “Performing arts?”

White Spot’s eyebrows were raised and there seemed to be three black lines hanging.

Walking out of the remote alley, Qin Ruiqi saw cars whistling by. After a few seconds, he regained his expressionless appearance. He knew those were cars, which had been in the story that his Dad told him and his Didi.

In the morning, H City gradually woke up. There were more and more people on the street. Housewives were going to the supermarket to shop, urban white-collar workers were hurrying, students were carrying schoolbags... all came and went in a hurry. On the square, twenty to thirty old men and women were exercising Taichi in leisure.

Qin Ruiqi thought for a bit before going to the square.

White Spot closely followed him and carefully walked on the outside to prevent the traffic on the road from accidentally hitting Qin Ruiqi.

When passers-by passed by Qin Ruiqi, they involuntarily looked at the little boy in ancient clothes curiously. Some people secretly took photos with their mobile phones.

Chapter 210: The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (2)

210 – The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (2)

“Yah, whose child is this? Looks like a little gongzi from an influential family in ancient times!”

“His wooden face is so adorable!”

“Yes, it’s cute!”

.....

Qin Ruiqi, as if unaware of it, came to the square and stood at the front of the group. After thinking about it, he first practiced a set of Meteor Fists taught by his Old Dad.

At the beginning, the old men and old women in the square saw him standing there gesticulating with hands and feet and treated it as a child horsing around. After watching for a while, they found that every gesture and motion of his fists were smooth and powerful. Evidently, it was not a mere form. They could not help but look straight and their movements slowed down as they earnestly watched.

After Qin Ruiqi completed the set of boxing, he politely bowed to the crowd with his hand cupped in the other, “Ruiqi accidentally separated from his family. If grandpas and grandmas think that this set of boxing is good, please praise it with tips for those who have money, and personal tips for those who have no money. Thank you very much!”

Most people were suspicious of his statement. But if the child was trying to cheat money, it didn't feel like it. He had a good temperament and didn't look like an ordinary child.

There was a doubt in Qin Ruiqi's eyes: could it be that the set of boxing just now wasn't well performed?

At this time, a young man in his thirties, dressed in sportswear, came briskly with a ruffian smile and sweat on his face. He threw the towel in his hand and joked, "Little guy, your skill seems uncommon. Why don't we compare? If you win, I'll give you money tips. How about that?"

An old lady recognized that this man was Wang Kun, a veteran army who often ran in the morning nearby and now worked as the Head of Security of a company. She laughed as she joked, "You have the nerve to bully a child."

Qin Ruiqi nodded with a serious face, "Alright, please."

Wang Kun didn't think that the child came here to cheat money. He just thought that this little guy looked like he was only seven or eight years old and that his wooden face was very interesting. That's why, he teased. He immediately nodded with a faint smile, "Come."

All the old men and old women thought it was very funny and heckled with the sound of laughter.

Wang Kun looked at the height of the child which was less than his waist, and said with a smile, "You move first?"

Qin Ruiqi saw the other party's contempt and didn't mind it. With a slight nod, he took the lead in attacking the other party's abdomen.

Wang Kun laughed merrily as he casually dodged to the side. Unexpectedly, the child suddenly changed his move. He didn't see the opponent's movement at all, so his wrist was clamped down. The opponent's hand was too small to hold his whole wrist, but the strength was not small. He said in his heart that it was not good. The next second, a force suddenly pulled him forward. Before he had time to react, there was a flash of light and then his

buttock hurt. To his surprise, he was made to fall on the ground by the child with a move similar to a shoulder throw.

Wang Kun was shocked to see a calm looking child. He couldn't believe that he was thrown by a child.

Qin Ruiqi released his hand and then cupped his hands as he said, "You let me win."

The crowd was in an uproar, so awed that one couldn't speak.

"Wang Kun'er, you did it on purpose?" An old man looked suspicious.

Wang Kun put away the expression on his face and got up from the ground. He laughed hollowly as he patted the little guy's small shoulder, "Uncle won't fight with you."

Then he took his wallet out of his pocket, took out a 50 bill and handed it to the child, "Treat you breakfast." He had been in the army for nearly ten years. He couldn't be said to be ever-victorious, but he also wouldn't be thrown down by a seven or eight year old child. He was sure that the child had a strange kungfu. He just laughed to protect the child. Since the child had no relation to him, he couldn't do much. He waved his hand to the child and jogged away.

None of the old men and old women thought that Wang Kun was really thrown by a child. They only thought that he was pretending to be defeated in order to help the child who was separated from his family.

Qin Ruiqi recognized the "50" on the bill, but he didn't know how much silver the "50" was equivalent to in his original world. Hence, his conclusion was: more money, the better.

"White Spot, you do it too."

White Spot was indeed the "dog" Qin Mian had seen in his previous life. It had been in this world for a period of time before and knew that its enormous real form could easily cause panic. At this time, it was only the

size of an adult dog. It first stood upright and then did a handstand. After it did a tap dance, it straightened up and bowed toward the crowd with its two forelegs folded in front of its chest.

The old men and old women were immediately amused. They all generously tipped; some tipped 5 and some 10.

An old lady kindly said, “Little guy, do you want Grandma to take you to the police station and ask the police uncle to help you find your family?”

Qin Ruiqi knew that the police station was the same place as the government office, but he thought that it was better not to run around and wait for the two fathers to find him. After refusing, he said his thanks and left with a pile of change.

His reaction had made many people think that he was instigated to trick. Seeing that he would soon go far away, they could only let go of the matter.

Qin Ruiqi counted the money he earned, which was 205 in total. He successfully bought two char siu buns at a breakfast shop. After a lot of effort, he found a roast duck shop and bought two roast ducks for White Spot. Wolves couldn’t eat cooked food, but White Spot was also a cultivator, so it was alright to eat cooked food.

It’s a bit expensive, Qin Ruiqi thought silently.

He looked behind him very casually. A man sneakily stalked him from the square.

Seeing that he was found out, the middle-aged man hesitated for two seconds before he put on a smile, walked over quickly, and kindly asked, “Little friend, why are you alone? Where are your parents?”

“Awoo!” White Spot threateningly looked at him and bared its teeth.

The man was frightened but gave Qin Ruiqi a gentle smile. “Little friend, Uncle bears no malice. Uncle saw you have no money to eat, so Uncle wants to help you.”

White Spot reminded Qin Ruiqi in a low voice, “Don’t believe him. He must be a human trafficker.”

Qin Ruiqi pressed down White Spot’s head and motioned it to squat down. He looked at the man with an ignorant look, “Really?”

The middle-aged man was overjoyed and beckoned, “Come with me. I’ll take you to eat a sumptuous meal.”

Qin Ruiqi nodded and walked over. Suddenly, he grabbed the man’s right arm with both hands, pushed his feet on the man’s back and climbed up. Then, he pressed down and easily pushed the man to the ground. At the same time, he locked the man’s other arm. With two cracking sounds, the man’s arms dislocated from his shoulder blades.

The man screamed and blood oozed out of his chin. Because his arms couldn’t work, he couldn’t get up on the ground, cutting a sorry figure. He stared at Qin Ruiqi resentfully, “Bad boy, you!”

Qin Ruiqi took out a gel pen and a small notebook from his sleeve pocket. He left a note of “human trafficker” on the man’s back, beckoned to White Spot, and quickly left.

Passers-by saw the note on the man’s back and called the police. The police station nearby quickly sent someone over and took the man back to check. It turned out, he was a human trafficker. Today, he just came from other places, wanting to avoid the limelight, but didn’t expect that he went to the road of ruin!

Meanwhile, in the neighboring city, Lei Ruilin and Golden Fur heaved a big sigh in the same manner.

“Kruk-kruk...” The sound came out from inside the belly. Lei Ruilin helplessly scratched his head, “I’m so hungry.”

The contents of his storage bracelet were almost the same as in Qin Ruilin’s. There were two juicy peaches; he and Golden Fur ate one each, but it didn’t curb their hunger at all. He knew that food could only be

obtained in places with many people, but the problem was that Golden Fur was too big. In the original world, many people were afraid of Golden Fur, and now it's the same in this strange world. If he left Golden Fur here alone, he would not be at ease.

“Golden Fur, if only you could get smaller, that'd be great.”

“Wu?” Golden Fur tilted its head and looked at him.

A streak of golden light flashed. Lei Ruilin rubbed his eyes in disbelief. Golden Fur actually became smaller. It used to be about 1000 Jin, but now it was only about 100 Jin at most. Although it was still a little big, it was much smaller than the real form.

“Haha, great! Let's go. Let's find something to eat.”

Lei Ruilin thought for a moment before he took out a leash from the storage bracelet and tied it to Golden Fur's neck. A human child and a bear left the woods together and walked along the road.

A royal blue SUV whistled past and then suddenly went backward. It stopped beside Lei Ruilin. When the car window was pressed down, a young man with blonde hair poked his head out and looked at Golden Fur with wide eyes. “Damn! Isn't this a bear?”

Lei Ruilin glanced at him and went on.

“The golden fur all over its body is so beautiful. It's like a golden wave when wind blows it!” Another young man pushed past and made that exclamation.

“Say, have you prepared the gift for Young Master Liu's birthday next month?” The young man with blond hair stared at the Golden Bear and asked pointedly.

A young man in the driver's seat had an understanding look on his face. He pointed his chin toward Golden Fur. “Yunzhao, do you want to...”

The blond-haired young man nodded. It was unknown what he was thinking as he looked complacent.

Lei Ruilin was alert when he heard the approaching footsteps.

Lu Yunzhao and the other two blocked the child's exit and stood a little far in case the brown bear attacked them.

“Kid, where are your family's adults?”

Lei Ruilin asked with a smile, “What noble business does big brother have?”

Lu Yunzhao said, “Take me to your parents. As long as your family's adults are willing to sell me this bear, I can give them a lot of money, enough to buy a lot of things. Do you understand?”

Light flashed past Lei Ruilin's eyes, “Not selling.”

Lu Yunzhao frowned, a little impatient, “You, an underaged kid, can't decide on this. Take me to your family's adults at once.”

“Golden Fur is a member of our family. It's not for sale.” Lei Ruiqi didn't want to talk more nonsense with him and planned to bypass them to leave.

“Wait!” Lu Yunzhao reached for him.

Lei Ruilin's figure flashed and started to run at once, “Golden Fur, run!”

Chapter 211: The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (3)

211 – The Vagrancy of Yuanyuan and Manman (3)

“Get in the car and chase!” cried Lu Yunzhao.

Lei Ruilin frowned. The car must run faster than him. To get rid of them, there was only one way—

He turned and ran back. Before Lu Yunzhao and the two men got in the car, he quickly stunned them, and then made a face at them before quickly slipping away with Golden Fur.

Lu Yunzhao couldn't move, his eyes widened, “Damnit! Why can't I move?”

“Me too!” Zhang Zixuan also exclaimed, “Shit! Are we being hit at a certain acupoint?”

Zhang Ting's mouth opened wide, “Frick! No way—how long will it take?”

Lu Yunzhao first responded, “Hey, kid, hey! Let us go, quickly.”

From the distance came the child's prepubescence voice of gloat, “Heehee! Rest assured, you can move in twelve [ancient] periods!”

Zhang Zixuan asked gloomily, “How long are twelve periods?”

Lu Yunzhao said with uncertainty, “Twelve hours?”

“It’s twenty four hours!” Lu Yunzhao glanced at the scorching sun above his head and said, “So we’ll be basking here all the time?”

The other two had a bitter face, looking at the curious passers-by, not interested in answering his question.

Lu Yunzhao said to a young man of his age, “Hey brother, we can’t move here. Could you please take out the mobile phone in my pocket and make a call for me?”

The young man glanced at the three people and didn’t believe what he said. “Are you recording a prank show, trying to capture the different reactions of passers-by?”

You’re overthinking. Lu Yunzhao said helplessly, “We really can’t move. We’ve been hit on a certain acupoint. Please do me a favor.”

“Hit on a certain acupoint?” A girl laughed in disbelief, “Are you kidding? What era is it now? You’re thinking of shooting a chivalrous drama?”

Zhang Zixuan was a little weak, “Pretty lady, just take it as we’re doing a prank. Do us a favor?”

Nowadays, there were so many swindlers in this society, if one got into a trap, it would be bad. The girl hesitated for a moment before she turned and left.

Lu Yunzhao left his hope on the young man.

The young man paused for a moment and turned to leave. “I remember that I have things to do.”

Lu Yunzhao:

Lei Ruilin, who had run far away, couldn’t help laughing when he remembered the strange postures of the three people. At the same time, he also realized that Golden Fur was still too eye-catching even after getting smaller.

“Golden Fur, can you be smaller?”

In fact, this was the result of Qin Mian and Lei Tie being too cautious. Because they were worried that the two children’s use of spiritual formulas in front of outsiders would arouse suspicion, they only taught the two children how to refine spiritual qi into vital energy force and did not teach them to use various spiritual formulas. Otherwise, Lei Ruilin only needed a spiritual formula to disguise Golden Fur as something else.

Golden Fur shook its head, stood up straight, and made a movement with its forelegs.

Lei Ruilin asked, “You mean, you need spiritual qi, or else you can’t do it?”

Golden Fur nodded.

Lei Ruilin had gotten an idea. He brought Golden Fur to the remote place and took off the jade pendant on his neck. This was the spiritual weapon that Old Dad made for him. It was compressed with spiritual qi, for his convenience to cultivate at any time.

Golden Fur kept the jade pendant in its mouth. After a while, its body shrunk again to the size of an adult cat.

“Golden Fur, you’re awesome!” Lei Ruilin praised it with satisfaction. He put on the jade pendant again and picked it up with a smile.

Lei Ruilin didn’t know that there were electronic eyes almost everywhere in this world. Fortunately, there were no electronic eyes around here.

Lei Ruilin walked forward quickly with Golden Fur in his arms. Following the fragrance aroma, he came to a KFC restaurant. Smelling the attractive aroma, he secretly swallowed.

He looked around and his eyes fell on a woman about fifty years old. The woman’s face was soft and her eyes were kind; she was gently saying something to a little boy beside her.

Lei Ruilin straightened his shirt and walked over with Golden Fur in his arms.

“Grandma.”

The woman was slightly stunned, and then gently asked, “What’s it?”

Lei Ruilin grinned with a shy blush, “Grandma, I’m hungry, but I don’t have money. If I do you a favor, can you please treat me to this...”

Wang Lan especially brought her grandson to KFC today. She didn’t expect to meet such an interesting little guy. She looked at him up and down, glanced at his jade jewelry, and said with a smile, “Little guy, you look really good. Okay, first of all, what can you do for me?”

The boy beside her and the people in the nearby seats looked at him curiously.

Lei Ruilin showed a trace of pride on his face. After staring at Wang Lan’s face for a moment, he asked, “Does grandma’s body feel discomfort anywhere?”

Wang Lan was taken aback, “You can tell from my complexion?”

Lei Ruilin was very smart. From his first appearance in this world to now, he had not found any energy in a human body, so he was very cautious. It was not good to say that he could even tell from the sound of her breath and heartbeat. He just said, “Yes. Grandma, can I check your pulse?”

Wang Lan merely played along with him, so she mindlessly nodded and extended her hand.

Lei Ruilin put his fingers on her pulse for a moment and then released her hand. “Does grandma often have chest tightness, short of breath, difficulty breathing, and cough? Especially at night and early in the morning.”

Wang Lan was surprised and immediately became suspicious. She couldn’t believe that a seven or eight year old child could really have such excellent medical skills. She immediately thought that it might be the adults in the

child's family who knew her. Therefore, the child had heard of her situation from the adults and played with her intentionally. It was even possible that the adults behind the child investigated her.

Before she could speak, the little boy beside her nodded, "Yes, yes. Gege is so amazing."

Lei Ruilin saw that the woman was suspicious. He felt somewhat helpless, but didn't show it on his face, "I really can tell from the pulse."

At the side, a young man with a fair complexion looked at Wang Lan's expression and asked curiously, "Is this child really got it right?"

Wang Lan nodded, but her doubts did not go away.

The young man looked at Lei Ruilin for a moment; his heart jolted. He reached out his hand and said with a smile, "Little brother, check my pulse, too? If you're right, I'll treat you and your pet to KFC until you're full."

Lei Ruilin nodded, felt his pulse and said confidently, "You have a palpitation illness. When the illness occurs, you get palpitations, difficulty breathing, chest pain, and even cough up blood." This palpitation was equivalent to modern heart disease.

The young man was surprised and pleased. "You're right! You, little imp, can truly tell."

Several customers nearby could not help suspecting that the young man was a decoy and glanced at him contemptuously.

But the young man didn't pay them any attention. He asked Lei Ruilin, "I have a congenital heart disease. Is there a way to cure it?"

Lei Ruilin thought, "My Dad can cure. I haven't mastered medicinal skill yet."

"Really?" asked the young man excitedly.

Lei Ruilin was somewhat helpless, "Why should I lie to you?"

The young man immediately asked, “Where is your Dad now?”

Lei Ruilin crossed his arms in front of his chest and said, “You said that if I’m right, you’ll treat Golden Fur and me to eat KFC.”

“I meant what I said. Let’s go and see what you want to eat.” The young man stood up and took his hand.

Lei Ruilin was even hungrier when he looked at the lifelike patterns on the publicity pictures. Qin Mian had taught him simplified Chinese, so the words on it didn’t overwhelm him. He said unceremoniously, “I want each of the things in the pictures.” As he spoke, he noticed the young man’s face.

The young man didn’t change his expression and paid for what he ordered.

Lei Ruilin saw someone washing hands at the hand washing table in the corner. “I’ll go wash my hands first.”

He didn’t understand the meaning of “sensor faucet”. When he saw other people put their hands under the faucet and then the water came out, he was surprised, but looked calm on the surface.

Back to the previous seat, the young man was already sitting there with Lei Ruilin’s spicy chicken wings, hamburgers, French fries, and so on all on two plates.

To Lei Ruilin’s surprise, Wang Lan was still there.

“Thank you.” After thanking the young man, Lei Ruilin picked up the chicken drumstick and ate it. He planned to feed Golden Fur after going out so as not to stain the floor.

The young man said with a smile, “You’re welcome. My name is Lin Feng. May I ask where your Dad is now?”

Lei Ruilin’s answer was very straightforward this time, “My Dad and I are separated, that’s why I don’t have money to buy food.”

Lin Feng hesitated for a long time before he asked, “Can your Dad really cure my illness?”

Lei Ruilin nodded, “Of course! Once, someone was poisoned by a strange poison. The most famous doctors in the world couldn’t detoxify it, but it was finally detoxified by my Dad.”

Lin Feng said actively, “Do you know your Dad’s phone number? I’ll lend you a phone so you can call him.”

Lei Ruilin opened his mouth wide, “Don’t have.”

Lin Feng did not give up, “Where do you live? I’ll take you back.”

“My home...” Lei Ruilin silently sighed. Of course, his home was in Green Mountain Village, but there were many high-rise buildings everywhere. It was obvious that he was not in the same world as his home. Even if he told this person his address, this person couldn’t send him back.

Lin Feng only thought that the child was wary of him and asked tentatively, “Or else, I’ll take you to the police station and let the police take you home?”

Lei Ruilin repeatedly shook his head, “No need, thank you. My Dad and Old Dad will certainly find me.”

Lin Feng had no choice but to ask directly, “If I want to ask your Dad to treat me, how can I find him?”

Lei Ruilin knew that the best way was to let Lin Feng take him away. However, he didn’t need to guess to know that Lin Feng would suspect he cheated him for food and drink. He thought about it and said, “Dad said that *a water drop of kindness should be returned with a gushing spring*. You’ve treated me and Golden Fur to a meal, I’ll repay you. When my Dad and Old Dad find me, I’ll leave a note at the counter with the detailed address or phone number. If you believe me, you can come and check it every day. Or else, you can tell me your phone number.”

Chapter 212: The Family Has No More Secret

212 – The Family Has No More Secret

Lin Feng heard him speak in a well-organized and articulate manner, and felt that he was not a child of ordinary people. A little hope floated in his heart. He nodded, “Okay, I’ll come to check it at any time. Also, this is my business card.”

Lei Ruilin took the business card, put it into the sleeve pocket, and continued to eat the chicken drumstick. After eating two pairs of chicken wings and two hamburgers, Lei Ruilin was full. He thanked Lin Feng again, asked the staff in the restaurant to pack the rest of the food, and carried the package, “Golden Fur, let’s go.”

After leaving the restaurant, Lei Ruilin took out a chicken roll from the package and fed it to Golden Fur. Golden Fur’s dietary habit had already changed unknowingly; it ate the chicken roll with relish. It had gotten smaller, so its belly also had gotten smaller. It shook its head after eating another crispy chicken burger.

Lei Ruilin walked forward with it, unhurried.

Wang Lan came out of the restaurant and stared at his back for a while. She shook her head with a somewhat ridiculing look. Did she really believe that someone can cure asthma? She took her grandson’s hand and went in the opposite direction.

Seeing many children playing in the park, Lei Ruilin walked over with interest.

Chen Yue was a film director. As of late, he was going to shoot a big movie. One of the characters was an eight year old child. Although it was not the main character, it played a crucial role in the movie. For this reason, Chen Yue held a special audition. However, he was not satisfied with all the auditioners. For Chen Yue who pursued perfection, except for “corpse”, any role in the film including the extras who only needed to walk with their backs to the camera once couldn’t just be made do with. The reason why Chen Yue appeared in the park was to see if he could find the right person.

He seized the swing in the park, sat on it, and turned a blind eye to the reproach from several adults who brought the children to play in the park.

Right here, he saw a seven or eight year old child swinging around with the [gymnastic] rings. Effortlessly and smoothly, he turned upside down and flipped over in two rounds on the rings. His grin was full of dexterity. Next to him, there was a little golden animal jumping around happily.

Chen Yue just felt a flash in front of his eyes before he jumped off the swing and said excitedly, “It’s him!”

Lei Ruilin was having a good time when he heard a man standing behind him calling, “Kid.”

He glanced back and fell to the ground silently, looking curiously at the middle-aged man in front of him.

Chen Yue looked at the child’s ancient costume and thought to himself, *which production team did the kid just come from?*

“What’s your name, little one?”

Lei Ruilin turned his back and said, “Shouldn’t your Excellency introduce yourself before asking others?”

Chen Yue raised his eyebrows in amusement. “My name is Chen Yue.”

“This junior is Lei Ruilin.” Lei Ruilin asked, “What advice does Senior have?”

His temperament made the light in Chen Yue's eyes more and more bright, "Little one, are you interested in shooting a film?"

Although Qin Mian had talked about many things in this world, Lei Ruilin didn't know what it was to shoot a movie. He said perfunctorily, "You should talk to my Dad and Old Dad about this."

"Dad and Old Dad?" There was a strange feeling in Chen Yue's heart, but he didn't think much about it. "Where are your Dad and Old Dad?"

Qin Mian and Lei Tie first caught their youngest son's spiritual sense and appeared invisible in the corner. Qin Mian looked around and made sure that there was no electronic eye around. Then he looked at Lei Tie; his mind moved. He kissed the scar on Lei Tie's face and put his right thumb on it. A soft white light flashed with it. When his thumb left, the scar on Lei Tie's face disappeared. Qin Mian raised a touch of appreciation and pride in his eyes and gave him a thumbs up. "Handsome!"

Lei Tie's lips curved slightly before he bowed and printed them on Qin Mian's head.

The two showed up together, wearing the same clothes as before, but used illusion to mask them. In the eyes of outsiders, they were wearing normal casual clothes.

Seeing his youngest son's back, Qin Mian called out in a raised voice, "Ruilin."

The Golden Eagle flapped its wings and flew to Lei Ruilin.

Lei Ruilin turned his head in a pleasant surprise and rushed over like a small cannonball.

"Dad! Old Dad!"

Chen Yue looked up; there was a strong appreciation seen in his eyes. The two young men standing not far away were both Dragon and Phoenix¹ among the people. The man on the left was handsome with elegant

demeanor; the man on the right was attractive with cold temperament. *Tsk, no matter who these two people are, once they enter showbiz, they are bound to set off a storm in the entertainment industry.*

Qin Mian spread out his arms, hugged his little son, and looked him up and down, “Son, did you get hurt?”

“No.” Lei Ruilin hugged him with a broad smile.

“Are you scared, being separated from us for so long?” Qin Mian asked again.

Lei Ruilin shook his head without hesitation. “No, I know that Dad and Old Dad will find me!”

“You’re truly awesome.” Qin Mian gave him a look of approval.

Lei Ruilin held his head high and looked proud.

“Dad, where’s my Gege?” Lei Ruilin was a little worried. “Gege and I were together at first, but we were separated later.”

“He’s fine. We’ll go to him now.” Qin Mian rubbed his head.

Chen Yue walked over.

Lei Tie looked at him indifferently.

Chen Yue had met all kinds of people, so he did not care and was very polite, “Hello. I’m Chen Yue, a film director. Ruilin is very suitable for a role in my film. I wonder if we can sit down and have a chat?”

“I’m sorry, we have an urgent business to deal with.” Qin Mian declined and took Lei Ruilin by the hand to leave.

Chen Yue quickly stopped him, “Wait. This is my calling card. I’m not a liar. I hope you can think about it seriously.”

Qin Mian thought about it and accepted the card. “We’ll think about it. Goodbye.”

Chen Yue regretfully watched them go farther and farther. He had an impulse to keep up with them, but rationally restrained himself and turned to leave.

Instead of taking any transportation, the three people and one bear flew directly to the neighboring city.

Qin Ruiqi was sleeping on the bench with White Spot squatting aside to guard him.

Seeing this scene, Qin Mian was both distressed and relieved.

Lei Tie quietly walked over and picked up his eldest son.

Smelling the familiar smell, Qin Ruiqi immediately opened his eyes. When he saw the person holding him, he smiled and clasped the person’s neck tightly, “Old Dad.”

“En.” After Lei Tie confirmed that his eldest son was not injured, he nodded to his wife.

“Dad, Ruilin.” Qin Ruiqi greeted his other father and younger brother and signaled his Old Dad to put him down.

Qin Mian hugged his eldest son, “Are you hungry?” While on the way, he had heard his youngest son talk about his experience in the restaurant, so his youngest son should not be hungry at the moment.

“No, I’ve eaten steamed buns.” Qin Ruiqi then told his story.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other with a proud smile on their faces and in their eyes. Both sons did very well.

Qin Mian took his two sons by hand and said, “Let’s go and buy clothes first, and then have a good meal.”

Lei Ruilin asked with concern, “Dad, do you have money?”

Qin Mian laughed, “My son ah, don’t worry. Your Dad, I, have money no matter where I am.” He thought that the 200,000 yuan cash in the space could only be used as waste paper, but now it came in handy.

The family of four came to a large shopping mall. Qin Mian bought only one set of clothes for each of them and put them on directly; then, he bought four mobile phones for the family. Later, they went to the jade store and Qin Mian sold a piece of jade that was awarded by Emperor Xiaohui.

Qin Mian was not sure that they would ever return to Great Xia, so he planned to complete all the family’s documents, including household registration and ID cards.

Qin Mian was most familiar with S City. The family flew to S City first. Qin Mian used the means of Cultivation of Trueness to control the staff of the Household Registration Administrative Office to fix the household registration of the family of four. Qin Mian, Qin Ruilin, and Lei Ruilin were in the same household register. Lei Tie could only be aggrieved and had a separate household register.

After that, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went to apply for their ID cards.

After getting these certificates, the family was busy looking for a house. The house they liked was in the park community, consisting of a master bedroom, three secondary bedrooms, a dining room, a living room, a kitchen, a bathroom, and a sundry room, with a total of 200 square meters, 26000 yuan per square meter. In addition to buying furniture and a car, 6 million was spent.

It was the fifth day when life was completely settled. In these five days, Qin Mian never forgot to teach Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin to learn modern knowledge and use modern tools and appliances, including transportation, communication, and household appliances. Lei Tie and his sons soon adapted to modern life.

Qin Mian pulled Lei Tie into the bedroom while his two sons were watching TV.

“A-Tie, let’s tell Ruiqi and Ruilin about the space.”

“Have decided?” Lei Tie asked.

Qin Mian nodded. “Now, Ruiqi and Ruilin have a profound understanding of the differences between different worlds. They must understand how serious the consequences will be if the mysterious existence of the space is exposed. I believe they can keep the secret.”

Lei Tie embraced Qin Mian’s shoulder and nodded, “Then tell them, and also tell them about Cultivation of Trueness.”

“Alright.” Qin Mian opened the door and beckoned to his two sons, “Sons, come here.”

Lei Tie went to the window and closed the curtains.

“Dad, what’s the matter?” Qin Ruiqi asked in puzzlement.

“Take you to a place.” Qin Mian held the elder son’s hand, while Lei Tie held the youngest son’s.

The next second, four people appeared in the space.

Learning of the existence of the space and the inside information of their birth, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were suddenly enlightened and all the previous questions had been answered.

The brothers soon figured out why the two fathers had concealed the space from them. With the principle of “one’s only crime was only to carry a jade”², they understood it all.

“Dad and Old Dad can rest assured that Didi and I will not tell anyone about the space.” Qin Ruiqi said.

Lei Ruilin repeatedly nodded, “This is our family’s secret.”

Lei Tie told them that the kungfu they usually practice was not the art of building one's strength through internal organs, but Cultivation of Trueness.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at the two fathers with admiration. It turned out that the two fathers were more amazing than they knew.

The two boys had a natural love for the space. Qin Mian and Lei Tie accompanied them to play in the space for three days.

Thanks for the treat and message, Tuc Tuc! *I didn't notice as I rarely check email.*

Footnotes

1. fine offspring
2. Being wealthy can invite disaster

Chapter 213: Gratitude

213 – Gratitude

It was now July. To be exact, it was the time for students to have their summer vacation. Qin Mian didn't arrange for Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to attend school. For the time being, the boys had a private tutor to teach them 5th Grade curriculum; the classes were held from 8 to 11 in the morning everyday. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were eight years old. Normally, they should be in 3rd Grade, but both of them were very smart. Their knowledge was almost equal to that of the 5th Grade students. Qin Mian didn't deliberately increase their learning intensity nor suppress their progress rate. The tutor would teach as much as they could learn. In short, he let nature take its course.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin had a good relationship, so Qin Mian put them in the same bedroom with two sets of beds, writing desks and wardrobes. The other two bedrooms were made into a guest room and a study. There were a writing board and two sets of desks in the study, which made up a classroom.

When Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were in class, Qin Mian held a business card in his hand and made a phone call on the balcony.

Lei Tie was not at home. He had been learning to drive in the driving school these days.

After the call got through, a polite voice came from the other end, "Hello, who is this?"

"Are you Lin Feng?" Qin Mian said, "I'm Lei Ruilin's father."

The harsh sounds of the chair legs rubbing against the ground and the chair falling to the ground were heard in the phone call, followed by an excited voice, “I’m Lin Feng! Hello, Mister Lei!”

“My surname is Qin.” Qin Mian said, “Mister Lin, thank you for treating my son to a meal. I’ve heard my son talk about you and have a general understanding of your illness, but I can’t make a conclusion until I check your pulse personally. I wonder if Mister Lin is free these days?”

“Yes, yes!” Lin Feng said, “Mister Qin, I’m free any time.”

Qin Mian could understand the other person’s feelings, “So, how about we meet at 2 o’clock tomorrow afternoon at the entrance of the KFC restaurant on Fuyuan Road, S City?”

“No problem.”

Lei Tie learned to drive very quickly and didn’t go to the driving school the next day. After Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin’s class, the family of four drove to the restaurant. Their car was a black SUV, which gave people a rough, stylish and heroic feeling. Qin Mian and Lei Tie liked it very much.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin sat in the backseat. Lei Ruilin described the spicy chicken wings he ate that day to his Gege. Qin Ruilin didn’t say a word, but his gentle eyes showed that he was listening to his Didi’s words.

After parking the car in the parking lot, the family of four walked diagonally to the restaurant across the way.

Passers-by had all eyes on them, full of appreciation. The group of four was excellent both in appearance and attire. Qin Mian had sunglasses on his head, dressed in a black short sleeve T-shirt and a white capri pants, looking handsome and easy-going; Lei Tie was dressed in a white V-neck long sleeves with sunglasses hung at the collar and matched with a black slim-fit suit and jeans of the same color with a red and black plaid belt, looking coldly charming, just like a celebrity; Qin Ruilin and Lei Ruilin wore identical baseball caps and identical light blue and silver sports outfits with

cartoon waist bags hung on their waist. They also got a 100% rate of turning heads.

Entering the restaurant, Lei Ruilin, just like he had been here before, took Qin Ruiqi to the ordering counter.

“Gege, this way.”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie followed, unhurriedly.

The people in the restaurant couldn't help staring at them. Especially the young girls; their admiring eyes toured on the two men as they exchanged confidential whispers with their friends.

“Ruiqi and Ruilin, what do you want to eat?” Qin Mian put his arm around his eldest son's shoulder and asked.

Qin Ruiqi said, “Daddy, Old Daddy¹; I want a family bucket, a pair of spicy chicken wings and a Coke.”

These two forms of address made people around a little surprised. *It turns out that these two are.....*

No matter where they were, Qin Mian would not deny his relationship with Lei Tie and his two sons. With a smile on the corner of his lips and an indifferent face, he turned a blind eye to other people's complex expression.

Lei Tie's face was expressionless; there was no one except Qin Mian, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin in his eyes.

Qin Mian looked at Lei Tie with a happy smile. Lei Tie understood and took out his wallet to pay.

Some girls looked back with disappointment, while others were excited. They peeked at Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Their eyes were more intense as they swept around the family of four.

“Ruilin boy.” After Lin Feng was sure that he didn't recognize the wrong person, he quickly walked over.

The man who had been sitting with him also kept up.

Lei Ruilin saw Lin Feng and nodded politely.

“Daddy, Old Daddy; this is the mister who treated me to KFC.”

Qin Mian politely shook hands with Lin Feng, “Mister Lin, thank you for your help to my son.”

“You’re welcome, Mister Qin. It’s just a little help.” Lin Feng eagerly said, “Mister Qin, I heard Ruilin say…….”

Lei Tie gave him a cold glance and frowned.

The man beside Lin Feng noticed it; he pulled Lin Feng’s arm and said, “A-Feng, why are you anxious? Mister Qin’s family hasn’t had lunch yet.”

Only then Lin Feng saw Lei Tie’s displeasure. It was obvious that Qin Mian specially brought his family to KFC restaurant for lunch, so that was why the appointment was set at 2 o’clock. It was he who came early. He said apologetically, “Sorry, I was in a moment of desperation. Mister Qin, I won’t delay you. We’ll talk later.”

Qin Mian said with a smile, “Do as you wish.”

Lin Feng and his friend went back to their original seats and ordered two sets of meals. It was just that, they didn’t have appetite.

Smelling the smell of Coke, Lei Tie looked away uninterested.

Qin Ruiqi didn’t notice it. There were four Cokes, one for each.

Qin Mian put his hand on Lei Tie’s thigh and winked at him with gloat.

Lei Tie gave him a doting look. He still took a sip and frowned, feeling unaccustomed. He watched his two sons drink it with relish and could not understand their taste at all. He pushed the Coke to his wife and said, “Wife, help me drink it.”

Qin Mian put his cup into Lei Tie's hand and said straightforwardly, "I don't like it either."

Lei Tie had no choice but to drink up the two cups. His brows were creasing all the time, as if he was drinking bitter herbs.

Qin Mian simmered in laughter and put a spicy chicken wing into Lei Tie's mouth.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin couldn't stop laughing.

Lin Feng and his friend were absent-minded. They saw the family over there had finished their meals before they went over.

"Let's talk about it somewhere else?" Qin Mian asked.

The restaurant was not really a place to talk about things. Lin Feng said, "Okay. There's a coffee shop not far away."

They sat down in the coffee shop and introduced themselves.

Together with Lin Feng was his good friend, Liu Yingchu. Qin Mian looked so young that Liu Yingchu didn't hold much hope for his medical skills, so he only looked at him lightly.

Qin Mian said directly, "I'll check your pulse first."

Lin Feng put his hand on the table without hesitation.

After checking the pulse, Qin Mian nodded, "Can cure."

Liu Yingchu straightened up and stared at him.

Lin Feng grasped the edge of the table in both hands, surprised and pleased, "Really?"

Qin Mian didn't mind him bearing suspicions. He reached out to Qin Ruiqi, "Son, pen and paper."

Qin Ruiqi took out a ballpoint pen and a notepad and handed them to him.

Qin Mian wrote a prescription, tore it off, and handed it to Lin Feng, “Here is the prescription. Also, there is a supplementary medicine that I made myself but didn’t bring with me. You decide for yourself whether you want it or not.” The implication was that this prescription was free of charge, but there was a charge for the supplementary medicine.

Lin Feng read the prescription and Liu Yingchu took it. Liu Yingchu looked at Qin Mian in surprise. There was a so-called “prolonged illness makes a doctor of a patient”. He and Lin Feng were childhood friends. He also knew some medical knowledge by the influence of what he saw and heard. This prescription basically had no problem and very likely to be an ancient prescription.

He nodded slightly to Lin Feng.

Lin Feng said, “Thank you, Mister Qin. However, I have to discuss this with my family. I’ll contact you later.” In fact, he needed to ask the experts to take a look at this prescription.

Qin Mian knew better, “Sure, you know my phone number.”

Lin Feng couldn’t wait to find out if the prescription could be used. After a few polite exchanges, he and Liu Yingchu left in a hurry.

Two days later, Lin Feng called and offered to spend 1 million yuan on the supplementary medicine. Qin Mian gave him a jar of spiritual spring water and dyed it brown with mild herbal juice. On the ground that Lin Feng had helped his son, he gave him a 20% discount and only accepted 800,000 yuan.

Qin Mian and his family went out to have a sumptuous meal. Chinese cuisine, Italian cuisine, and French cuisine came in turns in the morning, afternoon, and evening.

At dinner, Lei Tie’s mood was quite subtle.

“A-Tie, what are you thinking about?” Qin Mian ate a delicious fried foie gras and squinted.

Lei Tie’s answer was concise, “How to make money to support the family.”

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin completely understood their Old Daddy’s uncomfortable mood. They smiled and looked at each other. They did not participate in the dialogue between the two fathers and enjoyed the delicious food wholeheartedly.

“Er...” Qin Mian supported his chin with one hand as his brain spurned. Every man wanted to have a career, but he couldn’t figure out what his family’s poker face was suitable for.

When Lei Tie saw Qin Mian looking like that, he calmed down, “Not urgent, eat first.”

Chapter 214: Audition

V5: 214 – Audition

In the afternoon, the Qin Mian family did not go out. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were watching TV in the living room.

Lei Tie was sitting on the sofa with his legs folded and a notebook computer on his legs. He skillfully slid his right hand on the touch screen. He didn't look like a person who had just learned how to use a notebook computer for three days. The look in his eyes staring intently at the screen was full of fascination.

Qin Mian came out of the kitchen with a plate of cut fruits, feeling inexplicably jealous of the notebook on the man's knees. He walked over and sat on the armrest of the sofa, staring at the man without saying a word.

Lei Tie raised his head with a little smile in his eyes. He put the notebook on the coffee table, hugged his wife's waist, gently gathered the person into his arms and sealed his lips.

Qin Mian's eyes widened. He squinted at his two sons, making sure that their attention was still on the TV program before he relaxed, put his arms around the man's shoulder, and responded attentively.

"Go to the bedroom?" Lei Tie's hoarse voice gently blew into Qin Mian's cochlea.

Qin Mian shuddered, gasped and shook his head. "It's still daytime..." He said so, yet lingered on the man's lips, sucking it hard before he sat down beside the man, acting as if nothing had happened. Their hot hands were still tightly clasped to relieve the impulse in their bodies.

“Daddy.” Lei Ruilin pulled Qin Ruiqi’s hand and went to Qin Mian.

“What’s the matter?” Qin Mian pulled out his hand, held out the fruit plate, and signaled his two sons to eat some fruits.

“Daddy, I want to act in a film. Gege also wants to.” Lei Ruilin pointed to the TV where a little boy was crying with grievance in the corner. He was very excited.

Qin Mian thought of the man who claimed to be a film director he met last time. “Why did you suddenly think of this?”

Lei Ruilin said, “It’s very fun to act in a film.”

Qin Mian asked his eldest son, “Ruiqi, are you also interested?”

Qin Ruiqi nodded, “If there’s an opportunity, I want to try it.”

Lei Tie searched for “Chen Yue” on the Internet. There were photos of the person he did meet in the park; in addition, he was a well-known film director in China. He had directed many popular films, among which “Borrowed Heart” released in 2011 was number one in the mainland box office’s chart, and was still at the top of the list.

Both Qin Mian and Lei Tie had the ability to protect their two children. Since the boys were interested in acting, there was no reason not to let them experience it.

“You can, but once you participate in a series of shooting activities, your study time will lessen. Your Old Daddy and I won’t ask you to be first and second in the exam, but we don’t want you to be the bottom of the class afterward.” Qin Mian’s words were mild but severe.

Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin looked at each other with confidence.

Qin Ruiqi took the lead in saying, “Daddy can be at ease.”

“Gege and I will supervise each other.” Lei Ruilin said immediately.

Qin Mian found Chen Yue's business card and dialed it according to the phone number.

"Who is it?" The voice on the other side was a little agitated.

Qin Mian said, "Hello, Director Chen. We met in the park last time."

"You are the little friend Lei Ruilin's father!" Chen Yue asked in surprise, "Did you agree with what I said last time?"

Qin Mian did not deny that, "My son is interested to be filmed, but he has no experience in acting."

"It doesn't matter. He can learn." Chen Yue decisively said, "I'm in S City now. There's an audition session here. You should come over now."

"The address is? Okay, goodbye."

The family sorted things out and drove to the address given by Chen Yue. Lei Tie had gotten his driver's license. Since he got the license, he was basically the chauffeur of the family when they went out.

Chen Yue was famous for his superb insight in the showbiz milieu. The candidates he settled on after the audition hardly were unfit. After seeing Lei Ruilin last time, the "Tuan Tuan" in Chen Yue's mind was exactly Lei Ruilin. Anyone else who came to act as Tuan Tuan made him feel stress, not because their appearance was unfit but their temperament was. After leaving his business card to Lei Ruilin's father that day, he didn't receive the other party's phone call. Under exasperation, he had to hold an audition again. Time was money, the investor couldn't wait for him indefinitely. Fortunately, at the critical moment, he got to hear the good news nevertheless.

Zhang Qiong, the Assistant Director, and Sun Jianwen, the representative sent by the investor, noticed that Chen Yue was obviously excited after he received the phone call.

Zhang Qiong said, “Director Chen, what happy event did you chance upon? All the wrinkles come out to join in the fun.”

“You’ll see in a moment.” Chen Yue didn’t tell the truth. Lei Ruilin’s external image and personality were very suitable, but whether he had flexibility in acting or not, one could tell after his audition.

He took out his mobile phone and sent a text message to Assistant Xiao Zhou, asking him to insert Lei Ruilin’s name into the audition list.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin came to Huihong Building and went to the 18th floor. There were more than 30 young boys accompanied by adults in the large conference hall, all were seven to nine years old and excellent-looking. They were either standing or sitting; no one spoke. The atmosphere was quite tense.

When the adults saw Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, they all felt a little bit of impending crisis. The temperament and appearance of the two children were excellent.

Lei Ruilin was a little excited, but kept his equanimity and calmly sat in the chair.

Qin Ruiqi was clear that the director took a liking to his Didi. This time, he mainly followed to get experience.

A little boy in the company of his parents entered a room and then came out looking a little depressed.

A bespectacled middle-aged man pushed his glasses up on his nose bridge as he looked around the crowd, “Is Lei Ruilin here?”

“Here.” Lei Ruilin stood up and gave him a smile.

“It’s your turn.”

“Thank you.” Lei Ruilin thanked him politely.

When the middle-aged man saw that he and another boy were twins, his eyes stayed for a few more seconds.

Qin Mian stepped forward, “Hello, we’re his family. Can we go in together?”

“Of course.” The middle-aged man nodded.

As soon as Qin Mian’s family of four went in, Chen Yue, Zhang Qiong, and Sun Jianwen were all spontaneously impressed. The appearance and temperament of this family were so outstanding that any one of them could become popular in the entertainment industry. Simply put, they wouldn’t give other celebrities a way to survive.

Chen Yue stared at Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin for a while before he could tell which one was Lei Ruilin. Although the two brothers looked identical, their temperament was obviously different; Qin Ruiqi was cold, while Lei Ruilin was warm.

Qin Mian nodded to Chen Yue and stood aside with Lei Tie and Qin Ruilin.

Lei Ruilin boldly went to the middle, facing Chen Yue and the other two people, “Three uncles, my name is Lei Ruilin, eight years old. I came here to audition.”

Zhang Qiong nodded to himself, seeing that the boy with a calm bearing and quick-witted eyes had the feeling of Tuan Tuan up to 70%.

Chen Yue first told Lei Ruilin, “Little friend, you act a scene for us first. The role you’re playing is called Tuan Tuan. There’s a scene in the script where a villain comes to the door and tries to take a very important chip from your Gege, but your Gege has a gunshot wound. You need to draw the opponent’s attention to yourself.”

He asked Assistant Xiao Zhou and another staff member Xiao Liu to cooperate with Lei Ruilin and asked Lei Ruilin gently, “Can you start?”

After Lei Ruilin politely invited Xiao Zhou, who acted as his Gege, to stand in front of Chen Yue's group of three, he nodded to Chen Yue, "Ready."

Such a young child surprisingly had such a strong sense of camera shot. Chen Yue and Zhang Yuan looked at each other in pleasant surprise and signaled Xiao Liu.

Xiao Liu made a movement of kicking the door open with one foot and said to Xiao Zhou arrogantly, "Chen Kai, be sensible and hand in the microchip, otherwise, I'll humiliate you!"

Lei Ruilin's expression abruptly changed and he promptly hid behind Xiao Zhou. Immediately after, he seemed to realize that this reaction made him appear to be guilty of conscience. He leaned out half of his head from the back of Xiao Zhou's body, held his hands under his belly, and clamped his legs, making a posture of urgent need to urinate. He said to Xiao Zhou in a low voice, "Gege, I need to pee."

Xiao Zhou was stunned.

Lei Ruilin, however, did not wait for his reaction; he glanced at Xiao Liu guardedly and quickly forced his way out.

Xiao Liu subconsciously chased after him in a few steps before he returned to his senses and stopped.

Zhang Yuan couldn't hold back from clapping his hands, "Good!"

"He's the one. You don't have a problem, do you?" Chen Yue smiled and looked back and forth at Zhang Qiong and Sun Jianwen with eyes that allowed no question.

Zhang Qiong and Sun Jianwen both shook their heads. They were very satisfied with Lei Ruilin's performance and believed in Chen Yue's insight.

Lei Ruilin's role as Tuan Tuan had thus been decided.

Xiao Zhou came to Qin Mian with a folder, "Hello. Because Lei Ruilin isn't yet an adult, his guardian needs to sign the contract. Which of you is Lei

Ruilin's guardian?"

Qin Mian took out his and Lei Tie's credentials and handed them to him, "We both are."

Xiao Zhou looked at the credentials and nodded.

"Take a look at the contract and sign on the last page if there are no problems."

Qin Mian carefully read all the clauses and readily signed on the three contracts.

Xiao Zhou gave him the script, "This is the script. Let the child get familiar with it. We'll contact you when we start shooting."

Only until they got inside the car did Lei Ruilin cheer happily.

"I can be in a film!"

Qin Mian handed the contract to him with a smile, "See if you can understand it. Ruiqi, you can also have a look. If you have a chance to act in a film or TV drama in the future, it can be used as a reference."

The two brothers looked at the contents of the contract head to head.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had a discussion, "Our son's performance is good today. Why don't we eat out in the evening?"

Lei Tie said, "[They're] Not as good as your cooking."

Qin Mian felt proud of himself, "Really?"

"Hm." Lei Tie nodded.

Qin Mian was invigorated in both body and mind, "Okay, go home, I'll cook."

Chapter 215: Settling the Previous Accounts

V5: 215 – Settling the Previous Accounts

The next day, Qin Mian received a call from the crew asking him to take Lei Ruilin to the begin-shooting ceremony. This was Lei Ruilin's big day. Qin Mian's family of four appeared together in new clothes.

Chen Yue's begin-shooting ceremony was simple and solemn. He and the assistant director spoke a few sentences respectively. After offering a stick of incense, everyone worshiped, and the begin-shooting ceremony was considered over.

“Heart Caution” was a commercial film. The so-called commercial film was precisely a film for the highest purpose of earning box office's revenue that catered to the masses's preferences and appreciation standard. The male lead, Chen Haolong, which was the role of Tuan Tuan's elder brother, was currently the popular celebrity, Lin Xiang. He was not only handsome in appearance, but also first-class in acting. Because of Lin Xiang's tight schedule, the first day of shooting was mainly for his part. It was not time for Tuan Tuan to appear yet, but Xiao Zhou suggested that Lei Ruilin stay on the set. While he could find the feeling of acting, he could also learn from his senior's experiences in filming.

Lei Ruilin accepted his suggestion very willingly. His forthright attitude attracted many adults to be very fond of him.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Qin Ruiqi still stayed to accompany him.

“Heart Caution” was a science fiction film. The story took place in the futuristic world. It was about a scientist who, after years of crazy research, had discovered an equation that could enhance a human’s intelligence and physical strength by tampering with genes. He stored the equation in a special microchip. The microchip fell into the hands of acrobat Chen Haolong by accident, which led to a battle between Chen Haolong and a dark organization to seize the microchip. The film would combine a variety of commercial factors, such as popular movie stars, well-known directors, complex special effects, large investment, large-scale publicity, and so on. It could be predicted that it would once again set a high box office. Tuan Tuan appeared many times. According to the number of scenes, he was the third male lead in the film.

The first scene was relatively simple; it was the scene of Chen Haolong and the senior fellow apprentice of the acrobatic troupe making all manner of quips and jokes while comparing notes on skill.

With the guidance of a martial arts director, Lin Xiang passed this scene on first take. It could be considered as a warm-up.

Since Lei Ruilin was a child and a newcomer, it would not be good to get close to the director to watch the shooting effect on the screen. Qin Mian enlarged the screen with spiritual conjuration, making it like a projection in the air. Only he, Lei Tie, Qin Ruiqi, and Lei Ruilin could see it clearly.

With his superb acting skills, Lin Xiang has transformed from a big star with elegant temperament into Chen Haolong. In Lei Ruilin’s eyes, he was very novel and admired.

The second scene was the acrobatic performance of the acrobatic troupe. Because Lin Xiang often received scripts from different roles, he knew some martial arts skills, but he was not competent for acrobatic performance. Therefore, the real actor on the stage was the stuntman. Lin Xiang sat on the side to rest. His agent and assistant were around to take care of him. The agent took out a mobile phone and passed it to him, while the assistant handed him a towel and water.

Lei Ruilin and his Gege were whispering to each other.

Lei Ruilin did not have work on the first two days. Lei Tie put aside the matter of starting a career for the time being. Starting from the next day, he would take Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin to the set.

Qin Mian wanted to investigate what happened here after he transmigrated to Great Xia from the modern era. When he returned to the modern era, he pretended to be “Qin Mian’s good friend” and called the Qin family. It was confirmed that the original him was “unaccounted for” in the modern era. Qin Yongcheng suspected that he had an accident outside and called the police, but the police investigation had not made any progress so far.

Qin Mian couldn’t help but wonder if Qin Lian burnt his body to destroy the evidence after killing him.

Qin Mian already didn’t care about the people and affairs of the Qin family. But since Heaven let him return to the modern era, maybe there was an ordinance in the dark. When he thought that Qin Lian was still living comfortably off after trying to murder him, he felt ill at ease. Qin Lian did something wrong, so he should bear the consequences.

In fact, the story of Qin Mian’s mother and father was a very common case. Qin Mian’s mother went to work in a big city when she was young. The 17-year-old girl was young and naive. She was bewildered by Qin Mian’s father Qin Yongcheng’s sweet words and easily handed over her heart to him.

The Qin family was a business family. Qin Yongcheng’s father, Qin Aiguo, had a low sperm survival rate. Thus, he only bore an only son, Qin Yongcheng. The Qin family appeared to be weak in the business upsurge. Qin Yongcheng’s father naturally wanted to have his son marry with another business family. Qin Mian’s mother was pretty and pure. Qin Yongcheng did like her a little and had thought of marrying her. However, he liked the Qin family’s industry more. Knowing that his marriage partner was the eldest daughter of the Mo family, he agreed to the marriage without much hesitation. When Qin Mian’s mother heard the news, she finally saw Qin Yongcheng’s true face. She didn’t dare to tell him about her pregnancy and left secretly. But in the end, Qin Yongcheng had hurt her heart, and thereby hurt her body. Not long after Qin Mian was born, she died.

Qin Mian grew up with his maternal grandparents. When he was 15 years old, his grandparents' health had worsened. They were worried about him and took the initiative to contact Qin Yongcheng. After Qin Yongcheng confirmed that Qin Mian was his son, he took him back to the Qin family.

Not long after Qin Yongcheng married the Mo Family's eldest daughter Mo Feifei, she gave birth to a son, and that was Qin Lian. Qin Lian was only one year younger than Qin Mian.

Because Mo Feifei pampered Qin Lian, Qin Lian's temperament was not very good. Qin Mian was brought up by his grandparents and was the son of Qin Yongcheng's first love. After Qin Mian returned to the Qin family, Qin Yongcheng was quite good to Qin Mian. But no one thought that as Qin Mian and Qin Lian grew up, Qin Lian became more and more jealous of Qin Mian and more defensive, fearing that Qin Yongcheng would hand over the Qin family's industry to Qin Mian. Ultimately, he still extended his crime and pushed Qin Mian down the stairs. Judging from his fierce strength, it was obviously not unintentional.

Qin Mian pulled his thoughts away from his memory and drove to the original scene of the accident — the villa that Qin Yongcheng gave him. From afar, he saw someone watering the flowers on the second floor of the villa. The villa had most probably been sold to others. He drove away and came to the Haoyuan Group Building, the Qin family's company. He wanted to take a chance to see if he could see Qin Lian and gross him out at least.

There was no story without coincidences. After waiting for about three to four minutes, two people came out of the automatic rotating door on the first floor of the building. The person on the left was dressed in Western suits and leather shoes, looked pretentious with his head high and chest out, and had a contented look; that was Qin Lian. Walking next to him was an elegant-looking young woman with pear flower perm longhair, dressed in a desert-colored bodycon dress and stiletto heels which made the woman appear taller. From their occasional bumping shoulders, one could see that there was definitely an affair between them.

Qin Mian smiled meaningfully. He looked at his face in the mirror, which was almost the same as the original one. He opened the door and got out of the car. He put his hands in his pockets as he walked toward Qin Lian.

Qin Lian was talking and laughing with his secretary, Zhan Xiaomi when his eyes caught a glimpse of a man coming straight to his side. He cursed the man under his breath for not having eyes to look at where he was going. He frowned and looked up. When he saw the man's face, he was shocked. He froze in place, feeling anxious and doubtful.

“Qin Mian?”

Qin Mian was still unsure that he was “missing” rather than “dead”, so he didn't respond. He just stopped, looked at Qin Lian with a shadow of a smile, and pointedly glanced at Zhan Xiaomi with a profound attitude.

Qin Lian calmly sent Zhan Xiaomi away and looked at Qin Mian coldly, “Didn't you run away from home? What are you doing back here?”

“You must be so surprised that I'm back.” Seeing that his expression did not look like he was lying, Qin Mian patted him on the shoulder with a smile. “Since you dared to push me down the stairs, you should have thought that one day I would come back for revenge.”

Qin Lian paled. He looked around warily and said in a low voice, “What are you talking about? That's you who wasn't careful and rolled down the stairs!” At that time, he did plan to get rid of Qin Mian. But he must plan it thoroughly first by taking himself out and then do it, rather than doing it rashly. So, at that time when he pushed Qin Mian down the stairs, he was so shocked. Upon seeing the blood flowing steadily on Qin Mian's forehead, he was spooked out of his mind and his first reaction was to run away. When he came to his senses, it was the next morning. In the evening, he made up his mind to see if Qin Mian was dead or not. When he entered the villa, Qin Mian had disappeared. Even the pool of blood on the ground disappeared, leaving no trace. Up to now, Qin Lian was still a little flustered.

Qin Mian didn't know about the follow-up story. With a knowing expression, he said, "That's how you comfort yourself in the past two years, so you didn't have nightmares?"

"Don't talk nonsense." Qin Lian couldn't see through his smile. He felt guilty, but he had to guard against Qin Yongcheng's sudden appearance. Even if he tried to restrain it, his irritability still leaked on his face. "Let me tell you, Daddy has decided to leave the Qin family to me. Whatever your plans are, it's only your wishful thinking!"

"Where have your mind gone to?" Qin Mian replied ambiguously. "Give me both your and his phone numbers."

Qin Lian was very clear that if Qin Mian wanted to contact Qin Yongcheng, he could not stop it at all. He could only tell the phone numbers to him.

"What do you want to do?"

"What? No confidence in yourself?" Qin Mian was amused. The mobile phone in his pocket rang, and the call showed "Poker Face". He put on a warm smile on his lips, "A-Tie... Me? Outside, running into an 'old friend' and chatting a bit... How did Ruilin do? Okay... I'll go back now."

After the end of the call, he waved to Qin Lian smartly, "I've something to do, I'm leaving first. We'll have a meal some other day."

Qin Lian's face was as heavy as water. He watched coldly as Qin Mian's vigorous SUV went farther and farther after he got in the car.

"Ding~ding~dong..."

The mobile phone rang. As soon as Qin Lian glanced at it, he quickly put a decent smile on his cold face. "Young Master Yue, why are you calling me today?"

"What's your plan for Young Master Liu's birthday next month?" Yue Xiangkui's voice sounded utterly carefree.

Qin Lian gave a wry smile as his eyes showed a trace of contempt, but his tone was still very gentle, “Young Master Liu is not an easy master to serve. I don’t have any idea about it yet. Let’s meet and talk about it?”

“Okay, at the old place.”

Qin Lian quickly got in the car, slammed the door, and sped out, leaving only a cloud of exhaust smoke.

Chapter 216: A Day in the Production Crew

216 – A Day in the Production Crew

As a member of the crew, the crew would provide Lei Ruilin a box meal. However, Lei Tie and Qin Ruiqi were not members of the crew, so the crew naturally did not cover their meal. Lei Tie had just called to ask Qin Mian to deliver food.

Qin Mian went home and was busy cooking. With many people in the drama crew eating together, making too fine of food would be easy to attract people's eyes. Hence, Qin Mian just made several home dishes which included red-cooked fish, home cooked shredded meat, and stir-fried bok choy. He also cooked a pot of strongly flavored bone soup and put it in a large thermos.

After thinking about it, he picked some oranges from the space and squeezed a barrel of orange juice.

At the filming site, Qin Mian sent a text message to Lei Tie. Not a while later, Lei Tie came out. When the staff saw a provisional pass hanging around Lei Tie's neck, they just let him take Qin Mian in.

Qin Mian saw the camera facing Lei Ruilin and Lin Xiang, and knew that they were still shooting. He was curious about his son's performance and walked over quickly. Because he had read the script, he knew the content of this scene.

The quirky Tuan Tuan found something wrong with his Gege in recent days, who was always absent-minded in doing things. He secretly followed

Chen Haolong with funny ideas. Unexpectedly, he discovered that Chen Haolong had a big secret hidden. Tuan Tuan offered to help his Gege, but was rejected by Chen Haolong. The naughty Tuan Tuan proposed for them brothers to compete with each other. If he won, Chen Haolong had to promise to take him along.

“Heart Caution, Scene 1, Act 23. Action!”

“Ge, take me with you. My kung fu is so good; I can help you!” Lei Ruilin was wearing a blue cartoon T-shirt and a pair of black knee-length shorts with a reversed peaked cap on head, appearing a bit naughty; the hands behind his back and tilted head skillfully showed his cockiness and cunningness, remarkably alike the quirky Tuan Tuan. Even if his height was only to Lin Xiang’s waist, standing in front of Lin Xiang, he was not oppressed by Lin Xiang’s aura.

Chen Yue sat in front of the monitor screen, frequently nodded.

Not only he, but Lin Xiang was also surprised. He looked at the child in front of him with new eyes.

“Stop horsing around.” Chen Haolong patted Tuan Tuan’s head neither lightly nor hard. His playing down tone showed that he didn’t take his younger brother’s words seriously and was just perfunctory because he was afraid of being found out with the microchip in his hand. The expression in his eyes was grave.

“Ge!” Because of Gege’s distrust, Tuan Tuan was somewhat frustrated, but he still tried to persuade, “Ge~~let me go with you. I’m just a kid. No matter what happens, no one else will suspect me.”

Chen Haolong admitted that what he said was reasonable and glanced at him. Still, he didn’t want to involve his younger brother in danger. The expression in his eyes was still firm and remained unmoved.

Tuan Tuan had no choice but to say, “Come on, let’s have a fight! If I win, you take me with you. If I lose, I’ll... give up.” He put his hands on his

little hips, poked his right foot on the ground bit by bit, pouted his mouth, and aimed at him a pair of glistening eyes.

Chen Haolong was teased by his mischief and simply agreed. His tone was very perfunctory as he just wanted to send away his younger brother quickly, “Fine, fine. I’ll play with you.”

“Cut!” Chen Yue said with satisfaction, “Very good. The next scene is a fight between the two of you. The stuntmen will do it.”

Lei Ruilin immediately raised his hand, “Director, I can do it myself.”

Everyone looked at him in surprise. The main reason was that no one thought that Chen Yue could *dig out* a little master just by casually *digging* in the street.

Chen Yue was very surprised, “Personally?”

Lei Ruilin nodded cleverly, “I’ve learned martial arts for more than five years.”

A lot of people involuntarily laughed, taking it as though the little one was not sensible and joking around. He was no more than eight years old. If he had learnt for five years, didn’t he begin to learn when he was over two years old? How was that possible?

Zhang Qiong frowned, a little unhappy. It was not that he didn’t like Lei Ruilin. These days, Lei Ruilin’s twin brother, Qin Ruiqi, was here. He noticed that Qin Ruiqi was also interested in filming, so he thought that Lei Ruilin did such as brushing his sense of existence in front of Chen Yue was suspicious. Perhaps, his purpose was to attract Chen Yue’s attention to Qin Ruiqi.

In fact, he actually thought too much. People in the entertainment industry had seen people of various shapes and colors so much that they couldn’t help thinking of others in the direction of scheming. He simply forgot that Lei Ruilin was just a child. How could the child think so far?

Chen Yue was very pleasantly surprised. It was better not to use a stuntman. The shooting effect would be more natural and wonderful. But he didn't agree, instead, he asked, "Little guy, are you serious?"

His sight drifted to Lei Tie; he also saw Qin Mian.

Qin Mian wore a smile with eyes calm and confident, nodded slightly to him, to show that Lei Ruilin did not lie.

"I never lie." Lei Ruilin said.

Chen Yue cautiously said, "First, you do it with the martial arts instructor?"

Lei Ruilin nodded calmly and said to the martial arts instructor, "Please guide me."

The martial arts instructor was amused. With the director's instruction, there was nothing he was unwilling to do, "Okay, come."

Lei Ruilin knew that it was not the time to be modest. Since the martial arts instructor was embarrassed to take the first shot, he attacked first and threw a straight hook punch. The martial arts instructor immediately went to grab his wrist. Lei Ruilin knew that the purpose of the fight was not to win, but to transition. So, his fist flashed to the side, the other fist punched out, and at the same time, his right leg swept the footwork of the martial arts instructor. Although there were only two moves, the martial arts instructor had seen that he really knew martial arts, so he got serious. Two people went forth and back, fighting so wonderfully.

Others might not see it, but who was Chen Yue? He had made many action movies; he soon saw that the martial arts instructor was really serious, wanting to subdue Lei Ruilin. But Lei Ruilin had real skills. He had been swiftly slipping all the time, and even forced the martial arts instructor to retreat one step after another.

"Good!" Chen Yue was very happy, "Ruilin doesn't need a stuntman."

Lin Xiang's brow wrinkled up, but before others saw it, he smoothened them out. He felt a little uncomfortable. A little kid didn't need a stuntman, but him, the adult, needed it. If this got out, he might be a laughing stock. However, the other party was just a child, so he couldn't make a fuss over a child; he could only be depressed in the heart. Alas, his face appeared a little chilly.

"What's the matter?" The assistant asked with concern.

Lin Xiang casually said, "The two adults of Lei Ruilin's family have good genes. I wonder if they will also develop into the entertainment industry." He had to admit that both men were excellent looking. In the case they entered the entertainment industry, they would definitely be a threat to him. His eyes drifted to Qin Mian and Lei Tie.

Lei Tie seemed to look over inadvertently and his indifferent eyes met Lin Xiang's line of sight.

Lin Xiang was startled and hastily withdrew his eyes. His heart sank. He was actually suppressed just by a look from the other party.

Because Lin Xiang's stuntman and Lei Ruilin were both good at martial arts, Chen Yue simply refused to let the martial arts instructor arrange their moves. He let them move at will. It was no big deal to take many shots. After editing, only the brilliant moves would remain.

A total of three takes, about 20 minutes later, Chen Yue called "Cut".

"This scene is done." Today's shooting was still relatively smooth, Chen Yue looked at the watch and generously said, "Eat first. We'll continue in the afternoon."

All the staff were relieved.

"Mealtime, come here to get the box meal."

Lei Ruilin didn't want to be exceptional. He also took a box meal and ran to his family happily, "Daddy!" After shouting, he asked in a low voice, "Did

you see me filming? How did I do today?” The little cocky appearance made people laugh.

“Great.” Qin Mian was generous with praise. He rubbed his son’s head, took out the disposable bowls and disposable cups he had brought, poured two bowls of soup first, and said to his youngest son, “I’ve brought the soup and juice. You take it over and invite everyone to drink.”

Lei Ruilin and his Gege went over carrying barrels, bowls, and cups.

“Thank you for taking care of me. I’ll treat you to soup and juice. My Daddy’s soup and juice are the best.”

Toward a child, especially a cute child, everyone held goodwill; it was hard to refuse. Men all chose to drink soup and women all chose to drink juice. No matter how big the barrel was, it was limited. Only the main members of the crew got the soup and juice.

They just tasted it casually but didn’t expect that with a mouthful of soup or juice, it made them feel that their lips and teeth were fragrant and their spirits were boosted.

Chen Yue finished the soup in one mouthful, then reached out, “Little Ruilin, give me another bowl.”

Li Wanwan, the actress taking the female lead role, also handed her cup to Lei Ruilin. Wanwan was cute and witty, “Little brother, can I have another cup of juice? It’s the first time I’ve had such good juice. Where did your Daddy buy the fruit?”

“I don’t know.” Lei Ruilin said, “Sister Wanwan, if you drink a few more cups, you will become more and more beautiful!”

Everyone laughed.

After drinking three bowls of soup, Chen Yue still wanted to drink it, but he felt sorry for the two little guys who had yet to drink it. He simply drove them away, and when he couldn’t see them, he felt craving.

“Enough, enough. Leave some for Ruiqi and Ruilin and let them go to eat.”

Qin Mian had poured two bowls of soup for his two sons. The family of four sat together to eat. From time to time, they gave each other dishes, making people envious.

Many people were secretly guessing what Qin Mian and Lei Tie came for. That included Li Wanwan. Li Wanwan thought that the family had outstanding bearing, unlike ordinary people. She didn't feel that Qin Mian and Lei Tie were the same as those who came with interest.

Chapter 217: Meet by Chance

217 – Meet by Chance

The day was not finished until it passed 7 o'clock in the evening. Both children were a little tired; when they got in the car, they fell asleep. Back to the park community, after parking the car, Qin Mian and Lei Tie carefully carried the sleeping sons home. Lei Tie settled them in their room. Then, he went to the kitchen and saw that his wife was already rinsing the rice and a vegetable basket was on the kitchen table. He kissed his wife and rolled up his sleeves to trim the vegetables.

White Spot, Golden Fur, and Golden Eagle had been released from the magical space by Qin Mian; they moved freely in the house.

“Who is that old friend?” asked Lei Tie.

Qin Mian connected the pressure cooker to the power supply and teased, “In fact, he can be considered as our matchmaker.”

Lei Tie thought for a bit, then coldly said, “Qin Lian?”

Their talking did not affect their work. Qin Mian picked up the ginger and peeled it. “Yes, it looks like he’s doing well.”

“What sort of matchmaker is he?” The scene of his wife falling from the stairs emerged in Lei Tie’s mind, making him flustered. If Heaven had not been partial to his wife and let him borrow a corpse to come back from the dead, his wife might have died when Qin Lian pushed him down the stairs. To Qin Lian, he had only disgust.

He took the ginger from his wife’s hand and bent down to kiss him on the lips.

Qin Mian felt the man's fear and nervousness from his rapidly agitated tongue. Without caring that his hands might be stained with ginger juice, he put his arms around the man's shoulders and responded gently to calm the man's tense mood.

Only then Lei Tie found out that his wife's waist was propped against the solid kitchen table. Lei Tie quickly pulled him up, lifted up his clothes, and saw that his waist was red. His brows wrinkled as his big hands rubbed the area where his wife was squeezed.

"It's fine. It doesn't hurt." Qin Mian felt a little languid when Lei Tie kneaded him. He leaned on the man for a moment, pecked on the earlobe nearest to his mouth, and straightened up, "Cook first."

Lei Tie released him and continued to trim the vegetables. "What's your plan?"

Qin Mian didn't care very much. "He's just a nobody; he doesn't deserve our attention. Today, my sudden appearance in front of him is enough for him to have a nightmare for two days. If he behaves, I'll let go. If he dares to provoke me again, heh, I'll make him regret being born in this world."

Lei Tie was noncommittal. From the angle Qin Mian couldn't see, his eyes were cold and dark, filled with viciousness.

"A-Tie, do we need to buy another car?" Qin Mian thought of Lei Tie saying that he wanted to make a career. Having one car at home was not enough.

Lei Tie shook his head. "When I make money, I'll buy it for you."

Qin Mian chuckled, his joy overflowing into his eyes. He said briskly, "Okay, I'll wait. Anyway, I don't like a car that costs tens of thousands of yuan. Hahaha..."

Lei Tie glanced at his wife helplessly and dotingly. Did he get looked down upon?

“En, I’ll buy you a car that costs at least one million.”

Qin Mian was curious, “What do you want to do?”

The corner of Lei Tie’s mouth twitched almost imperceptibly, “...no idea yet.”

Qin Mian bowed his head and snickered. The man’s little troubled expression was novel and funny. However, in order to not hurt the man’s self-esteem, he kindly transferred the topic. “Don’t eat too much at night. Three dishes are enough, right? After that, add another plate of fruit.”

“Listen to you.”

When the meal was ready, Qin Mian woke up the two sons.

After eating, the family of four and three beasts went into the space for a walk to help digestion. Later, Lei Tie told his two sons to go to bed by 10 o’clock before he dragged Qin Mian into the bedroom, urging him to take a bath.

As soon as Qin Mian came out from the bath, the man stuffed a notebook into his hands. The window page showed an automobile net.

“Pick a brand you like.” After Lei Tie said that, he nonchalantly went into the bathroom.

Currently, money was really nothing for Qin Mian and Lei Tie. Not to mention that there were so many natural materials and treasures produced by themselves in the space. The total value of gold, silver, and jewelry awarded by the emperor alone was at least several hundred millions. But the meaning of the gifts that one bought with the money one earned was different. Qin Mian laughed and climbed to bed. Leaning on the bed, he chose carefully.

Lei Tie washed very quickly. He wore only a white bathrobe, with a faint steam still lingered on his body.

Qin Mian's eyes were staring at the screen without blinking. His side face was soft and charming under the wall lamp.

Lei Tie drew the curtain, sat down next to his wife, gathered the man into his arms to lean on his chest, and laid his chin on his wife's shoulder.

“What do you like?”

“I've taken a fancy to two models for the time being. This one...”

Qin Mian raised his hand and pointed at the picture. Because of this action, the bathrobe that was tied casually spread out, and Lei Tie's position just happened to be able to see the indistinct scenery in the bathrobe; his breathing constricted. His big palm on wife's waist glided slowly and untied the belt.

Although the air conditioner was on, the temperature in the room seemed to rise a few degrees at a time. Qin Mian wickedly bumped the man's lower abdomen with his elbow. The consequence of his crime was that he was immediately overturned on the bed.....

After breakfast, Lei Tie drove Lei Ruilin to the set.

Qin Ruiqi didn't follow them. Last night, he had searched the Internet for some acting books. Today, he was going to the bookstore to buy books.

When Qin Mian had cleaned up the kitchen later, he took Ruiqi out. Golden Fur, White Spot, and Golden Eagle had been “locked up” in the space for a long time. On the day of moving, Qin Mian reduced their size with spiritual conjuration and disguised White Spot as a Rottweiler and Golden Fur as a golden retriever. Greater Spotted Eagle was a second-class national protected animal; he disguised it as a parrot.

Golden Eagle didn't want to fly in the air; it stood on White Spot's back.

As soon as the two people and three animals appeared downstairs, they were noticed by other residents in the community, who secretly exclaimed that the family's pets were raised well. Some people secretly used their

mobile phones to shoot Golden Eagle and White Spot and posted it on microblogs.

Qin Mian and Qin Ruiqi didn't care.

The address of the bookstore had been checked for a long time. It was not far from the community, two li [1 km] at most. Qin Mian took his eldest son to walk over directly. By the way, he could get familiar with the environment near his home.

Along the way, White Spot and Golden Eagle got a lot of turning heads.

The bookstore was a relaxing book bar, which integrated the sections of a library, a bookstore, and a cafe. The environment was quiet and elegant. Qin Mian told White Spot and the gang to stay outside the door and requested the help of the staff at the counter to look after them. They could be seen through the glass door.

The staff member was a young girl with short hair. It was difficult for her to refuse the request of the handsome man. She blushed and sweetly smiled, "Okay, please rest assured."

Qin Ruiqi glanced at her and took Qin Mian's hand. "Daddy, let's go in."

The girl looked at Qin Mian and Qin Ruiqi in surprise. She couldn't believe that such a young man had such a big son.

Qin Mian was amused. He rubbed his eldest son's head gently. "A child, yet daring to do great mischief."

He first took his son to pick out books on acting, and then took him to pick out some storybooks.

"Awu awu!"

Suddenly, there came a loud sound of clamor and the bellows of White Spot and Golden Fur outside the door. The pair of father and son ran out in a hurry.

White Spot, Golden Fur, and Golden Eagle all glared at a young man and a young woman. The short-haired girl stood at the side, not knowing what to do.

“Excuse me, what’s the matter?” Qin Mian frowned and asked the short-haired girl politely.

The girl quickly explained, “It’s just a misunderstanding. This lady wanted to hold your dog, then...”

Qin Mian understood. Golden Fur and White Spot would not accept unfamiliar touch.

Before he could speak, the young man suddenly said, “Bad boy, is that you?”

Qin Mian turned his head. The young man scolded his eldest son; his expression turned grim. He put his arm around his son’s shoulders as he stared coldly at the young man, “What?”

Lu Yunzhao looked at him and laughed angrily, “You asked me what? This boy made this young master bask in the sun for more than an hour. You forgot, but this young master hasn’t forgotten!”

“Oh,” Qin Mian nodded, “it turns out to be you, who tried to rob my son.”

“You!” Lu Yunzhao hugged his girlfriend’s arm tightly, looking panicked. “Don’t evade from the subject! This boy had made me and a few of my buddies bask in the sun for so long; this account has to be settled.”

Qin Mian gave a faint smile and looked at his son.

Qin Ruiqi said in good order and well arranged manner, “You were the first to do harm to my Didi, so my Didi defended himself. No matter where this matter is spoken of, we’re on the right.”

Lu Yunzhao was stunned. “My Didi”? Were they twins? He took a closer look and found that although this boy looked identical to the boy who had stunned them, the temperament was different.

Qin Ruiqi did not show any diffidence in the face of an adult. He said in a light voice, “You seem to have a distinguished bearing; you must have come from a distinguished family. Can’t you tell right from wrong?”

Within the crowd, a girl exclaimed out-of-nowhere, “The boy is so handsome!”

More and more people gathered to watch the excitement. Lu Yunzhao became angry with embarrassment. He stared at Qin Mian with a profound look. Holding in his anger, he asked with an insincere smile, “I haven’t asked your surname yet?”

Qin Mian said calmly, “Qin Mian.”

Lu Yunzhao asked again, “Local?”

“Yes.” Qin Mian blurted out.

Lu Yunzhao said, “My surname is Lu; my name is Lu Yunzhao.”

Qin Mian curled the corner’s of his mouth.

Lu Yunzhao said strangely, “Have you never heard of me?”

Qin Mian said, “Har har.”

Who didn’t know that “har har” had the meaning of idiot? Lu Yunzhao’s face suddenly changed. He said in a cold voice, “Wait and see!” With that, even his girlfriend was left behind as he marched away.

The young woman glared at Qin Mian fiercely and stepped on the 8 cm thin-heels to catch up, “Young Master Lu, wait for me!”

Qin Mian and Qin Ruiqi did not care about this little episode. They went back to the book bar and continued to pick books. Qin Mian had asked White Spot how they actually got traversed, but White Spot wasn’t in the clear. According to Qin Mian’s analysis, maybe White Spot had an obsession with this time and space, or maybe when White Spot advanced, it attracted too much power that it tore open the time and space. Maybe the

next time White Spot was advanced again, it would be like this. So, he bought more books, even if he couldn't finish reading them temporarily, he could put them in the space and read them slowly later.

Chapter 218: Investment

218 – Investment

Ever since he met Qin Mian that day, Qin Lian had been anxious and fearful. Every time he saw Qin Yongcheng, he had to carefully observe the man's face and wondered if Qin Mian had contacted him.

Qin Yongcheng had been immersed in business for many years. His eyes had already become a pair of insightful eyes. He could see through all Qin Lian's little movements. Although he knew nothing of what Qin Lian was guilty of, Qin Lian's jittery look made him angry, exasperated at his son's failure to make good.

“Qin Lian!”

The chopsticks in Qin Lian's hands fell off and made two crisp sounds on the white and smooth floor.

When the servant heard the clamoring, he came over and saw the tension between the father and son. He did not dare to step forward.

“I'm sorry, Daddy.” Qin Lian quickly picked up the chopsticks and put them aside, squeezing out a stiff smile, “I have had some insomnia these two days...”

“Oh? Because what?” Qin Yongcheng asked coldly. He slowly drank the soup, while his sharp eyes still fell on Qin Lian, thoroughly probing.

“Nothing. Two days later, it's Young Master Liu's birthday. I haven't made up my mind about his birthday present. I'm worried about it.” Qin Lian quickly found an excuse.

Qin Yongcheng hummed coldly and sighed in his heart. He felt powerless. The Qin family's industry arose in his father's hands and developed in his hands. He was very worried that the foundation of the Qin family would be destroyed in his son's hands. Qin Mian's whereabouts were still unknown. He only had one son now. If the Qin family's industry was not handed over to Qin Lian, who else was it going to be? However, Qin Lian's performance truly dissatisfied him.

As Qin Yongcheng's gaze became profound, Qin Lian's heart beat faster. Knowing that Qin Yongcheng didn't like him, he made up his mind not to let him know that Qin Mian had come back.

Qin Yongcheng thought negatively that maybe he should marry his son to a capable daughter-in-law, and then hand over the Qin family's industry to his daughter-in-law. However, if he did so, their Qin family would definitely become a joke in the business circle. Plus, the Qin family's industry would fall into the hands of an outsider.

At this time, Qin Yongcheng's mind suddenly had an idea. He was still young and in good health. If he trained his grandson well.....

Madam Qin, Mo Feifei, did the peacemaking, "Enough, enough. Eat first. If you have something to say, wait until you finish eating."

Qin Yongcheng's expression relaxed. Looking at Qin Lian, he said in a grave tone and with sincerity, "You're our only son. We, the Qin family, still depend on you. Don't let me and your mother down."

Qin Lian quickly responded, "Yes. Daddy, I'll work hard."

After eating, Qin Lian went to the company. Qin Yongcheng called Mo Feifei to the study and said, "A-Lian is not young and he still hasn't mellowed. It's time for him to marry a wife to manage him."

Mo Feifei knew her son best. She felt that Qin Yongcheng suddenly said this because he found out that Qin Lian was having affairs with several female employees in the company. She immediately nodded in agreement,

“I think so too. I was going to mention this to you. Husband, do you have a candidate in mind?”

Qin Yongcheng’s look was hard to see through even to his wife, “Seem like you already have a candidate?”

Even though Mo Feifei was in her early fifties, her charm still lingered. Her soft smile had its own mature charm. “Yes, you know my eldest sister-in-law’s niece, Yage.”

“Yage?” Qin Yongcheng glanced at her meaningfully and said gently, “That child Yage is really good; smart and beautiful. But it’s too early to decide. A-Lian is our only son. We should be careful in choosing our daughter-in-law. Next month is the 40th anniversary of the company’s establishment. We’ll have a reception and invite more friends over.”

Mo Feifei’s eyes flashed, and she nodded with a smile. “Leave it to you to be so thoughtful.”

On the other side.

Lei Tie was busy on his notebook wherever he went these two days. Qin Mian was not allowed to peek at it. Even if Qin Mian teased him whether he was secretly on the “third rated porn website”, he still did not let Qin Mian see. Qin Mian took over his job taking Lei Ruilin to the filming site every day. Lei Tie stayed at home. Qin Ruiqi sometimes followed Qin Mian, and sometimes stayed at home with Lei Tie.

Today, Qin Mian came to the filming site with Lei Ruilin, but found that the atmosphere of the production crew was very dull. Chen Yue was gloomy, standing in front of the monitor, smoking. Zhang Qiong also had a grim face.

“What happened?” Qin Mian asked a familiar makeup artist in a low voice.

The makeup artist shook her head and whispered, “I don’t know. Director Chen just answered a phone call and then it became like this. ”

Qin Mian noticed that Zhang Qiong's sight passed over his son; his heart thumped. Was it related to his son? He went directly to Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong and greeted them with a smile, "Director Chen, Assistant Director Zhang. Good morning."

Chen Yue's face softened a little. "You're here."

Zhang Qiong nodded faintly and signaled Chen Yue with his eyes.

Chen Yue paid no heed to it and frowned as he mulled over.

Qin Mian said, "Is something wrong?"

Seeing that Chen Yue was silent, Zhang Qiong had no choice but to ask him, "Mister Qin, since you asked, I'll tell you straight away. Has your family ever offended someone?"

Qin Mian's first thought was Qin Lian, "Why are you asking this?"

Zhang Qiong said, "Just now, we received a call asking us to replace..." Afraid of the child becoming sad, he only hinted at Lei Ruilin, "Otherwise, the investor will withdraw the investment."

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows.

Lei Ruilin raised his eyebrows, the movement was very identical to his father; apparently, he understood the words of Zhang Qiong, but still remained calm.

Chen Yue noticed it, which made him like the boy even more. But he did not dare to say that he would continue to use Lei Ruilin. At this time, if the investor Zhao withdrew his investment, it would be detrimental to the future publicity of the film; while on the other hand, if he couldn't find a new investor in a short time, it would cause great losses.

Zhang Qiong thought that at this time, if Qin Mian really understood the truth, he should take the initiative to ask his son to quit. However, Qin Mian calmly asked, "How much money has the investor invested?"

Zhang Qiong was stunned. Chen Yue also looked over in surprised; he thought of a possibility and subconsciously straightened his waist.

“80 million.” Zhang Qiong replied.

Qin Mian nodded, “How about I invest?” It was not just about fighting for his son. He was really optimistic about the film. The film was first-class in terms of its directing team, leading roles, and script. It was impossible not to be popular.

Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong were astounded.

Chen Yue made a gesture and seriously said, “Let’s talk inside.”

Entering the nearest dressing room, he asked, “Are you serious?”

“Of course.” Qin Mian said, “It’s very likely that this incident is really aimed at me. However, I also want to ask. If I can ensure that the investment is in place, will other aspects be affected?”

“No.” Chen Yue firmly said, “Although I’m not powerful or influential, I won’t allow myself to be manipulated.”

Qin Mian didn’t doubt him. The network of a popular director couldn’t be underestimated.

“Good. I’ll transfer 2 million to you first; you continue shooting. The rest will arrive before dark.”

Afterward, without caring about whatever reaction Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong had, he lowered his head and asked his youngest son, “Ruilin, I want to go out for a while. Are you fine being alone?”

Lei Ruilin casually put his hands in his big pocket, not in the least looking worried, and said with a smile, “Daddy, rest assured.”

Qin Mian asked about the account number, nodded to Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong, and turned to leave.

Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong looked at each other, speechless.

An hour later, the text message reminded Chen Yue that there were 2 million more in his account. Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong settled down. At this time, they were not worried that Qin Mian tricked them because before they signed the contract, Qin Mian had transferred 2 million. In other words, if Qin Mian dared to trick them, he couldn't get back the 2 million.

When all the others had arrived, the shooting continued.

At lunch, Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong took care of Lei Ruilin. Lei Ruilin was very sensible and didn't let them worry much.

Qin Mian, on the other side, dug out a 500-year-old ginseng in the space after he transferred 2 million. He remembered that there was a 300-year-old ginseng that weighed 305 grams and sold for RMB 10 million. This 500-year-old ginseng weighed 589 grams and was rarer. It came from the magical space, so it was of better quality. It was worth at least 20 million. If there were too many hundred year old ginseng in the market, it would certainly attract attention. Hence, he only planned to sell this one.

Because of time constraints, he did not take the ginseng to the auction company, but directly contacted a reputable pharmaceutical company, asking for 30 million yuan. After some bargaining, he finally closed the deal with 28 million yuan.

After leaving the pharmaceutical company, Qin Mian put on illusion to change his appearance and mingled with the vast crowd. No one could find him.

Later, he and Lei Tie disguised themselves and sold three pieces of jade and two pieces of jewelry in different cities, making up 100 million.

Less than 4 o'clock, he reappeared in the crew, found Chen Yue, signed a contract, and transferred 78 million to the production crew.

Chen Yue and Zhang Qiong were completely relieved.

For the remaining 22 million, Qin Mian gave Lei Tie 12 million to start a business. Lei Tie's appearance when he seriously said "Wife, this is borrowed" was so cute that Qin Mian couldn't help pouncing on him. The counter-attack was expected.....

Qin Mian leaned on Lei Tie's body, pressed on his strong chest muscle, listening to the man's breathing speeding and slowing in the wake of his hand's movement. He laughed in amusement.

"Don't make trouble." Lei Tie's voice was hoarse as he patted the other party's hip in warning.

Qin Mian remembered that he still had something he had not done. He rolled up the sheets and sat up, "Where's my phone?"

Lei Tie picked up two mobile phones on the bedhead, compared them, and handed one to him. Their mobile phones were identical, but the screen savers were different.

Qin Mian dialed Qin Lian's phone, "Qin Lian, was today's matter your sly doing?"

Qin Lian was puzzled, "What?"

It didn't sound like he was lying when Qin Mian heard him. He soon thought of another suspect.

"He didn't admit it?" Lei Tie hooked the other party's hips, letting him move up.

Qin Mian hung up, a cold light flashed in his eyes as he smiled profoundly, "I might have mistaken him. Lu-Yun-Zhao."

At this time, the phone rang. The string of numbers displayed looked familiar.

"Hello?"

"Hello, Mister Qin. I'm Lin Feng."

“Mister Lin? Hello, what’s up? ” Qin Mian was surprised.

“My health has been much better recently. I want to express my thanks again.” Lin Feng added, “Also, one of my friends knows that Mister Qin is very skillful in medicine, so he wants to meet Mister Qin. He wants me to introduce you to him. I wonder if Mister Qin can do me the favor?”

Their family might have to live a long time in modern life, so it was necessary to develop a relationship. Qin Mian agreed without thinking more, “Sure.”

“We’re going to a ‘Crown Prince’ birthday party at 7 tomorrow night. Why don’t I pick up Mister Qin tomorrow afternoon?”

“Sure. I have my own car; how about meeting at Qingming Square at 6 o’clock? Um, goodbye.” Qin Mian would not easily disclose the address of his home.

Chapter 219: Crown Prince Liu

219 – Crown Prince Liu

As luck would have it, Lei Ruilin had to be on the filming set. Qin Mian let Lei Tie use the car, while he took a taxi to Qingming Square. At 6 o'clock, the street lights were on. After meeting with Lin Feng and exchanging a few simple greetings, he got in Lin Feng's car. The low-key black car swam in the ocean of lights and stopped at the entrance of a grand hotel.

The main character of the party was Liu Yaoming, Liu Yingchu's cousin. Not many people were invited, about twenty people, so a medium-sized banquet hall was booked in the hotel.

When Qin Mian and Lin Feng arrived, there were more than ten people in the hall, taking food from the buffet table; they carried plates and chatted in threes and twos. There were also people at the performing stage, singing with microphones.

Qin Mian's eyes flashed a faint trace of understanding. Right now, there were so many people coming about half an hour before 7 o'clock; it seemed that Young Master Liu's identity was unusual.

Many people came to greet Lin Feng. After listening to their talks, Qin Mian realized that Lin Feng was the eldest son of Lin Weijie, a famous entrepreneur in China. Lin Weijie, one of the representatives of the IT Industry, had been ranked in the top three in the domestic The Richest List for five consecutive years. It was no wonder that Lin Feng didn't even blink when he proposed to buy the supplementary medicine. 1 million was a drop in the bucket for the Lin family.

Lin Feng did not neglect Qin Mian and introduced him to others. The others had never heard of Qin Mian's name, so their reaction was mediocre. They just nodded to Qin Mian for Lin Feng's sake. It was considered a greeting, yet there was an aura field that excluded Qin Mian.

Qin Mian, who had seen the emperor before, was not affected by them at all. He gave a smile and nodded slightly. He took a glass of wine from the waiter's tray and sat down on the sofa with his legs overlapped, calm and composed.

Lin Feng knew Qin Mian's skills best. Since he took the medicine Qin Mian prescribed, his health was getting better and better day by day. In the past, he didn't even dare to speak aloud. Now, he was almost the same as ordinary people and was full of spirit every day. Just a few days ago, he went to the hospital again for an examination, and the doctor even had an expression of unbelievable. Therefore, he did not dare to neglect Qin Mian. Who dared to say that his family members would not be seriously ill in the future and need to ask Qin Mian for help?

However, even if he wanted to make friends with Qin Mian, he would not flatter him. Instead, he chose some suitable topics to chat with Qin Mian, so as to make Qin Mian feel comfortable.

Qin Mian saw his intention and appreciated him.

When the others saw Lin Feng's attitudes, they felt strange. This made them curious about Qin Mian's identity.

Voices came from the door. Lu Yunzhao, Zhang Zixuan, and Sun Ting came in together. Zhang Zixuan and Sun Ting were led by Lu Yunzhao.

"Young Master Lu, here you are."

The singers smilingly welcomed them.

Lin Feng didn't walk over. When Lu Yunzhao approached, he stood up and greeted him with a smile.

After chatting for a while, Lu Yunzhao noticed that the person sitting on the sofa didn't move; he was not happy. Once he took a clear look, his face darkened. "Qin Mian? Why are you here?"

Lin Feng stepped forward. With a faint smile, he said politely to Lu Yunzhao, but also polite to Qin Mian, "Mister Qin is my friend. I brought him here. Do you know each other, Young Master Lu?"

Lu Yunzhao didn't answer, but stared at Qin Mian darkly.

Qin Mian looked at him with indifference, "The production crew's problem was your doing."

Lu Yunzhao's expression turned even worse. He had some relationship with the investor of Heart Caution. After finding out that Lei Ruilin was actually a member of the cast, he immediately made a phone call to the investor and then sent someone to stare at the cast, waiting to see a drama. He thought that Chen Yue would replace Lei Ruilin if he threatened Chen Yue with investment withdrawal. However, he didn't expect to receive news that the film had changed investors so soon. His threat not only didn't work, but also made the original investor pay a lot of liquidated damages. But of course, the original investor wouldn't let him return the [lost] money, but he owed the favor.

Qin Mian's indifferent expression further angered Lu Yunzhao. He said to Zhang Zixuan and Sun Ting, "Drive him out!"

Lin Feng's expression abruptly changed and he squinted at Lu Yunzhao.

"Young Master Lu, today is Young Master Liu's birthday. He'll be here soon..."

Before Zhang Zixuan's words were finished, Lu Yunzhao said in an angry voice, "I said drive him out! I'll explain it to Young Master Liu myself."

Lin Feng stepped forward and said in a heavy tone, "Young Master Lu, Mister Qin is my friend."

“So what?” Lu Yunzhao was so angry that he could not choose his words.

Lin Feng asked flatly, “That is to say, Young Master Lu can decide for Young Master Liu in this event?”

Sun Ting stopped Lu Yunzhao before the latter opened his mouth, shook his head, and looked at Qin Mian with a complex expression, who had been sitting on the sofa calmly. Even though he was the only one sitting at the scene, Sun Ting still felt that everyone had a weak presence in front of Qin Mian.

At this time, two more people came in: Qin Lian and Yue Xiangkui.

When Qin Lian saw Qin Mian, his smile froze on his face.

“Someone you know?” Yue Xiangkui asked thoughtlessly.

Qin Lian responded ambiguously.

Yue Xiangkui did not ask further.

When Liu Yaoming and Liu Yingchu walked over side by side and saw that everyone was standing, they were puzzled and asked, “Why are they all standing?”

All of them changed into smiling faces and wished Liu Yaoming a happy birthday and presented gifts.

Only then Qin Mian stood up.

Liu Yaoming walked to Lin Feng with a smile, nodded to Qin Mian in a friendly way, and asked Lin Feng, “A-Feng, is this Mister Qin you mentioned?”

“Yes.” Lin Feng said with a smile, “This is Qin Mian, a doctor. Mister Qin’s medical skill is extraordinary. It’s to his credit that my illness has improved so quickly. Mister Qin, this is Liu Yaoming, the third generation of the legendary army.”

“What legendary?” Liu Yaoming smiled and slapped Lin Feng on the shoulder. One could see that he had a good relationship with Lin Feng.

He was Liu Yingchu’s cousin, so he had heard about Qin Mian from Liu Yingchu.

“Nice to meet you, Mister Qin.”

Qin Mian held out his hand and said, “Nice to meet you, Young Master Liu. I wish you a happy birthday.”

Lu Yunzhao heard their conversation clearly; his expression changed greatly and he was afraid. Although his status was not low, he was not as good as Liu Yaoming. Liu Yaoming was the real “Crown Prince”. It was no secret that the elderly man of the Liu family had been unwell in the past two years. The reason why Liu Yaoming attached so much importance to Qin Mian was obvious. He could not help but secretly congratulated himself that he had not driven Qin Mian away, otherwise, not only the Liu family would have blamed him, even his Lu family would not have spared him.

In addition to Lu Yunzhao, there was another person who didn’t look very good. That was Qin Lian. In the first place, he spent so much effort to get into this circle; so how did Qin Mian get into the relationship with Young Master Liu so easily? As the sense of crisis of forced restraint came to mind again, Qin Lian blurted out, “Young Master Liu, isn’t something wrong with this? As far as I know, this ‘Mister Qin’ had no contact with medical skills before he was 24 years old.” Even at this time, he did not say that Qin Mian was his elder brother. But in order to avoid being found out afterwards, he didn’t say anything. He just used a sarcastic tone in “Mister Qin”. Outsiders would only think that they had a private enmity.

It was not surprising that no one found out that Qin Mian was Qin Lian’s elder brother. Qin Mian was Qin Yongcheng’s illegitimate son. He entered the Qin family only when he was 15 years old. After graduation, he worked as a photographer of food programs. He didn’t touch the Qin family’s business and hardly appeared in front of the public. So outsiders didn’t know Qin Lian had an elder brother.

Liu Yaoming gave Qin Lian a cold glance. No matter whether Qin Mian's knowledge of medicine was true or false, Qin Lian should not put Qin Mian down on this occasion. This was slapping him, Liu Yaoming, in the face.

Qin Lian's heart thumped; even Yue Xiangkui looked at him with disapproval.

Liu Yaoming was too lazy to argue with Qin Lian and considered it as he didn't hear what the other party said. He said with a smile, "This way, please."

Intentionally or unintentionally, Qin Lian was excluded by everyone.

The birthday party, in blunt words, was wine, dine, and sing. More or less, everyone could see that Liu Yaoming was trying to rope in Qin Mian. Thus, they were apprehensive and did not go overboard. They went to the side to play minigames, or fight over to sing, and even turned down the volume.

Qin Mian, Liu Yaoming, Lin Feng, and Liu Yingchu were sitting in the booth in the corner.

Although Liu Yaoming was a Crown Prince, he was not as arrogant and arbitrary and treated people with contempt as most people would think. His speech and manner were very decent and elegant. "Mister Qin, to be honest, I want to invite you to give medical advice to an elder of mine."

Qin Mian handled the identity of the four members of his family very properly. The identity of Liu Yaoming's family was not ordinary. Qin Mian knew that Liu Yaoming must have investigated him, but he could only find out that their family just came back from abroad and settled in S City. Nothing else could be found out.

Qin Mian said, "Young Master Liu should know that my medical skills are not from regular medical schools."

"I know." Liu Yaoming gave him an apologetic smile, admitting that he had investigated him. Qin Mian's graduate school was not a medical school. "I'm very sincere, so let's get this straight. Hope you don't mind. First, I'd

like to ask Mister Qin to check the pulse of my elder. As for whether I need Mister Qin for treatment, we'll talk about it later. Of course, I'll pay for it."

Qin Mian was noncommittal. "If it's not inconvenient for Young Master Liu to say, how unwell is the elder?"

Liu Yaoming nodded and said in a low voice, "There is a sign of paralytic stroke."

"I don't charge a low consultant fee." Qin Mian didn't need to flatter anyone.

Liu Yaoming's smile deepened. "Of course, no problem." If Qin Mian didn't charge for the outpatient service, Liu Yaoming would owe him a favor. One must know that sometimes, owing someone a favor was more troublesome than owing someone money.

A waiter came over, stood a few steps away, and did not approach, "Young Master Liu, there is a Mister Lei outside seeking Mister Qin."

Qin Mian took out his mobile phone to take a look; it was turned off automatically when there was no power.

Seeing this, Liu Yaoming knew it was his (QM) friend and said to the waiter, "Please invite him in."

In a moment, a tall man strode in. His face was frosty as his cold eyes swept around indifferently; it was only when they fell on Qin Mian that they became gentle.

The civil smile on Qin Mian's face faded away and turned to genuine yet charming. He quickly walked over and said, "You come to pick me up?"

Lei Tie embraced his shoulder and nodded, "Can go?"

Liu Yaoming noticed the unique temperament of a soldier on Lei Tie. He asked Qin Mian with a smile, "Who is this?"

Qin Mian's eyes swept over to Qin Lian. A touch of cunningness flashed through his eyes. He said frankly, "This is my spouse, Lei Tie."

Liu Yaoming and the others were stunned. There were also gays among the friends around, but they had never seen such an honest and easy-mannered person as Qin Mian.

Qin Lian nearly slipped the wineglass in his hand. His eyes flickered; he couldn't restrain his excitement. *Qin Mian mingles with a man!*

Qin Mian said, "Young Master Liu, I'm sorry. I'm leaving first. You can get in touch with me at any time if you have made arrangements there."

Liu Yaoming said with a smile, "Okay, many thanks. I'll see you off."

Chapter 220: Second Honeymoon

220 – Second Honeymoon

Watching Qin Mian and Lei Tie leave side by side, Liu Yaoming and the others became unknowingly more or less envious.

As soon as they were out of the hotel, Qin Mian asked, “Where are Ruiqi and Ruilin?”

“‘Inside’,” said Lei Tie.

In the city at night, under the flashing neon lights, there were no fewer pedestrians on the streets than in the daytime. Not far in the opposite direction was the pedestrian street; there were not only all kinds of delicious food, but also all kinds of interesting games.

Qin Mian recalled that since he traversed back, his family had not gone sightseeing; he was ashamed. “A-Tie, we won’t go back first. I’ll show you guys around.”

Then, he said in a low voice, “Get in the car first and let Ruiqi and Ruilin come out.”

He pulled Lei Tie, but the latter didn’t budge. He looked back.

Lei Tie grasped Qin Mian’s hand and brought him back to his side. He said in a vexed voice, “You and me.”

Qin Mian could make out the little grievance on the man’s calm face; he felt guilty. It was really his negligence. During this period of time, there were either those things or such things, so much so that the two of them hardly lived their married life. Hadn’t he known about the man’s taciturn character

long ago? Now, the man couldn't endure it anymore and remonstrated, which showed that he was really nursing a grievance. Qin Mian's heartstrings were pulled tight. He grabbed the man's waist tightly and rubbed his cheek against the man's face. "En, just you and me." There was food and toys in the space, as well as White Spot and the gang, so there was nothing to worry about leaving Ruiqi and Ruilin inside.

He held the man's face and pecked on his lips. He didn't seem to care that passers-by were looking at them. He smiled at the man and walked forward. Who did he and Lei Tie need to fear now? Why care about other people's eyes? Yielding to one's heart was a great pleasure.

"I'll take you to eat delicious food first. It's not far away. Let's go straight over. That one has barbecue, shredded pancakes, iron-plated fried rice, spicy hotpot, oden, stinky tofu, sesame seed pancakes with broken bits... all of them are very delicious."

Lei Tie curled up a faint smile on his lips. He only felt that the radiance in his wife's eyes was more dazzling than the neon lights.¹

Qin Mian's train of thoughts deviated from the normal course and he found out that he really overlooked his family members too much. They might not be able to leave this world in a short time, but he should not pay too much attention to making money. Instead, he should take his spouse and children to sightseeing in this new world. As for money, they didn't need it at all.

"Fool." Lei Tie saw through Qin Mian's mind, "No hurry, we have a lot of time."

"A-Tie." Qin Mian stopped, took the man's hands and looked into his eyes seriously. "It seems that I have never asked you whether you like this world or this kind of life." Thinking that Lei Tie might not like the present life at all and just tolerate it for him, he felt both distressed and remorseful. This man was tolerant of him all the time, while he just blindly enjoyed the man's connivance and neglected the man's feelings.

When the radiance in the wife's eyes turned a lot dimmer, Lei Tie's heart became panicked. He tightened his grips and gathered the person into his

arms. “What are you thinking about? As long as you are always by my side, it’s the same everywhere.”

“You’re a fool, too.” Qin Mian stroked the man’s face and made up his mind to be more kind to him. He waved away his emotional feelings and decisively said, “Tomorrow, we’ll hire an assistant each for Ruiqi and Ruilin to take care of them. Then, the two of us will travel and live the best married life. After Ruilin’s film is finished, we’ll take the two children to travel around. They don’t have to rush to school. What do you think?”

Lei Tie smiled; his whole person was full of pleasure and satisfaction. He stared at Qin Mian with tender eyes and nodded, “Okay.”

Seeing him smile, Qin Mian’s heart felt nice and warm and his face was full of happy smiles. “Let’s go to the night market first.”

He took Lei Tie to taste takoyaki, shredded pancakes, grilled squid, oden, sour plum soup, sausages, fried liver, stinky tofu..... played catching small fish, ferrule, air gun balloon shooting, and made candy floss.....

At first, Lei Tie was still reserved. After Qin Mian coerced him to fish and make candy floss, he simply followed his wife to play and obeyed his wife’s requirements. They enjoyed themselves as much as ordinary lovers. Qin Mian’s stomach was a little hungry again. He took Lei Tie to a famous instant-boiled mutton restaurant to eat instant-boiled mutton.

When they got home, it was past midnight. Their two sons had already fallen asleep in the space’s room.

Qin Mian was a man of action. The next day, he hired an assistant for Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin each. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin knew that the two dads were going to have a “second honeymoon”, so they waved their hands with great understanding.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie felt a little bit lost, but also more relieved and glad. They filled the refrigerator and freezer in their home, and also filled their two sons’ storage bracelets with fruits, snacks, desserts, and enough money. Then they left at ease.

On the first day of their second honeymoon, Qin Mian didn't go far. He took Lei Tie to the shopping mall and bought several sets of clothes for him and his two sons from head to toe. After that, he bought two movie tickets and took Lei Tie to see a Sci-fi blockbuster. The purpose was not to experience the movie itself, it was to experience watching a movie and to date. They bought the last row of seats. Because the hall was dark and there were not many people watching the movie, they could not help but secretly kiss each other several times. As for what the movie was about, they only had a general idea.

In the evening, they didn't go home either. After making a phone call and confirming that their two sons were fine, they opened a room in the hotel.

Some supplies in the hotel opened a door to a new world for Lei Tie, so much so that they didn't wake up until more than 1 o'clock in the afternoon of the next day. For lunch, they went to the Lovers Restaurant specially. After lunch, Qin Mian dragged Lei Tie to the video game center. They were addicted to playing racing games. The next day, they spent another day in the video game center. As a result, the boys and girls in the video game city looked at them with strange eyes from time to time.

Qin Mian was so depressed that he couldn't endure it and pulled his man to roast them, "What are they looking at? Although I, this Young Master, am already pushing 30, I look to be about 20~23 years old. Why can't I be in this video game center?"

Lei Tie quickly coaxed him; his face was serious, "En. They were looking at me, I'm pushing 40."

"Pfft!" Qin Mian couldn't help laughing. He held his man's face and looked at it carefully. He seriously said, "You're not old. You appear to be about 27~28 at most." This was naturally true. When one's cultivation reached Lei Tie's level, one's appearance would not change anymore. That's why Lei Tie's time seemed to stop at the age of 28, looking young, mature, dignified, and charming. No matter where he went, he attracted the eyes of people around him.

Of course, I'm not bad either. Qin Mian thought narcissistically.

Lei Tie grasped his hand tightly and kissed him. He didn't notice the surprise of the others around them.

“Still playing?”

“No more.” Qin Mian said, “If we want to play again, we'll come later. Our tour is more important.”

When they went home and saw that their two sons were really doing well, they were more relieved. He told the two assistants that if the two assistants could get praises from the two children the next time they went home, he would give them a huge bonus.

The two assistants could guess from the value of the family's house that this family was not short of money. After hearing this, they were more energetic, and one after another said that they will take good care of their two children.

The next day, Qin Mian and Lei Tie went out again. When Liu Yaoming called to ask Qin Mian to see the elderly of the Liu family, Qin Mian declined and set the time half a month later.

Qin Mian intended to let Lei Tie experience different means of transportation. He took the man to the railway station by bus and bought a ticket to the neighboring city. After visiting the scenic spots of neighboring cities and tasting the special local snacks, they flew to the imperial capital.

After the journey, they did not take the means of transportation. Qin Mian acted as a navigator, while Lei Tie took him to fly to places with beautiful scenery or delicious snacks all over the country.

It was half a month later when Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin saw their two dads again.

After filming a scene on the roadside with endless traffic, Chen Yue announced for a moment's break.

Even though Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were calm, they were still eight years old after all. When they saw their two dads standing side by side not far away, they smiled with joy as they ran toward their dads.

“Daddy! Old Daddy!”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie each caught one boy. Everyone looked at them with admiration.

The two assistants looked at each other and walked over. It was so easy to take care of these two sensible children that they even hoped Qin Mian and Lei Tie could come back later.

“Mister Qin, Mister Lei. You guys are back.”

The two sons didn’t look thinner. Qin Mian was in a good mood and very satisfied with the two assistants. “En, you’ve worked hard.”

Chen Yue, Zhang Qiong, and the others noticed the two big baskets beside Qin Mian and Lei Tie, in which they were full of peaches and watermelons, adding up to at least 100 Jin. They knew that the baskets were brought for them to eat and inwardly said that these two fathers were very considerate. They were quite familiar with Qin Mian and Lei Tie. They went over to say hello with smiles, staring at the fruit baskets. Every time Qin Mian brought fruits, they were so delicious. No wonder they were so covetous.

Qin Mian inwardly laughed. “Director Chen, Assistant Director Zhang. My two sons have added trouble to you. These fruits are our little treats. Let’s share with everyone.”

Everyone had been waiting for his words. After thanking him, they took the baskets and went under the shade of the trees to share the fruits.

Qin Mian took a small basket out of the car and handed it to the two assistants. “This is for you two.”

“Thank you, Mister Qin.” Two assistants took the fruit basket and went to one side wisely.

Qin Mian took his two sons to the car to hide from the sun and asked about their recent situation.

2 more. Ugh, I'm reluctant to finish it.

Footnotes

1. Never too late to reply to someone's question [six month ago] about the word "wife" that LT uses. It's 媳妇 xí fù.

Chapter 221: Diagnosis and Treatment

221 – Diagnosis and Treatment

The elderly man of the Liu family was a meritorious statesman after the founding of the People's Republic of China. He had seen all kinds of people in his nearly 70 years of life. When he heard that the doctor his grandson found was only in his twenties, he knew that his grandson had been cheated. Thinking that his grandson would gain wisdom by suffering a cut, he didn't voice it out. He coldly watched his grandson receive a call from the other party to postpone the consultation time, and then coldly watched his grandson receive a call from the other party to ask about the meeting time.

Before his grandson looked over at him, he had withdrawn his eyes and continued to read the newspaper.

“Grandpa.” Liu Yaoming walked over and sat down at the elderly man's side. “I know you don't believe Qin Mian actually has such good medical skills, but it's true that Lin Feng's illness has been mostly cured. You only have to think of him as a friend of mine. It'll only take ten minutes to see him.”

Since this was his grandson's good intention, Elder Liu did not want to let him down. He patted his grandson's head and said, “Fine, fine, fine. But he should understand what can be said and what can't be said.”

“You can be assured, I'll make it clear to him.” Liu Yaoming stood up, “Grandpa, I'll go out and pick him up.” There were guards outside the residence; ordinary people couldn't come in.

“Go.”

Qin Mian followed Liu Yaoming into the enclosed courtyard residence and went straight to the third section. When he entered, he saw an old man in his sixties sitting on a mahogany bench. He had a square face and a pair of bright and expressive eyes, keenly sizing Qin Mian up with an imposing manner of a superior pouring out at him.

Qin Mian raised his eyebrows, *is this displaying one's severity?* He nodded slightly to the elderly man and turned to Liu Yaoming, “Is this the patient?”

His aura of being in a high position for a long time was not what ordinary people could bear, but this young man was not affected at all, like a double-edged sword stuck in the ground motionlessly braving the strong wind, refraining from showing its ability. Elder Liu was surprised. Only then did he face Qin Mian squarely.

Liu Yaoming was a little displeased. But his grandfather was the first to use his imposing manner to suppress Qin Mian, so he was not able to say anything. He said to Elder Liu, “Grandpa, this is Doctor Qin I told you about; Doctor Qin, this is my Grandpa.”

These people were overly suspicious [of him]. Qin Mian inwardly shook his head. Now, he had regretted that he promised Lin Feng. He didn't have to take this troublesome way to integrate into modern life. However, he had promised the other party, and neither would he come to an uneventful end.

Mister Liu had read countless people, so he was keenly aware of Qin Mian's cold-shouldering. Although he was not enthusiastic at first, he now wondered if Qin Mian really had the ability. He gestured with a hand, “Doctor Qin, please sit down.”

“Thank you very much.”

After Qin Mian sat down, Elder Liu asked Liu Yaoming to pour tea.

“I wonder where Mister Qin works?” Elder Liu had a smile on his face and a kind look.

Qin Mian didn't want to *practice Tai Chi*¹ with him and said directly, "Pardon me, Elder Liu. I have something else to do later. Let's get down to business first. I'll check your pulse first, and then write down the medical case and prescription. I can treat you myself, or you can ask someone else."

Elder Liu had the mind to test his ability. He reached out his hand and said, "Please."

Qin Mian put his fingers on the pulse about ten seconds before letting go. He looked at Elder Liu, "From your pulse, you have had three minor strokes, and because the treatment is timely, the condition is under control."

Elder Liu and Liu Yaoming looked at each other in surprise. Elder Liu's identity was not ordinary, so his medical records were confidential. It was impossible for ordinary people to look at it. In other words, Qin Mian's diagnosis was really seen from the pulse. Before this, they both looked down on him.

Liu Yaoming secretly congratulated himself for not being rude to the young doctor.

Qin Mian seemed to be unaware of their change of attitudes, "The interval between the first stroke and the second stroke is about four years, and the interval between the second stroke and the third stroke is about one year. Although all of them are under control, it can be seen from these that your condition has actually become more and more serious. One more stimulus will very likely lead to a severe stroke."

Elder Liu and Liu Yaoming looked grim. Severe stroke could be treated, but it was very difficult to recover to the condition before the onset of the disease; the person would be equal to a waste.

"In your opinion, can my Grandpa's condition be cured once and for all?" Liu Yaoming asked anxiously.

"Fortunately, Elder Liu always pays attention to physical exercise; his physical function is good." Qin Mian pondered for a moment, "the elder's pulse is powerfully stable with strong vitality. If nothing happens, he'll have

no problem living for another 14~15 years. Give him acupuncture several times, with a reasonable diet and proper exercise, his life can extend for another five years or so.”

Elder Liu appeared a little relaxed. He was 64 this year. In 20 years, he would be 84. 84 was already a long life.

Qin Mian asked, “Do you have a pen and paper?”

“Yes.” Liu Yaoming hurriedly went to the study to get pen and paper, and handed them to Qin Mian with both hands. He was a few years younger than Qin Mian; there was no look of disgrace in his act of respect toward Qin Mian.

Instead of writing immediately, Qin Mian said to Elder Liu, “Do you want me to do acupuncture for you or find another doctor? If it’s another doctor, I’ll write down the acupuncture method, but then I have one condition.”

“What is the condition? Please say it,” asked Elder Liu.

Qin Mian said, “To tell you the truth, my prescription is handed down from my ancestors. It’s the rule of my ancestors to not hand it down to others. If the elder asks for another doctor, I hope the other party can keep it secret.”

Liu Yaoming could not help but say, “Mister Qin, you should know how many people are suffering from stroke in today’s society. I can pay a high price for your prescription.”

Qin Mian shook his head lightly, “Sorry, it’s not for sale.” It was enough to give a couple of people treatment. If the prescription was really published, it would change the medical process to a great extent. He remembered Lei Tie once said that cultivators should not use their own abilities to interfere in the affairs of the secular world, otherwise, the punishment of the Heavenly Law’s Tribulation would be very heavy in the future. Back then when he and Lei Tie took part in the war between Great Xia and Tuluo, it had perhaps been “recorded” by the Heavenly Law. He should be more cautious in the future.

Liu Yaoming said, “The price can be properly discussed.”

Qin Mian said with a smile, “I’m not short of money. Young Master Liu and Lin Feng are good friends. You should be able to understand that if a person has too much money, money is just a number to him.”

Liu Yaoming didn’t know how rich Qin Mian was, but he totally agreed with him. Let’s take Lin Feng as an example; he had a hobby, which was buying houses. Whether domestic or abroad, as long as he saw the house he liked, he couldn’t help but buy it. The cheapest ones cost 800,000, while the expensive ones cost more than 20 million. He didn’t even blink when he bought them.

However, Liu Yaoming was still a little unwilling [to give up] and secretly signaled Elder Liu with his eyes.

Elder Liu understood his meaning. If their Liu family could donate this prescription, they would surely make the Liu family’s position more stable. However, he couldn’t do that because he suddenly remembered that there were still some “otherworldly experts” in the country about 50 years ago, when only their top brass had access to some classified information. He wondered whether the young doctor was a disciple of the otherworldly expert. If so, such people could only be roped in while maintaining gentlemen’s relationship, or even could be ignored, but only couldn’t offend.

He waved hand [in dismissal] at his grandson, “Doctor Qin, it’s you who checked my pulse, so you know my physical condition better than others. I think it’s better for me to have you treat me.”

“No problem.” Qin Mian nodded, “Also, I have one condition. I don’t plan to see other patients. I hope you don’t publicize my medical skills to the public.”

Elder Liu glanced at Liu Yaoming. “No problem.”

Liu Yaoming awkwardly said, “Uhm... Many people have already known about you treating Lin Feng, and many people have seen us at the party that

day.”

“I understand that.” Qin Mian said, “In a word, don’t talk about it outside henceforth.”

Liu Yaoming agreed.

Qin Mian wrote down a prescription and handed it to him, “Follow the prescription. The best time to drink the medicine is immediately after I gave the elder acupuncture.”

“Okay, I’ll go right now.”

After more than two hours, Qin Mian came out of Liu Residence. He would give the elder man acupuncture once every three days. After ten times of acupuncture, the elder man could just take another two months’ medicine and that would suffice.

Liu Yaoming personally sent him out of the door.

Passing by the bakery, Qin Mian stopped and bought four small cakes.

When he got home, as soon as he opened the door, he saw one big and two small ones sitting in a row on the sofa in the living room, looking up at him. Everyone had a luggage bag beside them.

“Daddy!” Qin Ruilin and Lei Ruilin ran over at full speed and took the cakes in his hand.

Qin Mian sat down beside Lei Tie and handed him a box of cakes. Looking at the three bags on the ground, he said with an amused face, “What are you guys doing with these?”

“Daddy, didn’t you say to take us on a tour?” Lei Ruilin, lying on the back of the sofa, reminded him. Yesterday afternoon, he finished his filming parts. Now, he was free.

“Yes.” Qin Mian took a bite of the cake, opened the zipper of Lei Tie’s luggage bag, flipped through the clothes inside, touched a box with his

finger, and saw the words on it clearly. His face became hot. He turned to look at Lei Tie. “One box is enough. You’ve packed four boxes. How much... Hmph.”

Lei Tie seriously explained, “Not that I wanted to buy. It’s an online purchase, buy three and get one free. Wife, don’t you often say that we should be diligent and frugal in running our household?”

Qin Mian stared at his innocent appearance without saying a word.

Lei Tie’s face didn’t change its color. He reached out and wiped the cream from the corner of his wife’s mouth and licked it. He turned his head and continued to watch the TV.

Qin Mian rubbed his face, amazed at the man.

“Set out after finishing the cake.”

Can I do the last chapter next year?

Chapter 222: END: Forever Partners in this Life

222 – Forever Partners in this Life

Qin Mian had asked his youngest son; his youngest son didn't plan to participate in any promotional activities of the film. So he took his family to visit several classic scenic spots in China, and then went abroad to see the White House in the United States, Big Ben in Britain, Eiffel Tower in France.....

After the trip, they came back to China, just in time for the movie premiere. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were the sons of the investor, plus Lei Ruilin was even one of the leading roles, so they got a better seat. When Lei Ruilin confronted the media interviews, he was not at all timid, but calm without extensive liveliness; he was very popular. Because Qin Ruiqi and him were twins, the reporters readily took more photos for them.

As the investor, Qin Mian had always been mysterious and did not show his face in front of the camera.

After the interview, the film was released to the public. The family of four enjoyed a visual feast. The next day in the news, "Heart Caution" made into the entertainment headlines without incident.

Photos and videos of the two little brothers appeared in newspapers and TV. Very quickly, they gained a group of fans.

When Qin Yongcheng unintentionally switched to the entertainment channel, he saw what Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin look like. The remote

control in his hand almost fell to the ground. These two children looked very similar to Qin Mian when he was a child.

Qin Lian came down from upstairs and yawned dispiritedly, “Good morning, Dad.”

Qin Yongcheng looked at the dark circles under his eyes and his dull face; he frowned, “What’s the matter with you?”

Qin Lian sullenly said, “I also don’t know how it can be like this. I haven’t slept well recently, always half asleep and half awake. I always feel that there is a shadow swaying in the room, like I’m being watched by something unclean...” As he said that, he couldn’t help shivering as if there was a wind blowing at the back of his neck.

“Pack of nonsense!” Qin Yongcheng shouted in a low voice. Seeing his son’s head droop, he was filled with powerlessness. He held back his anger and pretended to be casual as he asked, “Any good news from Yunyun?”

Qin Lian was stunned for a moment before he responded, “We’ve only been married for three months; how can we get that so fast? Dad, you seem to be impatient?” Today’s young people liked to move out and live alone after they got married, but Qin Yongcheng now had only Qin Lian as a son, so Qin Lian and Gan Yunyun still lived with their parents after they got married.

Qin Yongcheng glanced at him, picked up the remote control to change the channel, and said with a casual expression, “Your mother and I are getting older, so we want to play with our grandchildren while eating candy¹ a bit earlier. Is it strange?”

“No.” Qin Lian didn’t think about it anymore.

Qin Yongcheng pondered for a while, but still felt uneasy. Three months was not a short time. His father had the problem of low sperm motility. *Does Qin Lian also have it?*

Thinking of this, he couldn't sit still. He gently suggested, "Qin Lian, if you are free, you'd better have a comprehensive physical examination."

Qin Lian was a bit speechless, but also a bit frustrated. It felt like his father just used him as a tool to carry on the family bloodline. However, Qin Yongcheng had built up power and influence for a long time; he dared not disobey him and only stated his stand immediately. He was going to the hospital today.

On the other hand, Qin Mian lived a natural and unrestrained life. Soon after the photos of Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin were exposed, some directors took a fancy to Qin Ruiqi's cool and calm temperament and invited him to shoot s, TV dramas, and movies through several phone calls.

Qin Mian intended for his eldest son to experience the feeling of filming. He accepted a drama for Qin Ruiqi, which was an ancient costume TV drama. The protagonist was the emperor. He ascended the throne at the age of seven and became a puppet emperor. Qin Ruiqi played the role of the emperor when he was a child. He only acted in the first five episodes, but there were many scenes.

Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and Lei Ruilin accompanied him. It was now the 12th month of the lunar calendar.

The last scene was taken outdoors. Almost everyone in the crew braved the cold wind; their faces and hands were red with cold.

At present, Qin Ruiqi's cultivation was not low. He could adjust his body temperature automatically. Others didn't know about that. They felt heartache and emotional watching the children freezing with them.

It snowed when they came out of the filming site after the last scene. The catkin-like snowflakes drifted profusely and disorderly; the temperature dropped a few degrees.

"I'll bring the car," said Lei Tie.

“Okay, be careful and drive slowly.” Qin Mian put on a hat and a scarf for the two children. A honk suddenly sounded not far away. It was obviously aimed at them, which made him confused.

The door of the low-key black car opened and Qin Lian got out of the car. He looked at Qin Mian for two seconds before he opened the back door.

It was Qin Yongcheng who got off this time. After glancing at Qin Mian, his eyes fell on Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin, full of love and relief.

Qin Mian stood still, watching them approach.

“Since you’re back, why don’t you come home?” Qin Yongcheng asked.

After Qin Yongcheng took Qin Mian back to the Qin family, he was good to Qin Mian. But his mother’s death was greatly related to Qin Yongcheng. Moreover, Qin Yongcheng did not participate in the most important stage of Qin Mian’s life – the first 15 years. Therefore, Qin Mian did not have much deep feelings for Qin Yongcheng.

He only called him “father” in indifference.

Qin Yongcheng did not mind his indifference; his ardent eyes fell on the two children, “These two little ones are my grandchildren, right?”

Qin Lian’s expression turned gloomy, his mood dispirited.

Qin Lian had gone to the hospital and the result of the check-up was that his sperm motility was low. The doctor said that it extremely affected pregnancy. Therefore, Qin Yongcheng decided that Qin Lian and Gan Yunyun could not have a son. He was a little worried and sent people to look for Qin Mian again. Qin Lian couldn’t hardly retain his composure and let the cat out of the bag. Qin Mian’s whereabouts were soon known by Qin Yongcheng.

Qin Mian said, “They are my sons. The eldest is Qin Ruiqi and the youngest is Lei Ruilin.”

Qin Yongcheng's face changed. He had investigated Qin Mian and of course knew that Qin Mian was with a man.

At this time, Lei Tie drove over and saw two strangers standing with his wife. There was not a thread of surprise on his face. When his eyes swept over Qin Lian, there was even a touch of ridicule.

He was wondering if he was still too polite to Qin Lian. After scaring Qin Lian for a few days, surprisingly, Qin Lian could still hold himself up with all his might.

“Wife.” Lei Tie strode to Qin Mian's side, stood still, and very naturally embraced Qin Mian's shoulders.

Qin Yongcheng's face darkened, and he coldly asked, “What did you call him?”

Lei Tie said in a dull voice, “I know your purpose. Your youngest son has an unmentionable disease and there is perhaps a lack of male offspring. So, you put your idea on my wife and sons.”

Qin Yongcheng was shocked. This man investigated him, too? He had no idea.

Qin Mian squeezed Lei Tie's hand hard; Lei Tie actually didn't tell him what he knew.

Lei Tie also squeezed his hand, meaning to explain later.

“So that's it.” Qin Mian said, “Father, A-Tie is my spouse. Ruiqi and Ruilin are our sons. As for why I didn't go home, you can ask your youngest son.”

Qin Yongcheng looked at Qin Lian with puzzlement, and saw that Qin Lian's eyes were evasive, obviously feeling a little guilty. His face turned cold. In the end, he didn't blow his top on the spot. He turned to Qin Mian and said, “Regardless, let's go home first. It's not nice standing here.”

Qin Mian shook his head. “I think it's better to talk about meeting again after you ask him. Ruiqi, Ruilin, get in the car. A-Tie, let's go home. It's

snowing harder and harder. It'll be hard to drive if we delay any longer."

Lei Tie nodded and opened the door for his wife and sons.

Qin Yongcheng was very efficient. Early the next morning, he called Qin Mian and told him that he already knew about Qin Lian pushing him down the stairs.

"It's really Qin Lian's fault. I'll ask him to apologize to you and make it up to you. Now I want to talk to you about that man. Being with a man—"

Qin Mian interrupted, "We have been together for many years. Our sons are 8 years old. Do you think you can separate us?"

Qin Yongcheng's voice was serious, "Oh? In other words, you don't care about the Qin's right of inheritance?"

Qin Mian felt very funny and did laugh, but he didn't plan to explain his origin to Qin Yongcheng, "Father, have you really investigated my background now? I'm not interested in the Qin at all."

"Qin Mian!"

Qin Lian's current situation was almost equal to having no fertility. Except for Qin Mian, Qin Ruilin, and Lei Ruilin, there were no other successors of the Qin family's industry. This was a clear fact to Qin Mian and Qin Yongcheng. Therefore, Qin Yongcheng became furious and believed that Qin Mian was threatening him in order to propose more requirements.

"I'm serious." Qin Mian didn't like Qin Yongcheng, but he didn't intend to make the other party angry. "If you think it's necessary, I can write a document to give up the right to succeed."

Qin Yongcheng was silent for a long time before he asked, "Do you hate me?"

"Not really." Aware of the abnormality in the space, Qin Mian said quickly, "I can cure Qin Lian's disease, but not now. I have something else to do. I'm hanging up."

Lei Tie appeared out of thin air, looking serious, “Wife, White Spot is going to transform.”

“What? So soon?” Qin Mian was surprised, “Its cultivation speed is even faster than ours?”

Lei Tie explained, “It just found out that it has part of the bloodline of the mythical beast Celestial Mastiff in its body. These days, it has been staying in the space, so its promotion speed is very fast.”

“Let’s hurry in and have a look.” Qin Mian was worried about White Spot’s situation.

Lei Tie grabbed him, “When the daemon [yao] cultivator transforms, there will be a Heavenly Calamity. It can’t continue to stay in the space.”

Qin Mian responded quickly, “Are you worried that it will be the same situation as last time?”

Lei Tie nodded solemnly, “Yes. We don’t know how the descendants of the mythical beast are transformed. We’d better prepare for everything. We have two days at most, according to White Spot’s perception.”

Qin Mian did not know whether to cry or to laugh. *This White Spot really makes people choiceless.*

He made the best use of the time to write a prescription for Qin Lian; it was not for Qin Lian, but for Qin Yongcheng. He didn’t have to check Qin Lian’s pulse. Sperm motility was no more than those few reasons. He wrote a prescription of warm supplementation; the effect was slower at most, but there would be no side effects. He specially commissioned the express company to deliver the goods to Qin Lian after a year. This one year should be considered a punishment for Qin Lian.

After returning home, Qin Mian and Lei Tie put important things into the space, and took their two sons to a deserted place outside the countryside.

In case the family got separated again, only Qin Mian, Lei Tie, and White Spot remained outside, while Qin Ruilin, Lei Ruilin, Golden Fur, and Golden Eagle were all in the space.

Qin Mian gave Qin Yongcheng a last phone call. “Father, I have entrusted the express company to send the prescription to Qin Lian in a year later. You don’t have to worry about having descendants. Also, I have prepared a bottle of health care medicine for you, which should be delivered to you before dark. By this time, I’m not afraid to tell you the truth. Our family of four is cultivators of Trueness. Sooner or later, we’ll leave this world. Take care of yourself. Goodbye.”

At this time, Qin Yongcheng, who was in the office, was shocked. When he returned to his senses, he called back. The other party had turned off the power.

White Spot lay on the ground quietly, waiting for the most critical moment to break the cultivation barrier.

Qin Mian and Lei Tie sat side by side on a rock.

At this time, Qin Mian had time to ask White Spot what was actually going on.

White Spot explained, “In the previous incarnation, you saved me. Thus, you and I were bound by fate. There are causes and consequences. The reborn you and the reincarnated me meeting again concluded that ‘cause’. I’ve had memories of my previous ascension, but the content is so confusing that it’s like a game of chess in my head. So, I didn’t mention it to you. It was not until yesterday that I sorted out my memory. One of my ancestors was the mythical beast Celestial Mastiff, which is why I could unconsciously comprehend the cultivation method.”

“I see.” Qin Mian asked curiously, “Where did you get the ring that you gave me back then?”

White Spot said, “Found it accidentally. At that time, I only felt that this thing was good.”

Qin Mian was speechless for a while. That's pure luck.

It was rare for Lei Tie to ask a question, "How did you die in your previous life?"

White Spot said in depression, "... too careless. I was found out being too wise close to a daemon, so I was beaten to death."

Qin Mian and Lei Tie:

"BOOM!" a muffled thunder rumbled in the sky.

Qin Mian and the penalty violator Lei Tie quickly got up.

White Spot made a long wheezing noise in the open air, "AWOO~~!"

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other and retreated a hundred meters away. Heavenly Calamity was only aimed at the instigators. As long as they could resist the pressure of the calamity thunder, it was fine to stand closer.

With a "crack", the sky was suddenly torn open by an invisible hand. A lightning bolt as thick as an adult arm sprang out of the crack like a giant predatory snake.

"AWOO~~!" White Spot looked up at the sky without fear. When the thunder descended, he jumped up and went head on.

"BOOM!"

A strong wind swept through Qin Mian and Lei Tie, blurring their sight. In the next second, their body felt light and directly fell downward.

Lei Tie maneuvered his vital spirit, held his wife to suspend in the air, and steadily went downward.

Qin Mian pulled himself together, looked back, and saw a teenager about 10 years old closely following him and Lei Tie. Before he could take a proper look at the teenager, the three of them fell to the ground.

The teenager had hair hanging loosely, regular features, and a proud look. He was wrapped in a black robe and had no shoes on his feet. Probably not used to wearing clothes, he frowned and pulled at his robe, making it more messy.

Qin Mian said, “White Spot?”

“Yes, master. It’s me. I’ve succeeded in taking human form!” White Spot smiled at Qin Mian with a joyful look in his eyes.

Qin Mian chuckled and went forward to help him tidy up his robe.

“Congratulations!”

Lei Tie looked around and saw the pit on the ground. “Wife, this is where we left at that time.”

Qin Mian clicked his tongue, “We’ve been there for about half a year; I wonder how long it’s been here.”

“I’m going to scout the village.”

Lei Tie flew away and soon returned.

“It shouldn’t be long. I saw Miao Miao. She’s still that big.”

Qin Mian relaxed, “That’s good. Let’s get the children out and go back to the village.”

Ten minutes later, five people, one bear, and one eagle appeared at the entrance of the village.

White Spot carried Qin Ruiqi on his left and Lei Ruilin on his right. He looked so relaxed, like carrying two kittens. Qin Ruiqi and Lei Ruilin both held on his shoulders and looked at him curiously. Although they knew him to be White Spot, they still thought it was incredible.

White Spot looked arrogant, but doted on the two children very much; he grinned with a good-natured manner at them.

Lei Xiangli went outside the village with a vegetable basket and saw Qin Mian and the others. First, he was surprised, and then happy. He ran over quickly.

“Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law! Where have you been for so long? Why didn’t you notify us before? We’ve been looking for you all over the place.”

Qin Mian was embarrassed as he said, “Something unexpected happened. The people on the top asked us for urgent things, so...”

He deliberately spoke vaguely, so Lei Xiangli subconsciously thought that “the top” referred to the emperor and nodded in understanding, “As long as you’re fine.”

He looked at the boy in black robe curiously, “Who is he?”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie had a proper discussion while on the way.

“This is my adopted son, Qin Ruixuan, two years older than Ruiqi and Ruilin.”

Since he was adopted, there must be a story. Lei Xiangli did not ask anymore and said with a smile, “I see. Congratulations. Why don’t I see White Spot?”

“White Spot went into the mountain.” Qin Mian said this to make it convenient for Qin Ruixuan. Later, he could appear in human or animal form.

“Oh. By the way, Fifth Brother and his wife are also back to celebrate the New Year. Fifth Brother hasn’t been back for several years. Eldest Brother, Eldest Sister-in-law. What do you think about spending the New Year together in the evening? Your family also came back on New Year’s Eve; these are two happy events that come at the same time.”

Qin Mian was a little surprised. He didn’t expect that today was New Year’s Eve. With no Du Shi and Lei Daqiang making trouble, he and Lei Tie didn’t

mind being close to the brothers. They nodded in assent.

Lei Xiangli said happily, “great. See you all wear so little, hurry to go home, and I’ll go back and talk about it with my third brother and fifth brother. ”

In the evening, Qin Mian’s family, Lei Xiangyi’s family, Lei Xiangli’s family, and Lei Xiangzhi’s family had a reunion dinner at Qin Mian’s home. The adults sat at one table, the children sat at another table, next to a bear and an eagle. It was very lively. After all the dishes were served, everyone raised their glasses with a smile.

“This new year, we’ll get better and better. Here’s to you!”

Qin Mian and Lei Tie looked at each other with a smile; their hands were clasped under the table. As long as the spouse was always around, every day was a fairy-tale day.

Thanks for the journey!

Footnotes

1. (idiom)enjoy a happy and leisurely old age